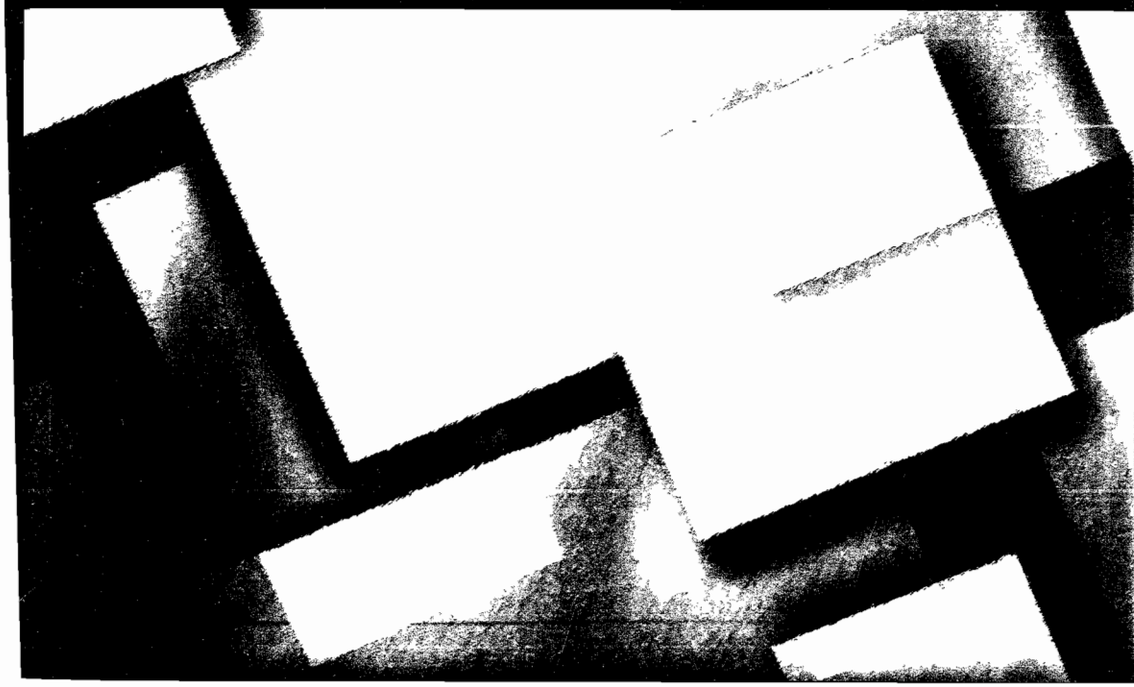


Systematic Theology
Creation, Christ, Salvation



Norman R. Gulley

Professor Norman Gulley's third volume of his *Systematic Theology* is a magnum opus. It presents significant insights on creation, Christology, Pneumatology, hamartiology, and soteriology. He convincingly demonstrates how Christian theology is not only rooted in the biblical doctrine of Creation, but stands or falls on it. There is no place for theistic evolution. Dr. Gulley, with compelling reasons, argues that God, through Christ, provides the Atonement to solve the sin-problem, and to save those who respond to His prevenient grace. He argues for relational freedom. His sound exegetical principles, comprehensive approach, and profound biblical insights make this an excellent volume. Those wanting the latest research need this book. He presents a very insightful summary of the Protestant-Catholic dialogue on justification. Congratulations professor Gulley for your outstanding theological masterpiece!

Jiří Moskala, Professor of Old Testament Exegesis and Theology
Chair, Old Testament Department, Seventh-day Adventist Theological Seminary, Andrews University

This is the third of a multi-volume series on systematic theology by Norman Gulley, one of the foremost Seventh-day Adventist systematic theologians. The present volume covers themes related to creation, Christ, and salvation. Gulley's presentation is very thorough. For example, his discussion of creation includes not only literary and theological issues in the Genesis creation accounts, but also a discussion of relevant references in the rest of Scripture, the image of God, sin and imputation, evolution, and related topics in science and philosophy. As always, his conclusions are biblically based and Christ centered. Gulley's *Systematic Theology* series is the fruit of a lifetime of theological research and reflection, a priceless treasure.

Tarsee Li, Professor of Hebrew Bible and Semitic Languages, Oakwood University

Professor Norman Gulley's third volume of his monumental *Systematic Theology* is again full of carefully presented biblical, historical, and theological data. The author introduces differing interpretations evenhandedly but is willing to listen to the biblical data and make a thoughtful, Scripture-based judgment call. Covering the doctrines of creation, Christ, and salvation, the volume will be a welcome reference work for many decades to come as future generations of biblical and systematic theologians interact with it. Gulley's thoughtful and clear language makes this volume a pleasure to peruse.

Gerald A. Klingbeil
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Systematic Theology

CREATION, CHRIST, SALVATION

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Dedication

This volume is dedicated to two
Adventist scholars

Raoul Dederen

for his important contributions made to
systematic theology

and

the late **Gerhard F. Hasel**

for his important contributions made to
Old Testament studies

Both served as Dean of the Seventh-day Adventist Theological Seminary
at Andrews University, and helped to mold
a generation of scholars

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Preface

Scholars are aware that the Enlightenment called into question metaphysical paradigms. Contemporary scientific method rejects the work of God in creation, introducing deep-time and positing an evolutionary process. By contrast, this *Systematic Theology* finds in the metaphysical reality of a relational Trinity foundational evidence for their acts in time as revealed in Scripture.

Volume 3 builds on the previous two volumes (see volume 1, chapter 1; and volume 2, chapters 1 and 4) by exploring the acts of the relational Trinity in creation, in Christ, and in applying salvation. All three areas (anthropology, Christology, and soteriology) are wrought in history and hence in time, providing further evidence that God is not timeless. Such a timeless view of God robs history of meaning, and devalues beings created in the image of God.

This volume argues that the creation of the world in six literal, consecutive, contiguous twenty-four-hour days is a historical reality compatible with the relational Trinity and their literal inner history of reciprocal love. From eternity God has acted in a temporal way, so it seems natural that temporal or sequential acts would characterize creation and all subsequent history. This volume considers evolutionary theory as primarily a contemporary assumption that has led traditional theology to accept nonbiblical ideas that are incompatible with a relational Trinity and with the biblical creation narrative. Questions about the theory of evolution remain, yet it is better to embrace Scripture and its revelation of God, allowing this inspired data to evaluate some of the evolutionary claims while waiting for further understanding.

It is understandable that Christ as the incarnate God-Man would live in historical time on earth. For Jesus Christ was a union of the divine and human—a union of (1) a Person of the Godhead who had eternally experienced an inner-Trinitarian history and now entered (2) an incarnational history. Some nonbiblical views of Christology will be evaluated—and in this volume *Christology* is broadened to include the post-resurrection ministry of Christ in the heavenly sanctuary and its contribution to theology.

The doctrine of salvation is the result of Christ's life and death for humans and needs to be biblically understood. Contemporary convergence and consensus of Roman Catholic and Reformation views need to be biblically evaluated. Justification by faith is forensic, an entry level to salvation (opposed to

New Perspectives on Paul, New Covenant Theology, and Federal Vision—see volume 2, chapter 12), and should not be confused with sanctification (as in Roman Catholic theology). Justification is the gift of Christ's righteousness imputed (not infused, as in Roman Catholic theology) to Christians as the basis for the impartation of Christ's righteousness in the sanctification process that follows.

So volume 3 is about three aspects of creation: (1) Christ's giving life to Adam and Eve in Eden; (2) Christ's entering human history in the Incarnation as the Son of God becoming also the Son of Man—this was a new creation, unique, without comparison, and necessary for human salvation; (3) through His bodily resurrection, ascension, and present intercession, Christ's entering human lives through the power of the Spirit: "[I]f anyone is in Christ he is a new creation; the old has gone the new has come" (2 Cor. 5:17). These events are supernatural *and* historical, not one without the other.

The written Word of God is as unchangeable and authentic as the living Word of God. Belief in supernatural creation is as important as belief in supernatural Incarnation and supernatural salvation. The power of both the written and the spoken Words of God are never confined to the natural realm, even though they work within it. Evolution is confined to the natural realm, and denies creation out of nothing by the omnipotent Trinity. Counterfeit gospels of Christ and critical studies of Jesus are devoid of the supernatural. The Catholic-Evangelical convergence jettisons some of God's supernatural doctrines in order to unite against secularism, setting aside essentials in God's Word while fighting against those who reject God's Word. Salvation is supernatural in the life, death, and intercession of Jesus Christ, and in the work of the Holy Spirit.

How much we need the guidance and wisdom of God found in His holy Word! Solomon said, "Unless the LORD builds the house, the builders labor in vain" (Ps. 127:1). This is a crucial principle for each one of the segments in this volume. Without God, there is no creation, no Jesus Christ, no salvation, and no true ecumenism with which to face a secular world. God's Word, all of it (*tota Scriptura*), is above all else (*prima Scriptura*) and interprets itself by comparing Scripture with Scripture (*sola Scriptura*). This is the only way forward. "Our help is in the name of the LORD, the Maker of heaven and earth" (Ps. 124:8); for, "The entrance of Your words gives light; it gives understanding to the simple" (Ps. 119:130, NKJV).

Departing from God's Word is like setting out to sea without a chart and compass. Thank God we have His Word, the Holy Spirit to explain it, and Christ to

journey with us, in this venture of life that leads to total transformation and fitness for heaven and the new earth—all because God *is* supernatural.

Soli Deo Gloria

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Creation

God's Supernatural Creation
1. Planet Earth and Its Heavens
2. Human Creation and Nature
3. Human Fall and Nature
4. Darwin's Journey from Scripture to Philosophy

Evolution Questioned
5. Theistic Evolution: The Quest for Reconciliation
6. Evolution Questioned: General Evaluation
7. Evolution Questioned: Scientific Evaluation
8. Evolution Questioned: Global Flood

Volume 3 begins with God's supernatural creation. Opponents of supernatural creation critique the Genesis account. They consider it to be indebted to Ancient Near Eastern texts, to be nonhistorical (saga or myth), nonscientific—a mere human narration open to historical-critical methods that call into question the Bible's authority as God's revelation to humans. By contrast, God's revelation documents that the earth and its immediate heavenly bodies, and all that was in the earth, sky, and sea, were created in six consecutive, continuous, contiguous days of twenty-four hours.

The Persons of the relational Trinity acted in time during the six days of creation, indicating they are not timeless. The Father created everything through Christ, who spoke things into existence out of nothing. That is why creation is supernatural, owing its existence entirely to God, and not to pre-existing matter.

Christ had firsthand knowledge of His creative work. Scripture contains Christ's divine commentary on the Genesis account in the fourth commandment, which Christ wrote on stone in His own hand: "For in six days the LORD made the heavens and the earth, the sea, and all that is in them, but he rested on the seventh day. Therefore the LORD blessed the Sabbath day and made it holy" (Exod. 20:11). Christ clearly attests that creation week was a literal, historical, and supernatural creation of God.

In biblical history the sacred Sabbath is always a literal day, and Christ informs us that the days preceding that first creation Sabbath were just as literal. There is no better authority than Christ's account of creation, which fully supports the Genesis account. Then why do so many sincere Christians who love Christ accept the day-ages theory, which is supposed to correspond to the deep-time of nearly five billion years of evolution? I do not doubt their sincerity, but

evidently they do not apply the biblical hermeneutic of allowing Scripture to interpret Scripture (*sola-tota-prima Scriptura*), a foundational discovery of the Reformation luminaries.

It seems to these Christian scholars that evolution provides some empirical evidence that needs to inform the interpretation of the Genesis account. So science moves in, rather than Scripture, to interpret Genesis. Ponder this: Satan denied the Creator's words to Adam and Eve about the fact that they would die if they ate the forbidden fruit. Satan deceived Eve by empirical evidence of what eating the fruit would do. It appeared to make the snake medium Satan used to speak her language, and it seemed good in her eyes. Like Eve, Christian scholars are swayed by evolutionary empirical evidence that questions God's Word. Christ upholds the Genesis creation account; and gave to John, in the last book of the Bible, a global call to "Worship him [God] who made the heavens, the earth, the sea and the springs of water" (Rev. 14:7b), a repetition of part of the fourth commandment in which Christ verified Genesis.

In Genesis the Creator-Christ made humans in a personal, up-close way, indicating the dignity and importance of humans, made in His image. Humans did not get here by chance—God created them. This segment documents the supernatural account of creation, the questioning of evolution with general and scientific data, and the evidence for the global flood. Theistic evolution, whereby God allegedly uses the evolutionary process to create, is shown to be false by the authority of Scripture and the nature of the relational Trinity.

CHAPTER ONE

Planet Earth and Its Heavens

Purpose

1. See the importance of the foundational chapters in Scripture.
2. Present evidence for creation as God's supernatural acts.
3. See how all creation reveals God.
4. Consider creation in the light of the Incarnation.
5. View creation in respect to God's eternity and sovereignty.

Summary

It is argued in this chapter that because God is a Trinity in eternal, reciprocal love, there was no inner necessity to create anyone in order to love. Their love for each other was eternally antecedent to their first creative act. Because the Trinity is eternally self-existent, the time prior to their first creation must have been eternal. The focus of Genesis 1–2 is on the creation of earth and its immediate heavenly environs. The tenfold *tôlĕdôt* structural sequence ("these are the generations of") in Genesis is internal evidence that Genesis 1–2 are as historical as the rest of the book, and as such they are to be read as a literal/historical genre rather than as myth or saga. The book contains evidences of being a carefully constructed literary work that counters the theory of multiple authors (JEDP), and indicates its independence from ancient Near Eastern (ANE) creation stories (*Enuma Elish* and *Atrahasis Epic*), for its dissimilarities with them are significant. The Genesis creation account is corroborated as historical and supernatural by other biblical passages. Creation is drawn from many references in Scripture in an intertextual

study that calls into question the criticism of the Genesis account. One does not need to look beyond Scripture to nature to discover how creation took place, for Scripture presents creation as God's work, without dependence on pre-existing material (*creatio ex nihilo*) and accomplished in six literal, continuous, contiguous days of twenty-four hours.

Outline

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V. Greatest Evidence for Creation

VI. Conclusion

VII. Study Questions

Introduction

TRINITY

This system rejects tritheism, for Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are one God. However, when the Trinity acted to bring about creation, Scripture states that God the Father created the universe through His Son (John 1:1–3, 14; Col. 1:15–16; Heb. 1:1–2), and in the creation account the "Spirit of God was hovering over the waters" (Gen. 1:2). Subsequently the Spirit participated in the creation of Christ's humanity (Matt. 1:20), and also re-creates humans in the process of salvation (Gal. 5:22–23; 6:5; 2 Cor. 5:17). So all three Persons of the Trinity are involved in creation.

God did not need to create in order for His love to be perfected. How could eternal love within the relational Trinity be less than perfect? God's inner history of Trinitarian love is the ultimate, and all other love is but a faint reflection of it. God is the sole source of love, and that love must necessarily define all that He does, including predestination and creation. Scottish theologian Edgar Dickie once said that Calvin "so stressed the sovereignty of God as to strain the whole structure of theology and render it incapable of giving

due weight to the divine love."[1] Suggesting that the Persons of the Trinity had a need to relate to other beings unwittingly calls into question the reality of their internal history with each other. I concur with Robert Jenson that "God does not first become active and relational when he creates; just so creating is *both* appropriate and unnecessary for him."[2]

It is important to notice purpose in creation. God said His creation was "very good" (Gen. 1:31). The Hebrew word for good (*ṭôb*) means "good for" which indicates purpose, so different from the supposed purposelessness of evolutionary chance that created humans accidentally.[3] Evolution is an alleged process of survival of the fittest or the best adapted, with billions of deaths over deep-time, in order to evolve humans. William Dembski challenged this claim. His first two questions need not detain us, but his third and fourth questions are pertinent to our study: "What sense does it make for God to call the creation 'good' and 'very good' if throughout the process of creation Satan has been infecting it?" and "What is the point in Genesis 1 of God's formally bestowing on humanity rulership of the earth if throughout its existence Satan has been undermining it with natural evil?"[4] (see chapters 4–8).

In other words, God's calling creation "very good" and placing it under human rulership is incompatible with Satan's prior fall being responsible for natural evil in the world. There is not even a hint in Scripture that death is natural; rather, it is quite the opposite: death in Scripture is due to sin (Rom. 6:23), to breaking God's law (1 John 3:4), which took place after the creation of Adam and Eve (Gen. 2:16–17; 3:1–24). The fall of humans—and not the fall of Satan—is responsible for all death on planet earth.

The fact that humans were to rule indicates their freedom to choose. That's why God asked Adam to name all the animals (Gen. 2:19). Human freedom to choose is indicated by God's test about the forbidden fruit (Gen. 2:16–17). C. S. Lewis argues that in order for God to create "a society of free souls" He had to create "a relatively independent and 'inexorable' Nature."[5]

1. Edgar P. Dickie, introduction to *The Nature of the Atonement and Its Relation to Remission of Sins and Eternal Life*, by John McLeod Campbell (London: James Clarke, 1959), xx.
2. Robert W. Jenson, *Systematic Theology: The Works of God* (New York: Oxford, 1999), 2:28.
3. Ibid., 2:13.
4. William A. Dembski, *The End of Christianity: Finding a Good God in an Evil World* (Nashville, TN: B & H, 2009), 37–38.
5. C. S. Lewis, *The Problem of Pain* (New York: HarperOne, 2001), 19; accessed June 25, 2012, http://www.amazon.com/The-Problem-Pain-C-Lewis/dp/0060652969/ref=sr_1_1?ie=UTF8&qid=1340653987&sr=8-1&keywords=problem+of+pain.

BIBLICAL CHIASM

Scripture begins and ends with parallel chapters. All of Scripture, from rebellion to restoration, is placed within this poetic parallelism.

Genesis 1: God creates the heavens and the earth
Genesis 2: The tree of knowledge of good and evil
Revelation 21: God creates the new heaven and the new earth
Revelation 22: The tree of life

Whereas Adam and Eve spent their first full day of life enjoying a Sabbath (Gen. 2:2–3) which was made for human benefit (Mark 2:27–28), so in the new earth "God's dwelling place is now among the people, and he will dwell with them. They will be his people, and God himself will be with them and be their God" (Rev. 21:3b); and they will experience the weekly Sabbath to worship God (Isa. 66:22–23). Like the most holy place of the sanctuary (1 Kings 6:20), so the New Jerusalem will be a perfect cube (Rev. 21:16). Whereas in the first creation there was night, in the new creation there will be no more night (Rev. 22:5a). Whereas humans were given the world to have dominion over (Gen. 1:26–27) so in the new earth "they will reign for ever and ever" (Rev. 22:5b). Just as God created and said "it is good" or "very good" (Gen. 1:4, 10, 12, 18, 21, 25, 31) so God will say "I am making everything new!" and "It is done, I am the Alpha and the Omega" (Rev. 21:5, 6a).

Just as God created a home in Eden prior to Adam and Eve's creation, so a New Jerusalem is being prepared for the redeemed. Prior to His ascension Christ promised His disciples, "My Father's house has many rooms; if that were not so, would I have told you that I am going there to prepare a place for you? And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come back and take you to be with me that you also may be where I am" (John 14:2b–3). Christ wants His followers to know that He will come to get them and take them to a place that He will prepare for them. This shows the love that Christ has for His people. He has a personal concern for them, and He wants them to know that He will personally do the preparation and then come to take them to their new home. Because this same Christ is the Creator of the world (Heb. 1:1–2; Col. 1:15–16), and does not change (Heb. 13:8), it is biblical to conclude that He created humans in the beginning with the same loving, personal interest. Scripture tells us that Christ created humans on the sixth day of creation (Gen. 1:27–31); based on the Bible, there was no long process of evolution, which would have been less personal and have made God seem distant from humans.

Christians have never taught that the new heaven and the new earth will come about through a natural process; neither do they teach that entrance

into the new heaven and new earth is through a natural process. They do not consider Christ's incarnation, resurrection, and their changed lives as natural processes. Because God acts in a sovereign supernatural way in the Incarnation (born of the Spirit), the Resurrection (God's work), changed lives (God's work), and creation of the new earth and new heaven (God's work), there is a congruity in God's supernatural work in the creation of this earth and its environs, and all that fills both.

IMPORTANCE OF LOGICAL CONSISTENCY

There are many good Christians who believe in predestination and in theistic evolution (God creating through the process of evolution). From the above mega-chiasm that enfolds Scripture, one is reminded that "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8). The Creator-Christ is the active agent through whom God the Father creates all things in the beginning of this planet's existence, and in the re-creation of it. When many Christians emphasize the absolute sovereignty of God in predestination, or His plan to elect and reprobate humans, they emphasize His sovereignty. He is not dependent upon any human input. But when it comes to creation, theistic evolutionists believe God was dependent upon the natural process over deep-time to create, which is inconsistent with the biblical view of the sovereign Creator, God Himself. This is not evident merely from human reason, but issues from the biblical revelation that God acted in a sovereign way through creating humans during part of one day (as noted above, Gen. 1:27–31).

Put differently, if predestination is confined to the sovereign will and acts of God, why does God need evolution (an outside means) to produce humans? If God had chosen this natural means, wouldn't the God of predestination seem at odds with this God of alleged theistic evolutionary creation? Does this sovereign God, who acted sovereignly in the eternal election/reprobation decisions, find Himself less than able to create humans *ex nihilo* (without dependence on anything else)? After all, His predestination was *ex nihilo*, so why not His creation?[6]

In another arena, many theologians rightly reject Process theology, which alleges God's dependence upon the world as His body, and rightly reject Openness theology that alleges God's dependence upon the decisions of humans, because such views necessarily mean God doesn't have absolute foreknowledge.

6. God created everything (even the dust from which He formed Adam and animals). There was no spontaneous generation of anything. God is the Creator of the heavens and the earth, so in this sense He created everything out of nothing, which means His command was sufficient to create everything (Heb. 11:3). The fact that He formed Adam and took a rib to create Eve is still a supernatural creation, dependent only upon God Himself.

To be consistent, doesn't one also need to reject the evolutionary creation of humans, in which God is dependent upon a natural process that is full of guts and gore, survival of the fittest and death, since He is more than able to bypass such a terrible process as the sovereign Creator? One important contribution of systematic theology is to ask these kinds of questions, and to probe to an inner coherence so that the God presented in one segment of a system is the same God presented in other segments of the system.

Some may reply, isn't God dependent upon humans (to a degree) to take the gospel to the world? I would argue that this is an example of God acting in a relational way, in a covenant way, for by grace He includes humans to work with Him as His messengers (Matt. 28:18–20). Salvation is a sovereign act of God, for only God can save (Acts 4:12; Jude 1:25), but humans are privileged to be used by the sovereign God in the saving process of communicating the good news. God is really not dependent upon humans to take the gospel to the world, as if He could not do it Himself. He chooses to relate with humans because He is a relational God. In the doctrine of salvation, God rejects salvation by human works because salvation is a work of God alone. Therefore, if Scripture says that God created without any dependence upon pre-existing matter (*ex nihilo*, Heb. 11:3), it follows biblically that in the creation of humans He was not dependent upon an evolutionary process.

HOW DID GOD CREATE?

Christians do not question whether God created; they question how He created. Some of them assume evolutionary theory is scientific and modern whereas the biblical record is primitive and pre-scientific.[7] Evolution is persuasive because Darwin's theory (natural selection, survival of the fittest or the best adapted, mutation of species, and chance) is considered a workable paradigm. In other words, Darwin's contribution was to present a paradigm which seemed to make sense of nature and natural history. The power of the paradigm carried the day for evolutionary theory, and people began to treat it as an established fact despite the lack of empirical evidence for its assumptions at the macro-level (compared to evolution at the micro-level, which has verifiable empirical evidence).

7. Thomas H. Huxley, a supporter of Darwin, wrote: "Genesis is honest to the core, and professes to be no more than it is, a repository of venerable traditions of unknown origin, claiming no scientific authority and possessing none," in "On the Reception of the 'Origin of Species,'" in *The Life and Letters of Charles Darwin: Including an Autobiographical Chapter*, ed. Francis Darwin (New York: Basic Books, 1959), 1:535. While supporting the *Origin of Species* as Darwin's book, Huxley fails to see Scripture's origin as belonging to God. The Creator God did not need to give a scientific account, for creation was supernatural, far beyond the understanding of humans.

Because some Christians believe God is confined to timeless acts, beyond time and space, this leaves a void in time waiting to be filled by some other alleged creative activity. They allow evolutionary theory to fill this vacuum. It does so without opposition from the timeless God, for it occupies time that God allegedly does not occupy. These theologians find no difficulty for their timeless God to create through a natural process in time because how else could He create and remain timeless, existing outside time? Augustine of Hippo (354–430), who greatly influenced Catholic and Protestant theology, declared that God "fashions things changeable, yet without any change in Himself, and creates things temporal, yet without any temporal movement in [Himself]."[8] Canale is right: "Conflict between evolution and creation can only take place if both theories are understood to refer to the same field of reality, i.e., to the temporal-spatial realm of creation."[9]

Theologians of a timeless God welcome harmony between God as Creator and evolution as His means of creation (for a discussion of theistic evolution, see chapter 5).[10] They see no problem with this arrangement. In their minds, there is no tension between these two, for both remain confined to their own places, and do not counter each other, but work together.

Atheistic scientists, on the other hand, have nothing to do with this kind of talk. God is out of place—utterly unnecessary—in creation. For them creation is all about nature. The supernatural is ruled out from the start. So what do many theologians and scientists bring to the table when discussing origins? They present a God of theology who is confined, and a process of evolution that is confined. Both confinements fail to grasp the larger picture of a supernatural God creating in space and time, which is the biblical view of creation, to which we now turn.

SUPERNATURAL CREATION

The question before us is this: Does creation have an absolute beginning or not? Was God dependent on eternally existing matter in His creation or not? Do Genesis 1–2 and the rest of Scripture support monotheism, which means

8. Augustine, *De Trinitate, Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, ed. Philip Schaff (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), 3:18 (1.3).

9. See Fernando Canale, "Evolution, Theology, and Method Part 1: Outline and Limits of Scientific Methodology," *Andrews University Seminary Studies* 41, no. 1 (Spring 2003): 79. I am indebted to him in this paragraph.

10. Instead of allowing Scripture to be the sole basis of their doctrine of creation, theistic evolutionists labor under the tyranny of two nonbiblical masters: (1) Platonic philosophy that confines their view of God and (2) evolutionary theory that confines their view of creation. When we come to know the truth of a Creator God in Scripture, this truth sets us free (John 8:32). This freedom affects all other doctrines, for we can only understand the different loci of a system when we understand the truth about the God to whom they testify. A relational God who enters into a heart-covenant with His people in time reveals the God of Calvary, and reveals the infinite value He places on humans—which is absent in evolutionary theory (which we would expect given that there is a cosmic controversy against the truth about God).

God alone is eternal, or dualism, which means He shares eternity with matter? "In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth" (Gen. 1:1). The first verse in Scripture introduces the biblical God as Creator. There was a beginning to His creation. It is not eternal as He is. There is no dualism between God and anything else. The world is not the body of God, as the last creation of prior creations that go back infinitely. Only God is infinite, eternal, and supernatural. The Trinity has existed from eternity. No one can understand this fact; no one can grasp the immensity of eternity; no one can comprehend how God had no beginning. He is self-existent, not dependent for life on anyone or anything. All creation is dependent upon Him.

As the Father redeemed the world through His Son, so He created the world through His Son. The Father did not create through the natural process of evolution, but through the supernatural power of the Son. There is no Marcionite (named for Marcion, who died ca. 160) distinction between the Creator God of the Old Testament and the Redeemer God of the New Testament. "In the beginning God created" (Gen. 1:1a) and "In the beginning was the Word" (John 1:1a) need to be compared. Leon Morris observes: "Genesis 1 described God's first creation; John's theme is God's new creation. Like the first, the second is not carried out by some subordinate being. It is brought about through the agency of the *Logos*, the very Word of God."[11] Scripture testifies to the Father's creating through the Son (Col. 1:15–16; Heb. 1:1–2) with respect to the first creation, and through the Holy Spirit with respect to the second creation (Matt. 1:20b). Here is the supernatural at work, and not the natural. God is involved in a way that is compatible with His omnipotence, and certainly God has no need of an evolutionary process in either act of creation.

When it comes to creation, as in salvation, we need to let God be God. Just as surely as the gospel is a supernatural restoration of human beings that only God can accomplish, so it was with His original creation of humans and their environment. If we call into question the supernatural ability of God at the beginning of Scripture, how can we consistently maintain His supernatural ability in the rest of Scripture? If God was dependent upon millions of years of evolution to bring His creation from a prebiotic soup to humans with brain capacity greater than that of the most intricate computer, then why in the end times does He resurrect the dead instantly (1 Thess. 4:16–18), and change the living in a twinkling of an eye (1 Cor. 15:52)? Why does He act in creation so slowly in the beginning when He acts so quickly in re-creation at the end? Why is He so dependent on nature in the beginning when He isn't

11. Leon Morris, *The Gospel According to John*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament*, rev. ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1995), 65.

dependent upon nature in the end? Christ is the Creator in the beginning and in the end, and He is the "same yesterday, today, and forever" (Heb. 13:8), so is it consistent to accept a natural creation in the beginning and a supernatural re-creation in the end?[12]

Scripture links the eternal gospel with creation. In fact, the eternal gospel includes creation. An angel proclaims "the eternal gospel...to those who live on the earth—to every nation, tribe, language and people. He said in a loud voice, 'Fear [or reverence] God and give him glory, because the hour of his judgment has come. Worship him who made the heavens, the earth, the sea and the springs of water'" (Rev. 14:6–7). So a part of the gospel is to give God the glory for creation, and to worship Him as the Creator. Today many people give glory to nature for creation, and some even worship nature. Some even think of evolution as continuous, and modern scientific inventions as the latest evidence, so that human history from the beginning to the present is one of continuing progress.

Scripture tells us that the end will come, through a supernatural in-breaking of history by the return of Jesus Christ as King of kings (Rev. 19:14–16; 1 Thess. 4:16–18; John 14:1–3). I will argue that only a supernatural creation gives us sufficient reason to worship God as Creator, because His creative acts reflect what He is in Himself—supernatural. How can we worship God as Creator if He put animals through a survival of the fittest (or the best adapted) process of death over deep-time in order to create humans?

The idea that God created the world we know through evolutionary struggle with so many deaths for millions of years is inconsistent with the relational love within the Trinity from eternity. Each Person in the Trinity loves the other two with utter selflessness, and hence loves the others more than He loves Himself. Such love involves a joyous giving of Himself, without any dependence on anything outside of Himself. Love has been an attribute of the Trinity forever. Each loves the others because this is the way God is; quite simply, God is love (1 John 4:8–16). How can a God of love act in an unloving way? How can He go outside His love, make Himself dependent upon that which is not loving (the torturous process of evolution), and use that means to reveal His love in the creation of humans? Such an idea is not only irrational, it also does great disservice to God.

Furthermore, the process of death is not good but evil. God does not choose evil as a means to reveal His goodness, for evil and God are mutually exclusive.

12. The theory of a Big Bang to jump-start the evolutionary process is an instantaneous act, albeit natural. Christians have reason (given in this chapter) to believe both in the supernatural acts of creation and in the creation week.

Think of the life of Jesus among humans. Did He ever use evil to reveal His love? How can evil contribute to His love, when the two are opposites? Any use of evil by a God of love is, to that extent, an endorsement of its value.[13] "The wages of sin is death" (Rom. 6:23), and it was Adam's sin that introduced death to planet earth (Rom. 5:14–19). How could death exist on the planet before Adam's fall? How could the God of love use the wages of sin (death) to create sinless humans? Any understanding that God used an unloving method to create calls into question His love, and would seem to validate Satan's charge against God. What is the good of God's love revealed in the life and death of Christ if He allegedly revealed Himself otherwise in the torture of evolution over millions of years?

In Christ's life on earth, where He was the God-Man, when the supernatural and the natural were united in one being, even then He did not use natural methods to perform His miracles of re-creation. He restored sight to the blind, hearing to the deaf, mobility to the lame, wholeness to the sick, and life to the dead. Throughout His works among humans Christ revealed His Father (John 14:9b)—indeed, He revealed the nature of the Trinity. He did so in supernatural acts of love (see chapter 10).

Christ's entire ministry among humans was predicated on a supernatural act of the Trinity in the Incarnation. God gave, Christ came, but He was conceived by the power of the Holy Spirit. This could never be described as a natural act. But it *could be* described as the most sublime of all supernatural acts, and the most difficult to grasp. So Christians accept the Incarnation by faith, because we will never understand it. How the omnipresent God could become a speck in Mary to be born a helpless baby nine months later defies human explanation. Christians accept the supernatural birth of Jesus as an important part of the Gospels. Although only the humanity of Jesus Christ was created, the resulting God-Man was a new reality in the universe, a unique, one-of-a-kind Person. Scripture calls Him the "last Adam" (1 Cor. 15:45). This links Him to the first Adam. If God can create the infinitely more complex God-Man, could He not create the first Adam? If the "last Adam" was created supernaturally, why not the first Adam?

I will argue that the supernatural creation of the first Adam was an act of God's love that tells us that humans are special to God, a fact proved by the supernatural creation of the second Adam (we will explore this further near the end of the chapter). Among all the things created on planet earth, only humans were created in the image of God (Gen. 1:27). This sets them apart from the

13. At times God uses sinful nations to punish His rebellious people, and so Assyria took Israel into captivity, and Babylon took Judah into captivity. Such nations were tools to deliver God's judgments. Later Babylon was overthrown by Medo-Persia (see Dan. 2).

rest. They are unique, one-of-a-kind beings compared to all other things on planet earth, just as Jesus Christ in His incarnation was "one of a kind" (Gr. *monogenēs*), the God-Man, unique among all persons everywhere. Scripture says Christ "is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn [first in importance, not time] over all creation" (Col. 1:15).

Unbelievers do not recognize the uniqueness of the "last Adam." "The god of this age [Satan] has blinded the minds of unbelievers, so that they cannot see the light of the gospel that displays the glory of Christ, who is the image of God" (2 Cor. 4:4). The god of this age has also blinded many believers so that they cannot see the light of the gospel in the uniqueness of the first Adam. The good news about the creation of the first Adam and Eve is their supernatural creation in the image of God.

The death of Christ was a supernatural act that brings salvation to all repenting sinners. Calvary is the place where the Son of Man died, where God took on the wages of human sin, and died in place of sinners as a substitutionary sacrifice. "God made him who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Cor. 5:21). This utter selflessness for rebel humans reveals the immanent love of the Trinity. This eternal relationship of love, in which each Person is utterly selfless in His love for the other two, is the love poured out at Calvary. The evolutionary struggle, based on the superiority of the strong and the necessary death of the weak, is utterly foreign to the loving God who gave everything for the weak, who died for them.

No wonder heavenly beings worship God as Creator. They give Him glory for what He did, saying, "You are worthy, our Lord and God, to receive glory and honor and power, for you created all things, and by your will they were created and have their being" (Rev. 4:11). Here they praise God the Father as Creator (cf. 1 Cor. 8:6a; Eph. 3:9a). Then with a loud voice people at the throne sang, "Worthy is the Lamb, who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and strength and honor and glory and praise!" (Rev. 5:12). Heavenly beings praise the Father and the Son for their power (among other things). For they created and redeemed through divine power—supernatural power. "Creation is an act of the personal God, not a process of nature."[14]

HISTORICAL

The literal meaning of *Genesis* is "origin." The book of Genesis is carefully crafted, indicating a single author, which calls into question the multiple-author

14. C. F. Keil and Delitzsch, *The Pentateuch*, vol. 1 of *Commentary on the Old Testament in Ten Volumes* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1986, repr.), 41.

theory (JEDP) of historical criticism. The formula *ēlleh tôlĕdôt* (these are the generations) appears ten times, and introduces various generations, as follows:

Genesis 2:4: "This is the account of the heavens and the earth"
Genesis 5:1: "This is the written account of Adam's family line"
Genesis 6:9: "This is the account of Noah"
Genesis 10:1: "This is the account of Shem, Ham and Japheth, Noah's sons"
Genesis 11:10: "This is the account of Shem's family line"
Genesis 11:27: "This is the account of Terah's family line"
Genesis 25:12: "This is the account of the family line of Abraham's son Ishmael"
Genesis 25:19: "This is the account of the family line of Abraham's son Isaac"
Genesis 36:1, 9: "This is the account of the family line of Esau"
Genesis 37:2: "This is the account of Jacob's family line"

The significance of this structure is the historical focus of each, which suggests that the creation record in Genesis 1–2 should be considered equally as history, rather than as myth (Bultmann) or a saga (Barth), or as indebted to ancient Near Eastern (ANE) creation stories such as the *Enuma Elish* and *Atrahasis Epic*. Victor Hamilton notes that "recent studies have tended to support the essential unity of Genesis. Leading the way are insights gleaned from discourse grammar (Andersen), rhetorical criticism (Kikawada and Quinn; Rendsburg), and literary/aesthetic criticism (Alter and Sternberg)."[15]

Martin Luther had it right. He rejected the allegorizations of Origen and Jerome. He said:

> I ask you, is this not a desecration of the sacred writings? Origen makes heaven out of Paradise and angels out of the trees. If this is correct, what will be left of the doctrine of creation? Particularly for beginning students of the Sacred Scriptures it is, therefore, necessary that when they approach the reading of the ancient teachers, they read them with discretion, or rather with the definite intention to disapprove of those statements for which there is less support. Otherwise they will be led astray by the authority of the name of the fathers and teachers of the church, just as I was led astray and as all the schools of the theologians were. Ever since I began to adhere to the historical meaning, I myself have always had a strong dislike for allegories and did not make use of them unless the text itself indicated them or the interpretations could be drawn from the New Testament.[16]

15. Victor P. Hamilton, *The Book of Genesis, Chapters 1–17*, in *The New International Commentary on the Old Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1990), 38.

16. Martin Luther, *Lectures on Genesis 1–5*, vol. 1 of *Luther's Works*, ed. Jaroslav Pelikan (St. Louis, MO: Concordia, 1958), 232.

This is wise counsel. Luther knew from experience that assumed deeper spiritual meanings beyond the historical "were empty speculations and the froth, as it were, of the Holy Scriptures. It is the historical sense alone which supplies the true and sound doctrine."[17]

UNIVERSAL

God creates a world (nature on planet earth as well as the surrounding heavens) prior to creating humans. This is not a local story but the beginning of the world, its environs and history. Gordon J. Wenham points out that "the material of chaps. 1–11 is markedly different from that in chaps. 12 onward. The opening chapters have a universal perspective dealing with all mankind.... Chaps. 12–50, on the other hand, deal almost exclusively with Israelite concerns."[18] The biblical creation record introduces the universal week, which has no evidence from nature like the month (moon's orbit around the earth) and year (earth's orbit around the sun). The week is dependent on the biblical account of creation week (Gen. 1–2).

INDEPENDENT OF ANE TEXTS[19]

A number of scholars speak against identification of the Ancient Near East creation stories with the biblical account of creation in Genesis. For example, Herman Bavinck asserts that "the creation stories in Genesis and that of Babylon

17. Luther, *Lectures on Genesis 1–5*, vol. 1 of *Luther's Works*, 233.

18. Gordon J. Wenham, *Genesis 1–15*, vol. 1 of *Word Biblical Commentary* (Waco, TX: Word, 1987), xxii.

19. See Robert B. Coote and David Robert Ord, *In the Beginning: Creation and the Priestly History* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1991); Bernard F. Batto, *Slaying the Dragon: Mythmaking in the Biblical Tradition* (Louisville, KY: Westminster/John Knox, 1992); Richard J. Clifford, *Creation Accounts in the Ancient Near East and in the Bible, The Catholical Biblical Quarterly Monograph Series 26* (Washington, DC: Catholic Biblical Association of America, 1994). Marduk the god of Babylon created in order to justify his "primacy among the Babylonian gods," Coote and Ord, *In the Beginning*, 6–7. The Babylonian *Enuma Elish* has two gods, god of the fresh water (Apsu) and goddess of the salt water (Tiamat). The offspring, or young gods, were noisy, disturbing the older gods sleep. Apsu and Tiamat were killed, and out of Tiamat's dead body Marduk creates the world, Coote and Ord, *In the Beginning*, 8–9. Perhaps this is sufficient to document that they were not real Gods, and that Marduk was dependent on Tiamat's body in order to create (no creation out of nothing). The Genesis creation account is vastly different from that ANE account. Hence, I disagree with Batto that "the so-called Primeval History (Genesis 1–11) is heavily dependent upon the mythic tradition of Mesoporamia," Batto, *Slaying the Dragon*, 2. *Atrahasis* is a Babylonian flood story, but is also called a "Babylonian Genesis," Batto, *Slaying the Dragon*, 27. In this account the high gods could "rest" while the lower gods did all the providing of food. "The ringleader of the rebel gods was killed and from his blood mixed with clay" a primitive humankind of seven males and seven females were fashioned. They were created to do all the work for the gods. But humans rapidly multiplied and caused a din, and so the council of the gods decided to send a flood to get rid of the noise, Batto, *Slaying the Dragon*, 27–28. "Since the gods created the world for their own benefit," Clifford, *Creation Accounts*, 199. These glimpses into the ANE creation stories present gods that are totally different from the biblical God of love, a relational Trinity, who does everything for the benefit of others.

are very different on all points."[20] Gerhard Hasel notes that nonbiblical cosmologies are deliberately rejected by the author of Genesis.[21] Gordon Wenham states, "Though Genesis shares many of the theological presuppositions of the ancient world, most of the stories found in these chapters are best read as presenting an alternative world-view to those generally accepted in the ancient Near East. Gen 1–11 is a tract for the times, challenging ancient assumptions about the nature of God, the world, and mankind."[22] Raymond C. Van Leeuwen states, "Even where OT accounts and ANE myths share similar actions or imagery, the ANE polytheistic context gives them a fundamentally different character."[23] He also points out that Yahweh's sovereignty clearly given in Scripture, "presupposes creation (e.g., 1 Kgs 8:23, 27, 30, 32). The separation of the 'Red' Sea and of the Jordan to form dry ground recapitulates the original acts of creation."[24]

Perhaps we could sum up the many dissimilarities that give evidence of the independence of the Genesis account: (1) humans are merely an afterthought in the ANE texts but the most important created beings in Genesis; (2) there are many gods in the ANE texts but the one God in the Genesis account; (3) there is primeval conflict in the ANE texts but a conflict-free environment in the Genesis account; (4) deities struggle to divide the waters in the ANE texts but God creates through speaking in the Genesis account; (5) there is a cosmic dualism between gods in the ANE texts but not in the Genesis account; (6) darkness is not created in the ANE texts but is created by God in the Genesis account; (7) there is no distinction between the gods and creation in the ANE texts, but there is a clear distinction between God and creation in the Genesis account; (8) there is no creation out of nothing (*creatio ex nihilo*) in the ANE texts, but God creates most things out of nothing in the Genesis account. Besides the content differences, there is a marked difference in style between the ANE texts and the Genesis account.[25]

So there is evidence that the Genesis 1–2 creation account is historical, universal, and independent of ANE texts. It is just as inspired as the rest of Scripture. It is the Word of God, and can be trusted as a divinely inspired record that merits on our part a response of humility and a desire to learn. There is another reason why it should be considered seriously as God's self-revelation about origins, and to this we now turn.

20. Herman Bavinck, *God and Creation*, vol. 2 of *Reformed Dogmatics*, ed. John Bolt, trans. John Vriend (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2004), 477.

21. Gerhard F. Hasel, "The Polemic Nature of the Genesis Cosmology," *Evangelical Quarterly* 46 (1974): 81–102.

22. Wenham, *Genesis*, vol. 1 of *Word Biblical Commentary*, xlv.

23. Raymond C. Van Leeuwen, "bārā'," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology & Exegesis*, gen. ed. Willem A. VanGemeren (Grand Rapids, MI; Zondervan, 1997), 1:729.

24. Ibid.

25. See Paul Copan and William Lane Craig, *Creation out of Nothing: A Biblical, Philosophical, and Scientific Exploration* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2004), 30–36.

COSMIC CONTROVERSY

The fact of a cosmic controversy, in which the rebellion is against God, means that His attributes and acts—including His work as Creator—are called into question. The rebellion is an attempt to instill in humans a desire to be independent of God, and thus join the rebellion against Him. God is the source of all truth, whereas the leading rebel Satan is the source of all lies; Scripture calls him the father of lies (John 8:44). It follows that for every truth about God the rebellion has a counterfeit. Whereas God reveals in Scripture that He is the Creator, the rebellion calls this into question by suggesting other ways humans and all else in the world came to be. So it is no surprise to see that there is a difference between the ANE texts and the Genesis account of creation: It suits the rebellion well to counter the truth with counterfeits.

It is the studied strategy of the rebellion to replace the Creator by any and every means that may be persuasive. The ANE texts serve the rebellion well, not merely in giving other accounts of how everything came to be on planet earth, but also in causing many scholars to believe that the Genesis record is dependent on them and to question the role of Scripture as revelation. The cosmic controversy allows us to pull back the curtain and see the context in which rival texts can be used by the rebellion to call the Genesis account into question (the controversy is presented in my *Systematic Theology*, volume 1, chapter 10; see also volume 2, chapter 8). Later in this chapter we will ask if the rebellion uses evolutionary theory for the same ends. Our only safeguard against counterfeits of the rebellion is to have a firm belief in the trustworthiness of Scripture as God's revelation which enables us to discern between the genuine and the counterfeit.

The Genesis Creation

IN THE BEGINNING

The words "in the beginning" open the creation account (Gen. 1:1), but they are not found in any ANE creation story. Nevertheless these words are interpreted in two different ways, and appear as such in different Bible translations. Some translate them as an independent clause: "In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth" (KJV, NASB, NJB, NKJV, NIV, REB, RSV), whereas others translate them as a dependent clause: "When God began to create the heavens and the earth" (AB, NAB, NEB, NRSV). The independent clause translation agrees with the primary method of creation through spoken commands (Gen. 1:3, 6, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24, 26). Consider: "By the word of the Lord were the heavens made" (Ps. 33:6) and "For he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm" (Ps. 33:9). It also agrees with "creation out of nothing." For, by "faith we understand that the universe was formed at God's command, so that what is seen was not made out of what was visible" (Heb. 11:3). This is the traditional translation.

The second translation, which is a more recent one, says when God began to create (v. 1) the earth was without form and void (v. 2), suggesting that the earth was already there before God formed it and filled it (during the six days). This translation agrees with ANE stories, like the *Enuma Elish* and the *Atrahasis Epic*, which both begin with a temporal clause, which requires a dependence on pre-existing things.[26]

The independent clause translation is corroborated by another biblical reference. The Gospel of John begins with the same words: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. He was with God in the beginning." Both state that God was there in the beginning. John links Christ's original creation with His incarnation, suggesting that both were supernatural acts of God. "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.... Through him all things were made, without him nothing was made that has been made.... The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us" (John 1:1, 3, 14).

The Hebrew word for "beginning" (*rēʾšît*) is without the definite article in the Hebrew text (Gen. 1:1). We noted two options for interpreting the clause "In the beginning": (1) Is it an absolute beginning or (2) a temporal beginning? There are four views below that indicate two ways for interpreting "In the beginning" as a temporal clause, and two ways of interpreting "In the beginning" as an absolute clause.[27]

How Genesis 1:1 Is Interpreted

Gordon Wenham considers the debate on interpreting Genesis 1:1–3 as "complex and protracted."[28] He outlines the four options of Genesis 1:1 considered by exegetes:

1. "Verse 1 is a temporal clause, subordinate to the main clause in verse 2": "In the beginning when God created...the earth was without form."
2. "Verse 1 is a temporal clause, subordinate to the main clause in verse 3 (verse 2 is a parenthetic comment)." "In the beginning when God created...(now the earth was formless), God said..."

26. Wenham, *Genesis*, vol. 1 of *Word Biblical Commentary*, 12.
27. See Copan and Craig, *Creation out of Nothing*, 38. These four views are adapted versions of the four views given in Gordon J. Wenham, *Genesis*, vol. 1 of *Word Biblical Commentary*, 11.
28. Wenham, *Genesis*, vol. 1 of *Word Biblical Commentary*, 11.

3. "Verse 1 is a main clause and serves as a title to the chapter as a whole, summarizing all the events described in 2–31." It is a title to the chapter as a whole, and could be rendered "In the beginning God was the creator of heaven and earth." What being the Creator of heaven and earth means is then explained in more detail in verses 2–31.
4. "Verse 1 is a main clause describing the first act of creation. Verses 2 and 3 describe subsequent phases in God's creative activity. This is the traditional view adopted in our translation."[29]

Hebraists defend different interpretations, so does it matter which one we choose? Here is the issue: Is the phrase "In the beginning" an absolute statement or a temporal clause? Or put differently, is it an absolute state or a construct state? Is it an absolute beginning to creation or not? Victor Hamilton focuses on the importance of making the right decision.

> The issue between these two options—"In the beginning when" and "In the beginning"—is not esoteric quibbling or an exercise in micrometry. The larger concern is this: Does Gen. 1:1 teach an absolute beginning of creation as a direct act of God? Or does it affirm the existence of matter before creation of the heavens and the earth? To put the question differently, does Gen. 1:1 suggest that in the beginning there was one—God; or does it suggest that in the beginning there were two—God and preexistent chaos? The latter approach separates itself from the former in that it dictates the existence of chaos prior to creation. But the concept of the creation of chaos would be a contradiction in terms.[30]

The Hebrew for "in the beginning" is "in beginning" with no definite article. The omission of the article does not prove that the words point to a temporal rather than to an absolute beginning. "Scholars such as G. Wenham, N. H. Ridderbos, James Barr, John Sailhamer, and others have shown that temporal phrases often lack an article (Isa. 40:21; 41:4, 26; 46:10; cf. Gen. 3:22; 6:3,4; Mic. 4:14 (5:1 ET); Hab.1:12)."[31] Concerning the word *beginning*, Victor Hamilton notes that "all the ancient versions translate the word as an absolute and the whole verse as an independent clause."[32] Examples include the Septuagint (LXX), Aquila, Theodotion, Symmachus, Targum Onkelos, and Jerome's Vulgate among others. Some following the LXX include Josephus in his *Jewish Antiquities*, Theophilus of Antioch (c. 180) in his *To Autolycus*, and Pseudo-Justine (220–300).[33]

29. Ibid., 11–13.
30. Hamilton, *Book of Genesis*, 105.
31. Copan and Craig, *Creation out of Nothing*, 39.
32. Hamilton, *Book of Genesis*, 107.
33. Copan and Craig, *Creation out of Nothing*, 44. See also Bill T. Arnold, "*rēʾšît*," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology and Exegesis*, 3:1025.

Old Testament scholar James Murphy presents five ideas about Genesis 1:1, asserting, "This verse forms an integral part of the narrative, and not a mere heading as some have imagined." He gives five reasons for this; we'll cite four of those here:

> 1. It has the form of a narrative, not of a superscription. 2. The conjunctive particle connects the second verse with it; which could not be if it were a heading. 3. The very next sentence speaks of the earth as already in existence, and therefore its creation must be recorded in the first verse. 4. In the first verse the heavens take precedence of the earth; but in the following verses all things, even the sun, moon, and stars seem to be but appendages to the earth. Thus if it were a heading, it would not correspond with the narrative.[34]

John Sailhamer sees three reasons for the words of Genesis 1:1: They (1) identify the Creator, (2) explain the world's origin, and (3) tie together past and future works of God. For the Creator-God is also the God who called Abraham (Gen. 12:1), the God who delivered Israel from Egypt (Gen. 3:15), and "the God of the covenant at Sinai" (Exod. 20). He notes that the principal argument for interpreting Genesis 1:1 as a construct state is the lack of an article with "beginning" (*rēʾšît*). It is argued that the absence of an article proves that Genesis 1:1 is not in the absolute state. However, this argument is called into question because Isaiah 46:10 ("I make known the end from the beginning") is in the absolute state, though the article is absent. The absolute state is supported by the simplicity of style, consistent with the rest of the chapter, and the finite form of the verb "to create" (*bārāʾ*). It is of interest that the two medieval Jewish scholars Rashi and Ibn Ezra both opted for a construct interpretation, not on grammatical grounds, but on presuppositions they brought to the text. Rashi was probably the first to suggest the construct interpretation.[35]

In commenting on Genesis 1:1, Keil and Delitzsch say:

> Heaven and earth have not existed from all eternity, but had a beginning; nor did they arise by emanation from an absolute substance, but were created by God. This sentence, which stands at the head of the records of revelation, is not a mere heading, nor a summary of the history of the creation, but a declaration of the primeval act of God, by which the universe was called into being. That this verse is not a heading merely, is evident from the fact that the following account of the course of the creation commences with ו (*and*), which connects the different acts of creation with the fact expressed in ver. 1, as the primary foundation upon which they rest.[36]

34. James G. Murphy, *Barnes Notes: A Commentary on the Book of Genesis* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 2005, 1st ed. 1847), 30.
35. John H. Sailhamer, *Genesis*, vol. 2 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan,1990), 19–23.
36. Keil and Delitzsch, *The Pentateuch*, vol. 1 of *Commentary on the Old Testament*, 46.

THE GAP THEORY

General Comments

We have noted biblical data and quoted various scholars, but without any regard to whether there is a gap in between the first two verses of the book of Genesis. The Gap theory suggests an indeterminate lapse of time between Genesis 1:1 and 1:2. We will consider two possibilities regarding this particular theory: (1) the Gap view is biblical and (2) the Gap view is unbiblical. Scripture says, "Study to show thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the Word of truth" (2 Tim. 2:15, KJV). We need to allow this wisdom to guide us as we proceed.

Genesis 1:2 presents the world "without form and empty" (*tōhû wābōhû*), "a desert and a wasteland"[37] which is unexpected in light of God's creative acts in the rest of Scripture (e.g., Rev. 21–22), and by His pronouncements over His created world in Genesis 1 as "good" (Gen. 1:4, 10b, 12b, 18b, 21b) and "very good" (Gen. 1:31a). It is rightly assumed that the creation noted in verse 1 would be "very good," and yet the state of the world in verse 2 is, for some, anything but good, for the world seems to be in a ruined state, and one could hardly consider God to be the cause of such ruination (cf. Isa. 45:18–19). Some suggest that one possible cause is Satan's rebellion against God, for God expelled him from heaven (Ezek. 28:16; Rev. 12:7–8), and it seems that in angry reprisal he ruined God's world. Such an interpretation necessarily considers verse 3 onward to be describing God's re-creation of the world. The indeterminable period between the first and second creations is the famous "gap" period between verses 1 and 2.

But if we examine the text more closely, we see that it does not suggest ruination (v. 2). It reads that the earth was "without form, and void" meaning unformed and unfilled. The nouns *tōhû* and *wābōhû* only appear three times together in the Old Testament (Gen. 1:2; Isa. 34:11; Jer. 4:23).[38] This description is identified with chaos in Isaiah 34:11. The etymology of these words is unknown.[39] The translation "formless and empty" "often stirs up images of the earth and the universe in a primeval stage of existence, much like the view of the origin of the universe in the physical sciences."[40] The Greek version of Genesis (LXX) uses the Greek word *aoratos* (unseen) for the Hebrew *tōhû*, and the Greek

37. Hamilton, *Book of Genesis*, 108.

38. Ibid., 108–109. There are twenty times when *tōhû* stands on its own without *bōhû* (*bōhû* never does), eleven in Isaiah (24:10; 29:21; 34:11; 40:17, 23; 41:29; 44:9; 45:18,19; 49:4; 59:4).

39. Keil and Delitzsch, *The Pentateuch*, vol. 1 in *Commentary on the Old Testament*, 48.

40. John Sailhamer, *The Pentateuch as Narrative: A Biblical-Theological Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1992), 84.

word *akataskeuastos* (unformed) for the Hebrew *bōhû*. Since both terms play an important role in the Hellenistic cosmologies at the time of the LXX translation, it is likely that the choice of these terms was motivated by an attempt to harmonize the biblical account with accepted views in the translator's own day rather than a strict adherence to the sense of the Hebrew text.

Hebraists agree that a chaotic condition is not backed up by Hebrew grammar, for Genesis 1:2 "is not a verbal clause but 'a pure noun clause', and must be translated as 'the earth *was* unformed and unfilled,' not 'the earth *became* unformed and unfilled.'"[41] Furthermore, "Genesis 1:2 clearly contains three noun clauses and the fundamental meaning of noun clauses in Hebrew is something fixed, a state, not a sequence or action."[42] "Thus Hebrew grammar leaves no room for the active gap theory."[43]

Later Greek translations after the LXX, such as Aquila ("empty and nothing") and Symmachus ("fallow and indistinct"), have moved away from Greek mythology to a more accurate rendering of the biblical Hebrew. The earlier English translations "formless" and "void" predate their meaning in this scientific age, influenced by evolutionary theory.[44] These words *tōhû* and *bōhû* appear in Genesis 1 with "darkness" "waters" and "the Spirit of God hovering over the waters." "Hovering" (*rḥp*) is in the *pi'el*,[45] and the only other use of *rḥp* in the *pi'el* is Deuteronomy 32:11.[46] "Like an eagle that stirs up its nest and hovers over its young, that spreads its wings to catch them and carries them aloft." It seems that the Holy Spirit is portrayed as hovering, waiting to care for the created beings about to be brought to life, which is what one would expect from a God of love. Then the Father creates all things through the Son (John 1:1–3; Col. 1:15–16; Heb. 1:1–2). All three Persons of the Trinity are involved in the creation.

Old Testament scholar Richard Davidson says, "The traditional translation as an independent clause conforms to the pattern of brief, terse sentences throughout the first chapter of the Bible." He also points out, "The account of creation throughout Gen 1 emphasizes the absolute transcendence of God

41. Sailhamer, *Pentateuch as Narrative*, 84; "The Creation Account in Genesis 1: Our World Only or the Universe?" *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, 13/2 (Autumn 2002): 111–112; referencing E. Kautzsch and A. E. Cowley, eds., *Gesenius' Hebrew Grammar* (Oxford: Clatendon, 1990; 1st ed. 1910), 454, and Richard M. Davidson, "In the Beginning: How to Interpret Genesis 1," *College and University Dialogue* 6:3 (1994): 11.

42. E. Kautzsch and A. E. Cowley, eds., *Gesenius' Hebrew Grammar*, 454; see also 451–455.

43. Richard M. Davidson, "In the Beginning," *Dialogue*, 11.

44. Sailhamer, *Genesis*, vol. 2 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary*, 27–28.

45. "The Piel Stem is used to express an intensive type of action with an active voice." http://www.becomingjewish.org/pdf/piel_stem-hebrew.pdf

46. Wenham, *Genesis*, vol. 1 in *Word Biblical Commentary*, 17.

over matter. This chapter describes One who is above and beyond His creation, implying *creatio ex nihilo* and thus the independent clause."[47]

The New Testament corroborates the independent clause of Genesis 1:1, showing that it speaks of an absolute beginning: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God" (John 1:1). This is a clear allusion to Genesis 1:1 for "in the beginning" in Greek (*en archē*) is without the article (also in the LXX version of Genesis 1:1) as it is in the Hebrew (*bĕrē'šît*).

Gerhard von Rad wrote: "We do not follow the old conjecture that v. 1 is not to be understood as an independent sentence but as the introductory clause to v. 2 or even to v. 3 ('at the beginning when God created heaven and earth…'). Syntactically perhaps both translations are possible, but not theologically. One must not deprive the declaration of v.1 of the character of a theological principle.... It is correct to say that the verb *bārā'*, "create," contains the ideas both of complete effortless and *creation ex nihilo*, since it is never connected with any statement of the material. The hidden grandeur of this statement is that God is the Lord of the world.... [He] alone is worthy of the predicate, Creator."[48]

Bill Arnold wrote: "The biblical witness is univocal in its support of creation ex nihilo, the ancient doctrine that God created the universe from nothing.... It is significant that the only other independent occurrence of *rē'šît* (i.e., absolute, and not in construct with another nom.) meaning 'beginning' is in Isa 46:9–10: 'I am God, and there is none like me. I make known the end from *the beginning*, from ancient times, what is still to come.' Thus the reason the first word in Gen 1:1 is grammatically peculiar and syntactically unique may be because the author (like Isaiah) is describing a unique event."[49]

Given this data, it is fair to say that God is before all creation, that there is an absolute beginning to the earth and its immediate environs in an unformed (*tōhû*) and unfilled (*bōhû*) state (literally formless and empty, Gen. 1:2), which were formed and filled during creation week.

> This ambiguity in the Hebrew text has implications for interpreting the Precambrian of the geological column, if one roughly equates the Precambrian with the "raw materials" described in Genesis 1:1–2 (of course this equation is debatable). There is a possibility of a young Precambrian, created as part of the seven-day Creation week (perhaps with the appearance of old age). There is also the possibility of the "raw materials" being created at a time of absolute beginning of this earth and its surrounding heavenly spheres, perhaps millions or billions of years ago. This initial unformed-unfilled state is described in verse 2. Verse 3 and following then describe the process of forming and filling during the seven-day Creation week. I conclude that the biblical text of Genesis 1 leaves room for either (a) a young Precambrian (created as part of the seven days of Creation), or (b) much older prefossil earth rocks, with a long interval between the creation of the inanimate "raw materials" on earth described in Genesis 1:1,2 and the seven days of Creation week described in Genesis 1:3 and following. But in either case, the biblical text calls for a *short* chronology for *life* on earth. There is no room for any gap of time in the creation of life on this earth: it came during the third through the sixth literal, successive 24-hour days of Creation week.[50]

47. Richard M. Davidson, "The Biblical Account of Origins," *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, 14/1 (Spring 2003): 4–43, 7.

48. Gerhard von Rad, *Genesis: A Commentary, The Old Testament Library,* Revised (Philadelphia, PA: The Westminster Press, 1972), 48–49.

49. Arnold, "*rē'šît*," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology and Exegesis*, 3:1025.

How the Gap Theory Is Interpreted

The Gap theory postulates an indefinite span of time, millions or billions of years, between Genesis 1:1–2 and 3. This means there is a huge gap separating the first two verses from verse 3, which begins creation week. Such a lengthy time span is sufficient to accommodate evolutionary deep-time while also fitting the Gap theory postulation that a cataclysmic judgment was pronounced upon the earth during this period as the result of the fall of Lucifer (Satan) and thus that the creation week is a re-creation—a ruin to restoration of the earth—not an initial creative effort on the part of God.

Though Gap theory has been around for a while, it's only become popular in recent years. Perhaps the first mention of Gap theory was made by the Dutch theologian Simon Episcopius (1583–1643) who taught at the University of Leiden.[51] Later, it was promoted by Thomas Chalmers (1780–1847), the Scottish theologian who was influential as the first moderator of the Free Church of Scotland and as a professor of theology at the University of Edinburgh.[52] The theory spread to many through the popular 1909 *Scofield Reference Bible*, although it isn't in my 1945 version. "Rev. William Buckland, a geologist, also did much to popularize the idea."[53] Perhaps this is sufficient to see that the theory gained wide exposure over time.

There are two major schools of thought among Old Testament scholars: (1) The Gap view is biblical, and (2) the Gap view is unbiblical. We will examine each.

50. Davidson, "In the Beginning," *Dialogue*, 11–12.

51. A. F. Johnson, "Gap Theory," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 2nd ed., ed. Walter A. Elwell (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2001), 480.

52. "What Is the Gap Theory? Its Origin and History," ChristianAnswers.Net, accessed January 8, 2012, http://www.christiananswers.net/q-aig/aig-c003.html.

53. Ken Ham, "What About the Gap & Ruin-Reconstruction Theories?" September 6, 2007, accessed January 9, 2012, www.answersingenesis.org/articles/.../gap-ruin-reconstruction-theories.

Is the Gap Theory Biblical?

In his commentary on Genesis, Old Testament scholar Gordon Wenham adopts the traditional view of Genesis 1:1. He says, "V 1 is a main clause describing the first act of creation. Vv 2 and 3 describe subsequent phases in God's creative activity."[54] He notes that most commentators believe Genesis 1:1 is "an independent main clause to be translated as "In the beginning God created." However, there is still disagreement on how verse 1 relates to verses 2–3. "The majority (Driver, Gunkel, Procksch, Zimmerli, von Rad, Eichrodt, Cassuto, Schmidt, Westermann, Beauchamp, Steck) adopt the view that Gen 1:1 is essentially a title to what follows."[55] Wenham says many modern commentators believe in the traditional view. He continues, "The versions and Masoretic pointing imply this was the standard view from the third century B.C. (LXX) through to the tenth century A.D. (MT). Modern advocates include Wellhausen (*Die Composition des Hexateuchs*), König, Heidel, Kidner, Ridderbos, Young, Childs (*Myth and Reality in the Old Testament* [London: SCM, 1960] 31–43), Hasel, Gispen, and Notter."[56]

Richard M. Davidson, Old Testament scholar, clearly distinguishes between a *no gap* interpretation and a *passive gap* interpretation. He prefers the latter one. He agrees with John E. Hartley: "The consistent pattern used for each day of creation tells us that verses 1–2 are not an integral part of the first day of creation (vv. 3–5). That is, these first two verses stand apart from the report of what God did on the first day of creation."[57] In verse 1 God created the heaven and earth; in verse 2 the earth is unformed and unfilled (*tōhû* and *bōhû*). On the first day of creation week (verses 3ff), God begins to form and fill the earth.[58] Davidson sees verse 1 as describing the creation of the universe, and clearly thinks this is compatible with John 1:3: "Through him [Christ] all things were made."[59]

Davidson believes that God is not dependent on pre-existent materials in verse 1. In the original creation (v. 1) God created *ex nihilo* (out of nothing). But He can use these created materials in creation week. For example, man was created from dust, and woman was created from the rib of man to name two.[60] Both were supernatural. Davidson says, "[I]f one accepts the 'passive gap' option (my preference), there is the alternate possibility of the pre-fossil 'raw material' being created at a time of absolute beginning of this earth and its surrounding

54. Wenham, *Genesis*, vol. 1 of *Word Biblical Commentary*,11.
55. Ibid.,12.
56. Ibid., 13.
57. Davidson, "The Biblical Account of Origins," *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, 21. Quoted from John E. Hartley, *New International Biblical Commentary: Genesis* (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson Press, 2000), 41.
58. Davidson, "The Biblical Account of Origins," *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, 21.
59. Ibid., 22n65.
60. Ibid., 23.

heavenly spheres, perhaps millions or billions of years ago."[61] He once believed the raw material and life forms were within the six literal days of creation. "But," he declares, "it is the text of Gen. 1, not science, that drives me to conclude that Gen. 1:1–2 is structurally outside the parameters of the six days." He continues, "Likewise, if 'heavens and earth' in Gen. 1:1 refers to the whole universe, then in light of Job 38:7 some of the creation described in the first verse of the Bible must of necessity be before the six-day creation week."[62]

Does Job 38:7 support this conclusion? The verse reads, "while the morning stars sang together and all the angels shouted for joy." What is the context of this verse? Does it include creation before the six days creation of this earth?

> Where were you when I laid the earth's foundation? Tell me, if you understand. Who marked off its dimensions? Surely you know! Who stretched a measuring line across it? On what were its footings set, or who laid its cornerstone—while the morning stars sang together and all the angels shouted for joy? (Job 38:4–7)

The context seems to be the creation of this world, not some time prior to it. In other words, it was in response to the creation of this earth that the morning stars and angels shouted for joy. It is true that the chapter mentions the Pleiades and Orion (v. 31), but there is no singing over them mentioned.

Davidson says, "I conclude that the biblical text of Gen 1 leaves room for either (a) a young pre-fossil rock, created as part of the seven days of creation (with appearance of old age), or (b) much older pre-fossil earth rocks, with a long interval between the creation of the inanimate 'raw materials' on earth described in Gen 1:1–2 and the seven days of creation week described in Gen 1:3ff (which I find the preferable interpretation)."[63] So Davidson concludes that the passive gap is biblical.

Marco Terreros, from Columbia Adventist University, approaches the issue from a different perspective from that of Davidson. In a recent article, Terreros asks, "Is this [Gap theory] not the result of a rather broad concordist endeavor to harmonize Scripture and Science? The point is, we are being forced to accept the gap by science, not by Scripture."[64] He continues, "And if we are willing to inject a long period of time between verses 1 and 2, why not accept the Gap Theory's other suggestions as to what happened during that period?" He finds it a problem that the Spirit hovers over the earth "for millions or billions of years to no effect."[65] He references an article by Davidson: "In the Beginning: How to

61. Ibid., 25.
62. Ibid., 24n69.
63. Ibid., 25.
64. Marco T. Terreros, "What Is an Adventist? Someone Who Upholds Creation," *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, 7/2 (Autumn 1996): 148.
65. Ibid.

Interpret Genesis 1,"[66] and concludes that "we face a grammatical problem. Verse 2 contains three substantival clauses whose fundamental function in Hebrew is to express something fixed, a state, and not to mark becoming, progression, or sequence in action."[67]

In Davidson's *Dialogue* article, with respect to the pre-creation state, he says: "The first variation sees Genesis 1:1 as a dependent clause, paralleling the extra-biblical ancient Near Eastern creation accounts.[68] So the translation proposed: '*When* God began to create the heaven and earth.' Therefore Genesis 1:2 equals a parenthesis, describing the *state* of the earth when God began to create ('the earth being…'), and Genesis 1:3 onward describes the actual work of creation ('And God said…'). The other major variation takes Genesis 1:1 as an dependent clause, and as a summary statement or formal introduction or title which is then elaborated in the rest of the narrative.[69] Genesis 1:2 is seen as a circumstantial clause connected with verse 3: 'Now the earth was unformed and unfilled…. And God said, 'Let there be light.'" [70] Davidson supports the independent clause view with its natural flow of Genesis 1–2 as follows:

1. God is before all creation (verse 1).
2. There is an absolute beginning of time with regard to this world and its surrounding heavenly spheres (verse 1).
3. God creates the heavens and earth (verse 1), but they are at first different than now, they are "unformed" and "unfilled" (*tōhû* and *bōhû*; verse 2).
4. On the first day of the seven-day Creation week, God begins to form and fill the *tōhû* and *bōhû* (verses 3 and following).
5. The "forming and filling" creative activity of God is accomplished in six successive literal 24–hour days.
6. At the end of creation week, the heavens and earth are finally finished (Genesis 2:1). What God began in verse 1 is now completed.
7. God rests on the seventh day, blessing and sanctifying it as a memorial of creation (2:1–4).[71]

66. Davidson, "In the Beginning," *Dialogue*, 11.

67. Terreros, "What Is an Adventist?" *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, 149.

68. See, for examples, the following modern translations of Genesis 1:1–3: the New Jewish Version (NJV), the Catholic New American Bible (NAB), and the New English Bible (NEB); see also E. A. Speiser, *Anchor Bible: Genesis* (Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1964), 3, 8–13.

69. See, for examples, von Rad, *Genesis, Old Testament Library*, 49; Bruce Waltke, "The Creation Account in Genesis 1:1–3; Part III: The Initial Chaos Theory and the Precreation Chaos Theory," *Bibliotheca Sacra* 132 (1975): 225–228.

70. Davidson, "In the Beginning," *Dialogue*, http://dialogue.adventist.org/articles/06_3_davidson_e.htm.

71. Ibid. In this article Davidson also writes: "This ambiguity in the Hebrew text has implications for interpreting the Precambrian of the geological column, if one roughly equates the Precambrian with the 'raw materials' described in Genesis 1:1–2 (of course this equation is debatable). There is a possibility of a young Precambrian, created as part of the seven-day Creation week (perhaps with the appearance of old age). There is also the possibility of the 'raw materials' being created at a time of absolute beginning of this earth and its surrounding heavenly spheres, perhaps millions or billions of years ago. This initial unformed-unfilled state is described in verse 2. Verse 3 and following then describe the process of forming and filling during the seven-day Creation week. I conclude that the biblical text of Genesis 1 leaves room for either (a) a young Precambrian (created as part of the seven days of Creation), or (b) much older prefossil earth rocks, with a long interval between the creation of the inanimate 'raw materials' on earth described in Genesis 1:1–2 and the seven days of Creation week described in Genesis 1:3 and following. But in either case, the biblical text calls for a *short* chronology for *life* on earth. There is no room for any gap of time in the creation of life on this earth: it came during the third through the sixth literal, successive 24-hour days of Creation week."

So Davidson accepts the passive Gap view, and Marcos Terreros concludes that any Gap view is unacceptable.

In 1960 Siegfried Horn, a professor of archaeology and history of antiquity, published the following evaluation of Genesis 1: "The word 'creation' in the broadest sense implies the formation by the Creator, or God Himself, of the universe, including our world and all living things in it. However, the Creation narrative (Gen 1 and 2) is concerned primarily with the bringing into existence of the earth, the sun, the planets, and living creatures found on the earth."[72] This seems to oppose the notion that there is any gap between the first two verses and the rest of the creation days.

Old Testament scholar Dr. William Shea, retired associate director of the Biblical Research Institute, rejects the view that the "heavens" in Genesis 1:1 refer to the universe. Thus he rejects a gap between the first verse of Genesis chapter 1 and what follows. He states it this way:

> The first objects of this creative activity identified in the text are the heavens and the earth. Some have taken the "heavens" as a reference to the universe. The way to evaluate this interpretation is to see how the phrase "heavens and the earth" is used in the rest of this narrative. An examination of those occurrences shows that the word "heavens" does not focus upon the universe, but rather upon the atmospheric heavens that surround this earth. Those were the "heavens" that God addressed when He divided the firmament on the second day of Creation week. Those were the heavens in which the birds flew after their creation on the fifth day (Gen. 1:20). Thus the focus of the use of the phrase "heavens and the earth" in Genesis 1 is upon this earth, not the universe or the starry heavens. This shows the geocentric emphasis of this Creation account.[73]

It follows that, by contrast with Davidson who supports an independent clause in Genesis 1, Shea supports a "dependent prepositional phrase, 'in the beginning.'"[74] Shea observes that some translate this as "when God began to

72. Siegfried H. Horn, *Seventh-day Adventist Bible Dictionary*, vol. 8 in *Commentary Reference Series* (Washington, D.C., Review and Herald Publishing Association, 1960), 230.

73. W. H. Shea, "Creation," in *Handbook of Seventh-day Adventist Theology*, vol. 12 in *Commentary Reference Series* (Silver Spring, MD: Review and Herald Publishing Association and the General Conference of Seventh-day Adventists, 2000), 420.

74. Ibid., 419.

create." He comments, "While that language may be more free than the original Hebrew, it does convey the ideas that the concern here is with the creation that follows rather than with the pre-existing state. The text acknowledges the fact that the inert earth was in a watery state before the events of Creation week, but it is not especially concerned with identifying how long it may have been in that state."[75]

The *Andrews Study Bible* comments on Genesis 1:1 ("heavens and earth"): "This has been understood as a reference to the entire universe. Because of the earth-centered focus of the creation account, however, it can also designate the earth and the atmospheric heaven surrounding it. Both views are possible."[76] The earth-centered focus of creation suggests that in Genesis chapter 1, the first verse is primarily focusing on this earth. Couldn't this be an introduction to what happened on the first day of creation, so that there is an immediacy between the introduction and the first day's creation?

H. C. Leupold, back in 1950, made the following statement about Genesis chapter 1: "Verse one is the record of the first part of the work brought into being on the first day: first the heavens and the earth in a basic form as to their material and then light. These two things constitute what God created on the first day."[77] So he also rejects a gap between verses 1–2 and verse 3.

Tentative Evaluation

While I have great respect for those scholars who have interpreted Genesis 1–3, there is an obvious problem with their exegesis: When Hebrew scholars take opposite positions on the basis of Hebrew grammar, it is sometimes difficult to decide which argument best meets the authorial intent of Genesis 1:1–2. Readers are invited to study each position and come to their own conclusions, and maybe in time clarification will be reached. However, I would like to look at this debate in the light of the biblical view of God. Here we transcend the debate and give evidence that would no doubt be acceptable to the scholars above; and we do so because it offers a perspective worth considering. Scripture states that God is love (1 John 4:8, 16). In the previous volume of my *Systematic Theology* (volume 2), we studied the reciprocal love that each Person of the Trinity has for each other in their inner history, and that it flows over into outer history in lavish love for humans (1 John 3:1). God wanted to create humans in His own image (Gen. 1:26–27). So in this context, consider the following:

75. Ibid., 419.
76. *Andrews Study Bible* (Berrien Springs, MI: Andrews University Press, 2010), 6.
77. H. C. Leupold, *Exposition of Genesis* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1950), 1:42.

1. If God wanted to create humans out of His great love, why did He wait so long after He had brought forth the world?
2. Why would God create the heavens and earth (Gen. 1:1) millions or billions of years before forming and filling them (Gen. 1:3–2:25)? This seems unlike God; after all He is omnipotent (Rev. 19:6) and spoke much of creation into immediate existence in Genesis 1–2.
3. A similar question concerns the enormous length of time the Holy Spirit hovered over the unformed and unfilled heavens and earth. Why would that be necessary when God could—and did—powerfully form and fill the heavens and earth in a mere six days?
4. If the alleged deep-time of Genesis 1:1–2 explains the age of the earth as much older than a recent creation, doesn't this give theistic evolutionists the deep-time necessary to incorporate evolution?
5. If evolution is incorporated into this deep-time, how could death precede the existence of human creation (Gen. 1:26–31), for it was Adam in his fall who introduced death into the world (Rom. 5:12)?
6. God created much of creation out of nothing (Rom. 4:17b; Heb. 11:3), "God made the earth by his power; he founded the world by his wisdom and stretched out the heavens by his understanding" (Jer. 10:12). Such wisdom seems to suggest that the heavens of Genesis 1:1 were those surrounding this world, that God created earth and its heavens out of nothing; the Spirit hovered over them momentarily (ready to participate in creation), and then immediately God formed and filled the earth. It seems unwise for God to have waited millions or billions of years to continue forming and filling what He had created so long before.

The above leads me to consider that there was no gap in God's creation of this world. Naturally Scripture is the final authority to decide this question, and perhaps sufficient biblical evidence has been given above to support this tentative conclusion.

CREATIO EX NIHILO OPPOSED

Harvard University theologian Gordon Kaufman claims that the formula creation out of nothing [*creatio ex nihilo*] "is found nowhere in the Bible."[78] Critical scholar Claus Westermann states, "It is quite inappropriate to ask if P's [the alleged priestly writer in the JEDP view, which posits multiple authors of Genesis] description of creation has anything to do with *creatio ex nihilo.*" He

78. Gordon D. Kaufman, *Systematic Theology: A Historicist Perspective* (New York: Charles Scribner's, 1968), 288n1.

goes on to say, "What Gen 1 says about the creator and creation cannot simply be integrated into and subordinated to what the Bible as a whole says about the action of God."[79] This view ignores the Bible's own hermeneutic of *sola Scriptura*, and places the scholar above that inherent, and hence, divine principle. Old Testament scholar Walter Brueggemann states, "I have also heretofore concluded, along with a consensus of Old Testament scholarship, that Israel's horizon of creation is not *ex nihilo*."[80]

Philosopher of religion and science Ian Barbour has said, "Creation 'out of nothing' is not a biblical concept";[81] he suggests its origins can be found in the fourth century as a response to rival philosophies.[82] In the *Timaeus* of Plato (427–347 B.C.), Timaeus says, "God desired that all things should be good and nothing bad, so far as this was attainable. Wherefore also finding the whole visible sphere not at rest, but moving in an irregular and disorderly fashion, out of disorder he brought order."[83]

Timaeus describes creation to Socrates and Critias. He begins with the generation of the world and finishes with the creation of humankind. Timaeus was an astronomer who made the nature of the universe his special study. He related his ideas in terms of probabilities, for he was only a mortal man who believed that God is beyond discovering, and that even if He were found, it would be impossible to tell of Him to all men.[84]

Here are some of the highlights of Timaeus's presentation on creation: (1) Everything created has a cause.[85] (2) Creation was out of a pre-existing "visible sphere." Athanasius (293–373) said Plato and others "argue that God has made the world out of matter previously existing and without beginning."[86] (3) "[T]he creator compounded the world out of all the fire and all the water and all the air and all the earth."[87] (4) He "created the world a blessed god" with a soul made prior to the body.[88] (5) "The world came into being—a

79. Claus Westermann, *Genesis 1–11: A Continental Commentary*, trans. John J. Scullion, S.J. (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1994, Ger. ed. 1974), 174–175. The degree of his criticism is shown in the following: "The interpretation of this chapter has shown that church teaching on creation and the Bible must be thoroughly rethought," 173.

80. Walter Brueggemann, *Theology of the Old Testament: Testimony, Dispute, Advocacy* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1997), 529.

81. Ian G. Barbour, *Issues in Science and Religion* (New York: Harper & Row, 1971), 384.

82. Ian G. Barbour, *When Science Meets Religion: Enemies, Strangers, or Partners?* (San Francisco, CA: HarperCollins, 2000), 49.

83. Plato, *Timaeus* in *Plato: The Collected Dialogues of Plato: Including the Letters*, ed. Edith Hamilton and Huntington Cairns (Princeton, NJ: Princeton, 2002), 1162 (30a).

84. Ibid., 1161–1162 (28c, 29d).

85. Ibid., 1161 (28c).

86. Athanasius, *On The Incarnation of the Word*, New Advent, accessed July 13, 2012, http://www.newadvent.org/fathers/2802.htm.

87. Plato, *Timaeus*, in *Plato*, 1164 (32c).

88. Ibid., 1165 (34b–c).

living creature truly endowed with soul and intelligence."[89] (6) There is one world.[90] (7) This world is an image of the eternal gods.

> When the father and creator saw the creature which he had made moving and living, the created image of the eternal gods, he rejoiced, and in his joy determined to make the copy still more like the original, and as this was an eternal living being, he sought to make the universe eternal, so far as might be. Now the nature of the ideal being was everlasting, but to bestow this attribute in its fullness upon a creature was impossible. Wherefore he resolved to have a moving image of eternity, and when he set in order the heaven, he made this image eternal but moving according to number, while eternity itself rests in unity, and this image we call time.[91]

In the *Sophist* of Plato, the Stranger tells Theaetetus about a commonly held belief: "That nature gives birth to them as a result of some spontaneous cause that generates without intelligence."[92]

CREATIO EX NIHILO IS BIBLICAL

By contrast to scholars who reject creation out of nothing, Scripture proclaims that God "calls into existence the things that do not exist" (Rom. 4:17b, ESV). "By faith we understand that the universe was formed at God's command, so that what is seen was not made out of what was visible" (Heb. 11:3). Here in principle are statements that say God was not indebted to anything in order to create: His creative commands didn't depend upon anything visible or pre-existing. This should dismiss the claims of the theory of evolution, which posits that pre-existing matter (a primordial soup) is the alleged origin of all that exists. This does not discount the fact that God used dust to create a man, and a rib from Adam to create Eve.

In this biblical analysis, it is important to remember the hermeneutical principle that we interpret the unknown by what is known; or interpret the less clear by that which is clearer. It is compatible with the omnipotence of God that He can create out of nothing, and so the biblical data that speaks of this creation *ex nihilo* fit with what we already know about God. What is hard, for some, is the claimed existence of the earth (some would say the first earth) in Genesis 1:2, which implies that the Genesis 1 creation story is what A. F. Johnson calls the "reconstruction theory,"[93] or what others call the "ruin-reconstruction theory."

89. Ibid., 1163 (30b–c).

90. Ibid., 1163 (31a).

91. Ibid., 1167 (37c–e).

92. Plato, *Sophist* in *Plato*, 1013c.

93. Johnson, "Gap Theory," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 480.

"In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth" (Gen. 1:1). The Hebrew verb "create" is *bārā'*, which occurs forty-nine times in the Old Testament. It is exclusively used of God's creating, appearing most times in the qal (thirty-eight times), several times in the niphal (ten times), and once in the nominal form (*bĕrî'â*, Num. 16:30). Karl Heinz Bernhardt concludes, "As a special theological term, *bārā'* is used to express clearly the incompatibility of the creative work of God in contrast to all secondary products and likenesses made from already existing material by man."[94]

Although *bārā'* "is not a term exclusively reserved for creation out of nothing" (Wenham),[95] and although *bārā'* "does not automatically connote creation out of nothing in the context of Genesis 1, its being 'without analogy' is part of a cumulative case pointing in the direction of *creatio ex nihilo*. The idea of *creatio ex nihilo* is implied in Genesis 1:1 since no 'beginning' for God is mentioned. Thus *bārā'* is a word best suited to express the concept of creation out of nothing. In fact, no other Hebrew term would do."[96] Gerhard von Rad adds, the verb *bārā'* "contains the idea both of complete effortlessness and *creatio ex nihilo*, since it is never connected with any statement of the material."[97] Concerning the use of *bārā'*, I concur with William Shedd when he says, "Unless it be employed, creation may be used to signify 'evolution' or 'development', which is a wholly different conception. *Ex nihilo* denoted that a created thing is not produced out of existing matter of any kind whatever."[98]

In creation God spoke many things into existence (Gen. 1:3, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24, 26), "for at his command they were created" (Ps. 148:5b). This Creator "was formed long ages ago, at the very beginning, when the world came to be" (Prov. 8:23). "For by him all things were created: things in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible" (Col. 1:16a). That's why creation is a supernatural work linked to the work of salvation, "For God, who said, 'Let light shine out of darkness' [reference to Gen. 1:3], made his light shine in our hearts to give us the light of the knowledge of God's glory displayed in the face of Christ" (2 Cor. 4:6).

This means there is no dualism between God and that which is not God, between an all-powerful Creator and the universe. There are no metaphysical first principles that are co-eternal with God, independent of Him, outside of His will. Such autonomous first principles would call into question God's sovereignty over everything. Nor is there any pantheism in Scripture, for God is

94. Karl Heinz Bernhardt, "*bārā'*," in *Theological Dictionary of the Old Testament*, ed. G. Johannes Botterweck and Helmer Ringgren, trans. John T. Willis (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1983), 2:245–246.

95. Wenham, *Genesis*, vol. 1 of *Word Biblical Commentary*, 14.

96. Copan and Craig, *Creation Out of Nothing*, 58.

97. von Rad, *Genesis: A Commentary*, 47.

98. William G. T. Shedd, *Dogmatic Theology*, 3rd ed., ed. Alan W. Gomes (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 2003), 367.

distinct from creation. In Scripture creation had an absolute beginning, before which only God eternally pre-existed.

- "Before the mountains were born or you brought forth the whole world, from everlasting to everlasting you are God" (Ps. 90:2).
- "This is what the LORD says—Israel's King and Redeemer, the LORD Almighty: I am the first and I am the last: apart from me there is no God" (Isa. 44:6).
- "I am the LORD, Maker of all things, who stretches out the heavens, who spreads out the earth by myself" (Isa. 44:24b).
- "I am the first and I am the last. My own hand laid the foundations of the earth, and my right hand spread out the heavens" (Isa. 48:12b, 13a).
- "For this is what the LORD says—he who created the heavens, he is God; he who fashioned and made the earth, he founded it; he did not create it to be empty, but formed it to be inhabited—he says: 'I am the LORD, and there is no other'" (Isa. 45:18).

Creatio ex nihilo was taught by the early church fathers,[99] even though they were influenced in other ways by Greek philosophy. They focused on the distinction between God and all that is not God, and emphasized that God alone is eternal, that He created everything out of nothing. This disagreed with the Greek view that matter is eternal, which meant that there is dualism in the universe between an eternal God and eternal matter. All ANE creation stories include the idea that creation was out of something. As Irenaeus (120–202) noted, such a view of creation was taught by various Gnostic teachers for "the Creator formed the world out of previously existing matter" just like "Anaxagoras, Empedocles, and Plato expressed before them."[100] Origination out of nothing is unique to the biblical record. This is what we would expect when the Creator is unique. For the Creator is the incomparable and only God.

Process theology denies that God created out of nothing, because the world is His body, and so there is an interdependent relationship between God and the world. Apparently they must be equally eternal, or there would be a time when God did not have the world as His body. William Lane Craig correctly points out the illogical stance of Process theologians, when they deny all that classical theism teaches because they find fault in its teaching on impassability

99. For further study on second-century apologists Ignatius of Antioch, Justin Martyr, Melito of Sardis, Theophilus of Antioch, and Irenaeus of Lyons, see Peter C. Bouteneff, *Beginnings: Ancient Christian Readings of the Biblical Creation Narratives* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2008), 55–87.

100. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies*, vol. 1 in *The Ante-Nicene Fathers: Translations of the Writings of the Fathers Down to A.D. 325*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Edinburgh: T&T Clark; Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1989), 377 (2.14.4).

and immutability, with its either/or mentality. "Why could not a passible God create the world *ex nihilo*? How would the mutability of God entail the falsity of *creatio ex nihilo*?" Even if classical theism is false, Craig asks, how does that make Process theism true? Both classical and Process theism could be false and a third option true.[101]

Process theologian David Ray Griffin rightly notes that the problem of evil has done more than anything else to call into question the existence of God. How could a good and all-powerful God allow evil to be in His universe? He denies *creatio ex nihilo* on the grounds that if God created out of nothing, then the universe has no inherent power—which means that God is in absolute control and therefore responsible for the evils in the universe.[102] But a view of God who is in absolute control is not compatible with the biblical view of a Trinity in which there is eternal reciprocal love, which overflowed to create humans (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapters 8–10, 14–15). Why deny an aberration of classical theism, which teaches that God is far less loving than He really is, without doing so from Scripture? Why deny another biblical truth (*creatio ex nihilo*) in the process? Why deny the biblical view of God as Creator who is distinct from all that He created, from all that is not God? Griffin, like other Process theologians, rightly denies a nonbiblical absolute sovereignty of God that overrides the God-given freedom of created beings, but he ends up using nonbiblical views to do so, and so loses credibility by using the method (nonbiblical views) of the opponents he critiques.

For the record, creation *ex nihilo* became official church teaching at the Fourth Lateran Council (1215).

MATTER IS NOT ETERNAL

Science-based theories claim that matter originated sometime after the Big Bang. Hence, in nonbiblical views of creation, matter is eternal, and so in this respect does not differ from the eternal God. But this posits a dualism in the universe, which means life is indebted to two sources, instead of one. Not all concur with an eternal dualism, for atheistic evolutionists speak of a Big Bang—a beginning to the evolutionary process. So the process is not eternal, even though it may go back beyond this world to previous ones. Yet the Big Bang is a natural process, separate from and certainly not indebted to God. So atheists who accept evolution insist that matter was not created by God. As in its

101. William L. Craig, "Creatio ex nihilo" in *Process Theology*, ed. Ronald Nash (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1987), 149.

102. David Ray Griffin, *God and Religion in the Postmodern World: Essays in Postmodern Theology* (New York: State University, 1989), 53.

beginning, so during the entire process, atheists look to naturalism alone (not to supernaturalism) for the development of the cosmic universe and all within it.

CREATIVE COMMANDS

The fact that God created the universe by His command without any dependence on pre-existing materials (Heb. 11:3) indicates that *all that is not God* is *dependent upon God* for its existence. Without God, the universe and all in it would not exist, and would not have been sustained since its inception. A universe apart from God would be a universe without purpose, whereas a universe created by God has purpose. Creation is a demonstration that only God is God. The recurring fact in the creation record is that God spoke and His word brought things into existence. There is no dependence upon pre-existing matter in this sovereign word of God (Gen. 1:3, 6, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24, 26). This is corroborated by other texts in Scripture: "By the word of the LORD were the heavens made" (Ps. 33:6); "he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm" (Ps. 33:9); and "Let them praise the name of the LORD, for at his command they were created" (Ps. 148:5). God's spoken word brought about creation.

The Hebrew word *bārā'* is used only of God in Scripture, for only God can create in this way, without dependence upon pre-existing matter. God's work is supernatural because He is God. Therefore God's spoken word and *bārā'* indicate the uniqueness of God's creative work as Creator—the source of all reality. This is why beings around God's throne in heaven fall down before Him in worship saying, "You are worthy, our Lord and God, to receive glory and honor and power, for you created all things, and by your will they were created and have their being" (Rev. 4:11). Peters adds, "[L]ong ago by God's word the heavens came into being and the earth was formed out of water and by water" (2 Pet. 3:5).

Compared to idols, God is both Savior and Creator, and the linking of these works underlines the fact that God is such without any dependence upon anything, for both issue from the fact that He and He alone is God. The prophet Isaiah understood this. He said, "Israel will be saved by the LORD with an everlasting salvation; you will never be put to shame or disgraced, to ages everlasting. For this is what the LORD says—he who created the heavens, he is God; he who fashioned and made the earth, he founded it; he did not create it to be empty, but formed it to be inhabited—he says: 'I am the LORD, and there is no other'" (Isa. 45:17–18). The New Testament speaks of these two acts—salvation and creation—together. Consider: "Then I saw another angel flying in midair, and he had the eternal gospel to proclaim to those who live on the earth—to

every nation, tribe language and people. He said in a loud voice, 'Fear God and give him glory, because the hour of his judgment has come. Worship him who made the heavens, the earth, the sea and the springs of water'" (Rev. 14:6–7).

God speaks of His creative work to Job, asking, "Where were you when I laid the earth's foundation?" (Job 38:4a). Even though Job wasn't there, God's angels were, showing that the creation of planet earth was after the creation of angels. For while God created planet earth, "the morning stars sang together and all the angels shouted for joy" (Job 38:7). Wisdom literature speaks of "the very beginning, before the world came to be" (Prov. 8:23b), and then moves forward to the creation of the world, at which point wisdom is personified as being present during creation: "I was there when he set the heavens in place, when he marked out the horizon on the face of the deep, when he established the clouds above and fixed securely the fountains of the deep, when he gave the sea its boundary so the waters would not overstep his command, and when he marked out the foundations of the earth" (Prov. 8:27–29).

LITERARY FRAMEWORK HYPOTHESIS

In recent years the Framework hypothesis (also referred to as the historico-artistic hypothesis) has become popular among Evangelical scholars. It claims that the seven-day week in Genesis 1 is a literary device that isn't literal or chronological. As Henri Blocher explains:

> The author's intention is not to supply us with a chronology of origins. It is possible that the logical order he has chosen coincides broadly with the actual sequence of the facts of cosmogony; but that does not interest him. He wishes to bring out certain themes and provide a theology of the sabbath. The text is composed as the author meditates on the finished work, so that we may understand how the creation is related to God and what is its significance for mankind.[103]

Blocher understands the week of Genesis 1:2—2:2 as a wise and admirable literary device that acts as a frame for the contents given[104] and commends itself far more than a "reconstructionist theory,"[105] a "concordist interpretation,"[106] or a "literal interpretation."[107] He argues, "The use of the anthropomorphic figure of the week for the logic of creation and of its completion allowed the author to outline a theology of the sabbath. That was the theme closest to his

103. Henri Blocher, *In the Beginning: The Opening Chapters of Genesis*, trans. David G. Preston (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1984, 1st French ed. 1979), 50.

104. Ibid., 49–59.

105. Ibid., 41–43. The days of Genesis 1 are not days of creation, but days of reconstruction, to restore the original after the earth became "formless and empty" (NIV; Heb. *tōhû wābōhû*, Gen 1:2).

106. Ibid., 43–46. The Hebrew word for day (*yôm*) isn't literal, and so is open to the deep-time of evolutionary theory.

107. Ibid., 46–49.

heart. The narrative has two peaks, mankind and the sabbath. This would be better expressed by saying that the creation of mankind crowns the work, but the sabbath is its supreme goal."[108]

However, this "logic" is meaningless, because if, as he asserts, the days are not literal, then there is no literal Sabbath. By contrast, God's intent in consecutive creation days was to focus on the importance of the Sabbath as a literal seventh day, at the end of a literal week, which is the way Christ interprets creation week in the Sabbath command (Exod. 20:4–11). When the Creator-Christ blessed the seventh day (Gen. 2:3), that act was just as specific as the blessings of the sea and air animals to multiply (Gen. 1:22) and of humans to multiply and subdue the world (Gen. 1:28). In other words, the blessing has a continuity, which offspring testify to around the world, and which the Sabbath testifies to each week. The Framework hypothesis fails to take into consideration what the Sabbath blessing means in the light of the other two blessings specified in Genesis 1.

But Blocher is not alone in his support of the Framework hypothesis. For example, Bruce Waltke's book *Genesis: A Commentary* considers the creation account as having a theological agenda rather than a historical (chronological) agenda.[109] Mark Ross also speaks of the Framework hypothesis as an organizing principle that is topical and not chronological. He notes that friend and foe alike consider Genesis 1:1–2:3 to be figurative, metaphorical, poetic, and non-literal.[110] Some who propound the Framework hypothesis do so on the grounds of alleged metaphorical language used in the creation account. For example, they claim that days one through three of creation, being prior to the creation of the luminaries, are metaphorical and not literal days, because they could not have a literal evening and morning. But there were no functioning luminaries during the darkness plague in Egypt, yet the same author of Genesis (Moses) comments on the darkness: "No one could see anyone else or leave his place for three days" (Exod. 10:23a). If you can have three literal days of darkness in Exodus, why not in the creation record?[111]

Recently, the book *The Genesis Debate: Three Views on the Days of Creation* presented evidence for the Literal Twenty-Four-Hour Day theory (J. Ligon Duncan III, David W. Hall), the Day-Age theory (Hugh Ross, Gleason L. Archer), and the Framework view (Lee Irons, Meredith G. Kline). The six scholars presented and

108. Ibid., 57.

109. Bruce K. Waltke with Cathi J. Fredricks, *Genesis: A Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2001), 78.

110. Mark Ross, "The Framework Hypothesis: An Interpretation of Genesis 1:1–2:3" in *Did God Create in Six Days?*, 2nd ed., ed. Joseph A. Pipa, Jr. and David W. Hall (White Hall, WV: Tolle Lege Press, 2005), 114.

111. This point is well made by Joseph A. Pipa, Jr., "From Chaos to Cosmos: A Critique of the Non-Literal Interpretations of Genesis 1:1–2:3," in *Did God Create in Six Days?*, ed. Joseph A. Pipa, Jr. and David W. Hall (Taylors, SC: Southern Presbyterian, 1999), 167.

defended their views while critiquing the other two views, and providing a helpful resource for examining this matter in more detail. Framework theorists believe in an old or a young earth, but refuse to speak where Scripture doesn't speak (on the age of the earth). They claim that creation days are like "picture frames." The data in each frame is literal history, but the "real theological message has been drowned out by its alleged sequential and chronological message." This includes losing sight of the covenantal aspect of the narrative.[112]

Augustine of Hippo (354–430), Anselm of Canterbury (1033–1109), and Peter Lombard (ca. 1100–1160) taught that Genesis was a nonliteral creation account. Irons and Kline distinguish between nonliteral and non-historical. For them the events are historical, but they are placed in a literary framework in a topical or nonsequential order.[113] Irons and Kline see the days of creation in a framework of two triads, the first giving created kingdoms, the second the creature kings over these kingdoms, and the climax is "the Creator King enthroned in His heavenly Sabbath rest over all creation."[114]

Creation Kingdoms		**Creature Kings**	
Day 1	Light	*Day 4*	Luminaries
Day 2	Sky	*Day 5*	Sea creatures
	Seas		Winged creatures
Day 3	Dry land	*Day 6*	Land animals
	Vegetation		Man

The Creator King

Day 7 Sabbath[115]

The luminaries rule over day and night (Gen. 1:16), and all created things receive a mandate ("Be fruitful and increase in number") and in that way rule the appropriate sphere in which they are placed, with humans given a mandate to have dominion over them all (Gen. 1:26, 28). "Finally, all the kingdoms of creation and their creature kings are subordinated as vassals of their Creator King on the seventh day."[116] Irons and Kline point out that the triads end up with trees (first triad) and with man (second triad), which prepares the reader for Genesis 3 where man takes fruit from the forbidden tree. They see a chiastic relationship between days two and five—where sea creatures are linked to the

112. Lee Irons with Meredith G. Kline, "The Framework View" in *The Genesis Debate: Three Views on the Days of Creation*, ed. David G. Hagopian (Mission Viejo, CA: Crux, 2001), 218.
113. Ibid., 219–221.
114. Ibid., 224.
115. Ibid.
116. Ibid., 225–226.

sky, and birds are linked to the sea—and a parallelism structure between days one and four. They believe that having light (day one) and luminaries (day four) structurally placed together is more logical than having God repeat on day four (giving light) what He did on day one.[117]

After going through a number of arguments, they favor the Framework hypothesis. Irons and Kline conclude, "Hampered by the unexamined assumption that the text addresses the earthly sequence and chronology of origins, the 24-hour and day-age views fail to grasp the overriding theological message of the text."[118] Proponents of each of the three views claim to believe in biblical inerrancy. So Norman Geisler writes in the foreword of the book, "[T]he creation-day debate is not over the *inspiration* of the Bible, but over its *interpretation*."[119] And so the book offers three ways of interpreting the data. Obviously, they cannot all be right, so to determine which view is correct, I suggest allowing Scripture to interpret itself *(sola-tota-prima Scriptura)*. This means we must examine all the relevant data in Scripture beyond the Genesis account that can provide an inspired commentary of the Genesis account; from that perspective we can check the relevancy of these three conflicting interpretations.

Scripture tells us that God created everything through His Son (John 1:1–3; Col. 1:15–16; Heb. 1:1–2). On Mount Sinai the Law was given to Moses, and Christ wrote it with His own finger (Exod. 24:12; 31:8; 32:15–16; cf. Deut. 4:13b). After the tables were broken because of the golden calf worship (Exod. 32:19), God rewrote on new tables of stone the same words that were on the old tables (Exod. 34:1), and also apparently wrote on the tables the law as given in Deuteronomy 5 (v. 22). The first rendition of the fourth commandment written by God said, "Remember the Sabbath day by keeping it holy. Six days you shall labor and do all your work, but the seventh day is a sabbath to the LORD your God.... For in six days the LORD made the heavens and the earth, the sea, and all that is in them, but he rested on the seventh day. Therefore the LORD blessed the Sabbath day and made it holy" (Exod. 20:8–10a, 11). God reminded the Jews that after their return from Babylonian captivity, the gate facing east of the inner court of the temple would be shut on the six working days but open on the seventh-day Sabbath (Ezek. 46:1).

As noted above, these words are Christ's words, and are the original autograph of the commandments—and thus they are important to those professing belief in the inerrancy of Scripture. Christ also said to His Father "everything is possible for you" (Mark 14:36; Luke 1:37), for God is omnipotent and therefore could have

117. Ibid., 228–230.
118. Ibid., 252.
119. Norman L. Geisler, foreword to *Genesis Debate*, 11.

spoken everything into existence instantaneously. The fact that God created everything in six days was to introduce His sacred Sabbath as the seventh, or last, day of that week. There is no other reason given in Scripture. The sequential chronological presentation of that week had everything to do with the Sabbath, and so creation week had a theological purpose. This theological meaning is understood when we realize that the first full day of life for Adam and Eve was a Sabbath rest spent with Christ, which is the essence of the Gospels: resting in Christ before a full week of work.

Even on the basis of the Framework hypothesis, if the Creator King rules over all "enthroned in His royal Sabbath rest," shouldn't those ruled over recognize the Creator-Christ's authority as ruler by remembering His sacred Sabbath that He blessed at the end of creation week (Gen. 2:2)? It cannot be stressed too much that the fourth commandment is Christ's divine authoritative commentary on creation week, and shows that He considered creation week to be sequential and chronological. He also added: "The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath. So the Son of Man is Lord even of the Sabbath" (Mark 2:27–28). In other words, Christ said the Sabbath was His gift to humankind, for their benefit, and Christ is Lord of the Sabbath—it is the Lord's day. No wonder Christ makes the appeal, "If you love me, keep my commands" (John 14:15).

In this case allowing Scripture to interpret Scripture is actually allowing Christ to interpret the creation account. Who else is more qualified to do so? Certainly He was there and knew what transpired and why. Here is the bottom line: Christ's is a commentary on the creation account that every Christian will want to ponder. For it was given by our Creator-Redeemer, which means the seventh-day creation Sabbath is Christian, given long before the Jews entered human history.

Christ's interpretation of creation week as literal days is overlooked (even if unwittingly) by Christian theologians. For example, the English Standard Version Study Bible states that the words about blessing the Sabbath in Genesis 2:3 "provide the basis for the obligation that God placed on the Israelites to rest from their normal labor on the Sabbath day" and references the fourth commandment (Exod. 20:8–11, ESV).[120] I would argue that the Sabbath did have relevance to the Jews, but no more than it had relevance to Adam and Eve, who were non-Jews, and who were the first of the human race. There is a disconnect when the Sabbath is confined to one segment of human history, when actuality it was given to the human race as a whole at the beginning of human history. If God never changes (Mal. 3:6), and "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8), and the Sabbath is still holy for the Redeemed in the new earth (Isa. 66:22–23), then the Sabbath

120. *ESV Study Bible* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2008), 52.

must reach from the original creation into the new creation, connecting it to humanity in the beginning and to the redeemed forever. (This is far more expansive than delimiting the Sabbath to a comparatively small span of time occupied by the Israelites.)

CONTRIBUTION OF THE HEBREW *WAW CONSECUTIVE*

According to Hebrew grammar, the *waw consecutive* means "what is now added is the *result* or sequence of the preceding."[121] This rule is helpful in two ways when considering the creation record: (1) With respect to Genesis 1–11, Old Testament scholar Walter Kaiser points out the creation account is prose and not poetry, indicated by a number of factors, including the "use of the *waw* consecutive with the verb to describe sequential acts." Hence the "spreading out of these events in a sequential order indicates that we are in prose and not in poetry. Say what *we* will, the author plainly intends to be doing the same thing in these chapters that he is doing in chapters 12–50."[122] (2) With reference to those thinking Genesis 2 has a different sequence than Genesis 1 (e.g., humans mentioned last in Genesis 1, and first in Genesis 2), Joseph Pipa rightly points out the use of the *waw consecutive* (pluperfect) refers to "logically anterior circumstances," so that animals were created before man. For example, "Now the Lord God had formed out of the ground all the wild animals and all the birds in the sky. He brought them to the man to see what he would name them" (Gen. 2:19).[123] So there is no conflict between the prose of Genesis 1–11 and the prose of Genesis 12–50, and there is no conflict between the sequence of animals/humans in Genesis 1 and 2.

CREATION AND TIME

There are far more ways of interpreting creation days than those we will consider below, but these examples should give the teader an idea of the confusion that arises when the literal meaning of Scripture is rejected. The data below present biblical evidence for a literal creation account. Although the six days of creation and the seventh day are considered, it is the putpose of this segment to answer doubts that creation days are literal twenty-four-hour periods. In other

121. A. B. Davidson, *An Introductory Hebrew Grammar* (Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1951, 1st ed. 1874), 84. See also Kautzsch and Cowley, eds., *Gesenius' Hebrew Grammar*, 20th ed., 61. (I found this sentence in the 20th edition [1909]; in it he calls it "Vav Convetsive" instead of "waw consecutive." I checked every edition all the way to the 26th edition [1966]; they changed the name to "waw consecutive" but did not include the quote.)

122. Walter Kaiser Jr., "The Literary Form of Genesis 1–11" in *New Perspectives on the Old Testament*, ed. J. Barton Payne (Waco, TX: Word, 1970), 59–60.

123. Joseph A. Pipa Jr., "From Chaos to Cosmos," in *Did God Create in Six Days?* (1999). 157.

words, from a biblical perspective, this segment attempts to counter the deep-time theory of evolution.

INSTANTANEOUS

The debate over the length of creation days goes back at least to Origen (ca. 185–254).[124] Hilary of Poitiers (300–367) in his *De Trinitate* said that the "creation of the heaven and earth and other elements is not separated by the slightest interval in God's working, since their preparation had been completed in like infinity of eternity in the counsel of God."[125]

Augustine of Hippo (354–430) wrestled with philosophical concepts of God's timelessness and immutability, and how in this context one should understand God's creation which suggests time (a beginning) and a change (making a new reality). He said, "[A]ssuredly the world was made, not in time, but simultaneously with time," but the result was puzzling to him. For example, if creation days are somehow related to timelessness, what are they? He concluded, "What kind of days these were it is extremely difficult, or perhaps impossible for us to conceive, and how much more to say!"[126] He ended up saying the days of creation were "the same 'one' day," and other Latin theologians followed him in this. In other words, creation was accomplished instantaneously.[127] Augustine's timeless God is "ever-standing eternity" compared to times that never stand. Eternal means "the whole is present,"[128] an "ever-present eternity."[129] He refers to God as "Thou, to whom nothing is future,"[130] for He is "unchangeably eternal."[131] So, for Augustine, the God of simultaneity created instantaneously, but logically that one instant act was forever present to Him from eternity.[132] Anselm of

124. In *On First Principles*, *The Anti-Nicene Fathers*, 4:359, 365, Origen viewed meaning on three levels (equivalent to humans): body, soul, and spirit. The body is the literal interpretation, and the spirit the spiritual interpretation (4.1.11); he gives a spiritual or figurative interpretation to creation days and the Garden of Eden (4.1.16). Origen thought it "foolish" to suppose God "planted a paradise in Eden" and that eating from one tree brought life and eating from the other brought evil, 4.1.16.

125. Hilary, *De Trinitate, Nicene Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, 9:228 (12.40).

126. Augustine, *The City of God, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 2:208 (11.6).

127. Augustine believed God "made a heaven before all days," and *spoke* of later days of creation, *The Confessions, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 1:178 (128.8). But he qualifies what he means by days of creation as follows: "There is no question, then, that if the angels are included in the works of God during these six days, they are that light which was called 'Day,' and whose unity Scripture signalizes by calling that day not the 'first day,' but 'one day.' For the second day, the third, and the rest are not other days; but the same 'one' day," *The City of God, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 2:210 (11.9).

128. Augustine, *The Confessions, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 1.167 (11.11.13).

129. Ibid., 1:168 (11.13.16).

130. Ibid., 1:170 (11.19.25).

131. Ibid., 1.175 (11.31.41).

132. Ibid., 1:170 (11.19.26), where he describes past, present, and future for a timeless God as "a present of things past, a present of things present, and a present of things future."

Canterbury (1033–1109) wrote that "the whole creation took place at once, and those days in which Moses appears to describe a successive creation are not to be understood like such days as ours."[133] Augustine's instantaneous creation was the view of the Lateran Council held in 1215.[134]

Origen, Hilary, Augustine, and Anselm are examples of theologians who fail to read creation days as literal days. They did not arrive at their conclusion through exegesis of the biblical text; rather, they brought to the text a spiritual interpretation (Origen) and a timeless worldview (Hilary, Augustine, Anselm), thus allowing this extraneous data to influence their understanding of the biblical text. Hence there is a long tradition that questions the literal days of creation.

ONE THOUSAND YEARS

Some scholars cite the Psalmist on "creation time" (Ps. 90:1–4) as if a creation day is a thousand years. But the Hebrew says, "for a thousand years in your eyes is *like* [Heb. *bĕ*] a day of yesterday gone by…[and like] in the night watch" (my own translation, v. 4). The word *day* is "like" a thousand years and a night watch (a segment of the night). Old Testament scholar Gerhard Hasel makes this insightful comment:

> From the point of view of Hebrew syntax, the comparative particle serves not only the expression "yesterday" but also the phrase "as a watch in the night," demonstrating that the comparison is not between a "day" being like 1,000 years. A thousand years with God are "like" yesterday, that is, the past day, or "like" "a watch in the night," even a briefer period of time than "yesterday." The point is that God reckons time differently than the way humans do.[135]

Hasel's further commentary can be summarized as follows:

- Genesis 1 has no interest in how God defines time. Rather, it presents creation time.
- Genesis 1 does not use any comparative particle, such as *like/as*, in connection with the word *day*.
- Genesis 1 gives us the seven-day week, which is literal time.
- Genesis 1 uses a "day" that is not defined by Psalm 90:4.
- 2 Peter 3:8 means that God is not limited by time to fulfill His promises, and the text is not related to creation.[136]

133. Anselm, *Cur Deus Homo*, 1:18.

134. Robert Jenson, *The Works of God*, vol. 2 in *Systematic Theology* (New York: Oxford, 1999), 6.

135. Gerhard F. Hasel, "The 'Days' of Creation in Genesis 1," in *Creation, Catastrophe and Calvary: Why a Global Flood Is Vital to the Doctrine of Atonement*, ed. John Templeton Baldwin (Hagerstown, MD: Review and Herald, 2000), 45–46.

136. Ibid., 46–47.

Terence Fretheim states that "*the word 'day' in the singular is probably never used in the Old Testament for a long period of time.* Given the more than 2200 references, this is striking. It is the plural form 'days' that is sometimes used with reference to a period of time."[137]

DAY-AGES

Many biblical scholars believe God took long periods of time to create, thus allegedly bringing the biblical account into harmony with evolutionary deep-time. They come to Scripture with a Concordist mind-set: attempting to preserve Scripture from being at odds with God's "book" of nature. They want to find harmony between the two, for God is the author of both. Many of these apologists have a mission to protect Scripture from unnecessary criticism so for them, the days of creation are not literal days, but day-ages, each one representing deep-time in which God accomplished His creative work (see footnote for different interpretations).[138] But one has to ask why the record is given in such specificity, noting "evening" and "morning" (Gen. 1:5b, 8, 13, 19, 23, 31) as indicators of the length of creation days. Why not allow the hermeneutical principle of the literal usage of language to indicate authorial intent? We would expect that days described as having an evening and a morning are literal, twenty-four-hour solar days? We assume that these biblical scholars would want to use this hermeneutical principle in other parts of Scripture, so why not in the creation record?

To set aside the literal meaning of language, even with the best of intentions, is to import into the text a meaning that is foreign to the text. This is akin to a reader-response hermeneutic, in which the meaning of a text is supplied by the reader and not by the author.

REVELATORY DAYS

Others consider that the creation days don't refer to God's acts of creation during those days, but to God's revelation of what He did in His creative acts. In his book *Creation Revealed in Six Days*, P. J. Wiseman refers to these days as six days of revelation rather than six days of creation. He said his task is to try "to find out how the *account* of creation came into existence, not how the

137. Terence E. Fretheim, "Were the Days of Creation Twenty-Four Hours Long?" in *The Genesis Debate: Persistent Questions about Creation and the Flood*, rev. ed., ed. Ronald Youngblood (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1990), 17.

138. There are a number of versions of the day-ages theory. Three of them include: (1) day-geological age, with different geological eras represented by each day; (2) modified intermittent day, where a twenty-four-hour-day precedes each geological era, and (3) overlapping day-age where each creative era is delimited by the words, "There was evening and there was morning." See P. P. T. Pun, "Evolution," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 417.

universe came to be."[139] He referred to Christ's words that the Sabbath was made for the benefit of humans (Mark 2:27), and thus he reasoned that the recital of creation of a six-day period was also for the benefit of humans.[140] "The creation narrative is a statement of what God said to man about the things He had created.... On each of the six days God told man about some aspect of His creative work, much of which had been accomplished in the long ages past."[141]

D. F. Payne of the University of Sheffield, England, delivered a lecture to the Tyndale Fellowship for Biblical Research at Cambridge University in July 1962. He pointed out a linguistic challenge faced by the revelatory days thesis: In the fourth commandment it says "in six days the Lord made (Heb. *ʿāśâ*), and how can that mean 'reveal'? Furthermore there isn't a hint that God is speaking to anyone in the creation record (Gen 1). When God blesses Adam and Eve, telling them to be fruitful and rule the earth (Gen 1:28), He is not revealing to them something that happened long ago, as is true of the blessing He gave to the sky and water creatures (Gen 1:22). Nor does God name any individual to whom He may be talking in the verse: 'This is the account of the heavens and the earth when they were created' (Gen 2:4)."[142]

TWENTY-FOUR-HOUR DAYS

Biblical Use of the Hebrew Word for Day *(yôm)*

Some scholars question whether the creation days are actually twenty-four hours in length. They rightly note that the Hebrew word for day (*yôm*) can represent various lengths, just like the English word *day*. For example, we can speak of "the day when a certain king ruled," where *day* means a time of greater duration than twenty-four hours. This isn't difficult because context determines authorial intent, and clearly the addition of "evening and morning" to the days of Genesis 1 means creation days of twenty-four hours in length.

Robert McCabe, professor of Old Testament at Detroit Baptist Theological Seminary, gives five reasons for the literal days of creation:

1. When the Hebrew word for day (*yôm*) "is used in the singular and is not part of a compound grammatical construction, it is consistently

139. P. J. Wiseman, *Creation Revealed in Six Days: The Evidence of Scripture Confirmed by Archaeology* (Edinburgh: Morgan & Scott, 1949, 1st ed. 1948), 10.

140. Ibid., 37, 39.

141. Ibid., 124; see also 40.

142. D. F. Payne, *Genesis One Reconsidered* (London: Tyndale, 1964), 8.

used in reference to a literal day of 24 hours or a portion thereof."[143] *Yôm* never refers "to an extended period of time involving more than a 24-hour day."[144]

2. Numeric qualifiers ("first day," "second day," Gen. 1:4, 8, 13, 19, 24, 31) and sequential numbering suggest an ordinary day.[145]
3. "Evening" and "morning," used with *yôm* (nineteen times besides the six in Genesis 1) or used without *yôm* (thirty-eight times), "are used consistently in reference to literal days."[146]
4. The use of *yôm* (as mentioned above) is consistent throughout Scripture (*sola Scriptura* hermeneutical principle). The two passages on the observance of the Sabbath (Exod. 20:8–11; 31:14–17) "cogently reinforce a literal interpretation of the days in the creation week." The seventh-day Sabbath follows six other literal days.[147]
5. The events in sequence do not make sense if creation days were day-ages. For example, some plants are dependent upon insects for pollination, and insects were not created until the sixth day. This symbiotic relationship requires literal days. Furthermore, if the days were days-ages, and because the days were comprised of light and dark periods (evening and morning), then the dark periods would make survival of plants and animals impossible.[148]

Opponents of literal creation days point to Genesis 2:4 in which the singular form of *yôm* refers to the whole week of creation. The Hebrew Bible reads: "This is the account of God's (*Elohim*) creation of the heavens and the earth, the day (*yôm*) God (*Yahweh Elohim*) created." "The day" in this verse is different from the single days in the creation verses, for it includes all of them. "Days" (referring to days one through six) are singular absolute nouns, whereas the "day" (Gen. 2:4) is a singular construct noun, for it "appears in a compound grammatical construction." The singular days of creation are simple nouns, whereas Genesis 2:4 "forms a temporal idiomatic construction" (in-the-day-of-making), which is equivalent to the word "when" in these versions: King James Version, New King James Version, New English Bible, New International Version, Revised Standard Version, and the Amplified Bible.[149]

143. Robert V. McCabe, "A Defense of Literal Days in the Creation Week," *Detroit Baptist Seminary Journal* 5 (Fall 2000): 102.
144. Ibid., 104.
145. Ibid.
146. Ibid., 105–106. Andrew Steinman argues that the creation days in the Genesis account are "regular solar days," *Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society*, 45/4 (December 2002): 584.
147. McCabe, "Defense of Literal Days," *Detroit Baptist Seminary Journal*, 110–111.
148. Ibid., 112.
149. Ibid., 117.

This distinction is apparently overlooked by theologian Wayne Grudem in his interpretation of the Genesis creation record: "In favor of viewing the six days as long periods of time is the fact that the Hebrew word *yôm*, 'day,' is sometimes used to refer not to a twenty-four-hour literal day, but to a longer period of time. We see this when the word is used in Genesis 2:4, for example: 'In the *day* that the LORD God made the earth and the heavens,' a phrase that refers to the entire creative work of the six days of creation."[150]

If creation-days are literal days, then the words "God said" (Gen. 1:3, 6, 9, 14, 20, 24) make sense, for speaking would not require a long period of time. Furthermore, for all but one of the creation days when "God said," the words that follow are "and it was so," suggesting instantaneous response. That's why God could say each day that the new created reality was "good" (Gen. 1:3, 10, 13, 19, 20, 24). On the sixth day "God saw all that he had made, and it was very good" (Gen. 1:31). So creation days are literal/historical, continuous, contiguous, twenty-four-hour periods of time. The creation record is a literal, historical account, in harmony with the rest of this book on beginnings, and reveals the method God used in creation: He commanded and it was so.

To think God needed long periods of time to create calls into question His power, for He is all powerful. Jeremiah exclaimed, "Ah, Sovereign LORD, you have made the heavens and the earth by your great power and outstretched arm. Nothing is too hard for you" (Jer. 32:17); and Jesus declared, "with God all things are possible" (Matt. 19:26b). For God not to exercise His awesome power in creation would call into question His wisdom. These are compelling reasons why the days should be considered literal.

Evidence for twenty-four-hour days in the creation week is found in Deuteronomy 4:32. Consider the temporal phrase "since the day that God created man on the earth" (ESV), which was the sixth day (Gen. 1:27–31). "This same phrase appears twenty-three times in the Old Testament and clearly refers to a normal 24 hour day."[151]

The normal meaning of the Hebrew word *yôm* (day), occurring 2,225 times, is usually a literal day; and the plural *yāmîm* (days), occurring 608 times, is always a twenty-four-hour day. So the preponderant meaning is a literal, twenty-four-hour day. As noted previously, the use of the words "there was evening and there was morning" (Gen. 1:5b, 8b, 13b, 19, 23, 31b) corroborate the literal interpretation. The creation of the sun to rule the day and the moon to rule the night on the fourth day (Gen. 1:16–18) requires that

150. Wayne Grudem, *Systematic Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1994), 293.
151. See Andrew S. Kulikovsky, *Creation, Fall, Restoration: A Biblical Theology of Creation* (Ross–Shire, Scotland: Mentor, 2009), 163.

the days be literal.[152] The one day God blessed is called the "seventh day" by Christ (Gen. 2:2–3).

Opponents of literal creation days claim that it was impossible to do all that Scripture says was done on day six, since it would have taken longer than one literal day. The answer to that is simple: God's omnipotence. He can do anything He wishes to do in that time frame; God brought some of the animals (cattle, beasts of the field, and all birds) to Adam, and this perfect human with God-given ability to rule over this world named the prototypes, from which all the rest have come subsequently. (Adam did not name creatures "'that move along the ground' [Gen 1:24] and the sea creatures [Gen 1:20]."[153]) If Moses had intended to mean "day-age," instead of a "twenty-four-hour period," he would have used the Hebrew term *ʿôlām* instead of *yôm*.[154]

Day Seven: Literal or Not?

Robert Newman and Herman Eckelmann in their book *Genesis One and the Origin of the Earth* note the seventh day of creation makes no mention of "evening and morning"; as a result, they believe the seventh day is different from the other six days (a view held by many scholars), just as Christ's blood in the communion is different from His blood at Calvary, and our baptism is different from Christ's. Furthermore they find it persuasive that the Jubilee Sabbath was not a twenty-four-hour Sabbath but a duration up to one year (Lev. 25:8–17). Hence, they claim the Sabbath command (Exod. 20:8–11) isn't a valid way to prove the literal seven-day week. They claim such reasoning is an argument of analogy instead of an argument of identity.[155]

The non-use of *evening and morning* for day seven doesn't suggest it is a time of longer duration, simply because the phrase *evening and morning* is missing. There would be no meaning to the Sabbath command if it was a day-age (in deep-time, a geological day), for that would arguably be longer than the history of humans. Such a command would question the wisdom of God. However, the biblical command is about a weekly Sabbath (Exod. 20:8–11). McCabe points out the distinction between creation days and the Sabbath day. The phrase *evening and morning* is a transitional formula, for each creation day was followed immediately by another creation day. There is no need of this formula for the

152. For first three, see Robert Reymond, *A New Systematic Theology of the Christian Faith*, 2nd ed. (Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 1998), 393–394.

153. McCabe, "Defense of Literal Days," *Detroit Baptist Seminary Journal*, 120–122.

154. Reymond, *New Systematic Theology*, 393–394. Reymond also gives six other reasons why the creation days are literal, twenty-four-hour days.

155. Robert C. Newman and Herman J. Eckelmann, Jr., *Genesis One and the Origin of the Earth* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1977), 61–63.

seventh day, for the creation is complete. The acts of creation are given each day prior to the formula.[156]

C. F. Keil (and Delitzsch) believe Genesis is "a historical document" and therefore "as the six creation-days, according to the words of the text, were earthly days of ordinary duration, we must understand the seventh in the same way."[157] The fourth commandment (Exod. 20:8–11) presents the seven days of creation week as literal, which makes the Sabbath command meaningful. Framework hypothesis proponents dismiss the seventh day as literal because it lacks the phrase *evening and morning*. They suggest it represents God's eternal rest. But "God does not bless his eternal rest, but he blesses a day (2:3)."[158]

Ivan Blazen argues:

> The fact that only the seventh day of creation week lacks the formula "There was evening and there was morning, the seventh day," suggests that the seventh day as God's rest is of permanent significance. Creation week does not close with the creation of human beings, but with God's rest. As God and his activity is the subject of the six days, so God and his rest is the subject of the seventh day. The account is theocentric, and it is precisely this emphasis that is of perpetual significance. Humans lose their humanity when God is not the center of their lives and the subject of their praise.[159]

Terence Fretheim declares, "To suggest that the seventh day is an indeterminate period of time because evening and morning are not mentioned flies in the face of clear evidence to the contrary. In Genesis 2:3 God blesses and hallows that day, clearly indicating that it is a specified day that is set aside as a special holy day."[160]

Creation week is the origin of the weekly cycle. The year is linked to the sun's cycle and the month to the moon's cycle, but the week has nothing in nature to which it is linked. The weekly cycle depends on the creation week for its origin. So the week depends upon the literal seven days of creation.

Scholars Supporting Literal Creation Days

Many scholars and theologians of note have supported the view that the days of creation are literal days. Thomas Aquinas (1225–1274) believed in the six days of creation.[161] Martin Luther (1483–1546) rejected Augustine and Hilary's view that equated six creation days with "instantaneous" creation. He declares that "we assert that Moses spoke in the literal sense, not allegorically or figuratively, i.e., that the

156. McCabe, "Defense of Literal Days," *DBSJ*, 114–115.

157. Keil and Delitzsch, *The Pentateuch*, vol. 1 of *Commentary on the Old Testament*, 37, 69.

158. Joseph A. Pipa Jr., "From Chaos to Cosmos," in *Did God Create in Six Days?* (2005), 167.

159. Ivan T. Blazen, "Theological Concerns of Genesis 1:1–23," in *Understanding Genesis: Contemporary Adventist Perspectives* (Riverside, CA: Adventist Today Foundations, 2006), 81.

160. Fretheim, "Were the Days of Creation Twenty-Four Hours Long?" in *The Genesis Debate*, 17.

161. Aquinas speaks of the days of creation in his *Summa Theologica*, trans. Fathers of the English Dominican Province (Westminster, MD: Christian Classics, 1981), 1:328–359 (66.1–74.30).

world, with all its creatures, was created within six days, as the words read." Luther holds that "the six days were truly six natural days."[162] John Calvin (1509–1564) opposed the idea of God's having created "in a moment." "God himself took the space of six days, for the purpose of accommodating his works to the capacity of men."[163]

Francis Turretin (1623–1687) rejected Augustine's "single moment" creation, saying, "in the fourth commandment (recommending the sanctification of the seventh day), God is said to have been engaged in creation six days and to have rested on the seventh (so that by this example the people might be induced to rest on the seventh day). This reason would have had no weight, if God had created all things in a single moment."[164]

Keil and Delitzsch note "that the different days [of creation] arose from the constant recurrence of evening and morning,...if the days of creation are regulated by the recurring interchange of light and darkness, they must be regarded not as periods of time of incalculable duration, of years or thousands of years, but as simple earthly days."[165] Herman Bavinck (1854–1921) offers this assessment:

> The first chapter of Genesis, however, hardly contains any ground for the opinion that we are dealing here with a vision or myth. It clearly bears a historical character and forms the introduction to a book that presents itself from beginning to end as history. Nor is it possible to separate the facts (the religious content) from the manner in which they are expressed. For if with Lagrange, for example, the creation itself is regarded as a fact, but the days of creation as form and mode of expression, then the entire order in which the creation came into being collapses, and we have removed the foundation for the institution of the week and the Sabbath, which according to Exodus 20:11 is most decidedly grounded in the six-day period of creation and the subsequent Sabbath of God.[166]

Louis Berkhof (1873–1957) considered the creation days to be literal because that was the normal meaning of the word *day* and because the days were qualified by "evening and the morning." He also believed that the seventh day was equally literal.[167] Karl Barth said the following about creation days:

> God has made and given to us a day which is not of a thousand years' duration but of twenty-four hours. It is certainly as such that the biblical authors understand the ensuing days of creation up to the seventh day, the day of God's rest. We only cloud the picture, involving it in dreadful and not very helpful confusion, if for the clear concept day we try to substitute an indeterminate and immense period of time under cover of which astronomical light-years and geological periods can be introduced for apologetic purposes.... God created time: not just time in general, but our time, the actual time in which each creature actually lives; or concretely time as a unit, i.e., the day, and time as a sequence, i.e., the week; and that He created it by giving to light the name day.[168]

162. Martin Luther, *Lectures on Genesis 1–5*, vol. 1 of *Luther's Works*, 4–5. Cf. "the six days were truly six natural days," 69.

163. John Calvin, *Genesis*, vol. 1 of *Calvin's Commentaries*, trans. John King (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1989), 78.

164. Francis Turretin, *Institutes of Elenctic Theology*, ed. James T. Dennison, Jr., trans. George Musgrave Giger (Phillipsburg, NJ: Presbyterian & Reformed, 1992), 1:444–445.

165. Keil and Delitzsch, *The Pentateuch*, vol. 1 of *Commentary on the Old Testament*, 50–51.

166. Herman Bavinck, *God and Creation*, vol. 2 in *Reformed Dogmatics*, trans. John Vriend (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2004), 499.

167. Louis Berkhof, *Systematic Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1996, 1st ed. 1932), 1:154–155.

We will end this discussion with three contemporary scholars. Gordon Wenham, commenting on the Hebrew word day (*yôm*) in Genesis 1, writes, "There can be little doubt that here 'day' has its basic sense of a 24-hour period. The mention of morning and evening, the enumeration of the days, and the divine rest on the seventh show that a week of divine activity is being described here."[169] Victor Hamilton also speaks of the "six days of divine activity" in Genesis 1.[170]

Robert L. Reymond rightly comments: "To call into question the historical reliability of Genesis 1 and 2 is to call into question the trustworthiness of the entirety of Scripture testimony on the issue." He then cites biblical texts that refer to creation as literal. These texts are: Exodus 20:11; 31:17; Deuteronomy 4:32; Psalms 33:6; 90:2; 136:5–9; 148:2–5; Isaiah 40:25–26; 42:5; 44:24; 45:12; 48:13; 51:13; Jeremiah 10:12; Amos 4:13; Zechariah 12:1; Matthew 19:4–5; John 1:2–3; Ephesians 3:9; Colossians 1:16; 1 Timothy 2:13; Hebrews 1:2; 11:3; 2 Peter 3:5; and Revelation 4:11; 10:6–7.[171]

Culture Impacting Theology

The Reason to Believe (RTB) Creation Model opts for day-ages, and hence it seems to ignore the biblical insights considered above.[172] Here is evidence that the evolutionary worldview impacts even theology, as day-ages replace the biblical evidence for creation days. And yet theologians inclined to opt for day-ages may want to consider what such accommodation to cultural influence has done to theology in the past:

> Deism and the natural religion of reason represented the accommodation of the Christian faith to the intellectual and cultural trends that convulsed Europe between 1670 and 1790. The limitations of the universal religion of reason were evident in the unequivocal and at times absurd reductionist tendencies

168. Karl Barth, *The Doctrine of Creation*, vol. 3, pt. 1 in *Church Dogmatics*, trans. J. W. Edwards, Rev. O. Bussey, and Rev. Harold Knight (Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1958), 125.

169. Wenham, *Genesis*, vol. 1 of *Word Biblical Commentary*, 19.

170. Hamilton, *Book of Genesis*, 119.

171. Reymond, *New Systematic Theology*, 118.

172. See Fazale Rana with Hugh Ross, *Who Was Adam?: A Creation Model Approach to the Origin of Man* (Colorado Springs, CO: NavPress, 2005), 42.

> of Enlightenment Christology...during this era Christology degenerated into a Jesuology that was exemplarist, rationlistic, anti-supernatural and thoroughly moralistic.[173]

> Christianity must be allowed to be what it really is, rather than being forced to conform to what the "spirit of our age" regards as acceptable. As an historical theologian, I am uncomfortably aware of how the settled cultural wisdom of an age is often overturned, and occasionally inverted, within a generation.[174]

Francis Schaefer said, "We of the West may not be brainwashed by our State, but we are brainwashed by our culture."[175] No citizens of any country are immune to cultural influences, and evolution has made a global impact on the study of the creation record. Colin Greene documents how cultures influence Christology in his book *Christology in Cultural Perspective.*[176] Thomas Kuhn documents how paradigms change even in hard science.[177] Because cultures and scientific paradigms come and go, the concept of day-ages may change in the future. It seems wise to conclude that we must not unwittingly question the miracle of Christ's creation days any more than the miracle of Christ's incarnation, resurrection, and re-creation of the new heavens and new earth.

There are good Evangelical theologians who argue that day-ages seem the most reasonable way to understand "days" in the Genesis creation record, and that the insights of evolution should not be brushed aside by the church the way the insights of Copernicus and Galileo were. While theologians should not be obscurantists, and certainly hard science has its contribution to make and should be respected, we are not talking about hard science when it comes to evolutionary theory. In other words, evolutionary theory is not on the same level of reality as the empirical findings of Copernicus and Galileo. We are talking about a theory (at the macro level) that has never been proven by empirical evidence. It is a philosophical, metaphysical assumption, not an empirical reality.

Scholars Newman and Eckelmann refer to R. John Snow's research "How Long Is the Sixth Day."[178] Snow urges theologians not to make the same mistakes the church made with Galileo (on cosmology) and Columbus (on a spherical earth). (It is of interest that those promoting heliocentricism—Copernicus,

173. Colin J. D. Greene, *Christology in Cultural Perspective: Marking Out the Horizons* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2003), 96–97.

174. Alister E. McGrath, foreword in *Christ the One and Only: A Global Affirmation of The Uniqueness of Jesus Christ*, ed. Sung Wook Chung (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2005), xvii.

175. Francis A. Schaefer, *The Complete Works of Francis A. Schaefer: A Christian Worldview* (Westchester, IL: Crossway Books, 1996), 1:141.

176. Greene, *Christology in Cultural Perspective.*

177. Thomas S. Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (Chicago, IL: University Press. 1962).

178. Newman and Eckelmann, Jr., *Genesis One*, 125–135.

Galileo, Kepler, and Newton—were "all young-earth creationists"![179]) Snow overlooks the fact that the ideas of Galileo and Columbus are verifiable using empirical science whereas the concept of day-ages is not.

Evolutionists believe the geological column provides some empirical evidence, but conclusions based on that data are dependent upon subjective assumptions brought to it. Those believing the trustworthy Word of God believe in a global flood. They read the geological column as evidence of this catastrophe, whereas atheistic scientists read the geological column as deep-time history of the evolutionary process. In other words, these two ways of reading the geological column are contraries. So it is incumbent upon Bible-believing Christians to consult all the biblical revelation on the topic. Intertextual biblical study corroborates the Genesis creation record.

Acts of Christ in History Provide Support for Literal Creation Days

Christ spoke and instantly Lazarus came forth from the grave (John 11:43–44). Christ "drove out the spirits with a word" (Matt. 8:16b; cf. Mark 9:25–26). Christ rebuked the furious storm and His disciples exclaimed, "Even the winds and the waves obey him!" (Matt. 8:27b). Christ declared that the Gentile centurion had more faith than those in Israel (Matt. 8:10) because his response to Christ had been "just say the word, and my servant will be healed" (Matt. 8:8). Scripture demonstrates that when Christ speaks He gets an instant response.

Christ said that in the final resurrection "the dead will hear the voice of the Son of God" (John 5:25b) and that "all who are in their graves will hear his voice and come out—those who have done what is good will rise to live, and those who have done what is evil will rise to be condemned" (John 5:28–29). Christ's power and human logic require the same instantaneous response to His creation commands. Evolution theory requiring deep-time (day-ages) is a human tradition. When considering the creation record, we need to remember Christ's words that "you nullify the word of God by your tradition" (Mark 7:13). Was Christ right to specify creation days as twenty-four-hour, literal days (Exod. 20:8–11), or is human reasoning on day-ages to replace His divine revelation? Followers of Christ will follow Him in every way, including accepting creation days to be just as literal as the Sabbath day that concluded creation week.

179. Jonathan D. Sarfati, *Refuting Evolution: A Response to the National Academy of Sciences' Teaching About Evolution and the Nature of Science* (Green Forest, AR: Master Books, 2004), 101.

Creation Record Not to Be Relegated to the Nonliteral (Spiritual) Level of Knowledge

The complementarity model of a relationship between theology and science (whose roots go back to Francis Bacon, 1561–1626) suggests that God has two books, Scripture and nature, and that common speech used in the biblical account is not literal but spiritual.[180] But this is not the way Christ inspired Moses to write about creation in Genesis 1–2, nor the way that Christ chose to write about it on tables of stone (Exod. 31:18; 34:28b) recorded in Exodus 20:8–11. It took a unified view of knowledge, in which God was included in the study of nature in order for science to be birthed. Early scholars believed in the Creator of nature, so God was not left out of their study of nature. This launched the various sciences by Copernicus (1475–1543), Galileo (1564–1642), Kepler (1571–1630), Faraday (1791–1867), and Maxwell (1831–1879) among others (see footnote for a source list of fifteen notable scientists).[181]

Today evolutionary "science" rejects God as irrelevant, and in this autonomous manner denies the Creator His rightful opportunity to explain what He has created. In this context Francis Schaefer concludes, "It is a very real question whether the scientists of today...would, or could, have ever begun modern science" because "it was the biblical mentality which gave birth to modern science."[182] The confined world of naturalism, the worldview of evolution, is like a rebel child who denies that his parents gave him life. The study of nature in evolution is about origins, yet it denies its true origin in the Creator.

When reality is confined to the world of nature, then the supernatural is shut out from reality, and is of no use in the acquisition of knowledge. In this context Genesis lacks real knowledge, for Genesis is at best only theological. This comes with all the earmarks of the cosmic controversy, as creation by God is replaced with evolution by nature. The new god is the created, with all the purposelessness that comes as a result of being severed from the real source and purpose of life.

CLIMAX OF CREATION

There is a correspondence between days one to three and days four to six, where the first three give the areas formed by *Elohim*, and days four to six give

180. See C. A. Russell, "Science and Theology" in *New Dictionary of Theology*, ed. Sinclair B. Ferguson and David Wright (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1988), 625.

181. Norman L. Geisler, *Baker Encyclopedia of Christian Apologetics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1999), 168.

182. Schaefer, *The Complete Works*, 1:226.

the days when *Elohim* filled those days with His creative works.[183] Wenham charts them as follows:[184]

Day 1	Light	Day 4	Luminaries
Day 2	Sky	Day 5	Birds and Fish
Day 3	Land (Plants)	Day 6	Animals and Man (Plants for food)

Day 7 Sabbath

So in the first three days *Elohim forms* the places to be *filled* in days four through six. And the remarkable fact in this carefully crafted structure moves to a climax: not the creation of humans on day six,[185] but the gift of the Sabbath on day seven. For the narrative ends with the Sabbath in Genesis 2:1–3. Consider the words of Josephus: "Moses says, That in just six days the world and all that is therein was made; and that the seventh-day was a rest, and a release from the labor of such operations;—whence it is that we celebrate a rest from our labors on that day, and call it the Sabbath; which word denotes *rest* in the Hebrew tongue."[186] Karl Barth says the Sabbath "is in reality the coronation of His work" for "not man but the divine rest on the seventh day is the crown of

183. Wenham, *Genesis*, vol. 1 of *Word Biblical Commentary*, 6–7.

184. Ibid., 7. Derek Kidner (*Genesis: An Introduction and Commentary*, vol. 1 in *Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries* [Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1967], 46) arranges the six days as follows:

Form		*Fullness*	
Day 1	Light and Dark	Day 4	Lights of Day and Night
Day 2	Sea and Sky	Day 5	Creatures of Water and Air
Day 3	Fertile Earth	Day 6	Creatures of Land

Wayne Grudem's arrangement, in *Systematic Theology*, 301, lists the six days as follows:

Days of forming		*Days of filling*	
Day 1	Light and darkness separated	Day 4	Sun, moon, and stars (lights in the heaven)
Day 2	Sky and waters separated	Day 5	Fish and birds
Day 3	Dry land and seas separated, plants and trees	Day 6	Animals and man

185. Humans are "the crowning work of Creation" in Seventh-day Adventist Fundamental Beliefs, #6 (which compares humans with other created things in space). *Seventh-day Adventists Believe: A Biblical Exposition of Fundamental Doctrines* (Hagerstown, MD: Review and Herald Publishing Association, 1988), 68. Davis A. Young considers humans as "the climax of creation" in this sense in *Creation and the Flood: An Alternative to Flood Geology and Theistic Evolution* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1977), 89.

186. Josephus, *The Works of Flavius Josephus*, in *Antiquities of the Jews*, trans. William Whiston (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1974), 1:66 (1.1). God didn't need to rest from creation, because it was an easy work for an omnipotent God who spoke most of it into being, but He knew humans needed this rest, even if it was the first day of life for Adam and Eve. They began their first day of life with a Sabbath communion with their Creator, which is the best way to begin, specifically with the fall in store (Gen. 3). Christ provided everything for Adam and Eve, so the fall need not have taken place. God could not have done more for them.

creation."[187] The Sabbath expresses the purpose of human creation—to enter a relationship with the Creator. Barth is right to maintain that the Sabbath rest reveals God's love; for "the reason why He [God] refrains from further activity on the seventh day is that He has found the object of His love."[188]

The seventh-day Sabbath isn't legalism—it reveals Christ's love, and also the love of the relational Trinity, for "God is love" (1 John 4:8–16). In Scripture God is revealed as love from the beginning: (1) in the way He created humans (see chapter 2), and (2) why He created them—to rest in a relationship of love with Him. The first humans spent their first full day of life in Sabbath rest with their Creator Christ (cf. Col. 1:15–16; Heb. 1:1–2). What an amazing value God placed on humans! This is worlds apart from the guts and gore survival theory taught by evolutionists; the theory of evolution demeans both God and humans.

As Keil and Delitzsch assert, this Sabbath was not confined to a future nation Israel, but was "for all mankind," as the seventh literal day, which God blessed and sanctified as holy after six literal days of creation.[189] Likewise, U. Cassuto says, "Scripture wishes to emphasize that the sanctity of the Sabbath is older than Israel, and rests upon all mankind."[190] Robert McCabe notes that "God's commanding Israel to keep the sabbath is grounded in the creation week."[191] John Sailhamer rightly discerns that with the coming of this seventh literal day, the style changes. Instead of speaking and creating during six literal days, God sanctified and made holy the seventh literal day, and rested in it.[192] Scholars have connected this creation Sabbath gift with the gift of humans being made in the image of God. John Sailhamer and Gordon Wenham, respectively, agree with this connectedness linking the Sabbath to humans who share His image:

> It is likely, as well, that the author intended the reader to understand the account of the seventh day in light of the "Image of God" theme of the sixth day. If the purpose of pointing to the "likeness" between man and his Creator was to call on the reader to be more like God (e.g., Lev 11:45), then it is significant that the account of the seventh day stresses the very thing that the writer elsewhere so ardently calls on the reader to do: "rest" on the seventh day (cf. Exod 20:8–11).[193]

> The seventh day is the very first thing to be hallowed in Scripture, to acquire that special status that properly belongs to God alone. In this way Genesis emphasizes the sacredness of the Sabbath. Coupled with the threefold reference to God resting from all his work on that day, these verses give the clearest of hints of how man created in the divine image should conduct himself on the seventh day.[194]

187. Barth, *The Doctrine of Creation*, vol. 3, pt. 1 in *Church Dogmatics* (1945 ed.), 223.
188. Ibid., 215.
189. Keil and Delitzsch, *The Pentateuch*, vol. 1 of *Commentary on the Old Testament*, 69–70.
190. U. Cassuto, *A Commentary on the Book of Genesis, Part One: From Adam to Noah*, trans. Israel Abrahams (Jerusalem, Israel: The Magnes Press, The Hebrew University, 1989), 64.
191. McCabe, "Defense of Literal Days," *DBSJ*, 111.
192. Sailhamer, *Genesis*, vol. 2 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary*, 38–39.
193. Ibid., 39.

Humans were made in the image of God (Gen. 1:26–27). This means that humans were created to enter a covenant relationship with their Creator. God created humans to enjoy a reciprocal love relationship with the Trinity, as experienced in the inner history, or communion, among the Persons of the Trinity. What an awesome privilege! The Sabbath was given to humans at creation so that during the six days of secular work they could live out of the fullness of fellowship they had shared with God on the Sabbath. Their first full day of life was lived in sacred communion with their Creator, the pre-incarnate Christ. The cosmic controversy made it important for humans to rest in Christ, which is the essence of the covenant, and would be the essence of gospel after the fall of humans. If the Sabbath was necessary before the Fall, how much more it is needed throughout human history.

As Kenneth Strand rightly points out, the first reference to the Sabbath (Gen. 2:2–3) is in a chiastic structure that emphasizes the importance of the day.

A. God finished his work (verse 2)
  B. And he rested on the seventh day from all his work which he had done (verse 2)
    C. So God blessed the seventh day and hallowed it (verse 3)
  B'. Because on it God rested from all his work which he had done (verse 3)
A'. In creation (verse 3, cont.)[195]

In an A-B-C-B-A chiastic structure, the middle statement is often the most important of the chiasm. So the emphasis is on the seventh day as the Sabbath, and the seventh day as the day He blessed. God's blessing (Heb. *bārak*) was only given to the seventh day. It was set apart from the other six, and in this way it was made holy. This setting apart is seen in Exodus 16:23, the Sabbath commandment in Exodus 20:8–11, in Exodus 31:14–16 where it is to be kept forever, and in Exodus 35:2 where death is commanded for Sabbath breakers. Isaiah states that the redeemed will keep the Sabbath in the new earth (Isa. 66:22–23). No wonder Christ said the Sabbath would be kept after His resurrection (Matt. 24:20). Scripture is consistent in stating the continuing importance of the creation seventh-day Sabbath as holy throughout human history, and throughout eternity.

194. Wenham, *Genesis*, vol. 1 in *Word Biblical Commentary*, 36.
195. Kenneth Strand, "The Sabbath," *Handbook*, vol. 12 in *Commentary Reference Series*, 495; see also 493–495.

On the six days God spoke things into existence in space, then on the seventh day God comes to be with humans in time—up close. A work in time by a God up close and personal speaks volumes of the seventh-day's distinction compared to the works of creation in space on the other six days. The seventh-day of creation is called the Sabbath by Christ (Exod. 20:8–11). Christ spoke everything into existence for humans. He gave them gifts in space. But on the seventh-day Sabbath, He gave Himself to them in time, to be their Creator, like His life on planet earth "to tabernacle" among them (John 1:14) and His coming in the earth made new when "God himself will be with them and be their God" (Rev. 21:3). This is Immanuel—"God with us" (Matt. 1:23).

Sabbath keeping is spending time in communion with Christ. He is the Lord of the Sabbath (Mark 2:28), so the seventh-day Sabbath is the Lord's day chosen and blessed by Christ for all humanity at the end of creation week. There is no other day that can claim to be the Lord's day, for none of the other six days were blessed by Him, in creation or since. One can no more *unbless* Christ's chosen day than undo Christ's incarnation. Both were acts of Christ for the benefit of humans (Mark 2:27; John 3:16) and are eternal gifts to the human race. For "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8; cf. Mal. 3:6).

In Genesis 2:1–2 the "seventh day" is mentioned three times. Wenham rightly notes that the "threefold mention of the seventh day, each time in a sentence of seven Hebrew words, draws attention to the special character of the Sabbath. In this way form and content emphasize the distinctiveness of the seventh day."[196]

Because the worship of sun and moon was prevalent from early times, God guided Moses to use the words "greater light" and "lesser light" in place of the *sun* and *moon* respectively (Gen. 1:16). Only the Creator-God is worthy of worship, not His creation. Satan wants to be worshiped instead of Christ (cf. Matt. 4:8–10; Rev. 13:4; 12:9), but he is only a created being.

As mentioned above, the word *Sabbath* is derived from the Hebrew word *šbt*, meaning to "cease" or "desist" from a previous activity—in this case, to desist from creating. God finished His work of creation during six days. He didn't cease because He was tired; rather, He ceased in order to celebrate with Adam and Eve what He had completed. So Sabbath is time to celebrate the finished work of Christ's creation. John concurs with a finished creation (John 1:2–3), for in the beginning (Gr. *archē*) God made (Gr. *egeneto, aorist*, meaning "completed action") all things through Christ. On day six, Christ judged creation as "very good" (Gen. 1:31), and hence it was completed (Gen. 2:3). For "in six days the LORD made the heavens and the earth, and on the seventh day he rested and was refreshed" (Exod. 31:17). Therefore, His "works were finished from

196. Wenham, *Genesis*, vol. 1 of *Word Biblical Commentary*, 7.

the foundation of the world" (Heb. 4:3, NKJV). Clearly the work of creation was finished on the sixth day of creation week, and hence the view of a continuing creation through theistic evolution is contrary to the biblical record.

Thus the first seventh-day Sabbath celebrated a finished work of Christ's creation. We find the same Sabbath celebration in history. In Deuteronomy 5:15, the seventh-day Sabbath celebrates Christ's finished work of deliverance of Israel from Egypt. Because Christ rested in the tomb according to the Sabbath commandment (Luke 23:54–24:1), one could say that the seventh-day Sabbath celebrated Christ's finished work of sacrificial atonement at the cross. Thus the seventh-day Sabbath celebrates Christ's gift of creation, liberation, and salvation. The Sabbath is a sign to God's people in every age. It is a set-apart day to set apart a people. "I gave them my Sabbaths as a sign between us, so they would know that I the LORD made them holy [or set apart]" (Ezek. 20:12). Christians find in each of these finished works of Christ reasons for celebrating by Sabbath resting on Christ's chosen seventh day. Therefore, seventh-day Sabbath keeping is Christian.

Seventh-day Sabbath celebrations honor Christ, as we rest in Him. Christians look forward to the new creation, when "the dwelling of God is with men, and he will live with them. They will be his people, and God himself will be with them and be their God" (Rev. 21:3). Sabbath is special time to rest in Christ and to look forward to the eternal weekly Sabbath rest in the new earth (Isa. 66:22–23).

As mentioned previously, the Sabbath (not human creation) is the crowning part of creation, a fact recognized by Karl Barth. Kenneth Wade has spoken to this fact in a unique and insightful way:

> I have been known to argue, and am still persuaded, that the seventh-day Sabbath was the crowning day of Creation, the day when God ministered to the spirit He had placed within Adam and Eve. Thus the seventh day is the completion of creation, for humans would be no different from the animal kingdom were it not for God's special creative work in developing their spiritual side on the Sabbath day. In Revelation the number of man (apart from the completion of this spiritual creation) is 666. The creation of the beast(s) was completed on the sixth day; the maturation and completion of creation of humans is only accomplished as their spiritual life develops through a relationship with God—the purpose of the Sabbath.[197]

There is no difference between the gift of the Sabbath throughout human history from the gift of the Sabbath in creation. This is why the first angel's message invites humans to "Worship him who made the heavens, the earth, the sea and the springs of water" (Rev. 14:7b). These words—"who made the heavens, the earth, the sea"—are taken from the fourth commandment (Exod. 20:11).

197. Note to the author.

So this linguistic reference to the Sabbath is in the context of the historical reference to the "eternal gospel" (Rev. 14:6). The gospel message goes all the way back to Genesis 3:15, just as the Sabbath goes all the way back to creation in six days (Gen. 1:1–2:3). Neither merely goes back to Israel. Properly understood, Christ's gospel includes Christ's seventh-day Sabbath, with its resting in Christ as the essence of the gospel.

Furthermore, this call to worship the Creator is a call to worship Christ the Creator. Scripture is replete with references to Christ as Creator. The Gospel of John (1:1–3) is a divine commentary on Genesis 1. "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. He was with God in the beginning. Through him all things were made; without him nothing was made that has been made." And verse 14 declares, "The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us. We have seen his glory, the glory of the One and Only, who came from the Father, full of grace and truth." Genesis 1 and John 1 take us back to the beginning of creation on planet earth, and we see that the *Elohim* of Genesis 1 and *Yahweh Elohim* of Genesis 2 is the Christ of John 1.

There is important linguistic evidence to show the Sabbath of Genesis 2 is a creation ordinance (given to all humans from the beginning of human history), not just a future day given to one race. H. Ross Cole describes this evidence:

> The question of whether or not Gen 2:1–3 pictures the Sabbath as a Creation ordinance is of intense practical and academic interest, as it is a *crux interpretum* that has long tended to divide those who believe the Sabbath is of universal, permanent significance, from those who believe it is of only local temporary significance.... The blessings of Gen 1 all have an immediate human focus, so there is a presumption that the blessing of the seventh day would be the same....
>
> It has been argued that in Gen 2:3 God sanctified the seventh day for its *future* use under the law, just as he sanctified Jeremiah as a future prophet in Jer 1:5. However, this argument fails to take into account the fact that while both verses use the verb קדשׁ, Gen 2:3 uses the Piel stem and Jer 1:5 uses the Hiphil stem. While the factitive use of the Piel lies close in meaning to the causative use of the Hiphil, evidence suggests that the former emphasizes result and the latter emphasizes process. Whenever the Piel stem of קדשׁ has a period of time as its object, it is never used as a "real" factitive, but always as an estimative or declarative Piel. Context rules out the estimative use in Gen 2:3, suggesting that קדשׁ is here used declaratively to picture the public proclamation of the sanctity of the seventh day at the time of Creation.[198]

Keeping in mind Cole's statement, consider the commentary Keil and Delitzsch offer:

198. H. Ross Cole, "The Sabbath and Genesis 2:1–3" in *Andrews University Seminary Studies*, vol. 41, no. 1 (Spring 2003): 11–12.

> The blessing and sanctifying of the seventh day had regard, no doubt, to the Sabbath, which Israel as the people of God was afterwards to keep; but we are not to suppose that the theocratic Sabbath was instituted here, or that the institution of that Sabbath was transferred to the history of the creation. On the contrary, the Sabbath of the Israelites had a deeper meaning, founded in the nature and development of the created world, not for Israel only, but for all mankind, or rather for the whole creation.[199]

Although humans were created in the image of God to have dominion over things on the earth—that was the extent of their dominion. William Shea rightly points out that "Adam was not made lord of the Sabbath. The 'Son of man,' Jesus Christ, holds that title."[200] The seventh-day creation Sabbath is the Lord's day. That is why in the commandment, Christ says that "the seventh day *is a sabbath* to the LORD your God" (Exod. 20:10a, emphasis added). That is why Christ says of Himself, "the Son of Man is Lord even of the Sabbath" (Mark 2:28). "The Sabbath expresses a dominion, too, but not the dominion of Adam and Eve over the creation. Rather, it expresses the dominion of God over Adam and Eve and over all that He had created."[201] The Sabbath has never ceased to express God's dominion over humans. God has a right to tell humans which day is His Sabbath. U. Cassuto, professor of Bible at Hebrew University in Jerusalem, said, "Scripture wishes to emphasize that the sanctity of the Sabbath is older than Israel, and rests upon all mankind."[202]

Creation in Scripture

CHRIST AND CREATION

Scripture declares that God created everything through Christ. John says: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. He was with God in the beginning. Through him all things were made; without him nothing was made that has been made. In him was life, and that life was the light of all mankind.... The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us" (John 1:1–3, 14a). Paul tells us that "there is but one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom all things came and through whom we live" (1 Cor. 8:6b). Paul further says that Christ "is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn over all creation. For by him all things were created: things in heaven and

199. Keil and Delitzsch, *The Pentateuch*, vol. 1 of *Commentary on the Old Testament*, 69.
200. Shea, "Creation," in *Handbook*, vol. 12 in *Commentary Reference Series*, 438.
201. Ibid., 425.
202. U. Cassuto, *A Commentary on the Book of Genesis, Part One: From Adam to Noah*, trans. Israel Abrahams (Jerusalem: Magnes Press, Hebrew University, 1961, 1st ed. 1944), 64.

on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or powers or rulers or authorities; all things were created through him and for him. He is before all things, and in him all things hold together" (Col. 1:15–17).

The writer of Hebrews says that through Christ God "made the universe" (Heb. 1:2; 11:3). In the Greek, the word for "universe" is *worlds* (Gr. *aiōnes*, plural). In the history of theology, there are references to worlds (plural) in the universe.[203] Science can speak in terms of a "multiverse."[204] The fact that Christ also created thrones and powers may suggest the creation of Adams of other worlds who had dominion and leadership over them just as Adam and Eve had over planet earth (see chapter 2).

In Job 1:6 and 2:1 it speaks of the sons of God (*bĕnê hā'ĕlōhîm*) who "came to present themselves before the LORD and Satan also came with them." Were these "sons of God" the Adams, or leaders, of different worlds, with Satan replacing the Adam of planet earth since the Fall? Both times *Yahweh* spoke to Satan about Job as one who is blameless. Given a cosmic controversy, this discussion is understandable, for Job seems to be one who disproves Satan's charge. Job is committed to God. On one occasion when God spoke to Job about creation, *Yahweh* asked Job:

> Where were you when I laid the foundations of the earth? Tell Me, if you have understanding. Who determined its measurements? Surely you know! Or who stretched the line upon it? To what were its foundations fastened? Or who laid its cornerstone, when the morning stars sang together, and all the sons of God shouted for joy? Or who shut in the sea with doors, when it burst forth and issued from the womb; when I made the clouds its garment, and thick darkness its swaddling band; when I fixed My limit for it, and set bars and doors; when I said, "This far you may come, but no farther, and here your proud waves must stop!" (Job 38:4–11, NKJV)

Here we find morning stars and sons of God shouting joyously over the creation of planet earth. They are amazed, awed, and moved to praise the Creator. There is no slow evolutionary development over deep-time involved in this scene. The exuberance and spontaneity of the shout call evolutionary theory into question.

203. For example, see my *Systematic Theology: God As Trinity* (Berrien Springs, MI: Andrews University Press, 2011), 2; see also chap. 7, "Creator of the Universe." See also John Polkinghorne, President of Queens College, Cambridge University: "If there are other life-bearing planets elsewhere in the cosmos it is conceivable that their inhabitants may be as innocent of moral evil as were the dwellers in C. S. Lewis's *Perelandra*," *Reason and Reality: The Relationship Between Science and Theology* (Philadelphia, PA: Trinity, 1991), 100–101.

204. Consider this analysis: "In fact, the wilder shotes of contemporary speculative physics exhibit a remarkable propensity to invoke freely the existence of entities not directly detected by experimental science, such as the supposition that there are extra unobserved dimensions of space (as the string theorists cheerfully assume [see B. Green, *The Elegant Universe*]), or even the hypothesis of a plethora of unobservable other universes (in the metascientific strategy of embedding this universe in an immense multiverse)," John Polkinghorne, "A Scientist Looks at the Epistle to the Hebrews," in *The Epistle to the Hebrews and Christian Theology*, ed. Richard Bauckham Daniel R. Driver, Trevor A. Hart, and Nathan MacDonald (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2009), 117.

Proverbs says, "By wisdom the LORD laid the earth's foundations, by understanding he set the heavens in place; by his knowledge the depths were divided, and the clouds let drop the dew" (Prov. 3:19–20). Some scholars believe "wisdom" represents Christ. Allen Ross says wisdom is "the agent of creation" (27–29), "wisdom was present when God created" (as in John 1:1–3; Col. 1:15–16), and wisdom rejoiced in God's creation (Prov. 8:30–31), just as God saw that it was "very good" (Gen. 1:31).[205] Derek Kidner rightly says, "The New Testament shows by its allusions to this passage (Col. 1:15–17; 2:3; Rev. 3:14) that the personifying of wisdom, far from overshooting the literal truth, was a preparation for its full statement, since the agent of creation was no mere activity of God, but the Son, His eternal Word, Wisdom and Power (see also Jn. 1:1–14; 1 Cor. 1:24, 30; Heb. 1:1–4)."[206]

Oskar Skarsaune of the Norwegian Lutheran School of Theology says these texts of God creating through Christ mean: "The Son or the Word is God's *mediator* in creating the world," and he points out that in "Jewish writings of the Second Temple period there is one such X [meaning thing or person] and only one: the Wisdom of God"; he goes on to quote Proverbs 3:19 and 8:29–30. Christ is the associate with the Father in creation. In other words, these verses in Proverbs are the root texts for these New Testament references to God's creating through Christ.[207]

Richard Davidson persuasively argues for "wisdom" as Christ.[208] Look at the players on the field. See what is taking place from their perspective. Look at the co-Creators as Richard Davidson does.[209] The Father and Son are on the field.

205. Allen P. Ross, *Proverbs,* vol. 5 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1991), 946.

206. Derek Kidner, *Proverbs*, vol. 15 in *Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1964), 1579.

207. Oskar Skarsaune, *In the Shadow of the Temple: Jewish Influences on Early Christianity* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2002), 326, emphasis in original but parenthesis added. Cf. 327–328 where Skarsaune compares Sirach 24 (Wisdom being present with God when He created the world) with John 1:14 on Christ's incarnation (cf. Sir. 24:8–10).

208. Richard Davidson, "Proverbs 8 and the Place of Christ in the Trinity," *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, 17/1 (2006): 33–54.

209. There has been much debate about the meaning of "wisdom" in Proverbs 8. Most contemporary commentators reject an earlier view that wisdom is Christ. Richard Davidson proves linguistically, contextually, and intertextually that it can be argued on sound hermeneutical grounds that wisdom is Christ. See "Proverbs 8," *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, 33–54. Some evidence he gives includes: (1) "I, wisdom" Wisdom in Proverbs assumes prerogatives elsewhere used for Yahweh alone (Prov. 8:35–36). (2) "I am Wisdom" (v. 12) is used elsewhere for God (Ezek. 12:25; 35; Zech. 10:6; Mal. 3:6). (3) Although wisdom (*ḥokmâ*) is feminine, workman/craftsman (*'āmôn*, v. 30) is masculine, but the sexuality is not important because the craftsman is the co-Creator God, which concurs with other texts linking God and Christ in creation (cf. Prov. 30:4). (4) The imagery of birth (Heb. *nsk*, Prov. 8:22–25) applied to Christ prior to the incarnation is best understood in a parallel text (*nsk* in Ps. 2:6–7) which refers to Christ's installation. (5) The installation was "from the beginning, before the world began" (Prov. 8:23b) as a mediator between God and humanity (Prov. 8:30b–31). (6) The macrostructure of Proverbs 8 climaxes with Wisdom as the ultimate mediator between God and humanity. This is not a subordination of Christ to the Father, for they are co-Creators.

We see creation underway. The Father is there with the Son (called Wisdom and craftsman in the passage). Listen to Christ: "I was the craftsman at his side. I was filled with delight day after day, rejoicing always in his presence, rejoicing in his whole world and delighting in mankind" (Prov. 8:30–31).

Davidson speaks of the biblical evidence for the laughter and play involved as Father and Son created. I was present at a professional meeting when Davidson presented this concept, and I rejoiced in this new insight. Following Davidson's lead, I looked up the word rejoicing (Heb. *měśaḥeqet*), which comes from the root *śāḥaq*, and it means "laughter, play."[210] So the Father and Son were overjoyed, happy, laughing, as if at play, as they created humans, and as they enjoyed humans after they were created. No wonder the morning stars and angels shouted for joy! They were caught up in the joy of the Father and Son, so great was the celebration. Davidson beautifully captures the joy of God in creation:

> This term *měśaḥeqet* is a participial form of the root *śḥq*, "to sport, play, laugh." Here is represented the mood of joyful celebration, pure delight, of the Son with Yahweh, and pure delight, joyful celebration with humanity. This verb *śḥq* is used elsewhere of children "playing" in the streets (Zech 8:5). The Father and the Son are having "the time of their life," as it were, rejoicing, laughing, playing, as they work together, Co-creators, fashioning this world and its inhabitants. Likewise, the Son is having "the time of His life," as it were, rejoicing, laughing, sporting with the humans He has created. This description introduces a dynamic into the theology of creation that has long been overlooked—a theology of divine play![211]

What an awesome picture of the Father and Son, with their love overflowing in sheer delight to create humans and be with them! What a divine estimation of humans! No greater love and dignity could surround them. What a contrast to the supposed evolution of humans through raw carnage, survival of the fittest (or the best adapted), and chance—devoid of purpose and meaning, only an arrival on a battlefield with no surety of survival. (While it is true that theistic evolutionists bring God into the creative act, the long process doesn't do justice to the sheer joy God had in the act of creation.)

Humans desperately need to recapture their roots. The Father "chose us in him before the creation of the world.... In love he predestined us for adoption to sonship through Jesus Christ, in accordance with his pleasure and will—to the praise of his glorious grace, which he has freely given us in the One he loves. In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, in accordance with the riches of God's grace that he lavished on us. With all

210. Barton J. Payne, *"śāḥaq"* (*"śāḥaq"* or *"śĕḥōq"* both mean "laughrer"), *Theological Wordbook of the Old Testament*, ed. R. Laird Harris (Chicago, IL: Moody, 1980), 2:763.

211. Davidson, "Proverbs 8," *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, 53.

wisdom and understanding" (Eph. 1:4–8). In the plan of salvation God continues rejoicing over humans, and today "The LORD your God is with you, the Mighty Warrior who saves. He will take great delight in you; in his love he will no longer rebuke you, but will rejoice over you with singing" (Zeph. 3:17). The Persons of the Trinity have not changed (Mal. 3:6a). From creation to new creation, the Trinity always shower humans with lavish love, for humans are very dear to them. How could they ever be satisfied with a hands-off, horrific process of evolution as a means of creating humans, who are made in their very image?

God would have none of this. Humans were wanted, planned for, made in the image of God, and so caught up in the reciprocal love of God that the love shared in the Trinity flowed equally to humans. This is what happened on the sixth day of creation, and then God singled out a day for humans to take time to be with Him, even in perfect Paradise. He gave them a Sabbath to be a delight for them, and it was a delight for God too, for God and humans entered into a close relationship of covenant love. The covenant relationship offered to humans at creation was not merely a one-day-a-week experience, confined to the seventh part of time. The covenant relationship was—and is still meant to be—like a marriage, a union of love for every day of life. Moses focused on this continuing covenant relationship in the context of the Ten Commandments given to Israel (Deut. 5):

> Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one. Love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength. These commandments that I give you today are to be on your hearts. Impress them on your children. Talk about them when you sit at home and when you walk along the road, when you lie down and when you get up. Tie them as symbols on your hands and bind them on your foreheads. Write them on the doorframes of your houses and on your gates...be careful that you do not forget the LORD who brought you out of Egypt, out of the land of slavery. (Deut. 6:4–9, 12)

David entered into the covenant relationship with God. Psalm 119 gives testimony of his experience.

- "I delight in your commands because I love them" (v. 47);
- "I remember, LORD, your ancient laws, and I find comfort in them.... Your decrees are the theme of my song" (vv. 52, 54);
- "I keep your precepts with all my heart...I delight in your law" (vv. 69b, 70b);
- "Oh, how I love your law! I meditate on it all day long" (v. 97);
- "Seven times a day I praise you for your righteous laws. Great peace have they who love your law, and nothing can make them stumble" (vv. 164–165).

The Sabbath is a tangible period in time to illustrate what God desires throughout all time: to have an unbroken covenant communion with humans. No wonder humans are invited to love God with all their heart, soul, and strength. As such the Sabbath is a "sign" of the covenant relationship (Exod. 31:13), just as the rainbow is a "sign" of "the everlasting covenant between God and all living creatures of every kind on the earth" (Gen. 9:12a, 16). That's why Christ said "the Sabbath was made for man" (Mark 2:27) referring to all humanity. For the goal of each covenant, in the unfolding of the everlasting covenant, is to bless all nations of the world (Gen. 12:1–3; 22:15–18; 26:2–5; 28:10–14).

Christ referred to the creation of Adam and Eve as husband and wife, as "joined together," and He warned against anyone attempting to separate married couples (Mark 10:3–9). Christ spoke of the end times as "days of distress unequaled from the beginning, when God created the world, until now—and never to be equaled again" (Mark 13:19). Christ speaks of Himself as "the ruler of God's creation" (Rev. 3:14). Scripture says the Word is Jesus Christ (John 1:14), and He was with God in the beginning, and "[t]hrough him all things were made; without him nothing was made that has been made" (John 1:1–3).

JOB/PSALMS

God asked Job, "Where were you when I laid the earth's foundation?" (Job 38:4). In fact, chapters 38–42 speak of God as Creator. "The order in Job follows the order of the Creation week in a general way."[212]

In the Psalms we read, humans were made "a little lower than the angels" (Ps. 8:5a; cf. Christ as man, Heb. 2:9). "By the word of the LORD the heavens were made, their starry host by the breath of his mouth. He gathers the waters of the sea into jars; he puts the deep into storehouses. Let all the earth fear the LORD; let all the people of the world revere him. For he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm" (Ps. 33:6–9). "In the beginning you laid the foundations of the earth, and the heavens are the work of your hands" (Ps. 102:25). "How many are your works, LORD! In wisdom you made them all; the earth is full of your creatures. There is the sea, vast and spacious, teeming with creatures beyond number—living things both large and small" (Ps. 104:24–25). "May you be blessed by the LORD, the Maker of heaven and earth. The highest heavens belong to the LORD, but the earth he has given to mankind" (Ps. 115:15–16).

Salvation and creation are often spoken of together. "My help comes from the LORD, the Maker of heaven and earth" (Ps. 121:2). "Our help is in the name of the LORD, the Maker of heaven and earth" (Ps. 124:8). "May the LORD bless

212. Shea, "Creation," in *Handbook*, vol. 12 in *Commentary Reference Series*, 429.

you from Zion, he who is the Maker of heaven and earth" (Ps. 134:3). Thanks are given to the Lord for His goodness, "who by his understanding made the heavens, *His love endures forever.* who spread out the earth upon the waters, *His love endures forever.* who made the great lights—*His love endures forever.* the sun to govern the day, *His love endures forever.* the moon and stars to govern the night; *His love endures forever*" (Ps. 136:5–9). "Blessed is he whose help is the God of Jacob, whose hope is in the LORD his God. He is the Maker of heaven and earth, the sea, and everything in them—he remains faithful forever" (Ps. 146:5–6). "Let them praise the name of the LORD, for at his command they were created and he established them for ever and ever—he issued a decree that will never pass away" (Ps. 148:5–6).

ECCLESIASTES

"This only have I found: God made mankind upright, but they have gone in search of many schemes" (Eccles. 7:29). This agrees with God's own declaration: "Let us make mankind in our image, in our likeness.... So God created mankind in his own image, in the image of God he created him; male and female he created them" (Gen. 1:26–27). To create male and female in the image of the Trinity means to create them in a loving relationship that mirrors God's reciprocal love. This can only be accomplished by a God of love, and cannot happen through a natural process survival of the fittest (or the best adapted), in which humans evolve in a long process of struggle which is so different from being created by God for an immediate relationship with Him.

ISAIAH

"Lift up your eyes and look to the heavens: Who created all these? He who brings out the starry host one by one and calls forth each of them by name. Because of his great power and mighty strength, not one of them is missing.... The LORD is the everlasting God, the Creator of the ends of the earth" (Isa. 40:26, 28b). Ecclesiastes says, "Remember your Creator in the days of your youth" (12:1a). Yet God said to Judah, "[Y]ou forget the LORD your Maker, who stretches out the heavens and who lays the foundations of the earth, that you live in constant terror every day because of the wrath of the oppressor, who is bent on destruction" (Isa. 51:13). Hezekiah prayed, "LORD Almighty, the God of Israel, enthroned between the cherubim, you alone are God over all the kingdoms of the earth. You have made heaven and earth" (Isa. 37:16). Isaiah says of God, "Do you not know? Have you not heard? Has it not been told you from the beginning? Have you not understood since the earth was

founded? He sits enthroned above the circle of the earth, and its people are like grasshoppers. He stretches out the heavens like a canopy, and spreads them out like a tent to live in" (Isa. 40:21–22). "This is what God the LORD says—the Creator of the heavens who stretches them out, who spread out the earth with all that springs from it, who gives breath to its people, and life to those who walk on it: 'I, the LORD, have called you in righteousness; I will take hold of your hand'" (Isa. 42:5–6).

God is shown to be incomparable compared to man-made idols, for He is the Creator. "I am the LORD the Maker of all things, who stretches out the heavens, who spreads out the earth by myself" (Isa. 44:24b). "It is I who made the earth and created mankind on it. My own hands stretched out the heavens; I marshaled their starry hosts" (Isa. 45:12). "For this is what the LORD says—he who created the heavens, he is God; he who fashioned and made the earth, he founded it; he did not create it to be empty, but formed it to be inhabited—he says: 'I am the LORD, and there is no other'" (Isa. 45:18).

JEREMIAH

No wonder God can say, "See, I will create new heavens and a new earth" (Isa. 65:17; cf. 66:22). The Creator God is the only God. So Jeremiah said, "Tell them this: 'These gods, who did not make the heavens and the earth, will perish from the earth and from under the heavens.' But God made the earth by his power; he founded the world by his wisdom and stretched out the heavens by his understanding." Other gods are worthless, but "He who is the Portion of Jacob is not like these, for he is the Maker of all things" (Jer. 10:11–12, 16). Whereas idols are created by humans, the one and only God created humans. "This is what the LORD Almighty, the God of Israel, says: 'Tell this to your masters: With my great power and outstretched arm I made the earth and its people and the animals that are on it, and I give it to anyone I please'" (Jer. 27:4–5).

God approached Jeremiah as the Creator. "This is what the LORD says, he who made the earth, the LORD who formed it and established it—the LORD is his name" (Jer. 33:2). The Lord Almighty "made the earth by his power; he founded the world by his wisdom and stretched out the heavens by his understanding" (Jer. 51:15).

Note that God made the earth by His power. Omnipotence was involved in creation, which bears no resemblance to the slow, torturous process required by evolution.

NEHEMIAH

When the inhabitants of Judah returned home from Babylonian captivity, they listened to the reading of the Book of the Law of Moses (Neh. 8:1) and worshiped God (v. 8). They praised the Lord saying, "Blessed be your glorious name, and may it be exalted above all blessing and praise. You alone are the LORD. You made the heavens, even the highest heavens, and all their starry host, the earth and all that is on it, the seas and all that is in them. You give life to everything, and the multitudes of heaven worship you" (Neh. 9:5b–6).

The God of the prophets was the Creator-God, which set Him apart as incomparable compared to idol gods created by humans. In the books of the minor prophets, there is a focus on God as judge. These two works of God—creating and judging—are brought together in the end-times message in the New Testament: "Fear [or reverence] God and give him glory, because the hour of his judgment has come. Worship him who made the heavens, the earth, the sea and the springs of water" (Rev. 14:7). Consistently throughout the Old Testament the fact that God is Creator is just as literal/historical as His past and future acts of judgment in history.

NEW TESTAMENT

Peter and John were imprisoned for preaching about Christ and His resurrection. On their release from prison, they returned to the believers in Jerusalem and gave them a progress report. "When they heard this, they raised their voices together in prayer to God. 'Sovereign Lord,' they said, 'you made the heaven and the earth and the sea, and everything in them'" (Acts 4:24; cf. 14:15; Exod. 20:11).

Paul compares the true God with counterfeit gods, saying "there is but one God, the Father, from whom all things came and for whom we live; and there is but one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom all things came and through whom we live" (1 Cor. 8:6). So the Old Testament argument for the true God is continued in the New Testament, for the true God is the Creator of all that is, whereas other gods are human creations.

Paul speaks of the revelation of the Creator in His creation, for "since the creation of the world God's invisible qualities—his eternal power and divine nature—have been clearly seen, being understood from what has been made, so that men are without excuse" (Rom. 1:20). He calls the sin of moral impurity a false worship, the serving of "created things rather than the Creator—who is forever praised" (v. 25b). There is no question for Paul that the world was created:

> The creation waits in eager expectation for the children of God to be revealed. For the creation was subjected to frustration, not by its own choice, but by the will of the one who subjected it, in hope that the creation itself will be liberated from its bondage to decay and brought into the freedom and glory of the children of God. We know that the whole creation has been groaning as in the pains of childbirth right up to the present time. (Rom. 8:19–22)

This new creation begins to be fulfilled for those who accept Christ. Nature still groans around them, but "if anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come; the old has gone, the new has come!" (2 Cor. 5:17). Paul refers to the first Adam's becoming a living being (1 Cor. 15:45a), and Paul speaks of the Second Advent where "we will be changed. For the perishable must clothe itself with the imperishable, and the mortal with immortality.... then the saying that is written will come true: 'Death has been swallowed up in victory'" (1 Cor. 15:52b–54).

This redemption of creation is referred to in Revelation, when there will be "a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and there was no longer any sea" (Rev. 21:1). "And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, 'Look! God's dwelling place is now among the people, and he will dwell with them. They will be his people, and God himself will be with them and be their God. He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the old order of things has passed away'" (vv. 3–4). Notice God's desire to dwell with humans; then realize that that is how it was in the beginning, for God does not change (Mal. 3:6), and "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8). God did not have to wait for millions of years to dwell with humans, for He is God, and He did so within six days of creating the universe (Gen. 1–2).

In the meantime Peter speaks of scoffers who doubt Christ's second advent, saying that "everything goes on as it has since the beginning of creation" (2 Pet. 3:4), which predicts the uniformitarianism so important to evolution. Christians "should commit themselves to their faithful Creator and continue to do good" (1 Pet. 4:19). The writer of Hebrews testifies, "By faith we understand that the universe was formed at God's command, so that what is seen was not made out of what was visible" (Heb. 11:3). John declares that Christ is referred to as "the ruler of God's creation" (Rev. 3:14). These texts presuppose a creation that is just as literal and historical as the creation of the first Adam. Revelation ends with the creation of a new heaven and a new earth (Rev. 21:1–4). So, the mighty acts of God in Scripture begin and end with creation.

Greatest Evidence for Creation

This segment is not intended to persuade those who do not believe in God and the authority of Scripture. It is not designed to convince atheistic evolutionists. It is for those who believe in the inerrancy of Scripture but still doubt the Genesis account of creation. It is for the many theistic evolutionists in the ranks of Christian denominations.

Scripture presents Christ as "Immanuel," God with us (Matt. 1:23). The greatest evidence of creation was not in Eden, but in Bethlehem. When Jesus was born of Mary through the power of the Holy Spirit (Matt. 1:20), we see a creative act of God in history, born in Bethlehem in Judea during the time of King Herod (Matt. 2:1). If God can create the second Adam, the God-Man Jesus, then creation of the first Adam was certainly doable—and much easier. For Christians who believe in the incarnation of the second Adam as a supernatural event, they should be able to easily accept the creation of the first Adam as a supernatural event. After all, both works of God had purposes outside the realm of the chance of naturalism.

As Christians, we are convinced that God creates in history, for "if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; the old has gone, the new has come!" (2 Cor. 5:17). Christ's creative work in humans climaxes at His second coming: "For since death came through a man, the resurrection of the dead comes also through a man. For as in Adam all die, so in Christ all will be made alive" (1 Cor. 15:21–22).

Judah forgot its Creator-God. Christ said to them,

> "See, I will create new heavens and a new earth. The former things will not be remembered, nor will they come to mind.... The wolf and the lamb will feed together, and the lion will eat straw like the ox...they will neither harm nor destroy on all my holy mountain," says the LORD. This is what the LORD says: "Heaven is my throne, and the earth is my footstool. Where is the house you will build for me? Where will my resting place be? Has not my hand made all these things, and so they came into being?" declares the LORD. "Those are the ones I look on with favor: those who are humble and contrite in spirit, and who tremble at my word" (Isa. 65:17, 25; 66:1–2).

I agree with Nigel M. de S. Cameron: "It is true that the closer and more adequately we study the Scripture, and the more we allow it to determine the form of our theology, the more nearly our thinking will conform to the truth about God himself. But, in order to study God, we look not at him (whom we cannot see, and may not), but at his image in Scripture. The paradox is that the more we revere and study the Book, the more we know its Author. This is other than the way in which we know the natural order."[213] Here is

213. Nigel M. de S. Cameron, "Talking Points: Science Versus Religion," *Themelios*, 8/1 (1982): 26.

no mere bibliolatry, or naïve fundamentalism; rather, this is a reverence for God's cognitive revelation that comes out of a reverence for Him as God.

The Word presents Christ as the Creator who will re-create the heavens and the earth as a place where the lion and lamb will dwell together. Natural evil will be gone forever. It is this same Creator who showed His love to human rebels, carried their sins to the cross, and died to rescue them, to re-create humans into His image, to resurrect and glorify them, and to re-create a new earth one day for them. This is the Christ of the Word.

How tragic that human reason led Darwin and others to miss this glorious revelation! How sad that they distanced God from the world, the very One who has the answer to the moral and natural evil of the world by being the God of love, the Lord of the Sabbath, the resident God in a world at rest, where God's love is reflected in total harmony between humans and God, and humans and all creation. The "new" earth (*kainos*, renewed; not *neos*, new; Rev. 21:1) will be an earth restored to its pristine state.[214]

Conclusion

Because God is omnipotent, why couldn't He create in six days (as Scripture states)? Why accept a nonbiblical view that it took deep-time? I salute Evangelical scholars who reject Process and Openness views that dismiss God's omniscience. But why defend the omniscient attribute of God in eschatological matters but not defend the omnipotence attribute of God in matters protological? Isn't there an unrealized inconsistency here?

> Even back in 1964 J. Marcellus Kik said, "One cannot help being concerned about the drift of some evangelical scholars to subject the interpretation of Genesis 1 to modern scientific opinions. There is a dangerous tendency to interpret the first chapter of Genesis, not by strict and accurate exegesis, but in a manner so as to satisfy the 'scientific mind.' This yielding spirit is fraught with danger not only to the biblical doctrine of creation but to other doctrines as well."[215]

Some Evangelical scholars reject the immutability and impassibility of God, because this makes God stand aloof from humans. Yet Evangelical scholars who accept theistic evolution, which claims that God used the natural process to create, promote an aloof God in creation compared to the biblical view of His direct involvement in creating and interacting with humankind.

214. In the doctrine of eschatology (vol. 4) we discuss what is new on the new earth. There is a new reality—God comes to dwell with the redeemed. The New Jerusalem descends from heaven to earth, and God's throne is in it (Rev. 21:2, 22).

215. J. Marcellus Kik, preface to *Studies in Genesis One*, by Edward J. Young (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 1964), iv.

It is time for Evangelicals to take their case to another level—to react against an aloof God in evolutionary creation. This is the logical next step in their attempt to present the fullness of God as seen in all His attributes. Such a presentation should include a theological ecology, for the Creator-God and Redeemer-God are one in Jesus Christ (see chapter 2). They are inseparable. Creation is just as much a gift as redemption is. God was no more dependent upon a natural process to create than He is dependent on human works to bring about salvation. Because "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8), His creation of the world was just as supernatural as His incarnation in the world.

No wonder God is worshiped in heaven as Creator, the Father who created all things through Christ (Heb. 1:1–2), the Redeemer:

> You are worthy, our Lord and God, to receive glory and honor and power, for you created all things, and by your will they were created and have their being. (Rev. 4:11)

> Worthy is the Lamb, who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and strength and honor and glory and praise! (Rev. 5:12)

Let Christians on earth join in the song and "[w]orship Him who made the heavens, the earth, the sea and the springs of water" (Rev. 14:7b). Such worship recognizes that God is God, and not man. He acts as God in a manner worthy of His holiness, sovereignty, and love, doing things that humans cannot do, that science cannot fathom, that natural processes cannot produce. For He is the only supernatural God, and His acts reveal His omnipotence.

Study Questions

1. How do Hebrew grammar and the biblical hermeneutic of *sola Scriptura* (Scripture interpreting Scripture) prove the days of creation were literal, twenty-four-hour days?
2. What are the arguments used by those who oppose literal creation days, and what is the biblical evidence to refute these arguments?
3. How does Hebrew grammar support the absolute creation interpretation of "In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth" (Gen. 1:1)?
4. Why is the Gap theory not compatible with the biblical record?
5. The creation record does not say when absolute creation took place. Explain the two possibilities the biblical text provides for fitting in the Precambrian of the geological column. Does the biblical text provide for a long chronology for life on planet earth?

6. Why should the Framework hypothesis be abandoned by Evangelicals?
7. Why is it significant that the Sabbath, and not human creation, is the climax of creation?
8. What contribution does Proverbs 8 make to our understanding of creation?
9. What is the greatest evidence in Scripture for a supernatural creation?
10. What is the next level for Evangelicals in questioning the diminished God of theism?

CHAPTER TWO

Human Creation and Nature

Purpose

1. Present the biblical view of creation of humans in the "image of God."
2. Determine what being created *wholistically* means.
3. Indicate what the pre-Fall nature of humans was like.
4. Study the Subordination debate.
5. Consider the importance of ecology.
6. Reflect on the meaning of death and the intermediate state.

Summary

The crowning work of creation was God's creation of humans. Unlike the animal and inanimate creation, humans were given special personal attention by God in their creation. God the Father made everything through His Son. Christ did not speak humans into being, as He did much of creation. He actively participated in the process, molding and breathing into Adam the breath of life, and Eve was formed from Adam's rib (clearly they did not evolve from animals). Adam and Eve were made in the image of God, which means that in various ways they were made like their Creator, even though they were contingent and dependent upon Him. Their nature was mortal, and they were wholistic[1] beings, body and soul in one inseparable union. Natural immortality is not a biblical doctrine, but came into Christian teaching from Greek philosophy. The idea of human immortality revolutionized the view of death, which led to the belief

1. The word "wholistic" is used to differentiate it from the New Age word "holistic."

about saints and Mary in heaven. By contrast Scripture presents immortality as gifted through salvation and not given through creation. Christ died to put death to death so that immortality can be given to the race when mortals put on immortality at the Second Advent (1 Cor. 15:53). In His infinite foreknowledge God knew of the cosmic rebellion, and if He had created intelligent beings with immortality (life without end), then upon sinning, angels and humans would have begun an endless rebellion. In mercy, God created all intelligent beings with mortality so that one day sin and sinners will be no more. Otherwise there would be no resolution to the cosmic controversy.

Outline

I. Introduction
II. Creation of Adam and Eve
- A. Cosmic Context
- B. Creation

III. Created in the Image of God
- A. Image of the Trinity
- B. Image as Dominion
- C. Image as Physical
- D. Image as Character
- E. Image as Communion
- F. Image as Freedom to Choose
- G. Image Remains

IV. Subordination Debate
V. Importance of Ecology: In a Theological System
- A. Introduction
- B. Ecological Theology
- C. Theology of Nature
- D. Contribution of Science
- E. Ecology as Part of Creation
- F. Ecological Crisis
  - 1. Texts Demonstrating the Importance of Ecology to God

VI. Solidarity of All Races
VII. Created Wholistically
- A. Humans as Living Souls
- B. Is the Soul Immortal?
- C. Nonbiblical View of Souls
- D. Nonbiblical View of Death

VIII. Expulsion from Eden
- A. No Intermediate State

IX. Great Counterfeit
- A. After-Death Apparitions
- B. God Opposes Spiritism

X. Corporate Victory Over Death
XI. Some Humans in Heaven
XII. Conclusion

Introduction

In the previous chapter we noted that references to creation are found throughout Scripture. To call the historicity or reality of the Genesis creation account into question is to call into question these other Scripture writers. Allowing the *sola-tota-prima Scriptura* principle of interpretation to function, we are able to determine the veracity of the Genesis account. Therefore, Genesis is not subject to any external critique, whether it be Near Eastern creation stories or modern evolutionary theory, for the Genesis creation account is subject to the testimony of Scripture. Scripture states that humans were created by God through Jesus Christ (John 1:1–4, 14; Col. 1:15–17; Heb. 1:1–2), and also says the humanity of Jesus was "created" by the Holy Spirit through Mary (Matt. 1:20).

The writer of Hebrews quotes Psalm 8:4–6 (NKJV) in which David speaks about the "son of man" with reference to the creation of humans (hence the psalm is referred to as a psalm of creation).[2] The writer of Hebrews follows the original intent about the "son of man" in creation (Heb. 2:6–7) and goes on to compare the original creation of humans with the incarnation-creation of the "Son of man" (humanity of Christ). So we have two levels of God's supernatural creation in this passage. The comparison indicates that the first creation of humans is no less supernatural than the creation of the humanity of Christ. The author makes no distinction when comparing the creation of humans and the incarnation of Christ. Ponder the evidence:

> It is not to angels that he [Christ] has subjected the world to come, about which we are speaking. But there is a place where someone has testified [referring to Psalm 8:4–6]: "What is mankind that you are mindful of them, a son of man that you care for him? You made them a little lower that the angels; you crowned them with glory and honor and put everything under their feet." In putting everything under them, God left nothing that is not subject to them. Yet at present we do not see everything subject to him. But we do see Jesus, who was made a little lower than the angels for a little while, now crowned with glory and honor because he suffered death, so that

2. Peter C. Craigie, *Psalms 1–50*, vol. 19 in *Word Biblical Commentary* (Waco, TX: Word, 1983), 106.

by the grace of God he might taste death for everyone. In bringing many sons and daughters to glory, it was fitting that God, for whom and through whom everything exists, should make the pioneer of their salvation perfect through what he suffered. (Heb. 2:5–10)

SON OF MAN (Ps. 8:4–6; Heb. 2:6–8)	**SON OF MAN** (Heb. 2:9)
Humans	**Jesus Christ (God-Man)**
• made a little lower than angels	• made a little lower than angels
• crowned him with glory and honor	• crowned Him with glory and honor
• not all things under his feet (8b)	• not all things under His feet
• all things were under his feet (8a)	• all things to be under His feet (1:13)

If humans are the product of evolution, then so is Christ's humanity, for He assumed human nature in His incarnation. Contrary to that view, the writer of Hebrews presents the supernatural acts of God as consistent throughout, which means the creation of humans is just as much a supernatural act of God as His crowning of humans with glory and honor, and putting everything under their feet before their fall; and just as much a supernatural act as the incarnation of Christ, and crowning of Him with glory and honor, and in the future putting everything under His feet. No wonder David exclaimed to God, "I praise you because I am fearfully and wonderfully made" (Ps. 139:14).

In this context, it is worth recalling Francis Schaefer's "A Christian Manifesto." With reference to the evolutionary worldview (which is essential to the Marxist worldview), he declares: "Their concept of Man is what Man is not, just as their concept of the final reality is what final reality is not." Schaefer continues:

> They have reduced Man to even less than his natural finiteness by seeing him only as a complex arrangement of molecules, made complex by blind chance...they see Man in his essence only as an intrinsically competitive animal, that has no other basic operating principle than natural selection brought about by the strongest, the fittest, ending on top. And they see Man as acting in this way both individually and collectively as society.[3]

While it is true that certainly "the fate of human beings is like that of the animals; the same fate awaits them both: As one dies, so dies the other. All have the same breath; humans have no advantage over animals...all come from dust, and to dust all return" (Eccles. 3:19–20). But God has "set eternity in the human heart" (Eccles. 3:11a), which is not true of animals. Humans can speak, reason, read, and worship. They have a vertical relationship with God, unlike

3. Francis Schaefer, *The Complete Works of Francis Schaefer: A Christian Worldview of the West*, 2nd ed. (Westchester, IL: Crossway, 1982), 5:428.

that of the rest of creation. Hence, "one thing that elevates us above the animal world, in addition to the God-given sense of eternity, is the desire to understand the whole.... This is an aspect of our creation in the likeness of God, who alone embraces the whole."[4] This means "his Creator has made him a thinking being, and he wants to pass beyond his fragmentary knowledge and discern the fuller meaning of the whole pattern."[5] This is why the biblical worldview, which embraces God's total plan, is so important for theological study (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 1, chapter 10; volume 2, chapters 8–16). These chapters are an important background to all our study in this system.

This text (Eccles. 3:11a) also means "his innermost wants cannot be satisfied by that which is temporal."[6] Humans were created in the image of God, and as such they were created for an intimate relationship with God. This means they cannot find lasting fulfillment in things of this fallen world. And so they hope in the future new world when God will dwell with them (Rev. 21:1–4). As Augustine puts it so beautifully, "Thou [Creator] hast formed us for Thyself, and our hearts are restless till they find rest in Thee."[7] This sets humans far apart from animals.

Creation of Adam and Eve

COSMIC CONTEXT

We need to put the creation of humans in the context of all God's known creation throughout space, realizing that there may be a staggering vastness beyond. Ponder the immensity of what we know about the created universe:

> Humanity's home is located in the Milky Way Galaxy. This spiral galaxy measures about 120,000 light-years across and consists of about 200 billion stars. Yet the Milky Way Galaxy is only one small galaxy in a collection of 27 galaxies spanning 3 million light-years. Together they comprise but a small fraction of the universe, which contains roughly 200 billion galaxies. Each galaxy includes an average of about 100 billion stars, making a total of about 20 billion trillion stars. As an infinitesimal part of the universe, Earth's smallness seems incomprehensible. But there, in its midst, stands man.[8]

4. J. Stafford Wright, *Ecclesiastes*, vol. 5 of *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1991), 1162.

5. John Jarick, *Gregory Thaumaturgos' Paraphrase of Ecclesiastes* (Atlanta, GA: Scholars Press, 1990), 65.

6. C. F. Keil and F. Delitzsch, *Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs*, vol. 6, pt. 3 in *Commentary on the Old Testament in Ten Volumes* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1986), 261.

7. Augustine, *Confessions*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Philip Schaff, First Series (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), 1:45 (1.1).

8. Fazale Rana with Hugh Ross, *Who Was Adam?: A Creation Model Approach to the Origin of Man* (Colorado Springs, CO: NavPress, 2005), 20.

Although David's view of the heavens was far less complete than the spectacular view the Hubble space telescope presents to us today, he still exclaimed: "When I consider your heavens, the work of your fingers, the moon and the stars, which you have set in place, what is mankind that you are mindful of them, human beings that you care for them? You have made them a little lower than the angels and crowned them with glory and honor. You made them rulers over the works of your hands; you put everything under their feet" (Ps. 8:3–6).

We need to ponder for a few moments the creation of humans in the context of evolutionary theory. In his book *Wonderful Life*, Stephen Jay Gould said humanity is "a thing so small in a vast universe, a wildly improbable evolutionary event."[9] Scientists from McGill University in Montreal, Canada, and from Michigan State University modeled the evolutionary process with computer simulations; they discovered that each time evolution took a different path. So Fazale Rana and Hugh Ross conclude that "Historical contingency drives away any hope one might derive from thinking evolution 'had humanity in mind' as it began its work 4 billion years ago. Evolution has no 'mind,' no direction, no tendency toward progressive advance. The evolutionary process, rightly understood, might not have produced human beings at all."[10] Humans are here by pure chance. That's how insignificant humans are in the context of all that is. Obviously these two estimates of humans are diametrically opposed, and both cannot be right. This brings us to the biblical account of creation.

CREATION

The Genesis creation record differentiates between Christ as *Elohim* (transcendent, omnipotent God) who creates (*bārā'*) by speaking things into existence in Genesis 1:3, 6, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24, 26, and His added name *Yahweh* (imminent, covenant God), the Christ who forms (*yāṣar*) humans in Genesis 2. *Yahweh* is only added to *Elohim* in Genesis 2:4, after which *Yahweh Elohim* is the name for Christ throughout the rest of Genesis 2.

Yahweh Elohim is the powerful Christ who creates humans up close and personal—in a way distinct from His creation of all the rest of created reality in Genesis 1. There is an important reason for this addition to Christ's name. As the all-powerful transcendent God, He spoke all created realities into existence (Gen. 1:3–2:3). But as the *Yahweh Elohim*, He drew close and formed[11] Adam and breathed the breath of life into him (Gen. 2:7); He then created Eve from

9. Gould quoted in *Who was Adam?*, 22–23. See Stephen Jay Gould, *Wonderful Life: The Burgess Shale and the Nature of History* (New York: Norton, 1989), 291.

10. Rana with Ross, *Who was Adam?*, 23.

11. *yāṣar*; cf. same word used by a potter forming a pot, Jer. 18:1–4.

a rib taken from Adam (Gen. 2:20b–23). The contrast emphasizes the stark distinction between the way humans and the rest of creation were created by Christ. Humans are singled out as unique, just as their being made in the image of God is unique (Gen. 1:26–27). They were not merely the final product of a process, but a hands-on creation by *Yahweh Elohim*. Evolutionary naturalism doesn't do justice to this distinction given in the biblical creation record.

The book of Genesis reveals God as the omnipotent Creator who acts without any dependence upon pre-existing matter, and the book of Exodus reveals God as the omnipotent Deliverer who is not dependent upon anyone or anything. Both creation and deliverance were foundational supernatural acts of God that point to the rest of Scripture and God's other supernatural acts: Christ's incarnation and resurrection, and the Second Coming and general resurrection followed by the creation of a new heavens and a new earth. In the time between creation and the new creation, the supernatural creative and delivering acts of the Holy Spirit in human lives give evidence that the God of Scripture does what He does because He is who He is. *God is no more dependent upon outside help in creation than He is upon human works for salvation.*

We must allow the supernatural acts of God throughout Scripture to interpret the supernatural acts of God in creation. How can those who believe in the inerrancy of Scripture—or as I prefer to speak of it, the trustworthiness of Scripture—question Scripture's first two chapters? How can Evangelicals, who believe in the importance of justification by faith, allow their faith in Scripture to be called into question by the Genesis record? For it is "[b]y faith we understand that the universe was formed at God's command, so that what is seen was not made out of what was visible" (Heb. 11:3). To be consistent one must have as much faith in God as Creator as one has in God as Redeemer.

Creation as God's act must be consistent with His self-existence (source of all life) and His nature (God of love). As Evangelical Christians, who believe God's Word, the revelation of God in Scripture must take priority over any revelation of God in nature. Scripture is God's written revelation and is clearer than God's unwritten revelation in nature. So Scripture has hermeneutical superiority over what one finds in nature. For example, it is impossible to test salvation against the natural world. The same is true of God's miracles: there is a vast void between the Creator and creation.

If the reverse were true, and evidence from nature were allowed to teach us how to interpret the Genesis creation, then we would have a disconnect between Genesis and the rest of Scripture. We cannot *demand* that God use natural means to create in Genesis 1–2 but then *allow* Him to use His supernatural power in later accounts in Scripture. This alone should cause us to

study evolutionary theory more closely to see what kind of God it portrays, and to see if it is consistent with the revelation of God in His supernatural acts throughout the rest of Scripture.

Christ believed in the Genesis creation account; He made reference to it when He fielded a question from the Pharisees about divorce.

> He answered and said to them, "Have you not read that He who made them at the beginning 'made them male and female,' and said, 'For this reason a man shall leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh'? So then, they are no longer two but one flesh. Therefore what God has joined together, let not man separate." (Matt. 19:4–6)

Christ refers to the creation and marriage of Adam and Eve, and He should know because He was the One who created and married them (John 1:2, 14; Col. 1:15–16; Heb. 1:1–2). There is no hint of, nor possibility of, an evolutionary process. Christ simply referred to the creation record in a matter-of-fact mannet. He said that in the beginning the Creator made Adam and Eve, and joined them in marriage. By contrast, the National Academy of Science suggests an evolutionary time line with humans at the end of a five-billion-year, deep-time process. There is a vast difference between humans placed six days into creation week or billions of years into the evolutionary process.[12]

It is fair to say that many who question the Word of God in Genesis 1–2 have gone on to question other supernatural acts of God in Scripture, such as a global flood, the virgin birth, the miracles of Jesus, and Christ's bodily resurrection. But what about those Evangelical Christians who have not followed these critics, who have not descended that slippery slope, who believe in these miracles, and yet cannot accept the creation record as an equally supernatural act of God? It seems to me that they give more credence to the teachings of evolution than is warranted. While belief in biblical creation requires trust in the supernatural inspiration of Scripture, there is also empirical evidence in the trustworthiness of Scripture, such as: (1) fulfillment of prophecies, (2) changed lives, and (3) daily nourishment to live a life of freedom in Christ. All of these are tested by Christians around the world—every day.

Created in the Image of God[13]

God said, "Let us make mankind in our image, in our likeness" (Gen. 1:26). What does it mean to be created in "the image of God"? Do we look

12. See Jonathan Sarfati, *Refuting Evolution: A Response to the National Academy of Sciences' Teaching About Evolution and the Nature of Science*, 2nd ed. (Green Forest, AR: Master Books, 2003), 138.

13. Evolution speaks of the similarities of humans and apes (genetic comparisons), but Scripture speaks about humans made in the image of God. Edward Heppenstall was right: "Man was made in the likeness of God, not in the likeness of the brutes," *Salvation Unlimited: Perspectives in Righteousness by Faith* (Washington, DC: Review and Herald, 1974), 8.

like God? Do we act like God? Do we reflect God? How does God look, and how is He described in Scripture? Although God is a spirit and omnipresent, God has form (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 2), and we are not talking about terms that some argue are anthropomorphic (speaking about God in ways humans can comprehend). The fact is God cannot be understood in His transcendency, but that must not interfere with the fact that God takes real form. Human minds cannot comprehend how God can be omnipresent and yet localized in a specific form at the same time.

In his Genesis commentary, Gerhard von Rad wrote:

> The creation of man is introduced more impressively than any preceding work by the announcement of a divine resolution: "Let us make man." God participates more intimately and intensively in this than in the earlier works of creation. The use of the verb *bārāʾ* in v. 27 receives its fullest significance for that divine creativity which is absolutely without analogy. It occurs three times in the one verse to make clear that here the high point and goal has been reached toward which all God's creativity from v. 1 on was directed.[14]

It bears repeating that the Hebrew word for create, *bārāʾ* is a verb used only with God as the subject, for the transcendent God is the only One who can create humans, and He does so as the immanent God who is up close and personal, forming Adam and Eve Himself. This necessarily rules out a meandering process of natural selection such as evolution posits to explain the development of humans.

In his 1970 lectures to all faculties at the University of Göttingen, Walter Zimmerli noted that "All other works of creation are introduced and called into being one after the other by God's commanding word" (during the days of creation), but "the creation of man begins with the divine reflection: 'Let us make man in our image and likeness.' And the effect of man's special likeness to God is unfolded immediately: he is 'to rule the fish in the sea, the birds of heaven, the cattle, all wild animals on earth, and all reptiles that crawl upon the earth.'"[15]

If the Persons of the Trinity created humans in their image (Gen. 1:26–27), it can be argued persuasively that this is contrary to the evolving of humans from lower levels of life. Note that "image of God" is a unique creative gift from God that is supernatural. This calls into question the theory that God

14. Gerhard von Rad, *Genesis: A Commentary*, trans. John H. Marks (Philadelphia, PA: Westminster, 1961, German ed. 1956), 55.

15. Walter Zimmerli, *The Old Testament and the World*, trans. John J. Scullion, S.J. (London: SPCK, 1976), 24.

used a natural process to form humans, and that the image was something added at the end of the process: an insertion into the body that had been naturally developed, a soul added to the physical frame. The magnificence of God's creation of humans in Scripture sets them radically apart from the rest of creation.

We need to penetrate the linguistic significance of God's momentous words in Genesis: "Let us make man in our image." "The Hebrew here has one verb in the plural, (*naʿăśeh*, 'let us make') and two nouns with plural suffixes (*bĕṣalmēnû*, 'in our image'; *kidmûtēnû*, 'in our likeness'). Since the subject is *ʾĕlōhîm* it is clear that God, who normally is perceived to be singular, is here at least cast in the plural not only grammatically but functionally."[16]

Herman Bavinck is right that the image of God in humans is not something they *bear* or *have*, but what they are. It is "not *something in man* but *man himself*." (I would add the image is not a soul, for the soul is the very person.) Humanity was created in the image of the triune God. We were not created in the image of Christ, but Christ was made in human likeness (Rom. 8:3; Phil. 2:7–8; Heb. 2:14), even though humans "conformed to the image of Christ, are now again becoming like God (Rom. 8:29; 1 Cor. 15:49; 2 Cor. 3:18; Phil. 3:21; Eph. 4:24; Col. 3:10; 1 John 3:2)."[17]

Does creation in the image of God mean that Adam and Eve were exactly like God? To be created exactly like God is by definition impossible, for God was never created. The fact that God has lived eternally in the past means He is infinitely different from any beings created in His image. To be created means to have a beginning; God never had a beginning. That's a quantitative comparison, and human history is hardly a second of time in the expanse of endless eternity.

But what are some of the qualitative differences? God created everything there is. He sustains everything He created. He provides life to all that He created. He is present throughout all space, and He knows every future event. He is all powerful in His dominion over everything throughout the universe. We are none of these things.

So how are we like God? In this segment, we will explore some of the qualitative differences between God and humans.

16. Eugene H. Merrill, "Is the Doctrine of the Trinity Implied in the Genesis Creation Account?" in *The Genesis Debate: Three Views on the Days of Creation*, ed. David G. Hagopian (Mission Viejo, CA: Crux, 2001), 120–121.

17. Herman Bavinck, *God and Creation*, vol. 2 in *Reformed Dogmatics*, ed. John Bolt, trans. John Vriend (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2004), 555, emphasis in original.

IMAGE OF THE TRINITY

The first person created by Christ was Adam (Gen. 2:7, 15, 18, 20–23). The word for Adam (*ʾādām*) is from the Hebrew word *ʾădāmâ*, meaning "earth."[18] The word *ʾādām* also means the human race.[19] So, although Adam is the male, the word *ʾādām* is not gender exclusive, but gender inclusive. It encompasses male and female. Adam is not so much a name as a collective noun referring to humankind.

When "God said, 'Let us make mankind in our image, in our likeness'" (Gen. 1:26), the word "man" is no more gender exclusive than the word "God" is exclusive to one member of the Trinity. The plurality of the Creator is emphasized in the Hebrew of Genesis 1:2b, as the Father makes worlds through the Son. Also, consider Ecclesiastes 12:1a in the original Hebrew, which says literally, "remember ones creating you." "So God created mankind in his own image, in the image of God he created him; male and female he created them" (Gen. 1:27). As male and female the first humans in their relationship with each other imaged the relationship among the three Persons of the Trinity. Just as the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit live in mutual love for each other, so male and female were to image God in their relationship of love for each other. The relational Trinity were to be imaged in humans being relational.

The fact that Adam was created first does not suggest his superiority over Eve. As Aecio Cairus rightly says, "In the biblical accounts of woman's creation, however, the story does not move from superior to inferior. In Genesis 1 the movement is the opposite, from lower creatures to higher ones; and in Genesis 2 it goes from incompleteness to wholeness. Physical derivation does not imply subordination; man is not subordinate to the ground." Eve was created from the rib of Adam. The word rib (Heb. *ṣēlāʿ*) is also rendered "side" "as in the symmetrical counterpart to a leaf of a double door (1 Kings 6:34), the matching second wing of a building (Ex. 26:26, 27), the opposite slope of a mountain (2 Sam. 16:13)"; and Eve as a "helper" for Adam comes from the Hebrew word *ʿēzer*, which never means subservience, but "can mean 'support' or 'benefactor,' and is regularly used of God, who helps human beings (Ps. 33:20; cf. Ps. 54:4)."[20]

The fact that the *rib* was taken from the side of Adam seems to symbolize that Eve was a companion by the side of Adam, to be his "suitable helper" (Gen. 2:20b). Eve was not formed from part of Adam's head or feet, to be superior or inferior to Adam. The equality is best represented by the fact that they were one flesh. Adam said, "This is now bone of my bones and flesh of my flesh; she

18. Keil and Delitzsch, *The Pentateuch*, vol. 1 of *Commentary on the Old Testament*, 80.

19. Gordon J. Wenham, *Genesis*, vol. 1 of *Word Biblical Commentary* (Waco, TX: Word, 1987), lii.

20. Aecio E. Cairus, "The Doctrine of Man," in *Handbook of Seventh-day Adventist Theology*, vol. 12 in *Commentary Reference Series* (Hagerstown, MD: Review and Herald, 2000), 210.

shall be called 'woman,' for she was taken out of man. That is why [in subsequent history] a man leaves his father and mother and is united to his wife, and they become one flesh" (Gen. 2:23–24). Collectively Adam and Eve imaged the equality in the Trinity.

Another way Adam and Eve imaged the Trinity was in their function. Whereas each member of the Trinity can do the same things, but chooses to divide up the work for practical reasons, to a degree Adam and Eve mirror this by the different functions each performs. Only the woman carries the unborn, for example. Just as God the Father, the Spirit, and the Son had different functions in creation so male and female have different roles in procreation. The different God-created functions of male and female image the different God-chosen functions of the Trinity.

IMAGE AS DOMINION

Ecofeminists "believe in the central belief of the essential convergence between women and nature because (1) biological makeup of women associates them more than men with the natural functions of reproduction and nurturing; and (2) women and nature have in common their exploitation by men both economically and in being objectified and politically marginalized."[21] They state that males have wrongly seized dominion over females and all else. This dominion, they claim, was self-appointed, selfish, and without appropriate respect for females. Consider the words of feminist Rosemary Radford Ruether:

> We need to recognize more seriously the latecomer status of humans to the planet, arising in the last 100,000 years of a 450,000 million-year earth history, not to mention an 18 billion-year history of the cosmos. Looked at from this perspective, it is absurd to say that the God of earth's creation gave humans dominion over this planet, much less over the cosmos, unless one believes that this 4.5 billion (or 18 billion)-year history of evolution was intentionally guided only for our very recent emergence as a species, with its achievement of a cancerous growth that is threatening the biotic life of this whole planet. Perhaps it is more appropriate to say that dominion is a usurpation given to (male) humans neither by animals nor by God. The God who gave (western male) humans dominion arose at a recent and particular context in human history. It is not by divine right. Dominant males need to begin by recognizing its shaky foundations and by seeking to consult with women.[22]

From a biblical perspective, one needs to say that the above reasoning is itself on shaky ground. Consider the clarity and fairness of the biblical record. After

21. "Ecofeminism," accessed July 2, 2012, http://stmarys.ca/~evanderveen/wvdv/environment/ecofeminism.htm.

22. Rosemary Radford Ruether, "Men, Women, and Beasts: Relations to Animals in Western Culture," in *Good News for Animals?: Christian Approaches to Animal Well-Being*, ed. Charles Pinches and Jay B. McDaniel (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 1993), 22.

God said, "Let us make mankind in our image, in our likeness," He continued by saying, "so that they may rule over the fish in the sea and the birds in the sky, over the livestock and all the wild animals, and over all the creatures that move along the ground" (Gen. 1:26). They were to exert careful dominion over planet earth in the same way that God has loving dominion over all things. Their dominion was limited to this world, and had nothing to do with the cosmos. Did you notice that *Adam and Eve were both* given this dominion? *Male and female together* were to share in this co-rule, even as each member of the Trinity shares in their co-rule. Here again, the equality of Adam and Eve is understood. As Luther said, "Eve, too, was made by God as a partaker of the divine image."[23]

Were Adam and Eve prepared to rule? After all, they had no experience, and yet they were adults on day one. Christ endowed humans with gifts to accomplish this mission, just as He endowed them with fully developed speech and a complete vocabulary. "God blessed them and said to them, 'Be fruitful and increase in number; fill the earth and subdue it. Rule over the fish in the sea and the birds in the sky and over every living creature that moves on the ground'" (Gen. 1:28). At creation humans, by nature, were given the ability to rule over everything on planet earth. They perfectly reflected the loving nature of their Creator. They had not arisen from the animal kingdom through survival of the fittest, or they would have manifested a victor's triumph over the animals. Rather, they came from the Creator and were made in the image of the Trinity, endowed with their relational love, to love one another, and to love all other created beings in the animal kingdom. (One should add that the equality of Adam and Eve, which imaged the equality of the three in the Trinity, is a creation ordinance, and is foundational to understanding biblical anthropology.)

Since Adam and Eve were given dominion over a perfect world, one can make the case that there is an even greater need for this rule today. Dominion needs a careful environmental concern which will guide an appropriate stewardship of creation for the Creator (see segment below titled "Importance of Ecology"). Of all persons, Christians who live under the dominion of Jesus Christ will support efforts to achieve a wise ecological protection of planet earth and its environment as fulfilling the original dominion given humans when made in the image of God (Gen. 1:26). The human race has not done a good job in this respect. That is why in the Second Advent God will destroy "those who destroy the earth" (Rev. 11:18).

23. Martin Luther, *Lectures on Genesis 1–5*, vol. 1 in *Luther's Works* (Saint Louis, MO: Concordia, 1958), 69.

IMAGE AS PHYSICAL

Although Moses speaks of seeing God's feet (Exod. 24:9–11) and back (Exod. 33:20–23), it is also true that "God is spirit" (John 4:24), omnipresent (1 Kings 8:27; Ps. 139:7–10), and thus not confined to a body. Since He became human, Christ is the only one of the Trinity so confined.[24] It is traditionally argued that speaking of God in human terms, like mentioning parts of His body, is anthropomorphic because it merely attempts to describe God in human terms which fail to do justice to Him. However, it should also be argued that God has taken physical form, as when the Father installed the Son as a mediator between the infinite Trinity and finite created beings. Consider also the theophanies of Christ as "Michael the archangel" and as a human prior to His incarnation into human form (see my *Systematic Theology,* volume 2, chapter 8).

With respect to the Old Testament, Christ, though being "the image of the invisible God" (Col. 1:15) and "the exact representation of his being" (Heb. 1:3), could take human physical form even before He became human. Then, on a deeper level, just as Christ created Adam and Eve in the image of God, so the Holy Spirit would make Christ in the image of humans through Mary. Christ remained the God-Man after His resurrection. He invited doubting Thomas to place his hands in His side (John 20:26–29). Christ ascended bodily to heaven, where today He is with the other members of the Trinity as the God-Man. One would assume that the present human form of Jesus is compatible with His pre-incarnation form. In other words, perhaps all humans are made in a physical form that allowed the pre-incarnate Christ to become human, and forever as the God-Man be compatible in form with the other members of the Trinity (keeping in mind that the Father and the Spirit also have an omnipresent spiritual presence as well). Perhaps this is the limit of our understanding in the present, but in the new earth we will discover much more about this topic. We know that the Trinity will live in covenant communion with the Redeemed in the new earth: "God himself will be with them and be their God" (Rev. 21:3). Whatever it takes to make this a meaningful relationship will be accomplished by the relational Trinity.

Old Testament scholar Gerhard von Rad says: "The marvel of man's bodily appearance is not at all to be excepted from the realm of God's image. This was the original notion, and we have no reason to suppose that it completely gave way, in P's theological reflection, to a spiritualizing and intellectualizing tendency. Therefore, one will do well to split the physical form from the spiritual as

24. We will take this up in the next loci on Christology.

little as possible: the whole man is created in God's image." Von Rad indicates that Ezekiel 28:12 and Psalm 8 point "decisively to the physical."[25] And von Rad is not alone in this conviction, as we will see below. One needs to be open to this possibility in light of what we have said above.

IMAGE AS CHARACTER

Adam and Eve also imaged God in terms of character: "God created mankind upright" (Eccles. 7:29), for man was "created to be like God in true righteousness and holiness" (Eph. 4:24). Just as each member of the Trinity is in relationship with God, so humans made in the "image of God" were made to have a relationship with God. Humans were made with the capacity to enter into a meaningful relationship with God. That's why they were given an intellect with reasoning powers and a conscience—in order to respond to God. The fact that God "set eternity in the human heart" (Eccles. 3:11a) and the fact that this is discernible today give evidence that the image of God was defaced but not destroyed in the Fall.

How do humans enter into a relationship with God? They must of necessity be spiritual in nature. They are not a spirit like God, but humans are spiritual (in their sphere) like God is spiritual (in His infinitely greater sphere). So what separates humans from animals? Spiritual and mental attributes separate humans from animals. None of the animals were created in the image of God or had the ability to enter into a spiritual and rational relationship with God. (We don't see dogs praying or cats singing in worship.) Since the Fall, most humans who live out of their carnal nature, with a dead spiritual nature, seem no more able to relate to God than brutes. That indicates human need. The good news is that a vestige of the image of God is left in many seemingly hopeless humans, for God can cause even hardened criminals to experience a new birth and a restoration of the image of God within them.

Adam and Eve were created in the image of God by sharing in the communicable attributes of God. God's relationship with them meant that God imparted Himself to them through His presence in and with them, and the impartation of His attributes. It is these attributes that formed their character and made them to be who they were (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 2, on communicable attributes).

25. von Rad, *Genesis: A Commentary*, 56.

IMAGE AS COMMUNION

Of course, being made in the character of God includes having the ability to commune with God. Adam and Eve were equipped with a spiritual nature and a mind with which to think. But even spiritual and intellectual abilities wouldn't be sufficient if humans were unable to talk. The ability to articulate thoughts and to communicate deep spiritual experience gives humans the ability to worship their Creator. Worship is an expression of the deepest emotions, and is a unique expression of human nature; it is simply not found anywhere else in God's creation on planet earth. Adam and Eve alone were gifted with a full range of good emotions and a full vocabulary to express them. They began life in fellowship with and worship of Christ their Creator.

IMAGE AS FREEDOM TO CHOOSE

In giving humans freedom to choose, God made them in His image. One use of freedom of choice was Adam's naming of all the animals (Gen. 2:19–20). Without the freedom of choice, the other gifts of dominion, procreation, and relationship with God would be meaningless. The freedom to choose is only fully exercised when there are options from which to choose: "And the LORD God commanded the man, 'You are free to eat from any tree in the garden; but you must not eat from the tree of knowledge of good and evil, for when you eat of it you will certainly die'" (Gen. 2:16–17). This wasn't a difficult test, for "the LORD God made all kinds of trees grow out of the ground—trees that were pleasing to the eye and good for food" (Gen. 2:9). They could choose whether to obey or ignore God's warning about the forbidden tree (Gen. 2:16–17). His warning was an utter waste of time if Adam and Eve didn't have the freedom to make a choice between two competing options.

Christ, in His pre-incarnate function as Creator of Adam and Eve, introduced the concept of conditionality right up-front—at the beginning of their existence. The essence of His message was: (1) if you don't eat the forbidden fruit you will live, but (2) if you eat the forbidden fruit you will die. So conditionality was a part of their sinless life in Paradise, prior to the Fall. Where there is conditionality, there human choice has meaning; sovereign predestination requires human response. If all created beings had their destiny decided by God, apart from their freedom to choose, that would mean that God is responsible for the rebellion of Satan and the angels and for the rebellion of humans.[26] If humans have no freedom to choose,

26. This would mean that the cosmic controversy charge of the enemy against God is upheld, and the controversy cannot be resolved.

they would not bear the image of God, who most certainly has the freedom to choose (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapters 15 and 16).

Orthodox theologian Georgios Mantzaridis notes,

> Free will—considered by Basil the Great, Gregory of Nyssa, John of Damascus, and other Church Fathers to be the crucial component of that which is "in the image"—is seen likewise by Palamas as the great prerogative of man fashioned in the image of God. It was of essential importance before the fall, and the realization of God's plan for man continues to depend on human free will even after the coming of Christ and the accomplishment of His mission of regeneration.[27]

IMAGE REMAINS

After humans were created in the "likeness of God," Adam "had a son in his own likeness" (Gen. 5:1–3). Does this mean the remnant of the image of God isn't transmitted to offspring in a post-Fall world? If that were so, then all that the image means would only apply to the pre-Fall Adam and Eve. Consider the following: "As Adam was created in the image of God, so did he beget '*in his own likeness, after his image*;' that is to say, he transmitted the image of God in which he was created, not in the purity in which it came direct from God, but in the form given to it by his own self-determination, modified and corrupted by sin."[28]

The Hebrew language states a prohibition in two ways: (1) *lō'* with the indicative; and (2) *'al* with the jussive. The first is a categorical prohibition, binding forever. We find it used in the second table of the Ten Commandments (Exod. 20:13–17). The sixth commandment says, "You shall not murder" (Exod. 20:13), and God explained to Noah why this was so: "Whoever sheds human blood, by humans shall their blood be shed; for in the image of God had God made mankind" (Gen. 9:6). That would have no meaning if the image of God in humans had been destroyed in the Fall. Paul wrote, "A man ought not to cover his head, since he is the image and glory of God" (1 Cor. 11:7a). James said, "With the tongue we praise our Lord and Father, and with it we curse human beings, who have been made in God's likeness [image] (Jas. 3:9). These verses indicate that although the image of God has been damaged, it has not been destroyed.[29]

Scripture states that even pagans (Gentiles) "show that the requirements of the law are written on their hearts" (Rom. 2:15). God is the light that

27. Georgios I. Mantzaridis, *The Deification of Man: St. Gregory Palamas and Orthodox Tradition* (Cresswood, NY: St. Vladimir's Seminary Press, 1984), 20.

28. Keil and Delitzsch, *The Pentateuch*, vol. 1 of *Commentary on the Old Testament*, 124.

29. Some scholars believe that only *males* bear the image of God. They base this on the full text of 1 Corinthians 11:7: "A man ought not to cover his head, since he is the image and glory of God; but the woman is the glory of man." If that were so, then God would only punish a person who murdered a man and not one who murdered a woman; yet He declared, "Whoever sheds human blood, by humans shall their blood be shed; for in the image of God has God made mankind" (Gen. 9:6).

enlightens everyone coming into the world (John 1:9; cf. 2 Cor. 4:6), and He does so through the image of God within each person. The Greek suggests that this translation—as well as Christ's coming into the world as its light—are both grammatically correct. "And we all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed [*metamorphoumetha*] into the same image [*eikona*] from one degree of glory to another. For this comes from the Lord who is the Spirit" (2 Cor. 3:18, ESV). Salvation is a process that includes the Spirit's restoration of the image of God in humans through all of God's communicable moral attributes.[30]

On the basis of the above verses, I concur with Victor Hamilton's conclusion about Genesis 9:6: "There is no evidence here that sin has effaced the divine image. It is still resident in post-Flood, post-paradise man."[31] David Clines of Sheffield University agrees, saying that "even after the Flood, man is made as the image of God."[32] Bruce Demarest is right to call humans throughout Scripture "wayward image bearers."[33]

God created humans with autonomy, with the freedom to choose (Gen. 2:16–17; 3:1–6). This autonomy has not been destroyed by the Fall, but as Scripture documents, most humans use their freedom to rebel against God. Yet the good news is that humans can respond to the gospel invitation. That is why God seeks humans throughout history, calling them to repent and come to Him for salvation. If humans are utterly unable to respond to God because they no longer bear the image of God, then the work of the Creator-Redeemer to win humans to salvation would be an utter waste of time. The fact that humans retain the image of God, though damaged, is important to our understanding of the doctrine of salvation (see chapters 14–17).

The image of God in the human soul, the power to choose, doesn't require predestination through God's choice alone (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapters 15–16). For God's choice, without input from human choice, is the driving force behind the doctrine of God's eternal decree or decrees. Predestination is grounded in an alleged human inability to respond to God due to the fact that the image of God in humanity has been destroyed (doctrine of total depravity). If God had made humans so fragile that the image of God could be destroyed through the Fall, then He would have failed to prepare humans for their post-Fall

30. See C. Gordon Olson, *Beyond Calvinism and Arminianism: An Inductive Mediate Theology of Salvation* (Cedar Knolls, NJ: 2002), 87.

31. Victor P. Hamilton, *The Book of Genesis, Chapters 1–17*, in *The New International Commentary on the Old Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1990), 314–315.

32. David J. A. Clines, "Noah's Flood: 1: The Theology of the Flood Narrative," *Faith and Thought* 100/2 (1972–1973): 139; and "The Image of God in Man," *Tyndale Bulletin*, 19 (1968): 53–103.

33. Bruce Demarest, *The Cross and Salvation: The Doctrine of Salvation* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 1997), 25.

experience in which human choice is so important in the Christian life and to covenant fellowship with God.

Subordination Debate

God said "Let us make mankind (*'ādām*) in our image, in our likeness and let them rule...over all the earth" (Gen. 1:26). Some scholars believe that because Adam and Eve were designated as "man," this indicates male headship over the woman. However, as mentioned before, the word *'ādām* means "humankind."[34] Moreover, "the word *'ādām* never means 'man' (in the sense or implication of male gender) in Scripture."[35] God's words to Adam and Eve (Gen. 1:26–28) are a creation ordinance that supports total equality. Both are created in the image of God, both are given dominion to rule over the earth (not one to rule over the other), both were blessed, and both were to participate in a posterity. Beyond these, their shared relationship was to image the reciprocal relationship in the Trinity.

It is agreed that males and females, though equal, have different functions. As such the Nicene Council (325) agreed that the Persons of the Trinity were equal, but the Father was the Father of the Son, and the Son was the Son of the Father. All three in the Trinity have different roles (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 3). Some scholars, including Augustus Strong (1907),[36] Charles Hodge (1970),[37] Wayne Grudem (1994),[38] and Bruce Ware (2001), believe there is an eternal subordination in the Trinity of Son and Spirit to the Father.[39] Other scholars, including Gilbert Bilezikian (1997),[40] Kevin Giles (2002),[41] and Millard Erickson (2009)[42] to name a few, reject the idea of eternal subordination.

34. Victor P. Hamilton, "*'ādām*," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology and Exegesis*, 1:262.

35. Richard M. Davidson, *Flame of Yahweh: Sexuality in the Old Testament* (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2007), 23.

36. Augustus H. Strong, *Systematic Theology* (Philadelphia, PA: Judson, 1949, 1st ed. 1907), 342, compares man as head over woman as Father is over subordinate Son, while both are equal.

37. Charles Hodge, *Systematic Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1970), 460.

38. Wayne Grudem, *Systematic Theology: An Introduction to Biblical Doctrine* (Leicester, England: InterVarsity; Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1994), 248–252. He says, "the Father and the Son relate to one another as a father and son relate to one another in a human family: the father direcrs and has authority over the son, and the son obeys," 249.

39. Bruce A. Ware, "Tampering With the Trinity: Does the Son Submit to His Father?", *Journal for Biblical Manhood & Womanhood*, vol. 6., no. 1 (Spring 2001): 9. See also by Ware, *Father, Son, and Holy Spirit: Relationship, Roles, and Relevance* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2005). He argues that "the Father is, in his position and authority, supreme among the Persons of the Godhead," 46. Ware refers to "the authority-submission relationship that marks their roles and responsibilities for all eternity," 131.

40. Gilbert Bilezikian, "Hermeneutical Bungee-Jumping: Subordination in the Godhead," *Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society* 40, no. 1 (March 1997). "Christ's self-humiliation..." (not subordination) was "an interim or temporary state" during His incarnation, 59.

41. Kevin Giles, *The Trinity & Subordinationism: The Doctrine of God & the Contemporary Gender Debate* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2002).

42. Millard J. Erickson, *Who's Tampering with the Trinity: An Assessment of the Subordination Debate* (Grand Rapids, MI: Kregel, 2009). See also his *Christian Theology*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1998), 363.

Grudem argues for the eternal subordination of the Son to the authority of the Father on the basis of the "unchangeableness of God."[43] In other words, the immutability of God requires that the Son be eternally the Son—or else the incarnation would have been a change for the Father and the Son. Grudem says:

> This truth about the Trinity has sometimes been summarized in the phrase "ontological equality but economic subordination," where the word *ontological* means "being." Another way of expressing this more simply would be to say "equal in being but subordinate in role." Both parts of this phrase are necessary to a true doctrine of the Trinity: If we do not have ontological equality, not all the persons are fully God. But if we do not have economic subordination, then there is no inherent difference in the way the three persons relate to one another, and consequently we do not have the three distinct persons existing as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit for all eternity. For example, if the Son is not eternally subordinate to the Father in role, then the Father is not eternally "Father" and the Son is not eternally "Son." This would mean that the Trinity has not eternally existed.[44]

The above reasoning fails to realize that the terms *Father* and *Son* applied to God are no more literal than the description of angels as sons of God (in Job 38:7, compare "angels" [NIV] with "sons of God" [ESV]). Nor is it any more literal than God's saying, "I am Israel's father, and Ephraim [Israel] is my firstborn son" (Jer. 31:9b). Christians are called "children of the Most High" (Luke 6:35b). The terms *Father* and *Son* used of God are only relevant in the plan of salvation when Christ was born the Son of Man (Luke 6:6; cf. 3:22) and called God "Father" (John 17:1). Even then it can be argued that the "father function" (as far as Christ's birth is concerned) belonged more to the Holy Spirit than to the Father (Matt. 1:20). (As seen in my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 3, these roles of father and son will have no meaning in future eternity.) What the eternal subordination view does is to transfer the reality of Christ's incarnational life back into past eternity and forward into future eternity without any biblical support, driven by the Greek view of God's immutability.

This is a major error caused by a nonbiblical philosophical idea. For if the second Person of the Trinity is eternally the Son of the Father in past and future eternity, this means He is derived from the Father, and hence He is somehow less than the Father. This calls into question His full divinity. On the basis of the biblical evidence (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 1), the three Persons of the Trinity are equally divine. For each one has eternal pre-existence that is self-existence, each has eternal life that is original, unborrowed, and underived. Therefore there is no such thing as eternal subordination either of the Son or the Spirit in Scripture. To think so is to unwittingly question the divinity of the Son

43. Grudem, *Systematic Theology*, 250.
44. Ibid., 251.

and Spirit. By contrast, the three Persons of the Trinity are fully and forever God, without any human qualifications. They are three Persons in one Godhead; they are not one without the other. This unity in the One Godhead transcends tritheism. The reciprocal love of the three Persons of the Trinity means full equality among them from eternity to eternity. It is this reciprocal love among the Trinity that is reflected in Adam and Eve as created in the image of God. Hence Adam and Eve were created fully equal, with no subordination of one to another.

Subordination on both levels (divine and human) would never have been a reality apart from the fall of humans. Sin severed the relationship of humans from God, and from one another. And the sin problem necessitated the temporary subordination of Christ during His incarnation. He was dependent upon the Father and Spirit because He lived on earth as a dependent human in order to be a sympathetic High Priest, one who understood human temptations (Phil. 2:6–11; Heb. 4:14–16; 5:7).

Whereas most commentators through the centuries have taught male leadership because of women's supposed inferior nature,[45] this is not what Genesis 2 presents (even though most think otherwise). Genesis 2 is a carefully structured passage, using the Hebrew *inclusio* device, in which the creation of man at the beginning and woman at the end "correspond to each other in importance," even using the same number of Hebrew words. As Davidson concludes, "The movement in Gen 2 is not from superior to inferior or from leadership to submission but from incompleteness to completeness."[46]

Adam and Eve in their completeness imaged the completeness of the reciprocal Trinity, because in both relationships there was mutual love which knows no hierarchy or subordination. (We will visit this perspective again when discussing the role of women in church leadership in my *Systematic Theology*, volume 4.)

Importance of Ecology: In a Theological System

INTRODUCTION

Is the relationship between humans and animals based on their (1) creation by God, or their (2) evolution by natural means? In other words, is the relationship vertical or horizontal? Many Christians, interested in ecology, focus on an

45. See Kevin Giles, *The Trinity and Subordinationism: The Doctrine of God and the Contemporary Gender Debate* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2002), 145–155.
46. Richard M. Davidson, *Flame of Yahweh*, 27. I find Davidson's exegesis on this subject to be compelling and crucial.

alleged horizontal relationship in the evolutionary process. They assume that humans do not have dominion over animals or nature, because they are fellow animals, albeit with more intelligence and made in the image of God.

Richard Bauckham states that the "loss of the horizontal relationship, in effect treating humans as gods in relation to the world, was, we shall argue, probably the most fateful development in Christian attitudes to the nonhuman creation. Only with this development did interpretation of Genesis 1:28 take its place in the ideology of aggressive domination of nature that has characterized the modern West."[47] Medieval historian Lynn White, Jr., wrote a famous and persuasive article titled "The Historical Roots of our Ecologic Crisis." He blamed Genesis 1:26, 28 for making Christianity the most anthropocentric religion in human history, and the cause of the modern ecological crisis.[48]

Although some scholars blame Christianity for ecological problems because of the belief in human dominion over nature (Gen. 1:28), the Genesis text does not command humans to destroy or abuse the planet. Created in the image of God, humankind was meant to exert a dominion over creation that images God's loving dominion over the cosmos (1 John 4:8–16). Francis of Assisi, patron saint of ecology, represents this kind of benevolent relationship with animals and nature in general.[49] As James Nash put it, humans "practice dominion properly when they care for God's creation benevolently and justly in accord with the will of the ultimate owner."[50]

Bauckham argues that the Renaissance humanists, absorbed with the supreme dignity of humanity, emphasized the vertical almost to the exclusion of the horizontal relationship between humans and nature. Human nature, with its deification in Eastern Christology, posited the idea that humans, unlike nature, can transcend their present status. Bauckham believes this gave birth to the modern view of the unlimited domination of nature by humans.[51] Based on his understanding of Genesis 1:28, Francis Bacon (1561–1626) viewed the goal of science as implementing human dominion over nature.[52] In his doctoral dissertation, Stephen Bauer commented on the rise of technology, resulting in "those who would

47. Richard Bauckham, *God and the Crisis of Freedom: Biblical and Contemporary Perspectives* (London: Westminster John Knox, 2002), 128.

48. Lynn White, Jr., "The Historical Roots of our Ecologic Crisis," *Science* 155 (1967): 1203–1207; Bauckham, *God and the Crisis*, 129–130.

49. See Marion A. Habig, *St. Francis of Assisi; Writings and Early Biographies: English Omnibus of the Sources for the Life of St. Francis* (Chicago: Franciscan Herald, 1973); L. Boff, *Saint Francis: A Model for Human Liberation* (London: SCM, 1982).

50. James A. Nash, *Loving Nature: Ecological Integrity and Christian Responsibility* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 1991), 105. On divine image and dominion as "responsible representation," see 102–108.

51. Bauckham, *God and the Crisis*, 154–157.

52. Francis Bacon, *The Works of Francis Bacon*, ed. Spedding, R. L. Ellis, and D. D. Heath (London: Longman, 1857–1858). See also Bauckham, *God and the Crisis*, 159.

try to express a theology of dominion compatible with Bacon's bold vision."[53] He cites Robert Boyle (1627–1691), Sir Mathew Hale (1609–1676), William Derham (1657–1735), Cotton Mather (1663–1728), and the Puritans, who all stressed the domination of humans over animals.[54]

ECOLOGICAL THEOLOGY

After White's article, John Davis evaluated twenty Evangelical theological systems published from 1970 to 2000, finding that most of them have theological "blind spots" manifested in "the neglect of environmental issues and environmental stewardship"; he attributes these blind spots to "deficiencies in the doctrines of *creation* and the *atonement*."[55] Davis believes these systems haven't answered the charges made by Lynn White, Jr. Therefore, Davis suggests three things that would help answer those charges:

> (1) correct the current imbalance in the doctrine of creation, shifting the focus from questions of *origins* (e.g. evolution, the age of the earth) to that of humanity's proper *relationship* to the creation; (2) incorporate texts such as Col. 1:19–20 that speak of the cosmic impact of the cross into standard treatments of the atonement; and (3) integrate more fully the treatments of the doctrines of creation and Christology, in recognition of the truth that "all things have been created by him (Christ) and *for him.*" (Col 1:16)[56]

Stephen Bauer considers it possible that White has built a straw man by reading industrial revolution thinking into the original text instead of reading what Genesis really says.[57] He also refers to Andrew Linzey, the first professor of animal theology in the world, who "set out to rethink Christian theology in terms of animals and their rights in their relationship with man."[58] Linzey rejects the idea that humans are to be favored above animals. Citing Barth, Linzey posited that humans use God's incarnation as justification for considering themselves superior to animals. Bauer concludes, "Linzey's significance lies in the fact that he appears to be the first Christian theologian to seriously attempt to reinterpret the 'Christian' exploitative view of nature and animals, and thus to establish a Christian theology of animal rights. Linzey thus is breaking new ground in Christian theological circles."[59]

53. Stephen Bauer, "Moral Implications of Darwinian Evolution for Human Preference Based in Christian Ethics: A Critical Analysis and Response to the 'Moral Individualism' of James Rachels" (PhD diss., Theological Seminary, Andrews University, 2006), 40.

54. Ibid., 40–49.

55. John Jefferson Davis, "Ecological 'Blind Spots' in the Structure and Content of Recent Evangelical Systematic Theologies," *Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society* 43, no. 2 (2000): 273.

56. Ibid., 285.

57. Bauer, "Moral Implications of Darwinian Evolution," 53.

58. Ibid., 55–56.

59. Ibid., 56.

Jürgen Moltmann of Tübingen University hasn't written a system, but he presented the Gifford Lectures at the University of Edinburgh, Scotland (1984–1985),[60] in which he argued that theology, with its focus on a transcendent God, has not done justice to nature. He believes that God has been presented as being over and against nature, a view that is "the foundation of hierarchical doctrines of sovereignty."[61] He argues for God *in* nature, through His Spirit, an immanent view of creation, through a Trinitarian view of a relational God. This indwelling of the Spirit in creation has problems, for it fails to distinguish the greater gulf between a fallen creation and a holy God after the Fall. The indwelling Spirit works through evolution as the chosen method of ongoing creation:

> The conception "God in creation" in the shape of the idea of creation in the Spirit is well suited to help us to stop thinking of creation and evolution as opposing concepts, and instead to link them with one another as complements: there is a creation of evolution, because evolution is not explicable simply in terms of itself; there is an evolution of creation, because the creation of the world has been so designed that it points in the direction of the kingdom of glory, and therefore transcends itself in time. We have to see the concept of evolution as a basic concept of the self-movement of the divine Spirit of creation.[62]

Moltmann devotes a chapter to "The Evolution of Creation." Rather than beginning with the differences between humans and animals, he starts with what they have in common.[63] Humans are not only the last of the line of animals created, but they are also dependent upon all of them.[64] Humans are "the embodiment of all other creatures. The complex system 'human being' contains within itself all simpler systems in the evolution of life, because it is out of these that the human being has been built up and has proceeded. In this sense they are present in him, just as he is dependent on them." [65] Thus humans are the "image of the world"[66] (*imago mundi*) just as much as they are the image of God (*imago Dei*). As *imago mundi* they are priests, interceding before God for the "community of creation."[67] Humans "stand before God on behalf of creation, and before creation on behalf of God."[68]

60. Jürgen Moltmann, *God in Creation: A New Theology of Creation and the Spirit of God* (San Francisco, CA: Harper & Row, 1985).
61. Ibid., 1.
62. Ibid., 19.
63. Ibid., 185.
64. Ibid., 187.
65. Ibid., 189–190.
66. Ibid., 190.
67. Ibid.
68. Ibid.

Moltmann relegates the creation narratives to stories "within a hermeneutical process of revision and innovation,"[69] in different historical eras, as merely human testimonies, and not God's revealed Word. Moltmann rejects a finished work of creation, instead opting for continuous creation (*creatio continua*) that flows from original creation (*creatio originalis*) to a future new creation yet to be consummated (*creatio nova*). Moltmann argues that belief in a past creation confines the focus to causality, disregarding other relations between God and creation, which he dubs a static, closed view of the world, in contrast to his dynamic view. He says, "The theory of evolution shook the self-interpretation of Christians" which included belief that humans are "the lord of nature."[70]

Moltmann is to be commended for attempting a theological ecology, but he fails to ground his thinking on Scripture as God's infallible revelation. To him Scripture is, at best, a collection of human testimonies to God's revelation, and thus a very human (and flawed) book.

THEOLOGY OF NATURE

Paul Santmire's book *The Travail of Nature: The Ambiguous Ecological Promise of Christian Theology* attempts to construct "a 'new theology of nature' in our time."[71] He rejects the view that theology has never been concerned with nature, and suggest two types of theology: (1) the spiritual motif, confined to knowledge of God, the soul, and nothing else; and (2) the ecological motif, which celebrates "God's presence in, with, and under the whole biophysical order, as the context in which the life of obedience to God is to be pursued."[72] He follows the latter, building on some constructs of Alfred North Whitehead and Langdon Gilkey.[73]

Santmire points out that Gnosticism is opposed to the ecological motif because it rejects matter as evil, as the Gnostic God is radically separated from mundane reality. In Gnosticism God is alien and the earth is evil. Some systems of Gnosticism state that one day the cosmos will be abolished.[74]

He goes on to show that by contrast with certain Gnostic thinkers, Irenaeus viewed history as finally fulfilling what God intended in creation, so that the creation of Adam is prerequisite to the incarnation of God into history. The Fall is not fatal, so "nature in general retains its created

69. Ibid., 192.
70. Ibid., 192–193.
71. H. Paul Santmire, *The Travail of Nature: The Ambiguous Ecological Promise of Christian Theology* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1985), 7.
72. Ibid., 9.
73. Ibid., 14–15.
74. Ibid., 32–34.

goodness."[75] Christ comes as "the Perfecter of creation," to fulfill the original intent of creation.[76] Origen believed the world was created because of the fall of beings, and the world is a kind of purgatory in which these spiritual beings are joined to matter (which he does not consider to be evil) in order to pass through a restorative process to once again become spiritual beings. Unlike Irenaeus, Origen believed the end would be like the beginning, and the world would become nothing at that time. So the world of nature was not valued by Origen.[77]

Augustine's thinking was influenced by Irenaeus, and so he shifted from the spiritual motif to the ecological motif, thus turning away from Gnosticism and Origen. But few theologians of the Middle Ages followed Augustine's ecological focus.[78]

Santmire asks: "Is the final aim of God, in his governance of all things, to bring into being at the very end a glorified kingdom of spirits alone who, thus united with God, may contemplate him in perfect bliss, while as a precondition of their ecstasy all the other creatures of nature must be left by God to fall away into eternal oblivion?" He states that most contemporary biblical scholars accept this spiritual future. He concludes that if these scholars followed Irenaeus, Augustine, and Francis (patron saint of nature), "that could lead to a new birth of Christian thought about nature. The travail of nature in Christian theology could come to a blessed ending."[79]

I don't think contemporary scholars need to follow Irenaeus, Augustine, Francis (or Alfred North Whitehead and Langdon Gilkey); instead, they should follow the biblical truth of the fall of humans (Gen. 3:1–6) and the redemption-restoration work of Christ (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 8). This involves a new heavens and a new earth (Rev. 21–22) and takes into account the whole of creation that is groaning (Rom. 8:22).

In the book *Good News for Animals?: Christian Approaches to Animal Well-Being*, we find Scripture being taken more seriously than it is in Moltmann's ecology. In God's covenant with Noah, animals were included. God promised that there will never be another global flood to affect humans and "every living creature" (Gen. 9:9–10). In the meantime all of creation is groaning, waiting for redemption (Rom. 8:22).[80]

75. Ibid., 35–40.
76. Ibid., 42.
77. Ibid., 49–52.
78. Ibid., 75–76.
79. Ibid., 217–218.
80. Pinches and McDaniel, eds., *Good News for Animals?*, vii–viii.

CONTRIBUTION OF SCIENCE

Science has taught humans much about the intricate and interdependent ecosystems, which require maintenance for the survival of species. Because this responsibility has not been understood, or has been violated (willingly or unwittingly), there are known extinct species (and probably far more that are unknown) as well as endangered species protected by law.

Carbon emissions into the environment are one cause of climate changes, and are a direct result of industrialization, which has treated the world's natural resources as though they were limitless. What happens in one nation can affect so many others, and so the industrialized world causes all the nations of the world to be affected. In more than one way we have become a global village, and we need to understand the need for stewardship: to sensibly protect the environment, for it is all we have. Scientists have sounded the alarm call; it's time for the church to reexamine the biblical call to stewardship and to answer the call.

ECOLOGY AS PART OF CREATION

Scripture teaches that this world was created by God. The Sabbath was the climax of creation week. The Sabbath commandment reminds readers of creation week, stating that the day of rest was for both humans and animals (Exod. 20:8–11), the latter indicating God's interest in ecology. Every seventh (Lev. 25:4–5) and fiftieth year (Jubilee, Lev. 25:8–55) the land was to rest. During the seventy years' captivity of Judah in Babylon, the land of Judah "enjoyed its sabbath rests" (2 Chron. 36:21). These are further evidences of God's interest in ecology.

If we look at the biblical record of the doctrine of creation, we find that God gave humans an important responsibility: He charged them to look after this world. Humans, made in the image of God (Gen. 1:16, 27), are to image Him in the way they are stewards over this world as He is over the universe. This is what is meant for humans to have dominion over the world (Gen. 1:26–28). Dominion does not mean to destroy but to protect the world—to reflect the way God's providential care protects humans. In ecological matters humans can image God, albeit in a limited way.

Wars have been destructive of humans and the environment, but greed in peacetime has wreaked its own brand of havoc. The word *destroy* is used with reference to Christ's second coming. One of His rewards will be "destroying [*diaphtheirai*] the destroyers [*diaphtheirontas*] of the earth" (*gēn*, Rev. 11:18b). Fallen human nature caused God-given stewardship to be replaced by a selfish drive to dominate nature—rather that have dominion over it. Humans describe devastating natural occurrences as "acts of God," but fail to think deeply enough about them to see

them as possible acts of the *enemy of God.* At creation, God said everything was "very good," but violent weather in the post-Fall world images the cosmic controversy more than the Creator does (although the beauties of nature still reflect the Creator).

The fact of a coming judgment on those who destroy the earth indicates that the original stewardship has never been repealed. God expects humans to do their part in preserving what He created, and of course His providence does much to preserve nature as well. This is why the world still bears marks of His work. Properly understood, in a balanced way, ecology is a theological topic. As a subsection of the doctrine of creation, it reflects the doctrine of salvation, where good is done to created beings. It also has implications for the doctrine of eschatology.

God is the premier Ecologist, whose providential care is a continuing gift to humans. In the new heavens and a new earth, the saved will carry out their stewardship of His new creation without interference from any cosmic controversy or human rebellion.

In the book of Romans, God gives us a glimpse of what creation has suffered since the fall of humans:

> I consider that our present sufferings are not worthy comparing with the glory that will be revealed in us. For the creation waits in eager expectation for the children of God to be revealed. For the creation was subjected to frustration, not by its own choice, but by the will of the one who subjected it, in hope that the creation itself will be liberated from bondage to decay and brought into the freedom and glory of the children of God. We know that the whole creation has been groaning as in the pains of childbirth right up to the present time. Not only so, but we ourselves, who have the firstfruits of the Spirit, groan inwardly as we wait eagerly for our adoption to sonship, the redemption of our bodies. (Rom. 8:18–23)

It should be noted that human redemption and the earth's reprieve come at the same time. Through the Fall, the cosmic controversy gained entrance into this world and invaded human nature and environmental nature. Restoration of both is the work of the Creator-Redeemer, and so both are equally a legitimate part of theology, and they need to be understood as such in this interim time, prior to the Second Coming.

In the meantime Christians should remember that God's creation of the world was a love gift for Adam and Eve, just as the creation of Adam and Eve for each other was a love gift. The creation of every creature was done in love, and animals had the same Creator God as humans. Christ said, "[A]re not five sparrows sold for two pennies? Yet not one of them is forgotten by God" (Luke 12:6). Although sparrows are not valued highly by humans, they are valued highly by God—He doesn't forget them. God created animals for humans to

enjoy. God gave animals life just as He gave humans life. Death entered a perfect world through sin, which resulted in all the cruelty to animals from humans, cruelty of ferocious animals toward humans, and cruelty of animals to animals. Prior to sin, and after it is no more, humans and animals will live together in perfect harmony (Isa. 11:6–9), for harmony is a gift of God's love.

Sin spawned selfishness among humans, so that earth's resources have been squandered in numerous ways. The rainforests have been cut for timber, oil has been used as if the supply were unlimited, and emission of polluting gases into the atmosphere is commonplace. These destructive behaviors have raised serious ethical questions. Ecological responsibility finds its logical foundation in God's creation of the world and everything in it, and in His asking humans to care for the world as the Trinity care for all creation. To reflect the relational Trinity in caring for the world is the biblical meaning of having dominion.

ECOLOGICAL CRISIS[81]

One could argue that nature was generally taken for granted until marine biologist Rachel Carson's 1962 book *Silent Spring* inspired the environmental movement, which informed the world of the ecological state of the planet caused by technology (in this case, the hazards of the pesticide DDT). Five years later Lynn White, Jr., gave an address—"The Historical Roots of our Ecological Crisis"—which was a scathing rebuke of Judeo-Christian theology and its doctrine of creation. This led to theology becoming serious about ecology.[82]

Soon it became obvious that the whole environment was an ecosystem with many smaller ecosystems within it. Ken Gnanakan claims, "Environmentalism was a clear reaction to the rising dominant culture of scientific materialism and the rigid dogma and apathy of established religion."[83] However, holistic spirituality, pantheism, Eastern religions, and the New Age movement are not helpful to a biblical study of ecology. Also not helpful are certain Christian theologians. Consider Jesuit Pierre Teilhard de Chardin (1881–1955), who rejected the literal creation account in Genesis in order to integrate theories of evolution with his theology, and Episcopal priest Matthew Fox (1940–), who emphasizes spirituality and rejects the Fall and the Redemption.[84] What is needed is a biblical ecology.

To meet these attacks upon the Christian doctrine of creation, Gnanakan suggests some foundational elements that need to be included in ecological and creation theologies: Ecotheology must be grounded in Jesus Christ as Creator (John

81. See Ken R. Gnanakan, "Creation and Ecology" in *Global Dictionary of Theology* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2008), 207–214.
82. Ibid., 208.
83. Ibid.
84. Ibid., 208–211.

1:3; 1 Cor. 8:6; Col. 1:16; Heb. 1:2); the One who holds all thing together (Col. 1:17); in whom all things will be united (Eph. 1:9–10); for He sustains all things (Heb. 1:3). All history is under His control (Rev. 1:8, 17; 22:13) for He is Creator and Redeemer. Humans are created in God's image, and their dominion over the earth should be like that of a caring shepherd, a steward for God, seeking to bring order out of chaos, for God plans to redeem the created order (Rom. 8:22). The Fall has not obliterated this image of God in humans. One may add that the image of God is relational. Since "God's creation is held together by an intricate network of relationships," it is true that "Theocentric relationships will restore true eco-relationships within the widest framework of the purposes of God."[85]

I would add that the God who created and redeemed the world through Jesus Christ did so wholistically, including humans and everything else. The new earth will be testimony to His restoration of both humans and all created things (Rev. 21:1–5). There is a need for a cosmic understanding of redemption. Restoration of humans and all creation includes more than this world. Just as Christ's creation includes more than this world (Heb. 1:1–2), so does His mission: "The Son is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn [preeminent] over all creation. For in him all things were created: things in heaven and on earth...and in him all things hold together.... For God was pleased to have all his fullness dwell in him, and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether things on earth or things in heaven, by making peace through his blood, shed on the cross" (Col. 1:15–20). God's caring for all things created should be mirrored by Christians. This is the biblical understanding of ecology that the world needs to understand; it is far better than the restricting of God to nature (pantheism) or to an unresolved ecological crisis (dualism).

It bears repeating that the image of God in the Fall was defaced but not destroyed (Rom. 2:14–15). This means that true Christians can and should image God in His caring for humans and nature as the relational love of the Trinity flows through them to humans and all things created. If Christians had manifested such compassion, they could have revealed God's care for all His creation. Then the Christian God would be known as the God who is devoted to ecology as the Creator-Redeemer.

In his *Systematic Doctrine: Systematic Theology*, James McClendon, Jr., of Fuller Theological Seminary calls for an ecological doctrine of creation.[86] Jo Ann Davidson of Andrews University Theological Seminary presented a professional paper to the Evangelical Theological Society in November 2006 titled

85. Ibid., 212–213.

86. James Wm. McClendon, Jr., *Doctrine*, vol. 2 in *Systematic Theology* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 1994), 157–159.

"Creator, Creation and Church: Restoring Ecology to Theology." This included biblical data demonstrating God's care for His creation, proving that ecology is an important part of theology, as seen below.[87]

God created the world of nature and animals as well as humans (Gen. 1–2). On the fifth creation day, God made air and water animals and blessed them to multiply (Gen. 1:20–23), and on the sixth day of creation, God made land animals and blessed them to multiply, just as He created and blessed humans to multiply on the same day (Gen. 1:24–28a). Humans and animals were created with "breath of life" in them (Gen. 1:30; 2:7).

Texts Demonstrating the Importance of Ecology to God

1. Animals were included in the covenant God made with Noah (Gen. 9:12–17; cf. Hos. 2:18–20, where a similar covenant is mentioned).
2. Animals and humans were given a Sabbath rest (Exod. 20:8–11; Deut. 5:14; Lev. 23:10–12).
3. Firstborn of animals and humans belong to God (Exod. 22:29–30; 13:12–13).
4. Sacrificial animals and priests must be without blemish (Lev. 21:17–21; 22:19–25).
5. Boys had to wait eight days until they could be circumcised, and sacrificial animals had to wait the same length of time before they could be sacrificed (Lev. 22:27; Exod. 22:30; Gen. 7:12).
6. In patriarchal period, after a journey, animals were given water before humans (Gen. 24).
7. Only violent persons (like Nimrod and Esau) were hunters; patriarchs were not (Gen. 10:8–9; 25:27).
8. Longest speech in Scripture is God asking Job to contemplate the magnificence of creation (Job 38–41).
9. Balaam heard a donkey's plea for respect after its beating, and angel's rebuke (Num. 22:21–23).
10. God "cares" for the promised land given to Israel (Deut. 11:10–12). Mosaic laws included protection of nature, so destruction of fruit trees was outlawed in time of war (Deut. 20:19). Animals were to be treated humanely, even if they belonged to an enemy (Exod. 23:4–5; Deut. 22:1–4). Work animals were not to be muzzled so they could eat while working (Deut. 25:4). Israel was taught to honor God and the God of creation and salvation in three festivals that marked different harvests (Exod. 23:14–16; cf. Deut. 16:16–17; 26:1–11).

87. Jo Ann Davidson, "Creator, Creation and Church: Restoring Ecology to Theology" (paper, Evangelical Theological Society, November 2006).

11. Forgiveness leads to healing of Israel's land (2 Chron. 7:12–14); and law breaking affects creation (Isa. 24:5–6; Jer. 9:7–10; Hos 4:1–3; Joel 1:15–20; Zech. 7:8–14; 11:1–3).
12. God provides for the needs of His creation (Ps. 148:7–13). God has pity for the people in Nineveh, as well as their livestock (Jon. 4:10–11).
13. God preserves humans and beasts (Pss. 36:6; 145:9); and cares for both (Jon. 4:11).
14. Future covenant includes restoration of humans and animals (Hos. 2:18; Isa. 11:6–9).
15. Sparrows are welcome in God's sanctuary (Ps. 84), and Christ cares for them (Luke 12:6; cf. Matt. 10:29).
16. Christ's care for Jerusalem was like a mother's care for her chicks (Matt. 24:37).
17. Christ who created two lavish sanctuaries marvels at the beauty of the lilies as more beautiful than Solomon (Matt. 6:28–29).
18. Humans and creation groan, looking forward respectively to resurrection and renovation (Rom. 8:18–23).
19. Christ is the Creator of all things (Col. 1:16–17). Creation reveals the nature of the Godhead (Rom. 1:20).
20. God uses nature to judge humans (Rev. 7:1–3). In the end times God will destroy those who destroy the earth (Rev. 11:17–18).
21. Salvation is God's reclaiming of the earth (Rev. 21:1).
22. Christ demonstrated His lordship over nature: turned water to wine (John 2); walked on water (Matt. 14:25–27); stilled the stormy sea (Mark 4:35–41); withered a fig tree (Matt. 21:18–19); caused fish to obey (Matt. 17:24–27; Luke 5:1–11; cf. Jon. 1:17; 2:10); healed the dreaded disease of leprosy (Luke 17:11–21); and death could not remain in His presence (Luke 7:16; John 11). The above texts demonstrate how important ecology is to God.[88]

Solidarity of All Races

One of the marvels of Christ's creation is the innate variety vested in the original creations. Consider that a single pair of dogs (which is all Noah had room for in the ark) is the source of all the varieties of dogs today. In the same way, Adam and Eve are the first parents of every race on planet earth. We all trace our roots to them. Adam's sin affects all humanity, irrespective of racial uniqueness. Likewise "God so loved the world that he gave his one and only

88. The above arrangement is mine, but the source of these data, besides the Bible, is unknown to me. I would like to give credit to the one who may have done this work originally. In the meantime, these verses from Scripture do demonstrate how important ecology is to God.

Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life" (John 3:16). No wonder the gospel is proclaimed "to those who live on the earth—to every nation, tribe, language and people" (Rev. 14:6). In all of them who are willing, God is re-creating His image.

All of the aspects of the image of God show the uniqueness of humans compared to the animal creation. Contrary to the notion that humans are the product of an evolutionary process, we find that God acted in a personal way to create them, and to make them in the image of Himself. The evolutionary process with its struggle is more like salvation by works than a creation gift of God. Evolution is predicated upon the stronger killing the weaker, which is contrary to God's way of having the stronger look after the weaker (Ps. 146:7; Jas. 1:27). How can the image of God, the source of all life, be formed through a process of death, or even implanted into humans as the by-product of this process? Belief in evolution degrades humans and God. By contrast the creation account elevates humans and God. For God is all powerful, and has no need of help in the creation process; further, He creates humans in a way that clearly conveys to them that they are His children—they bear His image. The high regard God and humanity have for the *imago dei* is seen in the death penalty for anyone who takes human life (Gen. 9:6).

Humans were made to be temples for the indwelling of God. "Don't you know that you yourselves are God's temple and that God's Spirit dwells in your midst?" (1 Cor. 3:16). Nowhere in Scripture does it say God dwells in nature or animals. Humans were made for God, whereas the rest of creation was made for humans. What a high view of human nature this is!

Created Wholistically

As seen above, the image of God includes a variety of factors. Some scholars consider the image of God to be wholistic, including all that is human—body, mind, and spirit. Irenaeus definitively states, "Man, and not [merely] a part of man, was made in the likeness of God."[89] Herman Bavinck declares, "The whole person is the image of the whole deity" and "the human body is an essential component of that image."[90] G. C. Berkouwer notes, "Scripture is never concerned with an independent interest in immortality as such, let alone with the immortality of a part of man which defies and survives death under all

89. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies*, *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*; Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1989), 1:531 (5.6.1).
90. Bavinck, *God and Creation*, vol. 2 in *Reformed Dogmatics*, 530.

circumstances, and on which we can reflect quite apart from man's relation to the living God."[91]

In religious studies the tendency has been to speak of humans as a soul within a body, as if the soul is the real person, and at death the soul moves out of the body and continues existence apart from the body, but this way of thinking overlooks the fact that the entire Bible was written by Jews, who thought wholistically of humans, even though the New Testament was written in Greek. This means that the word *psychē* (soul), though it is a Greek word, has a Hebrew meaning: "the seat of the will, desires, and affections," or it is used to refer to a person or self rather than an entity separate from the body. This warns against any mechanical understanding of the New Testament from classical Greek or contemporary Hellenistic influences, since the writers were Hebrews.[92] Many biblical and theological scholars fail to grasp the Hebrew meaning of *psychē*, so the Greek meaning supersedes the Hebrew meaning, and as a result, a pagan interpretation replaces the biblical interpretation. If the biblical *sola Scriptura* hermeneutic is applied, allowing Scripture to interpret Scripture, then the Hebrew meaning is preserved.

Theology has been influenced by the Greek translation of the Old Testament and Greek categories (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 6). Both influences took theologians away from the Hebraic thinking of Scripture. In 1950 George A. F. Knight referred to a number of Old Testament scholars (Otto Eissfeldt, Johns Pederson, and Wheeler Robinson) who studied Hebrew psychology and documented how Hebraic thinking is different from Greek ways of thinking about humans:

> They have made it abundantly clear that the Old Testament writers drew no line between what we, in our "Greek" way of thinking, would regard as two entities, man's body and man's soul. How foreign to the Old Testament, for example, is the whole question of the relationship of soul and body that bestirs, say, the thoughts of India, or the thoughts of the simple Westerner who considers where the soul must reside in the body. They have shown us clearly that in the Old Testament souls do not dwell in bodies; what we see there are *men*, and men who are not even aware that they might have souls. When the Psalmist says: "O thou my soul bless God the Lord", he is not addressing that part of himself which the Greek or the Indian would designate by the word "soul"; he is addressing his whole person, as an independent human being.[93]

91. G. C. Berkouwer, *Man: The Image of God*, in *Studies in Dogmatics Series*, 1st ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1962), 276.

92. See Jacques B. Doukhan, *Israel and the Church: Two Voices for the Same God* (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2002), 12.

93. George A. F. Knight, *A Biblical Approach to the Doctrine of the Trinity*, in *Scottish Journal of Theology Occasional Papers #1* (Edinburgh: Oliver and Boyd, 1957, 1st ed. 1953), 10.

In 1964, New Testament scholar Oscar Cullmann said the idea of the immortality of the soul "is one of the greatest misunderstandings of Christianity."[94] I would add that it is the root cause of a number of erroneous teachings, such as saints and Mary dwelling in heaven prior to the end-times resurrection (cf. 1 Thess. 4:16–18), encounters with dead loved ones, and eternal hell.

Medical science has long understood the interconnectedness of mind and body, with each affecting the other, and knows that human beings need to be understood and treated wholistically. Treatment is not to a part but to the whole. The mind has a powerful impact on the body, and the body on the mind. Scripture says a "happy heart makes the face cheerful, but heartache crushes the spirit" (Prov. 15:13); "A heart at peace gives life to the body, but envy rots the bones" (Prov. 14:30).

HUMANS AS LIVING SOULS

Paul says, "May your whole spirit, soul and body be kept blameless" (1 Thess. 5:23b).

Do humans have a soul? Or are they a soul? When Christ breathed into Adam, he became a "living being" (Gen. 2:7, NIV) or a "living soul" (KJV). Just as the phrase "the breath of life" is used of animals, so "living soul" is used of animals (Gen. 1:20, 24; 2:19), and even of God (Lev. 26:11; Isa. 42:1). Paul expressed creation as taking place when "Adam became a living being" (1 Cor. 15:45a, NIV, RSV, NKJV, TEV), an "animate being" (NEB), or a "living soul" (NASB, KJV, Phillips). The Hebrew words for "living soul" are *nepeš ḥayyâ*, and the Greek equivalent is *psychē*. Do these words suggest a separate entity? The simple answer is no—in biblical thinking, the *soul* is not considered a separate entity in humans or animals. The creation account doesn't say Christ gave humans a "living soul." Nowhere in Scripture are humans said to possess a soul. The word *soul* describes "being alive." To be alive is to be a "living soul." To be dead is to be no longer a "living soul." It follows, then, that humans don't have a soul. They *are* a soul.

That's why Solomon says about death that "the dust returns to the ground it came from, and the spirit returns to God who gave it" (Eccles. 12:7). In Genesis 3, the Creator-Christ described the future death of Adam and Eve as "dust you are and to dust you will return" (v. 19). The psalmist says that "when you take away their breath, they die and return to the dust" (Ps. 104:29b). This was Christ's commentary on His words "you will certainly die" (Gen. 2:17b), which is opposed to Satan's claim: "You will not certainly die" (Gen. 3:4a). The spirit/breath that returns to God is not a soul that survives death, for then

94. Oscar Cullmann, *Immortality of the Soul or Resurrection of the Dead? The Witness of the New Testament* (London: Epworth, 1964), 15.

Satan's claim, and not Christ's statement, would be right. There's no truth to the popular idea that when the body is dead the soul survives. Rather, Scripture looks to an eschatological hope for all the redeemed at Christ's return (John 14:1–3; 1 Cor. 15:51–53; 1 Thess. 4:16–18).

Satan propagated the idea that death is not really death. Christ said of Satan that "he is a liar and the father of lies" (John 8:44b). Yet Greek philosophy promotes Satan's view, as does paganism, which claims that souls live forever. If souls do not die, then souls do not need the death of Christ to live forever; this is why the Cross is foolishness to unbelievers (1 Cor. 1:17–24). Believing their souls are immortal, unbelievers think they have no need of Christ's death. They believe immortality is a gift received through creation, not through redemption. So according to their belief system, immortality is a natural gift.

There is a breadth of meaning to the Hebrew and Greek terms for *soul* in Scripture. They can denote various human emotions and inner powers.

> Man is called to love God with all his heart and soul (Deut. 13:3). Within the soul lies the desire for food (12:20–21), the lust of the flesh (Jer. 2:24), and the thirst for murder and revenge (Ps. 27:12). The soul is said to weep (Job 30:16; Ps. 119:28) and to be exercised in patience (Job 6:11). Knowledge and understanding (Ps. 139:14), thought (1 Sam. 20:3), love (1 Sam. 18:1), and memory (Lam. 3:20) all originate in the soul. Here the soul comes close to what today would be called the self, one's person, personality, or ego.[95]

In creation there were only good emotions, for human creation was also included in the pronouncement, "God saw all that he had made, and it was very good" (Gen. 1:31).

Soul comes from the Hebrew word *nepeš*. "Often *nephesh* refers to desires, appetites, or passions (cf. Deut 23:24; Prov 23:2; Ec 6:7), and is sometimes translated 'appetite' (Prov 23:2; Ec 6:7). It may refer to the seat of the affections (Gen 34:3; Song 1:7; etc.), and at times it represents the volitional part of man, as when translated 'pleasure' (KJV) in Deut 23:24; Ps 105:22; Jer 34:16."[96]

> A new soul comes into existence whenever a child is born, each "soul" being a new unit of life uniquely different, and separate, from other similar units. This quality of individuality in each living being, which constitutes it a unique entity, seems to be the idea emphasized by the Hebrew term *nephesh*. When used in this sense *nephesh* is not a part of the person; it is the person, and, in many instances, is translated "person" (see Gen 14:21; Num 5:6; Deut 10:22; cf. Ps 3:2) or "self" (Lev 11:43; 1 Ki 19:4; Is 46:2; etc). On the other hand, expressions such as "my soul," "your soul," "his soul," etc., are generally idioms for the personal pronouns "I," "me," "you," "he," etc. (see Gen 12:13; Lev 11:43, 44; 19:8; Jos 23:11; Ps 3:2; Jer 37:9 etc.). In more than 100 of 755 occurrences in the OT the KJV translates *nephesh* as "life" (Gen 9:4, 5; 1 Sa 19:5; Job 2:4, 6; Psa 31:13; etc.).[97]

95. Walter Elwell, ed., "Soul," in *Baker Encyclopedia of the Bible* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1988), 2:1987.

96. Siegfried H. Horn, "Soul," in *Seventh-day Adventist Bible Dictionary*, vol. 8 in *Commentary Reference Series* (Washington, DC: Review, 1960), 1037.

A human being is described as a soul by the Hebrew word *nepeš* (and the corresponding Greek word) one hundred and fifty-two times in the Old Testament and about sixteen times in the New. This and other uses of the word have so confused our translators that it is translated in forty-five different ways in the Old Testament alone.[98]

In the New Testament, the word *soul* encompasses the inmost being of the person. Thus we are to love God with all our soul (Matt. 22:37), and the expression *from the soul* means "from the heart" (Eph. 6:6; Col. 3:23). The human Christ speaks of His soul as being crushed (Matt. 26:38; Mark 14:34; cf. Ps. 42:6).[99] His total person is referred to here. He was the Sin-Bearer (2 Cor. 5:21). The sins of the whole world crushed Him and caused Him to suffer. His whole being was a guilt offering (Isa. 53:10).

The Hebrew *nepeš* (soul) means personality, while the Hebrew *rûaḥ* (spirit) refers to the life principle that makes one alive. There are times when the words *soul* (*psychē*) and *spirit* (*pneuma*) are used interchangeably. Thus "Mary said: 'My soul glorifies the Lord and my spirit rejoices in God my Savior'" (Luke 1:46–47). In the same way Jesus can speak of a human as soul and body (Matt. 10:28), and Paul refers to a human as spirit and body (1 Cor. 7:34).

IS THE SOUL IMMORTAL?

In his Encyclical *Caritas in Veritate*, Pope Benedict XVI said, "God chose to endow [humans] with an immortal soul" (segment 29).[100] So if the soul is the total person, what does it mean that the soul is immortal? That would mean the total person is immortal. If the total person is immortal from creation, what implications would follow?

The term *immortal* means the "inability to die." So if the total person is immortal since creation, then death is not an option. Yet humans die. Scripture says God "alone is immortal" (1 Tim. 6:16), and "the soul (Heb. *nepeš*) that sinneth, it shall die" (Ezek. 18:20, KJV). Scripture says that humans seek immortality (Rom. 2:6, 7). One does not seek immortality if one already has an immortal

97. Ibid., 1036–1037.

98. Basil F. C. Atkinson, *Life and Immortality: An Examination of the Nature and Meaning of Life and Death as They Are Revealed in the Scriptures* (Taunton, MA: Phoenix Press, n.d.), 3.

99. "Soul," *Baker Encyclopedia of the Bible*, 2:1987–1988.

100. Pope Benedict XVI, *Caritas in veritate*, June 29, 2009, accessed July 3, 2012, http://www.vatican.va/holy_father/benedict_xvi/encyclicals/documents/hf_ben-xvi_enc_20090629_caritas-in-veritate_en.html.

soul. This means that Adam and Eve were not immortal. If they were immortal, then their fall would have immortalized sin.

Many Christians believe the soul survives death, but apparently haven't thought through the consequences of such belief, for the soul would necessarily not be subject to the wages of sin (i.e., death, Rom. 6:23) and therefote not be in need of the Savior. And if the soul is the real person, this means the plan of salvation is only for the resurrection of the body. However, if the soul can live in heaven detached from the body, and if heaven is a spiritual experience (being in the presence of God who is a Spirit, which many refer to as the Beatific Vision), then why bother to resurrect the body at the second advent of Christ? And if the resurrection of the body isn't necessary for the soul to keep on existing by itself, then Christ's death on Calvary was an unnecessary waste of suffering.

Second, let's look at what happens after death, according to Scripture. The following texts provide evidence that the soul is not immortal. At death "the spirit [*rûaḥ*] returns to God who gave it" (Eccles. 12:7); "When their spirit departs, they return to the ground; on that very day their plans come to nothing" (Ps. 146:4); "in that very day his thoughts perish." Hence "the dead know not any thing" (Eccles. 9:5, KJV); "Among the dead no one proclaims your name. Who praises you from the grave?" (Ps. 6:5); "Do you show your wonders to the dead? Do those who are dead rise up and praise you? Is your love declated in the grave, your faithfulness in Destruction? Are your wonders known in the place of darkness, or your righteous deeds in the land of oblivion?" (Ps. 88:10–12); "It is not the dead who praise the LORD, those who go down to the place of silence" (Ps. 115:17); "For the grave cannot praise you, death cannot sing your praise; those who go down to the pit cannot hope for your faithfulness" (Isa. 38:18); "For the living know that they will die, but the dead know nothing; they have no further reward, and even their name is forgotten. Their love, their hate and their jealousy have long since vanished; never again will they have a part in anything that happens under the sun" (Eccles. 9:5–6); and of God it says, "If it were his intention and he withdrew his spirit and breath, all humanity would perish together and mankind would return to the dust" (Job 34:14–15).

Scripture is clear that there is no life after death; there is no such thing as a surviving soul, because the soul is not immortal. The idea of possessing an immortal soul now in life and after death is another cosmic controversy counterfeit to get humans to believe they already have through natural means what is only available through supernatural means in the future. The reality is that immortality is conferred at the second coming. Paul says,

> Listen, I tell you a mystery: We will not all sleep, but we will all be changed—in a flash, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, the dead will be raised imperishable, and we will be changed. For the perishable must clothe itself with the imperishable, and the mortal with immortality. When the perishable has been clothed with the imperishable, and the mortal with immortality, then the saying that is written will come true: "Death has been swallowed up in victory." (1 Cor. 15:51–54)

> For the Lord himself will come down from heaven, with a loud command, with the voice of the archangel and with the trumpet call of God, and the dead in Christ will rise first. After that, we who are still alive and are left will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And so we will be with the Lord forever. (1 Thess. 4:16–17)

These verses indicate that both the living and the resurrected dead meet the Lord together in the Second Advent. There is no private meeting of each person with Christ at the moment of death. After all, Christ remained in the grave from crucifixion Friday until resurrection Sunday. Even on resurrection Sunday, Christ said to Mary that He had not yet ascended to His Father (John 20:17).[101] Christ slept in the grave until His resurrection, as all the dead do, and promised His disciples that He was going to prepare a place for them in heaven and would return in His second advent to take them to be home with Him then, not before (John 14:1–3). In fact, Christ speaks of the final resurrection when "the dead will hear the voice of the Son of God" (John 5:25b) and "all who are in the graves will hear his voice and come out—those who have done good will rise to live, and those who have done evil will rise to be condemned" (John 5:28–29; 6:44a).

The incarnate Christ's promise to His disciples is consistent with what He said to Adam: "you will certainly die" (Gen. 2:17b) if he were to eat the forbidden fruit. It was Satan, the tempter of Eve, who questioned Christ's words, saying "You will not certainly die" (Gen. 3:4a). The idea of living on after death began with Satan's first lie in recorded Scripture, and is countered by Christ's first warning in Scripture and His later teaching on the final resurrection. It is not good enough to separate the soul and the body, saying the soul continues to live after death and the body will rise in the final resurrection, for at present immortality belongs only to God, and is not gifted to others until the final resurrection.

Of the two major views on human nature, the dualistic view coming from Platonic Greek philosophy contends that humans are embodied souls. This means that life is characterized as a soul imprisoned in the body until it is released at death. The other view is monistic, where the body, soul, and spirit are indivisibly one at creation, at birth, throughout life, at death, and in the resurrection.

101. What about His promise to the thief on the cross: "Truly I tell you, today you will be with me in paradise" (Luke 23:43)? This is easily explained: the comma was not a part of the revelation-inspiration process, but added later. The comma placed after "you" should be placed after "today," as this agrees with Christ's later statement to Mary.

The biblical view is that human nature is made up of body, soul, and spirit. The total person is what constitutes human nature. Nowhere in Scripture are there disembodied souls. To suggest such a separation, with the soul going to its reward at death, while the body has to wait until the resurrection, separates that which is one in creation and calls into question the need of a future judgment. For why should rewards be given to humans in the judgment if they have already been received at the moment of death?

The pre-incarnate creator Christ warned Adam that disobedience would end in death (Gen. 2:17), which Satan quickly contradicted (Gen. 3:4). Since the Fall, all humans have been subject to death. But what is death? Christ's definition would suggest cessation of life, but Satan's contention portrays death as a continuance of life. Pagans believe in life immediately following death, and so do many Christians. Where did this come from? It comes from Satan's contradiction of Christ, and has been present since ancient times. We will note three examples.

NONBIBLICAL VIEW OF SOULS

In Plato's writings we find that there is less distinction between the Creator and His creation than is found in Scripture. According to Plato, humans were created with an immortal soul and are thus participants in divinity. Consider Plato's *Timaeus*:

> And we should consider that God gave the sovereign part of the human soul to be the divinity of each one, being that part which, as we say, dwells at the top of the body, and inasmuch as we are a plant not of an earthly but of a heavenly growth, taises us from earth to our kindred who are in heaven. And in this we say truly, for the divine power suspends the head and root of us from that place where the generation of the soul first began, and thus makes the whole body upright...and in so far as human nature is capable of sharing in immortality, he must altogether be immortal, and since he is ever cherishing the divine power and has the divinity within him in perfect order, he will be singularly happy.[102]

The idea of an eternal soul, one that cannot die (which is the meaning of *immortal*) is not found in the Scriptures. The *Timaeus* describes well the context in which the idea arose. The context was the creation of the world out of pre-existing materials, joined to a pre-existing soul, to be an image of the eternal gods, and so humans were created with divinity within them, and kindred to those in heaven. This reminds us of Satan's desire to rise above his created level to become like God (Isa. 14:12–14), and his putting this idea into Eve's mind (Gen. 3:1–6), with the assurance "You will not certainly die" (Gen. 3:4a), which contradicted

102. *The Collected Dialogues of Plato, including the Letters*, ed. Edith Hamilton and Huntington Cairns, Bollingen Series LXXI (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2002, 18th ed. 1st 1961), 1209 (90a-c).

God's warning "you must not eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, for when you eat from it you will certainly die" (Gen. 2:17). Satan's premise was human immortality. God's premise was the mortality of humans.

The Greeks believed in the immortality of the soul. Because the soul is originally a part of God and hence eternal in the past, then the soul lives on after the body is dead, because the soul is eternal in the future. For all practical purposes, the soul is that part of God which inhabits a man or a woman and so lives on forever. Plato believed that the soul is the eternal element in humans, and sequentially lives in different bodies until it is eventually purged of evil.[103] Augustine (354–430), perhaps the most influential theologian of all time, posits that God made a separate soul to put into Adam's formed body.[104] Augustine never repudiated the Platonic dualism of body and soul.[105]

NONBIBLICAL VIEW OF DEATH

Adam and Eve were not immortal; otherwise God's statement about death as a consequence for disobedience (Gen. 2:17) would have no meaning. Likewise, after Adam and Eve had sinned, God told them they had to leave Eden, for if they were to eat of the tree of life they would "live forever" (Gen. 3:22). No wonder Scripture says God alone has immortality (1 Tim. 6:16; see more below), and adds that humans will receive immortality at the second advent of Christ, not before (1 Thess. 4:16–18; 1 Cor. 15:51–54). Reformed theologian Henry Bullenger's idea that humans are not immortal like God, but have a soul that "is both mortal and immortal"[106] is repudiated by the fact that God alone has immortality.

So humans were not created with immortality, nor do they receive immortality until the end of sinful history. This means no one survives death, living on as a soul. All questions about the meaning of death must be judged from this clear enunciation about when death is conquered by immortality. That final change will be the full outworking of the victory of Christ's death for the sake of bringing eternal life to humans.

The biblical data on death given above indicates that Spiritualism depends upon Satan's version of death, which means dead loved ones can appear and communicate with surviving relatives. The solace this brings to these relatives is to be abhorred, because it is a counterfeit. The idea that death is merely a door to hell or heaven means some stay in those places a lot longer than those who enter them later. If hell is a real place of suffering, why should those born

103. "Soul," *Baker Encyclopedia of the Bible*, 2:1987.
104. Augustine, *City of God, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 2:241 (12.23).
105. Norman L. Geisler, *Baker Encyclopedia of Christian Apologetics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1999), 63.
106. Henry Bullenger, *The Decades of Henry Bullenger* (Grand Rapids, MI: Reformation Heritage Books, 2004), 3:380.

thousands of years before the final judgment have to suffer so much longer than others? Does Scripture portray this about God, or is He no respecter of persons who treats everyone fairly (Acts 10:34; Rom. 2:11; 1 Pet. 1:17; cf. Mal. 2:9; Col. 3:25; Jas. 2:9)? In Scripture the entrance to heaven or hell occurs at the same time for all who enter. That's why Paul says:

> According to the Lord's own word, we tell you that we who are still alive, who are left to the coming of the Lord, will certainly not precede those who have fallen asleep. For the Lord himself will come down from heaven...the dead in Christ will rise first. After that, we who are still alive and are left will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And so we will be with the Lord forever. (1 Thess. 4:15–17)

This passage indicates that all the saints will meet God together in the air at the Second Advent, and then enter together into heaven. This is why they sleep until then, rather than having a conscious soul that preceded them. This demonstrates that all the lost face the final judgment at the same time, not individually at death. This also means that the holy ones (*tōn hagiōn*) that come with Christ in the second advent (1 Thess. 3:13) are angels and not humans. There are a number of texts that state angels will accompany Christ (Matt. 13:41; 25:31; Mark 8:38; Luke 9:26; 2 Thess. 1:7). Even though the Greek words *tōn hagiōn* (saints) are not used of angels in the New Testament, it seems the best translation, because the saints will be on the earth or raised from graves when Christ returns.

The words *tōn hagiōn* are never used of immortal souls separate from the bodies in the New Testament. This is because one can no more separate soul and body than one can separate the two natures of Jesus Christ. A body, soul, and spirit constitute one person just as Jesus Christ is one Person: divine and human natures in inseparable union. Based on the scriptural evidence above, it is a philosophical myth that souls go to heaven at death and live an independent life until joined to their bodies at Christ's second advent.

One must allow the communal, rather than individual, entrance into heaven or hell, and interpret texts in the light of this propositional revelation. For example, when Paul said he would rather depart to be with the Lord (Phil. 1:23), this cannot mean immediately upon death, because it wouldn't agree with what he wrote regarding the communal handing out of rewards. Similar language is found in 2 Corinthians 5:6–10 where all the aorist verbs focus on the future resurrection and judgment as one event.[107] Furthermore, Paul's verses above mention death as a sleep, and it doesn't matter if a person sleeps one night or

107. See Paul Barnett, *The Second Epistle to the Corinthians*, in *The New International Commentary in the New Testament Series* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1997), 267–277.

thousands of years, it still feels like a moment between death and the resurrection to meet Christ. Paul factored that reality into his expression about wanting to be with the Lord. From his perspective, since he would not know anything while dead—or be aware of the passing of time—the resurrection would seem to him as if it followed immediately after death.

Expulsion from Eden

Humans are not created or born immortal. They can only seek immortality and be granted immortality at the Second Advent. In the meantime, "The one who sins is the one who will die" (Ezek. 18:20). So souls can perish—they cease to exist. (This agrees with the texts above on humans knowing nothing after death.) Even though the word *soul* means "a person," it is still important to note that a soul can die; it is not inherently immortal. We see this clearly if we look closely at the Genesis account of the Fall.

It is important to ask why Adam and Eve were expelled from Eden. Ponder these words of God: "'The man has now become like one of us, knowing good and evil. He must not be allowed to reach out his hand and take also from the tree of life and eat, and live forever.' So the LORD God banished him from the Garden of Eden" (Gen. 3:22–23). What did God mean by these words spoken after Adam and Eve had sinned? Evidently the tree of life was necessary for continued human existence before the Fall, which means humans were not inherently immortal. They were dependent upon the tree of life. After the Fall, God banished them from eating of that tree so that death would eventually overtake them. When one considers the function of the tree of life, one realizes that the total person was affected by its life-giving fruit, and likewise, the total person was subsequently affected by no longer having access to its life-sustaining fruit.

Death is merely the reverse of creation. In Adam's creation God joined the dust of the ground with His life-giving breath and man became a living person. In death, the life-giving principle departs from the human, and the body goes back to dust. There's no soul involved. The equation is dust + God's in-breathing = living person. Or person - living principle = death of total person.

Consider a box as a metaphor for a person. The box is comprised of wood and nails in two piles. When the nails are driven into the wood, the box is formed; when the nails are removed from the wood, there is no box—just two piles, of wood and nails, once more. So at death the total person ceases to exist.

NO INTERMEDIATE STATE

In Scripture death is spoken of as "rest" or "sleep" (Heb. *šākab*, Deut. 31:16; 2 Sam. 7:12; 1 Kings 2:10; Gr. *koimaō*, John 11:11–14; Acts 13:36; 1 Cor. 15:51; 1 Thess. 4:13–14). The image of sleeping, or resting, is seen throughout both Testaments. Just as we saw the focus on the second coming of Christ, rather than personal death, as the moment for receiving immortality in the New Testament, so we see the same in the Old Testament. For example, "Multitudes who sleep in the dust of the earth will awake: some to everlasting life, others to shame and everlasting contempt" (Dan. 12:2). If death is the cessation of life, then resurrection is the beginning of life. The interim is expressed as a sleep.

Solomon said the dead are dead: "For the living know that they will die, but the dead know nothing; they have no further reward, and even their name is forgotten. Their love, their hate and their jealousy have long since vanished; never again will they have a part in anything that happens under the sun" (Eccles. 9:5–6). Solomon also tells us that "the dust returns to the ground it came from, and the spirit returns to God who gave it" (Eccles. 12:7). This refers back to creation where God created Adam from the dust and breathed life into him (Gen. 2:7). Breathing His life-giving Spirit into Adam had nothing to do with producing an independent soul; rather, it infused life into the molded clay form of Adam. It made him wholistically alive. Hence there is no intermediate state between death and resurrection for an alleged soul.

G. C. Berkouwer (1903–1996), who was a professor of systematic theology at Free University of Amsterdam, made a contribution to this topic in his book *Man: The Image of God.* His context is the whole man, body and soul inextricably united. The prior chapter to the one we will consider is devoted to the whole man. Whereas Bavinck believed natural immortality was present in the image of God,[108] Berkouwer takes a whole chapter to distinguish the innate immortality of the soul, which he denies, from the immortality that springs from a relation with the immortal God. Berkouwer notes that many scholars react to the Enlightenment views of natural immortality as if the soul is by nature immortal, and thus escapes God's death judgment on sin.[109]

Berkouwer notes that "recent theology…rejects the substantial dichotomy of body and soul."[110] Berkouwer states, "There then can be no idea that death affects merely the body,"[111] and there is "no way in which an 'immortality of

108. Berkouwer, *Man: The Image of God*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 234.
109. Ibid., 250; cf. 275–277.
110. Ibid., 205.
111. Ibid., 251.

the soul' can take away death's character of 'enemy' (1 Cor. 15:26)."[112] Scripture doesn't speak of the immortality of humans.[113] From an anthropological viewpoint, which doesn't understand how death affects the whole man, Berkouwer refers to Althaus who rejects "the idea of an intermediate state."[114]

Berkouwer also brings H. Thielich into the discussion; he believes that immortality devalues death, since the Christian view is resurrection, not immortality. At the end of his book *Tod und Leben*, Thielich speaks of the intermediate state. There is a "certain continuity" through "a personal communion with Christ." This is premised on Christ's promise to the thief on the cross about being with Christ that day in Paradise.[115] Berkouwer notes that even Cullmann who denied natural immortality did not reject the intermediate state because of the biblical promise of "being with Christ."[116]

Berkouwer says that Scripture speaks of eternal life as "communion with Christ."[117] As far as Scripture is concerned, there is no "idealistic view of immortality" as if immortality were inherent in human beings. Hence, "continued existence" beyond death is "in man's relation to the living God."[118] Berkouwer's following statement is key to his thinking: "Scripture is never concerned with an independent interest in immortality as such, let alone with the immortality of a part of man which defies and survives death under all circumstances, and on which we can reflect quite apart from man's relation to the living God."[119] He notes in this context that Christians know that "my times are in his hand" (Ps. 31:15)," so also in death one can "entrust one's life into His hands."[120]

The Church believes in immortality as life with Christ,[121] and "confesses that this eternal life already begins in this life."[122] The following sums up Berkouwer's theology on immortality and the intermediate state:

1. A human as body and soul is indivisible, "the whole man [person]."
2. The soul does not possess inherent, or natural, immortality, because God alone is by essence immortal.
3. No soul continues life with God after death as if it were inherently immortal.

112. Ibid., 268.
113. Ibid., 270.
114. Althaus, quoted in Berkouwer, *Image of God*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 252.
115. Thielich, *Tod und Leben*, quoted in Berkouwer, *Image of God*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 253–254.
116. Cullmann, quoted in Berkouwer, *Image of God*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 254.
117. Berkouwer, *Image of God*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 266.
118. Ibid., 267.
119. Ibid., 276.
120. Ibid.
121. Ibid., 277.
122. Ibid., 278.

4. Death is God's judgment on the body and the soul, not on one without the other.
5. Death does not cause a break between the body and soul.
6. The experience of eternal life continues from this life beyond death through a relationship with Christ.

There is a problem, though, with Berkouwer's intermediate state: If humans are an indissoluble union of body and soul in life and death, and go to heaven by virtue of their relationship with Christ, why would there be a need of a resurrection which is traditionally considered a resurrection of the body? Berkouwer does not take into consideration the biblical texts which clearly state that (1) the dead know nothing in the intermediate state and that (2) immortality is gifted to humans at the Second Coming, not before.

Some other scholars speak about the intermediate state. Oscar Cullmann, in his book *Immortality of the Soul or Resurrection of the Dead?*, directs people to the resurrection, and not to immortality. Philip Edgcumbe Hughes states: "[A]s sleeping is followed by waking so the Christian believer has the certain knowledge that, though overtaken by death, he will awaken at the resurrection to fulness of life in the presence and likeness of his Redeemer."[123] Stanley Grenz says, "The goal of our hope is the resurrection, not an intermediate state."[124]

Wholistic anthropology is biblical. There is no fast track for the soul to reach heaven ahead of the body. Christ died for the total person, and the total person awaits the resurrection at the Second Coming (see 1 Thess. 4:16–18). If this were not so, then the soul wouldn't need salvation. If humans were created with immortal souls, this would contradict God's statement that the wages of sin is death (Rom. 6:23). It means the soul would have no need of Christ or His death and resurrection. It means the soul would have had inherent ability to survive the Fall and sin, and through itself attain to eternal life because it is immortal.

Great Counterfeit

Much of the Christian world believes death is merely a door to walk through to the other side, eternal life. If this were true, then death is not death but a passage from life to a more abundant life. What implications does this have for the cosmic controversy which questions God, who said death comes to those eating the forbidden fruit in Eden (Gen. 2:16–17)? If death is merely a passage

123. Philip Edgcumbe Hughes, *The True Image: The Origin and Destiny of Man in Christ* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1989), 393.

124. Stanley J. Grenz, *Theology for the Community of God* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1994), 596.

of life to a more abundant life, then Satan was right when he said, "You will not certainly die.... For God knows that when you eat from it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God, knowing good and evil" (Gen. 3:4–5).

When did Jesus say death would be ultimately defeated? Jesus didn't say to His disciples just before His departure, "Cheer up, you will be with Me soon when you die." Rather, He said, "My Father's house has many rooms; if that were not so, would I have told you that I am going there to prepare a place for you? And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come back and take you to be with me that you also may be where I am" (John 14:2–3). The day of meeting is the Second Advent, not the moment of death.

Christ raised the daughter of the synagogue ruler, the boy from Nain, and Lazarus. Think of Lazarus. He had been dead four days (John 11:39). According to Greek dualism, that would mean his soul had been in heaven four days and had to exit heaven quickly when Christ gave the resurrection call. How do you think Lazarus felt? Wouldn't he ask Jesus, "Why did You bring me back?" For who wants to leave Paradise in order to return to this world?

Christ didn't say, "Lazarus is in heaven, but to comfort you I will bring him back to earth." Rather, Christ said, "Our friend Lazarus has fallen asleep; but I am going there to wake him up" (John 11:11, cf. Christ defines Lazarus's sleep as being dead, v. 14). George Beasley-Murray was right to conclude that "believers are to view death as a sleep from which they shall be awakened through Jesus."[125] But most do not subscribe to this view. They like the thought of going straight to heaven at death. Thinking that our loved ones are in heaven is a comforting thought.

But if those Christ resurrected did actually come back from heaven to earth, then one could argue that Christ didn't do them a favor. If, on the other hand, Christ raised them from the grave, that would be a marvelous gift to both them and their relatives and friends. Knowing that God is love, this latter option seems more reasonable merely from the standpoint of logic. And, as we have shown above, this is the more scriptural view.

Remember, it was Christ who warned of death to Adam and Eve; it was Christ who said He did not ascend to heaven to be with His Father as soon as He died; it was Christ who told His disciples that He would prepare them a place in heaven and only come to get them in His second advent; it was Christ who said He would call all people from their graves, the good and the bad. So Christ's words are contrary to Greek philosophy, and regrettably to the popular Christian understanding about death. It is time for Christian theology to re-examine traditional thinking on this topic, and allow Christ to define what is meant by death in Scripture.

125. George R. Beasley-Murray, *John*, vol. 36 in *Word Biblical Commentary* (Waco, TX: Word, 1987), 189.

AFTER-DEATH APPARITIONS

"Not so fast," some may say, "there are biblical texts that suggest death is really continued living. What do we do with 1 Samuel 28, where the deceased Samuel apparently came to speak to King Saul?" Ralph W. Klein believes this was a real interview with Samuel.[126] Keil and Delitzsch see this as the "unanimous" opinion of modern orthodox commentators.[127] This is not surprising since Greek ideas of an immortal soul have tainted Christian theology, clouding the biblical fact that God alone has immortality.

So let's look at what Scripture has to say about this idea of continued life after death. "Do not turn to mediums or seek out spiritists, for you will be defiled by them. I am the LORD your God" (Lev. 19:31). In fact, any person in Israel who is a medium or spiritist "must be put to death" (Lev. 20:27). If someone even consulted a medium or spiritist, God declared He would cut that person off from His people (Lev. 20:6). In obedience to God, King "Saul had expelled the mediums and spiritists from the land" (1 Sam. 28:3). Then why would Saul want to consult the medium at Endor? Previously he had inquired of God, but God didn't answer him (1 Sam. 28:6). So Saul sought a source of knowledge that God had condemned in Scripture.

It seems logical that if God didn't answer Saul directly, He would not answer through a medium He had condemned. It would be inconsistent for God to cooperate with an act that He rejects in the rest of Scripture. Yet Keil and Delitzsch claim, "God brought up" Samuel "from Hades through an act of His omnipotence." They further suggest, "The reality of the appearance of Samuel from the kingdom of the dead cannot therefore be called in question, especially as it has an analogon in the appearance of Moses and Elijah at the transfiguration of Christ." Keil and Delitzsch do not say that there was a difference between the coming of Samuel from Hades, and in his unchanged nature, whereas Moses and Elijah came from heaven, in a glorified state.[128]

Yet, why would God go to such an incredible extent when He could have answered Saul directly? The truth is, Saul had forgotten the omnipotence of God; he chose rather to rely upon his own efforts and consulted a medium who, by definition, belonged to those on the other side of the cosmic controversy.

126. Ralph W. Klein, *Samuel*, vol. 10 in *Word Biblical Commentary* (Waco, TX: Word, 1983), 270–273.
127. Keil and Delitzsch, *Joshua, Judges, Ruth, I & II Samuel*, vol. 2, in *Commentary on the Old Testament in Ten Volumes*, 266.
128. Ibid.

GOD OPPOSES SPIRITISM

The power of spiritism over humans is based on the view that death is not death, but merely a door to continued living. But according to Scripture, the dead do not know anything; they remain in their graves, and are raised only at the Second Advent—which means they have not met Him before that moment (and so they have not been in heaven). Scripture teaches that humans do not live on after death, but are buried. For if "Satan himself masquerades as an angel of light" (2 Cor. 11:14), should we wonder that dead loved ones seem to appear to humans? Certainly angels have the power to impersonate the dead in order to deceive loved ones with nonbiblical ideas. And this is most likely why Scripture warns that we should "test the spirits to see whether they are from God" (1 John 4:1).

Just as Satan's first lie was opposed to God's Word about death, so it is only God's Word that protects humans from other false claims brought by Satan and fallen angels. We must remember that there is a cosmic controversy. One of the most deceptive things the enemy can do is to use the testimony of a deceased loved one, who is supposedly still alive in heaven, to contradict God's Word. He succeeded in fooling a perfect Eve, so it is no wonder that he is able to fool fallen humans. As noted above, Scripture warns against mediums, adding, "When someone tells you to consult mediums and spiritists, who whisper and mutter, should not a people inquire of their God? Consult God's instruction and the testimony of warning. If anyone does not speak according to this word, they have no light of dawn" (Isa. 8:19–20). "The Spirit clearly says that in later times some will abandon the faith and follow deceiving spirits and things taught by demons" (1 Tim. 4:1).

CORPORATE VICTORY OVER DEATH

Scripture presents further evidence that death is not a continuation of life, and that entrance into eternal life will be experienced corporately, not individually. Abraham "was looking forward to the city with foundations, whose architect and builder is God" (Heb. 11:10). His descendants "were still living by faith when they died. They did not receive the things promised." They were "longing for a better country—a heavenly one" (vv. 13, 16). At the end of the chapter, it says, "These were all commended for their faith, yet none of them received what had been promised. Since God had planned something better for us so that only together with us would they be made perfect" (vv. 39–40). So Hebrews 11 presents a corporate view of the experience of heaven. Of course, it is true there are some exceptions, which we will look at in the next section.

Isn't it clear that these promises in Hebrews 11 are not just referring to the land of Canaan, but the heavenly city and country? It is this greater blessing, of which the earthly land of promise was a type, that all of them failed to receive when they died. Donald Guthrie notes the corporate nature of "*made perfect*" (Gr. *teleiōthōsin*): "No part of the true Christian community can be complete without the rest."[129] Leon Morris says that the "plan provides that the heroes of the faith throughout the ages should not 'be made perfect' apart from Christians. Salvation is social. It concerns the whole people of God."[130] William L. Lane adds, "God in his providence deferred the bestowal of the final reward until the advent of Christ and the enactment of the new covenant." In this context he suggests that *teleioun* (goal) "should be interpreted in terms of entrance into the promised eternal inheritance."[131]

As mentioned above, Paul states clearly that the resurrected and living saints rise into the air to meet Christ at the time of His return (see 1 Thess. 4:16–18). All humans enter their eternal destiny at the same time, irrespective of when they died. No one precedes others, except for a few, which we take up in the next section (an exception is the Millennium, which will be presented in my *Systematic Theology*, volume 4).

Some Humans in Heaven

What about those persons in Scripture who were resurrected or translated? We are talking about a few exceptions, one of which was Enoch, who "walked faithfully with God; then he was no more, because God took him away" (Gen. 5:24). Lenski explains this event: "By means of faith Enoch was translated so as not to see death and was not being found because God translated him. For he has received the testimony to have been before his translation well-pleasing to God." Lenski comments, "But for his faith Enoch would not have been taken to heaven without dying."[132] The Greek translation of Hebrews (LXX) uses the word "translation" for Enoch; and William Lane says of Enoch, he "escaped death through translation."[133]

129. Donald Guthrie, *The Letter to the Hebrews: An Introduction and Commentary*, vol. 15 in *The Tyndale New Testament Commentaries* (Leicester, England: Inter-Varsity, 1994, 1st ed. 1983), 247.

130. Leon Morris, *Hebrews*, vol. 12 in *Expositor's Bible Commentary with the New International Version of the Holy Bible* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1981), 132–133.

131. William L. Lane, *Hebrews 9–13*, vol. 47b in *Word Biblical Commentary*, ed. David A. Hubbard and Glenn W. Barker (Waco, TX: Word, 1991), 393.

132. R. C. H. Lenski, *The Interpretation of The Epistle to the Hebrews and The Epistle of James* (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg Publishing House, 1966), 385.

133. Lane, *Hebrews 9–13*, vol. 47b in *Word Biblical Commentary*, 336.

Consider these famous figures from the Bible: "Elijah went up to heaven in a whirlwind" (2 Kings 2:11). "Moses was a hundred and twenty years old when he died, yet his eyes were not weak nor his strength gone" (Deut. 34:7). Christ ("archangel Michael," see Dan. 10:13; 12:1; 1 Thess. 4:16; John 5:26–28) disputed with the devil over the body of Moses.

God took three people to heaven, two via translation (Enoch and Elijah) and one via resurrection (Moses). The documentation of the resurrection of Moses is through Elijah and Moses standing with Jesus on the Mount of Transfiguration (Matt. 17:1–9; Mark 9:1–8). What was the purpose of the Transfiguration? The promise Christ gave in Matthew 16:28 is that some standing before Him would not see death until they saw the Son of Man coming in His kingdom. The very next verse introduces the reader to the Transfiguration event that took place only six days later. There Peter, James, and John saw Christ glorified and surrounded by Elijah and Moses. They beheld a proleptic view of the Kingdom, for Christ was glorified, standing with Moses who represents the resurrected in the Kingdom and Elijah who represents the translated in the Kingdom. The glorified King stands with both resurrected and translated first fruits of His coming kingdom. The three represented a miniature type of the Kingdom.

Did Christ take any other people to heaven? At the moment of Christ's death, "The tombs broke open. The bodies of many holy people who had died were raised to life. They came out of the tombs, after Jesus' resurrection and went into the holy city and appeared to many people" (Matt. 27:52–53). With reference to Christ, "When he ascended on high, he took many captives and gave gifts to his people" (Eph. 4:8; cf. Ps. 68:18). Christ liberated them from captivity to death through resurrection. They were wholistically resurrected and went into the city. I believe Moses was wholistically resurrected as well, because Enoch and Elijah were translated just as they were as wholistic persons. This was a foretaste of the Second Coming when He will liberate all other captives.

What are the implications of only some persons being resurrected or translated to heaven prior to the Second Advent? This fact implies that they are exceptions, not the rule. Hence, these persons give added evidence that death is normally a cessation of life, with no interim period of consciousness prior to resurrection.

But why did Christ take only certain persons to heaven? Does He show favoritism? How could He do that and still be just or loving? The Bible says, "God does not show favoritism" (Acts 10:34b; Rom. 2:11; cf. Col. 3:25; Jas. 2:9; 1 Pet. 1:17). So that's not the reason. But we should assume that there is a very important reason for God to take some humans to heaven. And there is: Because of the cosmic controversy, and the fact that God is just, He wants

some human representatives to be in heaven to witness the unfolding of the controversy. Do we have any evidence of this?

The evidence is in the book of Revelation. The twenty-four elders are mentioned in Revelation 4:4, 10; 5:8; 7:11; 11:16; and 19:4. These are human beings, because they wear crowns (*stephanoi*), laurel wreaths of victory worn by winners at the Olympic games. They are conquerors who have run the race of life well. They wear a victor's crown. Enoch, Elijah, and Moses, as well as others from the group that ascended to heaven with Christ, will most likely be part of this group.

Conclusion

The biblical data has led us to conclude that the creation of humans and what happens to them in death is different from what most systems present. So the beginning and end of human existence is different from what is currently believed by most Christians.

We saw in the last chapter that God was not dependent upon pre-existing matter. He created out of nothing (*ex nihilo*, Heb. 11:3). In this chapter we saw that Christ, who spoke everything into existence as *Elohim* (transcendent, all-powerful God), stooped down as *Yahweh* (covenant God, up close) *Elohim* God, who has a hands-on approach, to create humans in the image of the Trinity, to be temples for His indwelling. These facts radically separate humans from animals and call into question whether humans could ever be products of an evolutionary process.

Scripture says that only God has immortality, that persons seek immortality (as something to come), and that they will receive immortality at the Second Advent, when it will be given to all the redeemed at the same time. Thus Scripture radically calls into question the normative Christian teaching on what constitutes a soul, and where the soul dwells after death. Satan said to Eve that she would not die, and Christians have accepted this lie for much of Christian history. We are faced here with the Greek way of thinking rather than the Hebrew way of thinking.

The idea that humans are the product of the horrors of animal death, through struggle over deep-time, calls into question the wisdom of God, since He has the power to create without all this pain and suffering. The idea of creation through evolution demeans God and degrades humans. This view questions God's wisdom and power just as much as Process and Openness views of God question His foreknowledge. What Scripture says about His wisdom, power, and foreknowledge must prevail over human traditions that are contrary. Whereas evolution takes away from humans their true dignity as personally created by God

in His image for covenant relationship with Him, the alleged immortality of the human soul bestows upon them what God alone has. Evolution lowers humans below the level of their creation, and immortality raises humans above the level of their creation. Neither is justified in the light of Scripture.

This is a sensitive matter, because it means our loved ones are not in heaven. They are dead, for the wages of sin has brought death upon all humans, even believers. Christians should not listen to the "dead," who allegedly come back to talk to them, for Scripture says "the dead know nothing" (Eccles. 9:5b). Hence post-death visitors are imposters. Satan's first lie on planet earth to Eve was "You will not certainly die" (Gen. 3:4a), which contradicted Christ's word "you will certainly die" (Gen. 2:17b). No wonder Christ called Satan the father of lies (John 8:44b). With Satan and his fallen angels seeking to deceive humans, what better method than to impersonate dead loved ones and return to those who grieve, give them comfort, and implant in their minds false ideas. This is a dimension of the cosmic controversy which is rarely, if ever, considered by theologians. When trusted loved ones seemingly return from heaven to convey some message, they seem to present overwhelming evidence of the supposed immorality of the soul. Yet "Satan himself masquerades as an angel of light" (2 Cor. 11:14). Only Scripture can question these encounters, as Jesus did when He encountered Satan's deceptions (Matt. 4:1–11).

Study Questions

1. Scripture says humans (Ps. 8:4–6; Heb. 2:6–8) and Jesus Christ (Heb. 2:9) compare in several ways. How do these texts help us understand Genesis 1–2?
2. How does evolution view humans? How does creationism view humans? Which one concurs with the view of Scripture? Specify how.
3. How does the creation of humans compare with the creation of all other things as recorded in the Hebrew account of Genesis 1–2? Fully explain.
4. What is the linguistic significance of "let us make man in our image"?
5. In how many ways are humans (individually) created in the image of God?
6. In the Hebrew language, what is the significance of Eve's having been created from Adam's rib?
7. Why is it important that God gave humans the freedom to choose to obey or disobey Him?
8. What is the biblical view of human souls? What impact does Scripture have on humans' understanding of what death means and doesn't mean? What connection does this have to the warning God gave to Adam and Eve in Eden?
9. How does Scripture evaluate Saul's alleged encounter with Samuel?

CHAPTER THREE

Human Fall and Nature

Purpose

1. Determine why humans fell, and see what this did to their nature.
2. Note that evil entered the world through the fall of humans.
3. Show that creation needs to be understood in the context of the cosmic controversy.

Summary

The Creator Christ made a beautiful world for Adam and Eve, gave them companionship with Himself, and gave them each other, with the joy of imaging God in their realm as God is in His realm. Christ gave them everything in space and gave Himself to them in time. The Sabbath was special time for communion and rest with their Creator. It is inexplicable how sin could arise in such a context. How could Eve listen to the claim of one who had given her nothing and reject the claim of Christ who had given her everything? Satan caused Eve to believe God was holding her back from her full potential. The tempter made himself appear more interested in Eve's future than her Creator. It worked, and led to the fall of the human race: doubting God caused Eve to disobey Him and a broken relationship led to law breaking.

Such law breaking, or sin, has a number of levels that lie behind the external act. At its deepest level, sin is a broken relationship with a relational Trinity. The broken relationship caused the posterity of Adam to be born sinners, needing a

Savior as soon as they enter the world. Adam's sin imputes a propensity to sin, but not the guilt of Adam's sin. The first sanctuary on planet earth was set up in Eden to minister salvation to sinners. In the context of the needs of fallen humans, we will consider the various theories of imputation.

Outline

I. Introduction
II. Structure of Genesis 1–3
III. Fall of Humans
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B. Method of Temptation
C. Purpose of Temptation
IV. Infallible Evidence
A. Effects of Sin on Adam and Eve
B. Damaged Image of God
C. *Total Depravity* and the Image of God
1. What *Total Depravity* Means
2. What Conscience Does to the Damaged Image of God
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V. God and Evil
VI. Sin Defined
A. Sin as the Absence of Good
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1. Immediate Roots
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VII. Two Adams Compared
VIII. Self-Centered Sinners at Birth
IX. Theories of Imputation
A. Pelagian Theory
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F. Augustinian Theory

G. Summary of Theories
H. Evaluation
X. Conclusion
XI. Study Questions

Introduction

In this new segment on creation, we look at three ways in which God's creation is questioned: (1) Satan questioned God's creation of Adam and Eve, claiming that He denied to them a chance to become like God by forbidding them to eat certain fruit (Gen. 3:1–5; 2:16–17); (2) Darwin questioned God's creation; and (3) Concordists, those who believe there is harmony between creation and evolution, ignore the mutually exclusive worldviews of Scripture and macroevolutionary theory and question biblical creation by God.

In the first two chapters, we have seen that God is the Creator; Scripture repeatedly tells us that God created *everything*. There isn't even a hint that the work of creation was accomplished through some other means. In fact, although the entire Trinity was involved in creation (including the Holy Spirit, Gen. 1:2), Scripture specifies that the Father created everything through His Son. Consider the following:

> In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. He was with God in the beginning. Through him all things were made; without him nothing was made that has been made.... The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us. We have seen his glory, the glory of the one and only Son, who came from the Father, full of grace and truth. (John 1:1–3, 14)

> All things came into existence through Christ. (Rom. 11:36; 1 Cor. 8:6)

> The Son is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn over all creation. For in him all things were created: things in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or powers or rulers or authorities; all things have been created through him and for him. (Col. 1:15–16)

> In the past God spoke to our ancestors through the prophets at many times and in various ways, but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son, whom he appointed heir of all things, and through whom also he made the universe. (Heb. 1:1–2)

Michael (or Christ, see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 8) cast Satan and his angels out of heaven when their revolt broke out into open rebellion (Rev. 12:7–8). Christ created planet earth, and everything in it, including Adam and Eve; Satan came to spoil this creation, to fight a battle

he hoped to win, and to some degree get even with Christ. It was after Christ gave humanity His seventh-day Sabbath (Gen. 2:1–3) that Satan came to deceive Eve (Gen. 3:1–6). Consider the following insights on the structure of Genesis 1–3.

Structure of Genesis 1–3

Randall Younker sees Genesis 2 as a bridge between the good creation of Genesis 1 (Gen. 1:3, 10, 12, 18, 21, 25, 31) and the fallen creation of Genesis 3. After the fall of humans, God said the ground would "produce thorns and thistles" (Gen. 3:18). In pre-Fall time, in Genesis 1:11–12, "vegetation" is the Hebrew word *deše'*, and "seed-bearing plants" is *'ēśeb mazrîa' zēra'*. By contrast, in Genesis 2:5 when it says, "no shrub had yet appeared," "shrub" is the Hebrew word *śîaḥ*. Younker links *śîaḥ* to the thorns and thistles of Genesis 3:18, and so it is a reference to a thorny xerophyte.[1] Just as Adam's fall caused death to enter the human race (Rom. 5:12), so it caused death to enter the natural world, which consequently longs for restoration (Rom. 8:18–22). Of course, this would not be the case if death were the means God had used to create the natural world. Younker denies the hypothesis that there are two creation records (Gen. 1–2).

Roberto Ouro rejects the hypothesis that there is a division between Genesis 2 and 3, demonstrating the unity of Genesis 2–3. He concludes "that Gen 2–3 is the work of a single author who used consistent patterns of thematic, literary, and linguistic terminology to describe what happened to the earth and its inhabitants some time after their creation. Consequently, Gen 2–3 presents *a new narrative—the account of the origin of evil and death*—in contrast to the Gen 1 account, which focuses on the origin of goodness and life."[2]

Genesis 1–3 can be considered a unit about beginnings: (1) the start of a good creation mostly by a fiat Word of God, and (2) the entrance of sin to mar the good creation by disobedience to the Word of God.

Fall of Humans

Humans were created in the image of God, and before learning of the law (not to eat the forbidden fruit, Gen. 2:16–17), they were created for a perfect relationship with God and with one another—which is the essence of the

1. Randy Younker, "Genesis 2: A Second Creation Account?" in *Creation, Catastrophe and Calvary*, ed. John Templeton Baldwin (Hagerstown, MD: Review and Herald, 2000), 72–74.
2. Roberto Ouro, "The Garden of Eden Account: The Chiastic Structure of Genesis 2–3," in *Andrews University Seminary Studies* 40/2 (Autumn 2002): 243, emphasis in original.

law as described later by Christ (Matt. 22:36–40). I concur with John Wesley's observation that "the entire law of love" was "written in his heart"[3] (referring to humankind, Adam and Eve, and hence "written in their hearts"). In other words, they had the law within, representing their relationship with God, a relationship that should have kept them loyal to Him through observing His external law. Knowing that humans would fall, it seems reasonable that the preincarnate Creator-Christ would give Adam and Eve a Sabbath-day of relationship with Him as their first full day of life. That is why it seems incredible that the Reformer Martin Luther believed Adam fell on that first Sabbath.[4]

Freedom of choice by fallen humans must be understood as possible within a relationship with God. Humans don't need God's help to disobey; this is the work of Satan. However, humans always need God's help to obey. Put differently, disobedience issues from a broken relationship with God, while obedience is a relational act with God's help. Fallen humans have a damaged image of God within them, and so they need God's help to choose rightly.

God has a book of life in which are written the names of those who accept His salvation (Exod. 32:33; Ps. 69:27–28; Dan. 12:1; Phil. 4:3b; Rev. 20:12, 15), a free choice made by them in history (John 3:16). After receiving the Ten Commandments, God's people worshiped a golden image. Moses said to God, "'[P]lease forgive their sin—but if not, then blot me out of the book you have written.' The LORD replied to Moses 'Whoever has sinned against me I will blot out of my book'" (Exod. 32:32–33). God indicated that salvation is dependent upon free choice; it is not dependent upon an eternal decree of the elect (writing of names in a book), and it is not dependent on irresistible grace (once saved, always saved). Salvation is conditional (see Deut. 28), for God wants a relationship with humans. That is why He gave Adam and Eve a choice in Eden. In the end times, "There will be a time of distress such as has not happened from the beginning of nations until then. But at that time your people—everyone whose name is found written in the book—will be delivered" (Dan. 12:1).

God is a relational God who prizes human freedom of choice. Creation and redemption are rooted in God's desire to have a real relationship with humans, and they with Him. The Persons of the Trinity have eternally enjoyed reciprocal love in their inner history, and they long to share reciprocal love in their outer history with humans.

3. John Wesley, *The Works of John Wesley* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1996), 5:54.
4. Martin Luther, *Lectures on Genesis 1–5*, vol. 1 in *Luther's Works*, ed. Jaroslav Pelikan, trans. George V. Schick (Saint Louis, MO: Concordia, 1958), 81–82.

COSMIC CONTROVERSY CONTEXT

The controversy began in heaven prior to the creation and fall of humans. Lucifer (named Satan after he became a rebel) was a guardian cherub in heaven. He was at the throne of God (Ezek. 28:14), and even had his own throne (Isa. 14:13a). But he became proud because of his beauty (Ezek. 28:17), and he said, "I will ascend to the heavens; I will raise my throne above the stars of God; I will sit enthroned on the mount of assembly, on the utmost heights of Mount Zaphon. I will ascend above the tops of the clouds; I will make myself like the Most High" (Isa. 14:13–14). Clearly Lucifer wanted to raise his throne to where God's throne is, and make himself like God; he was so proud of himself that he thought he could take God's place and rule the universe. Now that is a grandiose scheme, but he thought he could pull it off. Lucifer was delusional, but pride is like that.

Now Lucifer was greatly privileged. God said of him, "You were anointed as a guardian cherub, for so I ordained you. You were on the holy mount of God; you walked among the fiery stones. You were blameless in your ways from the day you were created till wickedness was found in you" (Ezek. 28:14–15). Christ created him, and the Trinity elevated him to his position. They gave him his beauty too, and he lived amidst the holiness and relational love of God. He had every incentive to revel in the amazing blessings lavished upon him. It seems that God gave him so much so that he would never have an excuse for the controversy God knew he would launch. For Satan to win a third of the angels (Rev. 12:4a) to his side must have taken crafty reasoning and patience, and it must have been motivated by his promise to improve their lot. For why else would they want to rebel? They had everything and seemed to lack nothing.

It worked. God says of Satan, "Through your widespread trade [Heb. *rĕkūllâ* can mean 'gossip'] you were filled with violence, and you sinned" (Ezek. 28:16a). One gets the picture that Satan was surreptitiously spreading gossip about God until open rebellion broke out. The verse continues, "So I drove you in disgrace from the mount of God, and I expelled you, guardian cherub, from among the fiery stones" (Ezek. 28:16b). "Disgrace" conjures up the picture of Lucifer's being exposed as a fraud, his gossip shown to be false. Then there was a war in heaven, whatever that means. It may have been a war of words: "Then war broke out in heaven. Michael [Heb., means "one who is like God," and is used of Christ, e.g., Jude 9] and his angels fought against the dragon [Satan, Rev. 12:9], and the dragon and his angels fought back. But he was not strong enough, and they lost their place in heaven" (Rev. 12:7–8). So the one who is like God (Christ) fought against the one who thought he was better than God.

METHOD OF TEMPTATION

Scripture says that "the serpent was more crafty than any of the wild animals the LORD God had made," and this serpent tempted Eve in Eden (Gen. 3:1). Genesis 3:1–6 presents the fall of humans, as Eve—followed by Adam—submits to the temptation of a serpent. If the serpent caused the fall of humans, it is important that the serpent be known. Gordon J. Wenham asks, "Why, it is often asked, did a snake appear and tempt the woman? Very diverse answers have been offered, though none appear entirely satisfactory. Early Jewish and Christian commentators identified the snake with Satan or the devil, but since there is no other trace of a personal devil in early parts of the OT, modern writers doubt whether this is the view of our narrator."[5] Gerhard von Rad is one of these writers. He claims, "The serpent which now enters the narrative is marked as one of God's created animals (ch. 2.19). In the narrator's mind, therefore, it is not the symbol of a 'demonic' power and certainly not of Satan."[6] But why is this analysis confined to one part of Scripture? We should look to Scripture as a whole to see if it identifies the serpent. This is the *sola-tota-prima Scriptura* principle of biblical interpretation that we stress in this system. As Alfred Edersheim of Oxford University puts it, "[T]he Bible should be viewed, not only in its single books, but in their connection, and in the unity of the whole."[7]

Looking at Scripture we find the following insights. With reference to Satan's final expulsion from heaven at Christ's death (Rev. 12:9–12), Scripture says, "The great dragon was hurled down—that ancient serpent called the devil, or Satan, who leads the whole world astray. He was hurled to the earth, and his angels with him" (Rev. 12:9). From the perspective of the cross, Satan was the "ancient serpent," and he had been leading the world astray since the Fall (Isa. 28:14–16). Scripture says of this former guardian cherub, "You were in Eden" (Ezek. 28:13a). Revelation adds that at the beginning of the future Millennium, an angel will seize "the dragon, that ancient serpent, who is the devil, or Satan" (Rev. 20:2).

Scripture says, "Satan himself masquerades as an angel of light" (2 Cor. 11:14) in human history, so did he masquerade as a serpent in Eden? Or did he use the serpent as a medium?

5. Gordon J. Wenham, *Genesis 1–15*, vol. 1 in *Word Biblical Commentary*, ed. David A. Hubbard and Glenn W. Barker (Waco, TX: Word, 1987), 72.
6. Gerhard von Rad, *Genesis: A Commentary*, trans. John H. Marks (Philadelphia, PA: Westminster, 1972), 87.
7. Alfred Edersheim, *Old Testament Bible History* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1982).

Keil and Delitzsch believe that Satan used the serpent as a medium to deceive Eve.[8] Why a serpent? Victor Hamilton believes there may be a connection between the Hebrew word for "serpent" (*nāḥāš*) and the Hebrew word for "bronze" (*nĕḥōšet*). "This connection with bronze suggests a shiny and luminous appearance, which would arrest Eve's attention."[9]

Evidence that Satan used a serpent as his medium is found in God's curse. "So the LORD said to the serpent, 'Because you have done this, Cursed are you above all the livestock and all the wild animals! You will crawl on your belly and you will eat dust all the days of your life'" (Gen. 3:14). God knew that it was Satan who used the serpent, that is why He says in the next verse, "And I will put enmity between you [Satan] and the woman, and between your offspring [followers] and hers; he [Christ] will crush your [Satan's] head and you will strike his [Christ's] heel" (Gen. 3:15). This is the first gospel promise in Scripture, well known and accepted as such by all Christians. Paul adds, "The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet" (Rom. 16:20a).

Humans were created "a little lower" than angels (Heb. 2:7a). Satan didn't appear as an angel (superior to Eve) but as a creature (inferior to Eve), which probably set her at ease. The creature's brilliance attracted her, and so did its ability to speak. "Did God really say, 'You must not eat from any tree in the garden'?" (Gen. 3:1b). His shock and surprise were effective, and his meaning clear: "You mean you cannot eat *any* fruit at all? Then why did He create it for you if you cannot eat it?" Satan knew this would elicit a response, even though he knew that in reality God had only forbidden them to eat from a single tree in the entire garden.

Eve replied, "We may eat fruit from the trees in the garden, but God did say, 'You must not eat fruit from the tree that is in the middle of the garden, and you must not touch it, or you will die'" (Gen. 3:2–3). Yet touching the fruit was not in Christ's prohibition (Gen. 2:17). Then Satan responded, "You will not certainly die" (Gen. 3:4a). Satan had rejected Christ's words. Here were two opposing claims, by two who were opposed in the cosmic controversy. Who would she believe? The One who had done everything for her, or the one who had done nothing for her?

Bruce Demarest says Eve was tempted "first to distrust God's goodness (Gen 3:1–3) and then to disbelieve God's Word (Gen 3:4–5)."[10] Satan tempted her to distrust God's love and then to doubt His wisdom. Satan always insinuates doubt

8. C. F. Keil and F. Delitzsch, *The Pentateuch*, vol. 1 in *Commentary on the Old Testament in Ten Volumes* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1986), 91–92.

9. Victor P. Hamilton, *The Book of Genesis, Chapters 1–17*, in *The New International Commentary on the Old Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1990), 187.

10. B. A. Demarest, "Fall of Man," *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, ed. Walter A. Elwell (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1984), 403.

as a way of breaking the relationship between humans and God. Doubt leads to disobedience and death. Henri Blocher says the snake's attack on God's word impugned "hidden motives" to God, which subject "the terms of the covenant to 'the hermeneutic of suspicion.'"[11] Why did the serpent question God's word? To suggest that God cannot be trusted. To say to Eve, "He's keeping something back from you which you could have if you were to eat this fruit. His forbidding is not in your best interest Eve. God knows if you eat the fruit your eyes will be opened, and you will become like God" (Gen. 3:5, paraphrase). Now that got Eve's attention—more than anything else up to that point. She could become like God. Now Satan appeared to be doing a lot for her. Yes, Christ had given her everything she had, but He hadn't said anything about becoming like God. Satan said that God knows that eating the fruit would make Eve like God—which implied that Christ had been holding out on humans. So the serpent was basically saying that Christ's death threat wasn't to keep them from harm, but to keep them from reaching their full potential. He didn't want them to discover His secret.

True, Adam and Eve were made in the image of God, but here was a way to become God. This was a way to become like the God of the universe, not merely have dominion over the earth. Satan knew this one would work, for it had worked for him. That is what had motivated his rebellion. But he didn't tell her anything about his having been cast out of heaven. She must have thought about that when she and Adam had to leave Eden (Gen. 3:22–24).

Eve knew that Christ made everything good (Gen. 1:3, 10, 12, 19, 21, 25, 31) and that Christ called the forbidden tree "good and evil" (2:17), but she called the forbidden fruit "good for food and pleasing to the eye, and also desirable for gaining wisdom" and took some and ate it (Gen. 3:6). Why did she say that the forbidden fruit was "desirable for gaining wisdom"? How did she know that? Was Satan eating the fruit, or at least touching it? Was this why he, a serpent, was speaking her human language? Satan succeeded on two levels: Doubt of God's Word led to disobedience (logical level), and the serpent was wise, spoke her language, and was very much alive (empirical level). "Seeing was believing" concurred with logic, and so Eve took the plunge and ate the fruit.

PURPOSE OF TEMPTATION

From the beginning of the cosmic controversy Satan has had one purpose: to separate persons from God. He was able to win a third of the angels to his side, which is no mean feat, given that they were perfect, intelligent beings who lived in the very presence of God. But logic would suggest that he accomplished this

11. Henri Blocher, *In the Beginning: The Opening Chapters of Genesis*, trans. David G. Preston (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1984, 1st Fr. ed. 1979), 139.

through the same means he employed in Eden—to claim that he had more to offer them, that God was keeping something from them. For why else would they rebel, when they had everything? They were tempted to gain more than was lawful for them—to become like God, just as Satan had schemed for himself. This temptation worked in heaven, it worked in Eden, and it continues to work throughout human history.

Satan's promise to Eve was a great lie, and after Adam joined Eve in eating the fruit (Gen. 3:6b), the floodgates were opened for all the evil that has ravaged humans on planet earth. It is no wonder that during His life in human history Jesus told rebels, "You belong to your father, the devil, and you want to carry out your father's desires. He was a murderer from the beginning, not holding to the truth, for there is no truth in him. When he lies, he speaks his native language, for he is a liar and the father of lies" (John 8:44). The Greek Bible calls Satan's lie "the lie" (*to pseudos*). *Questioning the trustworthiness of the Creator is "the lie" for Christ is "the way and the truth and the life"* (John 14:6a, emphasis added). The cosmic controversy, at its core, is the father of lies questioning the One who is the truth.

Christ knew from personal experience, both in heaven and on earth, that Satan works to separate intelligent beings from their Creator and that he does so through lies. We need to realize that these lies have entered theology, just as they entered heaven and Eden. Lies in theology are nonbiblical doctrines taught as if they were biblical. The purpose of these doctrines is to replace truth, to advance the cosmic controversy against Christ. In my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, we noted that traditional views of God have replaced the biblical views; in this volume we have noted how evolution replaces God's supernatural creation (chapter 1), and the immortality of the soul replaces death as a sleep (chapter 2). But there's more to discover as we journey through the system.

Infallible Evidence

Evangelicals speak of Scripture as inerrant in the original autographs, or trustworthy in its present form as authentic revelation from God. The life and teachings of Christ are dependable and of infinite value to Christians. It is of interest that Christ, who studied the Old Testament Scriptures, never criticized them, but upheld them as God's Word. Christ had read the creation record, and if there had been any error in it, He would have been the first to announce it openly. He certainly did that with the sins of the Scribes and Pharisees. The fact that Christ accepted the historical reality of Adam and Eve (Matt. 19:5) and the historical reality of the Sabbath at the close of creation week (Mark 2:27–28)—and

hence the literal twenty-four-hour creation days as contiguous, consecutive segments of that week—gives encouragement to Christians to embrace a historical/literal record of creation week. To do less is to doubt God's Word just as surely as Eve doubted God's Word. There isn't any difference in kind between God's written Word (the creation record) or doubting His spoken Word (His command to Adam and Eve). To doubt the literalness of both is to doubt God, which may surprise many Christians who really love Christ, yet are persuaded by evolutionary or geological information, to reject, to some degree at least, the creation recorded as recounted in Genesis.

Certainly isotope geology suggests deep-time, and seems to give empirical evidence for the time span required for Darwinian macroevolutionary theory. Thousands of members of the scientific community for many years have presented a body of information that seems to support the veracity of evolution. This information questions the biblical (not merely Mosaic) revelation of God's having created everything primarily through His spoken Word. Yet the two are contrary. Did God create through a long process of evolution, or did He speak most things into existence? Is evolution more correct because it is dependent upon a natural process from pre-existing matter, or is biblical creation more correct because God's act of creating is not dependent upon pre-existing matter (*ex nihilo*)? Scripture supports the latter view (Rom. 4:17b; Heb. 11:3).

That being the case, is it wise to accept the evolutionary rather than the biblical worldview? Was it wise for Eve to accept Satan's view instead of God's view when it came to the possible effects of eating the forbidden fruit? There is a straightforward resemblance involved, not merely an analogy. Doesn't evolution present empirical evidence, and didn't Satan present empirical evidence? Do not both question God's Word—written in the case of evolution, and spoken in the case of Satan's temptation of Eve? Scientific evidence can be authentic, but it should be tested by Scripture, because Scripture says that "Satan himself masquerades as an angel of light" (2 Cor. 11:14).

As Christians, we love Christ. He means everything to us. He fills us with His presence, giving us love, joy, peace, and hope. He is our Savior and Lord. He is our Creator. What He says about creation means more to us than any contrary convictions, and His view of creation is supported with insights from the rest of Scripture. The way to overcome human doubts is to believe the living and written Word of God and to study creation from the perspective of Christ's understanding. This is the biblical way to approach this much debated topic (see chapter 5).

The historicity of the Fall is clear in Scripture. Paul said to the Corinthians, "But I am afraid that just as Eve was deceived by the serpent's cunning,

your minds may somehow be led astray from your sincere and pure devotion to Christ" (2 Cor. 11:3). What about Adam? Scripture speaks also of the fall of Adam as a historical fact: "Adam was not the one deceived; it was the woman who was deceived and became a sinner" (1 Tim. 2:14). Eve gave some forbidden fruit to Adam (Gen. 3:6b), and in so doing became a tempter to her husband. Though not mentioned in Scripture, Adam obviously decided to join Eve and took the fruit, apparently in fear of becoming separated from her. If she was to die, then he would too. Adam joined his deceived wife and became a rebel, and by so doing broke God's covenant (Hos. 6:7). Adam and Eve had entered the realm of brokenness.

Doubt of God's Word led to a broken relationship, which broke the covenant of God, which led to breaking His command. This chain of brokenness was hidden by the deceptive tempter, who knew full well the results of commandment breaking. Sin leads to death (Rom. 6:23), contrary to Satan's claim.

Evolution claims that death over deep-time accidently resulted in the formation of humans. That is not what Scripture says. God's Word tells us that death came through the sin of Adam: "For since death came through a man [Adam], the resurrection of the dead comes also through a man [Christ]. For as in Adam all die, so in Christ all will be made alive" (1 Cor. 15:21–22). The historicity of Adam's fall is as valid as the historicity of Christ's salvation. Adam and Eve were not mythical figures in a fictional saga, as some believe. In fact there could be no greater evidence for the creation account and the fall of humans (Gen. 1–3) than this validation given by Christ. For Christ shows that death didn't come through evolution but through sin. In so doing, Christ Himself denies evolutionary theory.

EFFECTS OF SIN ON ADAM AND EVE

Sin had immediate effects on Adam and Eve. Look at the record in Genesis 3:

1. Adam and Eve hid from Christ (v. 8).
2. They had fear (v. 10).
3. They were naked (v. 10).
4. Adam blamed Eve (v. 12).
5. Eve blamed the serpent (v. 13).
6. Pain in childbearing became the norm (v. 16).
7. Husband was now to rule over the wife (v. 16).
8. Ground was cursed with thorns and thistles (vv. 17–18).
9. Painful toil and sweat of the brow became the norm (vv. 17, 19).
10. Death entered the earth (v. 19).

What do these ten effects tell us? They reveal a broken relationship between humans and Christ, and between Adam and Eve (the spousal blame game started right away [Gen. 3:12–13]). Childbirth became painful, dominion of the earth became difficult, and death entered human life (Gen. 3:16–19). But what about the image of God in Adam and Eve? The Fall meant a change in the human nature but not in the divine nature. Whereas sin brought nakedness to Adam and Eve, Christ clothed them with animal skins (Gen. 3:21). As soon as there was sin, Christ stepped into the breach and held death back. Although Adam and Eve had broken the love relationship between themselves and Christ, He never ceased loving them, even though He hated the sin for what it had done to them and to their relationship with Him. Yes, sin had introduced a new reality, as human nature fell. But God's love for sinners (not for sin) remained unchanged.

The fact that Eve sinned first doesn't mean she deserves more blame than Adam. Eve was deceived (2 Cor. 11:3), but Adam was not deceived (1 Tim. 2:13–14). It is true that Eve was created a helper (Gen. 2:18) but instead became a seducer (Gen. 3:6b); it is true Christ said to Eve that Adam "will rule over you" (Gen. 3:16b), but this is not a command from God. It seems to be saying that, because of the Fall, wives will desire their husbands, and the husbands will desire to rule over their wives. It seems to be a statement of what sin does, not what God ordains. For God created Adam and Eve to image the reciprocal love among the Trinity; they were to be equals as the Persons of the Trinity are equals. By contrast, sin is self-centered and strives for supremacy, husbands over wives and wives over husbands. Strife shatters the equality between spouses that God intended (Gen. 1:27).

The Hebrew word for "rule" used in Genesis 3:16b is not *bāʿal* (to rule over) which is a title for the god Baal, meaning "master."[12] Rather, the word is *māšal*, which is used to describe Cain's sin prior to his act (Gen. 4:7b): sin "is crouching at your door; it desires to have you, but you must rule [*māšal*] it." Victor Hamilton comments:

> Applied to [Gen] 3:16, the desire of the woman for her husband is akin to the desire of sin that lies poised ready to leap at Cain. It means a desire to break the relationship of equality and turn it into a relationship of servitude and domination. The sinful husband will try to be a tyrant over his wife. Far from being a reign of co-equals over the remainder of God's creation, the relationship now becomes a fierce dispute, with each party trying to rule the other. The two who once reigned as one attempt to rule each other.[13]

12. William T. Koopman, "bāʿal," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology and Exegesis* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1997), 1:681.

13. Hamilton, *Book of Genesis*, in *The New International Commentary on the Old Testament*, 202.

Gordon Wenham notes, "Though woman was created to be man's companion, she is told that her desire for independence will conflict with his demand for submission. Under the curse, those who were created to be one flesh will find themselves tearing each other apart."[14] The previous verse is the famous first gospel text (Gen. 3:15). Christ has promised Adam and Eve that He will destroy Satan and save them.

The gospel restores humans to their original dignity in order to experience God's original intent: (1) "There is neither Jew nor Gentile, neither slave nor free, nor is there male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus," (Gal. 3:28); so (2) "Submit to one another out of reverence for Christ" (Eph. 5:21). Just as Christ accepts all Christians as equal, so Christians should accept one another as equal (which includes Christian husbands and wives). This equality was given to Adam and Eve in creation because it imaged the equality in the Trinity. The sin problem brought a difference of function within the equality of the Trinity and a different function within the equality of Christian husbands and wives. Just as Christ submitted to do the Father's will (Heb. 10:5–7; John 17:4), so "wives, submit yourselves to your own husbands" (Eph. 5:22). In this economy of function, Christ and wives submit as equals, not as underlings. They submit in love as team players. This submission is compatible with mutual submission.

Since the Father loves Christ (John 17:23b), husbands love their wives as Christ loves the church, which means they are willing to die for them (Eph. 5:25). This is reciprocal love between spouses that reflects reciprocal love among the Persons of the Trinity. This matchless love is the context for this passage: "Wives, submit yourselves to your husbands, as is fitting in the Lord. Husbands, love your wives and do not be harsh with them" (Col. 3:18–19).

So what is the "rule" of Genesis 3:16? It is "a rule which was first softened by the sin-destroying grace of the Gospel, and changed into a form more in harmony with the original relation, viz. that of a rule on the one hand, and subordination on the other, which have their roots in mutual esteem and love."[15] It is mutual love for each other, the same love the Persons in the Trinity have for each other, which is not changed by functions given during the sin history of humans—the time of the sin problem. As the Father acted to save the world, so husbands act to save their families.

Did the fall of humans affect the gift of dominion? Adam and Eve were created in the image of God to have dominion over the world (Gen. 1:26–27). But their sin brought them under "the dominion of darkness" (Col. 1:13), for Satan took the place of Adam as the representative of this world. This is why he

14. Wenham, *Genesis 1–15*, vol. 1 in *Word Biblical Commentary*, 89.
15. Keil and Delitzsch, *The Pentateuch*, vol. 1 in *Commentary on the Old Testament*, 103.

went to councils (Job 1:6–7; 2:1–2), why Christ referred to him as the "prince of this world" (John 12:31), and why Paul spoke of him as "the god of this age" (2 Cor. 4:4). To this degree, Satan usurped the dominion from Adam and Eve that Christ had given them. However, even fallen sinners united with God can have a loving dominion, an ecologically sensitive protection, over nature. How much more should humans want to protect nature, for it is due to human sin in Eden (and ever after) that "the whole creation has been groaning as in the pains of childbirth" (Rom. 8:22).

DAMAGED IMAGE OF GOD

It is true that Adam "had a son in his own likeness, in his own image" (Gen. 5:3), a damaged image, but Adam's son still bore the image of God. This is why even after the Fall God can speak of the image of God in humankind. In His covenant with Noah, following the Flood, God said, "Whoever sheds human blood, by humans shall their blood be shed; for in the image of God has God made mankind" (Gen. 9:6). Clearly fallen humans retain the image of God, even if in a damaged form. James said the tongue can "curse people who are made in the likeness [*homoiōsin*, same Gr. word used in the LXX of Gen. 1:17 for likeness, a synonym for image, *eikona*] of God" (Jas. 3:9, ESV). Paul says men should not cover their heads, for they are "the image and glory of God" (1 Cor. 11:7).

Victor Hamilton says, "Murder is placed in the orbit of sacral law. To kill another human being is to destroy one who is a bearer of the divine image. Thus man's divine creation should be a deterrent to criminal behavior. There is no evidence here that sin has effaced the divine image. It is still resident in post-Flood, post-paradise man."[16] James Adamson says, "We note that James, like Jesus, knows nothing of what is popularly thought of as the doctrine of 'total depravity': though impaired the imago dei [image of God] is not totally destroyed."[17] John Calvin said, "Were any one to object and say, that the image of God in human nature has been blotted out by the sin of Adam; we must, indeed, confess that it has been miserably deformed, but in such a way that some of its lineaments still appear. Righteousness and rectitude, and the freedom of choosing what is good, have been lost; but many excellent endowments, by which we exceed the brutes, still remain."[18]

Some scholars believe that the image of God included an immortal soul that still remains in post-Fall humans. Commenting on James 3:9, R. C. H. Lenski

16. Hamilton, *Book of Genesis*, in *The New International Commentary on the Old Testament*, 315.
17. James B. Adamson, *The Epistle of James*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1976), 146.
18. John Calvin, *The Epistle of James*, vol. 22, pt. 2 in *Calvin's Commentaries* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1989), 323.

claims, "These human beings still bear much of the divine stamp with which God created man: each is an immortal spirit, a person who has will, self-consciousness, knowledge, dominion. These are damaged but not destroyed, conscience still binds man to the right and condemns the wrong."[19] Christ said, "I am the resurrection and the life. The one who believes in me will live, even though they die; and whoever lives by believing in me will never die. Do you believe this?" (John 11:25–26, emphasis added). Leon Morris comments, "They may die in the sense that they pass through the door we call physical death, but they will not die in the fuller sense. Death for them is but the gateway to further life and fellowship with God. This transcends the Pharisaic view of a remote resurrection at the end of time."[20] (We evaluated the claim of immortality in the previous chapter, so will not say more here. Simply put, Scripture teaches that human immortality comes only at the Second Advent, when death will be ultimately defeated.)

TOTAL DEPRAVITY AND THE IMAGE OF GOD

There is more to be said about this damaged image of God. We need to consider: (1) what *total depravity* means in a damaged image of God; (2) what conscience does in the damaged image of God; (3) why the new birth is so important; (4) what nature reveals regarding the damaged image of God; and (5) then explore what conclusions we have reached.

What *Total Depravity* Means

Depravity, though not total, leaves a person without salvation. Depravity affects body, mind, and spirit—the total person. In Reformed theology, total depravity requires God to choose human destiny because humans cannot choose, and then God gives them irresistible grace because humans are not capable of responding to His calling. However, human freedom to choose was not lost in the Fall, although humans now need God's enabling power in order to willingly choose God. Fallen humans are not responsible for Adam's choice to sin, but they suffer the full effects of that choice, and are self-centered from birth. They have fallen natures, and hence even their best deeds are without merit. These fallen natures remain until glorification at the Second Advent. So the entire Christian life, however well lived by God's grace, is without merit to God, and can never contribute one iota to salvation.

19. R. C. H. Lenski, *The Interpretation of the Epistle of James* (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg, 1966). Lenski also says that the likeness of God in post-Fall humans refers to a general image, but not to a special image (holiness and righteousness), 611. So immortality of the soul is included in the general image of God, pre- and post-Fall.

20. Leon Morris, *The Gospel According to John*, rev. ed., in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1995), 488.

Sanctification is God's gradual changing of humans so that they have victory through Him over their fallen nature. God's work within humans never eradicates the fallen nature. That happens only through the work of Christ at His second advent. In the process of sanctification the character is being changed toward perfection, but this is different from nature perfection. Augustine's view of total depravity meant all humans were participants in Adam's sin and thus shared in his guilt. To him, original sin means that all humans were present in the loins of Adam when he sinned, and so share in the guilt of that sin—"in which [sin] all have sinned."[21] It is correct to say that sin entered the world through Adam and that condemnation passed on to all humans (Rom. 5:18). This means all humans are born sinners (Ps. 51:5), but Scripture does not say the human race was in Adam and sinned in him, and thus share his guilt. In traditional theology, total depravity allows for freedom of choice in secular matters, but not in spiritual matters.[22]

What do we mean when we say that *total depravity* affected Adam and all his posterity? It means humans are fully under the control of Satan. This includes their freedom to choose. Sin did not merely lead to physical death but included moral death. The deeper humans sank into sin, the further defaced their image of God became—until it was almost obliterated. It is correct to say that the image of God in fallen humans was terribly disfigured but not destroyed.

There is much evidence in Scripture that fallen human beings are lost and without hope, and have no way to extricate themselves from their depraved condition. In fact, people are born sinners, and therefore they are in desperate need of a Savior before they even commit their first sin. In other words, all humans are born with a sinful nature, and they will remain hostage to that nature if they live under its control of their thoughts and deeds. Humans are born as prisoners to their fallen nature. David said, "Surely I was sinful at birth, sinful from the time my mother conceived me" (Ps. 51:5). He said,

21. Augustine, *On Forgiveness of Sins, and Baptism, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, ed. Philip Schaff (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1987), 5:19 (1.11).

22. See Robert L. Reymond, *A New Systematic Theology of the Christian Faith* (Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson, 1998), 450–456; Louis Berkhof, *Systematic Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1996), 246–248. William T. Shedd says, "Upon the Semipelagian, the Tridentine, and the Arminian theory of depravity, there may be cooperation [between humans and God], but not upon the Augustinian and Calvinistic," *Dogmatic Theology*, ed. Alan W. Gomes (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 2003), 768. The biblical freedom of choice isn't interested in the anthropological assumptions that give too much credit to fallen humans in Semipelagian, Tridentine, and Arminian theories of depravity. Humans are helpless ro save themselves, to earn salvation, or even to be worthy of salvation, but in awesome love, God reaches out to touch each life (John 1:9), to draw them to respond to the gift of salvarion. God doesn't change in nature or character (cf. Mal. 4:6; Heb. 13:8; Jas. 1:17). His nature is love (1 John 4:8–16); hence the fruit of the Spirit is love, which includes "longsuffering" and "gentleness" (Gal. 5:22–23). Calvary is the fullest revelation of God's love, so Christ's death for all humans should be the measure by which we interpret all Scripture about God. Properly understood all revelation of God in Scripture is compatible with Calvary, as this system attempts to show.

"Even from birth the wicked go astray; from the womb they are wayward, spreading lies" (Ps. 58:3).

The depraved nature reigns from birth. "Those who live according to the flesh have their minds set on what the flesh desires; but those who live in accordance with the Spirit have their minds set on what the Spirit desires. The mind governed by the flesh is death, but the mind governed by the Spirit is life and peace. The mind governed by the flesh is hostile to God; it does not submit to God's law, nor can it do so" (Rom. 8:5–7). "The person without the Spirit does not accept the things that come from the Spirit of God but considers them foolishness, and cannot understand them because they are discerned only through the Spirit" (1 Cor. 2:14). Gentiles "are darkened in their understanding and separated from the life of God because of the ignorance that is in them due to the hardening of their hearts" (Eph. 4:18). "The heart is deceitful above all things and beyond [human] cure. Who can understand it?" (Jer. 17:9). "A bad tree cannot bear good fruit" (Matt. 7:18).

These verses seem to describe the state of the wicked before they accept salvation. Many of the wicked have already chosen to reject salvation: "In his pride the wicked man does not seek him; in all his thoughts there is no room for God" (Ps. 10:4). Jesus said to some unconverted persons: "'[Y]ou refuse to come to me to have life.... you do not have the love of God in your hearts" (John 5:40, 42). These texts speak from the perspective of the unsaved. Some refuse salvation, and this goes beyond any mere inability they have. Their fallen nature under Satan's rule chooses to remain as it is, rejecting any overtures from God.

Fallen people, controlled by their fallen natures, can never choose to come to God by their own decision. In saving fallen humans God must always takes the initiative; otherwise, those people will always remain locked within their fallen natures. Theologians have called this approach of God to fallen people *prevenient grace.* It simply means that God comes to people to offer them freedom from their bondage to the fallen nature. He has a double right to make this invitation because He both created and redeemed humans. Furthermore, He is the only One who can undo the results of the Fall.

God understands the desperate plight of humans. He can do for them that which they can never do for themselves. He says,

> As for you, you were dead in your transgressions and sins, in which you used to live when you followed the ways of this world and the ruler of the kingdom of the air, the spirit who is now at work in those who are disobedient. All of us also lived among them at one time, gratifying the cravings of our flesh and following its desires and thoughts. Like the rest, we were by nature deserving of wrath. But because of his great love for us, God, who is rich in mercy, made us alive with Christ even when we were dead in transgressions—it is by grace you have been saved. (Eph. 2:1–5)

In other words, "[J]ust as through the disobedience of the one man [Adam] the many were made sinners, so also through the obedience of the one man [Christ] the many will be made righteous" (Rom. 5:19).

God's invitations can only be answered by His help. In other words, when persons sense the power of Christ or the Spirit and desire to respond, they do so only with the help of Christ and the Spirit. The Christian life is a relationship experience, a covenant between God and humans. Speaking through Joshua God said, "[C]hoose you this day whom ye will serve" (Josh. 24:15, KJV). God said, "Turn to me and be saved, all you ends of the earth; for I am God, and there is no other" (Isa. 45:22). "Let anyone who is thirsty come to me and drink" (John 7:37b); "Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest" (Matt. 11:28). Christ Himself explains this coming to God: "I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me" (John 14:6).

Some Gentiles, or non-Christians, respond to Christ without knowing who He is. Christ spoke some words that can be translated two ways—and both translations are true to the Greek grammar. Consider John 1:9: (1) The 2011 New International Version says: "The true light that gives light to everyone was coming into the world." The focus here is on Christ's incarnation. (2) The 1984 New International Version says: "The true light that gives light to every man was coming into the world." Here the focus is on Christ's enlightening every person. Christ came for every person; not only did He die for everyone (1 John 2:2), He also enlightens everyone (John 1:9). In other words, He takes the initiative through the Holy Spirit to enlighten every person.

What Conscience Does to the Damaged Image of God

Humans have a conscience on board even after the Fall. This has nothing to do with having an immortal soul. So what does it mean that "He [God] has also set eternity in the human heart" (Eccles. 3:11b)? Delitzsch says that man's "innermost wants cannot be satisfied by that which is temporal."[23] Stafford Wright believes a God-given sense of eternity and a desire to know the whole elevate humans above animals, and are evidence of their having been created in the likeness of God.[24] Humans were made for God—for a relationship and a future with Him. God knew there would be an interval of sin, but

23. Keil and Delitzsch, *The Book of Ecclesiastes*, vol. 6, pt. 3, in *Commentary on the Old Testament*, 261.

24. J. Stafford Wright, *Ecclesiastes*, vol. 5, in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1991), 1162.

that redemption would allow those made in the image of God to be prepared to realize their God-given destiny. For humans were made for God—not to be God, but to be with God.

The conscience is a point of contact for God's enlightening (John 1:9). This explains why many non-Christians have a sense of right and wrong. While the conscience alone does not equip humans to take the first step toward God, it is the destination of God's first step toward fallen humans. The conscience without God's enlightenment is insufficient to lead the fallen nature toward God. This explains the experience of the Gentiles as recorded in Romans: "Indeed, when Gentiles, who do not have the law, do by nature things required by the law, they are a law for themselves, even though they do not have the law. They show that the requirements of the law are written on their hearts, their consciences also bearing witness, and their thoughts sometimes accusing them and at other times even defending them" (Rom. 2:14–15). While this law written on their hearts and an active conscience are evidence that the image of God has not been destroyed but defaced, it doesn't alter the fact that fallen humans are hopelessly lost without God's saving invitation to them.

Humans cannot save themselves; salvation, by definition, must come from God alone. The wondrous good news is God saves humans without coercion of any kind, not even a predetermined destiny without their input—without their freedom of choice. That is because fellowship with God before the Fall was freely accepted by Adam and Eve, and can only be restored on the same basis. Likewise, the fellowship of God with Adam and Eve before the Fall was conditional—as long as they didn't eat the forbidden fruit (Gen. 2:16–17)—and can only be restored on the same basis, because conditionality respects the freedom of humans and doesn't require irresistible force.

The Persons of the relational Trinity are interested in genuine relationship with humans, for they are consistent: their inner history of reciprocal love reaches out to share that love with willing humans. What they are in their relationship with one another is what they are in their relationship with humans. In both relationships mutual freedom is the only basis for a loving fellowship. The Persons of the Trinity do not change; they are true to themselves in being the same in their outer relations as they are in their inner relations.

Why the New Birth Is So Vital

Some people try to be good in their own strength; they are attempting to earn salvation in their own fallen strength. That never works, anymore that a leap could take them from earth to heaven. Jesus said to Nicodemus, "Very truly I tell you, no one can see the kingdom of God unless they are born again" (John 3:3). An

outwardly respectable life is not enough. The first birth dooms people to destruction. Only the second birth in Christ brings salvation. Christ makes the difference, for if anyone receives Him they are "born of God" (John 1:11–13), for "if anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come" (2 Cor. 5:17). We have to become a new creation before we can enter the new creation, or new earth.

A new birth is like a new person. Paul expresses the change:

> At one time we too were foolish, disobedient, deceived and enslaved by all kinds of passions and pleasures. We lived in malice and envy, being hated and hating one another. But when the kindness and love of God our Savior appeared, he saved us, not because of righteous things we had done, but because of his mercy. He saved us through the washing of rebirth, and renewal by the Holy Spirit, whom he poured out on us generously through Jesus Christ our Savior. (Tit. 3:3–6)

The Father gives "us birth through the word of truth" (Jas. 1:18a). Each member of the Trinity works together in this new creation of humans, just as they did in the creation of the world.

The new birth is the beginning of a life that can lead to salvation. New babies look perfect, so do new Christians. They are bubbling over with joy and worship, praising Christ. But even the new birth fails to remove the fallen nature. The new birth is a decision to follow Christ in response to His invitation. The Christian life is a struggle between the two natures (Rom. 7–8) for the fallen nature will at times rear its ugly head. We are becoming changed (see chapter 15), but sanctification is a work of a lifetime. The fallen nature is not eradicated until the Second Advent (1 Cor. 15:51–53). Then, finally, the work of being changed that began in the new birth is completed.

In the meantime "all our righteous acts are like filthy rags; we all shrivel up like a leaf, and like the wind our sins sweep us away" (Isa. 64:6). Paul says, "[T]here is no one who does good, not even one" (Rom. 3:12b; cf. Ps. 14:3b).

What Nature Does to the Damaged Image of God

Nature reveals God, even to those who bear a damaged image of God. Job says, "But ask the animals, and they will teach you, or birds in the sky, and they will tell you; or speak to the earth, and it will teach you, or let the fish in the sea inform you. Which of all these does not know that the hand of the Lord has done this?" (Job 12:7–9). David adds, "The heavens declare the glory of God; the skies proclaim the work of his hands" (Ps. 19:1). Paul says about those who rebel against God that "what may be known about God is plain to them, because God has made it plain to them. For since the creation of the world God's invisible qualities—his eternal power and divine nature—have

been clearly seen, being understood from what has been made, so that people are without excuse" (Rom. 1:19–20).

Conclusion

Total depravity, in the Augustinian sense of original sin that is passed down to all humans, is not biblical. From the human perspective *total depravity* means humans are lost and without God, and they have no chance of being saved. They must be born again but have no inherent ability to be born again.

From God's perspective He is omniscient, knowing exactly the hopeless condition of humans after the Fall. For the Fall consisted of a broken relationship with God. Therefore, God planned for that fallen condition in the following ways: (1) He created humans in the image of God in such a way that the image could be damaged by the Fall but not destroyed. (2) This included placing a conscience in each human heart, a point of contact within humans through which God could make contact. Even after the Fall, that conscience, if open to God, could sense the difference between right and wrong. (3) It seems that the damaged image of God and conscience could still see God revealed in nature. With these three advantages, God takes the initiative to draw humans to Himself, to be born again. And even after their new birth, God stays with humans to assist in the process of sanctification until glorification completes His work in willing recipients. This is a relational way to restore the relationship lost in the Fall. During this relational remedy, God enables humans to use their freedom of choice to choose to live in loving relationship with Him.

God and Evil

Those who believe that God's absolute sovereign will determines all that happens in history are faced with the problem of evil. Did God will evil? Does He still will evil? Wayne Grudem believes God intended evil. He says,

> [I]f we maintain that God does not use evil to fulfill his purposes, then we would have to admit that there is evil in the universe that God did not intend, is not under his control, and might not fulfill his purposes. This would make it very difficult for us to affirm that "all things" work together for good for those who love God and are called according to his purposes (Rom. 8:28). If evil came into the world in spite of the fact that God did not intend it and did not want it to be there, then what guarantee do we have that there will not be more and more evil that he does not intend and that he does not want? And what guarantee do we have that he will be able to use it for his purposes, or even that he can triumph over it? Surely this is an undesirable alternative position.[25]

25. Wayne Grudem, *Systematic Theology: An Introduction to Biblical Doctrine* (Leicester, England: InterVarsity; Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1994), 328–329.

This statement is made in the context of belief in a sovereign God, but not in the context of the cosmic controversy. The cosmic controversy questions the sovereign God. His is sovereign as the only God, but as Creator He allows all created beings the freedom of choice. It was precisely this freedom of choice that launched to cosmic controversy. And so this Calvinistic emphasis on God's sovereignty fails to take human freedom into consideration. This controversy was not intended by God, but He foreknew that it would take place. He knew what sin would mean to Him, and He knew the enormous price of sin that humans could never pay, so He was willing to pay the price.

The fact that Christ gave Adam and Eve the power to choose is proven by the forbidden tree in Eden (Gen. 2:16–17). Why would God have a forbidden tree which in itself was "very good" like the rest of creation (Gen. 1:31) yet off-limits to His children? God didn't create an evil tree; rather, He used a good tree as a test for Adam and Eve. Why? He created humans for fellowship, which involves freedom to think, evaluate, and make choices. We assume that this God, who doesn't change in nature and character, did the same for angels in heaven, who also wrongly used their freedom of choice. The alternative would have been to create beings who were not given the power to choose, and hence would not have the freedom to elect to have a meaningful relationship with God.

It is of interest that John of Damascus, the last of the Greek church fathers (ca. 674–ca. 749), in his *Exposition of the Orthodox Faith*, said, "One should note that God foreknows all things but that He does not predestine them all [crucial point, He allows some things]. Thus, He knows the things that depend on us, but does not predestine them—because neither does He will evil to be done nor does He force virtue."[26] This concurs with the biblical data. Again he says, "So, when ever any creature freely rebels and becomes disobedient to Him who has made him, he has brought the evil upon himself.... Then, where does sin come from? It is an invention of the free will of the Devil."[27]

Second, although God did not intend or want evil, His comprehensive plan (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 8) includes the cessation of evil, so that it will not arise again (Rev. 21:2–4; 22:3–5). This comes in two stages: (1) Christ's defeat of the devil (Heb. 2:14) and His work (1 John 3:8b) at the cross (this will be fully realized in final events on planet earth [see volume 4]); (2) the revelation of God's love and Satan's unmasking at Calvary (John 13:27), and Satan's final attempt to capture the New Jerusalem (Rev. 20:7–10). Grudem rejects the Arminian position that God allowed for the possibility of evil so that

26. *An Exact Exposition of the Orthodox Faith*, 2:30 (263), in *The Fathers of the Church: St. John of Damascus, Writings*, trans. Frederick H. Chase, Jr. (Washington, DC: Catholic University Press, 1999, 1st ed. 1958), 37.
27. Ibid., 4:20 (387).

angels and humans could have the necessary freedom for meaningful choices. He maintains that this is unsatisfactory because "it implies that God will have to allow for the possibility of sinful choices in heaven eternally."[28] This fails to understand the power of the Cross. Sin (or wrong choices) will never rise again because Calvary love will draw all the saved and unfallen to love God more than any selfish choice (cf. John 12:31–32).

Grudem claims, "There are literally dozens of Scripture passages that say that God (indirectly) brought about some kind of evil," and he cites examples.[29] He concludes by saying, "In spite of all the foregoing statements, we have to come to the point where we confess that we do not understand how it is that God can ordain that we carry out evil deeds and yet hold us accountable for them and not be blamed himself."[30] Grudem ends by concurring with Louis Berkhof, saying, "the problem of God's relation to sin remains a mystery."[31]

Let's take a look at one example he cites: "I [God] form the light, and create darkness: I make peace, and *create evil*: I the LORD do all these things" (Isa. 45:7, KJV, emphasis in original).[32] Although the Hebrew word *rāʿ* can mean "evil," there is a wide semantic range of translations in various versions: "disaster" (NIV); "woe" (RSV; Goodspeed); "trouble" (NEB); and "calamity" (NASB, NKJV). Beyond this variance in translation, context removes the idea of mystery.

The alleged mystery is solved by understanding biblical conditionality, which is rejected in the Calvinistic TULIP.[33] For example, in Deuteronomy 28, God promises blessings to His people if they fulfill the conditions (vv. 1–14), and curses on them if they don't fulfill the conditions (vv. 15–68). Israel has freedom to choose either way (which was foundationally established in the forbidden fruit test before the Fall). What is involved is the principle of "you reap what you sow" (Gal. 6:7, NRSV). The context suggests that opposing one's Creator—something created beings are free to do—is the sowing that reaps disaster or evil. There would be no mention of evil or disaster with respect to God if there were no cosmic controversy against God. In other words, the curses come as a reaping which created beings have sown. Created beings are responsible for all evil, not God. Disasters do come from God in a sense, but not because He is evil; rather, because humans are evil.

And now we come to a very important conclusion: Evil exists because of the wrong choice of created beings, never because of the right choice of the Creator.

28. Grudem, *Systematic Theology*, 349.
29. Ibid., 323; for examples see pages 322–331.
30. Ibid., 330; each word is capitalized in original.
31. Ibid.; Berkhof, *Systematic Theology*, 175.
32. Grudem, *Systematic Theology*, 326.
33. TULIP is an acronym for Total depravity, Unconditional predestination, Limited atonement, Irresistible grace, and Perseverance of the saints.

However, because He is the Creator, and is unfolding His comprehensive plan of redemption and restoration, sometimes in Scripture God is referred to as doing that which He only *permits*. His permissive will is exercised only because He respects the free choice of His created beings. In the book of Daniel it is clear that "the Most High is sovereign over kingdoms on earth and gives them to anyone he wishes" (Dan. 4:17b; cf. the succession of kingdoms: Babylon, Medo-Persia, Greece, pagan Rome, end-times kingdoms, and God's kingdom). It should not be overlooked that each successive kingdom was inferior (Dan. 2:39) in metal and in reality (the last is merely a mixture of iron and clay, representing disunity, partly strong and partly brittle, Dan. 2:41–43); and the "reap what you sow" principle operates throughout.

Sin Defined

There are different ways in which *sin* can be defined, and we will consider some of them below. Eve was deceived, but then she chose to sin. She could have resisted Satan if she had remained in union with God and believed His Word. For believing is seeing—believing Christ's Word would have led Eve to see through Satan's counterfeit. Believing God's Word would have saved the world all the misery it has endured. Instead of embracing the idea that believing is seeing, Eve experienced the apparent reality that seeing is believing. Satan led Eve to doubt God's Word, and this led to disobedience. So where did sin begin? Was it with doubt, or with disobedience? We need to explore the biblical insights on sin, and in doing so we will come to a better understanding of how Scripture describes the fallen nature.

SIN AS ABSENCE OF GOOD

"Taking a page from Plato, Augustine espoused that evil is not a diabolical force ravaging the souls of the sinful, but rather the absence of good."[34] This means that sin cannot be caused by God, for God cannot create the absence of good because He is good. God is a relational Trinity. From eternity He has experienced a reciprocal relationship of love, in which each Person loves the other two more than He loves Himself. Creation is the overflow of this love, and so humans (made in His image, Gen. 1:26–27) were to reflect a relationship of love imaging the relationship of love among the Trinity. In other words, a relational Trinity made humans as relational beings. Augustine said that "the loss of good has received the name 'evil.'"[35] This definition from philosophy is not sufficient, so we turn to Scripture.

34. James Mannion, "Augustine of Hippo," accessed July 5, 2012, http://www.netplaces.com/philosophy-book/the-medieval-mind/augustine-of-hippo.htm.
35. Augustine, *City of God, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 2:210 (11.9).

SIN AS AN ACT

Scripture defines sin as "the transgression of the law" (1 John 3:4, KJV), or "lawlessness" (NIV, RSV). "Sin is always *against God.*"[36] "Therefore to him that knoweth to do good, and doeth it not, to him it is sin" (Jas. 4:17, KJV).

There are many Hebrew and Greek words translated by the one English word "sin," which emphasize sin as an act. Here are a few examples; *šāgâ* and *šāgag* mean "error," *tāʿâ* means "to err" or "wander about," *parakoē* means "to hear incorrectly," *ḥāṭāʾ* and *hamartanō* mean "missing the mark," *ʿābar* means "to cross over" or "to pass by," with *parabainō* as the Greek equivalent. The word *ʿāwal* means "to deviate from a right course," and *pāšaʿ* and *mārad* mean "to rebel," with *apeitheia*, *aphistēmi*, and *apostasia* as Greek equivalents. The words *māʿal* and *bāgad* mean "treachery," *parapiptō* means "to fall away," *ʿāwāh* means "to bend or twist," and *šiqqûṣ* means "abomination."[37] However, many of these words also imply or suggest a state of sin.[38]

SIN AS MORE THAN AN ACT

Scripture also speaks of sin as "more than an act." We will consider this under three headings: (1) immediate roots, (2) tendency to sin, and (3) sin as separation from God.

Immediate Roots

Romans 14:23 tells us that "everything that does not come from faith is sin." The context concerns acting without faith. Here the definition of sin reaches back behind the act to the motive that causes the act. This is the deeper, inner life of sin. These are "the thoughts and attitudes [*ennoiōn*, literally intentions] of the heart" (Heb. 4:12). Jesus said corrupt fruit comes from a corrupt tree (Matt. 12:33–35); likewise, evil proceeds out of the human heart (mind) (Mark 7:21–23).

This is why the law has more than some external relationship to the believer, for God said "I will put my laws in their minds and write them on their hearts" (Heb. 8:10; cf. Jer. 31:33; Heb. 10:16). This is why Jesus spoke of the inner meaning of law keeping, or law breaking (sin), as having to do with thoughts and motives, even though no external act ever took place. Thus a lustful look is the same as committing adultery, even though it only transpires in the mind

36. G. C. Berkouwer, *Sin*, in *Studies in Dogmatics Series* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1977), 242.

37. See Millard J. Erickson, *Christian Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1985), 564–575, for a good discussion of these terms; my own work on this topic is indebted to Erickson's insights.

38. See C. Ryder Smith, *The Bible Doctrine of Sin* (London: Epworth, 1953), and G. M. Staffen, *Sin as Set Forth in Holy Scripture* (New York: E. P. Dutton Company, 1986).

(Matt. 5:28). This is why the tenth commandment goes deeper than external acts, for covetousness is the internal act/state that precedes them (Exod. 20:17).

Tendency to Sin

"Even from birth the wicked go astray; from the womb they are wayward, spreading lies" (Ps. 58:3). So the word comes to Israel, "You were called a rebel from birth" (Isa. 48:8). Scripture penetrates beyond the thoughts, motives, and feelings that lie behind outward acts of sin, to a tendency to sin that is inherent in fallen human nature. David spoke of this when he said he was "sinful from the time my mother conceived me" (Ps. 51:5). Note that he says that he was not just sinful from birth, but from conception! In commenting on this verse, Keil and Delitzsch say, "David here confesses his hereditary sin as the root of his actual sin. The declaration moves backwards from his birth to conception, it consequently penetrates even to the most remote point of life's beginning."[39] (This verse supports the idea that life begins at conception, which needs to inform the abortion debate.)

In contrast to these statements, John the Baptist was "filled with the Holy Spirit even before he [was] born" (Luke 1:15). Leon Morris notes that John the Baptist is the only human spoken of in this way in the New Testament.[40] Of course, John was an exception because he was a chosen forerunner to prepare the way for Christ. At least we can say from history that even if the Holy Spirit is with humans from birth, all except Christ have given into the tendency to sin in spite of the presence of the Holy Spirit. "For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God" (Rom. 3:23). This is why all humans need to be born again (John 3:5).

In the Ten Commandments God says, "I, the LORD your God, am a jealous God, punishing the children for the sin of the fathers to the third and fourth generation of those who hate me, but showing love to thousands who love me and keep my commandments" (Exod. 20:5–6, RSV; cf. 34:7; Num. 14:18; 1 Kings 21:29). This passage seems to teach imputed punishment. It needs to be studied in the light of Ezekiel 18:20, in which we are told, "The son shall not suffer for the iniquity of the father, nor the father suffer for the iniquity of the son" (Ezek. 18:20, RSV). What is at stake here is the individual responsibility for sin. Natural results can be passed on, but guilt and punishment are never imputed. Irrespective of one's parents, all babies are born with a tendency to sin. Thus, humans enter the planet in need of a Savior before they ever sin.[41] But

39. Keil and Delitzsch, *Psalms*, vol. 5, pt. 2, in *Commentary on the Old Testament*, 136.

40. Leon Morris, *Luke*, vol. 3 in *Tyndale New Testament Commentaries* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), 77.

41. Strong, *Systematic Theology* (Philadelphia, PA: Judson, 1949, 1st ed. 1907), 579. This text implies that (a) sin exists in the case of infants prior to moral consciousness, and therefore (b) sin exists in the nature, as

why is this? To this we now turn as we consider what lies behind humankind's tendency to sin.

Separation from God

Behind these two roots of sin lies the need to understand exactly what Adam's sin was, what it did to him, and what he passed on to the race. God told Adam and Eve not to eat of the fruit of the tree in the midst of the garden (Gen. 3:1–5). They disobeyed. The resulting Fall was a withdrawal from a trusting relationship with God. So the essence of sin is separation from God, since it breaks the relationship with God. As soon as Adam and Eve sinned, they hid from God (Gen. 3:8) because sin had severed their ties with Him. Before the overt act of eating the fruit, Eve had broken her relationship with God. It was doubt—a broken relationship—that led to disobedience (Gen. 3:1–7). As Heppenstall points out,

> Original sin is not per se wrong doing, but wrong being. So there is a causal connection between the first sin of the first man and the self-centeredness of his posterity.... Trying to locate sin or the transmission of sin genetically simply misses the real problem. The issue is a spiritual one and not something in a gene. Sin is not transmitted genetically from parents to children. Sin must not be reduced to something physical.[42]

Therefore, because of Adam, humankind is also in a broken relationship with God. But, thank God, He provided the way back in and through Jesus Christ (John 14:6) who is "the true Light, which lighteth every man that cometh into the world" (John 1:9, KJV).[43] This is why each human must be born again (John 3:5–8). This is the deepest root of original sin, and the very essence of what Adam passes on to the race: "an inherited disposition to sin"[44] out of a broken relationship with God.

The essence of inherited sin from Adam is spiritual (broken relationship) and not genetic (physical). Although all humans are physically smaller, and live shorter lives than Adam, his original sin impacts us spiritually. The question of God's justice is involved in the way we look at the effects of Adam's sin. Heppenstall is right when he concludes, "Any position that makes genetically inherited sin or its moral consequences the specific ground for the condemnation of the race, involves God in the responsibility. Once solidarity with Adam is

distinguished from personal activity.

42. Edward Heppenstall, "The Law and the Covenant at Sinai," *Andrews University Seminary Studies* 2 (1964): 122.

43. The Greek verb for coming (*erchomenon*) can grammatically, in this passage, apply to Christ's coming in the first advent (as the RSV and NIV translate) or to each human's coming into the world (as in the KJV). Both are grammatically and theologically correct.

44. Heppenstall, "The Law and the Covenant at Sinai," *Andrews University Seminary Studies*, 107.

interpreted to mean transmission of sin by a procreated posterity, responsibility gets back to the Creator."[45]

Two Adams Compared

In studying Romans 5, Karl Barth reversed the Adam-Christ analogy with a Christ-Adam analogy, and thus did a disservice to history.[46] Nevertheless, I agree with G. C. Berkouwer that in Romans 5 "Adam, according to Paul, must stand in the *light of Jesus Christ*. Christ is the *theme* and the *starting-point* in this chapter."[47] Romans chapter 5 outlines the doctrine of justification within a soteriological framework. The super-abounding salvation through Christ is contrasted with the reign of death. The emphasis is on what Christ has done as the typological escalation to what Adam began. The indebtedness of the entire human race to Adam and Christ is spelled out in Romans 5.

The crucial parallelism between what the two Adams brought to the race is not identical, for Adam's broken relationship with God caused all his posterity to be born in need of a Savior; whereas Christ can only ultimately restore the broken relationship for those who accept what He did to bridge the gulf. Furthermore, what Christ has gained is even more than what the first Adam lost. The one sin of Adam has opened the gates to a sin situation, whereas the one act of Christ more than atones for Adam's sin, for it atones for all subsequent sin too.

In Romans 5, Paul broadens the definition of sin: "For just as through the disobedience of the one man the many were made sinners, so also through the obedience of the one man the many will be made righteous" (v. 19). Clearly Adam's sin affected the race and constituted them sinners. But what does this mean? Some answer this by going to verse 12: "[J]ust as sin entered the world through one man, and death through sin, and in this way death came to all people, 'inasmuch as all sinned.'" They suggest that Adam merely began the process, and each human enters sin through his or her own personal sin. However, that view is flawed because babies can die before sinning.

Others see Adam as the one who not only began the process but influenced it. Consider the contribution of the two Adams to the race. Romans 5:17–19 compares the two gifts to humankind from the two Adams. These gifts are genuine; they do not depend upon human works. Thus it is the obedience of Christ that constitutes a person as righteous, not his or her own obedience. Likewise

45. Ibid., 116.

46. Karl Barth, *The Epistle to the Romans*, trans. Edwyn C. Hoskyns (London: Oxford University Press, 1967), 149–187.

47. Berkouwer, *Sin*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 509–510.

the disobedience of Adam constitutes a person as a sinner (having a broken relationship with God) before his or her own acts of sin. Here Paul penetrates beyond personal acts of sin[48] as the reason for the human sin problem to the first sin of Adam that severed the race from its relationship with God.

Then why did Paul also say that "death came to all people, because all sinned" (Rom. 5:12)? Medieval Catholics used the Latin Vulgate translation: "*in quo omnes peccaverunt*," that is, "in whom all sinned," meaning all sinned in Adam (this is where Augustine got his view of original sin). This translation has been abandoned by most scholars, who favor "because all sinned" instead of "in whom all sinned."[49] More significant than this difference of translation is the immediate context. The next two verses, those that follow Romans 5:12, speak of death reigning even before the law, from the time of Adam to Moses (vv. 13–14). So death reigned from the first sin of Adam and on through all of human history. Clearly the reign of death is linked to its initiation in Adam rather to subsequent sin. Within this context the words "all sinned" are an ingressive aorist tense, meaning Adam's first sin began the process which has continued throughout (*dierchomai*) history. His first sin began the reign of death.

The fact that Paul singles out one period of human history, from Adam to Moses, indicates that he was not concerned with hereditary sin, a central problem in most imputation theories. His focus is on the super-abounding grace of Christ in spite of the reign of sin. Adam initiated the sin situation from which depravity and death result. Although death is not a punishment for Adam's sin, it is a consequence of his sin. Adam's sin gave humans a tendency to sin, a leaning toward sin, which is in the very nature of humans at birth. Human nature has certain propensities as a result of Adam's broken relationship with God.

Adam did not impute to humans condemnation, guilt, punishment, or sin. He did pass on a tendency to sin, because He led humans into a broken relationship with God. All sins issue from this state of sin into which humans are born. In his parallel passage to Romans 5, Paul compares death as a result of Adam's sin to resurrection as a result of Christ's death (1 Cor. 15:21). Both death and eternal life come from one "man," and this means that what Adam gifted the race is canceled by what Christ provisionally gifted the race. Because of Adam's sin, humans are born to die (first death). Because of their own sins, humans need to be born again to avoid the final judgment death (John 3:5).

Another important insight into the meaning of Romans 5 is found in comparing its parallel statements. The verse 12 and verse 17 in Romans 5 speak of death being passed on, and verses 18–19 speak of Adam's sin constituting his

48. Although, of course, each person's own sin obviously adds ro the sin problem, and is not to be condoned.
49. Berkouwer, *Sin*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 492.

descendants as sinners. It would seem that this constituting of a person a sinner is the death that is passed on. Both refer to the broken relationship with God which necessitates a Savior. That Adam's sin affects the race is mentioned five times in Romans 5:15–19. It is important to realize that the comparisons in this passage are between Adam and Christ (three times) and not between Adam and his posterity. Paul's focus is on Christ's super-abounding salvation in view of Adam's fall and its effects.

We need to follow the corresponding phrases in Romans 5, as pointed out by Richard Davidson.[50] There are three types: (1) the *hōs (hōsper)...houtōs*, or "as...so" phrases in verses 12, 18–19, 21; (2) the *ouch hōs...houtōs* or "as...so" phrases in verses 15–16; and (3) the *ei...pollō mallon* "if...much more" phrases in verses 15b and 17. The first group has a correspondence of similarities. Thus, as sin entered the world, so death passed to all humankind. As one offense brought all condemnation, so one act brought all justification/life (potentially); and as from one disobedience many were constituted sinners, so by one obedience were many constituted righteous. The "many" in these last two phrases are to be understood as equivalent to all, for verse 15 says that many died because of Adam's sin, whereas verse 12 says that death passed to all from Adam's sin.

The second group is a correspondence of opposites, for Christ's gift was not like Adam's sin and also condemnation came from Adam's one sin whereas justification comes to humans after many sins (Adam's and theirs). In this passage, "condemnation" (*katakrima*) is not to be understood as imputed punishment, but imputed tendency to sin.

The third group builds upon the second group by stressing that Christ's gift is much more than Adam's sin. The "much more" focus is mentioned five times in Romans 5 (vv. 9, 10, 15, 17, 20). From these corresponding phrases it is clear that (1) Adam and Christ are similar in gifting the race apart from human works, and (2) dissimilar in that all humans receive the gift from Adam whereas the gift from Christ is received only by those who accept it. Furthermore, (3) Christ's gift of the state of justification by faith in the new birth more than makes up for Adam's gift of the state of sin and death to the race at birth.

The soteriological context of Romans 5 is seen in verses 1–11. Paul glories in the super-abounding salvation through the life and death of Christ. The focus is on justification by faith, not on sanctification (the discussion of which follows in chapters 6 and beyond). Paul has argued convincingly in the first four chapters that justification is not by works of the law but by faith in the gift given by Christ. Romans 5:12 begins, "Therefore [as summation of what precedes], just

50. See Richard M. Davidson, *Typology in Scripture: A Study in Hermeneutical Typos Structures* (Berrien Springs, MI: Andrews University Press, 1981), 299–304.

as sin entered the world through one man [Adam], and death through sin, and in this way death came to all people," so "death reigned from the time of Adam to the time of Moses, even over those who did not sin by breaking a command, as did Adam" (v. 14). Paul continues by comparing the results of the one sin of Adam to the gift of righteousness to all humans (potentially) through the one gift of Christ (vv. 18–19).

Romans 5 mentions gifts (*charisma*, *dōrea*) in verses 15 and 16. But true gifts are never earned, and this is the crucial argument in Paul's doctrine of justification by faith. Justification is not by works; neither Christ's justification nor Adam's sin state depend upon human works. The two Adams give to the race without regard for human works, whether good or bad. So death comes to the whole race not when each one sins personally, but when each is born. Furthermore, in the whole context of Scripture, the gifts of both Adams are received at birth: sin as broken relationship (tendency to sin) at one's first birth, and justification when one is born again.

Terms such as *constituted sinners* and *condemnation*, although biblical, are often misinterpreted. Scripture knows of no imputation of sin, condemnation, punishment, or guilt. These terms are simply ways of expressing our broken relationship with God which has its source in the original sin of Adam. This is the essence of the tendency to sin into which all of us are born.

Self-Centered Sinners at Birth

If humans are born separated from God, then the center of their life is not God but self. Have you ever seen a baby who was essentially unselfish? As wonderful as babies are, I believe Edward Heppenstall is right when he declares, "Every child is born with an impossible self-centeredness. This Biblical truth is the primary fact of all human life at its beginning."[51] *Inherent propensities*, or an *evil, corrupt nature* are both ways to describe a broken relationship with God. Just as Adam and Eve were created in the image of God (Gen. 1:26–27), Adam "had a son in his own likeness" (Gen. 5:3). What is the significance of this change? Seth was a son of the fallen Adam. He was born in sin.

So sin is more than just an outward act. It precedes the act; sin is also about motive, the tendency to sin, and the broken relationship with God rooted in self-centeredness. As Erickson suggests, "[S]in is not merely wrong acts and thoughts, but sinfulness as well, an inherent inner disposition inclining us to wrong acts and thoughts. Thus it is not simply that we are sinners because we

51. Heppenstall, "The Law and the Covenant at Sinai," *Andrews University Seminary Studies*, 121.

sin; we sin because we are sinners."[52] What are the implications of the fact that all are sinners at birth, born separated from God, centered in self with a tendency to sin? When we grasp the utter desperate condition of the race, we better appreciate how great is the gift of salvation.

As Coates puts it, "The whole nature of the Christian religion stands upon these two great pillars, namely, the greatness of our fall and the greatness of our redemption."[53] Erickson agrees: "[T]he more radical our conception of sin, the more supernatural the salvation we will deem needed."[54] Because (1) Scripture teaches the depths of sin, that humans are sinners before they sin, and do not need to sin in order to become sinners; because (2) humans are born sinners due to Adam's broken relationship with God which was passed on to his posterity, all are born needing a Savior. The fact that Adam's sin has affected the entire human race has led to a number of theories about this matter.

At this juncture we will take up an examination of the theories of imputation.[55] (These are theories of imputation and not to be confused with theories of atonement given in chapter 14.)

Theories of Imputation

PELAGIAN THEORY

In 409 the British monk Pelagius presented his theory at Rome in which he argued humankind's natural innocence. His teaching was condemned at the Council of Carthage in 418. Socinians and Unitarians later came to advocate the same theory. This view teaches that every human soul is immediately created by God innocent, free from depraved tendencies, and with the ability to obey God as was Adam before his sin. According to this theory, the only effect of Adam's sin on his posterity was a bad example. So Adam's sin hurt no one besides himself.

Paradoxically, Pelagius also recognized the power of sin, that we are born unto perdition, that the image of God was eclipsed in the Fall, and that humans were in a certain sense corrupt, so that sin was natural. Nevertheless, in spite of human corruption, Pelagius holds that humans remain basically good.[56] Thus a person is not born with an inclination toward evil; such an inclination comes

52. Erickson, *Christian Theology*, 578.

53. Walter Grundmann, preface to Gottfried Quell, George Bertram, Gustave Stahlin, and Walter Grundmann, *Bible Key Words from Gerhard Kittel's* Theologisches Wörterbuch zum Neuen Testament, trans. Grundmann and Coates (London: Adam and Charles Black, 1959), v.

54. Erickson, *Christian Faith*, 562.

55. See Strong, *Systematic Theology*, 593–637, to whom I am indebted for material in this segment.

56. George Vandervelde, *Original Sin: Two Major Trends in Contemporary Roman Catholic Reinterpretation* (Washington, DC: University Press of America, 1981), 10–14.

only after personal acts of sin. Therefore, it is theoretically possible to live above sin, as Adam could have, and thereby get to heaven through living without sinning. This view doesn't consider Christ's incarnation and His saving mission to be essential for every human.

ARMINIAN THEORY

A professor at the University of Leyden in Holland, Arminius (1560–1605) proposed his theory which is dubbed "semi-Pelagian." He believed Adam's sin affected the race, so humans are born depraved in body and mind and hence cannot obey God; they are born without "righteousness." Therefore, God bestows a special gift of the Holy Spirit at birth to enable the newborn to obey. This is called *prevenient* grace (grace sent before conversion) which removes, and hence neutralizes, condemnation resulting from Adam's sin.

According to the Arminian theory, no baby is born with tendencies to do wrong. These only come from his or her own personal sins. Yet, the gift of the Holy Spirit to overcome depravity from Adam assumes that the Spirit, rather than Christ, saves humans from the results of Adam's sin. Also, each baby is seen as an isolated entity rather than a part of the human race. Salvation for the world (John 3:16), and the implications of this, have not been thought through. If humans have the ability to not sin, then the universality of sin and the universal need of a Savior are not a reality.

The Greek church holds this view, and Methodism later adopted it. There are different kinds of Arminians, just as there are different kinds of Protestants.

NEW SCHOOL THEORY

The New School theory was propounded by Hopkins, Emmons, Dwight, Taylor, and Finney. Some Presbyterians and Congregationalists support the view. It teaches that newborns enter the world with a predisposition to sin, but they don't sin until they arrive at moral consciousness. Thus sin is not a state, but solely an act. Hence, prior to gaining moral consciousness, babies do not need Jesus as their Savior.

FEDERAL THEORY

Also known as the theory of the covenants, Federal theory is linked to Cocceius (1603–1669) and Turretin (1623–1669). (1) Federal and (2) Natural (or Realistic) headship in Adam need to be distinguished. Federal headship traces physical nature through inheritance back to Adam, but with the soul as separately created for each newborn; this is the creationist view for the soul's origin.

Natural (Realistic) headship traces human nature wholistically (including the soul) back to Adam—this is the Traducianist view of the soul's origin—whereas realism states that humans were present in Adam and co-sinned with him. In different ways Anselm, Aquinas, Calvin, and Hodge have advocated these views.

The Federal theory teaches that God entered into a covenant with Adam as the federal head of the race—which means that if he obeyed God, eternal life would be given to his posterity, but if he disobeyed, death would be suffered by all his descendants.

This means that the human race suffered condemnation through God's covenant, not through Adam's sin; as well, this means that God immediately (not mediately) creates each soul with a corrupt nature. The race is not sinful because condemned by Adam's fall, but because God regards them as such due to His agreement with Adam.

MEDIATE IMPUTATION THEORY

Placeus, a French professor (1606–1655), promulgated the Mediate Imputation theory. It teaches that all are born physically and morally depraved due to Adam's sin. God creates each individual soul, but it becomes corrupt as soon as it is joined to the body. Each human is therefore born a sinner, which is the source of his or her own sins. Humankind's depravity is the consequence, not the penalty, of Adam's sin.

AUGUSTINIAN THEORY

Augustine (354–430)[57] taught that all the members of the human race were seminally present in Adam, and hence share not merely in the effects of his sin but also in the guilt for his sin. It follows that each human is therefore born sinful and guilty and needs salvation at the moment of birth. All sins issue as fruits from the one sin of Adam.

This theory is also known as Realism, and is promoted by W. G. T. Shedd, S. Greijdanus, and K. Schilder, who speak of all humans being "co-sinners" with Adam, so that they are responsible for the original sin. Adam's guilt is not an alien guilt, but their own. Texts that refer to humans dying for their own sin (Ezek. 18:20), being in the loins of "his ancestor" (Heb. 7:5, 10), and all sinning in Adam (Rom. 5:12) are cited in support of this theory.[58]

57. Augustine's view has roots in Tertullian (c. 150–220), and was held by the Reformers, except Zwingli. It is basic Catholic teaching and is espoused by A. H. Strong.

58. Berkouwer, *Sin*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 436–448.

Whereas Federalists believe humans are condemned because Adam broke the covenant,[59] Realists reject imputed condemnation. Realists' understanding of all humans as co-sinners with Adam views each person as individually responsible for sin. In this way Realists question the validity of the imputation of alien guilt or alien responsibility for sin. Not even Calvin's appeal to a divine decree can absolve God from being understood as capricious. In other words, all humans share Adam's guilt. This is not fair, for they were not present in Adam, despite the false claim that they were. Nor does Calvin's God, who decrees all human destiny (to be saved or lost) without any reference to what they themselves do. It alone is not only unfair, but makes God out to be unfair.

SUMMARY OF THEORIES

A. H. Strong has provided a helpful summary[60] of these various schools indicating that the Pelagian, Arminian, and New School do not believe humankind inherits condemnation from Adam's sin, whereas the Federal, Placean, and Augustinian theories believe that humankind does inherit condemnation from Adam's sin. Note that each theory, except the Augustinian theory, holds that the soul is created immediately by God, and to that extent without any ultimate connection with Adam (Creationism/Traducianism debate). Note the varying views concerning how a person sins: from following Adam's example (Pelagian); by conscious choice in spite of the Spirit's help (Arminian); by voluntary breaking of God's law (New School); by being accounted sinners in Adam's sin (Federal); by possessing depraved nature (Placean); by having a part in Adam's sin, as seminally present (Augustinian); and by being co-sinners with Adam (Realists). Note how the difference in whether humankind inherits Adam's condemnation or not impacts how humans are saved.

Although Catholic teaching on original sin is indebted to Augustine, since the 1950s and particularly following Vatican II Council (1963–1965), there has been an explosion of Catholic literature on this topic, fueled largely by the evolutionary worldview that dismisses a historical Adam and his fall. This is because Vatican II encouraged the discipline of science to explore its view of human origins.[61]

59. Berkouwer observes, "The federalists admit that not all men are *personally responsible* for the sin which Adam has committed," ibid., 465.

60. Strong, *Systematic Theology*, 628.

61. *The Documents of Vatican II*, gen. ed. Walter M. Abbott, S.J., trans. Joseph Gallagher (London: Geoffrey Chapman, 1967), 233–234.

EVALUATION

One major problem with many theories of imputation is their failure to penetrate to the essence of sin as a broken relationship with God. What is imputed to the race is a broken relationship, complete with its tendency to sin. Humans are born in need of being born again. Furthermore, nowhere in Scripture does it say that sin, punishment, condemnation, and guilt are imputed. If these were imputed, that would make God both unloving and unjust, and this alone would cause Him to fail to answer the cosmic controversy charges against Him.

Only the consequences of Adam's sin are imputed, and so the love and the justice of God are seen in *His imputed righteousness* through the second Adam—which more than makes up for the broken relationship imputed by the first Adam. There is only one place in Scripture where sin is imputed, and that is to Christ as the substitute of all humans at Calvary. Human sin was laid upon Him (Isa. 53:6) so that He who knew no sin became sin for us (2 Cor. 5:21). There are repeated references to righteousness being imputed to humans but never sin or guilt. This insight needs to guide our interpretation of Romans 5.

Conclusion

Sin is much more than an external act. It is more than a broken law. It is, in its essence, a broken relationship. Satan strives to separate humans from God, for each one who leaves God's side brings pain to God and makes Calvary less effective. Sin is separation from God, and out of this separation come all the acts of sin.

Study Questions

1. How does Satan's temptation of Eve give us insight into his prior temptation of the angels?
2. What is the biblical evidence that Satan used a serpent to tempt Eve?
3. What were the steps in Satan's strategy to deceive Eve?
4. What is the biblical evidence that the image of God was only damaged, not destroyed, by sin?
5. What are the various levels of the biblical definition of *sin*?
6. Are humans sinners because they sin, or do they sin because they are sinners? Fully explain.
7. How does Romans 5:15–19 compare and contrast the two Adams?
8. What is the biblical understanding of Romans 5:12?

9. What did Adam's sin impute to his posterity? What did it *not* impute?
10. How does Romans 5 compare the gifts given to humans?
11. How would you evaluate the theories of imputation in the light of the cosmic controversy?

CHAPTER FOUR

Darwin's Journey from Scripture to Philosophy

Purpose

1. Indicate the danger of replacing Scripture as the foundation for understanding God.
2. Note the influence of nonscriptural writers on Darwin.

Summary

One could argue that Darwin's journey from Scripture to philosophy occurred because he didn't allow the biblical *sola-tota-prima Scriptura* principle of interpretation to guide his understanding of the creation record in Genesis. If Darwin had researched the biblical record with as much scrutiny as he studied the natural record, he might not have adopted a purely naturalistic worldview. One could also argue that Darwin was a product of his time, and that his theological training failed to give him the guidance he needed. Darwin didn't believe that God was responsible for evil in the world, and thought his views would provide an alternative cause for evil. The problem is that his theory of evolution with its survival of the fittest (or best adapted) is not compatible with a God of love who opposes salvation by works. How could a God of love use the tortuous process of evolution to produce humans? In attempting to defend

God from being the author of evil, Darwin ends up with a natural evil that drives the evolutionary process: a bloody struggle to survive.

Outline

I. Introduction
II. Evolution's Attempt to Explain Evil
III. Darwin's Turn from Scripture to Other Books
- A. Influence from John Milton
- B. How Theologians Viewed Nature
  1. Influenced by Sir Charles Lyell
  2. Influenced by Thomas Malthus
  3. Kant and the Problem with Distancing God from Nature

IV. Conclusion
V. Study Questions

Introduction

Why is there evil in the world? Philosophers of religion have come up with two alternatives to explain the presence of evil: (1) evil is God's method to promote character development (as presented in John Hick's book *Evil and the God of Love*),[1] or (2) evil is a result of creaturely decision because God allows His creatures to have freedom of choice, and does not "monopolize decision-making" (as presented in Charles Hartshorne's writings).[2] But no philosopher has discovered the cosmic controversy and its implications, which can only be found in biblical revelation. Yet this is the broader biblical worldview from which questions of theodicy can be grasped, and only in this expanded context can they be answered.

In his *Where Is God When It Hurts?* Philip Yancey says, "I have yet to find in the Bible any grand unifying theory of causation,"[3] and so he looks to the future promises of Scripture as the only explanation of human suffering. By contrast, I submit that: (1) understanding of the cosmic controversy worldview of Scripture supplies the biblical understanding of causation; (2) the fall of humans explains the present problems; and (3) the Fall is diametrically

1. John Hick, *Evil and the God of Love* (New York: Harper and Row, 1966).
2. For example, Charles Harrshorne, "A New Look at the Problem of Evil" in *Current Philosophical Issues: Essays in Honor of Curt John Ducasse*, ed. Frederich C. Dommeyer (Springfield, IL: Charles C. Thomas, 1966), 205, 207–209. I do not agree with Hartshorne that God cannot (from eternity) foresee free decisions that will result in evil. See Richard Rice, *Reason and the Contours of Faith* (Riverside, CA: La Sierra University Press, 1991), 143–144.
3. Philip Yancey, *Where Is God When It Hurts?* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1990), 78–84.

opposed to evolution's notion that humans are constantly improving and advancing, which would make redemption unnecessary.

I submit that there is a counterfeit theory of creation known as natural selection through the survival of the fittest (or the best adapted), just as there is a counterfeit theory of salvation through human works. By contrast, biblical creation and redemption are gifts that do not depend in any way upon human works.

Evolution's Attempt to Explain Evil

The vast majority of evolutionists do not believe that what we call "evil" is just a natural part of existence. Conversely, as far as Christians are concerned, the source of evil in the world is Satan, the one who hates God, who works overtime in his attempts to ruin His creation. Indeed, every biological and chemical agent of death comes stamped with his name; anthrax and other deadly weapons come from his inspiration, for all evil in nature and in human history is a result of sin which he introduced into planet Earth (Gen. 3). Therefore, it is reasonable to think that he works through tempests and tornadoes (so called natural disasters). It may well be that many so-called acts of God are really acts of the devil.

Darwin's God: Evolution and the Problem of Evil, by Cornelius G. Hunter, is the best book I know of that looks at evolution in the light of evil in nature.[4] (We will look more at his contribution in chapter 6.) Hunter notes that Darwin wondered how a God who is infinitely wise, powerful, and good could possibly be the author of nature and its evil. Darwin puzzled over these facts in particular: (1) the waste of tons of pollen every year; (2) "some species are ill-adapted for their environment"; (3) parasites feed on their victims; and (4) "ants make slaves of other ants."[5] Darwin's letter to a friend spoke of his frustration and confusion about the state of the world: "What a book a devil's chaplain might write on the clumsy, wasteful, blundering, low, and horribly cruel works of nature."[6] He wondered, *If God is all loving and all powerful, why is there evil in nature?* Darwin's solution was to distance God from nature.

Isaac Newton presented a mechanical universe (shutting God out of the picture), and William Paley presented a rigid and highly static view of the

4. Cornelius G. Hunter, *Darwin's God: Evolution and the Problem of Evil* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2001).
5. Neal C. Gillespie, *Charles Darwin and the Problem of Creation* (Chicago, IL: University of Chicago, 1979), 72, 77–79, 127; Hunter, *Darwin's God*, 10.
6. Adrian Desmond and James Moore, *Darwin* (New York: W. W. Norton, 1991), 449, quoted in Hunter, *Darwin's God*, 10.

world.[7] Both had a lot to do with natural theology. Darwin studied theology at Cambridge University, where natural theology dominated divinity training.[8] "Natural theology was respected by many in Darwin's day—indeed, it was seen as essential by intellectuals who had taken seriously claims that undercut the authority of Scripture (historical criticism, the plurality of religions) yet wanted to maintain some sort of religious belief."[9] Darwin once believed in the faulty orthodox theory of his time which claimed that each species was created individually and had remained unchanged since creation. The above views were examples of a static, or unchanging, worldview. Darwin's five-year journey on the *HMS Beagle* debunked this traditional view of the fixity of species,[10] for he found contrary empirical evidence that caused him to lose confidence in Scripture. Darwin's *Origin of Species* repeatedly rejects the immutability of the species as separate creations, and this is a major focus in his conclusion.[11]

Some theorists considered that if God created new species, this would call into question His original creation, as if He didn't get it right the first time and hence the subsequent tinkering with creation to produce new species. So empirical evidence for new species suggested to Darwin that species evolve through natural laws, through evolution, for God would never keep trying to improve His original, less-than-perfect attempt to create.[12]

Darwin is to be commended for his careful research in nature, but one wishes he had carried out just as careful a study of the first nine chapters of Genesis. If he had carefully calculated the size of Noah's ark and considered the animals that went into the ark, he would have quickly seen that there was only a representative group that entered the ark, and yet all animals in the world today are descendants

7. With respect to Paley, see Alister E. McGrath, *A Fine-Tuned Universe: The Quest for God in Science and Theology, The 2009 Gifford Lectures* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2009), 168.

8. James Wm. McClendon, Jr., *Witness*, vol. 3 in *Systematic Theology* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 2000), 111.

9. Ibid., 108.

10. Prior to Darwin, the Swedish botanist Carl von Linne (Linnaeus, 1707–1778) believed in the fixity of species because he believed the species were made immutable by the Crearor. This religious belief was proved false by Darwin's discovery of new species, but the biblical record was not proved false, for it taught otherwise. This distinction was never grasped by Darwin, nor has it been understood by evolutionists.

11. Charles Darwin, *The Origin of Species: Complete and Fully Illustrated* (New York: Random House, 1979), 53, 223, 230; note his conclusion, 443–447. Darwin states in his introduction "that the view which most naturalists entertain, and which I formerly entertained—namely, that each species has been independently created—is erroneous," *The Origin of Species*, 69, cf. 230. He calls it "the common view," 317, and notes that "most eminent palaeontologists" (Cuvier, Owen, Agassiz, Barrande, Falconer, E. Forbes) "and all our greatest geologists" (Lyell, Murchison, Sedgwick) "have unanimously, often vehemently, maintained the immutability of species," 315–316. Darwin argues that each species is not "immutable," or "independently created" with varieties "produced by secondary laws," 443–455. He argues that "the theory of creation" is "inexplicable" in view of the variation of species, 446, and how they came about through hereditary modification, or internal rather than merely external conditions (climate and food), and mainly through natural selection, 66–68, cf. 342. Natural selection of species rather than divine fixity of species is Darwin's thesis throughout his *Origin of Species*.

12. Cf. Darwin stated that species are not produced "by miraculous acts of creation." Rather, "to my mind it accords better with what we know of the laws impressed on matter by the Creator" that species come through "secondary causes," or through evolution, *Origin of Species*, 457–458.

of those that were in the ark. He could have realized that it only takes an original pair of dogs from the ark to multiply into the wide variety of dogs in his day, and the same is true of all other species. This should have indicated to him that fixity is not about variation within the dog family, or other families, but is apparently a boundary. After all, Darwin had firsthand knowledge of diversity within a species from his breeding of pigeons.

As far as evil in nature is concerned, Darwin could have noted in Genesis 3 that the disobedience of Adam and Eve (their fall, contrary to evolution's alleged progress) impacted nature with a curse (Gen. 3:17–19). Paul comments that "creation was subjected to frustration, not by its own choice, but by the will of the one who subjected it" (Rom. 8:20), and so "the whole creation has been groaning as in the pains of childbirth right up to the present time" (v. 22). Humans distanced themselves from God in rebellion, and that's what introduced evil into nature. Darwin didn't need to distance God from nature, but he did need to understand that Adam and Eve had distanced themselves from God. A careful study of the first nine chapters of Genesis would have saved him from promulgating his theory of evolution (and it could have been accomplished in a few days).

Darwin was a product of his time. The Enlightenment had long before removed God from His world. Rationalism had exalted humans and their ability to reason. In a world where God and His revelation are banished, reasoning powers reign supreme. In Victorian times a deistic view of God, removed from the world of nature, was considered appropriate to His benevolence.

Just as God was removed from nature in general, so He was removed from the lives of humans. Evolutionists deny that humans have any special status. But divine revelation presents the Sabbath as the crowning work of creation (Gen. 2:1–3). Humans were not made from animals; they were made directly by God to commune with Him (hence the Sabbath). Darwin didn't know this, but he could have. He could have seen that a loving God, One who desired such communion with humans, could never be the cause of evil in the lives of those same humans.

C. S. Lewis was also troubled by the presence of evil in the world. But note how different his response was compared to Darwin's:

> My argument against God was that the universe seemed so cruel and unjust. But how had I got this idea of *just* and *unjust*? A man does not call a line crooked unless he has some ideas of a straight line. What was I comparing this universe with when I called it unjust? If the whole show was bad and senseless from A to Z, so to speak, why did I, who was supposed to be a part of the show, find myself in such violent reaction against it? A man feels wet when he falls into water, because man is not a water animal: a fish would not feel wet. Of course I could have given up my idea of justice by saying it was nothing but a private idea of my own. But if I did that, then

> my argument against God collapsed too—for the argument depended on saying that the world was really unjust, not that it just did not happen to please my private fancies. Thus in the very act of trying to prove that God didn't exist—in other words, that the whole of reality was senseless—I found I was forced to assume that one part of reality—namely my idea of justice—was full of sense. Consequently atheism turns out to be too simple. If the whole universe has no meaning, we should never have found out that it has no meaning: just as, if there was no light in the universe and therefore no creatures with eyes we should never know it was dark. Dark would be a word without meaning.[13]

Lewis thought it through carefully, and he realized that the rejection of God's existence in a world of cruelty isn't rational, because his objection to cruelty indicated there was a cause beyond himself that gave him a sense of justice. If Darwin had reasoned in the same way, he wouldn't have developed his theory of evolution within a natural worldview, completely casting aside the Supernatural. Darwin ended up an atheist, while Lewis left atheism and came to faith in God.

Darwin's Turn from Scripture to Other Books

If Darwin had studied Genesis 1–3, he would have discovered the truth about the origins of life and evil. Instead, he turned away from Scripture and its worldview; he went to other sources that gave him another worldview that launched evolution as we know it.

INFLUENCE FROM JOHN MILTON

One of Darwin's favorite books was Milton's *Paradise Lost.* At least the title should have made him think! Paradise was lost, yes, which would itself explain the presence of evil in nature. He had a well-worn copy of *Paradise Lost* with him for his five-year global voyage on the *HMS Beagle.* Both Milton and Darwin wrestled with the problem of evil, Milton with moral evil and Darwin with natural evil, and both found a solution in distancing God from evil. Milton's book had a great impact on Darwin. It helped him see the need to distance God from evil, and he even went beyond Milton in so doing.[14] He ended up dismissing the fact that God had anything to do with creation. So He rejected the God of creation for a view of nature in harmony with Newton's mechanistic worldview. Yet this went against the popular evidences for God's existence from nature, to which we now turn.

13. C. S. Lewis, *Mere Christianity* (New York: Macmillan, 1968), 34–35.

14. Charles Darwin, *The Autobiography of Charles Darwin* (New York: Harcourt, Brace and Company, 1958), 85, quoted in Cornelius Hunter, *Darwin's God*, 11–12.

HOW THEOLOGIANS VIEWED NATURE

It is well known that medieval theology attempted to prove the existence of God from nature. This includes the cosmological argument (everything has a cause, which itself goes back to a first cause, God) taught by Thomas Aquinas (1225–1274) in his theological system (*Summa Theologica*).[15] This was challenged by David Hume (1711–1776) in his *Treatise of Human Nature*[16] and by Immanuel Kant (1724–1804) in his *Critique of Pure Reason.*[17] Darwin believed his discoveries in nature during the nineteenth century called into question the claim that there are evidences for God in nature. He wrote to a friend: "There seems to me too much misery in the world. I cannot persuade myself that a beneficent and omnipotent God would have designedly created the [parasitic wasp] with the express intention of their feeding within the living bodies of caterpillars, or that the cat should play with mice."[18]

Darwin failed to factor in the Fall after the creation of the world, for there are as many evidences for the cosmic controversy in nature as there are evidences for God. Given Satan's hatred for God, it isn't surprising that the idea of God's being distant from nature and humans would be propagated throughout history.

The teleological argument (argument from design) was the most popular of the arguments for God's existence. Aquinas presented this argument in his *Summa Theologica.*[19] This argument goes back to the Stoic philosopher Anaxagoras, with more extended discussions in Plato's dialogues *Timaeus* and *Philebus.*[20] Hume and Kant critiqued the argument, but we focus here on others who influenced Darwin.

William Paley (1743–1805), who taught at Cambridge University, wrote *A View of the Evidences of Christianity.* While Paley was not an original thinker, he was an effective communicator. His book influenced many generations and people, including Charles Darwin. Paley was the one who popularized the famous watchmaker argument: The intricate machinery, the design of the watch, and its complicated workings could not have come about by chance, and hence necessitated a

15. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, trans. Fathers of the Dominican Province (Westminster, MD: Christian Classics, 1981), 1:13–14. Aquinas spells out five arguments for God's existence, causation being the second.

16. David Hume, *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding*, 3rd ed., ed. L. A. Selby-Bigge, rev. by P. H. Nidditch (Oxford, London: Clarendon, 1975), sect. IV.

17. Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, trans. Norman Kemp Smith (London: Macmillan, 1929), 417–421, 507–518.

18. Darwin, quoted in Steven Jay Gould, "Nonmoral Nature," in *Hens Teeth and Horse's Toes* (New York: W. W. Norton, 1983), in Hunter, *Darwin's God*, 12, brackets in original.

19. Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, 1:13–14. This is his fifth argument.

20. Michael Palmer, *The Question of God: An Introduction and Sourcebook* (New York: Routledge, 2001), 93. For those wishing to dig deeper into the different arguments, this is a primary source.

watchmaker. Just so in nature there are many evidences of design which presuppose a God, a master Designer.[21]

But Darwin gave up Paley's design argument when he discovered the process of natural selection.[22] Was natural selection a better option? Darwin thought so, which may say more about Darwin's waning faith than any logic inherent in the natural selection theory. Apologist Norman Geisler comments, "Paley's arguments for God and for Christianity still provide the backbone for much of contemporary apologetics. The only major difference is that we now have much more 'meat' to put on the skeleton" (he cites the contribution of the anthropic principle and microbiology).[23]

Influenced by Sir Charles Lyell

Why did Darwin make the change? Besides *Paradise Lost*, he took Sir Charles Lyell's first volume of *Principles of Geology* with him on his *HMS Beagle* voyage. Lyell called into question the view of catastrophism, which includes the Flood story. In its place he suggested the view of uniformitarianism. In other words, he gave up the destruction of the world for a view that there wasn't such an interruption. Darwin accepted this new view,[24] not realizing its prediction in Scripture: "Above all, you must understand that in the last days scoffers will come, scoffing and following their own evil desires. They will say, 'Where is this "coming" he promised? Ever since our ancestors died, everything goes on as it has since the beginning of creation'" (2 Pet. 3:3–4). Here's a direct prophecy about uniformitarianism being an end-times idea. Here again, Darwin, a theologically trained Cambridge University student, didn't consult Scripture. He was removing God from His Word just as much as He was removing Him from His world.

Influenced by Thomas Malthus

Thomas Malthus (1766–1824) was the next to influence Darwin. In his *Essay on Population*[25] (which Darwin read nearly two years after his *HMS Beagle* voyage), he gave his famous principle about the fact that population increases would place an intolerable burden upon the resources of the environment, leading to a struggle between humankind and nature; the result would be poverty, disease, starvation, and war. Although the Anglican clergyman Malthus looked at this problem from the perspective of natural theology, Darwin, as a

21. Ibid., 96.
22. Ibid., 126.
23. Norman L. Geisler, *Baker Encyclopedia of Christian Apologetics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1999), 575.
24. Palmer, *The Question of God*, 119.
25. Thomas Malthus, *An Essay on the Population* (London: Oxford University, 1993).

firm believer in Paley's view of design, took it out of this context and applied it to nature left to itself—nature without God. The notion of struggle is what Darwin derived from Malthus. The struggle, in Darwin's thinking, led to the principle of natural selection, or the survival of the fittest.

Malthus referred to breeders producing various modifications of form and color. Darwin picked this up and posited that nature did the same work as a breeder. In doing so, Darwin removed God as the cause, and assigned to nature the abilities of an agent of causation (equivalent to that of human breeders). He ended up critiquing Paley's design argument by exchanging chance for purpose. So things are not uncaused, but unpredictable, when specifying effects.[26]

Kant and the Problem with Distancing God from Nature

Many thinkers have tried to distance God from the world and humanity. Milton distanced God from moral evil in the same way that Darwin distanced Him from natural evil. Kant, the most influential philosopher to impact subsequent philosophy, rejected the arguments for God, but at least gave some assent to the moral proof for the "existence of a moral author of the world, i.e., the existence of a God." He could even call God "a moral cause for the world." But it is human reason that discerns this fact, for God can never be known as He is in Himself, only as He appears to humans.[27] How much better if Kant had gone to Scripture and discovered God as He is in Himself as the moral lawgiver (Exod. 20).

At the end of the day, without Scripture and left to reason alone, Kant attributes moral laws not to a moral lawgiver (divine or otherwise) but to an imperative of duty. He ends up with a very subjective view of the moral condition, which is not a proof of God's existence but an evidence of an internal moral imperative. For Kant reason is universal, and hence religious belief is not necessary to act morally. Humans are capable of moral actions that are a moral duty, or "categorical imperative." In other words, necessary duty can be done by autonomous humans without God's help. But if that is so, why is there any need of God?[28]

26. Palmer, *The Question of God*, 119–125.
27. Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Judgment*, trans. Werner S. Pluhar (Indianapolis, IN: Hackett Publishing, 1987), 336–353. Kant also takes up the moral argument in other works such as *Groundwork of the Metaphysic of Morals*, trans. H. J. Paton (*The Moral Law*) (London: Hutchinson & Co., 1972), 75; *Critique of Practical Reason*, ed. Mary Gregor (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997), 102–111; and *Religion Within the Limits of Reason Alone*, trans. T. M. Greene and H. Hudson (New York: Harper & Row, 1960).
28. Palmer, *The Question of God*, 235–250.

Conclusion

Milton, Darwin, and Kant all distanced God from humans more than they should have, and all of them did so because they placed reason above revelation. Evolution is thought of as scientific fact, but few see it as a worldview that has something to say about God. It is a theodicy that says God is distant from the evil in nature. Some of the factors that drive the theory of evolution are: (1) the desire to exalt human reason, (2) the desire to avoid moral judgment, and (3) the excesses of organized religion which have made religion and God very distasteful to many.[29] Evolution presents its ideas irrespective of God. Yet evolutionary presuppositions expose it to be dependent upon metaphysics, and not just science (even if its science is persuasive to some). Milton's theodicy considers God as all-good rather than all-powerful. God is virtuous and not dictatorial, and as such God is more worthy of worship.[30] But the "argument that God becomes all the more worthy of our reverence easily gives way to his loss of relevance."[31]

For Gnostics, Christ couldn't create the world nor could He become a human and suffer at Calvary. Hume and Darwin sought to give a reason for natural evil, but did so by proposing a distant God in order to prevent Him from having to take responsibility for evil. It is this view of God that constitutes the basic metaphysical purpose that fuels the quest of evolutionary theory. In other words, there is no place for the biblical God in evolution, which is purely a natural process guided by natural selection and the survival of the fittest or the best adapted. As spirit and matter are kept separate in Gnosticism so revelation (Scripture) and science are kept separate in evolution.[32]

Study Questions

1. In his quest to find a natural cause for creation, how was Darwin trying to protect God? From your own understanding of evolution, did his theory provide a better view of God?
2. In what way did the authors/thinkers mentioned in this chapter influence Darwin?
3. How could Genesis 1–9 have steered Darwin away from evolution and toward truth?

29. These three were given to the author by L. James Gibson.
30. Hunter, *Darwin's God*, 137–146.
31. Ibid., 153.
32. Ibid., 127–134.

CHAPTER FIVE

Theistic Evolution: The Quest for Reconciliation

Purpose

1. Consider whether Scripture (creation) and science (evolution) are reconcilable worldviews.
2. Determine whether God is transcendent in creation or immanent in evolution.
3. Document how God and His Word are affected by theistic evolution.
4. Note that atheistic evolution has no place for God.
5. Show that theistic evolution is promoted by those who believe in the inerrancy of Scripture.

Summary

Evolutionary theory, dependent on naturalism, is found to be incompatible with the God of Scripture. From eternity the Persons of the biblical Trinity are in themselves what they are seen to be in their acts in time: a God of love. He is also the all-wise and capable God who acts in a relational way in all that He does. God does not change (Mal. 3:6), so "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8). God's creation in the beginning, His act of incarnation in the midst of salvation history, His miracles while living on this planet, and His future acts of resurrection and creation of the new heavens and new earth are inherently compatible. Each of these acts reveals His nature as

love and omnipotence. But His love is best revealed in His utter dependence, dying on the cross as the atoning substitute for humans. His power is qualified by His love. God's personal, loving, and powerful relationship with humans is the everlasting gospel. Such a revelation of God seems at odds with the theory of evolution with its lack of providence, the struggle to survive, predation, and death. Impersonal evolution dismisses the biblical revelation of God and humans, rejecting the need for Calvary and robbing humans of hope in the eternal future.

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Introduction[1]

So far in this volume we have considered the creation of earth and its heavens (chapter 1), human creation and nature (chapter 2), human fall and nature (chapter 3), and Darwin's journey from Scripture to philosophy and deep-time evolution (chapter 4). There were many who preceded Darwin in thinking about evolution, but none like him who devised a theory held together by the driving idea of natural selection, which became a worldview that denied the need for God as Creator and stood opposed to the biblical account.

1. The basic ideas in this chapter were presented to the third Adventist International Faith and Science Conference (2004). Conferences convened for three consecutive years (2002–2004). My papers given at the first and second conferences were published in the *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, vol. 14, no. 1 (Spring 2003) and vol. 15, no. 1 (Spring 2004) respectively, and material presented in this chapter was published in the *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, vol. 15, no. 1 (Spring 2004).

The battle between Scripture and science has been often acrimonious. The purpose of this volume is not to win the war but to present a fair view of the two sides. This is by no means the last word on this topic, but it is intended to lead to a fruitful dialogue in which respect for different convictions is essential.

Are There Two Reconciliable Worldviews?

The biblical view of creation is a supernatural worldview in which God did the creating. By contrast, the atheistic evolutionary view of creation is a natural worldview in which God had—and still has—nothing to do with creation. Theistic evolutionists attempt to bridge the gap by suggesting that evolution is a process in which God did play a part. This suggests a Concordist view, which promotes a convergence between these worldviews that supposedly does justice to the realities involved. So this mediate worldview suggests that the supernatural God did act in the natural process. The problem is that this suggestion is of no interest to atheistic scientists who are being true to their no-God-involved presupposition. Some Christians are not interested, for they find this mediate view a compromise that questions the nature and ability of God. Yet this worldview of theistic evolutionists is the topic being explored in this chapter.

Most if not all conservative biblical scholars no longer believe in Ussher's chronology which considered that creation took place six thousand years ago. Perhaps most contemporary conservative biblical scholars consider that creation took place up to ten thousand years ago, but that is vastly different from the deep-time of evolution. Some suggest that the duration referred to in Genesis 1:1–2 could be a reason for the age of the earth prior to the forming and filling of Genesis 1–2. Many Evangelical scholars consider the six days of creation as day-ages, and find in them the deep-time necessary for the claims of evolution. So many Christians accept a hybrid of creation and evolution. From the above information, it is clear that there is a convergence sought between the two major worldviews, and to this extent evolution has gained significant ground among Christians.

As a believer in the six days of creation that happened in comparative near-time instead of evolutionary deep-time, I still want to show respect to those who think otherwise. Whether it happened in near-time or deep-time, no contemporary person observed creation in action. In other words, it takes faith to accept either view, for there is no original empirical evidence to document exactly when creation took place and how long it took to complete.[2]

2. I dislike the lack of courtesy sometimes shown by each side toward the other. If arguments are worth winning, they need to be presented with evidence conveyed in a scholarly and winsome way. Reasons should be placed before the other side with tentativeness when necessary and humbly when certain. To be dismissive toward the other side lessens confidence in those who do so, and may at times cause one to wonder if such behavior demonstrates a lack of real evidence. The fighting spirit is essential in boxing or wrestling, but is demeaning to those who pride themselves on careful reasoning and intensive examination of factual evidence. It is not wrong to come to the table with convictions, yet a true scholar will listen to the opposing view with an attempt to look at the evidence from the perspective of the presenter. Keeping in mind the presuppositions held by the presenter is key to understanding his or her logic. This may be difficult, because one's own presuppositions are often not the same as those of the presenter. It is often wise to present the presuppositions before getting into the data.

Of course, not all Christians agree about how creation happened, just as not all scientists agree about some ideas in evolution. So disagreement is present on both sides, and to be scholarly the varying convictions should be argued well without ignoring what is commonly held among those on both sides. Usually there is more that unites than divides both camps. However, things held in common should not deter persons from launching out into unchartered territory on the basis of evidence that seems convincing. This is normative on both sides, and is the reason why both disciplines can be enriched by professional society meetings and articles in scholarly journals.

There are also many subspecialties in each discipline, and thus there is a certain appropriate dependence on others' expertise. It is impossible in this day of specialization, when knowledge is increasing exponentially, to be well versed in several disciplines (as was common in medieval times). This means that it is impossible for a scholar to know all there is to know in both disciplines (Scripture and science). Nevertheless, when coming to the table, a scholar should know some basic facts about the other side, or a true dialogue cannot meaningfully take place.

MY PRESUPPOSITIONS

1. As a Bible-believing creationist, the biblical account of creation week (Gen. 1–2) is my foundation about origins. It tells me that God was the Creator, which is corroborated by other biblical passages. It also tells me that humans were created in such a way that they are special to God—created in a personal way, in the image of God, which indicates the dignity of humans compared to animals.
2. Genesis 3 introduces a different topic. A serpent (called the devil in Rev. 12:9) contradicts the Creator's words. With respect to eating forbidden fruit, the Creator said, "you will certainly die" (Gen. 2:17b), while the serpent countered, "You will not certainly die" (Gen. 3:4). This is the first evidence on planet earth that there is a controversy between the devil and the Creator-Christ (Col. 1:16a; Heb. 1:2). Eve succumbed to the devil due to empirical evidence (Gen. 3:4–6) which, to her, contradicted the Creator's words (Gen. 2:16–17).

3. This empirical evidence, which seemed to question the Creator's words, is like empirical evidence of evolution that questions the same Creator's words about His creation in six days.
4. The biblical account of creation is the only reason for the week. There is no scientific reason for the week, as there is for a month and a year.
5. If the supernatural creation account is dismissed, there is no basis for accepting the supernatural nature of Scripture. This would dismiss all supernatural events like Christ's incarnation, miracles, all prophecies, the Second Advent, and the creation of the new heavens and earth after the era of sin is over. So to give up the supernatural creation account in Scripture fundamentally questions God's Word—just as Satan did in Eden.
6. From God's perspective, He is the Creator of nature and the Author of Scripture; when properly interpreted, there is a common link between the two.
7. "Christian Darwinism" was an appellation first used in 1867. James Ivernich (1839–1922) studied mathematical and physical science, and then theology, at the University of Edinburgh, Scotland. He believed in an immanent God working through the process of evolution.[3] Scripture presents a primarily transcendent God who creates (Gen. 1–2)—except in the hands-on creation of humans (Gen. 2:7, 21)—as a present God, but not as an immanent God.

MY GENERAL UNDERSTANDING OF EVOLUTION

1. Darwin believed in the Bible story of creation when he set sail on the *HMS Beagle in 1831.*[4]
2. Darwin's five-year journey led him to reject the immutability of species, a belief rooted in the fixity of kinds in the biblical creation story. In so doing he misunderstood the difference between variance within kinds and the fixity of kinds. This led him to give up belief in the biblical account (Supernaturalism) and focus on naturalism.
3. All we see in nature today has evolved from a very simple beginning.
4. Evolution is through natural selection, random mutations, and natural laws.
5. Harvard University professor Robert Trivers states, "There exists no objective basis on which to elevate one species above another. Chimp

3. James R. Moore, *The Post-Darwinian Controversies: A Study of the Protestant Struggle to Come to Terms with Darwin in Great Britain and America 1870–1900* (London: Cambridge University Press, 1981, 1st ed. 1979), 242–259.

4. Patricia G. Horan, foreword to Charles Darwin, *The Origin of Species: Complete and Fully Illustrated* (New York: Gramercy Books, 1979), v.

and human, lizard and fungus, we have all evolved over some three billion years by a process known as natural selection."[5]
6. Richard Dawkins states, "I shall argue that the fundamental unit of selection, and therefore of self-interest, is not the species, nor the group, nor even, strictly, the individual. It is the gene, the unit of heredity."[6]
7. Alister E. McGrath holds that organisms adapt to their environment, survive, and pass on their genes to prodigy. "[S]mall random genetic changes (mutations) over long periods of time occasionally have positive survival value."[7]
8. Darwin in his book *The Descent of Man* maintains, "As all animals tend to multiply beyond their means of subsistence, so it must have been with the progenitors of man; and this would inevitably lead to a struggle for existence and to natural existence."[8]
9. The "survival of the fittest" was not a term used by Darwin until the sixth edition of his book *Origin of Species* due to the influence of the philosopher Herbert Spencer.[9] This term is not often used today.
10. The Big Bang began the existence and expansion of the universe, and Edmund Hubble (1889–1953) is credited with the origin of this theory.
11. Stephen J. Gould believes humans are "the accidental result of an unplanned process…the fragile result of an enormous concatenation of improbabilities, not the predictable product of any definite process."[10]
12. Evolution has no place for Intelligent Design, because it is confined to naturalism, which is essentially a world without God.
13. Evolution can be described as a tree with many originating branches.
14. Evolution not only promotes a theory related to a slow process of development, but giant steps forward are also involved. Hence gradualism includes spurts of rapid growth, as in the theories of the Cambrian Explosion and Punctuated Equilibria (Niles Eldredge and Stephen J. Gould).
15. Molecular biology has discovered complexity in the single cell, with a highly sophisticated working system of parts, which questions the

5. Robert L. Trivers, foreword to Richard Dawkins, *The Selfish Gene* (Clarendon Street: Oxford University Press, 2009, 1st ed. 1976), xix.

6. Dawkins, *The Selfish Gene*, 11.

7. Alister E. McGrath, *A Fine-Tuned Universe: The Quest for God in Science and Theology* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 2009), 175.

8. Charles Darwin, *The Descent of Man*, vol. 49 in *Great Books of the Western World*, ed. Robert Maynard Hutchins (London: Encyclopedia Britannica, Inc., The University of Chicago, 1984), 285.

9. C. John Collins, *Science & Faith: Friends or Foes?* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway Books, 2003), 259.

10. Stephen Jay Gould, *Wonderful Life: The Burgess Shale and the Nature of History*, quoted in McGrath, *Surprised by Meaning: Science, Faith, and How We Make Sense of Things* (Westminster: John Knox Press, 2011), 78.

whole premise of the theory of evolution: moving from the simple to the complex.

16. Evolution has gone through its own evolution from Darwinian to Neo-Darwinian to Meta-Darwinian. If the theory of evolution were the last word on how life on earth came to be, why has the theory itself changed over time?

IN WHICH WORLDVIEW SHALL WE LIVE?

There are two worldviews: that of Scripture and that of science. Both are understood as reasonable, given that each has a different premise upon which it is based. Both Supernaturalism and naturalism are believed by intelligent, thinking people. In our discussion so far we have devoted three chapters to the support of a supernatural worldview, which asserts that God created the world and all that is in it in just six literal, continuous, contiguous days of twenty-four hours each. Creation was a miracle in which everything apart from humans were made instantaneously within six days. "By faith we understand that the universe was formed at God's command, so that what is seen was not made out of what was visible" (Heb. 11:3). God took time to form Adam from dust and breathed life into him, so that he became a wholistic being: body, soul, and spirit. Then God put Adam to sleep to take a rib out of his side, and from this rib formed Eve. This process during part of day six indicated the special relationship God had with humans, and that they were to have with each other.

The relational Trinity created Adam and Eve in their image. This means, in part, that as there was a reciprocal love between the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, so there was a reciprocal love between Adam and Eve as long as they remained in a dependent relationship with the Trinity. The internal love of the Trinity overflowed into the relational love of Adam and Eve. This indicates the dignity of humans. They were made for God, and God loved them and affirmed them as different from the rest of His creation. Those who love God, and are filled with His presence, live in this relational world of love—a supernatural existence wholly indebted to a supernatural God, from beginning and ever afterwards.

The Creator warned Adam and Eve not to eat fruit from the forbidden tree, or they would die. Satan, the arch-rebel of God, contradicted the Creator and said they would not die. Evidently the snake ate the fruit, which caused it to speak the human language. Satan inferred that eating the fruit would make them like God, and so God was keeping them back from their full potential.

Scripture says, "When the woman saw that the fruit of the tree was good for food and pleasing to the eye, and also desirable for gaining wisdom, she took

some and ate it" (Gen. 3:6). Empirical evidence caused her to be beguiled. She accepted a false view of the fruit, and in so doing disobeyed the words of her Creator. She turned from the God who had given her everything, accepting the claim of one who had given her nothing but a false claim.

Evolution denies the Word of God, a repetition of the first lie in human history. Scripture says that "In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth" (Gen. 1:1). Evolutionary theory denies these words of the Creator with a counterfeit "creation" over deep-time, a process guided by natural selection in which humans evolved from lower primates, joined to the animal kingdom and not to God. Many people are beguiled by this lie through alleged empirical evidence. They have turned away from their Creator-God who gives them everything and instead accept a counterfeit view of "creation" from one who has given them nothing.

The human race, through Eve (and Adam joining her), turned from the Word of the Creator and accepted a criticism of Christ's words. So it is today. Scripture says so much about the true Creator and how He created. These words are critiqued and replaced by the theory of slow evolution of everything since the Big Bang nearly fourteen billion years ago, as well as the eventual evolution of humans from a torturous process of nearly five billion years. The omnipotent, supernatural, wise, and loving Creator has been replaced by a bungling natural process of chance, struggle, and death without purpose as if humans were an unwanted, unplanned surprise.

Satan's deception in the beginning of human history is now like his global one in the end-time of human history. Both deny God's Word. The words of fallen created beings are elevated above the sacred words of a holy God. The worldviews are two sides of the cosmic controversy, a battle against God by Satan, which seeks to win converts from loyalty to the Creator-God to that of His arch enemy. Seen in this light, these worldviews are mutually exclusive, no matter how scholars attempt to join them, to one degree or another.

In previous chapters we quoted Scripture showing that God's Word is worthy of trust. He did create the world and humans, and thus worship of God and dignity of humans is realized. We also noted the counterfeit against God's holy Word, and traced Darwin's drift from God's Word to evolution. Darwin's own experience indicates the perilous risk one takes when rejecting the holy Word of God.

This chapter will study the human attempt to join these two irreconcilable worldviews in theistic evolution. It is the same as saying that Satan loves God when he hates Him. Theistic evolutionists will be given their due, observing and evaluating what they say and do. There is much agreement among them, but also differences, often depending upon their scientific background or lack of

it. But together they support evolution (whether involving God or not) and do injustice to the Word of God.

It seems logical to bring in God's Word and see how clear it is, as understandable as the Creator's words to Adam and Eve in Eden. They clearly show that evolution is not just a squabble about the meaning of Genesis but is an attack on creation in the whole of God's Word. Foundationally evolution questions God's Word as Satan did in Eden, both by deflecting attention to alleged empirical evidence replacing trust in an all-wise Creator and His Word. The battle is between God and Satan, the Creator and created beings.

Science Indebted to Scripture

Leon Morris is right to interpret John 1:1–2 ("In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. He was with God in the beginning") as a "new creation" with the former creation (Gen. 1:1) in mind. "Like the first, the second is not carried out by some subordinate being. It is brought about through the agency of the *Logos*, the very Word of God."[11] Nor was creation brought about by some subordinate or natural process that calls into question God's supernatural power (omnipotence)—one attribute that makes God who He is: God (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 2). This is why evolution is such a counterfeit—it calls into question God's character, which is the very essence of the cosmic controversy against God.

Thomas F. Torrance says we must realize that "[i]t is the Fatherhood of God, revealed in the Son, that determines how we are to understand God as Almighty Creator, and not the other way round. It was through thinking out the inner relation of the incarnation to the creation that early Christian theology so transformed the foundations of Greek philosophy, science and culture, that it laid the original basis on which the great enterprise of empirico-theoretical science now rests."[12] Science is indebted to Scripture and not the other way round. If scientists would allow biblical revelation to inform their worldview, then they could go to nature and allow nature to provide confirming evidence for the biblical portrayal of creation as a supernatural act. Because God is the author of Scripture and the Creator of all that is, then properly understood there is a consistency between Scripture and nature (which calls into question all mutually exclusive worldviews), for both Scripture and creation are the result of supernatural divine acts.

11. Leon Morris, *The Gospel According to John*, rev. ed., in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1995), 64–65.

12. Thomas F. Torrance, *The Trinitarian Faith: The Evangelical Theology of the Ancient Catholic Church* (Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1998), 7.

Early Scientists Were Creationists

The following scientists were creationists, as were almost all scientists before 1860.[13] Of course there are some contemporary scientists who are creationists, but they are a minority.

- Johann Kepler (1571–1630): Celestial mechanics, physical astronomy
- Blaise Pascal (1623–1662): Hydrostatics
- Robert Boyle (1627–1691): Chemistry, gas dynamics
- Nicholas Steno (1638–1687): Stratigraphy
- Isaac Newton (1642–1727): Calculus, dynamics
- Michael Faraday (1791–1867): Field theory
- Charles Babbage (1792–1871): Computer science
- Louis Agassiz (1807–1873): Glacial geology, ichthyology
- James Simpson (1811–1870): Gynecology
- Gregor Mendel (1822–1884): Genetics
- Louis Pasteur (1822–1895): Bacteriology
- William Kelvin (1824–1907): Energetics, thermodynamics
- Joseph Lister (1827–1912): Antiseptic surgery
- James Clark Maxwell (1831–1879): Electrodynamics, statistical thermodynamics
- William Ramsay (1852–1916): Isotopic chemistry

Working with Scripture Without Compromise: Examples of How to Work with Two Worldviews

Leonard Brand, professor of earth and biological sciences at Loma Linda University, California, believes that both views about our origins (science and Scripture) can help by acting as quality control, calling into question assumptions that do not hold up under scrutiny. Brand finds it helpful to work with scientists who hold not only a different theory but also a different worldview. In other words, while Brand has not given up his belief in a supernatural worldview, he does not introduce Scripture into his scientific research. Rather, he comes to the data with his supernatural worldview, which provides him with a broader range of options not available to those who come to the data confined to a natural worldview.

The data before Brand and other scientists is the same. The rocks do not change; the scientific knowledge germane to the research is the same, but the basic

13. See Norman L. Geisler, *Baker Encyclopedia of Christian Apologetics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1999), 168.

assumptions are not the same. So Brand comes to the data as do all scientists, using the rigorous methods of science, with the same scientific instruments and logical processes employed, yet armed with an advantage, because his supernatural worldview broadens the range of possibilities.

An example of this research advantage is Brand's acceptance of the biblical account of a global flood. He is looking for evidence that is not even on the radar screen of fellow scientists who reject any biblical data. In an illuminating article "The Integration of Faith and Science," Brand cites examples of how embracing the biblical worldview has given him and like-minded scientists an advantage in scientific research.

Consider geologist Arthur Chadwick of Southwestern Adventist University; he and his collaborators found a geological deposit that changed the interpretation of the Tapeats Sandstone near the bottom of the Grand Canyon. Geologists examining this sandstone concluded that it is "an accumulation of sand in shallow water along an ocean shore, with the water level and sand deposit gradually rising along an existing cliff face over eons of time." The finding of Chadwick and Kennedy showed that accumulation required deep water and a much more rapid deposition. These findings were presented at a professional meeting of geologists. Brand reports:

> These geologists concluded that Chadwick and Kennedy's conclusions were correct. One geologist asked Dr. Chadwick afterwards why he had seen these things that other geologists have missed? The answer is that our worldview prompts us to ask questions that others are not asking, to question conclusions that others take for granted, and it opens our eyes to see things that are likely to be overlooked by a geologist working within a conventional naturalistic scientific theory.[14]

In the Miocene/Pliocene Pisco Formation of Peru, there are many exceptionally preserved fossilized whales. Brand speaks of the microscopic diatoms, organisms that float near the surface of lakes and oceans. "Upon death, their silica skeletons sink, and in modern oceans they form accumulations of diatomite a few centimeters thick in a thousand years. Most scientists assume that ancient (fossil) diatomite deposits formed at the same slow rate, a few centimeters per thousand years."[15] Brand's research with other geologists and paleontologists provides evidence for more rapid accumulations of diatomites than usually assumed:

> There are publications in scientific research journals on the geology of the Pisco Formation and on the systematics and evolution of the whales. But apparently no one has previously asked how it can be that sediment accumulating at the slow rate of a few centimeters per thousand years can contain complete, well-preserved whales, which would seem to require rapid burial for their preservation.[16]

14. Leonard Brand, "The Integration of Faith and Science," *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, vol. 14, no. 1 (Spring 2003): 127. This was also published as "Faith and Science: Can They Coexist?" *Dialogue* 14:3 (2002), 12–14, 33.

15. Brand, "Faith and Science: Can They Coexist?," *Dialogue* 14:3 (2002), 13.

Their findings were presented at annual meetings of the Geological Society of America and later published. Coming to the data with the added advantage of the supernatural worldview of a global flood gave them an insight to ask questions of the data that those confined to a naturalistic worldview did not think to ask.

The above examples illustrate how Christian scientists (who believe in biblical creation and the global flood) can use their knowledge to better interpret data, without ever demeaning the evolutionary worldview. This is one way to work with the two worldviews without compromising one's own convictions, and in so doing make a positive contribution to the body of the world's knowledge.

IAN G. BARBOUR

In his book *When Science Meets Religion*,[17] Barbour presents four ways that science and religion meet: conflict, independence, dialogue, and integration. Contrary to Alister McGrath, who believes Barbour supports "dialogue" (front end of the same word),[18] Barbour supports "Dialogue and Integration (especially a theology of nature and a cautious use of process theology)."[19] He opposes science and religion as enemies or strangers. He argues that they should be partners, and thus integrated. Barbour explains the four types in his book *Religion and Science*, which is the basis for the rest of this segment.[20]

Barbour notes several versions of conflict. The first one is found in Richard Dawkins's book *The Blind Watchmaker*.[21] Barbour says this book defends neo-Darwinism,[22] and rejects the need for God's existence because "chance and natural selection are the only source of complexity."[23] The second version of conflict is biblical literalism: scientists reject the literal six days of creation.[24]

Then Barbour speaks of the independence of creation and evolution. He cites neo-orthodoxy (Karl Barth, 1886–1968, being one of the leaders) in which Scripture is not God's revelation, but a record of the human response

16. Brand, "The Integration of Faith and Science," 128.

17. Ian G. Barbour, *When Science Meets Religion: Enemies, Strangers, or Partners* (New York: HarperCollins, 2000), 7–38.

18. Alister E. McGrath, *Science and Religion*, Second Edition (Chichester, West Sussex, England: Wiley-Blackwell, 2010), 48.

19. Barbour, *When Science Meets Religion*, 3–4.

20. Ian G. Barbour, *Religion and Science: Historical and Contemporary Issues*; A Revised and Expanded Edition of *Religion in an Age of Science*, The Gifford Lectures, 1989–1991 (New York: HarperOne, 1997), 77–105.

21. Richard Dawkins, *The Blind Watchmaker: Why the Evidence of Evolution Reveals a Universe without Design* (New York: W.W. Norton & Company, 1986).

22. Barbour, *Religion and Science*, 243.

23. Ibid.

24. Ibid, 243–244.

to God's revelation, and thus a human record. Neo-Orthodoxy espouses evolution because science and religion are assigned to separate spheres. God acts primarily in Christ, not in nature.[25] Barbour sympathizes with "many aspects of neo-orthodoxy, particularly its conviction that scripture should be taken seriously but not literally."[26] However, Barbour opposes the gulf between God and nature, and "neglect of divine immanence" in Neo-Orthodoxy.[27] That follows because Barbour accepts process theology in which God is immanent. Barbour accepts continuing creation, which is imbedded in process philosophy/theology.

Existentialism (focus on existence) is the second version of Independence. The two spheres are kept separate—God working in the human sphere through personal encounters, but not in the sphere of nature. This is an extension of the first version above. Barbour says, "The sharp separation of human and nonhuman life does not accord with the evolutionary view. If the ecological understanding of our participation in the wider web of life is ignored, the door to the exploitation of the environment is left wide open."[28]

Linguistic analysis is the third version of Independence. This has to do with a specific language for religion and science. Like the difference in games, each language has its own rules. Barbour says: "As a critical realist, I hold that both fields make statements about reality, though these statements are selective and partial and always revisable.... At some points we need to modify traditional religious doctrines in the light of biological evidence."[29]

In regard to the dialogue about creation and evolution, Barbour believes that cosmology "raises issues of *design*, *chance*, and *necessity*," which are also found in evolutionary biology. He suggests that scientists and theologians can remain true to their disciplines if they "pursue the neo-Thomist [modern revival of the philosophical and theological system, *Summa Theologica*, of Thomas Aquinas, 1225–1274, the greatest medieval Catholic theologian] distinction between primary and secondary causality. God as primary cause works through the secondary causes, which science describes. There are no gaps [no using God to fill the gaps that science has not explained] in the scientific account, which is complete on its own level. But God sustains the whole natural sequence." Notice how some doctrines are affected by Barbour's thinking, because he argues that the Bible is not literal. For example, he says, "The neo-Thomist position is

25. Ibid., 244. This is true of Karl Barth, but perhaps not of Emil Brunner (both Neo-Orthodox leaders). Barth's "Nein!" (No) to Brunner was over natural theology. He rejected it but Brunner accepted it. In other words, unlike Barth, Brunner came to believe that God works in nature as well.
26. Ibid.
27. Ibid.
28. Ibid.
29. Ibid., 245.

appealing because it shows great respect for science while maintaining many [not all] of the doctrines of classical theism."[30]

THE INTEGRATION OF CREATION AND EVOLUTION

Barbour suggests three kinds of integration: (1) natural theology, (2) a theology of nature, and (3) systematic synthesis. As integration is Barbour's main focus, I will present some of his thinking, followed by my evaluation. (1) Barbour believes that natural theologians are better equipped in contemporary biology than creationists, even though they sometimes misinterpret scientific evidence. For example, Barbour disagrees that a complex eye needs simultaneous development to function, stating that organs of vision range from simple to complex.[31] "Design is what one would expect with an intelligent and purposeful God," but Barbour suggests that "the presence of chance, evil, and human freedom should lead us to modify traditional ideas of omnipotence." A God far removed, who seems to gift nature with an inherent ability to be itself, seems to develop complexity from simplicity, just as God gives humans freedom to be themselves. Barbour objects to this view because the God of the Bible is far more intimately involved with humans and their world.[32]

(2) A theology of nature is Barbour's preference over natural theology grounded "primarily on religious experience and the life of the religious community" but including some "reformulations of traditional doctrines in the light of science. Theological doctrines start as human interpretations of individual and communal experience and are therefore subject to revision."[33] Obviously experience and the community, not Scripture, is fundamental to his thinking. Barbour considers Teilhard de Chardin's writings as a theology of nature. This Jesuit scholar is an integrationist, unifying evolutionary science and Christian tradition. For him there are no gaps in science covered by divine intervention. Teleology is seen throughout the process, which "introduces a concept of God as Omega." In other words, God is immanent throughout the natural order. Barbour states that Teilhard gives "an interpretation of science, not a strictly scientific account." He says, "According to Teilhard, the purpose of the incarnation was not primarily the 'remedial' work of atoning for human sin, but the 'constructive' work of uniting all reality and bringing it to union with God." Barbour, like Teilhard, finds the need to change Scripture in the light of evolution, and not the other way around. He is at home with Teilhard's "extensive doctrinal reformulation in the light of the idea of evolution."[34]

30. Ibid. All quotes in this paragraph are from Barbour, and all italics are his.
31. Ibid., 246; in response to Hugh Montefiore, *The Probability of God* (London: SCM Press), chap. 10.
32. Ibid., 246–247.
33. Ibid., 247.
34. Ibid., 248.

(3) Integration is accomplished through "the synthesis of evolution and creation within an inclusive metaphysical system." Barbour says, "An evolutionary metaphysics will give an important place to the temporality and change in its characterization of all entities. It will express the interdependence of all beings in an ecological understanding of the web of life." Barbour observes that Teilhard "rejected much of the Thomistic metaphysics to which he had been exposed in his training as a Jesuit. In place of the Thomistic categories of being and substance, he took becoming and process as the basic characteristics of reality." Barbour concludes by saying that Teilhard was not as well trained in philosophy as in science and theology. So Barbour believes that Whitehead's process philosophy "is the most promising metaphysical system in which evolution and continuing creation can be integrated."[35]

EVALUATION

Barbour's integration of evolution and continuing creation within a process metaphysic is a philosophical replacement of Scripture. He demeans Scripture as a product of people and the community, thereby cutting himself off from any divine illumination on the topic. He is trying to comprehend creation without the Creator. He supports a reformulation of biblical doctrines in order to be compatible with evolution, and clearly considers scientific evidence instead of Scripture as the foundation for integration. One must give him credit for the creativity of his metaphysical worldview, in which all parts relate to each other with an imminent God in the mix, even if at a higher level. Teilhard's attempt presents a revisionist view of the incarnation and Christ's atonement, which is just as imaginative though expressed in his own terminology.

What is forgotten by Ian Barbour and Teilhard de Chardin is the fact that evolution is an unproven theory. It takes faith to accept it, so faith is not merely confined to accepting Scripture. The biblical metanarrative of the cosmic controversy is the safest worldview for evaluating Barbour's work. He has attached himself to process philosophy instead of to the biblical metanarrative, and ended up far removed from the true God of love in Scripture who would never use the survival of the fittest and death as a means to develop humans in His image. Barbour's integration thesis is a sad speculation of a mind that has let go his only foundation and wisdom in Scripture.

Biologist L. James Gibson rightly points out: "'integration' is frequently used in a good sense—as in the 'integration of faith and science.' I think it is

35. Ibid., 249. All quotes are from Barbour.

good to try to integrate Scripture and nature; the problem comes not from the attempt to integrate the two, but from the attempt to mix two incompatible views."[36] Later this chapter will present a right way to employ integration with integrity. Leonard Brand gives examples of appropriate uses of integration. His basic presuppositions are as follows: "The integration method described here [in his article] encourages both science and religion to constantly challenge each other, raising our awareness of possible biases. The other important antidote to superficial thinking and biases is awareness of the thinking of others and working with those who disagree with us. We will each see things that the other is likely to miss, and this acts as an important quality control process."[37] It should be kept in mind that there is a harmony between Scripture and science when they are interpreted correctly, for God is the Author of both Scripture and nature.

Attempts to Reconcile Biblical Creation and Evolution

BACKGROUND

This segment will consider how theistic evolutionists attempt to reconcile the two worldviews of evolutionary science and biblical creation. They believe in God, but set aside the biblical account of creation in order to make room for evolutionary data. These scientists attempt to support evolution while no longer supporting the biblical account of origins. They hold onto belief in God as they seek to show that God used/uses the evolutionary process. On the one hand, they give credit to God, who directs the natural evolving process; yet on the other hand, by accepting the natural evolving process they must accept that natural selection is the determining factor in the process. Does this mean that God *and* nature are credited with guiding the process?

We should define what theistic evolutionary theory is and what it is not. It is not a critique of natural selection, and therefore of traditional evolutionary theory. Thomas Fowler and Daniel Kuebler state that "theistic evolution is not a new scientific theory to explain observed facts but a theological interpretation of a particular naturalistic scientific theory, either Neo-Darwinism or Meta-Darwinism."[38]

36. Personal correspondence with author.
37. Leonard Brand, "The Integration of Faith and Science," 134.
38. Thomas B. Fowler and Daniel Kuebler, *The Evolution Controversy: A Survey of Competing Theories* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2007), 355.

Meta-Darwinians consist of a variety of rival camps, all of which, however, share a common thread. "The common theme is that the Neo-Darwinian explanation of evolution [natural selection, the subtitle of Darwin's book *Origin of Species*] is inadequate, and therefore other naturalistic mechanisms must be found to supplement it."[39] The members of the school of Meta-Darwinism, though having a common theme, "part company, often drastically."[40] This statement made in 2007 should give pause to theologians, because dependence upon changing naturalistic worldviews is clearly not solid ground, as is seen in their questioning Neo-Darwinism, and yet Meta-Darwinism itself seems far from any substantive conclusion. After considering the various competing theories, the authors conclude: "There are no easy answers, and there may be none for decades or even centuries."[41]

We should include another matter which forms a part of the background to this topic, since the Enlightenment modern historical-critical theories have sought to oust Scripture from its position of authority. As a result, since the entrance of modern evolutionary theory, a battle continues over origins. How did humans arrive on planet earth? Are they here by plan, or by chance? Did they come through a creative act of God, or through the product of natural selection and random mutation? How does the purposelessness and chance of evolution mesh with the comprehensive plan of God for humans (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 8)? Today evolution and criticism of Scripture are in vogue, and popular in most institutions of higher learning.

Some historical theologians and biblical scholars call biblical accounts of creation into question through critical scholarship. For example, Alister McGrath, now at King's College, London, argues for a natural theology and supports theologian Charles Kingsley's (1819–1875) statement that "We knew of old that God was so wise that He could make all things: but behold, He is so much wiser than even that, that He can make all things make themselves."[42] Are McGrath and Kingsley correct? Does this show God to be wiser than the God whose creation was completed during creation week (Gen. 1–2)?[43] As we will see, such a view questions the wisdom of God, whether intended or not. McGrath called his thinking a "*Trinitarian* natural theology,"[44] but does it do justice to the Trinity as a God of love? Consider the ideas of other scholars below.

39. Ibid., 33.
40. Ibid.
41. Ibid., 360.
42. McGrath, *A Fine-Tuned Universe*, 218.
43. In order to distinguish between creation by God and His providence in subsequent reproduction and growth, it seems wise to consider Genesis 1–2 to be a finished, or completed, original creation.
44. McGrath, *A Fine-Tuned Universe*, xiii, emphasis in original.

GORDON D. KAUFMAN (1925–2011)

Harvard University theologian Gordon D. Kaufman's *Systematic Theology: A Historicist Perspective* views human history as evolving from its animal heritage up to the coming of Christ. From the primordial beginning it was God's plan to bring the kingdom of God into human history, and so the creation of humans was a step toward the incarnation when the Kingdom arrived in Jesus Christ. Hence, the "history of the cosmos" is "the progressive realization of the purposes of God."[45] Even human history proper moves upward from primitive to more advanced humans. Kaufman dismisses the story of Adam and Eve as a legend and says the Fall was not about Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden.[46] He even considers biblical passages about a future for the universe as merely being from people "with far less knowledge of the world and of history than we."[47]

Evaluation

Kaufman gives credit to God for using the evolutionary process to produce humans, thus enabling the incarnation of Christ to take place (creation as presupposition for the Incarnation is perhaps first articulated by Irenaeus, ca. 130–200). If humans move from a primitive form to become more advanced humans, Kaufman apparently places biblical writers in the less advanced category, and thus he can dismiss the reality of biblical creation, the Fall, and prophecy on those grounds. How then did Kaufman know with assurance that God used the evolutionary process if Scripture is so primitive?

HOWARD J. VAN TILL (1938–)

We now focus on the contribution of Howard J. Van Till, who sees no conflict between creation and science. In fact, to him, such an "either/or" is "wholly inappropriate."[48] God simply uses evolution as His method to create. Van Till calls his view "the fully gifted creation perspective" saying that "I believe that God has so generously gifted the creation with the capabilities for self-organization and transformation that an unbroken line of evolutionary development from nonliving matter to the full array of existing life-forms is not only possible but has in fact taken place."[49]

Van Till asserts, "I am a firm believer in the biblically informed historic doctrine of creation. However, I am equally firm in my belief that the Scriptures in

45. Gordon D. Kaufman, *Systematic Theology: A Historicist Perspective* (New York: Scribner's, 1968), 288.
46. Ibid., 360–362.
47. Ibid., 315.
48. Howard J. Van Till, "The Fully Gifted Creation: Theistic Evolution" in *Three Views on Creation and Evolution*, ed. J. P. Moreland and John Mark Reynolds (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1999), 163, 173.
49. Ibid., 171.

no way require me to favor or adopt the special creationist picture of the creation's formational history"[50] (note the word "picture"). In other words, apparently the findings of science must inform the meaning of the biblical record. He dismisses the biblical timetable (six literal days) for the conclusions of the "scientific community." He rejects the fact that Christians "have access to privileged information" from Scripture.[51] Although he would not phrase it this way, it means that human thinking must inform God's Word, since Van Till places human philosophy (deep-time of evolution) above divine revelation. Van Till opposes "an inordinate elevation of the status of a historic text, which could lead to the idolization of that text."[52] Yet he elevates his idea of gifted creation to the same level.

Evaluation

Van Till opts for a human idea of gifted creation instead of looking to gifted revelation in the biblical record. Far from elevating Scripture, he considers it to be merely "one of the many sources provided by God for our growth," and wrongly thinks this is the same as the *sola Scriptura* of the Reformation.[53] So he abandons the principle that Scripture must interpret Scripture, replacing it with his own "gifted creation" interpretation of Genesis 1–2.

He says, "In fact, I think Christian theology is now long overdue for a spurt of growth stimulated by our growing knowledge of the creation and its formational history.... I would encourage the most intellectually gifted of Christian youth to consider the challenge of bringing our theological reflection up-to-date in its engagement of contemporary science."[54] I believe the following words of Christian geologist Davis A. Young apply to Van Till: "Theistic evolutionists... have views of Scripture that are not themselves derived from Scripture."[55] Young should include himself, for his view of geological ages instead of six literal days does not come from Scripture.[56]

Van Till says that accepting the Genesis timetable of six days requires that "the judgment of both the old earth special creationists and practically the entire scientific community must be thrown out."[57] While apparently maintaining that he stands with indisputable science, he ignores the fact that evolutionary theories like

50. Ibid., 192.
51. Ibid., 194.
52. Ibid., 207. He rejects so-called humanly devised claims about Scripture, but has his own humanly devised claims.
53. Ibid., 207–212.
54. Ibid., 213.
55. Davis A. Young, *Creation and the Flood: An Alternative to Flood Geology and Theistic Evolution* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1977), 25. Young gives examples of other scholars who impose ideas onto Scripture instead of allowing it to be its own interpreter. This is a basic error in the debate between science and Scripture; see 25–41.
56. Ibid., 113.
57. Van Till, "The Fully Gifted Creation," 211.

his own "gifted creation" theory belong to philosophy and not to science. Further, Van Till distances Bible-believing students from those who are trained scientists; he thinks the untrained should look to the experts. J. P. Moreland rightly comments, "Van Till fails to take his own advice. The vast majority of his article conveys his views about matters in philosophy, theology, and biblical exegesis. Since Van Till is trained in science and not in these other fields, his own advice would, I think, require him to refrain from speaking authoritatively on these topics and, instead, defer to the majority of experts trained in these other fields."[58]

KEITH WARD (1938–)

Keith Ward is Regius Professor of Divinity at Oxford University. His book *God, Faith and the New Millennium: Christian Belief in an Age of Science* devotes a chapter to a theistic explanation of the evolutionary process and speaks philosophically. He suggests that "an omniscient cosmic intelligence could be the necessary being that provides an absolute explanation for the universe.... God has to exist, if anything at all is possible."[59] Though Ward states that God has to exist, he fails to see that the universe does not need to exist, since God acted freely to create the universe. Instead, Ward believes that "we can say that God exists by necessity, necessarily conceives all possible worlds, and contingently selects one for the sake of its distinctive goodness."[60]

Ward was brought up with a post-Kantian philosophy, which suggested that God's existence cannot be established by reason. While the existence of the whole universe can be credited to a more logical choice, God is the best explanation for the *whole structure* of the universe, which one may consider to be a meta-scientific explanation. "The hypothesis of God is one that would make the existence of such a universe as this much more probable than it would otherwise be."[61] Ward concludes: "To see that the universe is, both in its general structure and in its precise detail, a work of supreme wisdom, that it depends at every instant for its existence on a being of supreme goodness, and that the universe is destined to realize a goal of overwhelming goodness, is already to see the temporal world in a religious way," and the Creator's "glory and power are seen in the works of creation."[62]

Not until chapter 3 do we come to Scripture, and then the Genesis creation account is dismissed as consisting of two contrary accounts which

58. J. P. Moreland, "Response to Howard J. Van Till," in *Three Views on Creation and Evolution*, eds., J. P. Moreland and John Mark Reynolds (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1999), 233.
59. Keith Ward, *God, Faith and the New Millennium: Christian Belief in an Age of Science* (Oxford: Oneworld, 1999, 1st ed. 1998), 61–62.
60. Ibid., 63–64.
61. Ibid., 67.
62. Ibid., 68.

came, ultimately, from tribal origin stories.[63] Ward argues that a wise intelligence best describes how the simple emerged into the complex, generating consciousness and free action, so that design rather than chance directed the process.[64] In an open universe, God exercises continuing influence "sustaining the universe in existence at every moment and in actively guiding the way it develops, within the limits of the general laws of its intelligible structure."[65] Even though Ward supports evolution, he grants that miracles can take place,[66] which leaves one wondering why he doesn't accept the miracle of creation mentioned in Genesis 1–2. Paradoxically Ward accepts the miracle of Christ's birth[67] (second Adam), and yet fails to accept the miracle of the first Adam's creation.

Ward says that evolution from a Christian point of view "is no blind process, without any goal. It is intended from the first to attain a goal, and it is directed with supreme wisdom to that goal."[68] He does so by arguing from the present backward: "Since rational beings do exist, it looks much more probable that God should have influenced events to produce them, than that they should have evolved by blind chance."[69] Is it not much more persuasive (as a Christian) to see God's having created humans in His image in the beginning (Gen. 1:26–27)—which explains why they are rational today?

Ward rejects the literal scriptural language used about the end of the world, just as he rejects a literal creation. This is because two thousand years ago they had a different worldview which held that the end of the world was not the end of humans. He opts for a spiritual interpretation.[70] Although the law of entropy means the universe will die in about five thousand million years, Ward asks, "Might it not be possible for each body to be re-created in a more perfect form that could realize its inherent potentialities, so often frustrated by conflict and pain on earth?"[71] With the resurrection of Christ in mind, Ward points to the final resurrection as "a fuller form of transformed embodiment, in a world beyond this physical cosmos."[72] In that future "God desires all to be saved" and "God will assuredly make it possible for all to be saved."[73] If God can re-create

63. Ibid., 43–50.
64. Ibid., 58.
65. Ibid., 81–82.
66. Ibid., 89–90.
67. Ibid., 175.
68. Ibid., 106.
69. Ibid. Ward can also state, "As far as evolutionary biology is concerned, one can be happy just to say it is a very improbable process, but it has happened, and one has to deal with that," 119.
70. Ibid., 145–148.
71. Ibid., 186–187.
72. Ibid., 188.
73. Ibid., 190.

all in the future (and if even in hell repentance is possible), why could He not create Adam and Eve in the beginning? After all, Ward states, "The law of entropy, which decrees that this physical universe will end in a long empty darkness, suggests that the *parousia* [or second advent] must be or usher in a new form of creation."[74]

Ward rejects the final judgment, in which humans will be saved or damned. In contrast, he says that all humans will enter a "full loving relationship with God"[75] and "share in the divine nature."[76] Ward believes that God uses all religions, that Jesus is only one teacher among many, and that God does not act uniquely in Jesus.[77] All humans will be changed through "purgation and sanctification" in "Sheol and paradise" following death. This will be "the perfected form of material creation," and hence Ward claims, "The scientific worldview enables one to see this Christian vision in its full cosmic scope"[78] (like a continuing evolution after death). Hence, "Through the Spirit, God is a constant presence and cooperative agent in the process of emergent evolution."[79]

Evaluation

If God is loving and powerful enough to change even the worst sinners, why is He so dependent upon an alleged evolutionary development over millennia? If He can create so powerfully after death, why did He not create powerfully—supernaturally—in Genesis 1–2? Scripture proclaims that a God of love and power created humans directly, not indebted to anything, including evolution (Rom. 4:17b; Heb. 11:3). They were created in His image from the beginning (Gen. 1:26–27). How could the God of Calvary, the God of selfless love, the God who gives salvation to humans, use the guts and gore of evolution to create humans?

Ward's ruminations are in their essence contrary to Scripture. His is a type of theistic evolution in which human thinking questions divine revelation. Ward's response: "[M]odern science does necessitate quite a bit of reinterpretation of traditional Christian ways of putting things."[80] "The rise of the natural sciences changes our view of the universe, and so of the context within which religious beliefs are to be interpreted."[81] Not only did Ward attempt to reconcile two mutually exclusive worldviews—supernatural and natural—he also ended up radically altering the supernatural worldview of Scripture.

74. Ibid., 201, parenthesis added.
75. Ibid., 212.
76. Ibid., 217.
77. Ibid., 141–142.
78. Ibid., 217.
79. Ibid., 216.
80. Ibid.
81. Ibid., 13.

Ward claims that the vastness of the universe was not understood when Genesis 1–2 was written. It took modern science to introduce us to the vast expanse and 13.75-billion-year history. The scientific view posits the possibility of the end of planet earth and humans through a cosmic catastrophe, but that would not be the end of the universe, which will still exist for billions of years, perhaps evolving forms of life more advanced than humans. Ward speaks about the scientific finalé as an "inevitable destruction of the universe," which is like a Mozart symphony. Although Mozart is dead, his symphony is appreciated by humans; likewise, though humans will all be dead, the value of their existence will be appreciated by God. On the other hand, Ward can speak of the biblical finalé of evolution as humans united with Christ (Eph. 1:10), which he calls "a partly self-shaped conscious union with the creator."[82]

Ward views Genesis, not as a "scientific cosmology," but as "a spiritual interpretation of the universe's origin, nature and destiny."[83] Even though he sees Genesis 1–2 as two contrary creation stories (due to the different order of events), he views the first creation story as ending with the seventh-day Sabbath.[84] Overall, though, his book strains to find consonance between the scientific and biblical views. His problem is attempting to reconcile two mutually exclusive worldviews: either nature created, or God did. Saying that God created through nature portrays God as incompetent, not all-powerful or all-loving. Ward concludes, "If God wants to create life-forms very like human beings, God will have to create a universe with all the properties this universe has. To put it bluntly, God could not create *us* in a better universe, or a universe with fewer possibilities of suffering in it."[85] This fails to take into account the omnipotence of God.

KEITH B. MILLER

Keith Miller edited the book *Perspectives on an Evolving Creation*. In the chapter he wrote, he defines evolution as "the descent with modification of all living things from a common ancestor."[86] He points out that Christian theologians, including

82. Ibid., 30.
83. Ibid., 43.
84. Ibid., 48.
85. Ibid., 95. How can creation necessarily require a process of suffering and death to evolve human life? Is this what Ward means when he says, "When God creates, God expresses the divine nature in a way that would otherwise have remained only potential" (98)? Looking to the Cross as evidence of God's love (as Ward does, 99–100) leads one to ask how the God who died to do away with human death had to create humans through the death of animals. Such a god does not seem to be "the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8), but as one who is changing/evolving from causing death for animals before he chose death for humans, the first beyond his control, the other not. Ward sees this god as "compatible with evolution" (122), but he overlooks this god's incompatibility with the God of Scripture.
86. Keith B. Miller, "An Evolving Creation: Oxymoron or Fruitful Insight?," in Miller, ed., *Perspectives on an Evolving Creation* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2003), 3.

Evangelicals, recognize that "Scripture does not demand a young Earth," and it does not "prohibit God's use of evolutionary mechanisms to accomplish his creative will."[87] His views on evolution are as follows:[88]

- Evolution is not confined to metaphysical naturalism.
- Complete scientific explanations do not exclude divine action.
- Science does not deny the existence of a Creator; it is merely silent on His existence and acts.
- Science is no more based on a denial of God than is plumbing or mechanics.
- A metaphysical worldview (philosophical naturalism) is not a necessary component of evolution.
- God's creative activity includes natural processes in Scripture.
- Chance is not in conflict with God's creative action through evolution.
- Death and suffering in evolution require a knowledge of God's immanence.
- Efforts toward reconciling the existence of pain and suffering with divine goodness in an evolving creation have encouraged renewed contemplation of the doctrines of providence, the incarnation of Christ, the redemption, and the centrality of the Cross.
- Origin of life is possible because of what is learned from prebiotic chemistry and evolution.
- Intelligent Design's irreducible complexity is rejected, because complexity could be the result of a series of functional steps.
- God may act continually within creation, drawing out created potentials already present.
- Evangelicals must pursue integration because of the overwhelming evidence.

Evaluation

Any attempt to unite evolutionary naturalism with biblical Supernaturalism calls into question the reality of the Fall. Thus in Miller's book, Robin Collins said, "[I]t is difficult to make sense of how human nature could have been corrupted or distorted [through the fall], especially within an evolutionary perspective."[89]

Now to a fundamental flaw: Miller rejects the idea of a battle between faith and science, and speaks of the overwhelming and extensive perspective of the evolutionary worldview, which he believes does justice to the immanence of God, to His continued creative activity, and to an understanding of Calvary. Contrary to Miller's view is the far more expansive cosmic controversy worldview of Scripture, which presents an adversary against God, the devil, who is

87. Ibid., 4.
88. Ibid., 5–14.
89. Robin Collins, "Evolution and Original Sin," in Miller, ed., *Perspectives on an Evolving Creation*, 472.

doing all he can to distort the truth about God. How is the tortuous process of death to millions compatible with the love shown at Calvary? John Munday, in Miller's book, fails to take this biblical worldview into consideration:

> Do we find it acceptable that his [God] creating is responsible for millions of years of animal pain? The choice is before us whether or not to submit to him as Creator and Merciful Judge, as urged in Romans 9. In this regard we will seek to comprehend and construct morality concerning animals according to what he has done and said, not according to our own standard of fairness, equity, and justice.[90]

Now consider Miller's beliefs as outlined above. It makes no sense to speak as if the enormous suffering of animals over billions of years gives us a better understanding of the Cross. How can God choose to create through a tortuous process of suffering and death, when He could have spoken creation into existence (as He did in Gen. 1)? How can one understand the Cross more profoundly when the God of love who died was the same one who inflicted such horrors upon the animal kingdom for so long? If God used/uses the evolutionary process, when He is omnipotent and could have created the world and all in it in six days (the view of Gen. 1–2), then this alone would be sufficient evidence for Satan to win the cosmic controversy, proving from the evolutionary process that God is not a loving and just God. This in effect trumps the otherwise ultimate proof of God's love and justice at the Cross.

ARTHUR PEACOCKE (1924–2006)

What happens when a scientist tries to unite God and evolution? For twenty-five years Arthur Peacocke held academic posts in physical biochemistry at the universities of Birmingham and Oxford. As a theologian-scientist, he is Dean of Clare College, Cambridge and Director of the Ian Ramsey Center, St. Cross College, Oxford. His book *Theology for a Scientific Age*[91] presents a thoroughly evolutionary worldview, in which he attempts to fit God into the evolutionary worldview by focusing primarily upon His immanence in the world.

Peacocke rejects the authority of Scripture, stating that since the Enlightenment an external assessment is necessary, which for him is science and its evolutionary theory. The method he uses is critical realism. He chose to have J. Leplin explain its meaning: "What realists do share in common are the convictions

90. John C. Munday, Jr., "Animal Pain: Beyond the Threshold?" in Miller, ed., *Perspectives on an Evolving Creation*, 468. Munday's point is the same argument used by predestinarians (chap. 9), based upon a misunderstanding of Romans 9. In fact, God is not electing Jacob for salvation, and rejecting Esau. Rather, He is choosing the family line of Jacob (Israel) as an avenue to take His blessing to all nations, including the family line of Esau (Jacob and Esau are two nations, Gen. 25:23), not two destinies (saved or lost).

91. Arthur Peacocke, *Theology for a Scientific Age: Being and Becoming—Natural, Divine, and Human* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1993).

that scientific change is, on balance, progressive and that science makes possible knowledge of the world beyond its accessible, empirical manifestations."[92] This means science "is aiming to depict reality." This goes beyond logical positivism, which requires empirical data. Peacocke says, "Critical realism recognizes that it is still only the *aim* of science to depict reality and that this allows gradations in acceptance of the 'truth' of scientific theories."[93] In this context he claims that science and theology are "mutually interacting approaches to reality."[94]

Influenced by Process thinking, Peacocke says all being is in process of becoming, which includes the natural, divine, and human entities. So he rejects the static worldview of Newton, and accepts the dynamic worldview of Einstein's Theories of Relativity.[95] Although God's creation is intentional, not through pure chance, Peacocke alleges that since God is immanent in nature, He creates through chance, and these created realities have "unfulfilled potentialities." God takes risks, particularly with humans. In creating God imposes on Himself "a *'self-limited' omnipotence and omniscience*,"[96] so He chooses not to use the full extent of His powers and so He does not know how some things will turn out.

Such self-limiting shows that God is love, for "love is supremely manifest in self-limiting."[97] God willed humans to be free and willed the evolutionary process to achieve their freedom. So the question—Why would an omnipotent God allow evil?—is placed in a different context. In Peacocke's view of creation, God chose to limit His own omnipotence, and as the immanent God He "suffers in, with and under the creative processes of the world."[98] In this way Peacocke rejects the classical view of God's impassibility (inability to suffer). He tentatively suggests that through this process God is bringing about a greater good in which loving persons will be in communion with Himself and each other. This is the contribution made by suffering and death in the evolutionary process.[99]

Peacocke calls into question the classical view of God as timeless, for He could not know the world as temporal and changing if He is altogether outside of time. Rather, God is in time as the immanent God. Peacocke claims that God can only be personal if He is able to experience a succession of events. If God knows future outcomes, humans would not be free. He calls into question classical attributes of God from the context of science, where Heisenberg's uncertainty

92. J. Leplin, "Introduction" in *Scientific Realism*, ed. J. Leplin (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984), 2. Cited in Peacocke, *Theology for a Scientific Age*, 12.
93. Peacocke, *Theology for a Scientific Age*, 10–12.
94. Ibid., 21.
95. Ibid., 23–31.
96. Ibid., 119–121.
97. Ibid., 123.
98. Ibid., 126.
99. Ibid., 127.

principle is operative in micro-events, and where "non-linear dynamical systems" are "irreducibly unpredictable." God is in the process of creating every moment of time in a successive way. Showing indebtedness to Openness theism, Peacocke says, "God creates each instant of physical time with its open, as yet undetermined, outcomes." So God is temporal, for the *"Divine life is successive in its relation to us."*[100] As with Process and Openness theism, Peacocke states that God does not know future events because they do not exist in the present, for God is exploring as He continues to create.[101]

Causation in nature is looked at in the light of an immanent God. Just as the mind influences the body, God is somehow "exerting continuously top-down causative influences on the world-as-a-whole." But, unlike the God of Process theology, Peacocke's immanent God does not have the world as His body, for this would compromise His role as Creator. So God can be transcendent and immanent, and He needs to be transcendent to be the Creator—but it is the immanent God who interests Peacocke, for He is immanent in the evolutionary process.[102]

Peacocke alleges that the story of the Fall (original sin) is a myth, for creation and the Fall constitute an ongoing, moment-by-moment experience, and thus Adam and the Fall involved everyone. At the same time, human nature is becoming a merging of self with a divine ultimate reality. He speaks of an "awareness of a benevolent non-physical power," greater than the individual self is sensed today, as documented in the Alister Hardy Research Center at Oxford University. He claims that centuries ago this same awareness resulted in the great religions of the world, which are sources for the realization of human potential.[103]

So how does "Jesus the Christ" (Peacocke's designation, a term also used by New Agers)[104] fit into this evolutionary, Fall-free view of reality? Peacocke accepts the results of critical study that has taken place since the Enlightenment, saying it is "irreversible and should be welcomed by Christian believers." This critical research claims that none of the words or deeds of Jesus are certain, but Peacocke believes that one can still know facts about Jesus with certainty.[105] But the facts he suggests call into question who Jesus really was and is. For in order to be human, Jesus had to have a human father, and so Joseph was his father.[106]

100. Ibid., 128–132, emphasis added in last quote.
101. Ibid., 155–157.
102. Ibid., 184–187.
103. Ibid., 251.
104. See Norman R. Gulley, *Christ Is Coming! A Christ-Centered Approach to Last-Day Events* (Hagerstown, MD: Review and Herald, 1998), 179–210.
105. Peacocke, *Theology for a Scientific Age*, 261–263.
106. Ibid., 279.

Peacocke asserts that Jesus the Christ is not a "unique invasion" of a transcendent individual but "the distinctive manifestation of a possibility always inherently there for human beings in their potential nature" as "God created them to be and to become." So, logically, Peacocke can say that "what we have affirmed about Jesus is not, in principle, impossible for all humanity."[107] Thus the "Creator God in whom the world exists has all along been instantiating, 'incarnating' God's own personalness, in that world and this has been made supremely and explicitly manifest in particular in Jesus the Christ"; but this "does not confine the incarnating of God the Word to him alone."[108] Peacocke says, "[T]hat is the basis of our hope."[109]

Peacocke rejects the view that death came through sin because biological death is a part of the evolutionary process. Because of that process, which is ever upward, there was no golden age in the past, no subsequent Fall, and no need of a substitutionary atonement. The atonement theories were all culturally conditioned, and so now in an evolutionary culture Peacocke sees the atonement as God suffering, which "engages" us (cf. the "lure" of Process thought), or draws humans to Him and transforms their relationship with Him. Thus the atonement is no longer considered in static terms, as a transaction, but as a "manifestation of God's perennial, loving gracious intention to actualize the potential he has given us of a full and enriched personhood by bringing humanity into his own life through that self-offering and suffering love for God which God's own self kindles in us through his immanent presence as Holy Spirit."[110]

What is the goal of human becoming, or the end of human evolution? Peacocke refers to the resurrection of Jesus as a "transformation/re-creation, of the Jesus-whom-they-knew that led to him being designated as the Christ, as 'Lord' and later as 'Son of God.'"[111] This revealed "what humanity was meant by God to become—namely, united to God in self-offering love for God and others."[112] To become one with God actualizes "the purposes of God in the evolution of humanity."[113] The place Jesus the "Christ occupies in 'spiritual' history" is "the place that a mutation does in biological evolution—an irreversible transformation into a new kind of existence allowing the actualization of new possibilities."[114] Jesus is a human being who became united with the ultimate

107. Ibid., 302.
108. Ibid., 303–306.
109. Ibid., 320.
110. Ibid., 321–330.
111. Ibid., 316.
112. Ibid., 317.
113. Ibid.
114. Ibid., 317–318.

Being, which revealed God's intentions for humanity. The ultimate destiny of humanity is to be "in God."[115] Peacocke ends with a postscript on the Trinity as three modes of being, and says that "we are commanded to love God with our minds."[116] Hence his focus is on "critical realism."

Evaluation

Peacocke chooses critical realism (science aims at reality) and rejects creation revelation (Scripture presents reality). He accepts evolutionary theory as a fact and considers biblical data to be fiction. He rejects God's transcendent creation but embraces an alleged immanent creation. He rejects a finished creation for an ongoing creation. He rejects Adam and Eve and their Fall because their narrative does not fit with the upward progress of evolution. He rejects an incarnation that is outside the evolutionary process; he cannot accept that Jesus was the unique God-Man who died a substitutionary death to save humans from sin.

Peacocke rejects God's foreknowledge, for if God did know the future, then humans would not be free. But Peacocke also says that "Jesus the Christ" suffers for humans. Thus he rejects God's foreknowledge while accepting His love for humans. But true love means that God's foreknowledge does not interfere with human free choices. Like Process and Openness theists, Peacocke places limits on the love of God as well as the foreknowledge of God, and so is no better than classical theists in this respect, for they limit His love by claiming His immutability and impassibility (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 6).

Peacocke writes as a scientist, and yet attempts to place theology within the evolutionary worldview; as a result, he radically revises biblical revelation so as to fit Scripture into his evolutionary construct. A distorted view of God and a false theology are the result. In his system humans evolve to be like God through a natural process with some immanent infusion from "Jesus the Christ" who was fully human (both parents) and for the most part merely a prototype of what all can become. Peacocke denies the Fall and the need for a substitutionary atonement. Evolution is the hope of humans, for humans have always had potential (God-given, of course) to evolve into union with God.

Peacocke is like Friedrich Schleiermacher (leading theologian of the nineteenth century), for (1) both were impacted by Enlightenment criticism; (2) both desired to communicate with thinkers; (3) both wrote a theology in an age of science; (4) both rejected revelation in Scripture; (5) both dismissed theology as a study

115. Ibid., 344.
116. Ibid., 347–349.

of God; (6) both thought on a lower (human, rather than divine) level in man (Schleiermacher) or in evolution (Peacocke); (7) both rejected biblical doctrines that did not fit with their confined worldview of human existence or of human evolution; and (8) both relegated the Trinity to an afterthought (in his last pages [Schleiermacher] and in his postscript [Peacocke]).

Instead of unfolding evolution on a nonbiblical basis, Peacocke could have unfolded the Trinity on a biblical basis. The Trinity as an eternal, reciprocal relationship of love among Persons presents the essence of God's love that cannot be fathomed by the horrors of the evolutionary struggle to survive. Peacocke's revisionist theology illustrates how unwise it is to speak about the God of Scripture while holding on to an evolutionary worldview.

TED PETERS AND MARTINEZ HEWLETT

Lutheran systematic theologian Ted Peters and Catholic scientist Martinez Hewlett are theistic evolutionists. In their book *Evolution from Creation to New Creation*, they state: "Darwinian science and belief in God are not mutually exclusive."[117] The authors defend theistic evolution that embraces creation out of nothing (*creatio ex nihilo*), continuing creation (*creatio continua*), and providence, from an eschatological perspective (in a kind of futurism).[118] The authors claim that God's words "very good" describing creation will not be given until the new creation, which is the end of the continuing creation.[119] The authors base this interpretation (their epistemology) on Paul's comment that "Now we see in a mirror dimly" (1 Cor. 13:12a, ESV). Here's how they unpack the meaning of this epistemology: "God creates from the future, not the past. God starts redemption and then draws creation toward it. Or, perhaps better said, God's ongoing creative work is also God's redeeming work. Only a redeemed creation will be worthy of the appellation 'very good.'"[120]

Evaluation

The view of Peters and Hewlett is mere speculation, for their interpretation goes against the biblical record. Genesis states that after six days of creation "the heavens and the earth were completed" (Gen. 2:1), and thus "God had finished the work he had been doing" (Gen. 2:2). The next verse agrees: "God blessed the seventh day and made it holy, because on it he rested from all the work of creating that he had done" (Gen. 2:3). This is why the last verse of Genesis 1 says: "God

117. Ted Peters and Martinez Hewlett, *Evolution from Creation to New Creation: Conflict, Conversation, and Convergence* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 2003), 11.
118. Ibid., 22–34. See chapters 6 and 7.
119. Ibid., 158.
120. Ibid., 160.

saw all that he had made, and it was very good" (v. 31). This is why Gordon Wenham rightly states: "Elsewhere in the Pentateuch, e.g., Gen 17:22; 49:33; Exod 40:33, the phrase indicates that the action in question is past, and a pluperfect is used in English translations. There is no implication in the Hebrew of 2:2 that God was working on the seventh day before he finished."[121] Karl Barth says this about the Creator: "Since He is justified by His work, His celebration when it is finished is in reality the coronation of His work. We have already said that not man but the divine rest on the seventh day is the crown of creation."[122]

The authors furthermore state that God applies the words "very good" to the deep-time (probably 4.5 billion years)[123] of struggle and death of evolutionary history. But such torture is incompatible with a God of love (1 John 4:8–16), who has compassion for animals (Ps. 36:6; 84; 145:9; Isa. 11:6–9; Hos. 2:18; Jon. 4:11; Luke 12:6; cf. Matt. 10:29). In the light of Scripture, it is not sufficient for the authors to admit: "What we do not know theologically is why violence, suffering, and death have had to play such a role in the creation up to this point."[124] They do not provide sufficient justification for tampering with the revelation made at Calvary—its stunning testimony to God's love when Jesus "who had no sin" became "sin for us" (2 Cor. 5:21a). It is not helpful to suggest that His suffering is "the opposite of what we might expect from a God who is omnipotent and eternal and immutable."[125] Yet He was fully present there—just as He was present (according to Peters and Hewlett) in the untold suffering of continuing creation. If God is omnipotent, why not believe that He finished His creation in six days, and declared it "very good," without any suffering to nature, as God revealed in the Genesis creation account?

It is not helpful for the authors to state: "Our world is being redeemed while it is being created." They place the "Garden of perfection" in the future, not in the past as "an original perfection from which subsequent nature has fallen." One is left asking about the historicity of the Fall and of salvation. Why is perfection removed from the past and placed in the future? Is a perfect God incapable of creating a perfect creation and then calling it "very good"? Where did evil come from? Was it present from the beginning of creation? Did God need to use evil to create the good? The only answer we get is the following: "We do not invoke twists of logic to justify God for creating a world of struggle with the survival of the fittest and all its accompanying waste. Rather, we point to God's promise of resurrection and renewal. Death is not the final chapter in the story

121. Gordon J. Wenham, *Genesis 1–15*, vol. 1 in *Word Biblical Commentary* (Waco, TX: Word, 1987), 35.
122. Karl Barth, *Doctrine of Creation*, vol. 3, pt. 1 in *Church Dogmatics* (Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1958), 223.
123. Peters and Hewlett, *Evolution from Creation*, 167; deep time, 164.
124. Ibid., 172.
125. Ibid.

of God's drama with nature."[126] The authors make it clear that nature is without design, but God has an eschatological plan.[127] It does not seem to bother them that these two—naturalism and Supernaturalism, plan and lack thereof—are mutually exclusive.

The authors read into God's words "very good" the very opposite of the literal meaning of the text. They also question "the creation week of seven days" by asking if they are "inclusive of the entire history of creation from Big Bang to whatever will become of the universe in the future?" They ask, "Could we still be looking forward to the Sabbath day, to God's first day of rest yet in the future?" They find in Augustine one who "nearly approached" their view of a timeless God who created in the simultaneity of eternity, without succession of time, and looked to the eternal Sabbath as future. The authors conclude: "we consider that future consummation the crowning conclusion of creation, a single inclusive divine act whereby what comes into existence is perfected in its existence."[128] Why was this not done by the omnipotent God in the beginning? After all, the authors proclaim that the "the human soul is a special creation of God."[129]

So the human body is the product of philosophical naturalism, developing in the context of chance, whereas the soul is a supernatural creation by God, evidently planned. Why the distinction? The authors answer: "Our eschatological perspective relies upon the soul as the link between our future resurrection and our present anticipation of renewal beyond death." The "soul marks the dimension of the eternal within the ephemeral."[130]

Instead of being informed by Scripture interpreting itself (*sola Scriptura*), the authors are guided by a quadrilateral: "Scripture, tradition, experience, and reason."[131] They believe humans are created creators, who through genetic engineering are "on the threshold of designing" their "descendants" to "influence the future path of evolution."[132] Theistic evolution has attempted to reconcile two mutually exclusive worldviews (naturalism and Supernaturalism), and in the process the nature (love) and attributes (omnipotence, for example) of God are called into question. He is less than the God of Scripture. There it clearly records a historical completed creation, the Fall, and the plan of salvation as a gift of God, which has nothing to do with any ongoing creation (which confuses otherwise separate categories).

126. Ibid., 172–173.
127. Ibid., 167.
128. Ibid., 163–164.
129. Ibid., 169.
130. Ibid.
131. Ibid., 173.
132. Ibid., 174.

JOHN C. POLKINGHORNE (1930–)

Polkinghorne's book *Science and Creation* contains much intricate science, from his perspective, as one expects from a theoretical physicist who is past president of Queens College, Cambridge University. He was knighted by Queen Elizabeth II in 1997 "for distinguished service to science, religion, learning and medical ethics."[133] He is also an Anglican priest. So he seems uniquely qualified to speak about science and religion. As a theistic evolutionist, he argues that "there is an urgent need for dialogue between the two disciplines [science and religion]. The arena for their interaction is natural theology."[134] He is honest to state his limitations when it comes to theology.[135]

Though it is beyond our present purpose to present all the science Polkinghorne teaches, it is important to get an overview of what he thinks. He locates the second law of thermodynamics (entropy, everything runs down) in a context that he believes overcomes entropy. There are levels of existence, in which "small changes in circumstances produce only small changes in consequences."[136] In quantum events or fluctuations (waves and particles) there is disorderliness, which he calls "intrinsic randomness." He argues there are "systems that seem to be swimming against the tide of increasing entropy" to counter entropy.[137] It seems that this swimming against the tide is the process God, the immanent God working within the process.[138] His view apparently questions the mutually exclusive worldviews set forth in this chapter.[139]

It logically follows that Polkinghorne believes that "search for the unity of knowledge that inspires the physicist to seek his Grand Unified Theory,

133. John C. Polkinghorne, *Science and Creation: The Search for Understanding* (West Conshohocken, PA: Templeton Press, 1st 1988, 2006), back cover.

134. Ibid., 8.

135. "I certainly cannot pretend to write as a professional theologian, but only as a scientist deeply interested in the understanding of religion." Ibid., 7.

136. Ibid., 54.

137. Ibid., 56–57. His chapter ("Order and Disorder") "has portrayed a world whose processes can assemble complexity within a decaying environment and where random events can prove to be the originators of pattern. Such a world is a world of orderliness but not of clockwork regularity, of potentiality without predictability, endowed with an assurance of development but with a certain openness as to its actual form." Ibid., 61.

138. Ibid., 78.

139. He says, "natural and supernatural are simply ways of speaking about different levels in the one rationality, whose seamless character is a reflection of the oneness of the Creator and His consistency in relation to the world." *Science and Creation*, 107. With respect to the immanent God, Polkinghorne says, "The one who is love will grant a generous measure of independence to His world, for love is grounded in the free exchange between lover and beloved. The God of love can be no cosmic puppet master, pulling the strings of a world which is totally subservient to Him…genuine freedom granted to the world opens up the possibility of disorder. It is important to recognize that God's love for the world in creation, though including humanity, is not exclusively man-centered. The universe is not just a gigantic theater in which the human play is being performed after an overture lasting 14 billion years." Ibid., 64. Also, "We encounter here an idea of the greatest importance: the understanding that the act of creation involves a *kenosis* of God, an emptying of himself and an acceptance of the self-limitations inherent in the giving of creative love." Ibid., 75, italics his.

if pursued with tenacity [which he does], eventually leads beyond physics to theology."[140] In other words, he begins with science as the bed-rock, authoritative source, for the entire unified search towards theology. His book's subtitle is appropriate: *The Search for Understanding.* His quest is reminiscent of Anselm's (1033–1109) *fides quaerens intellectum* (faith seeking understanding). This time it is science seeking understanding. In this quest he goes beyond atheistic scientists who confine themselves within the realm of the natural without any care for what is beyond.

From Polkinghorne's process God view and integration assumption, it follows that: (1) "God, who is the ordainer and sustainer of nature, acts as much through natural processes as in any other way."[141] (2) "Physics needs metaphysics for its intellectually satisfying completion."[142] (3) Understanding the world "is a quest that unites science and theology in comradely concern, for they are both attempting to explore aspects of the way things are."[143] He gropes for "an understanding that does justice both to what science can tell us about the world and also to our experience of a much wider reality than that which science could ever claim to explain."[144]

Polkinghorne's problem lies in trying to marry this world as it is with a new one to come. Thus his question: "if all will find fulfillment in the New Creation, why do we have first to endure the imperfections of the old?" He answers that God patiently works through the process to achieve His purpose. "It is possible that Love can only work in such a way, out of respect for the beloved."[145] In other words, the evolutionary process over deep-time with its uncertainty and chance is the best way God's love can be shown to those whom He loves. For example, "The search for understanding is the search for the *Logos*."[146] The *Logos*, or Word, is Christ (John 1:1, 14). Christ's sacrifice for humans was during the long process of evolution through His *kenosis*, or self-emptying. This was witnessed in His birth in history, which "testifies to God's deepest possible involvement with His creation."[147]

Nevertheless, there is order and disorder in the process, so there is no "inevitable unfolding of an invulnerable plan. It is a world kept in being by the divine Juggler rather than by the divine Structural Engineer, a world whose precarious process speaks of the free gift of love." He notes "a vulnerability potentially present

140. Ibid., 43.
141. Ibid., xi.
142. Ibid., 5.
143. Ibid., 25.
144. Ibid., 98.
145. Ibid., 80.
146. Ibid., 81.
147. Ibid.

in the baby lying in the manger and realized to the full in the man hanging on the cross. What is there revealed of the divine in the human life of Jesus is also to be discerned in the cosmic story of creation.... God's steadfast love is revealed in the synergy of chance and necessity."[148]

Evaluation

Polkinghorne is controlled by his theory of evolution and religion as one seamless process over deep-time. He believes they cohere and belong together. The union of divinity and humanity takes place in the incarnation. That *kenosis*, or self-emptying, characterizes the deep-time process of evolution in which God and the world are united in the sense that God limits Himself to allow nature and humans to be themselves. This is because God is love, and love acts in love toward the beloved. This is a mixture of truth and speculation.

Polkinghorne is right to present a God of love instead of a dictator-God. But in the process he rejects an omnipotent Creator who acts out of love. He fails to view God's attribute of omnipotence (mighty Creator) as an outworking of His love (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 2, where all God's attributes reveal His love). His theology is primarily a conversation with theologians with little if any real contribution from Scripture. He dismisses Genesis 1–2 as a past creative act of God, and applies it to the entire length of the evolutionary process, still underway. He dismisses the Fall in Genesis 3. He says it is "an ever-contemporary picture of alienation from God rather than an account of a primeval disaster."[149]

The historical facts of Genesis 1–3 are rejected in favor of an evolutionary process. It follows that if there was no Fall, or primeval disaster, then the evolutionary process is not about salvation but about forming humans who in the incarnation became united with God. He says, "The center of Christianity lies in the *realized myth* of the incarnation."[150] Thus the joining of divine and human in Christ seems more the focus than Christ's death; after all, why would His death be necessary if humans never experienced the Fall of Genesis 3?

Polkinghorne is submerged in evolutionary theory and attempts to marry religion into the process as if they were at home together—as if the religion he endorses brings evolutionary science to completion. The wave and particle fluctuations of quantum events are likened to God's openness to give freedom to nature and humans, so that uncertainty is imbedded in the process. This allegedly reveals the love of the Creator for His creation. Scripture turns this on its

148. Ibid., 82.
149. Ibid., 116.
150. Ibid.

head. Because God is a God of love, He powerfully created a wonderful world in six days for Adam and Eve to enjoy, followed by a seventh-day Sabbath spent with them (Gen. 1—2:3). That is powerful love that can be trusted, for God is a true God, a unique God, in His powerful love. Scripture says, "For great is the LORD and most worthy of praise; he is to be feared [reverenced] above all gods. For all the gods of the nations are idols, but the Lord made the heavens" (Psa. 96:4–5). God is the only God because He through the divinity of Christ is the Creator (Col. 1:15–16; Heb. 1:1–3). He is the Designer (or Structural Engineer) and not a divine Juggler. Polkinghorne replaces the Omnipotent power of God as Creator with the vulnerability of Jesus as a human in birth and death.

Contra Polkinghorne, it is not a case of a rational God being connected with reason in evolution. It is a case of a relational God of love who spared nature and humans from the horrors of struggle and death in a long process to develop humans. God's love is best revealed in creating humans in a hands-on way, personally (Gen. 2:7, 20b–22) in the image of God (Gen. 1:26–27). God's love is also best revealed at the cross where Christ paid the penalty for all humans (1 John 2:2), which resulted from the Fall of humans in Eden (Gen. 3:1–6). The Fall and the cross are linked in Scripture. "Consequently, just as one trespass [Fall] resulted in condemnation for all people, so also one righteous act [cross] resulted in justification and life for all people" (Rom. 5:18).

The deep-time of suffering is an affront to Christ's suffering on the cross for all creation and humans. It makes the Calvary suffering infinitesimally small in the light of nearly five billion years of evolutionary suffering. All suffering is a result of the cosmic controversy, the rebellion of angels and humans against a loving God, and not the way God chose to create (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 1, chapter 10). God is all-powerful and wise, and He created in love during the first week in Scripture (Gen. 1–2). God's love is not shown by patiently working through the tortuous process of evolution, but by personally creating the world and humans in His supernatural way not dependent upon nature, and without any pain or suffering.

FRANCIS COLLINS (1950–)

The book *The Language of God: A Scientist Presents Evidence for Belief*[151] was written by Francis Collins, former head of the Human Genome Project and now head of the National Institute of Health. As one of the leading scientists in the world, he believes in the integration of science and Scripture. For him this means acceptance of evolution and belief in God. This does not mean that he

151. Francis S. Collins, *The Language of God: A Scientist Presents Evidence for Belief* (New York: Free Press, 2006).

subscribes to the "God of the gaps" theory, which introduces God where evolution does not have an answer—a view he believes becomes less necessary as the gaps are filled without God.

Collins believes that the universe is approximately 14 billion years old, that the Earth is approximately 4.5 billion years old,[152] and that the first Homo sapiens arrived about 195,000 years ago.[153] Although there is a continuing conflict between science and faith, Collins notes that "93 percent of Americans profess some form of belief in God,"[154] yet points out that "far from his being ostracized by the religious community, Darwin was buried in Westminster Abbey."[155] Nevertheless, a large majority of Americans question evolutionary theory.

By contrast, Collins believes, "Evolution, as a mechanism, can be and must be true."[156] To support this conviction, he noted that the human genome is "3.1 billion letters of the DNA code arrayed across twenty-four chromosomes."[157] From his study of a human chromosome and a mouse chromosome, Collins concludes that "a common ancestor for humans and mice is virtually inescapable. This kind of recent genome data presents an overwhelming challenge to those who hold to the idea that all species were created ex nihilo [out of nothing]." He continues, "The chimpanzee genome sequence has now been unveiled, and it reveals that humans and chimps are 96 percent identical at the DNA level."[158] There is a chromosomal fusion, which Collins interprets as follows: "The fusion that occurred as we evolved from the apes has left its DNA imprint here. It is very difficult to understand this observation without postulating a common ancestor."[159]

It is clear that if one comes to the data with a presupposition that evolution is God's method of creation, then one will interpret the DNA accordingly. It does not matter if the biblical record is different. Even though Collins believes in God, he seems to doubt God's Word. For example, he divides the creation story (Gen. 1–2) into two creation stories (Gen. 1 and Gen. 2), and finds alleged contradictions in the process. Collins questions whether the Genesis creation record is literal, with literal twenty-four-hour days, and then cites Augustine who states that God is outside of time. Collins notes that the Hebrew word for day (*yôm*) is not always a literal day in

152. Ibid., 88–89.
153. Ibid., 96.
154. Ibid., 4.
155. Ibid., 98.
156. Ibid., 107.
157. Ibid., 124.
158. Ibid., 136–137.
159. Ibid., 138.

Scripture. He concludes that "no human knows what the meaning of Genesis 1 and 2 was precisely intended to be."[160]

Evaluation

The problem with this reasoning is to conclude that God is timeless and failing to take into account that *yôm* used with ordinals (as in Genesis 1) is always a literal twenty-four-hour day. Contrary to Collins, there is no contradiction between chapters 1 and 2 of Genesis (see chapter 3 of this volume). Furthermore, Christ's commentary on creation (Exod. 20:8–11) states that six literal days were followed by a literal seventh-day Sabbath, a fact that the pre-incarnate Christ wrote in stone (Exod. 31:18; 34:28b; Deut. 5:22b; 10:2, 4).

Collins believes that the Genesis creation is "poetry and allegory rather than a literal scientific description of origins."[161] Though the Genesis account is not scientific, it is literal and historical. Properly understood, the book of Scripture and the book of nature should agree since God is the Author of both. This being true, Scripture deserves to be studied as seriously as nature, and both according to the appropriate rules that govern their disciplines. Collins attempts to integrate the two; but in doing so, he allows his view of science (evolution) to trump his view of Scripture.

The stated purpose of Collins's book is "to reflect upon the ways that a modern understanding of science can be harmonized with a belief in God."[162] By "a belief in God" Collins seems to mean his view of God, which falls short of the biblical belief in God. For example, Collins speaks of "the elegant mechanism of evolution"[163] and says nothing about the guts and gore of the survival of the fittest. How is the latter compatible with a God of love, whose grace is freely given (Rom. 5:15–17; 6:23) and does not depend upon human effort and striving (which are so essential to the evolutionary process)? Collins turns away from the "chance nature" of evolution, saying that "from God's perspective the outcome would be entirely specified."[164] If God has sufficient wisdom to know the outcome, why does He not have sufficient wisdom to create the same instantaneously, or does He lack the ability? Other biblical texts clearly state that God had the ability to create by speaking things into existence (Ps. 33:6–9; 148:5). Collins devalues Scripture in an attempt to integrate Scripture and science. Although such a view of Scripture removes a mutual exclusiveness between a supernatural worldview and a

160. Ibid., 150–153.
161. Ibid., 206.
162. Ibid., 124.
163. Ibid., 201.
164. Ibid., 205.

natural worldview (between Scripture and evolution), it does so by rejecting the supernatural worldview of Scripture.

EVALUATION OF AN UNOFFICIAL ADVENTIST INTEGRATION THESIS

The book *Understanding Genesis: Contemporary Adventist Perspectives* does not speak for the Seventh-day Adventist church, but was seemingly written as an attempt to present the relationship between science and Scripture that is at home in a theistic evolutionary perspective. The editors claim that the Adventist Geoscience Research Institute (GRI), with reference to an old chronology for the earth, "has, so far, failed to provide a reasoned alternative that is convincing to the majority of Adventist scientists."[165] In other words, contrary to the GRI, the majority of Adventist scientists reject a relatively recent creation of the earth.[166]

It is important to know that the editors focus on reason in their preface, and reason rather than revelation seems to be emphasized throughout the book. For example, the first chapter points out that God allowed the suffering of humans on a "massive scale" in history and yet did not intervene; therefore "any attempt to mount a theological argument against evolution solely on the basis of God's goodness will face serious obstacles."[167] This conclusion fails to distinguish the difference between biblical creation by God prior to the Fall, and the world after the Fall. The first three chapters of Genesis clearly make this distinction. Why infer that God used evolution when Scripture says otherwise? Why suggest that God was limited to the cruel process of evolution when Scripture says He was not indebted to any pre-existing matter (Heb. 11:3)?

In the second chapter, Brian Bull speaks of value judgments made about natural disasters (some believe they are acts of God), and concludes that those making these judgments "live mentally in a prescientific world."[168] Granted, reason dictates that scientists do not make value judgments, but revelation does. God sent a global flood to destroy a wicked world (Gen. 6–8), and God will send a massive earthquake and huge hailstones in the end times for the same purpose (Rev. 16:1–7, 17–21). These are only two biblical examples where value judgments are made by God, and they cannot be dubbed pre-scientific.

165. Brian Bull, Fritz Guy, and Ervin Taylor, eds., *Understanding Genesis: Contemporary Adventist Perspectives* (Riverside, CA: Adventist Today, 2006), vi.

166. "In a survey of college science teachers in the North American Division…less than half of 121 teachers affirmed the traditional Adventist position." *Understanding Genesis*, 3.

167. Richard Rice, "Creation, Evolution, and Evil," in *Understanding Genesis*, 20–21.

168. Bull, "Why Are Science and Religion Still Fighting?" in *Understanding Genesis*, 31–32.

Further, the writer claims the "world of the Bible" understood the category of the holy, but did not have a category for the secular.[169] Yet the distinction between the holy and the profane was important even in the Old Testament (Lev. 10:10), demonstrated by the sacredness of the ark of the covenant (2 Chron. 35:3) and the most holy place (Lev. 16:1–34), which was off-limits to all of God's people, save the high priest once a year (Lev. 16:1–2, 29–34). "When puzzled by a phenomenon of nature, they defaulted to a supernatural explanation."[170] This reasoning seems to overlook that biblical writers did not default to the supernatural; rather, they were communicating supernatural revelation. Scripture is not the product of secular reason but the product of divine revelation. Although Scripture is not a scientific book, the biblical writers knew that it was God who was communicating sacred revelation through them (2 Pet. 1:21). The Thessalonians received Paul's messages as sent from God: "[When] you received the word of God, which you heard from us, you accepted it not as a human word, but as it actually is, the word of God" (1 Thess. 2:13).

The third chapter in *Understanding Genesis* is titled "Creation and Time: A Biblical Reflection." In it, Dalton Baldwin opts for an ongoing creation, and reinterprets the six-day creation as "symbolic envisioning."[171] How does he come to this conclusion? "On the basis of evidence largely present in the Bible itself, most biblical scholars hold that all the statements referring to six days of creation came into being very late."[172] Then in a footnote following this sentence, Baldwin says, "Space does not permit discussion of the evidence that supports dating these texts at a time later than is often believed," but that is precisely what reason requires. The chapter is a biblical reflection on the time of creation, but no biblical evidence is given for Genesis 1–2 being much later than Deuteronomy 5:6–21, although it is posited as a fact.

Baldwin argues that the Sabbath was given to Israel to remind them of their deliverance from Egypt, and was written much earlier than the Exodus account in which the Sabbath is a memorial of creation in six days. In other words, the six-day time frame has nothing to do with the seventh-day Sabbath, for it was not considered when the Deuteronomy account was made. Thus re-interpreting the six days as long periods of evolution does not destroy the Sabbath. There are major problems with this reasoning.

Deuteronomy recaps the laws given at Sinai forty years earlier—just prior to the death of Moses. This is why restating the Ten Commandments (Deut.) three times adds a phrase to the Ten Commandments (Exod.): with respect to the Sabbath "as

169. Ibid., 33.

170. Ibid.

171. Dalton D. Baldwin, "Creation and Time: A Biblical Reflection," *Understanding Genesis*, 36.

172. Ibid., 40.

the Lord your God has commanded you" (Deut. 5:12b); "Therefore the Lord your God has commanded you to observe the Sabbath day" (Deut. 5:15b); and with respect to honoring parents "as the Lord your God has commanded you" (Deut. 5:16a). These additions to the Ten Commandments suggest that the Exodus version of the Ten is being referred to by Moses, for the Ten had been a written record for Israel for forty years. If this is correct, then the Deuteronomy record itself makes a time reference to the Exodus account as existing earlier.

The second biblical indicator about time is the fact that forty years separates Sinai from the time when Moses recapitulates the laws God gave to Israel at Sinai. No amount of quotes from liberal critical commentators changes this fact. It is not true that the historical backgrounds of biblical books have been off-limits for Adventist scholars,[173] as the *Seventh-day Adventist Bible Commentary* attests for every biblical book. Rather, what has been understandably off-limits is the destructive work of historical criticism, which is an altogether different matter, and this critical method seems to have driven the writer to his conclusions.

Baldwin claims that the "oldest Sabbath laws contain no reference to creation,"[174] but he does not provide biblical texts as evidence, even though the chapter title (in part) is "Biblical Reflection." In place of biblical evidence, he simply says, "There is a consensus among academic scholars of biblical literary history that the creation account in Genesis 2 as well as the deuteronomic ten commandments were developed some time before the creation account in Genesis 1:1—2:3 and the ten commandments in Exodus 20."[175] In asserting that "most biblical scholars believe that the passages describing ongoing creation were actually written earlier than those that describe creation occurring within a single week,"[176] he again gives no biblical evidence. Readers cannot be expected to accept his apparent ongoing examples of creation as nonmetaphorical, when the six-day creation is dismissed as nonliteral.[177] After checking all his biblical examples for alleged ongoing creation, I find every reason to understand them metaphorically. The final paragraph of this chapter provides biblical texts that convey a literal creation, supporting the biblical account that God completed His work of creation during the first six days of creation week (Gen. 2:1).

In another chapter of *Understanding Genesis*, Bull and Guy, a scientist and a theologian, distinguish between the biblical and scientific worldviews. Though there are some differences (e.g., a world-centered cosmology in Scripture compared to Einsteinium cosmology today), why can't God be

173. Ibid., 49.
174. Ibid., 47.
175. Ibid., 47n21b, 51.
176. Ibid., 37.
177. Ibid., 37–42.

credited with genuine miracles in Scripture? God's point of view believes in miracles, as does that of the biblical writers. Hence these authors seem to write from the biblical writers' point of view but question God's point of view (which is the same). They suggest that ancient Hebrews, when they did not understand the natural explanation for reality, defaulted to a divine explanation (a miracle). One example is when the biblical writer says that rain was sent by God (1 Sam. 12:17–18); yet the context clearly indicates the rain was out of season (during the harvest), sent as a judgment from God, and so had nothing to do with a natural occurrence. The people knew it was a judgment from God; they asked Samuel to pray to God so they would not die (1 Sam. 12:12–19). The elaborate (and interesting)[178] attempt to give a natural explanation for Israelites dying after eating quail (Num. 11:31–34) is unnecessary. The people complained to God (vv. 4–6) and rejected Him (v. 20), and God was angry (v. 10) and struck the people with a "severe plague" (v. 33). Thus "a wind went out from the Lord and drove quail in from the sea" (v. 31a). This is divine revelation, not an ancient people's default to the supernatural; in fact, they had departed from the supernatural. These are two examples of human reason questioning divine revelation.

In another chapter, Guy refutes the claim that Genesis 1–2 gives us the "scientific truth" about when and how creation took place.[179] Though Genesis was never intended to be a scientific explanation of origins, it should be added that the so-called scientific truth about when and how creation took place is a misnomer, for we are speaking about macroevolution that goes beyond the scientific parameters of data that can be empirically verified. No scientist can test any process that took place during deep-time. There are claims made about the fossil record, but even Darwin thought the record was too sparse to support his theory. So the fossil record is not the scientific basis of evolution, as the writers of *Understanding Genesis* claim. Macroevolution belongs to metaphysics or philosophy, not to "true science," and so remains only theory that cannot be proven. Empirical evidence for the process of evolution is confined to microevolution, which is presently observable. But such micro changes are perfectly compatible with the literal creation record of Genesis 1–2.

In coming to the purpose and function of Genesis 1–2, Guy considers that there are two incompatible accounts (due to the differing order of events) if both are interpreted as literal.[180] Historical-critical scholarship separates Genesis 1 and 2 on the basis of their having been written by two authors: Genesis 1 (P) and

178. Bull and Guy, "Then a Miracle Occurs," in *Understanding Genesis*, 57–61.
179. Guy, "The Purpose and Function of Scripture: Preface to a Theology of Creation," in *Understanding Genesis*, 87.
180. Ibid., 94.

Genesis 2 (J). But Christ cites both Genesis 1:27 and Genesis 2:24 as Mosaic (Mark 10:6–9; Matt. 19:4–5). So if there is one author, as Christ indicates, then we must compare the two chapters from that perspective, not from the perspective of two separate sources. With that in mind, should we posit that perhaps Moses was simply adding details in chapter 2 after giving the sequence of creation in chapter 1?

As Guy notes, Genesis 1 presents the transcendent God (*Elohim*), whereas Genesis 2 presents the creative activity of God (*Yahweh Elohim*).[181] But a crucial distinction is the clear difference between the creation of humans and animals. Animals were spoken into existence by the transcendent God, whereas humans were crafted in a hands-on, personal way by the immanent God. This contradicts the theory that humans evolved from animals. The uniqueness of humans is noted in Genesis 1, because they alone were created in the image of God (Gen. 1:26–27). Genesis 2 adds to this uniqueness by indicating that the process for creating humans was different from that of all other things. This difference is further suggested by the test in the Garden of Eden—a test that humans alone had, because they alone were intelligent beings (animals cannot sin, while humans can and did). Genesis is about beginnings, and chapter 1 presents the order of creation in the beginning, whereas chapter 2 focuses on further evidences of the uniqueness of humans in the beginning, and then chapter 3 is about the beginning of sin in human history. Together they form a logical unfolding of beginnings.

Of Genesis 2 Guy states that "the absence of grass and shrubs is given a natural explanation: the lack of rain and cultivation." But he says that if Genesis 1 is a literal reading, "so that land and vegetation emerged (day 3) only seventy-two hours (more or less) before the creation of humanity (day 6), and if the second representation is also read literally, the result is incoherent."[182] In other words, he says shrubs were present just before humans were created in Genesis 1, but absent due to lack of rain in Genesis 2. By contrast, I believe there is a coherent reason for this difference, which rejects any assumed contradiction.

Old Testament scholar Randall Younker rightly proves linguistically that Genesis 2 is a bridge between perfect paradise (Gen. 1) and the Fall (Gen. 3). There are four facts mentioned in Genesis 2 that are not mentioned in Genesis 1: "(1) the 'shrub of the field,' (2) the 'plant of the field,' (3) 'a man to work the ground,' and (4) 'rain to water the earth.'" All four point to a post-Fall state, and hence are not to be compared with Genesis 1 which is about the pre-Fall state.[183] This means a comparison of the two misses this distinction.

181. Ibid., 92.

182. Ibid., 95.

183. Randall W. Younker, "Genesis 2: A Second Creation Account?" in *Creation, Catastrophe & Calvary: Why a Global Flood Is Vital to the Doctrine of Atonement*, ed. John Templeton Baldwin (Hagerstown, MD:

The stark contrast between Genesis 1 and 2 is seen in the use of different Hebrew words:[184]

Genesis 1:11–12	**Genesis 2:5**
vegetation = *deše'*	shrub of the field = *śîaḥ haśśādeh*
seed-bearing plants = *'ēśeb mazrîa' zera'*	plant of the field = *'ēśeb haśśādeh*
fruit-bearing trees = *'ēṣ pĕrî 'ōśeh pĕrî*	*śîaḥ* = only in 21:15 and Job 30:4, 7 = thorny xerophyte in desert = compare with 3:18, after Fall

1. Note the post-Fall state, with its thorns and thistles, and the food for humans: "It will produce thorns and thistles [*wĕqôṣ wĕdardar*] for you, and you will eat the plants of the field [*'ēśeb haśśādeh*]" (Gen. 3:18).

2. "A man to work the ground": "Cursed is the ground because of you; through painful toil you will eat food from it" (Gen. 3:17). Prior to the Fall, humans were to rule over creation (Gen. 1:26–30), or work the garden (Gen. 2:15).

3. Rain does not come upon the earth until the flood, due to the Fall: "I will send rain" (Gen. 7:4) and "rain fell" (Gen. 7:12).

Yet Guy calls these two creation accounts "representations of the divine creation."[185] This word, "representation," seems to replace *revelation*, because the literalness of divine revelation in Genesis 1–2 is denied. For example, in speaking of Genesis 1:1–2:3, Guy considers these verses to be "composed as the author meditates on the finished work."[186] The verses are considered "a polemic against surrounding religions." Hence Genesis 1 "takes the pattern of six-plus-one days that occurs in the Babylonian compositions *Enuma Elish* and *Epic of Gilgamesh* and in Ugaritic literature, and proceeds to use it in desacralizing the sun, moon, and stars. The God of Genesis is actually the *Creator* of the alleged astral deities." Then he quotes Henri Blocher: "[T]he use of the anthropomorphic figure of the week for the logic of creation and of its completion allowed

Review and Herald, 2000), 69–78.

184. Ibid., 72–77.

185. Guy, "The Purpose and Function of Scripture: Preface to a Theology of Creation," in *Understanding Genesis*, 91.

186. Henri Blocher, *In the Beginning: The Opening Chapters of Genesis* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1984), 50, quoted in Guy, "The Purpose and Function of Scripture: Preface to a Theology of Creation," *Understanding Genesis*, 93.

the author to outline a theology of the Sabbath."[187] This reasoning is contrary to the straightforward reading of the literal presentation of creation week in Genesis 1:1–2:3.

Guy believes the "days" of Genesis 1 "can easily be misinterpreted as literal by a casual, modern reader." He argues that interpretation of Genesis 1 "requires enough respect for the text to listen to it on its own terms as much as we can, even though we live in a very different conceptual world."[188] To follow his suggestion here actually necessitates accepting the literal days of creation, for this is what the text presents. The seventh-day Sabbath presupposes a preceding six days of creation, as Christ wrote with His own hand in the fourth commandment (Exod. 20:8–11; 31:18; 34:28b). The fourth commandment (Exod. 20:8–11) is Christ's commentary on Genesis 1, and there is no greater authority to affirm a literal creation week of seven days, for He was there as the pre-incarnate Creator-Christ (Heb. 1:1–2).

In another chapter of *Understanding Genesis*, Ervin Taylor claims that a "massive body of scientific data points overwhelmingly to an earth that is billions of years old and life forms that have been in existence for hundreds of millions of years. Furthermore, it provides coercive evidence for the presence of humans over at least a hundred thousand years."[189] He rightly states that the "[s]cience-based understanding of the time frames involved in the development of life forms—including humans—is in profound tension with understandings derived from traditional Adventist theological reflection."[190] The last two chapters of *Understanding Genesis* refute a global flood.[191] The final chapter accepts that the author of Genesis knew of other flood stories, and considers the Genesis account "a polemic against the accounts of its neighbors."[192] With respect to the universality of the flood, see chapter 9. With respect to the creation of Adam and Eve, Christ said, "Haven't you read…that at the beginning the Creator 'made them male and female'" (Matt. 19:4; referencing Gen. 1:27). Christ believed in the Genesis creation account as literal, and the Genesis creation account clearly separates the creation of humans in God's image from the creation of animals. God's gift of life to humans and animals was direct; there was no evolutionary process of animals that resulted in humans coming to be.

187. Blocher, *In the Beginning*, 57, quoted in Guy, "The Purpose and Function of Scripture: Preface to a Theology of Creation," *Understanding Genesis*, 94.
188. Guy, "The Purpose and Function of Scripture: Preface to a Theology of Creation," in *Understanding Genesis*, 97.
189. Ervin Taylor, "Time for Mankind: It's Not About Evolution," in *Understanding Genesis*, 142.
190. Ibid., 144.
191. Warren H. Johns, "Theology and Geology of the Flood: Moving beyond Flood Geology," in *Understanding Genesis*, 163; see also Geraty, "Archaeology of the Flood," in *Understanding Genesis*, 191.
192. Lawrence T. Geraty, "Archaeology of the Flood," in *Understanding Genesis*, 191.

Except for Randall Younker, it seems that the authors of *Understanding Genesis* have no higher valuation of Scripture as divine revelation than the scholars studied above. As a result, they give evolutionary ideas priority over the biblical data when it comes to creation, the Fall, and the Flood.

Catholic Integration Thesis

Although theistic evolution cannot explain the origin of humanity, the Jesuit paleontologist Pierre Teilhard de Chardin espoused it, and Augustine of Hippo and Thomas Aquinas believed in progressive creation. The Second Vatican Council (1963–1965) addressed the relation between Scripture and science. It spoke of "the rightful independence of science,"[193] and of "the legitimate autonomy of human culture and especially of the sciences."[194] This is in keeping with the Catholic division between Scripture and Tradition. "Tradition" is written before "sacred revelation" in Vatican Council II documents, suggesting that human "tradition" is given priority over "divine revelation" as is done in Catholic practice."[195] In the same way, it seems to be expected that science takes precedence over Scripture when it comes to evolution.

EVALUATION

Placing tradition above Scripture opens the way for deep-time evolution to replace the biblical six-day creation. It is worth noting, as Richard McBrien does, "Even the highly conservative papacy did not place any of Darwin's books on the Index of Forbidden Books, nor was evolution mentioned in Pius IX's *Syllabus of Errors* (1864). The first reservations were expressed in *The Catholic Encyclopedia* (1909), but on scientific, not theological, grounds. So long as Darwin's theory was not used to explain the nature and origin of the human soul, the theory was regarded as a reasonable, albeit unproven, hypothesis."[196]

The current *Catechism of the Catholic Church* states, "The question about the origins of the world and of man has been the object of many scientific studies which have splendidly enriched knowledge of the age and dimensions of the cosmos, the development of life-forms and the appearance of man." The document gives thanks to God "for the understanding and wisdom he gives to scholars and researchers."[197]

193. *The Documents of Vatican II*, ed. Walter M. Abbott, S.J., trans. ed. Rev. Msgr. Joseph Gallagher (London: Geoffrey Chapman, 1967), 234 (4.3.36).
194. Ibid., 265 (4.2.59).
195. Ibid., 117 (2.2.9).
196. Richard P. McBrien, *Catholicism* (New York: HarperCollins, 1994), 104; cf. 106.
197. *Catechism of the Catholic Church* (Liguori, MO: Liguori Publications, 1994), p. 74.

National Geographic Integration Thesis

The editor of *National Geographic*, William L. Allen, asks, "Was Darwin Wrong?" He states, "Our magazine aims to explore the world, often by highlighting scientific concepts such as evolution. Is this approach necessarily at odds with faith, which lies beyond the possibility of scientific proof? No. Just as religion did not disappear after Galileo demonstrated that the Earth is not at the center of the solar system, evolution does not exclude God from our origins."[198]

EVALUTION

The above citation apparently speaks about those who find no problem with two mutually exclusive views (Supernaturalism and naturalism) being reconciled. We need to more deeply consider what theistic evolutionists seem to be saying. They allow for God's direction of the natural evolving process; yet by accepting the natural evolving process, they seem to accept that natural selection is guiding the process. Either God guides (supernatural worldview) or natural selection guides (natural worldview). This appears to be the foundational fallacy of theistic evolution's attempt to integrate mutually exclusive worldviews.

General Evaluation of Theistic Evolutionists

It seems that theistic evolutionists have been so impressed by the theory of evolution that they have felt the need to make room for it, even at the expense of biblical revelation. Hence, they have not achieved a true reconciliation between the biblical and evolutionary worldviews. Rather, they have given more weight to evolution than to God and His Word. Although not all of them share the same specific beliefs, yet as a group they question the biblical God, the biblical account of creation, the biblical understanding of Christ, the Fall, the plan of salvation, and biblical prophecies. In short, they have sacrificed so much that to call them theistic evolutionists seems inaccurate. They seem rather to be evolutionists burdened by biblical baggage (even though they reject much of the biblical authorial intent).

The root problem of theistic evolution is that it overlooks the worldview of evolution. Darwin did not believe in miracles or in the intervention of God as part of the evolutionary process. Logically his worldview is a closed system—God has been removed from the natural laws of cause and effect. Darwin's theory is a belief in natural selection: nature left to itself, without God, has achieved progressive evolutionary development. Yet anyone accepting biblical

198. William L. Allen, "From the Editor," *National Geographic*, vol. 206, no. 5, November 2004.

creationism believes in the supernatural act of God in creating. Therefore theistic evolution is a logical misnomer. It is like saying that God began the process and yet had no part in the process.

Behind the term *theistic evolution* are two opposing philosophical views and paradigms: Supernaturalism and naturalism. Yet marrying of the two does not explain anything, for one negates the other, and Scripture always suffers. The search for meaning by the scholars discussed above needed to begin with Scripture—discovering what God says about creation, realizing the importance of reverencing Him as the sole Creator, and heeding the urgent need to proclaim this truth about creation in the end-time when evolution is a counterfeit of the genuine.

Theistic Evolutionists with Greater Belief in Scripture

After the examples studied above, investigation here will determine whether any other theistic evolutionists have a greater respect for Scripture. P. P. T. Pun says, "Theistic evolutionists accept the trustworthiness of the Scriptures. They also accept the processes of organic evolution as the ways God used to create humans.... Despite the necessity to dispense with the historicity of the human fall, theistic evolutionists feel the fundamental Christian doctrines of original sin and the human need of redemption are unshaken by the incorporation of organic evolution into the Christian interpretation of life and origins."[199] Millard Erickson adds, "According to this view, God created in a direct fashion at the beginning of the process, and ever since has worked from within through evolution."[200] In other words, He acted transcendently at the beginning but immanently through evolution. Apologist Norman Geisler defines two types of *theistic evolution* as follows:

> The minimal theistic evolutionist believes that God performed two supernatural acts of creation: (1) the creation of matter out of nothing, and (2) the creation of first life. After that every other living thing, including human beings, emerged by natural processes that God had ordained from the beginning.... The maximal theistic evolutionist holds that God performed at least three supernatural acts of creation: matter, first life, and the human soul. After the initial creation of matter and life, all animal organisms, including the human body, evolved by natural laws God established from the very beginning. This is the traditional Roman Catholic view, at least for the last century.[201]

199. P. P. T. Pun. "Evolution/Theistic Evolutionism," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 2nd ed., ed. Walter A. Elwell (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2001), 416.

200. Millard J. Erickson, *Christian Theology*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1998), 409.

201. Geisler, *Baker Encyclopedia of Christian Apologetics*, 233.

There are many theistic evolutionists in a broad spectrum of Evangelical churches. Many Protestants and Catholics believe that God worked through the evolutionary process. It could be argued that some Christians who accept theistic evolution still believe in much of the Bible, recognize God as loving and not as distant, accept the supernatural (to the extent that God is involved), and believe in the power of Christ's creative words in the past, present, and future. There are theologians who accept theistic evolution, and yet they love the Lord and experience the joy of salvation. I respect their right to these conclusions, but am concerned with the consequences of those conclusions.

Theistic evolutionists believe God creates, but they struggle to find a way to understand the evidence of the physical world in relation to God's creation.[202] Ponder William Dembski's view of theistic evolutionists with respect to intelligent design in nature:

> Intelligent design is incompatible with what typically is meant by theistic evolution. Theistic evolution takes the Darwinian picture of the biological world and baptizes it, identifying this picture with the way God created life. When boiled down to its scientific content, however, theistic evolution is no different from atheistic evolution, treating only undirected natural processes in the origin and development of life. Theistic evolution places theism and evolution in an odd tension. If God purposely created life through Darwinian means, then God's purpose was to make it seem as though life was created without purpose.[203]

The words of biologist Jeffrey Schloss also need to be considered: "It is not just that natural selection is claimed to leave no room for a designer but that the competition inherent in natural selection leaves no room for 'goodness' in the emergence and development of life. Thus, even if we allowed that a designer might have used the naturalistic processes posited by Darwinism to create the world, a straightforward inspection of the world reveals that any such designer would have been monumentally wicked."[204]

As mentioned in chapter 2, the phrase "God created" (*bārā'*, Gen. 1:1) involves a significant Hebrew verb, for the verb is only used of God's action, never of any other person.[205] God creates by speaking (Gen. 1:3, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24), and by hands-on acts for Adam and Eve (Gen. 2:7, 21–22), which were instantaneous events respectively. There is no room for the deep-time of

202. Kenneth Wade in personal correspondence with author.

203. William A. Dembski, introduction to *Mere Creation: Science, Faith & Intelligent Design*, ed. William A. Dembski (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1998), 20.

204. Jeffrey P. Schloss, in *Mere Creation*, 237. It should be kept in mind that prominent theistic evolutionists like Ian Barbour, Nancey Murphy, Howard Van Till, Philip Hefner, Robert John Russell, Arthur Peacocke, and John Haught all accept the foundational principles of evolution, such as methodological naturalism, chance, and natural selection. See Phillip E. Johnson, *The Wedge of Truth: Splitting the Foundations of Naturalism* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2000), 89–93.

205. See Wenham, *Genesis 1–15*, vol. 1 in *Word Biblical Commentary*, 14.

evolution in the biblical creation record. The supernatural acts of an omnipotent God are not dependent upon an arduous, aimless, chance process of natural selection. The views are mutually exclusive.

I respect some wonderful Christian theologians who believe it is wise to allow evolutionary thinking to supply what is not explicit in the Genesis account (mainly the *how* of creation). They have a high view of Scripture and believe in God as Creator, but choose to consider evolution as God's chosen method of creation. Yet I hope they will carefully ponder the data given in chapters 1–8 of this volume and consider whether using Scripture as an authoritative guide (which was the traditional view prior to Darwin) is a better approach for those who seek to understand God's creation. Scripture does speak of the *how* of creation. Genesis 1 states that God spoke and it came to be ("let there be...and it was so" in Gen. 1:3, 6, 9, 11, 14–15, 24).

Even now advances in science are calling into question evolutionary theory (the changes from Darwinian to Neo-Darwinian, and now to Meta-Darwinian). Justin Holcomb's words should be kept in mind: "What contemporary theology needs now is not a theological method that one does independent of theology, which begins with, and in the end is a salute to, whatever branch of science is currently reigning."[206]

Intelligent Design advocate Phillip Johnson has said, "If theologians are willing to allow the reality of God to be decided by scientific naturalists according to the rules of methodological atheism, they do not deserve even the modest position in academic life which they presently occupy."[207] He continues with comments regarding "The Governing Discipline" (which he calls theology): "If God is real, however, and if theologians are prepared to assert that reality as a fact rather than a mere subjective reflection, then theology has a very important place in the world of knowledge."[208] This is a call for theologians to advance their own biblical knowledge of creation, and not be overcome by evolutionary naturalism: Stand up for Christ's official commentary on the six literal days of creation in the fourth commandment (Exod. 20:8–11; more on this later). "Allowing the conclusions of

206. Justin S. Holcomb, "Being Bound to God: Participation and Covenant Revisited," in James K. A. Smith and James H. Olthuis, eds., *Radical Orthodoxy and the Reformed Tradition: Creation, Covenant, and Participation* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2005), 254. I concur with this statement, but have reservations about Radical Orthodoxy. See my *Systematic Theology*, vol. 1, 90–92 (published in 2003 before the above book was published); cf. Reformed theology "makes explicit commitment to use biblical language and categories as much as possible, even at the expense of cultural relevance. Inversely, Radical Orthodoxy seeks explicitly to define theology in such a way as to free it from irrelevance in modern thought, and this leads it toward the philosophical and speculative"; Holcomb, "Being Bound to God," 255.

207. Phillip E. Johnson, *Reason in the Balance: The Case Against Naturalism in Science, Law & Education* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1995), 103.

208. Ibid., 105.

modern science to determine our doctrine of creation is essentially a denial of the historic, evangelical doctrine of *sola Scriptura*."[209]

These observations may give pause to theologians who view themselves as theistic evolutionists. A "conflict" between creation and evolution makes it seem as if the issue is about facts, when really it is about "ways of thinking."[210] Theistic evolutionists attempt to think in natural ways when speaking about the supernatural Creator, which results in an unsuccessful venture to join two mutually exclusive worldviews, or ways of thinking.

Evangelicals: Scripture Inerrant or Not?

Other examples of theistic evolutionists could be cited, and some are mentioned in the footnote below;[211] but those explored so far are sufficient to document how Christian scholars articulate their attempts to reconcile what some would say are irreconcilable worldviews. Perhaps the day-age theory, that replaces the six literal days of creation, leads most to see a way to accommodate the deep-time of evolution and still be biblical. But there are questions below which should give pause to those who consider joining this group.

CREATION WEEK QUESTIONED

There are Evangelical theologians who believe in the inerrancy of Scripture yet nevertheless question the literal creation days presented in Genesis 1–2. Empirical evidence from evolutionary science persuades them to do so. Thus Millard Erickson says, "At present, the view which I find most satisfactory is a variation of the age-day theory."[212] Erickson is tentative, which is wise, because ongoing scientific findings can change old scientific theories.

Much of the Christian world no longer recognizes Genesis 1–2 as a literal account of creation. Physicist Howard Van Till asserts, "I would even be so bold as to add that the misunderstanding of the historic doctrine of creation may be as widespread within the Christian community as it is outside of it."[213] Since

209. Andrew S. Kulikovsky, *Creation, Fall, Restoration: A Biblical Theology of Creation* (Ross-Shire, Scotland: Mentor, 2009), 27.

210. Johnson, *Reason in the Balance*, 109.

211. For example, see Peters and Hewlett, *Evolution from Creation to New Creation*, 120–157 for data on B. B. Warfield, Kenneth Miller, Denis Edwards, John Haught, Philip Hefner, and Robert John Russell, among others. Then in the next chapter (158–181), they present the topic "Theistic Evolution: A Constructive Proposal." They state that earthly history is 4.5 billion years, 164. Their thesis explains away Christ's verdict of creation as "very good" (Gen. 1:31): "God creates from the future, not the past. God starts with redemption and then draws all of creation toward it. Or, perhaps better said, God's ongoing creative work is also God's redeeming work. Only a redeemed creation will be worthy of the appellation 'very good,'" 160.

212. Erickson, *Christian Theology*, 407.

213. Van Till, "The Fully Gifted Creation," 161.

Darwin, natural processes are thought to explain the origin of life,[214] and Christian scholars have attempted to accommodate science by interpreting the Genesis record in the light of the current scientific worldview.[215]

A scientist who is also a Christian can say: "I know what the Scriptures say, and as a scientist I understand what we have discovered about nature. These two sources of revelation tell the same story. It is a myth that Christians must, in one way or another, reconcile their religious beliefs with what science has discovered."[216] Yet this is precisely what many Christians are attempting to do, for evolution has made remarkable inroads into Evangelical theology by calling into question the historicity of the Genesis account of creation. Paul K. Jewett notes that "few who confess the Christian doctrine of creation would suppose that the world was fashioned in a week of time some six to ten thousand years ago. Drafts of time of a vastly different magnitude are indicated by the findings of the natural sciences."[217] Theology has accommodated science by interpreting the Genesis record in the light of the current scientific worldview.[218]

In a time when science holds such preeminence, it is important that hard science, which accepts only the demonstrable, be distinguished from soft science, in which metaphysical assumptions abound. In reality, macroevolution is an assumption that can never be demonstrated, and so can never be verified or falsified. It seems disingenuous for evolutionists to reject supernatural causation because it cannot be proved, and then present natural selection as the cause for evolution which cannot be proven throughout deep-time.

ORIGIN OF DEATH QUESTIONED

Some Evangelical theologians believe that death existed before the human race prior to the Fall,[219] which raises questions about whether death is sin's wages,

214. In *The Origin of Species*, Darwin opposed the view that each species has been independently created (69) and that there is an "immutability of species" (317), and presented "the theory of descent with modification through natural selection" (435).

215. Evolution calls the Genesis creation account into question. Therefore, many theologians consider Genesis to be pre-scientific and thus have little interest in the process of creation which science allegedly provides. For example, Augustus Hopkins Strong stated, "Evolution does not make the idea of a Creator superfluous, because evolution is only the method of God," *Systematic Theology* (Philadelphia, PA: Judson, 1907), 465–466.

216. Cornelius G. Hunter, *Darwin's Proof: The Triumph of Religion over Science* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos, 2003), 13.

217. Paul K. Jewett, *God, Creation, and Revelation: A Neo-Evangelical Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI; Eerdmans, 1991), 479–480.

218. Some scholars who, in varying degrees, place evolutionary theory as the context in which to interpret the Genesis account include: Augustus Hopkins Strong, *Systematic Theology*, 465–466; Bernard Ramm, *The Christian View of Science and Scripture* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1954), 76–79; Langdon Brown Gilkey, *Maker of Heaven and Earth* (Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1965); Millard J. Erickson, *Christian Theology*, 381–382; and Paul K. Jewett, *God, Creation, and Revelation*, 378–484.

219. Marco T. Terreros, "Death Before the Sin of Adam: A Fundamental Concept in Theistic Evolution and Its Implications for Evangelical Theology" (PhD diss., Andrews University Theological Seminary, 1994).

and hence undermines the atonement. According to evolutionary theory, death is something natural and not a result of human sin. Karl Barth claims that death is a part of being finite. God has no beginning or end, but in contrast humans have a beginning and an end. Therefore, death is a part of being human.[220] Catholic theologian Richard McBrien of Notre Dame also believes death could have been a part of God's original creation.[221] Wayne Grudem says, "From the information we have in Scripture, we cannot now know whether God created animals subject to aging and death from the beginning, but it remains a real possibility."[222] However, the idea that Christ could have created animals to die seems to suggest that death was a part of His good creation, whereas Scripture speaks of death as the wages of sin (Rom. 6:23).

PLAN OF SALVATION QUESTIONED

Questioning the historical reality of the Genesis creation account logically questions subsequent acts of God in history. Thus the entire biblical story as history can be undermined by rejecting the historicity of Genesis 1–2, just as it was for Rudolf Bultmann, who after dubbing biblical cosmology as "pre-scientific," came to all sorts of other non-biblical conclusions.[223] Theistic evolution assumes that God uses evolution to arrive at the creation of humans, who are still in process, and some forms of evolutionary theory go so far as to say humans will evolve further to eventually become God. A similar falsehood was suggested to Eve in Genesis 3:1–6.[224] If humans are the result of a progress within natural evolutionary development, then there is no place for their Fall or death through sin, and

See *Andrews University Seminary Studies* 32, No. 1–2 (Spring-Summer 1994): 114.

220. Karl Barth, *Doctrine of Creation*, vol. 3, pt. 2, in *Church Dogmatics*, 511–640.

221. McBrien, *Catholicism*, 190.

222. Wayne Grudem, *Systematic Theology: An Introduction to Biblical Doctrine* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan; Leicester, England: InterVarsity, 1994), 293.

223. D. Rudolf Bultmann, "New Testament and Mythology" in *Kerygma and Myth: A Theological Debate*, ed. Hans Werner Bartsch, trans. Reginald H. Fuller (London: S.P.C.K, 1964, 1st ed. 1953), 1–4. He jettisoned the supernaturalistic worldview for a naturalistic worldview, and this called into question all God's supernaturalistic acts in history. For example, he said, "No one who is old enough to think for himself supposes that God lives in a local heaven. There is no longer any heaven in the traditional sense of the word...We can no longer look for the return of the Son of Man on the clouds of heaven or hope that the faithful will meet him in the air (1 Thess. 4:15ff.).... Even if we believe that the world as we know it will come to an end in time, we expect the end to take the form of a natural catastrophe, not of a mythical event such as the New Testament expects," Bultmann, *Kerygma and Myth*, 4–5. See also The Gifford Lectures Bultmann delivered at the University of Edinburgh in 1955, in which eschatology is the coming of the Holy Spirit in repeated encounters with human existence replacing a final cosmic coming of Christ. This is the extent of the reinterpretation and reductionism of Bultmann's existential hermeneutic. See Rudolf Bultmann, *History and Eschatology* (Edinburgh: The University Press, 1957).

224. See the "New Age Movement" in Gulley, *Christ Is Coming!*, chap. 13. If God allegedly held Eve back from becoming like God, then eating the forbidden fruit was an alleged natural process to achieve this end. So Satan not only caused Eve to doubt God's Word, His love, and His wisdom, but suggested a natural process to achieve this goal apart from Him. This is the whole thrust of naturalism. Evolution is atheistic, and it is illogical to consider it theistic.

there is no need for God's law, divine revelation in Scripture, salvation through Christ, the new creation work of the Holy Spirit, Christ's present intercession, the second coming, or final judgment.

If God did not create in a supernatural way in Genesis, this calls into question His promised future supernatural act to raise the dead and create a new heavens and a new earth. God spoke a number of things into existence in creation (Gen. 1:3, 6, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24, 26; Ps. 33:6, 9; 148:5), and He has promised that one day He will call the dead forth from the graves (John 5:25). If the concept of God's supernatural words is rejected, then the Word of God in Scripture is rejected, and Scripture becomes a natural collection of human sources. This idea appeals to many scholars, because it means that their ideas are just as important as those of the biblical authors.

BIBLICAL GOD QUESTIONED

If we judge God by the account in Scripture,[225] why would He choose a long, painful process? Why would an omniscient God need so much trial and error along the way? Why would the God who states that "everything should be done in a fitting and orderly way" (1 Cor. 14:40) do the opposite in the tortuous process of deep-time? Why would the God who opposes salvation by works (Eph. 2:9) use the survival-through-struggle method?[226] Del Ratzsch does a good job articulating this point:

> Evolution is fueled by predation and death. Evolution is prodigiously wasteful. Billions of creatures die waiting for some key mutation that may or may not emerge. Whole species, whole kinds, are done to death—roadkill on the evolutionary highway. Evolution is grossly inefficient. It works only by accident, by chance, and even if it works, it takes zillions of years to get anywhere. Would God as we know him from Scripture be expected to choose such a hit-or-miss method and call the resultant suffering, death, failure and extinction *good*?[227]

The evolutionary picture of God makes Him look like He does not know what He is doing. It conjures up the picture of an experimenter who tries many times, rejects the failures, and tries again.

225. Considering the nature of God is crucial when evaluating any quest to reconcile the two worldviews. Lesser reasons need to be judged by this primary standard. Given that the biblical worldview is the cosmic controversy worldview, in which Satan seeks to distort the truth about God (Ezek. 28:16a; Heb. *rēkūllâ* has a wide semantic range including "to gossip"; see context, vv. 12–18), would he not distort the truth about God as Creator, who created out of nothing (Heb. 11:3)? From a biblical perspective, it appears that the evolutionary worldview, positing a natural beginning out of something, is contrary to the biblical creation worldview—God creating out of nothing.

226. See Henry M. Morris and John D. Morris, *The Modern Creation Trilogy: Scripture and Creation* (Green Forrest, AR: Master Books, 1996), 40.

227. Del Ratzsch, *Battle of Beginnings: Why Neither Side Is Winning the Creation-Evolution Debate* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1996), 189.

Colin Gunton of King's College, University of London, was right to say that "the general characteristics of God's eternal being, as persons in relation, communion, may be known from what he has done and does in the actions that we call the economy of creation and salvation."[228] The biblical doctrines of creation and salvation reveal the love of God (1 John 4:8–16). If God depended on evolution to create, His sovereignty would be called into question (Dan. 4:25). If God used a method that required death to create humans, His resurrection and life would be called into question (John 11:25). If God used a process of predation and carnage, His love is called into question (1 John 4:8–16).

Judged by Scripture, why would God use the strong to oppress the weak, when in the Flood He punished the strong for oppressing the weak? (Gen. 6:11, 13 speaks of violence [*ḥāmās*] "which is virtually a technical term for oppression of the weak by the strong.")[229] If struggle enables survival, why will the meek "inherit the earth" (Matt. 5:5)? Why would the God who re-creates the damaged image in humans need to create humans in the first place in a less supernatural way? If God chose to create through the natural evolutionary process, in which the horrors of torture and death over millions of years were necessary to create humans, His would be the longest and cruelest holocaust imaginable. Why would He use such unjust carnage to create when justice is the foundation of His throne (Ps. 89:14)? How is such a model possible in view of His divine providence in history (Rom. 8:28–30; 11:36)? Why would God use death to create humans in His image (Gen. 1:26–27), which is love? If He used death to create, then why did He warn Adam of the evil of death (Gen. 2:17) and expose the depths of that evil by dying to save humans from the penalty of death (John 3:16; Rom. 6:23)? If death is the "last enemy to be destroyed" at the end of the cosmic controversy (1 Cor. 15:26), then how could God use it to create before the beginning of the controversy on planet earth? If there is no predation in the creation of the new earth, where the wolf and the lamb live together (Isa. 11:6–9), why would God produce and use predation to create the present earth?

George Bugg asks the right question: "I will not ask where is the *wisdom*, but where is the 'benevolence', not to say *justice* of all this? Not a creature capable of *offending* its Creator! Nevertheless we find 'whole genera' and whole nations of animals perishing in succession; and this numerous times repeated, as if their Author...were in sport, forming and destroying worlds again and again!"[230]

228. Colin E. Gunton, *The One, The Three and the Many: God, Creation and the Culture of Modernity, The 1992 Bampton Lectures* (Cambridge, England: Cambridge University Press, 1993), 230.

229. David J. A. Clines, "Noah's Flood 1: The Theology of the Flood Narrative," in *Faith and Thought*, 100/2 (1972–1973): 133.

230. George Bugg, *Scriptural Geology* (London: Hatchard and Son and L. B. Sealey and Son, 1827), 2:44, emphasis in original.

Physicist Alan Hayward wonders, "[W]hy should God spend all that time creating all sorts of wonderful living things, and then allow them to die out and be replaced by other species?"[231] Fredrick Nolan, in the Oxford Bampton Lectures of 1833, said:

> During the immensity of time in which, we are assured, this development of nature proceeded, the earth is represented as wholly abandoned to creatures...monsters of the most hideous forms and ferocious natures. If the notion of a Creator be admitted into this scheme, the moral incongruities...are...gross...he is represented as improving upon his first essays; as destroying in succession his earliest and rudest works, to exercise his skill in the production of others, more worthy of his contrivance.[232]

In 1991, David Hull of Northwestern University evaluated the evolutionary process as "rife with happenstance, contingency, incredible waste, death, pain and horror.... The God implied by evolutionary theory and the data of natural history...is not a loving God who cares about His productions. He is...careless, indifferent, almost diabolical. He is certainly not the sort of God to whom anyone would be inclined to pray."[233] Agnostics and atheists will say the same about plagues and famines, but we are not comparing apples with apples. The first is about God's methods for creating; the latter is about God's methods of punishment.

One must look at all biblical truths in the light of the greatest revelation: the God-Man at Calvary. The revelation at Calvary was made in history. It had witnesses. As such it provides empirical (historical) evidence of how loving God is, even to the point of asking His Father to forgive those who heaped cruelty upon Him (Luke 23:34). Assuming that this same Creator-Christ (Heb. 1:1–2) heaped cruelty on animals, not for part of a day but for billions of years, is not a historical datum but a metaphysical assumption that Calvary can rightly question. Calvary was a holocaust that others brought upon Christ, but the pain and death of animals for millennia would be a holocaust that He brought upon the animal kingdom, which is incompatible with Christ's love at Calvary.

The fact that the creatures of the universe shouted for joy at the creation of this world (Job 38:4–7) is inexplicable if Christ had created through causing animal suffering for billions of years. Christ called creation "very good" (Gen. 1:31) and that's worth singing about, but who could call the tortuous process of evolution "very good"? After Christ's ascension, beings in heaven worshiped God the Father as worthy and deserving of glory because He created all things (Rev. 4:10–11). That would be impossible if He created through the use of the

231. Alan Hayward, *Creation and Evolution: Rethinking the Evidence from Science and the Bible* (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock, 1985), 4.

232. Fredrick Nolan, *The Analogy of Revelation and Science* (London: Oxford, 1833), 130–131.

233. David Hull, "The God of Galapagos," *Nature* 352 (1991): 486.

cruel, tortuous processes required by evolution. Christ's warning to Adam about the tree of knowledge of good and evil—stating that eating its fruit would bring death (Gen. 2:17)—indicates that death was not yet a present reality. Here evil and death are associated with disobedience to the Creator. Such disobedience would bring a curse on nature as well as on Adam and Eve (Gen. 3:17–19). When Christ re-creates the earth, the curse will be no more (Rev. 22:3). Clearly curses and death are linked to disobedience; they have nothing to do with Christ's method of creation. If the new earth will have no curse, the curses came through the Fall, and the first creation was "very good" (Gen. 1:31), it is logical to assume that the first creation involved no curses, death, or destruction. That is why Scripture speaks of death as the wages for sin (Rom. 6:23) and an enemy (1 Cor. 15:26)—never as God's chosen method to create.

Scripture says that "sin entered the world through one man" (Rom. 5:12). It was Adam and not His Creator who brought death to this planet. It was Christ who came to die and liberate our fallen race (Rom. 4:25). It was the one act of the first Adam that caused this death and condemnation, and the one act of the second Adam's death provided salvation (Rom. 5:18). Christ did not use death to create humans in Eden, but He did die to save humans at Calvary. Given a cosmic controversy in which Satan, who hates Christ, has engaged in a process of disinformation about God (Heb. *rĕkūllâ* of Ezek. 28:15–16)[234] since the inception of his rebellion, it makes sense that a natural method of creation through horror is something he would promote, for it effectively destroys the drawing power of Calvary. Satan hates the cross because it reveals what God is really like and what he (Satan) is really like. Creation through violence is compatible with Satan's hatred of Christ at the cross, but certainly not compatible with a loving Creator-Redeemer who dies for others (rather than inflicting death). Life through death is a biblical concept of atonement, not a biblical concept of creation.

Christ created "every green plant for food" for animals (Gen. 1:30). Apparently animals were not created as predators, and nor will they be predators in the new earth (Isa. 65:25) as no death or pain will be there either (Rev. 21:4). Predation is a post-Fall phenomenon, and should not be read back into the creative process. As a God of love (John 4:7–16), God created in love. He sees the sparrow fall (Luke 12:6–7), feeds the ravens (Luke 12:24), and was concerned about the "many cattle" in Nineveh if it were destroyed (John 4:11). These instances are all evidence that He would not cause animal suffering in any evolutionary plan of creation. We can see now how essential it is to allow

234. The Hebrew word *rĕkūllâ* means "trading" or "peddling," referring to goods or gossip. In this context Satan spreads gossip about God. See Richard M. Davidson, "Cosmic Metanarrative for the Coming Millennium," *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, vol. 11, no. 1–2 (2000): 108.

Scripture to interpret Scripture (*sola-tota-prima Scriptura*), rather than allow a nonbiblical idea (naturalism) to have that function.

Because God created the God-Man through a supernatural act of creation, there is no question that He had the ability to create the first Adam, for the latter is an infinitely easier act of creation. To suggest that God was dependent upon a natural process of evolution to create all things on planet earth is to diminish God, just as much as the Process and Openness views of God diminish Him. To say God is dependent upon the world for His body (Process) or for His knowledge of the future (Process and Openness) is no different in kind from saying that He was dependent upon evolution to create. This is a point we repeat because it apparently has not been grasped by many Evangelicals.

We need to read the Genesis creation account in light of God's creation of the humanity of the God-Man (John 1:1, 14; Matt. 1:20), the creation of the first Adam in light of the incarnation of the second Adam (1 Cor. 15:45; cf. Rom. 5:18–19), for here we find a type/antitype gift of love which is fully compatible with God's gift of love at Calvary (John 3:16). Here is the biblical God of love and not the God of theistic evolution. Here is "Immanuel…God with us" (Matt. 1:23)—our Creator-Redeemer, rather than a distant and disinterested God of methodological naturalism.

CHRIST'S SPOKEN WORD QUESTIONED

Christ "is the image of the invisible God…in him all things were created: things in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or powers or rulers or authorities; all things have been created through him and for him" (Col. 1:15–16). God made the universe through Christ (Heb. 1:2b; cf. Rev. 4–5). The question is, Did Christ depend upon the natural process of evolution to create, or did He, as the omnipotent God, create without dependence on anything outside Himself?

Genesis 1 indicates how Christ created the world and all things in it. He spoke things into existence. As mentioned before, in all but one of those days the words "God said" (Gen. 1:3, 6, 9, 11, 14–15, 24) are followed by "and it was so," proclaiming the power of His commands. The supernatural power of Christ's creative word is demonstrated by the speed at which His commands were fulfilled, for the creation days were literal, continuous, contiguous, twenty-four-hour periods of time (the Hebrew word for day *yôm* when used with ordinals is always a literal day).[235] When the word *day* in Hebrew

235. Context decides the meaning of the Hebrew word for "day" (*yôm*). For example: (1) "This is the account of the heavens and the earth when they were created" (Gen. 2:4). The word "when" in Hebrew is *yôm*, meaning in the day they were created. Day = six days. (2) "A flood will carry off his house, rushing waters on

is used with a specific number (Gen. 8:14; 17:12), it refers to a twenty-four-hour day (except in Zech. 14:7).[236] Christ's commands had instant response. That is why He could say each day that the new created reality was "good" (Gen. 1:4, 10, 12, 18, 21, 25). That is why Scripture presents creation as one of the mighty acts of God. "For he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm" (Ps. 33:9), for "[b]y faith we understand that the universe was formed at God's command, so that what is seen was not made out of what was visible" (Heb. 11:3).

Throughout His life on earth, Christ manifested the power of His creative words and works. His first creative miracle changed water into wine, in obedience to His words "Fill the jars with water" (John 2:7–11). To someone who had been an invalid for thirty-eight years, Christ said, "Get up! Pick up your mat and walk," and he was instantly healed (John 5:1–15). Christ fed five thousand men, as well as women and children, through a creative miracle using "five small barley loaves and two small fish" (John 6:5–14). Christ's creative power gave sight to one born blind (John 9:1–7). Christ called Himself "the resurrection and the life" (John 11:25), and resurrections are the ultimate evidence of His creative power.

Christ raised Lazarus who had been dead four days. Jesus addressed the onlookers, "'Did I not tell you that if you believe, you would see the glory of God?' So they took away the stone. Then Jesus looked up and said, 'Father, I thank you that you have heard me. I knew that you always hear me, but I said this for the benefit of the people standing here, that they may believe that you sent me.' When he had said this, Jesus called in a loud voice, 'Lazarus, come out!' The dead man came out" (John 11:40–44a).

Looking to the future, Jesus spoke about His creative power: "Do not be amazed at this, for a time is coming when all who are in their graves will hear his voice and come out—those who have done what is good will rise to live, and those who have done what is evil will rise to be condemned" (John 5:28–29). Christ says of believers, "I will raise them up at the last day" (John 6:54). So one day all dead humans will hear the creative voice of Christ and will rise from their graves, so billions will be instantaneously raised by His creative word just

the day of God's wrath" (Job 20:28). Day = period of God's wrath (also; "Like the coolness of snow at harvest time," Prov. 25:13. Time = period of time). (3) In creation week the six days are designated within the time of an evening and a morning (Gen. 1:5, 8, 13, 19, 23, 31), and the seventh day (Gen. 2:2–3), and the Sabbath is the seventh day after six creation days in the fourth commandment (Exod. 20:8–11). The reason for the specificity of "literal, continuous, contiguous, twenty-four-hour periods of time" is because evolutionists look at the six creation days as day-ages, separated by a vast amount of time. The day-ages theory is popular among many Christian churches.

236. Terence E. Fretheim, *The Genesis Debate: Persistent Questions About Creation and the Flood*, ed. Ronald Youngblood (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1990), 18.

as Adam and Eve received life from His creative work. It is the same Christ who does both through His supernatural power.[237] He was no more dependent upon natural means in creation than He will be dependent on natural means in these final resurrections.

Christ demonstrated His power as Creator through these creative acts during His life on earth.[238] They give demonstration in human history of His creative power in the beginning. To accept His creative power during His life on earth necessitates accepting His creative power in the Genesis record, for both are equally supernatural, and both are given to us through divine revelation. The reason Christ's spoken word is so important in creation is because God's word is so important throughout Scripture. It is the revelation of that word which is supernatural, and hence inspired, and gives us God's supernatural worldview (which is contrary to the worldview of naturalism).

CHRIST'S SABBATH QUESTIONED

In Scripture the Sabbath is a celebration of the finished works of Christ in creation (Gen. 2:1–3; Exod. 20:8–11); in the Red Sea deliverance (Deut. 5:15); and on crucifixion Friday (John 19:30). Christ created Adam on creation Friday, and on crucifixion Friday He became the second Adam for the world in His death (Luke 23:44–24:6). Crucifixion Friday, like creation Friday, was a beginning for the race. The Sabbath celebrates (1) Christ's finished creation for Adam and Eve, (2) Christ's finished deliverance for a nation, and (3) Christ's finished sacrifice for a world. The first finished work of Christ is as literal as the other two finished works. Christ was no more dependent on an evolutionary process than He was dependent on any natural process in these miracles. This is an essential fact overlooked by theistic evolutionists.

Prior to Darwin there was general agreement that the creation days were literal.[239] Some even referred to creation days as literal because of a literal Sabbath,[240]

237. We are nor considering here the Millennium between the resurrection of the good and the resurrection of the evil (see Rev. 20).

238. In Genesis Christ created as God, for God worked through Him to create (Heb. 1:1–3). Having laid aside the use of His divinity in His incarnation (Phil. 2:5–11), Christ depended upon His Father to do creative acts (John 10:25, 32, 38; 14:10). As Son of God, He was dependent throughout His human life, but in choosing to die and in His resurrection His divinity operated again. As He chose to become human (Heb. 10:5–7), so He chose to lay down His life and to take it up again (John 10:17–18).

239. For example, John Calvin, *Genesis*, vol. 1 in *Calvin's Commentaries*, trans. John King (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1989), 92; John Brown, *The Systematic Theology of John Brown of Haddington* (Ross-Shire, Scotland: Christian Focus, 2002), 170; Heinrich Heppe, *Reformed Dogmatics*, ed. Ernst Bizer, trans. G. T. Thomson (London: Wakeman Trust, 1950, 1st ed. 1861), 199.

240. For example, Francis Turretin, *Institutes of Elenctic Theology*, vol. 1, trans. George Musgrave Giger, ed. James T. Dennison, Jr. (Phillipsburg, PA: Presbyterian and Reformed, 1992), 444–452; and Louis Berkhof, *Systematic Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1996), 155.

or referred to the Sabbath in creation week.[241] In denying the literal days of creation, and so denying a literal creation week, theistic evolutionists remove the God-given foundation for the seventh-day Sabbath, which the Creator Christ gave to the human race long before Israel entered history (Gen. 2:1–3; Mark 2:27). In other words, questioning God's word about creation (Gen. 1–2) leads to questioning God's holy day, which questions Christ's authoritative commentary on the creation account: It took place in six days, climaxed by the Sabbath that Christ wants us to "remember" (Exod. 20:8–11).

But by embracing theistic evolution, Evangelicals, who love Christ, unwittingly end up criticizing Christ, not only Moses. Wayne Grudem asks, "[I]f God did not create the earth by working for six days and resting on the seventh, then the command to imitate him would be misleading or make no sense."[242]

THEISTIC EVOLUTION QUESTIONED

Owen Gingerich, of the Harvard Smithsonian Center for Astrophysics, says in the foreword to *Not Just Science* that the book will "help delineate the areas of intersection [of science-religion] and provide a basis for integration. It includes a discussion of topics, such as the age of the earth, where the advancing frontiers of scientific knowledge suggest that a strictly literal interpretation of biblical texts is no longer appropriate."[243] Astronomer Jennifer Wiseman refers to Christians throughout history who have questioned the literal days of creation, noting that Scripture answers the "who" and the "why" questions of creation, and science answers the "how" questions.[244] Yet, as mentioned before, the "how" of creation is imbedded in the Genesis creation account (Gen. 1:3, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24, 26; Ps. 33:6–9), not being dependent upon pre-existing matter (Heb. 1:1–3).

In the same book, Larry Funk, professor of chemistry, rightly notes that believers espouse either young earth creationism or evolutionary creationism, depending on which method of creation (instantaneous or process) they believe God used. He adds, "Current origin of life science is riddled with widespread uncertainty. There are vast spaces of untouched territory involving difficult and often fundamental, unanswered questions."[245] He seems to leave open which method God used. There is need for humility as we attempt to understand the

241. For example, Martin Luther, *Luther's Works*, vol. 1, ed. Jaroslav Pelikan (St. Louis: Concordia, 1958), 80; see also 3–82.

242. Grudem, *Systematic Theology*, 304.

243. Owen Gingerich, foreword to *Not Just Science: Questions Where Christian Faith and Natural Science Intersect*, ed. Dorothy F. Chappell and E. David Cook (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2005), 14.

244. Jennifer Wiseman, cited in *Not Just Science*, 104.

245. Larry L. Funk, cited in *Not Just Science*, 221.

origin of life. Isn't humble acceptance of Genesis 1–2 a good place to begin, for it is God's certain Word?

Integration of science and Scripture needs to consider that the worldviews (or paradigms) of science are changing, as Thomas Kuhn so persuasively documents,[246] whereas the biblical worldview remains unchanged. Alister McGrath rightly observes, "Scientific theories change over time for two main reasons. First, new discoveries are made, which means existing ways of thinking have to be re-evaluated. Second, a new theory is developed which makes better sense of the observational evidence than existing theories."[247] Geologist Nigel Brush rightly out that "The primary obstacle harmonizing religious truth with scientific truth is that scientific truth is constantly changing."[248] By contrast, God never changes (Mal. 3:6) and "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8).This fact should be pondered by Evangelical theologians who believe in Scripture as inerrant revelation, and yet fail to trust in the Genesis account, choosing rather to trust in changeable scientific theories.

Supernaturalism and naturalism are two mutually exclusive worldviews. Atheistic evolution is a closed worldview, for it is confined to the natural workings within this closed world; God has been locked out. By contrast, Supernaturalism holds that God created the world. One cannot espouse both worldviews, for either the world is closed to God (naturalism) or open to God (Supernaturalism). So theoretically God cannot act in creation in a world that is closed to Him. Theologians who think God does act through evolution do not impress atheistic scientists.

God is the Author of two books, Scripture and nature, but only Scripture is inspired. At best nature gives a qualified revelation of God, for sin has caused that revelation to be tarnished with struggle and death, both results of the cosmic controversy that introduced sin and death into this world (Gen. 3). Scripture tells us, "We know that the whole creation has been groaning as in the pains of childbirth right up to the present time" (Rom. 8:22), and creation waits for the relief that will come when humans are redeemed (v. 23). God never intended humans to judge His inspired Scripture by nature. Rather, Scripture is God's revelation that must judge human ideas about nature. Doubting God's Word was the entry point for sin and all the subsequent woes that now dominate the world (Gen. 3:1–6).

Wolfhart Pannenberg has understood the issue and what is at stake: "The theologian must not be too quick to adapt theological ideas and language to the

246. Thomas S. Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, vol. 2, no. 2, *International Encyclopedia of Unified Science* (Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press, 1970).

247. McGrath, *Surprised by Meaning*, 17.

248. Nigel Brush, *The Limitations of Scientific Truth: Why Science Can't Answer Life's Ultimate Questions* (Grand Rapids, MI: Kregel, 2005), 51.

latest outlook in the sciences, especially where such adaptation requires substantial readjustment of traditional doctrine. The theological vision of the world can also function as a challenge to science and as a source of inspiration in developing new strategies of research."[249] And that biblical advantage must never be forgotten, but used. In commenting on theistic evolution, theologian James Oliver Buswell said:

> There are devout Christians who hold that the process by which man was created was biological and genetic, in other words that man's physical being was produced by evolution. A form of this theory, I well remember, appealed to me many years ago in my undergraduate days in the university. I devoutly believed in the inerrancy of the Bible, but I thought the Bible record could be harmonized with the idea that Adam was produced by a mutation, and that he was constituted as man in the image of God by a special supernatural act. I did not question the special creation of Eve. I argued that the mutation by which Adam's physical nature might have been produced would have been so great that he could not have mated with any of the stock from which his body was derived. I even went so far as to note that a gorilla's skeleton which hung in our biology lecture room at Minnesota had thirteen ribs whereas man ordinarily has only twelve![250]

Then he proceeded to tell why he changed his mind: (1) Mendelism (science of genetics) seems to corroborate the Genesis "after their kind" confinement of species (although this is a creationist legend—not a biblical teaching). (2) "The natural processes, except where personal intelligence intervenes, tend toward the simple and homogenous rather than toward what we call higher forms of life." (3) "As for the Darwinian theory of the survival of the fittest, it has often been said that Darwinism does not explain the *arrival* of the fit. There is nothing in naturalistic processes to account for man as we now observe him."[251]

That was in 1962. Since then much more has been discovered that calls evolution into question (see chapters 6–8). Evangelical theologians who have a high view of Scripture need to allow Scripture to test evolutionary theory, not vice versa. Scripture is God's self-revelation and presents Him as a supernatural Creator, creating in a way that is compatible with His nature and attributes. Some scientists believe the universe is fine-tuned, which they call the Anthropic Cosmological principle. "Roger Penrose, professor of mathematics at Oxford University and Wolf Prize winner for his analytic descriptions of the Big Bang, finds the laws of nature so fine-tuned for life that an intelligent 'Creator' must

249. Wolfhart Pannenberg, "Theology and Philosophy in Interaction with Science: A Response to the Message of Pope John Paul II on the Occasion of the Newtonian Tricentennial in 1987," in Robert J. Russell, William R. Stoger, S.J., and George V. Coyne, eds., *John Paul II on Science and Religion: Reflections on the New View from Rome* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1990), 78.

250. James Oliver Buswell, *A Systematic Theology of the Christian Religion*, vol. 1 (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1962), 323.

251. Ibid.

have chosen them."[252] However, Del Ratzsch, who specializes in philosophy of science at Calvin College, observes that "with most compromise positions…theistic evolution takes flak from both flanks—in this case, both from creationists and from evolutionists who are unbelievers."[253]

So theistic evolutionists, attempting to reconcile mutually exclusive worldviews, may want to pause and note that in 1981, the National Academy of Science declared, "religion and science are separate and mutually exclusive realms of human thought whose presentation in the same context leads to misunderstanding of both scientific theory and religious belief."[254]

Limits of Science

Sir Peter Medawar, who won the Nobel Prize (with Sir Macfarlane Burnett) in 1960 for his work on tissue transplantation, wrote the book *The Limits of Science* (2000). His concern is that science recognize its limitations:

> The existence of a limit to science is, however, made clear by its inability to answer childlike elementary questions having to do with first and last things—questions such as "How did everything begin?" "What are we all here for?" "What is the point of living?" Doctrinaire positivism [for definition see logical positivism, volume 1 of this system, pp. 60–66] dismisses all such questions as nonquestions or pseudoquestions—hardly an adequate rebuttal because the questions make sense to those who ask them, and the answers to those who try to give them. This essay tries to explain why science cannot answer these ultimate questions and why no conceivable advance of science could empower it to do so.[255]

So science cannot answer questions outside its competence, but there is no limit to the questions that science can answer within its competence.[256] Therefore, Medawar is right to oppose those who criticize science for its inability to answer matters beyond its competence. He described this graphically. "To reproach it [science] for its inability to answer all questions we should like to put to it is no more sensible than to reproach a railway locomotive

252. Bruce K. Walke with Charles Yu, *An Old Testament Theology: An Exegetical, Canonical, and Thematic Approach* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2007), 175. Cf. John D. Barrow and Frank J. Tipler, *The Anthropic Cosmological Principle* (Great Clarendon Street, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009). John A. Wheeler, Center for Theoretical Physics, University of Texas at Austin, in the Foreword writes: "The universe is adapted to man. Imagine a universe in which one or another of the fundamental dimensionless constants of physics is altered by a few percents one way or the other? Man could never come into being in such a universe. That is the central point of the anthropic principle. According to the principle, a life-giving factor lies at the center of the whole machinery and design of the world." Ibid., vii. How could the universe be adapted for the arrival of humanity through the chance of evolutionary theory? The perfect precision required for that adaptation is understood when an intelligent Creator made it so.

253. Del Ratzsch, *The Battle of Beginnings*, 10.

254. Alister E. McGrath, *Science and Religion*, Second Edition, 47.

255. Peter Medawar, *The Limits of Science* (Oxford, England: Oxford University Press, 1984), 59.

256. Ibid., 86–87.

for not flying or, in general, not performing any other operation for which it was not designed."[257]

Evaluation

Medawar presents a balanced view of limitations, where competence is the key: when incompetent there is limitation, where competent there is no limitation (within reason). Medawar says much more about this topic, but this will suffice for our purpose. This matter of competence works both ways. Scripture is incompetent to describe the intricacies of science. Scripture is a different sphere of study and has its own rules and language as does the various sciences each within their own expertise. Language games are involved in this discussion, for the rules of soccer are different from the rules of cricket, baseball, or basketball. They are all games, but operate within their own frame of reference. The rules of different scientific disciplines are well applied in their unique domains, but none of them can enter the supernatural domain of Scripture and still claim to be science. Naturalism, at home in science, is not at home in the supernatural revelation of Scripture. Just as different games respect the different rules in other games, so science and Scripture need to respect the different rules that are unique to them.

Scripture does not stray onto any scientific turf attempting to make scientific statements. Likewise, all sciences are incompetent to stray into the realm of Scripture and legislate on its unique contribution to creation knowledge. While science and Scripture work within their competencies, they should respect the unique contribution that each attempts to make, whether they agree with the other or not. Both science and Scripture are valid academic disciplines. The different worldviews of science (naturalism) and Scripture (Supernaturalism) are mutually exclusive, with neither competent to operate in the other. When science or Scripture stray into the domain of the other, they cease to be true to their own discipline. Below we cite two examples.

First, when science gets into metaphysics and becomes philosophical, it is no longer science. As Alister McGrath rightly assesses, metaphysical questions are not the same as empirical questions.[258] Richard Dawkins (b. 1941), an Atheistic scientist, is a good example of a scientist straying into metaphysics. In the name of science he dismissed the existence of God. For example, he said:

> Natural selection, the blind, unconscious, automatic process which Darwin discovered, and which we now know is the explanation for the existence and apparently purposeful form of all life, has no purpose in mind. It has no mind and no mind's eye. It does not plan for the future. It has no vision, no foresight, no sight at all. If it can be said to play the role of watchmaker in nature, it is the *blind* watchmaker.[259]

257. Ibid., xiii.

258. McGrath, *Surprised by Meaning*, 4.

This view opposed William Paley's (1743–1805) thesis that as an intricate watch presupposes a watchmaker, so design in nature presupposes a Creator God.[260] McGrath sums up this scientific trespassing into metaphysics as follows: "The real problem with the way in which recent atheistic apologies use science as a weapon against religion has to do with the smuggling in of atheistic metaphysical assumptions, which the sciences themselves neither demand nor legitimize."[261]

Second, the Roman Church is a good example of religion straying into the realm of science. When Galileo (1564–1642) discovered through a telescope that the earth was not stationary as taught by Aristotle (384–322 B.C, foundational philosopher for Roman church dogma), the church said this opposed Scripture. How different from when the Inquisition normally defined heretics as those opposed to church traditions not taught in Scripture. The main point is that the church dismissed a scientific fact beyond its competency to determine the same.

Another limitation of science is its inability to explain how human intelligence, an unequaled computer, can arise from the random and non-purposeful evolutionary process. David Lack, of Oxford University, once stated, "The most important cause of conflict between Darwinism and Christianity concerns the nature of man."[262] Science also has the inability to rightly interpret

259. Richard Dawkins, *The Blind Watchmaker*, 5.

260. For a full account, read William Paley, *Natural Theology: or, Evidence of the Existence and Attributes of the Deity; Collected from the Appearances of Nature* (Philadelphia, PA: Parker, 1802).

261. McGrath, *Surprised by Meaning*, 37.

262. David Lack, *Evolutionary Theory & Christian Belief: The Unresolved Conflict* (Strand, London: Methuen & Co., 1961, 1st ed. 1957), 80. Although that book was written in 1957, the crucial fact still remains in the twenty-first century. How can a process of chance over the deepest time possibly evolve into forming intelligence that causes humans to be different from animals? The ability to reason on either side of this debate is to exercise intelligence from a brain that is so complex that there is no computer system that can match it. How does a natural process lead many humans to worship the supernatural God? Science itself, including evolutionary knowledge, is the product of intelligence (whether the results are persuasive or not), and this intelligence constitutes the common ground between the two worldviews. This is not a reconciliation, or convergence; it is reality. Granted that some intelligence is found among animals like dolphins and elephants, but it is the level of intelligence that is important. For example, no animal invented a spaceship to take animals to the moon.

Perhaps a good way to start a friendly debate is to discuss the distinct difference between animals and humans because of the awesome presence of high-level intelligence in humans. What is common between the worldviews is the fact that all participants, on both sides, are humans who possess intelligence that is unique to them (such intelligence is not found in the animal world). As evolutionary scientists and biblical scholars sit together at the table, they experience what animals will never experience—a shared intelligence that sets them apart from animals. Should the debate begin with the words "We animals" as Dawkins begins his book *The Blind Watchmaker*? One major problem in the debate is how humans reached such an extraordinary level of intelligence through natural means alone.

biblical creation. Theologian John S. Feinberg compares interpreting Genesis 1–2 through evolution to interpreting biblical eschatology through current events. He concludes, "I don't think biblical data allow either an atheistic or a theistic evolutionary account.... I would prefer my views to be consistent with Scripture even if that means they are inconsistent with science."[263]

Meaning Different from Facts/Knowledge

Like Scripture, science deals with facts; but unlike science, Scripture deals with meaning. Science cannot explain the world, but only the phenomena in the world.[264] John Lennox, Oxford University mathematician and philosopher, imagines the scientific analysis of a cake, with chemical and physical factors discussed. But that excludes the fact that the cake is for a birthday party. Though this added factor is not incongruent with science, it is beyond its domain of study. In this context, the "how" question is different from the "why" question.[265]

EVALUATION

The same is true between science and Scripture. The truths of Scripture are divine revelation, are Supernatural, and thus are far removed from the confinement of science to naturalism. So although there are limits to both disciplines, Scripture has an advantage to speak out of the larger metanarrative of supernaturalism than can science in its limited metanarrative of naturalism. Though they are mutually exclusive worldviews, there is more to say about nature than science delivers, just as there is more to a cake than its chemical and physical components. There is a Creator which brings one to nature with an advantage in its study. Rightly understood, the best study of nature should not ignore the greater metanarrative that can throw light on the scientific quests into nature.

God's Urgent End-Time Challenge

Some Evangelical scholars question the Word of God, believing that Scripture is not God's revelation, but merely a witness to His revelation. In other words, the original encounter between God and the biblical writer is considered

263. John S. Feinberg, *No One Like Him: The Doctrine of God* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2001), 579–580. However, he is inconsistent in accepting a modified twenty-four-hour day system, in which some days are a little longer (615). His argument that literary symmetry (two triads in six days) questions solar days seems to overlook the fact that God does all things in an orderly way, which Scripture commends to humans (1 Cor. 14:40; Col. 2:5), 615–617.

264. For example, see McGrath, *Surprised by Meaning*, 43.

265. Ibid.

revelation, but then the biblical writer merely presents his account of that revelation. Thus Scripture is merely a human work and not God's Word. We can conclude, then, that the cosmic controversy not only questioned God's Word in the beginning but has continued its onslaught against God's Word up to postmodern times. Put differently, the rejection of the Genesis account of creation and the rejection of Scripture as God's revelation have occurred concurrently and form a massive attack on God and His Word.

Christ asked, "[W]hen the Son of Man comes [second advent], will he find faith on the earth?" (Luke 18:8b). Scripture says, "The Spirit clearly says that in the later times some will abandon the faith" (1 Tim. 4:1) and goes on to give reasons. It seems that abandoning the faith has as its basis the abandoning of God and His Word, which leaves persons under the influence of the other side of the cosmic controversy. This is why Paul said to Timothy that those abandoning the faith "follow deceiving spirits and things taught by demons" (1 Tim. 4:1).

God knows the future. Two millennia before Darwinian evolution was launched, he predicted:

> Above all, you must understand that in the last days scoffers will come, scoffing and following their own evil desires. They will say, "Where is this 'coming' he promised [Christ's Second Advent, John 14:1–3]? Ever since our ancestors died, everything goes on as it has since the beginning of creation [evolutionary theory of uniformitarianism]." But they deliberately forget that long ago by God's word the heavens came into being and the earth was formed out of water and by water. (2 Pet. 3:3–5)

The last phrase "formed out of water and by water" is not a good translation. It is better said as follows: "was formed out of the water and through water by the word of God" (ESV). In other words, the heavens and earth were created by the word of God: "By the word of the Lord the heavens were made, their starry host by the breath of his mouth" (Ps. 33:6); "By faith we understand that the universe was formed at God's command, so that what is seen was not made out of what was visible" (Heb. 11:3). Note that this forgetting of how God created (spoke into existence by a supernatural act) is located in the last days, and Darwin's theory of evolution through natural selection was first launched in 1859.

One sees that we are dealing with a supernatural God,[266] who knows the end from the beginning (Isa. 46:10). God has always known that evolution would arise

266. Does it make sense to accept the supernatural gift of salvation and not the supernatural gift of creation? Or is it the better part of wisdom to question the validity of Genesis because Moses wrote in prescientific times and could not have possibly known what evolutionary science would discover in the last two centuries? In other words, it seems wise to many to agree with science and relegate the Mosaic creation account to the status of a myth or saga. But then, why is Moses considered at all? For that matter, since all the biblical writers were pre-scientific, perhaps we should relegate all of Scripture to the irrelevant sphere of myth. Some scholars seem to forget that the Author of Scripture is God, and not humans. Granted, there is a human

to question Him, so He spoke long before to give us confidence to believe in His written Word. This is an amazing advantage for Bible believers (evolutionary theory has nothing comparable). Those who believe in this God are not unintelligent, but show their intelligence by choosing to believe in Him and His Word.

In this chapter we documented many theistic evolutionists who fulfilled this prediction of God. Theologians among them spent considerable time studying the Genesis account of creation and found it difficult to accept in light of empirical data from science. They tried earnestly to know the best way forward, not wanting to be naïve, and thus give Christian theology a bad name. Perhaps with some angst, while holding onto the inerrancy of Scripture, including Genesis 1 and 2, they found solace in saying that the Genesis creation days are really day-ages, an interpretation about length of creation that seemed to be in harmony with evolutionary deep-time.

But this decision unwittingly overlooks the first rule of hermeneutics: context is the first step in interpretation. Genesis speaks of God creating in six days, and then blessing the seventh day as the Sabbath, which throughout history has always been a weekly rest day. The context strongly indicates a literal seven-day week. So external empirical evidence from evolutionary science was more persuasive than the foundational law (context) in interpretation.

Thus those influenced by the empirical moved one step away from God's Word towards evolutionary time. The slippery slope soon led many to accept the process of evolution, even that God used the natural process to create. That was a deeper level than time. They had slipped into method, moving from the "when" question to the "how" question. God's prediction states that they deliberately forgot that God spoke everything into existence, a different method from that proposed by natural selection and struggle throughout deep-time.

These theistic evolutionists are imbedded in Christian churches and universities, with a huge influence on young Christians.[267] Of course, adherents agree that

side to Scripture (see my *Systematic Theology*, vol. 1, 311–316; 682–685), just as there is a human side to Christ, the God-Man. Both the living Word of God and the written Word of God are an indissoluble union of the divine and human. While the freedom of biblical writers is preserved (in terms of human language, logic, and literature), the result is that God speaks through inspired human instruments. The written Word of God on the Genesis creation, for example, is not merely the words of Moses, but the Word of God. The intelligent approach to whether God uses the evolutionary process to create must always be answered by the source that most clearly reveals God: Scripture, not nature. It is crucial to allow Scripture to interpret Scripture, and when this is done there emerges a view of an omnipotent (Rev. 19:6) yet loving God (1 John 8:8, 16): One who sees the sparrow fall (Matt. 10:29) and was concerned for animals in Nineveh (John 4:11). The compassion of God for animals makes it impossible for Him to put animals through struggle and death over deep-time. Scripture reveals a God who speaks and gets immediate results (Ps. 33:6–9; 148:5). This is compatible with His speaking the world into existence in just six days (Gen. 1:1–2:1).

267. In fairness, professors (scientific or theological) should compare both worldviews with appropriate evaluations and inform students why one is superior to the other. It is a disservice to students to teach the two worldviews but never tell them which one has better, more logical arguments. Students need to make an informed decision based on the arguments. (It is not wise to teach a biblical worldview on its own, because

the Big Bang began evolution about 14 billion years ago, and the Genesis creation began much later. Scientists and Bible-believers were not present for either event. But there was an eye-witness present at the Genesis creation—the Creator. What is unwittingly overlooked, but very remarkable, is that Christ the Creator wrote in a stone tablet (Exod. 31:18; 34:28b; Deut. 5:22b; 10:2, 4; the Ten Commandments) His commentary on what took place, and surely Christians will want to accept His divine, infallible report above any evolutionary theory. Christ wrote, "For in six days the Lord made the heavens and the earth, the sea and all that is in them, but he rested on the seventh day. Therefore the Lord blessed the Sabbath day and made it holy" (Exod. 20:11). Just as the Sabbath was a literal day, so were the six days of creation.

Here Christ, the Creator, went on record because He knew that the six days of creation would be criticized. Those who once believed the Genesis creation record were too quick to capitulate in these "last days" to the radical schedule of evolution. They should have read the official, infallible record of Christ and remained committed to His version over any other. Christ's record remains unchanged, for "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8).

No wonder that in this end-time context the Creator Christ wants to send an urgent message to all the world to set the record straight: "Then I saw another angel flying in midair, and he had the eternal gospel [this message is part of the eternal gospel] to proclaim to those who live on the earth—to every nation, tribe, language and people. He said in a loud voice, 'Fear [reverence] God and give him glory, because the hour of his judgment has come. Worship him who made the heavens, the earth, the sea and the springs of water'" (Rev. 14:6–7). The Genesis creation account, so ridiculed today, has become in the final book of Scripture a message that must go to all the world. It is just as important to

evolution may later sweep students off their feet.) Teaching both worldviews is sensible, but not without evaluation of both. Evaluation can be made within either worldview on the basis of whether the data is compatible with the basic presupposition(s) of the worldview. For example, for the scientific worldview, one may ask if evolution can explain the arrival of intelligence in human existence through merely natural means. For the biblical worldview, one can ask if the literalness of creation found in later biblical texts is compatible with questioning the Genesis account as literal. It is also appropriate to evaluate the other worldview by one's own worldview. If one believes in the biblical worldview of God at work in creation, one should ask whether God would ever use a natural process. The answer would be guided by what kind of God is revealed in Scripture, and whether evolution with its struggle and death is compatible with a God who is love and the source of all life. It is tragic that some Christian scholars, who once believed in Scripture, have departed from that position. They are biblical and theological professors in universities or seminaries who spend their professional career critiquing Scripture, as if it is subject to the same criticism as the works of William Shakespeare or C. S. Lewis. As a result, these scholars are often used as instruments to destroy the faith of students who come to higher education looking for truth only to have their faith undermined by the wrong side of the cosmic controversy. Those who believe the words "In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth" (Gen. 1:1) should not be considered naïve, since to question the Genesis account is to question the biblical account. If Scripture is unreliable in its introduction, on what basis is it reliable throughout?

know that Christ is the Creator (John 1:1–3; Col. 1:16; Heb. 1:1–2) as it is to know that He is the Savior. The everlasting gospel includes Christ as Creator and Redeemer. There is no redemption in evolution.

The reality of creation with God as Creator should not be questioned in the first book (Gen. 1:1) when it is God's will to proclaim it to the world in the last book (Rev. 14:6–7). The fact that this urgent message is to be given to the world indicates the world's need to learn who the Creator is. Just as salvation is a supernatural gift, so is creation. Both are a part of the eternal, unchanging gospel throughout Scripture. Just as no one can contribute to Christ's gift of salvation, so nothing can contribute to His creation, not even evolution. Christ said, "No one can serve two masters" (cf. Luke 16:13). An intelligent decision to follow Christ as Master includes accepting His version of the creation account (Gen. 1–2).

Conclusion

The overwhelming evidence in the Genesis creation record, as in the other books of Moses and the entirety of Scripture,[268] leads one to conclude that God created during six, twenty-four-hour literal, continuous, contiguous days followed by a literal twenty-four-hour Sabbath. Any modification of the literal historical creation week to fit theistic evolution (1) calls into question God's Word not only in Genesis but throughout Scripture; (2) replaces the uniqueness of human creation with humans as merely products of the process; (3) replaces the supernatural with the natural; (4) unwittingly replaces the biblically constructed worldview with one that concurs with the enemy's questioning of God's Word and nature (in the cosmic controversy); (5) replaces the loving God with a God who created through millions of years of suffering, which is incompatible with Calvary; (6) undermines Christ's supernatural words in Scripture in His past, present, and future ministry; (7) removes a literal Sabbath as the climax of a literal creation week, which calls into question the fourth commandment (Exod. 20:8–11); (8) rejects God's Word in Genesis 1–2, which is just as destructive as Eve's rejecting God's Word in Genesis 3;[269]

268. Although beyond the scope of this chapter, there are various references concerning Israel keeping the seventh-day Sabbath (Exod. 16:23–26; 31:16; Ezek. 20:12–24) as well as non-ethnic persons keeping the Sabbath ("foreigner residing in your towns," Exod. 20:10b), Christ's practice of Sabbath keeping (Luke 4:16), Sabbath keeping after Calvary (Matt. 24:20), Sabbath keeping for all humans (Mark 2:27), Sabbath keeping in the end times because the everlasting gospel, to all nations, calls all to worship Christ as Creator, with the words who "made the heavens, the earth, the sea and the springs of water" which recite a part of the Sabbath commandment (Rev. 14:7; Exod. 20:11a); and Sabbath keeping for all the redeemed in the new earth (Isa. 66:22–23).

269. Satan deceived Eve to believe she could become as God by rejecting His Word (Gen. 3:1–6), which was a type of natural "evolution" apart from God. Evolutionary theory that denies God's Word (as demonstrated in this chapter) is evolution apart from God, for *theistic* evolution is a misnomer. It is tantamount to

and (9) overlooks Christ's urgent message about His creation to be taken to the world in the end time—the Creator who was present in creation and the One who wrote the record on stone to give us His official commentary on the six days of creation.

Christians must not allow God's Word to be doubted as a result of empirical evidence; rather, they should test empirical evidence by God's Word.[270] For in the end times there are scoffers who "deliberately forget" that the heavens and earth were created "by God's word" (2 Pet. 3:5). They need to be countered by believers who "by faith…understand that the universe was formed at God's command, so that what is seen was not made out of what was visible" (Heb. 11:3). This supernatural creation is unanimously attested to throughout Scripture, leaving no room for theistic evolution. Multiple examples can be listed:

- Exodus 20:11
- Nehemiah 9:6
- Job 26:7, 13
- Psalms 8:3; 33:6; 96:5; 102:25; 104:24, 30; 115:15; 121:2; 124:8; 134:3; 136:5; 146:6; 148:4, 5
- Proverbs 3:19; 8:22–30
- Ecclesiastes 12:1
- Isaiah 37:16; 40:12, 26–28; 42:7; 43:7; 44:24; 45:11–18; 51:13, 16
- Jeremiah 51:15
- Zechariah 12:1
- Mark 13:19
- John 1:1–3
- Acts 4:24; 14:15; 17:24
- Ephesians 3:9
- Colossians 1:16
- Hebrews 1:1–2
- Revelation 4:11; 10:6; 14:7

We conclude that the biblical worldview cannot be reconciled with the evolutionary worldview. They are mutually exclusive.

saying God creates through natural evolution apart from His Word about supernatutal creation in Genesis 1–2. Such a premise questions the reliability of God's Word about a supernatural creation in history (Gen. 1–2) just as much as Satan, in tempting Eve, called into question a part of the creation record (Gen. 2:16–17; 3:1–6).

270. The same principle applies in testing miracles, prophetic claims, and speaking in tongues. God's Word is the divine standard to distinguish the genuine from the counterfeit (e.g., Jer. 28:9; Matt. 7:20; Gal. 5:22–23; 1 Thess. 5:20–21; 1 John 4:2–3; cf. Deut. 18:20–22).

Study Questions

1. How does the natural worldview of evolution question the dignity of humans? How does the biblical worldview support the dignity of humans?
2. How do Leonard Brand and Arthur Chadwick, without compromise, work with the two worldviews discussed in this chapter?
3. What are Ian Barbour's four types of relationships between science and religion, and what is your evaluation?
4. From your study of theistic evolution in this chapter, what are the many reasons you can cite as to why theistic evolution is a wrong approach?
5. Because Evangelicals believe scripture is inerrant, what views do they hold that question biblical inerrancy?
6. What does Nobel laureate, Sir Peter Medawar, say about the limitations of science? What are the limitations on the side of religion?
7. In criticizing the first book of the Bible (Genesis), what have scholars overlooked about the last book of the Bible (Revelation)? What is its urgent end-time challenge?

Appendix: Theodicy of William Dembski (2009)

William Dembski believes there is a need for a contemporary theodicy—an explanation of why evil is in the world when God is all powerful. Augustine's theodicy (*Enchiridion*) claims that God will bring greater good out of evil than would be possible if evil did not exist. On this foundation, Dembski builds a more elaborate theodicy to meet the new issues about God's goodness raised by science,[271] one of which is the alleged billions of years of death that preceded the fall of humans. How does one make God look powerful and good after He permitted carnage to be the means of creation?

Dembski argues that this carnage was due to the *future* Fall of humans. God permitted, even willed, the carnage, but humans were ultimately responsible for it.[272] In other words, the impact of the Fall was retroactive (backward causation) as

271. William A. Dembski, *The End of Christianity: Finding a Good God in an Evil World* (Nashville, TN: B & H, 2009), 5–6.

272. "To make us realize the full extent of human sin, God does not merely allow personal evils (i.e., the disordering of our souls and the sins we commit as a result) to run their course *subsequent* to the Fall. In addition, God allows natural evils (e.g., death, predation, parasitism, disease, drought, floods, famines, earthquakes, and hurricanes) to run their course *prior* to the Fall. Thus, God himself wills the disordering of creation, *making it defective on purpose*" (Dembski, *The End of Christianity*, 145, emphasis in original). Dembski also said: "invoking God's permissive will can never fully eliminate divine responsibility for natural evil (at least not if one's conception of God is classical and thus includes omnipotence as one of his attributes)" (150). He also says, "the world…became corrupt through natural evils that God brought about in anticipation of the Fall" (153). Even though Dembski says the pain of natural evil is not a judgment for rebellion (155), his theodicy stands or falls with the premise that natural evil issues from the future Fall as a retroactive reality. One cannot assert this connection between natural

well as proactive (forward causation). He finds a parallel in Calvary. Scripture says that Christ "was slain from the creation of the world" (Rev. 13:8b). The impact of Calvary was retroactive to those in the Old Testament, as well as proactive to those after Christ's death. In other words, just as Calvary was Christ's death for all humans who live before and after Calvary, so the Fall of humans (that necessitated Calvary) affects the evolutionary process before the Fall and affects human history after the Fall. Obviously the need for such a comparison stems from acceptance, at least to some degree, of the 4.5 billion years of evolutionary survival of the fittest. Dembski's theodicy is an attempt to embrace both Scripture and nature as two revelations of God, and thus equally important in providing a balanced understanding of the nature of God.[273] He believes nature seems to present strong evidence against a young earth [274] (e.g., according to present interpretation, ice cores suggest the world is more than 150,000 years old).[275]

Dembski claims that humans developed from animals out of this deep-time carnage of death, from a "world ravaged by natural evil."[276] The pre-human world was one where death reigned, caused by the coming death sentence of the fall of humans. Yet God was able to create a perfect Garden of Eden, a "*segregated area*,"[277] an "island of sanity"[278] fully protected from the rest of the world, an antiseptic exception to the effects of the Fall that prevailed over all the world, due to a Fall that was still future. For the will-be Adam and Eve ("when they enter the Garden")[279] "God breathes the breath of life into them," and "we may assume that the first humans experienced an amnesia of their former animal life.

evil and the Fall of humans and then state (near the end of the book, 154–155) that natural evil is not a judgment for rebellion. After all, the retroactive and proactive results of the Fall share God's ultimate judgment of death, keeping in mind that natural evil and its death is a decree of God based on the Fall. The trajecrory of Dembski's logic links the future Fall with the presenr pre-Fall natural evil which includes death. Surely there is no greater sign of God's judgment than death. It seems that Dembski does not want to accept the logical conclusion of his argument, and quickly puts on the brakes by saying that the innocent cannot experience the effects of the Fall. But it is too late, and his logic ends up in an opposite conclusion. This reminds me of Karl Barth's doctrine of salvation which is so realized in Jesus Christ that his logic leads to universalism (all will be saved). Yet (like Dembski) he attempts to put on the brakes, denying universalism, but it is too late—his logic demands it. Dembski knows that his logic means that God does judge the innocent with natural evils, long before they ever lose their innocence in the future Fall. There is no biblical example in which God judges the innocent in this way, for judgment always follows rebellion; it never precedes rebellion as it seems to do in Dembski's theodicy. Not even Satan, the first rebel (and cause of all rebellion), suffers for rebellion in his prior innocence. This problem of the innocent suffering the results of natural evils which "rage before" the future Fall (151) is only present in Dembski's logic because he is attempting to justify the presence of natural evil prior to the fall of humans. He does so through logic, without the full benefit of Scripture informing his logic.

273. Dembski, *End of Christianity*, 71–81.

274. Ibid., 55.

275. Ibid., 60. The ice cores are still an enigma to young-earth creationists. But this theory is not infallible, beyond the possibility of change in the future, as demonstrated in the history of science with its past paradigm changes.

276. Ibid., 152.

277. Ibid., 151, emphasis in original.

278. Ibid., 152.

279. Ibid., 154.

Operating on a higher plane of consciousness once infused with the breath of life, they would transcend the lower plane of animal consciousness on which they had previously operated—though, after the Fall, they might be tempted to resort to that lower consciousness."[280]

Evidently this infusion temporally removed the effects of the environment they left when entering the Garden. According to Dembski's theory, these hominids came from an environment that was anything but good. Evidently the purifying infusion changed their heredity (a kind of sanctification before their Fall), but was not enough to prevent the Fall, which placed them back outside the Garden under a death sentence under which all future humans were born.

By contrast, Scripture has the Garden in the east segment of Eden (Gen. 2:8). All of Eden was pristine paradise (Isa. 51:3). It was all of creation, the entire world, that God pronounced "very good" (Gen. 1:31), and the entire earth that was to be ruled by humans (Gen. 1:26). There is no hint that part of the world was untouched by creation—there was no savage place where survival of the fittest was the rule of the day. Only a formless and empty place existed before God's creation of the world (Gen. 1:2). No life at all.

To arrive at his conclusion, Dembski had to divide the Genesis creation account into two separate creations[281] (as do historical critics)[282] and distinguish the first creation (*kairos* time) from the second creation (*chronos* time): *kairos* is God's time and *chronos* is human time.[283] Dembski claims that time operates differently in heaven (*kairos*) than on earth (*chronos*). We should note that *chronos* is visible sequential time, whereas *kairos* is "the invisible realm, in which God resides."[284] Dembski says God is "transtemporal" and "unbound by time,"[285] an "infinite God who transcends time"[286] and "does not so much act *in* the world as *across* the world (across both space and time)."[287] This is the God of classical theology (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 6) who is timeless, confined by simultaneity, and does not act in time. This is why Dembski says, "Logical priority rather than temporal priority defines history for God."[288]

280. Ibid., 155.
281. Ibid., 111.
282. Dembski evidently believes in the Documentary Hypothesis where the Pentateuch (five books of Moses, Genesis through to Deuteronomy) have multiple authors—JEDP (the alleged four sources for the first five books of the Bible—Torah or Pentateuch—introduced by Julius Wellhausen [1844–1918]; J=Yahwist; E=Elohist; D=Deuteronomist; and P=Priestly. This is a critical theory that wrongly questions the one author of the Pentateuch); ibid., 151.
283. Dembski, *The End of Christianity*, 124–126.
284. Ibid., 126
285. Ibid., 50.
286. Ibid., 110.
287. Ibid., 140, cf. 111, emphasis in original.
288. Ibid., 124.

Biblical creation involves more than a sanitized Garden, to separate it from a world filled with natural evil.[289] Genesis presents a world creation, with space formed and filled with that which is pronounced "very good" (Gen. 1:31). The whole world and its contents are very good. There is no hint of natural evil present while humans are created in a segregated Garden. In fact, being created in the image of God is defined, in part, as ruling this very good world (Gen. 1:26–27), not merely ruling over a Garden. The creation of Adam and Eve took more than breathing into them life, and the hands-on approach of God is unique when it comes to creating humans. Even the name of God is changed when it comes to the creation of humans (see chapter 2). The significance of the Garden is God's giving Adam and Eve their own home in the world that eventually would be populated by their descendants, who would also have homes of their own.

God said to Job, "Where were you when I laid the earth's foundation? Tell me, if you understand" (Job 38:4). No humans were present, so God reveals creation in Scripture as His authoritative written account. We read this in other texts: "By the word of the Lord the heavens were made, their starry host by the breath of his mouth.... For he spoke, and it came to be; he commanded, and it stood firm" (Ps. 33:6, 9; cf. 2 Pet. 3:5). God was not dependent upon pre-existing matter or animals to create (*ex nihilo*); He created everything through Christ (Heb. 1:1–3), which rules out evolution. In Scripture Christ's miracles are instantaneous, so why would they be different during the miracle of creation? The fact that the creation's miraculous acts took place on six different days of sequential time, climaxing in the seventh-day Sabbath, constitutes the foundational week for humans. Scripture repeatedly refers back to "the day [*yôm*] God created human beings on the earth" (sixth day, *yôm*; e.g., Deut. 4:32), a phrase that occurs twenty-three times in the Old Testament.[290]

Although Dembski includes the Trinity in creation,[291] he apparently overlooks the nature of the Trinity. God is by nature love (1 John 4:8–16), and the relational Trinity have an inner history of reciprocal love. Thus, from eternity, God acts in a temporal, sequential way in an inner history, which means He can act in a temporal, sequential way in an outer history—in this case, in the creation of the world in six consecutive, literal, continuous, contiguous days of twenty-four hours each (Gen. 1). But in Dembski's attempt to find room for the deep-time of evolutionary theory, he disallows understanding God's creative acts in Genesis 1 in their temporal, sequential order as the author intended by the use of designations "first" through "sixth" days (vv. 5, 8, 13,

289. Ibid., 151.
290. Kulikovsky, *Creation, Fall, Restoration*, 163.
291. Dembski, *The End of Christianity*, chap. 10, 84–89.

19, 23, 31) followed by the "seventh" day (Gen. 2:1–3).[292] Dembski is aware that some scholars will challenge his conclusion:

> Young-earth creationists sometimes insist that the author of Exodus, in listing the Ten Commandments, could only be justified in connecting the Sabbath observance to the days of creation if the days of creation were successive 24–hour chronological days (see Exod 20:11, where Sabbath observance is justified in terms of God's creation of the world in six days and then resting on the seventh).... From a purely chronological perspective, however, there is nothing particularly fitting or distinctive about God's creating the world in six 24–hour days.[293]

Dembski apparently overlooks the fact that the commandments were spoken and written by the pre-incarnate Christ (Exod. 31:18; 34:28b; Deut. 5:22b; 10:2, 4), the Christ through whom the Father created everything (John 1:1–3, 14; Col. 1:15–16; Heb. 1:1–2). This means that in the fourth commandment Christ is giving a divine interpretation of the Genesis creation account, stating clearly that the creation days were just as literal as the seventh-day Sabbath that ended the creation week. Here is the origin of the weekly cycle, which unlike months and years is not designated by nature. Therefore, the argument over whether the days of creation are literal or should be otherwise interpreted needs to end, for Christ the Creator, the One who was there, states that days one through six were the same as the seventh day Sabbath: twenty-four literal hours.

Dembski has to reject Christ's commentary on the literalness of the Genesis creation days because, for him, the deep-time of evolutionary theory has come to be more authoritative. Andrew S. Kulikovsky, after presenting the major creation views and age of the earth, says:

> Indeed, it appears that the acceptance of an ancient earth, the minimization of the impact of the Noahic flood, the rejection of the traditional reading of the Genesis account, and its interpretation to fit in with the new geology, were all the result of a general trend away from Scripture as the final authority in matters of history, and towards the acceptance of scientific investigation as the most reliable record of historical information and truth in general.[294]

There is a hermeneutical principle that is overlooked if the creation days are not twenty-four hours in length. The Reformation hermeneutical principle is that only the Bible interprets the Bible, the famous *sola Scriptura* principle. This principle is operative when Christ defines the length of the creation days in His Sabbath commandment. If creation days are anything other than literal twenty-four-hour days, then the seventh-day Sabbath command has no meaning. Who

292. "Genesis 1 is therefore not to be interpreted as ordinary chronological time (*chronos*) but rather as time from the vantage of God's purposes (*kairos*)," Dembski, *The End of Christianity*, 142.

293. Ibid., 143.

294. Kulikovsky, *Creation, Fall, Restoration*, 83.

would charge Christ with such a conclusion? Scientific studies are commendable and necessary. But when they counter the expressed revelation and logic of Christ the Creator, it is more important to follow His interpretation than to read any other view into the creation days. Although unwittingly done, this is a case of reader-response theory, whereby the reader is not informed by the text (by Christ's interpretation of the text) but comes to the text to give it the reader's own interpretation.

Christ's interpretation of the creation days should give Christians confidence to accept the literal nature of the Genesis creation record. There is no greater authority for interpreting Scripture than a member of the Trinity, and Christ's view of creation is a biblical contribution to the study of the Genesis creation that cannot be ignored, even in an attempt to make room for evolutionary deep-time, for the latter unwittingly places a natural theory above Christ's words. This is no different from Satan's questioning the Creator-Christ's words in his temptation of Eve (Gen. 2:17; 3:1–6).

The first paragraph of this segment on Dembski's theodicy ended in a question about how to make God look good. Augustine did so by saying evil allowed greater good to be realized. But how does greater good come from God using billions of years of suffering and death in nature to produce humans because of the retroactive impact of the Fall of humans? Would it not be better for God to create a perfect world, with perfect humans, and only allow the Fall to impact future humans? That is the biblical scenario.

If God needs to use a tortuous process of billions of years in order to create perfect humans, is He really all-powerful and all-good? The answer to that question should now be perfectly clear.

CHAPTER SIX

Evolution Questioned: General Evaluation

Purpose

1. Consider questions that call into question the theory of macroevolution.
2. Identify the limitations of scientific methodology.

Summary

When seeking to determine whether evolution is an actual fact, it is important to realize the limitations of the scientific method even for hard science (such as physics and chemistry). We will begin this chapter by exploring examples of just such limitations.

We then question macroevolution (change requiring deep-time) with these objections: (1) It is too restricted, thus disallowing some evidence that needs to be considered. (2) It assumes from the start what needs to be demonstrated in the process. (3) It cannot explain the origin of life on its naturalistic terms. (4) Its natural selection theory is not substantiated by the fossil record. (5) Punctuated Equilibria and the Cambrian Explosion seem to be exceptions to Darwin's view of gradualism. (6) Cladistics begs the question of common ancestry as proposed by evolution.

In the light of these critiques, evolutionists defend the theory of macroevolution as if it were their religion. Evolution seems to be a religion without God and without human dignity. For atheistic evolutionists, there is no divine plan for

the creation of humans, whereas theistic evolutionists believe God used random chance to produce humans. Neither view does justice to God or humans.

OUTLINE

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B. Darwinism
II. Influential Worldview
III. Causation in Nature
IV. Descent or Design: Things to Consider
V. Evolutionary Research
A. Philosophical Assumptions
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INTRODUCTION

EVOLUTIONARY CLAIMS

The purpose of this chapter is to question the evolutionary theory of gradualism and its view of ancestral linkage. While this is a general evaluation since it focuses on the general theory of evolution (the foundation of its idea of progress over deep-time), in the next chapter we will examine problems with the details of the evolutionary theory. In both chapters we will present scientific reasons for questioning *the overarching theories and the specific claims* of evolutionary theory.

Evolutionists go to the book of nature, and read it through the lens of a uniformitarian worldview, as if everything is the same today as it has always been. This presupposition removes the possibility of the Fall, and therefore of the entrance of sin and death into a "good creation" (Gen. 1:4, 10, 12, 18, 21, 25, 31) and the global flood (Gen. 6–9). Contrary to uniformitarianism, nature reveals the impact of the Fall, not how it was before the Fall. Stanley Hauerwas and John Berkman express it well:

> The tragedy of the natural world being at war with itself inevitably leads to "survival of the fittest" conclusions, unless we realize that the words *nature* and *creation* are not referring to the same world. Those who believe that nature and creation are synonymous often buy into an implicit Deism. This quasi-Deist view (which sometimes also goes under the name Theism) believes that God functions primarily as "the first cause of it all" and thus presumes that nature is coextensive with what Christians mean by creation.[1]

Our Christian worldview holds that the creation world was radically different from the post-Fall world. This view of creation takes into consideration Christological and eschatological convictions, which Hauerwas and Berkman call Trinitarian. They rightly note that the chief end of creation was not to survive, but to serve others.[2] By contrast, evolutionists claim that survival of the fittest is the essence of evolution. Even theistic evolutionists, those who believe God used the evolutionary process to create, are faced with the fact that death preceded the arrival of humans.

DARWINISM

Although the process of conversion was gradual, Darwin was certainly an evolutionist by July 1837.[3] Although Darwinian evolution began with his book *The Origin of Species*, which was published in 1859, we can trace various forms of evolution back through Hume to the classical philosophers such as Democritus, Epicurus, Aristotle, and the "Ionian nature philosophers such as Empedocles."[4] As Isaac Asimov points out in his *Guide to Science*, "From Aristotle on, many men speculated on the possibility that organisms had evolved from one another."[5] "Lamarck (1744–1829), Saint-Hilaire (1772–1844), Oken (1779–1851), Von Baer (1836), H. Spencer (1852), Schaafhausen

1. Stanley Hauerwas and John Berkman, "A Trinitarian Theology of the 'Chief End' of 'All Flesh'" in *Good News for Animals?: Christian Approaches to Animal Well-Being*, ed. Charles Pinches and Jay B. McDaniel (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 1993), 68.
2. Ibid., 68.
3. Ernst Mayr, "Darwin and Natural Selection: How Darwin may have discovered his highly unconventional theory," *American Scientist*, vol. 65 (May/June 1977): 321.
4. Michael Denton, *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis* (Bethesda, MD: Adler and Adler, 1986), 37.
5. Isaac Asimov, *Asimov's Guide to Science* (New York: Basic Books, 1972), 743.

(1855), Huxley (1859), and Nägeli (1859) had already stated that humans were descended from animal ancestry.[6] Maupertuis (1698–1759) proposed a general theory of evolution that recognized descent with possible modification. Others include Georges Buffon (1707–1788), Georges Cuvier (1769–1832), Erasmus Darwin (1731–1802, Darwin's grandfather), Robert Malthus (1766–1834), and Robert Chambers (1844), who in various ways contributed to the beginnings of evolution in recent times.[7]

> Geoffrey Saint-Hilaire (1772–1844) suggested that the occasional deviant form of an organism may be the raw material for the evolution of new types, provided the abnormal form survived. Saint-Hilaire's theory helped lay the groundwork for the understanding that mutations provide a source of genetic diversity needed for evolution to occur through *natural selection.*[8]

"By the late eighteenth century, even before Darwin was born, it [evolution] was being widely discussed. And by the early nineteenth century, when geologists had produced a great deal of evidence for succession, the possibility of evolution was being treated very seriously indeed by advanced thinkers."[9] The concept of natural selection was suggested separately by social scientists Thomas Malthus (1776–1834) and Herbert Spencer (1820–1903). Malthus talked about the *"struggle for existence"* and Spencer "coined the term *survival of the fittest.*" Charles Darwin's contribution to evolution was to suggest the mechanism of "natural selection" as a result of his studying "strange animals found on the 15 islands" of the Galapagos, near Ecuador, and "[h]e also took some of his ideas from observations of fossils, such as in South America." Alfred R. Wallace (1823–1913) proposed the same theory based on animal migration in the Malay region. Darwin and Wallace presented their theory to the Linnaean Society in London in 1858, and gained the attention of the scientific community.[10]

Evolution did not catch on until Darwin gave it a seemingly reasonable integrated principle: gradual, random variations and natural selection (the result of chance). No other method has succeeded Darwin's method, so evolution, in its various forms, is still associated with Darwin. However, breeders have realized that changes can go only to a certain limit before the offspring become sterile or revert back to the original form.

6. Herman Bavinck, *God and Creation*, vol. 2 in *Reformed Dogmatics*, ed. John Bolt, trans. John Vriend (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2004), 513.

7. Colin Mitchell, *Creationism Revisited: A New Look at the Case for Creationism* (Grantham, Lincs, UK: Autumn House, 1999), 37–39; Pattle P. T. Pun, *Evolution: Nature and Scripture in Conflict?* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1982), 28–29.

8. Pun, *Evolution*, 29.

9. Alan Hayward, *Creation and Evolution: Rethinking the Evidence from Science and the Bible* (Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock, 1985), 4–5.

10. Pun, *Evolution*, 29.

> The most famous breeder of all, Luther Burbank, found no evidence of the unlimited plasticity of species that Darwin's theory demands and posited a Law of Reversion to Average. Richard Goldschmidt, a leading geneticist who taught at Berkley, spent years observing the mutations of fruit flies and concluded that biologists had to give up Darwin's idea that an accumulation of "micro" changes creates new species. If there were a thousand-point mutation in the genes of a fruit fly, a statistical impossibility, it would remain a fruit fly.[11]

One could argue that evolutionary theory has had its own evolution. From Classical Darwinism (1858–1890s) to the Modern Synthesis[12] (also called Neo-Darwinism [1915–1930s][13]), to Ultra-Darwinism,[14] to Post-Darwinism,[15] questioned by DNA and molecular biology (1950s), to Punctuated Equilibrium views and Cladistic taxonomy (1980–onward).[16] Meta-Darwinism is in its infancy, questioning the limits and abilities of natural selection.[17] The Classical period focused on natural selection as the sole mechanism for evolution until the Modern Synthesis: Mendelian genetics merged with natural selection to form Neo-Darwinism. The Darwinian period stressed the survival of the fittest, but Neo-Darwinism stressed how an "organism succeeds in passing on its genes."[18] In the 1950s the discovery of DNA by James Watson and Francis Crick in molecular biology caused scientists to take a second look at evolutionary theory.[19] Throughout these first two periods gradualism, a series of microevolutionary changes over sufficient time, was considered the way evolution occurred.

11. George Sim Johnston, "Evolution" in *Our Sunday Visitor's Encyclopedia of Catholic Doctrine*, ed. Russell Shaw (Huntington, IN: Our Sunday Visitor, 1997), 221.

12. In 1942 Julian Huxley coined the term "Modern Synthesis"; Roger Lewin, "Evolutionary Theory Under Fire: An Historic Conference in Chicago Challenges the Four-Decade-Long Dominance of the Modern Synthesis," *Science*, vol. 210 (Nov. 21, 1980): 883.

13. Sir Julian Huxley mentions the 1915 date and Ernst Mayr mentions the 1930s date. Perhaps this is the time during which the synthesis of Darwin's natural selection with Mendel's genetic heredity took place. Sir Julian Huxley in *The Evolution of Life: Its Origin, History and Future*, ed. Sol Tax (Chicago, IL: Chicago University, 1960), 10. Ernst Mayr, *Populations, Species, and Evolution: An Abridgment of Animal Species and Evolution* (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press, 1970), 1. Theodosius Dobzhansky was one of the architects of the Neo-Darwinian Modern Synthesis; see Brian Leith, *The Descent of Darwin: A Handbook of Doubts About Darwinism* (St. James Place, London: Collins, 1982), 19.

14. Pierre P. Grassé, *Evolution of Living Organisms: Evidence for a New Theory of Transformation* (New York: Academic Press, 1977), 5.

15. "Post-Darwinianism" is a term I have coined to represent the demise of the strictly Darwinian model. Although the Modern Synthesis added random genetic mutation to Darwin's sole principle of natural selection, the marriage proved to be an assumed strengthening of Darwin's basic thesis. With the advent of molecular biology, and the study of DNA, there came a persuasive challenge to the central thesis of Darwinian evolutionary theory. This continued in the work of Niles Eldredge and Stephen Jay Gould in their view of Punctuated Equilibrium. The sudden appearance of species in the fossil record radically called into question Darwinian gradualism.

16. In 1980 Stephen Jay Gould and Niles Eldredge proposed a new theory of abrupt, rather than gradual, changes in evolutionary development. Phillip E. Johnson, *Darwin on Trial* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1991), 11, 39, 50.

17. Thomas B. Fowler and Daniel Kuebler, *The Evolution Controversy: A Survey of Competing Theories* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2007), 347, cf. 278.

18. See C. John Collins, *Science & Faith: Friends or Foes?* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2003), 262.

19. Leith, *The Descent of Darwin*, 13.

Not so today. Punctuated Equilibrium (made popular by Stephen Jay Gould and Niles Eldredge)[20] suggests that new species appeared abruptly, as is seen in the fossil record. This new focus is rightly called a paradigm change in evolutionary theory,[21] because, in part, it rejects natural selection as the sole mechanism for change, and gradualism as the time frame for change. The modern form of taxonomy known as Cladistics (Simpson, Cox, Halstead, Hennig, Greenwood, Forey, Gardiner, Patterson, Nelson)[22] finds a distinct gap between species, with no ancestral linkage. Paleontologists, geneticists, immunologists, embryologists, and taxonomists are among those whose research supports the Post-Darwinian view. In the first third of the twentieth century, "Hans Driesch in Germany, Lucien Cuenot in France, Vernon Kellog and T. H. Morgan in America, biologists and geneticists with international reputations—all rejected Darwin's theory during this period."[23]

Although evolution has had its own evolution, it is still evolution. Therefore, in the literature, when later evolutionary views criticize former views, it does not mean to say that the exponents have given up evolutionary theory. It simply means that both Darwinian evolution and Neo-Darwinian evolution have been radically called into question by scientists who still believe in evolution.

We will now consider some evidence that calls into question the theory of evolution in its various forms.

Influential Worldview

Evolution is one of the most influential worldviews to affect the human race. It has become all-pervasive in nearly every contemporary discipline. Darwin believed that "his theories would necessitate a complete redrafting of the problems and scope of several sciences, including psychology, paleontology, and comparative anatomy."[24] Evolution has radically altered biology; it later became married to Mendelian genetics (Neo-Darwinian, or Modern Synthesis phase), and to Ultra-Darwinism,[25] which biologist Grassé considered to be very confident (unlike Darwin).[26]

20. Niles Eldredge and Stephen J. Gould, "Punctuated Equilibria: An Alternative to Phyletic Gradualism," in *Models of Paleobiology*, ed. Thomas J. M. Schopf (San Francisco, CA: Freeman, Cooper & Co., 1972).

21. Johnson, *Darwin on Trial*, 118.

22. L. Beverly Halstead, "Halstead's Defence Against Irrelevancy," *Nature*, vol. 292 (July 30, 1981): 404.

23. Johnston, "Evolution," in *Our Sunday Visitor's Encyclopedia of Catholic Doctrine*, 222.

24. Michael Bartholomew, Bernard Norton, and Robert M. Young, *Block VI, Problems in the Biological and Human Sciences* (Milton Keynes, London: The Open University, 1981), 17.

25. Ultra-Darwinism is represented by those who deny the existence of God like Richard Dawkins in *The God Delusion*, chapter l, "A Deeply Religious Non-Believer" (Boston, MA: A Mariner Book, Houghton Mifflin Company, 2006).

26. Grassé, *Evolution of Living Organisms*, 5; e.g., see Darwin's *The Origin of Species* (New York: Gramercy, 1979, 1st ed. 1859), 66, 205, 227, 231, 234, 262–263, 292, 341.

The Origin of Species "has had a massive influence not only on the sciences, which increasingly are built on evolutionary assumptions, but on the humanities, theology, and government."[27] As Ernst Mayr, a professor of zoology at Harvard University, has noted, Darwin's book "brought about a fundamental reorientation in the study of behavior."[28] Darwin's influence is so great that with him came a paradigm change. Mayr says of Darwin's theory, "It was one of the most novel and most daring new conceptualizations in the history of ideas."[29] No wonder he is widely considered the Newton of biology.

Alfred R. Wallace[30] and Charles Darwin independently considered natural selection to be the mechanism for evolution. Both studied theology before going on to make contributions to evolutionary studies, and Darwin drifted into agnosticism and atheism through his study of evolutionary theory. He lost his faith some twenty years before publishing *The Origin of Species*.[31] This loss of faith was a major contribution to Darwin's adopting of natural selection as the mechanism for his theory.[32] His evolutionary theory has caused many others to lose their faith as well. Martin Lings contends that "more cases of loss of religious faith are to be traced to the theory of evolution…than to anything else."[33]

Evolution has influenced social theory, with the "survival of the fittest" inspiring the extermination of six million Jews in the Holocaust. It continues to influence society. In the August 15, 1994, issue of *Time*, Robert Wright wrote a major article titled "Infidelity: It May Be in Our Genes." In the article, he promotes male promiscuity as a product of evolution. He says, "According to evolutionary psychology, it is 'natural' for both men and women—at some times, under some circumstances—to commit adultery." According to

27. W. R. Bird, *Science*, vol. 1 in *The Origin of Species Revisited: The Theories of Evolution and of Abrupt Appearance* (Nashville, TN: Regency, 1991), 1.

28. Ernst Mayr, "Behavior Programs and Evolutionary Strategies," *American Scientist* 62 (November–December 1974): 650.

29. Ernst Mayr, "Darwin and Natural Selection: How Darwin may have discovered his highly unconventional theory," *American Scientist* 65 (May/June 1977): 321.

30. Naturalist Alfred R. Wallace wrote a paper on natural selection and sent it to Charles Darwin in 1858. This was a shock to Darwin, who had been working on his theory for twenty years, and he feared that his own work on natural selection was now at risk as an original idea, even though both men had done their work independently. Charles Lyell, a friend of Darwin, arranged with the Linnaean Society in London that Darwin and Wallace could both present their papers in 1958. From 1869 onward, Wallace had an important difference with Darwin. He concluded that natural selection was not responsible for the emergence of humans. In 1910, at the age of eighty-seven, Wallace took a second major step away from Darwin. He wrote, "After 40 years of further reflection, I now uphold the doctrine that not only man but the whole world of life leads us to the same conclusion—that to afford any rational explanation or its phenomena, we require to postulate the continuous action and guidance of a higher intelligence." He thereby broke beyond the naturalistic paradigm of Darwin to allow for the supernatural, Paul Kildare, "Monkey Business," *Christian Order* (December 1982): 592. See also Bartholomew, Norton, and Young, *Block VI*, 19–20.

31. Henry M. Morris, *The Biblical Basis for Modern Science* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1990), 111.

32. Mayr, "Darwin and Natural Selection," *American Scientist*, 327.

33. Martin Lings, quoted in Huston Smith, "Evolution and Evolutionism," *The Christian Century* (July 7–14, 1982): 755.

Wright, in 1,000 of the 1,154 societies he studied, multiple wives were a reality. Furthermore, the article contends, "It is to a man's evolutionary advantage to sow his seeds far and wide." Wright concludes, "Lifelong monogamous devotion just isn't natural, and the modern environment makes it harder than ever."[34] With belief in the jungle mentality, that humans are mere animals, no wonder there is so much moral disarray, in which life as well as marriage are considered disposable.

As Henry Morris rightly observes:

> Untold damage has been wrought, especially during the past century, by this dismal doctrine that man is merely an evolved animal. Racism, economic imperialism, communism, Nazism, sexual promiscuity and perversions, aggressive militarism, infanticide, genocide, and all sorts of evils have been vigorously promoted by one group or another on the grounds that, since they were based on evolution, they were "scientific" and, therefore, bound to prove beneficial in the long run. What a tragedy that Darwin was blind to these possibilities, even saying that evolutionary theory ennobles![35]

It is in this context that *The God Delusion*, by atheistic evolutionary professor Richard Dawkins of Oxford University, needs to be evaluated. Throughout the book he cites the atrocities that Christians have perpetrated in the name of God, like the Crusades and the Inquisition. He rejects belief in God on the basis of these terrible persecutions. He never mentions that these were aberrations of Christian values. In other words, he cites those who engaged in non-Christian behavior as reason enough to dismiss Christianity and its God. This is a selective, unbalanced critique that utterly fails to give credit to the noble witness of so many Christians whose lives testified to a relationship with the living God who transforms humans into noble people who are a blessing to fellow humans.

Nor does Dawkins stop to evaluate evolution, a theory he has popularized as a fact. The survival of the fittest—or the best adapted—is not an aberration of evolution; it is the very mechanism by which natural selection favors the stronger over the weaker, in order for the development from molecule to man to take place. The untold suffering in this process is the very essence of evolution. Social evolution supports the theory that for the advancement of humanity, it is proper that the superior race wipe out any inferior race (which happened in Nazi Germany under Hitler when the so-called superior Aryan German white race wiped out six million Jews in gas chambers). Dawkins is absolutely silent about these atrocities that can be attributed at least in part to belief in evolution. This is illogical and unfair in light of his criticism of atrocities perpetrated by Christians.

34. Robert Wright, "Infidelity: It May Be in Our Genes," *Time* (August 15, 1994): 44–52.
35. Charles Darwin, *The Origin of Species* (New York: Carlton, 1859), 373.

It is important to note what biologist L. James Gibson has said, "I think Dawkins rejects the Christian God because of the problem of evil, especially the problem of evil in the behavior of people who call themselves Christian. Dawkins adopts evolutionary naturalism for the same reason as Darwin—there is too much evil in the world to be compatible with any kind of benevolent God, in their view. This is logically consistent in an odd sort of way."[36] If Darwin and Dawkins, together with so many others, had understood the cosmic controversy biblical worldview, they would understand why evil was allowed by a benevolent God: that it might manifest itself so that one day evil will never arise again (Rev. 21:2–4; 22:3–5). On the other hand, persecution was never God's plan; it is a counterfeit to genuine Christianity, and reflects the devil's hatred of God and truth.

David Berlinski, a secular Jew, quoting historian Richard Weikart, notes that Nazi Germany "prided itself in being scientific." Berlinski concludes, "A generation of German biologists had read Darwin and concluded that competition between species was reflected in human affairs by competition between races."[37] Berlinski chides scientific atheists (such as Richard Dawkins, Victor Stenger, Taner Edis, Emile Zuckerkandl, Peter Atkins, and Steven Weinberg) "who regard religious belief with frivolous contempt" and who claim that "[b]ecause scientific theories are true, religious beliefs must be false."[38] Berlinski's point is not the denial of God's existence by atheistic scientists, "but whether science has shown that he does not [exist]."[39] "One wonders," says Berlinski, "why religion *has* the power to console and why it has had this power over the course of human history."[40] In other words, although there are problems in religion that can be critiqued, there are also blessings it brings—blessings that science cannot offer. So even science, though it is an influential worldview, has its limits.

Causation in Nature

Darwin's central thesis was evolution through natural selection. This methodological naturalism cannot, however, be cut loose from causation. Darwin's *The Origin of Species* never explains anything about the origin of life. "Origin" is a misnomer, since Darwin never tells how that origin was possible. Nevertheless,

36. Personal correspondence with the author.
37. Weikart, *From Darwin to Hitler: Evolutionary Ethics, Eugenics, and Racism in Germany*, quoted in David Berlinski, *The Devil's Delusion: Atheism and Its Scientific Pretensions* (New York: Basic Books, 2009), 27–28.
38. Berlinski, *The Devil's Delusion*, 3.
39. Ibid., 44.
40. Ibid., 11.

the fact that "origin" is mentioned means that causation is assumed. It is not good enough to speak about natural laws as if they somehow transcend causation. J. P. Moreland has summed up the problem quite well:

> It is simply false to assert that scientists explain things merely by using natural laws, say by invoking a covering law model of scientific explanation. Scientists also explain by citing causal entities, processes, events or actions. For example, cosmologists explain certain aspects of the universe not only by using natural laws but also by citing the big bang as a single causal event.[41]

If evolutionary theory can speak of causation, why cannot theistic science? Henry M. Morris was right when he said that science is assumed to be "rational and causal and unified," and yet "banning by definition even the possibility of a supernatural First Cause of the rationality, causality, and unity of the universe with which science deals" is an "assumption is purely arbitrary."[42] Dr. Abraham Wolf, one of the greatest philosophers of science, and former professor and head of the Department of History and Method of Science at University College London, said every event has a cause: "This assumption is commonly known as the Postulate or Principle of Universal Causation." He pointed out, "The principle of conservation of matter or energy would lose all significance without the idea of causal continuity, according to which certain successive events not only follow, but follow from, one another. In fact, mere laws of sequence are only intelligible in the last resort, when they can be shown to result from direct or indirect causal connections."[43]

Sir Julian Huxley said of Darwin, "He had passion for natural history, which showed itself from early childhood."[44] The evolutionary view is historical, for it believes that every living animal is related by common ancestry. It is my contention that Darwin, even though focusing on natural selection in evolution, was still enamored with history (ancestral line) when he wrote his *Origin of Species*. Stephen C. Meyer points out correctly that Darwin's *Origin of Species* "does not explain by natural law. Common descent explains by postulating a hypothetical pattern of historical events which, if actual, would account for a variety of presently observed data.... In Darwin's historical argument for descent, as with historical explanations generally, postulated past causal events (or patterns thereof) do the primary explanatory work. Laws do not."[45] For example, "The law

41. J. P. Moreland, ed., *The Creation Hypothesis: Scientific Evidence for an Intelligent Designer* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1994), 55.

42. Morris, *The Biblical Basis for Modern Science*, 31.

43. Abraham Wolf, quoted in Henry M. Morris, *The Biblical Basis for Modern Science* (Green Forest, AR: Master Book, 1984), 35.

44. Sir Julian Huxley in *Evolution After Darwin*, ed. Sol Tax, vol. 1 in *The Evolution of Life*, 2.

45. Stephen C. Meyer, "The Scientific Status of Intelligent Design: The Methodological Equivalence of Naturalistic and Non-Naturalistic Origins Theories," in *The Creation Hypothesis*, 81.

'Oxygen is necessary to combustion' does not explain why a particular building burned down at a particular place and time."[46] An arsonist, lack of security, faulty wiring, kerosene stove, cigarettes—all are possible causes.

So evolutionary theory is premised on causality through the ancestral line. What does this mean? Besides *The Origin of Species*, Darwin wrote *The Descent or Origin of Man* in 1871, in which he provided evidence that humans were descendants of some lower form of animal. By contrast, supernatural theory presupposes design. How can a scientist determine whether homology among animals is due to descent or to design? Confinement to a natural worldview has no place for the supernatural. Does empirical evidence support descent or design? Or is the outcome determined by basic assumptions brought to the evidence: namely, that naturalism doesn't require Supernaturalism?

Descent or Design: Things to Consider

In this segment we look at what scientists must grapple with to discover what they believe is evidence for descent as the explanation for the origin of humans (rather than design). Descent is studied within the limitations of naturalism, whereas design is preferred by those who accept Supernaturalism as the ultimate explanation for the origin of humans.

Some biologists use demarcation arguments to attempt to separate so-called scientific approach to origins (descent) from what they consider the nonscientific (design). Such demarcation arguments come from the influence of a philosophy of science called logical positivism (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 1). Logical positivism focused on empirical data, and it influenced some twentieth-century scientists who were interested in the philosophy of science. Logical positivism confined meaning to empirical statements, but logical positivism itself cannot be verified—and so lacks the criteria required by logical positivism. Which means logical positivism fails because it cannot meet its own criteria. However, logical positivism was embraced nevertheless, and it consigned to meaninglessness the language of metaphysics, ethics, theology, and many other disciplines.

With the collapse of logical positivism, analytical philosophy filled the void, studying language in the context of its use. This came to be known as functional analysis: language used in biology and theology must be evaluated from within the respective contexts of biology and theology. Thus, the criteria for evaluating the authenticity of the one cannot be used to evaluate the authenticity of the other. Ludwig Wittgenstein, in his later thinking, likened the different contexts

46. Ibid., 79.

to different games. No one would apply the rules of baseball to football. Each game is played according to its own rules. Likewise the language of theology in discussing creation and design must be true to its own context, and is as valid within that context as views on descent are within biology. This means that a supernatural context is just as valid as a natural context, so that objective research must not confine reality to the natural context.

Stephen Meyer wrote on the philosophical equivalence of intelligent design and naturalistic descent. He says, "Design and descent prove equally scientific or equally unscientific depending upon the criteria used to adjudicate their scientific status and provided metaphysically neutral criteria are selected to make such assessments."[47]

The fact is that the word *design* has come back into scientific vocabulary due to the work of physicists. They have "unveiled a universe apparently fine-tuned for the possibility of human life."[48] "Despite this renewal of interest in the [intelligent] design hypothesis among physicists and cosmologists, biologists have remained reluctant to consider such notions." In fact, they vilify those who suggest it. "As historian of science Timothy Lenior observed, 'Teleological thinking has been steadfastly resisted by modern biology. And yet, in nearly every area of research biologists are hard pressed to find language that does not impute purposiveness to living forms.'"[49] Yet, as Mae-Wan Ho and Peter T. Saunders state, "the all-powerful force of natural selection has come more and more to resemble explanation in terms of the conscious design of the omnipotent Creator."[50] Robert Jenson notes that "modern sciences were established by, among other choices, the decision to abstain from teleological explanations. The fruitfulness of this decision doubtless justifies it pragmatically, but in itself the policy is extremely odd. For the world resolutely presents itself as purposefully designed.... Especially the biological world is one great gallery of things all of which give every appearance of being designed for a purpose.... If the world's teleological appearance is false it is difficult indeed to account for it."[51]

Evolutionary theory claims descent has taken place through small changes over deep-time, but if this were true, one would expect evidence through

47. Ibid., 71.

48. Ibid., 67.

49. Lenior, quoted in Meyer, "The Scientific Status of Intelligent Design" in *The Creation Hypothesis*, 68.

50. Mae-Wan Ho and Peter T. Saunders, eds., *Beyond Neo-Darwinism: An Introduction to the New Evolutionary Paradigm* (London: Academic, 1984), x. Gordon Rattray Taylor, educated at Cambridge University and Chief Science Adviser to BBC Television argues, "the world is ordered, but that the order springs from an inner necessity"; and he uses a fertilized egg as an example of being "clearly programmed to produce an adult organism." He confines this to the evolutionary process, not to any supernatural causation, Taylor, *The Great Evolution Mystery* (New York: Harper & Row, 1983), 2, 6.

51. Robert W. Jenson, *The Works of God*, vol. 2 in *Systematic Theology* (New York: Oxford, 1999), 127.

numerous transitionals. Paleontology states that various species have always lived at the same time without any "genealogical kinship through transitional forms." Professor Wilhelm Branco states that "in the diluvial period, man suddenly appeared, without ancestors."[52]

Gregor J. Mendel (1822–1884), an Austrian botanist, discovered the principles of heredity. He grew successive generations of plants and noted how certain characteristics were passed on from one generation to the next. His study of generations of garden peas showed him that there are dominant and recessive characteristics. The Natural History Society of Brünn (now Bruno) published his findings in 1866, and his work became the foundation for the study of heredity.[53]

> Mendel clearly demonstrated that individual characteristics were carefully conserved and Darwin, not being aware of Mendel's work, proposed change of inherited characteristics as the nurturing ground for evolution. Today we know that variations induced by the environment are not passed on to the next generation, as Darwin believed in his time. Individuals exposed to the sun get darker, physical activity enhances muscular development etc. but these traits are not inherited. Mendel also showed that genetic recombinants may have latent features which can resurface at a later stage, thus showing that the traits were not lost but could enhance or decrease variation in the phenotype in accordance to the level in which they were expressed. The genome is thus conservative yet versatile.[54]

Naturalism is the scientific worldview that confines the search for truth to nature alone, disallowing even the possibility of Supernaturalism. Yet this confined view of naturalism is being challenged academically: (1) the collapse of logical positivism gave way to functional analysis which allows Supernaturalism as a serious option, because it operates according to its own rules and language that are appropriate to its domain; (2) Stephen Meyer has suggested that design is equally as scientific as descent if assessed appropriately; (3) the work of physicists has brought *design* back into the discussion; (4) the lack of transitionals questions the validity of descent; (5) the sudden appearance of humans in the diluvial period without ancestors also casts doubt upon the whole concept of descent; and (6) the work by Mendel has demonstrated that individual characteristics are carefully conserved—refuting Darwin, who proposed the variation of inherited characteristics as the nurturing ground of evolution.

52. Branco, quoted in Herman Bavinck, *Essays on Religion, Science, and Society* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2008), 116.

53. Rogers McVaugh, "Mendel, Gregor Johann," in *The World Book Encyclopedia* (Chicago: Field Enterprises Educational Corporation, n.d.), 13:323.

54. Walter J. Veith, *The Genesis Conflict: Putting the Pieces Together* (British Columbia, Canada: Amazing Discoveries, 2002), 254.

Evolutionary Research

PHILOSOPHICAL ASSUMPTIONS

Biologist L. James Gibson states, "The idea of deep-time comes as an inference used to explain observations such as ratios of isotopes of radioactive elements and their daughter products, and succession of fossils" which are "not a philosophical assumption," whereas "[n]aturalism is the philosophical assumption."[55] In other words, there seems to be some empirical evidence (as presently interpreted) for deep-time, but the extrapolation of evolution from molecule to man over deep-time is a philosophical assumption that cannot be replicated in the lab.[56]

Consider some examples of a philosophical approach to knowledge. Aristotle's (384–322 B.C.) book *The Organon* [57] presents his deductive research method: deduction argues from general principles to specific instances. This was a philosophical approach to knowledge. Francis Bacon (1561–1626), like René Descartes (1596–1650), was an original thinker. He rejected deductive logic and mathematics, and endorsed an inductive reasoning method[58] in his *Advancement of Learning* and *Novum Organum*. His empiricist approach to knowledge valued experience. Induction argues from experience to general principles.

This turn to the subject greatly influenced subsequent scientific method, which began the process with induction—only using deduction for verification. This means that science begins with observation, which leads to hypotheses, then to a general idea. This is the experimental approach in science. The philosopher John Locke (1632–1704) in his *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding*[59] persuasively argues that "all knowledge comes from experience (observation and experimentation),[60] a conclusion similar to Francis Bacon's view.

David Hume (1711–1776) was an empiricist. He rejected any knowledge that cannot be proven through experience, so he rejected religion (since it is revelation from God). But he discovered that he could not prove empiricism on the basis of the inductive method. In his book *A Treatise of Human*

55. Personal correspondence with the author.

56. Personal correspondence with the author.

57. Aristotle, *The Organon*, trans. and ed. Harold P. Cooke and Hugh Tredennick (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1955). For information in this segment, I am indebted to "Foundation Built and Undermined" in Nigel Brush, *The Limitations of Scientific Truth: Why Science Can't Answer Life's Ultimate Questions* (Grand Rapids, MI: Kregel, 2005), 51–60. Compare what was presented about logical positivism in my *Systematic Theology*, 1:54–66, and what was presented on scientific method, 1:154–165 in chapters 2 and 4, respectively.

58. Deductive logic determines effects from the cause, and inductive logic determines the cause from effects. Deductive logic draws conclusions before examining experience, and inductive logic draws conclusions after looking at experience. See Norman L. Geisler, *Baker Encyclopedia of Christian Apologetics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1999), 357–360.

59. John Locke, *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding*, ed. John W. Yoltan (New York: Dutton, 1961).

60. Brush, *Limitations*, 56.

Nature, he ended up saying: "all our reasoning concerning causes and effects are deriv'd [his spelling] from nothing but custom; and that belief is more properly an act of the sensitive, than of the cogitative part of our natures."[61] In science, present hypotheses question former conclusions, which can lead to paradigm changes.[62] As Fernando Canale correctly says, "In so doing, they work not from 'facts' produced by nature, but from 'facts' produced by the human spirit, i.e., reason."[63] Brush rightly states, "Hume's empiricism eventually led him to the realization that *scientific truth cannot be equated with absolute truth.*"[64] Philosopher and scientist Bertrand Russell (1872–1970) commented on Hume's empiricism:

> It is therefore important to discover whether there is any answer to Hume within the framework of a philosophy that is wholly or mainly empirical. If not, there is no intellectual difference between sanity and insanity. The lunatic who believes that he is a poached egg is to be condemned solely on the ground that he is in a minority, or rather—since we must not assume democracy—on the ground that the government does not agree with him. This is a desperate point of view, and it must be hoped that there is some way of escaping from it.[65]

Geologist Brush comments on Russell's statement, saying: "If, then, according to Russell, universal statements in science that are based on empirical observations cannot be absolutely verified, then these statements, indeed, have no stronger claim to truth than the statements of a lunatic, which are based on subjective feelings. Perhaps the lunatic really is a poached egg and the rest of society is deluding itself by thinking otherwise?"[66]

Science has limited ability to probe the micro and macro spheres. Quantum mechanics theories of Max Planck (1900) and Niels Bohr (1913), and Werner Heisenberg's (1927) "uncertainty principle" teach us that the position and momentum of an electron in an atom cannot be known simultaneously, which presents an uncertain micro sphere, "a realm into which science could probe no deeper, a permanent barrier to the advancement of scientific knowledge, a limitation that future

61. David Hume, *A Treatise of Human Nature*, ed. L. A. Selby-Bigge (Oxford, London: Clarendon, 1978), 183, quoted in Brush, *Limitations*, 58.

62. This is persuasively argued by Thomas S. Kuhn in *The Structures of Scientific Revolutions* (Chicago: University Press, 1962).

63. Fernando Canale, "Evolution, Theology, Method Part 1: Outline of Limits of Scientific Methodology," in *Andrews University Seminary Studies* 41, no. 1 (Spring 2003): 78.

64. Brush, *Limitations*, 58, emphasis in original.

65. Bertrand Russell, *A History of Western Philosophy: And Its Connection with Political and Social Circumstances from the Earliest Times to the Present Day* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1945), 673, quoted in Brush, *Limitations*, 59.

66. Brush, *Limitations*, 59. I would add that on this basis science has no right to dismiss theological statements, which it denigrates as subjective. It seems that faith is a necessary component in both science and Scripture in the quest for truth. Postmodernity denies absolutes, and yet the search through science and Scripture has no meaning if there are no absolutes, and if they do not end up as different observations of the same absolute truth.

technological advances could not overcome."[67] "Quantum mechanics has caused scientists to question not only the nature of physical reality but also their ability to objectively study the physical universe."[68]

> It is obvious that Hume's statement—anything we cannot prove empirically has no meaning—has little relevance in modern science. Strings, dark matter, multiple dimensions, and multiple universes are, mathematically, part and parcel of modern physics and cosmology, yet no scientist has ever observed these entities, let alone been able to prove them empirically.[69]

With this background we need to evaluate the following statement made by Norman Newell, Curator Emeritus of the American Museum of Natural History and Professor Emeritus of Columbia University: "Let the creationists demonstrate that normal processes at reasonable rates and frequencies are inadequate to shape the earth over vast spans of time. Surely, there is nothing blasphemous about regarding the Genesis story as non-historical. Science cannot disprove miracles, indeed it would be futile to try. The scientific way relies on known, testable processes."[70]

Newell's statement above is illogical for the following reasons:

1. It is predicated on the assumption that science relies on known, empirically verifiable processes.
2. Deep-time, needed for the evolutionary process, is not empirically verifiable.
3. Hence, it is illogical to expect creationists to disprove what cannot be proved.
4. Genesis cannot be proven as nonhistorical. In fact, the Genesis record itself provides evidence of its historicity.

Postulating descent by comparative study isn't conclusive evidence for evolution, since it is a limited method. Herman Bavinck looks at this theory from the vantage point of literature:

> People detect slight corresponding traits between two stories, sagas, myths, and immediately they are ready to claim that both are in fact identical, that the differences merely concern the form, and that they are related to each other historically. Various sides have protested these premature conclusions. But even in the natural sciences such a warning is not superfluous. The theory of descent leans primarily on comparative anatomy, physiology, and psychology. But these are driven involuntarily by the desire for analogies, to give them full exposure, and to push difference and peculiarities into the background and to denigrate them.[71]

67. Ibid., 157.
68. Ibid., 162.
69. Ibid., 197–198.
70. Norman D. Newell, *Creation and Evolution: Myth or Reality?*, in *Convergence Series* (New York: Columbia University, 1982), 47.

In the light of the above, it is wise for science to realize its limitations. When evolution is presented as a scientific fact, one should remember the limitations of science. One must also realize that any alleged evolution from a simple beginning up to complex humans cannot be verified in the lab, and so belongs to philosophy, not science. It should be remembered that microevolution (e.g., differences in the beaks of Darwin's finches) which is demonstrable cannot be the basis for macroevolution (e.g., evolution from molecule to man), for it is a leap of logic to go from a small change within confined boundaries to the macro changes that overreach such boundaries. We now turn from limits to the scientific method in general to the limits to evolutionary research in particular.

TOO CONFINED

Evolutionary study is confined to naturalism. Hence, Supernaturalism in general and the biblical record of God as the Creator in particular are irrelevant to it. But as Colin Gunton of London University argues, "When God is displaced as the focus of the unity of things, the function he performs does not disappear, but is exercised by some other source of unity—some other universal." He speaks of the replacements as "surrogate divinities" and suggests that evolution is a replacement divinity.[72]

Evolutionary study confined to materialism is no different in kind from biblical study confined to a magisterium. Methodological naturalism is a confined method that cries out for freedom from arbitrary confinement in order to broaden the breadth of its research. A new reformation is called for to do justice to all that nature can reveal to humans, just as the sixteenth-century Reformation enabled Christians to do justice to all that Scripture can reveal to humans. In fact, the God of Scripture is the God of nature, the God who created the Canon and the cosmos. Unified knowledge calls for an end to a false dualism that confines the scope of research in both Scripture and science.

Scholars debate the pros and cons of whether a confined method helps or hinders the quest for truth in nature. Philosopher and historian of science Michael Ruse confines the scope of science to "unbroken, natural regularity,"[73]

71. Bavinck, *Essays on Religion, Science, and Society*, 114.
72. Colin E. Gunton, *The One, the Three and the Many: God, Creation and the Culture of Modernity, The 1992 Bampton Lectures* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 1993), 31, 35.
73. Michael Ruse, "Creation Science Is Not Science," *Science, Technology, & Human Values* 7, no. 40 (Summer 1982): 74.

but J. P. Moreland responds to this argument by evaluating these two statements: "By its very nature, NS [Natural Science] must adopt MN [Methodological Naturalism]," used in support of evolution, and "Theistic science is religion and not science" used in opposition to biblical creationism. Moreland rightly shows that both statements are not first-order claims *of* science about some scientific phenomenon. Rather, they are "second-order philosophical claims *about* science. They are metaclaims that take a vantage point outside science and have science itself as their subject of reference. Thus the field of philosophy, especially philosophy of science, will be the proper domain from which to assess these claims, not science. Scientists are not experts in these second-order questions, and when they comment on them, they do so qua philosophers, not qua scientists."[74] Thus such claims are not scientific statements, but philosophical statements, and do not deserve the authority usually ascribed to statements of empirical science. The leading philosopher of science, Alvin Plantinga, says that "we need Theistic Science."[75]

Are scientists experts in interpreting empirical evidence? Scientists share with other researchers their conclusions based not only on evidence, but also on their interpretation of evidence. Paul K. Feyerabend speaks about the various problems in empiricism. For different thinkers "have proceeded in different ways and thereby given rise to different kinds of scientific knowledge." He warns, "The unity of doctrine insinuated by the scientist's appeal to experimentation and by his hostility toward 'hypotheses' must therefore be viewed with extreme caution."[76] So there are different kinds of scientific knowledge. Why cannot the action of God, or the supernatural, be seen as one kind of scientific thinking, in which God is the cause of creation in Theistic Science? After all, as Charles B. Thaxton notes, "Science includes many elements; it includes asking what causes things."[77]

Knowledge of origins is not confined to research in nature but includes research in revelation, and for a balanced result, it should not be one without the other. My presupposition is that revelation provides written evidence not found in nature, and so has a prior claim in guiding the interpretation of the data. Without the input of biblical data, the interpretation of natural data can be too confined. Of course biblical data is limited when it comes to science, but the importance of a literal six-day creation in the Genesis record needs to be considered as an alternative to evolutionary deep-time.

74. Moreland, "Theistic Science and Methodological Naturalism" in *The Creation Hypothesis*, 43.

75. Alvin Plantinga, "When Faith and Reason Clash: Evolution and the Bible," *Christian Scholar's Review* 21, no. 1 (1991): 30.

76. Paul K. Feyerabend, quoted in *Beyond the Edge of Certainty: Essays in Contemporary Science and Philosophy*, ed. Robert G. Colodny (Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1965), 146.

77. Percival Davis and Dean H. Kenyon, *Of Pandas and People: The Central Question of Biological Origins*, ed. Charles B. Thaxton (Dallas, TX: Haughton, 1989), viii.

ASSUMED PARADIGM

Francis Schaefer rightly calls evolution a "closed system," which "makes the difference between natural science and a science that is rooted in naturalistic philosophy."[78] A science rooted in naturalistic philosophy is not a science but a philosophy. Philosopher Del Ratzsch notes that "science is increasingly seen as inextricably interlinked with a number of nonempirical factors, including worldviews, philosophical presuppositions and the like."[79] Philosophical evolution has come a long way from the science of Francis Bacon, which was guided by the inductive method without reference to presuppositions. The Baconian method gathered and studied data for its own sake, allowing it to speak for itself. Evolutionary study discriminates against evidence for a Creator in nature by simply ignoring persuasive facts.

Evolutionary theory is a paradigm whose premise is that naturalism is the only way to explain nature. Naturalism is the basic worldview that dictates the results, whether legitimate or not. Given this assumed paradigm, the study of nature is nothing more than a search to find evidence that can be interpreted within the paradigm. Thus the search is biased by the paradigm.

When we come to consider complexities in nature, we find them on every level. One has to ask the serious question, How can such complexity develop from random genetic mutation and natural selection? The enormity of the problem is well put by Michael Denton in speaking about DNA. He says:

> To the sceptic, the proposition that the genetic programmes of higher organisms, consisting of something close to a thousand million bits of information, equivalent to the sequence of letters in a small library of one thousand volumes, containing in encoded form countless thousands of intricate algorithms controlling, specifying and ordering the growth and development of billions and billions of cells into the form of a complex organism, were composed by a purely random process is simply an affront to reason. But to the Darwinist the idea is accepted without a ripple of doubt—the paradigm takes precedence![80]

With such complexity at the molecular level (DNA, for example), what observed process is known to be responsible for its development? The fact of the matter is that evolutionary theory has not come up with any clue as to how such complexity can exist at the very basic level of living organisms. Brian Leith, in his insightful book *The Descent of Darwin*, comments, "I don't think there

78. Francis Schaefer, *The Complete Works of Francis Schaeffer: A Christian Worldview* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway Books, 1982), 1:229.

79. Del Ratzsch, *Science & Its Limits: The Natural Sciences in Christian Perspective* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2000), 36.

80. Denton, *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis*, 351.

is an evolutionist alive who is particularly happy with existing ideas about how complex features arise."[81]

Oxford University zoologist Richard Dawkins recognizes complexity in nature. He says, "Every living cell, even a single bacterial cell, can be thought of as a gigantic chemical factory."[82] Yet, in the *New Scientist* journal, Dawkins states there are only two alternatives to Darwinism to explain "the organised and apparently purposeful complexity of life. These are God and Lamarckism." It is incredible to what lengths the evolutionary paradigm pushes Dawkins as he rejects the idea of God as reasonable complexity in nature. He says, "I am afraid I shall give God rather short shrift. He may have many virtues: no doubt he is invaluable as a pricker of the conscience and a comfort to the dying and the bereaved, but as an explanation of organised complexity he simply will not do. It is organised complexity we are trying to explain, so it is footling [foolish] to invoke in explanation a being sufficiently organized and complex to create it."[83] God is dismissed as the cause of complexity in nature—without any reason, other than Dawkins's assumption that He does not exist. This is an assumption that cannot be proved, yet for Dawkins this means the evolutionary paradigm is the only possible explanation.

Stephen C. Meyer is right when he observes, "If competing hypotheses are eliminated before they are evaluated, remaining theories may acquire an undeserved dominance."[84] This has happened in the case of the confined naturalistic paradigm of evolutionary theory. What is needed is to allow supernatural causation to be considered an equally reasonable cause for complexity when compared to random genetic mutation and natural selection. From the mega universe to the micro universe, complexity is found throughout, and it makes little sense, given our experience, to believe such complexity is only the result of random, purposeless evolution.

Kurt P. Wise speaks of the complexity in life as being the evidence that evolution leaves unexplained:

> Anyone who has taken college biochemistry has been impressed with the extraordinary complexity of replication, transcription, the Krebs cycle and other features of living things. For those who did not take such a course, these are a few of the many chemical processes that occur within any one of your trillions of body cells at any given moment. Photosynthesis, as an example of a subcellular process, is thought to involve as many as five hundred chemical steps—of which

81. Leith, *The Descent of Darwin*, 36.
82. Richard Dawkins, *The Blind Watchmaker: Why the Evidence of Evolution Reveals a Universe Without Design* (New York: W. W. Norton & Co, 1996, 1st ed. 1986), 120.
83. Richard Dawkins, "The Necessity of Darwinism," *New Scientist*, vol. 94, no. 1301 (April 15, 1982): 130.
84. Meyer, "The Methodological Equivalence of Design and Descent" in *The Creation Hypothesis*, 100.

> we "fully" understand only a few. Yet a number of these kinds of processes occur spontaneously within individual cells.[85]

Wise traces complexity up through different levels from the chemical process in the cell, to human organs and their interrelationships, to communities of organisms and their network of complex interactions, and finally to the earth and the complex arrangement of planets, asteroids, moons, stars, and galaxies which allow life to exist on planet earth. He concludes by stating, "Macroevolutionary theory has never successfully explained the acquisition of any level of this complexity, let alone the total complexity."[86] As Michael Denton has said, "In practically every field of fundamental biological research, ever-increasing levels of design and complexity are being revealed at an ever-accelerating rate."[87] This effectively calls into question the naturalistic philosophy that is the basis of evolution.

Beyond complexity is the question of integration.

> As if the basic complexity of things were not enough, the integration of that complexity is truly astounding. Not only do subcellular chemical processes involve a large number of complex molecules and chemical steps, but those items and events are connected in a well-balanced and well-timed series of items and steps to produce a well-integrated process. Similarly, the workings of subcellular organelles, cells in tissues, tissues in organs, organs in systems, systems in bodies, organisms with other organisms, organisms in communities, and communities in the biosphere all show staggering integration. As with the complexity of these items and events on any given level, such a level of integration has never been observed to arise from nonintelligent natural law and process. Integration seems to argue for intelligent cause.[88]

> The integration that is so striking *within* levels is even more striking *between* levels. Not only do subcellular organelle systems and chemical processes show integration, but the chemical and organelle systems are themselves linked together, and must be for the cell to survive. Even more impressive, a similar integration exists between all levels. Once again, this level of integration is unexplained by evolutionary theory but is addressable by intelligent cause theory.[89]

It is well known that evolution is a paradigm that believes in a gradual development from simple to the complex. But this segment indicates that this paradigm cannot address the complexity of the simple cell or issues related to integration. Therefore these issues call into question the evolutionary paradigm, which is assumed rather than proven.

85. Wise, "The Origin of Life's Major Groups," in *The Creation Hypothesis*, 228.
86. Ibid., 230.
87. Denton, *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis*, 342.
88. Wise, "The Origin of Life's Major Groups," in *The Creation Hypothesis*, 230.
89. Ibid., 230.

Natural Selection

Natural selection is a theory about the origin of biological diversity. It says nothing about the origin of the universe. In *The Origin of Species* Darwin questions his own theory: "Can we believe that natural selection could produce, on the one hand, an organ of trifling importance, such as the tail of a giraffe, which serves as a fly-flapper, and, on the other hand, an organ so wonderful as the eye?"[90]

In the nineteenth century, scientists, while accepting evolution as a fact, increasingly came to question the supposed mechanism of evolution through natural selection.[91] Today, it can even be said that natural selection has been "relegated to a back seat in terms of its shaping power in the *origin of species*."[92] Natural selection doesn't explain the origin of life, nor does it produce more variation, because it is a process of elimination.

There is solid evidence that random mutation and natural selection can lead to small-scale change (microevolution), but "there is at present little *direct* evidence that they can explain *all* evolutionary change [macroevolution]; what evidence we have is primarily circumstantial."[93] The "Neo-Darwinian school tends to mix too much extra-scientific material (philosophy) with purely scientific material. This admixture is a principal contributor to the acrimony of the evolution controversy. Advocacy of scientific naturalism in no way demonstrates the efficacy of natural selection and random mutation; only positive evidence will do that. Simply stating that these mechanisms are the best naturalistic option does not make them any more effective."[94]

In *The Origin of Species*, Darwin speaks of domestic breeding and says, "There is no reason why the principles which have acted so efficiently under domestication should not have acted under nature."[95] Darwin didn't have any examples of natural selection when he wrote his *Origin of the Species*; what he did have knowledge of was the way animal breeders selected domesticated animals to improve the stock. But this comparison is only valid if animals left to themselves will do the same as animals directed by breeders. Of course, that is not possible. At least science can speak of natural selection as "less intense than artificial selection, and the changes it produces are much slower."[96]

90. Darwin, *The Origin of Species*, 124.
91. Bartholomew, Norton, and Young, *Block VI*, 34. Ronald L. Numbers claims that perhaps most professional naturalists "remained skeptical about the primacy of natural selection" from the mid-1870s, *The Creationists* (New York: Knoff, 1992), 5.
92. Leith, *The Descent of Darwin*, 60, emphasis added.
93. Fowler and Kuebler, *The Evolution Controversy*, 344, emphasis in original.
94. Ibid., 346.
95. Darwin, *The Origin of Species*, 358–359.
96. Newell, *Creation and Evolution: Myth or Reality?*, 161.

The assumption behind this comparison is that nature left to itself can do the same work as intelligent breeders, even though it takes longer. But this cannot be proven, for deep-time makes it impossible for any empirical verification to be assessed, and hence the premise is not true science (an idea that can be objectively verified) but only a philosophical assumption. By contrast, the laws of physics and chemistry do not operate in this way. Hard science (such as physics and chemistry) can be empirically demonstrated in the lab.

Paradoxically, Darwin excludes an intelligent God from the process of natural selection, but considers intelligent humans to be the empirical evidence for natural selection. This is a basic logical inconsistency in his claim. He is not comparing apples with apples, even though there is a partial analogy involved. As Phillip Johnson rightly says, "The analogy to artificial selection is misleading. Plant and animal breeders employ intelligence and specialized knowledge to select breeding stock and to protect their charges from natural dangers. The point of Darwin's theory, however, was to establish that purposeless natural processes can substitute for intelligent design."[97]

From his experience in animal breeding, Darwin knew that mutations are not always beneficial. What he seems not to have taken into account is that breeding requires an external control (the breeder), and is not the same as changes in nature which are subject only to laws of nature (an internal reality, with no breeder). Can evolution really work if mutations resemble the findings below?

> Mutations are almost always (99.99%) harmful, if not lethal, to the unfortunate organism in which they occur. In other words, mutations produce organisms that are weaker and at a marked disadvantage; they are less able to compete for survival. This fact directly contradicts the assumptions and hopeful expectations of the modern evolutionary theory.[98]

> Mutations are quite rare. This is fortunate, for the vast majority are harmful, although some may be neutral. Recall that DNA is a molecular message. A mutation is a random change in the message, akin to a typing error. Typing errors rarely improve the quality of a written message; if too many occur, they may even destroy the information contained in it. Likewise, mutations rarely improve the quality of the DNA message, and too many may even be lethal to the organism.[99]

> [Can one extrapolate macroevolution from microevolution?] There is some experiential reason to think not; there seems to be a sort of envelope of limited variability

97. Johnson, *Darwin on Trial*, 17. By contrast, it is said of Plato's teleological view: "the universe results from the seminal effects upon matter of ideas, which, in their turn, are organized by divine thought," *Ancient and Medieval Science from Prehistory to AD 1450*, vol. 1 in *General History of the Sciences*, ed. René Taton, trans. A. J. Pomerans (London: Thames and Hudson, 1963, Fr. ed. 1957), 223.
98. Scott M. Huse, *The Collapse of Evolution* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1983; repr. 1986), 90.
99. Thaxton, ed., *Of Pandas and People*, 12.

> surrounding a species and its near relatives. Artificial selection can produce several different kinds of fruit flies and several different kinds of dogs, but, starting with fruit flies, what it produces is only more fruit flies. As plants or animals are bred in certain direction, a sort of barrier is encountered; further selective breeding brings about sterility or a reversion to earlier forms.[100]

C. P. Martin of McGill University notes, "Mutation does produce hereditary changes, but the mass of evidence shows that all, or almost all, known mutations are unmistakably pathological and the few remaining ones are highly suspect."[101] As Charles Thaxton comments, "an organism is made of many structures that must appear at the same time and work together in an integrated whole, if they are not to work to its disadvantage."[102] This is so complex that natural selection and chance must require miracles, and such are beyond the confines of methodological naturalism.

In *Evolution: A Very Short Introduction*, Brian Charlesworth, a Royal Society research professor at the Institute of Cell, Animal and Population Biology, University of Edinburgh, and former president of the Society for the Study of Evolution, and Deborah Charlesworth, professional fellow in the same institute, University of Edinburgh, and past president of the European Society of Evolutionary Biology, speak about those who believe complex adaptations evolve. They make the same category mistake Darwin made using his breeding model. They liken the improvement of knee replacements to evolutionary improvement (without a designer), yet clearly medical device researchers cause the design improvements whereas evolution is not credited with anything comparable.[103]

Whereas Darwin looked to natural selection as the central driving force for his theory of evolution, today "a growing number of scientists accept natural selection as a reasonable explanation for the modification of traits but not for the origins of new structures," and even if natural selection did operate on genetic variability to produce new species, "then the Darwinist is faced with several difficult problems":

> First of all, if organisms can be modified easily by natural forces to produce all of the variety we see among species today, why does any line exist at all that is stable enough and distinct enough to be called a species? Why is the world not filled with intermediate forms of every conceivable kind? In fact, the world corresponds much more closely to what can be expected from the intelligent design point of view: it is filled with distinct and stable species that retain their identity over long periods of time, and intermediate forms expected by Darwinists are missing.[104]

100. Plantinga, "When Faith and Reason Clash," *Christian Scholar's Review*, 23–24.
101. C. P. Martin, "A Non-Geneticist Looks at Evolution," *American Scientist*, 41(1):103.
102. Thaxton, ed., *Of Pandas and People*, 14.
103. Brian and Deborah Charlesworth, *Evolution: A Very Short Introduction* (Great Clarendon St., Oxford: University Press, 2003), 110–111. "In making complex machines and devices, less elegant initial models are refined over the course of time and diversified (adapted) to new, sometimes unanticipated, uses. The evolution of the total knee replacement is a good example of the process by which a crude initial solution to a problem was good enough to be useful, but was successively adapted to work better and better.... Simply by making a structure work better in one way or another, the end result is an improved design, without a Designer being necessary." They noted that different engineers contribute to an improved knee replacement, yet it appeats that no comparable designer is necessary for intricate improvements in nature.

Constancy, rather than change, seems to be the basic pattern found in nature.

We need to take a closer look at natural selection. "It does not explain the *arrival of the fittest*,"[105] the origin of species,[106] or altruism found in nature.[107] If natural selection is credited with producing all the species extant today, why is there so much stasis?[108] Stephen Jay Gould of Harvard University says "natural selection directs evolutionary change."[109] Actually there is no evidence that natural selection has creative power.[110] The theory of natural selection predates Darwin, and was considered by Edward Blyth to be the means of maintaining the fixity of species, an idea "postulated by virtually all proponents of intelligent design, including the father of taxonomy, Carolus Linnaeus."[111] How do evolutionists validate their choice that natural selection produces species under the descent model when it is also seen as maintaining the fixity of species under the design model? Particularly when it is unknown whether natural selection can produce a new species.[112]

Furthermore, for Darwin natural selection explains everything. But if it explains everything, does it really explain anything? As Brian Leith observes, "If the presence of adaptations is evidence *for* selection, but the absence of adaptations is not evidence *against* selection, then is it possible to deny the existence of selection at all? In other words, if selection can explain everything, then it really explains nothing. Good scientific theories should be testable and even falsifiable."[113]

104. Thaxton, ed., *Of Pandas and People*, 88.
105. Huse, *The Collapse of Evolution*, 89.
106. Leith, *The Descent of Darwin*, 78.
107. Ibid., 56. Richard Dawkins argues that when members of a species are "prepared to sacrifice themselves for the welfare of the group," they "may be less likely to go extinct than a rival group whose individual members place their own selfish interests first," *The Selfish Gene* (Oxford: Oxford University, 1989, 1st ed. 1976), 7. But Darwin's thesis of evolution includes extinct species (see *The Origin of Species*, chap. 10), so the survival of the fittest means that some species survive and others do not. Apparently evolution depends upon this struggle, not upon altruism. Even Dawkins seems to be inconsistent about altruism's advancing evolution: "The argument of this book is that we, and all other animals, are machines created by our genes. Like successful Chicago gangsters, our genes have survived, in some cases for millions of years, in a highly competitive world. This entitles us to expect certain qualities in our genes. I shall argue that a predominant quality to be expected is a successful gene is ruthless selfishness," *The Selfish Gene*, 2.
108. Thaxton, ed., *Of Pandas and People*, 88.
109. Stephen Jay Gould, "The Chance That Shapes Our Ends," *New Scientist* (5 February 1981): 347.
110. Johnson, *Darwin on Trial*, 96.
111. Thaxton, ed., *Of Pandas and People*, 67.
112. Leith, *The Descent of Darwin*, 59.
113. Ibid., 21.

Fossil Record

Concerning fossils, A. Hallam, of the Department of Geological Sciences, University of Birmingham, Great Britain, observes that "they are the only direct evidence we have of the history of life on our planet, and in particular of the course of evolution."[114] If this is so, then evolutionary theory is believed on a very flimsy basis, as we will see in this section. There are nearly one hundred thousand fossil species, and yet "where sequence does exist it is exceptional or relatively trivial."[115] Moreover, ninety-nine percent of "the biology of any organism resides in its soft anatomy" which isn't preserved, and so the fossil record is only one percent of the organism.[116] At best, it is estimated that "87.8 percent" of the "329" living families of terrestrial vertebrates were fossilized.[117]

Evolution necessitates a change from one species to another up the increasingly complex progression from the first cell to man. If this in fact happened, one would expect to find evidence of forms between the species. But one can search the fossil record at every level and find no evidence. In *The Origin of Species*, Darwin admits that the fossil record is "the most obvious and gravest objection which can be urged against my theory. The explanation lies, as I believe, in the extreme imperfection of the geological record."[118] Elsewhere he says that the reason why there are not innumerable transitions is due to "the record being incomparably less perfect than is generally supposed. The crust of the earth is a vast museum; but the natural collections have been imperfectly made, and only at long intervals of time."[119] He says that "the geological record is far more imperfect than most geologists believe."[120] Darwin concludes that "the noble science of Geology loses glory from the extreme imperfection of the record," for fossils are "a poor collection made at hazard and at rare intervals."[121]

Apparently Darwin came to the fossil record with his own preconceived assumption about evolution, rather than allowing the absence of transitional forms in the fossil record to call his theory into question. And this was done in the name of science. Such a procedure runs counter to scientific methodology that allows the objective data or experimentation to verify or falsify a theory. German paleontologist Otto Schindewolf "rejected out of hand the idea that

114. A. Hallam, ed.; *Patterns of Evolution As Illustrated by the Fossil Record* (New York: Elsevier Scientific, 1977), v.
115. Denton, *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis*, 185.
116. Ibid., 177.
117. Ibid., 189.
118. Darwin, *The Origin of Species*, 292.
119. Ibid., 25.
120. Ibid., 356.
121. Ibid., 372.

transitional forms could be found or even imagined."[122] Martin J. S. Rudwick, lecturer in history and philosophy of science, Cambridge University, in his book *The Meaning of Fossils*, notes the subjectivity of fossil study: "The 'meaning' of fossils has been seen in many different ways in different periods. Indeed, the same fossil specimens (for example sharks' teeth) have been reinterpreted several times within different frames of reference—they have, as it were, been seen with different eyes."[123] Moreover, study has shown that "there was no fossil evidence of one species changing gradually into another when traced through successive strata; and—much more seriously—there was no fossil evidence that any of the major groups, with their distinct types of anatomical organisation, had any common ancestors."[124] L. Beverly Halstead in *Nature* agrees, stating "no fossil species can be considered the direct ancestor of any other."[125]

The fossil record records some animals from the past that are identical today, having undergone no change. Also, the diversity of animals was much greater long ago than today, which means more and more are becoming extinct, the opposite of what one would expect from the process of evolution.[126] Yet evolutionary paleontologists still attempt to find evidence for evolution in fossils. "The Darwinist approach has consistently been to find some supporting fossil evidence, claim it as proof for 'evolution,' and then ignore all the difficulties."[127] On the other hand, perhaps surprising to many people is the fact that the fossil experts, rather than clergymen, have been "Darwin's most formidable opponents."[128] This means that the fossil record doesn't provide the evidence for evolutionary theory that one would have expected.

Punctuated Equilibria

Darwin described his natural selection as follows:

> It may be said that natural selection is daily and hourly scrutinising, throughout the world, every variation, even the slightest; rejecting that which is bad, preserving and adding up all that is good; silently and insensibly working, whenever and wherever

122. Johnston, "Evolution," in *Our Sunday Visitor's Encyclopedia of Catholic Doctrine*, 221.
123. Martin J. S. Rudwick, *The Meaning of Fossils: Episodes in the History of Palaeontology* (London: MacDonald, 1972), 266.
124. Ibid., 229.
125. L. Beverly Halstead, "Halstead's Defence Against Irrelevancy," *Nature*, vol. 292 (July 30, 1981): 403.
126. Professor J. Veith, a former atheistic evolutionist, who earned a doctorate in zoology, presents lectures on the Amazing Discoveries international TV channel. This idea was given in one of his lectures in July 2010. One of his books is *The Genesis Conflict: Putting the Pieces Together* (Delta, BC, Canada: Amazing Discoveries, 2002).
127. Johnson, *Darwin on Trial*, 84.
128. Ibid., 45.

opportunity offers, at the improvement of each organic being in relation to its organic and inorganic conditions of life.[129]

This description of what natural selection allegedly does throughout the world gives it an intelligence that is more akin to that of an omnipresent God. Even though Darwin claimed that the imperfection of the fossil record explained the absence of transitionals, he suggests that the "the number of intermediate and transitional links, between all living and extinct species, must have been inconceivably great."[130] As biologist James Gibson notes, there are two issues with this theory: "The idea of punctuated equilibria is that the small steps between similar species may be discrete rather than continuous. This, if true, would explain the gaps between similar species, but it does nothing to explain the lack of intermediates between species that are very different."[131]

In the 1970s Harvard professor Stephen Jay Gould and paleontologist Niles Eldredge proposed a theory called Punctuated Equilibrium in order to answer the absence of transitional forms in the fossil record. It was clear that the fossil record gives evidence of stasis (no directional change) as opposed to evolutionary gradualism. Also, species appear suddenly in the fossil record, without any sign of transitional forms. The sudden appearance is always followed by stasis—which radically calls into question the evolutionary theory. As Phillip Johnson says, "the fossil problem for Darwinism is getting worse all the time."[132] Gould and Eldredge were not the first to question gradualism by suggesting an "abrupt evolution." "Hugo de Vries led the Continental 'mutationists' with ideas of large-scale, abrupt evolution."[133] Scientists have modified "Darwin's basic tenet of gradual change to the concept of stasis (no change) alternating with episodes of rapid change," for the "the pattern of fossil organisms is not, by and large, a graded series, but clusters separated by gaps."[134] The above seems to call into question evolutionary gradualism.

Cambrian Explosion

Geologists study the stratified layers in the geological column. Their thesis is that the oldest strata contain primitive fossils, and the later strata contain more complex fossils. Thus the geological column is thought to support the evolutionary development from primitive to more complex as one moves through the

129. Darwin, *The Origin of Species*, 133.
130. Ibid.
131. Personal correspondence with the author.
132. Johnson, *Darwin on Trial*, 57.
133. Leith, *The Descent of Darwin*, 65.
134. Thaxton, ed., *Of Pandas and People*, 39.

time layers. However, it is well known that the early strata, known as Cambrian, have evidence of a plethora of organisms. "There is a virtual 'explosion' of life forms recorded in the rocks in the lower Cambrian. Any theory of the origin and development of life must explain how such a dramatic range of body plans made the early, abrupt appearance they did."[135]

The idea of common ancestry is also called into question by the abrupt arrival of complex animals in the Cambrian strata. Phillip Johnson considers that "one of the most powerful examples" against one ancestral line "is the Cambrian Explosion, in which the complex animal groups appear suddenly, without any evidence of step-by-step descent from single-celled predecessors."[136] Biologist James Gibson points out, "The Cambrian strata date from about 542 to 488 million years ago. The Cambrian Explosion is not a specific date but a period of geological time that is relatively short compared to the entire geological time scale."[137] Does this mean that there was no macroevolutionary development during many millions of years?

Cladistics

Whereas Darwin believed in an infinite number of intermediary links,[138] typologists did not believe in a common ancestor theory.[139] Typologists and taxonomists had carefully classified the species before Darwin wrote his book in 1859. (Actually, classification goes all the way back to Aristotle, and was continued by Linnaeus in his *Systema Naturae* in the eighteenth century.[140]) The most influential of the new schools of taxonomy is known as Cladistics, which was founded by German systematist Willi Hennig in the early 1960s.[141] Cladistics emphasizes patterns of shared characteristics rather than attempting to identify evolutionary ancestors.

The British Museum of Natural History decided to exhibit "Man's place in evolution" in 1980. The museum's book *A New Look at Dinosaurs* included, as Halstead reports, "that no fossil species can be considered the direct ancestor of any other."[142] This caused a great stir as exhibited in the pages of the journal *Nature*. Cladistics and traditional thinking about evolution were at loggerheads. Keith Thompson of Yale University comments on the battle:

135. Ibid., 22.
136. Phillip E. Johnson, "Response to Hasker," *Christian Scholar's Review*, vol. 22, no. 3 (1993): 299–300.
137. Personal correspondence with the author.
138. Denton, *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis*, 69.
139. Ibid., 93.
140. Ibid., 122–123.
141. Ibid., 128.
142. Halstead, "Halstead's Defence Against Irrelevancy," *Nature*, 403.

> No one needs reminding that we are well into a revolutionary phase in the study of evolution, systematics, and the interrelationships of organisms...to the thesis of Darwinian evolution...has been added a *new cladistic antithesis* which says that the search for ancesors [sic] is a *fool's errand*, that all we can do is determine sister group relationships based on the analysis of derived characters.... It is a change in approach that is not easy to accept for, in a sense, it runs counter to what we have all been taught.[143]

Cladists argue that classification is where biology has gone wrong.

> We have made the tail wag the dog. We ought never to have allowed evolutionary *theory* to settle our classification scheme for us. We ought to begin again and classify living things anew, strictly on the basis of the observed biological facts.... Cladists insist that Darwinism is still only an unproved theory which might well turn out to be true, but could possibly be false. Above all, cladism draws attention to what orthodox Darwinists—astonishingly—seem to have overlooked: that observed facts must always take precedence over an elegant theory.[144]

At the end of the day it is clear that the Cambrian Explosion and Cladistics call into question evolutionary gradualism, with its claim to identify evolutionary ancestors.

Molecules And Change

In the next chapter we will consider some specific scientific contributions made by molecular biology that question the idea of development from the simple to the complex, for nature at its micro level is already complex. Furthermore, a study of molecules provides evidence for stasis: "As more protein sequences began to accumulate during the 1960s, it became increasingly apparent that the molecules were not going to provide any evidence of sequential arrangements in nature, but were rather going to reaffirm the traditional view that the system of nature conforms fundamentally to a highly ordered hierarchic scheme. Moreover, the divisions turned out to be more mathematically perfect than even most die-hard typologists would have predicted."[145]

The Darwinian thesis that life arose through a naturalistic process has been thrown into serious doubt. In commenting on this thesis, Alvin Plantinga said, "Darwin thought this claim very chancy; discoveries since Darwin and in particular recent discoveries in molecular biology make it much less likely than it was in Darwin's day."[146] According to the evolutionary paradigm, how did

143. Keith Thompson, quoted in Michael Denton's *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis*, 139, emphasis added by Denton. "This is talking about taxonomic technique, not about paradigm of origin," Leonard Brand, personal correspondence with author.

144. Alan Hayward, *Creation and Evolution: The Facts and the Fallacies* (London: Triangle, 1985), 19–20.

145. Denton, *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis*, 277–278.

146. Plantinga, "When Faith and Reason Clash," *Christian Scholar's Review*, 20.

humans come to talk, to reason, to ask questions, to have a conscience? Microbiologist Michael Denton and Dimitri Kouznetsov found a profound similarity between human language capacity and "the unfolding series of biological language systems including the genetic code. For this reason, it is nearly impossible to address the question of how the human language capacity came to be without coming eventually to consider the closely related mystery of how life itself came to be. Conversely, biologists today are increasingly aware that insights from linguistics are apt to aid our understanding of molecular biology and biophysics (and vice versa)."[147] Molecular study has shown that there is molecular distance instead of ancestral linkage between species.[148] Also, "at the molecular level, the effect of natural selection is therefore mainly to prevent change."[149]

This data also calls into question the notion of evolutionary gradualism. The study of molecules reveals stasis, not change. The fact that humans can talk, reason, have a conscience—all of these characteristics seem to separate them from animal ancestry; further, molecular study supports this reality of distance rather than ancestral linkage between species.

Hoaxes and Assumptions Exposed

Up-front it should be understood that there are fossils of presumed human ancestors. As Leonard Brand has asserted: "There are a lot of good fossils, and we don't have a good explanation for them yet."[150] This reminds us that there are unanswered questions posed by the data, and we need to wait to see what further understanding will develop through research. With this in mind, we will now examine examples of a few researchers who have been too eager to allow their presuppositions to distort the evidence (which, to be honest, can happen in any field of research).

Hoaxes include the Nebraska Man, Nutcracker Man, and the Piltdown Man.[151] It is well known that a number of "leading ape-men contenders" for human ancestors have proved to be hoaxes. As Henry Morris notes, "Anthropologists have been searching all these years for the ape-like ancestor of man, and here it turns out to be nothing but an ape, and an ape contemporary with man at that! This is an odd sort of family tree, to say the least."[152]

147. John W. Oller Jr. and John L. Omdahl, "Origin of the Human Language Capacity: In Whose Image?" in *The Creation Hypothesis*, 242.

148. Johnson, *Darwin on Trial*, 90–93.

149. Ibid., 96.

150. Personal correspondence with the author.

151. See Francis Hitching, *The Neck of the Giraffe, Where Darwin Went Wrong* (New York: Ticknor & Fields, 1982), 201–214.

152. Morris, *The Biblical Basis for Modern Science*, 398, 400.

Evolution a Belief, Not a Science

An idea does not have to be a science to be accepted as true, for biblical creation is not science. However, since science has called into question aspects of evolutionary gradualism and ancestral linkage, then it is fair to question whether aspects of evolution are merely assumption, or belief, rather than being demonstrable (justified or falsified) and therefore a science.

When changes from molecule to man are assumed as factual across the stretch of deep-time, we are confronted with metaphysical speculation and not demonstrable science. When evolution confines itself to naturalism, intentionally setting aside the supernatural, it fails to employ the scientific method—which is, by definition, open to all possible explanations for causation of what exists in nature. What we have in evolution is human belief that cannot be verified. In the realm of ideas, evolution is a dictatorial view that isn't interested in any other view, and serves no more effectively in the world of ideas than a dictator does in the world of diplomacy. This may seem harsh, but humility about the limitations of evolution is long overdue.

Is evolution a fact? Given the conversation surrounding evolution, we would certainly think so. It is often presented as a fact compared to the biblical creation account. This suggests that evolution is scientific, but biblical creation is a religion. The implication is that evolution is more acceptable to thinkers than the biblical account—that evolution is superior to the biblical account. In 1960, scientist G. A. Kerkut, of the Department of Physiology and Biochemistry at the University of Southampton, England, wrote a book *Implications of Evolution* in which he stated and evaluated seven basic assumptions of evolution.[153]

He said, "The first point that I should like to make is that these seven assumptions by their nature are not capable of experimental verification."[154] Such humility is a laudable approach in scholarly endeavors, and the same should be manifest in biblical research.

At the end of his book, Kerkut concludes that the first assumption is still an assumption, and the second assumption "again is a matter for belief rather than proof." Note that spontaneous generation and its having taken place only once are no more than "belief"—the same word used of biblical creation by evolutionists.

153. The seven assumptions are: (1) "non-living things gave rise to living material" (spontaneous generation); (2) "spontaneous generation occurred only once." The other assumptions follow from the second assumption: (3) "viruses, bacteria, plants, and animals are all related"; (4) protozoa "gave rise to the metazoa"; (5) "various invertebrate phyla are interrelated"; (6) "invertebrates gave rise to vertebrates"; and (7) "within the vertebrates the fish gave rise to the amphibia, the amphibia to the reptiles and the reptiles to birds and mammals" (expressed sometimes as common ancestral stock), G. A. Kerkut, *Implications of Evolution* (New York: Pergamon, 1960), 6.

154. Kerkut, *Implications*, 7.

He grants that microevolution (Special Theory of Evolution) is demonstrable; but of macroevolution (General Theory of Evolution), he says, "the evidence that supports it is not sufficiently strong to allow us to consider it as anything more than a working hypothesis." He demonstrates honesty, fairness, and a true scientific openness to evidence beyond assumptions:

> It seems at times as if many of our modern writers on evolution have had their views by some sort of revelation and they base their opinions on the evolution of life, from the simplest form to the complex, entirely on the nature of specific and intra-specific evolution. It is possible that this type of evolution can explain many of the present-day phenomena, but it is possible and indeed probable that many as yet unknown systems remain to be discovered and it is premature, not to say arrogant, on our part if we make any dogmatic assertion as to the mode of evolution of the major branches of the animal kingdom.[155]

Most evolutionists have an implicit philosophical bias against the Genesis creation record. Professor Richard Lewontin, a well-known promoter of Neo-Darwinism, made very clear his devotion—and that of evolutionary theorists—to Darwin's belief system:

> We take the side of science in spite of the patent absurdity of some of its constructs, in spite of its failure to fulfill many of its extravagant promises of health and life, in spite of the tolerance of the scientific community for unsubstantiated just-so-stories, because we have a prior commitment, a commitment to materialism. It is not that the methods and institutions of science somehow compel us to accept a material explanation of the phenomenal world, but, on the contrary, that we are forced by our *a priori* adherence to material causes to create an apparatus of investigation and a set of concepts that produce material explanations, no matter how counter-intuitive, no matter how mystifying to the uninitiated. Moreover, that materialism is an absolute, for we cannot allow a Divine Foot in the door.[156]

Evolution as a Religion

When God, or the supernatural, is removed from the realm of causality, something has to fill the vacuum. Not only has naturalism taken the place of God, but evolution has become a religion in place of biblical religion that worships the Creator. Physicist H. S. Lipson observes that "evolution became in a sense a scientific religion: almost all scientists have accepted it and many are prepared to 'bend' their observations to fit in with it."[157] Alvin Plantinga has noted that "evolution has deep religious connections; deep connections with how we

155. Ibid., 155–157.

156. Richard Lewontin, "Billions and Billions of Demons," *The New York Review* (January 9, 1997): 31.

157. H. S. Lipson, "A Physicist Looks at Evolution," *Physics Bulletin*, vol. 31 (1980): p. 138.

understand ourselves at the most fundamental level";[158] therefore, it is fair to say that evolution "is by no means religiously or theologically neutral."[159]

The religion of evolution has replaced the religion of biblical creation. The natural worldview has replaced the supernatural worldview. Stephen Jay Gould sums it up well: "Evolution substituted a naturalistic explanation of cold comfort for our former conviction that a benevolent deity fashioned us directly in his own image."[160]

There is a conflict between Scripture and science when it comes to the doctrine of creation. It should be remembered that it is not just the historicity of Genesis that scientists call into question, for the doctrine of creation is found in sixty passages throughout the New Testament.[161] The doctrine of God as Creator is fundamental to the biblical worldview. So when scientists reject the Genesis account of creation, they are really rejecting a foundational basis of the biblical worldview.

Plantinga opposes the surrender of science to Scripture, and of Scripture to science. How do we know which surrender is the right one? "The belief that when there is a conflict, the problem must inevitably lie with our interpretation of Scripture, so that the correct course is always to modify that understanding in such a way as to accommodate current science—is every bit as deplorable as the opposite error. No doubt science can correct our grasp of Scripture; but Scripture can also correct current science."[162] Plantinga believes there is a battle being fought among Perennial Naturalism, Enlightenment Humanism, and Christian theism, all "three basically religious ways of viewing ourselves and the world." He observes,

> According to a popular contemporary myth, science is a cool, reasoned, wholly dispassionate attempt to figure out the truth about ourselves and our world, entirely independent of religion, or ideology, or moral convictions, or theological commitments. I believe this is deeply mistaken. Following Augustine (and Abraham Kuyper, Herman Dooyeweerd, Harry Jellema, Henry Stob and other Reformed thinkers), I believe that there is conflict, a battle between the *Civitas Dei*, the City of God, and the City of the World.[163]

I would suggest that this is the cosmic controversy that is basic to this system, and Plantinga is to be congratulated for having insight into the ultimate

158. Plantinga, "When Faith and Reason Clash," *Christian Scholar's Review*, 17.
159. Ibid.,15.
160. Stephen Jay Gould, introduction to *Evolution: The Triumph of an Idea* by Carl Zimmer (New York: HarperCollins, 2001), xxxiii.
161. Morris, *The Biblical Basis for Modern Science*, 392.
162. Plantinga, "When Faith and Reason Clash," *Christian Scholar's Review*, 14.
163. Ibid., 16.

reason for the battle between Scripture and science. In 1983 the *Humanist Journal* published an article "A Religion for a New Age":

> I am convinced that the battle for humankind's future must be waged and won in the public school classroom by teachers who correctly perceive their role as the proselytizers of a new faith: a religion of humanity that recognizes and respects the spark of what theologians call divinity in every human being. These teachers must embody the same selfless dedication as the most rabid fundamentalist preachers, for they will be ministers of another sort, utilizing a classroom instead of a pulpit to convey humanist values in whatever subject they teach, regardless of the educational level—preschool day care or large state university. The classroom must and will become an arena of conflict between the old and the new—the rotting corpse of Christianity, together with all its adjacent evils and misery, and the new faith of humanism.... It will undoubtedly be a long, arduous, painful struggle replete with much sorrow and many tears, but humanism will emerge triumphant. It must if the family of humankind is to survive.[164]

G. K. Chesterton saw scientific materialism as an "established Church" in Western culture.[165] In response, Nancy Pearcey suggests, "To defend a Christian worldview in our generation, we must learn how to challenge this 'established Church.' And a crucial first step is to demonstrate precisely that it *is* a church—a belief system or personal philosophy."[166]

This approach meets evolution head on. For criticism of evolution by biblical scholars evokes the response that Christianity is only a belief, but evolution is a science. Not so. Evolution is more than a belief—it is a religion whose metaphysical materialism is a belief that is no more scientific than the supernatural reality of a Creator-God. Both transcend the limits of hard science. Physicist Fred Hoyle, former professor at Cambridge University, said:

> I have always thought it curious that, while most scientists claim to eschew religion, it actually dominates their thoughts more than it does the clergy. The passionate frenzy with which the big-bang cosmology is clutched to the corporate scientific bosom evidently arises from a deep-rooted attachment to the first page of Genesis, religious fundamentalism at its strongest. A little should be said in favor of this mania.[167]

One needs to put Darwin's thinking in the context of the revolt (Enlightenment and Rationalism, 1600–1700s) against the medieval church. For the church views were dogmatic, undemocratic, and not open to question, as seen in the Crusades (1095–1270), various inquisitions (1231–1500s), and the many anathemas of the

164. John J. Dunphy, "A Religion for a New Age," *The Humanist* (January/Febtuary 1983): 26.
165. G. K. Chesterton, *Eugenics and Other Evils* (New York: Dodd, Mead, 1927), 98.
166. Nancy R. Pearcey, *Total Truth: Liberating Christianity from Its Cultural Captivity* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway Books, 2004), 157.
167. Fred Hoyle, *Astrophysics and Relativity: The Universe: Past and Present Reflections*, vol. 70 in *Reprint Series* (UK: Cardiff, University College, 1981), 40.

Council of Trent (1545–1563). Hence, for many years prior to Darwin's *Origin of Species*, "enlightened" humans exercised their freedom in opposition to ecclesiastical control. Therefore, I concur with philosopher Robert C. Koons's comment, "the birth and growth of Darwinism coincided with a very widespread cultural and political rebellion against religion and the authority of the church."[168] The problem is that the Darwinian aspect of the rebellion has proven to be just as dogmatic as the medieval church had been.[169] As is so often true in life, one extreme has given way to another extreme. But neither extreme is true to Scripture.

A 1982 Gallup poll in the United States revealed that forty-four percent of respondents believed God created humans much as they are today about ten thousand years ago; thirty-eight percent accepted evolution as guided by God; only nine percent believed evolution is not guided by God. This means that the overwhelming majority rejected a naturalistic worldview—which is essentially the Darwinian confined worldview. As Phillip Johnson rightly observes, "As the Darwinists move out to convert the nation's school children to a naturalistic outlook, it may become more and more difficult to conceal the religious implications of their system."[170] Harvard University biologist Edward O. Wilson, in his 1998 book *Consilience: The Unity of Knowledge*, states that "genetic evolution is about to become conscious and volitional, and usher in a new epoch in the history of life."[171] In other words, humans will take charge of their own evolution. This reminds one of New Age views that humans will evolve to become divine.

Contrary to popular belief in a Creator-God in America, evolution has become a global religion for many scientists. When beliefs are religious beliefs, adherents will do almost anything to defend them. When these beliefs reject a Creator-God and replace Him with a naturalistic worldview, they are unwittingly joining the other side of the cosmic controversy against God and His divine revelation about creation and the origin of life.

CONTRIBUTION OF CORNELIUS HUNTER

In his 2001 book *God: Evolution and the Problem of Evil*, biophysicist Cornelius Hunter exposes the shallowness of comparing religious faith and objective research (as if opposites) when it comes to the question of whether biblical creation should

168. Robert C. Koons, "The Check is in the Mail: Why Darwinism Fails to Inspire Confidence," in William A. Dembski, ed., *Uncommon Dissent: Intellectuals Who Find Darwinisn Unconvincing* (Wilmington, DE: ISI books, 2005, 1st ed. 2004), 13.

169. See Phillip E. Johnson, "Evolution as Dogma: The Establishment of Naturalism," in *Uncommon Dissent*, 23–40.

170. Ibid., 33, 39.

171. Edward O. Wilson, *Consilience: The Unity of Knowledge* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1998), 270.

be taught alongside evolution in public schools. We will mention a representative sampling of these religious assumptions in evolution.

Evolutionist Stephen J. Gould has said, "Orchids were not made by an ideal engineer; they are jury-rigged from a limited set of available components. Thus, they must have evolved from ordinary flowers."[172] Hunter comments: "Notice how easy it is to go from a religious premise to a scientific-sounding conclusion. The theory of evolution is confirmed not by a successful prediction but by the argument that God would never do such a thing."[173] Gould then says: "Odd arrangements and funny solutions are the proof of evolution—paths that a sensible God would never tread but that a natural process, constrained by history, follows perforce."[174] Hunter responds: "In other words, evolution is true because divine creation is false."[175] In commenting on these and other examples, Hunter says: "Darwin did not liberate biology from metaphysical thought as is sometimes claimed—he merely switched the metaphysics. What was right is now wrong, and vice versa." In other words, Hunter rightly says the use of a metaphysical interpretation as an argument against creation is a "move from the scientific to the metaphysical realm."[176] When evolutionists claim to prove their theory through disproving a culturally understood view of biblical creation (which is an incorrect view), they believe they have made their point without giving any empirical evidence for macroevolution, the process of development of molecule to man over deep-time.

In what sense is evolution claimed to be a fact? Hunter answers: Evolutionists "may not be able to tell us how evolution works, but they can tell us how it doesn't work. Evolution by natural means is a fact for the evolutionists simply because creation is impossible. But this whole argument for evolution depends on one's view of God and his creation."[177]

And so we come back to the problem of evil: The evils in nature could not have been created by a perfect God; since God can create only harmony, then the problems obvious in nature must be the result of natural laws.[178] So God must be distanced from evil. This overlooks the fact that God must have had something to do with nature's laws, and so is implicated in the result. Yet such a reality cannot be considered by evolutionists; the origin of the cosmic controversy through

172. Stephen Jay Gould, "The Panda's Thumb," in *The Panda's Thumb: More Reflections in Natural History* (New York: W. W. Norton, 1980), 20.

173. Cornelius G. Hunter, *Darwin's God: Evolution and the Problem of Evil* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos, 2001), 47.

174. Gould, "Panda's Thumb," in *The Panda's Thumb*, 20–21.

175. Hunter, *Darwin's God*, 48.

176. Ibid., 49.

177. Ibid., 84.

178. Ibid., 122. The Cambridge Platonists distanced the Creator from creation to explain natural evil, 123.

God's allowing freedom to intelligent beings (a biblical truth) is also not even on the table for discussion. There is a religious view assumed by evolutionists, although never admitted. Without their antagonism to supernatural creation by God, their views could not exist—there simply isn't the empirical evidence for the macro changes required. Hunter rightly concludes, "The plethora of metaphysical language in the evolution literature shows how the debate is about more than just science."[179]

In one sense, evolution is a theodicy, because it explains the presence of evil in nature. I concur with Hunter: "Evolution is no more objective than any of the other theodicies that preceded. Evolution provides a theological solution to a theological problem, and the science is sandwiched somewhere in between. But the theological premises are denied, so the theological result is seen as coming from science, and science inappropriately attains the status of truth-giver. Philosophy and science have always been influenced by theology. This is especially true for evolution. The difference is that evolution denies the influence."[180]

Hunter's 2003 book is *Darwin's Proof: The Triumph of Religion over Science.* In it he examines the work of evolutionist Joseph Le Conte (1888), who wrote much on comparative anatomy and his work "reveals evolution because it refutes divine creation." For example, development patterns in fish reveal a "bungling piece of work" and so could not have been created.[181] Hunter comments: "Darwin's claims about what the Creator can and cannot do are at the heart of evolution. Darwin's writings on evolution remain seminal today because he set forth the manner in which nature is to be interpreted."[182] With reference to the complexity in the fossil record, evolutionist H. H. Lane says it speaks conclusively "against the traditional view of creation."[183]

Hunter says, "The philosophical argument against evolution is that it contains an internal contradiction. Darwinists claim religion plays no role in their theory, but religion lies at its very foundation. It is the constant thread running throughout Darwinism. Evolutionists reject a particular religious explanation, but in doing so they proclaim their own religion. Declaring what or how God may not create is just as religious as declaring how or what he does create."[184] "Darwinism does provide an explanation for natural evil," and so has perhaps the "most successful theodicy." But, in protecting God from the world, it has no

179. Ibid., 157.
180. Ibid., 160.
181. Joseph Le Conte, *Evolution: Its Nature, Its Evidences, and Its Relation to Religious Thought*, 2nd ed. (New York: Appleton, 1891), 54.
182. Hunter, *Darwin's Proof: The Triumph of Religion over Science* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos, 2003), 70.
183. H. H. Lane, *Evolution and Christian Faith* (Princeton, NJ: University Press, 1923), 38.
184. Hunter, *Darwin's Proof*, 81.

empirical data to support the origin of life or evolution of species.[185] It has theories and speculations only—that's all. Yet Le Conte, after asserting that divine creation is not a rational concept, said of evolution: it "is as certain as the law of gravitation. Nay, it is far more certain."[186]

Hunter's third book, published in 2007, is *Science's Blind Spot: The Unseen Religion of Scientific Naturalism.* In this book Hunter speaks of evolution as indebted to *"theological naturalism."* He insightfully points out that "the assumption of naturalism in science is neither a result of atheistic influence nor an empirically based scientific finding. It is a consequence of metaphysical reasoning, and the implications for science are profound."[187]

There are experimental sciences (physics and chemistry) and historical sciences (evolution). Hunter says: "On the empiricism-versus-rationalism scale…our experimental scientist tends more toward empiricism while our historical scientist tends more towards rationalism. Dealing with limited observability of events in the distant past, the historical scientist will need to make more assumptions about the problem. Today, theological naturalism is the basis for such assumptions."[188]

Without empirical evidence for macroevolution, the very variety of species in nature seems sufficient proof for evolutionists that evolution took place. So evolution is considered a fact. When challenges arise to question evolution, evolutionists merely respond by saying further research will indicate that evolution is the only explanation for what is seen in nature today. Although in hard science there have been paradigm changes from Ptolemaic cosmology to Copernician cosmology to Einsteinian cosmology, in historical science, evolutionists have consistently dismissed any possibility of a paradigm change.

Hunter comments: "Theological naturalism has no way to distinguish a paradigm problem from a research problem. It cannot consider the *possibility* that there is no naturalistic explanation for the DNA code. If a theory of natural history has problems—and many of them have their share—the problems are always viewed as research problems and never as paradigm problems."[189] Johnston says, "Modern genetics shows that DNA programs a species to remain stubbornly what it is. There are fluctuations around a norm, but nothing more."[190]

Theological naturalism is the overriding paradigm of evolution, and that paradigm is never questioned by evolutionists. This is precisely evolution's

185. Ibid., 98.
186. Joseph Le Conte, *Evolution*, 65–66; Hunter, *Darwin's Proof*, 104; same claim made by Maynard Shipley with his tables of stone comment (see chap. 5 in *Darwin's Proof*).
187. Hunter, *Science's Blind Spot: The Unseen Religion of Scientific Naturalism* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos, 2007), 11.
188. Ibid., 42.
189. Ibid., 45.
190. Johnston, "Evolution," in *Our Sunday Visitor's Encyclopedia of Catholic Doctrine*, 221.

blind spot: "Naturalism is not a discovery of science—it is a presupposition of science as currently practiced." What this means for us is that naturalism arose in the history of ideas, and so like any idea, it has limits, and can be questioned.[191] Many evolutionists are atheists (such as Steven Weinberg and Richard Dawkins), but atheism did not give rise to naturalism—theism did. Hunter comments: "In this theological naturalism, religious justifications are freely used, but all explanations must be naturalistic. There are problems with many naturalistic explanations, but this is not why naturalism is ailing. It is ailing because it cannot contemplate the possibility that it may be wrong. It cannot evaluate these problems from a larger perspective."[192]

Hume and Darwin both viewed nature with its flaws as a product of natural laws, for a perfect God would not create such an imperfect world. Hunter comments: "Too often commentators today miss the crucial point. Darwin advanced naturalism with religious arguments rather than with compelling scientific explanations."[193] Based on the fact that nature with its flaws could not have been created by God, evolution is offered as the only alternative to divine creation. "Darwin could provide only speculations as to how this or that biological design may have arisen naturally, yet he was altogether bold in his pronouncements of the ultimate truth of his theory. For Darwin some form of evolution had to be true because it was theologically mandated."[194]

The famous trial in Little Rock in 1981 examined whether creationism is scientific. Ted Peters and Martinez Hewlett have concluded that the conflict between evolution and creationism is "a conflict between science and science, and it is a conflict between religion and religion,"[195] which concurs with Langdon Gilkey's evaluation that one needs "to distinguish the scientific from the religious elements of both creationism and evolutionary science."[196] Philosopher Michael Ruse, a critic of creationism, has written a paper titled "Evolution as Religion," in which he states, "I now think the Creationists like Gish [Duane Gish of the Institute for Creation Research] are absolutely right in their complaint! Evolution is promoted by its practitioners as more than mere science.... Evolution is a religion. This was true of evolution in the beginning and it is true of evolution still today."[197]

191. Hunter, *Science's Blind Spot*, 46–47.
192. Ibid., 50; see also 49–50.
193. Ibid., 107.
194. Ibid., 132.
195. Ted Peters and Martinez Hewlett, *Evolution from Creation to New Creation: Conflict, Conversation, and Convergence* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 2003), 96.
196. Langdon Gilkey, *Creationism on Trial: Evolution and God at Little Rock* (New York: Harper & Row, 1985), 25.
197. Michael Ruse, "Evolution as Religion," May 13, 2000, quoted in Peters/Hewlett, *Evolution from Creation to New Creation*, 19. See Michael Ruse, "Is Evolution a Secular Religion?" *Science* 299 (7 March 2003): 1523–1524.

The data in this segment shows that philosophical naturalism is a religion, for it is based upon a subjective belief that can no more be called science than biblical creation can. Faith is necessary in both disciplines. This is a war between two opposing religions: evolution and Scripture. Sadly, this war isn't fought on a level playing field: biblical teaching is ousted from public schools, while an opposing religion is taught under the guise of science. Naturalism has replaced Supernaturalism as the religion offered to youth in contemporary culture.

Nor are evolutionists fair when they discount Intelligent Design views as a religion (see chapter 7), when evolution itself is a replacement of the biblical account, merely swapping one religion for another. Did you know that materialism has led to postmodernity? Phillip Johnson puts it this way, "The postmodernist irrationalism that is sweeping our universities is thus the logical outcome of the scientific rationalism that prepared the ground by undermining the metaphysical basis for confidence in objective truth. A wrong view of mind has come out of science because science has become confused with materialist philosophy."[198]

Impact on Values

Methodological naturalism/materialism comes with a price tag. It is impossible to buy into the natural process, devoid of any influence from the supernatural, without having to embrace the results of the process. The survival of the fittest (or the best adapted) and all its carnage to weaker species through millions of years mean one thing: Upward mobility was a fight directed by selfish genes. Dawkins puts it this way:

> The argument of this book is that we, and all other animals, are machines created by our genes. Like successful Chicago gangsters, our genes have survived, in some cases for millions of years, in a highly competitive world. This entitles us to expect certain qualities in our genes. I shall argue that a predominant quality to be expected in a successful gene is ruthless selfishness.[199]

The alleged evolving to higher species, even to the point of becoming human, meant that human nature would be scarred by those rugged battles. Human nature would be the product of the carnage, doing what is right in its own eyes, without any obligation to the supernatural. This is the moral fallout from evolutionary theory.

All the moral evil in the world is linked to this evil process. So the worst acts of human nature merely reveal the result of the evolutionary struggle. The

198. Phillip E. Johnson in *Mere Creation: Science, Faith & Intelligent Design*, ed. William A. Dembski (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1998), 450.
199. Richard Dawkins, *The Selfish Gene*, 2. This is a "gene's eye view" of Neo-Darwinism. See preface, viii-xi.

survival of the fittest (or the best adapted) is the world of situational ethics. Evolutionary theory does not provide any justification for morality; there is no good or evil, just existence. The name of the game is for the individual to do whatever is best in a given situation for that person, regardless of how that decision affects others. It is the world of rugged individualism, into which the survival of others and the common good do not factor. (It is a world removed as far as possible from the relational Trinity, living in love and calling all to share in that abundant life.) And this worldview of the evolutionary theorists reigns supreme, despite the fact that "scientists see very little 'struggle for survival' in nature (many species tend to cooperate and occupy noncompeting ecological niches)."[200]

Dawkins's book *The Selfish Gene* does not advocate a morality based on evolution. In fact, he limits his focus to what is happening in biological nature, while claiming to desire "to build a society in which individuals cooperate generously and unselfishly towards a common good."[201] But one has to ask how he came to desire such an admirable society when he and all other animals (humans included) came to be in a context of necessary selfishness? Dawkins himself seems to be evidence of a higher good that transcends the evolutionary process, for how can unselfishness be the fruit of "ruthless selfishness" that permeates the entire alleged evolutionary process? It is as if humans, having arrived at the pinnacle, having defeated the competition, suddenly realize that unselfishness is better than what produced them. Who placed that idea in the genes when not a one of them lived that way? Put another way, if Dawkins, like all other animals, is created by ruthlessly selfish genes, who created in him the idea of unselfishness?

C. S. Lewis, in *Mere Christianity*, rightly states that "selfishness has never been admired." Further, he comments, "If we do not believe in decent behavior, why should we be so anxious to make excuses for not having behaved decently?" Or, what if when traveling on a train, someone takes a seat that belongs to another? Doesn't the reaction of the cheated one mean that he and the intruder recognize there is a law—or rule of fair play—of decent behavior? "If they had not," says Lewis, "they might of course, fight like animals, but they could not quarrel in the human sense of the word. Quarreling means trying to show that the other man is in the wrong."[202] There's a huge gap between fighting like animals and having a sense of right and wrong, between how the fittest animals survive and how humans behave in society.

200. Johnston, "Evolution," in *Our Sunday Visitor's Encyclopedia of Catholic Doctrine*, 222.
201. Dawkins, *The Selfish Gene*, 3.
202. C. S. Lewis, *Mere Christianity* (New York: HarperCollins, 1980, 1st ed. 1952), 6, 8, 3, 4, respectively.

So the sense of values among humans is totally different from the survival of the fittest (or the best adapted) among animals. These values, like speech and conscience mentioned above, are empirical evidence that humans are not indebted to animals for their ancestry, and this calls evolutionary theory into question.

Conclusion

Atheistic evolution is more like a religion than a science, for it takes faith to believe a number of its claims. In the questions posed to evolution in this chapter, we have a body of evidence that calls into question the fundamental claims of evolution. Thus the Cambrian Explosion and Punctuated Equilibrium call into question the fundamental theory of gradualism. Natural selection seems to function as if it were a godlike quality of a Creator-Designer. Beyond these obvious problems are the incremental changes over vast amounts of time which Darwin posits to make more acceptable philosophically what is not documented empirically.

1. What is the bottom line of evolutionary theory? Humans are an unplanned accident, and their lives are as self-centered and purposeless as the process. They have no more value than the alleged process that brought them onto the planet. Their future has no goal any more than their past. They are surrounded by continuing chance.
2. How is it then that humans search for meaning, purpose, and desire to worship? These innate yearnings are universally shared among all races, cultures, and ages. They witness to a time when humans were made in the image of God, capable of communion with God (Gen. 1:26–27; 2:1–3). They indicate that though sin has damaged the image of God within, it has not destroyed this image. How can one explain conversions to Christ around the world if humans were not created by God, for God?
3. Keith Ward, professor of divinity at Oxford University, speaks of the Big Bang that launched the universe 15 billion years ago (now considered to be 13.7 billion years ago). In that context, he tells how some people view the future of evolution (not his view):

> We do not know…that the universe has a finite life span. If it goes on expanding, the law of entropy will ensure that all complexity and organized structure is eliminated. If the universe contracts again, under the force of gravity, it will end in a Big Crunch, in which all things will be destroyed. Either way, the complexity of human life, which was always a freak event in the history of the universe, will inevitably be destroyed. The

> universe will simply run down, and in it the whole story of humanity will have been a peripheral sideshow, the flicker of a dragonfly's wing, present only for an instant in the long, blind, purposeless interplay of physical energies that is the real nature of this universe.[203]

To this general evaluation of evolution, it is only fair that we add a specific evaluation of theology, which to some extent contributed to the rejection of God as Creator. I have argued in this system (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapters 5 and 6) that a distorted view of God (timeless, immutable, impassible) from Greek philosophy led theology to present a God different from the God of Scripture. The Enlightenment, in its quest for freedom from the medieval church domination, rejected this God. Modernity and postmodernity continue this displacement of God, as well documented by Colin Gunton. He blames theology for an "inadequate theology of creation" and for "a monolithic conception of God and truth," concluding, "[b]y a kind of reflex or reaction, it [theology's failure] has given rise to modernity's displacement of deity,"[204] as in evolution. If theology had presented the relational Trinity of Scripture as Creator-Redeemer, it would have presented truth that called into question evolutionary theory. However, the Greek philosophical view of God, as embraced by the church, was unable to question philosophical naturalism.[205]

Study Questions

1. What are the implications of the evolution of evolution?
2. To what extent has evolution influenced contemporary culture?
3. Why is methodological naturalism too confined a view of reality?
4. What is your evaluation of Darwin's having used domestic breeding to illustrate natural selection?
5. In what ways does the fossil record pose challenges to the theory of evolution?
6. What are the significance of Punctuated Equilibrium and the Cambrian Explosion as part of a critique of gradualistic evolution?
7. On what basis is evolution classified as a religion?

203. Keith Ward, *God, Faith and the New Millennium: Christian Belief in an Age of Science* (Oxford: Oneworld, 1999, 1st ed. 1998), 21.

204. Gunton, *The One, the Three and the Many*, 129. See his argument in the first four chapters of his book.

205. There are contemporary theologians who have not accepted a fully Greek view of God, but have accepted evolution as His means of creation. These include theistic evolutionists (see chap. 5).

CHAPTER SEVEN

Evolution Questioned: Scientific Evaluation

Purpose

1. Evaluate evolution on the basis of science.

Summary

Science is based on this unchanging principle: Where there is no empirical evidence, there is no science. When theorists extrapolate mega change from molecule to man over deep-time, this is not true science (that which can be verified or falsified). Often an assumption lies beyond the possibility of empirical validation, beyond the realm of science—in the realm of philosophy.[1] As biologist L. James Gibson puts it, "The foundational metaphysical presupposition is naturalism, and the progressive principle over deep-time is a conclusion based on filtering the data through naturalism."[2] Gibson asks, "What is so important about determining whether something is 'true science' or not? Is 'true science'

1. There are exceptions, as noted by Kenneth Wade: "It is not empirically possible to validate the existence of electrons. We can't see them—we can only theorize based on the assumption that they exist. Yet much of science is based on that assumption. This is true on a deeper level with mesons, neutrinos, etc. In the macro univetse, we can't empirically demonstrate the existence of black holes, because we can't visit one and come back alive. However, much of astronomy is based on belief in their existence. We can't even empirically prove that nuclear fusion is occurring inside the sun, or that galaxies exist, or that our sun is a star like the other bright lights out there," personal correspondence with author.

2. Personal correspondence with author.

the same as 'true'? That might depend on the definition of 'science.' At present 'science' is typically defined as a system to identify naturalistic processes. Thus an idea can be 'scientific' and yet false (this is not the common understanding)."[3]

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INTRODUCTION

We ended the last chapter by noting that evolution is a religion. Yet criticism of evolutionary theory is met by responses such as, "You are just trying to bring God into the picture, but He is irrelevant because evolution is science, not religion." In *Intelligent Design Creationism and Its Critics*,[4] the authors claim that Intelligent Design theory is "the most recent—and most dangerous—manifestation of creationism" which promotes "the religious worldview that undergirds it." Then comes the supposed death blow: It is posited that the "wedge strategy" of Intelligent Design has been "very successfully carried out *except for its most important component:* the production of scientific data to support intelligent design" which is dubbed a "*scientific* failure."[5]

This criticism fails to admit that evolutionary theory hasn't produced scientific evidence to refute the claims of Intelligent Design. It is fair to make this observation because evolutionary scientists routinely rebuff critics of evolutionary claims by simply saying, "though they may be improbable, there is no *proof* that they could not have evolved."[6] In his preface to *Intelligent Design and Its Critics*, editor Robert Pennock states: "While most mainline Christian theologians and denominations have reconciled their faith and Darwinian evolution, a large number of fundamentalists and evangelical Christians continue to believe

4. Robert T. Pennock, ed., *Intelligent Design Creationism and Its Critics: Philosophical, Theological, and Scientific Perspectives* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2001). See Barbara Forrest, "The Wedge at Work: How Intelligent Design Creationism Is Wedging Its Way into the Cultural and Academic Mainstream," in *Intelligent Design and Its Critics*, 5–53.

5. Forrest, "The Wedge at Work," in *Intelligent Design and Its Critics*, 5–6, emphasis in original.

6. Cornelius G. Hunter, *Science's Blind Spot: The Unseen Religion of Scientific Naturalism* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos, 2007), 142.

that there are irreconcilable differences, primarily because they hold to a literal or inerrant interpretation of the Bible."[7]

By contrast, God's trustworthy and literal/historical account of creation has much more to recommend it than evolutionary theory does. At the macro level, deep-time is merely philosophy devoid of empirical science. In many cases, but not in all, hard science, to be science, operates under theories that can be tested or falsified scientifically in the lab (for exceptions, see footnote 1). Any theory that is not under these scientific controls should not claim to be true science.

G. C. Berkouwer is right to point out "the incompatibility of Modernism and the Christian faith." He refers to Abraham Kuyper's 1871 lecture on "Modernism: A Mirage in the Sphere of Christianity."[8] Kuyper makes a "passionate indictment" against Allard Pierson who resigned as minister in the Reformed Church because, "The concept of a supernatural revelation has become for him a chimera." Pierson caved in to modernism, and left the solid, unchanging Word of the omniscient God. He exchanged faith in the supernatural for faith in the natural.[9]

Such an exchange leaves one with some basic questions: (1) Why did Jesus come to live and die to save humans if there had been no Fall, for evolution claims that humans are the final result of ceaseless progress from molecule to man? (2) Why will Christ return to create a new heaven and a new earth and to resurrect Christians to an eternal life with Him if evolutionary progress is the way forward? One may conclude that Pierson gave up so much for so little (see the biblical evaluation in chapters 8 and 9). In this chapter we will consider the Intelligent Design movement's evaluation of evolution. But first we will review some historical background that will allow us to discover the ancient roots of evolution.

Historical Background

PARMENIDES AND HERACLITUS (CA. 540–470 B.C.)

In the last chapter we traced the evolution of modern evolution; in this segment we will examine the roots of evolution in ancient times. We begin in Greece, where there were two opposing, competing views of the universe. Parmenides (ca. 540–470 B.C.), who introduced the view that God is timeless, "advocated a concept of eternal absolute being. This view adopted the

7. Pennock, ed., *Intelligent Design and Its Critics*, ix.

8. Abraham Kuyper, *Fata Morgana*, in G. C. Berkouwer, *The Person of Christ*, in *Studies in Dogmatics Series*, trans. John Vriend (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1977), 9–13.

9. Berkouwer, *The Person of Christ*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 11–12.

concept of the changeless quality of true being. Apparent changes in the world of phenomena were explained away on the basis of the rearrangement, separation, and union of small unalterable particles."[10] Heraclitus (ca. 540–ca. 475 B.C.), a contemporary of Parmenides, took the opposite position, stating that everything is changing. Philosophical tradition interprets his thesis as "Everything is in flux," resembling "the constant flow of a river." Flux involves "cycles of generation and decay." Through his follower Cratylus, Heraclitus influenced Plato.[11]

PLATO (427–347 B.C.)

Plato heard someone reading a book written by Anaxagoras that said, "it is mind that produces order and is the cause of everything." Plato assumed that in Anaxagoras he had discovered "an authority on causation." After procuring the books of Anaxagoras, Plato's hopes were dashed. He said, "As I read on I discovered that the fellow made no use of mind and assigned to it no causality for the order of the world, but adduced causes like air and aether and water and many other absurdities." Plato likened the inconsistency of Anaxagoras to Socrates's positing that all causation is in the mind. "Athens has thought it better to condemn me, therefore I for my part have thought it better to sit here, and more right to stay and submit to whatever penalty she orders."[12] This seems to infer that Plato accepted intelligent causation as the real reason for his sitting there, rather than any physical (or materialistic) causation.

Behind the physical/materialistic causation of evolutionary theory, there is intelligent causation in nature itself, which questions evolution's confinement to natural causation.

ARISTOTLE (382–322 B.C.)

About twenty-five percent of Aristotle's writings consist of a study of nature.[13] Aristotle speaks of sudden creation, which later became known as spontaneous generation. The medieval church adopted his thinking, and any ideas of change since creation were put on hold for more than a millennium.[14]

10. See my *Systematic Theology*, 1:4–6.

11. P. T. Pun, *Evolution: Nature and Scripture in Conflict?* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1982), 27; A. A. Long, "Heraclirus (ca. 540– ca. 480 B.C.)" in *Concise Routledge Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (New York: Routledge, 2000), 346.

12. Plato, *Phaedo*, in *The Collected Dialogues of Plato, Including the Letters*, ed. Edith Hamilton and Huntington Cairns (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1961), 79–80 (97c–98e).

13. For example, *History of Animals, Parts of Animals, Generation of Animals, Movement of Animals*, and *Progression of Animals* are focused on biology; *Physics* and *Generation and Corruption* are accounts of nature, form and matter, cause and change; and *On the Heavens* is about natural philosophy—natural organisms and their behavior.

14. T. H. Irwin, "Aristotle (384–322 BC)" in *Concise Routledge Encyclopedia*, 50–51; Pun, *Evolution*, 27–28.

STOICISM (CA. 300 B.C.)

Although Epicurus comes before Zeno and Stoicism, we mention Stoicism now, because what follows will be impacted by Epicurus. Stoicism was founded by Zeno of Citium around 300 B.C. and developed into "the most influential philosophy in the Hellenistic age."[15] With respect to God and creation, the Stoics had something to say about design. Julia Annas, Regents Professor of Philosophy at the University of Arizona, puts it this way:

> The Stoics therefore take a different tack from Plato's appeal to the idea that God is like a craftsman. They appeal to evidence in the world that suggests that it is the product of design and rational ordering. They reject the idea that the world is the product of random events and forces, on the grounds that it is implausible—like, they say, the idea that random distribution of letters of the alphabet could produce a poem.... Some of their arguments for design in the world appeal to the sheer complexity of natural objects. Suppose, one argument goes, that a complicated mechanism like a clock were shown to people unfamiliar with it; they would still recognize it as the product of a rational being. Hence, natural objects, which display a greater complexity and suitability for their function than artefacts, must be the product of reason—clearly a reason greater than ours, one embodied in the universe as a whole. (This is strikingly similar to the "argument from design" common to Christian thinkers before Darwin.)[16]

EPICURUS (341–271 B.C.)

Epicurus was a Greek philosopher, born in 341 B.C., just seven years after Plato's death. He headed a school of philosophy in Athens from 306 to 270 B.C., and his primary aim was to minimize pain. For the body, this was achieved through a simple lifestyle. For the soul, this was attained through the study of physics, which offers freedom from disturbance (*ataraxia*). Epicurus believed that human minds are disturbed by two things: fear of the gods and fear of death. He said the gods were distant from humans and have nothing to do with them. Epicurus wrote three hundred books, or scrolls, and taught that "cosmic phenomena do not convey divine threats, and that death is mere disintegration of the soul, with hell an illusion."[17]

EPICURUS COMPARED TO DARWIN

Epicurus believed there are countless worlds and no divine mind responsible for their existence. In other words, there are no divine creators. Instead, he

15. David Sedley, "Stoicism" in *Concise Routledge Encyclopedia*, 862.
16. Julia Annas, *Ancient Philosophy: A Very Short Introduction* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000), 91.
17. David Sedley, "Epicureanism" in *Concise Routledge Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (New York: Routledge, 2003, 1st ed. 2000), 244–245.

considered atoms the simplest form of matter; he was clearly influenced by the materialistic atomism of Democritus and Leucippus (mid-fifth to fourth century B.C.).[18] Most of the writings of Epicurus are not extant, but three letters summarizing his beliefs and a poem "On the Nature of Things" by his disciple Lucretius have survived.[19] As a materialist, he saw no need to posit the existence of gods, and naturalism was his focus.

Benjamin Wiker, in his book *Moral Darwinism: How We Became Hedonists*,[20] suggests that Epicurus was a precursor of Darwin, for both did their research within a closed worldview, where naturalism reigned and the supernatural is irrelevant to their theories. In other words, Epicurean materialism was influential more than two thousand years before Darwinian evolution—which means Darwinian evolution is actually founded upon Epicurean materialism, whether realized or not. William A. Dembski says, "Epicurus's most prominent disciple is without question Charles Darwin. Darwinism is not only the most recent incarnation of Epicurean philosophy but also the most potent formulation of that philosophy to date."[21]

Both were hostile to the religion of their day: Epicurus wanted to eliminate the influence of Greek religion through his philosophy, and Darwin wanted to eliminate the influence of Christianity through his evolutionary theory. There is no doubt that it takes faith to accept the basic presuppositions of Epicurean philosophy and Darwinian evolution. In their antagonism to the religion of their day, they eliminated one faith by embracing another faith—one of their own design. We speak of faith (trusting that the idea is valid, though it cannot be demonstrated) because there is no way that Epicurus could know that the universe was eternal, for he could not be present to receive empirical evidence of this fact, and Darwin could not know that evolutionary change from one species to another species took place over deep-time, for he could not possibly have been present to verify it.

Epicurus claimed that "nothing comes into being from what is not."[22] This means he denied creation out of nothing (the biblical view). The great Epicurean poem *De Rerum Natura* ("On the Nature of Things"), written by Lucretius

18. David Sedley, "Atomism, Ancient," *Concise Routledge Encyclopedia* (2003), 63; and C. C. W. Taylor, "Democritus (mid 5th–4th century B.C.)," *Concise Routledge Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (2003), 200.
19. James B. Gould, "Epicurus," in *The World Book Encyclopedia* (USA: Field Enterprises Educational Corporation, 1973), 6:263. The poem is found in Isaac Newton, *Mathematical Principles of Natural Philosophy*, trans. Leon J. Richardson (Berkeley, CA: University of California, 1934), xiii–xv.
20. Benjamin Wiker, *Moral Darwinism: How We Became Hedonists* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2002). I am indebted to Wiker for ideas presented in this historical segment. He presents a very complete analysis, and his thinking is important because it demonstrates the ancient historical roots of Darwin's evolution.
21. William A. Dembski, foreword to *Moral Darwinism*, 11.
22. "Nothing comes into existence from what does not exist," "Epicurus (341–271 B.C.). Seg. 3 (Metaphysics), a (Existence of Atoms and Void), pt. 2," *Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, www.iep.utm.edu, accessed December 7, 2011.

near the middle of the first century B.C., declares, "In the beginning [*principio*] the earth gave forth"—which is the same as Darwinian evolution.[23]

Darwin's evolution was not new,[24] and yet it was new. James Gibson comments:

> The idea of common ancestry was not new; the idea of natural selection was not really new. What Darwin did was to link the two causally, using natural selection to explain a descent with modification from a common ancestor. In this sense, Darwin produced something new. It was premised on the materialistic foundation of Epicurean philosophy. And there is a history of influence that reaches from Epicurus to Darwin. For the materialistic cosmology of both has moral implications, for when matter is a closed universe, without any relation with gods or God, without a contingency of the created on the Creator, without a dependent relationship of nature on nature's gods/God, then one's view of human nature is impacted. Human nature is reduced to one aspect of materialism, so that humans are merely a collection of atoms. Such a reduction of humans who are really made in the image of God (Gen. 1:26, 27) has moral implications.[25]

Rather than positing the eternal Creator-God, Epicurus stated that fundamental bodies "are atomic and unchangeable" and hence eternal. So eternal nature replaced eternal the divine. This meant there is no need of the eternal Creator-God since nature itself is eternal. As well, since Epicurus believed in atomic simplicity, he had no need of the Creator-God to produce atomic complexity. Epicurus "took the limits of nature to be imposed by the restrictions of unintelligent matter, matter which by chance *happens* to make up our bodies and souls in a particular way."[26] According to Epicurean cosmology, unintelligent matter produced all that exists in all worlds; unintelligent matter replaced an intelligent divine Designer. Clearly the views of Epicurus and those of Darwin have much in common. They both have a creation process within nature, by nature, and both focus on chance without any possibility of Intelligent Design.

The Renaissance began in Italy in the 1600s and soon spread across Europe. The three-hundred-year period from the Middle Ages to Modernity was a time of real interest in ancient learning due to a discontent with Christianity in the Middle Ages. The Epicurean poem by Lucretius was discovered during this time, beginning a secularization process that today is nearly complete.[27]

23. The poem goes on to say, "the earth deserves the name of mother which she possesses, since from the earth all things have been produced," quoted in Wiker, *Moral Darwinism*, 62, brackets in the original.

24. French naturalist Jean-Baptiste Antoine Pierre de Monet, Chevalier de Lamarck (1744–1829), in 1793 was asked to reclassify the collection of lower animals in the Muséum National d'Histoíre Naturelle, which caused him "to abandon his belief in the immutability of species." He wrote the *Philosophie Zoologique* (1809), in which he presented his theory of evolution. See *A General History of the Sciences: Science in the Nineteenth Century*, ed. René Taton, trans. A. J. Pomerans (London: Thames and Hudson, 1965, 1st Fr. ed. 1961), 3:472–474.

25. Personal correspondence with author.

26. Wiker, *Moral Darwinism*, 48–49.

27. Ibid., 73–74.

From the Renaissance to the Enlightenment "the atomism of Epicurus and Lucretius moved from being an alien smuggled into Christianized culture in the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries to being the only tenable theoretical view of natural philosophy during the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries."[28] This was the time of Galileo Galilei (1564–1642) and Isaac Newton (1642–1727), and Wiker notes that their contribution was the "vindication of atomism through the victory of mathematics." The theoretical victory of ancient atomism took place "in the visible heavens" through astronomy, for "these victories were applied to the invisible, microscopic realm in the sense in which one applies capital made in one area to debts contracted in another."[29]

It is well known that Newton's universe was mechanistic, with natural and predictable laws. In fact, it was a self-contained universe, a closed system of nature, with God being inserted into the system at special points: (1) to create atoms, (2) to position atoms, and (3) to readjust the relation of atoms as needed. However, Wiker notes that Pierre-Simon, marquis de Laplace (1749–1827), a French mathematician and astronomer, demonstrated that the God of the gaps was unnecessary as he applied Newton's natural laws more fully. Soon God had been squeezed out by materialism, and Newtonian mechanistic cosmology became another example of Epicurean materialism. Although Newton's view of God as the grand Designer was nowhere found in Epicurean naturalism, God's causational role was eventually just a small part in Newton's system. Wiker describes this well: "God could only be a kind of divine billiard player, who racked up the atoms to begin with, took the opening shot, but then had to let the atomic billiard balls act and react according to the laws of motion. God had only enough power to take the opening shot."[30]

When it comes to a replacement for biblical creation, there is no essential difference between Epicurean and Darwinian naturalism, for both have a cosmology that excludes God and leaves nature to produce all that is within the world. They both deny a divine Designer, and so both need to come under the critique of Intelligent Design theorists.

DARWIN'S *ORIGIN OF SPECIES* (1859)

Darwin is to be commended for taking five years to travel on the *HMS Beagle* (1831–1836). His room was less than desirable; it was, in fact, quite cramped. He was seasick often, but nevertheless he went on expeditions hundreds of miles

28. Ibid., 111.

29. Ibid.,111–113.

30. Ibid., 135.

inland to study nature in South America, the islands of the Pacific and South Atlantic, and Australia and South Africa.[31]

There is no question that Darwin was true to the scientific method as he gathered data on that journey. He documented how species do change over time, which was contrary to the prevailing opinion of the day. So he made a contribution in that regard. He expressed his findings and his evaluation:

> Although much remains obscure, and will long remain obscure, I can entertain no doubt, after the most deliberate study and dispassionate judgment of which I am capable, that the view which most naturalists entertain, and which I formerly entertained—namely, that each species has been independently created—is erroneous. I am fully convinced that species are not immutable; but that those belonging to what are called the same genera are lineal descendants of some other and generally extinct species, in the same manner as the acknowledged varieties of any one species are the descendants of that species. Furthermore, I am convinced that Natural Selection has been the main but not exclusive means of modification.[32]

What made Darwin's theory so powerful to scientists was: (1) he had extensive data from different parts of the world that demonstrated that there are many species, and (2) he provided a simple reason for these findings, namely natural selection, entailing lineal descent and survival of the fittest (or the best adapted) and their supposed evolution. Thus diversity of species was theorized to be a process of modification and change into new species through nature alone, without any outside interference or guidance.

This had to have shaken his faith, since Patricia Horan rightly notes that the twenty-two-year-old Darwin believed in the Bible's story when he embarked on his five-year field trip.[33] He, along with so many others, believed biblical creation teaches the immutability of species.

FIXITY OF SPECIES

Fixity of species was a general belief in 1828 when Darwin entered Cambridge University to study theology. Whether he already believed it or learned it there doesn't matter, for the phrase "according to their kinds" in Genesis 1:12, 21, 24–25 was interpreted as fixity of species and was certainly Darwin's understanding when he set sail on the *HMS Beagle* in 1836.[34] During his five-year

31. For more details, see Patricia G. Horan, foreword to *The Origin of Species: Complete and Fully Illustrated*, by Charles Darwin (New York: Gramercy Books, 1979), vi.

32. Darwin, *The Origin of the Species*, 69.

33. Horan, foreword to *The Origin of the Species*, v.

34. Darwin states, "that the view which most naturalists entertain, and which I formerly entertained—namely, that each species has been independently created—is erroneous," *The Origin of Species*, 69, cf. 230. He calls it "the common view," 317, and notes that "most eminent palaeontologists, Cuvier, Owen, Agassiz, Barrande, Falconer, E Forbes, etc." "and all our greatest geologists, as Lyell, Murchison, Sedgwick,

voyage this fixity of species idea was called into question by his research. So in 1844, in a letter to his friend Joseph Hooker, Darwin said, "At last gleams of light have come, and I am almost convinced (quite contrary to the opinion I started with) that species are not (it is like confessing a murder) immutable."[35] Today "species are numbered in the millions."[36]

Does Genesis teach a fixity of species? Has this fixity anything to do with reproductive limits? It has been argued that Genesis 1 does not mention reproductive limits. Is there a difference between limits of kinds and fixity of species? Do the kinds speak of larger groupings within which there can be a plethora of species? First, it should be noted that Genesis does not give a taxonomy comparable to science, nor does it need to, for the designations are more from appearance than from detailed analysis. So we should not read into the text more than is intended by the author.

But what is the intent of the author? To answer this, and the above questions, one must study Genesis 1 with its intertextual connections, for the same author, Moses, wrote all the books in which the Hebrew term *mîn* (kinds) is found (except Ezek. 47:10). The word *mîn* occurs thirty-one times in the Hebrew Bible, ten times in Genesis 1, seven times in Genesis 6–7, nine times in Leviticus 11, and four times in Deuteronomy 14.[37] According to the *sola-tota-prima Scriptura* hermeneutical principle, we need to look at the word *mîn* in all these contexts in order to determine what sense Moses was trying to convey.

Genesis 1

The Hebrew word *mîn*, meaning "according to their kinds," occurs ten times in Genesis 1 (vv. 11–12, 21, 24–25). The verses speak of the land producing vegetation of "various kinds" (vv. 11–12). God "created" sea animals and winged birds "according to their kinds" (v. 21). "God said, 'Let the land

have unanimously, often vehemently, maintained the immutability of species," 315–316. Darwin argues that each species is not "immutable," or "independently created" with varieties "produced by secondary laws," 443–455. He argues that "the theory of creation" is "inexplicable" in view of the variation of species, 446, and how they came about through "hereditary modification," or internal rather than merely external conditions (climate and food, for example), and mainly through natural selection, 66–68, cf. 342. Natural selection of species rather than divine fixity of species is Darwin's thesis throughout his *Origin of Species*. However, to believe that species are the same today as in the beginning is to ignore the reality of a global flood. See Jonathan Sarfati, *Refuting Evolution: A Handbook for Students, Parents, and Teachers Countering the Latest Arguments for Evolution* (Green Forest, AR: Master Books, July 2004), 44–45.

35. Charles Darwin letter, quoted in Harold G. Coffin with Robert H. Brown, *Origin by Design* (Hagerstown, MD: Review and Herald, 1983), 447n4.

36. Lawrence B. Slobodkin, *Evolution of Scientific Theories and the Tension in Ecology*, in *History and Evolution*, ed. Matthew H. Nitecki and Doris V. Nitecki (Albany, NY: SUNY Press, 1992), 254.

37. Jiří Moskala, *The Laws of Clean and Unclean Animals of Leviticus 11: Their Nature, Theology, and Rationale (An Intertextual Study)* in *Adventist Theological Society Dissertation Series* 4 (Berrien Springs, MI: Adventist Theological Seminary, 1998), 210–211.

produce living creatures according to their kinds'" (v. 24), and "God made the wild animals according to their kinds" (v. 25).

Genesis 6 and 7

What reinforces the fact that the "kinds" of Genesis 1 refer to various groupings is the way the word *kinds* is used with reference to animals who enter Noah's ark. God said to Noah, "You are to bring into the ark two of all living creatures, male and female, to keep them alive with you. Two of every kind of bird, of every kind of animal and of every kind of creature that moves along the ground will come to you to be kept alive" (6:19–20). Of Noah's family it is said, "They had with them every wild animal according to its kind, all livestock according to their kinds, every creature that moves along the ground according to its kind and every bird according to its kind, everything with wings" (7:14).

Leviticus 11

Leviticus speaks of clean and unclean foods. In the following verses, kinds are designated with the use of the Hebrew word *mîn*: different kinds of black kites (v. 14); ravens (v. 15); hawks (v. 16); herons (v. 19); locusts, katydids, crickets, grasshoppers (v. 22); and great lizards (v. 29).

Deuteronomy 14

Deuteronomy (literally, second law) means the "second legislation," Exodus being the first. It is a repetition indicating the importance of the laws God gave to His people. Deuteronomy 14 speaks of clean and unclean foods, and some are designated by the Hebrew word *mîn* as follows: different kinds of falcons (v. 13), ravens (v. 14), hawks (v. 15), and herons (v. 18).

From the above it seems reasonable to conclude that the Hebrew word *mîn* in the writings of Moses includes groupings of creatures in Genesis 6–7, Leviticus 11, and Deuteronomy 14. This gives strong indication that Moses included this possibility when he used the same word to describe creatures in the creation record (Gen. 1). Based on the intertextuality between Genesis and Leviticus, A. Rahel Davidson Schafer says that it "lends the clue that Genesis is also referring to order and hierarchy created by God." Regarding that she says, "The kind does seem to be larger than a species in most cases," which explains how "all of the kinds of animals were taken onto the ark"; further, the kind-related boundaries "would allow for much microevolution

to take place, while prohibiting macroevolution."[38] Gordon Lewis and Bruce Demarest make the same assessment of the word *mîn:*

> God created each of the living "kinds" (Genesis 1:11–12, 21, 24–25). As a word study shows, the Hebrew word for kind (*min*) designates classifiable biological beings that are capable of reproducing. "Kind" is used in describing the animals that went into Noah's ark (Gen. 6:20; 7:14), or ravens (Lev. 11:15), hawks (v. 16), herons (v. 19), locusts, katydids, crickets, grasshoppers (v. 22), and lizards (v. 29; cf. Deut. 14:13–18).... Living animals will reproduce "each according to its kind" (Gen. 1:24). This allows for development of varieties within the kinds, but not evolution beyond the limits of the kinds. Since the Scriptures do not define the limits of the kinds of animals other than by reproductive capability (1:11, 24), we may leave it to the actual (not imagined or constructed) empirical data to determine where the limits are.[39]

In his article on *mîn*, Mark D. Futato presents several implications of its use:

> (a) There is no evidence in these texts for taking *mîn* as a technical term corresponding with precision to family, genus, or species. (b) *mîn* is used to indicate that the world is not a disorganized mass but a well-ordered subdivided whole, each individual plant and animal fitting into its own "kind," which in turns [sic] fits into a larger group...*mîn* is a key term used for articulating the theme of order through separation. (c) This biblical taxonomy, of which *mîn* is a part, does not reflect a modern taxonomic perspective...but uses "the language of visual appearance".... While modern taxonomy separates birds from bees, the biblical perspective groups them together as "winged creatures." (Gen. 1:20–21)[40]

The point is, fixity of species—the notion that the number of species created in the beginning had been without any increase ever since—as taught in Darwin's day is not what Moses is conveying through his use of *mîn*. Order of species, yes; fixity of species, no. This means that variation within a kind can be enormous, but a dog kind (with its vast variation) never produces a dog-cat kind; Darwin did not know this, and so extrapolated such a dog-cat boundary crossing in his evolutionary theory, thinking he had a right to think so because the variations with species had proved false the fixity of species (which had been wrongly considered biblical).

If Darwin had understood that the biblical account allows for enormous variations within kinds, would he have speculated about evolution from kinds to kinds? Would he still have claimed that the fossil record is to blame for not showing evolution from kinds to kinds? Would he have given nature the incredible ability to

38. A. Rahel Davidson Schafer, "The 'Kinds' of Genesis 1: What is the Meaning of Mîn?" *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, 14/1 (Spring 2003): 98.

39. Gordon R. Lewis & Bruce A. Dearest, *Our Primary Need, Christ's Atoning Provisions*, vol. 2 in *Integrative Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1990), 40.

40. Mark D. Futato, "*mîn*," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology and Exegesis*, (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1997), 2:934.

arrange design in itself, as if it were superhuman, rather than positing the idea that the Creator-God has orchestrated it? Would he have argued from animal breeding to breeding in nature, when animal breeding requires human intelligence?

QUESTIONS HIS THEORY

Darwin admits, "I am well aware that scarcely a single point is discussed in this volume on which facts cannot be adduced, often apparently leading to conclusions directly opposite to those at which I have arrived."[41] Further, he says, "Our ignorance of the laws of variation is profound."[42] By the time Darwin gets to chapter 6 of his *Origin of Species*, he says, "Long before having arrived at this part of my work, a crowd of difficulties will have occurred to the reader. Some of them are so grave that to this day I can never reflect on them without being staggered." Here he is speaking of the absence of transitional forms between one species and another, even though he downplays their absence.[43]

Repeatedly Darwin admits that certain data could scuttle his theory. One example is the complexity of the eye: "To suppose that the eye, with all its inimitable contrivances for adjusting the focus to different distances, for admitting different amounts of light, and for the correction of spherical and chromatic aberration, could have been formed by natural selection, seems, I freely confess, absurd in the highest possible degree."[44] In other words, there is no empirical evidence to overcome this absurdity, so what can overcome it? Darwin answers,

> Yet reason tells me, that if numerous gradations from a perfect and complex eye to one very imperfect and simple, each grade being useful to its possessor, can be shown to exist; if further, the eye does vary ever so slightly, and the variations be inherited, which is certainly the case; and if any variation or modification in the organ be ever useful to an animal under changing conditions of life, then the difficulty of believing that a perfect and complex eye could be formed by natural selection, though insuperable by our imagination, can hardly be considered real.[45]

There are so many conditions given here, as is true of other matters in his *Origin of Species*, that Darwin correctly calls his natural selection a "theory." Granted, all true science begins with observation, progresses to theories, and then proceeds to verify or falsify them. But Darwin's theory does not rise to the level of empirical evidence merely by extrapolating macroevolution from microevolution. Microevolution has empirical evidence, but evidently the development of a complex eye through this method seems insuperable to Darwin. Even

41. Darwin, *The Origin of the Species*, 66.
42. Ibid., 202.
43. Ibid., 205.
44. Ibid., 217.
45. Ibid., 217.

though some examples of natural selection have been observed in nature, no one has witnessed the development from a simple eye (whatever that means) to a complex eye (we will take up the complexity of the eye in more detail later in this chapter). Throwing the development back into deep-time, where no one could verify the change, is merely an unproved premise—without validity.

QUESTIONS OF ORIGIN

PREBIOTIC SOUP

The origin of life is unknown to empirical science, although lots of possibilities have been suggested by evolutionists. A popular thesis assumes that life arose out of a prebiotic soup, when a molecule crossed the divide from organic chemistry to biology. The positing of spontaneous generation to explain the beginning of life goes back to Aristotle (384–322 B.C.).[46] While at the "University of Chicago in 1953 graduate student Stanley Miller, on Harold Urey's lab, placed together methane, ammonia and hydrogen-substances thought to have been present in the primitive earth" and subjected "the chemicals to an electric shock."[47] "Because amino acids are used in building proteins, they are sometimes called the 'building blocks of life.' Subsequent experiments based on the Miller-Urey model produced a variety of amino acids and other simple compounds employed in the genetic process, with the result that the more optimistic researchers concluded that the chemicals needed to construct life could have been present in sufficient abundance on the early earth."[48]

Astrophysicist, Sir Frederick Hoyle, in his 1981 book *Evolution from Space*, declares, "The likelihood of the spontaneous formation of life from inanimate matter is one to a number of 40,000 noughts after it!" He concludes, "It is big enough to bury Darwin and the whole theory of evolution."[49] In the 1980s there was major skepticism of the Miller-Urey experiments. Atmospheric physicists doubted that the early earth's atmosphere contained significant amounts of ammonia, methane, or hydrogen. Molecular biologists discovered that RNA—a bridge from the chemicals to DNA—is "exceedingly difficult to synthesize under

46. Those who promoted the theory of spontaneous generation included Aristotle, Newton, William Harvey, Descartes, and van Helmont, and those who brought about its demise were Francisco Redi, Louis Joblot, and John Tyndall. See Pun, *Evolution*, 191–194.
47. Julius Rebek, Jr., "Synthetic Self-Replicating Molecules," *Scientific American*, vol. 271 (July 1994): 48.
48. Phillip Johnson, *Darwin on Trial* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1991), 102.
49. Fred Hoyle mentioned this in his book *Steady-State Cosmology Re-Visited* (Cardiff, UK: University College Press, 1980), and refers to it in his *Astrophysics and Relativity; The Universe: Past and Present Reflections* (Cardiff, UK: University College Press, May 1981), *Reprint Series #70*; see also Paul Kildare, "Monkey Business," *Christian Order* 23 (December 1982): 589.

the conditions that likely prevailed when life originated." Moreover, RNA is no longer thought to replicate itself easily as once believed.[50]

> Perhaps the most discouraging criticism has come from chemists, who have spoiled the prebiotic soup by showing that organic compounds produced on the early earth would be subject to chemical reactions making them unsuitable for constructing life. In all probability, the prebiotic soup could never have existed, and without it there is no reason to believe that the production of small amounts of some amino acids by electrical charge in a reducing atmosphere had anything to do with the origin of life.[51]

PANSPERMIA

Darwin's *Origin of Species* does not actually discuss origins. Darwin dealt with the evolving of life, not its origin. More than a decade later, in 1871,[52] Darwin stated that life could have emerged on planet earth through chemical processes, involving ammonia, phosphates, and other inorganic materials. This was called abiogenesis. But no one could explain how complex cells could come from random processes, so by the late nineteenth century, many scientists began to think life (like matter) is eternal, and hence they did not have to discover its origin, for it had always existed.

Svante August Arrhenius, Nobel laureate in chemistry in 1901, wrote a book in 1903 titled *Worlds in the Making* in which he attributed life's origin on planet earth to the arrival of living cells from elsewhere.[53] Lord Kelvin and von Hemholtz thought the first life forms were transported to earth by meteorites. Arrhenius said naked bacterial spores were propelled through space by radiation pressure from stellar systems.

So a natural cause of life transportation was ruled out. In its place directed panspermia was introduced by Nobel winner Francis Crick and his associate Leslie Orgel in 1973,[54] and was expanded by Crick in 1981. Crick suggested that life began on some other planet nine billion years ago. According to his view of directed panspermia, Crick believes that bacteria, such as *Escherichia coli*, about one micron wide and two microns long, were packaged and put aboard a space ship and sent to planet earth. The advantage of these bacteria was that they could be frozen alive and most of them survived. "At a very low

50. Walter L. Bradley and Charles B. Thaxton in *The Creation Hypothesis: Scientific Evidence for an Intelligent Designer*, ed. J. P. Moreland (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1994), 175.

51. Johnson, *Darwin on Trial*, 103.

52. *The Descent of Man*, vol. 49 in *Great Books of the Western World* (Chicago: Encyclopedia Britannica 1984), 252–600.

53. See Fred Hoyle and Wickramasinghe, *Evolution from Space: A Theory of Cosmic Creationism* (London: J. M. Dent & Sons, 1981), 35–36, 50–53.

54. Francis H. C. Crick and Leslie E. Orgel, "Directed Panspermia," *Icarus* 19 (1973): 341–346.

temperature, such as that of space, many of them might well survive for well over ten thousand years. They would be almost immune to impact shock and other similar hazards."[55]

Fred Hoyle published his book *Evolution from Space* in 1981; in it he interprets "biology within the framework of a cosmic theory" (which means that life began in the cosmos before it began on planet earth). He regarded genes as cosmic, arriving on earth ready to function. They did not come all at once, but arrived continuously, but not consistently. They were "like seeds in the wind" carried to begin life wherever they took root. They did not require space ships for travel, and were "potentially immortal."[56] Hoyle says:

> For life to have originated on the Earth it would be necessary that quite explicit instructions should have been provided for its assembly. A theory coming roughly within these terms was suggested some twenty years ago, half-jokingly by Tommy Gold. A space-ship landed on the Earth in its early days, scattering living cells, which have evolved and persisted ever since. So far as we are aware, this suggestion has not received much serious discussion in the halls of academe. Yet because it satisfies the need for explicit biochemical information to be supplied to the Earth, Gold's suggestion is less improbable by very many orders of magnitude than the usual organic soup theory. A more serious form of this idea was discussed in 1973 by Francis Crick and Leslie Orgel, once again with a far higher probability of being correct than the usual theory.[57]

Yet it was not long before "Three scientific discoveries called into question the idea of panspermia in the early 20th century: (1) Einstein's theory of general relativity and (2) Edwin Hubble's observation of space expansion, indicating that the universe is not eternal. Hence the universe (and life) had a beginning. (3) Experiments discovered that ultraviolet radiation would kill bacterial spores, because radiation is present in space, and no bacterial could have survived the journey."[58]

In 2006 *Science and Theology News* published three articles on "new scientific theories and findings on the origin of life." The first article looked at NASA findings that may support the common-ancestry hypothesis. Robert McLean, a biologist at Texas State University, San Marcos, collaborated with NASA to have microbiology experiments conducted aboard the space shuttle Columbia in 2003, yet it seemed certain that shuttle Columbia's explosion had destroyed the research work on board. Amazingly the payload was found among the shuttle debris. All three of the bacterial strains sent up with the shuttle were wiped

55. Francis Crick, *Life Itself: Its Origin and Nature* (New York: Touchstone, Simon & Schuster, 1982). 128. It is incredible that some scholars believe life began many times in the universe (Dawkins, Asimov, Billingham), since there is no evidence of life anywhere in the universe outside of planet earth.

56. Hoyle and Wickramasinghe, *Evolution from Space*, 31–32.

57. Ibid., 30.

58. Fazale Rana and Hugh Ross, *Origins of Life: Biblical and Evolutionary Models Face Off* (Colorado Springs, CO: NavPress, 2004), 23.

out during the over one-hundred-seventy-five-degree-Celsius reentry. Yet after a week, a survivor strain (*Microbispora*) was found alive. William Orem concludes that "some bacteria can survive the extreme stresses that would be involved in meteorite entry and impact."[59] Catherine Conley of the NASA Research Center in Moffett Field, California, had sent up six canisters of nematodes (worms about the size of a period after this sentence). Five canisters were found in the debris, and "all five had live populations inside."[60]

Paul C. W. Davies, a theoretical physicist interested in biogenesis (scientific view of how life began), in his book *The 5th Miracle* devotes chapter 7 to Panspermia and then in chapter 8 speaks of Meteorites from Mars. He says, "Hoyle, with collaborator Chandra Wickramasinghe, daringly suggested that maybe life did not originate on earth at all, but was brought here by comets."[61]

McClean is far more cautious: "I'm mindful of a saying by Carl Sagan that extraordinary claims require extraordinary proof. What we're reporting is just a really small piece of the puzzle."[62] William Orem's second article, titled "Life's Genesis: Chemical Genesis," considers how "Origin-of-life research understands how life began. A new Harvard University project known as the Origins of Life in the Universe Initiative was recently announced," and it will look into the cellular origins "to understand the transition from prebiotic to biotic matter." Many researchers support "the RNA World" hypothesis. "Tom Cech, the Nobel laureate found that RNA could be a catalyst [for chemical reactions that allow replication]."[63]

Directed panspermia means aliens brought life to the earth on one or many spaceship trips. But this view doesn't say how these aliens could survive such interplanetary trips and actually deliver the cargo of life. The data opposed to the likelihood of such trips is staggering:

1. The distance is enormous, with no nearby starting places: In 1996 the search for extraterrestrial intelligent life (SETI) demonstrated that such a place is beyond one hundred fifty-five light years away.
2. The dangers of the trip seem too great:

> The traveling life, or life products, would have to steer around nova and supernova remnants, giant stars, young stars, galactic arms, and radiation from the galactic bulge. A straight-line travel path is not possible. Given the zigzagging required, the minimum travel distance would likely exceed 250 light-years. The latest SETI search effort places the minimum travel distance much farther away again.... Any reasonably large spacecraft transporting physical life cannot travel at speeds greater than about 1 percent of the velocity of light (and even that's not a safe speed). The risk of damage to any conceivable physical craft—damage from cosmic rays, space dust, debris, and mechanical wear and tear—increases with the square of the velocity.
>
> Yet the longer the trip, the higher the risk from all other sources. A spacecraft traveling at 1 percent the velocity of light (nearly 7 million miles per hour) would require 25,000 years to traverse 250 light-years. And this makes for a quick trip. The odds of the travelers surviving so long in radiation and sustaining the journey's supplies—not to mention psychological isolation—seem utterly remote.[64]

3. The odds against any life form ready for transportation are enormous:

> Even if the observable universe contained as many as 10 billion trillion planets, the probability that even one of them would possess all the conditions necessary to support physical life, much less to explain its origin, is less than one in 10 [to the power of 172].
>
> Appealing exotic conditions or physics in some distant corner of the galaxy or the cosmos will not work. The universe is homogeneous and uniform, almost perfectly so.[65]

4. It only moves the problem to another location in the universe.

59. William Orem, "Panspermia: Life from the Sky," *Science & Theology News*, vol. 6, no. 9 (May 2006): 24–25.
60. Ibid., 25.
61. Paul C. W. Davies, *The 5th Miracle: The Search for the Origin and Meaning of Life* (New York: A Touchstone Book, 2000; 1st 1999), p. 16. Unlike the chemical version in life beginning in water (prebiotic soup, Darwin), or panspermia, Davies suggests microbes buried in the earth (p. 22).
62. Ibid.
63. Ibid., 16–17.

For a time, evolutionary scientists lacking natural evidence for the causation of life on planet earth, and refusing to consider divine causation, settled for ideas that defied any natural explanation. While rejecting the miraculous (divine causation), they turned to the miraculous (an impossible journey).

EVALUATION

How amazing is the human imagination! Certainly the idea of extraterrestrial life is an inviting explanation for the origins of life on planet earth. What these scholars fail to do is to explain how life began on these other planets. Failure to give an explanation of how life began on this planet (prebiotic soup) is not solved by transporting bacteria on a spaceship or positing genes propelled by cosmic winds from outer space. The question—How did life begin?—is simply moved out into the cosmos.

Furthermore, there is no empirical evidence that bacteria evolve into a complex organism as the first stage of the evolutionary climb to ever-greater complexity. As far as this planet is concerned, there is no evidence of a prebiotic

64. Rana and Ross, *Origins*, 207.
65. Ibid., 206.

soup in the earliest rocks.[66] And even if there were evidence, Klaus Dose from the Institute of Biochemistry, Johannes Gutenberg University, Germany, concludes, "It is extremely unlikely that the first forms of life could have evolved spontaneously in a primordial soup."[67] Granted, but is the theory of Hoyle and Wickramasinghe any more likely? If the prebiotic theory can be disproved, the extraterrestrial theory cannot be proved, although recognizing intelligence as the origin of life on planet earth is a step in the right direction.

Evolution—Fact or Theory?

In South Kensington, a suburb of London, the British Museum of Natural History marked its centenary in 1981 with a new exhibition on Darwinism. Near the entrance, the following notice in flickering lights introduced the exhibit:

> Have you ever wondered why there are so many different kinds of living things? One idea is that all the living things we see today have EVOLVED from a distant ancestor by a process of gradual change. How could evolution have occurred? How could one species change into another? The exhibition in this hall looks at one possible explanation—the explanation first thought of by Charles Darwin.[68]

The prestigious journal *Nature* reacted by immediately publishing an editorial titled "Darwin's death in South Kensington," claiming that this statement by the museum was opposed to the opinion of its staff of distinguished biologists to which twenty-two biologists responded by signing the following letter, which the editor of *Nature* published:

> Sir—As working biologists at the British Museum (Natural History) we were astonished to read your editorial "Darwin's death in South Kensington" (*Nature* 26 February, 735). How is it that a journal such as yours that is devoted to science and its practice can advocate that theory be presented as fact? This is the stuff of prejudice, not science, and as scientists our basic concern is to keep an open mind on the unknowable. Surely it should not be otherwise. You suggest that most of us would rather lose our right hands than begin a sentence with the phrase "If the theory of evolution is true." Are we to take it that evolution is a fact, proven to the limits of scientific rigour? If that is the inference then we must disagree most strongly. We have no absolute proof of the theory of evolution. What we do have is overwhelming circumstantial evidence in favour of it and as yet no better alternative. But the theory of evolution would be abandoned tomorrow if a better theory appeared.[69]

66. Michael Denton, *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis* (Bethesda, MD: Adler and Adler, 1986), 263.

67. Klaus Dose, "The Origin of Life: More Questions than Answers," *Interdisciplinary Science Reviews*, 13:4 (1988): 352.

68. Alan Hayward, *Creation and Evolution: Rethinking the Evidence from Science and the Bible: The Facts and the Fallacies* (London: Triangle, 1985), 13–14.

69. Hayward, *Creation and Evolution*, 14.

The distinction between theory and fact is one that many evolutionary scientists fail to make. They fail to distinguish between the assumption of macroevolution and the factuality of microevolution. But these British biologists exhibited a truly scientific attitude in keeping an open mind.

James McClendon, Jr., says, "We need to ask the following questions: (a) To what degree does the conflictual [conflict, survival of the fittest or the best adapted] language in which Darwin expressed his theory prejudice or distort scientists' observation of nature itself? And (b) What corrections are needed in the presumed theological implications of evolutionary biology?"[70] He also notes, "Philosophers of science have made it clear that no amount of evidence ever amounts to proof of a scientific theory.... Even when one theory is clearly ahead in the contest it can never be known in advance that the loser will not someday be turned around by a genius with a brilliant insight, or that some undreamed-of theory might not be proposed in its place."[71]

Evolution—Fact or Fiction?

Pope Benedict XVI claims that "the theory of evolution is an empirically based and verifiable theory that holds in the natural sciences a position comparable to that of the various theories of physics, for example [Newtonian] mechanics, electrodynamics, or quantum mechanics. In the form of population genetics, the theory has even been formalized mathematically."[72] By contrast Nancy Pearcey, in her book *Total Truth: Liberating Christianity from Its Cultural Captivity*, presents a number of fundamental beliefs of evolution that are false.[73]

Darwin's theory about finch beaks is the first example. He discovered that beak size slightly lengthened during drought periods, enabling finches to eat larger tougher seeds, but the beaks returned to normal size (only one millimeter, the thickness of thumbnail) when the drought ended. In short, minor changes allowed finches to remain finches. Darwin believed this was proof of the evolutionary process at work. Pearcey rightly counters, "Such limited, reversible change is hardly evidence for a theory that requires *un*limited, directional change."[74] Darwin clearly read into these changes among the finches far more than the evidence suggested; they simply do not support macroevolution.

70. James Wm. McClendon, Jr., and Nancey Murphy, *Witness*, vol. 3 in *Systematic Theology* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 2000), 116.

71. Ibid., 115–116.

72. Stephan Otto Horn and Siegfried Wiedenhofer, *Creation and Evolution: A Conference with Pope Benedict XVI in Castel Gandolfo*, trans. Michael J. Miller (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius, 2007), 28.

73. We will not take up fake embryo drawings, as these are considered in a segment below.

74. Nancy Pearcey, *Total Truth: Liberating Christianity from Its Cultural Captivity* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway Books, 2004), 160, italics in original.

Dysfunctional fruit flies are the second example used to support evolutionary theory. Since mutations are a basic premise for macroevolution, and because fruit flies reproduce in a few days, they afford scientists an opportunity to study several generations to see what effects induced mutations (radiation and toxic chemicals) have on subsequent offspring. Changes such as larger or smaller wings, shriveled wings or no wings, were achieved, but none of these changes enable the fruits flies to fly better, and all of them were still fruit flies at the end of the study. Further, fifty years of experimentation with fruit flies has not produced one example of an improved fruit fly. The changes were all within the confines of the species, with no exception.[75] (Hardly a way for the survival of the fittest, or the best adapted, to produce new species.)

Doctored moths are the third example. During the Industrial Revolution in England, smoke and soot darkened tree trunks so that dark gray-peppered moths were hard for predatory birds to see, but light-gray peppered moths were clearly visible and therefore eaten. Over time most peppered moths in existence were dark gray, and textbooks display photos of both varieties of peppered moths on tree trunks as evidence of natural selection. Recently it was discovered that peppered moths do not perch on tree trunks but are found higher up—which means the photos were staged. Scientists glued dead moths onto the trunks, yet these fake pictures still appear as evidence for evolution in textbooks.[76]

In fairness it should be said that camouflage does help in the survival of the fittest or the best adapted, but this is hardly evidence for macroevolution.

Evolution Questioned

FINITE UNIVERSE AND ENTROPY

We live in a finite universe (created by the Big Bang), and science tells us that natural resources are not infinite. Further, the second law of thermodynamics guarantees that living things are, by their nature, running down. As Charles Brown explains, "Heat will, of its own accord, flow only from a hot object to a cold object. Scientists decide from this second law that no heat engine can be completely efficient. A gasoline engine continuously converts heat into work. The second law requires that, even in a perfect engine, only part of the heat supply is converted into work."[77] Stanley Angrist adds, "The total entropy of the

75. Ibid., 160–161.
76. Ibid., 161–162.
77. Charles L. Brown, "Thermodynamics" in *The World Book Encyclopedia* (Chicago, IL: Field Enterprises Educational Corporation, n.d.), 19:193.

universe is increasing because, in time, all matter tends to lose available energy. Entropy is also used as a measure of the internal disorder in a substance. The atoms of a diamond are orderly because chemical bonds lock them in a rigid framework. But the atoms of helium gas in a balloon are disorderly because they shoot about inside the balloon. Therefore, a diamond has a much lower entropy than does helium."[78]

Leonard Brand points out that entropy only applies to physical systems like heat. Biological systems have a built-in energy-converting mechanism (photosynthesis, for example) to convert the sun's energy and so act against entropy. The problem for evolution is not entropy, but rather how a biochemical mechanism like photosynthesis originated.[79] In this section, we will give a few examples of evolution linked to entropy: (1) Some claim microevolution is evidence for macroevolution. Yet even in microevolution "chromosome and gene 'mutations' are themselves almost always deteriorative rather than progressive and so constitute further verification of the universal entropy principle";[80] (2) Henry Morris and John Whitcomb recognize that the "almost infinite accumulation of improbabilities in the theory of total evolution is nothing less than an absolute denial of the second law of thermodynamics—despite the fact that it has been always verified experimentally wherever tested!"[81]

Entropy (second law of thermodynamics) means that the universe is running down. So we must ask if unlimited advancement (biological evolution) is likely in a universe that is in the process of running down. Are they not mutually exclusive?

MUTATIONS QUESTIONED

In a finite universe with the problem of entropy, we have the larger context for understanding the limitations of mutations. The smaller context has to do with the immediate limitations in nature where mutations take place. Mutations are the very essence of evolutionary theory. Evolutionary theorists claim that the process of change takes place through chance and natural selection. If this seems impossible, then it is claimed that given sufficient time these changes can take place, for complex organisms do, after all, exist. But this doesn't tell us how they exist, or whether they have always existed. It is assumed that they must have evolved in order to be present now. But this really begins with the present complexity in nature and assumes that it has not always been that way—that the empirical evidence for micro change must necessarily be stretched to include

78. Stanley W. Angrist, "Entropy," in *The World Book Encyclopedia*, 6:260a.
79. Personal correspondence with the author.
80. Henry M. Morris and John C. Whitcomb, *The Genesis Flood: The Biblical Record and Its Scientific Implications* (Phillipsburg, NJ: Institute for Creation Research, 1961), 226–227.
81. Ibid., 226.

macro changes, even though there is no compelling evidence to substantiate the process from simple to complex that is required for macroevolution.

Scientist H. J. Muller, an expert in gene mutations, evaluates mutations within a biological context:

> It is entirely in line with the accidental nature of natural mutations that extensive tests have agreed in showing the vast majority of them to be detrimental to the organism in its job of surviving and reproducing, just as changes accidently introduced into any artificial mechanism are predominantly harmful to its useful operation. According to the conception of evolution based on the studies of modern genetics, the whole organism has its basis in its genes. Of these, there are thousands of different kinds, interacting with great nicety in the production and maintenance of the complicated mechanism of the given type of organism. Accordingly, by the mutation of one of these genes or another, any component structure or function, and in many cases combinations of these components, may become diversely altered. Yet in all except very rare cases the change will be disadvantageous, involving impairment of function.[82]

Japanese biologist Motoo Kimura proposed that most mutations are neutral, with no selective effect,[83] so they do not depend on natural selection—a scientific theory that questions evolutionary theory based on survival of the fittest (or the best adapted). James Barham notes that "to be viable, changes must be *coordinated*." Elementary statistical mechanics, a science in its own right, shows the need for such coordination. "One cannot tinker at random with a functionally integrated system and expect to achieve beneficial results." To believe otherwise "is no different from invoking miracles"[84] (which are anathema to evolutionary theory). If miracles are required to get around the science of statistical mechanics, then evolutionary theory exchanges hard science for imaginary miracles.

Physical chemist Jonathan Sarfati notes that the evolution process is dependent upon natural selection "coupled with hypothetical information-gaining mutations." Yet, when creatures adapt to a new environment, this adaptation takes "the form of *weeding out* some genetic information." So there is "*a loss of genetic information*, the opposite of what microbe-to-man evolution needs in order to be credible."[85] Similarities between ape and human DNA are often exaggerated. Sarfati says:

> A point often overlooked is the vast *differences* between different kinds of creatures. Every creature has an encyclopedic information content, so even a small

82. H. J. Muller, "How Radiation Changed the Genetic Constitution," *Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists* 1955, 11 (November 1955): 331, quoted in Morris and Whitcomb, *The Genesis Flood*, 227.

83. See Marcel-Paul Schützenberger, *Uncommon Dissent: Intellectuals Who Find Darwinism Unconvincing*, ed. William A. Dembski (Wilmington, DE: ISI Books, 2005, 1st ed. 2004), 48.

84. James Barham, "Why I Am Not a Darwinist," in *Uncommon Dissent*, 182–183.

85. Sarfati, *Refuting Evolution*, 3436, emphasis in original.

> percentage difference means that a lot of information would be required to turn one kind into another. Since humans have an amount of information equivalent to a thousand 500-page books, a 4 percent difference [the difference between ape and human DNA] amounts to 40 large books [again, even if we assume that the hybridization data really correlates to gene sequence similarity]. That is, random mutation plus natural selection is expected to generate the information equivalent of 12 million words arranged in a meaningful sequence. This is an impossibility even if we grant the 10 million years asserted by evolutionists. Population genetics calculations show that animals with human-like generation times of about 20 years could substitute no more than about 1,700 mutations in that time.[86]

Writing about the theory of common ancestry, Jonathan Wells concludes, "I found absolutely no evidence that genetic mutation can produce beneficial changes in anatomy, of the sort needed by evolutionary theory. Nor did I find evidence that mutations (any more than selection) could produce new species. So by 1978 I had become convinced that the Neo-Darwinian mechanism of evolution was scientifically unsupported."[87]

Lynn Margulis is famous for her research into the idea that mitochondria were once independent bacterial cells. Phillip Johnson says that she "regularly challenges scientific colleagues to name a single unambiguous example of the formation of a new species by the accumulation of micromutations. The challenge being unmet, she commented acidly that science will one day judge neo-Darwinism as 'a minor twentieth-century religious sect within the sprawling religious persuasion of Anglo-Saxon biology.'"[88]

EMBRYO SIMILARITIES QUESTIONED

Books on evolution present drawings that make the embryos of animals of different species appear quite similar. They are based upon the 1874 embryo drawings of German scientist Ernst Haeckel. Darwin was influenced and misled by Haeckel (a contemporary) as evidenced in a letter he wrote stating that embryos were "by far the strongest single class of facts in favor of" his theory.[89] Over one hundred years later, in 1997, Mike Richardson and his team collected photos of a large number of different embryos which show them to be "very distinct."[90] Recently, in 1998, in a letter to *Science*, Richardson said,

86. Sarfati, *Refuting Evolution*, 84.

87. Jonathan Wells, "Common Ancestry on Trial," in *Darwin's Nemesis: Phillip Johnson and the Intelligent Design Movement*, ed. William A. Dembski (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Academic, 2006), 165.

88. Phillip Johnson, *The Wedge of Truth: Splitting the Foundations of Naturalism* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2000), 72.

89. Charles Darwin, letter to Asa Gray, September 10, 1860, in *The Life and Letters of Charles Darwin*, ed. Francis Darwin (New York : Appleton, 1896), 2:131.

90. For a good picture showing the marked difference between Haeckel's drawings and real embtyos (which Haeckel hid from the public), see Nancy R. Pearcey, *Total Truth*, 164 (5.5), and compare with 163 (5.4). The

"The core scientific issue remains unchanged: Haeckel's drawings of 1874 are substantially fabricated. In support of this view, I note that his oldest 'fish' image is made up of bits and pieces from different animals—some of them mythical. It is not unreasonable to characterize this as 'faking'.... Sadly, it is the discredited 1874 drawings that are used in so many British and American biology textbooks today."[91]

LINEAR DESCENT QUESTIONED

The science of nonlinear dynamics refutes the claims of evolution. There are many examples of this in the book *Self-Organizing Systems*.[92] "Darwinists seem to me to have preserved a mechanistic vision of evolution, one that prompts them to observe merely a linear succession of causes and effects. The idea that causes may interact with one another is now standard in mathematical physics."[93]

With respect to the DNA, transmission sequencing has been understood as a vertical process, from ancestors up to the present day, so a single "tree of life" is envisaged for all the species. But the genome sequence studies revealed that this is not always true. In at least two microbial domains (bacteria and archaea), "much of the inheritance is in a horizontal direction. Significant portions of the genome of a particular species came not from its ancestors but arrived at various times from the species that were its neighbors through what is termed 'horizontal gene transfer.'"[94]

Developmental biologist Jonathan Wells has discovered that the "whole Darwinian story—pattern as well as process—was driven by an *a priori* commitment to materialistic, antitheistic philosophy. The pattern of evolution was not something that had been inferred from overwhelming evidence in paleontology, molecular biology and embryology, but something that was assumed from the start."[95] William Dembski rightly points out that evolutionists are in a "defensive posture. If they could demonstrate the power of material mechanisms to

contrast is so great that it indicates to what extent a fanatical evolutionary scientist will go to advance evolution.

91. M. K. Richardson, "Haeckel's Embryos, Continued," letter to *Science*, vol. 281, no. 5381 (August 28, 1998): 1289.

92. F. Eugene Yates, ed., *Self-Organizing Systems: The Emergence of Order* (New York: Plenum, 1987). The preface states, "Technological systems become organized by commands from outside, as when human intentions lead to the building of structures or machines. But many natural systems become structures by their own internal processes: these are the self-organizing systems, and the emergence of order within them is a complex phenomenon that intrigues scientists from all disciplines," xi. How can the evolutionary assumption of chance result in such complex self-organizing systems? Scientist L. James Gibson says, "The problem is that, according to theory, the systems did not arise by evolution, but the principle of self-organization gave rise to the systems. Chance starting points would give rise to different self-organizing systems," personal correspondence with author.

93. Marcel-Paul Schützenberger," The Miracles of Darwinism," in *Uncommon Dissent*, 46.

94. Roland F. Hirsch, "Darwinian Evolutionary Theory and the Life Sciences in the Twenty-First Century" in *Uncommon Dissent*, 217.

95. Wells, "Common Ancestry on Trial," in *Darwin's Nemesis*, 169.

generate biological complexity and diversity," the Intelligent Design movement would not exist.[96]

DEVELOPMENT THEORY QUESTIONED

When James Watson and Francis Crick discovered the structure of DNA in the 1950s, Neo-Darwinism saw this as a molecular basis for genetics, concluding that all organisms develop according to a program encoded in their genes, with DNA transmitted to descendants. In the 1980s comparative embryologists discovered "many cases in which organisms with very similar morphologies follow radically dissimilar pathways in early development." Biologist Jonathan Wells says, "recent discoveries in developmental genetics and comparative embryology pose serious problems for neo-Darwinism."[97]

This is because recent discovery has shown that biological structures are determined by their genes, and different structures must be a result of different genes. Wells says, "As homeotic genes [involved in development] turn out to be more and more universal, the control they exercise in development turns out to be less and less specific." Wells concludes, "Recent advances in developmental biology thus point to an impending paradigm shift. Advances in other fields do too, but the insights from developmental biology point so convincingly to a scientific revolution" which he believes "will be based on design."[98]

DEEP-TIME QUESTIONED: TOO SHORT TO EXPLAIN BIODIVERSITY

Biologist L. James Gibson questions whether deep-time can account for biodiversity. He maintains that (1) "even 15 billion years is much too short a time to plausibly allow for life to originate spontaneously"; (2) "unguided evolution is unthinkable in a short chronology." (3) As well, he asks "whether the rate of evolutionary change inferred from fossil intermediates is sufficient to account for biodiversity."[99]

96. Dembski, "Dealing with the Backlash Against Intelligent Design," in *Darwin's Nemesis*, 103.

97. Jonathan Wells, "Unseating Naturalism," in *Mere Creation* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Ptess, 1998), 51–53.

98. Jonathan Wells in *Mere Creation*, 53–68.

99. L. James Gibson, "Biology and Time" (paper, Faith and Science Conference, Glacier View, Colorado, August 2003), 1–2. Fred Hoyle said ten billion years was too short a petiod to account for "the vast store of information necessary for the development of biology," *Astrophysics and Relativity*, 7. Hoyle says further, "How does one deal with a probability as small as one part in 10 (to the power of 40000)? In my view only by giving the Universe a very long history, much longer that ten billion years," 8. Biologist J. R. Nusall of Edmonton University believes life arose simultaneously in many parts of the world. See Gordon Rattray Taylor, *The Great Evolution Mystery* (New York: Harper & Row, 1983), 199–200.

Scientists have demonstrated mutations or a change in a gene. They have succeeded in manipulating genes, such as changing the location of legs on fruit flies, but that is not the same as increasing complexity or evolution of new features. Gibson adds, "At this point, there seems to be good reason to doubt that gradual development of new organs through evolutionary processes is possible." For all experimentation to date demonstrates "developmental and morphological stability."[100]

Gibson notes, "Morphological change has been demonstrated and molecular mechanisms are known for variations within a species. What is missing is demonstration that the processes can explain different body plans and new organs."[101] The following quote is in this context, as contrasted with microevolution. "'Deep Time' is not a mechanism, and cannot substitute as an explanation for the origins of biodiversity. Without experimental demonstration of morphological change, and in the absence of a known molecular mechanism of change, evolution seems more like a 'metaphysical research program' than a scientific theory."[102]

Enormous amounts of time have been a safe haven for the evolutionary hypothesis. The theorists believe that, given sufficient time, any evolutionary development is possible. If evolution were a steady, linear development, then sufficient time makes the theory seem plausible. Yet Huston Smith says:

> We now see that significant organic changes require that innumerable component developments occur *simultaneously* and *independently* in bones, nerves, muscles, arteries and the like. These requirements escalate the demand on probability theory astronomically. It would be like having 26 come up simultaneously on [10] or 15 tables in the same casino, followed by all the tables reporting 27, 28, and 29 in lockstep progression; more time than the earth has existed would be needed to account for the sequences that have occurred.[103]

DEEP-TIME QUESTIONED: TOO LONG TO EXPLAIN THE CONTINENTS

While James Gibson argues that geological time is far too short for evolution to explain biodiversity, Ariel Roth argues that geological time is far too long for oceans not to be filled through land erosion—actually, filled twelve times.[104]

100. Personal correspondence with author.
101. Personal correspondence with author.
102. Gibson, "Biology and Time," 3.
103. Huston Smith, "Evolution and Evolutionism," *The Christian Century* (July 7–14, 1982): 756. See also Scott M. Huse, *The Collapse of Evolution* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1983; repr. 1986), 92, where he argues, "The handiwork of time is disassociation and disintegration, not synthesis."
104. Ariel A. Roth, "Scientific Evidence That Affirms a Recent Creation" (paper, Faith and Science Conference, Glacier View, Colorado, August 2003).

It is not a scientific solution to claim deep-time is needed to accomplish the small mutations necessary to originate life and develop it from molecule to man when that same deep-time would erode all land masses and fill the oceans twelve times.[105] Geologic time is entrenched globally in scientific academia. Yet empirical evidence in the minor erosion in the land masses of the world speaks volumes in favor of a young creation. To admit this is to be scientific. To ignore it is to leave the confines of science and commit to a metaphysical philosophy. (Even though radioisotope dating is an accepted scientific argument for deep-time, one must keep in mind that radiometric dating has been questioned, so even deep-time should be discussed with some degree of tentativeness, while waiting for further scientific research to shed light on this question.)

FAITH IS NOT EMPIRICAL EVIDENCE

Faith in either macroevolution or in creation by God is still only faith. It is not based on empirical evidence. Because it cannot be demonstrated in the lab today, the origin of humankind—whether by evolution or God's creation—lies beyond the proper domain of science, which is limited to that which can be tested. That which stands beyond the demonstrable belongs to the realm of philosophy or metaphysics, not the realm of science. Colin Patterson, senior paleontologist at the British Natural History Museum, characterized evolution and creationism "as scientifically vacuous concepts which are held primarily on the basis of faith."[106]

Is evolution a science? Most people tend to think that it is. Yet true science is able to be tested, and either verified or falsified through experimentation. On those terms, does evolutionary theory qualify as science? Different answers have been given to this question.

At one time, Karl Popper, a leading exponent of the philosophy of science, questioned whether evolution is scientific because it is not falsifiable. In 1974 he wrote, "I have come to the conclusion that Darwinism is not a testable scientific theory, but a metaphysical research programme."[107] Later Popper conceded that certain aspects of evolution are testable, and to that extent it is scientific.[108] But so much of evolutionary theory remains beyond the objectivity of science, such as the origin of life in the beginning and the assumed process of gradualism, which in transitional stages, over billions of years, produced the ascendancy of species

105. To be fair, one has to factor into this discussion the fact that radioisotope dating is a scientific argument that apparently supports deep-time.
106. Johnson, *Darwin on Trial*, 9.
107. Karl Popper, quoted in Brian Leith, *The Descent of Darwin: A Handbook of Doubts about Darwinism* (St. James Place, London: Collins, 1982), 26.
108. Leith, *Descent of Darwin*, 28.

from molecule to man. The claim that complexity was produced by random genetic mutation and natural selection (claims that have not been verified) questions the scientific nature of evolution. If it were true science, we would expect to have more evidence of transitionals in the fossil record, and perhaps some that are observable today. The shaky foundation of evolution was powerfully illustrated by Popper as follows:

> The empirical basis of objective science has thus nothing "absolute" about it. Science does not rest upon solid bedrock. The bold structure of its theories rises, as it were, above a swamp. It is like a building erected on piles (testing). The piles are driven down from above into the swamp, but not down to any natural or "given" base; and if we stop driving the piles deeper, it is not because we have reached firm ground. We simply stop when we are satisfied that the piles are firm enough to carry the structure, at least for the time being.[109]

Faith is better placed in Christ the Creator, in His commentary on creation in the fourth commandment—a literal Sabbath followed six literal days of creation (Exod. 20:8–11).

Stephen Jay Gould questions evolution, for "[t]he absence of fossil evidence for intermediary stages between major transitions in organic design, indeed our inability, even in our imaginations, to construct functional intermediates in many cases, has been a persistent and nagging problem for gradualistic accounts of evolution."[110]

Evolution Slowing Down

In 1977, French biologist Pierre-Paul Grassé wrote that evolution was all but completed:

> Evolution has not only slowed down, but with the aging of the biosphere, it has also decreased in scope and in extent. We are certain that it does not operate today as it did in the remote past. Something has changed. It is of the utmost importance to determine what has changed; this should shed light upon the internal mechanisms of the phenomena. The structural plans no longer undergo complete reorganization; novelties are no longer plentiful. Evolution, after its last enormous effort to form the mammalian orders and man, seems to be out of breath and drowsing off. I find this metaphor a good description of the present state of evolutionary phenomena.[111]

109. Karl Popper, *The Logic of Scientific Study* (London: Hutchinson, 1968), 111.

110. Stephen Jay Gould, in *Evolution Now: A Century After Darwin*, ed. John Maynard Smith (New York: Macmillan, 1982), 140.

111. Pierre-Paul Grassé, *Evolution of Living Organisms: Evidence for a New Theory of Transformation* (New York: Academic Press, 1977), 71. Sixteen years before Grassé's statement, botanist E. J. H. Corner of Cambridge University read a paper before the Botanical Society of Edinburgh (1961) in which he stated, "I strongly contest the view that we cannot learn how evolution has occurred from living things," *Contemporary Botanical Thought*, ed. Anna M. MacLeod and L. S. Cobley (Chicago: Quadrangle, 1961), 100.

How does biologist Grassé know evolution is slowing down? How does he know that it had greater intensity in the past? How does he know it had spent one last enormous effort to form mammalian orders and humans? He wasn't present to observe whether these claims were empirically trustworthy, so these claims cannot rise beyond the level of hypotheses. Critics can respond by asking why, if uniformitarianism is the foundational assumption of evolutionary theory, the present state of evolution can't be read back into the past in a uniform manner, with no change in variation. If uniformitarianism is true, on what basis does Grassé defend his thesis?

Grassé called for setting "aside the accepted doctrines, notably every form of Darwinism." Thus, evolution is not a random or continuous phenomenon tied to natural selection. Death often happens in the normal course of events, and "interspecific competition is very far from being universal." He offers a different theory of evolution, one that endows creation with the ability to create, for "[i]n order to create, evolution demands new materials, such as genes formed *de novo*.... Every novelty demands its own genes, which are themselves also novelties."[112] This confronts much of evolutionary theory with yet another theory which cannot be proved true.

Intelligent Design

Biblical creationists and atheistic evolutionists agree that design is found in nature, and they give design credit to God or natural selection respectively. Scientist James Gibson comments, "Design is found in nonliving parts of nature also, which no one would attribute to natural selection."[113] Atheists would attribute the appearance of design either to chance or to natural law. Apparently natural selection is endowed with intelligence, whatever that means, so that design appears through chance over deep-time.

On the other hand, Richard Dawkins of Oxford University says, "Biology is the study of complicated things that give the appearance of having been designed for a purpose," and then devotes the rest of his book to disproving that there is design in nature.[114] Stephen Meyer says some scientists believe design in nature is only an illusion.[115] Oxford University's Alister McGrath, commenting on Intelligent Design, says "It is not an approach which I

112. Grassé, *Evolution*, 203–204.

113. Personal correspondence with author.

114. Richard Dawkins, *The Blind Watchmaker: Why the Evidence of Evolution Reveals a Universe Without Design* (New York: W.W. Norton & Co., 1996, 1st ed. 1986), 1.

115. Stephen C. Meyer, *Signature in the Cell: DNA and the Evidence for Intelligent Design* (New York: Harper Collins, 2009), 12.

accept, either on scientific or theological grounds."[116] So is there design in nature or not?

Until recent times the design debate was confined to biology. Today it includes physics and cosmology. It is now known that the cosmos is intricately arranged. The anthropic principle is crucial to life on planet earth. If the world were only a little closer to the sun, it would be too hot for life on the planet, and if a little farther away from the sun, it would be too cold for life to exist on the planet. It is difficult to argue that this is the product of blind chance.

> The Anthropic Principle is the Law of Human Existence. It is well known that our existence in this universe depends on numerous cosmological constants and parameters whose numerical values must fall within a very narrow range of values. If even a single variable were off, even slightly, we would not exist. The extreme improbability that so many variables would align so auspiciously in our favor merely by chance has led some scientists and philosophers to propose instead that it was God who providentially engineered the universe to suit our specific needs. This is the Anthropic Principle: that the universe appears to have been fine-tuned for our existence.[117]

Some leaders of the Intelligent Design movement include Phillip Johnson, Michael J. Behe, and William A. Dembski.[118] Although the purpose of Intelligent Design scholars is not to prove the Genesis creation record, but to confront nonscience with science (see below), it is instructive to know, "By wisdom the LORD laid the earth's foundations, by understanding he set the heavens in place" (Prov. 3:19). The Creator is truly an Intelligent Designer. That is why, for example, "Ants are creatures of little strength, yet they store up their food in the summer; hyraxes are creatures of little power, yet they make their home in the crags; locusts have no king, yet they advance together in ranks" (Prov. 30:25–27).

Atheistic scientists claim that speaking of Intelligent Design is an excuse to smuggle God into the discussion, and hence to question science which is confined (by scientists) to methodological naturalism. These scientists reject

116. Alister McGrath and Joanna Collicutt McGrath, *The Dawkins Delusion? Atheist Fundamentalism and the Denial of the Divine* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2007), 30. McGrath claims that Intelligent Design "argues for an 'Intelligent Designer' based on gaps in scientific explanation, such as the 'irreducible complexity' of the world," 30. An apparently contrary view is held by molecular biophysicist Cornelius Hunter: "Intelligent design has not stepped into a God-of-the-gaps blunder for the simple reason that it is not predicating religious faith on scientific results." Intelligent design "is mainly interested in pursuing the experimental sciences without a priori assumptions about the right answer. Unfortunately, there is a common misunderstanding that intelligent design is opposed to all naturalistic explanations. Nothing could be further from the truth. Intelligent design is opposed, however, to simple-minded, dogmatic blinders when we are dealing with complex problems. We should not assume we know the kind of answers science must produce when there is much uncertainty," *Science's Blind Spot: The Unseen Religion of Scientific Naturalism* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos, 2007), 146–147.

117. "What is the Anthropic Principle?" accessed December 8, 2011, www.gotquestions.org.

118. See *Darwin's Nemesis: Phillip Johnson and the Intelligent Design Movement*, ed. William A. Dembski (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2006).

Intelligent Design as an attempt to credit God with life, and hence to support Scripture rather than science. However, as we will see below, Intelligent Design is supported by empirical evidence, and so should be accepted as a scientific quest as valid as any other.

INTELLIGENT DESIGN CONFRONTS NON-SCIENCE WITH SCIENCE

How can evolution be objective if it limits the possibilities that it can consider? As a science, it rejects the intrusion of the supernatural, and thus it is not unlike a detective who is searching for clues but is barred from considering some that may be helpful. As Phillip Johnson rightly observes, "That kind of science is not free of prejudice. On the contrary, it is defined by a prejudice. The prejudice is that all phenomena can ultimately be explained in terms of purely natural causes, which is to say unintelligent causes."[119]

In speaking of the battles between creation and evolution, Nancy Pearcey is right that "the heart of the battle is whether the universe is the result of Intelligent Agency or of blind, noncognitive forces—and that's where we must direct our energies. Christians need to bracket peripheral issues and focus on the crucial point of whether there is evidence for Intelligent Design in the universe."[120] William Dembski is right that no physicist argues for the truth of Einsteinian physics by pointing to another theory,[121] because the hard sciences (physics and chemistry) do not need to look elsewhere for evidence—they contain evidence. Neither do physicists vilify those who oppose their empirical views; they simply allow the evidence to speak for itself. While this is not to suggest that there is no evidence for the science that is defined by philosophical naturalism, it does mean that this kind of science is narrowly focused from the start, and so its results can be expected to reflect that.

Even though evolutionists do a credible work in carefully documenting empirical evidence for microevolution, they cannot scientifically explain the origin of the process. They have no empirical and incontrovertible evidence for the origin of life. Micro change is as verified by evidence as observations made in hard sciences. But to assume a giant leap from micro to macro change, from molecule to man, is a departure from empirical science, and a plunge into metaphysical and speculative philosophy. The radical distinction between empirical

119. Johnson, *Wedge of Truth*, 14.

120. Nancy R. Pearcey, *Total Truth*, 174. Pearcey speaks of Christians engaged in "endless arguments over theological questions like the length of the creation 'days' and the extent of the Genesis flood," 173. However, the truth about both is found in Scripture, because belief in the supernatural worldview means God has revealed that the days were literally twenty-four hours in length (see chap. 1) and the flood was global (see chap. 8).

121. Dembski, *Uncommon Dissent*, xx.

evidence and empty speculation must never be glossed over. It is not Intelligent Design that masquerades as science but evolutionary theory that masquerades as science. Hence, the contention between Intelligent Design and evolutionary theory can only be resolved on the basis of which seems to give the better, more plausible explanation of the evidence.

Even true science is rejected in the name of macroevolutionary theory: "What went wrong in the wake of the Darwinian triumph was that the authority of science was captured by an ideology, and the evolutionary scientists thereafter believed what they wanted to believe rather than what the fossil data, the genetic data, the embryological data and the molecular data were showing them."[122] These rejected areas of science present a formidable scientific refutation of macroevolutionary theory, and Intelligent Design scholars are again taking up the banner of scientific truth that has been long neglected.

As of 2010, Intelligent Design scientists "have a growing program of scientific research and are now publishing research supporting intelligent design in the peer-reviewed mainstream scientific literature, especially in the biological literature. A related indicator is that increasingly their work is being studied and critiqued within the mainstream scientific literature."[123] Special sciences, such as artificial intelligence, cryptography, and the science of random number generation (used for video games) employ the concept of design.[124] "Intelligence is the only type of cause with the demonstrated power to produce things like new information (such as we find in DNA) or complex machines that require all of their parts to function (like the rotary engines bacteria use to get around)."[125]

The charge that Intelligent Design is a religious, not a scientific idea, is turned on its head by Stephen Meyer. He notes that:

> scientists on both sides of the origins controversy have ideological or metaphysical or religious (or antireligious) motivations. Barbara Forrest, a leading critic of intelligent design, is a board member of the New Orleans Secular Humanist Association. Other prominent critics of intelligent design such as Eugene Scott and Michael Shermer have signed the American Humanist Manifesto 111. Richard Dawkins' sympathies are well known [atheist]. Aleksandr Oparin was a committed Marxist. Kenneth Miller takes a different, though no less disinterested tack. He claims that Darwinism illuminates his religious beliefs as a Catholic.[126]

122. Phillip Johnson, in *Mere Creation*, 448–449.
123. William A. Dembski and Jonathan Witt, *Intelligent Design Uncensored: An Easy-to-Understand Guide to the Controversy* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2010), 28.
124. Dembski and Witt, *Intelligent Design Uncensored*, 36.
125. Ibid., 39.
126. Ibid, 41. Meyer, *Signature in the Cell*, 448.

PURPOSE OF INTELLIGENT DESIGN ARGUMENT

As we come to examine the work of Intelligent Design theorists, we must be clear that these scholars evaluate evolutionary theory solely on the basis of whether it is good science. Intelligent Design can have theological implication,[127] but it can be promoted by those who are not Christians. Intelligent Design proponents attempt to meet evolutionary science on its own turf. This is misunderstood by many evolutionary theorists who react violently to the words *Intelligent Design*, convinced that Intelligent Design demands that science be evaluated by Scripture. Nothing could be farther from the truth. William Dembski declares:

> Whenever these methods detect intelligent causation, the underlying entity they uncover is information. Intelligent design properly formulated is a theory of information. Within such a theory, information becomes a reliable indicator of intelligent causation as well as a proper object for scientific investigation. Intelligent design thereby becomes a theory for detecting and measuring information, explaining its origin and tracing its flow. Intelligent design is therefore not the study of intelligent causes per se but of informational pathways induced by intelligent causes. As a result intelligent design presupposes neither a creator nor miracles. Intelligent design is theologically minimalist. It detects intelligence without speculating about the nature of the intelligence.[128]

Theologian William Paley (1743–1805), in his 1802 book *Natural Theology—Or Evidences of the Existence and Attributes of the Deity Collected from the Appearances in Nature*, posited that the complexities in nature argue for a Designer. His were arguments for God's existence from design in nature. The contemporary Intelligent Design (ID) theorists (scholars from different disciplines) have a different approach: they are "contrasting the '*argument to design*,' promoted by the ID [Intelligent Design] group, with the '*argument from design*' famously argued by Paley. The 'argument to design' is that nature has properties that would be expected if it were designed, therefore it must be designed. This is what the ID group claims. Paley argued that the design seen in nature points to the Christian Creator God. This is the 'argument from design.'"[129]

Intelligent Design theorists find signs of intelligence in nature itself, without any assumptions about what Scripture might say about the Designer behind nature. They confine their focus to what can be empirically discovered in nature itself: "Thus, instead of looking to signs of intelligence to obtain

127. See "Bridging Science & Theology" in William A. Dembski, *Intelligent Design: The Bridge Between Science & Theology* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1999), 187–236. Dembski notes, "Intelligent design is a scientific theory with theological implications," 187, and states, "My thesis is that all disciplines find their completion in Christ and cannot be properly understood apart from Christ," 206, noting that "God's act of creating the world is thus the prime instance of intelligent agency," 224.
128. Dembski, in *Mere Creation*, 17.
129. L. James Gibson, personal correspondence with author.

theological mileage, as Paley did, intelligent design treats signs of intelligence as strictly part of science."[130] A reading of the book *Signs of Intelligence: Understanding Intelligent Design* documents this fact.[131]

While atheistic evolution rests on a philosophical and metaphysical basis that confines the field of causation to the natural, by contrast Intelligent Design critiques this foundation and rests on empirical evidence in nature itself. This approach is scientific, and yet evolutionary theorists consistently reject Intelligent Design as mere religious fundamentalism. The reverse is true. Evolutionary theory is indebted to religious fundamentalism: As we noted in chapter 4, Darwin assumed that God would not have created such an imperfect world, and so he offered the only altetnative he could see: evolution based on natural laws alone. Yet he failed to factor in the fall of humans which affected all of nature (Rom. 8:22).

Philosophical naturalism is not empirical science when it comes to macro-evolution; rather, it becomes religious fundamentalism that seeks to negate biblical creationism, as well argued in three books by biophysicist Cornelius G. Hunter, whose work we studied in chapter 6.[132] And while Intelligent Design has raised some critical questions of evolutionary theory, evolutionary science has raised questions about Intelligent Design.[133]

Intelligent Design deserves a fair hearing. What has evolutionary science to lose? It is not good enough for atheistic evolutionist Richard Dawkins to claim that those opposed to evolutionary theory are "ignorant, stupid or insane (or wicked, but I'd rather not consider that)."[134] Anyone who has read the book

130. William A. Dembski, *The Design Revolution: Answering the Toughest Questions About Intelligent Design* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2004), 64.

131. William A. Dembski and James M. Kushiner, eds., *Signs of Intelligence: Understanding Intelligent Design* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos, 2001).

132. Cornelius G. Hunter, *Darwin's God: Evolution and the Problem of Evil* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos, 2001); *Darwin's Proof: The Triumph of Religion over Science* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos, 2003); *Science's Blind Spot: The Unseen Religion of Scientific Naturalism* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos, 2007).

133. Consider the following comparison: "One common criticism is that ID [intelligent design] is a religious theory by virtue of its appeal to a designer. As we shall see, it is evolution rather than ID that makes strong religious assumptions. ID is unacceptable to Darwinists because ID does not incorporate evolution's religious assumptions, but ID has no problem with the existence of particular evolutionary processes to the extent that they are supported by the empirical evidence. This is one reason why ID allows for more diversity in its explanation than evolution. Darwin's exclusive focus on natural laws fails to account for our complex and interconnected biological world," Cornelius G. Hunter, *Darwin's Proof*, 13. Critics charge that ID is a label to explain things not yet figured out by biology. "Nothing could be farther from the truth. The design inference is based on empirical evidence and rational analysis, not ignorance," 13.

134. Richard Dawkins, book review of Maitland A. Edey and Donald C. Johanson, *Blueprints: Solving the Mystery of Evolution* (Boston, MA: Little Brown, 1989), in the *New York Times*, April 9, 1987, sect. 7:34, quoted by Dembski in *Uncommon Dissent*, xvii. With respect to atheism, it is instructive to study Richard Dawkins, *The God Delusion* (Boston, MA: Houghton Mifflin, 2006) and a response from Alister McGrath and Joanna Collicutt McGrath, *The Dawkins Delusion?*. Dawkins rightly claims, "Darwin made it possible to be an intellectually fulfilled atheist" and continues, "I like to think that Hume would agree, but some of his writings suggest that he underestimated the complexity and beauty of biological design. The boy naturalist Charles Darwin could have

Uncommon Dissent: Intellectuals Who Find Darwinism Unconvincing know that the fifteen thinkers presented in the book prove Dawkins's comment to be derogatory and false. When thinkers such as Dawkins denigrate thoughtful questioning, comparing it to insanity or anything less than it is, this suggests they have no better (no *rational*) weapon to meet the arguments presented.

And certainly Intelligent Design is not a new concept. In some respects, Frederick Hoyle's ideas seem to have been a precursor of Intelligent Design. In his 1981 book *Evolution from Space* (with co-author Chandra Wickramasinghe), he wrote:

> From the beginning of this book we have emphasized the enormous information content of even the simplest living systems. The information cannot in our view be generated by what are often called "natural" processes, as for instance through meteorological and chemical processes occurring at the surface of a lifeless planet. As well as a suitable physical and chemical environment, a large initial store of information was also needed. We have argued that the requisite information came from an "intelligence," the beckoning spectre.[135]

Michael Denton observes, "If complex computer programs cannot be changed by random mechanisms, then surely the same must apply to the genetic programmes of living organisms."[136] It is not correct to compare the "evolution" of planes from Bleriot's monoplane to a Boeing 747, for that was not dependent upon chance.[137] The sheer perfection throughout the universe, at every level, cannot be explained on the basis of chance and random processes.[138]

So what do Intelligent Design advocates bring to the table? To answer that question we will consider two different contributions: (1) scientists who come to the table and speak out of their experience as scientists, and (2) scholars who come to the table with mathematical or logical data that needs to be heard. We will take

shown him a thing or two about that, but Hume [Scottish philosopher, who refuted Paley's design argument a century before Darwin] had been dead 40 years when Darwin enrolled in Hume's university of Edinburgh," Dawkins, *The Blind Watchmaker*, 6. McGrath's response to Dawkins's *The Blind Watchmaker* was "that Paley's ideas were typical of his age, not of Christianity as a whole, and that many Christian writers of the age were alarmed at his approach, seeing it as a surefire recipe for the triumph of atheism," *The Dawkins Delusion?*, 24–25.

135. Hoyle and Wickramasinghe, *Evolution from Space*, 150. "Just as the brain of Shakespeare was necessary to produce the famous plays, so prior information was necessary to produce a living cell," 148. Cf. Hoyle's instant insight into a mathematical problem, and how the deaf Beethoven wrote the Ninth Symphony—both through intelligence coming to them, *Astrophysics and Relativity*, 43–46. Even Charles Lyell (1797–1874), whose uniformitarianism affected geology and biology, couldn't accept the human mind as the result of natural selection. See Terry Mortenson, *The Great Turning Point: The Church's Catastrophic Mistake on Geology—Before Darwin* (Green Forest, AR: Master Books, 2004), 33. In his *Descent and Origin of Man*, Darwin admits that "the difference between the mind of the lowest man and that of the highest animal is immense" but qualifies this statement by saying the difference is "one of degree and not of kind," vol. 49 in *Great Books of the Western World*, 319. However, no animals were made in the image of God, worship God, and invent all that humans have invented. The human mind cannot be a result of natural evolution, Mortenson, *The Great Turning Point*, 33.

136. Denton, *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis*, 315.

137. Ibid., 316–317.

138. Ibid., 342.

them up in this order, because each of these groups has something significant to offer to sound, reputable science.

SCIENCE QUESTIONS EVOLUTION

Complexity of Eyes

Intelligent Design looks at complexity in nature. The fact of complexity was known prior to the work of Intelligent Design, but the vastness of complexity was unknown. In 1861, two years after his *Origin of Species* was published, Darwin wrote a letter to biologist Asa Gray saying, "The eye to this day gives me a cold shudder."[139] He wrote, "To suppose that the eye, with all its inimitable contrivances for adjusting the focus to different distances, for admitting different amounts of light, and for the correction of spherical and chromatic aberation [sic], could have been formed by natural selection, seems, I freely confess, absurd in the highest possible degree.... The belief that an organ as perfect as the eye could have formed by natural selection is more than enough to stagger anyone."[140]

If the eye made Darwin shudder, imagine what it would make him do today when so much more is known about the eye!

> Electro-physiological studies have recently revealed very intricate connections among the nerve cells of the retina, which enable the eye to carry out many types of preliminary data processing of visual information before transmitting it in binary form to the brain. The cleverness of these mechanisms has again been underlined by their close analogy to the sorts of image intensification and clarification processes carried out today by computers, such as those used by NASA, on images transmitted from space. Today it would be more accurate to think of a television camera if we are looking for an analogy to the eye.[141]

A good look at the human eye made Darwin shudder for good reason: How could natural selection produce such ordered, precise design and complexity? Furthermore, how could natural selection, which is a slow process, provide a workable eye at every stage of its development? Richard Dawkins admits that the human eye "could not possibly come into existence through single-step selection."[142] He believes the human eye could have taken several hundred million years to evolve.[143] Yet Dawkins can say, "The eye is, *par excellence*, a case where a fraction of an organ is better than no organ at all; an eye without a

139. Darwin, quoted in Denton, *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis*, 326.
140. Charles Darwin, quoted in Huse, *The Collapse of Evolution*, 73.
141. Michael Denton, *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis*, 333.
142. Dawkins, *Blind Watchmaker*, 140.
143. Ibid., 40.

lens or even a pupil, for instance, could still detect the looming shadow of a predator."[144] But a fraction of an eye isn't really an eye. Further, how can the alleged slow process of evolution produce the eye when the eye is only a part of a wider, complex network of interdependent parts of the visual network? As Alvin Plantinga has said,

> Here is the problem: how does the lens, for example, get developed by the proposed means—random genetic variation and natural selection—when at the same time there has to be development of the optic nerve, the relevant muscles, the retina, the rods and cones, and many other delicate and complicated structures, all of which have to be adjusted to each other in such a way that they can work together? Indeed, what is involved isn't, of course, just the eye; it is the whole visual system, including the relevant parts of the brain. Many different organs and suborgans have to be developed together, and it is hard to envisage a series of mutations which is such that each member of the series has adaptive value, is also a step on the way to the eye, and is such that the last member is an animal with such an eye.[145]

The eye is too complex in itself, and in its visual network, to be a product of evolution. This is why Dawkins's idea that an eye is an eye even in its early stages of development doesn't make sense. Harvard scholar Stephen Jay Gould asked what good five percent of an eye is. Realizing that it could not see, he thought it might have some function other than sight. Dawkins disagreed with Gould and said that the five-percent eye was used "for 5 percent vision." But how can five percent of an eye have five percent of vision, when there is no vision until the eye is a hundred percent an eye, with all the parts in place and fully functioning (as noted above by Plantinga)? Lawyer Phillip E. Johnson saw the illogic of Dawkins's conclusion, stating, "The fallacy in that argument is that '5 percent of an eye' is not the same thing as '5 percent of normal vision.'"[146]

What is said about the eye could be said about many other organs in the human body. There is a complex network involved, so that no one part can evolve without all parts evolving at the same time. But how can an emerging lung function as a lung? Then, of course, we come to the complexity of the human brain. Caltech neurobiologist Roger Sperry, winner of the 1981 Nobel Prize for study on the two hemispheres of the human brain, argues "that the brain system as a whole somehow controls its parts in ways that supersede the mechanistic physical states of the brain's 10 billion neurons."[147] Although he

144. Richard Dawkins in *But Is It Science? The Philosophical Question in the Creation/Evolution Controversy*, ed. Michael Ruse (Buffalo, NY: Prometheus, 1988), 210; cf. *The Blind Watchmaker*, 41.
145. Alvin Plantinga, "When Faith and Reason Clash: Evolution and the Bible," *Christian Scholar's Review* 21, no. 1 (1991): 25.
146. Johnson, *Darwin on Trial*, 34.
147. Sperry's comment in "Scientists in Search of the Soul," *Science Digest*, vol. 90 (July 1982): 78. Roger Sperry dismisses the supernatural and the existence of extra-physical phenomena.

dismisses the supernatural, Sperry at least apparently realizes that there is more to the brain than the "mechanistic physical" dimensions.

In fact, the intricacies of the human brain are equivalent to the most complex computer network known to humankind, and speak eloquently for a Creator rather than random chance for its existence. The eye and brain reveal Intelligent Design, and hence an Intelligent Designer: "Does he [Creator God] who formed the eye not see?" (Ps. 94:9b).

It is less than fair for atheistic scientists to suggest that Intelligent Design advocates are motivated by religion when they themselves are motivated *against* Bible-based religion.

Complexity of Cells

Darwinian evolution believes that through gradual microevolutionary steps, evolution explains the development of life from the prebiotic soup all the way to humankind (and even posits a development beyond humans).[148] This means that evolution includes change from the simple to the complex. Yet molecular biology has opened up a whole new world of complexity that staggers the imagination and exposes how incredible is the theory of evolution. W. R. Bird, in his book *The Origin of Species Revisited*, speaks of the enormous complexity of a single cell. Quoting Sagan, he concludes that the simple cell has "information content...comparable to about a hundred million pages of the *Encyclopedia Britannica.*"[149] Richard Dawkins says thirty volumes of the Encyclopedia, three or four times over.[150] Whichever analogy one prefers, every tiny cell has staggering storage capacity!

Of Pandas and People goes so far as to declare, "If the amount of information contained in one cell of your body were written out on a typewriter, it would fill as many books as are contained in a large library."[151] The tiny bacterial cells are incredibly small; "each is in effect a veritable micro-miniaturized factory containing thousands of exquisitely designed pieces of intricate molecular machinery, made up altogether of one hundred thousand million atoms, far more complicated than any machine built by man and absolutely without parallel in the non-living world."[152] Who can explain how the simplest, tiniest cell became so complex? There is no known evolutionary development of these

148. Richard Dawkins suggests that "human vanity cherishes the absurd notion that our species is the final goal of Evolution," *Blind Watchmaker*, 50.

149. W. R. Bird, *The Origin of Species Revisited: The Theories of Evolution and of Abrupt Appearance in Science* (Nashville, TN: Regency, 1991), 1:300.

150. Dawkins, *Blind Watchmaker*, 18.

151. Percival Davis and Dean H. Kenyon, *Of Pandas and People: The Central Question of Biological Origins*, 2nd ed. (Dallas, TX: Haughton, 1993), 7.

152. Denton, *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis*, 250.

so-called primitive cells. In fact, as Jacques Monod rightly states, "The simplest cells available to us for study have nothing 'primitive' about them."[153]

Irreducible Complexity

Michael Behe is professor of biochemistry, a discipline that wasn't even in existence when Darwin did his work. In his 1996 book *Darwin's Black Box*, Behe documents the complex biochemistry involved in vision. Biological processes are not foundationally understood until one is able to penetrate to the molecular level using sophisticated tools such as an electron microscope and x-ray diffraction. If Darwin had been able to observe nature at this level, his fears about the complexity of the eye would have been confirmed, and his materialistic naturalism based on random chance would have been called into question.

And rightly so, because evolutionary theory is incompatible with contemporary scientific empirical evidence at the molecular level. Evangelical theologians should keep up to date on recent scientific evidence which casts doubt upon evolutionary assumptions, while remembering that more discoveries may come in the future—which means it is not wise to interpret the creation record in the light of past theories claiming to be science. Since even hard science has a history of embracing unstable, changing worldviews, the biblical worldview of creation must not be confined to any passing scientific worldview.

Just as Epicurus believed that atoms were simple, so scientists once thought the basis of life was very simple: a prebiotic soup. Once cells were considered the foundational building blocks of life, but now the molecular world within cells has revealed that molecules are the foundation of life—and they are remarkably complex. Biochemistry and the complexity of molecules were unknown to Darwin, and they radically call into question his theory of evolution from the simple to the complex, because complexity (it is evident) is present from the start within the foundational molecules. So much so that Behe can say:

> Darwin was ignorant of the reason for variation within a species (one of the requirements of his theory), but biochemistry has identified the molecular basis for it. Nineteenth-century science could not even guess at the mechanism of vision, immunity, or movement, but modern biochemistry has identified the molecules that allow those and other functions.... Science has made enormous progress in understanding how the chemistry of life works, but the elegance and complexity of biological systems at the molecular level have paralyzed science's attempt to explain their origins.[154]

153. Jacques Monod, *Chance and Necessity: An Essay on the Natural Philosophy of Modern Biology*, trans. Austryn Wainhouse (St. James's Place, London: 1972), 134.

154. Michael J. Behe, *Darwin's Black Box: The Biochemical Challenge to Evolution* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 1996), x.

Behe is dealing with a foundational problem, for biochemistry unearthed the foundation of life at the molecular level. Since the mid-1950s a stunning new world of molecular machines has been discovered; just as the Hubble telescope and Einstein's Theories of Relativity opened up a vastly expanded view of the universe, so electron-microscopy and x-ray crystallography opened up a vastly expanded view of the micro world, which soundly refuted the supposed evolutionary process. There is no going back. No physicist would entertain going back to a vastly restricted Ptolemaic worldview; neither should scientists abandon the sheer complexity of the molecular worldview to defend an evolutionary worldview of simplicity as the origin of life.

Behe examines a number of complex molecular machines, and asks the question "could these come together through random mutation/natural selection?" In other words, how can such awesome designs be achieved through mere chance? Along with others in the Intelligent Design movement, Behe discovers in nature empirical evidence for Intelligent Design. Please understand: It is not the case that he believes in the biblical record of creation found in Genesis 1–2, and then comes to nature armed with that perspective. He doesn't. He believes in the evolutionary process, for he accepts that "all organisms share a common ancestor."[155] As a noncreationist, Behe says that "too often criticisms [of evolutionary theory] have been dismissed by the scientific community for fear of giving ammunition to creationists."[156] As a biochemist, he questions Darwinian evolution on scientific and not biblical grounds. (It is true that he is a Catholic and believes in God, but he evaluates the idea of evolution from a biochemical/molecular perspective, not from a biblical perspective.[157])

What is irreducible complexity? It means complexity cannot be reduced and still be expected to function.[158] Behe illustrates irreducible complexity with a mousetrap. The trap must have all its working parts functioning in order to catch mice. There is no such thing as a step-by-step evolution, for evolution requires some function in order to be subject to natural selection.[159]

Space doesn't allow us to give all Behe's examples of irreducible complexity, so one more will suffice. Consider bacterial flagellum as a complex machine.[160] Behe summarizes his argument as follows:

> The bacterial flagellum is quite literally an outboard motor that some bacteria use to swim. Like the machines that power motorboats, the flagellum is a rotary device, where the rotating surface pushes against the liquid medium, propelling the bacteria along. The part of the flagellum that acts as the propeller is a long whip-like structure made of a protein called flagellum. The propeller is attached to the drive shaft by hook protein that acts as a universal joint, allowing freedom of rotation for the propeller and drive shaft. The drive shaft is attached to the rotary motor, which uses a flow of acid from outside of the bacterium to the inside in order to power its turning. The drive shaft has to poke through the bacterial membrane, and several types of proteins act as bushing material to allow that to happen. Although this discussion makes the flagellum sound complicated, it really doesn't do justice to the full complexity. Thorough genetic studies have shown that about forty different proteins are required for a functional flagellum, either as parts of the flagellum itself, or as parts of the system that builds the machine in the cell. And in the absence of most of those proteins, one doesn't get a flagellum that spins half as fast as it used to, or a quarter as fast. Either no flagellum gets produced at all, or one that doesn't work.[161]

155. Behe, *Darwin's Black Box*, 4.
156. Ibid., 30.
157. Michael J. Behe, "A Catholic Scientist Looks at Darwinism," in *Uncommon Dissent*, 133–151.
158. Behe, *Darwin's Black Box*, 15–22.
159. Ibid., 43–45.
160. Ibid., 69–72.

As in the alleged formation of a complex eye, the empirical evidence does not support a step-by-step process of evolution. Behe says examples of irreducible complexity "are mammoth barriers to gradualistic, Darwinian evolution."[162]

Specified Complexity[163]

How does specified complexity compare with irreducible complexity? Irreducible complexity is an integrated functional system that depends on the presence of all its parts, for without one of them it would not work. This destroys the idea of gradualism, a step-by-step evolutionary process from simple to complex. But specified complexity "adds an intelligence" criterion; that is, the complexity demonstrates an intelligent cause rather than a natural cause.[164] Intelligent causes are investigated by forensic science, which plays an important part in solving criminal cases. Signs of intelligence are examined, and this is what the Intelligent Design movement investigates in nature.

Evolutionist Richard Dawkins rejected a designed universe. His 1988 book *The Blind Watchmaker: Why the Evidence of Evolution Reveals a Universe Without Design* was questioned by Neil Broom's 1998 book *How Blind is the Watchmaker?: Nature's Design & Limits of Naturalistic Science.*[165] Specified complexity in nature is "a reliable criterion for detecting design."[166] There is no materialistic

161. Behe, "A Catholic Scientist Looks at Darwinism," in *Uncommon Dissent*, 141.
162. Behe, "Intelligent Design Theory as a Tool for Analyzing Biochemical Systems," in *Mere Creation*, 177.
163. Specified complexity is a part of an explanatory filter discussed by Dembski in *The Design Revolution*, 87–93. Also see 94–99 on the reliability of specified complexity as a criterion for detecting design.
164. For further insights, see Christopher Michael Langan, "Cheating the Millennium: The Mounting Explanatory Debts of Scientific Naturalism," in *Uncommon Dissent*, 238–240.
165. Neil Broom. *How Blind Is the Watchmaker?: Nature's Design & the Limits of Naturalistic Science* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2001).
166. Dembski, *Intelligent Design*, 141–142.

explanation for the presence of information, and there is no natural process that can explain the ability of humans to think, speak, and have a sense of moral values. There is no natural explanation of how the survival of the fittest (or the best adapted) leads humans to have compassion for others or the desire to worship a Creator. Philosophical naturalism is too restrictive a worldview for understanding the complexity of the simplest cell, not to mention all that makes an intelligent and thoughtful human being. There is much more to reality than naturalism allows.[167]

How can chance produce complexity? As scientist Walter Bradley states, as the understanding of "enormous biochemical complexity associated with the origin of life and the development of more complex life forms has matured, appeals to chance have gradually lost credibility."[168] William Dembski says,

> My strongest argument against the sufficiency of natural causes to account for intelligent agency, however, comes from the complexity-specification criterion. This empirically based criterion reliably discriminates intelligent agency from natural causes. Moreover, when applied to cosmology and biology, it demonstrates not only the incompleteness of natural causes but also the presence of transcendent design.[169]

> Specified complexity's causal chains end not with blind nature but with a designing intelligence.[170]

> The design inference looks to one feature in particular—specified complexity—and uses it as the basis for inferring intelligence.[171]

No evolutionary scientist has discovered empirical evidence to explain the source of information. One cannot assume from the reality of information that the process that produced it was confined to naturalism.

It seems remarkable that few scientists even question this—perhaps they do not feel free to express any doubts regarding the sufficiency of naturalism. I concur with Phillip Johnson that if "the evolutionary scientists were better informed or more scientific in their thinking, they would be asking about the origin of information."[172]

167. Biologist Susumu Ohno argues for a longtime natural causation for the "enormous intelligence" of humans by means of: (1) an increase of neurons in an enlarged brain, (2) the fact that nature anticipated future intelligent needs of *homo sapiens*, like the immune system prepares for future attacks, *Evolution by Gene Duplication* (New York: Springer-Verlag, 1970), 142–145.
168. Walter L. Bradley, "Nature: Designed or Designoid," in *Mere Creation*, 41.
169. Dembski, *Intelligent Design*, 224.
170. Dembski, *The Design Revolution*, 36.
171. Ibid., 77.
172. Johnson, *The Wedge of Truth*, 167.

Functional Complexity

In 1966, Marcel-Paul Schützenberger was interviewed by the journal *La Recherche*. When asked how he would define *Darwinism*, he replied that it "accommodates two mutually contradictory schools" (gradualism and saltationism, which means slow development or jumps in development).[173] In response to the statement "Darwinism doesn't explain much," he said, "It seems to me that the union of chance mutation and selection has a certain descriptive value; in no case does the description count as an explanation."[174] With respect to gradualism, he says, "the gradualist thesis seems totally ridiculous in light of our growing knowledge of paleontology."[175]

Speaking of functional complexity, Schützenberger tells us, "Even among unicellular organisms, the mechanisms involved in the separation and fusion of chromosomes during mitosis [increasing number of nuclei] and meiosis [division of nucleus in all sexually reproducing organisms] are processes of unbelievable complexity and subtlety."[176] Schützenberger then explains why functional complexity is so difficult to understand:

> The evolution of living creatures appears to require an essential ingredient, a specific form of organization. Whatever it is, it lies beyond anything that our present knowledge of physics or chemistry might suggest; it is a property upon which formal logic sheds absolutely no light. Whether gradualists or saltationists, Darwinians have too simple a conception of biology, rather like a locksmith improbably convinced that his handful of keys will open any lock.[177]

William Dembski says of Schützenberger, "he was the first scientist of his stature publicly to question Darwin's theory of evolution, raising questions at the Wister Symposium of 1967 about life and chance that biologists did not comprehend and that mathematicians could not answer."[178] It was Neo-Darwinisn that he challenged "on complexity-theoretic grounds. At that symposium the biologists (notably C. H. Waddington and Ernst Mayr) simply dismissed Schützenberger's challenge. Instead of meeting his arguments, they reasserted that here we are the result of evolution and hence something must be wrong with Schützenberger's analysis."[179]

173. Schützenberger, quoted in Dembski, *Uncommon Dissent*, 41.
174. Ibid., 44.
175. Ibid., 44.
176. Ibid., 42.
177. Ibid., 42.
178. Dembski, ed., *Mere Creation*, dedication.
179. Dembski, *Intelligent Design: The Bridge*, 268.

LOGIC QUESTIONS EVOLUTION

In his 1991 book *Darwin on Trial*, Phillip Johnson brings his legal mind to evaluate the claims of Darwinian evolution. After admitting that he is not a defender of creation science, he states that his purpose "is to examine the scientific evidence on its own terms." He assumes that "creation-scientists are biased by their precommitment to Biblical fundamentalism," and investigates "whether Darwinism is based upon a fair assessment of the scientific evidence, or whether it is another kind of fundamentalism."[180] Throughout the book Johnson separates scientific empirical evidence from metaphysical or philosophical presuppositions. Repeatedly he comes to the conclusion that evolution is based upon theory and is not substantiated by empirical evidence.

Here we will consider one example of faulty logic that he critiques. Stephen Jay Gould's article "Evolution as Fact and Theory" included the following comparison:

> Facts are the world's data. Theories are structures of ideas that explain and interpret facts. Facts do not go away while scientists debate rival theories for explaining them. Einstein's theory of gravitation replaced Newton's, but apples did not suspend themselves in mid-air pending the outcome. And human beings evolved from ape-like ancestors whether they did so by Darwin's proposed mechanism or by some other, yet to be identified.[181]

Now the problem with this kind of comparison is that the fall of apples can be demonstrated, whereas evolutionary ascent cannot. As Johnson rightly says,

> The analogy is spurious. We observe directly that apples fall when dropped, but we do not observe a common ancestor for modern apes and humans. What we *do* observe is that apes and humans are physically and biochemically more like each other than they are like rabbits, snakes, or trees. The ape-like common ancestor is a hypothesis in a *theory*, which purports to explain how these greater and lesser similarities came about. The theory is plausible, especially to a philosophical materialist, but it may nonetheless be false. The true explanation for natural relationships may be something much more mysterious.[182]

This argument could be used against Intelligent Design—that it can no more be demonstrated than evolutionary ascent. Michael Behe has a compelling insight to this problem: "the chemical and physical knowledge we have gained as a result of four decades' work itself shows the implausibility of unintelligent causes for life. Further, as I have argued in *Darwin's Black Box*, the progress of science has also pointed to design at the cellular basis of life, where molecular machines of stunning complexity carry out life's most basic tasks."[183]

180. Johnson, *Darwin on Trial*, 14.
181. Gould, quoted in Johnson, *Darwin on Trial*, 66–67.
182. Johnson, *Darwin on Trial*, 67.
183. Behe, foreword to Dembski, *Intelligent Design*, 11.

One of the major weaknesses of evolutionary thinking is the acceptance of evolutionary theory as a fact, and then interpreting empirical data from that perspective. The quest is biased with basic presuppositions; the faith required to believe in the theory makes it more of a philosophy than a science. As James Gibson rightly comments, "all historical questions have weaknesses like this."[184]

In his 2000 book *The Wedge of Truth: Splitting the Foundations of Naturalism*, Johnson points out that the theory of evolution is accepted as a given in the same way as two plus two equals four is. All Darwinists need to do is to look for few confirming examples. Logic is often all that is needed, not evidence.[185]

FUNCTION OF DNA

It was in 1953 that Francis Crick and James Watson discovered the architecture of the double helix DNA molecule.[186] The discovery of DNA has added enormously to our understanding of living organisms relative to what drives their morphogenesis. The ideas of natural selection and random genetic mutation, with their emphasis on evolutionary descent, have now been shown to be too restrictive. It is not just that the chemical letters of DNA—adenine (A), thymine (T), cytosine (C), and guanine (G)—form different sequences to present messages, and are a unique storage of information that illustrates intelligent design, but also their "storage density…is several trillion times that of our most advanced computer chips."[187] No wonder "[c]hance is not an adequate explanation for the origin of biological specificity."[188]

Michael Denton, in his seminal book *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis*, speaks of the amazing information storage in DNA. He says: "The capacity of DNA to store information vastly exceeds that of any other known system; it is so efficient that all the information needed to specify an organism as complex as man weighs less than a few thousand millionths of a gram. The information necessary to specify the design of all the species of organisms which have ever existed on the planet, a number according to G. G. Simpson of approximately one thousand million, could be held in a teaspoon and there would still be room left for all the information in every book ever written."[189]

184. Personal correspondence with the author.
185. Johnson, *Wedge of Truth*, 39–46.
186. Davis and Kenyon, *Of Pandas and People*, 61.
187. See Stephen C. Meyer, "The Explanatory Power of Design," in *Mere Creation*, 120. Cf. DNA is a four character alphabet (ATGC), and they "combine in various ways to form a twenty-character alphabet of amino acids. Each amino acid 'word' is rhree DNA letters long. Those twenty different amino-acid words are used to write the long protein sentences, the molecular machines you see working all around us," Dembski and Witt, *Intelligent Design Uncensored*, 15.
188. See Meyer, "The Explanatory Power of Design," in *Mere Creation*, 126.
189. Denton, *Evolution: A Theory in Crisis*, 334.

John W. Oller, Jr., and John L. Omdahl have compared human language capacity with the capacity of DNA. They note that "the origin of the human language capacity is not unlike the problem of the origin of life itself."[190] Their conclusion is that:

> the intricate and articulate structures of language are mirrored in the delicate arrangements of biological representations in correspondence to information coded in DNA. We have shown logically that the language capacity cannot have originated in a purely materialistic manner. The logical gulf that separates mind from matter really is an uncrossable barrier to any materialistic origin. If the definitions of Peircey and Einstein are accepted, the gulf they describe cannot be crossed without the intervention of a truly transcendent Intelligence—a conclusion both of them accepted.[191]

It is not good enough to say with Richard Dawkins that God cannot be the origin of DNA: "To explain the origin of the DNA/protein machine by invoking a supernatural Designer is to explain precisely nothing, for it leaves unexplained the origin of the Designer. You have to say something like 'God was always there,' and if you allow yourself that kind of lazy way out, you might as well just say 'DNA was always there,' or 'Life was always there,' and be done with it."[192] What Dawkins needs to do is to take seriously the seminal work done by another Oxford University professor, Michael Polanyi, whose article "Life's Irreducible Structure" compares machines with evolutionary theory. Machines are made by humans even though they operate according to laws of inanimate nature. "So the machine as a whole works under the control of two distinct principles. The higher one is the principle of the machine's design, and this harnesses the lower one, which consists in the physical-chemical processes on which the machine relies."[193]

Polanyi considers live mechanisms and information in DNA as boundary conditions, with a sequence of boundaries above them. He reasons, "A boundary condition is always extraneous to the process which it delimits." For example, when Galileo's experiment of balls running down a slope was conducted, the choice of the slope had nothing to do with the laws of mechanics. Furthermore, the shape and manufacture of test tubes used in experiments have nothing to do with the laws of chemistry. Nor can the structure of machines be defined by the laws they harness. He concludes, "Thus the morphology of living things transcends the laws of physics and chemistry."[194] Relative to DNA, Polanyi questions evolutionary theory:

190. Oller, Jr., and Omdahl in *The Creation Hypothesis*, 238.
191. Ibid., 265.
192. Dawkins, *The Blind Watchmaker*, 141.
193. Michael Polanyi, "Life's Irreducible Structure," *Science* 21 (June 1968): 1308.
194. Ibid., 1309.

> In the light of the current theory of evolution, the codelike structure of DNA must be assumed to have come about by a sequence of chance variations established by natural selection. But this evolutionary aspect is irrelevant here; whatever may be the origin of a DNA configuration, it can function as a code only if its order is not due to the forces of potential energy. It must be as physically indeterminate as the sequence of words is on a printed page. As the arrangement of a printed page is extraneous to the chemistry of the printed page, so is the base sequence in a DNA molecule extraneous to the chemical forces at work in the DNA molecule.[195]

Polanyi asks, "Can the control of morphogenesis by DNA be likened to the designing and shaping of a machine by an engineer?"[196] He answers in the affirmative. The code-like structure of DNA acts on the organism like an engineer acts on a machine. The fact that the organism harnesses the physical-chemical substances within it in no way fully defines the organism, which is under dual control: from information in the DNA and the physical-chemical substances, with DNA being the primary level of influence. It would seem to me that this model has determined that design (not descent) from the DNA is the primary influence in the morphogenesis.

Scott M. Huse says of DNA, "Computer scientists have demonstrated conclusively that information does not and cannot arise spontaneously. Information results only from the expenditure of energy (to arrange the letter and words) and under the all-important direction of intelligence. Therefore, since DNA is information, the only logical and reasonable conclusion that can be drawn is that DNA was formed by intelligence."[197] This needs to be compared with calculations showing that spontaneous generation is impossible.[198] Nancy Pearcey speaks about the impossibility of gaining information by chance. It would be like being blindfolded, and yet drawing out scrabble letters time and time again and producing Shakespeare's *Hamlet*. In an interview, Norman Geisler gave Pearcey another illustration: "If you came into the kitchen and saw the Alphabet cereal spilled on the table, and it spelled out your name and address, would you think the cat knocked the cereal box over?"[199] Stephen C. Meyer says that when "it comes to information, we know of only one such cause. For this reason, the biology of the information age now requires a new science of design."[200]

195. Ibid.
196. Ibid., 1309.
197. Huse, *The Collapse of Evolution*, 95.
198. H. Quastler, a prominent biochemist, calculated the odds against it (spontaneous generation) as 10 to 301 (which is ten followed by three hundred and one zeros). A biologist computed spontaneous generation if there are 10 to the power of 20 planets on which life can appear. He came up with 10 followed by 415 zeros, and even up to 10 followed by 600 zeros "if a longer DNA molecule was required," Gordon Rattray Taylor, *The Great Evolution Mystery* (New York: Harper & Row, 1983), 202.
199. Geisler, quoted in Pearcey, *Total Truth*, 193.
200. Meyer, "The Explanatory Power of Design," in *Mere Creation*, 140.

Interventionist View[201]

In his 2006 book *Beginnings: Are Science and Scripture Partners in the Search for Origins?*, Leonard Brand, professor of biology and paleontology at Loma Linda University, proposes a constructive relationship between science and religion, allowing the findings in each field of knowledge to "challenge us to analyze the other more carefully," and to see them as "complementary and not exclusive of each other."[202] Taking both science and Scripture seriously enables one to think more carefully.[203] Science doesn't provide absolutes, for one studies a very small sample of the world at a brief moment of time, and then attempts to explain what is observed. It is like giving a progress report which is tentative forever; all scientific theories have a life span.[204]

Darwin's theory of natural selection wasn't accepted by the majority of biologists until 1940, ninety-one years after the publication of *Origin of Species*,[205] and if Darwin had proposed his naturalistic theory today for the first time, it would not have been accepted because of the intricacies of molecular biology.[206] Modern scientific theory depends on the following concepts: (a) Nature is not controlled by "capricious whims of supernatural spirits or the operation of magic" but by natural laws. (b) "Living things and physical phenomena are mechanisms that we can study and understand through experimentation." (c) "Neither living organisms nor the physical universe is static. New species of animals and plants have arisen, and geologic structures have changed."[207] Interventionist scientists don't rule out intervention by an intelligent being in biological and geological history, particularly in connection with the origin of life forms.[208]

The naturalistic origin of the universe and life forms is based on the rejection of the supernatural rather than on evidence.[209] It is important to understand that science can neither prove nor disprove creation nor the Flood.[210] The simple mixing of amino acids has never resulted in life, for natural laws cannot accomplish this—only information can correctly sequence twenty amino acids

201. Instead of using the term creation, Brand uses the term intervention, since it covers more than a "process that generates something: an earth, animals, and so forth"; "it covers not only the original creation of life forms and their habitat but also subsequent biological changes and geological history after Creation," Brand, with David C. Jarnes, *Beginnings: Are Science and Scripture Partners in the Search for Origins?* (Nampa, ID: Pacific Press, 2006), 12.
202. Brand, with Jarnes, *Beginnings*, 7.
203. Ibid. 12.
204. Ibid., 15–16.
205. Ibid., 21.
206. Ibid.
207. Ibid., 22–23.
208. Ibid., 23.
209. Ibid., 27.
210. Ibid., 33.

in a variety of sequences to form different proteins.[211] Life doesn't automatically appear through natural law any more than natural law creates Shakespeare's plays,[212] nor did natural selection plus change result in the intricate DNA sequence. Microevolution and speciation can happen much more quickly than most evolutionists believe possible, because now evidence indicates that organisms contain more genetic information than they use. They can switch off some genetic information, so the switching on and off "does not have to depend on the gradual accumulation and selection of random mutations."[213] Rapid rates of change observed in experiments and field studies are closer to what actually happens in nature, rather than dependence on the fossil record which is not based on a correct time scale.[214]

From our study thus far we can say that science does not have all the answers (nor does biblical creation when it comes to apparent deep-time isotopes). It is important that researchers in both camps be honest in their findings and in their judgments. For example, macroevolutionary interpretation claims that with the evolving of new body structures, some structures will become superfluous and disappear. At the end of the nineteenth century, there were more than eighty vestigial organs, but contemporary textbooks only classify a few, since research has discovered the function of most organs that were once regarded as vestigial.[215]

With respect to the fossil record, we can see now that it cannot explain the origins of life. "What evidence could the rocks contain to demonstrate whether or not the original life forms evolved from nonliving matter without any informed assistance? Can we be honest enough to say that science cannot answer that question?"[216]

With respect to creation, the biblical record has the Designer creating everything perfectly, but human rebellion introducing degenerative forces into nature, making the earth a less-than-ideal habitat. It is true that organisms have adapted through natural selection, though many adaptations are far less than ideal.[217] Mutation does not always lead to greater complexity, for trilobites are found only in the early layers of the fossil record, yet they have compound eyes and complex legs, whereas mollusks are the same throughout the fossil record.[218] The fossil record itself is a challenge to megaevolution: "Almost all the phyla of invertebrate animals occur early in the Cambrian." There is no explanation in

211. Ibid., 39.
212. Ibid., 40.
213. Ibid., 53.
214. Ibid., 55.
215. Ibid., 57–58.
216. Ibid., 42–43.
217. Ibid., 65.
218. Ibid., 74.

the fossil record for the "scarcity of fossil intermediates."[219] There is a lack of evidence for a genetic process of megaevolution, suggesting evolutionary science merely assumes the existence of a genetic process that evolves new structures or gene complexes, based on the assumption of naturalism.[220]

Molecular embryology is showing how Hox genes control the production of different cell types and structures in each part of the developing embryo. The Hox genes influence body length and placement of the head, limbs, and other body parts, and are found in animals from flies to humans. The Hox genes supervise the structure of each of these animals, even though they differ greatly in structure, which makes sense if an intelligent Designer invented the genetic system.[221] Because so many types of animals have Hox genes, evolutionary scientists recognize that they seem to have been present from the beginning.

This poses a problem for megaevolution. Brand says, "It suggests that somehow, mutation and natural selection created a system that could manage the embryological needs of diverse types of complex animals that wouldn't arrive on the scene until many millions of years later. People may choose to believe this could happen without a designer, but their belief is based on faith—just as an interventionist's belief in a designer is based on faith. Who has the right to insist that only one of these faith statements is valid science?"[222]

Naturalism believes that mutation plus natural selection played a creative role in life's origin and development, but "mutation, as a process that generates random changes in the DNA, generates only increasing chaos if not held largely in check by natural selection." Besides, "mutation plus natural selection has severe limitations as a truly creative process."[223]

At present, critics of Intelligent Design "don't have convincing arguments. They generally don't understand how modern, educated interventionists think, and they tend to rely primarily on philosophical arguments rather than specific biological evidence."[224] But interventionists look at the evidence. They suggest that "perhaps it would be scientifically productive for at least some researchers to ask the question, Are there any limits to the evolution process, and if so, what are they? rather than for everyone to ask only, What is the mechanism of megaevolution?"[225]

Radiometric dating, which includes Carbon-14, Potassium-Argon, and Helium Diffusion, is the most important evidence against short-age geology, but

219. Ibid., 72–73, 76.
220. Ibid., 84.
221. Ibid., 85–86.
222. Ibid., 86.
223. Ibid., 86–87.
224. Ibid., 87–88.
225. Ibid., 90.

it depends upon the assumption that certain elements have always been constant (principle of uniformitarianism). For instance, take Carbon-14 dating of organic material. This involves (a) the Carbon-14 decay rate, (b) the amount of carbon dioxide in earth's atmosphere, and (c) the amount of cosmic rays entering the earth's atmosphere. Brand says there is no "good reason to reject the constant decay rate," but "if fewer cosmic rays entered the upper atmosphere in ancient times than do now or if the atmosphere once contained more carbon dioxide than it does now, the fossils would contain a lower ratio of radioactive carbon-14 to the nonradioactive carbon-12. Consequently, the carbon-14 dating method would date them as much older than they actually are."[226]

There very well may have been differences in the past rate of cosmic-ray bombardment and of carbon-dioxide concentration, and this raises doubts about the accuracy of Carbon-14 dates. Brand concludes, "I predict, based partly on science but even more on faith in Scripture, that future scientific discoveries will lead to a reinterpretation of radiometric dating phenomena—a reinterpretation consistent with a much shorter time for the existence of complex life on earth.... Short-age geology predicts that we will find some new principle that drastically changes the interpretation of radiometric 'age.'"[227]

Leonard Brand befriends scientists who do their research within the naturalistic worldview, and he does not ridicule them for their confined approach to the data. This is the attitude of the true Christian: treating others with respect and seeking conversation rather than confrontation. It is worth repeating that this approach has led to publications in peer-reviewed scientific journals, a contribution made possible through his approaching the data with a broader worldview.[228]

Conclusion

Basic to the claim of macroevolution is the claim that the process takes place over deep-time through a cycle of selection, chance, and survival of the fittest (or the best adapted). The supernatural is ruled out from the start. The researcher comes to nature with a restricted interest in its reality. The supernatural, it is claimed, can never be proven. But neither can the natural. For whether one considers deep-time assumptions or supernatural assumptions, one is faced with the same kind of claim. So the question has to be, Which claim seems more likely?

The sheer complexity at the molecular level and the irreducible complexity of molecules rule out any development from simple to complex. The specified

226. Ibid., 104.
227. Ibid., 104, 111.
228. Ibid., 152–157.

complexity means Intelligent Design is front-loaded, for how can intelligence (or information) come from a natural process? How can evolution create information? These complexities, along with others, call into question the foundation of the theory of evolution, because philosophical naturalism cannot do justice to all the reality in nature, and to this extent it is a flawed worldview. It fails to deliver.

As one example, consider the human brain. The human brain has absolutely no equivalent in any other member of the animal kingdom—even among the chimps. In his logical and hilarious 2009 book *The Devil's Delusion: Atheism and Its Scientific Pretensions*, David Berlinski notes that Alfred Wallace (co-inventor of evolutionary theory with Darwin) believed that evolution was inadequate to explain the human brain.[229] He refers to Richard Dawkins's book *The Selfish Gene*, which, Berlinski says, illustrates self-delusion, because Dawkins affirms that he, at least, is not under the control of his genes. "'I too am an implacable opponent of genetic determinism,' he has written. His genes are not so selfish as to tell him what to do." Berlinski concludes, "On current views, it is the gene that is selected by evolution, and if we are not controlled by our genes, we are not controlled by evolution. If we are not controlled by evolution, *evolutionary* psychology has no relevance to the origin of the human mind."[230]

The medical doctor/mathematician Marcel-Paul Schützenberger (1920–1996), professor in the Faculty of Sciences, University of Paris, and member of the French Academy of Sciences, stated that "the gradualist thesis [evolution] seems totally ridiculous in light of our growing knowledge of paleontology."[231] In commenting on macromutations (which means the arrival of fully formed body parts/systems, like the eye), Schützenberger says such could only be possible if the history of evolution includes "thousands of miracles; miracles, in fact, without end." (What a paradox! evolutionists deny supernatural miracles, but evolution needs them anyway.) Schützenberger notes that both gradualists and saltationists "alike are completely incapable of providing a convincing explanation of the near simultaneous emergence of a number of biological systems that distinguish human beings from the higher primates." He concludes that "the Darwinian paradigm is conceptually bankrupt."[232]

With reference to (1) uniformitarian geological explanations and (2) Neo-Darwinian descriptions of the origin and development of life, John Walton, professor of reactive chemistry at the University of St. Andrews, Scotland, states: "Both theories were launched in the nineteenth century when the sciences of geology,

229. David Berlinski, *The Devil's Delusion: Atheism and Its Scientific Pretensions* (New York: Basic Books, 2009), 157.
230. Ibid., 176–177, emphasis in original.
231. Marcel-Paul Schützenberger, "The Miracles of Darwinism," in *Uncommon Dissent*, 44.
232. Schützenberger, "The Miracles of Darwinism," in *Uncommon Dissent*, 49–50.

biology, chemistry and palaeontology were in their infancy." He says, "It is no secret that the interaction of modern science with evolutionary theory has been unimpressive at the fundamental level." Walton mentions Darwin's rudimentary knowledge about cells. Bio- and geo-sciences have grown to "an awesome maturity, making available much more sophisticated and incisive tools for testing theories of origins." Walton mentions the phenomenal growth of molecular biology, which has revealed the complexity and encoded information in cells, flatly opposing the anti-design bias. So "science is now in far better shape to evaluate the claims of the two most important ideas about origins."[233] He concludes:

> Some of the apparently soundest pillars of evolution are proving to be dubious, if not thoroughly unbalanced. One of the most disturbing features of both micro- and macro-evolution is the failure of all attempts to provide a fundamental mechanism, based on sound physical principles, which could explain the postulated upward accumulation in living things of complex, information-rich structures.... Advances in biology, biochemistry and genetics have come, not from the application of evolutionary principles mediated by chance, but mainly from experiments in which intelligent intervention has played the key role.[234]

Stephen Meyer adds:

> Every major origin-of-life scenario—whether based on chance, necessity, or the combination—failed to explain the origin of specified information. Thus, ironically, origin-of-life research itself confirms that undirected chemical processes do not produce large amounts of specified information starting from purely physical or chemical antecedents. For this reason, it seemed entirely sensible to think that the conservation laws that computer scientists had devised to describe the flow of information in computational domain applied equally to the larger domain of nature itself. If so, it seemed plausible to think that the informational repositories of life—such as the DNA molecule—were pointing to a source of information beyond the realm of physics and chemistry.[235]

In other words, they were pointing to an Intelligent Designer—the Creator-God Himself.

Study Questions

1. Why was the prebiotic soup theory called into question?
2. Why was the panspermia theory called into question?
3. Does Scripture concur with Darwin's finding on the variety of species? What did Darwin overlook?

233. John C. Walton, foreword to *Creationism Revisited: A New Look at the Case for Creationism*, by Colin Mitchell (Grantham, Lincs, UK: Autumn House, 1999), 7.
234. Ibid., 8.
235. Meyer, *Signature in the Cell*, 332–333.

4. Why does the complexity of each of the following examples call evolution into question on the basis of science alone?
    a. Eye
    b. Information storage in a single cell
    c. Flagellum as a machine
    d. DNA
5. What is Intelligent Design, and what is it not?
6. How do the following scientifically question evolution?
    a. Specified complexity
    b. Functional complexity
    c. Second law of thermodynamics
7. How does good science evaluate the following?
    a. Mutations
    b. Linear descent
    c. Developmental theory
    d. Intermediates
    e. Competition
8. What advantages does the interventionist approach to nature bring to a scientific researcher?

CHAPTER EIGHT

Evolution Questioned: Global Flood

Purpose

1. Give biblical evidence that the flood was global.
2. Provide scientific evidence that the flood was global.
3. Explore the implications of a global flood.

Summary

Scripture does not mention the geological column. Some biblical scholars have come to strongly suspect the fossil layers were produced by the Flood, but the Bible does not state this. Observed facts in nature are the same whether one believes in a global flood or not, but the difference is in the interpretation of the observed facts. The biblical evidence for a global flood comes from the meaning of Hebrew words or phrases used in the book of Genesis, with corroborating data from other biblical references to the flood. The implications of this biblical evidence call into the assumption of geology that the visible layers of strata in the geological column are the result of millions of years of formation. Contrary to this view, believers in a global flood consider the visible layers of strata to be the result of the Flood. In other words, geologists consider the strata as evidence for the birth of the world, and global flood scholars consider the strata as evidence for the death of the antediluvian world. Thus biblical evidence for a global flood turns the world of geology upside-down, and calls into question one important piece of evidence used to support the theory of evolution.

However, the explanation for marine life present on every mountain range is agreed upon by both Flood believers and other geologists: the uplift of mountains raised marine fossils up to the mountain tops. The conflict here is in the timing: When did this happen, and how long did it take?

Outline

I. Introduction
II. Biblical Record
A. Deluge
B. Biblical God
C. Noah in Flood Stories
D. Noah's Ark
E. Denies Uniformitarianism
III. Claimed Evidence for Local Flood
IV. Biblical Evidence for Global Flood
V. In Fairness to Geology
A. Geological Column
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C. Rock Formation
VI. Historical Evidence for Global Flood
VII. Ark and Tabernacle
VIII. Protology and Eschatology
A. Two Beginnings
IX. Conclusion
X. Study Questions

Introduction

The geological column is foundational for the theory of evolution. This is because science lacks empirical evidence for what transpired during deep-time, but evolutionary scientists believe evolution must have taken place through many micro mutations resulting from natural selection, chance, and the struggle to survive. They realize, as did Darwin, that the fossil record in the geological column is incomplete and imperfect; still, they consider it persuasive evidence in support of the theory of evolution.

In chapter 7 we noted important insights from two scientists that radically call into question macroevolution: (1) L. James Gibson states that there is far too little time in the geological column for evolution to take place, and (2) Ariel Roth states

that there is far too much time in the geological column since it necessarily means all of the world's oceans would have been filled with eroded sediments multiple times over. Because empirical evidence shows little deposition present in the ocean beds, and continents patently visible, geological deep-time is called into question.

When it comes to the global flood, evolutionists dismiss it as fiction. For example, Norman Newell, Curator Emeritus of the American Museum of Natural History, and Professor Emeritus of Columbia University, New York, has said: "The poetic story of Noah and his Ark is now regarded by thoughtful people as allegory. All of the modern zoos combined, with their thousands of trained keepers and elaborate facilities for feeding, housing, sanitation, and essential control of environment could briefly accommodate only a few hundred selected species of the millions that exist. As for plants—they were not even mentioned by the chroniclers of the Flood event."[1] Newell apparently overlooks the fact that only a single pair of every kind of animals extant today were necessary to populate the planet. All the creatures God created in the Garden of Eden were represented in the Ark (cf. Gen. 6:20) and filled the earth (Gen. 8:17). As for plants, the seeds may well have survived the Deluge.

In this chapter biblical and scientific evidence is given to document a global flood, which would explain much (but not all) of what is seen in the geological column, and is in harmony with a recent time for the creation on planet earth (up to ten thousand years).

Biblical Record

The Hebrew word for flood is *mabbûl*. It is a technical term only used to refer to Noah's flood. It occurs in Genesis 6:17; 7:6–17; 9:11, 15, 28; 10:1, 32; and 11:10.[2] Outside of Genesis, it only occurs in Psalm 29:10.[3] Because the biblical flood is so well known, the word is usually preceded by a definite article (except Gen. 9:15),[4] so "the waters of a flood" (Gen. 9:11b) reads in Hebrew "waters of the flood." The record of the flood is "a carefully wrought and intricately complex narrative,"[5] "a carefully integrated whole"[6] which negates Wellhausen's division of the account between J and P, for the narrative unfolds as

1. Norman D. Newell, *Creation and Evolution: Myth or Reality*, in the Convergence Series (New York: Columbia University, 1982), 36.
2. J. E. Hartley, "Flood," in *The International Standard Bible Encyclopedia* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1982), 2:315.
3. Jack P. Lewis, "Flood," in *The Anchor Bible Dictionary* (New York: Doubleday, 1992), 2:800.
4. Walter C. Kaiser, "*mabbûl*," *Theological Wordbook of the Old Testament*, (Chicago: Moody 1980), 1:489.
5. John H. Sailhamer, *Genesis*, vol. 2 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1990), 79.
6. Gordon J. Wenham, *Genesis* 1–15, vol. 1 in *Word Biblical Commentary* (Waco, TX: Word, 1987), 157.

the work of one author. I concur with H. F. Vos that a "consecutive reading of the whole Flood narrative shows a continuous progress from beginning to end."[7] B. W. Anderson sees the story as a unit, based on its presentation in the form of an extended chiasmus, a popular Hebrew literary pattern:

Transitional introduction (6:9–10)
1. Violence in God's creation (6:11–12)
2. First divine speech: resolve to destroy (6:13–22)
3. Second divine speech: command to enter the ark (7:1–10)
4. Beginning of the flood (7:11–16)
5. The rising flood waters (7:17–24)

GOD'S REMEMBRANCE OF NOAH

6. The receding flood waters (8:1–5)
7. The drying of the earth (8:6–14)
8. Third divine address: command to leave the ark (8:15–19)
9. God's resolution: to preserve order (8:20–22)
10. Fourth divine address: covenant blessing and peace (9:1–17)

Transitional conclusion (9:18–19)[8]

In Scripture, the Hebrew word for ark (*tēbâ*) refers to Noah's boat twenty-eight times (e.g., Gen. 7:1), and once to the basket Moses was placed into in the Nile (Exod. 2:2, 5). Hence the word refers to a conveyance, large or small, used to save life.[9]

DELUGE

There are many terms for "rain" in the Hebrew language. The two general ones are *gešem* and *māṭār*, occurring thirty-five and thirty-eight times respectively, with *rĕbîbîm* and *ṭal* for light rains, and *zerem*, *sagrîr*, *sāpîaḥ*, and *śā'îr* for heavy rains.[10] The Hebrew word *gešem* "by itself does designate a heavy rain, as seen by the fact that *gešem* may be accompanied by words emphasizing that point (1K. 18:41, 45; Ezek. 13:11, 13). There can be a mighty, rushing *gešem*, but not a mighty, rushing *māṭār*."[11] With respect to the predicted flood, God said that in seven days, "I will send rain [Heb *māṭār*] on the earth" (Gen. 7:4a).

7. H. F. Vos, "Flood (Genesis)" in *The International Standard Bible Encyclopedia*, 2:317.
8. Bernhard W. Anderson, *Journal of Biblical Literature*, 97:1 (March 1978): 38.
9. Stephen T. Hague, "*tēbâ*," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology & Exegesis* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1997), 4:270.
10. Mark D. Futato, "*gšm*," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology & Exegesis*, 1:901.
11. Victor P. Hamilton, *The Book of Genesis, Chapters 1–17*, in *The New International Commentary on the Old Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1990), 288.

But, seven days later "the floodgates [*'ărūbâ*, meaning torrential downpour][12] of the heavens were opened. And rain [*gešem*] fell on the earth forty days and forty nights" (Gen. 7:11b–12; cf. 8:2). With the torrential downpour, the "springs of the great deep [*tĕhôm*] burst forth" (Gen. 7:11), and the force of water pouring down and gushing forth produced the Flood. The biblical account stresses the uniqueness of this event.

BIBLICAL GOD

The flood account in Scripture, compared with Ancient Near Eastern (ANE) accounts, reveals the superiority of the biblical God over pagan gods. One needs to keep in mind that the cosmic controversy involves an attempt to spread disinformation about God, to deceive the world with counterfeit views, in order to turn humans against God, so they will join the rebellion against God. Gordon Wenham compares the difference between the Genesis account and those common in the surrounding cultures: (1) "The heavenly council of gods led by Anu and Enlil decided to destroy mankind, for multiplying too much and making too much noise"; (2) "this decision was not unanimous, and the god *Ea* or *Enki* went so far as to tip off the flood hero"; "this was how he managed to escape, much to *Enlil's* subsequent annoyance"; (3) the gods can't control the storm, and are frightened by it; they "cower like dogs"; (4) after the Flood a sacrifice is offered to the gods, who are dependent on humans to feed them, and they are "greedily jostling for places at the open-air barbecue"; (5) *"Enlil,* the chief executive among the gods, arrives and is surprised to discover survivors of the flood. Clearly he is neither omnipotent nor omniscient."[13]

In contrast, the true God says, "My Spirit will not contend with humans forever" (Gen. 6:3), where the Hebrew word *dîn* (contend) is better translated "plead."[14] Here is a picture of God who longs to save His children. He is patient with them, "not wanting anyone to perish, but everyone to come to repentance" (2 Pet. 3:9b), for they have been created in His image (Gen. 1:26–27). But now the thoughts of their hearts are "only evil all the time" (Gen. 6:5b); they have imaged the *enemy* of God, and have become like him. "The LORD regretted that he had made human beings on the earth, and his heart was deeply troubled" (Gen. 6:6). God was just as pained with His children's rejection of Him before the Flood as Jesus was by the Jewish leaders' rejection of Him, which caused Him to cry out: "Jerusalem, Jerusalem, you who kill the prophets and stone

12. Victor P. Hamilton, "*'ărūbâ*," *Theological Wordbook of the Old Testament*, 1:68.
13. Wenham, *Genesis 1–15*, vol. 1 in *Word Biblical Commentary*, 164–165.
14. Robert D. Culver, "*dîn*," *Theological Wordbook of the Old Testament*, 1:188.

those sent to you, how often I have longed to gather your children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wing, and you were not willing" (Matt. 23:37).

Here is the same pleading God rebuffed and rejected by rebels. They didn't want anything to do with God. Their hearts were no different from those who later cried out "crucify Him!" They acted as if independent, having no need of God, as if gods themselves. So it is in the cosmic controversy. Humans become either more like the true God or like counterfeit gods. The on-looking universe sees the stark and staggering difference: Humans are either delivered or deceived. Their view of God makes all the difference. Relationship with God decides destiny. So it was that cut off from their Deliverer, the antediluvians were to suffer destruction.

NOAH IN FLOOD STORIES

Just as there is a great difference between the true God and counterfeit gods, so there is a big difference between the Noah of Scripture and his counterpart in the ANE stories. Noah doesn't say a word in the Flood story—we do not know his feelings. He has a low profile, because the focus is on God. By contrast, the ANE hero, *Utnapishtim*, is active and vocal, telling a yarn to neighbors about his ship building. Besides the animals, he brings a large crew on board with all his gold and silver. He describes what it is like to be in the eye of the storm, and his pain in seeing humans turned to clay. He weeps. *Utnapishtim* and *Ziusudra*, the Sumerian Noah, are both kings compared to the common man, the Noah of Scripture. At the end of these two pagan stories, the two "Noahs" receive immortality, and hence become gods.[15] They are the heroes of the stories, whereas God is the hero in the biblical story, for it is God who saves Noah and begins life for the world a second time.

"Noah was a righteous [*ṣaddîq*] man, blameless [*tāmîm*] among the people of his time, and he faithfully walked with God" (Gen. 6:9), just like Enoch (Gen. 5:22, 24). The on-looking universe not only observed the great difference between the true God and his counterfeits, but also between the true Noah and his counterparts. It is in history that God reveals who He is, and *the love He bears for humans*, and it is in history that Satan is *exposed for who he is by what he does through people.* The difference between the two sides of the controversy is clearly evident. After the Flood Satan uses the destruction of all humanity to distort the truth about God, making it appear that God is arbitrary, capricious, and cruel. The devil works to make humans hate or fear God—either way he hides the love of God from the children He so dearly loves. This is why it is important to allow God to speak for Himself in Scripture, to allow all Scripture to be a self-revelation

15. Wenham, *Genesis 1–15*, vol. 1 in *Word Biblical Commentary*, 165–166.

of God, and to place Scripture as sole judge over all nonbiblical ideas (including church traditions that lack biblical affirmation).

NOAH'S ARK

The ark was a huge ship.[16] Apparently no ship exceeded the length of the ark until the Cunard line built the Etruria in 1884.[17] God said to Noah, "Make a roof for it, leaving below the roof an opening one cubit high all around. Put a door in the side of the ark and make lower, middle and upper decks" (Gen. 6:16). This verse suggests that the sides of the ark were built to within eighteen inches of the roof. There would be posts to attach the roof to the sides, but evidently there was an eighteen-inch opening under the entire roof in order to provide ventilation, which makes sense considering all the animals on board.

DENIES UNIFORMITARIANISM

Scripture indicates that people's thinking during the end times will be characterized by a uniformitarian worldview. A uniformitarian worldview is the basis on which fossil evidence is used to establish the long geological time frame necessary for evolution. We noted this in chapter 5, but here we will add two judgments of God.

> Above all, you must understand that in the last days scoffers will come, scoffing and following their own evil desires. They will say, "Where is this 'coming' he promised? Ever since our ancestors died, everything goes on as it has since the beginning of creation." But they deliberately forget that long ago by God's word the heavens came into being and the earth was formed out of water and by water. By these waters also the world of that time was deluged and destroyed. By the same word the present heavens and earth are reserved for fire, being kept for the day of judgment and destruction of the ungodly. (2 Pet. 3:3–7)

16. Most translations give the measurement of the ark in cubits (300 cubits long, 50 cubits wide, and 30 cubits high; KJV, NKJV, NEB, NASB, RSV, Goodspeed). The cubit measure is interpreted variously by different translators and commentators. For example, some biblical versions state that the ark was "450 feet long, 75 feet wide and 45 feet high" (Gen. 6:15, NIV, Amplified), whereas Victor Hamilton suggests the ark was 440 feet long, 73 feet wide, and 44 feet high, with a water displacement of about 43,000 tons. The approximate total deck area was 95,700 square feet. See Hamilton, *The Book of Genesis*, in *The New International Commentary on the Old Testament*, 282. Whichever size one accepts, the ark was huge, for it was about "two and a half times the size of the large 'Byblos-boats' used by the Egyptians during the Early Dynastic Period" and "even larger than the largest wooden ships in the modern period of sailing. The Cutty Sark, a three-masted clipper ship launched in 1869, was just over 212 feet" in length, Sailhamer, *Genesis*, vol. 2 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary*, 83.

17. The Babylonian, Egyptian, and Hebrew cubits were different. The Hebrews had two cubit measurements: the long cubit (52 cm or 20.4 in) and the common cubit (44.5/46 cm or 17.5/18 in). Using the shorter cubit, the ark would be 450 feet long, 75 feet wide, and 45 feet high, with a volume of 150,000 cubit feet. With the longer cubit, the ark would be 510 feet long, "almost half the length of the Queen Mary." According to these measurements, the ark was even larger than the estimates given in footnote 16 above. See H. F. Vos, "Flood (Genesis)" in *The International Standard Bible Encyclopedia*, 2:316.

The scoffers, those who do not believe in God, teach uniformitarianism. They assume that all things continue as they have been since creation, so there is no possibility of a global flood. God says they forget that by His word He created the heavens and the earth. (We interpret this as planet earth and its immediate environs, because both will be destroyed by fire one day, so the "heavens" do not include the dwelling place of God.) God created the global planet by His word, and will destroy the global planet by fire. Both of these events are global in nature. The same language is used of the Flood—it was global. That is why destruction of the entire world by water is mentioned together with the destruction of the entire world by fire. To assert a local flood, or floods, is illogical in this context.

Claimed Evidence for Local Floods

There has been much debate over the extent of the Flood. Was it really global—or was it a local flood, or one of many local floods? Archaeologists assert that there is no empirical evidence for a global flood: "With the beginning of modern archaeology in Mesopotamia, it became popular to associate evidence of flood destruction in sites such as Kish, Ur, and Shuruppak with the biblical flood. Those places, however, were destroyed by different floods at different times."[18] "Extremely old sites in Palestine, such as Jericho, have revealed no flood deposits."[19] It is claimed that there are no flood stories in the cultures of Japan and Egypt, and very few in Africa.[20] Science, rather than Scripture, is what scholars look to for incontrovertible evidence of a global flood:

> The nature of the Genesis flood will continue to be a matter of debate among interested parties, but it seems unlikely that the issue will be resolved unless some new archaeological or scientific evidence of a compelling nature is forthcoming. That there was a flood of enormous proportions is hardly to be doubted in the light of the Genesis account and other ancient traditions. However, the precise nature and extent of the biblical deluge must remain a matter of interpretation and speculation until incontrovertible evidence settles the issue.[21]

In 1954 Evangelical theologian Bernard Ramm said, "Although many Christians still believe in the universal flood, most of the recent conservative scholarship of the church defends a local flood."[22] In 1967 Old Testament scholar Derek Kidner supported a local flood.[23] In 1977 Davis Young supported a local

18. Walter A. Elwell, ed., *Baker Encyclopedia of the Bible* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1988), 1:797.
19. Lewis, "Flood," in *The Anchor Bible Dictionary*, 2:798.
20. Bernard Ramm, *The Christian View of Science and Scripture* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1954), 242.
21. Elwell, ed., *Baker Encyclopedia of the Bible*, 1:798.
22. Ramm, *The Christian View*, 238.
23. Derek Kidner, *Genesis*, vol. 1 in *Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1967), 93–95.

flood.[24] In 1982 H. F. Vos said, "The flood geology position has been discredited by university geology departments and is being rejected almost universally by evangelical geologists."[25] In 1992 John C. Whitcomb stated, "many evangelical scholars continue to permit uniformitarian concepts of earth history to dominate their interpretation of Genesis 6–9,"[26] and many who defended a local flood published near the end of the millennium.[27] Yet Scripture clearly repudiates uniformitarian thinking (2 Pet. 3:4–6). These Evangelicals apparently overlook God's promise made to Noah, "[N]ever again will there be a flood to destroy the earth" (Gen. 9:11b). If the Flood was merely local, then God has broken His promise many times.

In spite of the above biblical statements, Bernard Ramm argues for a local flood, and here are a few of his reasons: (1) The entire flood record "must be interpreted phenomenally" because it looked that way to the observer who reported it, and not because it was so. (2) "The problem is one of interpretation, not inspiration." (3) "All the waters of the heavens, poured all over the earth, would amount to a sheath seven inches thick. If the earth were a perfect sphere so that all the waters of the ocean covered it, the depth of the ocean would be two and one-half to three miles. To cover the highest mountains would require eight times more water than we now have."[28]

To say that the Flood *only looked* universal to the observer overlooks the fact that the One who inspired the writing of the record was God (not a human), and because God is omnipresent, He knew the Flood was global—hence His pledge to never again destroy the earth through a flood. Further, if the Flood had not been universal, it would make little sense for Peter to use the universal flood as a type of the coming universal destruction of the world through fire (2 Pet. 3:6–7). Therefore, Ramm has a problem with inspiration, and this is clearly illustrated by his attempt to determine whether the flood was universal solely on the basis of the amount of water it would take. In 1995 Davis Young's case study of the church's response to extrabiblical evidence was published; in it he concludes:

> A large segment of the church has unfortunately locked itself into a biblical hermeneutic that requires a global flood and a recent six-day creation and that prevents it from dealing responsibly with God's creative work. I submit that there is

24. Davis A. Young, *Creation and the Flood: An Alternative to Flood Geology and Theistic Evolution* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1977), 171–210.
25. H. F. Vos, "Flood (Genesis)" in *The International Standard Bible Encyclopedia*, 2:318.
26. John C. Whitcomb, *The World That Perished: An Introduction to Biblical Catastrophism*, rev. ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1992), 64.
27. Donald C. Boardman, "Did Noah's Flood Cover the Entire World? No," in Ronald F. Youngblood, ed., *The Genesis Debate: Persistent Questions About Creation and the Flood* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1990), 210–229; Arthur C. Custance, *The Flood: Local or Global?* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1979), 15–27; T. C. Mitchell, "Flood," in *The New Bible Dictionary*, 2nd ed. (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1993), 380–383.
28. Ramm, *The Christian View*, 238–244.

> something inherently flawed in any hermeneutic that prevents us from reading God's handiwork properly and that repeatedly puts us at odds with the established conclusions of a scientific community that is composed not just of opponents of Christianity but also of confessing Christians. Some Christians delight in contrasting the infallible Word of God (that is to say, the Word of God infallibly interpreted by them) with the fallible ideas of sinful human beings and on that basis reject scientific conclusions they do not like.[29]

Actually Young describes what persons on both sides of the debate do. Scientists can also lock themselves into natural evidence and deny the relevance of Scripture. Such a narrow focus limits each side's ability to be objective. Since none of us were present at the flood, and none of us have firsthand empirical evidence, then the data is evaluated from our basic biases, irrespective of whether they are scientific or scriptural. But for Christians, when it comes to the biblical data, whether we are scientists or theologians, faith in God's Word has preeminence over faith in human ability to assess data. In other words, for us as Christians, God's revealed Word should guide us in the interpretation of data from the natural realm, rather than the other way around. Otherwise natural revelation becomes superior to God's self-revelation, and that isn't a position of faith in God, the Author of Scripture.

For those accepting the doctrine of uniformitarianism, the Flood simply doesn't fit into that system. As Alfred Rehwinkel puts it, the Flood "was rejected for geological, biological, and historical reasons. The textbooks of these sciences continue to ignore the Flood altogether, and anyone who still seriously contends for a belief in the universal Flood meets with opposition, scorn, and ridicule even in many quarters of the Church."[30]

Doctrine is not dependent upon nonbiblical sources, however persuasive they may appear to be at present. Time can bring new evidence to light. As Christians we know we are saved by faith (Rom. 1:17), and we need to accept the entirety of God's Word by faith too. The very essence of being a Christian is a profound faith in God's Word. After all, Scripture is the Word from the God who died for us, and who promises eternal redemption through faith in His atonement. The degree to which we are willing to trust God's Word in Scripture is an exercise of faith compatible with the exercise of faith in God for salvation. This is why God's saints in the Old Testament are singled out as persons of faith (Heb. 11). It should be remembered that Eve doubted God's Word, which led to the fall of the human race (Gen. 2:16–17; 3:1–6).

29. Davis A. Young, *The Biblical Flood: A Case Study of the Church's Response to Extrabiblical Evidence* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1995), 309–310.

30. Alfred M. Rehwinkel, *The Flood in the Light of the Bible, Geology, and Archaeology* (St. Louis, MO: Concordia, 1951), 127.

Biblical Evidence for Global Flood

God uses global language for the world's problem (evil) and its solution (the Flood). This includes comparing the Flood to creation, another global event. God grieved that He had created humans because they were evil. "So the LORD said, 'I will wipe from the face of the earth the human race I have created'" (Gen. 6:7a). The word that means "wipe" in Hebrew is *mḥh*. Used with reference to judgment, *mḥh* means "the complete removal (and thus destruction) of life by the Flood."[31] Every kind of animal (Gen. 6:20) echoes every kind in creation (Gen. 1:20b, 24). Just as God gave to Adam food to eat except one forbidden fruit (Gen. 2:16–17), so He gave food to Noah (Gen. 6:21), with only unclean animals off-limits, for Noah knew the difference between clean and unclean animals.[32] After the Flood, Noah was like a new Adam, for it was a new beginning for the world. God invited the family of Noah to "be fruitful and increase in number; multiply on the earth and increase upon it" (Gen. 9:7), the same invitation He had given to Adam and Eve (Gen. 1:28a). Life after the Flood marked a new beginning—just as it had been after creation, indicating that the Flood was as global in nature as original creation had been.

The universality of judgment given in the Genesis Flood account is clearly stated: "I will wipe from the face of the earth every living creature I have made" (Gen. 7:4b); "Every living thing on the face of the earth was wiped out; people and animals and the creatures that move along the ground and the birds were wiped from the earth. Only Noah was left, and those with him in the ark" (Gen. 7:23; cf. Gen. 6:8–9, 17–18; 7:1; 1 Pet. 3:20; 2 Pet. 2:5). Not only is "everything" wiped out, but "everything" means all except Noah and those in the ark.[33] Peter concurs with this, saying God "did not spare the ancient world when he brought the flood [*kataklusmos*, from which we get *cataclysmic*] on its ungodly people, but protected Noah, a preacher of righteousness, and seven others" (2 Pet. 2:5; cf. 1 Pet. 3:20).

Gerhard von Rad says God "allowed his created world to be engulfed by chaos."[34] The earth is introduced in Scripture as chaos before creation (Gen. 1:2). Through the global flood the earth returned to chaos. Joseph Blenkinsopp calls this "uncreation" because "[t]he world in which order first arose out of a primeval watery chaos is now reduced to the watery chaos out of which it arose—chaos-come-again."[35] Gordon Wenham sees the flood as the "undoing" of creation. In

31. Cornelius Van Dam, "*mḥh*," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology & Exegesis*, 2:913.

32. Wenham, *Genesis: 1–15*, vol. 1 in *Word Biblical Commentary*, 175–176.

33. L. James Gibson: "It is likely that this does not include fish, clams, insects, and plants," personal correspondence with author.

34. Gerhard von Rad, *Genesis: A Commentary* (Philadelphia, PA: Westminster, 1972), 129.

35. Joseph Blenkinsopp, in J. Blenkinsopp et al., *The Pentateuch*, 1971, 46–47, quoted in David J. A. Clines, "Noah's Flood 1: The Theology of the Flood Narrative," in *Faith and Thought* 100/2 (1972–1973): 136.

creation God separated the dry land from the waters (Gen. 1:9); in the flood He covered the dry land with the waters (a return to Gen. 1:2).[36] On the third day of creation, the dry land appeared, and the "third dated event in the flood story is the appearance of the mountains."[37]

Scripture states that the waters "rose greatly on the earth, and all the high mountains under the entire heavens were covered. The waters rose and covered the mountains to a depth of more than fifteen cubits" (Gen. 7:19b–20).

Critics question the covering of the highest mountains like Mount Everest, which is about five-and-a-half miles above sea level.[38] Critics claim: (1) "If the earth were a perfect sphere so that all the waters of the ocean covered it, the depth of the ocean would be two and one-half to three miles. To cover the highest mountains would require eight times more water than we now have."[39] (2) At such a height most occupants of the ark would be rendered insensible because of the rarified atmosphere.

Concerning the first point above, Psalm 104 is not the answer to the raising of the mountains, suggesting that they are lower than before the Flood, for the Flood covered the mountains (Gen. 7:19b, 20). Except for an insight from Martin Luther,[40] other commentators, and for the most part even Luther, rightly assert that Psalm 104 should be read in light of the creation account, not the Flood context.[41] The Hebrew Bible has no heading for this psalm, but the psalm itself is about creation and can be compared with the six days of the Genesis account.

Concerning the second point above, providing air for those in the ark to breathe would not have been a problem to God, for the ark would not have survived apart from His providential care. On a scientific level, John Whitcomb points out, "atmospheric pressure depends on elevation relative to sea level. The air column above the raised sea level during the Flood was just as high, and the resulting sea level atmospheric pressure just as great, as the present sea level pressure."[42]

Scripture uses the Hebrew word *ʾereṣ* (earth) for the world that was flooded (Gen. 6:7a) and the world that was created (Gen. 1:1). Although *ʾereṣ* does not

36. Wenham, *Genesis: 1–15*, vol. 1 in *Word Biblical Commentary*, 181.
37. Ibid., 185.
38. *The World Encyclopedia* (Chicago: Field Enterprises Educational Corp, n.d.), 13:731.
39. Ramm, *The Christian View*, 244.
40. Martin Luther, *Luther's Works: Psalms 78–126*, ed. Hilton C. Oswald (Saint Louis, MO: Concordia Publishing House, 1976), 11/8, 325.
41. Some examples are: John Calvin, *Psalm 93–150*, vol. 6 in *Calvin's Commentaries*, trans. James Anderson (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1989), 143–171; Albert Barnes, *Psalms*, vol. 3 in *Notes on the Old Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 1847), 80–93; Franz Delitzsch, *The Psalms*, vol. 10 in *Commentary on the Old Testament*, trans. Francis Bolton (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1986), 125–137; William A. VanGemeren, *Psalms*, vol. 5 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1991), 657–665.
42. Whitcomb, *The World That Perished*, 48.

always mean "global,"[43] the context will determine whether it conveys the sense of "global." The argument that the Hebrew word *tēbēl* (world as a whole) should have been used if a global flood had been intended[44] overlooks the fact that *tēbēl* is used "exclusively in poetic texts" (thirty-six times),[45] and the Flood passage is not poetic, because Christ (Matt. 24:37–39) and Peter (1 Pet. 3:20; 2 Pet. 2:5) attest to its historical reality. Magnus Ottosson points out that the word *ʾereṣ* in Genesis 8:9 "means that the water covered the whole earth" just as Genesis 11:1 "means that the whole earth had one language" before God confused them at the tower of Babel.[46]

The phrase "fountains [*maʿyān*] of the great deep" (Gen. 7:11, KJV, or "springs of the great deep," NIV) refers to subterranean waters created by God (Prov. 8:28) over which He has sovereign control.[47] The Hebrew verb "broken up" (Gen. 7:11) can mean "split open" (Num. 16:31, cf. Zech. 14:4), "opened up" (Judges 15:19), "split apart" (Mic. 1:4). It means the heavens split open and a deluge poured forth. It also means the subterranean springs were split open. The compound noun "great deep" "appears four times in the Hebrew Old Testament, with Isaiah 51:10 showing its meaning as a large sea or ocean." With reference to the latter, "all" (*kol*) were broken up implies "a catastrophe not geografically [sic] restricted."[48]

Steven Austin refers to the undersea volcano at Krakatoa, Indonesia, in 1883, with statistics that remind us of the tsunami in 2005. He says this "undersea explosion" provides insight into the "fountains of the great deep" contributory to Noah's flood. One should keep in mind that the Krakatoa eruption lasted only a few seconds, but the eruptions during the Flood continued for forty days (Gen. 7:11, 24; 8:2–3):

> The eruption of Krakatoa moved material from the sea floor, displacing ocean water and creating a sea wave that inundated coastal areas of Java and Sumatra up to an elevation of 130 feet above sea level. The sea wave penetrated as much as six miles inland from the shore, devastated 295 villages and towns, killed more than 36,000 people, and destroyed 5,000 boats in coastal areas.... After traveling at speeds of about 400 miles per hour through the open ocean, the waves were recorded on tide gauges in South Africa (5,000 miles away), Alaska (6,000 miles away), California (8,000 miles away) and the English Channel (11,000 miles away).[49]

43. Christopher J. H. Wright, "*ʾereṣ*," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology & Exegesis*, 1:518.
44. H. F. Vos, "Flood (Genesis)" in *The International Standard Bible Encyclopedia*, 2:317.
45. Wright, "*tēbēl*," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology & Exegesis*, 4:272.
46. Magnus Ottosson, "*ʾereṣ*," in *Theological Dictionary of the Old Testament*, 1:393.
47. Bryan E. Beyer, "*maʿyān*," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology & Exegesis*, 2:1018–1019.
48. Steven A. Austin, in *The Genesis Debate*, ed. Youngblood, 212–213.
49. Ibid., 213–214.

We can't imagine the turbulence caused by torrential rain gushing from the heavens, yet the magnitude of those waters was not dependent upon ordinary clouds, but upon a God who can do the extraordinary. We can't grasp the impact of the global flood following massive volcanic eruptions with their seismic upheavals all over the world. We cannot fathom the utter devastation caused by the havoc worldwide.[50] Planet earth was engulfed in a deluge from above and from below which changed the pre-Flood tropical climate into what we have today. The earth was convulsed and thrown off its axis. This is the world that geology should study, a world in its death throes, not a world evolving into new life.[51]

Unlike this gigantic global interruption, uniformity (no changes like the flood) is hard science. An experiment done today should be reproducible in the lab in a thousand years, or should have had the same results a thousand years ago. But it was a different matter when Scottish scholars James Hutton (1726–1797) and Charles Lyell (1797–1875) used the principle of uniformity to state that the past is explained by present processes. Lyell is often called the founder of modern geology, writing his *Principles of Geology* (three volumes, 1830–1833), based on the idea of uniformity. Though his books were very popular[52] and influenced Darwin on his *HMS Beagle* voyage, the uniformity principle doesn't quite measure up:

> It should be obvious that this principle can never actually be proved to be valid. To be sure, it *seems* eminently reasonable, because the same principle is basic in other sciences....
>
> But historical geology is unique among the sciences in that it deals with events that are past, and therefore not reproducible.... The uniformitarian assumption is certainly a reasonable assumption, provided there is no sufficiently valid evidence to the contrary, but it must always remain merely an assumption.[53]

The world after the Flood was different from the world before the Flood. This is why the philosophy of uniformitarianism isn't a valid way to arrive at truth about the past, and why Scripture warns against it as a false theory during the end times (2 Pet. 3:3–7). Modern geology is based upon the theory of uniformity since the beginning; such a presupposition brought to geological data produces conclusions that are incompatible with a global deluge. Yet true science considers all possibilities, rather than confining the scope of the research. Uniformity and evolution are assumptions, but they shape modern geology, causing geologists to completely disallow biblical data regarding a global flood. And while contemporary geologists

50. In May 1960 the great tsunami tidal wave in Chile traveled at five-hundred twenty-five miles an hour, and "caused exrensive damage to Pacific ports, from Japan to California and from Alaska to New Zealand," *The Genesis Flood*, 264.

51. For commentary by geologists and to study the geological time table, see *The Genesis Flood*, 131–135.

52. Carroll Lane Fenton, "Lyell, Sir Charles" in *The World Book Encyclopedia*, 12:465.

53. Morris and Whitcomb, *The Genesis Flood*, 131.

have accepted some catastrophism (neocatastrophism), they still do not recognize a global flood.[54]

The biblical flood record doesn't make sense unless it was global, because "on that day all the springs of the great deep [*tĕhôm*] burst forth, and the floodgates of the heavens were opened" (Gen. 7:11b, cf. 2 Kings 7:2, 19; Isa. 24:18b); and "[f]or forty days the flood kept coming on the earth, and as the waters increased they lifted the ark high above the earth.... They rose greatly on the earth, and all the high mountains under the entire heavens were covered. The waters rose and covered the mountains to a depth of more than fifteen cubits" (Gen. 7:17–20). "The waters flooded the earth for a hundred and fifty days" (Gen. 7:24), and the volume of water was so massive that it took five months for the waters to recede (Gen. 8:3). The immensity of the ark, the fact that only one human family was aboard, the complete diversity of animals on the ark, and a five-month flood are all incompatible with a local flood.

If it were only a local flood, God would have led Noah and his family away from the area designated for destruction rather than having Noah take a hundred and twenty years to build a huge ship (Gen. 6:15).[55] If it had been a local flood, why would birds need to enter the ark (Gen. 7:3) when they could have flown away to safety (some can fly hundreds of miles a day)?[56] God told them to take representatives of "all living creatures" or (two or seven) "of every kind" "throughout the earth" (Gen. 6:19–20; 7:2–4) for "I will wipe from the face of the earth every living creature I have made" (Gen. 7:4b). Every type is preserved because all the rest will be destroyed—globally. "I am going to bring floodwaters on the earth to destroy all life under the heavens, every creature that has the breath of life in it. Everything on earth will perish" (Gen. 6:17). "I will send rain on the earth for forty days and forty nights, and I will wipe from the face of the earth every living creature I have made" (Gen. 7:4).

Richard Davidson examines other expressions that have a universal meaning in the creation narrative and are used in the Flood narrative.

Term/Phrase (same in the Hebrew)	**Flood Narrative**	**Creation Narrative**
"on the face of the whole earth"	Genesis 7:3; 8:9	Genesis 1:29
"face of the earth"	Genesis 7:4, 22–23; 8:8, 13	Genesis 2:6
"all living creatures" of all flesh	Genesis 6:19, cf. 7:4, 23	Genesis 7:4 refers back to creation

54. Ariel Roth, *Origins: Linking Science and Scripture* (Hagerstown, MD: Review and Herald, 1998), 210, 215.

55. Estimated at one hundred thousand square feet of deck space; see Whitcomb, *The World That Perished*, 50.

56. Andrew S. Kulikovsky, *Creation, Fall, Restoration: A Biblical Theology of Creation* (Ross-Shire, Scotland: Christian Focus/Mentor, 2009), 232.

Davidson points out that the phrase "upon the face of all the earth" used in the Flood narrative is also used in creation (Gen. 1:29) before the Flood, and in the global dispersal following the building of the Tower of Babel after the Flood (Gen. 11:4, 8–9).[57] The flood was just as universal as the other two events.[58] Also:

> The phrase "under the whole heaven" or "under all the heavens" also universalizes the phrase "under heaven" (Gen. 6:17) in this same flood context. The word "heaven" by itself can have a local meaning (e.g., 1 Kings 18:45), but here the context is global. Ecclesiastes, which contains numerous allusions to creation, likewise utilizes the term "under heaven" with a universal intention (Eccl. 1:13; 2:3; 3:1; cf. the parallel universal expression "under the sun" in Eccl. 1:3, 9; 22:11, 17; etc.).[59]

Davidson refers to an article by Gerhard Hasel, who shows that the phrase "all the springs of the great deep" (Gen. 7:11; 8:2) is linked to the universal "deep" or "world ocean" in the creation narrative (Gen. 1:2, cf. Ps. 104:6). In another article, Hasel documents that "the Hebrew Bible reserved a special term, *mabbûl"* to speak of the Deluge. "(I)n its 13 occurrences," it "refers exclusively to the worldwide Genesis flood (12 occurrences in Genesis, once in Psalm 29:10)." As Davidson concludes, the word *mabbûl* is a technical term that "clearly sets the Genesis deluge apart from all local floods. Psalm 29:10 utilizes it to illustrate Yahweh's universal sovereignty over the world at the time of the Noahic flood: 'The Lord sat enthroned at the Flood, and the Lord sits as King forever' (NJKV)."[60]

In his own article[61] Davidson examines thirty different linguistic evidences (terms, expressions, complexes of terminology) found in Genesis 6–9 and elsewhere in Scripture; many echo "their intertextual counterparts in the account of global creation" in Genesis 1–2, and indicate a universal flood.[62] In this recent article, mention is made of the literary structure of the Flood narrative. Contrary to the popular Documentary Hypothesis, with its dividing of Genesis (and the Flood Narrative) into small textual units (J and P), a symmetrical literary structure of the Flood narrative provides weighty evidence for the unity of the narrative. See the next page.

57. Steven A. Austin presents the same evidence in "Did Noah's Flood Cover the Entire World?" in *The Genesis Debate*, ed. Youngblood, 210–229.

58. Richard M. Davidson, "Biblical Evidence for the Universality of the Genesis Flood," in *Creation, Catastrophe and Calvary*, ed. John Templeton Baldwin (Hagerstown, MD: Review and Herald, 2000), 81.

59. Ibid., 82.

60. Richard M. Davidson, "Biblical Evidence," 83–84. The articles of Gerhatd F. Hasel are: "Some Issues Regarding the Natute and Universality of the Genesis Flood Narrative," *Origins* 5 (1978): 83–98; "The Fountains of the Great Deep," *Origins* 1 (1974): 67–72.

61. Richard M. Davidson, "The Genesis Flood Narrative: Crucial Issues in the Current Debate," *Andrews University Seminary Studies*, 42, no. 1 (Spring 2004): 49–77.

62. Davidson, "The Genesis Flood," *Andrews University Seminary Studies*, 54.

E The flood proper

b The flood crests
The ark rests
God remembered Noah (8:1–5)

a The flood rises.....**a'** The flood abates
(7:17–24) (8:6–12)

D Preliminary to the flood..... D' After the flood

d Enters the ark.....**d'** Exits the ark
(7:11–16) (8:13–19)

c Brings in clean animals.....**c'** Noah's sacrifice
(7:6–10) (8:20–22)

b Bring in clean animals.....**b'** Noah's diet
(7:1–5) (9:1–7)

a My covenant with you..... **a'** My covenant with you
(6:11–22) (9:8–17)

C Secondary genealogy.....C' Secondary genealogy
(6:9–10) (9:18–19)

B Prologue: man's wickedness.....B' Epilogue: man's
(6:1–8) wickedness (9:20–27)

A Primary genealogy.....A' Primary genealogy
(5:32) (9:28–29)

****

e The Flood crests, the ark rests
God remembers Noah (8:1)

d 150 days prevail.....**d'** 150 days waters abate
(7:24) (8:3)

c 40 days of the flood.....**c'** 40 days first birds sent out
(7:12, 17) (8:6)

b 7 days till the flood.....**b'** 7 days next bird sent out
(7:10) (8:10)

a 7 days till 40 day storm.....**a'** 7 days last bird sent out
(7:4) (8:12)

Steven Austin notes, "The account says that 'all the high hills that were under the whole heaven were covered.' Because 'all…hills' might be understood to comprise only those hills within the geographic knowledge of the narrator, the Hebrew writer removes all possible ambiguity by attaching the phrase 'under the whole heaven.'" There are five other instances in the Old Testament where "under the whole heaven" has universal meaning (Deut. 4:19; Job 28:24; 37:3; 41:11; Dan. 9:12).[63] Austin adds:

> The phrase ["under the whole heaven"] is used to illustrate God's omniscience ("For He looks to the ends of the earth and sees under the whole heavens," Job 28:24 NKJV) and sovereignty ("Whatsoever is under the whole heaven is mine," 41:11 KJV). The God of the Old Testament does not see and own only what resides within the boundary of the nation Israel; he sees the whole earth and owns all of it. Because the same terminology is used to describe Noah's flood, it cannot be geographically restricted but must be universal.[64]

James Gibson points out, "Scientists can be 'catastrophists' by believing in numerous global catastrophes over long ages, not just the Biblical flood."[65] Some scholars think in terms of many local floods in place of a global flood. A global flood cannot be identified with multiple local floods, for the first is at the supernatural level, whereas local floods are natural disasters. If one believes in the trustworthiness of Genesis, as God's literal record of how He created the world and how He destroyed it, then the destruction of the world is just as supernatural as its creation. In other words, evidence for a global creation is also evidence for a global destruction.

After the Flood was over, the ark rested on the "mountains of Ararat" (Gen. 8:4; cf. 2 Kings 19:37; Jer. 51:27), and the covenant God made with Noah was global: (1) "Never again will I destroy all living creatures, as I have done" (Gen. 8:21b; cf. 7:21–23). (2) God blessed Noah and his sons, saying, "Be fruitful and increase in number and fill the earth" (Gen. 9:1; same blessing He gave to Adam, Gen. 1:28). (3) "Never again will all life be destroyed by the waters of a flood; never again will there be a flood to destroy the earth" (Gen. 9:11). (4) "I have set my rainbow in the clouds, and it will be the sign of the covenant between me and the earth" (Gen. 9:13). "This is the sign of the covenant I am making between me and you and every living creature with you" (Gen. 9:12). In Psalm 29, in the Hebrew, David literally says: "The LORD sits enthroned over the flood [*mabbûl*]; the LORD is enthroned as King forever" (Ps. 29:10). Keil and Delitzsch note that the Hebrew word for "flood" (*mabbûl*) "occurs

63. Austin, "Did Noah's Flood Cover the Entire World?" in *The Genesis Debate*, ed. Youngblood, 211–212.
64. Ibid., 212.
65. Personal correspondence with author.

exclusively in Gen. vi.–xi. as the name of the great Flood." The King remains true to His commitment to not send another global flood.[66]

Christ spoke of the Flood as a literal, historical fact, and as a global counterpart to His second coming:

> As it was in the day of Noah, so it will be at the coming of the Son of Man. For in the days before the flood, people were eating and drinking, marrying and giving in marriage, up to the day Noah entered the ark; and they knew nothing about what would happen until the flood came and took them all away. That is how it will be at the coming of the Son of Man. (Matt. 24:37–39; cf. Luke 17:26–27)

> Then will appear the sign of the Son of Man in heaven. And then all the peoples of the earth will mourn when they see the Son of Man coming on the clouds of heaven, with power and great glory. And he will send his angels with a loud trumpet call, and they will gather his elect from the four winds, from one end of the heavens to the other. (Matt. 24:30–31)

Just as God gathered eight humans into the ark (Gen. 6:18–7:5), so at His second advent He will gather all the redeemed to heaven (1 Thess. 4:16–18). Both are global events of salvation prior to global destruction (2 Pet. 3:6–7).

In Fairness to Geology

We have noted biblical evidence for a global flood, yet most geologists do not accept a global flood. How can we be fair to their analysis since they do not have biblical data to inform their conclusions? Leonard Brand, biologist and paleontologist at Loma Linda University, has provided some insight on this matter:

> There are definitely some types of evidence in fossils and rocks that seem to best fit rapid deposition, but you have to consider the fossils and the sediments they are in to support that. There are many fossil deposits, and features of the fossil record in general, that are very difficult to explain to a biblical view of geology. It does a disservice to readers if we don't give them an honest understanding of that. I firmly believe the literal biblical view of earth history, but we believe that largely on faith. Some evidence supports that faith (support, not proof), but other evidence is still a big problem. And much of the specific evidence you describe actually just supports the idea that at least some deposits formed rapidly, and don't tell us if it was in a flood. Even conventional geologists believe that almost all fossils were deposited by water, but not in a big flood. There are mass mortalities of well-preserved vertebrate fossils, and everyone agrees that they were buried rapidly—but most vertebrate fossils were not rapidly buried—they are isolated and/or broken bones and teeth. The biological evidence makes it hard to believe macroevolution, but geology and paleontology are the areas where we as Bible believers may have things that are troublesome—and I think many of these questions won't be

66. Keil and Delitzsch, *Psalms*, vol. 5 in *Commentary on the Old Testament in Ten Volumes*, trans. Andrew Harper (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1986), 373.

answered until we get to heaven. If we don't give our students/readers a balanced picture of the helpful evidence and the problems, they eventually lose confidence in us.[67]

Following Brand's advice, let us keep in mind the balance between biblical answers on the one hand and geological questions on the other, holding on to the former, but being honest about our limited knowledge when it comes to the latter. We do not want to be dogmatic when evidence suggests that we patiently wait for more information while holding on to the biblical story. Keep in mind also what Brand has said concerning flood catastrophes: "In recent decades, the data have led science to recognize that the deposition of the rocks involved much more catastrophism than was previously thought. Catastrophic geology, which does not make the *a priori* assumption of millions of years of time, predicts that continued research will indicate still far more catastrophic geological processes than have been currently envisioned. I even suggest that researchers who are open to that possibility ultimately will be more successful in understanding earth history."[68]

Within this context, we will note some examples of fossils, keeping in mind that though they cannot prove the biblical global flood, neither can they disprove it.

GEOLOGICAL COLUMN

Sediments from broken rocks and minerals cover much of the world's land mass and ocean beds. The earth's crust contains sedimentary deposits and rocks with fossils which form stratified layers often clearly visible, as dramatically demonstrated in the Grand Canyon. In his 2009 edition of *Faith, Reason, and Earth History*, Leonard Brand states:

> Whether we prefer short-age geology or conventional geology, the geological column is still a valid description of nature's history book. In fact, the original study and description of the divisions of the geologic column were done largely by creationists. Later, as scientific theories changed after the work of Lyell and Darwin, the original description remained essentially correct. What changed was the interpretation of how the rocks and fossils got that way.... The short-age geologist says that, at least from the beginning of the Cambrian, the geological record has formed very rapidly, not over the long evolutionary timescale.[69]

This rapid pace is not hard to imagine given the enormous upheaval when "all the springs of the great deep burst forth, and the floodgates of the heavens were opened" (Gen. 7:11b). This was judgment day for the planet. By the

67. Personal correspondence with author.

68. Leonard Brand, *Faith, Reason, and Earth History: A Paradigm of Earth and Biological Origins by Intelligent Design* (Berrien Springs, MI: Andrews University Press, 1997), 312.

69. Leonard Brand, *Faith, Reason, and Earth History: A Paradigm of Earth and Biological Origins by Intelligent Design*, 2nd ed. (Berrien Springs, MI: Andrews University Press, 2009), 348.

word of God the world was "deluged and destroyed" (2 Pet. 3:5–7). Everyone and everything perished, except those in the ark (Gen. 7:21–23). The water was twenty feet higher than the tallest mountains of the world at that time.

CATASTROPHE REVEALED IN FOSSIL RECORD

Not only did God destroy all humans, animals, and living things, but the global flood also had a catastrophic, devastating effect on the planet:

> A worldwide flood would have a profound effect on all living organisms, including those in lakes and seas. The erosion would produce turbid water that many sea organisms could not tolerate. Tectonic movements would generate heat, reducing the oxygen level and affecting temperature-sensitive organisms. Such a catastrophe as Scripture describes would cause mass mortality, rapid burial, and fossilization. In addition, we should be able to detect the action of water on animals and plants by the orientation of trees and bones, by death assemblages (taphonomy), by sorting, and by unnatural paleoecological associations.[70]

Fossils are found all over the world, yet fossils do not normally form, because things die naturally and quickly decompose. For example, the Old Testament says Palestine was "infested with lions for centuries (Job 38:39, Prov. 22:13, 2 Kings 17:25), but no fossil of a lion has yet been found there."[71] So how do we explain the countless fossils that have been discovered? "Formations have been discovered containing hundreds of billions of fossils and our museums now are filled with over 100 million fossils of 250,000 different species."[72] When the foundations of the deep broke open, and water was thrust upward and rain deluged downward, all kinds of animals, ferocious and tame, large and small, ignored their differences, and fled to higher ground to escape a common enemy.

Chapter 15, "Fossil Evidence in Support of Catastrophe" in *Origin by Design* provides many examples of this phenomenon:[73]

1. Hundreds of tracks researched in the Permian sandstone reveal that "nearly all tracks head uphill (Gilmore 1927)."[74] Brand (1979),[75] as well

70. Harold G. Coffin, Robert H. Brown, and L. James Gibson, *Origin by Design: Revised Edition* (Hagerstown, MD: Review and Herald, 2005), 183. This title is abbreviated as *Origin BD* in the notes that follow.

71. Whitcomb, *The World That Perished*, 76.

72. Luther D. Sunderland, *Darwin's Enigma*, rev. ed. (Santee, CA: Master Books 1988), 9, quoted in Whitcomb, *The World That Perished*, 76.

73. *Origin BD*, 183–195. All thirteen sections are from this chapter, and original sources cited are given in the footnotes below.

74. C. W. Gilmore, *Fossil Footprints from the Grand Canyon*, Second Contribution, Smithsonian Miscellaneous Collection, 80:1–79; *Origin BD*, 183.

75. L. R. Brand, "Field and Laboratory Studies on the Cononino Sandstone (Permian) Vetebrate Footprints and Their Paleoecological Implications," *Paleogeography, Paleoclimatology, Paleoecology* 28:25–38; *Origin BD*, 184.

as Brand and Tang (1991)[76] document that "footprints made underwater best duplicate the fossil examples."[77]

> Paleontologists occasionally find tracks that show the animal heading one way (as seen by the direction the toes are pointing) while the trail of footprints travels in another direction. How could animals walk in one direction while facing another? The most reasonable explanation is that the animals were drifting in a water current as they walked up the sand slope to get out of the water and to avoid the sand settling rapidly around them.[78]

The bones of the animals that made the tracks are not found together with the tracks. In other words, the tracks indicate the journey toward another place, a higher stratum, where death overtook the animals. "Altogether the evidence suggests a picture of major flooding, animals attempting to escape, and their eventual burial."[79]

2. Some fossils provide evidence for "rapid burial by water-transported sediments." For example there are sea organisms around Cincinnati, Ohio, where "fossils are found entombed in sediments several hundred feet thick over an area of thousands of square miles." How did such a mass of sea animal remains get there? Such large number of fossils, in such depth, is not found in modern mudflats and sea bottoms. Such an accumulation of "sea animal remains almost demands a catastrophe."[80]
3. The Mowry Shale in the Rocky Mountain states, which includes parts of Wyoming, Montana, western South Dakota, and northern Colorado, covers many thousands of square miles. Throughout this area there are abundant "fish scales, beautifully marked with concentric growth rings, pepper the shales at certain levels."[81] "The death of the vast numbers of fish needed to produce such a large number of scales is difficult to comprehend."[82] It is rare to find fish remains preserved in modern environments[83] because their bodies rapidly disintegrate, and bones and scales quickly disappear, because other "fish, worms, and creatures in the water, as well as bacteria and fungi, soon destroy them."[84]

76. L. R. Brand and T. Tang, "Fossil Vertebrate Footprints in the Coconino Sandstone (Permian) of Northern Arizona: Evidence for Underwater Origin," *Geology* 19:1201–1204; *Origin BD*, 184.
77. *Origin BD*, 184.
78. Ibid., 184.
79. Ibid., 185.
80. Ibid.
81. W. W. Rubey, "Origin of the Siliceous Mowry Shale in the Black Hills Region," United States Geological Survey Professional Paper 154 (1928): 153–170; *Origin BD*, 185.
82. *Origin BD*, 185.
83. J. R. Vallentyne, "On Fish Remains in Lacustrine Sediments," *American Journal of Science* 258–A (1960): 344–349; *Origin BD*, 186.
84. *Origin BD*, 185–186.

4. The Devonian Old Red Sandstone is found across hundreds of square miles in England, and was one of the first geological formations described in detail. This sandstone contains "staggering numbers of fossil fish."[85]

> At this period of our history, some terrible catastrophe involved in sudden destruction the fish of an area at least a hundred miles from boundary to boundary, perhaps much more. The same platform in Orkney as at Cromarty is strewed thick with remains, which exhibit unequivocally the marks of violent death. The figures are contorted, contracted, curved; the tail in many instances is bent around to the head; the spines stick out; the fins are spread to the full, as in fish that die in convulsions (Miller 1860).[86]

5. In the early 1960s scientists from the Chicago Natural History Museum dug extensively in the black shale of Indiana, finding fossils of fish and sharks.[87] Paleontologists found "strong evidence that the settling of sediments was rapid, quickly covering up the animals preserved in the black shales."[88] Scientists from the Chicago Museum conducted an experiment: Dead fresh fish (within a cage so predators couldn't get to them) were placed on the bottom of a warm Southern marsh. After six-and-a-half days, the scientists returned to find all fish flesh had decayed—even the bones were disconnected. This indicated to them that fossil fish with intact skeletons had to have been buried quickly.[89]
6. When naturally dying, bivalve mollusks have the two shells sprung wide open, and sometimes are found broken apart. This is not the case when they are buried suddenly, while alive, and such "fossils are abundant in certain beds. Sediment must have fallen onto the mollusks so rapidly that its weight kept the shells from springing apart when the animals died."[90]
7. Large deposits of diatomaceous earth near Lompoc, California, have been mined for years by a number of companies. The earth is made of up "microscopic capsules of one-celled water plants (diatoms) that have concentrated in countless numbers in this location." How did they get there? Did it take millions of years for them to settle onto the bottom, or did something transport them to that place? Scientists began to rethink these questions after miners "found the uncollapsed skeleton of an 80- to 90-foot baleen whale in the white earth."[91] "If it

85. Ibid., 186.
86. H. Miller, *The Old Red Sandstone* (Boston, MA: Gould and Lincoln, 1860), 221; *Origin BD*, 186.
87. Rainr Zangerl and Eugene S. Richardson, Jr., "The Paleoecological History of Two Pennsylvanian Black Shales," *Fieldiana: Geology Memoirs; Origin BD*, 186.
88. *Origin BD*, 186.
89. Ibid., 187.
90. Ibid., 187–188.
91. *Chemical and Engineering News*, 1976, Oct. 11; *Origin BD*, 188.

took a long time to cover the huge mammal, the bones would not have remained attached together."[92]

8. Commenting on the Geiseltal lignite deposits in Germany, Paleontologist Francis said:

> Here also is a complete mixture of plants, insects, and animals from all the climatic zones of the earth that are capable of supporting life. In some cases leaves have been deposited and preserved in a fresh condition, the chlorophyll being still green, so that the "green layer" is used as a marker during excavations. Among the insects present are beautifully colored tropical beetles, with soft parts of the body, including the contents of the intestines, preserved intact. Normally such materials decay or change in color within a few hours of death, so that preservation by inclusion in an aseptic medium must have been sudden and complete.[93]

9. G. Arthur Cooper of the United States National Museum, working with dilute acids, was able to obtain delicately preserved fossils from the Glass Mountains of Texas. From thirty tons of Permian limestone, Cooper extracted "3 million individual invertebrate fossils, almost all of which are exquisitely preserved.... A single control block of limestone weighing 186 pounds yielded 10,000 excellent specimens of invertebrates, including Foraminifera, brachiopods, bryozoans, gastropods, and pelecypods."[94]
10. "Unusual assemblages of fossil plants occur in various places around the world." For example, Ginkgo Petrified Forest State Park in central Washington State has over two hundred different kinds of plants. "They include a surprising range from tropical to temperate."[95] Yellowstone is another example. Paleobotanists identified nearly two hundred different kinds of petrified plants: "Once again the habitats represented by the types of plants range from tropic to temperate and include plants now living in geographical areas far removed from present-day Yellowstone."[96]
11. Messel is a middle Ecocene site near Darmstadt, Germany, where plants and animals (marine, freshwater, and terrestrial) are exquisitely preserved.[97] "[A]ccording to their relaxed position and the degree of disintegration, [a preponderance of the finds] must be regarded as having

92. *Origin BD*, 188.
93. Wilfrid Francis, *Coal: Its Formation and Composition* (London, UK: Edward Arnold Publishers, 1961), 18; *Origin BD*, 188–189.
94. Norman Newell, "The Nature of the Fossil Record," Proceedings of the American Philosophical Society 103 (1959): 264–285; *Origin BD*, 189.
95. George F. Beck, "Ancient Fossil Trees of the Sagebrush Area in Central Washington," *Journal of Forestry*, vol. 43, no. 5; U. Prakash, "Miocene Fossil Woods From the Columbia Basalts of Central Washington," *Paleontographica* 3:183–200; *Origin BD*, 190.
96. H. G. Coffin, "The Yellowstone Petrified 'Forests,'" *Origins* 24 (1997): 2–44; *Origin BD*, 190.
97. S. Schaal and W. Ziegler, *Messel: An Insight into the History of Life and of the Earth*, ed. Stephen Schaal and Willi Ziegler, trans. Monica Schaffer-Fehre (Oxford: University Press, 1992, Ger. ed. 1988); *Origin BD*, 190.

drowned."[98] Paleontologists consider Messel one of the best insect fossil sites in the world. Six genera of crocodiles are found in Messel, yet "[d]ifferent species of modern crocodiles seldom coexist. The presence of several genera and species in one small area might suggest that the animals were transported from different biotopes to Lake Messel."[99] The following are six strong evidences of unusual and catastrophic conditions that would have brought these diverse animals together:

a. Excellent preservation of most plant and animal remains.
b. The absence of remains expected in a small-lake environment such as herbivorous fish, roots, stems, and branches of trees and shrubs, water plants (except for water lilies), water insects (a few exceptions), amphibians (rare exceptions), and true waterbirds.
c. The presence of some species now with limited distribution in tropical Africa, South America, Asia, or other areas far removed from present-day Messel.
d. The presence of marine animals mixed with fresh-water organisms.
e. The relaxed position of many of the birds and mammals strongly suggesting death by drowning.
f. Tropical to subtropical climate indicated by both the flora and fauna.[100]

12. In eastern Brazil[101] three-dimensional fossil fish are found in an area of nearly one hundred twenty-five miles by thirty miles. "No modern habitat contains so unusual a mixture of oceanic and freshwater species as we observe here. They represent fish from deep water, intermediate depth, surface, open ocean, shore, and estuary." This assemblage "also includes surface feeders, planktonic feeders, small fish eaters, as well as two species of coela-canth fish." "Some of the fish have open mouths indicating death through suffocation." "Several factors associated with these fish (and other fossils), such as quick burial, mixed marine and freshwater fauna, and broad geographical extent, strongly indicate extensive geological catastrophes."[102]

98. Rainer Springhorn, "Carnivores: Agile Climbers and Prey Catchers" in *Messel: An Insight into the History of Life and of the Earth*, eds. Stephan Schaal and Willi Zeigler (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1993), 231; *Origin BD*, 191.
99. *Origin BD*, 191.
100. Ibid., 191–192.
101. D. M. Martill, "Preservation of Fish in the Cretaceous Santana Formation in Brazil," *Paleontology* 31 (1988): 1–18; "The Medusa Effect: Instantaneous Fossilization," *Geology Today* (November–December, 1989): 201–205; *Origin BD*, 192.
102. *Origin BD*, 192–193.

13. In 1997, Kurt Wise of Bryan College, a geologist who earned his PhD under Stephen Jay Gould at Harvard University, noted that "the geologic gradualism of the nineteenth century has given way to neo-catastrophism. In the last two decades it has even become increasingly fashionable to consider global-scale catastrophism."[103]

ROCK FORMATION

Scientists are no different from other researchers when it comes to suffering from bias. They approach data with basic assumptions that guide the way they interpret the data. In other words, a scientist believing in the biblical global flood and a scientist believing in uniformitarianism will interpret sedimentary rocks from their opposing worldviews. One will see the rocks as products of rapid formation, while the other sees them as products of slow formation. The rock layers are understood not by what one sees, but by what one thinks one sees. Although modern uniformitarian geologists allow for occasional catastrophic events, modern historical geology was developed from the principle of gradualism, which is "still the predominantly preferred framework of explanation for any geological formation. Nevertheless, the evidence for catastrophic formation is so pervasive that there is a growing body of neocatastrophists. But because of their naturalistic bias, they prefer, of course, to reject the explanation of the Genesis (global) flood."[104]

Jonathan Sarfati, who holds a doctorate in spectroscopy (physical chemistry), says, "A cataclysmic globe-covering (and fossil-forming) flood would have eroded huge quantities of sediment, and deposited them elsewhere. Many organisms would have been buried very quickly and fossilized." He refers to recent catastrophes that illustrate the quick formation of rock layers. One of these was the eruption of Mount St. Helens in Washington State—an eruption that "produced 25 feet (7.6 meters) of finely layered sediment in a single afternoon."[105] He refers to NASA scientists accepting "catastrophic floods" on Mars—floods that carved out the canyons—even though there is no water on the planet today. Yet these same scientists deny a global flood on earth, even though today there is enough water to cover the world to a depth of 1.2 miles (2.7 km), for water covers seventy-one percent of the world's surface today.[106]

103. Kurt Wise, foreword to Leonard Brand, *Faith, Reason, and Earth History: A Paradigm of Earth and Biological Origins by Intelligent Design* (Berrien Springs, MI: Andrews University Press, 1997), vii.

104. Jonathan Sarfati, *Refuting Evolution: A Handbook for Students, Parents, and Teachers Countering the Latest Arguments for Evolution* (Green Forest, AR: Master Books, July 2004), 105, emphasis in original.

105. Sarfati, *Refuting Evolution*, 105.

106. Ibid., 107.

Historical Evidence for Global Flood

If the flood was global, we would expect to find a widespread knowledge of it in countries across the world. Which is exactly what we do find. In fact, "No theme is more widely circulated in the world's epic and mythic literature than that of a great flood which long ago destroyed either the entire world or some vast portion of it. Such stories are found among the Chinese, Indians, Greeks, Mayas, islanders of the South Pacific, and elsewhere."[107] "Sixty-eight different peoples are known to have flood legends."[108]

Historical evidence seems to support a universal flood, for Flood stories are "found among nearly all nations and tribes," and they agree on several key matters: (1) water destroyed humans and other living beings, (2) some sort of ark or boat was used to escape the flood, (3) one or more humans survived, and sometimes (4) wickedness caused the flood.[109] These historical insights should be given some value in the debate. Byron Nelson cites Flood stories from Assyria-Babylon, Persia, Syria, Asia Minor, Greece, Egypt, Italy, Lithuania, Wales, Scandinavia, Lapland, Russia, China, India, North America, Central America, South America, and the Pacific islands.[110]Alfred Rehwinkel gives some examples.[111] (An interesting aside: When I was studying the Japanese language in Japan, I discovered that the ancient Chinese character [also used in Japan] that indicated a large boat also indicated that it held eight people—Noah's ark![112])

Ark and Tabernacle

On this particular topic, Westermann observes, "The parallel between the ark and the tabernacle has a profound meaning"[113] John Sailhamer makes an insightful observation:

> There are important similarities between the account of the building of the ark and two other narratives in the Pentateuch, viz., the account of Creation in Genesis 1 and the building of the "tabernacle" in Exodus 25ff. Each account has a discernible pattern: God speaks (*wayyō'mer/way^{e}ḏabbēr*), an action is commanded (imperative/jussive), and the command is carried out (*wayya'aś*) according to God's will (*way^{e}hî kēn/ka^{n}šer ṣiwwāh ^{e}lōhîm*). The key to these similarities lies in the observation that each narrative concludes with a divine blessing (*way^{e}ḇārek̲*, Gen 1:28; 9:1; Exod

107. *Baker Encyclopedia of the Bible*, 1:797.

108. Lewis, "Flood," in *The Anchor Bible Dictionary*, 2:798.

109. *Baker Encyclopedia of the Bible*, 1:708.

110. Byron C. Nelson, *The Deluge Story in Stone: A History of Flood Theory of Geology* (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg, 1931), 170–190. For other sources on Flood stories, see Rehwinkel, *The Flood*, 127–164.

111. Rehwinkel, *The Flood*, 127–152.

112. C. H. Kang and Ethel R. Nelson, *The Discovery of Genesis: How the Truths of Genesis Were Found Hidden in the Chinese Language* (St. Louis, MO: Concordia Publishing House, 1979), 95.

113. Westermann, quoted in Wenham, *Genesis 1–15*, vol. 1 in *Word Biblical Commentary*, 174.

39:43) and, in the case of the tabernacle and Noah's ark, a divinely ordained covenant (Gen 6:8; Exod 34:27; in this regard it is of some importance that later biblical tradition associated the events of Gen 1–3 with the making of a divine covenant; cf. Hos 6:7). Noah, like Moses, followed closely the commands of God and in so doing found salvation in his covenant.[114]

"Both narratives [ark and tabernacle completion], for example, emphasize that entry into the ark/tabernacle is to be accompanied by an animal offering." The "'unblemished animals' (*tāmîm*, Lev 1:3: NIV, 'without defect')" were used.[115] "The author had intentionally drawn a comparison between the salvation that lies in the ark of Noah during the impending 'forty days and forty nights' of rain (v. 4) and the salvation in the presence of the tabernacle during the impending 'forty years' in the wilderness. Again it is the centrality of the idea of a covenant relationship that lies behind the author's work."[116]

So Noah's ark and God's tabernacle were built according to a divine plan revealed to Noah and Moses, respectively. Both had to do with human salvation, through the Flood and through the blood. Without the presence of God, neither would have saved humans. They were merely a means used by God—He did the saving work. But they were God's means, and that needs to be grasped. There was only one way—God's way—to survive the Flood. Likewise, there is only one plan of salvation (outlined in the sanctuary structure) that brings salvation. Only Jesus saves, but what does salvation mean? It means (1) accepting His atonement at Calvary, (2) accepting His continuing intercession in heaven's sanctuary, and (3) accepting His resolution of the cosmic controversy, for redemption includes resolution. (We will consider these matters in chapters 9 and 10.)

In the Garden of Eden sacrifices were made for the sins of Adam and Eve (Gen. 3:21), and they were covered by animal skins. Christ the Creator ministered to them as Redeemer and Priest. As such He was "the Lamb who was slain from the creation of the world" (Rev. 13:8b). After the Flood "Noah built an altar to the LORD and, taking some of all the clean animals and clean birds, he sacrificed burnt offerings on it" (Gen. 8:20). The sacrifices in Eden and after the Flood pointed to Christ who would become the Savior of the world through His atoning death. The sacrifices suggest that life after sin and after the Flood was not deserved; rather, it was a gift of grace from Christ. Already the benefits of His future saving act were having a saving effect. The covenants God made with Adam and Eve, Noah, and Abraham

114. Sailhamer, *Genesis*, vol. 2 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary*, 82.
115. Ibid., 85.
116. Ibid.

were God's commitment to bless them. Every covenant blessing came with Calvary stamped upon it.[117]

PROTOLOGY[118] AND ESCHATOLOGY

Genesis is a book of beginnings. The beginnings include: life on planet earth (Gen. 1–2); (2) fall of humankind (Gen. 3:1–6); (3) promise of salvation (Gen. 3:15); (4) life after the global flood (Gen. 9); and (5) the launching of God's chosen nation (Israel) through the call of Abraham (Gen. 12:1–3). God entered into a relationship with humans in a covenant made at creation, at the time of the Flood, and with Abraham. Within this context, the unfolding of history "from the first creation to a new creation" typifies the cosmic history from creation to the new earth. Each of the five beginnings mentioned above was global in nature. God created the world, then the fall of Adam and Eve affected the human race and all of nature. Rather than abandoning Adam and Eve, God promised salvation to all humans. After the Flood new life was given to the human race, and Israel was chosen to be a medium through whom God could bless the world.

In his 1982 book *The Gospel of Genesis: Studies in Protology and Eschatology*, Warren Gage presented the eschatological structure of Genesis. He was not the first to do this, for Hermann Gunkel's *Schöpfung und Chaos in Urzeit und Endzeit*

117. The fact that Noah built an altar and sacrificed to God suggests that this was a common practice of those who loved God and recognized that all blessings come from Him. To those who loved God, the sacrifices were never to earn salvation; they were made in recognition of salvation already promised and applied. They were acts of worship, not merely acts of obedience. They were acts of personal, willing heart dedication. The sacrifices were made out of covenant love. One can understand that those who loved God built an altar at the entrance to Eden for the purpose of bringing their sacrifices to God. They knew that the only way back to Eden was through the Lamb of God.

All God's followers knew firsthand from Adam and Eve the tragic story of the fall of humans. They had heard them speak of their creation and of the first Sabbath spent in communion with their Creator. They had seen Adam and Eve's heartbreak as they spoke of the enemy's deception about there being no death, and of Christ's clear words that sin does bring death. They witnessed death in nature. They lived in a world of death. Yet, in stark contrast, they could come to the entrance of Eden and see beyond the cherubim the sinless Garden of Eden untouched by the curse of death. They knew that the only way to gain entrance to Eden would be through the death of their Creator-Redeemer. This first gospel promise of Christ's victory over the deceptive enemy (Gen. 3:15) brought hope and encouragement to them.

At the entrance of Eden there was an altar and cherubim guards, a miniature representation of God's later sanctuary. In the sanctuary, the altar of burnt offering was in the courtyard at one end of the sanctuary enclosure, and the cherubim were housed in the most holy place at the other end of the sanctuary. Sacrificing a substitute at the entrance of Eden was full of meaning. It was the gospel good news of life extended to a world of death. It was a powerful way to say that God so loved the world that Christ was committed to becoming the Savior of humankind. This would be far more costly than being the Creator of humans. Christ would become human Himself in order to die for humans, for divinity cannot die. In other words, Christ would enter into the world of death, take the death penalty of all sinners, and through obedience to His Father overturn the disobedience of Adam and Eve. Sacrificing animals at the entrance of Eden reminded the repentant person that the way of the Cross leads home.

118. Protology, as it is used here, means "first things," just as eschatology means "last things."

(1895) and Claus Westermann's *Anfung und Ende in der Bibel* (1969) preceded his work, but neither of them penetrated the theological significance of the relationship between first and last things as Gage did.[119] He put it this way:

> The thesis of this chapter is that the chronicle of prediluvian history (Genesis 1–7) is composed of five theological fundamental narratives, each of which finds consecutive, synthetic parallel[s] in the history (and prophecy) of the postdiluvian world. Consequently, by understanding the historical movement initiated in early Genesis, we may discern the relationship between the beginning and ending of biblical history.[120]

These five narratives are: (1) creation of the world out of waters of chaos, and re-creation of the world out of the waters of Noah; (2) the commission of Adam and Noah; (3) the sin of Adam and Noah; (4) the two groups of descendants from Adam and Noah; and (5) the uniting of sons of God and daughters of Man brings universal judgment as insight into eschatological universal judgment. These five parallel narratives present a logical and chronological sequence of God, humankind, sin, redemption, and judgment.[121] We will take a look at the first and the fifth.

TWO BEGINNINGS

Following the flood, Noah sacrificed a burnt offering to God, and the "LORD smelled the pleasing aroma" (Gen. 8:21a, NIV). Other translations say it was a "soothing aroma" (NASB, NKJV), "sweet savour" (KJV), "pleasing odor" (RSV), "soothing odor" (GOODSPEED, NEB), or a "pleasing odor, a scent of satisfaction to His heart" (AMPLIFIED). The Hebrew word for "soothing, pleasing" is *nîḥôaḥ*.[122] The root of this word is *nwḥ*, which has a semantic range that includes "take a rest" or "cease activity" such as "God 'rested from,' or ceased, his creative activity on the seventh day (Exod 20:11), and expected that his people would also cease from their activities on that day (Exod 23:12; Deut 5:14)."[123] Gage penetrates to this linguistic linkage between the rest of God after creation being completed (Gen. 2) and the "sacrificial rest of God after the new creation is completed" (Gen. 8).[124]

119. Warren Austine Gage, *The Gospel of Genesis: Studies in Protology and Eschatology* (Winona Lake, IN: Carpenter, 1984, 1st ed. 1982), 3, 7–8.
120. Ibid., 9.
121. Ibid., 9–10.
122. John N. Oswalt, "*nwḥ*," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology & Exegesis*, 3:56.
123. Ibid., 3:56–59.
124. Gage, *The Gospel of Genesis*, 10–11.

Gage considers Noah to be a new Adam,[125] and his drunkenness and nakedness to be like Adam's sin and nakedness.[126] The judgment at the Flood was an eschatological type of the eschatological judgments that will accompany Christ's second coming.

CONCLUSION

We noted the evidence for a global flood. Christ and Peter speak about this. Christ compares the two times of judgment (the Flood and the end of history), for before both humanity was/will be unprepared for God's judgments (Matt. 24:37–38). Peter goes further, considering both events to be as global in nature, just as the creation of the world was:

> But they deliberately forget that long ago by God's word the heavens came into being and the earth was formed out of water and by water. By these waters also the world of that time was deluged and destroyed. By the same word the present heavens and earth are reserved for fire, being kept for the day of judgment and destruction of the ungodly. (2 Pet. 3:5–7)

Scripture is the basis of this system, so Scripture is foundational in determining that the Flood was global. However, there is scientific and historical evidence that supports the notion of a global flood.

STUDY QUESTIONS

1. Some scholars claim that Noah's ark was too small to house all living things. What do they overlook?
2. How does the God of the biblical flood compare to the pagan gods of the ANE flood stories?
3. What are the differences between the Noah of Scripture, and *Utnapishtim* and *Ziusudra* of ANE texts?
4. Does the size of Noah's ark tell us anything about the nature of the flood?
5. How does 2 Peter 3:3–7 indicate that the flood was global?

125. Ibid., 11. Adam and Eve were made in the image of God (Gen. 1:26–27), and God reminded Noah and his family that "in the image of God has God made man" (Gen. 9:6b). God brought animals to Adam to name (Gen. 2:19) and brought animals to Noah to be protected (Gen. 7:15). God's blessing of fruitfulness is virtually identical to Adam's (Gen. 1:28a) and to Noah's (Gen. 9:1). It is true that Noah is like a new Adam or father of the race, but he is also unlike him, for Christ became the new Adam (Rom. 5:12–19; 1 Cor. 15:20–21, 45–49).
126. Ibid., 12. Gage considers Noah's drunkenness and nakedness (Gen. 9:21) to be like Adam's taking of the forbidden fruit and becoming naked (Gen. 3:6–7); Adam's nakedness was covered by God (Gen. 3:32) and Noah's nakedness was covered by his oldest sons (Gen. 9:23). However, Gage fails to note the differences in these two sins: there was only one fall that affected the entire human race, and that was a fall from sinlessness, unlike Noah's sin (Rom. 5:18–19).

6. How important is faith in God's Word when it comes to questions about the Flood?
7. How would you describe the Flood? If it destroyed the antediluvian world, how does this question the theory of uniformitarianism?
8. What evidence can you give to prove that the flood wasn't local?
9. What are the natural evidences for a global flood?

Christ

God-Man Jesus Christ

9. Redemption: Life, Death, Resurrection
10. King-Priest
11. Christ: History and Theology

The relational Trinity enjoyed eternal communion in their inner history of love for each other. They created the world, which was something apart from them. The first full day of life for humans was a Sabbath rest spent with God. They were made by God to enjoy the overflow of the love of the relational Trinity, as if taken up to participate in their inner circle as loved and wanted.

The Incarnation was a creation of a different kind. Christ, while remaining God, laid aside the use of divine powers in Himself, and descended to the level of fallen humans. He was fully God and fully man. But this God-Man did not live as God in this world (as taught by traditional theology), but lived on earth as a human, totally dependent on God. Never before had He been dependent. Previously He had been self-existent, like the other Persons in the Trinity. None were dependent on the others; they were God.

God acted in the Incarnation; it was throughout a divine miracle. Mary was merely a means for Christ's arrival as the God-Man. It was an enormous condescension for the immaculate divine Son of God to descend to the level of becoming also an immaculate human. In other words, the eternal God remained what He had always been through His incarnation and birth. He was the Creator of the universe and now became a baby, a tiny part of creation. Never had such humility been witnessed. Even more, He who never had a beginning was born to die and save all humanity.

There are three levels of human nature. Adam is at the level of pre-Fall human nature, while Christ is positioned below that level because He received the "innocent infirmities" (human limitations except sin) from the Fall of Adam. But Christ is also placed above the level that we occupy because He did not receive the evil propensities from the Fall that the rest of us receive. Therefore, Christ is neither like the pre-Fall Adam nor like the post-Fall human race. He occupies a place between the two. This is why it is correct to say that He received some of the post-Fall nature (innocent infirmities), but not the full post-Fall nature (sinful propensities). He received the weakness but not the wickedness that resulted from the Fall. He was deprived but not depraved; He

was sinless throughout life to give us His life. He was sinless when bearing our sins on the Cross to save us.

Christology extends beyond Christ's resurrection into His King-Priest ministry for humans in heaven's sanctuary, as the only mediator between God and humans. His twofold work includes interceding for us and resolving the cosmic controversy. There is a vertical and universal enlargement to biblical Christology which is not considered in most systems. Yet Christ's present ministry in heaven is as vital as His ministry on earth; and both contribute to the resolution of the cosmic controversy, for there is no redemption without resolution. The resolution requires judgments so that the entire universe can discern that God can justly save those who have accepted His death for them, and justly allow those to be lost who have refused to accept His death. This way the cosmos sees that God is just and loving, just the opposite of what Satan alleges.

Satan hates Christ. He does everything in his power to hide the truth about Christ and to distort the truth about Him. In traditional theology, Christ is presented either as One who lived on earth as God, or as One who was too human. His claimed omnipresence destroys His ability to live like humans so that He can be a sympathetic High Priest who understands human struggles. In reality, His struggle was not from sin within, but from *divinity within*, which He had eternally used in giving commands as God. His struggle on earth was worse than ours, like a strong addiction, for since He was divine, He was tempted to use His divinity to overcome. (Humans have no such power, and no such struggle.) But Christ remained at the human level as totally dependent upon God outside of Him, rather than upon His divinity within.

CHAPTER NINE

Redemption: Life, Death, Resurrection

Purpose

1. Explain Christ's dual mission as Redeemer and Restorer.
2. Define *kenōsis* and its contribution to Christ's mission as Redeemer and Restorer.
3. Explain the relationship between Christ's two natures.
4. Demonstrate why salvation is not achieved within the divine-human natures of Jesus Christ.
5. Show what is achieved by divinity uniting with humanity in Jesus Christ.
6. Illustrate how Christ resolves the cosmic controversy and restores the kingdom of heaven.

Summary

Sin is more than a rebel act, more than law breaking—it is a broken relationship. It took the relational Trinity to reach out to restore the relationship and thereby bring redemption to humans. The Father gave His Son, the Son was willing to come, and the Holy Spirit brought Him in the Incarnation to become the God-Man. The Christ who had always participated in the eternal reciprocal love in the inner history of the Trinity now entered into human history on a relational mission that would require His entire life and subsequent

death to accomplish. In this chapter we explore what it meant for Christ to become human, what kind of nature He received, and how this nature compared with His contemporaries and with Adam before and after the Fall. We will need to examine whether He retained His omnipresence when embodied as a human, to ask why Christ became human, and to determine which of His missions required His humanity. We will have to ask how being divine helped His mission. We will need to determine whether He was tempted like all other humans, whether being God gave Him any advantage, and whether He put His divinity aside. We will also need to examine how Christ as a God-Man could die. In these matters we will explore what it took for Christ to redeem humans and restore the cosmos.

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INTRODUCTION

GOD IN TIME

A timeless God cannot enter space and time and become the God-man revealed in Scripture. As mentioned in my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 5, we need to look at God's eternity in the light of the Incarnation. In assuming human nature, God accepted created reality into the Trinity through the Son of God who became also the Son of Man. In this act of Incarnation, finite time was taken up into God's infinite time. There is a qualitative distinction between the divinity and the humanity as well as the infinite time and the finite time of the Son of God who is also the Son of Man. However, the Incarnational act of grace resulted in a union between infinite time and finite time in the same way as it created a union between the divine and the human in Jesus Christ. In Jesus Christ the transcendent God was immanent in a way that He was fully God and fully human (*vere Deus, vere Homo*), without any lessening of either (this is, clearly, a divine mystery). The Incarnation was possible because infinite time and finite time are compatible in Jesus Christ (which is radically different from a timeless God trying to unite timelessness with time).

The pre-incarnate Christ said, "have them make a sanctuary for me, and I will dwell among them" (Exod. 25:8). This was proleptic of the Incarnation, which is why we read "The Word became [aorist tense] flesh and made his dwelling among us" (John 1:14, *eskēnōsen*), or literally "pitched His tent" among us, or "tabernacled" among us. In the Old Testament the pre-incarnate Christ dwelt with His people in the tabernacle/temple as a type of His coming to dwell among His people forever, as a fellow human as well as God. The sanctuary was a promise pointing to His incarnation—the temporary dwelling promised a permanent dwelling when He entered human history as the Son of Man. In the Incarnation Jesus Christ was "'Immanuel'—which means, 'God with us'" (Matt. 1:23).

The Incarnation was an event in temporality that was not temporal in the sense of a confined duration. For in taking on human nature, God acted in time in a way that will endure for eternity. There never will be a time when Jesus Christ is not God and Man in inextricable union. God acted in time not only to meet humans in time but also to become a human for all time. God's relation to time has everything to do with His utter condescension to save the human race.

In His entrance into time, He elevated humanity in Himself (the Son of Man) to become a part of the Trinity forever. It was the eternal reciprocal love of the Trinity that reached down to take up humanity (Son of Man) within itself, to share in the reciprocal love of the Trinity for eternity. In so doing Christ elevated humanity (all humans) to a new status with God. Humans became brothers and sisters of the Son of Man. This elevated them beyond their status in creation, when they were made in the image of God.

Let me be clear that I am not speaking of divinization in this elevation, which is popular in Orthodox theology.[1] Humans are not elevated to be divine. They are elevated to be redeemed humans. What outrageous grace and awesome love, to elevate all humanity (most of them lost) to this level of relationship with God. No wonder John exclaimed: "See what great love the Father has lavished on us, that we should be called children of God!" (1 John 3:1). "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life" (John 3:16). This gift of eternal life is the acceptance of this elevation of humans in Jesus Christ. Those who perish are those who never accept the gift and thereby fail to experience the elevation offered to all humans.

As well, I am not speaking of an unchangeable God reaching out to elevate humanity in Himself. This is not a mere assumption into a changeless God, an assumption of human time into the timelessness of God. As Jürgen Moltmann recognizes, "later christology replaced the idea of kenosis by the idea of the *assumption* of human nature by the eternal Logos."[2] What is overlooked is that the Redeemer has infinite time as the Son of God, and finite time as the Son of Man. In the Incarnation infinite time and finite time were united through the union of the divine and the human. The reality of God and man were fully preserved in the union.

If God is timeless, how can He enter time? Any lack of unity between a timeless Son of God and a temporal Son of Man disconnects the divinity of God from the humanity of the Incarnation. To be the Redeemer of humanity, Jesus had to be fully God and fully Man. His divinity made His sacrifice sufficient to save all humans, and His humanity allowed Christ to die.

Neither is God immutable, or impassible. His divinity can change (not His nature), and His divinity can suffer. There is no compartmentalizing of God, keeping His divinity beyond the bounds of being affected by His humanity. He is not schizophrenic. The Father and the Son are *homoousian* (of one being), which means all that the Father is, the Son is. There is no origin of the Son from

1. In deification humanity is not "diminished or destroyed," but it is said to "participate in God by the divine energies of grace," Daniel B. Clendenin, *Eastern Orthodox Christianity: A Western Perspective* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1994), 130.

2. Jürgen Moltmann, *The Coming of God: Christian Eschatology*, trans. Margatet Kohl (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1996, Ger. ed. 1995), 303.

the Father; rather, all the members of the Trinity are underived, self-existent, and equally eternal and immortal. They have chosen to differ in function, only for a time (temporary) in the plan of salvation, but this has nothing to do with an ontological (being or essence) difference among them.

What we have said above is contrary to the theology of Athanasius. His famous *De Incarnatione* (*On the Incarnation*) was successful in defeating Arius who considered Christ as created way back in eternity by the Father. While Athanasius rightly defended the full divinity of the Son as *homoousian* (same substance, hence consubstantial) with the Father, he failed to understand what was involved in the *kenōsis*, or self-emptying, of the Son, in humbling Himself to become a human (see Phil. 2:5–11).

This failure to understand the *kenōsis* was common in traditional theology for a thousand years. Consider John of Damascus (ca. 674–ca. 749), who believed the divinity of Christ deified the humanity He assumed.[3] "Therefore, the divinity communicates its excellences to the flesh while remaining with no part of the sufferings of the flesh [divinity was impassible]."[4] In Christ's incarnation His divinity remained consubstantial with the Trinity, and His flesh remained consubstantial with humanity.[5] "For, since He is consubstantial with God the Father, He freely wills and acts as God. And, since He is also consubstantial with us, the same one freely wills and acts as man. Thus, the miracles are His, and so are the sufferings."[6] Through the hypostatic union (union of divine and human) "the Lord's flesh was enriched with the divine operations but in no way suffered any impairment of its natural properties."[7]

By contrast, the history of the Son of Man on earth was a real history. When He prayed in Gethsemane that the cup might pass from Him, that He might be released from the awful death ahead, He said, nevertheless, "not my will but your will be done" (Mark 14:36). He came to do His Father's will (Heb. 10:7; Ps. 40:6–8). This suggests that He was free to carry out the will of God through His own willing to do so. This means He was not living on earth as God, doing God's will, but He lived on earth as a dependent human doing the will of His Father. This means it was possible for the Son of Man to pray that He be released from His mission.

It should be noted here that God did not predestine Christ to carry out the plan of salvation in a mechanical way, as if there was no sacrifice or suffering

3. *The Fathers of the Church: St. John of Damascus, Writings*, trans. Frederick H. Chase, Jr. (Washington, DC: Catholic University of America Press, 1999, 1st ed. 1958), 37: *Orthodox Faith*, 3:12 (295).
4. St. John of Damascus, *The Fathers of the Church, Orthodox Faith*, 3:15 (311).
5. Ibid., 3:3 (271).
6. Ibid., 3:13 (296).
7. Ibid., 3:17 (317).

for Christ, and as if the Son of God had no choice in the matter, either before He came to earth or during His life on earth. Throughout the process of salvation, Christ had the same freedom to act as He had within the inner history of the Trinity. Because the Trinity is love, each one respects freedom as foundational for true communion among themselves and for communion with all those beyond their community.

There are two histories in the one Son of God who became also the Son of Man. There is a continuation of His history with the Trinity, and the beginning of His history among humans. But these are not joined in such a way that He continued living within the inner history of the Trinity, with all the privileges that provides, so that His living as a Son of Man was compromised, or made to be different from how other humans live in communion with God in history. The Incarnation was an entrance into the realm of human history that the Son of God had never experienced before. This entrance necessitated the *kenōsis* (see Phil. 2:5–11), or self-emptying, the laying aside of His divinity while still remaining divine. In other words, in order to enter human history He left the inner history within the Trinity which had been His experience from eternity, and His communion with the Father and Spirit was now experienced as the Son of Man, making dependence and prayer a new reality for Him. The miracle of His birth and childhood was a necessary prerequisite for His human history in communion with the Father and Spirit. Whatever it took to bring Him to the level of human history was a gift of grace, not for His sake but for the sake of salvation of all humans willing to accept the same in their behalf.

In His post-resurrection ministry in heaven's sanctuary (see chapter 10), humans no longer have to go through priests, as in the Old Testament sanctuary sacrifices and services. For these sacrifices and services pointed to the coming of the Savior, who would be the sole way to God. Now that Christ has come, these Old Testament sanctuary sacrifices and services are no longer valid. This is why any theology that elevates priests, saints, and Mary, and sacraments as the means to get to God have not grasped the good news of the gospel. Christ is well able to be "the way and the truth and the life" for He said, "No one comes to the Father except through me" (John 14:6).

GOD AS TRINITY

The mission of Jesus Christ on planet earth requires that God be more than one Person. For if God was merely one Person, taking the form of a Father in the Old Testament, taking the form of the Son in the Gospels, and taking the form of the Spirit from Pentecost onward (Modalism), we would not have

the biblical story of the man Jesus. Modalism holds that there is only one God who exists in three different modes. If this were true, it would mean that when Jesus was on planet earth, there would be no Father to pray to and no Spirit to empower. He would necessarily live on earth as God, and we need to ask if that would have been sufficient for Him to fulfill the purpose of His coming.

If God is only one Person, then who ruled the universe when He died at Calvary? Who would call Him from the grave? Wouldn't Satan have claimed the throne, taking power while Christ was in the grave? Wouldn't His scheme to rule in place of God have been fulfilled? And if Satan had taken over the throne, what kind of meaning would this give to Christ's death which is considered (in part) Christ's victory over Satan?

We need to enquire whether becoming human necessitated giving up His omnipresence. If it didn't, then what is the point of becoming human if you are everywhere in the universe at the same time? On that basis could the man Jesus be tempted in the same ways as other humans? How could He be a sympathetic High Priest, and how could He be a model for us in our human living (Heb. 4:14–16)? If becoming human means God gave up the attribute of omnipresence, and He is the only Person who is God, then how could He be God of the universe now in His present ministry? How could He hear and answer prayers of all humans around the world?

These questions lay out some ground work thinking that needs to be done, guided by Scripture.

Survey of New Testament Data

RECENT HISTORICAL UNDERSTANDING OF JESUS

The eighteenth-century Enlightenment introduced doubt about the historical authenticity of the Synoptics. Miracles were jettisoned, including the resurrection of Jesus. The Tübingen school established the alleged need to choose between John and the Synoptic Gospels.[8] Subsequently, many scholars focused on getting back behind the Christ of faith (Christian community understanding of Him) to the Jesus of history (first-century understanding of Him). This led to a period of one-hundred-thirty-five years, from Reimarus to Wrede (1775–1910), during which many lives of Jesus were written. Yet the Gospels are not ordinary biographies of Jesus. Rather, some incidents and teachings are given, but with little more than the public ministry of Christ as the context. Little is

8. Albert Schweitzer, *The Quest of the Historical Jesus: A Critical Study of Its Progress from Reimarus to Wrede* (London: Adam & Charles Black, 1963, 1st ed. 1910, Ger. ed. 1906), 10.

said of Christ's childhood, and nothing is written about the intervening years from childhood to the age of thirty.

One could say that for scholars toward the end of the twentieth century a paradigm shift was taking place: The Gospels were no longer considered historical narratives but literary narratives. Yet when it comes to Scripture, the use of the reader-response hermeneutic, in which the reader brings meaning to the text, is inappropriate. We need authorial intent to be understood through grammatical-historical exegesis, where the "text has sovereignty over the interpreter" and the historical is not neglected. There is a story in the narrative, but not a story without history.[9] What the text meant to the first readers and what it means to contemporary readers are both important, as authorial intent is applied. This is best accomplished by allowing Scripture to interpret Scripture (*sola-tota-prima Scriptura* hermeneutic).

TWO WAYS TO STUDY THE GOSPELS

There are two ways that one can present the four Gospels: (1) present the Synoptic Gospels (Matthew, Mark, Luke) compared to John; or (2) present each one individually. The thesis of this system is that God is the author of all Scripture, but in communicating with humans, He allowed His chosen and inspired biblical writers to use their own logic, language, and literature. This means that each Gospel is unique, but the Gospels can never contradict each other because God is the author of all of them. This phenomenon is discovered through comparing the writings.

So while allowing freedom of individual expression, God inspire these writers when it came to content. We too will allow each writer to make his contribution, just as God did in the giving of Scripture.

MATTHEW

Matthew knew the Old Testament, and documented that Jesus Christ fulfilled predictions made about Him by the prophets. That's why Matthew repeats the phrase (or its equivalent) "to fulfill what was said through the prophet." Ten to fourteen (estimates vary) Old Testament quotations are unique to Matthew.[10] Matthew refers to Psalms (13:35), Isaiah (1:23; 3:3; 4:15; 8:17; 12:17–21; 13:14, 15), Jeremiah (1:18), Hosea (9:13; 12:7), Micah (2:6; 10:36), and Malachi (11:10). Jesus said His hearers were fulfilling the

9. Donald A. Hagner, *Matthew 1–13*, vol. 33a of *Word Biblical Commentary*, ed. David A. Hubbard and Glenn W. Barker (Dallas, TX: Word, 1993), 39–41.

10. D. A. Carson & Douglas J. Moo, *An Introduction to the New Testament*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2005), 163.

prophecy of Isaiah (15:7–9). I concur with Guthrie that Matthew wrote from the perspective of Christ fulfilling Old Testament prophecies.[11]

Matthew is a book for the church, showing Jewish Christians the continuity between their new faith and the faith of their ancestors "as the fulfilment of the Scriptures, and as the beginning of the realization of the hope of Israel."[12] The Greek word for church (*ekklēsia*) in the Gospels occurs only in Matthew (16:18; 18:17).[13] As noted above, fulfillment is an important theme, and the central emphasis in Matthew is upon the gospel of the kingdom (Matt. 4:23; 9:35; 24:14; cf. 26:13). The Greek word "kingdom" (*basileia*) appears more frequently in Matthew than in the other Gospels, and nearly three times as much as in Mark.[14] It is the "kingdom of heaven" (Matt. 4:17; 5:3b; 10b, 19–20; 11:11b–12; 13:24, 33; 13:44, 52; 18:23; 19:12, 14, 23; 20:1; 25:1), and has drawn near (10:7).

Christ warns the Jews that the "kingdom of God will be taken away from you and given to a people who will produce its fruit" (Matt. 21:43; they will become desolate: Matt. 23:28; cf. 11:10–13; 23:13), and the mission of Israel will be passed on to the Christian church, made up of Jewish and Gentile Christians. If only Judah had depended upon God, He could have used them, but they failed to live by faith. In Matthew's Gospel, Christ gives insight into His dependence upon the Spirit, saying, "if it is by the Spirit of God that I drive out demons, then the kingdom of God has come upon you" (Matt. 12:28). One day "the righteous will shine like the sun in the kingdom of their Father" (Matt. 13:43). He speaks of that future as the "kingdom of God" (Matt. 21:31), or "my Father's kingdom" (Matt. 26:29).

Jesus Christ is presented in Matthew as "Son of God" (e.g., Matt. 8:29; 14:33; 16:16; cf. 3:17; 17:5). He fulfilled prophecy as "Immanuel…'God with us'" (Matt. 1:23). He was called "the Son of God" by Peter (Matt. 14:33), and the demoniacs (Matt. 8:29), but most importantly by God (Matt. 3:17). Christ doesn't call Himself the Son of God, but often refers to God as "my Father" (Matt. 7:21b; 12:50; 18:35; 20:23) and speaks about the Father (Matt. 11:25–27). He says to His hearers "your Father" (6:1b, 4b, 18b, 26b, 32b; 7:11b) and the "Spirit of your Father" (Matt. 10:20). Christ taught His disciples to pray to the Father (Matt. 6:6–15), pleaded with His Father in Gethsemane (Matt. 26:36–42), and on the cross cried out in God-forsakenness to His Father (Matt. 27:46).

Christ refers to His post-resurrection ministry, when He will be seated at His Father's side on heaven's throne (Matt. 22:43–45), "Whoever acknowledges me before others, I will also acknowledge before my Father in heaven"

11. Donald Guthrie, *New Testament Introduction* (Downets Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1970), 25.
12. Donald A. Hagner, *Matthew 1–13*, 42, 59.
13. Ibid., 63.
14. Ibid., 60.

(10:32). He says that one has to become childlike (in faith and trust in God) to enter the kingdom of heaven; and also "whoever welcomes one such child in my name welcomes me" (18:5). He refers to the angels of these children as in heaven, and they "always see the face of my Father in heaven" (18:10). He declares that "your Father in heaven is not willing that any of these little ones should perish" (18:14).

Christ indicates that the Son of God and the Son of Man are the same person. With respect to His second coming, Christ tells us, "Then will appear in heaven the sign of the Son of Man, and then all the tribes of the earth will mourn, and they will see the Son of Man coming on the clouds of heaven with power and great glory" (Matt. 24:30–31). "For the Son of Man is going to come in his Father's glory with his angels, and then he will reward each person according to what they have done" (16:27). Christ says, "From now on you will see the Son of Man sitting at the right hand of the Mighty One and coming on the clouds of heaven" (Matt. 26:64). Beyond that, Christ speaks of the time when the Son of Man sits on his glorious throne" and the disciples will "sit on twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel" (Matt. 19:28). He adds, "When the Son of Man comes in his glory, and all the angels with him, he will sit on his glorious throne. All the nations will be gathered before him" (Matt. 25:31–32). Those gaining entrance to the Kingdom will be those who were kind to the needy, for as much as they were kind to them, they unknowingly were kind to Jesus. Kindness to children and to the needy reflects the loving ministry of Christ and the love of the Trinity for the lost. Heaven will be populated with those who love others.

It is clear from Matthew that the name "Son of Man" is applied to Jesus and is used by Christ (Matt. 8:20; 9:6; 10:23b; 12:8; 13:41a; 16:27; 19:28; 20:18; 24:30, 44; 25:31; 26:2, 23, 45, 64; 20:28; 24:39b, 44). Christ said, "the Son of Man is Lord of the Sabbath" (Matt. 12:8), having "authority on earth to forgive sins" (Matt. 9:6). He asked His disciples, "Who do people say the Son of Man is?" (Matt. 16:13), and told His disciples that the Son of Man would be betrayed (Matt. 26:23), "handed over to be crucified" (Matt. 26:2). The Son of Man was hated by religious leaders (who taught human doctrines, instead of the truth of God), culminating in their giving Christ over to be crucified. This is why Christ had to turn away from His nation, for they had turned away from Him. God always respects human freedom to turn Him down. Such humans manifest the spirit of the adversary, in direct contrast to the love of those who will enter the kingdom of heaven. Here is the stark and shocking difference between the two sides of the cosmic controversy: humans either become more like Christ, or more like Satan. Christ had compassion for the needy (14:14; 20:34), while Satan never does.

Christ lived His human life on the major battleground of the cosmic controversy. In contrast to the human traditions of the religious leaders (Matt. 15:6–9), He taught divine truths from Scripture (e.g., deeper insights into Scripture expressed as: "But I tell you"; Matt. 5:22, 28, 32, 34, 39, 44). He overcame Satan's temptations through Scripture (Deut. 8:3; 6:13; 6:16; Matt. 4:1–11), and spent time with His Father. After hearing of the death of John the Baptist, "he withdrew by boat privately to a solitary place" (Matt. 14:13a). Later, "he went up on a mountainside by himself to pray. Later that night, he was there alone" (Matt. 14:23).

We need to read this Gospel account from the perspective of Jesus Christ. Even though Christ does not call Himself the Son of God, it is important that *God calls Him His Son.* Christ came to meet humans on their level, to live a human life, and hence calls Himself the Son of Man. But this Son of Man performs miracles, forgives sin, and is now enthroned with God, and is to come with the Father in His second advent. Clearly these facts reveal the Son of Man to be the Son of God.

MARK

The Gospel of Mark at one time was deconstructed by form critics, such as Bultmann, but today it is considered narrative. In fact, Robert Guelich rightly says the narrative "involves conflict."[15] My assessment is that Mark highlights, in a dramatic way, the cosmic controversy, as the leaders of both sides meet head-on in Palestine. It is important that readers enter into the experience of Jesus, as far as is possible, and see what is taking place in the Gospel of Mark from His perspective.

One finds Jesus looking up to heaven and "with a deep sigh" healing the blind man (Mark 7:34); later, "he sighed deeply" over His contemporaries testing Him by asking for a sign when His miracles were evidence enough (Mark 8:12). As in Matthew, God declares at Christ's baptism, "You are my Son, whom I love; with you I am well pleased" (Mark 1:11); and at the Mount of Transfiguration, God says again, "This is my Son, whom I love. Listen to him!" (Mark 9:7b), and the Roman centurion at the cross exclaims, "Surely this man was the Son of God!" (Mark 15:39b). Christ calls Himself the "Son of Man" (Mark 10:33, 45; 14:20–21, 41b), which means He really did live on earth as a human, even though He was also God. Hence He could say, "the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins" (Mark 2:10), "is Lord even of the Sabbath" (Mark 2:28), and will sit "at the right hand of the Mighty One" in the Second Advent (Mark 14:62). As in Matthew, here is clear evidence that Jesus Christ is God and Man in one Person.

Christ's public ministry thrust Him into the midst of the cosmic controversy. A demon confronts Christ: "Have you come to destroy us? I know who you

15. Robert A. Guelich, *Word Biblical Commentary: Mark 1–8:26* (Dallas, TX: Word, 1989), 22–24.

are—the Holy One of God! 'Be quiet!' said Jesus sternly, 'Come out of him!' The impure spirit shook the man violently and came out of him with a shriek" (Mark 1:24–26). All who witnessed this confrontation were amazed: "He even gives orders to impure spirits and they obey him" (Mark 1:27). Then comes the leper, the untouchable, the one the Law and its observers declare "unclean! unclean!" Jesus was indignant. "He reached out his hand and touched the man. 'I am willing,' he said. 'Be clean!' Immediately the leprosy left him and he was cleansed" (Mark 1:41–42; cf. 6:34; 8:2). What a staggering contrast between the way demons and Christ treat humans!

Christ "drove out many demons, but he would not let the demons speak because they knew who he was" (Mark 1:34). He knew that this would shorten His ministry among humans, and He wanted to do much more for them before being killed because of jealous religious leaders. "So, he traveled throughout Galilee, preaching in their synagogues and driving out demons" (Mark 1:39). He asked the leper not to tell others, but he broadcast the news. "As a result, Jesus could no longer enter a town openly but stayed outside in lonely places" (Mark 1:45). "Whenever the impure spirits saw him, they fell down before him and cried out, 'You are the Son of God.' But he gave them strict orders not to tell who he was" (Mark 3:11–12).

Christ sent out the Twelve to preach and gave them "authority to drive out demons" (Mark 3:15; 6:7), and "they drove out many demons" (Mark 6:13a). He knew His Word would meet with resistance. Christ said, "As soon as they hear it, Satan comes and takes away the word that was sown in them" (Mark 4:15). God's Word and demons are never found together, either one or the other takes possession. A legion of demons possessed one man, who lived in the tombs. No one could bind the man. Often chained hand and foot he "tore the chains apart and broke the irons on his feet" (Mark 5:4, cf. v. 9). "Night and day among the tombs and in the hills he would cry out and cut himself with stones. When he saw Jesus from a distance, he ran and fell on his knees in front of him. He shouted at the top of his voice, 'What do you want with me, Jesus, Son of the Most High God? In God's name don't torture me!'" (Mark 5:7). "For Jesus had said to him, 'Come out of this man, you impure spirit!'" (v. 8). Consider the paradox: demons were torturing the man, but they themselves didn't want to be tortured.

"The demons begged Jesus, 'Send us among the pigs; allow us to go into them.' He gave them permission, and the impure spirits came out and went into the pigs. The herd, about two thousand in number, rushed down the steep bank into the lake and were drowned" (Mark 5:12–13). Fearing death for themselves, they delighted in killing others. Imagine wanting to enter pigs when they had

once been angels at the throne of God! That's what sin does to demean noble beings created by God. Soon after that Jesus raised the daughter of Jairus from the dead (Mark 5:35–41). Jesus held her hand and said, "Little girl, I say to you, get up!" and immediately she arose (Mark 5:41–42a). On another occasion, Jesus took a blind man "by the hand and led him outside the village" where he healed him, asking him not to go to the village to advertise the miracle (Mark 8:22–26). Demons destroyed life, but Jesus restored it.

Devils even take delight in afflicting the young: Jesus removed the demon from the daughter of the Greek woman born in Syrian Phonecia, without ever going to where she was (Mark 7:24–30).

A boy was demon-possessed, and the spirit had robbed the boy of speech. The father told Jesus: "Whenever it seizes him, it throws him to the ground. He foams at the mouth, gnashes his teeth and becomes rigid. I asked your disciples to drive out the spirit, but they could not" (Mark 9:18). Even "[w]hen the spirit saw Jesus, it immediately threw the boy into a convulsion. He fell to the ground and rolled around, foaming at the mouth" (Mark 9:20). But Jesus rebuked the evil spirit, and "[t]he spirit shrieked, convulsed him violently and came out. The boy looked so much like a corpse that many said, 'He's dead'" (Mark 9:26).

Christ was on enemy territory, and His days were numbered. The Christ who came to set captives free allowed Himself to become a victim of demon-possessed persecutors who mocked Him as the King of the Jews (which he admitted He was, Mark 15:2). "They put a purple robe on him, then twisted together a crown of thorns and set it on him. And they began to call out to him, 'Hail, King of the Jews!' Again and again they struck him on the head with a staff and spit on him. Falling on their knees, they paid homage to him" (Mark 15:17–19). In utter blasphemy, revolting wretches mocked and ridiculed Him with venom from demons that had goaded them on. His nation had forsaken Him. And in death He cried out, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Mark 15:34), which is to be expected from the One who is carrying the sins of the world as a substitutionary sacrifice. But God hadn't forsaken Him. Resurrection morning He was alive and "appeared first to Mary Magdalene, out of whom he had driven seven demons" (Mark 16:9), and "was taken up into heaven and he sat at the right hand of God" (Mark 16:19). He conquered as the Son of Man.

LUKE

Luke/Acts is like one volume written by the physician-historian Luke. Consider: The author categorizes his writing as narrative, an orderly account based

upon thorough research (Luke 1:1–4), and in the introduction to Acts, he gives his summary of Luke: "I wrote about all that Jesus began to do and to teach until the day he was taken up to heaven" (Acts 1:1–2). So Luke presents the deeds and teachings of Christ's earthly ministry. Acts introduces the resurrected Jesus, who spends forty days with His disciples and promises them the gift of the Holy Spirit so they could be His witnesses to the ends of the earth. Then "he was taken up before their very eyes," and two men dressed in white told them Jesus would return in the same way as they had seen Him go into heaven (Acts 1:3–11). Joel Green rightly compares the "began" of Christ's ministry on earth (Luke) with its "continuation" (Acts).[16] In his Luke/Acts volume, Luke links the continuing work of Christ in heaven with His preceding work on earth. The continuance is a vital New Testament insight, for even though His ministry on earth was completed, it needed to be applied through His heavenly ministry. Luke helps his readers get the full picture about what Jesus has done and is doing for humans.

This linking of what Jesus did on earth (Luke) with His ministry in the heavenly sanctuary (Acts) brings them together as one in Christ's saving mission. It seems appropriate, then, that Luke begins with the angel Gabriel coming from the presence of God in the heavenly sanctuary (Luke 1:19) to the priest Zechariah in the earthly sanctuary. Gabriel appeared to the right of the altar of incense in the holy place and gave him the good news of the birth of his son, John the Baptist, who would prepare a people for Christ's coming (Luke 1:8–17).

Six months later Gabriel visited Mary and said of Jesus: "The Lord God will give him the throne of his father David, and he will reign over Jacob's descendants forever; his kingdom will never end" (1:32–33). Gabriel directed Mary to look to the future time, when the resurrected Christ would be seated at the right hand of the Father, the time of Acts and beyond. So Gabriel connected the earthly ministry of Jesus with that future heavenly ministry, and was arguably looking forward to the fruits of those ministries in the Kingdom to come after Christ's second coming. The future reign was the goal of the coming birth. The birth of Christ was announced by angels, and an angel (probably Gabriel) declared, "Today in the town of David a Savior has been born to you; he is the Messiah, the Lord" (2:11). Then a host of angels sang: "Glory to God in the highest heaven, and on earth peace to those on whom his favor rests" (2:14), another uniting of heaven and earth. Just as the angels sang for joy at the creation of the world (Job 38:4–7), so the angels sang at the creation of the God-Man.

The very next scene is baby Jesus being brought to be dedicated in the temple. Less than a year before Christ had been sitting at the right hand of God in the

16. Joel B. Green, *The Gospel of Luke*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1997), 7.

most holy place of heaven's temple, and now He was a helpless baby in the earthly temple. The prophetic voice through Simeon and Anna knew that God and Man have been united in Jesus Christ. Simeon took Jesus in his arms and spoke to God, "my eyes have seen your salvation" (Luke 2:25–30), and Anna gave "thanks to God and spoke about the child to all who were looking forward to the redemption of Jerusalem" (Luke 2:38). Both saw in Jesus the promised Messiah, or Savior.

Another link between earth and heaven was John the Baptist's promise that Jesus would baptize with the Holy Spirit (Luke 3:16) which was not fulfilled until Jesus began His ministry in heaven's temple and the Holy Spirit was sent at Pentecost (Acts 2).

At the age of twelve Jesus sat among the teachers for three days, listening and asking questions, and everyone was "amazed at his understanding and his answers" (Luke 2:45–47). Full of the Holy Spirit, He overcame Satan's temptations through knowing and reciting Scripture (Luke 4:1–13). It was His custom to go to the synagogue on the Sabbath, and in the synagogue in Galilee He read from the Messianic passage in Isaiah 61:1–2, and then declared He had come to fulfill this prophecy. Yet His listeners knew Jesus was Joseph's son (rather than God's Son), and in fury planned to throw Him over a nearby cliff, but He disappeared at its edge (Luke 4:14–30).

Mark focuses on the immediacy of Christ's healings and the amazement/astonishment of people in response to Christ's teaching and miracles (Luke 4:31, 36; 5:9; 8:56; 9:43). "Everyone was amazed and gave praise to God. "They were filled with awe and said, 'We have seen remarkable things today'" (Luke 5:26). Jesus was filled with the Spirit, and "the power of the Lord was with Jesus to heal the sick" (Luke 5:17b). Jesus could say, "[I]f I drive out demons by the finger of God, [or "Spirit of God," Matt. 12:28] then the kingdom of God has come upon you" (11:20), and "people all tried to touch him, because power was coming from him and healing them all" (Luke 6:19). On one occasion "the crowds almost crushed him" (Luke 8:42b), yet in the midst of that crowd He said, "Someone touched me; I know that power has gone out from me" (Luke 8:46). Jesus touched the leper to heal him (Luke 5:13), and when all the sick were brought to Him, He laid "his hands on each one" and "he healed them" (Luke 4:40).

Luke documents the prayer life of Jesus, the source of His power: "At daybreak Jesus went out to a solitary place" (Luke 4:42a). "Jesus often withdrew to lonely places and prayed" (Luke 5:16). "One of those days Jesus went out to a mountainside to pray, and spent the night praying to God" (Luke 6:12). "Once when Jesus was praying in private and his disciples were with him" (9:18). In praying to His Father, Jesus was "full of joy through the Holy Spirit" (Luke 10:21a). Jesus then invited others to experience what He experienced: "If you then, though

you are evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father in heaven give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him!" (Luke 11:13). Jesus promised that the Holy Spirit will teach persons what to say when they are brought before synagogues, rulers, and authorities (Luke 12:11–12).

Christ's enemies were furious with Him (Luke 6:11) and "began to oppose him fiercely" (Luke 11:53). They objected to His healing the sick on the Sabbath (Luke 13:10–17; 14:1–6), because they had no compassion for the needy. Jesus sought to show them the error of their ways: "[Y]ou load people down with burdens they can hardly carry, and you yourselves will not lift one finger to help them. Woe to you, because you build tombs for the prophets, and it was your ancestors who killed them" (Luke 11:46–47). "Woe to you experts in the law, because you have taken away the key to knowledge" (Luke 11:52). These teachers had replaced God's Word with human traditions, and replaced the Spirit of God with the same demonic spirits who opposed God. There was no essential difference between hardened, uncompassionate religious leaders and demons who manifested the same spirit in possessed humans.

Yet these priests, ministering in the temple, were supposed to be types of Christ. But they actually resembled Christ's adversary, the proud rebel (Ezek. 28:17a). Christ said of them, "They like to walk around in flowing robes and love to be greeted with respect in the marketplaces and have the most important seats in the synagogues and the places of honor at banquets. They devour widows' houses and for a show make lengthy prayers" (Luke 20:46–47). Christ "came to that which was his own, but his own did not receive him" (John 1:11). Christ said, "I have longed to gather your children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, and you were not willing. Look, your house is left to you desolate" (Luke 13:34–35a). No wonder Christ wept over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41), the once holy city and once sacred temple. Speaking of His second coming, Christ asked, "[W]hen the Son of Man comes, will he find faith on the earth?" (Luke 18:8b). The answer is no, for some contemporary study of the Gospels treat Christ no better than the teachers of His day (see chapter 11). They accept Him as a Son of Man, but not as the Son of God.

Again in Luke Christ refers to Himself as the "Son of Man" (Luke 6:22b; 7:34; 9:26, 44, 58; 12:40; 13:10; 17:24, 26, 30; 18:8, 31b; 19:10; 21:27; 22:22, 69), but also as the Son of Man who "has authority on earth to forgive sins" (Luke 5:24; cf. 7:48) and as the Son of Man who "is Lord of the Sabbath" (6:5). Although Christ used this "Son of Man" title in order to relate to humans, the Synoptics give clear evidence (as noted above) that the Son of Man was/is also the Son of God. That's why the Gospel of Luke and the Book of Acts belong together. Matthew points out Christ's fulfillment of many Old Testament predictions. Luke

records Christ's having given two discouraged disciples "what was said in all the Scriptures concerning himself" (Luke 24:27, see 17–27), and said to all His disciples, "Everything must be fulfilled that is written about me in the Law of Moses, the Prophets and the Psalms" (Luke 24:44).

The Gospel writers and Christ turned to the Old Testament for evidence of Christ's divinity and His life, words, and deeds in the Gospels demonstrated He was God and Man. Luke ends by saying Christ "was taken up into heaven" and His disciples "returned to Jerusalem with great joy" (Luke 24:51–52). Finally the disciples knew that Christ was the Son of God. This radically transformed them from scared followers of a crucified Christ into bold proclaimers of His resurrection. No longer fearing for their own lives, they demonstrated the authenticity of this new understanding about Christ. They would rather die than deny the living Christ at God's right hand in heaven.

JOHN

Scholars often discuss differences between the Synoptics and the Gospel of John. In his book *New Testament Introduction*, New Testament scholar Donald Guthrie discusses the problems raised, and gives reasonable solutions to them, so we will follow him in this segment.[17] Our presentation is not exhaustive, but representative, and sufficient for our purpose to indicate the reasons why John's Gospel is equally authentic as the Synoptics, although many scholars question this conclusion. Here are some of the differences:

John was written later than the Synoptics, and John had access to them, and so did not repeat a number of events included by them, but added new events instead (see items 1–3 in the list that follows). Guthrie rightly considers two cleansings of the temple, one at the beginning, one at the end of Christ's ministry (see item 4).[18] There is an omission of the Judean ministry in the Synoptics, and they lacked data on the Jewish festivals (see item 5). The Passover date differed in two calendars, and the Synoptics and John were using different calendars (see item 6). Rather than being influenced by Hellenistic ideas, John probably used the *logos* language to convey truth of Christ to Gentile Greeks. John alone records that Christ's legs were not broken at His crucifixion—in fulfillment of Scripture (John 19:36); John refers to Abraham, Jacob, Moses, and refers to Scripture (as does Christ, John 10:34); there is more teaching

17. Guthrie, *New Testament Introduction*, 237–241; 287–300.

18. "The first difficulty may be obviated by postulating two cleansings, although this suggestion is usually dismissed, almost without consideration, as highly improbable. On the other hand it cannot be argued conclusively that a double cleansing was impossible. If it happened once it could in theory happen twice, if similar conditions were repeated," Guthrie, *New Testament Introduction*, 293.

about the Holy Spirit in John than in the Synoptics; and the theme of love is expressed more clearly in John than in the Synoptics (see item 7).

The different proportion of discourse to narrative is merely a writing style, and doesn't suggest contradiction (see item 8). The title "Son of Man" is used less frequently in John, and the title "Son of God" is used more frequently in John, yet all four Gospels present Jesus Christ as fully God and fully Man, and it may be that John wanted to stress Christ's divinity, even though it is not absent in the Synoptics. Yet this doesn't indicate contradiction. In fact, the humanity of Christ is more clearly revealed in John: He weeps at the grave of Lazarus, washes the disciples' feet in the upper room, and thirsts on the Cross. More of the inner consciousness of Jesus is revealed in John, climaxed when He prays aloud (John 17) (see item 9). The fact that Christ as Messiah is more easily recognized in John (by disciples, 1:14; and by Samaritan woman, 4:7–26) may mean that Christ may have felt more freedom to speak about His being the Messiah to a Samaritan than to Jews because of their false ideas of the Messiah's role (to liberate them from the hated Romans). It is of interest that in John alone Jesus thwarted the attempt by the multitude to make Him king (6:15) (see item 10).

1. The following facts (in the Synoptics) are not found in John's Gospel: virgin birth, baptism, temptation, transfiguration, cure of any demoniacs or lepers, the parables, Lord's Supper, agony in Gethsemane, dereliction cry, and the ascension.
2. The following facts (not found in the Synoptics) are found in John's Gospel: early Judean ministry, miracle at Cana, meeting Nicodemus, Samaritan woman, healing cripple, blind man in Jerusalem, raising of Lazarus, washing disciple's feet, farewell discourse, and parts of the passion narrative.
3. There is an absence of Synoptic-type parables in John, and an absence of Johannine-type discourses in the Synoptics.
4. The cleansing of the temple is placed at the end of Christ's ministry in the Synoptics, and at the beginning of His ministry in John.
5. The duration of Christ's ministry is about a year in the Synoptics and over three years in John.
6. The last supper is on Passover day according to the Synoptics and before the Passover in John.
7. The Word (Gr. *logos*, John 1:1) is considered a Hellenistic influence.
8. The proportion of narrative to discourse is much less in John than the Synoptics.
9. The title "Son of God" is found more often in John, "Son of Man" occurs more often in Synoptics.
10. Christ as Messiah is more easily recognized in John than in the Synoptics.
11. Synoptic Christ's discourses not the same kind as the Johannine Christ's discourses.

The reason Christ's discourses were different in John than in the Synoptics may be because John spoke to more educated people (in Jerusalem, in synagogue); whereas the Synoptic discourses were for the more common people (in Galilee, in the open air) (see item 11 in the list above). Guthrie raised a couple of important points: (1) "if Jesus could not have taught as the Johannine Christ taught, where did the idea arise that He did? It is inconceivable that such an unfamiliar picture could have received authentication if there were not already some basis for it in the tradition."[19] (2) "The difference between the Synoptics and Johannine teaching material must not be minimized, but is it not possible to find a solution in the versatility of Jesus as a teacher, rather than in the acceptance of one picture as authentic and the rejection of the other?"[20]

PAUL'S COSMIC CHRIST

The Roman emperor Nero (37–68) martyred Paul, which means he died before some of the Gospels were written; it also means that the first known written records of Christ circulating among the Gentiles came from Paul. Unlike the other apostles who lived with Christ during His public ministry, Paul encountered the risen Christ (Acts 9:1–6; Gal. 1:12b–17). It is important to note that Paul sees Christ as the cosmic Christ: Before creation God chose humans to be adopted as sons through Christ (Eph. 1:4), for when all is fulfilled God will "bring unity to all things in heaven and on earth under Christ" (Eph. 1:10b). Veli-Matti Kärkkäinen appropriately calls Christ the "cosmic ruler."[21] In the meantime, "God raised [aorist] us up with Christ and seated [aorist] us with him in heavenly realms in Christ Jesus, in order that in the coming ages he might show the incomparable riches of his grace, expressed in kindness to us in Christ Jesus" (Eph. 2:6–7).

As well, Paul shares with us that God's "intent was that now, through the church, the manifold wisdom of God should be made known to the rulers and authorities in the heavenly realms, according to his eternal purpose that he accomplished in Christ Jesus our Lord" (Eph. 3:10–11). Paul adds in Colossians: "Since, then, you have been raised with Christ, set your hearts on things above, where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God. Set your minds on things above, not on earthly things. For you died, and your life is now hidden with Christ in God" (Col. 3:1–3). Paul speaks of cosmic reconciliation: "For God was pleased to have all his fullness dwell in him [Christ], and through him

19. Guthrie, *New Testament Introduction*, 292.
20. Ibid., 292–293.
21. Veli-Matti Kärkkäinen, *Christology: A Global Introduction, An Ecumenical, International, and Contextual Perspective* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2003), 48.

to reconcile to himself all things, whether things on earth or things in heaven, by making peace through his blood, shed on the cross" (Col. 1:19–20).

In other words, the Cross not only redeems those who accept its gift, but it also impacts the cosmos. This is because the cosmic controversy against God was resolved through God's revelation at the Cross, a revelation made to all unfallen beings in the universe. But for humans, only a few saw Christ die, and fewer still understood the meaning of His death. Yet one day, at the final judgment, Christ's words will be fulfilled for all humans: "I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to myself" (John 12:32). Then it will be understood by all created beings that the Cross revealed the truth about the controversy because it revealed the truth about God. This cosmic revelation is the context in which the ministry of Christ, before and after the Cross, is best understood.

HEBREWS

We will say more about the Book of Hebrews in chapter 11, so we will mention just a few key points here. Like the Book of Acts, the Book of Hebrews has Christ enthroned at the right hand of the Father (1:3, 8–13; 8:1–2), carrying out His ministry in heaven's sanctuary and applying the benefits of His once for all completed atonement sacrifice at Calvary. It is the risen Christ who acts for His people, and who is in charge of affairs on planet earth. It is true that this world is still under the influence of the enemy, but Christ defeated Satan at the cross (Rev. 12:7–12; John 12:31; 16:11), although He still allows him freedom to do his work.

With the first coming of Christ to the world, the kingdom of God drew near, and in one sense it is being built up in the church as the earthly dwelling place of God. Hence Christ is at the throne of God in the heavenly temple, and resides through the Holy Spirit in the church temple, and in His followers as temples of the living God. This is relational language that one would expect from a relational God. In another sense, concerning the second coming of Christ, His prayer to the Father will be answered: "your kingdom come" (Matt. 6:10), for Christ said, "My kingdom is not of this world" (John 18:36a); rather, it is to come when He returns and takes the redeemed to be with Him in the kingdom in heaven (John 14:1–4). Christ works to bring history to its conclusion, and the end will come when the gospel has been preached in all the world (Matt. 24:14). In His ministry on earth, Jesus had to be human, so that He could be tempted like us and become a sympathetic high priest (Heb. 4:15–16). For His ministry in heaven, Christ has to be divine, for He is the sole mediator between humans and God, and God and humans. In other words, He had to be fully man and fully God for His ministry to be effective on earth and

in heaven. Only humanity can die for the human race, and only divinity can lift up the race into an eternal relationship with God. It is Satan's plan to hide both the true divinity and true humanity of Jesus Christ (see chapters 9–10).

BOOK OF REVELATION

The last book of the Bible is the "revelation of Jesus Christ." It is (1) a revelation given by Christ; and (2) a revelation about Christ. It reveals that Christ is God. Christ appears in a vision to John, saying, "Do not be afraid, I am the First and the Last [meaning He is eternal]. I am the Living One [source of life]. I was dead, and now look I am alive for ever and ever!" (Rev. 1:17b–18). He is the eternal God, the one raised from the dead. The scroll of history was sealed, and no one was found to open it. John wept. Who would be in charge of human history? "Then I saw a Lamb, looking as if it has been slain, standing at the center of the throne.... He went and took the scroll from the right hand of him who sat on the throne" (Rev. 5:6–7). Then a new song was sung: "You are worthy to take the scroll and to open its seals, because you were slain, and with your blood you purchased for God persons from every tribe and language and people and nation" (Rev. 5:9). He is the Savior of the world, and as such He has the right to be in control of the affairs of the world.

The goal of history is good news, the unfolding of the benefits of the Cross. Christ's death leads to eternal life for the redeemed, and we get to see a glimpse of that future: "they are before the throne of God and serve him day and night in his temple; and he who sits on the throne will shelter them with his presence. Never again will they hunger; never again will they thirst. The sun will not beat down on them, nor any scorching heat. For the Lamb at the center of the throne will be their shepherd; he will lead them to springs of living water. And God will wipe away every tear from their eyes" (Rev. 7:15–17).

After the millennium we read: "I saw the Holy City, the new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride beautifully dressed for her husband. And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, Look! God's dwelling place is now among the people, and he will dwell with them. They will be his people, and God himself will be with them and be their God" (Rev. 21:2–3). Then this world will know that Jesus Christ is fully God and fully Man, and God and humans will live together in covenant relationship forever.

IN THE BEGINNING

Two biblical books focus on the "beginning" in their introductions: (1) the beginning (Heb. *rē'šît*) before the creation of the world (Gen. 1:1) and (2) the

beginning (Gr. *archē*) before the Incarnation into the world (John 1:1, 14). They share a common truth: God is more than one Person. The Greek word *archē* is found fifty-five times in the New Testament and eighteen times in the writings of John.[22] "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God" (John 1:1). The "Word was God" literally means "the Word was toward God." In fact, "John thinks of no opposition between the Word and the Father. The whole existence of the Word was oriented toward the Father." John is not merely saying Jesus is divine-like, but that He is God, and the word order in the Greek is emphatic (the Greek word for "divine" is *theios*; instead of "God" *theos*; see 2 Pet. 1:4, "participate in the divine nature"). John did not write, "God was the Word," for the emphasis is on the last noun—the Word *was God.*[23]

R. V. G. Tasker speaks of the uniqueness of John's prologue for "it reveals the Word of God not merely as an attribute of God, but as a distinct Person within the Godhead, dwelling with the Creator before creation began, and acting as the divine agent in creation."[24] It is this God, the Christ through whom the Father created the universe (John 1:3, 10; Col. 1:15–16; Heb. 1:1–2), who was now to become a part of creation: "The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us. We have seen his glory, the glory of the one and only Son, who came from the Father, full of grace and truth" (John 1:14). When the Creator becomes a part of creation, this is a new beginning, which is the only way for humans to become a "new creation" in Christ (2 Cor. 5:17; Gal. 6:15) and one day enter a new heaven and a new earth (Rev. 21:1). In other words, humans and their habitat become new because of the life, death, and subsequent ministry of the God who also became human.

Divinity of Christ

CHRIST'S COMING PREDICTED

The Jewish leaders should have expected the coming of God to planet earth because the Old Testament clearly predicts this event. The prophet Isaiah said:

> For unto us a child is born, to us a son is given, and the government will be on his shoulders. And he will be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God,

22. H. Bietenhard, "*archē*," in *New International Dictionary of New Testament Theology*, ed. Colin Brown (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1986, German 1967), 1:547.

23. Leon Morris, *The Gospel According to John*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament*, rev. ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1995), 67–69. George R. Beasley-Murray, *John*, vol. 36 in *Word Biblical Commentary* (Waco, TX: Word, 1987), 10–11.

24. R. V. G. Tasker, *John*, vol. 4 in *Tyndale New Testament Commentaries* (Leicester, England: InterVarsity, 1988, 1st ed. 1960), 42.

> Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace. Of the greatness of his government and peace there will be no end. He will reign on David's throne and over his kingdom, establishing and upholding it with justice and righteousness from that time on and forever. (Isa. 9:6–7)

Micah prophesied, "But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah, though you are small among the clans of Judah, out of you will come for me one who will be ruler over Israel, whose origins are from of old, from ancient times" (Mic. 5:2). *Yahweh* Himself spoke of that same future through Jeremiah:

> "The days are coming," declares the LORD [Heb. *Yahweh*], "when I will raise up to David a righteous Branch, a King who will reign wisely and do what is just and right in the land. In his days Judah will be saved and Israel will live in safety. This is the name by which he will be called: The LORD Our Righteous Savior." (Jer. 23:5–6)

There's no doubt that God was the coming Messiah, but the Jewish leaders read the Old Testament through their own traditions, and so believed that the coming Messiah would be a mere man. True, this Messiah would liberate them from the hated Romans, but that's all. They didn't grasp that *Yahweh* God, who liberated Israel from Egypt, was the pre-incarnate Christ. They didn't grasp that the temple services and sacrifices typified a future salvation that was far greater than freedom from the Romans.

The sin problem can only be solved by God. As soon as there was sin, there was a Savior. In Eden the pre-incarnate Creator Christ took the skins from slain animals and clothed Adam and Eve, promising them that He would one day destroy Satan and redeem humans (Gen. 3:15, 20–21). On the basis of that future ministry, Christ became the Savior of humans as soon as sin entered the world. In this respect, Christ was "the Lamb who was slain from the creation of the world" (Rev. 13:8b). The promise made to Adam and Eve after the Fall was the first gospel promise, but the promise was repeated many times in the Old Testament.

Concerning His mission, Christ read from the scroll of Isaiah, "The Spirit of the Sovereign LORD is on me, because the LORD has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor. He has sent me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim freedom for the captives and release from darkness for the prisoners, to proclaim the year of the LORD's favor" (Isa. 61:1–2). He concluded saying, "Today this scripture is fulfilled in your hearing" (Luke 4:21). Justin Martyr (ca. 100–165), in his *First Apology*, presents Old Testament predictions of Christ.[25]

25. Justin Martyr, *First Apology, The Ante-Nicene Fathers* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, rev. 1989), 1:173–181 (32–53).

Below is biblical data on Old Testament prophecies about Christ and their New Testament fulfillment.[26]

Prophecy	**Fulfillment**
Born/Bethlehem (Mic. 5:2)	Born/Bethlehem (Luke 2:4–7)
Slain children (Jer. 31:15)	Slain children (Matt. 2:17–18)
Out of Egypt (Hos. 11:1)	Out of Egypt (Matt. 2:15)
Forerunner (Isa. 40:3–5)	Forerunner (Matt. 3:1, 3)
Betrayal (Ps. 41:9)	Betrayal (John 13:18; 18:2)
30 pieces of silver (Zech. 11:12)	30 pieces of silver (Matt. 26:14–15)
Spat on/beaten (Isa. 50:6)	Spat on/beaten (Matt. 26:67; John 19:1)
Gambled for garment (Ps. 22:18)	Gambled for garment (John 19:23–24)
No broken bones (Ps. 34:20)	No broken bones (John 19:32–33)
Side pierced (Zech. 12:10)	Side pierced (John 19:34, 37)
Resurrection (Ps. 16:10)	Resurrection (John 20:9)
At the Throne (Ps. 110:1)	At the Throne (Acts 2:34–36)

SALVATION WITHIN HISTORY: PROPHECY AND FULFILLMENT

Only God can accomplish the redeeming-resolving work necessary to restore the universe to its pre-Fall existence. It required God to come to this rebel planet, to enter the battle zone, to become sin itself, and die for humans. The problem of sin could not be solved by a fiat act of God (such as He did in creating out of nothing). The problem is in creation: created beings who have joined the rebellion and have become sinful—separated from God. God needed to become human, for the Creator must become a part of creation in order to reclaim it from sin and resolve the cosmic controversy. For the redeeming-resolving work of Jesus Christ has to be done from within. It is an internal assignment that is only possible through a life lived among sinful humans, a death inflicted by humans, and a resurrection of His humanity.

The entire history of humanity is the time frame in which God has been restoring within humans the damaged image of the Creator. It is an individual work, taking a lifetime of patient molding, with each person demanding particular attention. Foundationally, it took Christ's lifetime on earth, and it continues to take His continuing ministry in heaven (where He has been a high priest)—for nearly two thousand years now. It should be pointed out here that salvation wasn't achieved within Christ's nature, but within Christ's

26. These lists have an unidentified source. I will be glad to give credit to the author if made known to me.

life; it was not a matter of an internal history, but an entrance into human history; it was not a deification of His humanity by His divinity (Eastern theology), but an elevation of humanity through His human life and death for humanity and subsequent intercession and application of salvation benefits to each willing human.

CALLED "GOD"

In my *Systematic Theology*, volume two, chapter one, we considered the deity of each member of the Trinity, and so the reader may want to read what was said there about the deity of Christ. It is important to note that all four Gospels (not just the Gospel of John) present Christ as God.

- In Matthew, Jesus is called "Immanuel" which means "God with us" (Matt. 1:23, cf. v. 22, refers to Christ as the ultimate fulfillment of the prediction in Isa. 7:14).
- Mark begins his book, "The beginning of the good news about Jesus the Messiah, the Son of God" (Mark 1:1).
- In Luke the angel Gabriel says to Mary, "the holy one to be born will be called the Son of God" (Luke 1:35b).
- John begins his book with "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.... The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us.... No one has ever seen God, but the one and only Son, who is himself God" (John 1:1, 14a, 18a).

Paul speaks of the Jewish patriarchs: "and from them is traced the human ancestry of 'the Messiah,' who is God over all, forever praised! Amen" (Rom. 9:5). Doubting Thomas disbelieved Christ had risen, but when he placed his hand in Christ's side he exclaimed, "My Lord and my God" (John 20:28). After Christ's ascension to heaven, God the Father addressed Christ: "Your throne, O God, will last for ever and ever; a scepter of justice will be the scepter of your kingdom" (Heb. 1:8). Peter refers to "our God and Savior Jesus Christ" (2 Pet. 1:1). Paul speaks of "the Messiah, who is God over all" (Rom. 9:5b), and says, "in Christ all the fullness of Deity lives in bodily form" (Col. 2:9); he also refers to Christ's second advent as "the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior, Jesus Christ" (Tit. 2:13).

"Christ the Lord" (Luke 2:11b, KJV) is a title given to Christ, but what does it mean? The Greek word for "Lord" is *kurios*, which translates the Hebrew word *Yahweh* (Jehovah). In the Septuagint (LXX, Greek Old Testament), *kurios* "is used to translate the name of the Lord 6,814 times." Wayne Grudem concludes,

"Therefore, any Greek-speaking reader at the time of the New Testament who had any knowledge at all of the Greek Old Testament would have recognized that, in contexts where it was appropriate, the word 'Lord' was the name of the one who was the Creator and Sustainer of heaven and earth, the omnipotent God."[27] So "God" should be read whenever "Lord" is used of Christ, such as in John the Baptist's proclamation, "Prepare the way of the Lord" (Matt. 3:3), and in "there is but one God, the Father, from whom all things came and for whom we live; and there is but one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom all things came and through whom we live" (1 Cor. 8:6).

The word "Lord" is linked to the word "God" as well as the linguistic meaning of *kurios* already noted.

UNIQUE RELATIONSHIP WITH GOD

Christ is called the "Son of the living God" (Matt. 16:16; cf. Mark 1:1, Luke 1:35), and "Christ the Lord" (Luke 2:11, KJV). As the divine self-existent One, He has "life in Himself" (John 5:26) which is "eternal life" (1 John 5:20). He is even called the only begotten God (*theos monogenēs*) and referred to as "at the Father's side" (*patros kolpon*, John 1:18). What does it mean for Christ to be at His Father's side? Is it the same as His resurrection status when the Father "seated him at his right hand in the heavenly realms" (Eph. 1:20), when He was "Exalted to the right hand of God" (Acts 2:33), and also described as "standing at the right hand of God" (Acts 7:55b)?

There are two answers to this question given by commentators: (1) Leon Morris represents the first. He says, "When the Word became flesh his cosmic activities did not remain in abeyance until the end of his earthly life. There are mysteries here that we cannot plumb, but we must surely hold that the Incarnation meant the adding of something to what the Word was doing, rather than the cessation of most of his activities." This seems to suggest that Christ continued to experience His omnipresence, and activities related to it, while He also added to that experience His mission for humans on planet earth.[28] (2) Merrill Tenney represents the second view: "'At the Fathers' side' is substantially the same expression as that used in John 13:23 concerning 'the disciple whom Jesus loved,' who 'was reclining next to him.' It shows intimate association, which presupposes close fellowship. As the confidant of the Father, Jesus is peculiarly qualified to act as the intermediary who can carry the knowledge of God to men. The word translated 'is' is more accurately

27. Wayne Grudem, *Systematic Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1994), 544.
28. Morris, *John*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament*, 101.

rendered 'being' since it is a present participle. This implies constant relationship and presupposes preincarnate existence."[29]

The Greek of John 1:18 "is at" the Father's side is in the present active tense, and can be translated as "presently at the right hand of the Father in heaven" (Morris) or "presently in close fellowship with the Father while on earth" (Tenney). It is best to let John tell us what he meant when he wrote these words. We can do this by noting what else he wrote, and allow that to interpret John 1:18. Christ's own prayer provides guidance: (1) "And now, Father, glorify me in your presence with the glory I had with you before the world began" (John 17:5). "I am coming to you now, but I say these things while I am still in the world" (John 17:13). Christ seems very much in this world, and without the glory He once had from the Father. Would He pray in this way if He were at the Father's right hand in heaven? Doesn't His prayer suggest He wasn't omnipresent, but rather waiting His exaltation following His death (Phil. 2:8–11)? On the basis of this biblical data, it seems that Christ didn't remain in heaven at the Father's right hand when He came to live on earth.

Having said that, the Son remained at the Father's right hand in this world (for the Father was omnipresent). This is why Christ prayed "that all of them [disciples] may be one, Father, just as you are in me and I am in you. May they also be in us so that the world may believe that you have sent me. I have given them the glory that you gave me, that they may be one as we are one: I in them and you in me. So that they may be brought to complete unity. Then the world will know that you sent me and have loved them even as you have loved me" (John 17:21–23). Christ prayed that the intimate union between the Father and Himself be experienced by His disciples, and hence Christ was talking about an experience He had in this world, because He wanted His disciples to experience it too. In other words, He wasn't asking His Father to make His disciples omnipresent, but rather ensure that they sensed the nearness of the Father to them.

Just as Christ prayed, "Father, forgive them" (Luke 23:34) on the cross, He also prayed for the world: "Righteous Father, though the world does not know you, I know you, and they know that you have sent me. I have made you known to them, and will continue to make you known in order that the love you have for me may be in them and that I myself may be in them" (John 17:25–26). Here again, Christ wanted the Father's love experienced by Him to be experienced in this world.

Christ's miracles for others would be a legitimate use of His divine power, for His miracles were for the benefit of others (not for His own benefit) and

29. Merrill C. Tenney, *John*, vol. 9 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1981), 34.

revealed His union with the Father. Christ speaks of Himself as Son of God (John 5:25) and Son of Man (John 5:27). "Are you the Christ?" asked disbelieving Jews with evident contempt. "The works I do in my Father's name testify about me.... I and the Father are one" (John 10:25, 30). They picked up stones to throw at Him, but before they could, He spoke again. "I have shown you many good works from the Father. For which of these do you stone me?.... the Father is in me, and I in the Father" (John 10:32, 38).

Just as God created everything through His Son (John 1:3; Heb. 1:1–2), He accomplished salvation through His Son (John 3:16–17). They work together in both creation and re-creation. Christ says, "Whoever does not honor the Son does not honor the Father, who sent him" (John 5:23), and gave the invitation, "believe in God; believe also in me" (John 14:1). Jesus "was even calling God his own Father, making himself equal with God" (John 5:18b).

Three times in the Gospels God the Father spoke from heaven: (1) At Christ's baptism, "a voice came from heaven: 'You are my Son, whom I love; with you I am well pleased'" (Mark 1:11; cf. Matt 3:16–17; Luke 3:21–22; John 1:32–34); (2) At Christ's transfiguration, "a voice from the cloud said, 'This is my Son, whom I love; with him I am well pleased. Listen to him!'" (Matt. 17:5; cf. Mark 9:7; Luke 9:35; 2 Pet. 1:17); (3) In predicting His death, Jesus was troubled, and prayed "'Father, glorify your name!' Then a voice came from heaven, 'I have glorified it, and will glorify it again'" (John 12:28).

The Humanity of Jesus

SHEKINAH GLORY

"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God" (John 1:1), then "[t]he Word became [aorist tense, completed action at one point in time] flesh and made his dwelling among us. We have seen his glory [*doxa*], the glory of the one and only Son, who came from the Father, full of grace and truth" (John 1:14). The word "flesh" (*sarx*) here leaves no doubt that Jesus was human. "'Flesh' is a strong, almost crude way of referring to human nature (cf. its use in Rom. 1:3; 8:3; 1 Tim 3:16; 1 John 4:2).... John does not say, 'the Word became man,' nor 'the Word took a body.' He chooses that form of expression which puts what he wants to say most bluntly. It seems probable that he was confronted by opponents of a docetic type"[30] (those who

30. Morris, *John*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament*, 90.

denied Christ's humanity, saying He only appeared to be human). John Calvin's point is worth pondering:

> The word Flesh expresses the meaning of the Evangelist more forcibly than if he had said that he was made man. He intended to show to what a mean and despicable condition the Son of God, on our account, descended from the height of his heavenly glory. When Scripture speaks of man contemptuously, it calls him flesh. Now, though there be so wide a distance between the spiritual glory of the Speech [Calvin's translation of "the Word," or "*logos*" of John 1:1. 14] and the abominable filth of our flesh, yet the Son of God stooped so low as to take upon himself that flesh, subject to so many miseries. The word flesh is not taken here for corrupt nature, (as it is often used by Paul,) but for mortal nature, as in these and similar passages: for he remembered that they were FLESH, (Ps. Lxxviii. 39;) all FLESH is grass, (Isa. Xl. 6.).[31]

What utter condescension: the eternal, infinite Creator became human flesh, a helpless baby, in the battlefield of the cosmic controversy.

Christ's coming to "live for a while among us" (translated by most version as "dwell among us") reminds us of His dwelling in the sanctuary or tabernacle among His people. With reference to that time we read, "the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle" (Exod. 40:34). Leon Morris suggests the Sinai manifestation of glory could also be in John's mind: Many authors see a reference to the Sinai theophany rather than to the setting of the tabernacle. The points of contact with Exodus 33 are especially numerous:

Exodus 33	**John 1**
7 Now Moses used to take the tabernacle	
9 the pillar of cloud (the Shekinah) descended	**14** the Word became flesh and tabernacled among us
10 all the people saw the pillar of cloud	we beheld his glory
11 Yahweh spoke to Moses face to face	**17** the law was given through Moses
20 you cannot see my face	**18** no one has ever seen God
23 you will see my back; but my face shall not be seen	The only begotten Son… has made him known[32]

Paul wrote that the "wages of sin is death" (Rom. 6:23), and the "death he [Christ] died, he died to sin once for all" (Rom. 6:10a). For "God made him who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Cor. 5:21). John was familiar with Paul's epistles when

31. John Calvin, *Harmony of the Gospels*, vol. 17 in *Calvin's Commentaries*, trans. William Pringle (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1989), 2:45.

32. Morris, *John*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament*, 92.

he wrote his Gospel and letters. So John writes, "Everyone who sins breaks the law; in fact, sin is lawlessness. But you know that he [Christ] appeared so that he might take away our sins. And in him is no sin. No one who lives in him keeps on sinning. No one who continues to sin has either seen him or known him" (1 John 3:4–6). John records Christ words, "If you love me, keep my commands" (John 14:15).

On the basis of these texts, it is logical to assert that beholding the glory in Christ (John 1) has a valid connection with seeing the glory of the Lawgiver Christ at Sinai (Exod. 33). Just as Christ came to be close to humans, so He gave the law to keep His followers close to Him, so that they might love God and love their fellow humans (cf. Matt. 22:34–40), and thus reflect Christ's love as a result of a heart-relationship with Him. On another level, it was because of the broken law that the Lawgiver came as the Redeemer to pay the wages of law breaking through His death in place of theirs. It follows that positing a dichotomy between God's gifts of law and grace is no more logical than making a distinction between the Lawgiver and the Redeemer. A proper relationship to Christ's law *and* grace is the goal of salvation's plan. Heaven and the new earth will never know a distinction between law and grace. It is the cosmic controversy that questions both law and grace.

BRIDGING THE GULF

Sin separated the human race from God; a chasm left humankind alone. Yet Christ became human, and came to die, in order to bridge this yawning chasm. Paul describes the Incarnation as a descent from being God to becoming human, and even descending further to death for humans (Phil. 2:5–8): Jesus Christ was "in very nature [*morphē*] God" and so did not "consider equality with God something to be used to his own advantage" (*harpagmon*); but Christ emptied (*ekenōsen*) himself, "taking the very nature [*morphē*] of a servant [*doulou*], being made [*genomenos*] in human likeness [*homoiōmati*]." What is Paul actually saying here?

To say that the pre-existent Christ was in the form of God doesn't mean a mere outward appearance (that would need a different Greek word *schēma;* see 1 Cor. 7:31; 2 Cor. 11:13–15), but means His essential nature was divine. That's why He didn't need to grasp at being God (the aim of the controversy against God) because He was God. The "form of a slave" replaces the "form of God" in that He became essentially human in nature,[33] meaning He lived on earth as a human, not as God. This required a creative act, the incarnation of the Creator-Christ

33. G. Braumann, "*morphē*," in *New Testament Dictionary of New Testament Theology*, 1:705–708.

to become a part of His creation, and to live as a created being like any other human. It should be noted that this replacing of His essential nature, from divine to human, in no way lessened the fact that He was God and Man united together in one Person. The emptying of Himself means He chose not to live as God, even though He was also God; instead, He chose to live as a human because He was also human. In His pre-existence Jesus Christ related to creation as its Creator and ruled over the universe as a part of the Trinity. But in the Incarnation Jesus entered a new relationship: He came to serve, even to be a slave, even to die!

VIRGIN BIRTH

Scripture says Mary "was found to be pregnant through the Holy Spirit" (Matt. 1:18b). An angel spoke to Joseph in a dream, saying, "do not be afraid to take Mary home as your wife, because what is conceived in her is from the Holy Spirit. She will give birth to a son, and you are to give him the name Jesus, because he will save his people from their sins" (Matt. 1:20b–21). Let's take a closer look at Luke's account:

> But the angel said to her, "Do not be afraid, Mary; you have found favor with God. You will conceive and give birth to a son, and you are to call him Jesus. He will be great and will be called the Son of the Most High. The Lord God will give him the throne of his father David, and he will reign over Jacob's descendants forever; his kingdom will never end." "How will this be," Mary asked the angel, "since I am a virgin?" The angel answered, "The Holy Spirit will come on to you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you. So the holy one to be born will be called the Son of God." (Luke 1:30–35)

Paul says, "[W]hen the set time had fully come, God sent his Son, born of a woman, born under law, to redeem those under the law, that we might receive adoption to sonship" (Gal. 4:4–5).

It was the eternal, self-existent second Person of the Trinity who came to planet earth, and was born as a human through Mary by the Holy Spirit. The helpless baby was "God with us" (cf. Isa. 7:14). He was fully God and fully human. This is the greatest miracle and the greatest mystery that confronts human understanding. We attempt to grasp the infinite wisdom of God with finite minds. Like Moses before God in the burning bush, we are on holy ground (Exod. 3:1–6) and need to approach this subject with deep humility and total dependence upon the Holy Spirit to enlighten us.

Christ told His disciples, "I have much more to say to you, more than you can now bear. But when he, the Spirit of truth, comes, he will guide you into all the truth. He will not speak on his own; he will speak only what he hears, and he will tell you what is yet to come. He will glorify me because it is from me that

he will receive what he will make known to you" (John 16:12–14). For the Holy Spirit who brought Jesus Christ to the human race can bring understanding of Jesus Christ to willing human minds. He does this by giving understanding to what He has written about Christ in Scripture. Consider what the Spirit said through Paul, "My goal is that they may be encouraged in heart and united in love, so that they may have the full riches of complete understanding, in order that they may know the mystery of God, namely, Christ, in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" (Col. 2:2–3).[34]

An example of divine revelation about the divinity of Jesus is given in Scripture. Jesus asked His disciples, "'Who do people say the Son of Man is?' They replied, 'Some say John the Baptist, others say Elijah; and still others, Jeremiah or one of the prophets.' 'But what about you?.... Who do you say I am?' Simon Peter answered, 'You are the Messiah, the Son of the living God.' Jesus replied, 'Blessed are you, Simon son of Jonah, for this was not revealed to you by flesh and blood, but by my Father in heaven'" (Matt. 16:13–17). Yet the fact that so many deny the virgin birth should not come as a surprise to us. The Jewish leaders of Christ's time did not recognize Christ as God, nor do liberal theologians today. God said through Paul, "The person without the Spirit does not accept the things that come from the Spirit of God but considers them foolishness, and cannot understand them because they are discerned only through the Spirit" (1 Cor. 2:14). Jesus Himself said, "I praise you, Father, Lord of heaven and earth, because you have hidden these things from the wise and learned, and revealed them to little children" (Matt. 11:25).

We simply cannot deny the Incarnation: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. He was with God in the beginning.... The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us. We have seen his glory, the glory of the one and only Son, who came from the Father, full of grace and truth" (John 1:1–2, 14). The angel Gabriel said to Mary that she would give birth to a son and "He will be great and will be called the Son of the Most High" (Luke 1:32a). She was assured that "[t]he Holy Spirit will come on to you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you. So the holy one to be born will be called the Son of God" (Luke 1:35). Jesus Christ entered the human race as the Son of the Most High, the holy One.

Jesus Christ was God and Man. He wasn't one without the other. His divine nature was the same as it had always been from eternity. He was one with the Father and Spirit. There was no break in their relationship. Only sin brings a

34. Even during His life some people received this discernment. While Christ denounced the unrepentant cities in which most of His miracles had taken place (Matt. 11:20), He thanked His Father for revealing truth about Him to "little children" because it was His good pleasure to do so (Matt. 11:25–27). One such occasion was when Peter declared, "You are the Christ. You are the Son of the living God" because the Father revealed this to Him (Matt. 16:16–17). So the Father and Spirit rejoice to reveal truths about Jesus to those who will receive the same.

broken relationship. "[W]hen Christ came into the world, he said: 'a body you prepared for me.... I have come to do your will, my God'" (Heb. 10:5, 7). Christ came to do His Father's will. Such a mission is the greatest revelation of His oneness with God, of His unbroken relationship with Him. "For God so loved the world that He gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life" (John 3:16). The Father gave (John 3:16), the Son was willing to come (Heb. 10:7), and He was born of the Holy Spirit (Matt. 1:18). All three members of the Trinity participated in the coming of Christ into the world. It was a divine mission to save humans from sin, to bring them abundant, everlasting life.

The title "Son of God" is given to Christ because He was willing to become human. Christ is fully God, being self-existent as the "I am" passages declare. He was not dependent upon the Father or upon the Holy Spirit for His eternal divine existence. He co-existed with them from eternity. He remained God throughout the incarnational process, and was born the God-Man. His deity didn't change; rather, He was God throughout His incarnational life. He is God today and forever.

So what does it mean that He became the Son of Man? This is a crucial question that can only be properly understood if one keeps in mind we are speaking about the One who is also the Son of God. The God-Man is a union of two natures, the divine and the human. He is not two persons. He is God who became also Man. The Holy Spirit, in a miracle beyond human understanding, joined the two natures into one Person.

UNIQUE NATURE

It is the uniqueness of Jesus Christ that must be kept in mind as we grapple with the reality of a divine-human Person, for in the union of two natures we have one God-Man. Jesus Christ was unique in a number of ways: (1) He lived before He was born a human, (2) He had no human father, (3) He was born of the Holy Spirit through a virgin, (4) He was the Son of the Most High, and (5) His birth was supernatural and His life impeccable. He was God with us in human form.

Scripture calls Jesus Christ "only begotten." Etymologically the Greek word *monogenēs* ("only begotten") comes from *ginnomai*, not *gennaō*, which means "to beget." The Greek word *ginnomai* is derived from *genos*, meaning "kind" or "species." Hence *monogenēs* doesn't mean "only begotten" but "one of a kind," "unique," "unparalleled," "incomparable" (John 1:14, 18; 3:16, 18; 1 John 4:9) rather than "sole descent," as in only son of the widow of Nain (Luke 7:12),

only daughter of Jairus (Luke 8:42), only son of his father (Luke 8:42).[35] Abraham's son Isaac was a *monogenēs*, or "unique" son (Heb. 11:17), not the sole son, for Ishmael was the firstborn son; rather, Isaac was the unique son, a miracle son of Isaac, for Israel would come through his line.

"The Word was with God" and "the Word was God" (John 1:1) speaks of the equality (and distinction) between the Word and God. They are co-eternal and co-equal, as members of the Trinity. It was this Word, this God who "became flesh" (*sarx egeneto*); this phrase is in the aorist tense, which means completed action at one point in past time, and so refers to the Incarnation. Christ did not become flesh or a Son sometime in His pre-existence, for that was the time when He was an equal Person in the Trinity as God. There is no hint of eternal Sonship or eternal subordination. The uniqueness of the Incarnation doesn't detract from the equality of the Word with God, for it was this God, the Word, who became also human. It is the God-Man who is unique and who is now referred to as the Son of God, through the mystery and miracle of the Incarnation.

It is important to remember that "We should not read too much into 'only begotten.'... To English ears this sounds like a metaphysical relationship, but the Greek term means no more than 'only,' 'unique.'"[36] I agree with Merrill Tenney's comment on John 1: "Verse 1 states that the Word 'was,' referring to its permanent condition or state, while v. 14 states that the Word 'became' flesh, involving a change in state."[37]

Jesus Christ as the God-Man was not only unique in Himself, but He came with a unique mission: to save humans and reveal God. No one else had done this nor could they do it. Only God has the power to save humans, and He did so as a human. Only God can reveal God, and He did it through being human. He is the only means for human salvation as the only Mediator between God and humans, and He is the only One who can resolve the cosmic controversy by revealing the truth about God. The uniqueness of this Person and the uniqueness of His mission need to be factored into our understanding of His humanity.

SON OF MAN

Christ was eternally divine as God, and was miraculously born into this world through the Holy Spirit, receiving humanity through the Spirit's work in Mary. Credit for Christ's birth rests fully in God's Spirit—Mary was only a willing

35. F. Büchsel, "*monogenēs*," in *Theological Dictionary of the New Testament*, ed. Gerhard Kittel (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1967), 4:737–739. I do not agree that Christ was a begotten Son in His pre-existence (see 741). Rather the Incarnation is a new reality which is better described as unique rather than as "only begotten."

36. Morris, *John*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament*, 93.

37. Tenney, *John*, vol. 9 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary*, 33.

means. Just as our salvation rests fully in Christ, so Christ's birth as a human rests fully in the Holy Spirit.

The angel told Joseph, who would be the husband of Mary: Mary "will give birth to a son, and you are to give him the name Jesus, because he will save his people from their sins" (Matt. 1:21). There is no hint in Scripture that Mary should be honored for participating in saving the world as Roman Catholic dogma teaches.

We need to keep separate the immaculate conception of Mary (her physical birth) and the immaculate conception of Jesus (His physical birth): hers preceding His.

Her Immaculate Conception

Vatican Council II (1962–1965) says: "It is no wonder, then, that the usage prevailed among the holy Fathers whereby they called the mother of God entirely holy and free from all stain of sin, fashioned by the Holy Spirit into a kind of new substance and new creature. Adorned from the first instant of her conception with the splendors of an entirely unique holiness...."[38]

Another Catholic source says:

> The Immaculate Conception means that Mary, whose conception was brought about the normal way, was conceived without original sin or its stain—that's what "immaculate" means: without stain. The essence of original sin consists in the deprivation of sanctifying grace, and its stain is a corrupt nature. Mary was preserved from these defects by God's grace; from the first instant of her existence she was in the state of sanctifying grace and was free from the corrupt nature original sin brings.[39]

The latest Catholic Catechism says that, "By the grace of God Mary remained free of every personal sin her whole life long."[40]

His Immaculate Conception

God was eternally immaculate. The angel told Mary, "The Holy Spirit will come on you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you. So the holy one to be born will be called the Son of God" (Luke 1:35). Mary is not the mother of God, for Christ is the Son of God. Theology needs to give credit to God and not undue credit to Mary. Christ was already the holy one before leaving heaven. She added nothing to His holiness. According to Roman Catholic theology, the conception of Christ "did not diminish his mother's virginal integrity but sanctified it."[41]

38. *The Documents of Vatican II* (London: Geoffrey Chapman, 1967), 88 (1.1.56).

39. "Immaculate Conception and Assumption," accessed August 13, 2012, http://www.catholic.com/tracts/immaculate-conception-and-assumption.

40. *Catechism of the Catholic Church* (Liguori, MO: Liguori Publications, 1994), 124 (493).

41. Ibid., 126 (499).

It seems from the above quotes that Mary was saved from her birth. She had no sin, so it was her sinless being that was sanctified by Christ in His coming to Mary (whatever that means). This is a human idea brought to Scripture, and is contrary to Scripture. For all humans have sinned (Rom 3:23), and the "all" includes Mary. That's why "no one" comes to the Father except through Christ (John 14:6b), and that includes Mary. Catholic theology claims that Mary didn't need a Savior, but Mary declares the opposite: "My soul glorifies the Lord and my spirit rejoices in God my Savior" (Luke 1:46b–47). Even though the Greek words *sōtēr* can mean "healer" or "Savior," the hermeneutical principle requires that the context decides which meaning is intended. The biblical context favors "Savior," and the following versions translate the word *sōtēr* as "Savior" (ESV, NKJV, old and new NIV, NASB, NEB, RSV, PHILLIPS, and GOODSPEED). Note that Mary is not just talking about a Savior for her people, or for the world, but emphasizes "my Savior." As Lenski says, "'Savior' is the key to Mary's song, and by this one word she reveals most clearly that she understands God's plan regarding her great son."[42] So the Catholic teaching of the immaculate conception does not make a biblical contribution to our study.

Let us turn now to Christ Himself. The author of Hebrews said that Christ is the One "through whom he made the universe."[43] "The Son is the radiance of God's glory and the exact representation of his being, sustaining all things by his powerful word" (Heb. 1:3a). In other words, Christ was exactly like God the Father. Isaiah was given a vision of God, which is how the Son must have been prior to His incarnation:

> I saw the Lord, high and exalted, seated on a throne; and the train of his robe filled the temple. Above him were seraphim, each with six wings: With two wings they covered their faces, with two they covered their feet, and with two they were flying. And they were calling to one another: "Holy, holy, holy is the LORD Almighty; the whole earth is full of his glory." At the sound of their voices the doorposts and thresholds shook and the temple was filled with smoke. "Woe to me!" I cried. "I am ruined! For I am a man of unclean lips, and I live among a people of unclean lips, and my eyes have seen the King, the LORD Almighty." (Isa. 6:1–5)

42. R. C. H. Lenski, *The Interpretation of St. Luke's Gospel* (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg Publishing House, 1946), 85.

43. Christ created many worlds (*tous aiōnas*, plural, Heb. 1:2, translated "worlds" in KJV and NKJV and "universe" in PHILIPS and NIV). The English word "universe" translates two other Greek words, *ta panta* "all things" (Col. 1:16) and *tō kosmō* "the cosmos" (1 Cor. 4:9), but the context in both texts limits the universe to heaven (angels) and earth (humans). The universe seems to go beyond angels and humans in the language of "sons of God": (1) Adam is called "the son of God" in the Lucan genealogy of Jesus (Luke 3:37b). (2) In the Hebrew language it says "the sons of God" (plural) convene in a meeting in heaven (Job 1:6a and 2:1). (3) Satan attends this meeting coming from this world (Job 1:6b–7; 2:1b–2), indicating that these "sons of God" are leaders of different worlds (Satan replaced Adam as leader of this world through the Fall). Because God is eternal, there could be a vast number of worlds throughout space.

It was an amazing condescension for such an awesome God to come to a rebel planet where He was hated, hunted, despised, and rejected. He left heaven and entered hell. He came to the war zone where He was the enemy. He had no throne, no possessions, nowhere to lay His head. As the Son of Man, Jesus left the throne of heaven and was born in a cattle barn. He left the palace for a stable. He left the riches of heaven and entered the human race at the poverty level. He left absolute power and became a helpless babe. No one ever came down so far simply to embrace a mission fraught with such peril.

Of the incarnate Christ Scripture says, "He had no beauty or majesty to attract us to him, nothing in his appearance that we should desire him" (Isa. 53:2). He was ordinary in looks. From the awesome dignity of majesty, He became a very ordinary-looking baby. He left the devoted worship of heavenly angels and came to a world where even His own people (Jews) received Him not (John 1:11). Giver of all joy, He came to suffer. He was falsely accused as a glutton and a drunkard (Matt. 11:19), laughed at (Luke 8:53), mocked and beaten, and "many insulting things" were shouted at Him (Luke 22:63–65). Source of all life, He came to die, to bring immortality to humans at the Second Advent (1 Cor. 15:53).

SECOND ADAM

Adam and Christ are compared in Scripture: "The first man Adam became a living being; the last Adam, a life-giving spirit" (1 Cor. 15:45). Paul explains, "For since death came through a man, the resurrection of the dead comes also through a man. For as in Adam all die, so in Christ all will be made alive" (1 Cor. 15:21–22). Paul adds,

> For if by the trespass of the one man, death reigned through that one man, how much more will those who receive God's abundant provision of grace and of the gift of righteousness reign in life through the one man, Jesus Christ! Consequently, just as one trespass resulted in condemnation for all people, so also one righteous act resulted in justification and life for all people. For just as through the disobedience of the one man the many were made sinners, so also through the obedience of the one man the many will be made righteous. (Rom. 5:17–19)

The sin problem on planet earth began through Eve, but as the head of humanity, Adam was the one whose capitulation affected the race. Adam's sin is passed on through his children so that each is born with a sinful nature. In other words, all humans are born with a propensity to sin because all humans inherit a sinful nature due to the first sin of Adam. Rather, it means that each person is born with the need for salvation before they ever sin, for sin is more than an act—it is a nature. This is why "death reigned from the time of Adam" (Rom. 5:14a), for it was Adam's sin that "brought condemnation" (Rom. 5:16).

In other words, "by the trespass of the one man, death reigned through that one man" (Rom. 5:17a).

This is why we carefully looked at the issue of sin and the Fall in chapter 2. Since sin is more than an act, Christ didn't come to save humans only from sinning, but from sinful natures too. (It would be good to reread those pages, for one needs to grasp the nature of sin to comprehend the mission of Christ and understand the nature of Christ as a human.)

The consequence of sin is death. The one act of sin brought death to all humans, whereas the one act of Christ's death brought life to all humans who will accept the gift (John 3:16). Both Adams gift the race, one with death and the other with life. Both gifts are eternal. Humans would die forever if Christ had not paid sin's wages and set His followers free to live forever.

INCARNATIONAL NATURE

Jesus Christ crossed the sin-caused chasm between God and humans. The Son of God reached out from the inner relationship of the Trinity to come to humanity. Like a mighty bridge, He spanned the space separating the eternal God and rebel humans (that space is caused by sin even though God is omnipresent). Even as He became incarnate on earth, He remained the sinless God.[44] He did not change in His mission to save sinners. He remained sinless through the incarnational process (He did not need an immaculate mother any more than He needed humans to help Him save humans). No human, not even His own earthly mother, has anything to contribute to God's gift of salvation.

The New Testament is clear that Christ was sinless. Gabriel told Mary that "the holy one to be born will be called the Son of God" (Luke 1:35b). No other woman has given birth to a holy baby, who is the Son of God. Christ became human to do His Father's will (Heb. 10:5–7). Near the end of His life, Jesus said, "I have kept my Father's commands and remain in his love" (John 15:10). In His prayer to the Father, Jesus said, "I have brought you glory on earth by finishing the work you gave me to do" (John 17:4). Peter said to Jesus, "you are the Holy One of God" (John 6:69b). Peter's epistle referred to Isaiah 53:9, stating that Christ "committed no sin, and no deceit was found in his mouth" (1 Pet. 2:22). The writer of the Epistle to the Hebrews states that Jesus "has been tempted in every way, just as we are—yet he did not sin" (Heb. 4:15b). Paul says that Christ "had no sin" (2 Cor.

44. No human language is adequate to describe how an omnipresent Christ became localized in Mary, and then in His own humanity, in the Incarnation. So the language of "space" and "descent" is the best to describe the condescension involved in the Incarnation (cf. Phil. 2:5–11). We are dealing with a miracle that so transcends human understanding that it is like attempting to describe the Theories of Relativity to an ant.

5:21a), and John said Christ came "so that he might take away our sins. And in him is no sin" (1 John 3:5).

LIKENESS OF SINFUL FLESH

In his 1991 book *The Word Became Flesh*, Millard J. Erickson evaluates all the current theories on the incarnation of Christ. He deals with questions about the divinity of Christ, yet there is no comparable focus on His humanity. Erickson explains why: "The reason the humanity of Jesus, for example, does not receive separate treatment is that it is not an issue severely contested in contemporary Christology; for that matter, it is not contested at all."[45] There is general agreement that the Son of God did become also the Son of Man. But what did *becoming Man* mean? In other words, what kind of humanity did Christ assume? Was it a sinless nature as Schleiermacher (1768–1834) argues,[46] or a sinful nature as Barth (1886–1968) contends.[47] To answer these questions, we will consider whether Christ's humanity was like or unlike ours.

Christ's Humanity Like Ours

The first view considers that Christ was born in the "likeness of sinful flesh" (Rom. 8:3). To them this text means Christ's humanity was identical with ours. He was born with all the typical human hereditary tendencies and propensities. The only difference is He never yielded to those drives, whereas we do. So in nature He was like us, but in performance in that nature He was unlike us. In this way, Christ showed us a valid example to follow: We too can overcome as He overcame. This view has been called the post-Fall view, because Christ took the nature of Adam after the Fall. Traditional theology (Athanasius) taught that Christ had to assume fallen human nature in order to heal it. This refers to an internal healing, within Jesus Christ, where the divine nature heals the fallen human nature. Such a healing doesn't require Christ's crucifixion to save humans. In contemporary times, this Christology is articulated by Karl Barth and T. F. Torrance.

Christ's Humanity Unlike Ours

The second view also considers that Christ was born in the "likeness of sinful flesh" (Rom. 8:3), but Christ's humanity was only *like* ours, rather than the same as ours. He was born without the hereditary tendencies and propensities that we receive. His human struggle was not over internal propensities

45. Millard J. Erickson, *The Word Became Flesh* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1991), 14.

46. Friedrich Schleiermacher, *Christian Faith*, ed. H. R. Mackintosh and J. S. Stewart (Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1999, Ger. ed. 1830), 413–417 (98).

47. Karl Barth, *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, vol. 4, pt. 2 in *Church Dogmatics* (Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1958), 481; 92.

but internal divinity. His difference from us rather than sameness to us made the struggle genuine. His struggle was to remain on the level of helpless humanity when He was the omnipotent God. His overcoming made Him a valid example of submission for us to follow. This view has been called the pre-Fall view, because Christ took the nature of Adam before the Fall.

The meaning of the terms *pre-Fall* and *post-Fall* represent the omission or inclusion of the propensities and drives caused as a result of the fall of Adam. It is more correct to say that Christ's human nature possessed aspects of both the pre-Fall and post-Fall human nature. His nature was therefore both like and unlike ours. Or as Raoul Dederen puts it, "His humanity did not correspond to Adam's humanity before the Fall, nor in every respect to Adam's humanity after the Fall."[48] Christ was like us in every way except for sin. He "came from the Father, full of grace and truth" (John 1:14b), that "holy one" (Luke 1:35), "in him is no sin" (1 John 3:5), He "had no sin" (2 Cor. 5:21), and He "committed no sin" (1 Pet. 2:22a).

Christ's Humanity Like and Unlike Ours

This view can be represented as follows:

ADAM

CHRIST

US

The three levels are important. Adam is at the level of pre-Fall human nature, while Christ is positioned below that level because He received the "innocent infirmities" (human limitations except sin) from the fall of Adam. But Christ is placed above the level that we occupy because He did not receive the evil propensities from the fall of Adam that the rest of us receive. Therefore Christ is neither like the pre-Fall Adam nor like the post-Fall human race. He occupies a place between the two. This is why it is correct to say that He received some of the post-Fall nature (innocent infirmities), but not the full post-Fall nature (sinful propensities). He received the weakness but not the wickedness from the fall. He was deprived but not depraved.

Christ's Birth Like Our New Birth?

Another view has been presented as mediating between the so called pre-Fall and post-Fall views. This view suggests that Christ's birth in Bethlehem was equivalent to our new birth, in that both are the work of the Holy Spirit. In other words,

48. Raoul Dederen, "Christ: His Person and Work," in *Handbook of Seventh-day Adventist Theology*, vol. 12 in *Commentary Reference Series* (Hagerstown, MD: Review and Herald, 2000), 164.

Christ began in Bethlehem where Christians begin in their new birth. The physical birth of Jesus was like our spiritual new birth. Just as Christ overcame from His birth onward, so we can overcome from our new birth onward. But there is a difference between these two births: Christ was eternally One with His Father, whose will He came to obey in the Incarnation (Heb. 10:5–7), so obedience preceded Christ's birth. By contrast, disobedience precedes our new birth. Christ came without any record of sin in His birth, whereas only sinners are born again. We conclude, therefore, that these two births are not equivalent, even though the Holy Spirit is operative in both. In the birth of Christ the Holy Spirit is creatively present in a way that is unique, and which is never duplicated in the new birth.

PRE-FALL OR POST-FALL?

Above we noted that although Christ is the second Adam, He is not to be identified fully with either the pre-Fall or post-Fall views of human nature. We need to unpack that further. Whereas the first Adam sinned, the second Adam didn't sin. So where Adam failed, the second Adam succeeded. In so doing He won the right to become the new leader of the human race. The pre-Fall Adam had a sinless life, so did Christ, and in this respect they are the same. But there's a difference: Whereas Adam had a human nature free from the consequences of sin, Christ took upon Himself a human nature that was weakened by the long heredity of sin, even though He did not actually sin. In other words, the first Adam was created by the pre-incarnate Christ as a sinless human in the image of God. But as God became the second Adam, He entered human creation and assumed human nature with its damaged image of God, even though He did not take its depravity.

So in human nature, Christ was unlike the pre-Fall Adam and unlike the post-Fall Adam, even though there are similarities. Unlike the post-Fall Adam, Christ was the sinless Son of God on a mission to save sinners (their sinful natures and acts), and did not participate in sin, either in nature or acts. A doctor does not need to have cancer in order to save cancer patients. Nor does a sinless Son of God need to take on sin within His nature in order to save a sinful nature. For sin, whether in nature or acts, participates in a broken relationship with God. Christ didn't come to enter such a broken relationship but to restore it.

This means the phrase *the unassumed is unredeemed* (taught by Eastern theology from Athanasius onward) doesn't do justice to the uniqueness of the humanity of Jesus. If Christ assumed a sinful nature, how could He be a sinless Savior? We must be guided by the Son of God's reason for crossing the chasm between sinless God and sinful humanity. He came to save humans. He didn't cross the chasm to become a part of the sin problem—but to solve it.

This leads us to a hermeneutical principle: God's mission must determine the extent of His identity with fallen human nature. Getting tired, needing sleep, getting hungry, and so on were not problems for the pre-Fall Adam, but they were for the post-Fall Adam. Sin in nature and acts was a problem for the first Adam, but not for the second Adam.

Here's the bottom line: The Son of God did not break His relationship with God and humans in order to restore a broken relationship between God and humans. His mission was to restore and re-create the image of God in humanity, not to lose the image of God Himself. He identified with fallen human nature in every way except in sin in nature and life. He came to save humans from their sinful nature and sinful acts, and to do so He was necessarily sinless in nature and in acts.

Therefore, Christ says about Satan, "the prince of this world cometh, and hath nothing in me" (John 14:30b, KJV, NKJV, NASB). These translations are true to the Greek "has nothing in me" (*en emoi ouk echei ouden*), and penetrate to the inner reality, whereas "no power over me" (RSV), "no hold over me" (NIV), or "no rights over me" (NEB) speak of the consequences of Satan's having "nothing in me." No wonder John writes that Christ "appeared so that he might take away our sins. And in him is no sin" (1 John 3:5). This verse speaks of Christ's sinless nature in His mission to save humans from their sinful natures, for sin issues out of a nature of sin, the nature in which every human is born since the Fall.

The Bible places no saving value on our first birth. Christ clearly stated to Nicodemus, "Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God" (John 3:3, KJV). Jesus alone did not need the new birth—which says that something about His birth puts Him in a class by Himself. Just as all other humans need the new birth, so the saved will have their corruptible natures changed to incorruptible natures in the resurrection (1 Cor. 15). Yet no biblical verse speaks of Christ's need for either the new birth or a change of nature at His resurrection.

Incarnational Mission

Christ didn't come to this world to have a vacation; He came at enormous cost to save a lost world. If He hadn't come, no human could be redeemed. He came on a long, lonely journey to do for humans what they cannot do for themselves. He came also for an on-looking universe, to reveal to created beings in this world and beyond what God is like, and forever prove that the cosmic charge against God is false. He wanted all intelligent created beings to see Satan exposed for what he is, and God revealed for who He is.

Furthermore, Christ didn't come just to be head of the church, but, as John Wesley put it, to be "Head of mankind."[49] And we might add Christ didn't come just to reconcile the elect, for "in Christ [*en christō*] God was reconciling the world [*katallassōn kosmon*] to himself" (2 Cor. 5:19a, ESV). The writer of Hebrews says he tasted "death for everyone" (Heb. 2:9), so redemption was provided for every human, even though most turn it down. For God's love is inclusive, not exclusive. It is humans who exclude His love from their lives, and with sadness He allows them the freedom to do so, for true love respects the desires of others, even though it must hurt God far more than we will ever understand. Just as Adam was the representative of the race, so Christ as the second Adam is representative of the race (Rom. 5:17–19; 1 Cor. 15:22).

TO REVEAL GOD

The integrity of God is on the line in the cosmic controversy. What would convince rebels that the Law-Giver is not to be blamed for the breaking of His law? This is an issue that God needs to solve. He can do it through Christians who love Him and keep His commandments (John 14:15), but even the best have sinned and fall short of the glory of God (Rom. 3:23). Which means that there is only one fool-proof demonstration: allow Jesus to come as a human to planet earth, and live the life of a human, not keeping God's law through His internal divine power, but through relying upon the same external divine power available to any other human. The Son of Man proved that God's law can be kept, and in so doing showed that God is just to have such commandments (which means there is no excuse for law breaking). Through His sinless life, the Son of Man revealed the Father.

The name of God represents His character, so when Christ said to the Father, "I have manifested your name" (*onoma*; John 17:6a, NKJV), He was saying "I have revealed you" (John 17:6a, NIV).[50] The glory of God represents His character: "[I]t is the God who commanded light to shine out of darkness, who has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory [*doxa*, character] of God in the face of Jesus Christ" (2 Cor. 4:6, NKJV). "And we know that the Son of God has come and has given us an understanding, that we may know Him who is true.... This is the true God" (1 John 5:20, NKJV). Jesus said, "Anyone who has seen me has seen the Father" (John 14:9b).

49. John Wesley, *The Works of John Wesley* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1998), 5:55.

50. The same idea about *name* representing *character* is found in the following text: "to all who received him, to those who believed in his name [character], he gave the right to become children of God" (John 1:12).

TO EXPERIENCE HUMAN LIFE

Did Christ come to live a human life only to reveal the truth about His Father with respect to the cosmic controversy? Or did He also come to live a human life to understand human living? And if He came to live a human life to understand human living, why did He need to do this? Doesn't an all-knowing God know what it is like to live a human life without doing it? Are there biblical principles and passages that answer these questions?

It is granted that the pre-existent and self-existent Christ was fully God, co-equal and co-eternal with the Father and Spirit in the Trinity. As such they equally share in the absolute authority and power that is resident in the Godhead. After creating intelligent beings, it was a part of being God to give orders (in love) and be obeyed. After rebellion entered the universe, rebels would naturally say that it is the authority of God—His willingness to give orders—that poses a problem for intelligent created beings. Rebels would say that God doesn't know what it is like to live as a created being. This is another way of saying He is out of touch with those He created (that's one reason why Deism—a distant God—is such an inadequate view of God).

Similarly, classical theology didn't help with its view of an aloof God—a God who is immutable, impassible, removed beyond creation. After all, how can a timeless, unchangeable God, who exists in pure simultaneity, understand the changes involved in the give-and-take of the temporal realm?

In reality, God came down to live as a human, in order to know firsthand (existentially) what He knew intellectually (from observing humans). The Incarnation means He entered into human living personally, and from His own experience learned what it is like to live as a human. He had a human birth, had to grow up like any other human, and along the way "he learned obedience from what he suffered" (Heb. 5:8). Christ was "made like them [his brothers] fully human in every way, in order that he might become a merciful and faithful high priest in service to God" (Heb. 2:17). "Because he himself suffered when he was tempted, he is able to help those who are being tempted" (Heb. 2:18). "For we do not have a high priest who is unable to empathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who has been tempted in every way, just as we are—yet he did not sin. Let us then approach God's throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need" (Heb. 4:15–16).

So Christ lived a temporal life in order to help those who do the same. No timeless deity, frozen in simultaneity, could ever live a human life. No immutable God could learn obedience and be tempted, let alone die for humans. No impassible God could sympathize with human suffering in order to minister

out of His human experience. Jesus really lived a human life, as is proved by His need of power from beyond Himself, making His prayer life a necessity.

When in the inner history of the Trinity, the Second Person had never had to pray for help. But during His human life on earth, on the battleground of the enemy, prayer was His lifeline for survival. "Jesus often withdrew to lonely places and prayed" (Luke 5:16), and "One of those days Jesus went out to a mountainside to pray, and spent the night praying to God" (Luke 6:12). He pled with His Father to take the cup in Gethsemane, yet prayed that not His will be done, but the will of His Father (Luke 22:39–46). He clung to His Father in utter dependence. Irenaeus (120–202) said some allege that "Christ remained impassible" while "it was Jesus who suffered"[51] as if there was dualism within the God-Man, which is contrary to Christ's total dependence as the God-Man.

No wonder Christ said, "By myself I can do nothing; I judge only as I hear, and my judgment is just, for I seek not to please myself but him who sent me" (John 5:30, cf. v. 65); for "I do nothing on my own but speak just what the Father has taught me" (John 8:28b), for "These words you hear are not my own; they belong to the Father who sent me" (John 14:24b); and "No one can come to me unless the Father who sent me draws them" (John 6:44a). His temptations in the wilderness were preceded by forty days of communing with His Father while fasting, and He quoted Scripture to overcome the devil (Matt. 4:1–11).

During His entire life Jesus developed a sinless human character which He offers to humans as their righteousness, as if they had lived that life. This is likened to a garment of righteousness that covers humans who repent and desire to receive it, and was typified by the skins of the lambs slain for Adam and Eve that covered their nakedness. It was the pre-incarnate Christ as Creator of Adam and Eve who provided the covering for these first sinners (Gen. 3:21). These are the wedding garments that the Bride of Christ needs to wear to get into the wedding supper of the Lamb in heaven (Matt. 22:3–14). Christians need the "white clothes" (Rev. 3:18).

Further, those who receive Christ's righteousness, through receiving Christ, will demonstrate works of righteousness (Rev. 19:7–8). Righteous works (*dikaiōmata*) are not the same as righteous character (*dikaiosunē*), rather *dikaiosunē* is what one hungers and thirsts for (Matt. 5:6), and the reception of it enables one to be "declared righteous" (Rom. 3:20). Righteous works are the fruit of a righteous character gifted through the righteousness of Christ.

51. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies, The Anti-Nicene Fathers* (Edinburgh: T&T Clark; Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1989), 1:428 (3.11.7); cf. Jesus as receptacle for Christ, *The Anti-Nicene Fathers* 1:440 (3.16.1), "Jesus Christ suffered for us," *The Anti-Nicene Fathers* 1:446–449 (3.18.1–3.19.3).

Christ lived and died as a human in order to minister in heaven's sanctuary, to meet human needs. It was on the basis of His death and His life that He gave humans what they needed. He died to pay the price for human sins, and He lived a human life to enable Him to sympathize with humans in their struggle and to provide a garment of a righteous life to cover their sins.

TO BE AN EXAMPLE TO HUMANS

Although Christ's followers are a "new creation" (2 Cor. 5:17), being fitted for heaven (2 Cor. 3:18), they still exist in a corruptible nature until the second advent of Christ (1 Cor. 15:50–54), and so Christ gifts them His sinless life as well as a His substitutionary death. For Christ is "our righteousness, holiness and redemption" (1 Cor. 1:30). Christ lived His obedient human life, doing His Father's will, as an example for humans to follow. Nearing His crucifixion, Christ said that the enemy had no hold on him, "but he comes so that the world may learn that I love the Father and do exactly what my Father has commanded me" (John 14:31). This is why Christ can say of those who follow His example: "Whoever has my commands and keeps them is the one who loves me. The one who loves me will be loved by my Father, and I too will love them and show myself to them" (John 14:21).

This is not legalism or bondage. It is a covenant experience with God. Jude captures this experience in his doxology: "To him who is able to keep you from stumbling and to present you before his glorious presence without fault and with great joy—to the only God our Savior be glory, majesty, power and authority, through Jesus Christ our Lord, before all ages, now and forevermore! Amen" (Jude 24–25). Christ's power saves humans from sin, keeping them from falling, and does so with great joy. David said to God, "I delight in your commands because I love them" (Ps. 119:47), and "I have set the LORD always before me; Because He is at my right hand I shall not be moved.... You will show me the path of life; In your presence *is* fullness of joy; At your right hand *are* pleasures forevermore" (Ps. 16:8–11, NKJV). Obedience is not Jewish legalism, for we are speaking about "the perfect law that gives freedom" (Jas. 1:25a).

Calvary means God hates sin so much that its wages must be paid. Although Christ was willing to do His Father's will, and become a substitutionary sacrifice for humans, all the members of the Trinity hated the sin that caused them to suffer at Calvary. Followers of Christ must hate sin because of what it does to Christ and to the Trinity, and because they love God and His law. "But if anybody does sin, we have an advocate with the Father—Jesus Christ, the Righteous One. He is the atoning sacrifice for our sins, and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world" (1 John 2:1–2).

TO DIE FOR HUMANS

We need the life and death of Jesus Christ to get us to heaven. But how can God die? God alone has immortality (1 Tim. 6:16), for He never had a beginning nor can He die. The Son of God, or the divine nature in Jesus Christ, was not born in the Incarnation. He had eternally self-existed as God in the Trinity. He was not dependent upon anyone for life. In the Incarnation He became also the Son of Man, who could die. Paul says, "For what the law was powerless to do because it was weakened by the flesh, God did by sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh to be a sin offering" (Rom. 8:3, NIV; "as a sin offering," NASB, GOODSPEED). Although the word "offering" is not in the Greek text, it can be implied. Another rendering is "sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh, and for sin, he condemned sin in the flesh" (RSV, KJV, NKJV).

Both translations above are true to the author's intent, for the Son of God became also the Son of Man so that He could die. Athanasius (293–373) put it succinctly, "He takes to Himself a body capable of death."[52] In His death He condemned sin in the flesh.

TO DEFEAT THE DEVIL

Scripture states, "The reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the devil's work" (1 John 3:8b). The author of Hebrews concurs, saying, "he too shared in their humanity so that by his death he might break the power of him who holds the power of death" (Heb. 2:14; this text also recognizes that Jesus had to be human in order to die). The cosmic controversy attack on God brought a severance of some angelic and all human beings from God. We call this severance sin. Sin is a broken relationship, and it was the mission of Jesus Christ to restore the broken relationship, thereby redeeming all willing humans, and resolving the conflict for all intelligent beings. Properly understood, the redeeming-resolving work of Jesus Christ restores the universe to its pre-Fall state.

Christ's cosmic mission is articulated by Paul: "For God was pleased to have all his fullness dwell in him [Christ], and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether things on earth or things in heaven, by making peace through his blood, shed on the cross" (Col. 1:19–20). Christ's crucifixion and mission impact Christians who enter into a heart-relationship with Christ, for the covenant mission is not only global (Matt. 28:20–21) but also cosmic: "His intent was that now, through the church, the manifold wisdom of God should be made known to the rulers and authorities in the heavenly realms [*tais exousiais*

52. Athanasius, *De Incarnatione Verbi Dei, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series (Edinburgh: T&T Clark; Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1987), 4:40 (#9).

en tois epouraniois, plural], according to his eternal purpose that he accomplished in Christ Jesus our Lord" (Eph. 3:10–11).

The heavenly realms (plural) seem to go beyond heaven (singular) where angels live. A cosmic emphasis in Ephesians 3:10 is mentioned by Andrew Lincoln[53] and Francis Foulkes.[54] Walter Liefeld says rulers and authorities may be "all the unseen powers, good and evil" yet offers a caveat that they may only be all the evil powers.[55] It is probably fair to say that these commentators don't envisage multiple worlds as part of the cosmos, but we do know of unfallen angels. Nothing is said in Scripture about other inhabited worlds for the focus is on the redemption of this one fallen world. Nevertheless, for those who believe there could be other unfallen worlds, they would also be included in the revelation made by Christ in this world.

It is clear from the references above (Col. 1, Eph. 3) that Christ's mission was/is more than the redemption of planet earth, for this is only a part of the reconciling of all things "whether things on earth or things in heaven" involving "rulers and authorities in heavenly realms." Here is a redemption-reconciliation ministry that has everything to do with resolving the cosmic controversy, in order to restore the universe to its pre-controversy state.

TO BE A SINLESS SUBSTITUTE

The mission of Christ determines the extent of His identity with human nature. It is agreed that Christ could never be our Savior from sin if He Himself had sinned. Likewise He had to be free from sin in His nature (not just external acts) in order to save humans from their sinful natures. To fully understand this, we must penetrate to the root cause of sin. Prior to the acts of sin there is a cause of those sinful acts.

As we studied in the doctrine regarding humans in chapter 2, foundationally sin is a broken relationship with God. It is this broken relationship that leads to law breaking. So behind sinful acts, behind a sinful nature, we find a broken relationship. It is the broken relationship between God and humans that is the chasm Christ crossed, not to enter the broken relationship Himself, but to bridge the gap, to join divinity and humanity within Himself, and then in His life, death, and post-resurrection ministry to save humans so that they might be fit to belong to a sinless society, on God's side of the chasm.

53. Andrew T. Lincoln, *Ephesians*, vol. 42 in *Word Biblical Commentary*, ed. David A. Hubbard and Glenn W. Barker (Dallas, TX: Word, 1990), 188–189.

54. Francis Foulkes, *Ephesians*, vol. 10 in *Tyndale New Testament Commentaries* (Leicester, England: InterVarsity, 1988, 1st ed. 1956), 98–99.

55. Walter L. Liefeld, *The IVP New Testament Commentary Series: Ephesians*, ed. Grant R. Osborne (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1997), 86.

Just as the first Adam broke the relationship with God, the second Adam restored the relationship with God and humans within His own incarnational nature. He united God and humans within Himself. But that was only a beginning. Christ's mission was more than becoming incarnate as the God-Man. His mission included His subsequent life, death, resurrection, high priestly ministry in heaven, His second advent, and the final judgment. It reaches from the first advent to the third advent after the Millennium, and each segment of His saving ministry deserves to be understood in its own right, in its relationship to Calvary, and in its relationship to the entire mission of Christ.

In the next segments, we will penetrate deeper into the life and death of Jesus Christ, and attempt to grasp some of what He went through to save humans.

Incarnational Message

KINGDOM OF HEAVEN IS NEAR

There is an eschatological future focus in the teaching of Jesus, and it began with His forerunner John the Baptist proclaiming "the kingdom of heaven has come near" (Matt. 3:2). Satan knew that these words pointed to the coming Kingdom, and so he tempted Jesus to distract Him from that future. Satan "showed him all the kingdoms of the world and their splendor" and said he would give them to Christ in that moment if He would "bow down and worship" Satan (Matt. 4:8–9). Here was an alleged way to avoid the Cross, and still save the kingdoms of the world. But it was a false promise, for the kingdom of heaven cannot be restored by worshiping the one who brought rebellion into the kingdom of heaven.

The kingdom of heaven can only be restored by the God-Man who remains loyal to the kingdom of heaven and does God's will as a dependent human. Christ depended on the Word of God and didn't yield (see Matt. 4:3–4 [Deut. 8:3]; Matt. 4:6–7 [Deut. 6:16]; Matt. 4:9–10 [Deut. 6:13]. After the Baptist was put in prison, "Jesus began to preach, 'Repent, for the kingdom of heaven has come near'" (Matt. 4:17; cf. Mark 1:15), the same message declared by the Baptist. Jesus said that ever since the days of the Baptist "the kingdom of heaven has been [forcefully advancing]" (Matt. 11:12). Christ refers to the kingdom of heaven five times in the beatitudes. He said the kingdom of heaven is for the poor in spirit (5:3), for the persecuted (5:10), and for those who have a proper relationship to God's law (5:19–20)—qualities reflecting Christ and not Satan.

Christ invited people to "seek first" the heavenly Father's kingdom (Matt. 6:33a), which means to seek to do the Father's will even as Jesus did His will

(Heb. 10:7). For "Not everyone who says to me, 'Lord, Lord,' will enter the kingdom of heaven, but only the one who does the will of my Father who is in heaven" (Matt. 7:21). In response to the Gentile centurion's faith (compared to the Jews' lack of faith), Jesus said, "I say to you that many will come from the east and the west, and will take their places at the feast with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob in the kingdom of heaven. But the subjects of the kingdom will be thrown outside, into the darkness, where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth" (Matt. 8:11–12). Christ declared that those who become humble like little children will enter the kingdom of heaven (Matt. 18:2–5, cf. 19:14).

Giving to the poor is a way to store up treasure in the coming kingdom (Matt. 19:21b), but it is hard for a rich man to enter the kingdom (Matt. 19:24b). The kingdom of heaven's wages are the same for all workers, no matter when they entered the employ of the Owner (Matt. 20:1–16). To the chief priests and elders, Christ said, "the tax collectors and the prostitutes are entering the kingdom of God ahead of you" (Matt. 21:31b). The king sends out invitations to the wedding banquet of the kingdom, but few respond (Matt. 22:1–14). Teachers of the law and Pharisees "shut the door of the kingdom of heaven in people's faces" but will not enter themselves (Matt. 23:13–14).

At the Last Supper Jesus said, "I tell you I will not drink again from the fruit of the vine until the kingdom of God comes" (Luke 22:18; cf. Mark 14:24b), which points to the eschatological future when Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and all the prophets are "in the kingdom of God" together with many others (Gentiles) who "will take their places at the feast in the kingdom of God" (Luke 13:29). Jesus too spoke of His second coming (Matt. 24:3, 29–31; Mark 8:38b; 13:26–27; 14:62).

KINGDOM OF HEAVEN HAS ARRIVED

Jesus went to all villages and towns "teaching in their synagogues, proclaiming the good news of the kingdom and healing every disease and sickness" (Matt. 9:35). As a teacher, preacher, and healer, Jesus ministered to the total needs of humans, in a work of restoration that reflected in history what the coming Kingdom will be like. To this extent the Kingdom arrived in history as a revelation and anticipation of its final coming. Jesus commissioned the twelve to "go to the lost sheep of Israel…preaching 'The kingdom of heaven has come near.' Heal the sick, raise the dead, cleanse those who have leprosy, drive out demons. Freely you have received: freely give" (Matt. 10:6–8).

Christ offered this invitation: "Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For my

yoke is easy and my burden is light" (Matt. 11:28–30). Here is the essence of the kingdom of heaven—resting in Jesus. When the Pharisees plotted to kill Him for healing on the Sabbath, He quietly withdrew. But many followed Him, and "he healed all their sick" (Matt. 12:1–15). Christ's Father spoke through Isaiah about this Jesus who would announce the Kingdom by word and deed:

> Here is my servant whom I have chosen, the one I love, in whom I delight; I will put my Spirit on him, and he will proclaim justice to the nations. He will not quarrel or cry out; no one will hear his voice in the streets. A bruised reed he will not break, and a smoldering wick he will not snuff out, till he has brought justice through to victory. In his name the nations will put their hope. (Matt. 12:18–21; cf. Isa. 42:1–4)

What a picture of the humble Servant treating people with justice, and through this means bringing victory and hope to the nations. Jesus lived the Kingdom life in the present, and as such revealed what the kingdom of heaven is like, and through such brought the revelation and power of the kingdom of heaven into history.

At the same time, Jesus was unafraid to confront those opposed to God's kingdom, saying to the Pharisees that "if it is by the Spirit of God that I drive out demons, then the kingdom of God has come upon you" (Matt. 12:28). What does this mean? It means more than the Kingdom is near (*ēngiken*) (Matt. 3:2). It means the kingdom has arrived (*ephthasen*). This is the aorist form of the verb. As Darrel Bock points out, this aorist verb is found in Romans 9:31; 2 Corinthians 10:14; 1 Thessalonians 2:16; and Philippians 3:16, and in each case it means "has arrived" or has "reached."[56] There is a difference between drawing near and arriving. Exorcising demons demonstrated the present power of God's kingdom over Satan's kingdom: "All the people were amazed and said to each other, 'What words these are? With authority and power he gives orders to impure spirits and they come out!'" (Luke 4:36). Jesus didn't deny that He was God. He commended Peter for knowing He was God, saying the Father had revealed it to him (Matt. 16:17), and said "the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins," which only God can do (Luke 5:24a).

One demon asked Jesus, "Have you come to destroy us? I know who you are—the Holy One of God!" (Luke 4:34b). Other demons "begged Jesus again and again not to send them out of the area" (Mark 5:10). Both encounters indicate how scared the demons were in the presence of the Son of Man (by contrast a believing woman just touched Christ's clothes and was healed, Mark 5:25–34). Christ gave the same exorcising authority to His disciples (Mark 3:15; 6:7; cf. Mark 9:14–29; 16:17). Together they represented the Kingdom inaugurated, a community under

56. Darrell L. Bock, *Jesus According to Scripture: Restoring the Portrait from the Gospels* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2002), 577.

the power of God. Christ even exorcised a demon from the daughter of the Syrian-Phoenician woman, though the daughter was not present (Mark 7:26–30). God was present among humans. What a tragedy that the Jewish leaders did not recognize Christ as God, while "demons came out of many people, shouting, 'You are the Son of God!'" (Luke 4:41a). It is tragic to have less discernment than demons.

Jesus taught parables of the kingdom of heaven that indicated its presence in human history. Whereas Matthew calls it the "kingdom of heaven," Mark calls it the "kingdom of God" (e.g., Mark 4:11, 26, 30; 9:47b; 10:14–15), and so does Luke (e.g., Luke 4:43; 6:20b). The sower sows good seed and an enemy sows weeds, and they both grow together until harvest at the end of the world (Matt. 13:24–30; cf. Mark 4:13–20). Further, the Kingdom is like a mustard seed, small at first but growing always larger (Matt. 13:31–32), and like yeast working all through the dough (Matt. 13:33). The Son of Man sows the seed, the devil sows the weeds. In the harvest at the end of the age, the wicked will go to the fire, and the "righteous will shine like the sun in the kingdom of their Father" (Matt. 13:37–43). The Kingdom is like treasure hidden in a field, a pearl of great price to those who discern its value and give themselves fully to its claims (see Matt. 13:44–46). In this way the prophecy about Jesus was fulfilled: "I will open my mouth in parables, I will utter things hidden since the creation of the world" (Matt. 13:35; cf. Ps. 78:2). So hidden things about the Kingdom, never revealed since creation, were being revealed and demonstrated by Jesus. He spoke of wise persons preparing for the kingdom of heaven while the unwise do not prepare (Matt. 25:1–13).

So in these two segments we have two foci on the kingdom of heaven—it is coming in the future, and in one sense it has already come in the present.

KINGDOM OF HEAVEN IN CONTEXT

Judaism looked for the coming of the Messiah: They expected that the arrival of the Messiah would mark an abrupt change between the then-present age and the Messianic age. Yet in reality, with the coming of Christ, the kingdom of heaven arrived, and was concurrent with the then-present age.[57] In other words, there was no abrupt break between the two ages, but an overlap between

57. Zechariah, father of John the Baptist, prophesied "filled with the Holy Spirit" and praised God for redeeming His people, raising up "salvation for us in the house of his servant David" (sending of Jesus), to fulfill His promise made to Abraham, and as spoken through the prophets, that God's people would be saved from their enemies (Luke 1:67–75). The true Kingdom is rooted in biblical and not traditional ideas, and agrees with (1) The angels' announcement, "Today in the town of David a Savior has been born to you; he is Christ the Lord" (Luke 2:11). (2) Simeon's statement that when "Moved by the Spirit," he went to where Jesus was and took the baby in his arms, praising God, saying "my eyes have seen your salvation, which you have prepared in the sight of all people, a light for revelation to the Gentiles and for glory to your people Israel." Simeon then said to Mary: "This child is destined to cause the falling and rising of many in Israel" (Luke 2:25–34). (3) The prophetess Anna "gave thanks to God and spoke about the child to all who were looking forward to the redemption of Jerusalem" (Luke 2:36–38). True redemption of Jerusalem may still have been

the two ages. The Kingdom can be understood both as Christ's rule and as the realm over which He rules. Although His rule began with His coming, He has not yet ruled over the entire realm. This will not be until all the kingdoms of this world yield to the kingdom of God in a new heaven and a new earth. Then we will see the ultimate fulfillment of the Lord's Prayer: "[Y]our kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven" (Matt. 6:10). This is the future dimension of the Kingdom. Prior to that final realm of the Kingdom, the Kingdom now is wherever God's power is present in the lives of His people and in their ministry for Him.

But in the meantime, in human history, Christ inaugurated His rule as the Son of Man. As a human He lived on earth, filled with the Spirit, empowered by the Father, revealing what God is like, dependent as a human on God. The inbreaking of the Kingdom was through this dependence. Never before had such power been seen on planet earth. Even the dead came to life, and Christ spoke with authority as none other. Here was a foretaste of what was yet to come. Miracles and messages of the Son pointed beyond this world as it is (under the prince of this age) to a new world when sin and sinners will be no more. In that new world Jesus will live as the Son of God, no longer as a dependent human. The rebellion will be over, and God's rule will be universal again.

In eternity Christ shared in that rule. When rebellion broke out, He was willing to leave the throne and enter the realm where Satan ruled. At the appointed time He came to live on the dangerous battleground as a dependent human. He steadfastly overcame all that Satan flung at Him, trials and temptations, hatred of His own nation and religion. He went to the cross willingly but in great agony and died a conqueror. Satan was defeated at the Cross. His rule must now come to an end—it is only a matter of time. It was during the time when Satan still ruled that Christ as the Son of Man began His rule. The conflict between these two rules reveals the essence of the cosmic controversy—Satan wants to replace Christ.

We need to realize that the kingdom of heaven entered into human history with the Incarnation. The Son of Man was the object of hatred under the rule of Satan on planet earth, since all hell broke out when the Son of God became also the Son of Man, when Christ laid aside the use of His divinity, and as a dependent man met Satan, the leader of the rebellion, on his home turf. Both faced each other as created beings. Yet the fight began when Jesus was only a babe and Satan a master of skillful deception, having overcome angels and humans. What a disadvantage! God must have given Jesus special protection during the early years, or Satan would have won hands down. Whatever God did to aid the very

an option if the nation would accept Jesus as their Savior; see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 10. For Christ spoke of His mission in terms of setting the prisoners free spiritually (Luke 4:18–19).

young Jesus was not just for Jesus—it was for all humans, for without that help humans would not have had a Savior. Even as a growing boy who still had much to learn, Jesus faced a brilliant, devious, and tyrannical enemy.

So God sent Jesus behind enemy lines in the midst of the greatest battle to win back the Kingdom through pain and suffering that took Him to Calvary. He suffered, desiring to escape the cruelty from humans and the agony of being a sin-bearer for a world. Human salvation lay in the balance as He cried out, "Take this cup from me" (Luke 22:42). But in submission to His Father's will, He descended into the darkness of evil as all human sin was laid on Him, crushing His human life. He died a conqueror and won back the Kingdom; at His second coming and beyond, His rule will be revealed to all:

> This theme, then, provides the broad but proper context in which the Christ-event is to be interpreted, for it gives a single, integrated framework in which the Rule—inaugurated by incarnation, effected decisively by Jesus' cross-work, and concluded by the *parousia* and its concomitants of the final subduing of all evil and the return of the pacified cosmos to the Father—can be understood.[58]

This is why the quests for the historical Jesus (see chapter 11), which narrowly focused on the human Jesus, missed the fuller reality of who He was and is, and dismissed the relevance of the Gospel of John which presents Jesus as God (of course the other three Gospels reveal His divinity too, but the Questers were selective in their use of the Synoptics). But in the above segments we looked at Matthew's Gospel, in which the three-dimensional reality of the kingdom of heaven is evident. It was inaugurated by Christ's incarnation (past), is active throughout His ministry (present), and will be coming in the future.

Incarnational Life

There's no question that Christ was God with us, but what does it mean to have God and humankind united in one Person? For a thousand years theology thought Christ had lived on earth as God. However, compared to the pre-Fall Adam, Christ had some obvious disadvantages, for He began as a helpless babe compared to Adam, who was married to Eve the first day of his life. Christ was born into a sinful world compared to Adam, who was created in a sinless paradise, and Christ had physical limitations (the consequences of sin): He was often tired and hungry; he was small of stature and His longevity was drastically reduced. The first Adam was the leader of the human race, but when Christ came on the scene, Satan was the leader of the human race. Christ was dogged by the tempter every day of His life,

58. David F. Wells, *The Person of Christ: A Biblical and Historical Analysis of the Incarnation* (Westchester, IL: Crossway, 1984), 25.

wherever He was, whereas the pre-Fall Adam did not have temptations every day, everywhere, for the place of temptation was confined to the forbidden tree.

Nevertheless, Christ essentially began where the first Adam had begun. Where the God-human relationship was broken by the first Adam, the second Adam began by restoring the broken relationship within His divine-human nature. This incarnational union of God and humanity in the person of Jesus Christ was only the beginning of a long restoration process: "God was reconciling the world to himself in Christ" (2 Cor. 5:19). Notice the text does not say Christ's divine nature was reconciling the world in Jesus Christ, but God was accomplishing the reconciliation. (In Eastern theology, where salvation is purely an internal matter, where the divine nature of Christ divinized the humanity of Christ, so that humanity in Christ became deity. This is not reconciliation, but a transformation of humanity never intended by God.)

KENŌSIS

Scripture describes what was involved in Christ's incarnational life: "Who being in the very nature God, did not consider equality with God something to be grasped, but made himself nothing, taking the very nature of a servant, being made in human likeness. And being found in appearance as a man, he humbled himself and became obedient to death—even death on a cross!" (Phil. 2:6–8).The words "made himself nothing" are better translated "emptied himself" (*heauton ekenōsen*).[59] This emptying, or *kenōsis*, was not an emptying of His deity, as if He were only human, but an emptying of His prerogative to use His deity to help His humanity. He laid aside the use of His divine powers while remaining fully divine and human. So the divine-human reality was fully present, but He continually refrained from acting as God as He lived out His human life. That is why the text speaks of Jesus Christ humbling Himself as a servant (*doulos* means slave, Phil. 2:7), even unto death. Like other humans the Son of Man depended on divine power from beyond Himself, and lived a dependent life on the Father and the Spirit. In so doing Christ became a model for humans, and showed them how to live a Christian life: "though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor, so that you through his poverty might become rich" (2 Cor. 8:9).

Jesus says, "Very truly I tell you, the Son can do nothing by himself; he can do only what he sees his Father doing, because whatever the Father does the

59. In the New Testament *kenōsis* is nearly always in Paul's writing. The verb *kenoō* appears only in Paul: *heauton ekenōsen* (Phil. 2:6) means literally "he emptied himself." "He emptied himself in the sense that he freely exchanged his pre-existent, divine mode of being (v. 6) for common, human, earthly existence," C. Brown "*kenos*," in *New International Dictionary of New Testament Theology*, 1:547.

Son also does" (John 5:19). Further, He declares that He does "exactly what my Father has commanded me" (John 14:31b). Jesus answers His critics with this reply: "My teaching is not my own. It comes from him who sent me" (John 7:16; cf. 14:24b), for "what I heard from him, I tell the world" (John 8:26b). That is why Christ has said, "I did not speak of my own, but the Father who sent me commanded me to say and all that I have spoken" (John 12:49).

Repeatedly Christ said He did not do or speak on His own. In His dependent humanity, He could say "everything that I have learned from my Father I have made known to you" (John 15:15b). Notice that it was not His own divinity He depended upon, but the divinity of His Father. So it was that He said, "I do nothing on my own but speak just what the Father has taught me. The one who sent me is with me; he has not left me alone, for I always do what pleases him" (John 8:28–29). "I and the Father are one" (John 10:30) for "the Father is in me, and I in the Father" (John 10:38b).

When Philip asked Jesus to show them the Father, Jesus replied, "Anyone who has seen me has seen the Father.... Don't you believe that I am in the Father, and that the Father is in me? The words I say to you I do not speak on my own authority. Rather, it is the Father living in me, who is doing his work. Believe me when I say that I am in the Father and the Father is in me; or at least believe on the evidence of the works themselves" (John 14:9b–11). Jesus came to reveal the Father. He came to reveal the humility of eternal love. He came to reveal that the Father and the Spirit would have entered the *kenōsis*, just as He did, if they had come instead of Him, for all three reveal and reciprocate the same love in their inner history. He did not come to complete what was begun in creation (as in Irenaeus), as if creation had been a pre-requisite for the Incarnation (Karl Barth). God did not plan to become a human, even apart from the sin of Adam (this would call into question His utter selflessness in becoming human). Why would the Creator-God long to become a part of creation? The Incarnation was not a dream come true for Christ, but a great risk of failure and eternal loss. He lived as a dependent human, even as He sought to win salvation for humankind. He lived in the power of His heavenly Father and the Holy Spirit.[60]

When people rejected Christ's miracles, He could say "they have hated both me and my Father" (John 15:24b). In the future, because of His successful mission, the Father will exalt Jesus to the highest place "that at the name of Jesus

60. Although the Bible is silent on the early life of Jesus, it seems true that the Father and Holy Spirit provided Him with special protection during the period from birth to the age of accountability. If this is true, it did not give Him an advantage over other humans, because they are born sinners and He was incarnated sinless. Furthermore, the bottom line is Christ did not have to come to save us, and any help He gained in His formative years was not for His sake (He could have remained in heaven on the throne of the universe), but it was only for the sake of all other humans.

every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, and every tongue acknowledge that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father" (Phil. 2:10–11).

OMNIPRESENCE

Did the *kenōsis* (self-emptying of divinity while remaining divine, Phil. 2:5–8) mean Christ gave up His omnipresence? From eternity Christ was present throughout the universe together with the Father and Spirit. Theology hasn't been clear about the extent of Christ's presence after His incarnation. Many theologians believe He remained omnipresent during His incarnational life (see chapter 11), which means His omnipresence didn't change when He became a human, so He lived everywhere, not just in Palestine. Yet could an omnipresent Christ really be human? Would remaining omnipresent negate most of His reasons for His becoming human?

For example, if He were on the throne of the universe while being tempted by the devil in the wilderness, then His defeating the enemy is rather unimpressive. Furthermore, His prayer life and Bible study to overcome temptation would be a farce if, at the same time, He was at the throne of heaven ruling over everything, including Satan the tempter. How could humans relate to Him as their high priest in heaven's sanctuary now, as One who really was a man of sorrows and acquainted with grief, who experienced human struggles just like other humans, without any advantage over them, even experiencing a disadvantage (which we will discuss later).

We need to look more deeply into this issue, and ask questions that might help us sort out the answer: Was the Son of God's entrance into a human body a confinement of His omnipresence? Did He retain His omnipresence but never use it for His own advantage while living a human life? If that was so, how could He be omnipresent and yet not be omnipresent? Or did He give up the attribute of omnipresence, and to that extent cease to be God in one dimension (omnipresence)? Or could He still be God without omnipresence? Was the laying aside of His omnipresence (whatever that means) only during His life on earth, but received back subsequently (as is true of His other attributes)?

If His omnipresence was given up forever, does this mean that the Holy Spirit became Christ's successor on earth, to do for humans that which Christ is unable to do—to be universally present? Does the Holy Spirit bring the localized Christ at the right hand of the Father to be omnipresent on earth, just as He made the omnipresent Son of God present in the womb of Mary? Is Christ with us through the Holy Spirit in the Christian era a reverse to the miracle of

Incarnation where the Spirit brought Christ to be born the God-Man? Should we accept the one as we accept the other, not understanding how the Spirit was able to do both, but accepting this divine mystery by faith?

If Christ gave up His omnipresence forever, how could He hear and act on the requests of humans worldwide in His intercessory ministry in heaven's sanctuary? If Mary is rejected as an intercessor for humans on the basis of her localization in one human body, wouldn't the same disqualify Christ?

We need Scripture, as God's revelation, to answer these questions. There are several aspects of biblical data that need to be brought to the table at this point, and allowed to make their contribution.

Holy Spirit's Ministry on Earth

Prior to His departure, Christ made it clear that a ministry of the Spirit would begin on planet earth:

> I will ask the Father, and he will give you another advocate to help you and to be with your forever—the Spirit of truth.... I will not leave you as orphans; I will come to you. (John 14:16–18)
>
> But very truly I tell you; it is for your good that I am going away. Unless I go away, the Advocate will not come to you; but if I go, I will send him to you. When he comes, he will prove the world wrong about sin and righteousness and judgment: about sin, because people do not believe in me; about righteousness because I am going to the Father, where you can see me no longer; and in regard to judgment, because the prince of this world now stands condemned. I have much more to say to you, more than you can now bear. But when he, the Spirit of truth, comes, he will guide you into all truth. He will not speak on his own; he will speak only what he hears, and he will tell you what is yet to come. He will glorify me because it is from me that he will receive what he will make known to you. All that belongs to the Father is mine. That is why I said the Spirit will receive from me what he will make known to you. (John 16:7–15)

The Holy Spirit has a ministry on earth which brings glory to Christ (John 16:12–14), just as Christ had a ministry on earth that brought glory to the Father (John 17:4). There is a parallel here. There was a time for Christ to minister on earth followed by a time for the Spirit to minister on earth. After His ascension it was time for Christ to minister in heaven until His return to earth in the second advent (John 14:1–4; 1 Thess. 4:16–18). In the time between His ascension and return, Christ promises His followers that He will be with them until the end of the world (Matt. 28:20). Does Christ fulfill this global presence on earth through the Holy Spirit, as He concurrently remains at the right hand of the Father, or is He omnipresent in both?

Christ's Global Rule

At His ascension Christ returned to heaven and sat down at the right hand of the Father on His throne (Heb. 1:3). It was then that Christ began His rule. "And I saw a mighty angel proclaiming in a loud voice, 'Who is worthy to break the seals and open the scroll?' But no one in heaven or on earth or under the earth could open the scroll or even look inside it" (Rev. 5:2–3). "Then I saw a Lamb, looking as if it had been slain, standing at the center of the throne.... He went and took the scroll from the right hand of him who sat on the throne" (Rev. 5:6a–7). "And they sang a new song, saying: 'You are worthy to take the scroll and to open its seals, because you were slain, and with your blood you purchased for God persons from every tribe and language and people and nation'" (Rev. 5:9). And again, "In a loud voice they were saying: 'Worthy is the Lamb, who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and strength and honor and glory and praise!'" (Rev. 5:12).

The opening of the seven seals opens up new periods of history (Rev. 6, 8), so the one opening the seals is the one in charge of human history. Christ died for humans around the globe, so it is fitting that He is inaugurated to rule over human history: Universal atonement leads to universal rule. Paul says the ascended Christ, seated at the right hand of God, is "far above all rule and authority, power and dominion.... And God placed all things under his feet and appointed him to be head over everything for the church" (Eph. 1:21–22).

How could Christ rule over all authorities unless He is omnipresent? Yet, as far as the earth is concerned, does Christ rule through the Holy Spirit who is His successor on earth? Paul says of humans, "our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the powers of this dark world and against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly realms" (Eph. 6:12). It is good to know that Christ rules over these forces, because through His death He defeated them, and Calvary calls into question their right to rule. Some may argue that since Calvary, and its acceptance in heaven at Christ's inauguration, Christ has once again received the gift of omnipresence to effectively rule over the realm He defeated. In other words the *kenōsis*, or laying aside the use of His divinity for Himself while on earth, was reversed in His post-resurrection ministry. Christ is now in full use of His divine powers—including His omnipresence—just as He was before His incarnation. Is this affirmed by Christ's universal presence?

Christ's Universal Presence

Paul states that Christ "ascended higher than all the heavens, in order to fill the whole universe" (Eph. 4:10). In the Greek, Ephesians 4:10 (*ta panta*) is translated in the New International Version "the universe," as it is in Hebrews 1:2b—"the

universe" God created through Christ. Does this mean that just as the pre-incarnate Christ created the universe, so the ascended Christ fills the universe? Some commentators, including F. F. Bruce,[61] Andrew T. Lincoln, [62] and A. Skevington Wood,[63] believe Christ's omnipresence is attested to in Ephesians 4:10.

We need to look at Ephesians 4:10 in the context of the rest of the letter. Paul says in Ephesians that "God raised us up with Christ and seated us with him in the heavenly realms in Christ Jesus" (Eph. 2:6). This has a spiritual rather than a literal meaning, for Christ's followers literally reside on earth. On earth, the church is the "holy temple" and its members together "become a holy temple in the Lord" (Eph. 2:21–22). Note, in the following text, the relationship of the Trinity to members of the church: Paul told the members about his prayer for them to the Father, "that out of his glorious riches he [Father] may strengthen you with power through his Spirit in your inner being, so that Christ may dwell in your hearts through faith" (3:16–17a). It seems that the Spirit imparts the riches of the Father, and brings Christ to indwell members. The ascended Christ gave spiritual gifts (4:11–12) at Pentecost (4:8), when He and the Father sent the Spirit.[64] It seems that in the work of applying Christ's salvation the Spirit is sent by the Father and Son to indwell the church and its members, and in this way represents the Trinity, by making Christ present. In so doing, the Holy Spirit makes Christ omnipresent in a mystery beyond human comprehension.

In Colossians, Paul says of Christ "in him all things hold together" (Col. 1:17), for Christ "is the head over every power and authority" (Col. 2:10), so that "Christ is all, and is in all" (Col. 3:11b). Does this imply omnipresence? If it does imply omnipresence, it contradicts Ephesians. Is there another possible interpretation? This quote can be reconciled with Ephesians if the Colossian verses express supremacy rather than omnipresence. Certainly supremacy seems to be Paul's focus as all the universe is reconciled through the Cross: "For God was pleased to have all his fullness dwell in him, and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether things on earth or things in heaven, by making peace through his blood, shed on the cross" (Col. 1:19–20). The benefits of the

61. F. F. Bruce, *The Epistles to the Colossians, to Philemon, and to the Ephesians*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1984), 344: "To pervade the universe with his presence."

62. Andrew T. Lincoln, *Ephesians*, vol. 42 in *Word Biblical Commentary* (Dallas, TX: Word, 1990), 248: "It is by virtue of his exaltation that Christ can be said to fill the universe in every respect as he pervades it with his rule."

63. A. Skevington Wood, *Ephesians*, vol. 11 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1978), 58: "His exaltation is 'higher than all the heavens.'"

64. Knowing that He would depart from His disciples, Jesus promised that "the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, will teach you all things and will remind you of everything I have said to you" (John 14:26). He also said, "I will send to you from the Father" the Spirit (John 15:26; 16:7). So the Spirit was sent by the Father and the Son.

Cross can be expressed as "Christ in you, the hope of glory" (Col. 1:27b) and "Christ in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" (Col. 2:2b–3), both termed a "mystery" (because humans do not know how the Holy Spirit makes this possible). As in Ephesians, Paul says "Since, then, you have been raised with Christ, set your hearts on things above.... your life is now hidden with Christ in God" (Col 3:1, 3). As in Ephesians this is a spiritual rather than a literal fact, for believers reside on earth. So the benefits of Calvary, for the universe and for believers, are spiritual, which means these texts focus on a literal supremacy rather than on a literal omnipresence of Christ.

This is why the function of the Holy Spirit is so important in the Christian era, and why the Spirit for the first time in salvation history is called the "Spirit of Christ" (Rom. 8:9). In the mystery of salvation's plan, the function of the Holy Spirit is to make the localized Christ omnipresent, just as in the Incarnation He brought the omnipresent to be localized in one human body. Neither of these works of the Holy Spirit can be understood by humans, but they are mysteries that can be accepted in faith. So Paul agrees with what Christ said to the disciples: that it was to their advantage that He leave, because the Holy Spirit would make Him present globally (John 14:16–18; 16:7–11; cf. Matt. 28:20b).

TEMPTATIONS

Since through *kenōsis* (Phil. 2:7) Christ laid aside the use of His divine nature, to live as a human on earth, logically this included laying aside His omnipresence. I concur with Bruce Ware that Christ did not overcome "by recourse to his divine nature but through the resources provided to him in his full humanity."[65] Yet I will go beyond Ware's model, and suggest that the divine nature was a disadvantage to Christ in His temptations. How are humans tempted? Scripture says that "each person is tempted when they are dragged away by their own evil desire and enticed" (Jas. 1:14). Evil propensities (a leaning to sin) are (1) acquired through being born a sinner, and are (2) developed through sinning. Christ had neither. He was born "that holy thing" (Luke 1:35, KJV), and Satan had no hold on Him (John 14:30). Yet Scripture also says because Jesus "suffered when he was tempted, he is able to help those who are being tempted" (Heb. 2:18).

Unless He had been subjected to temptation like us, He could not be a sympathetic High Priest in His present ministry in heaven. He could only accomplish these things by living on earth as a human, being tempted like humans, and overcoming as a human by relying upon His Father (Heb. 2:17–18; 4:14–16). Only if

65. Bruce A. Ware, "The Man Christ Jesus," *Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society*, vol. 53, no. 1, (March 2010): 13–14.

He were tempted as a human could he understand human temptation. So did He understand human temptation?

Christ's temptations were greater than ours for the full force of temptation is not known by those who give in, but only by those who never do—Christ alone belongs in this latter category. When humans give in, it is over—there is no more pressure to resist. As F. F. Bruce puts it, "Yet He endured triumphantly every form of testing that man could endure, without any weakening of His faith in God or any relaxation of His obedience to Him. Such endurance involves more, not less, than ordinary human suffering."[66] B. F. Westcott expresses it this way, "sympathy with the sinner in his trial does not depend on the experience of sin but on the experience of the strength of the temptation to sin which only the sinless can know in its full intensity. He who falls yields before the last strain."[67]

Scripture states that Jesus "has been tempted in every way, just as we are—yet did not sin" (Heb. 4:15). "In every way" doesn't mean the same temptations (plural) but the same temptation (singular). For example, Jesus was never tempted to speed down the highway or gamble in Las Vegas, but He was tempted to act as God. Why would that have been a temptation? He had an eternal habit of acting as God, and that was never sin. However, while on earth, if He had acted as God to gain an advantage in overcoming temptations, that would have a betrayal of what He set aside in becoming a dependent human (Phil. 2:6–8). To act as God would give Him an advantage in overcoming temptation and would have disqualified Him from understanding human temptation as faced by all other humans. How could He be the Suffering Servant of humanity if He were acting out of His power as Almighty God?

The essence of temptation is not only to do a wrong act, but to break a right relationship with God, which then leads to that wrong act. The fact that Christ as God was sinless in nature, and hence unlike other humans, didn't give Him an advantage; in fact, it was a great disadvantage. While this may come as a surprise to some readers, consider this: If the thrust of temptation is to get one to rely upon oneself, and thus sever relational ties of dependency upon God, who would have the greater temptation, Jesus who had His own divinity to empower Him, or humans who have nothing comparable? Christ's disadvantage in temptation issued out of His uniqueness, not out of His likeness with humans. In this uniqueness rests both His far more difficult human life and our salvation. Only Jesus felt the full force of Satanic hatred, for Satan's controversy is against Christ and not against any other human, and yet only Jesus could not receive forgiveness if He had yielded to temptation. Would you want to live, even one day, under

66. F. F. Bruce, *Commentary on the Epistle to the Hebrews* (London: Marshall, Morgan and Scott, 1974), 87–88.
67. B. F. Westcott, quoted in Bruce, *Hebrews*, 88.

such pressure, with no chance of repentance if you succumbed? No one has suffered like Jesus, and no one has ever been driven to hold on to God as He did. He hated sin and had no propensities to sin, so that was no problem. But He knew how to act as God. He had an eternal habit of doing so. To remain a dependent human, and not rely upon His own divinity within, was a temptation that no other human will ever experience or understand. Starving for nearly six weeks in the wilderness when He could have turned stones to bread was a temptation far harder than any sinful urge any of us will ever experience (Matt. 4:1–4).

So Christ's uniqueness, not His identity with us, gave Him a disadvantage in temptations and gave us the advantage of a sinless Savior, who could live and die as our substitute. Jesus Christ, the "one of a kind" person (*monogenēs*), was in nature as well as in acts "holy, blameless set apart from sinners" (Heb. 7:26), and this is why He could say that Satan found "no hold over me" (John 14:30). The writer of Hebrews speaks of Christ's true humanity:

> (1) [H]e had to be made like them, fully human in every way, in order that he might become a merciful and faithful high priest in service to God, and that he might make atonement for the sins of the people. Because he himself suffered when he was tempted, he is able to help those who are being tempted. (Heb. 2:17–18)
>
> (2) [W]e do not have a high priest who is unable to empathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who has been tempted in every way, just as we are—yet he did not sin. (Heb. 4:15)
>
> (3) During the days of Jesus' life on earth, he offered up prayers and petitions with fervent cries and tears to the one who could save him from death, and he was heard because of his reverent submission. Son though he was, he learned obedience from what he suffered and, once made perfect, he became the source of eternal salvation for all who obey him and was designated by God to be high priest in the order of Melchizedek. (Heb. 5:7–10)

Christ lived on earth as a human so that He could understand what humans go through. Because He lived a human life, He is able to be a merciful and sympathetic high priest in His present ministry in heaven's sanctuary. He knew what it was to earnestly petition God, even with tears. Christ was burdened for the salvation of His people: "As he approached Jerusalem and saw the city, he wept over it" (Luke 19:41). Jesus knew He was about to resurrect Lazarus, yet He "wept" (John 11:35), knowing death would come to so many of His people, both when Jerusalem was destroyed and in the final judgment.

He lived as a human, submitted and dependent upon God for His presence and power to live a life free from sin.[68] Therefore, I cannot agree with Bruce

68. Compare the temptations of Eve and Christ. She ate the fruit because it looked good, and promised to offer her an exalted status. She was in the prime of life, surrounded by everything she needed. She wasn't hungry because all the other trees were loaded with fruit for her to eat. By contrast Jesus was in the wilderness, and after six weeks of starvation, He was near the point of death. When Satan tempted Him, saying, "If you are the Son of God, tell this stone to become bread" (Luke 4:3), He did what Eve didn't do—He refused to eat because He was on earth to do the will of His Father. Eve ate because she failed to do the will of Christ. If she thought her eating the fruit was legitimate, how much more could Jesus have felt the same? But He didn't. He would rather have died than to act against the will of His Father in heaven. He said, "I have come down from heaven not to do my will but to do the will of him who sent me" (John 6:38). That was the reason He came. About His incarnation He could say, "I have come to do your will, O God" (Heb. 10:7). So Wayne Grudem is right to say, "Jesus, unlike Adam and Eve, refused to eat what appeared to be good and necessary for him, choosing rather to obey the command of his heavenly Father," *Systematic Theology*, 536.

Ware when he states, "even though Christ's human will could sin, his divine will strengthened the human will such that the human will, so divinely empowered, could not sin." This would call into question His dependence upon the Father and Spirit.[69]

CHRIST'S DEPENDENCE ON THE SPIRIT

We have already noted that Christ depended upon the Father for what to say and to do, rather than depending upon His own divinity. In this segment we will see that Christ also lived dependent upon the Holy Spirit, rather than upon His own divinity.

Christ entered planet earth "conceived…from the Holy Spirit" (Matt. 1:20), baptized by the Spirit (Mark 1:9f–10), "led by the Spirit" (Luke 4:1), offered Himself up to die through the Spirit (Heb. 9:14–15), and, in part, was resurrected by the Spirit (Rom. 8:11). Jesus depended upon the Spirit as much in His human life as He did in His incarnation. He said, "It is by the Spirit of God that I drive out demons" (Matt. 12:28).

Isaiah noted the Son's dependence upon the Spirit: "The Spirit of the Lord will rest on him" (Isa. 11:2, cf. v. 3). Jesus testified: "The Spirit of the Lord is on me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim freedom for the prisoners" (Luke 4:18, cf. Isa. 61:1). Peter stated: "God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and power, and how he went around doing good and healing all who were under the power of the devil, because God was with him" (Acts 10:38).

In both the Incarnation and at Pentecost, the Spirit brings Christ to humans. In the Incarnation He brought the omnipresent God to earth and made Him present in Mary. In Pentecost He brings the God-Man and makes Him omnipresent. In both cases He comes to bring Christ to humans. He comes not with His own credentials, as if to add to what Christ accomplished, as if that were not sufficient. He comes to bring Christ's completed work to us, that it may be applied in us. He brings Christ and works on His behalf. We receive the robe of Christ's righteousness (Isa. 61:10), the wedding garment (Matt. 22:11)—it is

69. Bruce A. Ware, "The Man Chtist Jesus," *Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society*, 53/1 (March 2010): 5–18.

Christ's perfect human life and the Spirit's working with us to imitate that life in obedience as we receive the Giver. Or as Swete puts it, "where the Spirit was Christ was, and what the Spirit wrought was wrought in fact by Christ."[70]

Thus we read from the human perspective, "Christ in you, the hope of glory" (Col. 1:27), and "Christ lives in me" (Gal. 2:20). We read from Christ's perspective, "lo, I am with you always, even unto the end of the world" (Matt. 28:20, KJV). The Christian is invited to "Come to me" (Matt. 11:28), and "Abide in me...for without me ye can do nothing" (John 15:4–5, KJV). So when we speak of the Spirit's application of what Christ accomplished for us, "even the work of application is a work of Christ, but a work which He accomplishes through the agency of the Holy Spirit. Though this work stands out in the economy of redemption as the work of the Holy Spirit, it cannot for a moment be separated from the work of Christ."[71]

Thus far we have considered Christ's dependence upon the Spirit; we now turn to consider the Spirit's dependence upon Christ.

SPIRIT'S DEPENDENCE ON CHRIST

Humans were made to be temples for the Spirit's indwelling (1 Cor. 3:16), but suffered partial loss of the Spirit's fullness through the Fall, having chosen a usurper spirit—Satan. Through His life and death Christ won back the right to become the second Adam, to regain the leadership of this world. Why did the Spirit's fullness have to wait until Pentecost? The fullness of the Spirit had everything to do with the fulfilled work of Christ. Old Testament believers longed for the coming of two members of the Godhead—the Messiah presented in Isaiah 53 and the Holy Spirit promised in Joel 2:28. Apparently the fullness of the Spirit was not just a return to pre-Fall fullness but also had to do with bringing the human Jesus, source of our robe of righteousness, and the wedding garment, to forgiven Christians. For never before had the Spirit brought the God-Man to humans, even though the "eternal gospel" (Rev. 14:6) means salvation through Christ was available throughout human history (Gal. 3:8–9; Heb. 4:2).

Can we find evidence that (1) in the Incarnation the Spirit brought God to humans, and (2) in Pentecost, and its extension in history, the Spirit brings the God-Man to willing recipients? Evidence of this is found in Christ's own mission. John prophesied that Jesus would baptize with the Spirit (Matt. 3:11), something never done before. But we look in vain for even one fulfillment of this during His ministry on earth. He never baptized with the Spirit. Not until after Calvary, after paying the price to win back the world from the usurper

70. Henry B. Swete, *The Holy Spirit in the New Testament* (London: Macmillan and Co, 1931), 301.
71. Louis Berkhof, *Systematic Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1976), 424.

Satan, did Jesus begin to fulfill John's prophecy. Thus, after Calvary, Jesus said to His disciples, "Receive the Holy Spirit" as He breathed on them a special blessing (John 20:22). Yet Calvary's acceptance by God the Father was also a prerequisite for Pentecostal fullness: "As yet the Spirit had not been given, because Jesus was not yet glorified" (John 7:39, RSV). When Jesus sat down at God's throne, He was glorified (Heb. 1:3; Rev. 4–5). He then sent the Spirit, through whom He occupied human thrones, filling human minds (John 15:26; cf. 14:25). At last Christ baptized with the Spirit in His ministry—from heaven. Christ was dependent upon the Spirit (and the Father) during His human life on earth. The ascended Christ is now dependent upon the Spirit to bring Him to humans (to be omnipresent) all over the world.

Man of Sorrows

During much of His life Jesus knew He would die, and this caused Him concern: "I have a baptism to undergo, and what constraint I am under until it is completed" (Luke 12:50). Jesus prayed to His Father just before He went to Gethsemane (notice the sense of calm in His prayer): "Father, the hour has come. Glorify your Son, that your Son may glorify you" (John 17:1). "I have brought you glory on earth by finishing the work you gave me to do" (v. 4); "I have given them your word and the world has hated them, for they are not of the world any more than I am of the world. My prayer is not that you take them out of the world but that you protect them from the evil one" (vv. 14–15). He prayed that "all of them may be one, Father, just as you are in me and I am in you" (v. 21). "Father, I want those you have given me to be with me where I am, and to see my glory, the glory you have given me because you loved me before the creation of the world" (v. 24).

John tells us that when "he had finished praying [the prayer of John 17], Jesus left with his disciples and crossed the Kidron Valley. On the other side there was a garden, and he and his disciples went into it" (John 18:1), and in so doing—they entered Gethsemane. Alfred Edersheim describes the scene as follows:

> Passing out by the gate north of the Temple, we descend into a lonely part of the valley of black Kidron, at that season swelled into a winter torrent.... It [Gethsemane] was a small property enclosed (χωρίον), "a garden" in the Eastern sense...that enclosed garden was—the other Eden, in which the Second Adam, the Lord from heaven, bore the penalty of the first.... in that night the fierce wind of hell was allowed to sweep unbroken over the Saviour, and even to expend its fury upon those that stood behind in His Shelter.[72]

72. Alfred Edersheim, *The Life and Times of Jesus The Messiah* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1986, 1st ed. 1971), 533–535.

Mark the change in His prayers in Gethsemane and Calvary: They express His horror and deep heart-rending anguish as never before. The sin-bearer pled with His Father for release from His mission, if it would please His Father. He was "deeply distressed and troubled" (Mark 14:33b), and exclaimed, "'My soul is overwhelmed with sorrow to the point of death'.... Going a little farther, he fell to the ground" (vv. 34–35a), indicating the anguish He carried was a crushing load to bear. Three times He shrank from His mission (Mark 14:34–41) but added three times "not as I will, but as you will" (Matt. 26:39b, 42b, 44b; cf. Mark 13:46; Luke 22:42b). He had come to do His Father's will (Heb. 10:5–7), but Gethsemane and Calvary were a reality that made Him tremble near the finish line. "An angel from heaven appeared to him and strengthened him. And being in anguish, he prayed more earnestly, and his sweat was like drops of blood falling to the ground" (Luke 22:43–44).

That blood was evidence that Christ, the only Substitute for humans, was becoming a sacrifice for them. It was not the physical agony that troubled Him; rather, sweating blood speaks of extraordinary mental anguish. The burden of Calvary had settled on Him, and He longed for relief. The sin-burden born on Calvary would cause Him unimaginable agony of soul as He felt godforsaken, even though He wasn't. Gethsemane was the beginning of this suffering. "Not as I will, but as you will" reveals Christ's submission, as He clung to the Father in His agony.

The will of His Father was not arbitrary. Consider the evidence: (1) The crucifixion of Christ was voluntary on His part. "The reason my Father loves me is that I lay down my life—only to take it up again. No one takes it from me, but I lay it down of my own accord. I have authority to lay it down and authority to take it up again. This command I received from my Father" (John 10:17–18). (2) The crucifixion was voluntary on the part of the Romans and the Jewish leaders: "'Here is your king,' Pilate said to the Jews. But they shouted, 'Take him away! Take him away! Crucify him!' 'Shall I crucify your king?' Pilate asked. 'We have no king but Caesar,' the chief priests answered. Finally Pilate handed him over to be crucified" (John 19:14b–16). Based on this biblical evidence, the following idea has to be rejected: "On the other hand, we cannot but acknowledge that the election of Israel to be the sphere in which the Son of God willed to let Himself be condemned as a sinner and to be put to death on the Cross, meant that Israel could only fulfil the gracious purpose of God by rejecting Christ and condemning Him to a sinner's death."[73] The above conclusion is the ultimate failure in traditional predestination. Instead of Jewish rebellion causing Christ's crucifixion, that rebellion is sanctified as God's will—see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapters 8–9, 14–15. This

73. T. F. Torrance, *Order and Disorder*, vol. 1 in *Conflict and Agreement in the Church* (London: Lutterworth, 1959), 295.

is no different in kind from making God Himself responsible for the cosmic controversy, which questions His wisdom. This view of predestination overlooks creaturely responsibility and questions the reality of all of God's judgments against sin.

Christ suffered through the mockery and hatred of several trials. Scripture says the Roman soldiers "seizing" Christ led him to the house of the high priest (Luke 22:54a). In the court of Caiaphas, the high priest, "The chief priests and the whole Sanhedrin were looking for false evidence against Jesus so that they could put him to death" (Matt. 26:59). "The chief priests and the teachers of the law were standing there, vehemently accusing him" (Luke 23:10). He was tortured. They "blindfolded him" (Mark 14:65a), and "spit in his face and struck him with their fists. Others slapped him and said, 'Prophesy to us, Messiah, Who hit you?'" (Matt. 26:67–68). "And they said many other insulting things to him" (Luke 22:65). This all took place while it was dark, before day break (Luke 22:66a). Christ was condemned by Caiaphas's court to die, and then bound and led to the court of Pilate, for Jews could not implement a death decision, but the Roman governor could. There "the chief priests and the elders persuaded the crowd to ask for Barabbas and to have Jesus executed" (Matt. 27:20). Even though Pilate said he found no fault in Him, "he had Jesus flogged, and handed him over to be crucified" (Matt. 27:26).

> Then the governor's soldiers took Jesus into the Praetorium and gathered the whole company of soldiers around him. They stripped him and put a scarlet robe on him, and then twisted together a crown of thorns and set it on his head. They put a staff in his right hand. Then they knelt in front of him and mocked him. "Hail, king of the Jews!" they said. They spit on him, and took the staff and struck him on the head again and again. After they had mocked him, they took off the robe and put his own clothes on him. Then they led him away to crucify him. (Matt. 27:27–31)

Mark adds that they wove a crown of thorns and set it on His head. Then they struck the crown again and again, driving the spikes into His head. Afterward, in utter mockery "[f]alling on their knees, they paid homage to him" (Mark 15:19b). Then Jesus was taken to the court of Herod, who "plied him with many questions" while the priests were "vehemently accusing him" (Luke 23:9–10b). "Then Herod and his soldiers ridiculed and mocked him. Dressing him in an elegant robe, they sent him back to Pilate" (Luke 23:11). All of this suffering during the night hours was heaped upon the man Jesus after He had struggled the evening before in the Garden of Gethsemane.

CHRIST'S DEATH: UNLIMITED ATONEMENT

Christ came to this earth to die. Never was there a moment in eternity when He did not understand this. Most of His mission on earth was lived under the

shadow of the Cross. He knew that the consequence of sin is death (Rom. 6:23). This is the principle of reaping what is sown (Gal. 6:7). Because humans sinned, humans deserved to die. Death from sin is a natural result, and can no more be changed than gravity. The laws of spiritual life are as fixed as the laws of nature. Christ didn't die in order to assuage the anger of God, as if the Father needed to be appeased by Christ (cf. John 16:26–27). This is a pagan concept. But Christ did suffer *God's awful wrath against sin.* God hated sin and was wrathful against sin laid on Christ, because of what it did to Christ, what it did to all humans and fallen angels, and what it did to fuel the cosmic controversy.

God gave Christ to save the world. His death was the means of salvation: "it is the blood that makes atonement" (Lev. 17:11). The Father loved the world just as much as Christ loved the world (John 3:16–17). The love of the members of the Trinity for each other was the same love that was poured out for all humans at Calvary. Humans needed a Savior, and the Trinity came to the rescue of the human race by paying for the consequences of sin. Each member of the Trinity was deeply affected by the death of Christ. No wonder Christ said, "The reason my Father loves me is that I lay down my life" (John 10:17). God wasn't angry at Christ as the sin-bearer. He was angry that Christ had to undergo such a sacrifice in order to save humans. All the Persons of the Trinity, in different ways, suffered at the Cross. The Cross is a revelation of the love of the Trinity for sinners, and the hatred of the Trinity for sin. They hated sin because it separates humans from a loving relationship with God.

So Christ's death was a substitutionary atonement, bearing the penalty for all human sin. The price was paid for each human—no one was left out. This is a long way from God's electing a few and rejecting the rest. Calvary defines election, not the other way round. Unfortunately, Reformed theology has defined Calvary by election, so that if God chooses a few, then the atonement is limited to these few. Bruce Demarest is to be commended for taking this Reformed position a step further, noting that "by divine *intention* Christ's suffering and death are universal in its provision and particular in its application."[74] Demarest rightly points out that the reason for God's decision to save is "supremely his agapic love (John 3:16; 15:13; Rom 5:8; Eph 5:2; 1 John 4:9–10),"[75] which is the position taken in this system, for God is by nature love, which is demonstrated in all His attributes (Gal. 5:22–23); see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 2.

While Demarest believes God's general will is to save all humans, he believes that His special will is to save the elect, for "the Father loves the 'sheep' with a

74. Bruce Demarest, *The Cross and Salvation: The Doctrine of Salvation* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 1997), 193, emphasis in original.

75. Ibid., 188.

special love."[76] This seems to allow election to qualify God's love. Wouldn't it be better to begin with God's love for all humans at Calvary, and allow that to define the meaning of election? Could there be any more "special love" than the love poured out on the Cross—for every human? True love knows no partiality (Prov. 28:21; Mal. 2:9; Acts 10:34; Rom. 2:11; Col. 3:25; Jas. 2:9; 1 Pet. 1:17).

Jesus said He came to planet earth to reveal His Father (John 14:9). His life of unconditional love for Jews and Gentiles alike demonstrated impartiality, and His death for all humans did the same. God's will is not defined by some secret, inexplicable decree in eternity past or an unending hell in future eternity, but by the full revelation of God in the incarnational life and death of Jesus Christ. In the Incarnation Christ said, "I have come to do your will, my God" (Heb. 10:7b). The Father sent Jesus because He loved the world (John 3:16). There is no incompatibility between God's will and His love at Calvary—an overflowing grace for every human sinner: "All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned—every one—to his own way; and the Lord has laid on him the iniquity of us all" (Isa. 53:6, ESV).

John is very clear that Christ's death was for all humans: "[I]f anybody does sin, we have an advocate with the Father—Jesus Christ, the Righteous One. He is the atoning sacrifice for our sins, and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world" (1 John 2:1b–2). Once one limits the atonement to a few, Calvary has been robbed of its power by the ideas of mere mortals. Hell should never be a motive to get people to be saved, for salvation is for all at Calvary.[77] There is no greater drawing power than the universal self-sacrifice of God at the cross.

God is the Savior who "wants all people to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth. For there is one God and one mediator between God and mankind, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a ransom for all people" (1 Tim. 2:4–6a). Peter agrees saying, "The Lord is not slow in keeping his promise, as some understand slowness. Instead he is patient with you, not wanting anyone to perish, but everyone to come to repentance" (2 Pet. 3:9). The universality of human salvation is found in the Old Testament: "Do I take any pleasure in the death of the wicked? declares the Sovereign LORD. Rather, am I not pleased when they turn from their ways and live?" (Ezek. 18:23). God's sovereign will acts in love toward all humans.

76. Ibid., 193.

77. If hell is only for the lost, why preach hell to move the elect to be saved, for predestination (as traditionally taught in the Reformed tradition) means the elect cannot be lost, for nothing done in human history can change God's electing decree in eternity. But why should hell be taught in Baptist churches, for example, as if the fear of hell will cause people to want to be saved? Is this not a human construct that robs the cross of God's far superior means to draw humans to Him? God doesn't use fear to win people—He uses love. The greatest power in the universe is God's love. Scripture declares: "perfect love drives out fear" (1 John 4:18). Fear never produces love, and love is the existential condition of the redeemed with the relational Trinity in eternity. Jesus said, "Do not fear, little flock, for it is your Father's good pleasure to give you the kingdom" (Luke 12:32, NKJV).

On the basis of this universal love, God calls humans to repent and speaks of the future judgment of all, which would be meaningless if He has already prejudged them as either elect or reprobate. "Therefore, you Israelites, I will judge each of you according to your own ways, declares the Sovereign LORD. Repent! Turn away from all your offenses; then sin will not be your downfall. Rid yourselves of all the offenses you have committed, and get a new heart and a new spirit. Why will you die, people of Israel? For I take no pleasure in the death of anyone, declares the Sovereign Lord. Repent and live!" (Ezek. 18:30–32).

God's love poured out at Calvary is a call for all humans to accept the gift of salvation provided so lavishly and unselfishly. Consider the fact that Christ is the "true light that gives light to everyone coming into the world" (John 1:9).[78] The words "coming into the world" can correctly refer to Christ's coming into the world, and also to every human coming into the world. In other words, Christ came once to save everyone, but He also keeps coming throughout history to seek and to save all humans. One is one event, the other is continuous. Here "everyone" (*panta anthrōpon*) means either that (1) Christ comes as the Light (in His incarnation) for everyone; or (2) Christ comes as light, through the Spirit, to everyone who comes into the world. Greek grammar allows both translations. C. H. Dodd believes both are intended.[79] Leon Morris offers a perceptive insight by asserting that it is "common teaching of the New Testament writers that God has revealed something of himself to all people (Rom. 1:20), sufficient at least for them to be blameworthy when they take the wrong way instead of the right way. John attributes this general illumination to the activity of the Word."[80] As Christ draws people and illumines them, they have the ability to choose.

Calvary is no country club for members only. Calvary includes the world; Calvary impacts the universe. For Calvary says more about God than anything else, and so Calvary is the most important evidence of God's character in the cosmic controversy. No wonder Satan and his fiends strive to keep that vision away from human minds. At Calvary "God was reconciling the world to himself

78. As Henry Alford says, "The construction of this verse has been much disputed" *The Greek Testament* (Chicago: Moody, 1968), 1:683. For a summary of the debate, see W. Robertson Nicoll, *The Expositor's Greek Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), 1:686–687. The grammatical construction allows either the verb to refer to Christ's coming into the world, or to humans' coming into the world. The Vulgate and Authorized Versions follow the first; the Revised Version follows the second. Either way the universal focus is intact. Whether Christ comes for everyone who enters the world, or whether Christ comes to everyone who enters the world, both are universal. I believe both are legitimate, for His coming as a light for everyone would be meaningless if He does not follow through, via the Holy Spirit, to come as the light to everyone coming into the world. So Christ is the universal light in His mission on earth which includes enlightening all humans throughout history.

79. C. H. Dodd, *Interpretation of the Fourth Gospel* (London, UK: Cambridge, 1953), 284.

80. Morris, *John*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament*, 95.

in Christ" (2 Cor. 5:19). Christ tasted "death for everyone" (Heb. 2:9). He was the substitutionary sacrifice for all mankind (John 3:16–17).[81]

Judas had forsaken Him, Peter had denied Him, and all the disciples had run away and forsaken Him in His hour of greatest need. "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Matt. 27:46; Mark 15:34) was the question wrung from quivering lips and broken heart. This was the price of our redemption, a cost we will never fathom even during eternity in the Kingdom. We will attempt to penetrate into this unfathomable dereliction cry when we take up the atonement theories in chapter 13.

SIN FOR US

So when did the sinless Christ become "sin for us"? Isaiah responds, "the LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all" (Isa. 53:6b). Peter concurs, "'He himself bore our sins" in his body [*en tō sōmati autou*] on the cross, so that we might die to sins and live for righteousness; 'by his wounds you have been healed'" (1 Pet. 2:24). What does "in his body" mean? It doesn't mean that He Himself became sinful within His body, for it was upon Christ who "knew no sin" that God laid human sin (2 Cor. 5:21). In this context, the words "in his body" mean Christ carried the weight of human sin upon His body, and this crushed out His life. He could only have redeemed these sins if He Himself remained sinless throughout the process.

Part of Isaiah 53:9 is quoted by Peter, indicating that the suffering servant passages in Isaiah refer to Christ: "'He committed no sin, and no deceit was found in his mouth.' [Isa. 53:9] When they hurled their insults at him, he did not retaliate; when he suffered, he made no threats. Instead, he entrusted himself to him who judges justly. 'He himself bore our sins' in his body on the cross, so that we might die to sins and live for righteousness; 'by his wounds you have been healed'" (1 Pet. 2:22–24).

81. In Luke 14:16–24 it is Jesus who sends out the invitations, which is logical because Scripture speaks of "the wedding of the Lamb" (Rev. 19:7). Those turning Christ down were the elect Jews, who "thought that heritage alone and being a part of God's chosen people alone were enough," Darrell L. Bock, *Luke*, in *The New International Version Application Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1996), 399. This should indicate that election can be lost. When Christ bids them to compel the invitees, this doesn't suggest force, for Christ never used force in His ministry (Matt. 5:43–47; 6:14–15; 7:1–5, 12). Compare with Matthew 14:22 where Jesus made (*ēnankasen*) them to enter a boat, F. D. Nichol, ed., *SDA Bible Commentary* (Washington, DC: Review and Herald Publishing Association, 1956), 5:810. "To 'make them come in' is not compulsion but 'an insistent hospitality,'" Manson, *Sayings of Jesus*, 130, quoted in Walter L. Liefeld, *Luke*, vol. 8 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1984), 978. "He initiates a new community grounded in gracious and uncalculating hospitality," Green, *The Gospel of Luke*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament*, 562. "*Compel* them. That is, urge them, press them earnestly, one and all. Do not hear their excuses on account of their poverty and low rank of life, but urge them so as to overcome their objections and lead them to the feast," Albert Barnes, *Luke*, in *Barnes New Testament Notes* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2005, 1st ed. 1847), 98. At the cross Christ died for all those invited to the feast. Ultimately (on the basis of Calvary), His death is the invitation.

On Calvary, Christ "who knew no sin" became "sin for us." Never before this time of sacrifice had sin brought separation from His Father, so in His anguish He cried out, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me" (Matt. 27:46). For the first time the man Jesus became sin for us in mission at death, rather than in nature at birth. Christ lived on earth so that He could die for humans, for deity is immortal (1 Tim. 6:16). He came to earth to become "sin for us" and die as our substitutionary atonement. If He had sin in His nature, the bearing of this external sin would have been impossible, for only a sinless Christ can atone for sin. This is why the Old Testament animal sacrifices that typified Christ had to be without blemish (Exod. 12:5).

Nothing can separate a person from God (Rom. 8:35–39), except sin (Isa. 59:2; cf. Psa. 51:4a, 11; Jer. 3:12), and Christ felt this separation to His depths, for He bore "the sins of the whole world" (1 John 2:2b). From eternity, as a member of the Trinity, Christ enjoyed personal, intimate, reciprocal love from the Father and the Spirit. He was surrounded by their love. There could be no greater love than the love of God, and He experienced this love to the full. How utterly staggering, foreign, and tragic must have been His separation from them. Never before had He entered this unknown depth of condescension. Humans are unable to fathom it, for who can understand the heights of eternal love and the plunge to eternal hell? For hell is ultimate separation from God. He plunged into that abyss to save humans, whatever the price to Himself. There is no greater manifestation of love!

> Surely he took up our pain and bore our suffering, yet we considered him punished by God, stricken by him, and afflicted. But he was pierced for our transgressions, he was crushed for our iniquities; the punishment that brought us peace was on him, and by his wounds we are healed. We all, like sheep, have gone astray, each of us has turned to his own way; and the LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all. He was oppressed and afflicted, yet he did not open his mouth; he was led like a lamb to the slaughter, and as a sheep before its shearers is silent, so he did not open his mouth. By oppression and judgment, he was taken away, and yet who of his generation protested? For he was cut off from the land of the living; for the transgressions of my people he was punished. (Isa. 53:4–8)

REDEMPTION-RESOLUTION

Christ's double mission of (1) human redemption, and (2) cosmic controversy resolution means that His death contributed to both. This means Christ became human in order to die to redeem humans and to resolve the cosmic controversy. No wonder the writer of Hebrews says, "Since the children have flesh and blood, he too shared in their humanity so that by his death he might

break the power of him who holds the power of death—that is, the devil" (Heb. 2:14). It is important to remember that Calvary is more than human redemption. Because there can be no redemption, or a return to the pre-Fall universe, without resolution of the cosmic controversy. Christ died to redeem, but He also died to destroy the devil.

Just as human redemption is still to be fully realized, so the devil's defeat has yet to be finally realized. Calvary assured that both will one day be a fact. In the meantime, believers can rejoice in the "already" of both while looking forward to the "not yet" fulfillment. The New Testament speaks of new heavens and a new earth, where there will be no more sin or sinners (Rev. 21). Then Calvary will have reached its goal. Satan charged that God is not a God of love or justice. Calvary refutes the charge, showing that God loves all humanity, that He died for everyone, and died so His love will banish forever any desire to question Him again (Nah. 1:9). Calvary is the greatest revelation of love and justice. Christ died to remove sin and sinners from the universe, so paradise can be restored, and redemption can be realized as a post-cosmic-controversy-resolution new world that will bring eternal peace—the peace that reigned before the invasion of sin. Then, finally the war will be over because Christ's victory at Calvary will have been fully realized.

CHRIST AND THE GRAVE

Some critics have said Christ didn't really die, but it only appeared that He died. This view is compatible with Satan's claim, yet Scripture counters that Christ "was delivered over to death for our sins and was raised to life for our justification" (Rom. 4:25). There's no meaning to Christ's resurrection if Christ didn't die. Having said this we need to carefully think through what death means to an eternal God compared to what death means to a created being, for Jesus Christ was both, united in the unique God-Man forever. This means He was a union of an immortal divine nature and a mortal human nature; for God alone is immortal (1 Tim. 6:16).

So what did it mean for Christ to die as far as the biblical data is concerned? This is rarely, if ever, thought through, because the death of Christ is just as much a mystery as the birth of Christ. Both His birth and death were unique acts that cannot ever be experienced by anyone else. This is holy ground, and one can only bow in reverence before our Savior, declaring that He really did die and really did rise again to give us eternal life in His second advent. In this context we can say the following: Just as Christ's divine nature was alive but quiescent in the womb, so it was alive and quiescent in the tomb. Divinity cannot die because it is immortal. But, throughout His human life, His divinity

was laid aside (*kenōsis*, Phil. 2:6–8), meaning that while He remained fully God, He chose not to use His divinity to His own advantage, because He came to live and die as a human. This is why Paul says Christ came "in the likeness of sinful flesh to be a sin offering" (Rom. 8:3b). So we leave it at that and look forward to asking Christ more about this in the Kingdom. All that matters in the meantime is to know Christ died in our stead, to save us, which is a substitutionary sacrifice that we could never pay.

When it comes to Christ's time in the grave, we need to probe a bit further. How do we interpret the following text?

> For Christ also suffered once for sins, the righteous for the unrighteous, to bring you to God. He was put to death in the body but made alive in the Spirit. After being made alive, he went and made proclamation to the imprisoned spirits to those who were disobedient long ago when God waited patiently in the days of Noah while the ark was being built. In it only a few people, eight in all, were saved through water. (1 Pet. 3:18–20)

Does this text mean the during the time He was in the grave, Christ, through the Spirit, preached to persons still alive since the days of Noah? Consider what a few contemporary commentators have to say about this passage. (1) Lenski affirms that in His death Christ's human spirit went to heaven while His body was in the tomb and the two were united in His resurrection. "In that instant, but timelessly, Christ in his human body and spirit descended to hell and did what Peter relates. In the other world time and space as we know both here on earth do not exist." He further claims that His ascension was "timeless," and thus His journey from earth to heaven cannot be measured by time.[82]

(2) Edwin Blum says this "section contains some of the most difficult exegetical problems in the NT." After mentioning three interpretations, he concludes that Christ "made a victorious proclamation to the fallen angels during his ascension."[83] Blum believes "flesh and "spirit" in 1 Peter 3:18 do not refer to Christ's body and soul, nor does the spirit refer to the Holy Spirit, but "'flesh' refers to Christ in his human sphere of life and 'spirit' refers to Christ in his resurrected sphere of life." So the one who does the preaching in 1 Peter 3:19 is "the risen Lord." The fallen spirits are fallen angels, so in His resurrection Christ goes "to the place of angelic confinement. Since this is another realm, we cannot locate it spatially. However, there does not seem to be good evidence for seeing here a 'descent into hell.' The same word *poreutheis* is used in v. 22 of his

82. R. C. H. Lenski, *The Interpretation of The Epistles of St. Peter, St. John and St. Jude* (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg, 1966), 159, 161; see also 162.

83. Edwin A. Blum, *1, 2 Peter*, vol. 12 in The *Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1981), 241.

ascension." He concludes that Christ "was put to death in the human sphere of existence but was made alive in the resurrection sphere of existence, in which state of existence he made a proclamation of his victory to the fallen angels."[84]

(3) J. Ramsey Michaels concurs that the distinction between "flesh" and "Spirit" is the distinction between "his earthly existence and his risen state." He concurs with Dalton that Christ's proclamation "follows rather than precedes Christ's resurrection"[85] He disagrees with J. S. Feinberg who said the proclamation of Christ refers back to the time of Noah, rather than to the time of His death-resurrection (a view that goes back to at least Augustine).[86]

By contrast, note what the reformers Luther and Calvin have said. (1) Martin Luther (1483–1546) states: "This is a strange text and certainly a more obscure passage than any other passage in the New Testament." He claims that Jesus went and preached in hell after His resurrection, and not during His entombment. He bases his interpretation on the difference between consecutive time on earth and the "divine computation of time" (i.e., timelessness, for "before God everything takes place in one moment."). Luther spiritualizes the preaching to mean preaching to spirits like those of Noah's time, but concludes "let him to whom a better interpretation is revealed follow it."[87]

(2) John Calvin (1509–1564) states: "the obscurity of this passage has produced as usual, various explanations." Even though Calvin considers a number of options, he concludes (in agreement with Beza, Doddridge, Macknight, and Scott) "that the reference is to what was done in the time of Noah, that is, that Christ by the Spirit employed him as a preacher of righteousness, though with no success, as the spirits of the men to whom he preached were then in prison, reserved, as the fallen angels are represented to be, for the judgment of the last day."[88] In spite of his election focus, at least Calvin (like others) was correct to place the event historically in the time of Noah rather than at the time of Christ's entombment.

If it refers to people of Noah's time still alive, then death is not death—either for Christ or for the people of Noah's day—and Satan was right to disagree with the Creator-Christ about death in Eden. It would mean that Christ is illustrating the idea that humans get a second chance after death, which is never taught in Scripture. It is important that we come to a text like this, not with assumptions from tradition, but with evidence from biblical insights. The hermeneutic of *sola-tota-prima Scriptura* is crucial to rightly interpret Scripture. On the basis

84. Blum, *1 Peter*, vol. 12 in The *Expositor's Bible Commentary*, 242.

85. J. Ramsey Michaels, *1 Peter*, vol. 49 in *Word Biblical Commentary* (Waco, TX: Word, 1988), 204.

86. Ibid., 210.

87. Martin Luther, *The Catholic Epistles*, vol. 30 in *Luther's Works*, ed. Jaroslav Pelikan (St. Louis, MO: Concordia, 1967), 113–115.

88. John Calvin, *The Catholic Epistles*, vol. 22 in *Calvin's Commentaries*, trans. and ed. John Owen (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1989), 2:116, see 112–116.

of these texts, it is clear that death means death, and no human who dies lives on after death; and so the people of Noah's day would not still be living, and so any preaching to those of Noah's day would mean preaching to them while they lived in Noah's day, and not after they died.

Resurrection

Christ's laying aside of His divine powers (*kenōsis*, Phil. 2:7) while remaining divine in His incarnate life is preceded and followed by the Trinity's acting jointly in His incarnation (John 3:16; Matt. 1:20; Heb. 10:5–7) and in His resurrection (Heb. 13:20; Rom. 8:9–11; John 10:18). In other words, Christ acted as God in His incarnation and in His resurrection, but did not act as God for Himself in His interim human life. It is not true, as R. C. H. Lenski claims, that the "soul or spirit of Christ was returned from Paradise, from the Father's hands (Luke 23:43, 46), where it had been since the moment he expired on the cross, God returned Christ's spirit to the body in the tomb."[89]

There is no separation of body and spirit (soul).[90] Christ is quoting David's Psalm 31:4–5: "Keep me free from the trap that is set for me, for you are my refuge. Into your hands I commit my spirit; deliver me, LORD, my faithful God." Joel Green rightly concludes, "Employing this psalm, Jesus manifests his own faith in the sovereign God whom, he believes, will rescue him from the hands of his enemies." Thus "we may hear in Jesus' prayer his faith in the God who raises from the dead."[91] Green adds: "Jesus' entrusting his 'spirit' need not be read as a reference to the separation of his body and spirit at death. Such a reading owes more to a Cartesian anthropology than to that shared by Luke's contemporaries." For "πνεῦμα refers to 'life (in its totality).'"[92] Stephen uttered the same prayer as Christ when he said: "Lord Jesus, receive my spirit" (Acts 7:59). Whereas Christ committed Himself to the Father, Stephen committed himself to Christ, indicating the equality of the Father and Son as God.[93]

89. R. C. H. Lenski, *The Interpretation of St. Paul's Epistles to Galatians, Ephesians, and Philippians* (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg, 1961, 1st ed. 1937), 416.

90. See chapter 3.

91. Green, *The Gospel of Luke*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament*, 826.

92. Ibid., 826n57.

93. See I. Howard Marshall, *Acts*, vol. 5 in *Tyndale New Testament Commentaries* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988, 1st ed. 1980), 150; F. F. Bruce, *Acts*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), 160. Because humans are a totality of soul and body that is just as indivisible as the divine and human in Jesus Christ (although there is no comparison of the two parts in this comparison of indivisibility of the two), Calvin (like so many) shows he did not understand this biblical anthropology, when he said "we know our souls do not wander up and down when they flit out of our bodies, but that Christ receiveth them, that he may keep them faithfully, if we commend them into his hands," Calvin, *Acts*, vol. 18 in *Calvin's Commentaries*, 319.

EMPTY TOMB

Christ's empty tomb is clearly recorded in Scripture, with supernatural events that made it possible. Just as the resurrection of Christ was an act of the Trinity, so there was a violent earthquake, and an angel came from heaven to roll back the stone (which had been sealed with a Roman seal and was guarded by Romans sentinels). The angel's appearance was as bright as lightning and the guards were terrified; "they shook and became like dead men" (Matt. 28:1–4). "The angel said to the women, 'Do not be afraid, for I know that you are looking for Jesus, who was crucified. He is not here; he has risen, just as he said. Come and see the place where he lay'" (Matt. 28:5, 6; cf. Mark 16:6; Luke 24:1–8; John 20:1–9). The angel said, "He is going ahead of you into Galilee. There you will see him, just as he told you" (Mark 16:7).[94]

Perhaps the greatest evidence of the empty tomb and resurrection of Jesus was the transforming effects these realities had on Christ's followers. Scared disciples were radically transformed into bold preachers as they went forth to share the good news of Christ's resurrection. They rejoiced in the resurrection as they shared the company of Christ for forty following His coming forth a conqueror from the grave. Their utter boldness reflected Christ's victory, a fantastic miracle that would be impossible if the empty tomb (and resurrection) had been a hoax.

BODILY RESURRECTION

The Gospel accounts clearly detail the resurrection of Christ (as well as His life, death, and present ministry in heaven's sanctuary). Christ arose bodily from the dead. That is why doubting Thomas could put his hand into His crucifixion scars (John 20:24–28); Mary of Magdala could cling to Him (John 20:17); the two Marys could clasp His feet (Matt. 28:8–10); and Christ could take bread, break it, and give it to two disciples (Luke 24:30). These events indicate that Christ's resurrection was a bodily resurrection. There is a bodily continuity between the Jesus of Calvary and the Jesus of resurrection. Christ didn't need to be changed from corruptibility to incorruptibility, or from mortality to immortality, for He was sinless and divine (1 Tim. 1:17; 6:16) throughout His life on

94. "Those who want to dispute the empty tomb of Jesus must show that contempotary Jewish witnesses to belief in the resurrection included some who did not think the resurrection of the dead need have anything at all to do with the body in the tomb. They must also assume that such views (not thus far attested) were sufficiently popular in Palestine, else the first Christians could not have successfully preached the resurrection of Jesus if his body had been intact in the tomb. Even then, an explanation would still be needed as to why the Gospels present debates between Christians and their opponents regarding what happened to the body. So long as no proofs are offered on these points, we must assume that the tomb of Jesus was in fact empty," Wolfhart Pannenberg, *Systematic Theology*, trans. Geoffrey W. Bromiley (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1994, Ger. ed. 1991), 2:358–359.

earth, and thus different from all His followers who will be raised at His second advent (1 Cor. 15:50–57; 1 Thess. 4:16–18).

Christ raised Lazarus from the dead (John 11:38–44), and He will raise all His followers from their graves in His second advent (1 Thess. 4:16–18). This is why Christ said to Martha, "I am the resurrection and the life" (John 11:25a). This is why Christ participated with the Father and the Spirit in His resurrection (Acts 4:10; Rom. 8:11; Gal. 1:1; John 10:18). The other side of Calvary is resurrection. The two are held together like two sides of a coin. The one leads to the other. The one is not victory without the other. Resurrection completed Calvary and makes it the ultimate decisive battle in the cosmic controversy. The victory of Calvary is manifest in the resurrection of Christ in the past and in the future resurrections.

Gordon Fee sees Paul arguing for a bodily resurrection in 1 Corinthians 15, and that "He simply would not have understood the double-talk of Christian existentialism, which affirms 'resurrection language' theologically but denies that anything actually happened as an event in history."[95] On the basis of Christ's resurrection the "next event in this scheme happens at the *coming* of Christ, when he raises from the dead those who are his."[96] Herman Bavinck says that "everything depends on the *physical* resurrection of Christ." For, "if Christ did not arise physically, then death, then sin, then he who had the power of death has not been defeated. In that case, actually, not Christ but Satan came out the victor."[97]

IMPORTANCE OF THE RESURRECTION

The Sadducees didn't believe in the resurrection (Mark 12:18; Acts 23:8), nor did Hymenaeus and Philetus who "departed from the truth" (2 Tim. 2:18), nor did some Christians in Corinth (1 Cor. 15:12). Why is Christ's resurrection so important? Without His resurrection, all that Christ accomplished through His life and death would be of no avail, and His continuing ministry wouldn't be possible. Paul said to the Corinthians, "if Christ has not been raised, our preaching is useless and so is your faith…if Christ has not been raised, your faith is futile; you are still in your sins. Then those also who have fallen asleep in Christ are lost. If only for this life we have hope in Christ, we are of all people most to be pitied" (1 Cor. 15:14, 17–19). To doubt His resurrection is to doubt a work of God.

Without Christ's resurrection, the death of Christ would have been a defeat. His resurrection began a new phase of His work of salvation in heaven's sanctuary,

95. Gordon D. Fee, *First Corinthians*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1987), 743.

96. Ibid., 753.

97. Herman Bavinck, *Sin and Salvation*, vol. 3 in *Reformed Dogmatics*, trans. John Vriend (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2006), 442.

which is brought out in two books—Hebrews and Revelation. Peter included the importance of His resurrection in His Pentecost presentation:

> Fellow Israelites, I can tell you confidently that the patriarch David died and was buried, and his tomb is here to this day. But he was a prophet and knew that God had promised him on oath that he would place one of his descendants on his throne. Seeing what was to come, he spoke of the resurrection of the Messiah, that he was not abandoned to the realm of the dead, nor did his body see decay. God has raised this Jesus to life, and we are all witnesses of it. Exalted to the right hand of God, he has received from the Father the promised Holy Spirit and has poured out what you now see and hear. For David did not ascend to heaven, and yet he said, "The Lord said to my Lord: 'Sit at my right hand until I make your enemies a footstool for your feet.'" [quoting Ps. 110:1] Therefore let all Israel be assured of this: God has made this Jesus, whom you crucified, both Lord and Messiah. (Acts 2:29–36)

Peter clearly distinguished between a non-resurrection of David and the resurrection of Jesus. As we explored in chapters 2 and 3, this agrees with the fact that souls are not immortal (they die), and only receive immortality at the second advent of Christ (1 Thess. 4:16–18).

Scripture says Christ "was delivered over to death for our sins and was raised to life for our justification" (Rom. 4:25). His ministry in the heavenly sanctuary is crucial to our redemption (applying the benefits of His death) and to the restoration of the universe, so that the cosmic controversy can be resolved, and a new heaven and a new earth, free from the controversy, can begin an eternity of peace and tranquility. The resurrected Christ, on the basis of His life and death, ministers as King-Priest in heaven's sanctuary, which is the subject of the next chapter.

CHRIST'S CONTINUING REVELATION OF GOD

Forty days followed the resurrection (Acts 1:3) in which the same sympathetic, comforting, and loving Savior continued to reveal what God is like, as He did in His life and in His death. We will mention a few examples.

Mary wondered where Jesus was laid, for the tomb was empty. Then she recognized Jesus, and with great joy hugged Him. "Jesus said, 'Do not hold on to me, for I have not yet ascended to the Father. Go instead to my brothers and tell them, "I am ascending to my Father and your Father, to my God and your God"'" (John 20:17). Christ's words "Do not hold on to me" (NIV, RSV, PHILLIPS, TEV) or "Cling to Me" (GOODSPEED, NEB, NASB, NKJV, ESV) convey His deep compassion, not captured by "Touch me not" (KJV). After all, He entered into that hug and delayed His departure to heaven in order to comfort one who longed to see Him. That's what God is like.

Christ entered that embrace, demonstrating His love for Mary, and then finally said, "Let me go now, Mary, so that I can go to My Father and to your Father." Here is family talk at its best—*My Father, your Father.* Imagine how the angels longed to welcome Christ home to heaven, how God the Father and the Holy Spirit were ready to do the same. But Christ kept them waiting, because He wanted to minster to one who sorrowed for Him. Christ put everything on hold for the sake of one who needed Him. What an awesome God!

Two of Christ's "brothers" were discouraged as they walked on the road to Emmaus. Unknown to them, Jesus joined them, asking what they were discussing. Their faces were downcast. They thought this stranger must be the only one who had not heard of the news of Christ's crucifixion (Luke 24:13–15). Christ asked them what had happened. They recounted how the chief priests and rulers had handed Christ over to be crucified, adding mournfully that "we had hoped that he was the one who was going to redeem Israel," and yet He had died. They recounted how "some women of our company amazed us. They were at the tomb early in the morning, and when they did not find his body, they came back saying that they had even seen a vision of angels, who said that he was alive" (Luke 24:22–23, ESV).

The quickest way to get them to cheer up would have been an instant revelation to them that He was the risen Christ. But Christ didn't choose to do this. He knew that their failure to understand His death was due to their not having taken the time to study the Old Testament Scriptures. So Christ said to them:

> "How foolish you are, and how slow to believe all that the prophets have spoken! Did not the Messiah have to suffer these things and then enter his glory?" And beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he explained to them what was said in all the Scriptures concerning himself. (Luke 24:25–27)

Although Christ's presence during the forty days gives empirical evidence that He had risen, Christ didn't direct these discouraged disciples to Himself, but to the Scriptures that speak about Him. He wanted them to be grounded in Scripture, for the Old Testament Scriptures with their writing about Him were God's revelation to humanity long before Christ came personally to reveal what God is like (John 14:9). The fact that His disciples didn't understand what was happening on His ascension day (Acts 1:6–8) demonstrates Christ's insight when He previously said to them, "I have much more to say to you, more than you can now bear. But when he, the Spirit of truth, comes, he will guide you into all the truth. He will not speak on his own; he will speak only what he hears, and he will tell you what is yet to come" (John 16:12–13).[98]

98. Part of the Spirit's guidance led the Gospel writers to link the mission of Jesus with Old Testament prophecies or statements concerning it (Matt. 1:22; 2:15, 17, 23; 4:14; 8:17; 12:17; 13:35; 21:4; 27:9; 27:35; Mark 15:28; John 12:38; 18:32; 19:24, 28, 36). Clearly The Holy Spirit primarily used Matthew to record these connections.

This indicates how important the Old and New Testament revelation is to the cause of Christ, to His church, and its commission to the world. Even the Holy Spirit didn't speak on His own account. Christ knew His disciples needed further revelation from the Spirit of Truth to guide them into all truth they did not yet understand. How tragic that many theologians believe the New Testament documents are merely human witnesses to Christ. On the contrary, Christ knew that His disciples needed much more than that.

Christ knew that His disciples needed to know more about Him and His mission, and much would be revealed in the New Testament about these matters. The forty days gave Christ an opportunity to explain His crucifixion and resurrection, not merely from His own accounting, but from a Christ-directed Bible study into Old Testament revelation. Prior to these events, Jesus had spoken about His crucifixion and resurrection on the third day (Matt. 12:40; 20:18–19; 27:63; Mark 8:31; 9:31; 10:33, 34; 14:58; 15:29; Luke 18:31–33; 24:46; John 2:19–20; cf. Matt. 26:61; 27:40), but the record of the disciples' discouragement proved they had not understood what He said.

The overriding reason why they did not understand was because their religious tradition was etched so deeply into their consciousness that their preconceived idea of the Messiah was hard to replace—even with the teaching of Christ, and even though He often referred back to the Old Testament prophecies or statements that were being fulfilled in His mission (Matt. 13:14; 26:52–54, 56; Mark 14:49; Luke 4:18–21; 21:22; 24:44; John 13:18; 15:25; 17:12; 18:9). Christ told Peter, James, and John not to say anything about the transfiguration "until the Son of Man had risen from the dead. They kept the matter to themselves, discussing what 'rising from the dead' meant" (Mark 9:9b–10). Even at the empty tomb of Christ, the apostle John records, "They still did not understand from Scripture that Jesus had to rise from the dead" (John 20:9).

The two discouraged disciples knew that Christ had died, and they knew that it was the third day after His death, yet they failed to understand the good news of these two facts. So as a patient teacher, Christ took them back to the same Old Testament revelation that He had used on several occasions to explain His mission. So Christ directed them to the written Word of God before revealing that He was the Living Word of God. He was revealed later when He broke bread and gave it to them (Luke 24:30). Jesus appeared to these two disciples to encourage them and ground them in Scripture. He had once said, "If you continue in My word, then you are truly disciples of

Mine; and you will know the truth, and the truth will make you free" (John 8:31–32, NASB).

This dramatically illustrates how difficult it is for humans to give up their religious or theological traditions when confronted by contrary revelation from God, whether the Living or written Words. The solution? Christ pointed to the coming of the Spirit (Acts 1:8). The Spirit of Truth, promised by Christ, now came to "guide them into all truth" and to empower them to proclaim it, and not one without the other. For the disciples needed both understanding (revelation of the truth) and unction (empowerment to reveal it to others).

The Holy Spirit directed Peter the Pentecost preacher to Old Testament Revelation, to the prophecy of Joel, and to its promise of visions and dreams for Christ's followers (Joel 2:17–18), and to the gospel good news that "everyone who calls on the name of the LORD will be saved" (Joel 2:32), which goes back to God's Word in Genesis. In the covenant with Abraham, all nations of the world are to be blessed through his descendants (Gen. 12:2–3), which far transcends the tradition of a national kingdom. Christ and the Holy Spirit honored God's Word above tradition, and so should Christians.[99]

For forty days Jesus spoke about the kingdom of God (Acts 1:3), not about the kingdom of Judah. Under the Holy Spirit's leading, the Gospel writers would speak of the kingdom of God as the kingdom of heaven. That eschatological kingdom would include peoples from all nations, so the gospel was not restricted to a national dream but gave hope to all nations of the world (Rev. 14:6). Hence Christ's commission to take the good news to all the world, and the promise that He would be with them through the Holy Spirit (Matt. 28:18–20; John 14:16–18).

During those forty days the risen Redeemer revealed what the kingdom of heaven is like and how the King will treat His citizens. The glorified Christ was the same as the Christ of the Incarnation, for He is still the Son of Man as well as being the Son of God, for "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8). That is why the angels from heaven at His ascension said to His disciples, "'This same Jesus…will come back" (Acts 1:11b).

99. All disciples, no matter in what generation, need the same baptism of the Holy Spirit, the Author of Scripture, to enable them to rise above human traditions and proclaim God's revelation. In postmodernity, when everyone thinks and does what is right in his or her own eyes, we need this baptism of the Holy Spirit in great measure, and there is a coming Pentecost in our end time (Joel 2:28–29) which we will study in the doctrine of eschatology, volume 4 of my *Systematic Theology.* The works of the Holy Spirit are always in harmony with Scripture. For example, they will manifest the fruit of the Spirit (Gal. 5:22–23; cf. Matt. 7:16, 18–20), and the difference between true and false prophets (which Christ spoke about, Matt. 24:11) can be tested by Scripture (1 Thess. 5:20–22; 1 John 4:1–3; cf. Deut. 18:21–22; Isa. 8:20; Jer. 28:9; Jas. 1:17).

Conclusion

In Christ's life on earth we find a dramatic contrast between Christ and Satan. Christ came to set the captives free (Luke 4:18–21; Isa. 61:1–2; Ps. 146:6–9) which He accomplished through His teachings (John 8:32) and miracles, while Satan came to enslave humans. Satan and his angels possessed humans to exercise sovereign-like power over them, disallowing them freedom of choice. Christ exorcized the demons and set these people free so they could enjoy freedom of mind and body. Perhaps the way Satan controlled demon-possessed victims and the way Christ sets them free gives insight into the two sides of the controversy—how destinies are decided in both arenas. Christ said, "[M]y Father's will is that everyone who looks to the Son and believes in him shall have eternal life, and I will raise them up at the last day" (John 6:40).

Calvary was an eschatological event. It was God's determinative victory over Satan and his rebels. It decided their destiny (Rev. 12:9–11). Christ's victory at the cross was the completion of a life that revealed what God is really like (John 14:9). At Calvary the universe saw that God was willing to die for those who rebelled against Him. They gazed into the depths of His love and justice. He, the Sinless One, took the place of sinners. Satan's claim that God was unloving and unjust was utterly exposed as a lie. By contrast they saw who worked behind the scenes to crucify Christ. Satan had dogged His footsteps throughout life to get Him to sin, and he had fiendishly worked through Jewish leaders, Roman authority, and the rabble to crucify Him.

On Calvary redemption and rebellion met head on. Christ died for sinners. Satan crucified the Sinless One. What a stark contrast. Calvary was the ultimate revelation of God and Satan. Not God, but Satan was exposed as unloving and unjust at Calvary. The universe noticed the startling distinction. And in that double revelation at the cross, Christ answered the charges in the cosmic controversy. That's why Calvary is the ultimate revelation of both sides of the controversy.

That is why this system submits that Calvary defines God, His plan of salvation and predestination—see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapters 8, 14–15—better than any other self-revelation of God. The Cross made possible the present ministry of Christ in heaven's sanctuary, which we take up in the next chapter.

Study Questions

1. How does the Greek of John 1:14 indicate the extent of the Incarnation?
2. Could the Incarnation have taken place if God were only one Person?

3. What are the biblical evidences that Jesus Christ was (1) fully God and (2) fully man? Is this evidence demonstrated in the Synoptics?
4. How does the Greek of John 1:1 emphasize that Christ was God?
5. What is the meaning of the *kenōsis* in Philippians 2:5–8?
6. What is involved, and not involved, in God's becoming human? Please explain both answers.
7. What does "only begotten" mean and not mean with reference to Christ?
8. Did Christ have a pre-Fall or post-Fall human nature, or are there deeper dimensions that need to be understood? Fully explain.
9. Why did Jesus become human? Give as many reasons as you can.
10. What is the meaning of Romans 8:13?
11. How would you compare the pre-Fall Adam and the humanity of Christ? How would you best describe the humanity of Christ?
12. Was Christ omnipresent during His incarnational life? Fully explain.
13. What is the biblical evidence that the risen Christ is not omnipresent?
14. How was Christ tempted like other humans? In His temptations, did Christ have an advantage over other humans, or was He at a disadvantage? Fully explain.
15. How should we interpret 1 Peter 3:18–20?

CHAPTER TEN

King-Priest

Purpose

1. Comprehend the meaning of Christ as Priest, in His redeeming-restoring work.
2. Document that restoration includes intercession and judgment as functions of the King-Priest, and so foundationally belongs to Christology.

Summary

Isaiah says, "The LORD is our judge, the LORD is our lawgiver, the LORD is our king; it is he who will save us" (Isa. 33:22). Zechariah predicts that Christ "will be a priest on his throne" (Zech. 6:13). With respect to Zechariah 6:13, it has been said, "Nowhere else in the Old Testament is it made so plain that the coming Davidic king will also be a priest,"[1] except possibly Psalm 110.[2] The throne is "the promised Davidic throne (2 Sam 7:16; Isa 9:7; Luke 1:32)" that the coming Messiah will occupy.[3] Since His ascension, Christ is seated at God's right hand (Ps. 110:1; Matt. 22:44; Acts 2:34–36; Heb. 1:1–13) as "a priest forever, in the order of Melchizedek" (Ps. 110:4; cf. Heb. 5:6; 7:1–21). Here is

1. Joyce G. Baldwin, *Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi: An Introduction and Commentary*, vol. 24 in *The Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1972), 137.
2. Kenneth L. Barker, *Zechariah*, vol. 7 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1985), 640.
3. Ibid.

Christ as King-Priest.[4] The inauguration of Christ as King-Priest is revealed in Hebrews 1:8–13 and Revelation 4–5.[5] Christ "was designated (*prosagoreutheis*) by God to be high priest in the order of Melchizedek" (Heb. 5:10). In Psalms (110:4) and Hebrews (Heb. 5:6, 10; 7:1–3, 15–17), Melchizedek was a King-Priest (Gen. 14:18). Like Melchizedek, Christ has no beginning or end, and is a "king of righteousness" (Heb. 7:3; Heb. 1:8). The cosmic significance of the cross opens up the cosmic significance of Christ as King-Priest at the right hand of God, on the throne of heaven in the sanctuary. Zechariah prophesied that Joshua would be a king-priest, a type of Christ ("Branch," Isa. 11:1; Jer. 23:5; 33:15). Based on the sanctuary model, Christ became a priest after He had a sacrifice to administer (Heb. 8:2; 9:15; 10:12). He could only be the King-Priest because He was God, lived a human life, and died to save all humans. Only one Person in the universe can be *the* King-Priest, with the authority to redeem and to restore. No priest in the earthly sanctuary has been qualified to fill that role (Heb. 4:14–16; 5:3; 7:26–27; 9:15, 24–27; 10:1–14)—not God's followers in the Old Testament as a "kingdom of priests" (Exod. 19:6), nor the "royal priesthood" of the New Testament (1 Pet. 2:9).

Outline

I. Introduction
II. Throne of David
A. Psalm 110
B. Present Rule of David
III. King-Priest: During the Final Day of Atonement
A. More Than Calvary
B. Christ at the Throne
C. First Phase: Redemption
D. Second Phase: Resolution
E. The Truth as It Is in Jesus
IV. Pre-Advent Judgment
A. Opposed by Most Christians
B. Redemption and Restoration: Solving the Sin Problem
C. Contemporary Research: Two Ministries and Theodicy
V. Conclusion
VI. Study Questions

4. C. F. Keil and F. Delitzsch, *Zechariah*, vol. 10 in *Commentary on the Old Testament in Ten Volumes* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1986), 2:300.

5. See my article "Revelation 4 and 5: Judgment or Inauguration?" in *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, 8/1–2 (1997): 59–81.

Introduction

It could be rightly argued that Christ was our High Priest from His ascension to heaven until the end of His intercession in heaven's sanctuary. During this time He is seated on His Father's throne (Heb. 1:1–3) and does not receive His own throne until after His priestly ministry is ended. Nevertheless, I call Him a King-Priest from His inauguration (Rev. 5:7–10), because when He sat down on His Father's throne, His Father said to Him (referring to the prophecy in Gen. 22:17), "You are a priest forever, in the order of Melchizedek" (Heb. 5:6; cf. 5:10; 6:20; 7:1–3, 11, 15, 17, 24, 28). Melchizedek is a type of Christ, and he was a king-priest (Gen. 14:18). The repetitive linking of Christ's priesthood to the king-priesthood of Melchizedek seems to imply that Christ is the King-Priest throughout His priestly ministry in heaven's sanctuary.

It can also be argued that though God called Christ God (Heb. 1:8)—which of course He was—that verse (Heb. 1:8) points to a future time when Christ is seated on His own throne: "Your throne, O God, will last for ever and ever; a scepter of justice will be the scepter of your kingdom," adding, "Sit at my right hand until I make your enemies a footstool for your feet" (Heb. 1:8, 13). This seems to imply that Christ will be seated on His Father's throne until the Father has made all Christ's enemies subject to Him, which means until the end of the cosmic controversy at the end of the Millennium. Then Christ will sit on His own throne, and begin His reign. This fulfills the prophecy made at the birth of Christ, "The Lord God [Father] will give him [Christ] the throne of his father David, and he will reign over Jacob's descendants [Israel, or all the redeemed] forever; his kingdom will never end" (Luke 1:32–33).

In summary, it is biblical to say that Christ became our King-Priest when He sat down on His Father's throne. His mission will continue until the close of the cosmic controversy. At that time He will move to His own throne and begin to reign as King over all the redeemed. Between these two events, Christ comes in the second advent as King of kings (Rev. 19:16), because He was victorious at Calvary.

In 1975 Nils A. Dahl, professor at Yale Divinity School, wrote about God being the neglected factor in New Testament theology.[6] I would add that the ministry of Christ as King-Priest has never been fully developed in biblical or systematic theology. Bruce Demarest rightly states, "whether or not Jesus bodily rose from the grave profoundly affects the future resurrection of those who trust him. Likewise his ascension to heaven, session at the Father's right hand, and

6. Nils A. Dahl, "The Neglected Factor in New Testament Theology," in *Jesus the Christ: The Historical Origins of Christological Doctrine*, ed. Donald H. Juel (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1991), 153–163; originally published in *Reflections* 75 (1975): 5–8.

continuing intercession on our behalf significantly impacts the quality and permanence of the spiritual life we profess to have received."[7] Demarest is right about Christ's present ministry as the only one we need:

> The two poles of Christ's *priestly ministry* consist of his earthly oblation and his heavenly representation of the people of God. Through his sacrifice on the cross, Christ has washed away past sins and blotted out guilt. But the risen Christ continues his priestly ministry in the heavenly sanctuary forever (Ps 110:4; Heb 5:6; 7:17, 21).... Believers have no need for any earthly priest or human mediator to represent us before God (1 Tim 2:5). Confidently, then, look to Jesus Christ as your divine Advocate and Intercessor.[8]

The aim of this chapter is to present Christ's post-resurrection ministry in heaven's sanctuary. It is noted that His ministry affects soteriology and eschatology, which will be taken up under those headings later in the system—soteriology follows in this volume, and eschatology in volume 4. In this chapter, we will establish that Christ has a twofold ministry in heaven's sanctuary as the present dimension of Christology.

Calvary was the judgment day that qualified Jesus Christ, as High Priest and King, to be inaugurated as King-Priest, with a later rule to follow. Long after the redemption and restoration of Jesus Christ is completed, the Cross will be the ultimate revelation to the universe of the truth about the Trinity and the truth about the rebellion against them. Rebellion will never arise again (Rev. 21:2–4; 22:3–5) because the redeeming and restoring work of Jesus Christ will be forever accepted. The enormous sacrifice made at Calvary will impact all intelligent beings, and keep them loyal to the relational Trinity who mean everything to them. That sin will not arise again seems to be clear from two statements about the new earth:

> I saw the Holy City, the new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride beautifully dressed for her husband. And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, "Look! God's dwelling place is now among the people, and he will dwell with them. They will be his people, and God himself will be with them and be their God. 'He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death' or mourning or crying or pain, for the old order of things has passed away." (Rev. 21:2–4)
>
> No longer will there be any curse. The throne of God and of the Lamb will be in the city, and his servants will serve him. They will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads. There will be no more night. They will not need the light of a lamp or the light of the sun, for the Lord God will give them light. And they will reign for ever and ever. (Rev. 22:3–5)

7. Bruce Demarest, *The Cross and Salvation: The Doctrine of Salvation* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 1997), 46.
8. Ibid., 199.

It is important to keep in mind that the ministry of the King-Priest is cosmic as well as for all humans.[9] Jesus Christ is Redeemer (see previous chapter) and Restorer (current chapter), and not one without the other, for the one requires the other. In other words, the sequential ministry of Christ on earth and in heaven embraces His mission for humans and the cosmos.[10] Delitzsch states it well: "Redemption is the beginning and the judgment the end of His work."[11]

Throne of David

God promised David: "Your house and your kingdom will endure forever before me; your throne will be established forever" (2 Sam. 7:16; cf. Ps. 89:3–4, 35–37; Jer. 17:24–25); "I will establish his line forever, his throne as long as the heavens endure" (Ps. 89:29).[12] Critics may say there hasn't been a king on David's throne since the last king of Judah, well over two thousand years ago, and the heavens are still enduring! So was this promise conditional? Conditionality is one answer, for God said to David: "If your sons keep my covenant and

9. Scripture says Christ is "appointed heir of all things, and through whom also he [God] made the universe" (Heb. 1:2b, *ta panta).* For "by him all things [*ta panta*] were created" (Col. 1:16a). How does Scripture define "all things"? Scripture specifies "all things" as "things in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or powers or rulers or authorities [note that all four nouns are plural] all things [*ta panta*] have been created through him and for him" (Col. 1:16b). The first context is creation. Christ created these thrones and rulers in heaven and on earth. The only throne mentioned in Scripture prior to sin's entrance is the throne of Lucifer (Satan, Isa. 14:13). Did Christ create many thrones and rulers in heaven, or is this an insight into places in the heavens that had thrones or rulers (Adam-like leaders of different worlds), which seems to be indicated in the presence of Adam-like rulers who came to a council in heaven, just as Satan (who took Adam's place) came to represent the world (Job 1:6–7; Job 2:1–2)? Origin, Hilary of Poitiers, and the Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed (325 and 381) are proof that some believed there were worlds (plural) in God's creation.

The second context is Calvary. "God was pleased to have all his fullness dwell in him [Christ], and through him to reconcile to himself all things [*ta panta*], whether things on earth or things in heaven, by making peace through his blood, shed on the cross" (Col. 1:19–20). We can understand that Christ made all things in heaven and earth, but what does it mean that through His cross Christ reconciles all things in heaven and earth. Evidently the Cross affects more than sinners needing salvation, for no one in heaven (or in the heavens) needs salvation. Reconciling all things means Calvary brings resolution to the cosmic controversy. For Christ's death doesn't redeem all things, but it does reconcile all things. It resolves the sin problem, which is added to His mission to save willing humans.

10. Restoration gets into eschatology, the subject of volume 4, so this is only a brief introduction. End-times judgments will resolve the cosmic controversy and the final judgment (when all intelligent created beings are present, redeemed and resurrected wicked). Then, and only then, will all the world be impacted by Calvary, for certainly that has never taken place in human history. Only a minority of humans have been so impacted. But the final judgment day is coming—a day when Christ's words will be fulfilled: "I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to myself" (John 12:32). That's when every being in the universe bows before Christ (Isa. 45:23b; Rom. 14:11; Phil. 2:10–11; Rev. 5:13; 15:3; 19:1–6). We will examine this in greater detail in volume 4.

11. Keil and Delitzsch, *Psalms*, vol. 5 in *Commentary on the Old Testament in Ten Volumes*, tr. James Martin (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1987), 1:91.

12. Even though David was not the first king of Israel, following his reign the royal line was often referred to as "David's throne," even in the days of Jeremiah (Jer. 17:24–25). Later, when Jehoiakim burned the scroll containing the words from God, the Lord said to Jehoiakim: "He will have no one to sit on the throne of David" (Jer. 36:28–30).

the statutes I teach them, then their sons will sit on your throne for ever and ever" (Ps. 132:12).

But is there more to this promise? Could it refer to Christ as King, who is called "the son of David" (Matt. 1:1, cf. vv. 6, 16)? The work of Jesus Christ as King-Priest is so important that Scripture has much to say about it. One way Scripture speaks of this work is to speak about Christ as the promised King on David's throne. While on earth, Jesus read the following predictions, among others, in the biblical scrolls:

> The scepter will not depart from Judah, nor the ruler's staff from between his feet, until he comes to whom it belongs shall come and the obedience of the nations be his. (Gen. 49:10)
>
> For to us a child is born, to us a son is given, and the government will be on his shoulders. And he will be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace. Of the greatness of his government and peace there will be no end. He will reign on David's throne and over his kingdom, establishing and upholding it with justice and righteousness from that time on and forever. The zeal of the LORD Almighty will accomplish this. (Isa. 9:6–7)
>
> "In those days and at that time I will make a righteous Branch sprout from David's line; he will do what is just and right in the land. In those days Judah will be saved and Jerusalem will live in safety. This is the name by which it will be called: The LORD Our Righteous Savior." For this is what the LORD says: "David will never fail to have a man to sit on the throne of Israel, nor will the Levitical priests ever fail to have a man to stand before me continually to offer burnt offerings, to burn grain offerings and to present sacrifices." (Jer. 33:15–18)
>
> I will place over them one shepherd [not many kings], my servant David, and he will tend them; he will tend them and be their shepherd. I the LORD will be their God, and my servant David will be prince among them. I the LORD have spoken. (Ezek. 34:23–24)

In fact, Mary the mother of Jesus may have told Christ what the angel Gabriel told her about His future ministry: "The Lord God will give him the throne of his father David, and he will reign over Jacob's descendants forever; his kingdom will never end" (Luke 1:32b–33). God says to the ascended Christ seated at His right hand, "Your throne, O God, will last for ever and ever" (Heb. 1:8a). The book of Revelation says of Mary and Jesus: "She gave birth to a son, a male child, who will 'rule all nations with an iron scepter.' And her child was snatched up to God and to his throne" (Rev. 12:5). This takes place at Christ's ascension. Note that the "reign" prophesied by Gabriel concurs with the "rule" and "scepter" stated in connection with the resurrected Christ's going to His Father's throne in heaven.

The New Testament repeatedly mentions that the resurrected Christ "was taken up into heaven and he sat at the right hand of God" (Mark 16:19; cf. Acts 2:23, 34; 5:31; 7:55–56; Rom. 8:34; Eph. 1:20–23; Col. 3:1; Heb. 1:1–3; 1 Pet. 3:22). This event was specifically predicted in royal psalms (Pss. 2, 18, 20, 21, 110): "The LORD says to my lord: 'Sit at my right hand until I make your enemies a footstool for your feet'.... The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind: 'You are a priest forever, in the order of Melchizedek.' The Lord is at your right hand; he will crush kings on the day of his wrath. He will judge the nations, heaping up the dead and crushing the rulers of the whole earth" (Ps. 110:1, 4–6).[13] A footstool represents victory, for the victorious king placed his feet on the neck of the vanquished: (1) Joshua had the victorious commanders place their feet on the vanquished (Josh. 10:24), and (2) Solomon sent a message to Hiram saying: "because of the wars waged against my father David from all sides, he could not build a temple for the Name of the LORD his God until the LORD put his enemies under his feet" (1 Kings 5:3; cf. Isa. 51:23).

With respect to David's victory over all his enemies, he is a type of the son of David, Jesus Christ, who one day will have victory over all His enemies. With respect to the King-Priest rule of Jesus Christ (*Yahweh*), His words are significant: "Heaven is my throne, and the earth is my footstool" (Isa. 66:1a). For unlike other kings, the King of kings has already defeated the enemy at the Cross, and this decisive victory unfolds in history to reveal its irreversible reality. This climaxes in Christ's second advent, when "Coming out of his mouth is a sharp sword with which to strike down the nations. 'He will rule them with an iron scepter'" (Rev. 19:15), and they will be destroyed (vv. 17–21). In the meantime, Christ's reign as King-Priest has been from heaven's throne for nearly two thousand years.

PSALM 110

The fact that Jesus studied Psalm 110 is evidenced by his question to religious teachers:

> "What do you think about the Messiah? Whose son is he?" "The Son of David," they replied. He said to them, "How is it then that David, speaking by the Spirit, calls him 'Lord'? For he says, 'The Lord said to my Lord: "Sit at my right hand until I put your enemies under your feet."' If then David calls him 'Lord,' how can he be his son?" (Matt. 22:42–45; cf. Mark 12:35–37; Luke 20:41–44)

Christ had a burden for His nation; He wanted them to look beyond belief in a merely human Messiah to liberate them from the hated Romans. As the divine Son of God, He is the King-Priest whose rule will liberate the world and the cosmos

13. This is corroborated in another royal psalm: "The kings of the earth rise up and the rulers band together against the LORD and against his anointed [note Father and Son].... The One enthroned in heaven laughs; the Lord scoffs at them. Then he rebukes them in his anger and terrifies them in his wrath, saying, 'I have installed my king on Zion, my holy hill.'... 'You are my Son; today I have become your father. Ask me, and I will make the nations your inheritance, the ends of the earth your possession. You will break them with a rod of iron; you will dash them to pieces like pottery'" (Ps. 2:2, 4–6, 7b–9).

from the cosmic controversy. Joshua (the Old Testament equivalent of the name Jesus) was crowned as a king-priest as a type of Christ (Zech. 6:9–13). Just before His ascension, although His disciples knew the resurrected Christ was God, they asked Him, "'Lord, are you at this time going to restore the kingdom to Israel?' He said to them: 'It is not for you to know the times or dates the Father has set by his own authority. But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit comes on you; and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth'" (Acts 1:6–8). Then moments later "he was taken up before their very eyes" (Acts 1:9), and the descent of the Spirit was given soon after (Acts 2). Pentecost was Christ's first act after His inauguration as King-Priest at God's throne:

> Exalted to the right hand of God, he has received from the Father the promised Holy Spirit and has poured out what you now see and hear. For David did not ascend to heaven, and yet he said, "The Lord said to my Lord: 'Sit at my right hand until I make your enemies a footstool for your feet.'" Therefore let all Israel be assured of this: God has made this Jesus, whom you crucified, both Lord and Messiah. (Acts 2:33–36)

The reign of the King-Priest is corroborated by other passages: (1) "The last enemy to be destroyed is death. For he 'has put everything under his feet'" (1 Cor. 15:26–27a). God said to the resurrected Christ, (2) "Your throne, O God, will last for ever and ever; a scepter of justice will be the scepter of your kingdom. You have loved righteousness and hated wickedness; therefore God, your God, has set you above your companions by anointing you with the oil of joy.... Sit at my right hand until I make your enemies a footstool for your feet" (Heb.1:8–9, 13). When (3) "this priest had offered for all time one sacrifice for sins, he sat down at the right hand of God, and since that time he waits for his enemies to be made his footstool" (Heb. 10:12–13).

This passage documents that Christ was inaugurated, or anointed with oil, as His King-Priest at God's throne after His ascension; He will be victorious over all His enemies, and His rule will last forever. It documents that He, the one King David, fulfilled all the promises made to Israel.[14] As Paul expresses

14. In His resurrection Christ fulfilled all the promises given to Israel, and to David. "For no matter how many promises God has made, they are 'Yes' in Christ" (2 Cor. 1:20). For "the promises were spoken to Abraham and to his seed. Scripture does not say 'and to seeds,' meaning many people, but 'and to your seed,' meaning one person, who is Christ" (Gal. 3:16). Where Israel failed, Jesus succeeded. The original promise to Abraham was to be "a father of many nations" (Gen. 17:5), with heirs as countless as the stars and sand (Gen. 22:17), which transcends race (Israel) and region (Palestine).

In Christ the distinction between Israel and other nations has been removed (Eph. 2:13–14), so they have become "one new humanity" (Eph. 2:15), "one body" (Eph. 3:6), "a holy temple" (Eph. 2:21), and one "olive tree" (Rom. 11:24). "In other words, it is not the children by physical descent who are God's children, but it is the children of the promise who are regarded as Abraham's offspring" (Rom. 9:8). So Paul addressed Christ's disciples as "the Israel of God" (Gal. 6:16b). In Christ, Christians, as heirs of the promise, constitute the new Israel of God, made up of every race, including Jews.

it: "What God promised our fathers he has fulfilled for us, their children, by raising up Jesus. As it is written in the second Psalm: 'You are my son; today I have become your father.' [Ps. 2:7b] The fact that God raised him from the dead, never to decay, is stated in these words: 'I will give you the holy and sure blessings promised to David'" (Acts 13:32–34). Paul's inspired commentary on Psalm 2 is about the inauguration of Christ as His King-Priest at the throne in heaven. Psalm 2 says: The Father is "enthroned in heaven" and proclaims, "I have installed my king...You are my Son; today I have become your father" (Ps. 2:4–7). He was King from His inauguration. In fact, Peter says of Jesus that He "has gone into heaven and is at God's right hand—with angels, authorities and powers in submission to him" (1 Pet. 3:22). That is an enormous realm over which to rule, implying the cosmos and all its inhabitants, and indicating the impact of Christ's life and death on these persons.

The eternity of Christ's rule is expressed many times in Scripture: (1) "The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Messiah, and he will reign for ever and ever" (Rev. 11:15b). Yet Scripture also says that after Christ's victory over all of His enemies, (2) "then the Son himself will be made subject to him who put everything under him, so that God may be all in all.... Then the end will come, when he hands over the kingdom to God the Father after he has destroyed all dominion, authority and power. For he must reign until he has put all enemies under his feet. The last enemy to be destroyed is death" (1 Cor. 15:28, 24–26). At first glance these texts seem contradictory. But not when we allow Scripture to solve the problem. Where is the King-Priest ruling? His rule is at the Father's right hand, and because of this one would expect that it is a joint rule with the Father on His throne. Scripture corroborates this conclusion: "The kings of the earth rise up and the rulers band together against the LORD and against his anointed" (Ps. 2:2).

The joint rule is borne out in the joint coming in the Second Advent. Even though the Second Advent is traditionally called the second advent of Christ, Christ predicted: "I say to all of you: From now on you will see the Son of Man sitting at the right hand of the Mighty One and coming on the clouds of heaven" (Matt. 26:64). Hence it seems that the shared rule with the Father is from Christ's installation onward, is manifested in the Second Advent, and will continue eternally. Scripture says "The kingdom of the world has

By virtue of the completion of His mission on the cross, the resurrected Christ spoke to His eleven disciples as the antitypical King David, saying, "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you. And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age" (Matt. 28:18–20). It is this King David who ascended to heaven, and was inaugurated into His eternal rule at the Father's right hand (Rev. 4–5). These insights are gained from a proper understanding of the sanctuary ministry as a vital process that follows a sacrifice, both in type and antitype.

become [prophetic perfect][15] the kingdom of our Lord and of his Messiah, and he will reign for ever and ever" (Rev. 11:15b). Robert Mounce suggests that in the future Christ will "share the eternal rule of God"; it will be a "joint sovereignty."[16] Alan F. Johnson says the kingdom of God and of Christ is "a dual kingdom eternal in its duration,"[17] and Grant Osborne says, "The kingdom belongs to both equally."[18] So Christ fulfills the promise made to Israel that the Davidic rule will be eternal.

PRESENT RULE OF DAVID

Clearly Scripture predicts an eternal rule of David on His throne, which of course could not be realized by the first king David. Biblical evidence examined above indicates that since His installation on heaven's throne at His Father's side, Christ (son of David) has experienced a joint rule with the Father. The King-Priest rule of Christ continues until redemption and restoration is completed. Christ's handing over of the Kingdom to the Father means that Christ will no longer function as King-Priest (for redemption and restoration); rather, He will join the Father as King and they will rule forever on the other side of the completed work of Christ. In other words, after the King-Priest functions are completed, Christ rejoins the Trinity in a joint rule for eternity. For the joint rule of the Trinity apparently began at the creation of intelligent beings and continued until Jesus left heaven to launch His mission to redeem humans and restore the cosmos to its pre-Fall state. When the pre-Fall state has been restored, then the joint rule of the Trinity will resume. This means there is no future time when Jesus becomes the new David on an earthly throne, as many scholars believe, ruling over a restored Israel.[19]

Christ's present rule is designed for the completion of redemption and restoration. This double assignment as Redeemer and Restorer has everything to do with the double ministry of Christ in heaven's sanctuary, at the Father's throne. This is why the present ministry of Christ is that of *King-Priest.* Both the priestly ministry and kingly ministry of Christ are required to bring about the fullness of redemption and restoration.

15. Stephen S. Smalley, *The Revelation to John: A Commentary on the Greek Text of the Apocalypse* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2005), 289.

16. Robert H. Mounce, *Revelation*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament*, rev. ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1977), 226.

17. Alan F. Johnson, *Revelation*, vol. 12 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1981), 509.

18. Grant R. Osborne, *Revelation: Baker Exegetical Commentary on the New Testament*, ed. Moisés Silva (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2002), 441.

19. For more on this topic, see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 1, chapter 15.

KING-PRIEST: DURING THE FINAL DAY OF ATONEMENT

Yale University historian Kenneth Latourette was right to say of Christ: "He was also named as savior and as priest who once for all had offered up himself as a sacrifice and continues to make intercession for the faithful to God."[20] Little space is given in many theological systems to Christ's priestly ministry in heaven's sanctuary, even though it spans two millennia, and the book of Hebrews and Revelation documents it. The sanctuary has meaning that demands exploration. Consider the origin of Satan's rebellion in heaven's sanctuary, the investigative judgment in heaven's sanctuary, and the execution of the final judgment from heaven's sanctuary, to destroy sin and sinners. God rules the universe from heaven's sanctuary, and all human history takes place within the scope of that rule. Christ left heaven's sanctuary to come to live and die in human history and ascended to heaven's sanctuary to begin a twofold ministry. The judgment aspect of His ministry is not mentioned in most biblical commentaries and theological systems.

So the sanctuary opens up this further ministry of Christ that the cosmic controversy makes necessary. The controversy questions God, and through the sacrifices and services of the sanctuary, God reveals Himself innocent of the charges against Him. Redemption and resolution are held together in the sanctuary system, and both have everything to do with the ministry of Christ. So the sanctuary presents the whole ministry of Christ from the inception of sin until its resolution, documenting that God is not timeless (as traditional theology teaches), but acts in time through a sequential process.[21] This is the biblical breadth of Christology.

By contrast, traditional systematic theology does not include a Day of Atonement after Christ's sacrifice on the cross. It is argued that atonement was completed at Calvary. However, there is biblical evidence for a post-Calvary Day of Atonement, and thus the evidence will be considered below. This evidence is very important because it has been unintentionally overlooked by most scholars.

Intertextual study of Leviticus 16 provides evidence of the importance of the Day of Atonement in the Jewish religious year, and its link to the ongoing

20. Kenneth Scott Latourette, *A History of Christianity: Beginnings to 1500* (New York: Harper & Row, 1975, 1st ed. 1953), 1:142.

21. It is clear that the sanctuary system is not merely confined to the nation of Israel. Those who limit the sanctuary relevance to a nation whose mission is finished bypass the universal and cosmic significance of the heavenly sanctuary for all intelligent created beings, for redemption and resolution of the cosmic controversy is relevant to all of them. God bears witness to this expanded view: Yahweh said "my house will be called a house of prayer for all nations" (Isa. 56:7b), and Christ repeated these words about the temple (Mark 11:17). This means that even in the Old Testament, and time of Christ, the earthly temple (sanctuary) was in principle available to all humans, just as the gospel was accessible to all humans.

ministry of the King-Priest in heaven's sanctuary today and in the future. In his 1999 book *Literary Artistry in Leviticus*, Wilfried Warning presents evidence for a sole author, noting "that Leviticus has been artistically structured by thirty-seven" divine speeches, and concluding, "This structure seems to substantiate the hypothesis that Lev 16:2–34, the DS [Divine speech] on *Yom Kippur*, is both the structural *and* theological center of Leviticus."[22] This indicates the importance of the Day of Atonement. In this work we will limit our consideration of the structure of Leviticus 16 to examination of its chiastic structure. A chiasm is a corresponding mirror inversion, with the most important event in the middle.

Angel Manuel Rodriquez illustrates the chiasm found in Leviticus 16:

"And Yahweh said to Moses"
- A Aaron should not go into most holy place any time he wishes 16:2
  - B Aaron's sacrificial victims and special vestments 16:3–4
    - C Sacrificial victims provided by the people 16:5
      - D Aaron's bull, goat for Yahweh, goat for Azazel 16:6–10
        - E Aaron sacrifices his bull as a sin-offering 16:11–14
          - F Community's goat is sacrificed as a sin-offering 16:15
            - G Make atonement 16:16–19
            - G' Atonement is finished 16:20a
          - F' Community's goat for Azazel sent to the wilderness 16:20b–22
        - E' Aaron's closing activities 16:23–25
      - D' Goat for Azazel, Aaron's bull, goat for sin-offering 16:26–28
    - C' People rest and humble themselves 16:29–31
  - B' Anointed priest officiates wearing special garments 16:32–33
- A' Anointed priest makes atonement once a year 16:34

"As the Lord commanded Moses"[23]

Paulien points to Revelation 12–14 as the center of the eight-segment chiasm, and the precise center of the center is Revelation 14:6–12, which is about the three angels' messages.[24] The first angel's message calls attention to the pre-advent judgment, and thus to the antitypical Day of Atonement. The angel

22. Wilfried Warning, *Literary Artistry in Leviticus,* vol. 35 in *Biblical Interpretation Series*, ed. R. Allan Culpepper and Rolf Rendtorff (Leiden, Netherlands: Brill, 1999), 168, 178 consecutively, parentheses added.

23. Angel Manuel Rodriquez, "Leviticus 16: Its Literary Structure," *Andrews University Seminary Studies*: 34/2 (August 1996): 283.

24. Jon Paulien, *The Deep Things of God* (Hagerstown, MD: Review and Herald, 2004), 122; see 123 for Paulien's A-B-C-D-C'-B'-A' with the final crisis (D, 11:19–15:4) as the fulcrum of the chiasm. This center differs from Kenneth A. Strand's center. His division of Revelation is as follows: history from 1:12–14:20 and eschatology from 15:1—22:5. See *Interpreting the Book of Revelation: Hermeneutical Guidelines with Brief Introduction to Literary Analysis* (Ann Arbor, MI: Ann Arbor Publishers, 1976), 51.

proclaims the gospel to the entire world (14:6), saying: "Fear [reverence] God and give him glory, because the hour of his judgment has come. Worship him who made the heavens, the earth, the sea and the springs of water" (14:7). Only Seventh-day Adventists accept a pre-advent judgment as a part of the gospel, because it allows the universe to see why some will go to heaven at the Second Advent, and why others will not. An omniscient God does not need the judgment process, but it is necessary for God to reveal His justice to answer the cosmic controversy charges against Him.[25]

MORE THAN CALVARY

The sanctuary on earth was a copy of the original sanctuary (temple) in heaven, a topic I covered extensively in the second volume of this system (*Systematic Theology: God As Trinity*). The reader may wish to read chapter 14 in that volume, as background to this discussion, and see its chart on page 459.

In the sanctuary on earth there was an outer court with the altar of burnt offering, and closer to the tabernacle was the laver. In the tent of the congregation" (Exod. 40:22, 34, KJV), or "tent of meeting" (NIV), or "Tent of Appointed Meeting" (John Durham),[26] there were two rooms. In the holy place was a table of bread on the north side, and a lampstand on the south side; an altar of incense was in front of the curtain separating the holy from the most holy place, where the ark of the Testament, or throne, was placed (Exod. 40:1–38; cf. Heb. 9:1–7). This layout goes from the altar to the throne and represents the chronological unfolding of Christ's ministry from Calvary to the throne.

ALTAR	HOLY	MOST HOLY
Calvary	**Ascension**	**End Time**
	Intercession	Intercession
		Judgment
	Book of Hebrews	Leviticus 16; Daniel 7; Revelation 13–19
		Day of Atonement (*Yom Kippur*)

25. For sources of those against the pre-advent judgment, and why it is held, see my "Another Look at the Pre-Advent Judgment" in the Festschrift *"For You Have Strengthened Me": Biblical and Theological Studies in Honor of Gerhard Pfandl in Celebration of His Sixty-Fifth Birthday*, ed. Martin Pröbstle, with Gerald A. Klingbeil and Martin Klingbeil (Austria: Seminar Schloss Bogenhofen, 2007), 305–329.

26. John I. Durham, *Exodus*, vol. 3 in *Word Biblical Commentary* (Waco, TX: Word, 1987), 497.

As far as the cosmic controversy is concerned, both its inception and resolution take place before the throne of God. It spans the entire unfolding of salvation's plan, from ruin to restoration for the human family. Such a theology is true to the historicist view of biblical interpretation, and every doctrine is seen as compatible with the sanctuary system of theology. Each part interfaces with the whole, and the whole with the parts. The sanctuary system of theology is compatible with the *sola-tota-prima Scriptura* principle.

It needs to be remembered that in the earthly sanctuary the work at the altar was always followed by work in the two apartments. So an offering on the altar of burnt offering in the outer court didn't complete the ministration for sin. After the sacrifice on the altar, the blood of the offering (or a portion eaten by the priest) was taken into the holy place and sprinkled on the altar of incense before the veil in front of the most holy place. Once a year, on the Day of Atonement (judgment), the blood was taken by the high priest into the most holy place. So the ministration for sin was the sacrifice on the courtyard altar, but that sacrifice was the basis for ministry in both apartments of the sanctuary. The sacrifice was finished at the altar, but the benefits of that finished sacrifice needed to be ministered from the two apartments of the sanctuary.

Most Christians rejoice in the death and resurrection of Christ, but do not give much thought to what the risen Christ is doing in heaven. It is natural to glory in the Cross, for it means our salvation. But the Cross doesn't only forgive sins; it also makes victory over sin possible because of what Christ is doing for sinners in heaven's sanctuary.

CHRIST AT THE THRONE

In the above sanctuary layout, the journey from altar (Calvary) is completed at the throne. The throne was housed in the most holy place, so did Christ have to wait until He began His work in the second apartment before arriving at the throne? The biblical data examined above says He sat down at the throne immediately upon His ascension. There was no wait. Did Christ commence His ministry as King-Priest in the holy or most holy place? What does Scripture say?

Some translations tell us that "he entered the Most Holy Place once for all by his own blood, thus obtaining eternal redemption" (Heb. 9:12). "Most holy place" is given in the New International Version and New King James Version translation of the Hebrew *ta hagia*, whereas the King James Version and New American Standard translate it as the "holy place." The Hebrew noun *ta hagia* is the plural of holy, literally meaning "the holies" or the whole Sanctuary, or "holy places" (ESV), not just one inner room. Which is it, the most holy place, the holy

place, or the whole sanctuary? Here we must allow Scripture to interpret Scripture. Hebrews 10:19–20 says Jesus opened up a new way for us to inaugurate (*enkainizō*) His ministry in heaven. In the Septuagint (LXX), the Greek version of the Old Testament, *enkainizō* is a "technical term for the 'inauguration' of the sanctuary (Num. 7:10, 11, 84, 88)," and it "implies that Christ at His ascension entered the heavenly sanctuary to inaugurate its services, not to commence His day of atonement ministry."[27] Scripture portrays the inauguration in the holy place as the throne was in front of the seven candlesticks (Rev. 4:5; 5:1–14).

This means the throne is movable. If it was in the first apartment from ascension on, then did the throne move into the second apartment for the judgment phase or the restoration phase of Christ's ministry? If this is so, we would expect a movement of the throne prior to the judgment ministry. And this is precisely what we find in Scripture:

> As I looked, "thrones were set in place, and the Ancient of Days [the Father] took his seat. His clothing was as white as snow; the hair of his head was white like wool. His throne was flaming with fire, and its wheels were all ablaze. A river of fire was flowing, coming out from before him. Thousands upon thousands attended him; ten thousand times ten thousand stood before him. The court was seated, and the books were opened." (Dan. 7:9–10)

Daniel and Ezekiel were contemporaries. Compare Daniel's description with Ezekiel's description of God's moveable throne: both have wheels, moved, and looked like fire (Ezek. 1:4–28). So we can safely conclude that Christ is at the throne throughout both phases of His heavenly ministry, from inauguration until completion, and so the movable throne takes Him from the first phase into the second phase.[28]

FIRST PHASE: REDEMPTION

There is a sanctuary in heaven with two apartments like the type in the earthly sanctuary.[29] Christ entered the sanctuary of heaven "on our behalf"

27. Richard M. Davidson, "Biblical Interpretation," in *Handbook of Seventh-day Adventist Theology*, vol. 12 in *Commentary Reference Series* (Hagerstown, MD: Review and Herald, 2000), 79.

28. Added insight into movable thrones is seen in the kings of Israel and Judah, who ideally were supposed to typify Christ as king. Most kings failed to do this, but at least it is instructive that there are examples of their thrones being movable; such as 1 Kings 22:10 and 2 Chronicles 18:9.

29. There is a sanctuary in heaven. The vastness and magnificence of it is beyond our understanding. Scripture says, "Christ did not enter a sanctuary made with human hands that was only a copy of the true one; he entered heaven itself" (Heb. 9:24a). There are biblical indications that heaven's sanctuary is a real place. The facts that the earthly sanctuary structure was built after the pattern shown to Moses by God and that both have two main rooms are evidence of its reality. The book of Revelation speaks of some furniture in heaven's sanctuary, also typified by furniture in the earthly sanctuary. Fot example, there are the seven lamps (Rev. 4:5b), the altar of incense before the throne (Rev. 8:3b), and the Ark of the Covenant (Rev. 11:19).

Some have argued that there are not two rooms in heaven's sanctuary, and that mention of the same merely means that there are two phases. They say that the ministry of Christ is about function and not about

(Heb. 6:20a). The earthly sanctuary was temporary, and so were its benefits, for they depended upon Christ's future death for sin (Heb. 10:3–13). The crucified Christ "has become the guarantor of a better covenant" with a "permanent priesthood." "Therefore he is able to save completely those who come to God through him, because he always lives to intercede for them. Such a high priest truly meets our need—one who is holy, blameless, pure, set apart from sinners, exalted above the heavens" with a "once for all" sacrifice (Heb. 7:22–27).

"The main point of what we are saying is this: We do have such a high priest, who sat down at the right hand of the throne of the Majesty in heaven, and who serves in the sanctuary, the true tabernacle set up by the Lord, not a mere human being. Every high priest is appointed to offer both gifts and sacrifices, and so it was necessary for this one also to have something to offer" (Heb. 8:1–3). Christ offers His own sacrifice, the only one that can take away human sin. So His subsequent ministry is not incompatible with His death, but actually ministers the benefits of His death.[30] This is true in both the holy and most holy places of heaven's sanctuary. In Christ's inauguration at the throne (Rev. 4–5), Christ was the only one who could open the scroll to unfold salvation history because He alone was crucified for humans (Rev. 5:9). Calvary unites Christ's

furniture. But a careful reading of Scripture has led me to realize that both are revealed in Scripture. The miniature model of the heavenly sanctuary that was the basis of the earthly sanctuary argues for a "copy" between antitype and type. This includes the furniture in the correct rooms. Less than this would call into question the specificity between the heavenly and earthly directions given to Moses by the pre-incarnate Christ. It would also question whether there is a literal sanctuary in heaven. Admittedly the heavenly sanctuary is enormous, but it is as real as God's throne and the presence of the Father and the Son at the throne.

30. Scripture documents that Christ ministers the benefits of Calvary to humans from heaven's sanctuary.
    a. "The tombs broke open. The bodies of many holy people who had died were raised to life. They came out of the tombs after Jesus' resurrection and went into the holy city and appeared to many people" (Matt. 27:52–53).
    b. "When he ascended on high, he took many captives and gave gifts to his people" (Eph. 4:8).
    c. "Because he himself suffered when he was tempted, he is able to help those who are being tempted" (Heb. 2:18).
    d. "For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who has been tempted in every way, just as we are—yet he did not sin. Let us then approach God's throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need" (Heb. 4:15–16).
    e. Christ "is able to save completely those who come to God through him, because he always lives to intercede for them" (Heb. 7:25).
    f. He "is at the right hand of God and is also interceding for us" (Rom. 8:34).
    g. "For there is one God and one mediator between God and mankind, the man Christ Jesus" (1 Tim. 2:5).
    h. "For Christ also suffered once for sins, the righteous for the unrighteous, to bring you to God" (1 Pet. 3:18; cf. Rom. 6:10). "'He himself bore our sins in his body on the cross" (1 Pet. 2:24).

So Christ took humans with Him to heaven, and gives gifts to humans left behind. He is the only Mediator who intercedes as a sympathetic High Priest, because He too was tempted. He is therefore merciful, gives grace, and is able to save completely. These gifts are given on the basis of His greatest gift at Calvary. He died for humans, and He cannot wait to share the benefits of Calvary with them. The full implementation of Calvary includes redemption for humans and resolution of the cosmic controversy for all intelligent created beings, including humans. Christ's twofold ministry involves both.

finished work on earth (John 19:30) with His unfinished work in heaven (Heb. 6:20), and so holds together what Christ has done for humans with what He is doing for humans.

What Christ did on the cross was for all humans (1 John 2:2). What He does in the first phase of His post-Calvary ministry is to represent His followers before the Father. Redemption took place on the Cross, while representation takes place in heaven.[31] Redemption-representation are the two sides of atonement for humans. Christ's sacrifice gives Him the right to minister as our priest, for none can minister without a sacrifice (Heb. 8:3). But the ministry adds nothing to the Cross, nor does it imply that Christ's sacrifice was insufficient or incomplete (Heb. 9:24–28). Rather, the ministry brings the benefits of Calvary to humans: (1) Only in and through Christ can humans approach God. So Christ is the sole representative. (2) Only through Christ can humans receive God's blessings. So Christ is God's representative for humanity. Thus Christ's High Priestly ministry is a two-way mediation between humans and God, and God and humans. Calvary is the fulcrum upon which the priestly ministry turns. Both the Godward and humanward ministry function because of Calvary, and both belong to the first phase of Christ's sanctuary ministry in heaven. Expressed differently, redemption is freedom from the penalty of sin through Calvary and freedom from the power of sin through Christ's intercession. Redemption was completed at the cross (sacrificially) and is being completed during Christ's intercession (sanctification). It takes both to be redeemed. Redemption is objective and subjective: Christ died for us (completed) and works in us (to be completed). Christ applies the benefits in us of His death for us. This work proceeds during His ministry in both apartments (or phases) of His ministry in the heavenly sanctuary, from inauguration (Rev. 5) to close of probation (Dan. 12:1).

Saints in the Old Testament knew that God interceded for them. For example, Job said, "Even now my witness is in heaven; my advocate is on high. My intercessor is my friend as my eyes pour out tears to God; on behalf of man he pleads with God as one pleads for a friend" (Job 16:19–21). Intercession for Job was given in the context of the cosmic controversy questioning of Job by Satan (Job 1 and 2). Joshua was the first high priest in Judah after the return from Babylonian captivity (see Joshua in Ezra 2:2). He stood before the "angel of the Lord," who was the pre-incarnate Christ.[32] Satan (*śāṭān* "has clearly the meaning of a heavenly

31. "By virtue of that one perfect sacrifice for sin, Christ now exercises His priestly ministry at the right hand of the Father, presenting and representing His people here on earth," Edward Heppenstall, *Our High Priest* (Washington, DC: Review and Herald, 1972), 50.

32. When Moses stood before the burning bush, "the angel of the LORD appeared to him in flames of fire from within a bush.... When the LORD saw that he had gone over to look, God called to him from within the bush, 'Moses, Moses!'.... Then he said, 'I am the God of your father, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac and the God of Jacob.' At this, Moses hid his face, because he was afraid to look at God" (Exod. 3:2–6).

accuser"[33]) was accusing him (to accuse in Hebrew is *śāṭān*, a verbal form of the noun Satan [Pss. 38:20; 71:13; 109:4, 20, 29][34]), but the Lord (*Yahweh*) rebuked him. For he was snatched from the fire, then the angel of the Lord asked that the filthy clothes of Joshua be taken off, so he could be clothed in "fine garments" and a clean turban be placed on his head (Zech. 3:3–5). This represented forgiveness and clothing similar to what the pre-incarnate Christ did in Eden for Adam and Eve (Gen. 3:21), which followed the sacrifice from which the skins were made. The pre-incarnate Christ intercedes for the high priest and nation of Judah, while Satan accuses them, which is an insight into the cosmic controversy. Note that the accusation and defense are made verbally, so all onlookers can follow the drama as two sides of the cosmic controversy meet head-on, revealing how different the two sides are, one supportive, the other destructive.

Later Christ spoke of His intercession, saying, "I am not saying that I will ask the Father on your behalf. No, the Father himself loves you" (John 16:26–27). The Persons of the Trinity are all involved in the redeeming of humans and the resolution of the cosmic controversy. The interceding work is public because it reveals to the observer world what God is like, which refutes the cosmic controversy charges against Him.

The prayer of Christ gives insight into His intercession in heaven: "Holy Father, protect them by the power of your name, the name you gave me, so that they may be one as we are one.... My prayer is not that you take them out of the world but that you protect them from the evil one.... Sanctify them by the truth; your word is truth" (John 17:11, 15, 17). Then His prayer extends to all subsequent disciples, "My prayer is not for them alone. I pray also for those who will believe in me through their message, that all of them may be

But the pre-incarnate Christ promised to give Moses success in his mission in leading God's people (Exod. 3:16–4:17). Israel was terrified as the army of Pharaoh closed in behind them as they faced the Red Sea. Then "the angel of God, who had been traveling in front of Israel's army, withdrew and went behind them. The pillar of cloud also moved from in front and stood behind them," and during the Red Sea crossing "the LORD looked down from the pillar of fire and cloud at the Egyptian army and threw it into confusion. He jammed the wheels of their chariots so that they had difficulty driving" (Exod. 14:1–25a). In praising the angel of the Lord (Exod. 14:19), Israel sang the song of Moses after the Red Sea deliverance: "Who among the gods is like you, O LORD? Who is like you—majestic in holiness, awesome in glory, working wonders?" (Exod. 15:11). New Testament corroboration says the angel of the Lord through Moses "led them out of Egypt and performed wonders and signs in Egypt, at the Red Sea and for forty years in the wilderness" (Acts 7:35–36). For forty years in the desert they were fed by manna (Exod. 16:15, 31, 33; Ps. 78:24); drank water (Neh. 9:20); and their clothes didn't wear out (Deut. 8:4). Paul identifies the angel of the Lord: "For I do not want you to be ignorant of the fact, brothers and sisters, that our ancestors were all under the cloud and that they all passed through the sea. They were all baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea. They all ate the same spiritual food and drank the same spiritual drink; for they drank from the spiritual rock that accompanied them, and that rock was Christ" (1 Cor. 10:1–4).

33. Bruce Baloian, "*śāṭān*," in *New International Dictionary of Old Testament Theology and Exegesis*, ed. Willem A. VanGemeren (Gtand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1997): 3:1231.

34. Ibid.

one, Father, just as you are in me and I am in you. May they also be in us so that the world may believe that you have sent me" (John 17:20–21). Jesus asks for protection, sanctification, and unity for His followers, that they may be kept from the power of Satan. Christ pours out His concern for human salvation in the context of the cosmic controversy. So even in the first phase of His ministry, Christ applies the victory of His death to meet human needs for salvation, and also meets human needs against their adversary in the cosmic controversy. The two aspects of His ministry are inseparable.

SECOND PHASE: RESOLUTION

Jesus says, the Father "has given him authority to judge [*krisis*, process, or pass judgment, NEB] because he is the Son of Man" (John 5:27, several versions have "execute judgment," KJV, NKJV, RSV, NASB). The King-Priest is given authority over the judgment process (in heaven) and authority to execute the judgment verdict in judgments. So Christ has the authority in the process and execution (*krima*, verdict at end of judging process). The fact that Christ has the authority to execute judgment is well documented in texts such as Revelation 19:14–21. Although the Father is equally able to judge fairly, in His fairness He gives the judgment work to Jesus because He lived a human life and was judged. It is His human life that qualifies Him to be a sympathetic and understanding High Priest, because He knows experientially what it is like to live a human life and die a human death on the ultimate battleground of the cosmic controversy.

The greatest proof that Christ loves humans is His life and death for them. His life and death qualify Him to rule as King-Priest, redeeming humans and resolving the cosmic controversy. Not even the Father and the Spirit, though equally loving and just, can contribute to these aspects of the sin problem as effectively as the God-Man Jesus Christ. That is how important Christ's rule is in heaven's sanctuary.

Just as there were two apartments in the earthly sanctuary, so there are two apartments in the heavenly sanctuary. The two apartments of the earthly sanctuary were the places in which two phases of ministry were conducted, the first by priests, the second by the high priest; the first throughout the year, and the second on one day of the year called the Day of Atonement. During the Day of Atonement, the ministry effected the ritual cleansing (purgation) of the sanctuary by the removal of sin placed there since the previous Day of Atonement. The Day of Atonement typified the end of sin and the entrance of the eternal sinless Kingdom for the redeemed. So the judgment has everything to do with the gospel. That is why Scripture calls attention to this finale: "Fear [reverence]

God and give him glory, because the hour of his judgment has come" in the context of the "eternal gospel" (Rev. 14:6–7).

It is important to note the difference between the first apartment ministry, or daily ministry, that continues during the Day of Atonement, and the second apartment ministry, or yearly ministry. Roy Gane points out the focus on purgation, rather than forgiveness, in the Day of Atonement, which distinguishes it from the forgiving ministry of Christ throughout the year.

> Contrary to widespread misconception dating as early as the Second Temple period, *none of the rituals to the Day of Purgation lead to forgiveness at all.* The root *slḥ* ("forgive") does not appear once in Leviticus 16 or any other passage that has to do with the Day of Purgation (cf. 23:26–32; 25:9–10; Num. 29:7–11).[35]

In other words, the work of intercession continues during the second phase of judgment, for the daily (*tāmîd*) ministry also takes place during the yearly Day of Atonement, because in the typical Day of Atonement, the morning and evening sacrifices (or daily ministry) were offered as well (Exod. 29:38–42; Lev. 6:9, 12–13; Num. 28:3–8). We will consider this second phase of Christ's ministry further in the doctrine of eschatology, in volume 4; then we will take up the second phase in the context of the book of Revelation and allow that context to add to what is presented here in Christology.

THE TRUTH AS IT IS IN JESUS

We want to know "the truth that is in Jesus" (Eph. 4:21b), truth that has not yet become well known among Christians. We are speaking about what Christ is doing in heaven's sanctuary now, before His second coming. We who love Christ with all our hearts, who embrace His death for our sins, who live in His forgiveness that cast our sins into the deepest depths; we know that He is our Savior and Lord, and always will be. We long to worship Him and bring glory to His name. We know that "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8), so we know that whatever He is doing now is done with the same love that He revealed in His death for us. Christ is involved in an investigative judgment, which, at first glance seems incompatible with His Calvary judgment in our place. Why should there be any added judgment when the decisive judgment took place at the Cross?

God knows all truth. He knows that human understanding of truth is progressive. Even after being with Christ who is the Truth (John 14:6), and the greatest teacher ever to live on planet earth, the disciples had more to learn. So

35. Roy Gane, *Leviticus, Numbers,* in *The NIV Application Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2004), 278.

Christ has given a promise that is crucial for His disciples of every generation, who are often bound by religious or cultural traditions. Christ knows that when humans know the truth, it sets them free (John 8:32), and the more they know "the truth that is in Jesus" (Eph. 4:21b) the more they will rejoice and revel in the unfolding depths of freedom commensurate with unfolding truth. Prior to His death, Christ tells His disciples:

> But very truly I tell you, it is for your good that I am going away. Unless I go away, the Advocate will not come to you; but if I go, I will send him to you. When he comes, he will prove the world to be in the wrong about sin and righteousness and judgment: about sin, because people do not believe in me; about righteousness, because I am going to the Father, where you can see me no longer; and about judgment, because the prince of this world now stands condemned. I have much more to say to you, more than you can now bear. But when he, the Spirit of truth, comes, he will guide you into all the truth. He will not speak on his own; he will speak only what he hears, and he will tell you what is yet to come. He will glorify me because it is from me that he will receive what he will make known to you. (John 16:7–14)

The first function of Christ's new ministry in heaven was to send the Holy Spirit to be His administrator on earth, and one of the Spirit's assignments is to guide Christians into all truth, to discover in Scripture meaning not seen before. This second phase of Christ's ministry is an example of this illumination. Consider the church in Laodicea, which has spiritual needs, yet doesn't realize it; she needs spiritual discernment in order to understand (Rev. 3:18). Such discernment will enable Laodicea to understand biblical truth essential to the cosmic controversy today in the end times.

The angel Gabriel told Daniel, "Go your way, Daniel, because the words are rolled up and sealed until the time of the end" (Dan. 12:9). We need to pray for discernment to understand what is given in the book of Daniel and its companion, the book of Revelation. This involves a pre-advent judgment. We will only introduce the topic here, exploring why the judgment is necessary before Christ returns; those who are judged, and why, will be taken up in the doctrine of eschatology.

Pre-Advent Judgment

"He [angel] said in a loud voice, 'Fear [reverence] God and give him glory, because the hour of his judgment has come. Worship him who made the heavens, the earth, the sea and the springs of water'" (Rev. 14:7). Very few Christians believe that this verse heralds a pre-advent judgment, a judgment that precedes the second coming of Christ. We will first present what two Christian commentators think of this idea.

OPPOSED BY MOST CHRISTIANS

The investigative judgment is unacceptable to most Christians. Donald Barnhouse, in the foreword to Walter Martin's 1960 book *The Truth about Seventh-day Adventism*, declares, "I believe that the ideas of investigative judgment and a secondary sanctuary ministry have no basis in Scripture." Further, "The doctrine of investigative judgment, however is held by no other group of Christians, and was unknown until the middle of the nineteenth century. It was promulgated at that time, in my opinion, as a means of softening the harsh blow of 'The Great Disappointment.'"[36] He refers to the disappointment on October 22, 1844, when Christ didn't return to earth to cleanse the sanctuary (the earth) as William Miller (not a Seventh-day Adventist) taught, but actually entered the second phase of His heavenly ministry to cleanse the heavenly sanctuary.

In his 1997 book *The Kingdom of the Cults*, Martin rejects the "investigative judgment," saying, "Several judgments are mentioned in the Bible, but it is my opinion that not one passage substantiates the 'investigative judgment' theory—for theory it truly is, relying upon out-of-context quotations and supported by the 'Spirit of prophecy.'"[37] Martin rejects the sanctuary cleansing from sin in the investigative judgment, because Christ teaches that our sins are forgiven and forgotten immediately upon repentance. He notes that Scripture teaches, "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness" (1 John 1:9), and he quotes Christ's promise: "'He that hears my word and believes him that sent me has everlasting life and shall not come under judgment but is passed from death to life' (literal translation)."[38] These texts teach immediate cleansing when forgiven, so there seems to be no need for believers to come to judgment. While I fully agree with these biblical texts, we must ask: Do these texts deny the investigative judgment? We need to remember that the Day of Atonement has nothing to do with forgiving sins.

REDEMPTION AND RESTORATION: SOLVING THE SIN PROBLEM

The present judgment is called *pre-advent*, denoting its time, and *investigative*, denoting its method (Rev. 14:6–7). Why is a pre-advent judgment necessary? We need to penetrate to the heart of what is underway in the pre-advent judgment, and for that matter, what will continue in the millennial and postmillennial judgments (Rev. 20:7–15). God doesn't need the judgments, because He is omniscient

36. Donald Grey Barnhouse, foreword to *The Truth About Seventh-day Adventism*, by Walter R. Martin (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1960), 7.

37. Walter Martin, *The Kingdom of the Cults*, rev. ed. (Minneapolis, MN: Bethany, 1997), 585. The "Spirit of prophecy" is a reference to the writings of Ellen G. White, one of the founders of the Seventh-day Adventist church who had the prophetic gift.

38. Ibid., 584–585.

(Pss. 33:13–15; 56:8, 104:24; 139:2, 6; 147:4; Isa. 44:28; 46:9–10; Mal. 3:16; Matt. 10:29–30; Acts 15:8; Rom. 11:33; Eph. 3:10). "The Lord knows those who are his" (2 Tim. 2:19). Jesus declares, "I know my sheep" (John 10:14). Which means that God holds these judgments for the sake of created beings.[39]

Redemption has to do with forgiving sins, cleansing them, and forgetting them. In fact, God says, "For as high as the heavens are above the earth, so great is his love for those who fear [reverence] him; as far as the east is from the west, so far has he removed our transgressions from us" (Ps. 103:11–12). Hezekiah, king of Judah, said about God, "In your love you kept me from the pit of destruction; you have put all my sins behind your back" (Isa. 38:17b). After the sins of Judah (see Ezek. 8) and their return from exile, Micah said of God, "You will again have compassion on us; you will tread our sins underfoot and hurl all our iniquities into the depths of the sea" (Mic. 7:19). These metaphors forcefully prove God forgives and forgets our sins in His work of redemption. Just as nothing has to be added to His death, neither does anything have to be added to His cleansing from sins when they are forgiven and forgotten. The status of Christians as forgiven sinners, experiencing life in Christ (John 3:15, 36; 6:47) is unchanged by the pre-advent judgment.

So what's the point of the pre-advent judgment? Without the cosmic controversy, there would be no need of this judgment. Satan and his angels were dismissed from heaven for their rebellion (Rev. 12:7–9). Why will sinners from planet earth be taken to heaven in the Second Advent? That is a crucial question if God is to be seen as fair. How can He dismiss some from heaven while admitting others. The purpose of the judgment is to demonstrate God's fairness prior to taking humans to heaven.

In fact, there are three eschatological judgments which reveal God's fairness to three different groups of intelligent beings. The pre-advent judgment is for all human beings, the Millennial judgment is for redeemed humans, and the post-Millennial judgment (which will be witnessed by all intelligent beings) is for rebel humans. These judgments reveal the fairness of God and give further indication that God is different from what Satan has tried to make Him out to be. The purpose of these judgments is to answer the charges, to prove to all created beings that God is just and loving, and to etch this so forcefully upon the consciences of the redeemed and unfallen beings that rebellion will never arise again (Rev. 21:2–4; 22:3–5). As well, God is so fair and loving that the wicked will not be eternally separated from God before seeing that the choice was theirs—and theirs alone.

39. All intelligent created beings participate in the evaluation of God's judgments and find Him to be just (Rev. 15:3). The issue in the cosmic controversy, calling into question the love and justice of God, is thus answered. If there were no cosmic controversy the present, millennial, and final judgments would not be necessary.

These judgments allow all intelligent created beings (unfallen, saved, and lost) to see that God is just and loving, and that Satan is the opposite.

At the cross Christ was judged in the place of humans, providing a substitutionary atonement: "God made him who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Cor. 5:21). Salvation depends on acceptance of Christ's death. Loss of salvation depends upon rejection of Christ's death. That is why John 3:16 says that whoever believes in Christ will not perish but have eternal life, indicating that perishing results from lack of belief. Those accepting Calvary as the only basis of salvation are candidates for salvation, while those who reject Calvary are not.

This turns traditional predestination on its head, for those who elect Christ as their Savior will be saved, and those who reject Christ as their Savior will be lost. Election-rejection is not a decision made by God in eternity, but a decision made by humans in time. Humans do the electing or rejecting rather than God. The judgment process ends in a verdict of judgment. Genuine Christians do not come into judgment. Rather, God reveals their loyalty as the basis of His decision to save them, and by doing so is seen to be fair. So it needs to be stressed, as mentioned above, that the pre-advent judgment would not be necessary if the cosmic controversy charges against God were not on display before the universe. Christians need to gain an enlarged vision of what is going on in the heavenly sanctuary—to see that Christ's mission of restoration completes His mission to redeem.

So what is the pre-advent judgment all about? It is about Christ's work of restoration. Redemption requires restoration, or else redemption isn't complete. Christ's completed sacrifice on the cross was both to redeem humans and to restore them and the universe to its pre-Fall pristine sinless state. The judgment does not change the relationship of the forgiven with the Forgiver. Restoration to the pre-Fall state requires resolution of the cosmic controversy. This work is taken up prior to Christ's return in the second phase of His ministry in heaven's sanctuary as King-Priest.

We need to clearly show that Scripture teaches that there is a second phase of Christ's heavenly ministry, and so we take this up in the next segment.

CONTEMPORARY RESEARCH: TWO MINISTRIES AND THEODICY

Christ's ministry on earth can be divided between working for people, and His judgment for humans in Gethsemane, trials and crucifixion, followed by resurrection. In the same way, Christ's ministry in heaven can be divided between working for people, and in the end times His added pre-advent judgment for

humans as the last part of His ministry. Ponder the evidence for a second phase for Christ's ministry in heaven.

Yahweh said to Moses, "Have them make a sanctuary for me, and I will dwell among them. Make this tabernacle and all its furnishings exactly like the pattern [*tabnît*] I will show you" (Exod. 25:8–9, cf. v. 40); so the earthly sanctuary is a "copy [*hupodeigmati*] and shadow [*skia*] of what is in heaven" (Heb. 8:5a), with two rooms, "the Holy Place" and the "Most Holy Place" (Heb. 9:2–3). David said, "You, God, are awesome in your sanctuary" (Ps. 68:35). The Hebrew Bible says, "sanctuaries" rather than "sanctuary," which is also reflected in the King James Version. In commenting on this verse, F. Delitzsch writes, "Awful is Elohim out of thy sanctuaries." He says this is not a reference to the sanctuary in heaven and earth, "but one sanctuary in Jerusalem…in the manifold character of its holy places."[40] Richard Davidson demonstrates that "the typological structures of Heb 8 and 9 (viewed in the light of Exod 25 and numerous other OT passages) appear to indicate that vertical as well as horizontal typology is indigenous to the biblical perspective."[41]

The two ministries in the earthly tabernacle/temples were called the *daily* and the *yearly*. The daily ministry, in the Holy Place, was every day of the cultic year (Lev. 4), while the yearly ministry, in the Most Holy Place, was on the Day of Atonement of the cultic year (Lev. 16). These two ministries typified what transpires in heaven's sanctuary: (1) Christ's daily ministry from ascension to the close of probation, to fit humans to enter heaven (applying the benefits of Calvary); and (2) Christ's yearly ministry, the antitypical Day of Atonement, is a day of judgment (as in the type, Lev. 23:27–32). This last phase is what most Christians reject. They say, "Why is a judgment in heaven necessary when Calvary was Judgment day?" (John 12:31–32).

The cyclical cultic rituals, in two phases, repeated year after year, give insight into Christ's post-resurrection ministry in heaven's sanctuary. Applying the benefits of Calvary to humans is a well-known biblical truth, as seen in *Calvin's Institutes*.[42] Whereas Calvary was provided once for all as the objective side of atonement, applying the benefits of Calvary is the subjective side of atonement, a work of sanctification, or fitness for heaven.

Isn't redemption enough? Why is there a judgment, or second phase to Christ's ministry in the heavenly sanctuary? This second phase reaches beyond

40. Keil and Delitzsch, *Psalms*, vol. 5 in *Commentary on the Old Testament in Ten Volumes* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1986), 2:271.

41. Richard M. Davidson, *Typology in Scripture: A Study of Hermeneutical* τύπος *Structures* (PhD diss., Andrews University Seminary, Berrien Springs, MI, 1981), 407.

42. "So long as we are without Christ and separate from him, nothing which he suffered and did for the salvation of the human race is of the least benefit to us," John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, trans. Henry Beveridge (London: James Clarke, 1962), 2:463 (3.1.1).

redemption to deal with the cosmic controversy. Satan's rebellion calls into question the character of God. He slanders God, or distorts the truth about Him. That is why Christ said of Satan, "When he lies, he speaks his native language, for he is a liar and the father of lies" (John 8:44). The Hebrew word *rĕkūllâ* used in reference to Satan (Ezek. 28:16) means "trading" or "peddling," referring to goods or gossip. In this context Satan has spread gossip about God, creating disinformation about Him, so that a third of the angels joined his rebellion against God.[43] Rebellion means distrusting God. If, at the second advent, Christ takes some humans to heaven, and not others, this could be seen as evidence for Satan's claim, and inspire further rebellion. That is why there is a pre-advent judgment, so all intelligent beings can see why some will go to heaven, while others will not. Traditional theology does not comprehend the cosmic controversy, and hence fails to see what God must do in order to prove the charges false.

God has nothing to hide. He is not the God of traditional theology (Augustine-Calvin) who in eternity predestined who will be saved and who will be rejected. He is not the God whose eternal secret decree is off-limits for humans to pry into and to question. "After all," Predestinarians say, "He is God, and can do what He likes with humans, for none are worthy of salvation. It is an act of mercy and grace that He saves any."[44] This is why traditional theology has no contribution to make to answering the charges of the enemy. An investigative judgment indicates that God is willing to reveal that humans choose their own destiny, which is compatible with God's love (1 John 4:8–16). The judgment has nothing to do with salvation by human works, but has everything to do with the salvation work of Christ.

Jacob Milgrom, Professor Emeritus of Biblical Studies at the University of California-Berkeley, considers the sanctuary priestly theodicy.[45] Whereas Milgrom argues that one phase of purgation was sufficient, Roy Gane documents that two phases of purgation are necessary:

> Analysis of the Day of Atonement rituals, including terms for the evils that they purge, shows that they provide a second major phase of כפר for expiable moral faults. This phase constitutes a corporate judgment for the community, through which YHWH is cleared of judicial responsibility for having forgiven guilty people. YHWH's vindication results in moral clearing for those who continue to demonstrate loyalty to him, but he rejects those who are disloyal.[46]

43. See Richard M. Davidson, "Cosmic Metanarrative for the Coming Millennium," *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society*, 11 (2000): 1–2, 108.

44. To follow the debate on predestination, see my *Systematic Theology: God As Trinity* (Berrien Springs, MI: Andrews University Press, 2011), chapters 15 and 16.

45. Jacob Milgrom, *Leviticus 1–16*, vol. 3 in *The Anchor Bible* (New York: Doubleday, 1991), 260.

46. Roy Gane, *Cult and Character: Purification Offerings, Day of Atonement, and Theodicy* (Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2005), xxi.

> From the numerous details of pentateuchal cultic legislation, the present study has established that expiable sins are removed from their offerers by purification offerings throughout the year (e.g., Lev 4), and these are included among the evils purged from the sanctuary in a corporate second phase of כפר on the yearly Day of Atonement (ch. 16). Penetrating a long-standing puzzle, I have found a reason for this second phase: when YHWH forgives guilty people, he incurs judicial responsibility (עון) by creating an imbalance between justice and kindness that affects his reputation as ruler (cf. 2 Sam 14:9). Restoration of equilibrium is enacted through ritual purification of the sanctuary, which represents vindication of YHWH's administrative justice as he sheds judicial responsibility. As a result, Israelites who show their continuing loyalty to him receive the secondary benefit of moral cleansing/clearing in the sense that the forgiveness already granted them is confirmed when the Forgiver is vindicated.[47]

God's dwelling among forgiven sinners was vindicated by the annual Day of Atonement, for God's reputation was not compromised because those forgiven had remained loyal, and those who had not been forgiven were shown to have remained defiant rebels.

Consider what happened on the typical Day of Atonement. After a sin offering and burnt offering (Lev. 16:6), two goats were presented to the Lord at the entrance of the Tent of Meeting (v. 7). With casting of lots, the goat for the Lord was sacrificed as a sin offering (v. 9), whereas the other goat was "presented alive before the LORD to be used for making atonement by sending it into the wilderness as a scapegoat" (v. 10). The sins of Israel for the past year were placed upon the head of the scapegoat (which carried the guilt of Israel) and was released into the desert (vv. 20–22). The death of the first goat represented Christ's sacrificial atonement to save sinners for eternity, whereas the guilt placed upon the scapegoat represented a judicial atonement (not a sacrifice for sin, but bearing the responsibility for sin). This goat represented Satan, who is responsible for all sin in the universe. The end of the yearly Day of Atonement marked the cleansing of the camp of Israel (v. 30), for Christ bore the sins for loyal forgiven sinners (2 Cor. 5:21), and Satan bears all sin because he is responsible for all sin (John 8:44). "It is a day of sabbath rest" (Lev. 16:31a).

So the present Day of Atonement includes three judgments, which stretch from a pre-advent period, to the Millennium, to the post-Millennium final judgment. We must keep in mind that these are only necessary because of the cosmic controversy and its need of resolution. They do not call into question Christ's sacrifice at the cross, but reveal that human destiny is decided by our accepting or rejecting the Cross judgment. So the three judgments are based upon the Cross judgment, and constitute the outworking of what happened at the Cross.

47. Ibid., 379–380.

This yearly enactment focuses on the resolution of the controversy, or sin problem, in the universe. At the end of the Day of Atonement, all loyal Hebrews (individually) were clean, restored to an original state through Christ's expiation, and all of Israel (corporately) was clean, restored to an original state, with all sin placed on Satan, the original cause of all sin. This typical Day of Atonement gives insight into the antitypical Day of Atonement, the end of which finds the eradication of Satan, sin, and sinners (cf. second death, Rev. 20:11–15; 21:8), and sinless saints rejoicing in their salvation, in a new earth (*kainos*, new in quality, not *neos*, new in point of time), and the eradication of the cosmic controversy (Rev. 21:1–7).

It follows that there is no redemption without resolution of the cosmic controversy. In his doctoral dissertation, Brazilian Old Testament scholar Elias Brasil de Souza says:

> The examination of several passages conveying the idea of judgment from the heavenly sanctuary/temple reveals that this judgment, in some cases, occurs in a two-stage process. Thus, as implied in Gen 11:1–9 and made more explicit in passages such as Mic 1:2–3, Pss 11:4, 102:19–20, the actual execution of the judgment is preceded by an investigative phase in which the facts of the matter are weighed and evaluated. The same idea can also be discerned in Dan 8:9–14 which, as suggested by the contextual indications of Dan 7, portrays the purification/vindication of the heavenly sanctuary in the context of the judicial activities of the Day of Atonement. In this regard, the connection of the heavenly council of YHWH in conjunction with the heavenly sanctuary/temple allows one to infer that the heavenly beings were also involved as assistants or witnesses in this process of judgment, an inference that can be made on the basis of texts such as 1 Kgs 22:19–23, Zech 3:1–10, Dan 7:9–14.[48]

Conclusion

The pre-advent judgment does not repudiate Calvary. It is the Crucified Christ who intercedes for humans and has won the victory over death. In reality, the pre-advent judgment is part of the unfolding in salvation history of what was accomplished at the Cross. Calvary moves inexorably to the deliverance of God's people and the destruction of their enemies, because both were accomplished by Christ's death on the cross. This is Christ's redeeming-resolution work as King-Priest in the end times of His ministry in heaven's sanctuary. It is by the authority of Calvary that Christ delivers His saints and destroys Satan and all rebels in the coming battles of Armageddon (Rev. 19:14–21; 20:11–15).

48. Elias Brasil de Souza, *The Heavenly Sanctuary/Temple Motif in the Hebrew Bible: Function and Relationship to the Earthly Counterparts* (PhD diss., Andrews University, 2005), *Adventist Theological Society Dissertation Series* (Berrien Springs, MI: ATS, 2005), 486–487.

This will be the pre-advent and post-advent implementation of the judgment verdict. The judgment verdict carries out the deliverance-destruction verdict of Calvary (see an in-depth study of this in the doctrine of eschatology in the next, and last, volume of my *Systematic Theology*).

The rejection of the pre-advent judgment by most scholars is understandable. They don't want anything to detract from Calvary, from the gospel message. This is a legitimate concern, yet when this judgment is understood in the context of the cosmic controversy, we see that Christ provides this process *for the sake of others* just as Calvary is for the sake of others. There is no difference in God's unfathomable love in both judgments, Calvary and pre-advent. For in a sense, Christ is on trial in the pre-advent judgment, not that created beings have the right or the ability to judge Him, but God has a right to reveal His justice and love to answer the charges leveled by Satan in the cosmic controversy. God's revelation will be so overwhelming and irrefutable that all will concur He is loving and just when they bow in the final judgment (Isa. 45:23b; Rom. 14:11; Phil. 2:10–11; Rev. 5:13; 15:3; 19:1–6).

The pre-advent judgment is compatible with Calvary, for the intercession of Christ continues during the Day of Atonement judgment process, for the daily intercession took place every day of the cultic year in the earthly sanctuary (Exod. 29:38–42; Lev. 6:9, 12–13; Num. 28:3–8). It is the Christ of Calvary, the Christ who intercedes, who is given the pre-advent judgment verdict that implements the double verdict of Calvary (Dan. 7:13–14). Hence the pre-advent judgment is part of the gospel (Rev. 14:6–7), as is true of the Millennial and post-Millennial judgments, as they prove that the controversy charges against God are false, and they clear the way for redemption to find completion in restoration. In other words, there is no completion to the gospel without the pre-advent judgment, and the subsequent judgments.

Study Questions

1. How will David's rule endure forever?
2. What does it mean to make one's enemies a footstool? Give biblical examples.
3. How do we know Jesus studied Psalm 110, and why is it significant that He mentions it?
4. What is the significance of 1 Corinthians 15:24–26, 28? Fully explain.
5. What are the two phases of Christ's King-Priest rule? Give biblical support.
6. In the earthly sanctuary type, what ministry follows the sacrifice at the altar of burnt offering, and how does this relate to the ministry of Jesus Christ?

7. What is the meaning of Hebrews 9:12 as it relates to Christ's King-Priest ministry?
8. How was Christ able to sit down at God's throne in His ascension, when the throne is in the second apartment? How does knowledge of Daniel 7 and a Greek word in Hebrews 9 support your answer?
9. What are the two sides of redemption? Fully explain.
10. What are the two phases of Christ's ministry on earth and in heaven?
11. What is the purpose of the pre-advent judgment?
12. Why is it important to know that the pre-advent judgment has nothing to do with forgiveness?
13. How important is it to understand the cosmic controversy, and what is the reason for the Millennial and post-Millennial (or final) judgments?

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Christ: History and Theology

Purpose

1. Present some wrong theological views of Jesus Christ.
2. Show how these views fail to do justice to His mission.

Summary

Satan hates Christ and entered Judas for the purpose of betraying Him (John 13:27), which led to His death. Given the cosmic controversy of Satan against Christ, we expect to see theological views that fail to do justice to Jesus' Person and His mission. Satan's scheme has always been to hide the purpose of Christ's life and death on earth, and distort His continuing twofold King-Priest ministry in heaven. He does this to try to make Christ's victory over Satan at Calvary meaningless in the lives of humans. Satan's recent work to this end can be traced; his attacks in the Christian era are well known.

When it comes to these attacks, we need to defend Christ by providing Scripture-based answers to these questions: (1) What did the union of the divine and the human do to the divinity of the Son of God, and the humanity of the Son of Man? (2) Were they two persons with two wills in one body, or were they one Person with one will in one body? (3) Did Jesus Christ live on earth as God, or as man?

The Councils of Nicaea (325) and Chalcedon (451) decreed that Jesus Christ was "fully God and fully man" (*vere Deus, vere homo*), yet they only spoke in negative terms with reference to what Jesus Christ was not. They failed to

explain the relationship between the divine and human in Jesus Christ. The twentieth-century quests to "discover" the historical Jesus were failed attempts to get "back to the Jesus of history behind the Christ of faith," as if there is a difference between the two. The Jesus Seminar deleted eighty percent of the words attributed to Him. All false views of Jesus Christ in history and theology follow from a rejection of Scripture as God's self-revelation.

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Introduction

Christology has many facets, some of which are: (1) the study of Christ as a person (ontology) and (2) study of what He has done for us (functional). In

other words, what He is in Himself (two natures), or what His effects are upon us (soteriology). (3) Christology includes knowing Christ's benefits (Melanchton, 1497–1560; Calvin, 1509–1564), and (4) knowing His liberation (Liberation theology in Latin America).[1] (5) Some Christologies are presented prior to and sequentially separate from soteriology; (6) others are combined, as in the *De Incarnatione* (*On the Incarnation*) of Athanasius (293–373), which presents why God became a man, or (7) Christology has to do with divinization of humans (Eastern Christology). (8) Antiochene Christology stressed the duality of natures, whereas Alexandrian Christology stressed the unity of His Person, (9) early Christologies began from above (Son of God) and led toward His humanity, whereas (10) later Christologies began from below (Son of Man) and led toward His divinity. (11) Several recent Christologies have been quests for the historical Jesus (Reimarus to Wrede, 1775–1910; Schweitzer 1875–1965; Dunn 2003), with Scripture subject to historical-critical methods.

At some point scholars began turning away from history—and turned their back on the historical Jesus. History gave way to preaching (Greek, *kerygma*), which was essentially revelation taught in place of Scripture as revelation. The Jesus of history was replaced by the Jesus preached (neo-orthodoxy, existentialism). But there was no objective norm to keep this focus from being subjective, so kerygmatic Christology was later replaced by a return to history, but of a different kind. History was no longer ordinary history (German, *Historie*) but salvation history (German, *Geschichte*), and history could even be the basis for proving the divinity of Christ through the resurrection and empty tomb (Pannenberg, 1928–). Eschatological history became the time when the reality of Christ will be fully known (Moltmann, 1926–, Pannenberg, 1928–).

Central to Christology is (1) the Incarnation (Athanasius), (2) the Cross (Luther), (3) the resurrection (Pannenberg), or (4) eschatology (theology of hope, Moltmann). The life, death, and resurrection of Jesus are included in most Christologies, but the risen Christ's ministry in the heavenly sanctuary is all but absent in most of them. For example, one of the most fully presented Christologies is Kärkkäinen's; it confines the biblical study of Christ to the Gospels and the writings of Paul, leaving out Old Testament predictions about Him and omitting the book of Hebrews evidence of His present heavenly sanctuary ministry.[2]

The relation of the cosmic controversy to Christ's life is another area largely missing in Christology. In Scripture there is a dramatic contrast between Christ and Satan during Christ's life on earth: Demons possessed humans and enslaved

1. Gustavo Gutiérrez Merino, O.P., is a Peruvian theologian and Dominican priest regarded as the founder of Liberation Theology. He holds the John Cardinal O'Hara Professorship of Theology at the University of Notre Dame.

2. Veli-Matti Kärkkäinen, *Christology: A Global Introduction* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2003), 17.

them; Christ set them free. Christ announced that liberating people from various enslavements was His mission (Luke 4:18–21), as predicted in Isaiah (Isa. 61:1–2), and explained in the Psalms (Ps. 146:6–9). He told believers that His teaching would set them free (John 8:32). Christ warned them about Satan for "there is no truth in him. When he lies, he speaks his native language, for he is a liar and the father of lies" (John 8:44). Satan's cosmic controversy is a distortion of the truth about God, and one would expect Satan to distort the truth about Jesus and His life on earth, because Christ came to reveal what God the Father is like, saying, "Anyone who has seen me has seen the Father" (John 14:9b).

The Jesus Seminar believed very few of the words attributed to Jesus in the Gospels were actually spoken by Him. We will take a look at the quests for the historical Jesus and examine the conclusions of the Jesus Seminar. In the meantime, it is instructive to remember that there are many theories about Jesus which reflect the cosmic controversy against Him: (1) He was not virgin born; (2) He had a human father; (3) He didn't pre-exist before His human birth; (4) He didn't perform miracles; (5) He didn't live on earth as the Son of Man, but as the Son of God; (6) He didn't suffer in His life or in His death; (7) He didn't die, but only appeared to die; (8) He didn't rise bodily from the grave; and (9) His promise to return during the generation of His hearers was never fulfilled.

Since the Enlightenment and the Age of Reason, a number of scholars have questioned the historical Jesus. Is the Jesus of the Gospels the one who lived as the God-Man among humans, or is the Gospel portrait of Him a mere human response to who He is? In other words, is Scripture the revelation of Jesus Christ, or only a witness provided by those who encountered Him? Do the Gospels merely present what the writers remembered (Dunn)? Does human remembrance replace divine revelation? Some of these issues will be considered below.

Many questions are raised about Jesus not only because the enemy spreads lies about Him, but also because humans attempt to reason beyond revelation, and the result is that human ideas replace God's revelation. But the foundational hermeneutic to guide us in this study is this: the truth about God, and about the Christ who came to reveal Him, is found in the written Word of God. Many of these questions arise out of a rejection of the written Word of God; once scholars give up belief in God's divine revelation in Scripture, they are adrift like boats out to sea without a compass. No wonder so many theories about Jesus Christ have arisen during the Christian era.

Some of these theories are presented below. But first, let us take a look at the Jewish world at the time of Christ.

Jewish Religious World

What kind of world did Jesus enter as the God-Man? Alfred Edersheim of Oxford University, in his 1883 book *The Life and Times of Jesus the Messiah*, expressed it well:

> Wherever a Roman, a Greek, or an Asiatic might wander, he could take his gods with him, or find rites kindred to his own. It was far otherwise with the Jew. He had only one Temple, that in Jerusalem; only one God, Him Who had once throned there between the Cherubim, and Who was still King of Zion. That Temple was the only place where a God-appointed, pure priesthood could offer acceptable sacrifices, whether for forgiveness of sin, or for fellowship with God. Here, in the impenetrable gloom of the innermost sanctuary, which the High Priest alone might enter once a year for most solemn expiation, had stood the Ark, the leader of the people into the Land of Promise, and the footstool on which the Shechinah had rested. From that golden altar rose the sweet cloud of incense, symbol of Israel's accepted prayers; that seven-branched candlestick shed its perpetual light, indicative of the brightness of God's Covenant Presence; on that table, as it were before the face of Jehovah, was laid, week by week, "the Bread of the Face" (literal translation of "shewbread"), a constant sacrificial meal which Israel offered unto God, and wherewith God in turn fed His chosen priesthood. On the great blood-sprinkled altar of sacrifice smoke the daily and festive burnt-offerings, brought by all Israel, and for all Israel, wherever scattered; while the vast courts of the Temple were thronged not only by native Palestinians, but literally by "Jews out of every nation under heaven." Around this Temple gathered the sacred memories of the past; to it clung the yet brighter hopes of the future. The history of Israel and all their prospects were intertwined with their religion; so that it may be said that without their religion they had no history, and without their history no religion. Thus, history, patriotism, religion, and hope alike pointed to Jerusalem and the Temple as the center of Israel's unity.[3]

Sacrifices and services at the temple found their meaning and fulfillment in Jesus Christ, yet very few Jews realized that their religion really centered in a Person, to whom temple types pointed. Sadly Christ "came unto his own, and his own received him not" (John 1:11, KJV). Jews didn't look for a Messiah who would give the temple its meaning as a shadow of the reality in Him. Instead, they longed for a Messiah to conquer the hated Romans who ruled over them. What they failed to long for was liberation from slavery to religious rules, routine, and ritual, devoid of the reality of a covenant relationship with their Messiah who came to save them from sin. They needed liberation from this deeper slavery that would be present even if they were freed from Roman rule.

3. Alfred Edersheim, *The Life and Times of Jesus the Messiah* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1986), 3–4.

Christological Debates

In chapter 9, we noted how the Synoptics, John, Pauline writings, Hebrews, and Revelation reveal that Jesus Christ is fully God and fully human. The first three centuries after Christ's ascension to heaven was the time when the Trinitarian doctrine was worked out, and the divinity of Christ and the Spirit was included in this thinking (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 1). The Greco-Roman world was full of gods. Athens even had an altar to the "unknown god," suggesting they didn't want to leave any god out of their worship (superstition about pleasing the gods led them to play it safe—they wanted full insurance coverage against bad things that could happen to them). Worship of gods was strictly for alleged benefits to be gained.

At the same time, there was an anti-Christ type of flawed theology already at work in early Christian times. John speaks of this originating among former Christians (1 John 2:18–19):

> Dear friends, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits to see whether they are from God, because many false prophets have gone out into the world. This is how you can recognize the Spirit of God: Every spirit that acknowledges that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is from God, but every spirit that does not acknowledge Jesus is not from God. This is the spirit of the antichrist, which you have heard is coming and even now is already in the world. (1 John 4:1–3)

Antichrist is made up of two words, *anti* and *Christ*. The word *anti* means "against" or "in place of." The above text says a spirit not from God (false prophet/teacher) believes that God didn't really become human. To John it was obvious that Jesus was the Son of God (e.g., 1 John 3:8b). Because antichrist is against Christ, it would not be long before it would question whether He was God. In other words, fallen spirits (the cosmic controversy rebels) were opposed to both the humanity and divinity of Christ, and both false ideas began to flourish in the early centuries of Christian history.

It is important to the cosmic controversy to distort the reality of Jesus Christ by questioning His humanity and His divinity, to either present Him as too divine or too human. Either way, they achieve their objective: to question the authenticity of the Incarnation. Then they can take the place of Christ (the other meaning of *anti*) through their theoretical Christ. The first section presents some "too divine" views of Christ, followed by some "too human" views of Jesus.

TOO DIVINE

The word *Monachian* comes from two Greek words *mono* (one) *archē* (ruler). The Monarcians considered the Father alone as sovereign, and denied that there

are three Gods (tritheism). Proponents (primarily in the West) of this teaching "den[ied] the personal distinctiveness of a divine Son and Holy Spirit in contrast to God the Father."[4] There are two kinds of Monarchianism: (1) Modalistic, which is presented in this segment, and (2) Dynamic, which is taken up in the next section. The Modalistic followers considered Christ too divine, the Dynamic group considered Jesus too human. So the first group is taken up now, and the second group in the next segment.

Modalistic Monarchianism

I place Modalism in the Too Divine category because it denies the humanity of the God-Man, asserting that it was the Father who suffered (Patripassianism). So Modalism was monotheism, rejecting the functional distinctions in the Trinity. Tertullian was the first to use the term Monarchianism in order to protect the monarchy of God. Modalistic Monarchianism is often referred to as Sabellianism,[5] named after the third-century Sabellius, its best known exponent (others include Noetus and Praxeas). Sabellius denied the Trinity. Augustine correctly stated the Sabellian Trinity "has no real distinction of persons."[6] Sabellius taught that God was one Being, and merely manifested Himself at different times as Father, Son and Spirit.[7] In other words, God has the ability to exist in these three modes of being sequentially, but not concurrently. He simply takes the form of the Father, then takes the form of the Son, and finally takes the form of the Holy Spirit.

Yet, in Scripture, Christ prayed to His Father (John 17), which means the Father and the Son existed concurrently. Furthermore, at Christ's baptism, the Spirit descended in the form of a dove upon Christ, and the Father spoke about Christ, so all three were present at the same time (Matt 3:13–17). It is clear that Modalism disallows the Incarnation in which the Father and Spirit participate (John 3:16; Matt. 1:20), and the dependence of Jesus upon His Father and the Spirit during His incarnational life (see chapter 9). It is also clear that when Christ died, there was no God to run the universe, or to call Him from the grave (Acts 2:32).

Modalism also disallows the post-resurrection ministry of Jesus Christ at the right hand of the Father where He intercedes with the Father on behalf of humans (1 Tim. 2:5; Heb. 8:6; 9:15; 12:24), sends the Holy Spirit from the Father to humans (Acts 2:33), and bestows spiritual gifts (1 Cor. 12:1–11, 27–31; 13:13; Gal. 5:22–23; Eph. 4:1–3, 7–8). It takes the biblical Trinity to enable Christ to fulfill His heavenly ministry, just as it did to fulfill His ministry on earth. In Modalism the Son cannot become a King-Priest at the right hand of the Father in a joint rule.

4. C. Blaising, "Monarchianism," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 2nd ed., ed. Walter A. Elwell (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic; Cumbria, UK: Paternoster, 2001), 784.
5. Ibid., 784.
6. Augustine, *The City of God, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, ed. Philip Schaff (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), 2:210 (11.10).
7. C. Blaising, "Monarchianism," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 785.

Monophysitism

Even though the Western and Eastern churches accepted the "fully God, fully man" verdict of the Chalcedon Council, there was an influential dissent in the Eastern church. It started in Alexandria and spread to Egypt, Ethiopia, much of Syria, and to an extent in Armenia. The dissent was called Monophysitism, meaning "one nature," because it believed that the divine in Jesus Christ transformed the human, making Jesus fully divine and not fully human.[8] In this way Jesus Christ lived on earth as God, rather than as a human.

Docetism

The name *Docetism* comes from the Greek verb *dokeō*, "to seem" or "to appear." This term refers to Christ's humanity: He just appeared to be human. Whereas Ebionitism (see next segment) denied the divinity of Jesus, Docetism denied the humanity of Christ. If Christ wasn't really human, did He really suffer? Those opposing Docetism assumed that the divinity of Christ wasn't touched by suffering, and hence the only suffering He experienced was through His apparent humanity. For example, Irenaeus argued against Docetists "who separate Jesus from Christ, alleging that Christ remained impassible, but that it was Jesus who suffered."[9]

Tertullian argued against any suffering by an apparent humanity: for "the sufferings of Christ will be found not to warrant faith in him. For he suffered nothing who did not truly suffer; and a phantom could not truly suffer. God's entire work, therefore, is subverted. Christ's death…is denied."[10] McGrath rightly concludes that among Docetists, "The sufferings of Christ are thus treated as apparent rather than real."[11] "Apparent suffering" was an idea with which Gnostics were comfortable, for they taught that there is a gulf between the Creator and the creature, and this can only be bridged by a descending order of beings who become ever more human, and ever less divine as they got closer to the realm of humans. One may call this an apparent incarnation, for

8. Kenneth Scott Latourette, *Beginnings to 1500*, rev. ed., vol. 1 in *A History of Christianity* (Peabody, MA: Prince, 1997), 172.
9. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies*, *The Anti-Nicene Fathers*, eds. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1989), 1:428 (3.10.7).
10. Tertullian, *Against Marcion, The Anti-Nicene Fathers*, 3:328 (3.8).
11. Alister E. McGrath, *Christian Theology: An Introduction* (Oxford, UK: Blackwell, 1994), 282.

it was really not the true Incarnation at all. Cerinthus, Ebion, Marcion, and Valentinus were Docetists.[12]

Apthartodocetism

Apthartodocetism is a type of Monophysitism promoted by Emperor Julian the Apostate (332–363). Julian was born in 332 at Constantinople, the son of Julius Constantius. This view taught that because Christ was divine, He experienced no change through His incarnation and His birth through Mary. Christ "was incorruptible, incapable of suffering" and was incapable of natural passions. So His humanity was severely limited.[13]

Nestorianism

Nestorius (fifth century) may not have taught the doctrine named after him, but it was taught by his followers. The controversy had to do with the term *theotokos* (God-bearing) used in regard to Mary. Was Mary the mother only of Jesus (human nature), or was she also the mother of God (divine nature)? Nestorius thought the term was appropriate if one used the term *anthrōpotokos* (human-bearing). Nestorius actually preferred the term *Christotokos* (Christ-bearing). Nestorius feared that using the term *theotokos* would lead to either Arianism (Christ not equal with God) or Apollinarianism (Jesus not a real man). Cyril of Alexandria considered that Nestorianism taught a moral union of two natures, rather than a real union. In other words, Christ was actually two persons, a view rejected by Nestorius, and a view rejected by the Council of Ephesus (431). *Theotokos*, as understood in Alexandria, was equivalent to *communicatio idiomatum*, or the interchange of properties, the divine with the human and the human with the divine, and hence one Person. This was a view of the Eastern Church.[14]

Eutychianism

In reaction to the Eastern church's view of Nestorianism, the Western church (fifth century) declared that Christ had two natures before the Incarnation and only one nature after the Incarnation. This meant that the two natures were united without confusion (or without the *communicatio idiomatum*). But this unity meant the human nature was absorbed by the divine nature. Christ was only God. The Synod of Constantinople (448) rejected this view, and yet the

12. Donald Macleod, *The Person of Christ: Contours of Christian Theology*, ed. Gerald Bray (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1998), 157.
13. Latourette, *Beginnings to 1500*, rev. ed., vol. 1 in *A History of Christianity*, 282.
14. Kärkkäinen, *Christology*, 76–77.

"Robber Synod" in Ephesus (449) reinstated the view of Eutychus. The final decision would finally come at Chalcedon (451).[15]

The Pope Leo the Great of Rome opposed the idea that there was only a single nature in Jesus Christ after the Incarnation, stating that Eutychus did "not recognise our nature to exist in the Only-begotten Son of God, either by way of lowliness of mortality, or of the glory of resurrection."[16] In his letter to John of Antioch, Cyril taught the "union of two natures" and opposed a "mingling or mixture" of the two. Cyril opposed those who thought "a shadow of change could occur concerning the Nature of the Word of God. For he remains that which he always was, and has not been changed, nor can he ever be changed, nor is he capable of change. For we all confess in addition to this, that the Word of God is impassible.... To the same purpose the all-wise Peter also said when he wrote of Christ as having 'suffered in the flesh,' and not in the nature of his ineffable godhead. In order that he should be believed to be the Savior of all, by an economic appropriation to himself, as just said, he assumed the sufferings of his own Flesh."[17]

Apollinarianism

Apollinaris of Laodicea was concerned about the *Logos* taking full humanity, for that would mean, in his thinking, that the *Logos* would be contaminated, which would mean that Christ was not sinless. So he suggested that the human mind in Jesus was replaced by a divine mind, assuring that Christ would be sinless. This was a view to protect the full divinity of Christ, but it questioned the full humanity of Jesus.[18]

TOO HUMAN

Dynamic Monarchianism

Dynamic comes from the Greek word *dunamis*, meaning *power*. It holds that God's presence was in Jesus in such a powerful way that Jesus was different from any other human, but He was never God, only close to being God. Theodotus of Byzantine said this dynamic presence of the Father came upon Jesus at His baptism. This is also known as Adoptionism, which teaches that Jesus was adopted as the Son of God either at His baptism or resurrection. Paul of Samosata denied that "the Word [*Logos*] was God" (John 1:1), for the

15. Ibid., 75.
16. Leo the Great, the *Tome of St. Leo, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series (Edinburgh: T & T Clark; Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), 14:257.
17. Cyril, *The Letter of Cyril to John of Antioch, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, 14:252.
18. Kärkkäinen, *Christology*, 73–74.

Word was merely the dynamic presence of God. This view was condemned at the Synod of Antioch (268).[19]

Ebionitism

Ebionites were a Jewish sect, and their name is a Hebrew term meaning "the poor ones." They were committed to the Hebrew *Shema*: "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one" (Deut. 6:4). To them, there can only be one God, so Jesus Christ could not be God as well. They rejected the idea that He was divine, and held that He remained merely a son of Joseph and Mary, fully human, even though He became the Messiah that His baptism. Adoptionism was read into the text "You are my son; today I have become your father" (Ps. 2:7). Because He was a mere man adopted by God, "His death had no salvific significance."[20] Ebionites embodied legalistic Pharisaism (salvation by works) and were the "successors of the Judaizers opposed in the Epistle to the Galatians." No wonder they opposed Paul, considering him "an apostate and heretic."[21] Ebionites "persisted, as small minorities, until at least the latter part of the fourth century and perhaps much longer."[22]

Gnosticism

Gnostics believe that *gnōsis* is enlightenment, or saving knowledge. Hence salvation is not through a Savior, but through knowledge, a belief popular in Eastern religions. Gnosticism was an early heresy against which apologists Irenaeus, Tertullian, Hippolytus, and Epiphanius wrote. Gnosticism was a "combination of Greek philosophy and Christianity."[23] Other critics of Gnosticism during the second to fourth centuries include Augustine, Justin Martyr, Clement of Alexandria, and Origen.[24]

Gnosticism presents a dualism between spirit and matter (good and evil) with the "God" of the Old Testament being less than the "God" of the New Testament. It teaches that creation resulted from the fall of Sophia (Wisdom). The Gnostic redeemer wasn't really human, nor did he die on a cross. Rather salvation was a secret *gnōsis* (knowledge) that the Gnostic "God" communicates through the redeemer after his resurrection (spiritual, not physical, and

19. Kärkkäinen, *Christology*, 67–69; Latourette, *Beginnings to 1500*, rev. ed., vol. 1 in *A History of Christianity*, 143–145.
20. Hans Schwartz, *Christology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1998), 149.
21. Philip Schaff, *Ante-Nicene Christianity (A.D. 100–325)*, vol. 2 in *History of the Christian Church* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1962, 1st ed. 1910), 433.
22. Latourette, *Beginnings to 1500*, rev. ed., vol. 1 in *A History of Christianity*, 122.
23. G. L. Borchert, "Gnosticism," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 485.
24. Norman L. Geisler, "Gnosticism," in *Baker Encyclopedia of Christian Apologetics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1999), 274–275.

is the same for humans). Gnostics look forward to escaping from the body and being reunited with "God" (leaving the physical body and becoming only a spirit).

Arianism

Arius was born around 250 in North Africa. For him, the Supreme Being was God the Father rather than the Trinity. The Father could not communicate His essence to another being like Christ.[25] Arianism rejected the equality of Christ with the Father, for the Father alone was self-existent, having no dependence upon anyone but Himself for His existence. By contrast Christ originated from the Father in a subordinationist sense, so that Christ was dependent upon the Father for His existence. Arius placed this dependence way back in eternity, but that didn't alter the fact that there was a kind of Creator-creature relationship between the Father and Christ. Hence Christ was not divine in the sense of being a co-equal Person in the eternal Trinity. There was an ontological distinction between the Father and the Son, and this meant that Christ could not save humans because only God can do that.

If the Father is understood as "fully timeless; the Son and the Spirit can thereupon be allowed their biblical roles." This means the Son and the Spirit would be temporal, and in this respect would be considered ontologically below the Father. Apologists from Justin Martyr (ca. 100–165) to Origen (ca. 185–254) "built and worked within a subordinationist theological structure." Because the *Logos* originated from the Father, He would not be "utterly timeless" like the Father, because He had an origin in Him which would be temporal, and subordinate.[26]

Socinianism

Faustus Socinus (1539–1604), an Italian, opposed the Trinity, following his uncle Laelius Socinius. He eventually became leader of the Anabaptist Unitarian sect in Poland. He believed Scripture should be interpreted rationally, and he denied the divinity of Christ, saying He did not become God until after His resurrection. Socinus rejected the atonement of Christ on Calvary, saying the Father can forgive sin without any sacrifice. His views prepared the way for later Unitarian movements.[27]

25. See G. A. Keith, "Arianism," in *New Dictionary of Theology*, ed. Sinclair B. Ferguson and David F. Wright (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1988), 42.
26. Robert W. Jenson, *The Triume God*, vol. 1 in *Systematic Theology* (New York: Oxford, 1997), 96–97.
27. P. Kubricht, "Socinus, Faustus," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 1122.

RELATIONSHIP OF THE SON TO THE FATHER

Council of Nicaea (325)

In volume 2 we took up the Council of Nicaea (pages 91–131) with respect to the Trinity. Now in volume 3 we will return to this Council in the context of Christology. Naturally there is an overlap, but we will attempt to briefly review and add some insights. (The reader may wish to reread those pages in volume 2 at this juncture.)

The two leading thinkers at the Council, and beyond, were Arius (b. 250) and Athanasius (293–273). Arius was the reason the Council was called, and Athanasius, during and after the Council, made the most important contribution to solving the dilemma which occasioned the Council. Hence we will be noting the contribution of both to the Council.

The Council of Nicaea (325) was the first ecumenical Council in church history, with over three hundred bishops from the East. The Bishop of Rome was quite elderly, so he was not able to attend, but sent two presbyters to represent him.[28] It was largely an Eastern Council because the problem of Arianism (Arius taught that Jesus was created) was prevalent in the East. It was called by the Emperor Constantine in an effort to reunite the Empire after a schism caused by Arianism. The Council was a religious matter due to doctrinal divisions, but it was equally a matter of State, and the emperor gave the opening address on the importance of unity. Our interest is on the Christology debated at the Council, and the Council's outcome.

One divisive issue was the relation of the Son to the Father. As early as the writings of Justin Martyr (ca.114–165) in his *First Apology*, we find Christ referred to as "the first-born of the unbegotten God."[29] What did "first-born" mean? For Origen (ca.185–254) it meant (1) Christ was Son of the Father from eternity, and (2) the Son and Spirit are subject to the Father. This latter idea led to the problem of subordinationism, which influenced Arius.[30] For Arius, God is immutable, and therefore Christ had to be made out of nothing by God, so there was a time when He was not. So Christ is not eternal, and does not proceed from God's substance. In arriving at these two conclusions Arius had gone much farther than Origen in diminishing Christ to not much more than any other created being.

Most of the bishops present were not familiar with the issue. They were more concerned with Sabellianism, which held that God had three modes of

28. Latourette, *Beginnings to 1500*, rev. ed., vol. 1 in *A History of Christianity*, 154.
29. Justin Martyr, *The First Apology of Justin*, *The Anti-Nicene Fathers*, 1:180 (53).
30. C. C. Kroeger, "Origen," *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 870.

being as Father, Son, and Spirit, than with the view of Arius in subordinating Christ to the Father. Twenty-eight of them supported Arius, and one of them stood up and declared that Christ was not God. An uproar resulted, after which the bishops were more prepared to make a statement. Before coming to that, let us look at the problem in greater depth and discover who Athanasius was—and why he proved to be so important to this debate.

Gregory of Nazianzus, in his oration *On the Great Athanasius*, says Athanasius was "first in the holy Synod of Nicaea, the gathering of the three hundred and eighteen chosen men, united by the Holy Ghost, as far as in him lay, he stayed the disease [of Arius]. Though not yet ranked among the Bishops, he held the first rank among the members of the Council, for preference was given to virtue just as much as to office."[31] It may be instructive to gain an insight into the Arian views through the description offered by Athanasius:

> "God was not always a Father. When he was God alone he was not yet a Father; later he became a Father." "The Son was not always," for since all things came into being from nothing, and all existing creatures and works came into being, even the Word of God himself "came into being from nothing," and "there was once when he was not," and "he was not before he came into being," but even he himself had a "beginning of his own creation." Arius said God was alone, and the Word and Wisdom were not yet. Then God, wishing to fashion us, made a certain one and named him Word, Wisdom, and Son, in order that through him he might fashion us.... Arius dared to say, "The Word is not true God...in all respects the Word is alien and unlike the substance and property of the Father.... The substances of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit are divided in nature, estranged, detached, alien, and nonsharers in one another."[32]

In his *Four Discourses Against the Arians*, Athanasius said, "it is more pious and more accurate to signify God from the Son and call Him Father, than to name Him from His works only and call Him Unoriginate."[33] In focusing on the relationship between Father and Son, rather than on the works of the Son, Nicaea followed the lead of Athanasius.[34]

31. Gregory Nazianzus, *Oration 21: On The Great Athanasius, Bishop of Alexandria, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, eds. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1989), 7:273 (21:13–14), parenthesis added. See footnote: "Athanasius was present as theological assistant to Alexander of Alexandria." By contrast V. L. Walter says Athanasius was at Nicaea, but didn't take part much in the Council which met on May 20, 325. Three years later (328) Athanasius became bishop of Alexandria and played a major role in defeating Arianism, which lived on after the Council. See V. L. Walter, "Arius, Arianism," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 95–96.
32. Athanasius's *Orations Against the Arians* in *The Trinitarian Controversy* trans. and ed. William G. Rusch (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1980), 66–68.
33. Athanasius, *Four Discourses Against the Arians, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, 4:326 (1.34).
34. Thomas F. Torrance, *The Trinitarian Faith: The Evangelical Theology of the Ancient Catholic Church* (Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1988), 6.

Eusebius, the church historian, was present at the Council, and in writing to his church included the statement issued at the close of the deliberations, which condemned Arius.

> We believe in one God, Father, all-sovereign, maker of all things seen and unseen, and in one Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, begotten from the Father, that is only-begotten from the substance of the Father, God from God, Light from Light, true God from true God, begotten not made, *homoousios* [same essence] with the Father, through whom all things, those in heaven and those on earth, came into existence, who on account of us men and on account of our salvation came down and was made flesh, was made man, suffered, arose on the third day, went up into heaven, is coming to judge living and dead. And in the Holy Spirit. And those who say, "There was once when he was not" and "Before he was begotten, he was not" and that "he came into existence from nothing," or those who allege that the Son of God is "from another *hypotasis* or substance" or is created or mutable or different, the catholic and apostolic church anathematizes.[35]

In simple language, the decision was that Christ was "begotten not made," which means that He was not a created being but of the same substance (*homoousios*) as the Father. This was a victory against Arius.[36] After this decision, Arius was banished to Illyricum, where he continued writing and appealed to a growing "circle of political and ecclesiastical adherents to Arianism." Emperor Constantine, who was not theologically equipped, made contact with Arius in 332 or 333, which led to a meeting of the two in Nicomedia in 335. Arius handed the emperor a confession which Constantine considered sufficient, and then had Arius reinstated. Hence, "instead of resolving the issues, the Council of Nicaea had launched an empire-wide Christological debate by its condemnation of Arius."[37] We will look further at the debate in the doctrine of salvation, and will see that Athanasius made an important contribution to combating Arianism.

Subsequent to the Council of Nicaea, the state of affairs in the church might persuade us that Arianism was on its way to defeating the biblical view of Christ.

> Beginning with Constantius, the court was often Arian. Five times Athanasius of Alexandria was driven into exile, interrupting his long episcopate. A series of synods repudiated the Nicene symbol in various ways: Antioch in 341 and Arles in 353. In 355 Liberius of Rome and Ossius of Cordoba were exiled, and a year later Hilary of Poitier was sent to Phrygia. In 360 in Constantinople, all earlier creeds were disavowed and the term *ousia* (substance) was outlawed. The Son was simply declared to be "like the Father who begot him."[38]

35. "*Eusebius of Caesarea's* Letter to His Church Concerning the Synod at Nicaea" in *The Trinitarian Controversy*, trans. and ed. by William G. Rusch (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress Press, 1980), 58–59.
36. Adapted from Roger E. Olson, *The Story of Christian Theology: Twenty Centuries of Tradition & Reform* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1999), 151–155.
37. Walter, "Arius, Arianism," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 95.
38. Ibid., 95.

The Cappadocians (Fourth Century)

The final resolution was made through the Cappadocian theologians, Basil the Great, Gregory of Nyssa, and Gregory of Nazianzus. They "divided the concept of substance (*ousia*) from that of person (*hypostasis*) and thus allowed the orthodox defenders of the original Nicene formula and the later moderate or semi-Arian party to unite in an understanding of God as one substance and three persons. Christ therefore was one substance with the Father *(homoousion)* but a distinct person."[39] Nicaea did not address the issue of God's impassibility, and the Cappadocians only acknowledged a relation of origins in the Trinity, and in so doing did not penetrate to the biblical history which reveals the relation among the three Persons of the Trinity.[40]

This led to the Council of Constantinople (381) which reaffirmed the Nicene Creed, and added an article on the divinity and personality of the Holy Spirit. So the Nicaea-Constantinople Councils presented the official understanding of the Trinity as it was understood near the end of the fourth century,[41] even though Arianism was not finally accepted by Eastern Orthodoxy until the seventh century.[42]

Conclusion

The idea of a pre-existent *Logos* (Word, John 1:1) was the primary debate in theology during the second and third centuries.[43] At the close of the third century and into the fourth century, theology vacillated between Sabellianism (one God in three modes) and subordination (Son and Spirit subordinate to the Father). In the fourth century, Christians began to consider the absoluteness of the Christian religion, believing that the head of Christianity (Christ) should not be considered subordinate to God (Father). Theology in the East was more speculative, and in the West was more practical. In this context the following three ideas were discussed:

1. Arianism—Son was created out of nothing; He is different in essence (*heteroousios*) from the Father.
2. Athanasian—Son is identical (same) in substance (*homoousios*) with the Father.

39. Ibid., 96.
40. Cf. Robert W. Jenson, *Systematic Theology: The Triune God* (New York: Oxford, 1997), 108. In her chapter "God in Communion with Us: The Trinity," Catherine Mowry LaCugna notes that the Cappadocians made "*person rather than substance*" the primary ontological category. See *Freeing Theology: The Essentials of Theology in Feminist Perspective*, ed. Catherine Mowry LaCugna (New York: HarperSanFrancisco, 1993), 86.
41. Philip Schaff, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Christianity: From Constantine the Great to Gregory the Great*, vol. 3 in *History of the Christian Church* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1960, 1st ed. 1910), 349–350.
42. Walter, "Arius, Arianism," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 96.
43. See Albert Henry Newman, *Ancient and Medieval Church History*, vol. 1 in *A Manual of Church History* (Philadelphia, PA: American Baptist, 1948, 1st ed. 1899), 324–329, for this and the next paragraph in text.

3. Semi-Arianism (Eusebian party)—Son is like (*homoiousios*) the Father, but not the same in substance with the Father.

Was the Son different, the same, or similar in substance/essence with the Father? If He was different or similar, He was not fully God. Only if He was of the same substance/essence was He fully God.

RELATION OF DIVINE/HUMAN

The councils of Nicaea (325) and Chalcedon (451) established that Christ was fully divine and fully human, thus overcoming the many one-sided views concerning His divinity and humanity noted above. So a fully divine Christ was united to a fully human Christ. But the councils said nothing about the relationship between the two natures, the divine and the human. As a result, the ensuring centuries presented Jesus Christ living as God in the world, which didn't adequately emphasize the reality of the humanity of Jesus: (1) what He gave up in order to save humans (*kenōsis*, or "self-emptying" of Phil. 2, see below); (2) His temptations; and (3) His sufferings.

Eastern Dominance in Councils

Early Church history is dominated by the Eastern Church—not the Western Church, as some believe. For a long time Rome was just one of the centers of the church with a bishop in charge. The Councils were held to solve debates, and to enhance the unity of both church and empire. The first seven Ecumenical Councils were Nicaea (325); Constantinople (381); Ephesus (431); Chalcedon (451); Constantinople (553, 680–681); and Nicaea (787). We will consider the Council of Nicaea (325) and the Council of Chalcedon (451).

It is worthy of note that all seven Councils were held in the territory of the Eastern Church, and the new capital of the Roman Empire was moved to Constantinople (old Byzantium) by Constantine I in 330. These Councils were convened by emperors rather than church potentates.[44] It needs to be kept in mind that there was no Papacy in the early centuries. Before the

44. Leo the Great (440–461) is considered the "first pope, in the proper sense of the word" and the first important theologian in the chair of Rome. He established the dogmatic arguments for the papacy Schaff, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Christianity: From Constantine the Great to Gregory the Great*, vol. 3 in *History of the Christian Church*, 315, 319. But the twenty-eighth canon of Chalcedon (451) gives equal place to the Bishop of Constantinople, so the Pope did not have primacy. The canon says: "The bishop of New Rome shall enjoy the same honor as the bishop of Old Rome, on account of the removal of the Empire. For this reason the (metropolitans) of Pontus, of Asia, and of Thrace, as well as the Barbarian bishops shall be ordained by the bishop of Constantinople," *The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers* Second Series, 14:87. Gregory I (461–590) and Gregory the Great (590–604), as bishops of Rome, "mark the transition of the patriarchal system into the strict papacy of the middle ages," Schaff, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Christianity: From Constantine the Great to Gregory the Great*, vol. 3 in *History of the Christian Church*, 328.

fifth century, the church at Rome was not regarded as the head over all other Christian churches.

Success of Nicaea-Chalcedon

Nicaea (325) and Chalcedon (451) were successful in stating the fact that Jesus Christ was fully God and fully man, not one without the other. Theirs was a balanced view of the Incarnation:

> We believe in one God, the Father Almighty, maker of all things visible and invisible; and in one Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, the only-begotten of his Father, of the substance of the Father, God of God, Light of Light, very God of very God, begotten (γεννηθέντα), not made, being of one substance (ὁμοούσιον, consubstantialem) with the Father. By whom all things were made, both which be in heaven and in earth. Who for us men and for our salvation came down (from heaven) and was incarnate and was made man. He suffered and the third day he rose again, and ascended into heaven. And he shall come again to judge both the quick and the dead. And [we believe] in the Holy Ghost. And whosoever shall say that there was a time when the Son of God was not (ἦν ποτε ὅτε οὐκ ἦν), or that before he was begotten he was not, or that he was made of things that were not, or that he is of a different substance or essence [from the Father] or that he is a creature, or subject to change or conversion—all that so say, the Catholic and Apostolic Church anathematizes them.[45]

This statement from the Council of Nicaea embraces the Trinity, and Christ as begotten (not made) as one substance (*homoousion*) with the Father. There was no time when Christ was not, nor was He made out of things, a different essence from the Father, for He isn't a creature subject to change. This statement emphasizes the equality of the Son with the Father. But there is nothing in this statement that elucidates the post-ascension ministry of Christ. The need to understand what Christ is doing in His heavenly ministry is as great today as it once was to know what He was doing in His ministry on earth. He needs to be fully God and fully man to accomplish both, and the Nicene and Chalcedon Councils laid the foundation for a true understanding of Christology. Chalcedon completed the work done at Nicaea:

> We, then, following the holy Fathers, all with one consent, teach men to confess one and the same Son, our Lord Jesus Christ, the same perfect in Godhood and also perfect in manhood; truly God and truly man, of a reasonable [rational] soul and body; consubstantial [co-essential] with the Father according to the Godhead, and consubstantial with us according to the Manhood; in all things like unto us, without sin; begotten before all ages of the Father according to the Godhood, and in these latter days, for us and for our salvation, born of the Virgin Mary, the Mother of God, according to the Manhood; one and the same Christ, Son, Lord, Only-begotten, to be acknowledged in two natures, inconfusedly, unchangeably, indivisibly, in together

45. *The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, 14:3.

> separately; the distinction of natures being by no means taken away by the union, but rather the property of each nature being preserved, and concurring in one Person and one Subsistence, not parted or divided into two persons, but one and the same Son, and only begotten, God the Word, the Lord Jesus Christ, as the prophets from the beginning [have declared] concerning him, and the Lord Jesus Christ himself has taught us, and the Creed of the holy Fathers has handed down to us.[46]

Here Christ is said to be truly God and Man, consubstantial with God and humans. These two natures are defined in negative terms (what they are not). The two natures are not confused, not changed, not divisible, and not separable. The union doesn't negate the uniqueness of each nature, nor is the union of two persons. So the Nicene and Chalcedon Councils agreed that Jesus Christ is fully God and fully human (*vere Deus, vere homo*).

Failure of Nicaea-Chalcedon

Although these Councils achieved a new level of articulation of Christ's divinity and humanity, they didn't say anything about how the two are related. It was of foundational importance that the Councils lay the groundwork for a balanced Christology, but it is equally necessary that Christians understand how the divinity of Christ relates to His humanity, and how His humanity relates to His divinity. Did He act on earth as God, or as a human—and does it matter which is true?

Veli-Matti Kärkkäinen states the gains made by Chalcedon, and rightly sees what it didn't do: "The main concern of Chalcedon was to steer a middle course between the dangers of Nestorianism, which separated the two natures—thus the use of the words 'indivisibly' and 'inseparably'—and Eutychianism, which eliminated the distinction between the two natures—thus the use of the words 'inconfusedly' and 'unchangeably.' Although the council was unable to state definitely how the union of the two natures occurred, it was able to show this union cannot be expressed."[47] Then he speaks about the controlling principle of Chalcedon which reveals that those at the Council did not understand the importance of Christ's humanity to His ministry on earth, and to His ministry in heaven's sanctuary: "The controlling principle of Chalcedon holds that provided that Jesus Christ was both truly divine and truly human, the precise manner in which this is articulated or explored is not of fundamental importance."[48]

Irenaeus (ca. 130–200) gained from Scripture an insight into the relationship between the divine and the human natures in Jesus, which not even the Councils

46. Kärkkäinen, *Christology*, 77–78.
47. Ibid., 78.
48. Ibid.

of Nicaea (325) and Constantinople (451) achieved. He said that Christ "became man in order to undergo temptation, so also was He the Word that He might be glorified; the Word remaining quiescent, that He might be capable of being tempted, dishonoured, crucified, and of suffering death."[49] Irenaeus rejected the heretical idea that Jesus "was merely a receptacle of Christ" who came upon Him in the form of a dove, so that "He merely suffered in outward appearance, being naturally impassible."[50]

Here is the real humanity of Jesus: He could be tempted (not impassible) and His divinity was quiescent (Jesus lived on earth as a human). If subsequent theology had followed Irenaeus in this biblical understanding of Christology, the history of theology would have been dramatically different. Instead, many theologians took up his nonbiblical view that human creation was the first step toward the Incarnation—that Christ would have come in the Incarnation even if there had been no Fall. This view of Christ fails to grasp the sacrifice involved in Christ's becoming human to live a dependent, intense life as the "man of sorrows" in order to save humans, and to understand their struggles, allowing Him to be a sympathetic High Priest in the heavenly sanctuary ministry during the Christian era (Heb. 4:15–16).

Wrong Views of God

The impassible, immutable, or removed God of classical theology is the God who, paradoxically, ruled over the Son of Man as Son of God. For example, Tertullian (155–220) states that neither the Father nor the Spirit suffered, for God only suffered in the Son. This leads to the dereliction cry, "My God, my God, why hast Thou forsaken me?" Tertullian says this was the cry of the humanity of Christ, suggesting "it was uttered so as to prove the impassibility of God, who 'forsook' His Son, so far as He handed over His human substance to the suffering of death."[51] The aloofness of Tertullian's God did not allow him to grasp the suffering at the cross of each Person of the Trinity.

On the other hand, Novatian (210–280) argues for the inferiority of the Son of God to God the Father. Novatian demonstrates this from the following texts: the Father has the Son sit on His right hand until He defeats His enemies (Ps. 110:1); "Father, glorify me in your presence with the glory I had with you before the world began" (John 17:5); "I have brought you glory on earth by finishing the work you gave me to do" (John 17:4); and "All things have been

49. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies, The Anti-Nicene Fathers*, 1:449 (3.19.3).
50. Ibid., 1:440 (3.16.1). "Christ remained impassible…it was Jesus who suffered" *The Anti-Nicene Fathers*, 1:428 (3.11.7).
51. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies, The Anti-Nicene Fathers*, 3:623–627 (27–30).

committed to me by my Father" (Luke 10:22).[52] The text "I and the Father are one" (John 10:30) is interpreted as "the Father and Son are one in agreement, in love" which he calls the "loving association." He continues with his reasoning that the Son of God is "inferior to the Father" because the Father sanctified Him (set Him apart) and sent Him into the world (John 10:36). He cites Christ's words, "If you loved me, you would be glad that I am going to the Father, for the Father is greater than I" (John 14:28).[53] These texts, except the first one, are appropriate in light of the Incarnation, for Jesus Christ was dependent upon His Father and the Spirit as He lived a human life. However, these texts are used out of context when seeking to establish the Son of God as inferior to God the Father in an ontological, pre-incarnational sense.

Tertullian and Novatian are examples of those with a wrong view of God—a God who is removed from all others (Tertullian) and superior to His Son (Novatian), and one could argue that the latter is a logical result of the former. An ontological subordination is presented in the context of an impassible, immutable, unchanging God of classical theology (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 5) but not in the context of a relational Trinity, where all three Persons are self-existent, equal, eternal, and in a reciprocal relationship of love (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 1). A relational Trinity manifests itself in continuing love, so that the Son of God is equally divine, but in the incarnational self-emptying (*kenōsis*, Phil. 2:6–8) lives on earth as a dependent human to learn to sympathize with other humans by entering into the human struggle (Heb. 2:17–18; 4:14–16). He remained fully God throughout His life on earth, but did not use His divinity for Himself as an advantage over other humans. Salvation was possible because He was God, but it was worked out in time and history through His human dependency upon God outside of Himself, rather than dependence on the God within (see chapter 9).

Christ Lived on Earth as God

We have mentioned that some scholars teach that Christ lived on earth as God. In this segment we give examples that represent this traditional way of interpreting the life of Jesus. Some of these examples reach back prior to the Councils, and some are subsequent to the Councils. Both conveyed human traditions in place of biblical revelation.

52. Ibid., 5:636–637 (26).
53. Ibid., 5:637–640 (27–28).

OMNIPRESENT[54]

Scripture states that God is omnipresent (1 Kings 8:27; Ps. 139:7–12; Jer. 23:23–24; Amos 9:2–3; Acts 17:27–28; Heb. 4:13). So how could an omnipresent God enter the womb of Mary and be born nine months later? Some theologians answered that the Son of God retained His omnipresence during His incarnational life, so that although united to the Son of Man within the human body, He was concurrently omnipresent throughout the universe. This assumption is based upon the idea that God is immutable (unchangeable)—a theory embraced by several scholars over the centuries:

Origen (ca. 185–254)

> [W]e are not to suppose that all the majesty of His divinity is within the limits of His slender body, so that all the "word" of God, and His "wisdom," and "essential truth," and "life," was either rent asunder from the Father, or restrained and confined within the narrowness of His bodily person, and is not to be considered to have operated anywhere besides; but the cautious acknowledgment of a religious man ought to be between the two, so that it ought neither to be believed that anything of divinity was wanting in Christ, nor that any separation at all was made from the essence of the Father, which is everywhere.[55]

Athanasius (293–373)

> For He was not, as might be imagined, circumscribed in the body, nor while present in the body, was He absent elsewhere; nor, while He moved the body, was the universe left void of His working and Providence...even while present in a human body and Himself quickening it, He was, without inconsistency, quickening the universe as well, and was in every process of nature, and was outside the whole.... And in this was the wonderful thing that He was at once walking as man, and as the Word was quickening all things, and as the Son was dwelling with His Father. So that not even when the Virgin bore Him did He suffer any change, nor by being in the body was (His glory) dulled; but on the contrary, He sanctified the body also...being incorruptible, He quickened and cleansed the body also, which was in itself mortal.[56]

54. No Creeds before the sixteenth-century Reformation attributed omnipresence to the human nature of Christ. See Philip Schaff, *The History of the Creeds*, vol. 1 in *The Creeds of Christendom* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1996, 1st ed. 1931), 286. In volume 4 of my system, we will note that omnipresence is important to the debate on the Eucharistic presence of Christ. The Lutherans believe that the communication of properties between the divine and human natures of Jesus Christ (*communication idiomatum*) made His humanity as omnipresent as His divinity; whereas Calvin and his followers denied that the divinity of Christ could be encapsulated within humanity, for the finite is not capable of the infinite (*finitum non est capax infiniti*); so His divinity remained omnipresent while united to His humanity.
55. Origen, *De Principiis, The Anti-Nicene Fathers*, 4:377 (4.1.30).
56. Athanasius, *De Incarnatione, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, 4:45 (17.1–2, 5–6).

Augustine of Hippo (354–430)

> God, because "in the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God" [John 1:1]; and man, inasmuch as "the Word was made flesh and dwelt among." [John 1:14]. By this means—by the difference between His divinity and His humiliation—He remained in heaven as Son of God, and as Son of man walked on earth; whilst, by that unity of His person which made His two natures one Christ, He both walked as Son of God on earth, and at the same time as the very Son of man remained in heaven.[57]

Cyril of Alexandria (376–444)

> Neither do we say that the flesh was converted into the divine nature, nor surely that the ineffable nature of God the Word was debased and changed into the nature of flesh, for it is unchangeable and unalterable, ever continuing altogether the same according to the Scriptures: but we say that the Son of God, while visible to the eyes, and a babe in swaddling clothes, and still at the breast of his Virgin Mother, filled all creation as God, and was seated with His Father. For the divine nature is without quantity and without magnitude and without limit.[58] We do not say that the Word became flesh, that is perfect man, as if constricted in the limits of the body, for that would indeed be the height of stupidity. No we believe that he still continued to fill the heaven and earth and the underworld, for in God all things are fulfilled and to him all things are small.[59]

Leo the Great (400–461), Pope from 440–461 (Western Church)

> Accordingly, the Son of God, descending from his seat in heaven, and not departing from the glory of the Father, enters this lower world, born after a new order, by a new mode of birth. After a new order; because he who in his own sphere is invisible, became visible in ours; He who could not be enclosed in space, willed to be enclosed; continuing to be before times, he began to exist in time; the Lord of the universe allowed his infinite majesty to be overshadowed, and took upon him the form of a servant; the impassible God did not disdain to be passible…the Word that is performing what belongs to the Word, and the flesh carrying out what belongs to the flesh; the one of these shines out in miracles, the other succumbs to injuries. And as the Word does not withdraw from equality with the Father in glory, so the flesh does not abandon the nature of our kind.[60]

57. St. Augustine and Anti-Pelagian Writings, *The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, ed. Philip Schaff, 5:39.

58. Cyril of Alexandria, *Enchiridion Patristicum*, 18th ed., ed. M. J. Rouet de Journel (Freiberg I. B., 1953), 39, quoted in Johannes Quasten, *Patrology: The Golden Age of Greek Literature* (Westminster, MD: Christian Classics, 1990), 3:66; cf. 138.

59. James A. McGuckin, *Saint Cyril of Alexandria and the Christological Controversy: Its History, Theology, and Texts* (Crestwood, NY: St Vladimir's Seminary Press, 2004), 320.

60. Leo the Great, *The Tome of St. Leo*, *The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, 14:256.

John Calvin (1509–1564)

> Another absurdity which they obtrude upon us—viz. that if the Word of God became incarnate, it must have been enclosed in the narrow tenement of an earthly body, is sheer petulance. For although the boundless essence of the Word was united with human nature into one person, we have no idea of any enclosing. The Son of God descended miraculously from heaven, yet without abandoning heaven; was pleased to be conceived miraculously in the Virgin's womb, to live on earth, and hang upon the cross, and yet always filled the world as from the beginning.[61]

William G. T. Shedd (1820–1894)

> Because the Logos was localized and limited by a human body on the earth, it does not follow that he did not continue to exist and act in heaven.[62]

ASSUMPTION OF HUMANITY

Some theologians equate the assumption of humanity with an act of God that continues throughout the Incarnation experience, so that the Son of God is the one in charge of the Son of Man in the life of Jesus Christ on earth.

Hilary of Poitiers (300–367)

Hilary of Poitiers viewed the Incarnation as an assumption of humanity into Christ's divinity, a plan that preceded human sin, and would have taken place even if humans hadn't sinned.[63] The purpose of the Incarnation was to meet the human need for progressive revelation, and it was also God's plan to elevate human nature through uniting human nature with the divine nature.[64] In fact, in Hilary's thinking, the relation of Christ's divinity and assumed humanity is more central than Calvary as the means of human salvation. The "Father's nature, with which He was in natural unity, was not affected by this assumption of flesh…. For the object to be gained was that man might become God."[65]

According to this teaching, Christ lived on earth as God, so that even in the cradle He upheld worlds. This led Hilary, naturally, to deemphasize Christ's sufferings. He claimed that Christ was impassable to suffering because human feelings were absent from Him. The assumption of human nature into His divinity

61. John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, trans. Henry Beveridge (London: James Clarke, 1962), 2:414 (2.13.4).

62. William G. T. Shedd, *Dogmatic Theology*, 3rd ed. (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 2003), 621; see also 624–626.

63. E. W. Watson, "Introduction: The Theology of St. Hilary of Poitiers," in *St. Hilary of Poitiers, John of Damascus: Select Works*, ed. Philip Schaff, *The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, 9:xcvi.

64. "God the Word became flesh, that through His Incarnation our flesh might attain to union with God, the Word," Hilary of Poitiers, *De Trinitate, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, 9:43 (1.11).

65. Hilary Poitiers, *De Trinitate, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, 9:167 (9.38).

means that Christ is humanity and not just a human. Salvation for Hilary seems identified more with the effect of Christ's divinity on the humanity He assumed, rather than on His work in the believer. Yet, paradoxically, he embraces a teaching on salvation that is more concerned with works than grace.[66]

Gregory of Nazianzus (ca. 330–389)

Gregory of Nazianzus speaks of Christ's living on earth as God, and enabling humans to become God too.

> What is lofty you are to apply to the Godhead, and to that Nature in Him which is superior to sufferings and incorporeal; but all that is lowly to the composite condition of Him who for your sakes made Himself of no reputation and was Incarnate—yes, for it is no worse thing to say, was made Man.... What He was He continued to be; what He was not He took to Himself. In the beginning He was uncaused; for what is the Cause of God? But afterwards for a cause He was born. And that cause was that you might be saved.... While His inferior Nature, the Humanity, became God, because it was united to God, and became One Person because the Higher Nature prevailed...in order that I too might be made God so far as He is made Man.... He was tempted as Man, but He conquered as God.[67]

EVALUATION

Christ's living on earth as God calls into question the real humanity of Jesus, and in this sense is no better than the teaching of Apollinaris (ca. 310–c. 390) who believed Christ did not assume a human mind, but "an immutable and heavenly divine mind,"[68] or monothelitism which promoted the idea that Christ had a divine will. These ideas imply that the human Jesus had an advantage that no other human has ever had. Scripture repudiates any advantage for the human Jesus: (1) "For we do not have a high priest who is unable to empathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who has been tempted in every way, just as we are—yet he did not sin" (Heb. 4:15). This alleged advantage for the human Jesus fails to grasp why He came. He came to understand what it is like to be a human in a sinful world. This seems—yet doesn't—call into question His omniscience (knowing all things), yet how could He know firsthand suffering and forsakenness unless He experienced it?

Scripture says Jesus was a "man of suffering" (Isa. 53:3), was tempted by Satan (Matt. 4:1–11) "in every way, just as we are" (Heb. 4:15), and cried out on the

66. Ibid., 9:lxvi–xcvi.

67. Gregory Nazianzen, *The Third Theological Oration: On the Son, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, 7:307–308 (18.19.20).

68. Alister E. McGrath, *Historical Theology: An Introduction to the History of Christian Thought* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1998), 53.

cross, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me"? (Matt. 27:46). How can we understand the enormous sacrifice at Calvary if the Son, while hanging on the cross, was at the same time with the Father and Spirit in heaven? How could the Son cry out "Why have you forsaken me" if they were together in heaven? These experiences would be an utter farce if He were experiencing them while also in resting the security of heaven. This view of Christ's incarnate life on earth fails to take seriously the self-emptying (*kenōsis*, Phil. 2:7) of God (remaining divine but choosing not to use His divinity for His benefit), which involved "taking the very nature of a servant, being made in human likeness" (Phil. 2:7).

The view of Jesus being omnipresent in His incarnation also fails to take into consideration that it was not until His ascension that He sat down at the right hand of the Father at the throne, which clearly suggests that He was not there prior to that event. An omnipresent Christ in the incarnation of Jesus means that there was no temporal sequence for His divinity (leaving heaven, remaining on earth, and in His ascension returning to heaven). This is a timeless view of His divinity, which is ontologically joined to His temporal humanity. How can a timeless divinity and a temporal humanity be ontologically united in the God-Man? How could Jesus be fully human in such a union, and how could He really gain the experience necessary to become a sympathetic high priest?

Robert Jenson was right to add other failures of these Councils: (1) "[T]he assumption that deity is equivalent to impassibility" remained "unchallenged." (2) The biblical understanding of *Logos* as God's speech was not recovered (it still retained Greek philosophical meaning).[69] (3) The Cappadocian focus on origins as constitutive of the divine life was not challenged. The focus on origins in the Trinity means that "the *eschatological* character of God's scriptural history was suppressed" (a major concern in the rest of his book),[70] and a major concern in this system about the relational Trinity (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2).

In other words, the Eastern theologians (Basil the Great, his brother Gregory of Nyssa, and Gregory of Nazianzus, during the latter part of the fourth century) focused on the three Persons in the Trinity (the three *hypostases*/Persons that shared the same *ousia*/essence); whereas Augustine in the West never understood the difference. Augustine wrote, "They [Cappadocians] indeed use also the word hypostasis; but they intend to put a difference, I know not what,

69. *Logos* begins as a philosophical term with Heraclitus (ca. 540–480 B.C.); it was used as a "link between rational discourse and the world's rational structure." Used by Plato, Aristotle, and especially the Stoics to interpret the world order as immanent deity, Christopher, "Logos" in *Concise Routledge Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (London: Routledge, 2003, 1st ed. 2000), 508.

70. Jenson, *Triune God*, vol. 1 in *Systematic Theology*, 108. Prior to discovering this in Jenson's book (August 2006), I argued for the fact that the origins focus replaced the biblical focus on relations in the Trinity. See "A One-Sided Trinity in Theology: Its Continuing Impact," *Journal of the Adventist Theological Society* 16, 1–2 (Spring-Autumn, 2005): 43–74; see also my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 2.

between οὐσία and hypostasis; so that most of ourselves who treat these things in the Greek language, are accustomed to say, μίαν οὐσίαν, τρεῖς ὑποστάσεις, or, in Latin, one essence, three substances."[71]

What was the basic difference between the East and the West? In the East the Trinity was made up of three Persons who shared one essence, whereas in the West the Trinity was simple, unchangeable, and hence one essence, because the Persons in the Trinity didn't have a temporal reciprocal relationship.

Such a position did injustice to God's work in time, where the Son reveals the glory of the Father (John 14:9; 17:4) and subsequently the Spirit reveals the glory of Christ (John 16:12–15). In other words, because there is an eternal, reciprocal relationship among the Persons of the Trinity (which is a foundational thesis of this system), then there can be an overflowing of this individualization to matters beyond them; each Person of the Trinity accepts a division of responsibilities in the plan of salvation (an economy of function: Father as Source, Son as Mediator, and Spirit as Actualizer), rather than all Persons being present in every work because of a failure to see a differentiation in the Trinity with respect to acting in time.[72] This individualization doesn't signify three gods, but three Persons in the one Trinity.

This affects Christology, for Christ alone comes into the incarnational experience, depends upon the Father and Spirit to really live a human life, and is separate from them in location. He is local, while they are omnipresent, and so He does suffer as the Man of Sorrows and feels separated from them.

Christ Considered to be Too Human

QUESTS OF THE HISTORICAL JESUS

The Enlightenment (ca. 1650–1780) provided the context for birthing the quests of the historical Jesus. When the Catholic scientist Galileo was forced to recant (1633) for questioning Copernican cosmology, thinkers began to break from authority and tradition—including biblical authority and tradition. René Descartes' (1596–1650) theory of doubt began to be applied to previously accepted ideas. Modern scientific method focused on the observable, and not on biblical and church ideas. History was redefined as a science. It was not long before the historical method was used to allegedly get behind the Christ of Scripture to the Jesus of history, and the historical-critical methods fueled the quest for one-hundred-and-fifty years. It was assumed that human reason (rationalism) was well able to

71. Augustine, *On the Trinity, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 3:92 (5.8.10).
72. See Jenson, *Triune God*, vol. 1 in *Systematic Theology*, 104–111.

distinguish what is true from what is false. Science posited a closed system, with immutable laws that operated from cause to effect, without need of divine intervention. Eventually this replaced biblical views of creation with evolution, and replaced the divinity of Christ with the humanity of Jesus.[73]

Prior to the quests of the historical Jesus, the Gospel narratives were viewed as history. This changed with the entrance of the historical-critical methods into biblical interpretation in the eighteenth century (the reader may want to review the relevant historical, literary, and cultural paradigms of interpretation in volume 1, chapter 13). Historical-critical studies viewed Scripture as the product of oral tradition that finally took literary form. The content of the Gospels was considered a mere collection of testimonies in honor of the memory of the historical Jesus. Yet history was considered less than an objective accurate account of what took place. Rather, the record was considered an account of the impact of Jesus on the writers, and so there are different accounts of Jesus.

Of course, along the way miracles were thrown out, along with the revelation of Scripture, as seen in the writings of Herman Reimarus (1694–1768) and David Friedrich Strauss (1808–1874). Many followed in their footsteps, which, in the twentieth century, led to Rudolph Bultmann's demythologizing program. The result? The Gospel of John, which speaks of the divinity of Christ, was rejected by the Questers (those searching for the "historical Jesus"). It isn't necessary for us to give all the names and contributions of the Questers (at the end of this segment in footnote is a list of some sources for further study); rather, our major purpose here is to highlight the attacks on the Person of Jesus Christ, as we would expect given the cosmic controversy against Him. We will mention two Questers and explore the Jesus Seminar as representative of these scholars.

I cannot speak for all Questers, but the Jesus Seminar ended up deciding that eighty percent of the words of Jesus in the Gospels were not His words, but merely attributed to Him by later redactors.[74] Nearly half of these Jesus Seminar members either taught or graduated from the three primarily liberal New Testament Departments in America (Harvard, Claremont, and Vanderbilt).

Before we study the writings of these scholars, we must ask: What is the appropriate way to approach God's holy revelation? Is it to come to the text as God's holy Word to humans, with all the divine authority that entails? For Christianity is a historical religion with supernatural roots. Robert Jenson asks: "When the preacher or teacher is to expound a Gospel text, what is the event to be expounded: that narrated by the text assigned, or that which

73. James D. G. Dunn, *Jesus Remembered*, vol. 1 in *Christianity in the Making* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2003), 25–34.
74. Jimmy Williams, "The Jesus Seminar," http://www.leaderu.com/orgs/probe/docs/jesussem.html

historical-critical study of the text may reconstruct? Nor will it do, as recent writing has urged, to finesse this question by recourse to ahistorical modes of reading, appropriate as these might be to the sacred texts of a different sort of religion."[75] Keeping Jenson's words in mind, we will now examine some of the work of a few prominent Questers.

H. S. Reimarus (1694–1768)

Reimarus questioned the Christian view of Jesus Christ, considering Him a mere man. He wrote a book, but didn't publish it during his life. He was afraid of the repercussions of his radical ideas. After his death, Gotthold Lessing published the book in 1778, and it later appeared in English. About this hateful book about the "life of Jesus," Schweitzer says:

> For hate as well as love can write a Life of Jesus, and the greatest of them are written with hate, that of Reimarus, the Wolfenbüttel Fragmentist, and that of David Friedrich Strauss. It was not so much hate of the Person of Jesus as of the supernatural nimbus with which it was so easy to surround Him, and with which He had in fact been surrounded. They were eager to picture Him as truly and purely human, to strip from Him the robes of splendor with which He had been apparelled, and clothe Him once more with the coarse garments in which He had walked in Galilee. And their hate sharpened their historical insight. They advanced the study of the subject more than all the others put together.[76]

Such hatred can only come from Christ's supreme enemy who tried to kill Jesus through Herod's slaying all the babies of Bethlehem, and who used Judas to betray Jesus (John 13:27). Satan imparts his spirit to humans who then become instruments to destroy the truth about Christ. Christians have no quarrel with the historical facts about Jesus, but not at the expense of faith in Him as God. This is why the King-Priest reality of the ascended Jesus Christ at the right hand of God in heaven's sanctuary must not be left out of our study. Scripture clearly presents the divinity of Christ—clearly present Christ as God at the right hand of His Father in heaven's sanctuary. The Questers ignore this evidence, as well as evidence of divinity in the Gospels (even in the Synoptics).

The study of Jesus Christ is a holy undertaking. The pre-incarnate Christ, in the burning bush, tells Moses to take off his shoes because he is on holy ground (Exod. 3:4–6). The One who says "Heaven is my throne, and the earth is my footstool" tells Isaiah that "These are the ones I look on with favor: those who are humble and contrite in spirit, and who tremble at my word" (Isa. 66:1a–2b).

75. Jenson, *Triune God*, vol. 1 in *Systematic Theology*, 172.
76. Albert Schweitzer, *The Quest of the Historical Jesus*, trans. W. Montgomery (London: Adam & Charles Black, 1910, 1st ed. 1906), 4–5.

Albert Schweitzer (1875–1965)

Schweitzer's book *The Quest of the Historical Jesus* reviews the various books about the life of Jesus that had been written between 1775 and 1906 (including those by Reimarus, Paulus, Hase, Schleiermacher, Strauss, Bauer, Renan, and Wrede). He evaluated one-hundred-thirty years of German scholarship, critiquing the scholars for failing to consider the influence of later Jewish eschatology on the Synoptic Gospels. In other words, they had written their lives of Jesus upon a non-eschatological foundation.

Schweitzer speaks of the "supra-mundane Christ and the historical Jesus 'as united in one' single personality at once historical and raised above time" by Gnosticism and Logos Christology. Schweitzer considered it "fortunate that the Synoptics were already so firmly established that the Fourth Gospel could not oust them." Unlike the view of Jesus in Eastern theology, Western theology's two-nature view of Jesus Christ had to be "shattered before men could once more go out in quest of the historical Jesus." Even when Jesus was once more recalled to life, "He was still, like Lazarus of old, bound hand and foot with graveclothes—the graveclothes of the dogma of the Dual Nature."[77]

Schweitzer said the lives of Jesus were written either in a spirit of hate or of love. The greatest hate was demonstrated by Reimarus and Strauss. Schweitzer says this was not hate against the Person of Jesus, but against the supernatural that surrounded Him.[78] Schweitzer claimed that the Synoptic Gospels were written from a Jewish perspective, and the Gospel of John from a Greek standpoint, concluding, "No man can serve two masters." And the Questers didn't.[79] They stayed with the Synoptics. The Tübingen School established the alleged need to choose between the Synoptics and John's Gospel. Before Strauss the dominant interest was in miracles, but after Strauss miracles were deemed mythical.[80]

Here is the summation of Schweitzer's understanding of Jesus:

> There is silence all around. The Baptist appears, and cries: "Repent, for the kingdom of Heaven is at hand." Soon after that comes Jesus, and in the knowledge that He is the coming Son of Man lays hold of the wheel of the world to set it moving on that last revolution which is to bring all ordinary history to a close. It refuses to turn, and He throws Himself upon it. Then it does turn; and crushes Him. Instead of bringing in the eschatological conditions, He has destroyed them. The wheel rolls onward, and the mangled body of the one immeasurably great Man, who was strong enough to think of Himself as the spiritual ruler of mankind and to bend history to His purpose, is hanging upon it still. That is His victory and His reign.[81]

77. Ibid., 3–4.
78. Ibid., 4–5.
79. Ibid., 6–7.
80. Ibid., 10.
81. Ibid., 368–369.

As a result of his radical rejection of the God-Man of Scripture, all Schweitzer is left with is the Spirit of Jesus. He claims that "it is not Jesus as historically known, but Jesus as spiritually arisen within men, who is significant for our time and can help it. Not the historical Jesus, but the spirit which goes forth from Him and in the spirits of men strives for new influence and rule is that which overcomes the world."[82] This means Schweitzer opts for "the spiritual Kingdom of God on earth, he is Lord who will rule in our hearts."[83]

Karl Barth (1886–1968)

Schweitzer's "spiritual Kingdom" was a religious experience, and hence subjective. In 1830, the subjectivity of religious experience was championed by Schleiermacher's "feeling of absolute dependence" in his system *The Christian Faith.* Schleiermacher said that "the feeling of absolute dependence, in which our self-consciousness in general represents the finitude of our being...is therefore not an accidental element, or a thing which varies from person to person, but is a universal element of life; and the recognition of this fact entirely takes the place, for the system of doctrine, of all the so-called proofs of the existence of God."[84] This pure subjectivity ousted the classical objective proofs for God's existence (as did Kant's moral imperative). Now God existed because an individual felt his or her dependence upon Him.

Barth said, "Schleiermacher tried to interpret the attributes of God as an objectification of the individual aspects of the religious self-consciousness."[85] So one could argue that Schleiermacher's quest for God was looking deep into the God-consciousness. He also disbelieved in the Trinity (because one cannot feel dependence on three, only on one). So the quest was pure subjectivity.[86] The early Barth counters Schweitzer's subjective religiosity with a Wholly Other (*Ganz Andere*) God. Instead of embracing a historical Jesus, Barth raises Jesus from history to a timeless state on the border that separates timelessness from history:

> Is there any historical occurrence so defenceless against brilliant and stupid notions, against interpretations and misinterpretations, against use and misuse; is there any historical happening so inconspicuous and ambiguous and open to misunderstanding—as the appearance in history of God's own Son? There is no single incident in His life known to us in such a way as to be free from ambiguity and free from the possibility of giving offence. A hundred incidents are manifestly offensive: so much so that modern theologians blurt out awkwardly and with touching simplicity: "Here we feel otherwise than Jesus felt"—a truth so desperately obvious that one would have thought it hardly worth while mentioning. Sin-controlled flesh: human, worldly, historical, natural, scintillating with every variation of ambiguity, a playground where men can exercise their ingenuity in propounding all manner of noble and absurd ideas and notions, but a playground so covered with stones that each man stumbles after his own fashion—such is the life of Jesus, more than any other life.[87]

82. Ibid., 399.
83. Ibid., xvi, cf. 2.
84. Friedrich Schleiermacher, *The Christian Faith*, trans. H. R. Mackintosh and J. S. Stewart (Edinburgh, Scotland: T & T Clark, 1999, 1st Ger. ed. 1830), 133–134.
85. Karl Barth, *The Doctrine of God*, vol. 2, pt. 1 in *Church Dogmatics* (Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1964), 338.
86. Schleiermacher, *The Christian Faith*, 739.

Here we have a wholly other focus (Early Barth) compared to a wholly within focus (Schweitzer and Schleiermacher). Both represent an overemphasis that needs correction. Any true understanding of Jesus Christ requires that equal emphasis be placed on His divine and His human reality—one which a proper reading of the Gospels provides. There is no Jesus of history that is separate from the pre-existent, self-existent Son of God. The Son of Man is the Son of Man as the Son of God, and is never the Son of Man without being the Son of God.

N. T. Wright (1948–)

With N. T. Wright we come to the third and most recent quest for the historical Jesus, a study of Him in the context of Second Temple Judaism. Involved are New Perspectives on Paul scholars (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 12, and chapter 16 of this volume). This quest ends up questioning the traditional understanding of justification by faith, a crucial part of the Reformation. Wright has taught in Cambridge and Oxford Universities, and he wrote the 1996 *Jesus and the Victory of God*[88] as the second volume of six on *Christian Origins.* Three years later, in January 1999, he gave four lectures at a conference on "Following Christ/Shaping the World" in Chicago, under the auspices of InterVarsity Christian Fellowship; a thousand graduate students and university professors from across North America were in attendance. Since these lectures[89] have developed thinking beyond his *Jesus and the Victory of God*, we will mainly focus on those lectures.

Wright supports questing for the historical Jesus as long as it is confined within the historical data of the first century, both in the Gospels and in contemporary literature that illuminates the thinking of the contemporaries of Jesus. Wright recognizes there are "huge problems and even dangers" with questing, but notes there are misleading views of a supernatural Jesus that portray Him "as a first-century version of Superman." He rejects the fact that Christian faith can

87. Barth, *The Epistle to the Romans*, 280.
88. N. T. Wright, *Jesus and the Victory of God* (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg Fortress, 1996).
89. N. T. Wright, *The Challenge of Jesus: Rediscovering Who Jesus Was and Is* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1999).

preempt the historical questions about Jesus, for historical study cannot be done in a vacuum, and that history and faith are not antithetical as Questers believe.[90]

One must be able to answer historical challenges to Christianity. The Enlightenment's challenge to Christianity, as Wright sees it, is "*its asking a necessary question in a misleading fashion.*"[91] Wright sees the Reformation as a protest against a timeless system (Roman Catholic theology) when Christ died once and for all.[92] So the Reformers favored a historical and eschatological reading of Christianity. Post-Reformation theology elevated the insights of the Reformers to a new set of timeless truths, and created a new system of dogma and ethics. Wright's point is that denominational dogmas should be tested, and he ponders whether the Enlightenment was a secularized counterpart to the Reformation?[93] He says, "the Enlightenment's raising of the question of Jesus was done in a radically misleading manner" because it separated history and faith. A reintegrated worldview has not yet been attempted, for the deeper problem with the Enlightenment is its view of eschatology that rivals Christian eschatology.[94]

Wright presents that reintegrated worldview, and to this extent makes a contribution beyond what the previous Questers had made. He defines eschatology as based on the "thoroughly Jewish belief that world history was focused on a single geographic place and a single moment in time." The place was Palestine and Jerusalem, and the time was imminent. Wright says early Christians believed that in principle this happened in and through Jesus and His crucifixion: "This is what early Christian eschatology was all about: not the expectation of the literal end of the space-time universe but the sense that world history was reaching, or indeed had reached, its single intended climax." But with the Enlightenment many believed, "World history was finally brought to its climax, its real new beginning, not in Jerusalem but in Western Europe and America, not in the first century but in the eighteenth."[95]

Questing for the historical Jesus in terms of Enlightenment categories (divorced from faith, founded on reason alone) results in inevitable contradictions, which in postmodern-like fashion forged out portraits of the historical Jesus that reflected the reasoning of each individual writer. Wright says Jesus appeared "as the teacher of either liberal timeless truths or conservative timeless truths. The thought that he might have been the turning point of history was, to many on both sides of the

90. Ibid., 13–16.
91. Ibid., 19, emphasis in original.
92. See N. T. Wright, *The Climax of the Covenant: Christ and the Law in Pauline Theology* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1993).
93. Wright, *The Challenge of Jesus*, 19–20.
94. Ibid., 21.
95. Ibid., 21–22.

divide, almost literally unthinkable."[96] Schweitzer introduced the eschatological perspective back into questing, and to that extent made a necessary contribution, but he interpreted Jesus as a deluded man thinking that going to the cross would bring the desired climax of history.[97] In contrast to Schweitzer, who thought Calvary was a failure, Wright believes Calvary was the climax of history. Wright states: "It is this, I believe, that has given fresh impetus to the study of Jesus and makes it imperative that we engage in this study."[98]

For Wright, Jesus knew all along that He was Israel's Messiah.[99] Adolph Harnack said Jesus "declared himself to be Messiah."[100] In this regard Wright was more like Schweitzer than like Wrede and most twentieth-century scholars who followed him. For Wright, what Jesus did in the upper room was complementary to what He did in the Temple, and Jesus knew "that the *exile* had reached a climax" in His coming death.[101] So it is that Wright can say, "It is Easter that validates Jesus' interpretation of his own death."[102]

Wright is correct to embrace faith *and* history, which distinguishes him from other Questers. He is right to look at a historical answer to historical questions from critics, and to show from Scripture and contemporary literature that the first-century historical evidence is helpful in understanding the deeds and sayings of Jesus. It is valid for Wright to question church dogma that presents the divinity of Christ in such a way that His humanity is called into question. It is to be appreciated that Wright doesn't approach the study as a critic, but instead looks for historical data that will verify that the historical Jesus was an actual Person who walked the earth in the first century.

But I have some questions about some of his interpretations. He sees the mission of Jesus as leading Judah out of Exile, as an exodus. The Kingdom was initiated with John's baptism, which was "a coded dramatization of the exodus," a return from exile at last.[103] He confuses the destruction of the Daniel 2 image with the climax of the ministry of Jesus, rather than His second advent (Dan. 2:41–44). He does the same with the exaltation of the Son of Man over the beasts in Daniel 7, for it takes place at the end of Christ's earthly ministry rather than at the Second Advent (Dan. 7:26–27).[104]

96. Ibid., 23.
97. Schweitzer, *Quest*, 368–369.
98. Wright, *The Challenge of Jesus*, 23.
99. Ibid., 81.
100. Adolf Harnack, *The History of Dogma*, trans. Neil Buchanan (Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 1997), 1:59–60.
101. Wright, *The Challenge of Jesus*, 89; see also 83–89.
102. Ibid., 93.
103. Ibid., 39.
104. Ibid., 41.

Wright believes the prodigal son's journey into a far country and his return home represents the Babylonian exile and restoration. He says the parable does not illustrate the timeless truth of God's forgiveness, for "Jesus told the story to make the point that *the return from exile was happening in and through his own work.*"[105] The problem is that in addition to telling the story of the prodigal son, Christ shares two other parables, those of the lost sheep and lost coin (Luke 15:1–32). Both were lost, and Jesus states that there is rejoicing in heaven when they are found, which Jesus interprets as their repenting. The prodigal son also returns to his father after repenting (Luke 15:18–19a). Yet if this return represents Judah after the exile, why did Judah reject Jesus? The idea "that the inbreaking kingdom Jesus was announcing created a new world"[106] seems premature, because the world has never reflected that fact, and so the biblical teaching that the new world is yet to be created (of course based upon what Jesus did and is doing) is still to be realized at the Second Advent (John 14:1–3; 1 Thess. 4:16–18; Rev. 19:21–22).

Wright takes the warnings of coming judgment in the Synoptics, and says they will take place "*within history.*"[107] Wright also interprets the whole chapter of Mark 13 (and Matthew 24; Luke 21) as the fall of Jerusalem, not the end of the World.[108] The context includes both. For Jesus predicted the destruction of the temple (Matt. 24:2), and the disciples asked Him when this event would take place: "[W]hen will this happen, and what will be the sign of your coming and of the end of the age?" (Matt. 24:3b). Jesus was in their midst. He had told them that they should not be troubled because He was going away, for "I will come back and take you to be with me that you also may be where I am" (John 14:3). The disciples asked Jesus what would be the sign (*to sēmeion*, singular, Matt. 24:3b) of His coming, or return. After giving cosmic signs in the heavens, Jesus said:

> At that time the sign [*to sēmeion*] of the Son of Man will appear in the sky, and all the nations of the earth will mourn. They will see the Son of Man coming on the clouds of the sky, with power and great glory. And he will send his angels with a loud trumpet call, and they will gather his elect from the four winds from one end of the heavens to the other. (Matt. 24:30–31)

This is unquestionably the time when the Son of Man will come back, for it involves all nations. Wright correctly gives full credit to the climax reached by Jesus at Calvary, but not at the expense of the ultimate working out of that climax in the return of the Son of Man in His victorious second advent. For

105. Ibid., 41–42.
106. Ibid., 46.
107. Ibid., 49, emphasis in original.
108. Ibid., 50–51.

that's when the victory of Calvary is dramatically demonstrated. In emphasizing only one teaching of Jesus, Wright doesn't take seriously the question of the disciples, nor the answer that Jesus gave to them. So Wright ends up with a kind of realized eschatology based on a selective reading of the first-century documents (e.g., Gospels, as well as Hebrews, James, Pauline, and Petrine sources). For Wright, Jesus lived during "the second-Temple Jewish worldview," and aimed at reconstituting "the people of God around himself, to accomplish the real return from exile, to inaugurate the kingdom of God."[109]

Thus, for Wright, the master returning in the parable (Matt. 25:14–30; Luke 19:11–27) is not the Second Advent but His return to Jerusalem for the last time. This is contrary to the end-times *parousia* coming of the Bridegroom in the first parable (Matt. 25:10), and the final judgment coming of the Son of Man (Matt. 25:31–46). Logic suggests that the returning of the Master takes place at the same time as the return of the Bridegroom and the return of the Son of Man (Matt. 25:19). Furthermore, in each parable some were ready, and some were not, for the coming of the Bridegroom, Master, or Son of Man, which points to the same conditions and to the same time, the end of the Christian age. In placing his emphasis on a kind of realized eschatology (climax at the Cross) with little attention to how that affects future eschatology, one could argue that to this extent Wright does not grasp the intervening King-Priest ministry of Christ in heaven's sanctuary at God's throne.

The so-called Jesus Seminar dismisses most stories of Jesus due to the inability of His contemporaries to remember them. Wright counters this with the traditions of instant storytelling among peasant societies (like Galilean peasants) which prove otherwise.[110] Being a Quester is the same as being a disciple to Wright, and can lead not only to a better understanding of Jesus but also to a better understanding of God.[111] Wright says God purposed from the beginning (election) to deal with the problems of his creation through Israel—when its history reached a climax (eschatology).[112] Based on the biblical evidence given previously (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 10), it is better to say that this plan to get a saving message to all nations had long ago been thwarted by Israel/Judah's rejection of the covenant relationship with God, the pre-requisite to actualizing His plan. There was no doubt that Jesus died for all who will accept Him, Jews and Gentiles, but before He died the Jewish leaders declared "We have no king but Caesar" (John 19:15).

109. Ibid., 55, 73.
110. Ibid., 26.
111. Ibid., 32.
112. Ibid., 35.

Jesus Seminar

Robert W. Funk, leader of the Jesus Seminar, and his colleagues wrote the book *The Five Gospels: The Search for the Authentic Words of Jesus.*[113] (Out of the seventy-four scholars, nearly half either teach at or have a degree from the very liberal New Testament departments at Harvard, Claremont, and Vanderbilt.[114]) The title indicates that this team of scholars attempts to determine whether the words spoken by Jesus were His words, or only attributed to Him by later redactors. The book took six years to produce, and in the process the scholars decided that eighty percent of the words of Jesus are not *actually* His. Four colors are used, red (His words); pink (similar to what He said); gray (didn't say these words, although same ideas are found in the Gospels); and black (didn't say these words). The Jesus Seminar not only reduced the Gospel text to a comparatively few words that Jesus spoke, but also only a few deeds that He did. They deny that Jesus was more than human, instead basing their study on seven assumptions: (1) the historical Jesus is not the same as the Christ of the church; (2) the Johannine Jesus is mostly fictitious; (3) Mark is the source for most of Matthew and Luke; (4) the hypothetical document Q (about 225 verses common to Matthew and Luke) was more important to Matthew and Luke than Mark; (5) Jesus' own second coming, or God's cataclysmic intervention to come, were not a part of the vision of Jesus; (6) there is an oral tradition culture, quite different from the written culture, in which one must understand Jesus; (7) the history in the Gospels is false unless proven otherwise by modern skeptics. Items three and four have some support, but are not accepted by many scholars. I concur with R. W. Yarbrough that "The other five are either unproved or unprovable. They are at best mere arbitrary working guidelines, 'pillars' suspended in rhetorical midair."[115]

EVALUATION

In a previous segment, we saw that for a thousand years theologians portrayed Jesus as living on earth as God, so that the human Jesus was swallowed up in the sheer divinity of His dual nature. In other words, Jesus did not really live a human life so that He could be our understanding intercessor in His current ministry in heaven (see Heb. 4:15–16). It is important, then, to note the attitude of Gnostics. N. T. Wright speaks of this, noting that our forbearers "saw Jesus as a demigod, not really human at all, striding through the world as a divine, heroic figure, untroubled by human questions, never

113. *The Five Gospels: The Search for the Authentic Words of Jesus* (New York: Macmillan, 1993).
114. "Who does the Jesus Seminary really speak for?", ChristianAnswers.net, accessed December 12, 2011.
115. R. W. Yarbrough, "Jesus Seminar," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 632.

wrestling with vocation, aware of himself as someone from outside the whole system, telling people how they might escape the wicked world and live forever in a different realm altogether."[116]

If the human Jesus had been appreciated for who He was on earth, and for what that means to His present ministry in heaven, then theology would have understood the balance between the human nature of Jesus and His divine nature. Put another way, the overemphasis on His divinity in theology gave way to a reactionary overemphasis on His humanity by the Questers. Both were in error. What Wright attempts to do is to address this imbalance by presenting a Jesus of history who is also the divine Son of God. It should be remembered that if Jesus lived on earth as God, then He would not be qualified to be the King-Priest at the Father's throne in heaven.

The failure of the Quests for the historical Jesus is due to: (1) their criticism of the Gospels, (2) their focus on the Synoptic Gospels, excluding the Gospel of John, and (3) their use of reason that dismissed revelation because they found in sources some justification for their focus on the human Jesus. Yet even in the Synoptic Gospels there is evidence for the divinity of Christ (see chapter 9). The Questers didn't consider the rest of Scripture when it came to the question of the divinity of Christ. Confining the research from the outset calls into question the objectivity of the quest, and hence casts doubt upon assumptions brought to the research. Questers need to remember Paul's insight: "So from now on we regard no one from a worldly point of view. Though we once regarded Christ in this way, we do so no longer" (2 Cor. 5:16).

The Enlightenment and Age of Reason proved that human reason left to itself is not enlightened. Scholars approached the Synoptic Gospels as they would any other human book. The conventions of history were applied to sacred writings as if they were secular. The approach was from below (the human Jesus) which often ignored the eternal, divine pre-existence and self-existence of God. In short, Questers focused on the historical context of the human Jesus and ignored His divine nature. But they went further. Not only did they ignore His divine origin, they denied it, as did Schweitzer when he dubbed Jesus a deluded man.

This cleared the way for them to deny the authority of Jesus in His teaching and in His miracles. This placed Questers in a parallel position with the Jewish leaders who confronted Jesus. They too viewed Him as merely human; they too denied His divinity, authority, miracles, and teachings. They treated Him with contempt and had Him crucified. The same spirit is evident in the writings of certain Questers (e.g., Reimarus); it is as if Jesus is being crucified again. When a critic rejects the written Word of God (Scripture), it is logical to then reject

116. Wright, *The Challenge of Jesus*, 24.

the living Word of God (Jesus Christ). As N. T. Wright reminds us, "Many Jesus scholars of the last two centuries have of course thrown Scripture out of the window and reconstructed a Jesus quite different from what we find in the New Testament."[117] (See below for some sources for further study into the quests.[118])

QUESTING IN SCRIPTURE

Darrell Bock's 2002 book *Jesus According to Scripture: Restoring the Portrait from the Gospels* looks for internal evidence in the Gospels (including John) to create a valid portrait of Jesus. As far as the Synoptics are concerned, Bock works from the same Gospels as the Questers, but his conclusions are different. Questers come to the Gospels to critique them, challenge them, and focus on alleged contradictions. But Bock approaches the Gospels with respect for their authority, and looks at what they say, allowing each Gospel writer to make his contribution to the same unique portrait.[119] "All four present Jesus as a messianic claimant who challenged the Jewish leadership while offering deliverance to any who would embrace him and his message as the unique, anointed one sent from God. This is why he is called Jesus Christ."[120]

Whereas Questers work like deconstructionists, Bock works like a detective. Questers destroy the Gospel presentation of Jesus; Bock allows the portrait of

117. Ibid., 17.

118. N. T. Wright, "Quest for the Historical Jesus," in *The Anchor Bible Dictionary* (New York: Doubleday, 1992), 3:796–802; R. H. Stein, "Jesus Christ: The Quest of the Historical Jesus," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 631–632; I. H. Marshall, "Historical Jesus, Quest For," in *New Dictionary of Theology* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1988), 305–306; James D. G. Dunn, *Jesus Remembered*, vol. 1 in *Christianity in the Making*, 11–92; *The Historical Jesus: Five Views*, ed. James K. Beilby and Paul Rhodes Eddy (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2009); this book presents the views of Robert M. Price, John Dominic Crossan, Luke Timothy Johnson, James D. G. Dunn, and Darrell L. Bock.

119. Darrell L. Bock, *Jesus According to Scripture: Restoring the Portrait from the Gospels* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2002). More than the others, Matthew focuses on Jewish issues and concerns. He explains the relation of Jesus to Israel, and Israel's rejection of Him. Matthew presents "*a royal, messianic understanding of Jesus*, who as *Son of God* comes to be seen as the revealer of God's will and the bearer of divine authority." The kingdom is stressed, 26–28. Mark is considered the first one written. Mark is a Gospel of action, more than of teaching (twenty miracles), so the authority of Jesus is seen in His acts, not just in His pronouncements. But the authority of Jesus is not raw power, for Mark presents Jesus as the Son of Man and Suffering Servant more than the other Gospels. Mark also presents the emotions of Jesus and the disciples more than the other Gospels. Mark addresses the church under duress, 31–33. Luke is the longest Gospel, and includes more parables than the others. At least half of the material is unique to his Gospel. Many of the discourses happen at a meal, and he has a concern for geographical details. The Gospel follows Jesus from Galilee to Jerusalem, and goes to great lengths to prepare His disciples for His departure. The focus is "God's plan," which reflects promise to fulfillment. Jesus appears as the Messiah-Servant-Lord. His great authority is seen as the "judging Son of Man," and in the concept of "Lord." National leadership rejects His message, yet efforts to call Israel to faithfulness continue. By contrast to the Jewish leaders, tax collectors and sinners respond to Jesus, and many women respond too. Reassurance is the key motive of the Gospel, 34–37. John highlights the uniqueness of Jesus as the One sent from God. Unlike the Synoptics, Jesus speaks little of the Kingdom. He speaks of eternal life instead. Unlike the Synoptics, there are no exorcisms in John. The role of signs is crucial to the work of Jesus, and His miracles indicate His superiority to Jewish institutions or leadership. The Holy Spirit is presented as the Paraclete, 39–41.

120. Bock, *Jesus According to Scripture*, 43.

Jesus in the Gospels to speak for itself. Questers approach Jesus with principles of secular history that call into question the history of Jesus; Block allows the history of Jesus in the Gospels to portray the historical Jesus. Two opposite methods yield two different sets of results: (1) reason ruins the portrait, and (2) revelation restores the portrait.

It should be remembered that an appropriate understanding of the humanity of Christ was necessary even in the first century. John says, "Every spirit that acknowledges that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is from God, but every spirit that does not acknowledge Jesus is not from God. This is the spirit of the antichrist, which you have heard is coming and even now is already in the world" (1 John 4:2b–3). "Antichrist" is a reference to the cosmic controversy against Christ, and includes both a denial of His divinity and His humanity. The only persuasive response is God's self-revelation in Scripture, which holds together in ontological union the divine and the human in the Son of God who is also the Son of Man.

CONCLUSION

When evaluated against the biblical norm, theories examined in this chapter come up short. They fail the test, because the authors of these ideas were not guided by biblical revelation. Systematic theology is a study of God, and so God is a theme running throughout the system. Scripture portrays a relational God: The Father, Son, and Spirit are equally God in an eternal, reciprocal relationship of love (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapters 1 and 2). This fact is seen in His eternal and comprehensive plan for humans (volume 2, chapter 8); His eternal covenant for humans (volume 2, chapters 9–11); His supernatural creation of humans (chapters 1 and 2); and His supernatural global flood to preserve humans (chapter 8). These biblical insights prepare one to appreciate the supernatural gift of Christ to save humans (chapters 9–10). He is infinitely more than minimalist views that merely consider Him human. In this system we also considered God in theology from the early fathers of the church until contemporary views (volume 2, chapters 3–7). From time to time in our journey, we have noted some aberrations from Scripture, especially as they relate to the Trinitarian procession (see volume 2, chapter 4, instead of a relational Trinity in volume 2, chapters 1 and 3).

In the Appendix to follow and in the next chapter, we will consider further distortions of truth about God, with particular reference to Christ, documenting examples of failure to accept Scripture as the revelation of God to humans.

There is no substitute for Scripture (*sola-tota-prima*) as the enduring foundation for a study of God and an understanding of Christ. Whether intended as such or not, all lesser views of any member of the Trinity work in concert with the cosmic controversy distortion of the truth about God.

Study Questions

1. When did Antichrist begin in the Christian era, and how should it be defined?
2. In what ways were the following views of Jesus Christ too divine?
   a. Moralistic Monarchianism
   b. Monophysitism
   c. Nestorianism
   d. Eutychianism
   e. Apollinarianism
3. In what ways were the following views of Jesus Christ too human?
   a. Dynamic Monarchianism
   b. Ebionitism
   c. Docéticism
   d. Gnosticism
   e. Arianism
4. In what ways were the Councils of Nicaea (325) and Chalcedon (451) successes?
5. In what ways were the Councils of Nicaea (325) and Chalcedon (451) failures, and what was the consequence?
6. What evidence can you give to show that for many centuries the church at Rome did not have primacy over the other churches? How does this impact the argument that the papacy began with Peter?
7. Was Christ omnipresent in His incarnation because He was God, and if He was, what were the implications?
8. How was "assumption of humanity" understood by Hilary of Poitiers and Gregory of Nazianzus? How would you evaluate their views?
9. What is the mission of the Quests, and what is your evaluation of their ideas?
10. What are the assumptions of the Jesus Seminar, and what is your evaluation of them?

Appendix: Counterfeit Gospels

Satan hates Christ, and so he hates the gospel, doing all he can to counter it. Sadly, his success has been almost universal throughout human history. In the early church, the enemy infiltrated churches in Galatia with a counterfeit gospel. But Paul boldly met it head-on:

> I am astonished that you are so quickly deserting the one who called you to live in the grace of Christ and are turning to a different gospel—which is really no gospel at all. Evidently some people are throwing you into confusion and are trying to pervert the gospel of Christ. But even if we or an angel from heaven should preach a gospel other than the one we preached to you, let them be under God's curse! As we have already said, so now I say again: If anybody is preaching to you a gospel other than what you accepted, let them be under God's curse! (Gal. 1:6–9)

This counterfeit gospel was a Judaizing voice that claimed the necessity of including some outdated Jewish traditions in the gospel, and must not be confused with Gnostic gospels which came later (second to fifth centuries). But they do share one thing in common: They constitute an attack on the true gospel, and an attempt to replace the true gospel with counterfeit teaching.

After studying the true gospel (chapters 9–10), and exploring some deviant views (this chapter), we will consider some ancient manuscripts, recently discovered, which some contemporary scholars put on a par with the four Gospels in Scripture. Do they provide additional information that should have been included in the Gospels, or are they more counterfeit voices clamoring to be heard?

NAG HAMMADI TEXTS

General Introduction

In December 1945, in the Jabal al-Tarif mountains in Upper Egypt, Muhammad 'Ali al-Samman discovered thirteen papyrus codices bound in leather and containing fifty-two texts. These texts were Gnostic writings that claimed to be gospels. Today these are known as the Nag Hammadi texts.[121] They include the *Gospel of Thomas* and the *Gospel of James.*

In his 1969 book *Hidden Records of the Life of Jesus,* Jack Finegan quotes John 6:12: "Gather up the fragments left over, that nothing may be lost" and applies the principle to the New Testament Apocrypha.[122] These words of Christ have to do with the food still remaining after feeding the five thousand (v. 10), and have nothing to do with gathering up alleged gospels, as if ignoring them

121. Elaine Pagels, *The Gnostic Gospels* (New York: Random House, 1979), xiii; Marvin W. Meyer, *The Secret Teachings of Jesus: Four Gnostic Gospels* (New York: Random House, 1984), xv–xvi.
122. Jack Finegan, *Hidden Records of the Life of Jesus* (Philadelphia, PA: Pilgrim Press, 1969), vii.

would be a loss of truth. To his credit, Finegan notes the distinction between those which are canonical and those which are "realms of imaginative amplification which are unmistakably legendary, or to those areas of thought which are clearly mythological."[123]

With the discovery of non-canonical gospels, various conclusions were put forward: (1) the Gnostic Gospels are just as legitimate as the biblical Synoptics and John (Elaine Pagels);[124] (2) there were many Christianities, and not just one Christianity (Gregory Riley).[125] In his 2001 *Hidden Gospels*, Philip Jenkins notes that for the previous two decades the *Gospel of Thomas* "has widely, if controversially, been attributed a degree of authority little less than that of the four gospels—and perhaps a great deal more."[126] Some assume that the four canonical Gospels survived, whereas others didn't because orthodox adherents destroyed any rival teachings.[127] But this doesn't make sense with reference to the *Gospel of James* because it is an adulation of Mary—and therefore compatible with the adulation of Mary in the Catholic church.

In chapter 11, we studied the different quests for the historical Jesus. The third quest of the historical Jesus (1980s and 1990s) is different from the first two quests (in the nineteenth century, and in the 1960s and 1970s) as a result of the 1945 discovery of the hidden gospels. The Jesus Seminar was influenced by the hidden gospels, and the group's founder Robert Funk speaks of this as "the end of canonical imperialism."[128] In 1993, the Jesus Seminar published *The Five Gospels*,[129] which added the *Gospel of Thomas* (alleged sayings of Jesus) to the canonical four, and Jenkins states that "Throughout the writings of Seminar Fellows, *Thomas* is used as a yardstick to assess the accuracy of words attributed to Jesus."[130] In 1992 and 1994, the Seminar published *The Complete Gospels*, which include twenty-one Gospels,[131] classified as (1) Narrative Gospels, (2) Sayings Gospels, (3) Infancy Gospels, (4) Fragmentary Gospels, and (5) Jewish-Christian Gospels (as well as some orphan sayings and stories).[132]

123. Ibid., viii.

124. Pagels, *The Gnostic Gospels*.

125. Gregory J. Riley, *One Jesus, Many Christs: How Jesus Inspired Not One True Christianity, but Many* (San Francisco, CA: Harper, 1997). See also Rosemary Radford Ruther, *Women and Redemption* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1998), 51, 55.

126. Philip Jenkins, *Hidden Gospels: How the Search of Jesus Lost Its Way* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2001), 5; *The Nag Hammadi Library in English* was published in 1977.

127. Jenkins, *Hidden Gospels*, 7.

128. Ibid., 9.

129. See Robert W. Funk, Roy W. Hoover and The Jesus Seminar, *The Five Gospels: What Did Jesus Really Say? The Search for the Authentic Words of Jesus* (New York: Polebridge, 1993).

130. Jenkins, *Hidden Gospels*, 9.

131. Robert J. Miller, ed., *The Complete Gospels* (Sonoma, CA: Polebridge, 1994, 1st ed. 1992).

132. (1) The Narrative Gospels are: Mark, Matthew, Luke, Signs Gospel, John; (2) Sayings Gospels are: Sayings Gospel Q, Thomas, Greek Fragments of Thomas, Secret Book of James, Dialogue of the Savior, Gospel of Mary; (3) Infancy Gospels are: Infancy Gospel of Thomas, Infancy Gospel of James; (4) Fragmentary Gospels are: Peter, Secret Gospel of Mark, Egerton Gospel, Gospel Oxyrhynchus 840, Gospel Oxyrhynchus 1224; (5) Jewish-Christian Gospels are: Gospel of Hebrews, Gospel of Ebionites, Gospel of Nazoreans.

The Complete Gospels was advertised as an attempt to restore suppressed Scriptures, and the authors compared their work to that of the Reformers who gave the Bible to persons in their own native tongue.[133] The parallel made is that the early church suppressed the Gnostic gospels just as the later church suppressed Scripture. It is assumed that the hidden Gospels opened up the reality of the earliest days of Christianity, but this is only possible if they were written at an early date. But scholarly consensus dates them late in the second and third centuries (one from the fifth century);[134] and hence hardly comparable to the canonical Gospels. Jenkins concludes:

> Far from being the alternative voices of Jesus' first followers, most of the lost gospels should rather be seen as the writings of much later dissidents who broke away from an already established orthodox church. This is not a particularly controversial statement, despite the impression that we may get from much more recent writing on the historical Jesus. The late character of the alternative texts is crucial to matters of historicity and reliability. Historical research is as good as the sources on which it relies, and to the extent that the latest quest for the historical Jesus is founded on the hidden gospels, that endeavor is fatally flawed.[135]

COMPARED TO DEAD SEA SCROLLS

In 1947, two years after the discovery of the Nag Hammadi texts, the *Dead Sea Scrolls* were found in eleven caves above the Wadi Qumran, probably remnants of an Essene community library. There are over four hundred texts, and though fragmentary, a hundred are biblical texts from every Old Testament book except Esther. This was a valuable find because these manuscripts date from the closing centuries B.C. and the first century A.D., taking readers about a thousand years nearer to the original texts than any previous Old Testament manuscripts.[136] The value of the *Dead Sea Scrolls* is their confirmation of the accuracy of the Gospel texts, showing that the copying of inspired writings was done with great care. By contrast, the alleged gospels reflect Gnostic views that are contrary to the biblical Gospels.

133. Jenkins, *Hidden Gospels*, 9.

134. Bart Ehrman lists what he and others call the lost gospel, mostly coming from the second century (*Epistle of the Apostles, Gospel According to the Hebrews, Gospel of the Ebionites, Gospel of the Egyptians, Gospel of Mary, Gospel of the Nazareans, Gospel of Peter, Gospel of the Savior,* (Coptic) *Gospel of Thomas,* (Infancy) *Gospel of Thomas, Gospel of Truth* (*Papyrus Edgerton 2, Proto-Gospel of James*) and later the *Gospel of Philip* (third century) and *Gospel of Nicodemus* (fifth century), *Lost Christianities: The Battles for Scripture and the Faiths We Never Knew* (New York: Oxford, 2003), xi–xii.

135. Jenkins, *Hidden Gospels*, 12.

136. F. F. Bruce, J. J. Scott Jr., "Dead Sea Scrolls," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 322–323.

GNOSTICISM

The Gnostics twisted biblical truths to make them agree with their own ideas, and through this means, they deceived the unsuspecting. Irenaeus said of their method: "Their manner of acting is just as if one, when a beautiful image of a king has been constructed by some skillful artist out of precious jewels, should then take the likeness of the man all to pieces, should re-arrange the gems, and so fit them together as to make them into the form of a dog or of a fox."[137] From king to fox is a work of deconstruction, or better, a work of deception!

Tertullian mentioned a number of heresies that were "instigated by philosophy." He referred to Paul's writing to the Colossians: "'See that no one beguile you through philosophy and vain deceit, after the tradition of men, and contrary to the wisdom of the Holy Ghost.' He had been at Athens, and had in his interviews (with its philosophers) become acquainted with human wisdom which pretends to know the truth, whilst it only corrupts it, and is itself divided into its own manifold heresies, by the variety of its mutually repugnant sects. What indeed has Athens to do with Jerusalem?... Away with all attempts to produce a mottled Christianity."[138]

Church historian Adolf Harnack (1851–1930) believed "Gnostic systems represent the acute secularising or hellenising of Christianity" and stated, "with regard to the most important Gnostic systems the words hold true, 'The hands are the hands of Esau, but the voice is the voice of Jacob.'"[139] No wonder, because the Christian veneer of Gnosticism made its deception as successful as Jacob's, for the Old Testament was, "for the first time, systematically and also in part historically criticised."[140]

GOSPEL OF JAMES

The *Gospel of James* was allegedly written by the apostle James in Jerusalem after the death of Herod (chap. 25)[141]; it is also called the Protoevangelium of James. The word *protoevangelium* is classically applied to Genesis 3:15, when the Creator-Christ gave Adam and Eve the first recorded promise of the gospel. After cursing the snake for tempting Eve (Gen. 3:14), the pre-incarnate Christ said, "And I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and hers; he will crush your head, and you will strike his heel"

137. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies*, *The Anti-Nicene Fathers*, 1:326 (1.8.1).
138. Tertullian, *On Prescription Against Heretics*, *The Anti-Nicene Fathers*, 3:246 (7).
139. Adolf Harnack, *The History of Dogma*, (Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 1997), 1:227, 230.
140. Ibid.
141. The full text is found in B. Harris Cowper, *The Apocryphal Gospels and Other Documents Relating to the History of Christ: Translated from the Originals in Greek, Latin, Syriac, etc., with Notes, Scriptural References and Prolegomena*, 2nd ed. (Edinburgh: Williams and Norgate, 1867), 1–26.

(Gen. 3:15). Catholic exegesis interprets this verse as referring to Mary, the mother of Jesus.

In the *Gospel of James*, the alleged parents of Mary were Joachim and Anna. Joachim could not make an offering at the temple because he had no offspring, so he "did not show himself to his wife" but went to the wilderness for forty days and fasted until God visited him (chap. 1).[142] Meanwhile Anna grieved for her widowhood and childlessness, put on her wedding garments, and entered her garden to pray that God would open her womb as He had done for Sarah to give birth to Isaac (chap. 2). An angel came to tell her she would conceive; then two angels came to tell her Joachim was coming with his flocks, and she told him the good news—which another angel had already told Joachim before he began his homeward journey (chap. 4).

Mary walked seven steps when only six months old (chap. 6). At the age of three, Mary was taken to the temple, where on the third step of the altar "the Lord God bestowed grace upon her, and she danced about on her feet, and all the house of Israel loved her" (chap. 7).[143] "And Mary was like a dove brought up in the temple, and received food from the hand of an angel." When Mary was twelve, the high priest entered into the holy of holies, and an angel of the Lord instructed him to summon widows from all over Judea to take a rod each, and God would indicate who should marry Mary (chap. 8).[144]

"Joseph received the last rod, and, behold, a dove went out of the rod, and flew upon the head of Joseph." The priest said Joseph was to receive Mary, but he refused, and the priest warned him that he should fear God, and not be like Dathan, Abiram, and Korah. So he took Mary (chap. 9). Mary was sixteen when she was pregnant (chap. 12). Joseph was away from home at the time and returned from house building when Mary was six months pregnant.[145] When he found her pregnant, Joseph wept bitterly, comparing the deception of Eve by the serpent with Mary getting pregnant. Joseph asked the *why* and *who* questions, asking Mary, "[W]hy hast thou humbled thy soul, thou that was brought up in the holy of holies, and received food at the hand of an angel?" (chap. 13).

142. *The Gospel of Pseudo-Matthew* claims that Anna didn't see Joachim for five months, chapter 2, in *The Apocryphal Gospels*, 30–31. Here is a discrepancy between around forty days and five months.
143. In *The Gospel of Pseudo-Matthew* "Mary was in admiration with all the people of Israel. When she was three years old, she walked with so firm a step, spoke so perfectly, and was so assiduous in the praises of God, that all were astonished at her, and marvelled; and she was not regarded as a little child, but as an adult of about thirteen years, she was so earnest in prayer," in chapter 6, in *The Apocryphal Gospels*, 37.
144. In chapter 8 in *The Gospel of Pseudo-Matthew*, Mary was fourteen when this took place, so there is a discrepancy of two years, *The Apocryphal Gospels*, 40.
145. In *The Gospel of Pseudo-Matthew*, Mary was nine months pregnant, not six months, when Joseph returned home from making tabernacles, chaptet 10, so there is a discrepancy of three months, in *The Apocryphal Gospels*, 45. During Mary's pregnancy, angels talked to her every day, and every day she received food from the hand of the Lord, *The Gospel of Pseudo-Matthew*, chapter 10, in *The Apocryphal Gospels*, 45.

Joseph decided to secretly divorce Mary, but an angel appeared to him at night and said the conception was through the Holy Spirit (chap. 14).

Joseph and Mary were brought to the place of judgment in the temple, where the priest questioned them regarding the pregnancy. Addressing Mary: "[W]hy hast thou done this? And wherefore hast thou humbled thy soul, and hidden thyself from the Lord thy God; thou that wast brought up in the holy of holies, and didst receive food at the hand of an angel, and didst hear hymns, and didst dance before him; why hast though done this? And she wept bitterly." Both Mary and Joseph said they were not the cause of the pregnancy, and the priest said, "Bear not false witness" (chap. 15). The priest said to Joseph, "Restore the virgin which thou receivedst from the temple of the Lord. And Joseph wept very much" (chap. 16). There are twenty-five chapters in all, but perhaps this is sufficient to get an insight into the alleged Gospel.

Evaluation

The purpose of the alleged Gospel is to elevate Mary, and by so doing, to call into question the uniqueness of Christ's incarnation. For Mary herself was born of the Holy Spirit without a human father, and to this degree her birth was similar to Christ's birth (although, unlike Mary, Christ pre-existed the Incarnation). Mary grew up from the age of three to sixteen in the holy of holies of the Jerusalem temple, being miraculously fed by an angel for thirteen years. These insights alone make her more than a normal human. Yet in the canonical Gospels, Jesus never gives Mary a privileged position, as seen on the following occasion:

> While Jesus was still talking to the crowd, his mother and brothers stood outside, wanting to speak to him. Someone told him, "Your mother and brothers are standing outside, wanting to speak to you." He replied to him, "Who is my mother, and who are my brothers?" Pointing to his disciples, he said, "Here are my mother and my brothers. For whoever does the will of my Father in heaven is my brother and sister and mother." (Matt. 12:46–50)

It seems inconsistent that Mary and Joseph, who experienced angel visitants, should weep "bitterly" and "very much" as they did when the priests doubted their honesty about the pregnancy. Could they not trust the angels to tell the priest too? After all, the angel met with the priest to providentially bring Joseph and Mary together, so he could have easily gone to the priest again. Joseph and Mary should have rejoiced that God had blessed them as the angels had promised. In other words, the story shows lack of spiritual discernment about the calm and assurance that messages from angels and the miracle of the Incarnation would give to Joseph and Mary; for the fruit of the Spirit includes joy and

peace (Gal. 5:22–23). On these grounds alone, the alleged gospel is shown to be judged by Scripture as less than authentic.

INFANCY *GOSPEL OF THOMAS*

The first discovered *Infancy Gospel of Thomas* is probably less than its original length, and contains miracles and other acts of Jesus during a seven-year period (five to twelve years of age).[146] At the age of five, He gathered water into pools from a stream, and by His word made them immediately pure; and on the Sabbath Jesus created twelve sparrows from soft clay, and when questioned about profaning the Sabbath, He "clapped his hands and cried unto the sparrows, and said to them, Go away: and the sparrows flew up and departed, making a noise" (chap. 2). The son of Annas the Scribe spilled some water Jesus had collected. In response, Jesus "was angry and said to him, 'Wicked, impious, and foolish one, wherein have the pools and the water wronged thee? Behold, now thou also shalt wither as a tree, and shalt not produce either leaves or root or fruit.' And suddenly the boy withered altogether. And Jesus departed, and went away to the house of Joseph. And the parents of him that was withered carried him, bemoaning his youth, and brought him to Joseph, and accused him, saying, 'Such a son hast thou as doeth such things'" (chap. 3).

This shocking narrative continues. "Then again he went through the village, and a boy ran and thrust against his shoulder; and Jesus being vexed, said to him, Thou shalt not finish thy journey. And immediately he fell down and died." The dead boy's parent complained to Joseph, saying, "Thou that hast such a child canst not dwell with us in the village; teach him to bless and not to curse; for he killeth our children" (chap. 4). Jesus caused his accusers to go blind (chap. 5). The teacher Zacchaeus said of Jesus, "Take him away…I entreat thee, brother Joseph, I cannot bear the severity of his gaze…. Perhaps he was begotten before the world was made" (chap. 7). When the Jews encouraged Zacchaeus, Jesus "laughed greatly" and said, "I come from above that I may curse them, and call to things on high, as He who sent me ordained for your sakes…. And thenceforward no one dared provoke him, lest he should curse him and he become blind" (chap. 8).

On his way to heal a young man, "the child Jesus ran thither, and by force he passed through the throng" (chap. 10). In one miracle he "stretched" some wood to make it equal to another piece of wood (chap. 13). Another teacher told Joseph he would instruct Jesus in Greek and then in Hebrew. Jesus asked the teacher to tell him the power of Alpha, and then He would tell the teacher

146. In the *Arabic Gospel of The Infancy*, Christ speaks in the cradle, and says to His mother Mary, "I am Jesus the Son of God, the Word, whom thou hast borne as the angel Gabriel announced to thee; and my Father hath sent me for the salvation of the world," chapter 1, in *The Apocryphal Gospels*, 172.

the power of Beta; "and the teacher, being annoyed, struck him on the head, and the child was vexed and cursed him, and immediately he became senseless, and fell upon his face on the ground, and the child returned to the house of Joseph. And Joseph grieved, and charged his mother, saying, thou shalt not send him outside the door, for they die who provoke him to anger" (chap. 14). A neighbor's child died, and Jesus raised him, and then went to play with other children (chap. 17).

At the age of twelve, Jesus went to the temple with His parents, questioned the doctors of the law, and was lost by His parents who then hunt for him; the whole story is the same as that which is recounted in Luke 2:41–52 (chap. 19).

Evaluation

The anger and harshness of the boy Jesus is at extreme odds with the Jesus of the canonical Gospels. This Jesus kills people for minor annoyances. There is a mixture of the sacred and the profane, as Jesus goes from performing a miracle to playing with kids. There is a doubt about His pre-existence, being merely "begotten before the world was made." It was with utter insensitivity that Jesus "laughed greatly" at His teacher Zacchaeus, stating that His mission "from above" was to "curse them," so that people were afraid of Jesus, lest He make them blind. These are abhorrent pictures that obviously distort the truth about Jesus; they also distort the view of the God whom He came to reveal (John 14:9). The true gospel says: "God did not send his Son into the world to condemn the world, but to save the world through him" (John 3:17).

LATER *GOSPEL OF THOMAS*[147]

This later and longer *Gospel of Thomas* is called by some the fifth Gospel.[148] Whereas the shorter Greek version is about the infancy of Jesus and is fragmentary (containing only nineteen chapters), the longer Coptic version presents one hundred fourteen sayings of Jesus. The Greek version comes from around the year 200, and the Coptic version from about 350.[149] There is no narrative about Jesus, not

147. The discovery of the Nag Hammadi library in Egypt in 1945 brought to light fifty-two texts, probably dated from the fourth or early fifth century. The Coptic version (there are also Greek and Latin versions) may go back to materials found in the Greek version in the second and third century Oxyrhynchus Papari 654, 1 and 636, or the *Diatessaron* may be its principal source. The best-known text from Nag Hammadi is the *Gospel of Thomas.* See Robert Winterhalter, *The Fifth Gospel: A Verse-by-Verse New Age Commentary on the Gospel of Thomas* (San Francisco, CA: Harper & Row, 1988), 1; Jenkins, *Hidden Gospels*, 5; Jack Finegan, *Hidden Records of the Life of Jesus*, 243, 271; and Nicholas Perrin, *Thomas and Tatian: The Relationship Between the Gospel of Thomas and the Diatessaron* (Atlanta, GA: SBL, 2002), 7–18.

148. See Robert W. Funk, Roy W. Hoover and The Jesus Seminar, and Robert Winterhalter, *Fifth Gospel.*

149. *The Five Gospels*, 474.

even about His death and resurrection—just sayings. This indicates the relative importance of teachings, for Gnostics believed in salvation by knowledge, not through a substitutionary death.

We'll examine the alleged sayings of Jesus, and note that they are described as "secret sayings."[150] Jesus said that the Father's "imperial rule within you and it is outside you" (3). Nothing is hidden that will not be revealed (5–6). Jesus said James the Just would be the leader after He left (12). "Jesus said, 'Congratulations to the one who came into being'" before coming into being (19), suggesting a Gnostic idea of personal pre-existence.[151]

Jesus said, "There is light within a person of light, and it shines on the whole world" (24, which is a Gnostic view, cf. 50).[152] Jesus said, "If you bring forth what is within you, what you have will save you. If you do not have that within you, what you do not have within you (will) kill you" (70). The subjective focus includes pantheism, for Jesus said, "I am the light that is over all things. I am all: from me all came forth, and to me all attained. Split a piece of wood; I am there. Lift up a stone, and you will find me there" (77).

The only saying that reminds one of Jesus as He is portrayed in the Greek fragments of the *Gospel of Thomas* is the following: "The Father's imperial rule is like a person who wanted to kill someone powerful. While still at home he drew his sword and thrust it into the wall to find out whether his hand would go in. Then he killed the powerful one" (98). The commentary says, "The sheer violence and scandal of the image of the assassin suggests that it might well have originated with Jesus. It is unlikely that the early Christian community would have invented and have attributed such a story to Jesus since its imagery is so contrary to the irenic and honorific images, such as the good shepherd, they customarily used for him."[153]

These sayings, however, remind us of scenes from the true Gospels, though with some *major* variations: "Jesus said, The (Father's) imperial rule is like a shepherd who had a hundred sheep. One of them, the largest, went astray. He left the ninety-nine and looked for the one until he found it. After he had toiled, he said to the sheep. 'I love you more than the ninety-nine'" (107). "Simon Peter said to them, 'Make Mary leave us, for females don't deserve life.' Jesus said, 'Look, I will guide her to make her male, so that she too may become a living spirit resembling you males. For every female who makes herself male will enter the domain of Heaven'" (114).

150. Ibid., 471–532.

151. Ibid., 483.

152. Ibid., 487.

153. Ibid., 524–525.

Evaluation

Having read all the sayings, it is only necessary to choose a representative number to ascertain what type of literature we find in the longer *Gospel of Thomas.* Because there is a mixture of canonical statements and original statements in the *Gospel of Thomas*, it has some credence. Yet beyond the superficial similarities, there are some differences that are glaring. For example, consider carefully (1) the subjective focus; (2) Gnostic ideas about preexistence; (3) light; (4) pantheism; (5) attributing a violent saying to Jesus simply because it is not in agreement with other images used; (6) the idea that Christ would say that He loves the one lost sheep more than the ninety-nine is counter to canonical revelation that God is no respecter of persons (Prov. 28:21a; Acts 10:34; Rom. 2:11; Jas. 2:9; 1 Pet. 1:17); (7) the statement that a female must become a male to enter Heaven is contrary to Scripture, which says, "There is neither Jew nor Gentile, neither slave nor free, nor is there male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus" (Gal. 3:28).

Clearly the *Gospel of Thomas* fails to measure up to the canonical Gospels, and so is wrongly considered the "fifth Gospel." If any writing deserves that title, it is the book of Hebrews, which presents the good news of Christ's present ministry for humans in heaven, just as the four Gospels present the good news of His past ministry for humans on earth. I concur with Robert Grant and David Noel Freedman that the "Gnostic atmosphere" of the *Gospel of Thomas* "made it unacceptable to the Christian Church."[154] It seems to me that Bart Ehrman's 2003 book title *Lost Scriptures: Books That Did Not Make It into the New Testament*[155] could give the impression that Gnostic gospels were authentic Scriptures, but internal evidence leads us to a contrary conclusion.

DETRIMENTAL EFFECT OF THE *GOSPEL OF THOMAS*

A popular defense of the *Gospel of Thomas* is Elaine Pagels's 2005 book *Beyond Belief: The Secret Gospel of Thomas.*[156] The defense is presented as part of the author's journey from the tragic news that her eighteen-month-old son, Mark, has been diagnosed with pulmonary hypertension (a fatal disease with life-expectancy unknown) to her discovery of the hidden *Gospel of Thomas*, and the meaning it brought to her life.

On a cold February Sunday morning in New York—the day after bringing Mark home from the hospital—she was out jogging, then stopped to enter a

154. Robert M. Grant and David Noel Freedman, *The Secret Sayings of Jesus* (Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1960), 73.
155. Ehrman, *Lost Scriptures*, 1–5.
156. Pagels, *Beyond Belief: The Secret Gospel of Thomas* (New York: Random House, 2005).

church to get warm. She hadn't been inside a church in decades. At the back of the church, feeling uncomfortable, she suddenly realized she needed to be there. She went often after that, but she was "not looking for faith."

> When people would say to me, "Your faith must be of great help to you," I would wonder, What do they mean? What is faith? Certainly not simple assent to the set of beliefs that worshipers in that church recited every week ("We believe in one God, the Father, the Almighty, maker of heaven and earth...")—traditional statements that sounded strange to me, like barely intelligible signals from the surface, heard at the bottom of the sea. Such statements seemed to me then to have little to do with whatever transactions we were making with one another, with ourselves, and—so it was said—with invisible beings. I was acutely aware that we met there driven by need and desire; yet sometimes I dared hope that such communion has the potential to transform us.[157]

Pagels doesn't "identify Christianity with a single, authorized set of beliefs" and doesn't accept that "Christian belief alone offers access to God." Hence the name of her book, *Beyond Belief.* She refers to the *Gospel of Thomas* as a Christian gospel. She believes this gospel was composed in the first century (it actually was composed in the second century [Greek version] and the fourth century [Coptic version]); she further believes that Western Christianity was "decisively shaped—and inevitably limited" by the inclusion of John's Gospel in the canon, and denouncing "Thomas's gospel as 'heresy.'"[158] According to Pagels, John's Gospel *told* people what to believe, whereas the *Gospel of Thomas* challenges people to *discover* what is within. For John the light is in Jesus, for Thomas the light is within each person made in the image of God.[159] (Pagels also alleges contradictions between the Gospel of John and the Synoptics which are unfounded, and need not detain us here.)

Pagels joined an evangelical church at the age of fourteen. Yet she became distressed when a close friend (who was sixteen years of age) died in an automobile accident, and her Evangelical friends commiserated that he was eternally damned because he was a Jew and hadn't been born again. She left the church and studied Greek in order to discover true Christianity for herself—she wanted to see the earliest Christian sources. She entered Harvard University where she discovered the Nag Hammadi library. One day she read an alleged saying of Jesus in the *Gospel of Thomas:* "'If you bring forth what is within you, what you bring forth will save you. If you do not bring forth what is within you, what you do not bring forth will destroy you.'" She said, "The strength of this saying is that it does not tell us what to believe but challenges us to discover what lies

157. Ibid., 5.
158. Ibid., 29.
159. Ibid., 30, 34.

hidden within ourselves; and, with a shock of recognition, I realized that this perspective seemed to me self-evidently true."[160] It dawned on her that salvation lies within, and not in revealed beliefs.

Evaluation

With her turn to inner reality, she had no objective basis for evaluating the *Gospel of Thomas*. She rejected the idea of faith and beliefs, and yet paradoxically she had faith in this pseudo gospel and embraced it as authentic. In the relativism of our times, everyone's experience is just as authoritative as anyone else's. Truth is truth...if it is truth for you. It is alleged that there is no universal truth, which really means there is no absolute truth, and hence there is no unchanging measure of truth. This leaves humans in an ever-changing pluralism, without any meaning. Once Pagels accepted the *Gospel of Thomas* as authentic, she dubbed the church's rejection of it as a rejection of true Christianity. This concurs with the idea of Christianities (plural),[161] with alleged hidden records of the life of Jesus[162] and hidden gospels.[163] Such ideas spring from a rejection of Scripture as God's authentic and authoritative revelation.

The gospel of Scripture is the good news about Jesus Christ. The fact that it was necessary for Christ to come into human history to save humans proves that salvation does not lie within humans. Salvation can only break into human history as a gift in the life, death, resurrection, and heavenly ministry of Jesus Christ. Salvation depends upon the return of Jesus and the end of the world, with a creation of a new heaven and a new earth. All these events of Christ's life are fundamental beliefs without which there is no salvation. It is the Christ who acts in human history who acts in human lives, and He doesn't do the one without the other. His acts within are always subsequent and dependent upon His acts in human history. A turn from belief in objective truths to an inner reality is turning away from the Savior to embrace human experience. Pagels claims the Gospel of John replaced the *Gospel of Thomas*—and at great detriment to Christianity. But she turned away from the only Gospel (Jesus Christ) to an alleged gospel focus within. Yet John (the same apostolic writer) in his first letter, warned against the counterfeit, yet Pagels never speaks of that.

Given the cosmic controversy, there are always two sides to the conflict: Christ's side and the side of the enemy of Christ. The Gospel of John declares that Christ is the truth (John 14:6), and the enemy is the father of lies (John 8:44). There is the Spirit of truth (John 16:13) and the spirit of Antichrist (1 John 4:3b). There is

160. Pagels, *Beyond Belief*, 30–32.
161. For example, Ehrman, *Lost Christianities*.
162. For example, Finegan, *Hidden Records of the Life of Jesus*.
163. Philip Jenkins, *Hidden Gospels: How the Search for Jesus Lost Its Way* (New York: Oxford, 2001).

a Spirit who brings glory to Christ (John 16:14) and a spirit who is against Christ. Therefore, we can expect there to be a true gospel, and a false gospel/gospels. But how can we tell the difference?

It is not by looking within. Humans need God's authoritative revelation that is unchanging throughout human history and transient cultures. That revelation is Scripture. The Canon wasn't decided by the church, but the Spirit of truth guided Christians to discern the difference between the true Gospels (Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John) and counterfeit gospels, so Scripture could be a reliable guide to Christians throughout Christian history.[164] Only then could Christians have a solid, objective, God-given basis by which to test the spirits to discern between the true and the false (1 John). Beliefs matter. John says the true gospel teaches that Christ came in the flesh, while the false gospel doesn't believe Christ came in the flesh (1 John 4:1–3). This is precisely the difference between the Canonical Gospels, and the *Gospel of Thomas* with its Gnostic theology (and denial of the Incarnation).

Christ promised His disciples: "I have much more to say to you, more than you can now bear. But when he, the Spirit of truth, comes, he will guide you into all the truth. He will not speak on his own; he will speak only what he hears, and he will tell you what is yet to come. He will glorify me because it is from me that he will receive what he will make known to you" (John 16:12–14). The Canonical Gospels bring glory to Christ, but the counterfeit gospels do not. Scripture is a reliable, time-tested guide to help us discern the difference, for Christ promised and provided this solid guidance for His disciples.

Looking to the end times, Jesus asked, "[W]hen the Son of Man comes, will he find faith on the earth?" (Luke 18:8). Even in the beginning of human history, there was a faith problem. Satan's temptation of Eve was to get her to look beyond belief, or beyond faith in God. Although Christ told Adam that eating the forbidden fruit would result in death (Gen. 2:16–17), the tempter countered, "You will not certainly die.... For God knows that when you eat from it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God, knowing good and evil" (Gen. 3:4a–5). The tempter offered hidden knowledge and a secret elevation, which the Creator-Christ was keeping from her. Both were beyond belief in Christ's Word. After all, here was a serpent speaking her language: "When the woman saw that the fruit of the tree was good for food [secret of how to become like God] and pleasing to the eye, and also desirable for gaining wisdom [hidden knowledge], she took some and ate it" (Gen. 3:6).

Contrary to Satan's rejection of God's Word, Scripture states, "faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God" (Rom. 10:17, KJV). To step beyond belief is to step beyond God—beyond Christ. The gospel is clear: "For God so

164. See my *Prolegomena*, vol. 1 in *Systematic Theology* (Berrien Springs, MI: Andrews, 2003), 320–325.

loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life" (John 3:16). This is found in the Gospel of John, which she believes should have been ousted from the canon in favor of the *Gospel of Thomas*.

CONCLUSION

Gnosticism has a God and a Creator who are not in relationship with one another, which is a distortion of the relational Trinity. "Beginning with the Genesis account of creation and the element of belief in an absolute, transcendent God," many Gnostics "strove to attain and develop the knowledge (*gnōsis*) that this world is the product of a foolish creator (demiurge) who set to work without the permission of the highest and therefore 'Unknown' God." Furthermore, "Without the knowledge or consent of the foolish creator, the highest God provided humankind with an otherworldly, divine substance variously called 'spirit,' 'soul,' and 'spark.'"[165] It is a tragedy that classical Christian theology presented a God who is unknowable because He is timeless, transcendent, aloof, impassible, and immutable. This is why it is so important to understand the relational Trinity as the God of biblical theology. As one would expect, a wrong view of God affects the entire system of theology, for theology is a study about God. This included a wrong view of Jesus.

Satan is behind these heresies, promoting hidden mysteries through alleged Gnostic gospels, for through them the rage of the enemy is vented by replacing the true gospel with a counterfeit gospel, just as Satan wanted to replace God on His throne. Irenaeus mentions one example: "the Savior assumed an animal body, formed in accordance with a special dispensation by an unspeakable providence, so as to become visible and palpable."[166]

The Apocalypse of Peter (81:4–24) states:

> I saw him apparently being seized by them, And I said, "What am I seeing, O Lord? Is it really you whom they take? And are you holding on to me? And are they hammering the feet and hands of another? Who is this one above the cross, who is glad and laughing?" The Savior said to me, "He whom you saw being glad and laughing above the cross is the Living Jesus. But he into whose hands and feet they were driving the nails is his fleshly part, which is substitute. They put to shame that which remained in his likeness. And look at him, and [look at] me!"[167]

Eastern Orthodox scholar Frederic Mathews-Green has said this about the best-known Gnostic, Valentinus:

165. Kurt Rudolph, "Gnosticism," in *The Anchor Bible Dictionary*, 2:1033.
166. Ibid.
167. http://www.evidencetobelieve.net/gnostic_gospels.htm, accessed August 22, 2012.

> Valentinus supposedly taught a hierarchy of spiritual beings called "aeons." One of the lowest aeons, Sophia, fell and gave birth to the Demiurge, the God of the Hebrew Scriptures. This evil Demiurge created the visible world, which was a bad thing, because now we pure spirits are all tangled up in fleshly bodies. Christ was an aeon who took possession of the body of the human Jesus, and came to free us from the prison of materiality.... "Us," by the way, didn't mean everybody. Not all people have a divine spark within, just intellectuals; "*gnosis*," by definition, concerns what you know. Some few who are able to grasp these insights could be initiated into deeper mysteries. Ordinary Christians, who lacked sufficient brainpower, could only attain the Demiurge's middle realm. Everyone else was doomed. Under Gnosticism, there was no hope of salvation for most of the human race.[168]

This is a limited atonement, and therefore no different from Calvinistic theology. Biblical redemption is for the world (John 3:16–17), for Christ tasted "death for everyone" (Heb. 2:9b), for Jesus Christ "is the atoning sacrifice for our sins, and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world" (1 John 2:2).

On Gnostic terms, there can be no human life of Jesus, nor death, and no wonder there could be no King-Priest at the right hand of the Father, which depends on these two prerequisites. All that is offered is secret knowledge for the few who have these moments of enlightenment, giving them knowledge that saves them because they are better informed than ignorant Christians who believe in divine revelation in Scripture. The hidden knowledge comes from hidden gospels. The secrecy of it all makes this akin to the Calvinistic predestination whereby God elects a few and bypasses the majority. There is no salvation for those without this secret knowledge or for those not included in the secret decree of the Father in eternity. The similarity gives witness to the sameness of the source of these ideas. Calvary is downplayed by all the non-Christian gospels, which is sufficient to unmask who is behind them.

The *Gospel of Judas* was used by a gnostic group (Cainites), who believed the world was created by a lesser god (the God of the Old Testament), and salvation was based upon secret knowledge. The Cainites believed that Judas, rather than being a traitor, alone understood the mystery of Christ, and did His will. So, he was not a villain but a hero. They believed that Judas was the only disciple who was faithful, and he received salvation, and the other disciples, and their religion, are rooted in ignorance.[169]

The *Gospel of Judas* claims to be "the secret account of the revelation that Jesus spoke in conversation with Judas Iscariot during a week three days before he celebrated Passover." Often Jesus appeared to the disciples, not as

168. Frederic Mathews-Green, "What Heresy," *Books and Culture* (November–December 2003), quoted in *Breaking*, 73.
169. Bart D. Ehrman, foreword to *The Lost Gospel: The Quest for the Gospel of Judas Iscariot*, by Herbert Krosney (Washington, DC: National Geographic, 2006), xv–xxiii.

He was, but as a child.[170] Jesus laughed at their eucharistic prayer of thanksgiving and claimed that no human can know Him, assuring them that their god was within them.[171]

Judas alone of the Twelve was selected by Jesus to hear the mysteries of the Kingdom; he knew that he alone was reflecting on something that was exalted. Jesus told Judas about his destiny: "you will be cursed by the other generations—and you will come to rule over them. In the last days they will curse your ascent to the holy (generation)."[172]

Jesus discussed the destruction of the wicked with Judas and others. He mentions that some "will fornicate in my name and slay their children" [and the six and a half lines are missing to complete the thought]. Then it says: "After that Jesus (laughed)." The last word is supplied, evidently fitting in with other expressions about His laughing.[173] Jesus said that each disciple "has his own star," and says that when people die, "their souls will be alive, and they will be taken up."[174]

This *Gospel of Judas* clashes with the Canonical Gospels in many ways. Consider: (1) Judas is singled out for special treatment; (2) Judas is given special insights into mysteries; (3) the laughing of Jesus presents Him as frivolous; (4) stars have a guiding influence on people; and (5) the gospel is devoid of spirituality, or sense of the holy. These are some indicators that we are dealing with a counterfeit gospel. Scripture does not credit Judas with carrying out the will of Christ to betray Him, but the will of Satan. Thus in the upper room "Satan entered into" Judas to betray Christ (John 13:27).

These gospels, so called, demean rather than elevate Christ. One would expect that Satan would do this from the cosmic controversy presented in this system, for Satan hates Christ and seeks to distort the truth about Him (Ezek. 28:16a, "trade" in the Hebrew *rĕkūllâ* has a wide semantic range that includes the meaning of gossip). The glorious gift of salvation at the cross is replaced by human *gnosis* (knowledge) to earn your own salvation through knowledge (hence Gnosticism). Satan twists the truth. In short, as G. L. Borcheret says, "The Garden of Eden story is then transformed so that the biblical tree of knowledge of good and evil becomes a vehicle of knowledge (*gnosis*) established by the heavenly or pleromatic realm. But the tree of life becomes a vehicle of bondage and dependence established by the demiurgical realm."[175]

170. *The Gospel of Judas*, introduction, in Krosney, *The Lost Gospel*, 303–304.
171. Ibid., 304–305.
172. Ibid., 312–314.
173. Ibid., 321.
174. Ibid., 311 and 312 respectively.
175. G. L. Borchert, "Gnosticism," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 2nd ed., ed. Walter A. Elwell (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2001), 487.

Salvation

12. Salvation: Cosmic Implications
13. Atonement Theories
14. Salvation Applied: Work of the Holy Spirit
15. Salvation Debate: Augustine of Hippo to Council of Trent
16. Salvation Debate: Post-Tridentine to Contemporary
17. Roman Catholic-Protestant Divide: "Evangelicals and Catholics Together" Documents

God's comprehensive plan was introduced in the doctrine of God (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 8), and includes mediation, redemption, and restoration. This plan, made in eternity, is unfolded in time through the everlasting covenant. This is the biblical background to the doctrine of salvation. The plan was not only devised by the relational Trinity, but is also realized through the relational Trinity. Whereas some say there is no salvation outside of the church (which claims apostolic succession), in reality there is no salvation outside of the relational Trinity. For the Persons of the Trinity are the sole source and means of salvation. Therefore, they have not handed over the management of salvation to any human means (church, sacraments, or intercessors) for they are well able, and the only Ones able, to fully carry out the plan of salvation.

The Father gave Christ to the world, and divine God became also human, lived a human life, dependent wholly upon God, and became an example of how humans should live. As the Son of Man, His perfect life becomes a robe of righteousness for humans, whereas His sacrificial death as the sin-bearing substitute for all humans has provided atonement for the broken law. On the basis of His life and death, Christ is the only qualified Priest in the Christian era, and as such He ministers in the heavenly sanctuary.

Salvation involves justification, sanctification, and future glorification. There is only one "eternal gospel" (Rev. 14:6) with "Jesus Christ the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8). The church worked out the doctrine of the Trinity and the doctrine of Christ, but never worked out the doctrine of salvation. In fact, one can profess different views on salvation and not be heretical. Even though the Cross has been central to the Christian faith from the earliest times, there has never been agreement on the exact way in which the Cross saves. Before the Reformation, salvation was not a separate doctrine. Even the greatest of the schoolmen, such as Peter the Lombard and Thomas Aquinas,

pass on at once from the discussion of the Incarnation to that of the church and the sacraments.

Biblical salvation is more expansive; it has cosmic implications. It has everything to do with the cosmic controversy and the restoration of the universe to its pre-Fall state: without sin and without sinners. Justification is by faith, a forensic declaration that is a change of status, an imputation of Christ's righteousness and not an infusion that elevates humans to merit further justification. The debate between Roman Catholics and Evangelicals over justification is no longer an "anathema judging" of each other, but a work toward convergence and consensus, motivated by a desire to defeat secularism. However, a forced union isn't the best way to meet secularism: truth is. Any consensus that buries truth is itself a worse kind of secularism.

The Reformation isn't over yet. There is an urgent need to remove traditions that hide Christ and His ministry (in the heavenly sanctuary) from believers. That is one of the most important contributions that theology has yet to make.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Salvation: Cosmic Implications

Purpose

1. Focus on salvation through Christ alone.
2. Show that salvation is more than forgiveness of sin.
3. Document that salvation has cosmic implications.

Summary

God takes the initiative in the plan of salvation: It is not something earned by humans, but a gift made available to all humans. It is a gift planned before creation. Salvation is worked out in human history in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ (supplied), and worked out in human lives (applied). The application (see chapter 14) has been made throughout human history, for Christ is "the Lamb who was slain from the creation of the world" (Rev. 13:8b). The plan includes Christ's present ministry as King-Priest in heaven's sanctuary, His second advent, glorification of His followers, and their ascension to heaven. It also involves a new creation of the earth and its environs, and life in the new earth that will never end. The plan is paradise regained after paradise was lost through the fall of humans (Gen. 3:1–6). It took God to become also human (chapter 9), and as a human, to work out in His human life a character to give to His followers, as well as a death to atone for their sins. But there is more. Salvation transcends what God does for humans. It involves the entire cosmos. Salvation's plan is prior to human creation (Eph. 1:3–14), and extends beyond

human restoration, for it involves resolution of the cosmic controversy, so that sin will never arise again (Rev. 21:1–5a; 22:1–5).[1] The above is the scope of the full mission of Jesus Christ. Salvation includes all that the Persons of the Trinity do for intelligent created beings, as an outworking of their inner-Trinitarian love.

OUTLINE

I. Introduction
II. Salvation in Scripture
A. Old Testament
1. Exodus Salvation
2. Redemption in the Wilderness
3. Salvation Context at Sinai
4. Perspective Is Crucial
5. Sanctuary: God's Dwelling with Humans
6. Sanctuary Sacrifices and Services
7. David
8. Isaiah
9. Exodus Story Used for Judah in Babylon
10. Micah
B. New Testament
C. Cosmic Dimension of Salvation
D. Plan Precedes Creation
E. Plan Reaches into the Coming Ages
III. Conclusion
IV. Study Questions

INTRODUCTION

With this chapter we begin a new segment on salvation (chapters 12–15). I concur with Millard Erickson that salvation is a point of transition in a theological system, moving from the objective (God, sin, Christ) to the subjective (application to our lives, which affects the doctrines of the church and final things).[2] It follows that our understanding of the Trinity (as a relational God) affects our understanding of salvation. One purpose of Christ's mission on earth was to reveal what God is like (John 14:9)—which indicates how important Christ's mission was through His life, teachings, and death. He continues to

1. I will have more to say on this topic in my *Systematic Theology*, volume 4, which deals with eschatology.
2. Millard Erickson, *Christian Theology*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1998), 799.

reveal what God is like in the application of salvation through the Holy Spirit, and His intercession on behalf of humans in heaven's sanctuary.

The church worked out the doctrine of the Trinity and the doctrine of Christ, but never worked out the doctrine of salvation. In fact, "people can profess almost any view of the atonement without branding themselves as heretical."[3] It follows that despite "the centrality of the cross from the earliest days of the church, there has never been agreement on the way the cross saves us."[4] "In pre-Reformation theology scant justice is done to soteriology in general. It does not constitute a separate locus, and its constituent parts are discussed under other rubrics, more or less as *disjecta membra* [disconnected parts]. Even the greatest of the Schoolmen, such as Peter the Lombard and Thomas Aquinas, pass on at once from the discussion of the incarnation to that of the Church and the sacraments."[5]

Catholic theology locates salvation in the church, rather than in Jesus Christ. This does not mean Christ is not the Savior, but means His salvation is found only through the church. Even Protestant sacramental theology is in danger of depending on the sacraments instead of solely depending on the Savior. Anything that comes between Christ and His followers questions Christ as the only mediator between God and humans.

It is important to realize that the life, death, resurrection, and present ministry of Christ in heaven's sanctuary have everything to do with human salvation, and the resolution of the cosmic controversy so that rebellion will never rise again (Rev. 21:1–5a; 22:1–5). Yale historian Jaroslav Pelikan has said:

> The Creed adopted at Nicea confessed that it had been "for the sake of us men and for the purpose of our salvation" that Christ "came down [from heaven] and was made flesh, was made man, suffered, was raised on the third day, ascended into the heavens, and will come to judge living and dead." But neither it nor later dogmas specified in any detail just how the salvation which was the purpose of Christ's coming was related to these events in his earthly and heavenly states.[6]

It needs to be kept in mind that sin began in heaven, not on earth (Rev. 12:7–8). God's response to human sin is called salvation, but His response to sin involves more than the human race. When Lucifer sinned in heaven, God didn't snuff him out. If God had destroyed Lucifer, created beings would have served God out of fear. So God's judgment was held back, as He allowed sin to reveal itself over time. Sin is rebellion against God and misrepresents His character to the universe. But how can God be loving when He allows sin to cause suffering to so

3. Leon Morris, *The Cross of Jesus* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), 12.
4. Ibid., 11.
5. Louis Berkhof, *Systematic Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1996), 417.
6. Jaroslav Pelikan, *The Emergence of the Catholic Tradition (100–600)*, vol. 1 in *The Christian Tradition, A History of the Development of Doctrine* (Chicago: Chicago University Press, 1971), 141.

many? God knows He needs to reveal His justice and love, and so He sends Christ into the world, not only to save humans, but to reveal the character of God (John 14:9). Sin deserves and demands justice be exercised against it. That judgment that Christ takes upon Himself (2 Cor. 5:21) is a righteous act, and in so doing He acts in love (John 3:16). Justice and mercy meet at the Cross, revealing the character of God in an unparalleled way. In this chapter, we will see that this has cosmic implications, far beyond the salvation of humans.

Salvation flows out of God's eternal and comprehensive plan (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 8), which involves the eternal covenant that unfolds in history (volume 2, chapters 9–11), and encompasses redemption through the life and death of Jesus Christ (chapter 9) and restoration through the high-priestly ministry of the risen Christ in heaven's sanctuary (chapter 10), and application through the Holy Spirit (now called "the Spirit of Christ," 1 Pet. 1:11; chapter 14). Salvation requires understanding the nature of sin (chapter 3), the function of the law (this chapter), and the relationship between justification and sanctification (chapters 15–16). In summary, salvation is rooted or grounded in the "pact of salvation" (*pactum salutis*) of the Trinity (which I call the Covenant of Redemption and Restoration), and thus in their eternal reciprocal love. Their plan to redeem humans and restore the cosmos to its pre-Fall state was a plan made prior to human creation, which is worked out in human history through the everlasting covenant (embracing old and new covenants), through the Father's giving of His Son, the Person and work of Jesus Christ, and the work of the Holy Spirit.

Salvation in Scripture

All non-Christian religions emphasize the *teaching* of their leader, not what the leader has done for them, for leaders do not save them. The teaching is about how they can earn their own salvation. One method of salvation is enlightenment (gaining knowledge) through meditation and mantra recitations, a system of rigorous and arduous works that may take a lifetime; another method is *samsura*, or multiple reincarnations that take numerous lifetimes to overcome *karma* in order to arrive at the goal of salvation. By contrast, Christ's central teaching is His atoning death sacrifice in place of humans, for "the wages of sin is death" (Rom. 6:23a). Salvation is God's gift through Christ's life, death, resurrection, and present intercession in heaven's sanctuary and His resurrection of the saints and their glorification at the Second Advent; and hence any attempt to earn it by human works is an utter waste of time—because it is both impossible and unnecessary.

OLD TESTAMENT

In this segment our primary focus is on the Old Testament, with occasional insights from the New Testament. As soon as sin entered human history, Adam and Eve "sewed fig leaves together" (Gen. 3:7) to cover their nakedness, and shortly after that the pre-incarnate Christ clothed them with "garments of skin" (Gen. 3:21). Skin suggests the death of animals as a sacrifice for sin. They were probably lambs, because Christ is "the Lamb who was slain from the creation of the world" (Rev. 13:8b; cf. 1 Pet. 1:18–19). In simple language, Christ's death was typified by the death of those lambs, for death is the wage exacted by sin (Rom. 6:23), for "without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness" (Heb. 9:22b).

Imagine the pain Christ endured that day. He had done everything for Adam and Eve: given them life and fellowship with each other, and with Him. He had given them the Sabbath, and they had no doubt spent their first day of life with Him (Gen. 2:1–3). Yet Adam and Eve chose to follow a deceptive rebel (Gen. 3:1–6) against Christ (Rev. 12:7–9) instead of following their Creator (Gen. 2:17). As the lambs were slain and the garments made, Christ knew that one day He would die for all sinners, and make available to them a garment of His righteous life, so He could become "The LORD Our Righteous Savior" (Jer. 23:6b); and yet He also knew that most people would reject both. Christ knew that Adam's sin would affect all humans, and that His death would be for all humans (Rom. 5:17), "For since death came through a man, the resurrection of the dead comes also through a man. For as in Adam all die, so in Christ all will be made alive" (1 Cor. 15:21–22). This resurrection of all humans is in the eschatological future (1 Thess. 4:16–18; Rev. 20:4–5).

Cain and Abel were the first two humans born into a fallen world, and they came to worship God, Cain bringing some of his "fruits of the soil" (Gen. 4:3) and Abel "some of the firstborn of his flock" (Gen. 4:4). Cain's offering typified salvation by works, while Abel's offering typified salvation through the coming Lamb of God. Only Abel's sacrifice was acceptable, for it pointed to God's gift of salvation, whereas Cain's fruits pointed to his own works (Gen. 4:4b–5a). So salvation by human works infiltrated the first family in human history, and the formalism of Cain's gift was demonstrated by his killing of Abel (Gen. 4:8), indicating that worship without a heart-relationship with God often leads to persecution of one who has a heart-relationship with God. This is found throughout Scripture and church history, and climaxes in the end times when a death decree will be passed to enforce false worship (Rev. 13:15).

Cain's legalism led to further law breaking in killing—both a result of a broken relationship with God. In fact, the divine commentary says, "Do not be like

Cain, who belonged to the evil one and murdered his brother. And why did he murder him? Because his own actions were evil and his brother's were righteous" (1 John 3:12). Already the first firstborn child on planet earth was controlled by Satan. Much later, in speaking to the Pharisees (John 8:13), Christ said, "You belong to your father, the devil, and you want to carry out your father's desires. He was a murderer from the beginning, not holding to the truth, for there is no truth in him" (v. 44a). Satan's law breaking, rebellious spirit inspired Cain to kill Abel, and the Jewish leaders to plan Christ's death (Matt. 26:4; Luke 22:2; John 5:18). If Satan was a murderer from the beginning, it seems he wanted to murder Christ, if not the Godhead, in the beginning, when and where his rebellion against God began. Law breaking is rebellion against the Lawgiver, and needs to be understood as such.

After the global flood, Noah built an altar of burnt offerings, and sacrificed to God "some of all the clean animals and clean birds" (Gen. 8:20). These sacrifices were offered in gratitude for salvation that had been extended to Noah and his family during the Flood, recognizing that their safety was due to God's provision and protection. It should be noted that sacrifices preceded the coming of Israel onto the stage of history, just as the seventh-day Sabbath preceded Israel (Gen. 2:1–3; Mark 2:26).

Exodus Salvation

God's people in Egypt suffered greatly "because of their discouragement and harsh labor" (Exod. 6:9b). The Lord promised them, "I will bring you out from under the yoke of the Egyptians. ...I will redeem you with an outstretched arm.... Then you will know that I am the LORD your God, who brought you out from under the yoke of the Egyptians" (Exod. 6:6b–7).

The "Passover sacrifice" (*zebaḥ-pesaḥ*) was a slain one-year-old male lamb or goat without defect (Exod. 12:1–5; 27), whose blood was placed "on the sides and tops of the doorframes" (v. 7) of houses in Egypt. The houses that had the blood applied were passed over, protecting the firstborn child and firstborn animals from a death judgment (vv. 12–13). During that Passover night, "the LORD kept vigil to bring them [Israel] out of Egypt" (Exod. 12:42a).

The Lord even went with them into the wilderness. But when the Israelites saw Pharaoh's army pursuing them, they were "terrified" (Exod. 14:10). "Then the angel of God, who had been traveling in front of Israel's army, withdrew and went behind them. The pillar of cloud also moved from in front and stood behind them, coming between the armies of Egypt and Israel. Throughout the night the cloud brought darkness to the one side and light to the other side; so neither went near the other all night long" (Exod. 14:19–20). Moses said to

Israel, "Do not be afraid. Stand firm and you will see the deliverance the LORD will bring you today. The Egyptians you see today you will never see again. The LORD will fight for you; you need only to be still" (Exod. 14:13–14).

How soon they forgot the mighty plagues and God's protection of them; how soon they forgot their liberation from Egyptian slavery; how soon they forgot that it was blood that had saved their firstborn. In each, God was teaching them that He is their Redeemer, that they need to depend on Him and not be distracted by threatening conditions in the world. Scared stiff, they were desperate, trapped between the world's greatest army and the Red Sea. But God opened up a way through the sea. He "divided the Red Sea asunder" (Ps. 136:13a). "The surging waters stood up like a wall" (Exod. 15:8), and Israel "went through the sea on dry ground, with a wall of water on their right and on their left" (Exod. 14:22).

The Egyptians followed, but "During the last watch of the night [three to six in the morning] the LORD looked down from the pillar of fire and cloud at the Egyptian army and threw it into confusion. He jammed the wheels of their chariots so that they had difficulty driving" (Exod. 14:24–25a). Even the Egyptians knew God was fighting against them (v. 25b), and the entire army was drowned. Not one escaped (Exod. 14:2–30; 15:19). What an amazing revelation of God's salvation. This awesome miracle caused Israel to reverence God and trust Him (Exod. 14:31). What utter relief and gratitude!

They sang, "The LORD is my strength and my defense; he has become my salvation" (Exod. 15:2). "Who among the gods is like you, O LORD? Who is like you—majestic in holiness, awesome in glory, working wonders? You stretch out your right hand, and the earth swallows your enemies. In your unfailing love you will lead the people you have redeemed" (Exod. 15:11–13). Much later Peter said, "Salvation is found in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given to mankind by which we must be saved" (Acts 4:12).

The Exodus-Red-Sea deliverance was the greatest manifestation of God's saving power amid seemingly impossible circumstances. It became the foundational event to demonstrate salvation—that human extremity is God's opportunity, that there is nothing too hard for the Lord; a lesson that Abraham, father of Israel, learned (Gen. 18:14; 21:1–3; cf. Eph. 3:20). The Exodus impacted all future generations until Christ entered the world to save humans from within history. Even then Christ was called the Passover Lamb (1 Cor. 5:7), for salvation comes through "the precious blood of Christ, a lamb without blemish or defect" (1 Pet. 1:19), "the Lamb who was slain from the creation of the world" (Rev. 13:8b). This means that the grace of salvation was available from the moment there had been sin in Eden.

Redemption in the Wilderness

Without Christ, Israel would have perished in the wilderness. Moses said to Israel, "If you listen carefully to the LORD your God and do what is right in his eyes, if you pay attention to his commands and keep all his decrees, I will not bring on you any of the diseases I brought on the Egyptians, for I am the LORD, who heals you" (Exod. 15:26). Instead of being grateful for their freedom from slavery, the miracle of the Rea Sea, and this promise of being free of disease, "the whole community grumbled against Moses and Aaron." The Israelites said to them, "If only we had died by the LORD's hand in Egypt! There we sat around pots of meat and ate all the food we wanted, but you have brought us out into this desert to starve this entire assembly" (Exod. 16:3). The pre-incarnate Christ replied, "At twilight you will eat meat, and in the morning you will be filled with bread. Then you will know that I am the LORD your God" (Exod. 16:12).

The God who saved them in the Exodus would continue to provide for them in the wilderness. Where was their faith? How foolish of Israel to wish God had killed them in Egypt when He had protected them in Egypt during the plagues and annihilated their enemies in the final plague and in the Red Sea. What would they have gained if God had killed them in Egypt? They had forgotten the bigger picture and allowed doubts to dominate their minds, shutting out God's great salvation by being preoccupied with death—back in Egypt, and now in the desert. To help them remember the mighty power of God, the Lord asked that a pot of manna be placed with the sacred Ten Commandments in the Ark of the Covenant (Exod. 16:34).

God provided the manna for forty years (Exod. 16:35), indicating His desire to help the Israelites in every way, day by day. Unlike other days, on the sixth day the manna kept until the seventh day (Exod. 16:19–23). The point is that they had manna every day. That is the way salvation works. It is a daily receiving of spiritual bread, allowing us to be nourished by Christ each day. Just as the Israelites had to gather food each day, so each day we must feast on the Word of God. Jesus declared, "I am the bread of life. Whoever comes to me will never go hungry" (John 6:35). Quoting from Israel's wilderness experience (Deut. 8:3), Jesus said, "Man shall not live on bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God" (Matt. 4:4). The Words of God in the Word of God are the daily spiritual food for Christians.

In spite of their daily food, Israel grumbled again, and were "almost ready to stone" Moses (Exod. 17:4). "Why did you bring us up out of Egypt to make us and our children and livestock die of thirst?" (Exod. 17:3b). They were focusing on death again, even after all the evidences of God's salvation

from death. The Lord said, "I will stand there before you [Moses and some of the elders] by the rock at Horeb [Mt. Sinai]. Strike the rock, and water will come out of it for the people to drink" (Exod. 17:6). Paul comments on this miracle, saying, "they drank from the spiritual rock that accompanied them, and that rock was Christ" (1 Cor. 10:4). So even as they drank physical water from a physical rock, they drank spiritual water from the spiritual rock Christ, who was with them.

Later, God gives His invitation to Judah in captivity: "Come, all you who are thirsty, come to the waters" (Isa. 55:1a). Christ repeats the invitation many centuries later, "Let anyone who is thirsty come to me and drink. Whoever believes in me, as Scripture has said [cf. Isa. 58:11b], rivers of living water will flow from within them." By this He meant the Spirit, whom those who believed in Him were later to receive (John 7:37b–38a). Paul says, "Now these things occurred as examples to keep us from setting our hearts on evil things as they did" (1 Cor. 10:6). The bottom line is that they seemed more interested in the physical food and drink than in the spiritual nourishment.

Looking back to their time in the wilderness, Israel was asked to "Remember how the LORD your God led you all the way in the wilderness these forty years, to humble and test you in order to know what was in your heart, whether or not you would keep his commands" (Deut. 8:2). "During the forty years that I led you through the wilderness, your clothes did not wear out, nor did the sandals on your feet. You ate no bread and drank no wine or other fermented drink. I did this so that you might know that I am the LORD your God" (Deut. 29:5–6).

Salvation Context at Sinai

Horeb, where Israel received life-giving water, was also where they received the life-preserving Ten Commandments. The prelude to these Ten was about the Exodus; "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of Egypt, out of the land of slavery" (Exod. 20:2). The implication was that that if they allowed Him to remain as their God, He would maintain their spiritual freedom. These commandments were to guide them away from law breaking, which is slavery to sin. So God asked them to "Worship the LORD your God, and his blessing will be on your food and water. I will take away sickness from among you, and none will miscarry or be barren in your land. I will give you a full life span" (Exod. 23:25–26). What wonderful promises and blessings!

The pre-incarnate Christ was promised to help Israel, "to guard you along the way and to bring you to the place I have prepared.... I will send my terror ahead of you and throw into confusion every nation you encounter. I will

make all your enemies turn their backs and run" (Exod. 23:20, 27). In the future God would say through Solomon, "My son, pay attention to what I say [commandments and all of Scripture]; turn your ear to my words. Do not let them out of your sight, keep them within your heart; for they are life to those who find them and health to one's whole body" (Prov. 4:20–22).

While Moses was up on the mount with God, Israel asked Aaron to "make us gods" (Exod. 32:1). Rather than reveling in the presence of the living God dwelling with them, the One who had given them such miraculous victories and provisions, they were enslaved to their fallen nature. God had brought Israel out of Egypt, but Egypt was still within Israel. With a tool they fashioned an idol in the form of a calf. Then they said, "These are your gods, Israel, who brought you up out of Egypt" (Exod. 32:4).

They indulged in revelry and became corrupt (Exod. 32:6b–7). They were "running wild" and "out of control" (Exod. 32:25), no doubt enslaved by Satan. No wonder they gave credit to the calf for their escape from Egypt, for this deflected attention away from the only awesome God who alone liberated and redeemed them from Egypt. Distorting the truth about God is Satan's studied strategy to cause people to lose their salvation, for false views of God never draw people to Him. This is why it is crucial to understand who God is. Why did Israel worship something they had just made when the God who brought them out of Egypt is eternal and self-existent? How incomprehensible!

When Moses asked Aaron why he allowed this to happen, he replied, "I threw it [gold and silver jewelry] into the fire, and out came this calf" (Exod. 32:24). He implied a miracle, as if it had come from the God of miracles. This idol worship was a "great sin" (Exod. 32:30), and so it was severely punished. God commanded the Levites to take a sword, and three thousand Israelites were slain (Exod. 32:27–28) as punishment for their idolatry. Then God sent a plague upon Israel (Exod. 32:35). Because they had worshipped idols like the Egyptians, they also received a plague like the Egyptians. God called them "a stiff-necked people" (Exod. 32:9; cf. 33:3). They were unconverted, and had no victory in their lives—victories that should have reflected God's victories for them in Egypt and beyond. After all, it is the same God, and He alone, who produces both kinds of victories. They cried out to God for one type of victory, but not for the other.

Although the Israelites were God's chosen people, most of them did not choose God as their personal Savior, as the One who could daily give them the joy of salvation. What was the point of being freed from slavery in Egypt if they were still slaves to their fallen natures?

Perspective Is Crucial

It is important to know the awesome power and promises of God. God "brought you [Israel] out of Egypt by his Presence and his great strength, to drive out before you nations greater and stronger than you and to bring them into their land to give it to you for your inheritance" (Deut. 4:37b–38). This should have been uppermost in their minds: namely (1) God was present with them, and (2) He would defeat nations far greater than they.

However, repeatedly Israel allowed circumstances to hide God from them. Rarely did any look beyond themselves to God as they had at the Red Sea. There they were told not to be afraid because God was in charge. For a golden moment they looked beyond themselves and their enemy and trusted in God. Deliverance came as a gift. But that focus was short-lived. On the borders of the Promised Land, twelve leaders, one from each tribe (Num. 13:4–15), went into the Promised Land to bring back a report. God told Moses that it was the land "which I am giving to the Israelites" (Num. 13:1–2), just as much a gift as freedom from Egypt and from the Egyptian army in the Red Sea. All leaders reported that it was a land flowing with milk and honey, and they brought fruit to prove it, but ten of them said the people are "powerful" and the cities are "fortified" (Num. 13:27–28).

Not Caleb. His eyes looked beyond the people and were fixed on the Almighty God. He said, "We should go up and take possession of the land, for we can certainly do it" (Num. 13:30). But the others said the people were stronger and greater than the people of Israel (Num. 13:31–33), indicating certain failure. All Israel wept and grumbled, saying, "If only we had died in Egypt! Or in this wilderness!" (Num. 14:2). They blamed God for bringing them out to die by the sword, and suggested they choose another leader to take them back to Egypt (Num. 14:3–4). Moses and Aaron pled with Israel not to be afraid, but the Israelites wanted to stone them (Num. 14:9–10).

Then the Lord said, "How long will these people treat me with contempt? How long will they refuse to believe in me, in spite of all the signs I have performed among them? I will strike them down with a plague and destroy them, but I will make you into a nation greater and stronger than they" (Num. 14:11–12). This was the second time God said this to Moses (Exod. 32:10), which indicates how badly Israel was behaving. The intercession of Moses for them represents Christ's intercession in heaven's sanctuary today. It was not enough to save Israel from slavery in Egypt. They needed intercession to forgive their incorrigible thanklessness and to save them from themselves.

So it is with salvation. It is not enough to liberate sinners through the death of Christ (their liberation day), but there is also a necessary intercession in heaven's sanctuary to save them during their preparation to enter the ultimate Promised Land. Moses knew God. He had a heart for God. He had a right understanding of God. He said, "In accordance with your great love, forgive the sin of these people, just as you have pardoned them from the time they left Egypt until now" (Num. 14:19). There is no salvation without such a pardoning from God. But there are consequences.

The Israelites wallowed in griping and complaining which robbed them of seeing God—how great and awesome He is, and how He yearned to be their Savior. Ten times Israel rebelled and grumbled at God who was patient with them, but there are consequences for such faithless behavior. As a result of their grumbling, God declares that those over twenty years of age would die in the wilderness, never to enter Canaan (Num. 14:22–23, 29). God spoke of them as a "wicked community" (Num. 14:35), and of Caleb as one who "follows me wholeheartedly" (Num. 14:24). The whole camp rebelled. By contrast, Caleb and Joshua were devoted to God. They alone gave a good report of the land. They loved and trusted God; they had a heart-relationship with Him; they were unafraid of any obstacles. They believed in the power of God over anyone or anything that opposed them, because He was powerful in their lives. They experienced His salvation in its present form, looking forward to its final stage to come (cf. Heb. 11).

Immediate death came to the ten leaders who had given a bad report and had influenced Israel to doubt God. Their song at the Red Sea had included a confident praise: "The LORD is my strength and defense; he has become my salvation" (Exod. 15:2). How soon they forgot that there is only one God, one Savior, and that He was all they needed to be victorious. It is amazing that God would live among such unthankful people. He was dwelling among those who constantly rebelled and grumbled against Him, a foretaste of His coming incarnate life to save humans.

It has cost God so much to work out our salvation. Only a God of love could endure such insults and rebuffs. Only a gracious God could minister to those so ungracious and ungrateful.

Sanctuary: God's Dwelling with Humans

While the golden calf was being created and worshiped (Exod. 32:1), the Creator-God (the pre-incarnate Christ) gave Moses the pattern for an earthly sanctuary to demonstrate the plan of salvation (Exod. 26–31). Just as Christ wrote the Ten Commandments, He showed Moses the pattern, or miniature model, of the place in which He would dwell among the children of Israel. Note

the vital context of these two gifts: Just like the Ten Commandments were given in the context of the deliverance from Egypt (Exod. 20:1), so Christ said of the sanctuary: "I will dwell among the Israelites and be their God. They will know that I am the LORD their God, who brought them out of Egypt so that I might dwell among them. I am the LORD their God" (Exod. 29:45–46).

God did not want Israel to forget that He alone was God. He alone redeemed them from captivity in Egypt, and He alone went with them through the Red Sea. He alone would dwell among them in the sanctuary, and He alone could save them from sin. Having the Savior in their midst was to remind them that Christ saved them from Egypt in order to dwell with them, just as He would save all willing souls from sin in order to dwell with them forever. For in the new earth "I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, 'Look! God's dwelling place is now among the people, and he will dwell with them. They will be his people, and God himself will be with them and be their God'" (Rev. 21:3). Christ's dwelling in the midst of Israel was a type of the Trinity's dwelling with humans in the new earth.

Salvation is not merely saving people from sin, but restoring the broken relationship caused by sin in Eden. Salvation is relational. This makes sense when salvation is the plan of the relational Trinity who created humans in their image (Gen. 1:26–27). There is no salvation apart from an intimate relationship with God. Attempting to earn salvation is worthless, for a relationship with God is never restored by human works. God must take the initiative and come to dwell with humans so their works will be a love-response to such an awesome and lavish love bestowed on them.

Sanctuary Sacrifices and Services

The unfolding of God's plan in the sanctuary was presented in my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 14. In this context, the sacrifices, along with the dwelling of the pre-incarnate Christ in the sanctuary, were intended to teach the love of God for sinners. Forgiveness of sin in the Old Testament was only possible through the coming sacrifice of Christ on Calvary. Those in Israel who had spiritual discernment through a saving relationship with Christ, and in reading the Messianic prophecies understood Isaiah 53, could rightly assess their present hardships in the light of the death of Christ for all sinners. Their sufferings were infinitesimally small compared to His utter anguish on the cross. It was God's purpose that those bringing a lamb to the altar would catch a glimpse of God's ultimate gift—death to pay for all human sins.

Christ resided in the most holy place, the Shekinah glory above the mercy seat of the earthly throne of God. As Christ dwelt there, He knew that at the other

end of the sanctuary was an altar in the courtyard. He knew of the many sacrifices made there every day, and knew that one day the relevance of those sacrifices would cease as He became the ultimate sacrifice on the Altar called Calvary.

The pre-incarnate Christ lived among a wicked community, and knew that another wicked community would give Him over to die. On both occasions this wicked community was His own chosen people who, for the most part, did not choose Him. Amid it all Christ knew that few in Israel and few in the world would accept Him as their Savior, even after all that the relational Trinity had done to save them. Christ dwelt in the sanctuary, but longed with the Spirit to indwell humans, knowing that this was the only way to save them.

As Christ dwelt in the sanctuary, He was reminded every day that the priests came from the altar and ministered in the first apartment of the sanctuary. He also knew that on the day of atonement the high priest ministered in the second apartment of the sanctuary. These priestly ministries reminded Him of His priestly ministry in the apartments of the heavenly sanctuary after His death. He knew that this vital part of the gospel would not be understood by many who only focus on the Cross. The sacrifice of Christ at Calvary accomplished justification, the priestly ministry of Christ in heaven's sanctuary, and Christ's work through and with the Holy Spirit in humans accomplishes sanctification. Both are necessary for salvation. The work of Christ in the second apartment has to do with the final response to the cosmic controversy which is necessary to salvation, for there is no redemption without resolution of the controversy.

Witnessing legalism must have been very painful to Christ, for endless formal sacrifices without love were an affront to the relationship He longed to share with them. He dwelt in their midst, but their religious routine crowded out any thought of a relationship with Him. No wonder He later said to His Father: "Sacrifice and offering you did not desire," but "I desire to do your will, my God; your law is within my heart" (Ps. 40:6a, 8; cf. Heb. 10:4–7). Christ had the new covenant experience (see Jer. 31:31–33), a heart experience that caused Him to willingly and lavishly sacrifice Himself as a substitute for sinners. He was and is in love with all sinners, even though He hates the sin that separates sinners from Him. Christ longed for His people to have the same heart experience. He said to Moses: "Oh, that their hearts would be inclined to fear me and keep all my commands always, so that it might go well with them and their children forever" (Deut. 5:29).

David

God wanted His people to focus on the Savior, rather on the sacrifices they brought to Him. The sacrifices had been intended to point them to Calvary—to teach them that it takes the giving of life to secure salvation, and also the

giving of one's life to be saved. In other words, the sacrifice is in place of the sinner (Heb. 9:22), but in order to receive the gift the sinner must give his or her life to the Savior.

David had this experience. He said "my eyes are fixed on you, Sovereign Lord" (Ps. 141:8a). "I will keep my eyes always on the LORD. With him at my right hand, I will not be shaken. Therefore my heart is glad and my tongue rejoices.... You make known to me the path of life; you will fill me with joy in your presence, with eternal pleasures at your right hand" (Ps. 16:8–9a, 11). David had joy in the present and looked forward to fullness of joy in eternity—both a gift from the presence of God within him. Relationship rather than ritual or rules describes David's experience; he came to know that God wants to save humans in order to give them fullness of joy in relationship with Himself.

No wonder David said: "One thing I ask from the LORD, this only do I seek: that I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life, to gaze on the beauty of the LORD and to seek him in his temple" (Ps. 27:4). Later he said: "I have seen you in the sanctuary and beheld your power and your glory. Because your love is better than life, my lips will glorify you. I will praise you as long as I live" (Ps. 63:2–4a). In fact, David exclaimed: "Your love, LORD, reaches to the heavens, your faithfulness to the skies. Your righteousness is like the highest mountains, your justice like the great deep. You, LORD, preserve both people and animals. How priceless is your unfailing love.... For with you is the fountain of life" (Ps. 36:5–7a, 9a). "The salvation of the righteous comes from the LORD; he is their stronghold in time of trouble. The LORD helps them and delivers them; he delivers them from the wicked and saves them, because they take refuge in him" (Ps. 37:39–40).

This includes spiritual as well as physical salvation, for salvation is the work of God in both. When David said, "I desire to do your will, my God; your law is within my heart" (Ps. 40:8), it was because he had a heart-relationship with God. He asked God to "give me an undivided heart, that I may fear [reverence] your name. I will praise you, Lord my God, with all my heart; I will glorify your name forever" (Ps. 86:11b–12). "How precious to me are your thoughts, God! How vast is the sum of them!" (Ps. 139:17).

David gave us insight into God's salvation, which is the eternal gospel offered to Israel and Judah. David knew that God's love is not confined to a few He has elected to save. He said, "The LORD is gracious and compassionate, slow to anger and rich in love. The LORD is good to all; he has compassion on all he has made" (Ps. 145:8–9). David declared,

> He does not treat us as our sins deserve or repay us according to our iniquities.
> For as high as the heavens are above the earth, so great is his love for those who

> fear [reverence] him; as far as the east is from the west, so far has he removed our transgressions from us. As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear [reverence] him; for he knows how we are formed, he remembers that we are dust.... But from everlasting to everlasting the LORD's love is with those who fear [reverence] him, and his righteousness with their children's children—with those who keep his covenant and remember to obey his precepts. (Ps. 103:10–14, 17–18)

God revealed to David insights into Christ's salvation-suffering: "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Ps. 22:1a). "All who see me mock me; they hurl insults, shaking their heads. 'He trusts in the LORD,' they say, 'let the LORD rescue him. Let him deliver him, since he delights in him'" (Ps. 22:7, 8; cf. Matt. 27:39, 43; Luke 23:35). "Dogs surround me; a pack of villains encircles me; they pierce my hands and feet. All my bones are on display; people stare and gloat over me. They divide my clothes among them and cast lots for my garment" (Ps. 22:16–18; cf. Luke 23:34; John 19:23). "I am an object of scorn to my accusers; when they see me, they shake their heads" (Ps. 109:25). "Scorn has broken my heart and has left me helpless; I looked for sympathy, but there was none, for comforters, but I found none. They put gall in my food and gave me vinegar for my thirst" (Ps. 69:20–21; cf. Matt. 27:34, 48).

Isaiah

Isaiah says more about the Savior, the Suffering Servant, than any other Old Testament prophet. "He had no beauty or majesty to attract us to him [he evidently emptied himself of these divine attributes along with the use of his own divinity, Phil. 2:6–8], nothing in his appearance that we should desire him. He was despised and rejected by mankind, a man of suffering, and familiar with pain. Like one from whom people hide their faces he was despised, and we held him in low esteem" (Isa. 53:2b–3). Why? "Surely he took up our pain and bore our suffering...he was pierced for our transgressions, he was crushed for our iniquities; the punishment that brought us peace was on him, and by his wounds we are healed.... the LORD laid on him the iniquity of us all. He was oppressed and afflicted, yet he did not open his mouth; he was led like a lamb to the slaughter, and as a sheep before its shearers is silent, so he did not open his mouth. By oppression and judgment he was taken away...he was cut off from the land of the living" (vv. 4–8). "Yet it was the LORD's will to crush him and cause him to suffer"; "the Lord makes his life an offering for sin" (v. 10); "he poured out his life unto death, and was numbered with the transgressors" (v. 12b). (We will unpack these insights when we come to the New Testament segment later in the chapter.)

Exodus Story Used for Judah in Babylon

How incredible that Israel would turn to objects of their own making and worship them as their gods. Idolatry was an internal slavery that led Israel into captivity to Assyria and Judah into captivity to Babylon. They had not learned from the golden calf incident when they attempted to replace their Creator-God, as if salvation had been in their hands and not in His. With respect to the Babylonian captivity, God sent messengers to remind the captives of the great exodus from Egypt and through the Red Sea—to remind them of His faithfulness and love. Isaiah was one of the prophets during the Babylonian captivity. He said to Judah, "This is what the LORD says—he who made a way through the sea, a path through the mighty waters" (Isa. 43:16). Isaiah asks a rhetorical question: "Was it not you who dried up the seas, the waters of the great deep, who made a road in the depths of the sea so that the redeemed might cross over? Those the LORD has rescued will return. They will enter Zion with singing; everlasting joy will crown their heads. Gladness and joy will overtake them, and sorrow and sighing will flee away" (Isa. 51:10–11).

By referring to the Exodus deliverance, the God who never changes (Mal. 3:6a) was reminding them that He was able to deliver Judah from the Babylonian captivity. These deliverances were demonstrations of what He longed to do for all people: to deliver them from the power (and finally the presence) of sin.

Micah

Micah the prophet proclaimed God's burden: "I brought you up out of Egypt and redeemed you from the land of slavery." Micah asked: "Will the LORD be pleased with thousands of rams, with ten thousand rivers of olive oil? Shall I offer my firstborn for my transgression, the fruit of my body for the sin of my soul? He has shown you, O mortal, what is good. And what does the LORD require of you? To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God" (Mic. 6:4, 7–8). Note the presence of justice, mercy, and humility in their lives—attributes God revealed at Calvary (to be taken up later). In other words, God wants His people to reflect Him, and they can only do so in relationship with Him and through Him.

From the Scripture verses we have been studying, it becomes evident that the God of the Old Testament is no different from the God of the New Testament. Many think that believers in the Old Testament were under law while in the Christian era they are under grace. But these distinctions are no more valid than saying salvation could be earned in the Old Testament, but not in the New Testament. It is true that Israel and Judah were rebels during most of their long

history, but this has to do with their wrong response to God—and has nothing to do with God's loving concern for them. The plan of salvation does not change an iota throughout human history. Yes, the means to teach the plan of salvation were different (through the sanctuary sacrifices and services) from the means used today, but they all pointed to the *same* Savior, and "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8). His robe of righteousness was available in the Old Testament (Isa. 61:10), even before He lived on earth (Jer. 23:6; 33:16b).

NEW TESTAMENT

It is understood in the New Testament that Christ fulfilled the sacrifices of the Old Testament. Paul pointed back to the beginning of Israel's history when he wrote: "Christ, our Passover Lamb [*pascha*], has been sacrificed" (1 Cor. 5:7). Compared to the sanctuary/temple lambs (and other sacrifices) that only potentially dealt with sin, John the Baptist pointed to Jesus and said, "Look, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29). This reminds us of the bronze serpent in the desert, when Moses said, "Make a snake and put it up on a pole; anyone who is bitten can look at it and live" (Num. 21:8).

Paul made the same comparison when speaking of Christ, "God presented Christ as a sacrifice of atonement, through shedding of his blood. He did this to demonstrate his righteousness, because in his forbearance he had left the sins committed beforehand unpunished" (Rom. 3:25). The author of Hebrews made the same comparison: "[N]ow that he has died as a ransom to set them free from the sins committed under the first covenant" (Heb. 9:15b), "he has appeared once for all at the culmination of the ages to do away with sin by the sacrifice of himself" (v. 26b); because "it is impossible for the blood of bulls and goats to take away sins" (10:4).

In the Old Testament the sacrifices were on behalf of the sinners that offered them. The animals died in place of the sinners. This focus continues in the New Testament. Jesus understood His function as a substitute: "I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for [*hyper*] the sheep" (John 10:11). Paul said: "Christ died for [*hyper*] the ungodly" (Rom. 5:6b); "While we were yet still sinners, Christ died for [*hyper*] us" (Rom. 5:8b); "Christ died for [*hyper*] our sins" (1 Cor. 15:3); "gave himself for [*hyper*] our sins" (Gal. 1:4a); "the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for [*hyper*] me" (Gal. 2:20b); "Christ loved us and gave himself up for [*hyper*] us as a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God" (Eph. 5:2); "He who did not spare his own Son, but gave him up for [*hyper*] us all" (Rom. 8:32a). All these verses are summed up in the following

statements: "God made him who had no sin to be sin for [*hyper*] us" (2 Cor. 5:21); "He himself bore our sins in his body on the cross…by his wounds you have been healed" (1 Pet. 2:24).

Prior to his Damascus road conversion, Paul (then called Saul) was a Pharisee and bent on all sorts of works to merit salvation (Gal. 1:13–14). Ponder long his experience before and after he met Christ:

> I [Paul] too was convinced that I ought to do all that was possible to oppose the name of Jesus of Nazareth. And that is just what I did in Jerusalem. On the authority of the chief priests I put many of the saints in prison, and when they were put to death, I cast my vote against them. Many a time I went from one synagogue to another to have them punished, and I tried to force them to blaspheme. I was so obsessed with persecuting them that I even hunted them down in foreign cities. (Acts 26:9–11)

> If someone else thinks they have reasons to put confidence in the flesh, I have more: circumcised on the eighth day, of the people of Israel, of the tribe of Benjamin, a Hebrew of Hebrews; in regard to the law, a Pharisee; as for zeal, persecuting the church; as for righteousness based on the law, faultless. But whatever were gains to me I now consider loss for the sake of Christ. What is more, I consider everything a loss because of the surpassing worth of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord, for whose sake I have lost all things. I consider them garbage, that I may gain Christ and be found in him, not having a righteousness of my own that comes from the law, but that which is through faith in Christ—the righteousness that comes from God on the basis of faith. I want to know Christ—yes, to know the power of his resurrection and participation in his sufferings, becoming like him in his death, and so, somehow, attaining to the resurrection from the dead. (Phil. 3:4–11)

Before he met Christ, Saul was clearly consumed with attempts to earn salvation through law keeping, which he later called "legalistic righteousness." But after he met Christ, Paul was transformed, in utter awe of Christ's surpassing righteousness, so unlike his attempted self-righteousness, which was only rubbish by comparison. To be in Christ was the joy of his life, bringing death to self, and Christ's resurrection power within, so he experienced Christ's offer: "If you love me, keep my commands" (John 14:15), for saints "keep his commands and remain faithful to Jesus" (Rev. 14:12b). What a difference Christ had made in his life! Paul no longer attempted to earn salvation through law keeping, but *in utter gratitude for salvation received it, was a delight for him to be filled with Christ's love, reveling in a relationship with Him*, so he could testify to others that "it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure" (Phil. 2:13, ESV); and "I can do all this through him [Christ] who gives me strength" (Phil. 4:13). Salvation doesn't set one free from the law any more than it sets one free from the Lawgiver Jesus Christ. Salvation sets us free from

sin to experience Christ's gift of grace—"the perfect law that gives freedom" (Jas. 1:25). The wise man said, "Fear [reverence] God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of mankind" (Eccles. 12:13b).

Paul is an example of salvation, the transforming power of God in the lives of humans. Ever since the cosmic controversy began in heaven and spread to planet earth, there has been a blight of selfishness that grips every human from birth. The plan of salvation sets sinners free from the shackles of sin, free to live a life in relationship with God. The restoration of this world to its pre-Fall state is part of the cosmic plan to rid the universe of the presence of sin and sinners, so that the work of God and angels in heaven will no longer be occupied with the cosmic controversy and the need to save humans.

After Paul met Christ, he knew that Christ is our salvation. Paul explained it this way:

> Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come: The old has gone, the new is here! All this is from God, who reconciled us to himself through Christ and gave us the ministry of reconciliation: that God was reconciling the world to himself in Christ, not counting people's sins against them.... God made him who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God. (2 Cor. 5:17–19, 21)

God's reconciling work was done in Christ, and the reconciled are in Christ (Rom. 5:10–11; 2 Cor. 5:17–21; John 15:3–4). It takes both to produce a "new creation" (2 Cor. 5:17), and a new creation is another way of speaking about salvation. Note that salvation is through Christ, not through a church or human works. Claiming that there is no salvation except through the church is as wrong as saying there is no salvation without earning it, for both of them replace Christ as the only means of salvation. The good news is that "'He [Christ] himself bore our sins' in his body on the cross, so that we might die to sins and live for righteousness; 'by his wounds you have been healed'" (1 Pet. 2:24). The internal salvific work in Christians produces the fruit of the Spirit (Gal. 5:22–23), which is "Christ in you, the hope of glory" (1 Cor. 1:27).

Reconciliation is freedom from the slavery of sin, freedom to love God, demonstrated by freely and willingly obeying His law (John 14:15), not to earn salvation but in grateful response to salvation received. John wrote about God's law in the context of God's great love that He has "lavished on us" (1 John 3:1). He says, "Everyone who sins breaks the law; in fact, sin is lawlessness" (1 John 3:4); adding that, "No one who lives in him [Christ] keeps on sinning" for "the one who does what is sinful is of the devil" (1 John 3:6a, 8a). So it is clear that a love-relationship with Christ is not grace without law, but grace and law living in harmony.

The devil is the chief lawbreaker, the leader in the cosmic controversy rebellion against God's rule, and hence against God's law as the basis of His rule. Satan invented sin, which is law breaking born of a broken relationship. Law should never be seen as incompatible with grace, except if law is foolishly used to attempt to earn salvation. The greatest act of grace took place at Calvary, where Christ died for all sin, and hence for all law breaking. "The reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the devil's work. No one who is born of God will continue to sin, because God's seed remains in them" (1 John 3:8b–9a). What a promise!

John said, "My dear children, I write this to you so that you will not sin. But if anybody does sin, we have an advocate with the Father—Jesus Christ, the Righteous One. He is the atoning sacrifice for our sins, and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world" (1 John 2:1–2). Paul wrote, "We know that the law is good if one uses it properly" (1 Tim. 1:8). It is improper to use law as a means of earning salvation, "for if righteousness could be gained through the law, Christ died for nothing!" (Gal. 2:21). "[T]rying to be justified by law" is improper for this means those lawkeepers "have been alienated from Christ...have fallen away from grace" (Gal. 5:4). "The only thing that counts is faith expressing itself through love" (Gal. 5:6b). James knew this when he said, "a person is considered righteous by what they do and not by faith alone...for faith without deeds is dead" (Jas. 2:24–26). Deeds of love are what Paul speaks about in first Corinthians 13, where he defines love (vv. 4–7) as fully compatible with God's law of love as defined by Christ (Matt. 22:37–40).

Christ said, "Be perfect, therefore, as your heavenly Father is perfect" (Matt. 5:48). Some may say, "That's impossible!" But the context is good news.

> You have heard that it was said, "Love your neighbor and hate your enemy." But I tell you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you, that you may be children of your Father in heaven. He causes his sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous. If you love those who love you, what reward will you get? Are not even the tax collectors doing that? And if you greet only your own people, what are you doing more than others? Do not even pagans do that? (Matt. 5:43–47)

This passage identifies God's perfection with His impartial way of dealing with all humans. Here is further biblical evidence that God does not show favoritism by electing a few and reprobating the rest. Conditionality is found throughout Scripture, which again is opposite of the unconditionality of predestinarian theology. The passage above shows that God is impartial in His love of all humans, good and bad, and hence their different destinies rest in their free choice to love or not love God in return. Perfection for God's followers filled by God's

presence is meant to show the same kind of impartiality. Scripture says, "If you really keep the royal law found in Scripture, 'Love your neighbor as yourself' [Lev. 19:18], you are doing right. But if you show favoritism, you sin and are convicted by the law as lawbreakers" (Jas. 2:8–9).

There are other matters that cause fear in the minds and hearts of sincere people. Again, our focus is everything. To focus on our sins only brings sorrow and loss of joy. It sometimes pushes people to work harder to earn forgiveness, as Martin Luther did, heaping flagellations upon himself until he almost died. Others try hard to gain God's favor by multiplying works without His help. Christ invites such persons to embrace His love: "Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For my yoke is easy and my burden is light" (Matt. 11:28–30). This yoke is shared between Christ and the one who comes to Him. Because of Christ's affirming love, the yoke (including law keeping) is light and brings rest. Christianity is not a lawless experience, nor is it legalism; rather, it is a relationship that transcends mere rules.

Christ says, "If you remain in me and I in you, you will bear much fruit; apart from me you can do nothing" (John 15:5). Christ further promises, "If you remain in me and my words remain in you, ask whatever you wish, and it will be done for you.... As the Father has loved me, so have I loved you. Now remain in my love. If you keep my commands, you will remain in my love, just as I have obeyed my Father's commands and remain in his love" (John 15:7–10). Notice how the awesome love of God is the context for speaking about the law. No wonder law keeping is a love response to the Lawgiver. Jesus has said, "If you love me, keep my commands" (John 14:15), which means, "If you don't love me, it's an utter waste of time trying to keep My law. For I'm not interested in rules but in relationship."

True law keeping is as relational as the relational Lawgiver. James said, "[H]umbly accept the word planted in you, which can save you" (1:21b). There is power in God's written Word. The Psalmist said, "I have hidden your word in my heart that I might not sin against you" (Ps. 119:11), for "[t]he unfolding of your words gives light; it gives understanding to the simple" (Ps. 119:130). God said to Israel, "Fix these words of mine in your hearts and minds" (Deut. 11:18a). Paul said, "Let the message of Christ dwell among you richly as you teach and admonish one another with all wisdom through psalms, hymns, and songs from the Spirit, singing to God with gratitude in your hearts" (Col. 3:16).

The law cannot save any more than looking into a mirror can change one's appearance. The law is like a mirror—it reveals one's true condition. So does Scripture. James says:

> Do not merely listen to the word, and so deceive yourselves. Do what it says. Anyone who listens to the word but does not do what it says is like someone who looks at his face in a mirror and, after looking at himself, goes away and immediately forgets what he looks like. But whoever looks intently into the perfect law that gives freedom, and continues in it—not forgetting what they have heard, but doing it—they will be blessed in what they do. (Jas. 1:22–25)

Scripture is God's self-revelation, and the author Holy Spirit uses His Word effectively to save humans. In the Spirit's work Scripture is alive, dynamic, and gets results. The writer of Hebrews says, "For the word of God is alive and active. Sharper than any double-edged sword, it penetrates even to dividing soul and spirit, joints and marrow; it judges the thoughts and attitudes of the heart" (Heb. 4:12). In commenting on the Word in this text, F. F. Bruce says, "it diagnoses the condition of the human heart, saying, 'Thou ailest here, and here'; it brings blessing to those who receive it in faith and pronounces judgement on those who disregard it."[7]

Peter declares, "Salvation is found in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given to mankind by which we must be saved" (Acts 4:12). And Jesus says, "I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me" (John 14:6). Paul assures us that "there is one God and one mediator between God and mankind, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a ransom for all people" (1 Tim. 2:5–6a).

COSMIC DIMENSION OF SALVATION

Scripture attests that God is consistently the same: "I the LORD do not change" (Mal. 3:6a), and "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8). In looking at God in the Old and New Testaments, we find this to be true. There is only one plan of salvation and one gospel, because there is only one unchanging relational Trinity. God loves the world (John 3:16), whether we are speaking of Old or New Testament times.

There is universal agreement that salvation is for humans—but there is debate as to whether salvation is for all humans, or for the elect only (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapters 15 and 16). The question before us is whether salvation benefits more than just humans. We know that there are unfallen angels. The fallen angels were once their companions, but they rebelled

7. F. F. Bruce, *The Epistle to the Hebrews*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1990), 111.

against God. So God has two kinds of humans and two kinds of angels, those loyal and those disloyal. Salvation and its benefits need to be understood within the cosmic controversy context. The unfallen angels must have been in awe of their Creator, the Son of God, becoming also human, living in a sin-filled world, and dying for sinners. Calvary was the greatest revelation of God's love that they had ever witnessed. If this is so, then salvation impacted them as well.

From the above summary of salvation in the Old and New Testaments, it is clear that Satan and his rebellion against God and His law is the context in which to think through all that is involved in salvation—and to see that it is more than redemption of humans, for it extends beyond our planet to the universe, restoring the entire cosmos to pre-Fall status. Considering that an on-looking universe is involved and a resolution of the cosmic controversy is required, it is evident that we need a more expansive worldview than is usually understood with respect to salvation.

The Hubble telescope has already opened up the vastness of space, and there is so much more to be discovered. We have hardly reached the surface of the immense depths of outer space. Given all this immensity created by a God of love, is it feasible that there are multitudes of inhabited planets that are also loyal to God? At least Scripture, and some commentators, indicate there is more than one inhabited world throughout the vastness of space. It seems reasonable that a God of love would create many worlds.[8] I submit that the plan of salvation affects the entire cosmos, and invite you to ponder this. The Trinity knew that freedom given to created beings would result in its wrong use, and rebellion would enter the cosmos. God also knew that it was better to allow rebellion to occur than to create beings as mere robots, unable to image the freedom enjoyed by the Persons of the Trinity. More than anything else, God prizes the free choice of created beings so that they can enter into a meaningful relationship with Him that reflects the relationship among the Persons of the Trinity.

8. Although there is no biblical statement about God's creating other worlds, it does say in Hebrews 1:2 that Christ created (*tous aiōnas*), translated "worlds" in the King James Version and the New King James Version, and "universe" in Philips and the New International Version. The English word "universe" translates two other Greek words, *ta panta* "all things" (Col. 1:16) and *tō kosmō* "the cosmos" (1 Cor. 4:9), but the context in both texts limits the universe to heaven (angels) and earth (humans). There are at least one hundred twenty-five billion galaxies, each one containing billions of stars. Because God is love, we can imagine that He created vast numbers of persons on different planets, and also quarantined our world at a distance from the rest, knowing that we would sin. Hilary of Poitiers says, "He who upholds the universe," *The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series 9:59 (2.25); interpreted as "worlds" in the same book, lxix; and the Chalcedon Creed (381) added to the Nicene Creed (325) reads: "And in one Lord JESUS CHRIST, the *only-begotten* Son of God, begotten of the Father *before all worlds*," Philip Schaff, *Ante-Nicene Christianity, AD 100–325*, vol. 2 in *History of the Christian Church* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1962, 1st ed. 1910), 537. Scripture is written for humans, and so heaven and earth are the major focus in the Bible. This doesn't rule out the existence of other inhabited planets, but it doesn't prove their existence either.

Without free choice, there is no possibility of a genuine relationship. (That is why "irresistible grace" is foreign to a relational Trinity.)

This is counter to the dominant view of Calvinism, which holds that God chooses a few elect, and rejects the rest. It goes against the ideas that fallen humans are totally depraved (in the Augustinian sense of original sin—all humans were present in the loins of Adam and therefore share responsibility in his sin). This denies the freedom of choice, and hence an absolute sovereign decree to save some is necessary, confining God's love to a limited atonement and irresistible grace. Because of the cosmic controversy over the love and justice of God, the popular worldview of predestination is not only inadequate to present the magnitude of salvation, but also aids Satan in his questioning of God. Prior to the creation of Lucifer, God knew of his rebellion and that a third of the angels would join him (Rev. 12:3–4, 9). They rebelled in the presence of God, who had given them life and all the blessings they enjoyed. They knew God's love in a face-to-face communion that made their rebellion inexplicable. Satan said in his heart: "I will ascend to the heavens; I will raise my throne above the stars of God; I will sit enthroned on the mount of assembly.... I will ascend above the tops of the clouds; I will make myself like the Most High" (Isa. 14:13–14). What arrogant pride, to think that he could become as God and sit on His throne. No wonder God said of Satan: "Your heart became proud on account of your beauty, and you corrupted your wisdom because of your splendor" (Ezek. 28:17).

Satan's pride blinded him to his utter folly. Eventually "war broke out in heaven" and the fallen angels "lost their place in heaven" (Rev. 12:7–8). At the end of the Millennium, Satan will "deceive the nations...to gather them for battle. In number they are like the sand of the seashore." They will "[surround] the camp of God's people" (Rev. 20:7–9). They evidently think they will be able to take the city. This clearly indicates that the battle begun in heaven continues unabated throughout human history, for Satan and his angels are not interested in submitting. They war against God in order to take His place. Pride doesn't sense any need for salvation; it is bent on rebellion alone.

Rebellion against God is a rejection of God's law, the basis of His rule. Salvation is never freedom from God's law; rather, it is freedom, through repentance, from the penalty of law breaking, and it is power, through communion with God, to be loyal to Him. Salvation is freedom, made possible through Christ Jesus, from the penalty and power of sin. Christ sums up the principles of the Ten Commandments as love of God and love of our fellow beings (Matt. 22:37–40). No wonder Christ has not come to destroy the law (Matt. 5:17), and Paul tells us that "he who loves another has fulfilled the law" (Rom. 13:8, NKJV; cf. Gal. 5:14). Hence, the first four commandments have to do

with love of God, the last six commandments relate to the love we are to bear others. John adds,

> By this we know that we love the children of God, when we love God and keep His commandments. For this is the love of God, that we keep His commandments. And His commandments are not burdensome. For whatever is born of God overcomes the world. And this is the victory that has overcome the world—our faith. Who is he who overcomes the world, but he who believes that Jesus is the Son of God? (1 John 5:2–5, NKJV)

The law is a transcript of God's character, for each member of the Trinity loves God and in so doing loves their fellow beings. Calvary is the greatest revelation of God's character. Hanging on the cross, Christ loved God and loved His fellow beings in the Trinity, and they reciprocated that love as they had done from eternity. Sin is law breaking (1 John 3:4), and Christ died for all sin, and in so doing upheld God's law. Christians who claim that the Cross does away with the law unwittingly question God's wisdom. If the law can be done away with, then it should have been abolished long ago so that Christ need not have died to pay the penalty of a broken law. Furthermore, if the law could be done away, then Satan cannot be criticized for wanting to do away with God's law.

Prior to Adam and Eve's creation, God knew they would join the rebellion. He knew that most humans would not want salvation, yet salvation was provided for all, and is accepted by those who so choose. Calvary was the foundational event in salvation's plan. The Trinity knew sin would cost them everything, and they were willing to pay the price for two reasons: (1) to save all who would accept their gift, and (2) to secure the loyalty of created beings for eternity, so rebellion will never arise again (Rev. 21:1–5a; 22:1–5).

Unfallen created beings have seen what sin does to the human race, and what God did for the human race. God met selfish pride (Ezek. 14:12–14) with selfless humility (Phil. 2:5–8). While Satan wanted to take God's place, God took the place of fallen humans in life and death. What a stark contrast! While Satan coveted God's cosmic rule, Christ left His throne for the cross. Furthermore, Christ's death at Calvary allows "whoever believes in him" to "not perish but have eternal life" (John 3:16). Salvation is not determined but offered, not an arbitrary choice in eternity but free choice in human history. The freedom to choose the Savior in human history is just as available today as it was before the fall (Gen. 3:1–6). This is a long way from God's choosing for humans in a hidden eternal predestination.

Created beings are given the power of choice, and that power of choice is vital for the future security of the cosmos. For unfallen and redeemed created beings will forever see in the Cross the justice and love of God that exposed the horror of rebellion, and they will choose to remain loyal to God forever. God helps people

to choose the right when it is their desire to do so. A saving experience is never accomplished alone; it happens in relationship with the relational Trinity.

The plan of salvation was not merely to deal with sin but also to secure the cosmos from any future rebellion. It follows that the Cross must be seen by created beings as utterly fair—as God's undeserved death to save all undeserving rebels. Anything less than this would rob the Cross of its power to secure the cosmos in eternity to come (John 12:31–32). Both the redeemed and unfallen created intelligent beings will forever remain loyal to God, and will testify, "Christ's love [on the cross] compels us, because we are convinced that one died for all" (2 Cor. 5:14). Christ's universal sacrifice on the Cross fully explodes the theory of unconditional predestination of the elect few and eternal reprobation of the rest. God's partiality for a few, and eternal burning for the rest, could never draw humans to love God and freely choose to remain loyal to Him.

PLAN PRECEDES CREATION

God did not arbitrarily choose to save only the elect in eternity; instead He chose to save all humans who would accept the plan of salvation decided from eternity (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 8). Ponder the following texts, for in them we find that God had the best interests of created beings in mind when He gave them freedom of choice, and then He paid the full price for the wrong use of that freedom. In so doing He secured forever the continuance of that freedom in a way that would keep it from ever being used wrongly again.

> Praise be to the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us in the heavenly realms with every spiritual blessing in Christ. For he chose us in him before the creation of the world to be holy and blameless in his sight. In love he predestined us for adoption to sonship through Jesus Christ, in accordance with his pleasure and will—to the praise of his glorious grace, which he has freely given us in the One he loves. In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, in accordance with the riches of God's grace that he lavished on us. With all wisdom and understanding, he made known to us the mystery of his will according to his good pleasure, which he purposed in Christ, to be put into effect when the times reach their fulfillment—to bring unity to all things in heaven and on earth under Christ. (Eph. 1:3–10)

> We do, however, speak a message of wisdom among the mature, but not the wisdom of this age or of the rulers of this age, who are coming to nothing. No, we declare God's wisdom, a mystery that has been hidden and that God destined for our glory before time began. None of the rulers of this age understood it, for if they had, they would not have crucified the Lord of glory. However, as it is written: "What no eye has seen, and no ear has heard, and what no human mind has

conceived"—the things God has prepared for those who love him—these are the things God has revealed to us by his Spirit. (1 Cor. 2:6–10)

The Son is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn over all creation. For in him all things were created: things in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or powers or rulers or authorities; all things have been created through him and for him. He is before all things, and in him all things hold together. And he is the head of the body, the church; he is the beginning and the firstborn from among the dead, so that in everything he might have the supremacy. For God was pleased to have all his fullness dwell in him, and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether things on earth or things in heaven, by making peace through his blood, shed on the cross. (Col. 1:15–20)

So do not be ashamed of the testimony about our Lord or of me his prisoner. Rather, join with me in suffering for the gospel, by the power of God. He has saved us and called us to a holy life—not because of anything we have done but because of his own purpose and grace. This grace was given us in Christ Jesus before the beginning of time, but it has now been revealed through the appearing of our Savior, Christ Jesus, who has destroyed death and has brought life and immortality to light through the gospel. (2 Tim. 1:8–10)

For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life. (John 3:16)

PLAN REACHES INTO THE COMING AGES

Calvary is the climax of all history, and will preserve all intelligent beings, saved and unfallen, to freely be loyal to God. For Calvary reveals the inner history of the divine eternal reciprocal love of the Trinity, that Christ was willing to leave the face-to-face fellowship of that eternal love and enter human history as a dependent human, relying upon the Father and Spirit to succeed in His salvation mission, and enduring the anguish of Calvary which wrenched the hearts of the Father and Spirit as well.

Not only was each member of the Trinity involved in Christ's death, but angels also must have been hovering near the earth, amazed at His sacrifice. After Christ ascended to heaven and was inaugurated into His saving ministry in heaven's sanctuary, John says: "I looked and heard the voice of many angels, numbering thousands upon thousands, and ten thousand times ten thousand. They encircled the throne and the living creatures and the elders. In a loud voice they were saying: 'Worthy is the Lamb, who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and strength and honor and glory and praise!'" (Rev. 5:12). Then John tells us: "I heard every creature in heaven and on earth and under

the earth and on the sea, and all that is in them, saying: 'To him who sits on the throne and to the Lamb praise and honor and glory and power, for ever and ever!'" (Rev. 5:13).

All sing praise to the Lamb forever, for His gift of utter grace at Calvary. Paul adds: "And God raised us up with Christ and seated us with him in the heavenly realms in Christ Jesus, in order that in the coming ages he might show the incomparable riches of his grace, expressed in his kindness to us in Christ Jesus" (Eph. 2:6–7). It seems that in the coming ages Christ will reveal the incomparable riches of His grace through: (1) an ever-deepening understanding of His sacrifice and through (2) the redeemed manifesting the riches of Christ's imparted grace. For the redeemed will show to all created beings the extent of Christ's salvation in their lives as they praise Christ for what His sacrifice has done for them.

Conclusion

There is one single gospel throughout the Old and New Testament periods because God does not change (Mal. 3:6), and "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8). The unchanging God is love (1 John 4:8–16), which is abundantly revealed in the Old and New Testaments.

Christ came to planet earth to reveal what God is like (John 14:9), and thus to counter the counterfeit satanic misrepresentation of God. The ultimate revelation of God took place on the cross where Christ died for human sin, for human law breaking. The Cross reveals the awesome depths of God's love for all—both humans and other intelligent beings such as angels—to see. The Cross has a cosmic impact far beyond the salvation of humans, although that is a very important part of what took place there. The Cross is a unique event that has no rivals, and forever repudiates the lies about God promulgated by the cosmic controversy against Him. The Cross is not a simple event; in fact, it is humanly unfathomable. No wonder Christ's death has influenced many theories of the atonement, which we take up in the next chapter.

Study Questions

1. How does the Old Testament demonstrate that there is only one gospel?
2. Because sin is law breaking, what does salvation involve?
3. How does Calvary reveal that the law is inseparable from the gospel?
4. Why is freedom of choice so important, and how does it guarantee that rebellion will never arise again in the eternal future?

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Atonement Theories

Purpose

1. Show why there are so many atonement theories.
2. Present the two major theories.
3. Appreciate what happened at the Cross.

Summary

Just as a rainbow is made up of several colors (red, orange, yellow, green, blue, indigo, violet), so God's atonement is made up of many perspectives. Just as one color of the rainbow is inadequate to describe the rainbow, so one theory of the atonement is inadequate to describe fully the atonement. There are many atonement theories, biblical images of atonement, and attributes of God. Sometimes an atonement theory is linked to one attribute of God. We would not do justice to God by describing Him as only omnipresent, omniscient, or omnipotent, because He has all these attributes, and far more besides. The fact is, all existing atonement theories combined still fail to portray all that is involved in God's atonement.

The atonement is about an awesome God, a relational Trinity, who devised a plan that was so costly that it will take eternity to understand the enormity of that cost. Salvation will be the science and song of the redeemed throughout eternity as ever broader and deeper comprehension of salvation unfolds to the wonderment and adoration of the redeemed and unfallen beings alike.

Throughout this revelation it will be seen that God's nature as love is foundational to an understanding of God, His attributes, and atonement theories. As H. O. Wiley rightly notes, "The tendency to exalt one attribute above another, has been the source of much error in theology"[1] (see chart in Appendix C).

In Appendix E, I propose that we need to add the cosmic effect of Christ's death, since His sacrifice was not only for humans but also for the cosmos—to keep created beings from another cosmic controversy. I call it the *substitutionary and cosmic view of the atonement.*

Outline

I. Introduction
II. Biblical Balance
- A. Propitiation
- B. Redemption
- C. Justification
- D. Reconciliation

III. Different Perspectives
- A. Recapitulation
- B. Incarnation
- C. Salvation as Completion of Creation

IV. Ransom Theory
V. Moral Influence Theory
- A. Forgiveness
- B. Revelation
- C. Does Forgiveness Require Christ's Death?
- D. Problems of Lawlessness
- E. God's Attributes: Justice and Mercy
- F. The Cross as an Example

VI. Substitutionary Theory
- A. God's Self-Sacrifice
- B. Meaning of *Substitutionary*

VII. Corporate Atonement
VIII. Calvary Atonement
IX. Did God Have Other Options?
- A. Cross Centered
- B. We Crucified Christ
- C. Cosmic Controversy Worldview

1. H. O. Wiley, *Christian Theology* (Kansas City, MO: Beacon Hill Press, 1958–1959), 2:285.

X. Conclusion
XI. Study Questions
XII. Appendices
- A. Appendix A: Brief History of Some Atonement Theories
  1. Church Fathers
  2. Middle Ages
  3. Reformers
  4. Nineteenth Century
  5. Twentieth Century
- B. Appendix B: Theories of Atonement in Light of God's Holiness and Human Sin
- C. Appendix C: Theories of the Atonement in Light of God's Attributes
- D. Appendix D: Nonviolent View of the Atonement
- E. Appendix E: My Proposal—The Substitutionary and Cosmic Atonement View

Introduction

Our understanding of the atonement impacts the rest of our theology, for the atonement is the very heart of theology. It is the center around which all other theological truths orbit. Atonement studies God, humans, sin, Christ, and salvation. It involves the reason Christ became human, lived a human life, and died. Did He do so out of a necessity in God? Leon Morris warns, "The atonement is the crucial doctrine of the faith. Unless we are right here it matters little, or so it seems to me, what we are like elsewhere."[2] Theologians have battled for theoretical victories while too often losing out experientially. They have argued for a theory of atonement while the "at-one-ment" between them lay in shreds. In fact, every leading atonement theory has been taken to an extreme. Some proponents have been carried away by their own logic.

While this topic can be complex, I will attempt to present it in a simple way. This will necessitate relegating some data to the appendices, in order to aid in the flow of the topic in the text. But as we do, we must never lose the sense of majesty and mystery involved. God cannot be encapsulated in neat formulas, nor His actions reduced to mere human terms. As well, we should not read our attitudes, purposes, and methods into God's.[3] As H. R. Mackintosh reminds us, "The wise man will look with suspicion on theories of

2. Leon Morris, *The Cross in the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1965), 5.
3. H. A. Hodges, *The Pattern of Atonement* (London: SCM Press, 1955), 12.

atonement which are only too complete.... If atonement be the act of God, it has in it the unfathomable quality of God Himself."[4]

Biblical Balance

By nature, God is love (1 John 4:8–16), which means that the sum total of His attributes and not merely one or a few of them, reveal Him as a God of love. I suggest that "holy love" is a more balanced way to look at God's nature during the time of the cosmic controversy, even though prior to and after the controversy God's nature is love (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 2). Scripture is balanced in presenting different attributes together. Consider some of the couplets found in Scripture that indicate the breadth among the attributes of God:

Compassion and punishment	Exodus 34:6–7
Love and faithfulness	Psalm 85:10
Righteousness and peace	Psalm 85:10
Righteousness and a Savior	Isaiah 45:21
Anger and mercy	Micah 7:16
Wrath and mercy	Habakkuk 3:2
Grace and truth	John 1:14
Justice and forbearance	Romans 3:26
Kindness and sternness	Romans 11:22
Faithfulness and justice	1 John 1:9

It is the same God who gives eternal life who judges rebels. God acts to meet different circumstances in human history, but does not change (Mal. 3:6) in doing so. Even in judgments we behold the "wrath of the Lamb" (Rev. 6:16b), for "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8). Wherever God's attributes seem to be opposites, never should they be considered as operating either/or, for they act together. It is through them that God acts.

In Scripture atonement is looked at from a variety of perspectives that are complementary. In the same way that the four Gospels witness to the same Jesus Christ but have their own emphases, the Bible offers many ways of looking at the atonement, with different writers making their own contribution. Indeed, a single author can write about the atonement from numerous viewpoints.

4. H. R. Mackintosh, *Christian Experience of Forgiveness* (London: Nisbet and Co., 1934), 195.

The variety of human images used to express the divine truth of atonement gives insight into the depths involved and should caution us against any simplistic conclusion. Because Scripture uses many images, each one expresses a dimension of the atonement that would be lost if it were not included.

We will now look at some of these images. We will consider four word images: propitiation, redemption, justification, and reconciliation. These four words come from four different vocabularies as summarized below, and they are all found in one passage from Paul.

> for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and all are *justified* freely by his grace through the *redemption* that came by Christ Jesus. God presented Christ as *a sacrifice of atonement*, through the shedding of his blood—to be received by faith. He did this to demonstrate his righteousness, because in his forbearance he had left the sins committed beforehand unpunished—he did it to demonstrate his righteousness at the present time, so as to be just and the one who justifies those who have faith in Jesus. (Rom. 3:23–26)

Word	**Language Context**	**Meaning**
Propitiation	Temple	Appeasement
Redemption	Commerce	Ransom
Justification	Law	Restored Status
Reconciliation	Home	Restored Relationship

PROPITIATION

These three verses employ four images of atonement (italicized words) and remind us that it is insufficient to focus on one image to the exclusion of the others. All are equally inspired, relevant, and authentic. Central to the debate over propitiation is this question: Who is the object of the propitiation, God or humans? If Jesus died to appease the wrath of God, was His doing so any different from the pagan sacrifices made to mollify angry gods? Greek words translated "propitiation" include *hilasmos*, a noun (1 John 2:2; 4:10); *hilastērion*, also a noun (Rom. 3:25); and *hilaskomai*, a verb (Luke 8:13; Heb. 2:17).

The major contenders in this debate have been C. H. Dodd and Leon Morris. In 1931 Dodd presented his classic study on the use of *hilasmos*, in which he concluded that the word should not be understood as "propitiation" but as "expiation," meaning that God provided the atonement rather than was appeased by it.[5] But in 1951 Leon Morris called Dodd's findings into question, concluding that

5. "The common rendering 'propitiation' is illegitimate here as elsewhere," C. H. Dodd, "'Hilaskesthai' Its Cognates, Derivatives, and Synonyms, in the Septuagint," *Journal of Theological Studies*, 32 (1931): 360.

hilasmos does mean "propitiation."[6] Scholars subsequently sided with one or the other.[7] James Dunn believes that the debate constituted "an unnecessary polarizing of alternatives."[8] F. Biichsel offers a mediating interpretation, namely, that "*hilasmos*...is the action in which God is propitiated and sin expiated."[9]

Hilastērion occurs twenty-one times in the Greek version of the Old Testament (the Septuagint, or LXX)—in Exodus, Leviticus, and Numbers. *Kappōret*, the Hebrew word sometimes translated by the Greek *hilastērion*, is used when speaking of the mercy seat as the place of propitiation. *'ăzārâ* is used of the rim around the altar of burnt offering (Ezek. 43:14, 17, 20). The important fact is that both the mercy seat and the altar were provided by God. Therefore, propitiation is not humankind's appeasement of God but God's provision for humankind to participate in God's self-propitiation. "God 'did set forth for himself' (middle voice) Christ Jesus" (Rom. 3:25).[10] D. A. S. Ravens is right when he asserts that Christ's "death in no way changed the nature or the attitude of God, as some theories of the atonement seem to imply."[11] God's love is the cause, not the consequence, of the atonement.[12] "God presented him as a sacrifice of atonement" (Rom. 3:25). God offered the sacrifice rather than being merely its recipient (see John 3:16). Christ's death was His self-offering. He was priest and victim at Calvary.

REDEMPTION

Jesus said, "The Son of man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many" (Matt. 20:28). The Greek word *lutron*, here translated "ransom," is used, along with its cognates, nearly one hundred forty times in the Septuagint, "usually with the thought of deliverance from some sort of bondage in exchange for the payment of compensation or the offering of a substitute."[13]

6. Leon Morris, "The use of *Hilaskesthai*, etc., in Biblical Greek," *Expository Times*, 62 (1951): 227–233.

7. For example, Nicole sided with Morris; see R. R. Nicole, "C. H. Dodd and the Doctrine of Propitiation," *Westminster Theological Journal*, 17/2 (1955): 117–157. Vincent Taylor supported Dodd; see Runia, "Doctrine of the Atonement," 45–56. cf. Norman H. Young, "C. H. Dodd, '*Hilaskesthai*' and His Critics," *Evangelical Quarterly*, 48 (April–June 1976): 67–78; and Norman H. Young, "'*Hilaskesthai*' and Related Words in the New Testament," *Evangelical Quarterly*, 55 (July 1983): 169–176.

8. James D. G. Dunn, *Romans*, vol. 38a in *Word Biblical Commentary* (Dallas, TX: Word, 1988), 171.

9. F. Büchsel, "*hilaskomai, hilasmos*," in Gerhard Kittel et al., *Theological Dictionary of the New Testament*, (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1985), 3:317.

10. R. C. H. Lenski, *The Interpretation of St. Paul's Epistle to the Romans* (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg, 1961), 255.

11. D. A. S. Ravens, "St. Luke and Atonement," *Expository Times*, 97/10 (1986): 294.

12. F. F. Bruce, *Romans*, vol. 6 in *Tyndale New Testament Commentaries* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1985), 100; John Murray, *Romans*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1982), 117–118; Lenski, *The Interpretation of St. Paul's Epistle to the Romans*, 254.

13. Millard K. Erickson, *Christian Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1986), 807.

JUSTIFICATION

All "are justified freely by his grace through the redemption that came by Christ Jesus" (Rom. 3:24). "We have now been justified by his blood" (Rom. 5:9). In these verses the death of Christ is presented as having put humankind in a proper relationship to God's broken law. Christ "was delivered over to death for our sins and was raised to life for our justification" (Rom. 4:25). This verse indicates that the resurrected ministry of Christ in the heavenly sanctuary also contributes to justification.

RECONCILIATION

Sinners have been made one with the Savior: "Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come: The old has gone, the new is here! All this is from God, who reconciled us to himself through Christ" (2 Cor. 5:17–18). Jews and Gentiles have been made one in Christ, who abolished "in his flesh the law with its commands and regulations. His purpose was to create in himself one new humanity out of the two, thus making peace, and in one body to reconcile both of them to God through the cross, by which he put to death their hostility" (Eph. 2:15–16). In these passages the Cross is presented as having restored the proper relationship of humans to God and humans to fellow humans.

Different Perspectives

The biblical view of the atonement includes the incarnation, life, and death of Christ, and His present ministry in heaven's sanctuary, which embraces the final judgment and the eradication of sin and sinners. Theologians have focused on less than the complete biblical presentation of salvation; this has often led to an imbalance, and at times even allowed error to be presented. We will first consider false perspectives: (1) Recapitulation and (2) Salvation located in Christ's birth (Incarnation).

RECAPITULATION

The recapitulation theory of Irenaeus (ca. 130–200) seems to be the first example of considering creation as the prerequisite for the Incarnation. Irenaeus, in his *Against Heresies*, declares, "His [the Creator's] hands formed a living man, in order that Adam might be created [again] after the image and likeness of God."[14] In this context, note the importance of the Incarnation. It seems that the union of

14. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies*, *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, eds. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1989), 1:527 (5.1.2). The bracketed word "[again]" was in the original quotation while "[the Creator's]" has been added here.

the corruptible humanity with the incorruptible divinity in Jesus Christ was the means of partaking of that incorruptibility, a view that we come to in the next segment on the Incarnation.

> And unless man had been joined to God, he could never have become a partaker of incorruptibility. For it was incumbent upon the Mediator between God and men, by His relationship to both, to bring both to friendship and concord, and present man to God, while He revealed God to man.... Wherefore also He passed through every stage of life, restoring to all communion with God.... For as by the disobedience of the one man who was originally moulded from virgin soil, the many were made sinners, and forfeited life; so was it necessary that, by obedience of one man, who was originally born from a virgin, many should be justified and receive salvation.... God recapitulated in Himself the ancient formation of man, that He might kill sin, deprive death of its power, and vivify man; and therefore His works are true.[15]

Recapitulation means that the second Adam (Jesus Christ), in taking human nature, recapitulated the original creation of Adam on the sixth day, and did so on crucifixion Friday.

> For by summing up in Himself the whole human race from the beginning to the end, He has also summed up its death. From this it is clear that the Lord suffered death in obedience to His Father, upon that day on which Adam died while he disobeyed God. Now he died on the same day in which he did eat. For God said, "In that day on which ye shall eat of it, ye shall die by death." The Lord, therefore, recapitulating in Himself this day, undetwent His sufferings upon the day preceding the Sabbath, that is, the sixth day of the creation, on which day man was created; thus granting him a second creation by means of His passion, which is that [creation] out of death.[16]

INCARNATION

We next consider Christ's birth. There are theologians who believe the Incarnation, or incarnational life of Jesus Christ, is the location where objective salvation took place. This view holds that salvation was achieved through an inner history shared by the divine and human natures of the God-Man, and it has been expressed in a variety of ways. It was believed that Christ assumed fallen nature in the Incarnation, in order that this fallen human nature may be changed by the indwelling divine nature of Christ. While in the body of Mary, "He sanctified the body."[17] "He was made man that we might be made God."[18] This means that the sinful nature of humans was

15. Ibid., 1:448 (3.18.7).
16. Ibid., 1:552 (3.23.2).
17. Athanasius, *De Incarnatione Verbi Dei, Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, eds., Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1987), 4:45 (17.5).
18. Ibid., 4:65 (54.3).

assumed by Christ in His incarnation, otherwise human nature could not be redeemed. In short, the unassumed is unredeemed. In other words, the redemption process was within Jesus Christ, between the two natures of the God-Man, the divinity transforming the fallen humanity Christ assumed. In this process, Christ was not affected by the sinful nature, but the sinful nature was affected by His divine nature, and so redemption was carried out by the divine nature of Christ.

Athanasius influenced the teachings of the Orthodox Church in the East. Eastern Orthodox theology claims that Christ took our fallen sinful human nature in order to join it to His holy, sinless, divine nature, and His divinity changed that human nature in a process that brought salvation to it (*theosis*). Christ has assumed our sinful nature and divinized it (for more on Eastern Orthodox theology, see chapter 15). This atonement is sometimes called the "mystical theory."[19]

Like Athanasius, Edward Irving (1792–1834) believed Christ took the fallen human nature in the Incarnation, which received "immortality and incorruption" through union with God and through the Holy Spirit.[20] So he taught a subjective purification, understood by some as a "charismatic Christology."[21] The purification process in Jesus Christ was completed in His death. Salvation was not through Christ's death to propitiate God, but through faith in Christ's new humanity.[22]

Friedrich Schleiermacher (1768–1834) saw Christ as the second Adam, who completed the creation begun in the first Adam[23] (like Irenaeus). The second Adam brought a "new spiritual life" because "the impartation of the Spirit to human nature which was made in the first Adam was insufficient."[24] In the incarnation, "for the first time," one moves "in the sphere of the potent God-consciousness."[25] Human nature was perfected in Christ, and only lived in a provisional form before.[26] "*In the uniting of the divine nature with the human, the divine alone was active or self-imparting, and the human alone passive or in process of being assumed; but during the state of union every activity was*

19. On the "mystical theory," see Louis Berkhof, *Systematic Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans; Cambridge: UK, 1996), 389–390.
20. Edward Irving, *The Collected Writings of Edward Irving*, ed. G. Carlyle (London, UK: Alexander Strahan, 1864), 1:604–605.
21. I. S. Rennie, "Irving, Edward" in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 2nd ed., ed. Walter A. Elwell (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2001), 617–618; cf. Graham McFarlane, "Irving, Edward" in *The Dictionary of Historical Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2000), 275–276.
22. Augustus H. Strong, *Systematic Theology* (Chicago: Judson Press, 1949), 744.
23. Friedrich Schleiermacher, *The Christian Faith* (Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1999, Ger. ed. 1830), 366–367.
24. Ibid., 389.
25. Ibid., 370.
26. Ibid., 374.

a common activity of both natures."[27] In other words, the atonement was a process of assumption which began in the Incarnation and continued throughout Christ's life.

Schleiermacher set the Bible aside,[28] and said one can "believe in Christ as Redeemer without believing in His supernatural conception,"[29] and it is "much safer" to "establish the doctrine of Christ independently of that doctrine of the Trinity."[30] This questions God's revelation. The view that the Incarnation completed the creation means that it had been incomplete. The idea that the impartation of the Spirit to human nature through Adam was insufficient questions God's wisdom and questions that He made everything "very good" (Gen. 1:31). Here is a subjective, revisionist, mystical theory of atonement through union of the two natures in Jesus Christ providing the fullness of God-consciousness.

Barth viewed creation as the external basis of the covenant,[31] and the covenant as the internal basis of creation[32] (like Irenaeus and Schleiermacher, he saw creation as prerequisite for Incarnation). So the creation of Adam was merely a means to the creation of the second Adam, Jesus Christ. For Barth the history of the covenant secretly began on creation Sabbath,[33] for on that day God came close to Adam and Eve. Speaking of humankind, Barth says, God "ordained and equipped him only for what is good" so "the transgression of man cannot be deduced from what God positively willed."[34] "God did not create them transgressors."[35] For the very act of creation was their election.[36]

> The secret, the meaning and the goal of creation is that it reveals, or that there is revealed in it, the covenant and communion between God and man, and therefore the fulfilment [sic] of being as a whole, which is so serious and far-reaching that the Word by which God created all things, even God Himself, becomes as one of His creatures, being there Himself like everything else, like all the created reality distinct from Himself, and thus making His own its twofold determination, its greatness and wretchedness, its infinite dignity and infinite frailty, its hope and its despair, its rejoicing and its sorrow. That is what has taken place in Jesus Christ as the meaning and end of creation. His humiliation and exaltation as the Son of God are the self-revelation of God the Creator.[37]

27. Ibid., 398.
28. Ibid., 362.
29. Ibid., 404.
30. Ibid., 400.
31. Karl Barth, *The Doctrine of Creation*, vol. 3, pt. 1 in *Church Dogmatics*, trans. J. W. Edwards, O. Bussy, and Harold Knight (Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1958), 94–228.
32. Ibid., 228–329.
33. Ibid., 217.
34. Ibid., 264–266.
35. Ibid., 329.
36. Ibid., 331.
37. Ibid., 377.

Salvation, for Barth, takes place in the incarnational life of Jesus Christ.[38] Salvation is not attained in the assumption of sinful human flesh in the act of Incarnation, but it begins in that act, and continues throughout the life of Jesus Christ up to His death. Salvation, therefore, is located in the inner history of the God-Man. Barth interprets this as God in Christ reconciling the world to Himself. The humanity of Jesus is not one human (*homo*) but humankind (*humanitas*). So salvation takes place in history, not in external events, but in internal change in Jesus Christ. Barth describes this as the journey into the far country as the Son of God,[39] and a concurrent homecoming of the Son of Man (like the prodigal of Luke 15).[40] Whereas Anselm (1033–1109) asked in the eleventh century why God became Man (*Cur Deus Homo*), Barth asks in the twentieth century why God has become humankind. He says,

> [God] wills this and does this in an outward activation and revelation of the whole inward riches of His deity in all its height and depth, that He wills it and does it especially that the world created by Him might have and see within it, in the Son as the image of the Father, its own original, that He wills it and does it for the sake of His own glory in the world, to confirm and proclaim His will not to be without the world, not to be a God in isolation.[41]

If the goal of creation was the Incarnation, this does disservice to both creation and Christ's incarnation. For God created humans because He loved them, and not because He needed to create them in order to become the God-Man. Nor was Christ's becoming human something which He wanted to do for His own enjoyment, but it was a great sacrifice which He entered into because of His great love for humans and His desire to save them. Any idea that creation was for the benefit of Christ's incarnation makes both creation and Incarnation self-centered, rather than great acts of God's selfless love. Besides, the creation record shows that the goal of creation was Christ's Sabbath and not His incarnation (Gen. 2:1–3), and that was a gift to the human race even before humans rebelled.

God had a far greater goal in mind than merely becoming human because He wanted to become human. He had all created beings in mind when He came at the risk of failure and eternal loss to live a human life on the battleground of the cosmic controversy where His enemy Satan was bent on His destruction. He came as a helpless babe, giving Satan a huge advantage. Yet He came to do His Father's will, and so was dependent upon the Father and the Spirit to enable

38. See sect. 59 in Barth, *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, in vol. 4, pt. 1 in *Church Dogmatics*, 157–357.
39. Ibid., 157–210.
40. Barth, *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, vol. 4, pt. 2 in *Church Dogmatics*, 20–134.
41. Barth, *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, vol. 4, pt. 1 in *Church Dogmatics*, 212.

Him to carry out that will, not in a *fiat* way—as if salvation could be spoken *ex nihilo* (out of nothing) like creation, but He became a part of creation in order to work out the plan of salvation in human history, where in His human life, He remained dependent on divinity from without, and not from within (Phil. 2:5–8).

Christ lived a human life, and not a divine life in human history. He was the God-Man, with salvation dependent upon doing His Father's will (Heb. 10:5–7; John 17:4), going to the Cross, where salvation was realized in His death as the Son of Man (Rom. 8:3; Heb. 2:14; 1 John 3:4–5). In other words, His incarnation was a prerequisite for His saving sacrifice, rather than creation being a prerequisite for (1) His incarnation and (2) His inner history of salvation.

When salvation is located in the inner history of Jesus Christ, the divine nature is considered active and the human nature passive, which means Christ lived on earth as the Son of God, rather than the Son of Man. Yet Scripture says that Christ though "being in very nature [*morphē*] God," "made himself nothing" (*ekenōsen*, laid aside the use of His divine nature, while remaining divine) "taking the very nature of a servant [*doulou*]" (Phil. 2:6–7).

SALVATION AS COMPLETION OF CREATION

Although Christ was dependent upon human history to enter human history, on another level it was not a case that the creation of humans necessitated the coming of the God-Man. Human creation would not have required God to become human if humans had not sinned. The astounding fact is that God chose to enter a sin-filled world to save it, and through His life and death to so demonstrate divine love and justice that no created being throughout the vast reaches of space would ever question God's love and justice again. Calvary was the event that assures the loyalty of all created beings for eternity. God's love was so lavishly poured out on the Cross that such self-sacrifice for the totality of human sin will forever call forth adoration and praise.

In theology there are two ways of relating creation and incarnation: (1) incarnation is the goal of creation, and (2) incarnation would take place even if there was no Fall. These are similar, as both question the true value of God's creation, "made in His image" at the beginning, and not "made in His image" in Jesus Christ's incarnation. Scripture speaks of a completed creation (Gen. 2:2), so the Fall was the reason for the incarnation. Some in the first group (incarnation as goal of creation) include Friedrich Schleiermacher (1768–1834),[42] Karl

42. Schleiermacher, *The Christian Faith*, 366–379; 389, 411.

Barth (1886–1968),[43] Wolfhart Pannenberg (1928–),[44] Gordon D. Kaufman,[45] and Robert W. Jenson.[46] Richard P. McBrien[47] even stated that creation was an act of grace. Some of those in the second group (incarnation without the Fall) include Hilary of Poitiers (ca. 300–367),[48] John Duns Scotus (ca.1266–1308),[49] Andrew Osiander (1498–1552),[50] Thomas F. Torrance,[51] and Jürgen Moltmann.[52] Gregory of Nyssa (ca. 335–395)[53] believed both the creation and the Fall were necessary for the incarnation.

John Calvin called this idea speculation, stating, "since the whole Scripture proclaims that he [Christ] was clothed with flesh in order to become a Redeemer, it is presumptuous to imagine any other cause or end."[54] Calvin also said, "How silly and distorted this view is"—an idea that "all men of sound judgment will at once discern."[55] Commenting on Eastern Orthodox theology, Clendenin stated, "Deification takes center stage in this worldview, for it is the ultimate purpose of God's creation."[56]

Herman Bavinck (1854–1921) believed that infralapsarian predestination views creation as teleologically oriented to the Incarnation, "that creation was designed to make re-creation possible;" this was God's eternal decree.[57] He

43. Barth, *Doctrine of Creation*, vol. 3, pt. 1 in *Church Dogmatics*, 55; 94–228.

44. Wolfhart Pannenberg, *Systematic Theology*, trans. Geoffrey W. Bromiley (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1991, Ger. ed. 1988), 1:327.

45. Gordon D. Kaufman, *Systematic Theology: A Historicist Perspective* (New York: Charles Scribner's, 1968), 383. He has an evolutionary progress of history, in which the purpose of human creation is the kingdom of God arriving in the incarnation of Jesus Christ.

46. Robert W. Jenson, *The Triune God*, vol. 1 in *Systematic Theology* (New York: Oxford, 1997), 72–73. "Perhaps Martin Luther stated the position most simply: 'God created us just in order to redeem us.... The present work will follow the minority line of Luther—and, in their various ways, of Barth, the medieval Franciscan schools, the Calvinist 'supralapsarians,' and others—and will accept the resultant burdens. For the present purpose, it will suffice to say that something like Barth's teaching must be true: the goal of God's path is just what does in fact happen with Jesus the Christ, and sin and evil belong to God's intent precisely—but only—as they do appear in Christ's victory over them."

47. Richard P. McBrien, *Catholicism* (New York: HarperCollins, 1994), 256.

48. Hilary of Poitiers, "The Life and Teachings of St. Hilary of Poitiers," *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, ed. W. Sanday (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1989), Second Series, 9:xivi.

49. Richard Cross, "John Duns Scotus (c. 1266-1308)" in *The Dictionary of Historical Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2000), 166.

50. Andrew Osiander, quoted in Philip Schaff, *The Creeds of Christendom* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1996, 1st ed. 1931), 273; see also John Calvin, *Institutes*, 1:405 (2.12.5–6).

51. Thomas F. Torrance, *The Christian Doctrine of God: One Being, Three Persons* (Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 2001, 1st ed. 1996), 210.

52. Jürgen Moltmann, *The Trinity and the Kingdom: The Doctrine of God* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1993, Ger. ed. 1980), 116–117.

53. Gregory of Nyssa, *Prolegomena, Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, 5:20, 21.

54. John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion* (London: James Clarke, 1962), 2:402 (2.12.4).

55. Ibid., 2:405 (2.12.6).

56. Daniel B. Clendenin, *Eastern Orthodox Christianity: A Western Perspective* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1994), 135.

57. Herman Bavinck, *God and Creation*, vol. 2 in *Reformed Dogmatics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2004), 340.

rejected this orientation as Gnostic, stating, "Creation as a work of God is not inferior to re-creation; nature is not lower than the order of grace; the world is not profane of itself."[58]

Calvin rejected the view that the eternal decree depended on God's foreseeing the fall of humans. He said, "those who propose to inquire, or desire to know more of Christ than God predestinated by his secret decree, are presuming with impious audacity to invent a new Christ."[59] In others words, predestination depends solely on omnipotence (will) and not on foreknowledge. It makes sense that any reason for Christ's incarnation without the Fall questions the validity of the eternal decree to save and reprobate humans. Without the Fall, this mission of Christ would be unnecessary, and what does this do to the eternal, absolute, sovereign predestinating will of God? Either God's sovereign will to elect and reprobate takes place, or it fails because the Fall doesn't take place. How can predestinarians accept both views?

Positing God's foreknowledge is a better approach. Because God is omniscient, He eternally knew the Fall would take place as a result of human free choice, which He would permit. He also knew that Christ would come as the Savior of the world, allowing humans to elect or reject salvation. He also knew that Christ's incarnation would never take place without the Fall. So God's foreknowledge, the very attribute Calvin rejected, is the key to a rational answer.

God didn't speak salvation into existence as He spoke things into existence during creation week (Gen. 1:3, 9, 11, 20, 24, 26), but He sent His Son to enter human history, to live a genuine human life to form a perfect human character (to give to repentant sinners), and to die a substitutionary death (for God is immortal). Christ accomplished both as a human, fully dependent upon His Father and the Holy Spirit and so His genuine human life was crucial. It means the Son of Man was active (and the Son of God passive) in His incarnational life and death.

Ransom Theory

Christ said, "For even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for man" (Mark 10:45). The ransom theory of the atonement seems to have been the most popular theory in the early Christian church, and present for the first thousand years. But the words of Christ did not always guide those who believed in this theory. Christ always taught that He was a substitutionary sacrifice to pay the penalty for the sins of

58. Ibid., 424.
59. Calvin, *Institutes*, 1:404 (2.12.5).

humanity. Christ took our place, suffered for our sins, and in so doing saved anyone who accepts this gift (John 3:16). It was a great exchange. He became like us so that we can become like Him. He died our death that we may receive His life. Paul put it this way, "God made him who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Cor. 5:21).

Origen (ca. 185–254) and Gregory of Nyssa (ca. 330–395) taught this theory. Origen's theology claimed that Christ was not a ransom paid to God, but a ransom paid to Satan. "Now it was the devil that held us, to whose side we had been drawn away by our sins. He asked, therefore, as our price the blood of Christ."[60] Satan eagerly grasped Jesus, not knowing that His human appearance hid His divinity. Satan grasped Christ because he knew the ransom was valuable. Origen claims that in this act Satan was deceived. "This Deity was hidden under the veil of our nature, that so, as with ravenous fish, the hook of the Deity might be gulped down along with the bait of flesh."[61] Satan never saw the hook, which was Christ's divinity. So he got more than he bargained for.

Years later, Gregory of Nyssa believed it was appropriate for God to use deception against Satan, because Satan had used deception against Eve. However, God does not use Satan's tools. For God, "the end does not justify the means." That is why victory over rebellion doesn't justify using the means of hell in the eternal future. During the cosmic controversy, God remains true to Himself and acts according to His nature of holy love. There is nothing humans can do to make God love them more (versus a belief in salvation by works), and there is nothing humans can do to make God love them less (versus reprobate theology). Even in the final punishment, God's love accompanies His judgment. Holy love consumes those who refuse eternal life with Him; it is a loving act to allow them to be no more.

To be forced to live with God would be hell to those who hate Him. Because God is love, He never uses force, even in electing to salvation. Biblically speaking, God's sovereign will is not contrary to His unchanging love; God is love, so hell-fire consumes. Following the consummated controversy, holy love will be no more. Then God will be love alone. Restoration of paradise means God's love remains forever. In the Incarnation, Calvary, intercession in heaven's sanctuary, Second Coming, and final judgment, His love is unaltered. He is the unchanging God (Mal. 3:6; Heb. 13:8). The universe will see in the final judgment that God loved His enemies, and with sorrow allowed them to be disconnected from

60. Origen, *Commentary on the Epistle to the Romans* (Washington, DC: Catholic University of America Press, 2001), 2:13.
61. Gregory of Nyssa, *The Great Catechism, The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, 5:424 (24).

Him forever. Love was the consistent means throughout, for God remains true to His nature as love throughout the controversy and throughout eternity to follow. Christ revealed that unchanging love when He cried out, "Jerusalem, Jerusalem, you who kill the prophets and stone those sent to you, how often I have longed to gather your children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, and you were not willing" (Matt. 23:37). He never forced them. They had freedom of choice, and He respected that freedom. So it has been throughout history and will be in the final judgment.

Moral Influence Theory

We will consider two related ideas about the Cross: (1) that it was not necessary for salvation because God, being God, can forgive; (2) that at best Calvary is a revelation of God's love, and not a redemption of humanity from the bondage of sin.

FORGIVENESS

Some thinkers believe the Cross was not necessary for God to forgive sin. They claim that God is love, and an expression of that love is to be merciful to sinners and to forgive their sins just by saying, "I forgive you." In other words, forgiveness does not require atonement; it just needs to be stated, for God is well able to forgive because of who He is. Thomas Chubb is an example of this view. In his 1739 book *The Gospel of Jesus Christ Vindicated*, Chubb says: "God's disposition to show mercy...arises wholly from his own innate goodness or mercifulness, and not from anything external to him, whether it be the suffering and death of Jesus Christ or otherwise."[62]

Mere forgiveness fails to consider the eternal contribution Calvary's substitutionary atonement makes to securing the freedom and loyalty of created beings in unending ages (Rev. 21:2–4; 22:3–5). His death will cause the redeemed to hate sin, because of what it did to Christ and the Trinity (more on Calvary will be discussed later in this chapter). Forgiveness wouldn't cost God anything compared to dying to save sinners, which cost God everything. Calvary was not cheap grace. Calvary was the most expensive act of love that ever took place, and there will never be a more expensive act in the future. Further, this truth will be increasingly understood as the ages of eternity unfold. In utter wonderment and gratitude all created beings will forever admire and adore God for this indescribable and unfathomable sacrifice.

62. Thomas Chubb, *The Gospel of Jesus Christ Vindicated*, quoted in Alister E. McGrath, *Christian Theology: An Introduction* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1994), 344.

REVELATION

Those theologians who stress the moral influence theory do so because it expresses an extremely important truth: The Cross changes lives. No other event affects intelligent beings like the cross. Calvary is God's incomparable self-revelation. Nothing moves me so much as a steady gaze at my Savior hanging there dying for me! "God's kindness" leads me "to repentance" (Rom. 2:4; cf. KJV). As I look to Christ on the cross, by beholding Him, wonder of wonders I am becoming changed (2 Cor. 3:18). I heartily endorse all attempts to lift up the Cross, and echo the words of Paul: "God forbid that I should glory, save in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ" (Gal. 6:14, KJV). Christ Himself promised, "I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to myself" (John 12:32). There is no more momentous focus. The Cross is the supreme revelation of what God is like.

However, my concern about the moral influence theory, considered in isolation as an exclusive theory of the atonement, is that those who hold it do not seem to see in Calvary a Savior dying for them, bearing their sins, shedding His blood to redeem them, paying the price without which they could never get to heaven. For the fact that Jesus proved His love for humanity by His death is only one part of the truth about God. Another truth is that Jesus loved humanity so much that He died for the sins of all humans: Jesus Christ "suffered death, so that by the grace of God he might taste death for everyone" (Heb. 2:9b), and "He is the atoning sacrifice for our sins, and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world" (1 John 2:2). His shed blood paid the price for human salvation.

Think of it this way: If we say that God merely allowed Christ to die to change people, with no larger reference to paying our sin debt, the perception sounds hollow in view of the biblical terms already noted (propitiation, redemption, justification, and reconciliation), in addition to revelation. Leon Morris illustrates the weakness of focusing solely on revelation, without including the need of redemption. He uses an analogy:

> a man who jumps into a rushing stream to show his love for me. If I am in the water in danger of drowning, that is meaningful. But if I am quite safe, sitting on the pier and enjoying the sun, then I cannot but deplore his action and I fail to see how it in fact shows his love. If sinners were in no danger on account of their sin, then why should Jesus have died at all? In that case we need an act of revelation, but not an act of atonement. It seems that no understanding of the cross is going to be satisfactory that does not view the death of Christ as accomplishing something.[63]

63. Leon Morris, *The Cross of Jesus* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), 21.

If the Cross were just a revelation, then why wasn't Christ's entire life of sacrificial service a sufficient revelation of God? If the Cross is a necessary revelation to change people, and only that, then is this not "salvation by knowledge," a kind of Gnosticism?[64] And if the Cross is only a revelation, "God would be saying more than He did," says Forsyth.

> We are exposed to the danger there always is when we make revelation a word rather than a deed, something said instead of something done, when we make it manifestation only and not redemption. The work of Christ would be only something educational, or at most impressive. And what happens then? If the work of Christ is only impressively educational, if the need and value of it ceases when we have recognised its meaning, when we have taken God's word for it in Christ that He does really love us, what happens then? Why, as soon as the lesson had been learnt, the work of Christ might be left behind.[65]

T. H. Hughes is right when he maintains that

> God must work in the Atonement itself, as well as in the life that follows. There must, therefore, be an "objective" source of power, and not merely a subjective change in man, before the Atonement can become effective. The degenerations and losses wrought by sin have to be met and conquered, and for this more than knowledge is necessary.[66]

Moral influence proponents believe that the manifestation made at Calvary is sufficient to evoke repentance. But if this is true, the Jewish leaders and Roman soldiers surrounding the Cross would have repented. W. J. Wolf is right to note that revelation does not always result in gratitude.[67] If revelation alone were involved, we might question its fairness, for it works in an inequitable way, some people being easily moved, others not. Would God work in such a way?[68] Although revelation was unquestionably involved at the Cross, there must have been something much more profound about it than mere revelation.

This much more profound dimension has everything to do with (1) the holiness of God and (2) the sinfulness of humankind. Both depths are overlooked, to some degree, by the moral influence adherents. Consider the holiness of God:

> When that holiness is wounded or defied, could God be content to take us back with a mere censure or other penance and the declaration that He was holy?... Sinners would despise a God who would take us back when we wept, and speak thus: "Let us say no more about it. You did very wrong, and you have suffered for it, and I; but let us forget it now you have come back." We should not respect that. We should go on...to take more liberties still. He would be a God who only talked His holiness and did not put it into force.[69]

64. Moral influence advocates, reminiscent of Gnostics, believe humankind's problem is merely intellectual, so they assume that we need merely a revelation of God and our ignorance will be overcome.
65. P. T. Forsyth, *The Work of Christ* (London: Independent Press, 1948), 101–102.
66. T. H. Hughes, *The Atonement* (London: George Allen and Unwin, 1949), 205–206.
67. William J. Wolf, *No Cross, No Crown: A Study of the Atonement* (Garden City, NY: Doubleday and Co., 1957), 120.
68. See Hughes, *The Atonement*, 204–205.

Do moral influence proponents realize what love is? Love needs holiness to be love. "Love cannot be exhibited apart from holiness," contends H. O. Wiley.[70] "Holiness," says Mackintosh, "is the austere element in love, preserving it from wrong."[71] Morris agrees, for, he says, "Apart from law, how are we to distinguish love from caprice?"[72] Calvary is no neutral revelation of love. It reveals "the Father's holy love"[73] (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 2 for the discussion of "holy love").

This is a crucial insight. Moral influence theories that overlook the fact that there can be no fellowship between God and humankind—except on the plane of holiness—are inadequate. Moral influence theories, says James Stewart, overlook "the New Testament's concentration upon the demonic nature of the evil from which the world has to be redeemed."[74] The New Testament presents Christ on Calvary as the sin-bearer, not just as the bearer of God's revelation (Acts 10:43; 1 Cor. 15:3; Gal. 1:4; Heb. 1:3; 2:17; 9:28; 10:12; 1 Pet. 2:24; 3:18; Rev. 1:5).

The moral influence theory, with its denial of a substitutionary atonement, is compatible with a worldview that denies the authority of Scripture and accepts historical criticism.[75] This is a serious indictment, but Vernon Grounds has laid the matter on the line: "'Back to the Bible!' must be no empty shibboleth," he demands, "but rather an all-controlling principle in our thinking about the atonement."[76] And the Bible reveals that Christ did indeed do more than die for us—He died for our sins (John 1:29; 2 Cor. 5:21; Heb. 9:26).

Denial of the holiness of God and the sinfulness of man go hand in hand. As Forde affirms, "The cross is not in the first instance a revelation of the love or mercy of God. It is rather the climactic manifestation of God's wrath against

69. Forsyth, *The Work of Christ*, 131–132.
70. H. O. Wiley, *Christian Theology*, 2:284.
71. Mackintosh, *Christian Experience of Forgiveness*, 215.
72. Morris, *The Cross of Jesus*, 16.
73. Mackintosh, *Christian Experience of Forgiveness*, 226.
74. J. S. Stewart, *A Faith to Proclaim* (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1953), 79.
75. Hastings Rashdall, a leading exponent of the moral influence theory, preached a university sermon at Oxford in 1892 entitled "Abelard's Doctrine of the Atonement." McGrath comments, "The central theme of his sermon is that in the twelfth century figure of Peter Abelard can be found a theory of the Atonement which meets the demands of an age shaped in the spirit of Darwinism and historical criticism," "The Moral Theory of the Atonement: An Historical and Theological Critique," *Scottish Journal of Theology*, 38/2 (1985): 205.
76. Vernon C. Grounds, *Baker's Dictionary of Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1960), 75.

sin."[77] It is partly because sin does not provoke our own wrath that we do not believe that sin provokes the wrath of God. A revelation of holy love must expose sin, and with such an exposure of sin must come power to do something about it. Holy love can change a person. Mere revelation of love is not enough to meet human needs: "For no other reason than that example without the power to follow it, knowledge without the power to put it into practice, revelation without the power to turn it into life, can bring nothing but bitter frustration."[78] There is no revelation in Scripture apart from redemption.[79]

It comes down to one thing. "If we feel that Christ has really put our sins out of the way, effectively and finally, our view of the faith will be very different from what would be the case if we felt that He had simply given us an example, or had won a spectacular victory which has little regard for the rights of the case."[80] Given that God is holy love and that we are needy sinners, the Cross is far more than a revelation. It is evidence of forgiveness that we can depend upon.[81]

If moral influence proponents have too shallow a view of human sinfulness and divine holiness, they also have too superficial a view of the profundity of God's attributes. For what God ought to do because He is righteous needs to be understood with what He cannot do because He is love, and vice versa.[82]

DOES FORGIVENESS REQUIRE CHRIST'S DEATH?

Those who believe exclusively in the moral influence theory point to the prodigal son in Luke 15 and say that in the story atonement was accomplished between father and son without any reference to Christ's death on Calvary. Are we then to infer that we can be reconciled without Jesus? A parable is never the basis of a doctrine. Luke 15 doesn't deny the need of Calvary, because Luke presents the crucifixion in chapter 23. W. L. Liefeld is right to see the gospel in Luke 15, with the Cross mentioned later.[83] Henry Alford said the sacrifice of Christ "is presupposed in the whole parable,"[84] and N. Geldenhuys agrees.[85] It is true that the love of the Father for the

77. G. O. Forde, "The Work of Christ," in *Christian Dogmatics* (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1984), 2:90.
78. W. Barclay, *Crucified and Crowned* (London: SCM, 1961), 98.
79. Brunner, *The Christian Doctrine of the Church, Faith, and the Consummation* (Cambridge, UK: James Clark, 2000, 1st 1962).306; Wolf, *No Cross, No Crown*, 119.
80. Morris, *The Cross in the New Testament*, 6.
81. Mackintosh, *Christian Experience of Forgiveness*, 218.
82. Cf. Forsyth, *The Work of Christ* (London: Hodder and Stough, 1910.
83. W. L. Liefeld, *Luke*, vol. 8 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1984), 985.
84. H. Alford and E. F. Harrison, *Gospels*, vol. 1 in *The Greek Testament* (Chicago: Moody, 1968), 594.
85. N. Geldenhuys, *Luke*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1983), 412.

returning prodigal (Luke 15) is the same love of the Father who gave His Son to save all prodigals (Luke 23; John 3:16).

Only those who do not adequately comprehend human sin and divine hatred of sin can believe that forgiveness is all that the Father needs to give to prodigals. But humans need far more than forgiveness.[86] If the entire gospel message is in this parable, then why, asks Forsyth, did not the apostles use it in their preaching? Indeed, why didn't Christ conclude His mission and return to heaven right after giving this parable, if it contains the complete gospel?[87] Christ's mission was more than to preach parables. He went to the Cross to become our substitute (2 Cor. 5:21), for "without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness" (Heb. 9:22b); for "it is the blood that makes atonement for one's life" (Lev. 17:11b; cf. Heb. 10:4–14).[88] No wonder John the Baptist pointed to Jesus and said, "Look, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29), for later "'He himself bore our sins' in his body on the cross" (1 Pet. 2:24a; cf. Matt. 20:28; 26:28; Acts 20:28b; Rom. 5:9a; 1 Cor. 15:3b; Gal. 1:4a; Tit. 2:14).

In the same way that moral influence advocates have too shallow a view of the holiness of God and the sinfulness of man, they also have too shallow a view of God's responsibility for governance of the universe. There is a distinct difference between forgiving if one is an ordinary citizen, and forgiving if one leads a nation, a world, or the entire cosmos. The responsibility of maintaining law and order for the sake of others is involved.[89] "God could not let sin go as if a mere slip. God demanded the atonement and provided it."[90] Restoration of the original plan for humankind takes more than a word of forgiveness. Changing the heart and lifestyle of humans is involved, and change can only come when humans realize the horror of sin, what sin cost God, and how expensive forgiveness really is. When this happens, humans won't want to sin anymore and thus God's original plan will be realized.[91]

No deep experience can come from a shallow concept. As John Stott puts it, "We can cry 'Hallelujah' with authenticity only after we have first cried 'Woe is me, for I am lost.'"[92] We need to see sin from Christ's perspective,

86. T. H. Hughes says, "it is being growingly realized that this parable does not go to the heart of the matter, nor does it give a complete revelation of God's attitude to a sinner," *The Atonement*, 220.
87. Forsyth, *The Work of Christ*, 106.
88. Offerings for consecration and thanksgiving did not require blood shedding, so grain, oil, and wine were used for these offerings in the Old Testament. See Charles E. Hill, "Atonement in the Old and New Testaments," in Charles E. Hill & Frank A. James, eds., *The Glory of the Atonement: Biblical, Historical, & Practical Perspectives: Essays in Honor of Roger Nicole* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2004), 25.
89. M. Green, *The Empty Cross of Jesus* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 1984), 73.
90. A. T. Robertson, *Epistles of Paul*, vol. 4 in *Word Pictures in the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1931), 348.
91. Cf. H. W. Clark, *The Cross and the Eternal Order* (New York: MacMillan, 1944), 21.
92. Stott, *The Cross of Christ* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 1986), 109.

as does the author of Hebrews, for sinning is "crucifying the Son of God all over again" (Heb. 6:6). Forgiveness only comes through sacrificial atonement at the Cross.

PROBLEM OF LAWLESSNESS

The need for governance of the cosmos becomes even greater because of sin—which was essentially rebellion against God's rule, His government, His law. Near the beginning of the previous chapter, we mentioned the importance of law with respect to salvation. In this segment we add the importance of law in gaining a true understanding of atonement. Revisionists are working to change Christ's substitutionary atonement. They propose a view of the atonement that does not involve sacrifice, and are now at work within Evangelicalism.[93] Apparently what lies behind this movement is a loss of recognition of the sacredness of God's holy law. Scripture states that death is the price for sin (Rom. 6:23), and sin is breaking God's law (1 John 3:4). God could not merely forgive sin, for this would question the holiness of His law and lower the value of the law in the estimation of all intelligent created beings. If it were a mere trifle to sin and easy to get forgiveness, the floodgates to lawlessness would burst open. Questioning of God's law as holy would soon lead to questioning God as holy, and the universe would be engulfed in hopeless rebellion.

God believes that His law is holy and that it is eternally important for created beings. He did not say "Let there be salvation" as He said "Let there be" in creating the world. Creation required His word, but salvation (re-creation) requires that the Word become flesh (John 1:1, 14). The immutable law required that the Creator-Lawgiver undergo incarnation, incarnational life, and substitutionary death in order to gift salvation to humans. In undergoing these changes, Christ showed to what extent He would go to support the unchangeability of His law. The fact that classical theology affirmed the unchangeability of God (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 6) and the changeability of His law (in the Christian era; cf. prophecy of Dan. 7:25) shows a disconnect between God and His law. By contrast, Calvary reveals the connection between God and His law. Christ died to uphold the immutability of God's law. His death was a sacrificial atonement for law breaking (1 John 3:4–5a; 1 Cor. 15:3b).

93. See Royce Gordon Gruenler, "Atonement in the Synoptic Gospels and Acts" in *The Glory of the Atonement: Biblical, Historical & Practical Perspectives: Essays in Honor of Roger Nicole*, ed. Chatles E. Hill & Frank A. James (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2004), 90, 9; reference to revisionists, 91n.

Christ said that love to God and fellow beings is fundamental to "all the Law and the Prophets" (Matt. 22:37–40). The law is about love. It is only the wrong use of the law that is legalistic. God's law is as immutable as God is unchangeable in character, because the law reveals God's character (nature) as love (1 John 4:8–16). The relational Trinity have eternally enjoyed reciprocal love in their inner history. This means that each Person in the Trinity loves the others, and this divine love overflows into willing humans who love God and their fellow beings. God longs for all humans to reflect the love that is shared among the relational Trinity.

Law breaking is not merely breaking a law; it is breaking a relationship with the Lawgiver. Law breaking is not merely rebellion against the law, but rebellion against the Lawgiver. God is in the business of restoring broken relationships. Salvation is the remedy, for "without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness" (Heb. 9:22b). So Bavinck is right to say that the moral law is "grounded in the nature of God himself…so that Christ satisfied not God but its demand…Christ, accordingly, came not to abolish the law but to fulfill it (Matt. 5:17–18; Rom. 10:4). He upheld its majesty and glory; and faith, accordingly, does not nullify the law but upholds it (Rom. 3:31)."[94]

Bavinck's two other observations are correct as well: (1) "if as the righteous and holy one he [God] did not have the right to punish, we cannot speak of grace in relation to him either.... Those who deny justice thereby also deny grace."[95] (2) If the dualism between justice and grace is maintained, "The law has no eternal significance but only a temporary, passing, pedagogical function. The Old Testament as the religion of law no longer concerns us."[96] This would mean that the God of the Old Testament is different from the God of the New Testament; that God requires law keeping in the Old Testament, but doesn't require law keeping in the New Testament. Such a view is opposed by Scripture, for God does not change (Mal. 4:6), and "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8).

Joseph Bellany (1719–1790), Yale graduate, and minister under the tutelage of Jonathan Edwards, states, "we cannot see our need of the atonement of Christ, unless we see the excellency of the divine law."[97] Those who deny Christ's sacrificial atonement have apparently lost the sense of the holiness of God's law. Christian theology should never lose sight of the full reason why Christ died. He died to save His law as well as to save lawbreakers. Beyond

94. Herman Bavinck, *Sin and Salvation in Christ*, vol. 3 in *Reformed Dogmatics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2006), 373.
95. Ibid., 374.
96. Ibid., 375.
97. Joseph Bellany, *Sin, the Law, and the Glory of the Gospel* (Ames, Iowa: International Outreach, 1998), 47.

examining Calvary, theology needs to consider Christ's present ministry as King-Priest in heaven's sanctuary as equally a part of His atoning work. John exhorts us, "My dear children, I write this to you so that you will not sin. But if anybody does sin, we have an advocate with the Father—Jesus Christ, the Righteous One. He is the atoning sacrifice for our sins [*hilasmos peri hēmōn tōn hamartiōn*], and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world" (1 John 2:1–2). On the basis of the atoning sacrifice there is atoning intercession—and both are required in Christ's mission of salvation. The law is not changed in salvation, but humans are changed from lawbreakers to lawkeepers, because they demonstrate that they are filled with the love of God by their law keeping (cf. John 14:15).

GOD'S ATTRIBUTES: JUSTICE AND MERCY

It bears repeating that both justice and love (mercy) were operative at the Cross. Justice demanded punishment for sin, while love demanded forgiveness for sin. God's love is strong, not sentimental; He paradoxically reveals His love through justice and His compassion through wrath. God's wrath must be seen as an expression of His love.[98] God cannot be dissected as if He were schizophrenic. All of God is present in the use of any of His attributes. He is fully present in His wrath as He is in His mercy, and without contradiction.[99] Properly understood, His nature as love works through all of His attributes. If someone abducts your child, love for the child is expressed by anger for the deed. Anything less than anger would call your love into question. On Calvary God was angry at the seduction of humans by the enemy. God was angry at sin *precisely because of His love* for sinners.

Furthermore, God's action on the Cross was not abstract, some accomplishment of forensic bookkeeping. Far more was involved. "God so loved the world" (John 3:16a). The church is His bride.[100] Sin took His bride hostage. She divorced Him. She needed far more than a revelation of God. She needed restoration by God. He still loved her and hated the sin that separated her from Him. On the cross Christ plunged down to the depths to release His hostage bride by dealing a death blow to the hostage taker.[101] But, in doing so, He received the death wages of sin Himself, for God's wrath is

98. The Bible says God is slow to anger (Exod. 34:6) but does reveal anger against sin (Rom. 1:18). Note the balance between wrath and mercy. "He has torn us to pieces but he will heal us" (Hos. 6:1–2).

99. "Love and wrath are not contradictory; love and hatred are," J. Murray, *The Atonement* (Philadelphia, PA: Presbyterian and Reformed, 1962), 15.

100. Although Scripture only mentions His followers as His bride (Isa. 62:5; Matt. 9:15), potentially all humankind were included, just as Christ potentially died for the whole world.

101. The Cross was an attack against sin. It also constituted the death knell for Satan, the originator of sin.

against sin (because it separates persons from Him), and on the cross Christ died in place of sinners. He died as a criminal under God's wrath as if He were responsible for the guilt of the world. There are six billion persons living today, how many since Adam and Eve? He bore the sins of billions. What a load of guilt! Yet He bore that guilt, and He suffered the death that was ours—separation from God. Yet His death doomed the enemy and restored guilty humans who will accept His substitution for them. The one act of liberation demonstrates that justice and mercy met at the cross. Some scholars throw up their hands at this juncture, sure that the Father is unfair in punishing the Son for something He didn't do. "Isn't He a God of love? How could He do this to His Son?" they protest. They would seem to have a case. We will return to this in the segment below on the substitutionary theory.

THE CROSS AS AN EXAMPLE

American Congregationalist Horace Bushnell's (1802–1876) book *The Vicarious Sacrifice*[102] was written during the Civil War in America, and in light of his reflection on Christ's death. "His conclusion was that the death of Christ was intended primarily as an example for the human race to follow in self-giving sacrifice."[103] McClendon, Baptist theologian at Fuller Seminary says, "My intuition is that the church will return to the theme of sacrifice, historically very little explored. The New Testament's sacrificial metaphors have so far reappeared only in subordinate roles." He then goes on to praise Bushnell's book as a "great work,"[104] which he sums up as "vicarious sacrifice."[105] However, McClendon rightly questions Bushnell's view that on Calvary Christ experienced sympathy for humans, for death is more than sympathy, and death is the gospel meta-narrative.[106]

McClendon claims that "there is no single Old Testament motif that fully prepares us for it [the Savior and the cross is novel in the New Testament]...there was no 'expectation' of Christ in Scripture that could have enabled even the keenest Hebrew reader to concretely foretell Jesus' ministry, his suffering, his death and resurrection." He concludes that they can only be understood in the light of the events themselves.[107] There is truth in this claim, but didn't the sanctuary/temple sacrifices, not to mention the Messianic prophecies, point to a coming

102. Horace Bushnell, *The Vicarious Sacrifice, Grounded in Principles of Universal Obligation* (New York: Scribner, 1866).

103. M. A. Noll, "Bushnell, Horace," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 196.

104. James Wm. McClendon, *Doctrine*, vol. 2 in *Systematic Theology* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 1994), 232.

105. Ibid., 210.

106. Ibid., 210–211, 227.

107. Ibid., 216.

Savior? Didn't they teach that forgiveness is not enough, that a substitutionary sacrifice was necessary? It is my conviction that the Hebrews failed to understand the redemptive mission of the coming Messiah because of their lack of spiritual discernment, due to their disconnect from God—not because God's sanctuary/temple sacrifices and services were an unsuccessful teaching device and thus failed to communicate clearly God's intent in those sacrifices and services. Didn't Isaiah 53:5–12 present a substitutionary sacrifice—the Suffering Servant—for sinners?

Has spiritual Israel done any better? Have Christians grasped the intent of those sacrifices and services? How many theological systems have followed Christ from Calvary into His ministry in the heavenly sanctuary and done justice to the ongoing gospel meta-narrative unfolding in the Book of Hebrews? How many have understood that His present ministry, based on Calvary, is because of the biblical meta-narrative of the cosmic controversy?

Substitutionary Theory

Calvary is more than a moral influence; it involves Christ's self-sacrifice. This sacrifice is the content of the revelation made at Calvary. The revelation at Calvary is a revelation of redemption, and redemption is nothing less than the complete self-sacrifice of the relational Trinity. "Substitution fits into a Trinitarian framework, for 'Christ offered himself without spot to God through the eternal Spirit' (Heb. 9:14)."[108]

GOD'S SELF-SACRIFICE

Evidence that the substitutionary atonement is not humankind's appeasing God but God's own self-sacrifice is seen in the morning and evening sacrifices, the Day of Atonement ministry on behalf of the entire nation, and the annual Passover celebration. In celebrating the Passover, Jesus kept the first Lord's Supper with His disciples (Mark 14:12–25). As Carey notes, "Jesus himself was the first to unite his death with the Passover in the Words of Institution at the Last Supper."[109] Paul connected them too, referring to "Christ, our Passover lamb" (1 Cor. 5:7).

God provided the offering, the means of escape from death, on that first Passover night back in Egypt. All homes with the blood applied to lintel and doorposts were protected. In such homes the firstborn would live (Exod. 12:7, 13, 23). But this was not true for those who neglected the substitutionary sacrifice of the slain lamb (Exod. 12:12). The firstborn's escape from death was just as much a gift of God as the whole nation's escape from Egypt. Substitution

108. J. Van Genderen and W. H. Velma, *Concise Reformed Dogmatics* (Phillipsburg. NJ: P&R, 1992), 525.
109. G. L. Carey, "The Lamb of God and Atonement Theories," *Tyndale Bulletin*, 32 (1981): 119.

and Exodus were forever burned in Israel's memory as interrelated acts of God's grace. In fact, as Dillistone mentions, the New Testament passages concerning Christ's blood and redemption point back to the Passover escape from Egypt.[110] For, as Reid puts it, "at the heart of the Passover stands the idea of atonement through believing sacrifice."[111]

It should be noted that the blood was shed to redeem the firstborn male from death and not to put life within him. Some today view Christ's death as a blood transfusion, designed to place life within, making His death sacramental rather than substitutionary.[112] It is true that "the 'blood' of Christ is mentioned in the writings of the New Testament nearly three times as often as 'the Cross' of Christ and five times as frequently as the 'death' of Christ,"[113] but it is never equated with "life transfusion." Christ's blood always symbolizes His substitutionary death in place of the redeemed, as in the Passover. We have redemption through Christ's blood (see Eph. 1:7; 1 Pet. 1:18; Rev. 5:9).[114] As Lyon and Toon remind us, "Elsewhere blood may be a symbol of life, but in the sacrificial motif it symbolized death."[115]

MEANING OF *SUBSTITUTIONARY*

Rightly used, the word *substitutionary* in no way connotes that Christ took our place in living a perfect life so that we do not need to live fit for heaven! It doesn't connote this anymore than Christ's ascending to heaven in our place means there is no future life in heaven and the new earth for us (1 Thess. 4:16–18; Rev. 21:1–4). The word *substitutionary,* properly understood, applies solely to Christ's taking our place at the cross, doing for us what we could never do for ourselves, that is, perish in the second death (Rev. 20:6) and yet live again. He paid the wages of sin (Rom. 6:23), so that we do not have to, and gave us eternal life. In paying the price for our sins, He alone could be our substitute. He had to be God in order to pay the debt and live beyond the grave; He had to be human to die our death, so that we can live beyond the grave (if not translated). This is the most glorious good news—the wondrous exchange. "God made him who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Cor. 5:21).

110. F. W. Dillistone, *Jesus Christ and His Cross* (Philadelphia, Westminster Press, 1953), 88.
111. W. S. Reid, in G.W. Bromiley, ed., *The International Standard Bible Encyclopedia* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), 1:353.
112. Vincent Taylor, *Jesus and His Sacrifice* (London: MacMillan, 1939), 63–64.
113. A. M. Stibbs, *The Meaning of the Word "Blood" in Scripture* (London: Tyndale, 1947), 3.
114. Cf. George Eldon Ladd, *A Theology of the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1974), 426; J. Behm, "*haima*," in Kittell et al., *Theological Dictionary*, 1:173; Wiley, *Christian Theology*, 2:231.
115. Robert W. Lyon and Peter Toon, "Atonement," in *Baker Encyclopedia of the Bible*, ed. Walter A. Elwell (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Book House, 1988), 1:232.

If Calvary defeated Satan's scheme to take the entire human race down with him, then we would expect Satan to hate the truth about the Cross. And this is precisely what we find in occult literature. We find sheer hatred for the substitutionary theory. We find this hatred in spiritualism,[116] in the Theosophical Society,[117] and in the New Age Movement[118] and its "bible," the *Aquarian Gospel of Jesus the Christ.*[119] Look at the rendering of John 3:16 in the *Aquarian Gospel*: "For God so loved the world that he sent forth his only son to be raised up that men may see the love of God." Calvary, at best, is reduced to a moral influence.

As noted above, some Christian revisionists dislike the substitutionary theory. John Stott puts it frankly, "No two words in the theological vocabulary of the cross arouse more criticism than 'satisfaction' and 'substitution.'"[120]

Corporate Atonement

Sin's wages require death (Rom. 6:23). On the cross Christ paid the price for all humans by His death (not just for the elect). For Christ became the substitute for all sinners at Calvary (see chapter 9, "sin for us"), providing a vicarious atonement for all sin (1 John 2:2). But Calvary isn't an automatic atonement for all humans. This is where Karl Barth's subjective atonement in the inner history of the God-Man isn't biblical. Barth says, "His [Christ's] death was the death of all."[121] There is a big difference between death *for all*, and death *of all.* God invites all sinners to accept Christ's death for them as the only way to be saved (John 3:16). We need to probe this at a deeper level. There is no corporate atonement, in which all sinners have already died for their sins in Christ's death, in the sense that Christ died *as us* rather than *for us.*[122] Only the latter is the consistent view of Scripture (John 10:13; 15:13; Rom. 5:7–8).

Humans have not died for sin at Calvary, even through Christ, or we would be faced with a problem akin to predestination—that God does something for us without any input from us. God didn't elect or reject humans

116. J. A. Pike, *The Other Side: An Account of My Experiences with Psych Phenomena* (New York: Doubleday, 1968), 383.

117. Helena P. Blavatsky, *The Key to Philosophy* (Wheaton, IL: The Theosophical Publishing House, n.d.), 131; Alice Bailey, *The Externalization of the Hierarchy* (New York: Lucis, 1957), 542–543.

118. Elliot Miller, *A Crash Course on the New Age Movement* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1989), 28.

119. Throughout Levi, *The Aquarian Gospel* (Marina Del Rey, CA: DeVorss, 1987), there is a hatred of any substitutionary sacrifice for human sin. For example, see 29–30.

120. Stott, *The Cross of Christ*, 111; cf. G. O. Forde, "Caught in the Act: Reflections on the Word of Christ," *Word and World* (Winter 1983): 22–31.

121. Barth, *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, vol. 4 pt. 1, in *Church Dogmatics*, 295. For the full context, see chapter 14, "Jesus Christ, The Lord as Servant," 157–357.

122. See Stephen Bauer, "Universal Legal Justification and Vicarious Atonement," in *Reflections: The Biblical Research Institute Newsletter*, no. 24 (October 2008): 3–6.

in eternity, nor save all humans at the Cross, but He died for all so they can personally accept or reject His death. Barth's view of Christ's death as *all died* leads him to say, "Jesus Christ, the Son of God made man, was justified by God in His resurrection from the dead. He was justified as man, and in Him as the Representative of all men all were justified."[123]

Even though Barth claims that all died at the Cross, justification takes place by faith in human history. There is no eternal justification by faith (see chapter 15, "Justification from Eternity"). Likewise there is no corporate atonement at the Cross, for atonement is Christ's bearing all sin as a vicarious substitute in death for all sinners. His death is for all, but all didn't die any more than all were justified in Christ's resurrection. Justification is by faith in Christ's death *for us*, but not by believing Christ died *as us.* This latter view bypasses human freedom to choose one's destiny, and so is the same as predestination.

So what do we do with Paul's words, "one died for all, and therefore all died" (2 Cor. 5:14)? Paul continues, "And he [Christ] died for all, that those who live should no longer live for themselves but for him who died for them and was raised again" (v. 15). Paul is not suggesting that Christ's death automatically constituted a corporate atonement in the sense that the lives of all were changed by it. The change of lives only takes place in human history, if it takes place at all, and it is for those only who experience this change that the words "therefore all died" have any meaning. The fact that most of the world gives no evidence of being changed disproves corporate atonement. Harris rightly says, "Paul is not suggesting that, irrespective of their response and attitude, all men know forgiveness of sins or experience selfless living. There is universalism in the scope of redemption, since no man is excluded from God's offer of salvation, but there is a particularity in the application of redemption, since not all men appropriate the benefits afforded by this universally offered salvation."[124]

The earthly sanctuary had a morning and evening sacrifice for all Israel (Num. 28:1–4), with other special offerings such as Sabbath offerings (Num. 28:9–10), and monthly offerings (Num. 28:11–15). But these were insufficient without personal repentance for sin and transferring the same onto a sacrificial substitute, which was daily ministered in the holy place of the sanctuary (Lev. 4:27–35). On Yom Kippur, the annual day of atonement, the final transfer of sin from the sanctuary was placed on a scapegoat (representing Satan, the cause of all sin), which was led away to die, leaving the sanctuary and persons engaged in the service of the day cleansed of all sin (Lev.

123. Barth, *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, vol. 4 pt. 1, in *Church Dogmatics*, 305–306.

124. Murray J. Harris, *2 Corinthians*, vol. 10 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1976), 352.

16:1–34). The transfer of sin onto the Savior that crushed out His life was a vicarious substitutionary atonement for all humans, but had no meaning except for those who personally receive it.

Two observations deserve attention: (1) The fact that Christ died for all disproves atonement for the elect alone. Lenski rightly says, "The Calvinistic efforts to limit this word to 'all the elect' constitute one of the saddest chapters in exegesis.... The real assurance for me that Christ died *for me* is this alone, that he died for absolutely *all*. If he omitted any, then, knowing what a fearful sinner I am, I must come to the judgment that he surely passed by also me. In regard even to the lost 2 Pet. 2:1 declares: They deny 'the Lord that bought them and bring upon themselves swift destruction.'"[125]

(2) The fact that Christ died for all has cosmic implications. Albert Barnes seems to broaden his gaze to the universe, which is of particular interest to this system, because God's character is questioned in the cosmic controversy, and God's self-revelation in salvation history refutes the charges that He is unjust and unloving (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 1, chapter 10, and volume 2, chapter 8). Barnes says that if God died for less than all, there would be cause enough to question Him.

> But if Christ died only for a part, if there is a large portion of the human family for whom he died in no sense whatever; if there is no provision of any kind made for them, then God must know this, and then the offers cannot be made with sincerity, and God is tantalizing them with the offers of that which does not exist, and which he knows does not exist.... It is God who does it, and he knows who the elect are, and yet *he offers salvation to all. And if there is no salvation provided for all, and no possibility that all to whom the offer comes should be saved, then God is insincere; and there is no way possible of vindicating his character.*[126]

> It was doing much when it rendered it consistent for God to offer salvation to all; it is much that God could be seen to be just and yet pardoning the sinner; it was much when his determined hatred of sin, and his purpose to honour his law, was evinced; and in regard to the benevolence and justice of God to other beings and to other worlds, much, very much was gained, though all the human race had rejected the plan and been lost, and in regard to *all* these objects, the plan was not in vain, and the sufferings of the Redeemer were not for naught.[127]

125. R. C. H. Lenski, *The Interpretation of I and II Corinthians* (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg, 1963, 1st ed. 1937), 1029, emphasis in original.

126. Albert Barnes, *Notes on the NT: II Corinthians and Galatians* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2005, 1st ed. 1847), 117, emphasis in original.

127. Ibid., emphasis in original.

Calvary Atonement

Any idea that God's love is tolerant of sin misunderstands His wrath against sin. He knows the difference between the sacred and the profane (cf. Lev. 10:10), and He knows the difference between good and evil. He says, "Woe to those who call evil good and good evil" (Isa. 5:20a). Christ's substitution on the cross was not carried out because the Father was vengeful or severe. It was because the Trinity—all three—were acting in love to save sinners and to judge sin, and not one without the other. What does this mean? Calvary was judgment day for Christ, not because of any sin in His life, but because "God made him who had no sin to be sin for us" (2 Cor. 5:21a).

As the Son of Man, fully dependent upon His Father and Spirit, Christ went to the cross. Far from living as God on earth, in an immutable, impassible,[128] protective armor, Christ was constantly buffeted by the turbulence of Satan's hatred against him, and Christ felt this more keenly as He took His final steps toward Calvary. Never before had the eternally self-existent divine nature of Jesus faced death. He trembled in His humanity as He plunged toward the inevitable. Yes, He had chosen to come, to die, but that didn't make the reality any easier to bear. Prior to the cross Christ could say: "No one knows the Son except the Father, and no one knows the Father except the Son" (Matt. 11:27); "I and the Father are one" (John 10:30); "it is the Father, living in me, who is doing his work" (John 14:10b; cf. 2 Cor. 5:19a); and "I do nothing on my own but speak just what the Father has taught me. The one who sent me is with me; he has not left me alone" (John 8:28b–29).

Christ told the disciples what would happen in His final trials, "You will leave me all alone. Yet I am not alone, for my Father is with me" (John 16:32b). If Calvary is inexhaustibly profound, Christ's dereliction cry (Matt. 27:46) is doubly so. God suffered at the Cross. The Father and the Spirit endured the agonies of Calvary with Christ. Calvary was the self-giving of the entire relational Trinity.

In a church in Italy (George Buttrick tells us) hangs a painting which, at first glance, seems like any other painting of the crucifixion. But look more closely and you'll see "a vast and shadowy Figure behind the figure of Jesus. The nail that pierces the hand of Jesus goes through to the hand of God. The spear thrust into the side of Jesus goes through into God's."[129] The Holy Spirit needs to be included.

128. See also *Divine Impassibility and the Mystery of Human Suffering*, eds. James F. Keating and Thomas Joseph White, O.P., ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2009). Bruce Marshall claims that God the Son remains impassible because He remains God, quoted in ibid., 298.

129. Stott, *The Cross of Christ*, 158.

Von Balthasar notes that on Calvary "the Son had placed himself at the disposal of the Father so as to guarantee the goodness of the world by his unconditional sacrifice unto the cross. Should not one add—always speaking in human terms—that such willingness on the part of the Son must have affected the Father to the depths of his heart? That it must have required from the Father as great and as selfless a love to accept this offer without mitigation as from the Son who consummated it and from the Holy Spirit who sustained this mutual abandonment of Father and Son and had to endure it himself."[130]

What we have here is more than the Son's dying to satisfy God, His law, and His honor—or to reveal His love. We have the entire Godhead plunging into the depths of self-abnegation. Christ came to reveal what God is like (John 14:9), and He did so in an unparalleled way at the Cross. We see that there is no dualism in the Godhead any more than there is a division among the attributes of God. The entire Godhead is involved in self-sacrifice and self-satisfaction, in which their holiness and love, their justice and mercy, are all active. All members of the Godhead, in the plurality of their attributes, remain true to themselves in the act of saving humans and defeating that which caused them to become lost. Revelation and restoration, self-abnegation and judgment, reconciliation and victory, all were present in Christ's death.

Substitutionary atonement means Christ took our place, received our judgment for sinning, and gave His life a ransom (Matt. 20:28b; Mark 10:45b), even for "all people" (1 Tim. 2:6). He died for all (2 Cor. 5:14). He is the propitiation for the sins of the whole world (1 John 2:2). He took the punishment of sin for everyone, so that no one else needs to receive it. That is holy love. With the sins of billions of humans heaped upon Him, Christ became the Person and place where all sin was present as never before. Sin separates a person from God (Isa. 59:1–2). No wonder the totality of sin was so abhorrent to the Father and the Spirit—and no wonder it was so horrendous to Christ when He cried out, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Mark 15:34b). In the Person of Christ on the cross the Father judged sin, for the wages of sin is death (Rom. 6:23). Christ died because of sin, even though He was sinless. Christ suffered the judgment even though it was in our place. This is universal substitution. This is holy love!

Sin is law breaking (1 John 3:4) and required Calvary to pay sin's wages (Rom. 6:23). What an infinite price for law breaking! God's love is defined at Calvary as a union of justice and mercy, judgment and redemption. Justice does not destroy mercy, and mercy does not destroy justice. They are indissolubly

130. Glenn W. Olsen, "Hans Urs von Balthasar and the Rehabilitation of St. Anselm's Doctrine of the Atonement," *Scottish Journal of Theology*, 34/1 (Feb. 1981): 60–61.

joined. Christ is Judge and Savior (Jas. 4:12); Calvary destroys and delivers; God hates sin and heals the sinner. This is holy love. God's love is not cheap grace. It expects an all-loving response (Ps. 119:2), for "this is love: that we walk in obedience to his commands" (2 John 6). God's love is holy love. In Christ holiness and love are compatible; they differentiate His love from any love that is not *Calvary love.*

John Stott asks, "How, then, could God express his holy love?—his love in forgiving sinners without compromising his holiness, and his holiness in judging sinners without frustrating his love?" The answer: "He bore the judgment we deserve in order to bring us the forgiveness we do not deserve. On the cross divine mercy and justice were equally expressed and eternally reconciled. God's holy love was reconciled."[131] As such God was "a righteous God and a Savior" (Isa. 45:21b).

> The essential background to the cross, therefore, is a balanced understanding of the gravity of sin and the majesty of God. If we diminish either, we thereby diminish the cross. If we reinterpret sin as a lapse instead of a rebellion, and God as indulgent instead of indignant, then naturally the cross appears superfluous. But to dethrone God and enthrone ourselves not only dispenses with the cross; it also degrades both God and man. A biblical view of God and ourselves, however, that is, of our sin and of God's wrath, honors both. It honors human beings by affirming them as responsible for their own actions. It honors God by affirming him as having moral character.[132]

Sin must never be trivialized. There was no way for God to remain true to Himself, true to His attributes of justice and mercy, except to deal with sin in the way that He did. God's justice and mercy were equally involved in solving the sin problem. For God's character, His nature and attributes, are immutable, and that is why He is trustworthy. He is unchangeable (Mal. 3:6). "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8).We can depend on a Trinity that is consistent throughout human history and beyond.

God must be true to Himself as the moral leader of the universe. What should God do with sin, with the rebellion caused by Satan, and with a third of the angels and all humans overtaken by sin? He must deal with sin in such a way that, after its judgment, sin will be hated by all created beings forever. The rebellion questions God's character. The only way God can respond to sin is to allow His character to be revealed. The greatest revelation of God's character takes place at the Cross. John Stott is right to stress God's self-sacrifice at Calvary: "The necessity of 'satisfaction' for God, therefore, is not found in anything

131. Stott, *The Cross of Christ*, 88–89.
132. Ibid., 110.

outside himself but within himself, in his own immutable character. It is an inherent or intrinsic necessity. The law to which he must conform, which he must satisfy, is the law of his own being."[133] Precisely, that is why this system sees that the inner history of reciprocal love among the Persons of the Trinity expresses the essence of God's law—love for God and love for our fellow beings (Matt. 22:37–40).

There is a decisive difference between the death of Christ and that of a martyr. For example, Huss and Jerome experienced the promise that not even death can separate a follower from His Lord (see Rom. 8:38–39). But death separated Christ from His Father (see Matt. 27:46; Mark 15:34). Socrates faced death with joy compared to Christ's utter terror.[134] If Christ's death was merely to reveal God's love, why did He plunge into abject horror, consternation, loathing, and agony?[135] Becoming sin for us was infinitely more than revelation. It was redemption. Christ knew Isaiah predicted "it was the lord's will to crush him and cause him to suffer," even to make Him "an offering for sin" (Isa. 53:10a). So on Calvary Christ "poured out his life unto death, and was numbered with the transgressors" (v. 12b). He "was crushed for our iniquities" (v. 5a). "He himself bore our sins in his body on the cross" (1 Pet. 2:24a). "Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us, for it is written: 'Cursed is everyone who is hung on a pole'" (Gal. 3:13).

In a very real sense Jesus died for us, not for God. In becoming "sin for us," Forsyth suggests, Jesus was "treated as sin (though not as a sinner)." He "experienced sin as God does, while he experienced its effects as man does. He felt sin with God, and sin's judgment with men. He realized, as God, how real sin was, how radical, how malignant, how deadly to the Holy One's very being." He died "at sin's hands," for holiness and sin cannot co-exist.[136] Christ allowed Himself to be put to death by the sins of humanity (John 10:15, 18; 15:13).

There was no other way: "God was reconciling the world to himself in Christ" (2 Cor. 5:19a). All the Trinity suffered at Calvary, for they all experienced the separation: Christ from the Father and the Spirit, and the Father and Spirit from Christ. For the first time in eternity they experienced separation among them, and to that extent experienced the result of sin. Their love for one another did not cease. Christ said, "The reason my Father loves me is that I lay down my life" (John 10:17a). What did cease, through the hours of sin bearing,

133. Ibid., 124.

134. See Oscar Cullmann, *Immortality of the Soul; or, Resurrection of the Dead?* (London: Epworth, 1964), 19–27.

135. For a description of Christ's agony, see Stott, *The Cross of Christ*, 73–74.

136. T. Forsyth, *The Cruciality of the Cross* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1909), 101–102.

was an uninterrupted communion with each other that they had always known. This was the first time the self-sacrificing love of the Trinity had been invaded by sin. That is to say, the effects of sin reached into the inner-Trinitarian being of God to cause the suffering of separation.

Within this context we are now ready to consider the dereliction cry, "*Eli, Eli, lama sabachthani*," which means, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Matt 27:46). These words are dismissed by some as if they were merely put into the mouth of Jesus by the church (one explanation of why they were written in two languages).[137] Some even suggest that this was a normal cry after suffering and loss of blood.[138] Such observations miss the depths of agony involved. D. A. Carson says, "It is better to take the words at face value. Jesus is conscious of being abandoned by his Father. For one who knew the intimacy of Matthew 11:27, such abandonment must have been agony; and for the same reason it is inadequate to hypothesize that Jesus felt abandoned but was not truly abandoned.... In this cry of dereliction, the horror of the world's sin and the cost of our salvation are revealed."[139]

It was heart-wrenching for Christ to be turned down by His own nation, His own church. "We have no king but Caesar" (John 19:15b); "Crucify him! Crucify him!" (Luke 23:21). Had they not read in the holy scroll, "Rejoice greatly, Daughter of Zion! Shout, Daughter of Jerusalem! See, your king comes to you, righteous and victorious, lowly and riding on a donkey"? (Zech. 9:9; cf. Matt. 21:1–4). Christ's mission had not changed them: "Jerusalem, Jerusalem, you who kill the prophets and stone those sent to you, how often I have longed to gather your children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, and you were not willing" (Matt. 23:37).

Judas betrayed Him (Matt. 26:14–56), Peter denied Him (Matt. 26:69–75), and all His disciples ran away and forsook Him when He needed them the most (Matt. 26:56; cf. Isa. 63:3). No wonder He prayed such a mournful prayer: "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Matt. 27:46b)—a cry wrung from quivering lips and a broken heart. This was the price of our redemption, a cost we could never pay and will never fathom, even throughout eternity. The word "cried" (*anaboaō*) is only used here in the New Testament. This "is a strong verb indicating powerful emotion or appeal to God. This is no dispassionate theological statement, but an agonized expression of a real sense of alienation, reflecting the full meaning of Jesus' death as a

137. Alexander Balmain Bruce, "The Synoptic Gospels," in *The Expositor's Greek Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), 1:331–332.

138. W. F. Halliday, *Reconciliation and Reality* (London: Headley Bros. Publishers, 1919), 192.

139. D. A. Carson, *Matthew*, vol. 8 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary*, 579.

'ransom for many' (Matt 20:28). This is, remarkably, the only time in the Synoptic Gospels where Jesus addresses God without calling him 'Father.'"[140]

It is those who "have received the Spirit of adoption as sons (*huiothesias*)" who cry (*krazomen*) "Abba! Father!" (Rom. 8:15, ESV; cf. Gal. 4:6). More than anyone else the Son of God was qualified to address God as *Abba* or *Father*. *Abba* is an Aramaic word for God, an "intimate form for father ('daddy')." Throughout the Gospels Jesus, as the Son of Man, spoke of and prayed to His Father, and He taught His followers to pray "Our Father in heaven" (Matt 6:9, ESV; cf. Luke 6:9). So why did Christ say "My God" instead of *Abba* or *Father*?

Nothing can separate a person from God (Rom. 8:35–39), except sin (Isa. 59:2; cf. Ps. 51:4a, 11; Jer. 3:12), and Christ felt this separation to the depths as He bore "the sins of the whole world" (1 John 2:2b). "The lord has laid on him the iniquity of us all" (Isa. 53:6b). As an eternal member of the Trinity, Christ had always been embraced by the wondrous love of the Father and Spirit. How staggering His separation from them! Never before had He known such loneliness. From the heights of eternal love, He plunged into the abyss to save humanity, whatever the price to Himself, knowing most would reject Him. There is no greater love than this.

Christ felt abandoned, wrenched from the Father, as if no longer the Son of God, for the enormous sum total of sin cursed Him, crushing out His life. Sin bearing separated Jesus from the fellowship He longed for from the Father and Spirit. It was not a case of Christ's dying to appease the wrath of God the Father. Nor did Christ die only to satisfy the law's demand that sin brings death, although this was included. At its deepest level, the plan of salvation was devised by the Trinity to deal with the sin problem.

Each member of the Trinity entered into the self-sacrifice experience of Calvary, each one suffered to a depth that human understanding may never grasp, for infinite, divine, and eternal love was present as Father and Spirit were separated from Christ as He became sin for the world. For humans, nothing can separate them from the love of God (Rom. 8:38–39) because the Trinity took that separation upon themselves in self-sacrifice for sinners at Calvary. That is why God says to humans, "never will I forsake you" (Heb. 13:5b) because Christ experienced God-forsakenness for them (Mark 15:34). The Trinity shared in Christ's substitutionary atonement for humans, not through death, but through separation.

Calvary was judgment on (1) Satan the originator of sin (John 12:21), and on (2) the Savior as substitute for sinners (2 Cor. 5:21; cf. Isa. 53:10–11). Christ's death was the penalty for all human sins. Christ took the place of every human and suffered God's judgment on their sin. Oh wondrous exchange! All

140. R. T. France, *Matthew*, vol. 1 in *Tyndale New Testament Commentaries* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1985), 398.

through His life Christ had clung to God. He depended solely on God (Father and Spirit) in a union that knew no separation, and sometimes required whole nights in prayer (Luke 6:12). Fellowship with God was heaven to Him in a world so unlike His real home. Christ found escape from the depravity all around Him by communing with God. He sensed the Father so close that He could say, "the Father is in me, and I in the Father" (John 10:38b).

The God-Man Jesus came to the brink—where He needed God the most. Yet precisely at the time of His greatest need, He felt utterly abandoned. It is impossible to comprehend the utter horror of that terrible loneliness. To watch Jesus suffer and die as the God-Man must have caused immense pain to the Father and Spirit, as they suffered together with Jesus. Christ's cry was "the most staggering sentence in the gospel record.... That is a saying before which we must bow in reverence, and yet at the same time we must try to understand."[141] Although Christ had previously spoken of His resurrection (Matt. 16:21) and even of His return at the second advent (Matt. 16:27), during the darkest hour on the Cross He could not see through the darkness to His resurrection and second advent. Yet, He was willing to perish in order to save humans as "he poured out his life unto death" (Isa. 53:12b).

Each member of the Trinity suffered at the Cross, for Christ was deeply loved by the Father and the Spirit, and it wrenched their hearts to hear the Man of Sorrows cry out, "My God, my God, why have your forsaken me?" (Mark 15:34). They had not forsaken Him (cf. John 16:32), but the payment for all human guilt meant Christ as substitute bore the punishment for sin. There was no other way. It was not only an angry God punishing human guilt, but a heart-broken Father and Spirit suffering with Christ as He alone was the sacrifice for sin. None will ever understand the depths of shared suffering of the Trinity during the hours Jesus hung on the cross. Only faintly does it come to mind in the words: "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son" (John 3:16a). All the Trinity were present at the Cross. Never was Jesus loved more by the Father and Spirit than when He felt abandoned by them.

Bavinck has it right, "At the same time, seeing the death of Christ as satisfaction for sin, as divine punishment, does not mean there is a rift in the Godhead between an angry Father and the loving Son he punishes. Through Christ's death, expiation of sins, righteousness, and eternal life are secured for believers. God's grace does not nullify the satisfaction and merit of Christ but is the ultimate ground for that merit. It is the love of God that sent the Son into the world (John 3:16), and on the cross Jesus remained the beloved Son."[142] Morris says

141. W. Barclay, *The Gospel of Matthew* (Philadelphia, PA: Westminster, 1975), 2:368.
142. Bavinck, *Sin and Salvation in Christ*, vol. 3 in *Reformed Dogmatics*, 325–326.

it well, "We are not to think of a loving Son wringing salvation from a just but stern Father. It is the will of the Father that all be saved and salvation is accomplished—not with the wave of the hand, so to speak—but by what God has done in Christ: 'God was in Christ reconciling the world to himself.' (2 Cor 5:19 RSV), reconciliation brought about by the death of Christ (Rom 5:10)."[143]

Just before death, in sheer faith, Christ again speaks to God as Father: "Father, into your hands I commit my spirit" (Luke 23:46b). Oh wonder of wonders, the helpless human Jesus, possessing full divinity within, never depended on His own divinity, but hung on to the divinity of His Father, even though as sin-bearer He felt forsaken by God! Who can understand the depths of sacrifice involved?

As I gaze upon the Cross, I cry out to God to break my heart, to cause me to realize it was for my law breaking, my sin, my guilt, that He died; I cry out that I might love Him with all my heart, and love His law and hate sin because of what it did to Him. Sin crucifies Christ afresh (Heb. 6:6). May we all declare, "Lord, break my heart that I may not break Yours. May I accept your Calvary love, Your power over sin!" We cannot live as He did without Him. Because Christ plunged into the agony of separation from God, experiencing what it is like to be God-forsaken, He promises us "Never will I leave you; never will I forsake you" (Heb. 13:5b; cf. Deut. 31:6). He experienced the ultimate in suffering so that we will never have to—what awesome substitution! (See Appendix D for the nonviolent view of the atonement, which fails to appreciate the depth of the substitutionary atonement.)

Did God Have Other Options?

Was salvation through the death of Christ the only option for God? Even though all things are subject to God's power, Augustine said, "there neither was nor need have been any other mode more appropriate for curing our misery."[144] Aquinas agreed, adding that "man knows how much God loves him, and is thereby stirred to love Him in return."[145] The nature of God is love (1 John 4:8–16; see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 2). Rebellion is the opposite of love. Salvation's plan is to restore sinners to a relationship of love with God, and to achieve this God acts out of His loving nature to win rebels through love. In other words, the greatest weapon God has is love, and that love was not revealed through omnipotence but in humility—even death on the Cross. Restoration of the cosmos to what it once was, a

143. Leon L. Morris, "Atonement," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 114.

144. Augustine, *On the Trinity*, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, ed. Philip Schaff (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988), 3:174 (13.10.13).

145. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, 4:2260 (Pt. 3, Q.46, Art. 3).

place where love alone existed, is achieved through God's manifesting His love as never before: by taking the place of all sinners in His sacrifice on the cross.

CROSS CENTERED

All the atonement theories relate to the Cross in one way or other. Some attempt to describe what took place there, while others detract from the reality of what happened there. The key fact is that no single theory that exists can do justice to what took place on the Cross, nor can the sum of all known theories exhaust the meaning of what happened there.

It is also true that the Cross must be understood within the context of the eternal plan of the Trinity to save humankind (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 8). Many theories of the atonement are Binitarian rather than Trinitarian. They speak of the Father and Christ, leaving out the place and function of the Holy Spirit. But any balanced understanding of the atonement must include all three members of the Godhead.[146] One must grasp the fact that "God could be atoned by no outside party…the Father suffered in His Son even more than the Son did."[147] I believe this is also true of the Holy Spirit.

A balanced atonement theory must include these three crucial facts as well: (1) our involvement in crucifying Christ, since the Cross was not merely a payment offered to God (Anselm), a revelation by God (Abelard), or a victory by God (Aulen); (2) the cosmic controversy context which considers the Cross as having cosmic significance rather than simply God's doing something for humans (Abelard) or as the God-Man's doing something just for God (Anselm); and (3) a careful study of the dereliction cry, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Matt. 27:46). When these are understood as they should be, then the *substitutionary and cosmic atonement theory*[148] that I am proposing in this chapter can be seen to better reflect the breadth of the atonement as found in Scripture. Let us ponder this as we take up the remaining segments of this chapter, keeping in mind that there is more to the atonement than this or any other theory can present.

WE CRUCIFIED CHRIST

Many theories of atonement examine Christ's work from outside it, but the real culprit can only be seen if we reflect inward. "Indeed, the fatal flaw in most thinking about the atoning work of Christ is the tendency to look away from the actual events, translate them into 'eternal truths,' and thus to ignore

146. One "general feature of Western thought in the atonement" is that it is "essentially binitarian"; Keith W. Clements, "Atonement and the Holy Spirit," *Expository Times*, 95/6 (1984): 169.

147. P. T. Forsyth, *The Justification of God* (New York: C. Scribner's Sons, 1917), 174.

148. Although I coined this term, this theory is not exclusively mine.

or obscure what actually happened and our part in it. We interpret Christ's death as though it were an idea, a necessary part of a logical scheme of some sort, as though God were tied to a scheme of honor or justice making him the obstacle to our reconciliation. We exonerate ourselves, so to speak, by blaming the necessity for the cross on God."[149]

An element missing or inadequately treated in the three major views of the atonement (Anselm, Abelard, and Aulen) is the fact that we crucified Christ. Abelard at most touched on it when he asked Anselm, If Adam's sin had to be "satisfied" (as Anselm insisted), how much more satisfaction was needed for those who crucified Christ?[150] Without detracting from our involvement in Christ's crucifixion, the answer to how much more satisfaction was needed is found in the truth that Calvary is God's self-sacrifice made with a cosmic scope and an eternal depth measurable only in the cosmic controversy worldview and the dereliction cry.

COSMIC CONTROVERSY WORLDVIEW

Many theories of atonement concern only humankind and God. Anselm focused on what humans alive in Christ can do to restore God's honor, whereas Abelard focused on what God can do to restore humans. Grotius looked beyond to God's government, and Aulen to His victory over the devil. In broadening their focus, Grotius and Aulen began to open up the issues involved in the cosmic controversy. This broader worldview is essential in order to understand what happened at the Cross, because the Cross had to do with more than human salvation. It was necessary that the mercy and justice of God be clearly manifested. Because Satan charged that no created being could keep the law, Christ had to come, and as a dependent human live the law, showing that He could keep the law, though obedience to God would take Him even to death—actually the second death. Calvary was the ultimate demonstration of an obedient, law-keeping human life, a revelation of a perfect Man. Calvary also revealed a perfect God. "God was in Christ, reconciling the world unto himself" (2 Cor. 5:19, KJV).

The substitutionary suffering at Calvary was necessitated by God's own nature. God could not allow rebellion to go unpunished and expect to preserve His government, and those within His rule. When scholars revolt against a Father punishing His Son, and call it child abuse, they overlook two critical facts: (1) Punishment was not merely necessitated by the Father's

149. Forde, "Caught in the Act," *Word and World*, 23.

150. Peter Abelard, "Exposition of the Epistle to the Romans," in Eugene R. Fairweather, ed. and trans., *A Scholastic Miscellany: Anselm to Ockham*, vol. 10 in *The Library of Christian Classics* (Philadelphia, PA: Westminster Press), 282–283.

nature, but by the nature of the Trinity. So each member of the Trinity poured themselves out at Calvary—true, in different ways—but they all suffered. (2) Christ was not a mere child at Calvary, but an adult who willingly lay down His life to bring salvation to humans. Christ said, "The reason my Father loves me is that I lay down my life—only to take it up again. No one takes it from me, but I lay it down of my own accord. I have authority to lay it down and authority to take it up again. This command I received from my Father" (John 10:17–18). So Christ was not a victim, but a willing accomplice.

So Paul was right when he said Jesus "gave himself for me" (Gal. 2:20). There is an eternal freedom of choice in the Trinity, for the reciprocal love in their inner history is an overflowing love, and this includes the Father's love for His Son. Although it was "the Lord's will to crush him [Christ] and cause him to suffer" (Isa. 53:10), this was done in overflowing love for Christ. Knowing the entire plan of salvation, Jesus said, "I have come to do your will, my God" (Heb. 10:7b). Christ consented to become the sin-bearer, and it was excruciating for the Father and Spirit to see Him carry out the plan. Just before Calvary, Jesus said to the Father, "[Y]ou loved me before the creation of the world" (John 17:24b). That love was present among the Persons of the Trinity as they together participated in saving humans at the Cross. All three members of the Trinity bore the punishment for sin, and this was a necessity arising from their nature and government. This is not the language of tritheism, but the reality of the One God that suffered at Calvary in different ways, "[f]or God so loved the world" (John 3:16).

The love of the Trinity was revealed at the Cross, as well as their justice in dealing with rebellion. Satan questioned the love and justice of God, but Calvary showed how wrong he was, and how deceptive is the cosmic controversy, for it parades itself as having a just cause but is exposed on the Cross as instrumental in putting to death the Son of God. Whereas Satan was bent on destroying Christ, the Savior bore the sins of the world to save as many humans as would accept His gift. For Calvary was atonement day. But atonement even includes the present ministry of Christ in heaven. Whereas the atonement sacrifice was completed on Calvary, the atonement sanctification is an ongoing application of what took place at the Cross, through an outpouring of the Spirit (to be taken up in chapter 14).[151]

If Calvary was the completed atonement sacrifice that exposed Satan and revealed God to a depth never comprehended before, why was it not the final moment of human history? Why didn't the Second Advent take place immediately? The Cross is like a mountain. Up close one cannot take in the entire

151. Christ returned to earth at Pentecost through the Spirit (John 14:16–18) and remains with His people until the Second Coming (Matt. 28:20; Heb. 13:5).

mountain or view its full context. But from a distance one can better see it for what it is. The passing of time has no more added to the Cross than walking to a distant vantage point adds anything to a mountain. But the passing of time has brought into clearer focus what really took place at the Cross. All eternity will serve to continue its clarification. Neither one atonement theory nor the sum of all atonement theories can match its profound depths.

Conclusion

The atonement sacrificially took place at the Cross, in a substitution that affected all the Trinity as participants in the gift, all humans willing to receive the gift, and all unfallen created beings who observed the gift. This plan of salvation has eternity behind it and eternal study ahead of it. This atonement will enable all created beings, unfallen and redeemed, to be loyal to God, so that rebellion never arises again. This is why I choose to call it the *substitutionary and cosmic atonement.* Calvary is the inestimable gift of substitutionary atonement, which is the solid foundation for the application of it since Calvary (which is taken up in and beyond the next chapter).

Paul said, "If Christ has not been raised, your faith is futile; you are still in your sins" (1 Cor. 15:17). The author of Hebrews says it is the risen Christ who "always lives to intercede" for humans (Heb. 7:25). "For if, while we were God's enemies, we were reconciled to him through the death of his Son, how much more, having been reconciled, shall we be saved through his life!" (Rom. 5:10). Some have considered the importance of the resurrection,[152] but few theologians have considered the importance of Christ's ministry in the heavenly sanctuary, throughout the post-resurrection Christian era, as vital to the atonement. The book of Hebrews and parts of the book of Revelation reveal God's post-crucifixion work of atonement.

Study Questions

1. How was salvation's plan illustrated after Adam and Eve's first sin?
2. How did the Passover reveal salvation's plan?
3. How did the earthly sanctuary provide an outline of salvation's plan?
4. What does considering the origin of salvation's plan tell us about God?
5. What is the biblical critique of John Calvin's view of salvation?

152. Here are a few. The importance of the resurrection is given by Theodore R. Clark, *Saved by His Life* (New York: Macmillan, 1959), 70–93. The same concern, cited here by Clark, 40–41, is found in G. R. Beasley-Murray, *Christ Is Alive* (London: Lutterworth, 1947), 12, and Hugh T. Kerr, "Theological Table Talk," *Theology Today*, 14/1 (April 1957): 107–108; cf. Wolf, *No Cross, No Crown*, 107.

6. Many theologians believe creation was the first step toward Christ's incarnation. How does this impact our understanding of the Incarnation, and why is this wrong?
7. Why are there so many atonement theories?
8. What is the moral influence atonement theory, and how should it be evaluated in light of Scripture?
9. Why did Christ feel abandoned on the cross, and how did this affect the Father and Spirit?
10. What is the *substitutionary and cosmic atonement theory*? Fully explain why it does the best justice to the full breadth of salvation?
11. Why is the atonement a vicarious transfer of sin, and not corporate?

Appendices

APPENDIX A: BRIEF HISTORY OF SOME ATONEMENT THEORIES

Karl Runia once observed, "To write a book on the subject of the Atonement is a hazardous enterprise, to write an article is even more hazardous."[153] This is due to several reasons,[154] including the fact that the atonement is unfathomable in this life,[155] or in eternity. Theories of the atonement abound. However, the Christian church has never taken an official stand on the atonement as it has on Christology[156] and the Trinity. There is an orthodox position on the person of Christ but not on the work of Christ. As Gerhard Forde notes, "The church in America is sorely split between the children of Anselm (the 'satisfaction theory' or 'substitutionary sacrifice') and the children of Abelard (the 'moral influence theory')."[157] Frank A. James III puts it this way: The atonement "has proven difficult for Christian theologians to adequately probe the full depth of the meaning of this doctrine within a single all-encompassing theory.... It is complex and multifaceted and has

153. Karl Runia, "The Doctrine of the Atonement: Are We Heading Towards a Consensus?" *Reformation Theology Review*, 21.2 (1962): 45.

154. Because of space limitations, and especially because this subject has aroused "fiercer resentment and opposition" than any other, compare J. K. Mozley, *The Doctrine of the Atonement* (London: Gerald Duckworth and Co., 1962), v.

155. Leon Morris, *The Cross of Christ in the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1965), 412; William J. Wolf, *No Cross, No Crown*, 25; Thomas H. Hughes, *The Atonement, Modern Theories of the Doctrine* (London: George Allen and Unwin and Co., 1949), 306.

156. The Councils of Nicaea (321) and Chalcedon (451).

157. See Gerhard Forde, "The Work of Christ" in *Christian Dogmatics*, vol. 2, ed. C. E. Braaten and R. W. Jensen (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1984).

therefore defied Christian consensus."[158] Therefore, none of the theories have gained universal acceptance.

Most theories of the atonement are not wrong in what they assert, but there is more to the atonement than what they expound (although the ransom to view is simply wrong). In fact, the sum total of all good atonement theories fails to do full justice to the atonement. So at best, most theories contribute a valuable insight, but fail to do more than that.

Church Fathers

Besides the ransom theory of the atonement (presented earlier), different theories of the atonement are found in the writings of the church fathers, with Irenaeus and Athanasius stressing the Incarnation, a focus continued in the divinization or deification process (*theosis*) of Eastern Orthodox theology, and Origen and Gregory of Nyssa viewing the crucifixion as a ransom made to Satan. The truth is Christ never paid a ransom to Satan to free humans. Satan laid claim over fallen humans, but this was a usurped claim, for sinners do not cease to belong to God. For example, Christ taught that a prodigal sinner can still be a prodigal son (Luke 15:11–32).

Middle Ages

Anselm (1033–1109) of Canterbury wrote *Cur Deus Homo* (*Why God Became a Man*), in which he presented the satisfaction theory that criticized the ransom theory. Sin didn't usurp humans from God's ownership, but sin was an affront to God's honor. Because sin was so immense an insult to God that only God could pay it, yet it was Adam who sinned, God became human and as the God-Man paid the price to restore God's dignity. But in this transaction the Cross was not an act of salvation for sinners, which meant the Cross was not necessary to save humans. This theory seems to be a reaction to sin rather than an atonement for sin. Anselm's contemporary Peter Abelard (1079–1142) held a moral influence theory that took the Cross more seriously by saying that Christ's death affected humans, revealing God's love for them, but the Cross did not do more than that.

Reformers

The Reformers' penal substitution theory did not merely focus on God's honor (Anselm) or the effects of the Cross (Abelard), but on the law of God upheld by redemption secured at the Cross. After all, more than God's honor

158. Frank A. James III, general introduction to *The Glory of the Atonement*, ed. Charles E. Hill & Frank A. James III (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2004), 16.

was at stake, His law had been challenged—and His law is the foundation of His rule. Not even God could change His law by merely forgiving lawbreakers. Christ died to maintain the sacredness of His law. Therefore, the Cross needed to be more than a revelation of God's love; it also needed to reveal the unchanging nature of His law. Law breaking called for atonement. In simple terms, the Cross was more than a revelation, it was redemption. There is no value to revelation if it lacks the content of redemption.

John Calvin (1509–1564) and the Reformed wing of the Reformation believed in a limited atonement, meaning Christ died only for the elect. The rest were reprobates. This view was officially adopted by Synod of Dort (1618–1619), and is expressed in the acronym TULIP: total depravity, unconditional predestination, limited atonement, irresistible grace, and perseverance of the saints.

Hugo Grotius (1583–1645), a jurist in the Dutch Republic, was a philosopher, Arminian theologian, and Christian apologist. He stated that God as ruler of His government declared that sin should be punished by death, and so sinners should die. But when sin entered the human race, God didn't want them to die; "he relaxed that rule and accepted the death of Christ instead." Morris comments: "He could have simply forgiven humankind if he wanted to, but that would not have any value for society. The death of Christ was a public example of the sin and the lengths to which God would go to uphold the moral order of the universe."[159]

This doesn't do justice to an unchanging God (Mal. 3:6; Heb. 13:8). Some argue that it does justice to the Cross as the place where God's moral order of the universe is maintained. But how can the moral order be maintained when a moral rule can be changed?

Nineteenth Century

In the nineteenth century the mystical theory of the atonement was made particularly popular by the leading theologian of that century, Friedrich Schleiermacher (1768–1834); his system is *The Christian Faith* (1830). This view didn't require any contribution from the Cross.

James McLeod Campbell (1800–1872), in his 1856 book *The Nature of the Atonement*, posited an existentialist presentation, which viewed atonement from a human experience perspective. Campbell didn't view Calvary as a substitutionary sacrifice but as a sympathetic identification, a repentance rather than an expiation, a vicarious repentance rather than a vicarious punishment.[160] Perhaps his greatest contribution was to focus on Christ's

159. L. L. Morris, "Atonement, Theories of," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 118.

160. James McLeod Campbell, *The Nature of the Atonement: And Its Relation to Remission of Sins and Eternal Life* (London: James Clark & Co., 1959), xv-xvii; Lewis Sperry Chafer, *Systematic Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Kregel, 1993, 1st ed. 1947–1948), 3:160–161.

death for all humans, rather than limited to the elect as in John Calvin and Reformed theology.[161] However, he taught universalism, the same ultimate end as Barth's system, Barth's protestations notwithstanding. Campbell was condemned by the Church of Scotland in 1831.

Edward Irving (1792–1834) called John Campbell (1788–1866), a contemporary and fellow Scotsman, a "holy man of God" for understanding God's gift of salvation to be for both the reprobate and the elect.[162] Irving and Campbell were going beyond the limited atonement in the Church of Scotland, which followed Calvinism. In understanding the Cross as a universal gift of salvation, they were biblical, and were providing a necessary corrective to the more limited view that confined God's love to the elect, which was an injustice to God's love revealed in Scripture (John 3:16; 1 John 2:2). Both men were expelled from their ministry, but both had other nonbiblical beliefs. So like Campbell, Irving failed to understand the substitutionary atonement at Calvary, even though both understood the universal atonement at Calvary. They were right in including all humans in redemption, but wrong in excluding all that God accomplished in redemption.

Twentieth Century

Gustaf Aulén (1879–1977) was Bishop of Strängnäs in the Church of Sweden, a theologian, composer, and president of the Royal Swedish Academy of Music (1944–1950). His greatest theological work was *Christus Victor*, in which Christ's death is presented at Calvary as a victory over the enemy. This is in harmony with Christ's victory over Satan at Calvary, but this was only one aspect of the Cross.

To balance this victory focus, it should be stressed that it was Christ's humanity that concluded a perfect human life at Calvary, assisted by God's grace which is available to all humans. Christ's victory from Incarnation to crucifixion was never achieved through His own divinity. Calvary was not a showdown between the Creator and Satan; rather, it was Satan's failure to defeat the humanity of Christ in death.

B. B. Warfield spoke about "Modern Theories of the Atonement" in a religious conference at Princeton Seminary on October 13, 1902. He noted there is no such thing as a modern theory of the atonement because all theories are found in history.[163]

161. Ibid., 297–316.

162. Irving, *The Collected Writings of Edward Irving*, 1:606, cf. 1:600.

163. B. B. Warfield, "Modern Theories of the Atonement," *Princeton Review*, 1903, quoted in Chafer, *Systematic Theology*, 3:155–164.

APPENDIX B: THEORIES OF ATONEMENT IN LIGHT OF GOD'S HOLINESS AND HUMAN SIN[164]

In this section we take up some atonement theories in light of God's holiness and human sin.[165] There are many classifications.[166] We will follow the arrangement and arguments used by Millard Erickson, who classifies theories as Socinian, Moral Influence, Governmental, Ransom, and Satisfaction. To this we will add data of our own.

(1) *Socinian theory: atonement as example.* For Faustus Socinus (1539–1604) and his uncle, Laelius Socinus (1525–1562), Christ's death was merely an extension of His teaching, an example He presented to humankind. The Socinians minimized the holiness of God and the sinfulness of humans.

(2) *Moral Influence theory: atonement as demonstrating God's love.* For Peter Abelard (1079–1142), the death of Christ provided a moral influence to do right. Christ did not come to die, but He died because He came. Horace Bushnell (1802–1876) and Hastings Rashdall (1858–1924) were later exponents of this view. Again, both the holiness of God and the sinfulness of humans were minimized.

(3) *Governmental theory: atonement as demonstrating God's justice.* For Hugo Grotius (1583–1645), a lawyer, the law was vital, and hence sin, or law breaking, was taken seriously. This was an advance over the two theories we have examined so far. Whereas those two theories were relatively subjective in nature (aimed at producing a change in humans), the governmental theory was both subjective and objective.

164. For this segment, see Morris, "Atonement, Theories of," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 116–119; Louis Berkhof, *Systematic Theology*, 384–391; John Calvin considered Christ's one "office" from the Father; to be prophet and king and also priest (His present intercession being vital), *Institutes*, 1:425–432 (2.15.1–6) and 1:463 (3.1.1). Some theologians consider Christ's death and intercession as two aspects of the atonement; for example, Hans LaRondelle, *Christ Our Salvation: What God Does for Us and in Us* (Mountain View, CA: Pacific Press Publishing Assn., 1980). For some "salvation, resides in the total fact of Christ" rather than "one element, such as his birth or his death," George S. Hendry, *The Gospel of the Incarnation* (Philadelphia, PA: The Westminster Press, 1958), 115. Early Christians focused on the "being" of Christ, the Reformers on the "work" of Christ, and Karl Barth on His being and work together as a double movement within the divine and human natures of Jesus Christ. For Barth, atonement included the going into the far country of the divine Son of God so that concurrently there could be a homecoming of humanity in the Son of Man, Barth, *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, vol. 4, pt. 1 in *Church Dogmatics*, 157–779, and vol. 4, pt. 2, 3–840. The co-existence of the states of humiliation/exaltation reminds one of John Brenz, or Brentius (1499–1570). The states co-existed from the Incarnation onward, for His humanity on earth was weak and suffering while simultaneously His divinity was almighty and omnipresent in heaven. See Schaff, vol. 1 in *The Creeds of Christendom*, 291. Others have seen Calvary as central to the atonement, Leon Morris, *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 97; Stott, *The Cross of Christ*, 17; cf. Dillistone, *Jesus Christ and His Cross*, 11; Grounds, *Baker's Dictionary of Theology*, 71.

165. See Douglas Bennett, "A Review of the Doctrine of Atonement," *Adventist Perspectives* 211 (1988): 35–48.

166. Major atonement theories are classified as (1) Socinian, Bushnellian, Grotian, Irvingian, Anselmic, and Ethical: A. H. Strong, *Systematic Theology*, 728–766; (2) Objective-Anselmian, Subjective-Abelard, and *Christus Victor*: G. Aulen, *Christus Victor* (New York: The MacMillan Co., 1969), 2; Hendry, *The Gospel of the Incarnation*, 115–116; (3) Substitutional, Representational, and Moral Influence: Halliday, *Reconciliation and Reality*, 19; (4) Victory, Satisfaction, and Effect: Morris, *The Cross in the New Testament*, 397; (5) Greek, Latin, Reformation, Moral Influence, and Others: Wolf, *No Cross, No Crown*, 930; and as (6) Socinian, Moral Influence, Governmental, Ransom, and Satisfaction: Erickson, *Christian Theology*, 781–800.

Christ's death was seen as satisfying the justice of God (objective) and as a deterrent to prevent humankind from sinning (subjective). Both the holiness of God and the sinfulness of humans were kept in view in this theory. But because Grotius did not believe punishment could be transferred from one person to another, he said Christ did not suffer humankind's punishment. Rather, he said, Christ suffered to make punishment unnecessary, because the demonstration He provided was supposed to turn humans from sin—and thereby preserve God's government. Thus, Grotius's view was diametrically opposed to the view of Socinus.

(4) *Ransom theory: atonement as victory over evil.* Gustaf Aulén (1879–1978) considered God's self-reconciliation[167] to be the classic view.[168] Before the appearance of Aulen's 1931 *Christus Victor*, studies on the atonement usually began with Anselm. Aulen's contribution was to focus on the thousand years before Anselm and to present Christ's victory as the theme running through the writings of such persons as Origen (185–254), Gregory of Nyssa (ca. 330–395), and Augustine (354–430). After the fall of Adam and Eve, Satan was the usurper-ruler of this world. Origen believed that Satan, not God, demanded Christ's death as a ransom for humankind. Gregory of Nyssa added to Origen's view, stating that Christ's divinity was hidden behind His human flesh so that, in accepting Christ as a ransom, Satan would be like a fish that swallowed the hook with the bait. Gregory saw no problem in such a deception. Augustine could even liken the Cross to a mousetrap with Christ's blood as the bait. Unlike other theories, this one claimed atonement had no effect on God or humans but only on Satan. As W. J. Wolf observed, "Aulen has done a service by recovering one of four distinct patristic insights into the nature of salvation and atonement, but he has seriously distorted the case by stressing the *Christus Victor* theme as the 'dominant' one in both the fathers and the New Testament."[169]

(5) *Satisfaction theory: atonement as compensating the Father.* Anselm (1033–1109), sometime archbishop of Canterbury, lived during the feudal period of British history, a time when the idea of satisfaction was popular. In his *Cur Deus Homo* (*Why God Became Man*), Anselm denied that any ransom was paid to Satan. Both humans and the devil belong to God, he said. Christ died to satisfy a principle in God Himself. Anselm's theory was based on a view of sin as the failure to render God His due. Man owed God a debt so great that only God could pay it. But humankind, not God, owed the debt, so humans must pay. Why did God become the God-Man? So that He could pay humankind's debt to God.

167. Called the ransom theory by Erickson, *Concise Dictionary of Christian Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1986), 139.

168. Aulen, *Christus Victor*, 4–7.

169. Wolf, *No Cross, No Crown*, 100.

Let's summarize the major views we've glanced at in this segment. The ransom-to-the-devil theory was popular in the early church. Anselm brought in a change by stating that satisfaction was paid to God, not to the devil, by the human Jesus. Abelard challenged Anselm, saying that God made the payment on the Cross and that He did so to change humans. Finally, Aulen reconsidered the first thousand years, claiming that the Cross was a victory over the devil rather than a ransom to him.

APPENDIX C: THEORIES OF THE ATONEMENT IN LIGHT OF GOD'S ATTRIBUTES

Theory	God's Attribute	Basic Goal	Object	Key Verses	Proponent
Recapitulation	Omnipotence	Reverse the Fall	Satan	Rom. 5:15–21	Irenaeus
Ransom	Wisdom	Defeat Satan	Satan	Mark 10:45	Origen
Moral Example	Love	Show God's love to us	Humanity	Rom. 5:8; 5:17–19	Pelagius, Abelard
Necessary Satisfaction	Majesty	Pay the debt of sin	God	1 John 2:1	Anselm
Optional Satisfaction	Mercy	Restore the sinner	Humanity	Luke 19:10	Aquinas
Substitution	Justice	Appease wrath; release mercy	God	2 Cor. 5:21; Rom. 3:21–25	Calvin
Governmental	Sovereignty	Keep moral order	God and Humanity	Isa. 42:21	Grotius
Mystical	Oneness	Unite us with God	Humanity	Eph. 4:3–4; 5:30–32	Schleiermacher

In the above table, Norman Geisler indicates how atonement theories relate to the attributes of God.[170]

In conclusion, Geisler, an apologist, states, "Each view of the Atonement appears to be related to one or more of God's attributes, showing how His redemptive actions are rooted in His very nature and not simply His arbitrary will."[171] I concur that most of the theories do not focus on the will of God. However, I would add that Calvin's theory of the atonement is an exception, because it is based solely upon God's absolute sovereign will (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 15). I would also add that the attributes of God are grounded in His nature as love, so that properly understood God's loving will is appropriately involved in biblical atonement.

APPENDIX D: NONVIOLENT VIEW OF THE ATONEMENT

Written from a pacifist perspective, Mennonite J. Denny Weaver's 2001 book *The Nonviolent Atonement* opposes the substitutionary sacrifice of Christ. True to Mennonite tradition, Weaver rejects violence. He presents a narrative *Christus Victor* (Christ as victor) atonement theory. His thesis is this: The satisfaction atonement theory is founded on violence, or God's punishing Christ on the cross. By contrast, Weaver points to the life of Christ as revealing God's nonviolent rule (for example: turning the other cheek, and asking Peter to sheath his sword).[172] Weaver focuses on "Jesus' life as the reign of God rather than on Jesus' death as an act of God. Narrative *Christus Victor* is a biblical way of understanding the salvific work of Jesus without imaging God as one who abuses the perfect Son for the benefit of others."[173] He calls for the "narrative *Christus Victor* to replace Anselm as the Christian understanding of atonement."[174]

God did not abuse His Son on the cross. The Trinity all entered into the suffering of Calvary, as far as sin's separation is concerned. This was the first time the Persons of the self-existent Trinity had been separated, and no human can understand the immense suffering they shared. Was it not harder to see Christ go through the agony than to do so themselves? Christ willingly came to do His Father's will (Heb. 10:5–7; cf. Ps. 40:6–8), which is totally different from being abused. We also need to understand that it was God in Christ reconciling the world (2 Cor. 5:19).

170. Norman Geisler, *Sin, Salvation*, vol. 3 in *Systematic Theology* (Minneapolis, MN: Bethany, 2004), 217.
171. Ibid., 217–218.
172. J. Denny Weaver, *The Nonviolent Atonement* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2001), 9, 40.
173. Ibid., 226.
174. Ibid., 228.

Further, Weaver insists that the narrative *Christus Victor* is:

> much more than an atonement motif. It poses a comprehensive way to see God working in the world, and thus suggests a reading of the Bible story from beginning to end. In this story, God enters the world with the call of Abraham. The history of Israel shows their continuing effort to understand who they were as the people of God and how to understand their mission to make God's rule visible in the world. In Jesus there is a new level of God's working in the world. Through this story it is the calling of God's people to be a visible witness to the reign of God made visible.[175]

There seems to be only a difference in degree among the revelation of God's rule made through Abraham, Israel, and Christ. The focus is on revelation in history—revelation made in the lives of God's representatives. Yet what is the purpose of the revelation of God's reign, even in human lives, if there is no redemption content supplied through Calvary? Revelation without redemption reminds one of the moral influence view of the atonement. At best these views are only partial.

Weaver also points out that African-American and feminist contributions deplore the fact that God killed Christ, which reminds them of violence against African-Americans and women.[176] Weaver claims, "Jesus' death is not a loving act of God, but the ultimate statement that distinguishes the rule of God from the reign of evil."[177] Hence:

> Salvation is to begin to be free from those evil forces, and to be transformed by the reign of God and to take on a life shaped—marked—by the story of Jesus, whose mission was to make visible the reign of God in our history. In carrying out that mission, Jesus was killed by the earthly structures in bondage to the power of evil. His death was not a payment owed to God's honor, nor was it divine punishment that he suffered as a substitute for sinners. Jesus' death was the rejection of the rule of God by forces opposed to that rule.[178]

How can God's victory over Satan produce salvation? Had not the children of Israel witnessed God's amazing defeat of the entire Egyptian army at the Red Sea? Was that not sufficient to provide salvation, with no need of a substitutionary sacrifice at Calvary? That's the kind of reasoning Weaver is using about the Cross. It follows that "Jesus' death is not a loving act of God, but the ultimate statement that distinguishes the rule of God from the reign of evil."[179] Weaver attempts to present a nonviolent God, and in so doing fails to grasp God's hatred of sin, ignoring God's judgments against sin and sinners,

175. Ibid., 226.
176. Ibid., 5.
177. Ibid., 45.
178. Ibid., 44.
179. Ibid., 45.

for Christ said of Calvary, "Now is the time for judgment on this world" (John 12:31a). Justice and mercy met each other at the Cross. Justice was God's judgment on human sin, and mercy was God's taking that judgment upon Himself in place of humans. If Calvary doesn't reveal God's love and provide redemption through the sacrifice of Christ, then how can the Cross draw all created beings to God (John 12:32) and keep them loyal and free so that the entire cosmos will be secure forever (Rev. 21:2–4; 22:3–5)?

Even though the *Christus Victor* atonement theory speaks of Christ's victory, and hence of the conflict between Christ and Satan, Weaver fails to understand the contribution of Christ's death in defeating the cosmic controversy so that it will never arise again in the eternal future. Christ says of the Cross judgment: "[N]ow the prince of this world will be driven out" (John 12:31b). Weaver fails to realize that the cosmic contribution of Calvary is to secure the universe from another controversy arising in the future, because all created beings will be in awe of the awesome sacrifice of Christ on the cross.

Contrary to Weaver's view of Calvary as merely humans killing Christ, Scripture presents God as the One who gave Jesus to the world in order to save humans. "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life. For God did not send his Son into the world to condemn the world, but to save the world through him" (John 3:16–17). "He [Christ] was delivered over to death for our sins" (Rom. 4:25a). For "without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness" (Heb. 9:22b).

APPENDIX E: MY PROPOSAL—THE SUBSTITUTIONARY AND COSMIC ATONEMENT VIEW

The *substitutionary and cosmic atonement* view transcends the governmental theory, which only focuses on humans, thus denying the substitutionary atonement. The substitutionary and cosmic atonement view breaks new ground by noting the cosmic future results of Christ's substitutionary death. In so doing, this theory penetrates to the broadest meaning of salvation—to save humans from sin, and to keep all created beings from sinning. In this regard it includes a moral influence on created beings that preserves God's government forever, which takes the *Christus Victor* theme to its logical conclusion. However, even this theory cannot fully do justice to all that is involved in the atonement.

Even though the *Christus Victor* atonement theory speaks of Christ's victory, and hence of the conflict between Christ and Satan, it fails to understand the contribution of Christ's death to defeat the cosmic controversy in terms of its never arising again in the eternal future.

Perhaps one reason why the cosmos is not included in the atonement through Calvary is because hell is alleged to be an eternal reality. In other words, the victory at the Cross is questioned to the extent that Satan and his followers will have eternal existence, so that Christ's death will not ultimately destroy them, even though Christ's mission was to destroy the devil's work (1 John 3:8b). Because eternal hell allegedly does not destroy Satan and his followers, there is a qualified dualism in the eternal future, where the enemies of God remain (even though they are being punished), and this questions the *Christus Victor* (or victory of Christ) at Calvary. It becomes a qualified victory because there is no final death of Christ's enemies.

In Eden the Creator tells Adam and Eve that eating the forbidden fruit will bring death (Gen. 2:16b–17). Satan bluntly denies God's words, saying "You will not surely die" (Gen. 3:2a). Scripture supports Christ, for sin brings death (Rom. 6:23). When Christ later says that there are two choices for humans, eternal life or eternal death (John 3:16), He uses the word "perish." God says of the coming new heavens and new earth that in them "there will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the old order of things has passed away" (Rev. 21:4). This disallows a continuing hell.

According to the substitutionary and cosmic view of atonement, hell is separation from God through the second death (Rev. 20:14; cf. Matt. 27:46; Mark 15:34) from which there is no resurrection. Whereas some scholars believe an eternal hell will keep humans loyal to God, which must be through fear; Calvary keeps created beings loyal to God through love and justice revealed in the death of Christ. God's love at Calvary keeps created beings loyal, and that is an infinitely better means compatible with the unchanging (Mal. 3:6; Heb. 13:8) love of God (1 John 4:8–16).

Paul says, "God presented Christ as a sacrifice of atonement, through the shedding of his blood—to be received by faith. He did this to demonstrate his righteousness, because in his forbearance he had left the sins committed beforehand unpunished—he did it to demonstrate his righteousness at the present time, so as to be just and the one who justifies those who have faith in Jesus" (Rom. 3:25–26). Here Calvary is presented as a sacrifice to atone for sins, and to demonstrate that God was just in forgiving sins in the Old Testament because their payment would be made at the Cross. These verses clearly teach a substitutionary sacrifice of Christ at Calvary, as did the sanctuary sacrifices and services.

That is why Christ is "our righteousness, holiness and redemption" (1 Cor. 1:30b), "in whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins" (Col. 1:14). "For God was pleased to have all his fullness dwell in him, and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether things on earth or things in heaven, by making

peace through his blood, shed on the cross" (Col. 1:19–20). "In him [Christ] we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, in accordance with the riches of God's grace that he lavished on us. With all wisdom and understanding... to bring unity to all things in heaven and on earth under Christ" (Eph. 1:7–10). Consider this commentary on Ephesians 1:10:

> "All things" (*ta panta*) is literally "the all" (Col 1:17; Heb. 1:3) and includes the whole creation. Everything in heaven and on earth will be subsumed under Christ (1 Cor 15:24–28; Phil 2:10, 11). The verb *anakephalaioō* ("to bring together") means *to sum up together again* (Rom 13:9). It is derived not from *kephalē* ("a head") but from *kephalaion* ("a summary, or sum total"). When a column of figures was added up, the total was placed at the top. At the end of the age everything will be seen to add up to Christ. This recognition of his preeminence will ensure that the original harmony of the universe is restored (Rom 8:18–21). The mission of Christ extends beyond the human race and assumes cosmic dimensions.[180]

An insightful commentary on Colossians 1:20 declares, "We should therefore understand this statement to be a reference to the cosmic significance of Christ's work."[181] Clearly, Calvary was more than for this world—it was also for the cosmos. Hence, I propose that to the substitutionary atonement at Calvary for sinners we add that the cosmos was also impacted, so that all created beings are and will be forever affected by Christ's death.

180. A. Skevington Wood, *Ephesians*, vol. 11 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary*, 26.
181. Curtis Vaughan, *Colossians*, vol. 11 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary*, 186.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Salvation Applied: Work of the Holy Spirit

Purpose

1. Show that salvation is a creative work of God alone.
2. Indicate the importance of salvation applied to the life of each human.

Summary

The sacrifice for salvation was made once at Calvary, and needs no repetition. On the basis of that sacrifice, Christ ministers in heaven's sanctuary, and the Holy Spirit ministers to humans. The mediation of Christ is an objective intercession before the Father on behalf of humans, while the concurrent ministry of the Spirit is a subjective application of salvation in the lives of humans. The benefits of Calvary are applied to humans through this twofold ministry of Christ at God's throne and of the Spirit in the minds and hearts of responsive humans on earth. This needs to be studied in the context of the cosmic controversy and God's comprehensive plan to redeem and to restore, so that in the earth made new will be a return to the pristine pre-Fall state of the universe. The eternal reciprocal love in the inner history of the Trinity overflowed in the plan of salvation for all humans, and for all willing recipients there comes an overflowing of that love into them so that they reflect divine love—in loving God and fellow beings as each member of the Godhead does in their communion. That is why the fruit of the Spirit is

love (Gal. 5:22). Simon Chan penetrated to this eternal source, saying: "For the Christian love is the cardinal and defining virtue because the ultimate reality is the triune God who is eternally Persons-in-loving-communion."[1]

That is precisely the focus of this system. Salvation is more than forgiveness for sins; it is victory over sins. For "God is faithful; he will not let you be tempted beyond what you can bear. But when you are tempted, he will also provide a way out so that you can endure it" (*hypenenkein*, from *hypo*, under; *pherō*, remain; 1 Cor. 10:13b). Salvation is freedom from the penalty and power of sin. Yet pardon is not enough; it must reach out to perfection in and through Christ, that humans might become like Him (1 John 3:2b). No humans contribute to the saving process, for at best they are forgiven sinners, recipients of salvation and not contributors to salvation. They are invited to respond by accepting the gift, for salvation is not received apart from human free choice (John 3:16). The Trinity are the only Ones in the universe qualified to be the means of salvation, even as they were the only Ones who created (Gen. 1:1; John 1:1, 14). For salvation is a "new creation" (2 Cor. 5:17).

Outline

I. Introduction
II. Focus on Christ
III. Jesus Christ Mediates Salvation
- A. Salvation Available Throughout History
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  - 3. Focus on Remaining in Christ

VII. Good News of Salvation
VIII. Christian Living
IX. Sanctification
X. Conclusion
XI. Study Questions

1. Simon Chan, "Sanctification," in *Global Dictionary of Theology* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2008), 790.

Introduction

Salvation needs to be studied in the context of the relational Trinity. Salvation is not human works of merit as in Catholic theology, nor is salvation God's work in terms of deciding human destiny in eternal decree(s) as in Protestant predestination theology. The former looks at salvation as a human work, the latter looks at salvation as a divine work. Protestant soteriology (study of salvation) was launched to counter the Catholic view, but both theologies need to consider soteriology in the context of the relational Trinity, in which born-again Christians are in covenant relationship with God, and He with them (see my Systematic Theology, volume 2, chapters 9–11). What God and humans contribute to this covenant relationship is crucial, for God alone saves (opposed to human works to earn salvation), and humans are given the freedom to accept or reject the gift of salvation (as opposed to divine works in predestination that deny human freedom to choose). James William McClendon (1924–2000) was an Anabaptist theologian, who stated, "Above all, there must be no gap between what we know of God in the biblical narrative that climaxes in Jesus Christ and what we say of God's inclusive, electing love."[2]

The gulf between sinners and the Savior cannot be crossed from the sinners' side. It took God to come from His side and cross the abyss in order to rescue humans. Salvation requires the life, death, resurrection, and present ministry of the Savior. Salvation requires the work of the Holy Spirit, who restores the damaged image caused by sin. Salvation is a work of re-creation. Salvation requires justification, sanctification, and final glorification. That is why Scripture speaks of those who "were saved" (*esōthēmen*, Rom. 8:24a); those "being saved" (*sōzomenois*, 1 Cor. 1:18); and those who "will be saved" (*sōthēsetai*, Matt. 24:13). Salvation is a process, beginning in the new birth (John 3:3–7), and ending in glorification and immortality at the second advent of Christ (1 Cor. 15:51–55). Salvation means

2. James Wm. McClendon, Jr., *Doctrine*, vol. 2 in *Systematic Theology* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 1994), 185, emphasis in original.

restoration of humans and the world to a pre-Fall pristine state. Ivan Blazen said it well, "as believers are regenerated in the present, so at the end of time the world will be made new (*palingenesia*, Matt 19:28) by the same power at work in spiritual renewal now (Rom 8:21)."[3]

Some people claim that all faiths lead to the same destination. But how is this possible when faiths hold contrary beliefs? How can non-Christian religions that urge devotees to earn their salvation reach the same goal as Christians for whom salvation is a gift? The so-called holy books of non-Christian religions such as "the Veda of Brahmans, the Purana of Siwa and Vishnu, the Qur'an of the Muslims, and the Sendavesta of the Parsis" present salvation by works.[4] This became very obvious to me as I read through the Qur'an. Genuine Christianity presents the only way to be saved. In so doing, Christianity is both inclusive and exclusive.

It is inclusive because God loves the world and sent Jesus to die for every human being (John 3:16). Yet salvation is exclusive for "Salvation is found in no one else" (Acts 4:12). Jesus said: "I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me" (John 14:6). Christ is our salvation (Pss. 27:1; 95:1; 98:3; 118:14; 119:166, 174; Isa. 12:2; Jon. 2:9; Rev. 7:10; 19:1), for we only "receive salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ" (1 Thess. 5:9). Christianity is exclusive because only Jesus lived the life we should have lived and died the death we should have died. Buddha, Confucius, and Muhammad did not live the life we should have lived or die the death we should have died. Only Christ lives today and ministers for humans in the heavenly sanctuary; none of the other religions have a post-resurrection ministry by their leaders, nor do they have a Holy Spirit to apply salvation.

So it must be stressed that Jesus is the only Savior, and the only means of salvation. "And there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved" (Acts 4:12, ESV). "And it shall come to pass that everyone who calls upon the name of the Lord shall be saved" (Acts 2:21, ESV). "For there is no difference between Jew and Gentile—the same Lord is Lord of all and richly blesses all who call on him, for, '[E]veryone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved' [Joel 2:32]. How, then, can they call on the one they have not believed in? And how can they believe in the one of whom they have not heard? And how can they hear without someone preaching to them?... faith comes from hearing the message, and the message is heard through the word about Christ" (Rom. 10:12–14, 17).

3. Ivan T. Blazen, "Salvation," in *Handbook of Seventh-day Adventist Theology*, vol. 12 of *Commentary Reference Series* (Hagerstown, MD: Review and Herald, 2000), 293.

4. See Herman Bavinck, *Sin and Salvation in Christ*, vol. 3 in *Reformed Dogmatics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2006), 492n.

Human freedom has been misunderstood in theology. Pelagius believed humans contribute to their salvation, as if they have the capacity to do so. Semi-Pelagianism is a form of works-based salvation, and includes human mediators in heaven and human mediators and sacraments on earth. Church worship and proclamation of the Word are opportunities God uses to effect His saving work, but He is able to reach human minds and hearts in the quietness of their personal reading or meditation. Scripture is a powerful tool God uses.

Salvation is the work of the Trinity in an overflowing of Trinitarian love to redeem humans, reaching from their agreement made in eternity until there is a new heaven and a new earth. The Trinity devised the plan of salvation, not humans. Human additions to the plan unwittingly barge onto holy ground, which is off-limits to humans. In Leviticus 10:10, God doesn't merely say you "may" (KJV, NKJV) or "can" (NIV) distinguish "between the holy and the common," but "you must distinguish" (HCSB), "you are to distinguish" (RSV, ESV). Commentators add, "you must distinguish,"[5] "it is your duty to distinguish,"[6] and you must "make the proper distinctions."[7] In other words, it is mandatory that the distinction between the holy and the profane be made.

The work of salvation is holy. Any view of human merits and human ability to earn the gift of salvation is an oxymoron. It is profane. It treats the holy gift as a trifle, able to be earned or merited. Such presumption knows no limit when it projects humans into the very presence of God as mediators between God and humans. God ordained human priests to be mediators in the sanctuary-temple services, but they did so only as a type of Christ, even as the sacrifices were a type of Christ's sacrifice at Calvary.

There is one other means of enlightening those who may not even hear the truth. The Greek grammar of John 1:9 can be translated in two ways: (1) "The true light [Jesus Christ], which enlightens everyone, was coming into the world [incarnation]" (ESV), and (2) "That was the true Light [Jesus Christ], which lighteth every man that cometh into the world" (KJV). Both translations speak of Christ's being the One to enlighten all humans, perhaps quietly through the Holy Spirit in places where a preacher has never gone. This should not question the divine commission to take the gospel into all the world (Matt. 28:18–20), but it shows that God is working in all the world, because He practices what He preaches.

5. R. Laird Harris, *Leviticus*, vol. 2 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1990), 567; Roy Gane, *Leviticus, Numbers*, in *The New Application Commentary; From Biblical Text to Contemporary Life* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2004), 186.

6. Gordon J. Wenham, *The Book of Leviticus*, in *The New International Commentary on the Old Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1979), 152.

7. John E. Hartley, *Leviticus*, vol. 4 in *Word Biblical Commentary* (Dallas TX: Word Books, Publisher, 1992).

The above texts inform us that God uses various means to enlighten, many of which are not mentioned, but the statement or promise is that every human being will be enlightened by God. It could be the Holy Spirit's working quietly in willing hearts to fit them for life with God. God knows that many have never read a Bible or heard a sermon. God is fair and has no partiality (Prov. 28:21; Rom. 2:11; Col. 3:25; Jas. 2:9; 1 Pet. 1:17). Salvation is not ultimately determined by geography. The omnipresent God is close to all humans, however remote their place of residence. So we know the God of love will give every one of His children a chance to be saved, which means God will show mercy (*eleate*, Jude 23).

We seem to have an illustration of that mercy in Zechariah. Looking into the future of the Kingdom, the prophet records one who asks Christ a question: "If someone asks, 'What are these wounds on your body?' they will answer, 'The wounds I was given at the house of my friends'" (Zech. 13:6). Apparently, even in the Kingdom, persons will come to Christ and ask Him about His wounds. These redeemed ones are saved, but they do not know about the plan of salvation and Christ's death that saved them. So it seems that in mercy, knowing their hearts, knowing they are safe to save (and will not begin a new rebellion), Christ saves them, and will teach them about salvation's plan in paradise. They didn't have a chance to know in this life, but will learn the good news in the life to come. God truly loves the world (John 3:16).

Focus on Christ

In this segment we consider the life of Christ as a model for salvation. He didn't need salvation, but His life revealed how Christians should live. So we go beyond the way He earned salvation for us (life, death, and present ministry in heaven's sanctuary, and final glorification at His second coming) to the example He left for us to follow.

When tempted by Satan, He uses Scripture to overcome the enemy (Matt. 4:4, 7, 10). All those who study Scripture can depend upon God's Word in times of trial. In fact, Christ assures us, "[W]hen they arrest you, do not worry about what to say or how to say it. At that time you will be given what to say, for it will not be you speaking, but the Spirit of your Father speaking through you" (Matt. 10:19–20).

By contrast, Christ told the Sadducees, "[Y]ou do not know the Scriptures or the power of God" (Matt. 22:29). The two go together, for God's power comes through God's Word. Because Christ knew the book of Isaiah (Luke 24:44), He said to the Pharisees and some of the teachers of the law, "Isaiah was right when he prophesied about you hypocrites; as it is written: 'These people honor

me with their lips, but their hearts are far from me. They worship me in vain; their teachings are merely human rules'" (Mark 7:6–7; Isa. 29:13). He continued, "You have let go of the commands of God and are holding on to human traditions" (v. 8). Christ told them straight, "Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them. For truly I tell you, until heaven and earth disappear, not the smallest letter, not the least stroke of a pen, will by any means disappear from the Law until everything is accomplished" (Matt. 5:17–18). So Christians can know that Scripture and the Ten Commandments are unchangeable throughout the plan of salvation and in eternity to come; for God does not change (Mal. 4:6), and "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8).

Practicing Christ's words is essential to salvation. Christ commended one who "hears my words and puts them into practice" (Luke 6:47b). A righteous person keeps God's laws (Ezek. 18:9), because He loves Christ (John 14:15). Christ warned, "the one who hears my words and does not put them into practice is like a man who built a house on the ground without a foundation. The moment the torrent struck that house, it collapsed and its destruction was complete" (Luke 6:49). There was a difference between the sisters Martha and Mary, for Mary "sat at the Lord's feet listening to what he said. But Martha was distracted by all the preparations that had to be made." Christ said, "Mary has chosen what is better, and it will not be taken away from her" (Luke 10:39–42). So many people are like Martha, busy doing good and necessary things, but have little or no time for listening to the words of Christ. "A woman in the crowd called out, 'Blessed is the mother who gave you [Christ] birth and nursed you.' He replied, 'Blessed rather are those who hear the word of God and obey it'" (Luke 11:27–28).

Christ's words come in parables, plain talk, and beatitudes. We will cite a few of the beatitudes. "Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they will be filled" (Matt. 5:6). "Blessed are the pure in heart, for they will see God" (v. 8). These focus on a relationship with God, a longing to be filled with His presence, the desire for a heart-relationship with Him. "Blessed [or happy] are the meek, for they will inherit the earth" (v. 5). "Blessed are the peacemakers, for they will be called children of God" (v. 9). Here are two results that come from having a heart-relationship with God. Meekness and peacemaking speak of a relationship with other humans, yet a real relationship with God is required in order to have a genuine relationship with other persons. The vertical relationship anchors the horizontal relationships. Christ talks about this in His vine analogy. He says, "I am the vine; you are the branches. If you remain in me and I in you, you will bear much fruit; apart from me you can do nothing" (John 15:5). Branches have two ends. To look to the outer end, where the fruit grows, is to be like Martha, occupied

with personal acts. To focus on the inner end, abiding in Christ, is to be like Mary, where relationship with Him produces the right fruit naturally. Those who try to earn salvation by human works are occupied with fruits at the end of the branch. Those abiding in Christ find salvation in Him alone.

Christ had the power of God in His life, not because He was the Son of God (Phil. 2:6–8), but because He was the Son of Man, totally dependent upon the power of God, just as any other Christian is. As a boy of twelve, "Moved by the Spirit, he went into the temple courts" (Luke 2:27a). John the Baptist prophesied that Christ would "baptize you with the Holy Spirit" (Luke 3:16b). When Jesus was thirty, the Spirit of God descended upon Him at His baptism (Matt. 3:16). The Father said, "This is my Son, whom I love; with him I am well pleased" (v. 17). Many chapters later, we read, "Here is my servant whom I have chosen, the one I love, in whom I delight; I will put my Spirit on him" (Matt. 12:18), words taken from Isaiah 42:1, where the Father says He will "uphold" Christ. Jesus was "full of the Holy Spirit" after His baptism, and "was led by the Spirit" to the temptations from Satan (Luke 4:1).

Then He returned to Galilee, where Christ said, "The Spirit of the Lord is on me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim freedom for the prisoners and recovery of sight for the blind, to set the oppressed free, to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor" (Luke 4:18–19, taken from Isaiah 61:1–2). Christ encouraged people to ask for the Holy Spirit, saying that if fallen human beings know how to give good gifts to their children, then "how much more will your Father in heaven give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him!" (Luke 11:13).

Christ was Spirit-filled because He had a vibrant prayer life. Consider just a few examples. "One of those days Jesus went out to a mountainside to pray, and spent the night praying to God" (Luke 6:12). The next day He chose the twelve apostles. "After he had dismissed them [the crowd], he went up on a mountainside by himself to pray. Later that night, he was there alone" (Matt. 14:23). On another occasion, "Very early in the morning, while it was still dark, Jesus got up, left the house and went off to a solitary place, where he prayed" (Mark 1:35). "Jesus often withdrew to lonely places and prayed" (Luke 5:16). When His disciples couldn't cast out a demon, He said to them, "This kind can come out only by prayer" (Mark 9:29).

The fruit of the Holy Spirit is love (Gal. 5:22a), and God is love (1 John 2:8–16). "When he [Christ] saw the crowds, he had compassion on them" (Matt. 9:36). "When Jesus landed and saw a large crowd, he had compassion on them and healed their sick" (Matt. 14:14). To His disciples in the boat, Jesus said, "Take courage! It is I, Don't be afraid" (Matt. 14:27). In response to God's voice

at Christ's transfiguration, the disciples "fell facedown to the ground, terrified. But Jesus came and touched them. 'Get up,' he said. 'Don't be afraid'" (Matt. 17:6–7). Facing two blind men, "Jesus had compassion on them and touched their eyes" (Matt. 20:34a). A leper begged Christ on his knees: "'If you will, you can make me clean.' Moved with pity, he stretched out his hand and touched him and said to him, 'I will; be clean'" (Mark 1:40–41, ESV). "They begged him to let them touch even the edge of his cloak, and all who touched it were healed" (Mark 6:56b). Even though He must have known that the rich young ruler would turn him down, "Jesus looked at him and loved him" (Mark 10:21a). A widow was mourning her son's death. "When the Lord saw her, his heart went out to her and he said, 'Don't cry'" (Luke 7:13). Christ said, "Do not be afraid, little flock, for your Father has been pleased to give you the kingdom" (Luke 12:32). With an aching heart, Christ wailed, "Jerusalem, Jerusalem, you who kill the prophets and stone those sent to you, how often I have longed to gather your children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, but you were not willing" (Luke 13:34).

Jesus Christ Mediates Salvation[8]

Theologians often confine salvation to the life and death of Jesus Christ and the work of the Holy Spirit. But we must raise some questions. Is the present work

8. All humans except Christ are born sinners, confined by the sin problem with nothing to contribute to its solution. Only Jesus Christ, the God-Man, is the Mediator between God and sinners (1 Tim. 2:5). It takes His divinity and His humanity to gift us salvation. For only a divine Person can forgive, and only one also human can grant us human righteousness. Jesus Christ is the only Savior through His life, death, present intercession in heaven's sanctuary, His second advent, and final judgment. As God He became also human in order ro work out the plan of salvation in history (incarnational life), which is the basis of His present ministry. His perfect life was lived for humans to be exchanged (2 Cor. 5:21) for their imperfect lives, just as He died in place of humans. Properly understood, Christ is our substitute in life and death as far as salvation is concerned. In other words, we need His life and His death to receive His salvation. His death paid for all human sin, removes our guilt. His life is the righteousness humans need to be fitted for heaven.

Catholic theology teaches that there are other mediators in heaven (Mary and saints); this seemingly either fails to comprehend the one-of-a-kind Person Christ is, or fails to understand that He is well able, and is the only One able, to mediate. It isn't good enough for Catholic theology to claim a multitude of mediators in heaven and yet say Christ is the sole Mediator. Living in a Catholic country for years taught me that Catholics pray to Mary and saints as if they are closer to humans and understand them better, and thus they seem to replace Christ who really knows us best (as our Creator-Redeemer), and as Immanuel, "God with us." All alleged mediators have no qualifications for this sacred work of salvation, for after all, Christ mediates His death for sinners in heaven. Belief in human mediators in heaven does great disservice to Calvary and to Christ's ministering the benefits of the cross as He alone can do. After all, Christ defeated Satan by His death on the cross, and did it for all humans, without any contribution from them. He did it for them, not with them.

Just as God, not humans, made the heavenly sanctuary, so the God-Man, not humans, functions as Mediator in it. The good news is "if anyone sins, we have an Advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous" (1 John 2:1, NKJV). For "He is also able to save to rhe uttermost those who come to God through Him, since He always lives to make intercession for them" (Heb. 7:25, NKJV).

Christ's present mediation in heaven's sanctuary is just as important as His work at Calvary, for He applies Calvary to humans, and He does it without any human mediators, for the Holy Spirit is His chosen means, and humans should not presume to rhink they can make a contribution that the Trinity are unable to make. For the Trinity who devised the plan of salvation are the only Ones who can bring it to a

of Christ as important as His life and death? Should salvation include the ministry of Christ and the Holy Spirit during the post-resurrection era? If the present ministry of Christ and the Holy Spirit should be included in salvation's plan, what contribution do they make, and how important is their contribution?

Scripture says, "Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come: The old has gone, the new is here! All this is from God, who reconciled us to himself through Christ and gave us the ministry of reconciliation: that God was reconciling the world to himself in Christ, not counting people's sins against them.... God made him who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Cor. 5:17–19, 21). Reconciliation took place at the Cross, when Christ died for human sin as the substitute for human salvation. It is "in Him" that we become righteous. What is involved in that process? "For if, when we were God's enemies, we were reconciled to him through the death of his Son, how much more, having been reconciled, shall we be saved through his life!" (Rom. 5:10).

It is after being reconciled by His death that we need to be saved by His life. This means that Christ's ministry in the heavenly sanctuary contributes to our salvation, because it is rooted in His saving sacrifice at the Cross. Calvary is the sacrificial foundation for the process of salvation. Although Christ has been a Mediator from before human creation (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 8), His post-crucifixion mediation between humans and God is based upon His death (the conclusion of a perfect life). Scripture says He is the only Mediator (1 Tim. 2:4–5), which means that no church can claim that role, nor Mary nor saints, because only Christ is the One who died to reconcile humans with God.

Christ is mediating His human life and death, which cannot be added to, improved, or completed. His life ended in His death, and His death is a once-for-all, never-to-be-repeated sacrificial atonement.

Perhaps at this juncture the reader may wish to go to my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 11, to read about the old and new covenants. Whereas priests as mediators were necessary in the Old Testament, that is no longer true since Christ came and fulfilled all temporary types. Christ's victory at Calvary heralded a new phase in salvation's plan. Salvation didn't change, but access to God did. Now only the Savior who lived and died for humans is qualified to be the Mediator of human salvation from heaven's throne in the new covenant era. Christ has provided a direct access to God, not requiring priests anymore. He is the God-Man and doesn't need any help.

successful conclusion, for their plan includes the priesthood of all believers (1 Pet. 2:9), for each believer is directly united to Christ as high priest through the Holy Spirit, without the need of any other mediation, whether through the church, Mary, saints, or priests.

I concur with Herman Bavinck, who says that

> the work the mediator was charged to do did not end with his suffering and death. Christ is not a historical person like others in the sense that, after living and working for a time on earth, he now still affects people by his mind and exerts influence on them by his word and example. Although he completed all the work the Father had instructed him to do on earth, in heaven he continues his prophetic, priestly and royal activity.... That activity is distinct from that which he performed on earth, though it is most intimately connected with it. Nothing can be added to it, and nothing can be detracted from it: it is complete, perfect. The Father rests in it and sealed it with the resurrection of his Son. All the benefits that God bestows in the covenant of grace he bestows "through and on account of the Son."[9]

John Calvin was the first theologian to present the threefold office of Christ (*triplex munus*) as prophet, king, and priest.[10] He devoted about seven pages to Christ's post-ascension ministry as advocate and intercessor.[11] He rightly stated: "the whole sum of our salvation, and every part of it, are comprehended in Christ."[12]

Some scholars claim that the old covenant was less effective than the new covenant, and hence the need for the new one. For example, Jason Meyer claims that the old covenant was "impotent and transitory," "ineffectual," and could "only create children of spiritual slavery."[13]

> The new covenant is "new" in terms of God's eschatological intervention. Therefore, the new covenant is "new" in that it cannot be broken. The reason for its inviolability is not the moral improvement of the human race since the time of Moses. The difference is owing to the fact that God deals with the same sinful people in a remarkably different way: by creating the faithfulness for which He calls through the new covenant, which is inaugurated by the atoning death of Christ and carried forward by the transformative power of the Holy Spirit.[14]
>
> The Mosaic covenant lacked this power to produce what it demanded.[15]

Scripture refutes this idea of special help being given to those in the new covenant, and so rejects the above two statements. To the returning captives from Babylon, God promised the same help: "I will give them a heart to know me" (Jer. 24:7); "I will give them singleness of heart and action, so that they will always fear [reverence] me and that all will then go well for them...so that they will never

9. Bavinck, *Sin and Salvation in Christ*, vol. 3 in *Reformed Dogmatics*, 570.
10. John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, trans. Henry Beveridge (London: James Clarke, 1962), 1:425–432 (2.15.1–6).
11. Ibid., 1:431, 432 (2.15.6); and 1:448–452 (2.16.14–19).
12. Ibid., 1:452 (2.16.19).
13. Jason C. Meyer, *The End of the Law: Mosaic Covenant in Pauline Theology* (Nashville, TN: B&H, 2009), 275.
14. Ibid., 277.
15. Ibid., 2.

turn away from me" (Jer. 32:39–40; cf. Ezek. 11:19; 14:11). A few chapters later, the prophet is clear that God's promises are conditional (Jer. 42:11–17). While noting the legitimate differences between the old and new covenants, it is crucial to note the same Savior in both covenants. Embedded in the old covenant are the words "The Lord Our Righteous Savior" (Jer. 23:6; 33:16b).

SALVATION AVAILABLE THROUGHOUT HISTORY

Although the book of Hebrews says the new covenant is "superior" to the old one, founded on better promises (Heb. 8:6), and hence the old one is "obsolete" (v. 13), Hebrews also gives a qualification: "For if there had been nothing wrong with that first covenant, no place would have been sought for another. But God found fault with the people.... they did not remain faithful to my covenant" (vv. 7–9b). The fault seems to have been with the people and not with the covenant (cf. Deut. 5:29).

The old covenant, God's covenant, must be the same as His new covenant because God does not change (Mal. 4:6); "from everlasting to everlasting you are God" (Ps. 90:2b), and "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8). There is no distinction between the God of the Old Testament and the God of the New Testament, as if He were the God of law in the first and the God of grace in the second. Evidence abounds in the Old Testament that He is the God of awesome grace (e.g., Exod. 34:6–7a; Ps. 86:15; Joel 2:13). The evidence that God is not at fault, and hence the old covenant was not at fault, is the fact that the saints were saved on the basis of faith in the old covenant (Heb. 11) as in the new covenant (Rom. 1:17). Although the sacrifices in the old covenant couldn't take away sins (Heb. 10:1–14), the Savior could take away sins: "as far as the east is from the west, so far has he removed our transgressions from us" (Ps. 103:12), because He is "to Israel a forgiving God" (Ps. 99:8; cf. Jer. 50:20; Ezek. 18:22). Evidently He deals with sins the same way in both covenants on the basis of His future or past payment for sins at Calvary (Isa. 53:5).

So one must qualify what is obsolete. The typical sacrifices and services are obsolete, but not Jesus Christ's forgiving and saving power available from the beginning of human history (Gen. 3:15; Mic. 7:18–19; cf. Isa. 61:10). The gospel was preached to Abraham (Gal. 3:8), to Israel (Heb. 4:6), and is called the "eternal gospel" (Rev. 14:6). In a saving sense, Jesus Christ is "the Lamb who was slain from the creation of the world" (Rev. 13:8b). It is important to know that sin is defined as law breaking (1 John 3:4), which applies to both covenants, just as the Savior forgives sin in both covenants.

This definition of sin as law breaking (in the New Testament), emphasizes the continuing importance of the law in the new covenant. In fact, Paul says that "we uphold the law" (Rom. 3:31), for it follows that "where there is no law there is no transgression" (Rom. 4:15). Hence God's unchangeable law is present in both covenants. In other words, existentially (from the perspective of human experience), believers in both covenants were treated the same because Christ is not limited to saving persons after His death. The Ten Commandments remain the same throughout both covenants, for salvation from law breaking remains the same, and the eternal gospel remains the same throughout human history.

I like to refer to the book of Hebrews as the fifth gospel. Whereas the other four record Christ's ministry on earth, the fifth records His ministry in heaven. It should be pointed out that all five Gospels give insights into the one plan of salvation. This plan began before the creation of the world with a Christ-centered promise: "[W]e have redemption through his blood" (Eph. 1:7). It doesn't matter whether a person lives before or after Christ's death—all are redeemed in the same way. Prior to Christ's death animal sacrifices represented Christ's sacrifice, but they didn't redeem. Nevertheless, these sacrifices prescribed by God's ceremonial law taught the awfulness of sin and the awesomeness of salvation through the coming death of Christ.

Does the Holy Spirit function in both covenants in the same way? Although it can be argued that the Spirit is more fully present in the new than in the old covenant period, because His coming was prophesied in the old (Joel 2:28–32) and has been fulfilled in the new (Acts 2:16–21), and although it can be argued that the Spirit mainly equipped persons for tasks in the old covenant, it still says of Hur (builder of the sanctuary) that he was "filled...with the Spirit of God" (Exod. 35:31, ESV). What we said about Christ's ability to save in the old covenant also applies to the Spirit. For, although the old covenant was the period which looked forward to the coming of Christ and the Spirit, this didn't lessen the Trinity's ability to save in the old covenant period. The fullness of the Spirit was future in the old covenant period; nonetheless, there was a sufficient presence of the Spirit to produce the fruit of the Spirit in the lives of God's people (cf. Ps. 119:97, with Rom. 7:22).

Isaiah could say, "I delight greatly in the Lord; my soul rejoices in my God. For he has clothed me with garments of salvation and arrayed me in a robe of his righteousness" (Isa. 61:10a; cf. loving God's law, Ps. 119). The promise to the returning captives from Babylon (in the old covenant period) was, "I will pour out my Spirit on the house of Israel, declares the Sovereign Lord" (Ezek. 39:29). "I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit in you; I will remove from you your heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh. And I will put my

Spirit in you and move you to follow my decrees and be careful to keep my laws" (Ezek. 36:26–27; cf. Ps. 104:30).

From these biblical texts, it seems reasonable to conclude that love for God and His law in the old covenant period is an indication of the Spirit's internal work (cf. John 14:15). We need to remember that Christ lived before His death, and thus during the old covenant period, and in that time He encouraged people to ask for the Holy Spirit, saying that if fallen human beings know how to give good gifts to their children, then "how much more will your Father in heaven give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him!" (Luke 11:13). Christ told Nicodemus that "no one can enter the kingdom of God unless they are born of water and the Spirit" (John 3:5). This seems to suggest that even in the old covenant period, without the Spirit no one could enter the kingdom of God.

CHRIST'S TWO MINISTRIES

Salvation has everything to do with focus. In this segment we note Christ's post-ascension ministries in heaven, which are as important to human salvation as are His life and death. There is far too much focus on salvation being delivered through a church on earth, and far too little in looking to Christ's saving ministry in heaven.

Christ's Better Ministry

The key idea in Hebrews is "superior" (*kreittōn*, 1:4, ESV) or "more excellent" (*diaphorōteron*, 1:4, ESV). This term primarily serves to indicate how much better Christ's sacrifice and priesthood are compared to the sacrifices and priests of the past. So we will begin a review of Hebrews with its revelation of Christ.

Consider how much better He is, for Christ created the worlds (*aiōnas*, 1:2) by His word (11:3) and "upholds the universe [*panta*, literally "all things"] by the word of his power" (1:3, ESV). God the Father says to the ascended Christ, "Your throne, O God, is forever and ever" (1:8, ESV). He was crowned with "glory and honor, putting [*hypetaxas*, aorist, once for all] everything in subjection under his feet…he left nothing outside his control" (2:7b–8a, ESV). He is crowned with glory and honor because of His death (2:9a). While the book of Revelation shows that Christ is put in charge of unfolding history because He has died to save humans (Rev. 5:9), the book of Hebrews says He had tasted death for all humans (2:9b); He is called "the founder of their salvation" (2:10b, ESV). Christ's death delivers sinners from "lifelong slavery" and will destroy the devil (2:14–15); and because He Himself has been tempted, Christ is able to help the tempted (2:18).

In biblical hermeneutics (interpretation), types point beyond what they are to antitypes. Lambs sacrificed at the altar of the tabernacle or temple pointed to Christ the Lamb of God's sacrifice at Calvary. By contrast, a priest in the earthly sanctuary/temples "again and again…offers the same sacrifices, which can never take away sins. But when this priest [Christ] had offered for all time one sacrifice for sins, he sat down at the right hand of God" (Heb. 10:11–12). The unrepeatable reality of Calvary is emphasized in Hebrews, for Christ offered his life "once" (*ephapax*, 7:27b) in a "single sacrifice" (*mian thysian*, 10:12), or "single offering" (*mia prosphora*, 10:14).

> For Christ has entered, not into holy places made with hands, which are copies of the true things, but into heaven itself, now to appear in the presence of God on our behalf. Nor was it to offer himself repeatedly, as the high priest enters the holy places every year with blood not his own, for then he would have had to suffer repeatedly since the foundation of the world. But as it is, he has appeared once for all at the end of the ages to put away sin by the sacrifice of himself. (Heb. 9:24–26, ESV)

Priests in the earthly sanctuary and temples entered the holy place and ministered there throughout the year (Lev. 4), and on the day of atonement the high priest ministered in the most holy place (Lev. 16). This type suggests that Christ did the same in the two rooms of the heavenly sanctuary. Therefore, it isn't correct to say that Christ went into the most holy place after His ascension, as translated in the New International Version (Heb. 9:12). The English Standard Version is correct, for Christ "entered once for all into the holy places [*ta hagia*] not by means of the blood of goats and calves but by means of his own blood, thus securing an eternal redemption" (Heb. 9:12). The Greek language in Hebrews documents that Christ ministers in "holy places" (*hagiōn*, 8:2; 9:12a, 25; 10:19), which includes a holy place (*hagia*, 9:2), and a most holy place (*hagia hagiōn*, 9:3). In order for Hebrews 9:12 to be the most holy place, the Greek should be *hagia hagiōn* and not *hagiōn*.

There is a great distinction between sacrifices and priests in the earthly sanctuary, and one sacrifice and one high priest in the heavenly sanctuary: (1) the atonement work took many priests and many sacrifices during the Old Testament era, whereas the atonement work takes one high priest and one Calvary in the New Testament era; (2) not even all the sacrifices in the ministry of the earthly sanctuary could take away human sin, but one sacrifice in the ministry of the heavenly sanctuary takes away all human sin. We need to keep in mind that a sacrifice was only the beginning of the ministry for human sin in the earthly sanctuary, and Calvary is only the beginning of the ministry for human sin in the heavenly sanctuary. We need to ponder what this means and what it does not mean.

Scripture is not merely speaking of different functions of Christ when referring to two rooms[16] in the heavenly sanctuary, for the sanctuary on earth was a type of the pattern of the original sanctuary in heaven. There is no meaning to the two rooms in the earthly type if there are not two rooms in the heavenly antitype. Nor should the omnipresence of God be considered incompatible with the idea of rooms in heaven; after all, God has a throne in heaven, so God has the ability to localize Himself without ceasing to be omnipresent. The evidence of this was in the earthly sanctuary, where the pre-incarnate Christ was present in the most holy apartment, while being omnipresent throughout the universe. Had not the pre-incarnate Christ said, "have them make a sanctuary for me, and I will dwell among them" (Exod. 25:8), adding these words about the second apartment, "There, above the cover between the two cherubim that are over the ark of the covenant law, I will meet with you and give you all my commands for the Israelites" (v. 22).

The book of Revelation concurs with Hebrews in speaking of a real sanctuary in heaven with real furniture. Of course, the grandeur of the heavenly sanctuary and furniture far surpasses its copy in the earthly sanctuary, but the earthly sanctuary was a pattern (*tabnît*, Exod. 25:9) of the heavenly sanctuary, or in the plural (including rooms, furniture, and function) the earthly sanctuary represented "copies [*hypodeigmata*] of the heavenly things" (Heb. 9:23, ESV). That is why we find furniture in the heavenly temple (Rev. 11:19) or sanctuary (Rev. 15:5–6, 8; both translations of the Greek *naos*). John "saw seven golden lampstands" (*hepta chrysas lychnias*, 1:12), a gold altar (*chrysoun thysiastērion*, 8:3) with a golden censer and much incense (*polla thymiamata*, 8:3) "in front of the throne" (*enōpion tou thronou*, 8:3), which is the golden altar of incense before the veil in the holy place. Looking beyond that veil, John saw "the ark of his covenant" (*kibōtos autou tēs diathēkēs*, 11:19, ESV). Note that as we progress through the book of Revelation, the present ministry of Christ moves from the holy place into the most holy place. This has significance, as we will see below.

Eternal redemption was obtained at Calvary, and on the basis of this gift, Christ entered the heavenly sanctuary, where He is referred to as a high priest (Heb. 3:1; 4:14–15; 5:5, 10; 6:20; 8:1; 9:11, 25), priest (5:6), "great priest" (10:21), "great Shepherd of the sheep" (13:20), "forerunner" (6:20), and "mediator of a new covenant" (9:15).

As in the earthly sanctuary type, the sacrifices were administered in the sanctuary, so Christ's sacrifice must be taken into the heavenly sanctuary and administered there. There are two ministries for the world: (1) Christ died for

16. One should not be concerned that heaven's sanctuary has two rooms, any more than we should be concerned by Christ's words, "In my Father's house are many rooms" (*pollai monai*, John 14:2a, ESV). Of course, the magnitude of these rooms is beyond our grasp, but that doesn't question their reality.

all humans as "the atoning sacrifice for our sins, and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world" (1 John 2:2); and (2) Christ "wants all men to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth. For there is one God and one mediator between God and mankind, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a ransom for all people" (1 Tim. 2:4–6). In other words, the twofold ministry is sacrifice and mediation for all humans—mediation on the basis of the sacrifice. That is why the present ministry of Christ in heaven's sanctuary is as important as His death on the cross.

ATONEMENT ON THE CROSS AND IN THE SANCTUARY

Several offerings for sin made atonement at the altar of burnt offering (Lev. 4:25–26, 30–31, 34–35), which represented that sin was atoned for at the Cross. For the unintentional sin of the community, the priest took blood into the holy place of the sanctuary, sprinkled it before the veil, and put some on the horns of the altar of incense to "make atonement" for them (Lev. 4:16–20). On the day of atonement the high priest made atonement for the altar, the holy place, the most holy place, and for all Israel (Lev. 16:20, 24b, 30, 33). This means atonement was made at the altar of burnt offering in the courtyard, and also inside the sanctuary. Two goats were involved in making atonement on the day of atonement: the Lord's goat that was sacrificed as a sin offering (Lev. 16:7–9) and the scapegoat that was sent away to die in the wilderness (Lev. 16:10). The goat for a sin offering represents Calvary, and the goat being sent to die in the wilderness represents Satan, the originator of sin, who will be judged for his part in causing all sin.

The day of atonement ministry reaches from Calvary judgment (for human salvation) to post-Millennial judgment (upon Satan as the originator of all sin). Calvary was *the* day of atonement when human sins were placed on Christ who knew no sin (2 Cor. 5:21; cf. Gal. 3:13), and at the end of the antitypical day of atonement human sins will be placed on Satan who caused all sin. Both are judgment days, the first a substitutionary judgment in place of sinners, the second a final judgment to do away with Satan and sin forever (Heb. 2:14–15). Only then will the judgment of Calvary against "the prince of this world" (John 16:11; cf. 12:31) reach its conclusion. Only then will the devil be destroyed (Heb. 2:14–15).

These two atonement events, along with the interim application of atonement (salvation) in Christ's heavenly ministry, embrace all that atonement involves. Calvary atonement is the basis of Christ's present atonement ministry in heaven's sanctuary. Hence the present mediation between God

and humans is a work of atonement, for Jesus Christ is mediating an "at-one-ment" between God and humans on the basis of His atoning sacrifice. Christ's present atoning ministry does not add to His atoning sacrifice as if it were insufficient; rather, it applies the all-sufficiency of His atoning death to human lives in blessings.

It is significant that Christ's final phase of ministry is on the day of atonement in the most holy place where the atonement cover is over God's sacred Ten Commandments within the Ark of the Covenant, which is the throne where God dwells. Here atonement is linked to God's covenant, God's law, God's presence, and God's rule. Lucifer initiated rebellion (sin) at the same throne of God, the most holy place in heaven (Ezek. 28:14–16; Isa. 14:12–14; Rev. 12:7–8), and sin is law breaking (1 John 3:4). It is significant that the resolution of the sin problem in Christ's final ministry during the antitypical day of atonement takes place where sin began. This resolution of the sin problem is the final unfolding of the redemption sacrifice made at Calvary.

The earthly sanctuary was the longest-used teaching device to explain the truth about salvation. Atonement was made at the altar (courtyard), before the veil (holy place), and at the Ark of the Covenant (most holy place). This means the ministry of Christ in the heavenly holy and most holy places is intimately related to His atoning death at Calvary. In fact, the throne (Ark of the Covenant) in the earthly sanctuary is called "the atonement cover" (Lev. 16:2). While the high priest stood before the throne in the most holy place on the day of atonement, he was told that incense "will conceal the atonement cover above the tablets of the covenant law, so that he will not die" (Lev. 16:13).

The atonement cover is over the Testimony, or the Ten Commandments (Exod. 31:18), placed in the Ark (Exod. 25:16), which represents the law as the foundation of God's rule. Because the Ten Commandments were called the "Testimony," the ark in which they were housed was often called the Ark of the Testimony in the Old Testament (Exod. 25:22; 26:33; 30:6; 31:7; 40:3, 5, 21; Josh. 4:16). Moses could even refer to "the tabernacle of the testimony" (Num. 10:11b, ESV). This all indicates how holy, sacred, and unchanging is God's law, as unchangeable as God and His rule. Sin is breaking God's law (1 John 3:4); and rather than change the law, Christ died to change lawbreakers—this is atonement—to restore a broken relationship, so that one day law breaking will be eradicated. Ultimately, the atonement means that forever "God's dwelling place is now among the people, and he will dwell with them. They will be his people, and God himself will be with them and be their God" (Rev. 21:3).

Calvary is atonement supplied, and the heavenly ministry has to do with atonement applied. We must have claimed the atonement supplied in order to receive the atonement applied. In other words, we must be in a saving relationship with Christ. Calvin puts it well: "[S]o long as we are without Christ and separated from him, nothing which he suffered and did for the salvation of the human race is of the least benefit to us."[17] The word *atonement* must not be confined to a past event (Christ's death), although without that foundational sacrifice there wouldn't be any subsequent atonement. Nothing can ever take the place of Calvary; it is unique, unrepeatable, and unrivaled in cosmic history, and always will be. Calvary was so amazing, so unsurpassable, that its impact will be eternal. Thus we can speak of atonement as past, present, and future. The past cannot exhaust the fullness of Calvary, for it overflows into the eternal future. It will eternally keep created intelligent beings in "at-one-ment" with God (Rev. 21:2–4; 22:3–5). There is a three-dimensional fullness of atonement which is not given its due if it is confined to its past dimension. We will return to the focus on the heavenly sanctuary below.

Holy Spirit Applies Salvation

Christ is the only Savior of humans, for He alone became incarnate in human history, lived a human life, died for all humans, rose again, serves as a high priest in heaven's sanctuary, and applies His finished work to willing recipients. Christ is confined to a human body at God's right hand at the throne of the universe, and the Holy Spirit carries out His work of application of salvation to humans. Just as Christ was born of the Holy Spirit and ministered through the Holy Spirit on earth, this working together continues in His current ministry of application. I believe the work of Christ in heaven's sanctuary is just as important as His work on the Cross, for what is the good of salvation supplied (Christ's life and death) if it cannot be applied (Christ's and the Spirit's present work).

Note how interrelated, though distinct, the works of Christ and the Spirit are. Together they are involved in the application of salvation, but it is the work of Christ and not that of the Spirit that is applied. Salvation has been provided *for us by Christ*, and is applied *in us by the Holy Spirit.* Paul says, "But when the kindness and love of God our Savior appeared, he saved us, not because of righteous things we have done, but because of His mercy. He saved us through the washing of rebirth and renewal by the Holy Spirit, whom he poured out on us generously through Jesus Christ our Savior" (Tit. 3:4–6). Only Christ can be called Savior.

17. Calvin, *Institutes*, 1:463 (3.1.1).

But the Spirit functioned in the salvation work during Christ's life on earth and also functions during His ministry in heaven. James Buchanan understands the Spirit's work: "The work of the Holy Spirit is as necessary for our Justification as the work of Christ Himself; but it is not necessary for the same reasons, nor is it effectual for the same ends."[18] I would add that the work of Christ in heaven's sanctuary is just as important as His work at Calvary; for without the application, there is no salvation realized in human lives. In other words, sacrificial and substitutionary atonement took place on the Cross. Calvary is the central event of salvation, the ultimate sacrifice for salvation. Atonement theories are merely human attempts to comprehend the breadth of what took place there.

Although salvation was supplied at Calvary, it must be applied to be of benefit to humans. *Salvation applied* is not a mere transaction between Calvary and the Christian, but is the Holy Spirit's creative inner work to bring change, to restore the damaged image of God, to bring the fruit of the Spirit (Gal. 5:22–23), so all that Christ's salvation supplies is applied to humans who cling to the Cross. This is sanctifying atonement which prepares recipients to be like Christ, and thus fitted for glorification and immortality as the crowning work of atonement in their lives when He appears in the Second Advent (1 John 3:2; 1 Cor. 15:51–55). (We will note later that because Christ indwells Christians through the Spirit, they both share in applying the blessing of salvation to them. In other words, the Christian life, in its broadest sense, is a relationship with the relational Trinity.)

NECESSITY OF HUMAN FREEDOM

Salvation is supplied and applied by God alone. It is a work accomplished without human contribution. Humans receive both gifts. Yet, as long as human freedom to respond to God's salvation is absent, salvation has no benefit to humans. When God encounters humans, He draws them to Himself (prevenient grace), but in this drawing He never violates human freedom. Human freedom doesn't contribute to the drawing, but responds to God's invitation. That kind of human freedom is possible because humans were made for God, in His image, even though the image has been damaged through sin. The image of God in humans has not been destroyed, as some theologians believe; unless humans have rejected the Holy Spirit's drawing until they commit the unpardonable sin, and are beyond help. Normally the conscience is a receiving center to respond to God's invitation. God placed this point of contact in humans in creation, knowing that after the Fall He would draw humans to Himself for salvation, a work that only He can do.

18. James Buchanan, *The Doctrine of Justification* (London, UK: The Banner of Truth Trust, 1961, 1st ed. 1867), 406.

Just as God is a Trinity in a reciprocal relationship of love, so in those who respond to their drawing, their reciprocal love overflows, causing the recipients to reflect the Trinitarian relationship. This requires "relational freedom" (presented in my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 15). In other words, the God of the everlasting covenant is a God who respects human freedom, and salvation has to do with God's relationship with humans and human relationship with God. It is neither a one-sided human work nor a one-sided divine work; it is a covenant communion relationship. Salvation is God's work to restore a broken relationship between God and the sinner; and to be a real relationship, it is necessary that humans freely respond to the invitation through God's prevenient grace. In other words, the purpose of salvation is a dynamic, meaningful relationship and not a mere static status entered into some ledger of the elect.

Reformed theologian Herman Bavinck asserts, "Predestination's only ground is the absolutely sovereign will of God."[19] The Canons of the Synod of Dort (1619) deny the use of human "free-will" in responding to the gospel call (Art. 10) and state that the Spirit "pervades the inmost recesses of the man; he opens the closed and softens the hardened heart, and circumcises that which was uncircumcised; infuses [note this Catholic word; see chapter 16] new qualities into the will, which, though heretofore dead, he quickens; from being evil, disobedient, and refractory, he renders it good, obedient, and pliable" (Art. 11).[20]

Perhaps *infusion* best reflects the alleged absolute sovereignty which ignores human freedom. One gets the impression that humans don't have an opportunity to make a choice, for it is made for them by God. So they have no freedom, and therefore no relationship. So how much better off are they? Ponder the following: There is no relationship in Satan's plan for humans, and no relationship in God's sovereign decree for the elect. Isn't there something wrong when both sides of the cosmic controversy disregard human freedom?

This lack of freedom needs to be thought through carefully, for salvation frees humans from the slavery of sin, from the bondage into which the great deceiver lured them. Satan couldn't care less that humans lose freedom; he exults in their wretchedness resulting from whatever sin addicts them. If humans lack freedom of choice when impacted by a sovereign God, this means they are less free to choose salvation than to choose sin. In such a scenario, it would seem that neither God nor Satan cares about human freedom to choose.

19. Herman Bavinck, *God and Creation*, vol. 2 in *Reformed Dogmatics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2004), 350.

20. Philip Schaff, *The Evangelical Protestant Creeds*, vol. 3 in *The Creeds of Christendom*: (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1996, 1st ed. 1931), 589–590.

However, the Spirit's alleged infusion of salvation that ignores human freedom is contrary to the way the Spirit actually treats people in human history. The fruit of the Spirit is "love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness and self-control" (Gal. 5:22–23). That is a long way from forced infusion. The new birth is not an infusion but *a change of mind* (*metanoeō*, Matt. 3:8), and such a change requires freedom to choose. Freedom of thought and action is necessary for a genuine relationship. Salvation is just such a genuine relationship with the Savior, born out of freedom and love.

Salvation includes justification, sanctification, and final glorification, all contributing to the restoration of a dynamic relationship with God (see the debate taken up in chapters 15–17). Salvation is not through God's omnipotence either in eternity (decrees) or in human history (infusion or irresistible grace); for such means of salvation are nonrelational and ignore the freedom of humans. Salvation respects the free will of humans whom God invites and helps to respond by accepting the gift (justification by faith). Saving faith is faith in Christ, not in lesser means (clerical or sacramental). Faith without works is dead (Jas. 2:26), because the love of God leads to voluntary law keeping in a covenant relationship with God (John 14:15). Salvation is not just a head-knowledge but a heart-relationship (Deut. 5:29). Character change, imparted righteousness, and the fruit of the Spirit (Gal. 5:22–23) are gifts available to willing recipients.

Salvation is God's work to counteract the sin problem. Since the Fall, all humans are born sinners. This means all are born outside of a saving relationship with God. Sin is a broken relationship (Rom. 14:23b), and salvation is a restoration of that relationship. God takes the initiative to reach sinners (John 1:9) through prevenient grace, to draw them through love into a new birth (John 3:3) to be free in Him and able to experience *relational freedom* that frees them to choose to follow Him. This is accomplished through a respect for human freedom to reject Him.[21]

ACCOMPLISHED IN HUMAN HISTORY

Salvation must be understood in the context of the cosmic controversy in which the damaged image of God is being restored in willing humans and Satan is being defeated—which is an unfolding in history of the victory of the Cross. Salvation includes perfection as a perfect relationship with God, a

21. Since relationship involves a decision from God and humans, infant baptism can never establish such a relationship, even though infant baptism is widely practiced by Christians. It is another form of God's acting apart from human response, as in the eternal decree. Even though birth is in human history, babes have no clue about the meaning of infant baptism, and so are unable to respond to it. The necessity of human freedom in salvation is absent in infant baptism. Belief, and hence intelligent response to God's salvation, is the biblical way of salvation (John 3:16).

likeness to Him, a reflection of the relational Trinity. This perfection doesn't require further work beyond death in cycles of reincarnation (pagan theology) or in purgatory (Catholic theology). Salvation must be accepted in the present, for there are no second chances beyond this life. That is why Scripture speaks in urgent terms that "now is the day of salvation" (2 Cor. 6:2). There is no future day of salvation (beyond history) any more than there was a day of salvation (before history) in the timeless decree of election. History must be taken seriously, because Scripture takes it seriously.

Objective salvation was worked out in human history, in the life and death of Jesus Christ. It was not enough to have God decide to save humans prior to human history. Likewise, it is not good enough to have humans continue a process of subjective salvation after their individual human history. Biblical death is a cessation of life, and there is no history beyond the grave, only beyond the end-times resurrection from the grave (1 Thess. 4:16–18).

SPIRIT AS ENABLER

One day Christ told His disciples He would leave them, but they would not be orphans because He would send the Holy Spirit to them. He couched His promises to them in this covenant context:

> If you love me, keep my commands. And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another advocate to help you and be with you forever—I will not leave you as orphans; I will come to you.... Because I live, you also will live. On that day you will realize that I am in my Father, and you are in me, and I am in you. Whoever has my commands and keeps them is the one who loves me. The one who loves me will be loved by my Father, and I too will love them and show myself to them.... Anyone who does not love me will not obey my teaching. These words you hear are not my own; they belong to the Father who sent me. (John 14:15–16, 18, 19b–21, 24)

The final words of Christ on this planet were, "in a few days you will be baptized with the Holy Spirit...you will receive power when the Holy Spirit comes on you; and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth" (Acts 1:5b, 8). Then, "Exalted to the right hand of God, he has received from the Father the promised Holy Spirit and has poured out what you now see and hear" (2:33). That is when "All of them were filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit enabled them" (2:4).

The law and the Spirit are equally gifts of God given at Pentecost, for the pre-incarnate Christ came down to Mount Sinai at the time of Pentecost (in the Jewish calendar) to give the Ten Commandments, and at Pentecost the Father and Christ sent the Holy Spirit. The fruit of the Spirit is love (Gal.

5:22a), and God's law is love (Matt. 22:37–40). Christians should seek to have the Holy Spirit enthroned in their hearts, so He can rule within, enabling them to reflect the love of God through a covenant relationship of delighting in His law (cf. Ps. 119:47).

The pre-incarnate Christ wrote the Ten Commandments on tablets of stone (indicating their permanence, Exod. 31:18; 34:28b; Deut. 5:22b; 10:2, 4). The same law is written on the hearts of Christians in the new covenant (Jer. 31:31–34; Heb. 8:10), the same heart experience God longed to see in the old covenant (Deut. 5:29). It is said even of Gentiles, "the requirements of the law are written on their hearts" (Rom. 2:14–15).

Evidently God's law is as changeless as His plan of salvation for lawbreakers. Calvary and Pentecost uphold the law, because breaking it caused the need of salvation, and salvation is about restoring a broken relationship with God, which includes a restoration of loving to keep His law, a restoration of the damaged image of God, so rebellion will never arise again (Rev. 21:2–4; 22:3–5). When a church claims to have changed God's law (cf. prophecy in Dan. 7:25) and yet says it is the agent of salvation, that is a logical inconsistency. Claiming to change God's law is the same thing as breaking God's law, and salvation is opposed to law breaking, for it is rebellion against God. One cannot appreciate the urgency of eschatology without understanding this disparity. (This is a contribution that needs to be made to theology, and will be addressed in my *Systematic Theology*, volume 4.)

The Holy Spirit comes to work within Christians, "for it is God who works in you to will and to act in order to fulfill his good purpose" (Phil. 2:13). Hebrews puts it this way: "[M]ay the God of peace, who through the blood of the eternal covenant brought back from the dead our Lord Jesus, that great Shepherd of the sheep, equip you with everything good for doing his will, and may he work in us what is pleasing to him, through Jesus Christ, to whom be glory for ever and ever. Amen" (Heb. 13:20–21). Paul spoke of "divine power" which takes "captive every thought to make it obedient to Christ" (2 Cor. 10:4–5). God enables humans to obey His will (keep His Ten Commandments), because humans cannot do this through their own power, for they are sinners by nature, which means that they are lawbreakers by nature. Any works system for salvation has no room for Christ or the Holy Spirit. That is why there is no joy and peace for troubled hearts who attempt to save themselves.

Law keeping is only achieved in a covenant relationship with the Lawgiver through the indwelling Holy Spirit. God writes the law within those who are in covenant relationship with Him. Christ intends that the new covenant succeed

through Christians remaining in covenant relationship with Him. Christ's contribution toward this is His modeling what a covenant-law-keeping relationship looks like. Christ was the only Israelite, the only human, to remain in a covenant relationship with His Father. "No one knows the Son except the Father, and no one knows the Father except the Son" (Matt. 11:27); "I and the Father are one" (John 10:30); "It is the Father, living in me, who is doing his work" (John 14:10b, cf. 2 Cor. 5:19a); "I do nothing on my own but speak just what the Father has taught me. The one who sent me is with me; he has not left me alone" (John 8:28b–29).

This turns the alleged saving function of the church on its head. It is the Father who worked through Christ—it is God who writes the law in human hearts. The Persons of the Trinity do not need anyone or anything to come between them and humans, for they are well able to do the saving work. In fact, they are the only Ones who can do this work. To think otherwise is sheer blindness, for it fails to see the utter sinfulness of humans and the supreme majesty and power of God.

Some say their sin problem is genetic and cannot be remedied. But all humans are born sinners, and in salvation God does for them what they cannot do for themselves. Belief that one cannot overcome a genetic predisposition to sin is to unwittingly call into question the adequacy of salvation's plan, and therefore God's wisdom and power. The gospel is freedom from the reigning power of the sinful nature. Paul assures us:

> There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus. For the law of the Spirit of life has set you free in Christ Jesus from the law of sin and death. For God has done what the law, weakened by the flesh, could not do. By sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh and for sin, he condemned sin in the flesh, in order that the righteous requirement of the law might be fulfilled in us, who walk not according to the flesh but according to the Spirit. (Rom. 8:1–4, ESV)

No sin is beyond the healing, transforming power of the gospel through the new birth. Being born again is the only way to overcome being born sinners. Any view that victory over hereditary or cultivated tendencies to sin is impossible fails to grasp the full meaning of Calvary, [22] the present high priestly ministry of Christ, and the present ministry of the Holy Spirit.

22. Some believe they have been born with a sexual orientation that is beyond change. For those struggling with this question, the good news is that the power of the gospel can bring freedom. Consider the research of psychologists Stanton L. Jones and Mark A. Yarhouse, *Ex-Gays?: A Longitudinal Study of Religiously Mediated Change in Sexual Orientation* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2007). More importantly, all believers, whether heterosexual or homosexual in their inclinations, can live the lives Christ is calling them to live—we are all sinners in need of a loving Savior.

Sin needs to be thought of in a relational context (rather than a performance context). The latter is compatible with works to earn merit, whereas a relationship with God is so treasured that sin, which separates one from God (Isa. 59:2), is considered a hated enemy. But how can that be possible when one sins as easily as water running downhill? Victory over sin comes only when one gazes long at Christ hanging on the Cross as the sin-bearer and realizes what it cost Him; then, in love for Him, and in covenant communion with Him, one learns to hate what put Him there and learns to cling to Him and His overcoming power. Calvary exposes the utter folly of attempting to earn salvation. No amount of work to earn salvation produces a relationship. It does the opposite. Such work keeps the doer fixated on self, outside of a saving relationship.

SPIRIT AS "SPIRIT OF CHRIST"

In chapter 9 we noted that when Jesus Christ was confined to a human body through the Incarnation, He gave up His omnipresence. This is why the function of the Holy Spirit is so important in the Christian era, and why the Spirit for the first time in salvation history is called the "Spirit of Christ" (Rom. 8:9). Nowhere in the Old Testament is the Spirit called the "Spirit of Christ." Why? In the mystery of salvation's plan, the function of the Holy Spirit is to make the localized Christ omnipresent, as in the Incarnation the Holy Spirit brought the omnipresent Christ to be localized in one human body. Neither works of the Holy Spirit can be understood by humans; both are mysteries that are accepted in faith.

Just as Christ has a new post-resurrection ministry, so the Holy Spirit has a new post-resurrection ministry. In this sense, the ongoing work of Christ in heaven's sanctuary and the ongoing ministry of the Spirit of Christ within Christians are two dimensions of the one ongoing plan of salvation. Because of the Trinity's plan to send the Holy Spirit, Christ promises Christians that "surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age" (Matt. 28:20b), and Paul refers to, "Christ in you, the hope of glory" (Col. 1:27b). Mark it carefully—even the Holy Spirit doesn't claim to be Christ's successor on earth, but even He brings glory to Christ (John 16:14). The Holy Spirit is the infallible, eternally self-existent God, but never speaks about this in Scripture, for He stays quietly in the background, content to point humans to Christ alone.

The gospel is Jesus Christ. Scripture attests that the life and death of Jesus Christ is the gift of salvation for humans. The Holy Spirit applies the gift to make subjectively real in Christians what has been made objectively real by Christ.

The whole process of salvation is a creative work without any contribution from human works, "[f]or we are God's handiwork, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance for us to do" (Eph. 2:10). This is a new creation as supernatural as the original creation in Eden (Gen. 1–2). Scripture testifies to this in several places: "Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come: The old has gone, the new is here!" (2 Cor. 5:17); "what counts is the new creation" (Gal. 6:15b); "to put on the new self, created to be like God in true righteousness and holiness" (Eph. 4:24).

It is this same salvation that was offered in the old covenant: Scripture speaks of God as Creator in gathering the nation of Israel—"Is he not your Father, your Creator, who made you and formed you?" (Deut. 32:6b). But Israel "abandoned the God who made them and rejected the Rock their Savior" (v. 15b). The Psalmist gives the invitation to Israel: "Come, let us bow down in worship, let us kneel before the Lord our Maker; for he is our God and we are the people of his pasture, the flock under his care" (Ps. 95:6–7; cf. Ps. 100:3). "Let Israel rejoice in their Maker" (Ps. 149:2). In commenting on Psalm 100:3, Calvin says:

> it must be remembered that the prophet is not here speaking of creation in general...but of that spiritual regeneration by which he creates anew his image in his elect. Believers are the persons whom the prophet here declares to be God's workmanship, not that they were made men in their mother's womb, but in that sense in which Paul, in Eph. ii. 10, calls them, Τὸ ποιημα, the *workmanship* of God, because they are created unto good works which God hath before ordained that they should walk in them; and in reality this agrees best with the subsequent context. For when he says, *We are his people, and the sheep of his pasture*, he evidently refers to that distinguishing grace which led God to set apart his children for his heritage, in order that he may, as it were, nourish them under his wings, which is a much greater privilege than that of merely being born men.[23]

The work of salvation is a work of creation that only the Creator can do. Just as God was not dependent upon anything to create in the beginning (Eden, Gen. 1–2; Heb. 11:3), so He is not dependent upon anything (church and its sacraments) or anyone (Mary, saints, priests) to re-create His image in humans in the plan of salvation. It can be argued that just as God alone gave His Son, and Jesus alone lived and died for humans, so the Holy Spirit alone applies to humans all that Christ wrought for them. Yet Christ and the Holy Spirit both dwell within and contribute to Christian growth. It is in the area of application that humans claim to have a part in their salvation, but it is

23. Calvin, *Psalms 93–150*, vol. 6 in *Calvin's Commentaries* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1989), 84. Note that this is for the elect (the chosen few), whereas Scripture teaches that this is done for whosoever believeth in Christ (John 3:16). The choice is not made by God in eternity but by humans in history.

just as impossible to contribute to the application of their salvation as it is to help God offer up His Son, and to help Christ live His human life and die His sacrificial death. Salvation applied is just as much a gift as salvation supplied.[24]

The work of salvation includes Christ and the Spirit, and the Father who sent Christ and with Christ sent the Spirit. The key to salvation is relationship with the relational Trinity, which includes Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. Ivan Blazen indicates the closeness of the work of Christ and the Spirit.[25]

24. Human tradition, or human wisdom, often replaces God's Word in the history of God's people. For example, Jeroboam, the first king of the Israel after the division of the kingdom into Israel and Judah, set out to establish his rule by human means contrary to God's directions. He fortified Shechem (1 Kings 12:25), forgetting what God had said in that place (see next paragraph). Now there's nothing wrong in fortifying your capital city, except if your plan to save yourself from enemies includes disobeying God's commandments. Rather than seeking advice from God, which was available to kings in the book of the law (Deuteronomy) which they were to read each day of their rule (Deut. 17:18–20), the king asked advice of humans, which included setting up his own sacrificial system, with his own priests, golden calves, and places of worship (1 Kings 12:28–33).

The king forgot that God renewed the covenant with His people at Shechem (Deut. 27:1–4, 12–15; 28:1–30:20). The final words of Joshua recalled the pagan-gods environment out of which Abraham was called (24:2–3), and challenged the people to choose to worship these gods or to worship God, and Joshua declared he would worship God (24:15). He warned that if they chose to worship the gods, then God would bring disaster upon them (24:20), which is contrary to the human idea of once saved always saved, because of irresistible grace. For God respects the choice of humans. Hence it was for them to choose whom they wished to worship.

The king also forgot the last words of Moses, found in Deuteronomy, the book he should have read each day. God's plan to save Israel from their enemies is clear. "Then I said to you, 'Do not be terrified; do not be afraid of them. The Lord your God, who is going before you, as he did for you in Egypt, before your very eyes, and in the wilderness. There you saw how the Lord your God carried you, as a father catries his son, all the way you went until yout reached this place'" (Deut. 1:29–31).

Prior to entering the Promised Land, twelve spies were appointed to visit the country and bring back a report. Even though the minority report said it was "a good land" (Deut. 1:25), the majority report said, "We can't attack those people; they are stronger than we are" (Num. 13:31), the land "devours those living in it" (v. 32), and we "seemed like grasshoppers" (v. 33). The majority view was believed, but how foolish in the light of the Red Sea miracle when the greatest army of the then-known world was decimated by God! All of them witnessed that momentous victory. How could they forget? How could they say "The Lord hates us; so he brought us out of Egypt to deliver us into the hands of the Amorites to destroy us" (Deut. 1:27). There's a reason: human plans of salvation (from enemies) look to human works; God's plan focuses on His work. Their preoccupation with human works to save themselves hid the Red Sea God from their vision.

Yet when they learned that none of them would enter the Promised Land but die in the desert (except the two who gave the good report; Deut. 1:35–36), they launched into a plan to save themselves. The God who would have fought for them before now said don't go and fight, because He wasn't going to fight for those who didn't trust Him, but depended solely in their own human works (Deut. 1:42–45). They were defeated, for no human works bring salvation. The foolishness of going to battle in an attempt to save themselves through human works is in sharp contrast with the way God had accompanied and carried them in their journey (Deut. 1:31). When God does the fighting and carrying, we are reminded of Christ the Good Shepherd who carried the lost sheep all the way home (Luke 15:5). The battles against pagan nations were to be an insight into what God wanted to do for them in spiritually saving them. Whether in warfare or the spiritual fight, only God's work brings victory, never human works.

So Jeroboam was blinded to these truths as he set up his false system of worship, placing human ideas above God's revelation.

25. Ivan T. Blazen, "In Christ: Union with Him as Savior and Lord in Paul," *Biblical Research Institute Release #2* (May 2005): 9.

QUALITIES	"IN THE SPIRIT"	"IN CHRIST"
righteousness	Rom. 14:17	2 Cor. 5:21
justification	1 Cor. 6:11	Gal. 2:17
faith	1 Cor. 12:9	Gal. 3:26
sanctification	1 Cor. 6:11	1 Cor. 1:2
peace	Rom. 14:17	Phil. 6:7
joy	Rom. 14:17	Phil. 3:1; 4:4
love	Col. 1:8	Rom. 8:39
sealing	Eph. 4:30	Eph. 1:13
charisma (gift)	1 Cor. 12:9	Rom. 6:23
standing	Phil. 1:27	Phil. 4:1
being in	Rom. 8:9	1 Cor. 1:30
being filled	Eph. 5:18	Col. 2:10
speaking	1 Cor. 12:3	2 Cor. 2:17
testifying	Rom. 9:1	Eph. 4:17
the temple	Eph. 2:22	Eph. 2:21
one body	1 Cor. 12:13	Rom. 12:5

This sharing of qualities does not negate the functional distinctions among the Trinity in carrying out the work of salvation. The Father does the sending of His Son. The Son is the only One who became also human and lived a human life and died a substitutionary death, totally dependent upon the Father and Spirit. The Spirit is the One who brought Christ to be born as the Son of Man through Mary in a miracle of the Trinity. Father and Spirit suffered with Christ on the Cross. Salvation means unselfish suffering of the relational Trinity. Baptism is appropriately in the name of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, since the new Christian has been accepted into a relationship with the relational Trinity.

The Holy Spirit brings Christ now to be with His followers. Together the Holy Spirit and Christ work in Christians, but it is always the finished work of Christ (His life and death) which is applied. God the Father and the Holy Spirit have no independent work to offer. Christ's life, death, resurrection, and intercession in heaven's sanctuary, and His final glorification constitute the only plan of salvation. That's why *Christians* are so called—they bear the name of Christ. The Holy Spirit joins Christ even in interceding for Christians. But only Christ is seated at the right hand of God in intercession in the two apartments of the

heavenly sanctuary. However, the internal salvific work in Christians produces the fruit of the Spirit (Gal. 5:22–23), which is also "Christ in you, the hope of glory" (Col. 1:27).

Order of Salvation

Roman Catholic theology places the church ahead of salvation in their systems, because the church is the means of or to salvation. By contrast, most Protestant theologians place salvation before the church in their systems, although there are a few exceptions.[26] The truth of salvation dawned on Luther and Calvin as a relief from the Roman Catholic church with its many human requirements to earn salvation, for they found salvation in Jesus Christ alone.

The order of events in salvation (*ordo salutis*) is hardly found before the sixteenth century, and is attributed to the Reformation;[27] it was developed in the eighteenth century by Lutheran theologians Franz Buddeus and Jacob Carpov,[28] but has occupied a rather major place in soteriology ever since. For example, justification precedes sanctification (Luther), and regeneration (sanctification) precedes justification (Calvin). Most Reformed theologians follow Calvin's order, but some begin with justification rather than regeneration.[29] However, because Calvinists assume that the fall of Adam and Eve resulted in total depravity, all humans are born totally depraved. This means their only chance for salvation is to be among the elect whom Christ predestined in eternity, with an order of salvation that requires regeneration to precede salvation, in order to gain a human response to their elected salvation.

With respect to which comes first, justification or sanctification, arguably we should not allow to decide. Scripture seems to indicate that the order is not always of primary importance. Consider the order in the following texts:

Rom. 8:30: calling, justification (*edikaiōsen*), glorified [sanctification missing]
1 Cor. 1:30: wisdom, righteousness (*dikaiosynē*), sanctification (*hagiasmos*), redemption
1 Cor. 6:11: washed, sanctified (*hēgiasthēte*), justified (*edikaiōthēte*) [redemption missing]

Note that justification precedes sanctification (1 Cor. 1:30) and follows sanctification (1 Cor. 6:11), and yet both were written by Paul in his same

26. See Bavinck, *Sin and Salvation in Christ*, vol. 3 in *Reformed Dogmatics*, 524.
27. Hardly found among the Scholastics, see Louis Berkhof, *Systematic Theology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1996, 1st ed. 1932), 417.
28. See Bruce Demarest, *The Cross and Salvation: The Doctrine of Salvation* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 1997), 36.
29. Berkhof, *Systematic Theology*, 418.

letter to the Corinthians.[30] The most important fact is that all of the benefits of salvation are found in Jesus Christ. It is a relationship with Christ that these different words attempt to explain. I believe this relationship is best described by Paul as follows: "I have been crucified with Christ and I no longer live, but Christ lives in me. The life I now live in the body, I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me. I do not set aside the grace of God, for if righteousness could be gained through the law, Christ died for nothing" (Gal. 2:20–21).

These verses are crucial, for they show that salvation is Christ's dying for humans and then living in humans; and any attempt to gain this experience through law keeping is the same as saying Christ's death doesn't count. Calvary is either taken seriously or not—this is what separates the genuine from the counterfeit experience. The genuine focuses on what Christ did (Calvary) and does (live in humans), while the counterfeit focuses on human works that deny Calvary. True law keeping reveals one's love for Christ (John 14:15). A saving relationship with Christ is His work from beginning to end, and humans willingly cooperate with Him while filled with his Spirit. Paul says the Spirit lives within a true Christian (Eph. 2:22), and "Christ in you [is] the hope of glory" (Col. 1:27b). He then prays, "May God himself, the God of peace, sanctify you through and through" (1 Thess. 5:23a), for "it is God who works in you to will and to act according to his good purpose" (Phil. 2:13).

We have looked at some of the debate in the previous two chapters, but it needs to be kept in mind that salvation is experienced solely in a relationship with the Savior, and this is even more important than anything else (even than the order of justification, sanctification, glorification). We must hold together two aspects of salvation: (1) Christ lived and died for all humans, so salvation is available for all; (2) yet it is only those who accept the gift of Christ's life and death who receive salvation. Faith (or belief/trust) in Christ's salvation is not a saving work but a *response* to a saving work (Christ's alone), and never becomes a human contribution to salvation. Nowhere along the process of salvation does human effort merit salvation, for salvation is purely a gift of grace. "For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith—and this is not from yourselves, it is the gift of God" (Eph. 2:8). As William Shedd puts it: "A debt to God cannot be paid by man out of God's purse, though it can be so paid by God himself."[31] Heaven is not remuneration for human works, but redemption through the human works of Christ.

30. It can be argued that sanctification begins as soon as the person is justified, so that the two can be considered as simultaneous. There is an obvious distinction between the two, because a repentant sinner is declared justified instantly, whereas sanctification is a process that continues throughout life.
31. William G. T. Shedd, *Dogmatic Theology* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 2003, 1st ed. 1888–1894), 796.

Scripture says, "The Lord *Our Righteous Savior"* (Jer. 23:6b; 33:16b, emphasis added). The Hebrew *ṣādēq* (in the *hip'il*) and the Greek *dikaioō* mean the same (Exod. 23:7; Deut. 25:1; 2 Sam. 15:4; Job 27:4; Ps. 143:2; Prov. 17:15; Isa. 5:23).[32] "For in the gospel the righteousness of God [*dikaiosynē theou*] is revealed—a righteousness that is by faith from first to last, just as it is written 'The righteous will live by faith'" (Rom. 1:17; cf. Hab. 2:4). Christ's active righteousness (obedience) and passive righteousness (sacrifice) is imputed to humans. It takes the imputation of both His active and passive righteousness to save humans, to be their substitute, to be their righteousness. Paul says that "we have now been justified [*dikaiōthentes*] by his blood" (Rom. 5:9a). "He was delivered over to death for our sins and was raised to life for our justification" (*dikaiōsin*, Rom. 4:25). Here justification is given through Christ's death and through His resurrected ministry in heaven's sanctuary.

Both Christ and the Spirit have a saving ministry in the present for humans. "And if the Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead is living in you, he who raised Christ from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies because of his Spirit who lives in you" (Rom. 8:11). "The Spirit helps us in our weakness. We do not know what we ought to pray for, but the Spirit himself intercedes [*hyperentynchanei*] for us through groans wordless" (Rom. 8:26). "Christ Jesus who died—more than that, who was raised to life—is at the right hand of God and is also interceding [*entynchanei*] for us" (Rom. 8:34). No wonder Paul exclaims:

> Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall trouble or hardship or persecution or famine or nakedness or danger or sword?... No, in all these things we are more than conquerors through him who loved us. For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor demons, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord. (Rom. 8:35, 37–39)

Could there be any greater promise than this? When Christ is our righteousness, all the blessings of salvation are assured. This is thoroughly Christ centered, and thoroughly relational. Even the Holy Spirit is Christ centered. Jesus said that "when he, the Spirit of truth, comes, he will guide you into all truth. He will not speak on his own; he will speak only what he hears, and he will tell you what is yet to come. He will glorify me because it is from me that he will receive what he will make known to you" (John 16:13–14).

As noted before, salvation is not based on Calvary alone. While it is true that the sin debt was paid in full, humans also need to be clothed with Christ's

32. Robert Duncan Culver, *Systematic Theology: Biblical & Historical* (Ross-Shire, GB: Christian Focus, 2006, 1st ed. 2005), 735.

life of righteousness. Just as sinners need Christ's sacrifice, they also need His character. Isaiah writes that "he has clothed me with garments of salvation and arrayed me in a robe of his righteousness" (Isa. 61:10). John N. Oswalt points out that "Throughout this division, beginning with 56:1, it has been plain that God expects the delivered to manifest his nature. Those whom he wraps in his *robe of righteousness* experience not only deliverance from unrighteousness and the effect but also divine enablement to live out his righteousness.... God commands righteousness, and he by his power alone provides it. That is cause for joy indeed."[33] John Calvin agrees, "Since the Lord bestows these benefits, it follows that from him alone we should seek and expect them."[34]

Just as the gospel and law were important to the Savior, so they are important to salvation. The gospel and the law are not mutually exclusive. Christ never broke the law, but He died because humans broke the law. Law breaking is sin (1 John 3:4), and sin separates a person from God (Isa. 59:2). By contrast, God says, "These are the ones I look on with favor: those who are humble and contrite in spirit, and who tremble at my word" (Isa. 66:2b). God also said, "Obey me, and I will be your God and you will be my people [covenant language]. Walk in obedience to all I command you, that it may go well with you" (Jer. 7:23). Gospel and the law belong together in the old covenant, and they belong together in the new covenant, for Christ said, "If you love me, keep my commands" (John 14:15).

It is a great paradox in Christian theology that so much emphasis is placed upon the unchanging God and His unchanging will, but little emphasis is placed on His unchanging law, which expresses His unchanging will. If His unchanging will is off-limits for mere mortals, shouldn't it be the same when humans consider changing His unchanging law? This has never been thought through in traditional theology. Yet if His eternal will has so much to do with salvation (in His decree), wouldn't His eternal will have much to do with salvation (in His Law)? If His eternal unchanging will is a hidden matter, isn't His eternal will in His unchanging law a revelation of His will that surpasses anything allegedly hidden? Arguably God's immutability includes His law as well as His decree—as both express His unchanging will. That reality alone could revolutionize theology, revealing the consistency between law and grace, between the old and the new covenants, that all salvation history reveals an unchanging God (Mal. 3:6) and reveals that "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8).

33. John N. Oswalt, *Isaiah 40–66*, in *The New International Commentary on the Old Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1998), 575, emphasis in original.

34. Calvin, *Isaiah 33–36*, vol. 8 in *Calvin's Commentaries*, 316.

Aspects of Salvation

In the different aspects discussed below, we find a foundational principle in salvation. In order to receive the gift of salvation, humans must exercise freedom of choice (John 3:16). God doesn't force Himself upon anyone. Christ makes this very clear when speaking about the history of His elect people (Israel and Judah): "Jerusalem, Jerusalem, you who kill the prophets and stone those sent to you, how often I have longed to gather your children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, but you were not willing. Look, your house is left to you desolate" (Matt. 23:37–38).

This is a divine commentary on election. Christ respected their freedom of choice. They could turn down their election; there was no irresistible grace at work. Christ did not force them to do His will. In the end, God's chosen people exercised their own free will, and rejected God's will, which led to the cosmic controversy and ultimately will lead to a final judgment. To suggest that everything that happens is under the absolute will of God is to unwittingly charge Him with the cosmic controversy, which makes the holy God the cause of sin, and makes a mockery of Christ's lament over Jerusalem.

In Christ's lament over Jerusalem God's will is seen as compatible with His love. The fruit of the Holy Spirit is clearly defined as "love, joy, peace, forbearance, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness and self-control" (Gal. 5:22–23a). God's will is compatible with each one of these attributes. "God is love" (1 John 4:8–16), so that His will can only be expressed in the context of His love. He is a relational Trinity, and the exercise of His will can only be in a relational way. "See what great love the Father has lavished on us, that we should be called children of God!" (1 John 3:1a). Yet we are just as free to exercise our freedom of choice as were His children of old, for God and His love never change.

REPENTANCE

One does not have to repent before coming to Christ. In fact, Christ comes to the sinner and invites the sinner, "Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest" (Matt. 11:28). Just as it is impossible to be pardoned without Christ, so it is impossible to repent without Christ. For Christ says that it takes lifting Him up to draw sinners to Him (John 12:32). There is no greater drawing power than the uplifted Christ dying on the cross. So much has been said about the total depravity of humans, of their inability to contribute anything to their own salvation. But it is far more important to speak of the total deliverance of humans through Christ's death. Total deliverance is God's answer to total depravity.

Without violating human freedom, God invites humans to repent. Paul says, "God's kindness" (*chrēston*) leads to repentance (Rom. 2:4b, ESV). Peter says of Christ, "God exalted him to his own right hand as Prince and Savior that he might bring Israel to repentance and forgive their sins" (Acts 5:31). So repentance is just as much a gift as pardon and salvation. Without the drawing power of God, humans would never be led to repent, so there is no merit to repentance as if it were a human contribution. Rather, repentance is a human response to God's invitation, and is a result of God's working on the mind and heart of the one who is brought to repentance. Again, God knew He would do this after the Fall, and made provisions for humans to be able to respond to His invitation. Put another way, repentance is not predestined, but offered.

BELIEF/FAITH

"Believe" (*pisteuōn*, John 3:16) and "faith" (*pistis*, Rom. 10:17) come from the same Greek word. So we will consider them both in this segment. "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life" (John 3:16). This favorite text of Christians has more to it than one may think. God's love is the key, and it is defined in this text by two facts: (1) God invites people to believe in Him, and (2) if they respond they will have eternal life, and so will not perish. This text, therefore, is contrary to two well-accepted Christian traditions, predestination and hell.

God's love is defined by giving humans freedom to believe, and by saving those persons from perishing. Put differently, God's love is meaningless if humans don't have the freedom to believe, and if they have to suffer eternal torment. Paul says he wasn't ashamed of the gospel, "because it is the power of God that brings salvation to everyone who believes" (Rom. 1:16). Salvation requires belief, for it is not only a gift, but also a relationship. Hence, without belief, there is no realized salvation. As the author of Hebrews puts it, "they were not able to enter, because of their unbelief" (Heb. 3:19).

Paul states that "faith comes from hearing the message, and the message is heard through the word about Christ" (*rhēmatos Christou*, Rom. 10:17). Faith does not originate in humans, but comes to them through the Word of Christ, or through God's inspired words in Scripture. Faith also comes to humans through hearing the preached Word, with the Holy Spirit bringing conviction and implanting faith to respond to what they have heard. Faith doesn't come by looking to ourselves, to what we have done or not done; faith comes by looking to Christ. Listen to His invitation: "Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you and learn from me,

for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For my yoke is easy and my burden is light" (Matt. 11:28–30); "whoever comes to me I will never drive away" (John 6:37b). There is no faith received without the free will of the recipient to respond to the gift.

Christ often taught spiritual truths through acts of healing, for in the Greek the word for "healing" and "salvation" is the same. We will note two examples of Christ's healing which illustrate the importance of true faith, and to this extent they help to define saving faith.

1. The centurion in Capernaum built a Jewish synagogue, which Jewish elders wrongly thought merited the healing of his servant. The elders "pleaded earnestly" with Jesus about this (Luke 7:3–5). But healing by works was no more a part of Christ's mission than salvation by works. The centurion's request to Christ was "say the word, and my servant will be healed" (v. 7b), to which Jesus responded, "I tell you, I have not found such great faith even in Israel" (v. 9b). The centurion had evidently heard enough about Jesus that he was in awe of Him, saying, "I do not deserve to have you come under my roof" (v. 6b). His was a true faith in response to knowing, to some degree, the holy life and ministry of Jesus.

Jesus was astonished and spoke to His followers: "I say to you that many will come from the east and the west, and will take their place at the feast with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob in the kingdom of heaven. But the subjects of the kingdom will be thrown outside, into the darkness, where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth" (Matt. 8:11–12). Whereas the Roman centurion did not feel worthy, the Jewish leaders thought he was worthy. The centurion had faith in Jesus whereas the Jewish leaders did not—they pled with Jesus on the basis of the centurion's works rather than on the basis of his faith. The Jewish leaders prized human works, for they depended on their own, whereas the centurion depended on Jesus, and his request was made out of his great need.

2. A woman suffered a great deal through having suffered a hemorrhage for twelve years; she had spent all her money on doctors, but only grew worse (Mark 5:25–26). She heard of Jesus and went to see Him. "A large crowd followed and pressed around him…she came up behind him in the crowd and touched his cloak, because she thought, 'If I just touch his clothes, I will be healed.' Immediately her bleeding stopped and she felt in her body that she was freed from her suffering" (vv. 24b, 27b–29). Jesus knew that power had left Him, so He asked who had touched His clothes. The disciples didn't know why He was asking, for many people pressed Him from all sides. But Jesus knew the difference between a casual touch and a touch of faith (vv. 30–31). Many name the name of Christ, but He is only a casual acquaintance, and theirs is only an intellectual assent to Him. But spiritual healing comes to those who want to be near to Him, to have

Him as a personal Savior, and He honors them with the healing they need, for true faith is relational—the believer wants to be close to Christ.

By faith we must accept the righteousness of Christ, knowing that not even a lifetime of good works will earn salvation, yet salvation is not given without a faith that works by love and purifies the soul. In the Council of Jerusalem, Peter comments on the Gentiles: "God, who knows the heart, showed that he accepted them by giving the Holy Spirit to them, just as he did to us. He did not discriminate between us and them, for he purified their hearts by faith" (Acts 15:8–9). Faith and purification are gifts from God, yet faith is to be exercised as a response to God's work, so the human cooperates with God through faith. For God respects human freedom, and only works in people who respond. Christ says: "I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in and eat with that person, and they with me" (Rev. 3:20).

Faith dispels fear. Yet many Christians do not enjoy the liberty that comes through an indwelling Christ who works in them. Why? Because they are so preoccupied with the busyness of life. Christ wants us to focus on Him as our Savior, and not on the burdens of life that often hide Christ from our view. Christ says to those of little faith, "[D]o not worry, saying, 'What shall we eat?' or 'What shall we drink?' or 'What shall we wear?' For the pagans run after all these things, and your heavenly Father knows that you need them. But seek first his kingdom and his righteousness, and all these things will be given to you as well. Therefore do not worry about tomorrow, for tomorrow will worry about itself. Each day has enough trouble of its own" (Matt. 6:31–34). Faith in a God who is well able to provide for all our needs (physical and spiritual) focuses on the only One who is able to remove all worry, replacing it by the freedom He imparts. Salvation is wholistic, having to do with the total person, day by day, and makes life a spiritual experience even as we live in a secular world.

BAPTISM

Christ has commissioned His disciples to "make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded" (Matt. 28:19). Teaching precedes and follows baptism. So Christ is speaking of adult or believer's baptism. Nowhere in Scripture does Christ commission disciples to baptize infants. Infant baptism is practiced by most churches, and most of those infants never receive adult baptism. Historically Anabaptists, who believed that adults should receive adult baptism, were persecuted for teaching adult baptism for those who had only had infant baptism.

Infant baptism means parents make the decision for babies to be baptized because infants cannot make that decision. As mentioned previously, this is compatible with the theory of God's election of people prior to their birth, making a decision for them. In predestination and infant baptism, human freedom to choose is not important. This denies the freedom of choice which God considers very important. He says, for example: "Choose you this day whom ye will serve" (Josh. 24:15a, KJV), and "Repent and be baptized" (Acts 2:38a). Those arguing for infant baptism do so in a covenant context, linking circumcision in the old covenant with infant baptism in the new covenant. Some scholars compare infant baptism with the eternal decree. Robert Booth puts it this way, "The Scriptures indicate that the covenant is sovereignly initiated by God, not by man, and therefore that the covenant sign and seal [infant baptism] is God's, not the believer's."[35] So the decree and infant baptism are sovereignly initiated without any participation from humans. At least the logic is consistent in seeing both as a work of God that has nothing to do with human response.

However, two questions need to be raised. First, is circumcision a viable type of infant baptism? Second, would we expect a relational Trinity to use an eternal decree and infant baptism, thus not allowing for human free choice? Circumcision was confined to male membership in Israel and so couldn't include membership in the ancient church. In those days circumcision was a sign of males belonging to the Jewish race, but had nothing to do with salvation. John the Baptist confronted Pharisees and Sadducees, calling them a "brood of vipers" (Matt. 3:7) reminiscent of "the ancient serpent called the devil, or Satan" (Rev. 12:9a; cf. Gen. 3:1–6), and saying, "do not think you can say to yourselves, 'We have Abraham as our father'" for "fruit" in the life is what counts (Matt. 3:9–12). That is why Scripture speaks against dependence upon being included in the race as sufficient for salvation and urges that Jews be circumcised in their hearts (Deut. 10:16), a saving relationship offered to both females and males. "A person is not a Jew who is one only outwardly, nor is circumcision merely outward and physical. No, a person is a Jew who is one inwardly; and circumcision is circumcision of the heart, by the Spirit, not by the written code. Such a person's praise is not from other people, but from God" (Rom. 2:28–29).

The limited focus of circumcision (males only) disqualifies it from being a type of infant baptism (for all infants). As a firstborn male, Christ was dedicated when an infant (Luke 2:21–24; Exod. 13:2, 12; Lev. 12:8) and baptized when an adult. Dedication of the firstborn was to remind the Jews of the Exodus when their firstborn were protected by the blood of the lamb (Deut. 21:17).

35. Robert R. Booth, *Children of the Promise: The Biblical Case for Infant Baptism* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 1995), 112.

No other Jewish children were dedicated in infancy as were the firstborn. However, the blood of the Lamb shed at Calvary covers all humans until they are old enough to decide to accept that sacrifice and be baptized. In that context it seems more appropriate that infant dedication to Christ be a precursor of adult baptism, so that baptism is reserved for its adults, as experienced and commissioned by Christ. All the arguments for infant baptism can be satisfied with infant dedication.[36]

Now to the second question about relationship: The purpose of God's covenant with humans, in its several manifestations, was to enter a two-way meaningful relationship. The covenant relationship was meant to reflect the relationship among the Persons of the Trinity. It follows that the covenants are voluntary, for God respects human freedom to choose to respond or not to His covenant invitation. A relational God would never be arbitrary, choosing some as the elect, and rejecting the rest to everlasting abandonment. This is utterly foreign to a God of love. Neither would a relational God be interested in a sacrament taking His place in His outreach to humans, a mechanical form for infants who have no choice.

Patristic references to adult baptism are found in the first four centuries. For example, Cyprian (ca. 200–258) wrote of Jesus' conversation with John the Baptist, "it becomes me to do this first, and thus to teach.... Baptize me, John, in order that no one may despise baptism."[37] Chrysostom (347–407) wrote *Instructions to Catechumens*, which prepared adults for baptism.[38] In his homily on *The Epistle to the Romans* (6:3–5), he speaks of baptismal burial and resurrection as being baptized into Christ's death and resurrection, which would require immersion.[39] But the greatest influence for change from adult to infant baptism is due to Augustine of Hippo's arguments. Now infant baptism is practiced in Protestant churches. In the Reformed Churches of the Netherlands infant baptism is based on (1) presupposed regeneration (Kuyper), or (2) the covenant of grace (Calvin, Beza, Zanchius, Buchanus, Walaeus, Ames, Heidegger, Turretin, and Bavinck).[40]

36. For example, see Booth, *Children of Promise*; Samuel Miller, *Infant Baptism: Scriptural & Reasonable* (Philadelphia, PA: Crowns Right, 1997, 1st ed. 1835); and Gregg Strawbridge, ed., *The Case for Covenantal Infant Baptism* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 2003).

37. Cyprian, *Discourse on the Holy Theophany*, eds. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson, *Ante-Nicene Fathers* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1990), 5:236.

38. Chrysostom, *Instructions to Catechumens*, ed. Philip Schaff, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1989), 9:159–171.

39. Chrysostom, *Homilies on Second Corinthians*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 12:405, 409.

40. See J. Mark Beach, "Introductory Essay," in Herman Bavinck, *Saved by Grace: The Holy Spirit's Work in Calling and Regeneration* (Grand Rapids, MI: Reformation Heritage Books, 2008), xxxii–xxxiii, cf. The Synod of Utrecht (1905), 169–172.

Augustine (350–430) prayed to God to forgive his dead mother's sins, which supports prayers for those in purgatory, a practice that evidently began in the time of Tertullian (ca. 155–220).[41] Such prayers for the dead entered theology long before infant baptism, although they have much in common—making decisions for others. Augustine introduced the idea that all are born with the guilt of Adam (original sin),[42] because their souls were present in the loins of Adam when he sinned.

Augustine rejected Pelagians because "they refuse to believe that in infants original sin is remitted through baptism, for they contend that no such original sin exists at all in people by their birth."[43] Although Scripture speaks of the consequences (condemnation/death) of Adam's sin being passed on to all his posterity (Rom. 5:16–17), it does not include Adam's guilt. Nevertheless, on the one hand Augustine said babies will perish without infant baptism,[44] and yet he said, "the devil's power is exorcised in infants and that they renounce him by the hearts and mouths of those who bring them to baptism."[45]

Through a wrong view of the soul, a wrong view of imparted guilt entered theology, which introduced a wrong view of infant baptism to get rid of the imparted guilt as soon as the baby is born. Augustine believed God "engrafts into His body even baptized infants" stating that God "secretly infuses" "hidden grace" into these babes.[46] The secrecy and hiddenness of this gift in Augustine's theology is based upon his understanding of God's election: "what He has chosen to be kept secret" for "His judgments are unsearchable."[47]

This secret election has impacted Protestant as well as Catholic theology. For example, Calvin quotes Augustine more than any other theologian.[48] He speaks of election as the "secret counsel of God" which is the "hidden counsel of God."[49] By contrast, God's revelation contradicts this alleged secrecy, for the glorious gospel declares Christ was born in order to save the world (John 3:16) and died in order to save the world (1 John 2:2). God's covenant with humans is a trajectory

41. Augustine, "The Confessions of St. Augustin," *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 1:140–141 (for history see 141n).

42. Augustine, "On Forgiveness of Sins and Baptism," *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 5:24; and "On Original Sin," 5:253.

43. Augustine, "On Forgiveness of Sins and Baptism," 5:18.

44. Ibid., 5:31, 37–38, 62, 237–238.

45. Augustine, *On Marriage and Concupiscence*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, ed. Philip Schaff (Grand Rapids, MA: Hendrikson, 1987), 5:273.

46. Augustine, *On the Merits and Forgiveness of Sins, and on the Baptism of Infants*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, ed. Philip Schaff (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1994), 5:19.

47. Augustine, O*n the Predestination of the Saints and on the Gift of Perseverance*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, ed. Philip Schaff (Grand Rapids, MA: Hendrikson, 1987), 5:506. However, Augustine was clear that infant baptism and partaking of the Eucharist are insufficient to save those who continue in sin, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 2:472.

48. Calvin, *Institutes*, 2:510–511 (4.14.26).

49. Ibid., 2:227 (3.23.1).

through history of His unfailing, unchanging love for all humanity. God's election and atonement are universal because He gives all humans the freedom to elect or reject Him (John 3:16), which makes infant baptism worthless.

In 1967, in the final book of Karl Barth's thirteen-volume *Church Dogmatics*, he rejects infant baptism. He writes, "I have had to abandon the 'sacramental' understanding of baptism."[50] Baptism is the free response of people to the Holy Spirit as "a faithful partner in the covenant of grace."[51] Baptism is the "free and active answer of man to the divine work and word of grace."[52] This is a welcome development in Barth's later theology, and I salute him for this change that the biblical view of the covenant forced upon him.

SAVING RELATIONSHIP

In this segment we explore the different aspects of the relationship between Christ and humans in the process of salvation. In this context Christ is not only Savior but Lord, not only Redeemer but also Ruler. These attributes are a gift of freedom so recipients can speak of "the perfect law that gives freedom" (Jas. 1:25b).

Focus on Christ

It is not enough to receive pardon; Christians also need to receive power. Power is not something God gives to a person, expecting the person to use the power to overcome. Rather, Christ comes to the Christian, and together they are one in living the Christian life. Salvation is righteousness that is imputed and imparted through Christ, "our righteousness" (1 Cor. 1:30). God never expects Christians to live alone, without Him. Instead of Christians using God's power or righteousness, God comes within to live His life in them.

Paul puts it this way: "I have been crucified with Christ and I no longer live, but Christ lives in me" (Gal. 2:20a). That is the secret of a successful relationship, loving God and loving fellow humans; it is law keeping that is just as much a delight as it was for David (Pss. 119:47, 70, 77, 92, 143, 174). Christ is the only human who has kept the law of God perfectly. He knows what it takes to overcome the tempter, and He brings all this experience to live through humans to give them power over sin and thus complete what He gave them in pardon for sin.

Scripture proclaims, "Christ [is] in you, the hope of glory" (Col. 1:27), but consider a more expansive context: "[I]n him all things were created: things in heaven and on earth…in him all things hold together…he is the head of the body,

50. Barth, *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, vol. 4, pt. 4 in *Church Dogmatics*, x.

51. Ibid., 4; question form in original, which intends a positive answer from context, for baptism is the "beginning and initiarion of the faithfulness of man which replies and corresponds to the faithfulness of God," 3.

52. Ibid., ix.

the church; he is the beginning and the firstborn from among the dead, so that in everything he might have the supremacy. For God was pleased to have all his fullness dwell in him, and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether things on earth or things in heaven, by making peace through his blood, shed on the cross" (vv. 16a, 17–20). Christ is the power Christians need.

The Persons of the relational Trinity invite humans into a covenant relationship with them, so that God can be their God, and they can be God's people. All attempts at salvation outside of this covenant relationship are worthless, no matter how sincere. God is the only capable and authorized Savior, and no other entity, whether church, sacraments, priests, or human mediators, will suffice.

Richard Foster's 1978 *Celebration of Discipline: The Path to Spiritual Growth* presents spiritual disciplines which he believes are central to spiritual growth, for they are a "door to liberation."[53] His book is divided into inward, outward, and corporate disciplines. My comments are confined to the inward segment, which raises a concern. Although Foster distinguishes between Christian meditation and eastern meditation,[54] and suggests meditation on Scripture,[55] there is an inward focus that is similar:

(1) In the context of entering the "inner world," he says, "If we are willing to listen to the Heavenly Monitor, we will receive the instruction we need."[56] Consider this in view of counterfeit Christology.[57] (2) He quotes approvingly the Russian mystic Theophan the Recluse's statement, "To pray is to descend with the mind into the heart, and there to stand before the face of the Lord, ever-present, all seeing, within you."[58] (3) He quotes approvingly St. Teresa of Ávila's statement, "as I could not make reflection with my understanding I contrived to picture Christ within me."[59] (4) In the context of study, Foster says, "Of course, the New Testament replaces laws written on the doorposts with laws written on the heart and leads us to Jesus, our ever-present and

53. Richard J. Foster, *Celebration of Discipline: The Path to Spiritual Growth* (New York: HarperCollins, 1998, 1st ed. 1978), 1.

54. Ibid., 20, "Eastern meditation is an attempt to empty the mind, Christian meditation is an attempt to fill the mind."

55. Ibid., 29–30. Also he rightly says, "Study provides a certain objective framework within which meditation can successfully function." 64.

56. Ibid., 11.

57. In the New Age Bible *The Urantia Book* (1955), when Jesus was five years of age, a "Thought Adjuster" came to abide in him: "Jesus was no more aware of the coming of the divine Monitor than are the millions upon millions of other children who, before and since that day, have likewise received these Thought Adjusters to indwell their minds and work for the ultimate spiritualization of these minds and the eternal survival of their evolving immortal souls," *The Urantia Book*, 1357. In this alleged gospel, Jesus didn't seek divine power from above or depend upon God beyond Himself, but looked solely within for guidance and power, *The Urantia Book*, 1386, 1421, 1424, 1492.

58. Theophan the Recluse, quoted in Foster, *Celebration of Discipline*, 19.

59. Teresa of Ávila, quoted in Foster, *Celebration of Discipline*, 25, cf. 41.

inward Teacher."[60] (5) Foster sums up this segment by saying, "You will be constantly learning and growing as you plumb the inner depths,"[61] adding, "Meditation introduces us to the inner life."[62] (This is similar to the inner focus of New Age meditation.)

Focus on Christ in Heaven's Sanctuary

Rather than focusing on the "inner sanctuary of the heart" as Foster does,[63] Scripture repeatedly mentions that Christ is at the right hand of the Father at the throne in the sanctuary of heaven (Mark 16:19; Acts 2:23, 34; 5:31; 7:55–56; Rom. 8:34; Eph. 1:20–23; Col. 3:1; Heb. 1:1–3; 1 Pet. 3:22). It is far more important to focus on what Christ is doing in the sanctuary of heaven than what the Spirit is doing inside a Christian life, for what happens within is the fruit of what happens in heaven. Hebrews says: "Therefore, since we have a great high priest who has ascended into heaven, Jesus the Son of God, let us hold firmly to the faith we profess. For we do not have a high priest who is unable to empathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who was tempted in every way, just as we are—yet he did not sin. Let us then approach God's throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need" (Heb. 4:14–16). It is far more important to be focused on Christ's ministry in the sanctuary of heaven than on the results of this ministry in the sanctuary of the heart.

Isaiah said: "I saw the Lord, high and exalted seated on a throne; and the train of his robe filled the temple," and angels called to one another: "Holy, holy, holy is the Lord Almighty; the whole earth is full of his glory." Isaiah's response was "Woe is me!...I am ruined! For I am a man of unclean lips, and I live among a people of unclean lips, and my eyes have seen the King, the Lord Almighty" (Isa. 6:1, 3, 5).

Before being stoned, "Stephen, full of the Holy Spirit, looked up to heaven and saw the glory of God and Jesus standing at the right hand of God. 'Look,' he said, 'I see heaven open and the Son of Man standing at the right hand of God'" (Acts 7:55–56). The book of Revelation presents more scenes of heaven. John said, "At once I was in the Spirit, and there before me was a throne in heaven with someone sitting on it. And the one who sat there had the appearance of jasper and ruby. A rainbow that shone like an emerald encircled the throne" (Rev. 4:2–3). Then created beings never stopped saying: "Holy, holy, holy is the Lord God Almighty, who was, and is, and is to come" (Rev. 4:8b).

60. Foster, *Celebration of Discipline*, 64.

61. Ibid., 32.

62. Ibid., 33.

63. Ibid., 20.

After this John saw a sealed book which no one was worthy to open, and he wept. "Then one of the elders said to me, 'Do not weep! See, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has triumphed. He is able to open the scroll and its seven seals.' Then I saw a Lamb, looking as if it has been slain, standing at the center of the throne" (Rev. 5:5–6). He came and took the scroll, and twenty-four redeemed humans sang a new song: "You are worthy to take the scroll and to open its seals, because you were slain, and with your blood you purchased for God persons from every tribe and language and people and nation. You have made them to be a kingdom of priests to serve our God, and they will reign on the earth" (vv. 9–10).

Then angels sang with a loud voice: "Worthy is the Lamb, who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and strength and honor and glory and praise!" Then everyone sang: "To him who sits on the throne and to the Lamb be praise and honor and glory and power, for ever and ever!" (Rev. 5:12–13). Jesus said of the Holy Spirit who works in human hearts: "He will glorify me" (John 16:14a), and so will Christians, in whom the Spirit dwells, bring glory to Christ.

Below are two passages to compare. In the Ephesian passage Christ makes humans alive, in a spiritual resurrection from the dead, followed by a spiritual ascension with Christ to the throne of God. Both are supernatural miracles beyond the ability of humans. In the Colossians passage, baptism is shown to be a burial and resurrection with Christ, entering into His death and resurrection. He died for human sin so that humans can die to sin, applying His death to their sin through baptism, followed by sharing in His resurrection. They are made alive through Christ, a resurrection with Christ, which means they can set their hearts on things above where Christ is at God's throne.

In Ephesians, it is as if the baptized are with Christ at the throne. In Colossians, the baptized focus on Christ at the throne. Both represent the miraculous new life made possible through the death, resurrection, and present ministry of Christ in heaven's sanctuary. The resurrected new life in Christ shares, as it were, in His enthronement (in a proleptic sense) because He is enthroned within; so the Christian focuses on Christ's heavenly enthronement (and all that means) because Christ rules in the minds and hearts of Christians where He is also enthroned. The focus is on Christ's enthronement in heaven and not on His enthronement within, for the new life in Christ is Christ centered and not Christian centered. This focus is crucial because salvation applied is the work of the Spirit, who always brings glory to Christ (John 16:14a), and causes Christians to do the same. In studying the application of salvation, Christians have a mandate from the Spirit that involves "fixing our

eyes on Jesus, the pioneer and perfecter of faith" who "sat down at the right hand of the throne of God" (Heb. 12:2).

Ephesians 2:4–7

But because of his great love for us, God, who is rich in mercy, made us alive with Christ [*synezōopoiēsen*] even when we were dead in transgressions—it is by grace that you have been saved. And God raised us up with Christ [*synēgeiren*] and seated us with him in heavenly realms in Christ Jesus, in order that in the coming ages he might show the incomparable riches of his grace.

Colossians 2:12–15; 3:1–3

Having been buried with him [*syntaphentes*] in baptism, in which you were also raised with him [*synēgerthēte*] through your faith in the working of God, who raised him from the dead...God made you alive with Christ [*synezōopoiēsen*]...and having disarmed the powers and authorities, he made a public spectacle of them, triumphing over them by the cross.... Since, then, you have been raised with Christ, set your hearts on things above, where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God. Set your minds on things above, not on earthly things. For you died, and your life is now hidden with Christ in God.

Peter says: "For you were like sheep going astray, but now you have returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls" (1 Pet. 2:25). This is relationship language, for redemption is restoration of a relationship between the Savior and the saved. Christ within brings a hatred of sin and a yearning to be righteous, because the relationship is desired above everything else. Jesus expresses it well: "Blessed [*makarioi*, happy] are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they will be filled" (Matt. 5:6).

Focus on Remaining in Christ

Christ has said, "I am the vine; you are the branches. If you remain in me and I in you, you will bear much fruit; apart from me you can do nothing" (John 15:5). In fact, Christ promises: "If you remain in me and my words remain in you, ask whatever you wish, and it will be done for you.... As the Father has loved me, so have I loved you. Now remain in my love" (vv. 7, 9). This is a metaphor for the saving relationship God wants to see continued throughout our lives, for union with Christ is the only way to remain in a saved experience.

There is no once-saved, always-saved reality. Those born again can fall away: "We must pay the most careful attention, therefore, to what we have heard, so

that we do not drift away…how shall we escape if we ignore so great a salvation?" (Heb. 2:1, 3a). Drifting does not question God's omnipotence (or sovereignty), for He is able; but drifting exposes human weakness—without Christ we can do nothing, apart from Him we cannot live the Christian life. Some Christians don't sense their need of Christ, and think, *I am rich; I have acquired wealth and do not need a thing*. Christ says to them: "[Y]ou do not realize that you are wretched, pitiful, poor, blind and naked" (Rev. 3:17). They don't realize their true spiritual condition. They think they need nothing, but in fact they need everything that Christ offers them. The tragedy is Christ stands outside of them, knocking, wanting to gain entrance, but the text never says Christ entered. Evidently they drifted so far they were never able to realize their need of the Savior.

Sin as rebellion is another matter, for Scripture says that "it is impossible for those who have once been enlightened, who have tasted the heavenly gift, who have shared in the Holy Spirit, who have tasted the goodness of the word of God and the powers of the coming age and who have fallen away, to be brought back to repentance. To their loss they are crucifying the Son of God all over again and subjecting him to public disgrace" (Heb. 6:4–6). There is a huge difference between sin as rebellion and temptation. If we are tempted, "we have an advocate with the Father—Jesus Christ, the Righteous One" (1 John 2:1b), a sympathetic high priest who was tempted just as we are, and ministers for us in heaven's sanctuary (Heb. 4:14–16).

God wants humans to hate all sin. He knows this is humanly impossible; that is why He invites humans to let Him into their lives and asks them to remain in Him (which are two ways to express a saving relationship). With Christ all things are possible. Paul declares, "I can do all this through him who gives me strength" (Phil. 4:13). How do we remain in God's love? (1) We must recognize that apart from Him we can do nothing, we cannot keep the law, we cannot bear fruit, we are merely broken branches—disconnected from the lifeblood of the vine; (2) God makes a promise—gives us assurance: "If you keep my commands, you will remain in my love, just as I have kept my Father's commands and remain in his love" (John 15:10).

The three foci: "Christ in you," Christ in heaven's sanctuary, and "remain in Christ" speak of a necessary relationship between Christ and Christians, because a Christian life is never a solo experience. God never expects or asks Christians to go it alone. He invites us: "Come to me" (Matt. 11:28a). Salvation is a restoration of a broken relationship between God and humans caused by sin. Christ came into human history, lived as a human, dependent solely upon God beyond Himself. Much of His life was a lonely experience, even feeling forsaken by God

on the Cross, but He entered the loneliness as our substitute so that in Him we may be lonely no more.

Good News of Salvation

Christians who attempt to be saved through their own works are trapped in a hopeless task. "Since they [do] not know the righteousness of God and [seek] to establish their own, they [do] not submit to God's righteousness. For Christ is the culmination of the law so that there may be righteousness for everyone who believes" (Rom. 10:3–4). Once Martin Luther zealously worked to earn salvation (beating his body with flagellations) until he met Christ in the book of Romans and discovered that the just live by faith (1:16–17). God called Luther to proclaim the gospel in the sixteenth century, just as he called Paul to proclaim it in the first century. The book of Romans became the Magna Carta of the Reformation. So what contribution does Romans make to the doctrine of salvation, and has its message been fully understood today?

Paul in Romans shows us that humans have nothing to offer to earn salvation: (1) "None is righteous, no not one" (3:10, ESV). (2) "All have turned aside; together they have become worthless; no one does good, not even one" (3:12, ESV). (3) "[A]ll have sinned and fall short of the glory of God" (3:23, ESV). There is no saving virtue in humans. Sinners must look outside of themselves to One who is sinless, who is righteous in Himself. Sinners need Christ as their righteousness. The promise is that "if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved" (10:9, ESV). "For everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved" (10:13, ESV). Salvation is found in a Person and not in a practice, in a relationship and not in a regimen. There is no salvation apart from Jesus Christ.

Paul says the gospel "is the power of God for salvation" (1:16a, ESV). This power includes "God's love" which "has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit" (5:5, ESV). This is the Holy Spirit who raised Christ from the dead, and when he "dwells [*oikei*] in you," He "will also give life [*zōopoiēsei*] to your mortal bodies" (8:11b, ESV). This means "now that you have been set free from sin and have become slaves of God, the fruit you get leads to sanctification and its end, eternal life" (6:22, ESV). These fruits include: (1) not being "conformed [*syschēmatizesthe*] to this world, but being transformed [*metamorphousthe*] by the renewal of your mind" (12:2a, ESV). Gifts (*charismata*, 12:6) of grace include humility (12:3), prophecy (*prophēteian*, 12:6b), teaching (*didaskalia*, 12:7b), exhortation (*paraklēsei*, 12:8a), "the one who contributes [*metadidous*], in generosity

[*haplotēti*]; the one who leads [*proistamenos*] with zeal; the one who does acts of mercy [*eleōn*], with cheerfulness" (12:8b, ESV).

Paul mentions some Christian works in Romans 12.

> Let love be genuine. Abhor what is evil; hold fast to what is good. Love one another with brotherly affection. Outdo one another in showing honor. Do not be slothful in zeal, be fervent in spirit, serve the Lord. Rejoice in hope, be patient in tribulation, be constant in prayer. Contribute to the needs of the saints and seek to show hospitality. Bless those who persecute you; bless and do not curse them. Rejoice with those who rejoice, weep with those who weep. Live in harmony with one another. Do not be haughty, but associate with the lowly. Never be wise in your own sight. Repay no one evil for evil, but give thought to do what is honorable in the sight of all. If possible, so far as it depends on you, live peaceably with all. Beloved, never avenge yourselves, but leave it to the wrath of God, for it is written, "Vengeance is mine, I will repay, says the Lord." To the contrary, "if your enemy is hungry, feed him; if he is thirsty, give him something to drink; for by so doing you will heap burning coals on his head. Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good." (vv. 9–21, ESV)

Paul says that "love is the fulfilling of the law" (13:8–10, ESV), which rejects persecution as a Christian tool (anathemas were hurled by both sides in the Catholic-Protestant debates of the sixteenth century). Christians will love one another for eternity. Denominational differences will not hinder, for all are God's saved children. In the meantime, Christians await a Savior from heaven whose second advent will accomplish the final act of salvation that resurrects the dead (1 Thess. 4:16–18), and changes the bodies of the resurrected and translated saints from a perishable to an immortal state (1 Cor. 15:50–54). The gifting of immortality is the final creative act of salvation—the final result of Christ's death. He died to impart eternal life in justification-sanctification and to gift immortal life in glorification (1 Cor. 15:51–53).

Though Christ is the only Savior, the relationship with Him requires humans, with His help, to do their part in the saving relationship between them. Paul spoke of this to church members at Philippi: "Finally, brothers and sisters, whatever is true, whatever is noble, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthty—think about such things" (Phil. 4:8).

In the cosmic controversy the battle is for possession of the mind. Satan bombards minds with everything that will make them unholy and incapable of a relationship with a holy God. By contrast, God moves out to draw people to things that are infinitely better. God does not coerce or disrespect human freedom, but He longs to give humans true freedom that will last for eternity, to bring them into an unending relationship with the God who loves them.

Christian Living

Christian living is an intimate, ever-deepening, joyous relationship with Christ. It includes study of His life, gazing upon His substitutionary sacrifice at Calvary, thanking Him for such an awesome gift as His forgiveness of sin, and gratefulness for the gift of the Holy Spirit to live the Christian life.

Practicing the presence of Christ includes focusing on His present ministry interceding for *you* in heaven's sanctuary. Revel in the fact that "The Lord *your* God is with *you, the Mighty Warrior who saves. He will take great delight in you*; in his love he will no longer rebuke you, but *will rejoice over you with singing*" (Zeph. 3:17, emphasis added).

Christian living includes pondering the great promises of Scripture and reveling in the fact that each member of the Trinity loves us with a lavish love that is indescribable. "For the Lord your God is God of gods and Lord of lords, the great God, mighty and awesome, who shows no partiality and accepts no bribes. He defends the cause of the fatherless and the widow, and loves the foreigner residing among you, giving them food and clothing" (Deut. 10:17–18). We can declare, "The Lord is my light and my salvation—whom shall I fear? The Lord is the stronghold of my life—of whom shall I be afraid?" (Ps. 27:1). For "you, God, are my fortress, my God on whom I can rely" (Ps. 59:9b–10a).

"Praise be to the Lord, to God our Savior, who daily bears our burdens" (Ps. 68:19). For "you, Lord, are a compassionate and gracious God, slow to anger, abounding in love and faithfulness" (Ps. 86:15). "For he stands at the right hand of the needy, to save lives from those who would condemn them" (Ps. 109:31). "Give thanks to the Lord, for he is good; his love endures forever" (Ps. 106:1). Christians can say with confidence about the past and future, "You have made known to me the path of life; you will fill me with joy in your presence, with eternal pleasures at your right hand" (Ps. 16:11).

Christian living takes in the bigger picture, the cosmic controversy, and Christians dedicate their lives to God's side, to be used as He chooses. So the day begins in communion with God as with a friend, praying "not my will, but yours be done" (Luke 22:42b). Christians ask for the Holy Spirit to take full control to bring a sense of Christ's presence that will bless their lives and impact others. They pray that Christ may be Savior and Lord of their lives. They ask for angels to abide with them, Christ to remain in them, and that their lives be instruments that God can use to His glory. The Christian life is Christ centered, a life spent gazing at the life of Christ, a life that longs to reflect His.

After Adam and Eve's sin in Eden, the Creator-Christ clothed them with skins from lambs slain (Gen. 3:21), which indicates that humans need salvation

from the results of sin, and salvation to keep them from sin by being clothed with the righteousness of Christ (1 Cor. 1:30). Peter says that "the Lord knows how to deliver the godly out of temptations" (2 Pet. 2:9a, NKJV). Jude tells us that Christ "is able to keep you from stumbling and to present you before his glorious presence without fault and with great joy—to the only God our Savior" (Jude 24–25a). Salvation is not merely forgiveness but power to live a Christlike life through Christ's covering us. The Exodus was freedom from Egyptian slavery through total dependence upon Christ. That's why Christ said that "apart from me you can do nothing" (John 15:5b). This was dramatically demonstrated in the Exodus and at the Red Sea (as noted in chapter 13).

SANCTIFICATION

The previous three segments (saving relations, Good news of salvation, and Christian living) are aspects of sanctification. The unchanging context of sanctification is important.[64] Many Christians believe that once they are saved, they are always saved. Although salvation has cosmic influence (chapter 13), it cannot make a person remain a saved individual. Such a phenomenon would be contrary to human free will, and would be a type of predestination in history, as if God decrees the eternal salvation based upon a once-saved, always-saved experience. This moves predestination one step from a decree made in eternity to a decree made in history.

When persons accept salvation, they are merely at the entry level of a process that leads to ultimate salvation. They still need to go through the process of

64. Although through the Fall humans are helpless, God took the initiative in other ways that are compatible with His prevenient grace. The moral image of God was not destroyed, merely damaged through the Fall. This in no way detracts from the fact that humans are helpless to save themselves—even atheists have a sense of right and wrong if they have not driven the Holy Spirit from them. This is seen in little children too. God has placed a conscience in humans which is a point of contact for prevenient grace. Consider the biblical evidence: If humans do not have a "seared" conscience (1 Tim. 4:2), a "corrupted" conscience (Tit. 1:15), God has a way into each human heart (John 1:9). This is true even of nonbelievers. Paul declares, "Indeed when Gentiles, who do not have the law, they are a law for themselves, even though they do not have the law. They show that the requirements of the law are written on their hearts, their consciences also bearing witness, and their thoughts sometimes accusing them and at other times even defending them" (Rom. 2:14–15). Even nature, affected by the Fall, is still used by God. Paul says, "For since the creation of the world God's invisible qualities—his eternal power and divine nature—have been clearly seen, being understood from what has been made, so that people are without excuse" (Rom. 1:20). It is correct that the human part in salvation is a response to God's work. The biblical context is obedience. Paul says, "as you have always obeyed…continue to work out your salvation with fear and trembling, for it is God who works in you to will and to act in order to fulfill his good pleasure" (Phil. 2:12–13). The balance is working together in covenant relationship (Matt. 24:13; Luke 13:24; Rom. 3:22; Col. 3:9; Heb. 12:1; James. 4:7). Although the Holy Spirit was not poured out until Christ's work was completed and accepted, and the function of the Spirit as the "Spirit of Christ" to bring Christ to humans was begun, it is still true that the Holy Spirit was sufficiently active in the old covenant era to sanctify the saints, like Enoch, Elijah, Moses, and those listed in the hall of fame in Hebrews 11 to name a few (cf. Exod. 31:13). Even though the sacrifices of the old covenant could not save (only Christ's sacrifice saves), yet the Savior could save throughout human history, for He was active in this work, and is therefore referred to as "the Lamb who was slain from the creation of the world" (Rev. 13:8b). Thus "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8).

sanctification. Once-saved, always-saved means there is no need for the work of the Holy Spirit beyond acceptance of Christ, nor the intercession of Christ in heaven's sanctuary. Yet both are important components of preparing people to be fit to live with God.

Change includes partaking of the divine nature. But how? Not by plumbing the depths of interior life, but by penetrating to the depths of God's "very great and precious promises" for "through them you may participate in the divine nature, having escaped the corruption in the world caused by evil desires" (2 Pet. 1:4). Christ prays to His Father: "Sanctify them by the truth; your word is truth" (John 17:17). James exhorts us to "receive with meekness the implanted [*emphyton*] word, which is able to save your souls" (1:21, ESV). *Implanted* means God's written Word is taken within the mind and heart, memorized or read often, and this implanting bears fruit in sanctifying the person. Change comes through the Word of God, for His Word is just as creative within as it was in the creation of the world (Gen. 1:3, 9, 11, 20, 24, 26) and the universe (Heb. 11:3). The Holy Spirit and His Word within the life sanctify and cause the Christian to reflect the life of Christ.

Sanctification has been the primary focus of this chapter. There are two aspects of sanctification. The word *qādôš* (Hebrew) and *hagias* (Greek) mean "set apart." The objective aspect is to be "set apart" like Israel from other nations, or the sanctuary and later temples "set apart" from the citizens. The subjective aspect of sanctification is to be experientially "set apart," to be holy and thus separate from that which is not holy. Being "set apart" can be instantaneous, as in the new birth, or in Abraham and his family leaving Ur of the Chaldees. But being "set apart" also includes duration. God wanted Israel to be His people and He to be their God—and that had no time limit. Sanctification in the Christian life is a process that never ends, except in death or in glorification at Christ's return (1 Cor. 15:53).

Sanctification is a continuous change. It is a relationship with a holy God, so that one distinguishes between the holy and the profane (see Lev. 10:10; Ezek. 44:23). Humans were created in the "image of God" (Gen. 1:26–27), and contrary to popular theological tradition, the image of God was not destroyed in the Fall. God Himself gives evidence for a continued image of God in fallen humans: "Whoever sheds human blood, by humans shall their blood be shed; for in the image of God has God made mankind" (Gen. 9:6; cf. Jas. 3:9b). Victor Hamilton comments, "To kill another human being is to destroy one who is a bearer of the divine image."[65] Fallen humans, in varying degrees, still bear the image of God. The image was damaged but not destroyed in the Fall.[66]

65. Victor P. Hamilton, *The Book of Genesis, Chapters 1–17*, in *The New International Commentary on the Old Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1990), 315.

66. Those who have committed the unpardonable sin, who are hardened against God, reflect the image of Satan and not the image of God.

Sanctification is the renewal of that damaged image. Paul speaks of putting on the "new self" (new birth) "which is being renewed in knowledge in the image of its Creator" (Col. 3:10). Curtis Vaughan comments that "by constant renewal [the person] takes on more and more of the image of its Creator. 'Being renewed' (*anakainoumenon*) is present tense, expressing a continuous process of renewal."[67] One way to describe sanctification is as Paul has said, "And we all, who with unveiled faces contemplate the Lord's glory [character], are being transformed into his image with ever-increasing glory, which comes from the Lord, who is the Spirit" (2 Cor. 3:18). Lenski comments "At one time it [human nature] had a form that corresponded to the world, sin, flesh; now it is more and more receiving a form that corresponds to 'the same image,' that of the Lord. 'That ye may become partakers of the divine nature,' I Pet. 1:4; 'until Christ be formed in you,' Gal. 4:19."[68] John speaks about the second return of Christ, that "when Christ appears, we shall be like him" (1 John 3:2b).

A holy God created Adam and Eve. In their Fall they sinned and became unholy. The plan of salvation is to restore humans, but they cannot make themselves holy. That is utterly impossible. Christ comes to woo all to choose, by His help, to enter a relationship with Him (cf. John 1:9). It is only through an intimate relationship with their holy God that they can eventually become holy. Holiness is a gift of salvation. It is not just the power of God; it is also the presence of God. Christ came in the image of a human in order to restore the image of God in humans. God describes His plan to Israel: "You are to be holy to me because I, the Lord, am holy, and I have set you apart from the nations to be my own" (Lev. 20:26). These words are not mechanical legalism but an intimate heart-relationship. Can you sense the same love of God for Christians? Peter says: "But just as he who called you is holy, so be holy in all you do; for it is written: 'Be holy, because I am holy'" (1 Pet. 1:15–16; the Leviticus text is quoted in v. 16b). Peter also says, "Humble yourselves, therefore, under God's mighty hand, that he may lift you up in due time. Cast all your anxiety on him because he cares for you" (1 Pet. 5:6–7).

"Make every effort to live in peace with everyone and to be holy; without holiness no one will see the Lord" (Heb. 12:14). Only holy people will inhabit heaven and the new earth, and each one will arrive at that blessed freedom through the relational Trinity who make it possible. God's covenant love for His people has always been the same, for He does not change (Mal. 3:6). This is another indication that the plan of salvation is the same in old and new covenants, for a holy God wants to transform fallen sinners into holy people who

67. Curtis Vaughan, *Colossians*, vol. 11 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Regency Reference Library, Zondervan, 1978), 213.

68. R. C. H. Lenski, *The Interpretation of 1 and 11 Corinthians* (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg Publishing House, 1963), 949.

reflect His image, who are like Him in character, and thus fit for heaven. Christ left heaven to make this possible, but one day the relational Trinity will leave heaven to be with redeemed humans. The climax of redemption, the plan of salvation, the work of sanctification, will be realized. "Look! God's dwelling place is now among the people, and he will dwell with them. They will be his people, and God himself will be with them and be their God" (Rev. 21:3).

Conclusion

The plan of salvation was worked out in the conference of the Trinity in eternity (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 8) and is a divine rescue of sinners only possible through the great love they have for humankind. The gift of salvation is a daring rescue of sinners by the sinless God-Man Christ. One day all the redeemed will join the song, exclaiming: "Worthy is the Lamb, who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and strength and honor and glory and praise!" (Rev. 5:12). Not one of them will claim to be worthy of salvation! They are forever the recipients of the greatest gift that could ever be given to sinners. Paul says it well: "And because of him [God] you are in Christ Jesus, who became to us wisdom from God, righteousness and sanctification [*hagiasmos*] and redemption" (1 Cor. 1:30, ESV).

Study Questions

1. Why does the system of Catholic theology place the church ahead of salvation?
2. In 1 Corinthians 1:30 and 6:11, Paul gives two different orders of events in salvation. Why? Compare with his statement in Galatians 2:20–21.
3. Why is salvation not through God's omnipotence?
4. Is there any sin that is genetic and beyond remedy? If so, what would that say about God and the gospel?
5. What unique qualifications does Jesus Christ have to be our high priest today? What does this imply regarding human priests, Mary, and saints?
6. How does the inner history of the Trinity demonstrate the two principles of the Ten Commandments, and what does this suggest about the importance of God's law?
7. Is there anything about Richard Foster's theology that should cause us concern? If so, explain why.
8. What does Christ's life teach us about the Christian life?
9. Fully explain what is involved in sanctification.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Salvation Debate: Augustine of Hippo to Council of Trent

Purpose

1. Present the different ways salvation is understood in Catholic, Orthodox, and Protestant theologies.

Summary

The sixteenth-century Reformation was a revolt against the doctrine of salvation as taught by the medieval church. Roman Catholic theology believed human works make a contribution to salvation, whereas the Reformers rejected that function of human works. A Catholic Augustinian monk, Martin Luther, launched the Reformation after discovering new freedom in Christ from the text "The just shall live by faith" (Rom. 1:17, NKJV). He wrote in the margin of his Bible next to this text the Latin word *sola* which means "alone." This was inspired by his reading of the rest of the text: "For in the gospel a righteousness from God is revealed—a righteousness that is by faith from first to last" (1:17a). "Faith alone" seemed the appropriate human response to the gift of justification. By contrast, the medieval church believed that faith without works is dead, which seems to find support in James: "a person is considered righteous by what they do and not by faith alone" (2:24). The medieval church

did not believe in justification by faith alone (as do Protestants); rather, they believed in justification by faith.

These positions are radically different (and let me point out that this is not just another debate—the meaning of the gospel is at stake). Faith seems to be confined to the front-end of salvation for Catholics, but not present throughout. Put another way, salvation is through Christ from beginning to end in biblical theology; but is mostly through the church and sacraments in Catholic theology (and through sacraments in the Orthodox church, and in some Protestant denominations). Some argue that there is little difference among the teachings of Luther, Calvin, and the Catholic church, for all three go back to Augustine, and all three unite justification and sanctification. Official pronouncements from both sides indicate the differences. Orthodox theology has no interest in justification by faith, and focuses rather on divinization (*theosis*) of humanity in Christ and in believers.

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Introduction

The final three chapters of this volume (15–17) focus on the debate among Christians about salvation. General biblical data on salvation is at the beginning, in chapter 12, and serves as the biblical basis for the following five chapters on salvation and justification. During the first three-hundred-fifty years of the Christian era, the doctrine of justification was not debated in the same way that Christology and the Trinity were. Nevertheless, seeds were sown in those formative years that bore fruit in the medieval period. For example, just as the impassibility (*apatheia*) of God was a philosophical view that questioned God's compassion (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 6), so self-power (*autoexousia*) was a philosophical term introducing humanity to the doctrine of justification (cf. Latin *liberum arbitrium*). Also, the Greek word *meromai* (to receive one's share) was translated by the Latin word *meritum* (to be worthy of something), which brought the concept of *merit* into medieval theology, affecting the biblical doctrine of justification.[1] So alien philosophical ideas distorted the biblical meaning of justification, contributing to the Roman Catholic concept of justification.

While philosophical meanings crept into theology, some pagan views of salvation were vigorously repudiated, such as Gnosticism and Pelagianism, to which we now turn. Pelagianism is addressed in my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 15, so we will only touch on some highlights here.

Sub-Christian Theology

GNOSTICISM

In Iranian Gnosticism the struggle between light and darkness is about releasing humans from the "prison of this world so that they may reenter the sphere of heavenly light." In Syrian Gnosticism Christ (or the Holy Spirit)

1. See Alister E. McGrath, *Iustitia Dei, A History of the Christian Doctrine of Justification: From the Beginnings 1500* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 1986), 1:23.

"tricks the Creator-Demiurge into breathing into man the breath of life," which passes light particles into the first man. The realm of the Demiurge entombs man in a body of death. The trees in Eden are transformed, so "the biblical tree of the knowledge of good and evil becomes a vehicle of knowledge (*gnōsis*)," whereas the tree of life becomes a vehicle of bondage. Man is encouraged to eat of the tree of knowledge and comes to know more than the Creator, and in anger the Creator confines man to "an earthly body of forgetfulness."[2]

The Gnostic "God is the unfathomable abyss exalted above all contact with the creature world."[3] Gnostics are "spiritual persons [*pneumatikoi*] who possess the light particles and need only to be awakened in order to inherit their destinies."[4] In Gnostic theology Christ communicates *gnōsis* (knowledge) to a select group, which is a type of predestination.[5] For humans "are by nature divided into different moral classes, and so fitted for different destinies. No member of a lower class can transcend the circle which fate, or an absolute predestination, has drawn about him."[6] So there is an uncrossable gulf between God and the elect, and salvation (destiny) is through knowledge (*gnōsis*), and not through Christ, who only temporally adopted a body (perhaps at baptism) and left it before the crucifixion. This docetic Christology means that Christ only appeared to be a human, and as the resurrected one awakens humans, or enlightens them.[7] There is no crucifixion as the means of redemption. Although knowledge can be received, it is apparently also within, and so humans only need to recover from forgetfulness to recognize this knowledge—which they already possess.

Against Gnostics who considered matter to be evil, Irenaeus rightly emphasized that salvation is wholistic (soul and body) for "the saved man is a complete man."[8] Compared to the Gnostic God and demiurge, he said of Christianity: "in both Testaments there is the same righteousness of God,"[9] for it is the same God in both.[10] Irenaeus criticized Gnostics for their misuse of Scripture to support their opinions,[11] and said: "there are as many schemes of 'redemption' as there

2. G. L. Borchert, "Gnosticism," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2001), 486–487.
3. Henry C. Sheldon, *The Early Church*, vol. 1 in *History of the Christian Church* (Hendrickson, 1944), 205.
4. Borchert, "Gnosticism," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 487.
5. Philip Schaff, *Ante-Nicene Christianity*, vol. 2 in *History of the Christian Church* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1962, 1st ed. 1910), 456.
6. Henry C. Sheldon, *The Early Church*, vol. 1 in *History of the Christian Church*, 205–206.
7. Borchert, "Gnosticism," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 487.
8. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies, Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1989), 1:532 (5.6.1).
9. Ibid., 1:501 (4.28.1).
10. Ibid., 1:505 (4.32.1).
11. Ibid., 1:326 (1.8.1), 330 (1.9.3).

are teachers of these mystical opinions."[12] He told them to heed the teaching of church leaders because they "have received the certain gift of truth" through apostolic succession.[13] This was tantamount to saying truth is found only in the church, yet apostolic succession of office doesn't guarantee succession of apostolic truth, as we will demonstrate in examples given below. (Just as Gnosticism has mystical opinions so does Catholic theology, as we will see later. Evaluation of apostolic succession is given in my *Systematic Theology*, volume 4.) Irenaeus compared the two Adams (no human fathers), one caused sin through disobedience while the other "by yielding obedience, became the cause of salvation."[14] He also compared the two virgins (Eve and Mary): "as the human race fell into bondage to death by means of a virgin, so is it rescued by a virgin."[15] These two comparisons give too much credit to mere mortals. The problem with the soteriology of Irenaeus is his comparison of the two virgins, whereas Scripture only compares the two Adams (Rom. 5:17–19; 1 Cor. 15:21–22).

Although Irenaeus believed that the corruptible body puts on incorruption at the coming of Christ (1 Cor. 15:53),[16] he seems to suggest that the Eucharist in some way makes this reality present, for human bodies "when they receive the Eucharist, are no longer corruptible."[17] Maybe this incorruption is partial because, in a later segment on the gifts of the Holy Spirit, Irenaeus says, "we do now receive a certain portion of His Spirit, tending towards perfection, and preparing us for incorruption, being little by little accustomed to receive and bear God; which also the apostle terms 'an earnest,'... This earnest, therefore, thus dwelling in us, renders us spiritual even now, and the mortal is swallowed up in immortality" (2 Cor. 4:4–5).[18]

Even though Irenaeus claimed to be a person with apostolic succession, his two interpretations above have Mary and the Eucharist deflecting attention from the Savior Jesus Christ as means of salvation; for Mary is only a willing mortal, "for all have sinned" (Rom. 3:23), and Mary called Christ her "Savior" (Luke 1:47); and the bread and wine are only symbols of Christ's body and blood, for Christ Himself handed the bread and wine to His disciples at the Lord's Supper (1 Cor. 11:24–25). If the bread was literally His body, and the wine literally His blood, then were there two Christs in the upper room? In other words, the elevation of Mary above fellow sinners in need of a Savior, and the elevation of the bread and wine to the body and blood of Christ,

12. Ibid., 1:345 (1.21.1).
13. Ibid., 1:497 (4.26.2); cf. 415–416 (3.3.2) ; 498 (4.26.5).
14. Ibid., 1:455 (3.22.4).
15. Ibid., 1:547 (5.19.1).
16. Ibid., 1:528 (5.2.3).
17. Ibid., 1:486 (4.18.5).
18. Ibid., 1:533 (5.8.1), cf. "ripening for immortality," in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, 1:558 (5.29.1).

were human, nonbiblical traditions already present in the early church.[19] So we have Gnostic nonbiblical ideas being met by other nonbiblical ideas, for both were traditions contrary to Scripture. Although in different ways, neither Gnosticism nor its refutation by Irenaeus does justice to Christ as the sole means of salvation for humans.

PELAGIANISM

While the oriental or Greek church (East) was occupied with Christological controversies, the Latin church (West) was occupied with anthropological and soteriological controversies.[20] In the first four centuries, theologians were focused on objective truths about the Trinity, but the fifth century introduced a new subjective focus because of Pelagius (ca. 360–420), who rejected the idea that persons are born with a sinful nature and denied all supernatural influences upon the human will. His ideas launched the Pelagian controversy.[21] Human freedom became the soul of the Pelagian view, and divine grace became the soul of Augustine's refutation of Pelagius.[22] Pelagius was shallow compared to Augustine, for he had not had the personal experience of God's grace in his life. Pelagius was more mechanical than relational in thinking humans can keep the law in their own strength, and Augustine knew from experience that law keeping is impossible apart from divine grace. Apparently Pelagius did not sense his need of a Savior to the extent that Augustine did.

Pelagius believed that humans are born sinless and can remain sinless (law abiding) by the strength of their will, an external legalism that knows no need of salvation. Coelestius, pupil of Pelagius, influenced Zosimus, bishop of Rome, to support the Pelagian teaching. The Africans did not go along with that decision, and in a general African council at Carthage (16th Council of Carthage· 418), more than two hundred bishops registered their opposition to Pelagius. As a result, Zosimus changed his mind and issued an encyclical to all bishops, in the West and in the East, opposing Pelagius and Coelestius, stating that he supported the Council of Carthage decision.[23] (It should be noted that the African bishops prevailed over the bishop of Rome,

19. Irenaeus (ca. 130–200). The *Catholic Encyclopedia* on the "New Testament Canon" says: "From the testimony of St. Irenæus alone there can be no reasonable doubt that the Canon of the Gospel was inalterably fixed in the Catholic Church by the last quarter of the second century." The Gospels alone are sufficient to critique the elevation of Mary and the bread and wine. Furthermore, the apostolic church of the first century knew the Gospels and Epistles were God's Word.

20. See Philip Schaff, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Christianity*, vol. 3 in *History of the Christian Church* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1960, 1st ed. 1910), 785.

21. *St. Augustine, Writings Against the Pelagians,* in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, ed. Philip Schaff (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1987), 5:4.

22. Schaff, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Christianity*, vol. 3 in *History of the Christian Church*, 787.

23. Ibid., 798–799.

and that the latter was not considered to have primacy over the church as a whole. That was in the fifth century; the Roman Catholic church would not rise to prominence until the next century.)

Augustine's belief in a sovereign God's predestining the elect had a great influence on the Reformers, who added the decree of reprobation, which included everyone in God's election—a decision made in eternity that could not be changed in history. So Augustine influenced later Protestant theology.

Semi-Pelagianism is found midway between Pelagius and Augustine, and developed in the fifth century in southern France during the last years of Augustine's life. Semi-Pelagianism rejects both the sinlessness of human nature (Pelagius) and the entire corruption of human nature (Augustine); and it rejects grace as external (Pelagius) and grace as irresistible (Augustine), among other things (this view is generally closer to Pelagius's teachings than Augustine's).[24]

John Cassian headed up the Semi-Pelagian party and affirmed the universal sinfulness of humans, but rejected Augustine's election and irresistible grace, stating that the image of God and human freedom were not destroyed but damaged (weakened) by the Fall, and people need to cooperate with God's grace in their salvation.[25] Some believed that Augustine's attributing predestination, irresistible grace, and perseverance solely to God would undermine all moral works, for if God calls and preserves the called, then why is human effort necessary? John Cassian rejected Augustine's election of the few, for God wants to save all humans.[26] In two provincial synods (Arles, 472; and Lyons, 475), Augustine's doctrine of predestination was condemned.

Augustine presents the will of God in contrast to the will of humans, but God's predestinarian will determines who is to be saved and who is to be lost;[27] so God's will alone is operative in salvation. This is the opposite of Pelagius's view that human will alone is operative in salvation. Both views are opposite extremes that overlook the appropriate relationship required between God and humans in the process of salvation. Christ Himself expressed this relationship: "For God so loved the world [not just the elect] that he gave his one and only Son [God's part], that whoever believes in him [human part] shall not perish but have eternal life [salvation]" (John 3:16). Neither Augustine nor Pelagius understood this balanced biblical view of the

24. Ibid., 857–858.

25. Ibid., 861.

26. See Kenneth Scott Latourette, *Beginnings to 1500*, vol. 1 in *History of Christianity* (Peabody, MA: Prince, 1997), 181–182.

27. Augustine, *On Forgiveness of Sins and Baptism*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 5:46 (2.6); 5:63 (2.47).

salvation process. Whereas Pelagius believed that humans can live a sinless life through use of the will, Augustine believed that infants can be baptized and saved, even though their will is not involved (belief).[28]

Augustine is known for giving more than one side of an argument, so the Reformers used his writings to refute the medieval church that is founded, in part, on his writings. For example, he speaks of the sacraments of baptism and the Eucharist in the same treatise where he writes the following, which if fully applied would do away with sacraments as means of salvation. Under the heading "Only Christ Justifies," Augustine writes:

> he [Paul] mentions that justification whereby Christ justifies the ungodly, and which he did not propose as an object of imitation, for He [Christ] alone is capable of effecting this. Now it was quite competent for the apostle to say, and to say rightly: "Be ye imitators of me, as I also am of Christ;" but he could never say: Be ye justified by me, as I also am by Christ;—since there may be, and indeed actually are and have been, many who were righteous and worthy of imitation; but no one is righteous and a justifier but Christ alone. Whence it is said: "To the man that believeth on him that justifieth the ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness."[29]

While opposing Pelagius's claim that some died without sinning, Augustine says the Virgin Mary may have lived without sin.[30] Both are refuted by Scripture, "for all have sinned" (Rom. 3:23).

From the above it is clear that both Irenaeus and Augustine rightly refuted the Gnostics and Pelagians respectively, but both did so with nonbiblical views in addition to their biblical evidences. Giving nonbiblical data equal honor with biblical texts always has a detrimental effect on the truth. In other words, errors are not overcome by errors, despite the best intentions of Irenaeus and Augustine. Errors were an appeal to the church beliefs, even though not biblical beliefs. B. B. Warfield concludes, "Thus, although Augustine's theology had a very strong churchly element within it, it was, on the side that is presented in the controversy against Pelagianism, distinctly anti-ecclesiastical. Its central thought was the absolute dependence of the individual on the grace of God in Jesus Christ."[31] I would add that the developing ecclesiological traditions also played a role in his refutations.

28. Ibid., 5:15–78.
29. Ibid., 5:21–22 (1.18), parentheses added.
30. Ibid.,135 (2.41–42).
31. B. B. Warfield, "Introductory Essay on Augustine and the Pelagian Controversy," in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 5:lxxi.

Catholic Theology: History Behind Medieval Church

AUGUSTINE OF HIPPO (354–430)

In his early thirties, after a profligate life, Augustine flung himself down under a fig tree and wept bitterly. Then, from a nearby house, he heard the voice of a child chanting, "Take up and read; take up and read." He sensed that God was speaking to him, got up, went inside, reached for his Bible, and read the verses upon which his eyes first fell. It was Romans 13:13–14. Verse 14 enumerates various sins, and the next verse says, "[C]lothe yourselves with the Lord Jesus Christ, and do not think about how to gratify the desires of the flesh." In that moment, Augustine was converted.[32]

Early in his career, when a presbyter, Augustine delivered a discourse on the creed before a council of the whole North African episcopate assembled at Hippo Regius. He began by quoting "the righteous person will live by his faithfulness" (Hab. 2:4; Rom. 1:17; Gal. 3:11; Heb. 10:38) as "the most solid foundation of apostolic teaching." He elucidated the apostolic teaching by again quoting Paul: "With the heart man believeth unto righteousness, and with the mouth confession is made unto salvation" (Rom. 10:10).[33] Here is a belief that confesses, a faith that works, a union which apparently defines righteousness and salvation. Augustine said Christ assumed "the entire nature of man…body, soul, and spirit…. For surely, since that assumption was effected in behalf of our salvation, one must be on his guard lest, as he believes that there is something belonging to our nature which sustains no relation to that assumption, this something may fail also to sustain any relation to our salvation."[34] This was the same point made by Athanasius (293–373), the bishop of Alexandria, who believed that the unassumed is unredeemed.[35]

Augustine's belief in the guilt of Adam's sin inherited at birth (original sin) led him to believe that God's grace is infused in babies at birth,[36] which is not a logical basis for imputed justification. Throughout his writings Augustine glories in God's grace, and justification is by grace, but it isn't a "declared justification" but an "internal justification." In the context of justification, Augustine says God "works in His saints."[37] Augustine asks, "For what else

32. Augustine, *The Confessions of St. Augustine*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 1:127 (12.28–29). For Augustine's age at the time of his conversion (31years), see 123 (8.7.17).
33. Augustine, *A Treatise on Faith and the Creed*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 3:321.
34. Ibid., 3:325 (4.4.8).
35. Athanasius, "*De Incarnatione Verbi Dei*," in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, 4:40, 41 (8–9).
36. Augustine, *On Forgiveness of Sins and Baptism*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 5:18–19.
37. Augustine, *On the Spirit and the Letter*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 5:113 (65), cf. 103 (50).

does the phrase 'being justified' signify than 'being made righteous'—by Him, of course, who justifies the ungodly man, that he may become a godly one instead?"[38] Augustine explains what "justifieth the ungodly" means—"the ungodly maketh pious."[39] "For when the ungodly is justified, from ungodly he is made just."[40] This view apparently means justification includes healing.[41]

The Catholic ontological view (infusion) of justification is different from the forensic view (imputation) of justification in some Protestant theology. Infusion characterizes Roman Catholic theology from birth throughout life. Predestination had not been thought out as a doctrine prior to Augustine, and he confined his attention to election (not including reprobation). The source of Augustine's anthropology and soteriology was the sovereign will of God, which is irresistible, and hence God imparted irresistible grace to the elect, who are the minority of humans. Therefore, the gospel was not universal, so Augustine gave "forced interpretations" to texts that speak of God's universal love.[42]

Alister E. McGrath of Oxford University wrote about Augustine in two books.[43] He believed that humans have some freedom of choice, but sin keeps them from coming to God. Only grace liberates or causes human free will to come to God. As such, grace is the healer of human nature. For Christ said, "apart from me you can do nothing" (John 15:5). So, for Augustine, God's promise of grace is the basis of human justification.[44] And grace is the work of the Holy Spirit.[45] Augustine's "Faith working through love," from Galatians 5:6, was his contribution to justifying faith for a thousand years.[46] Augustine does not distinguish between the event and the process of justification. In fact, he considered righteousness as inherent, not imputed.[47]

It is too bad that Augustine misread Romans 9, a common error among predestinarians (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapters 15–16). It was God's call to Augustine to be clothed by Jesus Christ that converted him, and influenced his understanding of justification by faith. From Romans 3:20 he knew that justification doesn't come through the law.[48] Rather, justification is

38. Ibid., 102 (45).
39. Augustine, *On the Gospel of St. John,* in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 7:21 (3.9).
40. Augustine, *On the Psalms,* in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 8:22 (Ps. 7.5).
41. See J. Van Genderen and W. H. Velema, *Concise Reformed Dogmatics* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 2008, original ed. 1992), 634.
42. Schaff, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Christianity*, vol. 3 in *History of the Christian Church*, 856; see also 851–856.
43. *Justification by Faith* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan Academic, 1988), 33–45; and *Iustitia Dei: A History of the Christian Doctrine of Justification,* Second Edition (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 1998). The latter book is the first complete history of this doctrine throughout the Chtistian era.
44. McGrath, *Justification by Faith*, 35–44.
45. McGrath, *Iustitia Dei*, 1:29.
46. Ibid., 1:30.
47. Ibid., 1:31.
48. Augustine, *On the Spirit and the Letter*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 5:88 (14–15).

God's gift through the Holy Spirit. So one is "justified freely by His grace" so grace may "heal" the will to enable one to keep the law.[49] Throughout his writings Augustine glories in God's grace, and justification is by grace. To him it isn't a "declared justification" but an "internal justification," for in the context of justification, Augustine says God "works in His saints."[50] Augustine tells us that he didn't know Hebrew,[51] and he disliked the difficulty of learning Greek.[52] He was therefore limited to the Latin word *justifico.* The etymology of the Latin *justifico* means to "make righteous" rather than to "declare righteous."[53] As David Wright states, "There is general agreement that he took it to mean 'to make righteous' and held to this throughout his writing career."[54]

Augustine believed that salvation is solely within the church, communicated through the sacraments. By contrast, Scripture finds salvation in Christ alone. Grace is irresistible for Augustine, a position that is based on his foundational view of predestination. Grace is not for all people—it is only given to the elect for their regeneration. There are degrees of grace: "prevenient grace" produces a longing to be saved; "operating grace" creates faith and free will to do good and unites the soul to Christ; "co-operating grace" combats remaining evil, producing works called fruits of faith; and "perfect grace" enables perseverance until reaching a perfect state, not in this life, but when sin and death is no more.[55] When it comes to justification by faith, "Augustine regards love rather than faith as the central principle of justification,"[56] a view that influenced Catholic interpretation of justification throughout history.

Enchiridion

Augustine's *Enchiridion* was written after Jerome's death (September 20, 420; Jerome had translated the Vulgate) in the last decade of Augustine's life. The *Enchiridion* teaches that original sin from Adam affects the entire race, causing each one to have "inherited guilt" and a loss of free will.[57] Salvation is found only in the church because "outside the Church sins are not remitted. For the Church alone has received the pledge of the Holy Spirit,

49. Ibid., 5:89 (15).
50. Ibid., 5:113 (65).
51. Augustine, *The Confessions of St. Augustine*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 1:164 (11.3.5).
52. Ibid., 1:51–52 (1.14.23).
53. H. George Anderson, T. Austin Murphy, and Joseph A. Burgess, *Justification by Faith: Lutherans and Catholics in Dialogue VII* (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg, 1985), 18.
54. David F. Wright, "Justification in Augustine," in *Justification in Perspective: Historical Developments and Contemporary Challenges.* ed. Bruce L. McCormack (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2006), 56.
55. Schaff, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Christianity*, vol. 3 in *History of the Christian Church*, 849.
56. David C. Steinmetz, *Luther in Context*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2002), 12.
57. Augustine, *Enchiridion*, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, First Series, 3:246–247 (25–29).

without which there is no remission of sins."[58] That is why the "sacraments of salvation" are in the church.[59] Augustine adds that "there are many kinds of alms, by giving of which we assist to procure the pardon of our sins,"[60] so some human works for salvation are found in his theology. In fact, works gain merit, even helping others who have died.[61] Augustine prays for his dead mother that her sins be forgiven, even though she had lived a wonderful life.[62] Merits contribute to one's final state, for all receive "degrees of happiness" or "degrees of misery."[63]

Augustine held that salvation is not for everyone, for "not even a majority" will be saved.[64] Consider two infants "whose cases seem in all respects alike, one is by the mercy of God chosen to Himself, and the other is by His justice abandoned." God could save all but does what He pleases instead.[65] All are born with original sin so "it is grace alone that separates the redeemed from the lost."[66] The choosing of some, while rejecting the majority, seems just to Augustine, for "if not a single member of the race had been redeemed, no one could justly have questioned the justice of God."[67]

These are nonbiblical ideas that replace biblical truths. There is not a single verse in Scripture that suggests that salvation is not available for all humans, nor that all humans receive Adam's guilt, even though the death-consequences of his sin are received (Rom. 5:18–19; 1 Cor. 15:21–22). Neither does Scripture suggest that salvation is confined to the church and that sacraments are a means of salvation. Nor do works save or gain merit, for salvation is a gift and not merited (John 3:16); sinners only merit death (Rom. 6:23).

Augustine said very little about what Christ is doing in heaven since His ascension. He takes time to say that Christ's tomb was never used before nor after Christ was there; and likewise Mary's womb was never used before nor after Christ was there. All that is mentioned of Christ's ministry in heaven is His "awarding deserts as men deserve them."[68] He overlooks the post-resurrection ministry of Christ in heaven and its important contribution to human salvation (as explained in Hebrews).

58. Ibid., 3:258 (65).
59. Ibid., 3:258 (66).
60. Ibid., 3:261 (72).
61. Ibid., 3:272 (109).
62. Augustine, *The Confessions of Augustine,* in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers,* First Series, 1:140–141 (9.12.34–35).
63. Augustine, *Enchiridion,* in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers,* First Series, 3:273 (111).
64. Ibid., 3:267 (97).
65. Ibid., 3:267 (95).
66. Ibid., 3:269 (99).
67. Ibid.
68. Augustine, *On Faith and the Creed,* in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers,* First Series, 3:326–327 (5.11–7.14).

Second Council of Orange (529)

Supporters of Augustine (in Gaul) arranged for the Synod of Orange, which condemned Semi-Pelagianism and agreed with the anthropological and soteriological views of Augustine, some of which were: (1) Adam's sin injured body and soul of all humans, bringing death to all; (2) God's bestowed grace causes humans to pray for salvation; (3) all good thoughts and works are a gift from God; (4) even saints and the regenerate continually need God's help; (5) the will weakened through Adam's sin is only restored through the grace of baptism; (6) unmerited grace precedes meritorious works; (7) even if there had been no Fall, humans would have needed God's grace for salvation.[69] Among other questions that could be raised, how can baptism restore the will (item 4)? How are works meritorious when they are done through unmerited grace (items 5–6)? Why would persons need salvation apart from the Fall (item 7)? Even though, according to Augustine, humans are devoid of any virtue and depend fully on God's grace alone to be saved, their works are still meritorious, which isn't logical, for merit for human works and full dependence on God's works alone are mutually exclusive.

MEDIEVAL CHURCH

Martin Luther called the medieval church the "Aristotelian church," for it depended on Aristotle more than on Scripture.[70] Sacramental theology (systematized during 1050–1240) linked justification with the sacraments.[71] This alleges that continuous justification is mediated through the church and its sacraments. In the late twelfth century, the idea of merit for works of continuous justification entered Roman Catholic theology.[72] There were five main schools of thought on justification in the late medieval period, and hence among Catholic thinkers (including early Dominican, early and later Franciscan, and medieval Augustinian), with considerable diversity which need not detain us.[73] What is important is the unanimous view of medieval theology that justification is both an act and a process in which the status and the nature of humans are altered.[74]

69. Schaff, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Christianity,* vol. 3 in *History of the Christian Church,* 867.
70. Luther rightly speaks of Aquinas's view of the Eucharist as dependent on Aristotle, not on Scripture, and calls the medieval church the "Aristotelian church" in the "Babylonian Captivity," *Three Treatises* (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1973, 1st ed. 1960), 144.
71. McGrath, *Iustitia Dei,* 1:91.
72. Ibid., 1:100–102; see also 1:109–119.
73. Ibid., 1:155–187.
74. Ibid., 1:182.

THOMAS AQUINAS (1225–1274)

Augustine and Aquinas are the most influential Catholic theologians. Whereas Augustine believes in predestination to eternal life but not reprobation, Aquinas believes in both, and considers reprobation as "the cause of abandonment by God."[75] The theology of Aquinas is by far the most intricate Catholic system ever written, and Aquinas was the leading medieval Catholic theologian. It is important that we get an overview of this system before looking at ideas within it. (Because of space limitations, this overview will focus on ideas germane to soteriology, and will be representative, not exhaustive.)

Summa Theologica

The *Summa Theologica*[76] is the theological system of Thomas Aquinas. "This brilliant synthesis of Christian thought has had a decisive and permanent impact on religion since the thirteenth century and has become substantially the official teaching of the Catholic Church."[77] A. G. Sertillanges, O.P., says "The Church believes today, as she believed from the first, that Thomism is an ark of salvation, capable of keeping minds afloat in the deluge of doctrine."[78] The system is a veritable source of church traditions and comments from philosophers; it uses the Latin Vulgate, which is not always an accurate translation. Besides this, the system is written using typical medieval scholastic reasoning, which makes it difficult for many modern readers to comprehend.[79]

Aquinas claims that God's being is immutable (doesn't change, Q. 9),[80] that He predestines persons to salvation and reprobation (Q. 23), and that the Holy Spirit dwells in humans and gifts them with "sanctifying grace" (Q. 43).[81] However, sacraments of the Old Law "were ordained to the sanctification of man" (Q. 102)[82] (yet "they neither contained nor caused grace"),[83] and sacraments

75. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, trans. Fathers of the English Dominican Province (Westminster, MD: Christian Classics, 1981; 1st, 1911), 127 (1.23.3).
76. Ibid.
77. Cover comment on back cover of each of the five volumes of the *Summa Theologica*.
78. Cover comments on back cover of the five volumes.
79. Here is one example: "origin" and "relation" are two levels of reasoning about God: God is a Trinity in which the Holy Spitit proceeds from the Father and Son (Q. 36); and with respect to relationship, the Holy Spirit is the bond between the Father and Son, because "He is love." Whereas "the Father and the Son love one another" the Holy Spirit, even though the Third Person in the Trinity, "loves essentially as love proceeding; but not as one whence love proceeds," *Summa Theologica*, 1:190 (Q.37.1.1). Put a different way, in an *essential sense* (through their essence), the Father and Son love each other (not through the Holy Spirit); but at the same time in a *notional sense*, "the Father and the Son love each other by the Holy Ghost," 1:191 (Q.37.1.2). Acts "which designate the order" of origin in the Trinity are called "notional," 1:208 (Q.41.2.1).
80. Q = question, as Aquinas arranged his topics as questions.
81. Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, 1:221 (Q.43.1.3).
82. Ibid., 2:1068 (Q.102.1–11.5).
83. Ibid., 4:2349 (Q.61.3.4).

of the New Law are for "the sanctification of man,"[84] for they "contain grace" and are "an instrumental cause of grace."[85] Aquinas claims, "The sacraments are signs in protestation of the faith whereby man is justified."[86] Aquinas teaches that the Holy Spirit and sacraments sanctify. In so doing, he gives credence to justification through the sacraments, as if they are of vital importance in making a person righteous.

Whereas Scripture finds justification in Christ alone, the Catholic view called this biblical view into question by focusing on the sacraments as if they were as important as Christ in the justification by faith process. According to Aquinas, the Holy Spirit and sacraments sanctify. For Aquinas, God's grace "is nothing short of a partaking of the Divine Nature, which exceeds every other nature." He says it is "necessary that God alone should deify, bestowing a partaking of the Divine Nature."[87] This means justification is deification, a *theosis* like that found in Orthodox soteriology. Here justification has become a qualified sanctification.

Where is Christ in this theology? Christ and the sacraments are both instruments for God's sanctification: "Now the principal efficient cause of grace is God Himself, in comparison with Whom Christ's humanity is as a united instrument, whereas the sacrament is as a separate instrument."[88] Aquinas claims that "it seems that by the sacraments God imprints His character on us."[89] The grace sacraments confer "afford a remedy against sin."[90] Yet "ministers of the Church can confer the sacraments, though they be wicked."[91] This is because (1) the priest never loses his ordination,[92] and (2) "Ministers of the Church do not by their own power cleanse from sin those who approach the sacraments, nor do they confer grace on them: it is Christ Who does this by His own power while He employs them as instruments."[93]

Contrary to the above statements of Aquinas, God does not mix the holy with the profane. Of Judah, He said, "Her priests do violence to my law and profane my holy things; they do not distinguish between the holy and the common" (Ezek. 22:26a; cf. 44:23). Eli's sons Hophni and Phineas were priests (1 Sam. 1:3b) and were "scoundrels" and "had no regard for the LORD" (1 Sam. 2:12), and so God sent a message to Eli saying they would

84. Ibid., 4:2342 (Q.60.3.5); cf. 4:2346 (61.3.1), 4:2348 (61.3.1).
85. Ibid., 4:2351 (Q.62.3.3).
86. Ibid., 4:2348–2349 (Q.61.3.4).
87. Ibid., 2:1140 (Q.112.1.1).
88. Ibid., 4:2353 (Q.62.3.5).
89. Ibid., 4:2355 (Q.63.3.1).
90. Ibid., 4:2359 (Q.63.3.6).
91. Ibid., 4:2364 (Q.64.3.5).
92. Ibid., 5:2675 (Q.36.Suppl. 3).
93. Ibid., 4:2364 (Q.64.3.5).

both die on the same day. Then God said, "I will raise up for myself a faithful priest, who will do according to what is in my heart and mind. I will firmly establish his priestly house, and they will minister before my anointed one always" (1 Sam. 2:35). It seems inconsistent to me that in Catholic theology Christ confers sacramental grace through sinful instruments when He needed an immaculate Mary in order to confer grace as a Savior. The sacrament of baptism is even conferred by pagans,[94] for "[f]aith is not necessary in the one baptized any more than in the one who baptizes."[95] In spite of these conditions, Aquinas claims that "the grace of the Holy Ghost and the fullness of the virtues are given in Baptism."[96] Here are examples of mixing the holy and the profane, which is contrary to Scripture.

The above examples also ignore the fact that God is a relational God and does not impart salvation through a mechanical means which implies that a relationship with Him is optional. The covenants are not experienced outside of a relationship between God and humans (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapters 8–11), and neither is salvation. There is only one means of mediation, and that is through Christ and the Holy Spirit, or through a divine means that issues out of the relational Trinity, applying salvation that is relational and reflects the inner history of the relational Trinity. Any other alleged means of impartation is an empty counterfeit.

Now we come to two other aspects of Catholic theology, penances and purgatory, which call into question God's free gift of forgiveness. Catholicism teaches that salvation is by meritorious works—many works—that continue into purgatory after death, and can be aided by the works of others too. Purgatory is for cleansing, but takes place in hell,[97] in "the bowels of the earth."[98] There is no assurance in the Catholic system, and the eternal loyalty of the redeemed to God is made possible through the eternal existence of hell, as if loyalty is not attained through the memory of Christ's death on Calvary. Aquinas puts it this way: "The everlasting punishment of the wicked will not be altogether useless. For they are useful for two purposes. First, because thereby the Divine justice is safeguarded which is acceptable to God for its own sake...He is for ever unappeased by the punishment of the wicked. Secondly, they are useful, because the elect rejoice therein, when they see God's justice in them, and realize that they have escaped them."[99]

94. Ibid., 4:2389 (Q.67.3.5).
95. Ibid., 4:2398 (Q.68.3.8).
96. Ibid., 4:2405 (Q.69.32.4).
97. Ibid., 5:3011 (Appendix 11.2).
98. Ibid., 5:2990 (Q.97.Suppl.7).
99. Ibid., 5:2997 (Q.99.Suppl.1).

The above words of Aquinas turn the gospel on its head. Christ said of Calvary, "And I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to myself" (John 12:32). This has not happened yet, but in the final judgment all will be drawn to Christ through a replay of Calvary, and all created beings will bow down before Him (Isa. 45:23b; Rom. 14:11; Phil. 2:10–11; Rev. 5:13; 15:3; 19:1–6).

How can Christ be unappeased by endless human suffering when He "is the atoning sacrifice for our sins, and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world" (1 John 2:2), "not wanting anyone to perish" (2 Pet. 3:9b). We are talking about the Christ who wept over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41), saying "Jerusalem, Jerusalem, you who kill the prophets and stone those sent to you, how often I have longed to gather your children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, and you were not willing" (Matt. 23:37). We are talking about the God of the Old Testament, who said of Israel at the time of their Babylonian captivity, "'Is not Ephraim my dear son, the child in whom I delight? Though I often speak against him, I still remember him. Therefore my heart yearns for him; I have great compassion for him,' declares the Lord" (Jer. 31:20b). We are talking about the gospel that gives humans two choices—believe or perish: "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life" (John 3:16). It is the love of God that saves and keeps all created beings close to Him, for they have seen the stark difference at the Cross between Christ and Satan, the one dying for others, the other killing the One who gave him life. If Christ is unappeased by human suffering in eternal hell, then there is no difference between Him and Satan. They are both vengeful and vicious, and it is God, not Satan, who perpetrates the worst holocaust ever in an ever-burning hell. What will be the result? As endless time passes by, won't God be seen as more heartless than Satan, and won't Calvary be overshadowed and forgotten?

Both Augustine and Aquinas fail to comprehend God's universal love for all humans, and in their doctrine of predestination we find a God who is unaffected by having chosen a few for salvation and reprobating the rest to damnation. No wonder both understand God as impassible. This makes humans uneasy, because it leaves them insecure as to whether they will be saved or not. In this context, the work of salvation is not God's alone, for Catholic theology claims that the church is the means of salvation through the ministry of priests, the seven sacraments, and the intercession of Mary and saints. All of these are an affront to God, as if the Persons of the Trinity are incapable of saving persons without these human means. In reality these human means become more important to many members than the only mediator between God and humans, Jesus Christ (1 Tim. 2:5). Don't we find a "different gospel" (*heteron euangelion*) in Catholic theology, one that Paul (in principle) wrote about in Galatians (Gal. 1:6b)?

Berkouwer says it well: "In studying the Reformation, one is struck by the remarkable correspondence between Paul's struggle against Judaism in both its gross and its refined work-righteousness and the Reformation struggle against human merit."[100] Salvation by faith alone (*sola fide*, Reformed view) is the opposite of works of merit (Roman Catholic view). "It is the works of the law, not those of faith, which threaten *sola fide*."[101]

Paul declares that the "different gospel" (Gal. 1:6) is due to some who want to "distort [*metastrepsai*] the gospel" (Gal. 1:7, ESV). Twice Paul says these people should be "accursed" [*anathema*] (1:8–9, ESV), because their "gospel" is only "man's [*kata anthrōpon*] gospel" (1:11b, ESV). Paul states that once he peddled a human gospel by being "extremely zealous" (*perissoterōs zēlōtēs*) for the "traditions of my fathers" (*paradoseōn mou patrikōn*, 1:14b, ESV).

In like manner, others were doing the same to the churches in Galatia by promoting circumcision as a means of salvation, a tradition of the Jewish fathers (cf. 2:9b, 12b; 5:2–3). These Judaizers wanted members to be circumcised "that they may not be persecuted for the cross of Christ" (6:12–14, ESV). A tradition of the fathers caused them to turn away from the Cross. The Judaizers' mission was to "spy out our freedom that we have in Christ Jesus, so that they might bring us into slavery" (2:4, ESV). True freedom means "a person is not justified by works of the law [*ergōn nomou*] but through faith in Jesus Christ" (2:16a, ESV). For "if righteousness were through the law, then Christ died for no purpose" (2:21, ESV), for "no one is justified before God by the law, for 'The righteous shall live by faith'" (3:11, ESV), for "if a law had been given that could give life [*zōopoiēsai*], then righteousness would indeed be by the law" (3:21, ESV). "You are severed from Christ [*katērgēthēte apo Christou*] you who would be justified by the law; you have fallen away from grace" (5:4, ESV). Scripture calls the gospel the "eternal gospel" (Rev. 14:6a). Paul says that the gospel preached to Abraham was a promise that all nations will be blessed; it is a universal gospel, it knows nothing about electing a few. For Christ suffered "death for everyone" (Heb. 2:9b). Amazing grace is all humans need in order to have righteousness imputed to them, for Christ is "Our Righteous Savior" (Jer. 23:6b), and only Christ is "our righteousness, holiness and redemption" (1 Cor. 1:30), for "no one will be declared righteous in God's sight by the works of the law" (Rom. 3:20a).

It is important to understand that there is no imputation of Christ's righteousness in the theology of Aquinas, even though there is a non-imputation

100. G. C. Berkouwer, *Faith and Justification*, in *Studies in Dogmatics Series* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1977, 1st ed. 1954), 72.

101. Ibid., 112.

of sin. Instead, God allegedly infuses grace into the human soul as the basis of God's forgiveness. This apparently replaces the work of God in Christ for humans by the work of God in humans, and so fails to give proper place to Christ as the righteousness humans need to have imputed to them.[102] Infusion is a human doctrine, a tool in the hands of the church, to allegedly convey grace through sacraments, but in reality it replaces Christ the Savior in whom alone there is the fullness of grace through His life and death to save humanity.

Christ said, "my Father's will is that everyone who looks to the Son and believes in him shall have eternal life" (John 6:40). The ministry of the resurrected Christ as high priest in heaven's sanctuary is where believers should focus their attention, not on priests below. The writer of Hebrews says that we should "[fix] our eyes on Jesus, the pioneer and perfecter of faith. For the joy set before him he endured the cross, scorning its shame, and sat down at the right hand of the throne of God" (Heb. 12:2). Christ's priestly ministry is better than that of human priests in the past, because He ministers on the basis of a better sacrifice—the only perfect sacrifice. All can come directly to Him without having to go through priests as they did in the Old Testament: "For we do not have a high priest who is unable to empathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who has been tempted in every way, just as we are—yet he did not sin. Let us then approach God's throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need" (Heb. 4:15–16). This gospel rejects the need of any other intercessors—no one ever suffered like Jesus, and there are no others who could be more sympathetic than He is.

The freedom of the gospel, with its gift of salvation and direct access to the Savior, and the indwelling of the Holy Spirit, is a covenant relationship of love that one can revel in with security, peace, and hope. Reading through major segments of Aquinas's system, with its church, sacraments, priests, Mary, and saints reminds one of the multiplied rules and regulations of the Old Testament era, human ways that robbed the people of a relationship with God. Christ said about these people, and it seems to apply to much of Catholic dogma, "in vain do they worship me, teaching as doctrines the commandments of men" (Matt. 15:9, ESV). It reminds one of a minister at the altar, after marrying the bride and groom, saying, "I'm coming with you on the honeymoon." No one has a right to come between bride and groom, nor should they come between the Bridegroom Christ and the bride represented individually by each Christian. Catholic theology risks losing the exuberant joy of the gospel by placing the magisterium

102. See Bruce L. McCormack, "What's at Stake in the Current Debates over Justification," in *Justification: What's at Stake in the Current Debates*, ed. Mark Husbands and Daniel J. Treier (Downers Grove, IL: Intervarsity, 2004), 90.

above Scripture, which in turns leads to replacing the only means of salvation provided by God with human means.

God doesn't need sacraments, for He not only sent His Son to save the world (John 3:16) but "sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, 'Abba! Father!'" (Gal. 4:6, ESV). As well, "Christ is formed in you" (*Christos morphōthe en hymin*, Gal. 4:19b, ESV), and the fruit of the Holy Spirit "is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control" (5:22–23, ESV). I feel like Karl Barth, who cried out against anthropological liberalism, "Let God be God!" The Persons of the Trinity are well able to save humans, and no one else can—whether church, sacraments, or saints. Christ overthrew the works-oriented, false gospel in the temple, and the money changers and animal traffickers fled (John 2:12–16; Matt. 21:12–13; Mark 11:15–17; Luke 19:45–46). If Christ were on earth today, I believe He would overthrow all human means of salvation in the church, so that people could once again see the simplicity and glory of the gospel—that God loves them and that He came to save them. Nothing more, nothing less.

Orthodox Theology[103]

The Orthodox Church, present in different countries, claims to be as ancient as the Catholic Church, having departed from Catholicism in 1054 over doctrinal and hierarchical differences. Does it have a doctrine of salvation? Orthodox theology is rooted in the church fathers, like Irenaeus, Athanasius, and John the Damascene, to name a few. Orthodox theology is incarnation-centered. It asserts that when God became human, the divine nature assumed human nature, and there was a great exchange.

For example, Irenaeus said that the Son of God did "through His transcendent love, become what we are, that He might bring us to be even what He is Himself."[104] Similarly Athanasius said, "He was made man that we might be made God."[105] The same fundamental principle is noted in the following statements: "*The unassumed is unhealed* (Gregory of Nazianzus), or "*What Christ has not assumed has not been saved* (Cyril of Alexandria)."[106]

103. There are almost no Orthodox Systematic Theologies. The exception is the very important work *Exposition of the Orthodox Faith* by John of Damascus (675–754). The focus of Orthodox theology is adoration rather than analysis. See Daniel B. Clendenin, *Eastern Orthodox Christianity: A Western Perspective*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2003), 53. Mystery is more important to Orthodox theology, and it rejects *sola Scriptura*, 106–107. Tradition is placed before Scripture, 115.

104. Irenaeus, "Against Heresies," in *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1989), 1:526 (Book 5, Preface).

105. Athanasius, "Incarnation of the Word," in *The Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers, First Series*, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1987), 4:65 (#54.3).

106. T. F. Torrance, *Atonement: The Person and Work of Christ*, ed. Robert T. Walker (Milton Keyes, London: Paternoster; Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2009), 441; italics his.

Later, Gregory Palamas (1296–1359), Archbishop of Thessalonica and theologian in Greece, said, "Moreover, the transformation of our human nature, in deification and transfiguration—were these not accomplished in Christ from the start, from the moment in which He assumed our nature?"[107] Also from Thessalonica is a contemporary, Georgios Mantzaridis, chair of Moral Theology and Christian Sociology in the Theological School of the University of Thessaloniki. He puts it this way: "The consequence of this hypostatic union in Christ of the two natures was the deification of the human nature He assumed."[108] Palamas stated that the deified human nature in Christ is "an inexhaustible source, transmitting this divinizing energy to men and thereby deifying them."[109] Mantzaridis projects that "The process of man's deification, begun in this life, becomes perfect, and irreversible in the age to come."[110]

This process in Greek is called *theosis* (deification), which was coined by Gregory of Nazianzus, bishop of Constantinople in the fourth century.[111] Contemporary orthodox bishop Kallistos Ware explains what deification means: "By virtue of this distinction between the divine essence and the divine energies, we are able to affirm the possibility of a direct or mystical union between man and God—what the Greek Fathers term the *theosis* of man, his 'deification'—but at the same time we exclude any pantheistic identification between the two: for man participates in the energies of God, not in the essence. There is union, but not fusion or confusion."[112]

So in Orthodox theology there is a difference between God's energies and His essence (or nature). Humans participate in God's energies, not in His essence. Bishop Ware states that God is unknowable; He is "beyond and above all that we can think or express, yet closer to us than our own heart."[113] Let us probe the assumption behind this division of energies and essence. It has to do with what can be known or experienced of God. Orthodox theology (Greek) has to do with an apophatic way (negative way to know God by what God is not) rather than in Western (Latin) theology which is cataphatic (positive way to know God by what God is).[114] Ware said, "We are taught when reciting the Jesus prayer [repetitive

107. Gregory Palamas, *The Triads*, ed. John Meyendorff, trans. Nicholas Gendle (New York: Paulist Press, 1983), 76.

108. Georgios I. Mantzaridis, *The Deification of Man: Saint Gregory Palamas and the Orthodox Tradition*, trans. Liadain Sherrard (Crestwood, NY: St. Vladimir's Seminary Press, 1984), 29.

109. Palamas, cited in Ibid., 33.

110. Mantzaridis, *The Deification of Man*, 117.

111. *Theosis: Deification on Christian Theology*, ed. Stephen Finian and Vladimir Kharlamov (Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2006), 1.

112. Kallistos Ware, *The Orthodox Way* (Crestwood, NY: St. Vladimir's Seminary Press, 2001, 1st 1979), 22–23.

113. Ibid.

114. Bill Long, "Apophatic and Apopthegmatic and Relatives" (10/06/04), http://www.drbilllong.com/Words/Apop.html, accessed September 4, 2012. In *Systematic Theology: God as Trinity*, I evaluated some of

prayer "Jesus Christ, Son of God, have mercy on me a sinner"], to avoid so far as possible any specific image or picture,"[115] but this seems contrary to the biblical view of God revealed in Scripture. Of course the biblical self-revelation of God is finite and representative of an infinitely greater reality, but it is authentic and a positive aid to salvation. For example, we are asked to fix our eyes upon Jesus (Heb. 12:2a), who revealed God (John 14:9; 17:25–26), because by beholding we are being changed as we "contemplate the Lord's glory" (*doxan kyriou*; 2 Cor. 3:18), so that when Christ comes in the Second Advent we "shall be like Him" (*esometha homoioi autō*, 1 John 3:2).

Participation in divine energies in a direct mystical sense seems removed from biblical statements like the following: Through "his very great and precious promises...you may participate in the divine nature" (2 Pet. 1:4), or be "partakers of the divine nature" (ESV). Christ put it this way: "I am the vine; you are the branches. If you remain in me and I in you, you will bear much fruit; apart from me you will do nothing" (John 15:5). Paul says, "For the fruit of the Spirit [*karpos tou pneumatos*] is love, joy, peace, forgiveness, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness and self-control" (Gal. 5:22–23). This fruit refers to God's attributes or divine nature (what He is like), brought to humans by the Holy Spirit. This does not seem confined to divine energies. Through the Holy Spirit and indwelling Christ, humans reflect God.

EVALUATION

It is time for an overall evaluation. There is a fundamental problem with the divinized humanity of Orthodox theology. If Christ's human nature was divinized, this would have disqualified Him on two levels from being our Savior. Level one has to do with the purpose of His human life, and level two has to do with the purpose of His present ministry in heaven's sanctuary. Both levels necessitated that Christ be truly human (not a divinized humanity).

Level one: Jesus Christ, "Who, being in very nature God, did not consider equality with God something to be used to his own advantage; rather, he made himself nothing by taking the very nature of a servant, being made in human likeness" (*homoiōmati anthrōpōn;* Phil. 2:6–7). Christ was human for the advantage of humans in two ways. It was to perfect a human character to give to humans as their robe of righteousness, His sinless character in place of their sinful character (Isa. 61:10). In this way Christ is our righteousness (1 Cor. 1:30). He also needed to be truly human (mortal not immortal) so He could die a

these negative ways such as immutable, impassive views of God (chapter 6), and the timeless view of God (chapter 5).

115. Kallistos Ware, *The Orthodox Way*, 22–23.

substitutionary death and pay the price of all human sin (a divinized humanity could not die).

Level one also questions the doctrine of justification by faith (taken up in this volume). The Eastern Orthodox *theosis*, or divinized humanity, suggests more than imputed righteousness. It includes imparted righteousness. In the book *Theōsis*, we find the following quotation:

> Through the appeal to justification as involving both declaration and deification Torrance [T. F. Torrance of Edinburgh University] anticipates the move within Lutheran scholarship[116] to see Luther's doctrine of justification as more than a declatory [sic] "legal fiction," but as actually involving the making righteous of the sinner through deification. Like Torrance, Luther does not separate the person of Christ from his work. Rather, Christ himself, both his person and his work, is the ground of Christian righteousness as the believer participates in the divine nature through Christ.[117]

Level two: With respect to Jesus Christ in His present ministry in heaven's sanctuary, "we do not have a high priest who is unable to empathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who has been tempted in every way, just as we are—yet did not sin. Let us then approach God's throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need" (Heb. 4:15–16). A divinized humanity would disqualify Christ from being our understanding high priest today. Living on earth as God, Christ could not qualify as the mediator between God and humanity. He would not know what to live as a man meant, and He would not have bridged the huge gulf between God and humanity if merely divine and divinized humanity.

There is another fundamental problem with the divinized humanity of Christ and His followers. This is a philosophical view derived from human thinking, focusing on what humans guess took place when the divine and the human united in Jesus Christ. As noted above, these Orthodox assumptions are not in agreement with Scripture. There is a reason for problems in theology, such as in T. F. Torrance, Karl Barth, and others, because they identify Jesus Christ as revelation rather than Scripture, which is relegated to a mere witness to revelation and to the Living Word of God. There is some truth to this, for Scripture does point to the Living Word of God, Jesus Christ, but only because He is first revealed as such in Scripture. Where would we know of Christ and His incarnation without Scripture?

116. Perhaps referring to the Finnish School of Lutheran interpretation, after the bilateral dialogue between the Church of Finland and the Russian Orthodox Church. See Jonathan Linmann, "Martin Luther: 'Little Christs for the World'—Faith and Sacraments as Means to *Theōsis*" in *Partakers of the Divine Nature: The History and Development of Deification in the Christian Traditions*, eds., Michael J. Christensen and Jeffery A. Wittung (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2007), 189–199.

117. See *Theōsis: Deification in Christian Theology*, ed. Stephen Finlan and Vladimir Kharlamov (Eugene, OR: Pickwick Publications, 2006), 165.

Foundational to any genuine knowledge of Jesus Christ (His two natures, and all He has accomplished and is doing for our salvation) is the written Word of God. Human traditions have replaced divine revelation through Scripture in Catholic, Protestant, and Orthodox theologies. Based on the above, it seems that Orthodox theology is less relational than the relational Trinity revealed in Scripture. For example, Christ's divinized humanity remains a "wholly other" God, removed from the reality of being fully human. This is not a biblical incarnation that united a fully God nature with a fully human one. In spite of its good intention, the Orthodox incarnation seems to be only a mechanical replacement for the genuine coming of Christ into human history—to reveal God's love for the world He longed to save.

Panayiotis Nellas in his book *Deification in Christ* provides insight into the union of creation and incarnation—that creation was the first step towards incarnation. He says, "The union of God and man 'according to energy' which was granted to mankind with the creation of Adam 'in the image' had as its aim the leading of human nature to hypostatic union with the divine Logos in Christ. This aim constituted the original destiny of Adam and remained permanent and immutable—'for the counsels of the Lord are not repented of'—even after the fall."[118]

Orthodox Theology believes that Christ's incarnation would have taken place even if there had been no Fall. Put differently, the creation of humans was only complete in the incarnational union of God and humanity. This diminished the sacrifice in Christ becoming human. The Orthodox incarnation idea is absent in Scripture and contradicts Scripture that creation was completed (Gen. 2:1–3). This is no better than Satan's blatant contradiction of Christ's words about dying if forbidden fruit was eaten (Gen. 2:16–17; 3:2–4). That led to the Fall of the race, and Orthodox theology is imbedded with the same problem—disbelief in God's Word.

The biblical plan of salvation is questioned by the divinization of the humanity of Christ, for Christ is disqualified from producing a robe of righteousness and being a sympathetic high priest in heaven's sanctuary. Even though the cross is part of Orthodox theology, it is arguable that the great exchange took place between God and humans at the cross and not before. At Calvary "God made him who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Cor. 5:21). Deification of humans is never mentioned in Scripture.

118. Panayiotis Nellas, *Deification in Christ: The Nature of the Human Person*, trans. Norman Russell (Crestwood, NY: St. Vladimir's Seminary Press, 1997), 32–33.

Reformation Theology[119]

Money paid for Masses and indulgences (in order to lessen time in purgatory) was a great financial boon for the Roman Catholic church in medieval times (and this no doubt is one reason for preserving the salvation by works system). It may also explain why so many joined the Reform movement to proclaim salvation through faith, apart from works. European countries under papal power wanted their sovereignty, and so the desire for freedom from Rome's power and the Reformers' desire to be free from Catholic theology aided in their severance from the medieval church. From the outset, the Reformers wanted to console believers who had been trying to earn their salvation. They shared the freedom of the gospel which saves people on the basis of Christ's righteousness (life and death), not on the basis of infused righteousness in sinners through God's grace, for no focus should replace the work of Christ's life and death.[120]

In the medieval period the Roman Catholic church had developed sacramental theology. During the years 1050–1250, justification was linked to the sacraments of baptism and penance.[121] In the late twelfth century, supernatural grace raised human acts from the natural to the supernatural plane and made them meritorious.[122] For Thomas Aquinas (1225–1274), habitual grace healed the wounded nature, justified the recipient (making him or her acceptable to God), and "functions as the principle of meritorious action."[123]

McGrath finds in the medieval understanding an exclusion of the distinction between justification and sanctification characteristic of the Reformation.[124] The late medieval period (from the fourteenth century onward) had multiple theories of justification. Hence "the question about justification was not sprung on Western Christendom by the Protestant Reformers in the sixteenth century."[125] Some believe that the Council of Trent (1545–1563) defined the limits of this pluralism with a final declaration.

The sixteenth-century Reformation included some sacramental theology, but was their view on justification a new understanding of the doctrine—or was it the same as the medieval understanding? Those opposed to the Reformation said it was a new view. Others dismissed this conclusion, claiming that the Reformation view was a return to the earlier teaching of the church that had been distorted by the later medieval teaching. They held that the Reformation view

119. In this segment I have followed McGrath, *Iustitia Dei*, 1:180–187.
120. See H. George Anderson et al., *Justification by Faith*, 22–24.
121. McGrath, *Iustitia Dei*, 1:91.
122. Ibid., *Iustitia Dei*, 1:102.
123. Ibid., 1:107.
124. Ibid., 1:41.
125. See Payton, Jr., *Light from the Christian East*, 134.

was really the same as Augustine of Hippo's teaching (354–430). Others said the Reformation was not so much a rediscovery of Pauline justification as it was a rediscovery of Augustine's doctrine of grace.[126]

Was there a forerunner of the Reformation view among these various views of the medieval period? From 1530–1730 (first era of the Reformation), there were three characteristics of the Protestant Reformation: (1) Justification was considered a forensic declaration of being righteous, but not a process that made a person righteous, so justification was a change of status and not a change of nature. (2) A distinction was made between justification (extrinsic divine declaration of a new status) and sanctification (intrinsic process of divine renewal of the justified sinner). (3) The immediate cause of justification was the alien righteousness of Christ imputed in justification, which involved a synthetic and not an analytic judgment by God.

One should keep in mind that the above understanding of Protestant justification was influenced by Philipp Melanchthon (1497–1560), for Martin Luther and Huldrych Zwingli don't present justification exactly this way. As Bruce McCormack notes, the break with medieval Catholicism was "less than complete due to a residual commitment to Medieval Catholic understandings of regeneration and a shaky grasp of the relation of justification and regeneration."[127] This is why Luther and Calvin join regeneration with justification, which some scholars believe is the same as Roman Catholic theology, but there is a difference because Luther and Calvin never taught an infusion of grace, with its elevation of human nature (Catholic view). One wonders whether Luther's focus on Christ's alien justice has influenced the idea of forensic (or declarative) justification. Medieval theology understood justification as both an act and a process, or a change of status (act) and nature (process). Luther's decisive break with medieval theology means understanding the justified person as both intrinsically sinful and extrinsically righteous (the latter is opposite to infusion).

The uniqueness of the Reformation understanding is well recognized. For example, historian Kenneth Latourette says that while Luther was lecturing on Romans and Galatians (1515–1517), the phrase "'the righteous will live by faith' [Rom 1:17], brought him the illumination by which he was thereafter to live. 'Justification by faith' became, through him, a distinctive principle of Protestantism."[128] Historian Philip Schaff says justification by faith "is the very

126. McGrath, *Iustitia Dei, A History of the Christian Doctrine of Justification: From 1500 to the Present Day* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 1991; 1st 1986), 2:1–2.

127. McCormack, "What's at Stake in the Current Debates over Justification," in *Justification*, 90.

128. Latourette, *Reformation to the Present*, vol. 2 in *A History of Christianity*, 706.

soul of evangelical Protestantism."[129] Herman Bavinck is right: at "issue was nothing less than the essential character of the gospel."[130]

However, we need to recognize that the Reformation view of justification was not a sudden discovery of the Augustinian anti-Pelagian views and predestination; rather, the Augustinian views from the fourteenth century were continued in the Reformation, for both focused on the mode rather than on the nature of justification. With respect to the nature of justification in the medieval period, humans are made righteous (sanctified, regenerated). The Reformation distinction between justification and regeneration was a brand-new idea, and should be regarded as notional, for they cannot really be separated. In other words, Protestant justification was new because it was forensic (imputed not infused). This means that the new focus differed from Augustine's focus on the nature of justification. Add to this the fact that Anselm of Canterbury (1033–1109) overthrew the "ransom theory" of the atonement with his "satisfaction theory," and the "Reformers were later to build on Anselm's insights and would develop a forensic perspective on justification."[131]

MARTIN LUTHER (1483–1546)

Disturbed by indulgences to buy salvation, Luther banged his Ninety-Five Theses to the Wittenberg church door, declaring, essentially, that the money traffickers in the temple must be thrown out. Luther wanted to reform the church from within and had no intention, at that time, of forming a new church. Luther never dreamed how rapidly and deeply his convictions would shake the church. The newly developed process of movable-type printing helped spread his message. In the providence of God, a new day of hope dawned to close the night of the Dark Ages. Luther considered grace as rooted in predestination, then later, without retracting that view, came to emphasize grace in Christ, with salvation as a universal gift (also Melanchthon).[132] Luther would devote more time to justification by faith than any other doctrine, except the doctrine of the Lord's Supper.[133]

Augustine and Luther were converted through reading Romans (13:13–14 and 1:17, respectively). Augustine changed from a profligate life, and Luther from salvation by works that nearly destroyed him. Luther said, "I hated the word 'righteousness'" in Romans 1:17, because he thought "God is righteous

129. Schaff, *Modern Christianity: The German Reformation*, vol. 7 in *History of the Christian Church*, 21.

130. Herman Bavinck, *Sin and Salvation in Christ*, vol. 3 in *Reformed Dogmatics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2006), 519.

131. See Norman L. Geisler and Ralph E. MacKenzie, *Roman Catholics and Evangelicals: Agreements and Differences* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1995), 91.

132. Ibid., 520–521.

133. Paul Althaus, *The Theology of Martin Luther* (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1975, 1st Ger. ed. 1963), 225.

and punishes the unrighteous sinner." Then he discovered that it meant, "He who through faith is righteous shall live." Luther said that "here I felt that I was altogether born again and had entered paradise itself through open gates." Later Luther read Augustine's *The Spirit and the Letter* and found he had a similar understanding of the text, "as the righteousness with which God clothes us when he justifies us."[134] Luther believed justification was a doctrine taught in Scripture,[135] and so he reached back beyond the subjectivism of medieval theology to Augustine and Paul.[136]

Did Luther's view of justification change? Carl Trueman believes his view changed between 1515–1520,[137] and Alister McGrath puts the time frame for a radical change between 1514–1519.[138] Luther began lecturing on Romans at Wittenberg University in the summer of 1515 and completed the book in 1516, at the end of the summer. From Luther's published notes, we gain two insights into his early understanding of righteousness by faith: (1) Outward justification is imputed by God to recipients, so the recipients are sinners (inwardly) but justified (outwardly), or as Luther put it they are "at the same time both righteous and unrighteous"[139] (*simul justus et peccator*); (2) God "has begun to heal him…He will continue to deliver him from sin until He has completely cured him."[140] This is "the gift of grace, which begins to take sin away."[141]

Comparing the two insights, the first seems to deal with an outward reckoning, but the second is an inward healing; the reckoning seems to be a present, extrinsic fact, but the healing begins an intrinsic process that reaches into the future. In simple terms, Luther's justification includes sanctification. Luther's change also involves a departure from his earlier belief that human freedom made people capable of receiving justification without the need of God's grace, but now Luther believes that such an acceptance is only possible through God's grace that gifts faith to humans, and thus makes them capable of

134. Martin Luther, *Luther's Works*, in *Career of the Reformer IV*, ed. Lewis W. Spitz, gen. ed. Helmut T. Lehmann (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress Press, 1960), 34:336–337.

135. Eric W. Gritsch, "The Origins of Lutheran Teaching on Justification," in *Justification by Faith: Lutherans and Catholics in Dialogue*, ed. H. George Anderson, T. Austin Murphy and Joseph A. Burgess (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg, 1985), 162–163.

136. Gritsch, "The Origins," in *Justification by Faith*, 170.

137. Carl Trueman, professor of historical theology and church history at Westminster Theological Seminary, argues for a change in Luther's understanding of justification by faith between 1515–1520. See "*Simul peccator et justus*: Martin Luther and Justification," in *Justification in Perspective*, ed. McCormack, 73–97. I am indebted to Trueman for leading me to study into this development by going to the original sources, and concur with his findings, and add some of my own.

138. McGrath, *Iustitia Dei*, Second Edition, 191; cf. 192; also "decisive break" from his thinking of humans capable of coming to Christ after his lectures on Romans, 193.

139. Luther, *Luther's Works*, 25:258; see also 257–258; emphasis in original.

140. Ibid., 25:260.

141. Ibid., 25:261.

accepting justification. This new insight seems to have come while exegeting Romans in 1515.[142]

It was Philipp Melanchthon (1497–1560), Luther's younger colleague at Wittenberg, who introduced the concept of justification as forensic.[143] McGrath claims, "The origins of the Reformation at Wittenberg are more complex than might be imagined, and there are excellent reasons for suggesting that it was initially based directly upon Augustine, rather than Luther's interpretation of him,"[144] even though there are differences between Luther and Augustine.[145] But McGrath notes that, for Christians, Christ is their present but alien righteousness (extrinsic to them; Luther), whereas Christians become righteous in justification (Augustine).[146] It could be argued that, in this respect, the Reformation followed Luther and not Augustine.

However, can more be said about Luther's view of justification? Consider the following: In 1519, on Palm Sunday,[147] Luther preached a sermon titled "Two Kinds of Righteousness": (1) The first is "alien righteousness," "infinite righteousness," or "Christ's righteousness," which, through faith, "becomes our righteousness and all that he has becomes ours; rather, he himself becomes ours," and he "swallows up all sins in a moment…. For this is the righteousness given in place of the original righteousness lost in Adam."[148] Although sins are dealt with in a moment, Luther says, "alien righteousness is not instilled all at once, but it begins, makes progress, and is finally perfected at the end through death."[149] Here justification (as alien righteousness) moves into the category of sanctification. (2) Luther's second kind of righteousness is "proper righteousness" as the "fruit" or "consequence" of alien righteousness.[150] This is the fruit of Christ's righteousness in the life, and belongs to the domain of sanctification. The fact that "proper righteousness" is another kind of righteousness flowing from "alien righteousness" suggests that Luther is open to this distinction, even though in discussing "alien righteousness" he said this is applied to the recipient until death. In other words, Luther posits a definite—but not decisive—break between justification and sanctification.

142. McGrath, *Iustitia Dei*, Second Edition, 201.

143. Geisler and MacKenzie, *Roman Catholics and Evangelicals*, 98; see also 98–100. See also Peter Toon, *Foundations for Faith: Justification and Sanctification* (Westchester, IL: Crossway, 1983), 58.

144. McGrath, *Iustitia Dei*, Second Edition, 196.

145. Man is responsible for sin (Augustine); God is responsible for sin (Luther); the slavery of man's will is due to sin (Augustine) and is due to creatureliness (Luther); predestination is for salvation (Augustine) and is for salvation and reprobation (Luther). See McGrath, *Iustitia Dei*, Second Edition, 198–202.

146. *Iustitia Dei*, Second Edition, 204–205.

147. Luther, *Luther's Works*, 31:295.

148. Ibid., 31:297–299.

149. Ibid., 31:299.

150. Ibid., 31:299–300.

Trueman says the words "alien righteousness and proper righteousness" have a parallel structural simultaneity of status with "*simul peccator et justus*" (at the same time sinner and justified) but believes Luther's language of justification is more relational.[151] Now arguably Luther continues the Augustinian intrinsic justification, but also adds an extrinsic, or alien righteousness, not found in Augustine. If this represents his intent, then Luther includes a forensic righteousness (declarative or alien, because extrinsic), even though he doesn't use the word "forensic."[152]

In Luther's 1520 *The Freedom of a Christian*, which distinguishes between the body (outer) and spiritual (inner) nature of humans, the inner person is justified by faith in Christ alone, not by outer works. Hence, obedience to God is rendered by faith alone, not by works.[153] In this context faith unites the soul with Christ, as bride to Bridegroom, so that "whatever Christ has as though it were its own, and whatever the soul has Christ claims as his own." Here is the gospel—the awesome exchange between Christ and the Christian in their "true marriage."[154] Here is the relational nature of Luther's justification. As historian Martin Brecht has noted, for Luther, "Christ was the ground and also the reality of justification."[155]

In 1531 Luther lectured on the book of Galatians at Wittenberg University, which proved to be his most exhaustive treatment of the topic.[156] After I had been reading extensively in the *Summa Theologica* of Thomas Aquinas, it was a welcome breath of fresh air to read Luther's *Commentary on Galatians*! Christ is the focus throughout, and there is no room for human works to earn salvation. What a relief to turn away from medieval formulas to the outstretched arms of the crucified-risen Savior who longs only to draw weary humans into His embrace, into a relationship with Him that guarantees salvation. Awesome Savior—amazing grace! How wretched any counterfeit gospel that hides the Savior from those who need him so much. To Luther, the gospel is Christ, and faith in Him—never faith itself. Luther declares:

> The heart must behold and apprehend nothing but Christ the Saviour.... Faith taketh hold of Christ, and hath him present, and holdeth him inclosed, as the ring doth the precious stone. And whosoever shall be found having this confidence in Christ apprehended in the heart, him will God account for righteous. This is the means, and this is the merit whereby we attain the remission of sins and righteousness. Because thou believest in me, saith the Lord, and thy faith layeth hold upon Christ, whom I have freely given unto thee that he might be thy mediator and high priest, therefore be thou justified and righteous. Wherefore God doth accept or account us as righteous, only for our faith in Christ.[157]
>
> Faith therefore is a certain steadfast beholding, which looketh upon nothing else but Christ the conqueror of sin and death, and the giver of righteousness, salvation and eternal life.[158]

Luther is clear that placing faith in our own works is to put ourselves in the place of God:

> For it belongeth only to the divine power to destroy sin and to abolish death, to create righteousness and to give life. They have attributed this divine power to our own works, saying: If thou do this work or that, thou shalt overcome sin, death and the wrath of God. And by this means they set us in God's place, making us in very deed naturally, if I may say, God himself. And herein the Papists under the name of Christ, have shewed themselves to be sevenfold more wicked idolaters than ever were the Gentiles.[159]

Luther considers justification by faith to be the crucial truth of the gospel, for only the divine power of God can save; further, works (performed in order to save ourselves) deny the divinity of Christ:

> Wherefore they that deny the divinity of Christ, do lose all Christianity and become altogether Gentiles and Turks. We must learn therefore diligently the article of justification (as I often admonish you). For all the other articles of our faith are comprehended in it: and if that remain sound, then are all the rest sound. Wherefore, when we teach that men are justified by Christ, that Christ is the conqueror of sin, death and the everlasting curse, we witness therewithal that he is by nature God.[160]

In his preface to the Galatians commentary, Luther says: "the one doctrine which I have supremely at heart, is that of faith in Christ, from whom, through whom and unto whom all my theological thinking flows back and forth day and night." This is in response to "the horrible profanation and abomination which have always raged in the Church of God, and still rage to-day, against this one solid rock which we call the doctrine of justification."[161]

Because Christ is our righteousness, Luther speaks of this as "passive righteousness" rather than "active" righteousness, adding, "although I know that I

151. Trueman, "*Simul Peccator et Justus*: Marrin Luther and Justification," in *Justification in Perspective*, 78.
152. Compare Geisler and MacKenzie, *Roman Catholics and Evangelicals*, 222. Imputive justification is the same as alien or declarative justification.
153. Luther, *Luther's Works*, 31:344–350.
154. Ibid., 31:351.
155. Martin Brecht, *Martin Luther: Shaping and Defining the Reformation, 1521–1532* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1994, 1st Ger. ed. 1986), 451.
156. Ewald M. Plass, comp., *What Luther Says: An Anthology* (Saint Louis, MO: Concordia, 1959), 2:701.
157. Martin Luther, *A Commentary on St. Paul's Epistle to the Galatians* (London: James Clarke, 1961, 1st ed. 1535), 136–137.
158. Ibid., 343.
159. Ibid., 275.
160. Ibid., 274.
161. Ibid., 16.

ought to have it, and also to fulfil it"[162] (meaning active law keeping in gratitude for salvation):

> But be it so that I had it, and did fulfil it indeed, yet notwithstanding I cannot trust unto it, neither dare I set it against the judgment of God. Thus I abandon myself from all active righteousness, both of mine own and of God's law, and embrace only that passive righteousness, which is the righteousness of grace, mercy and forgiveness of sins. Briefly, [I rest only upon] the righteousness of Christ and of the Holy Ghost, *which we do not, but suffer, and have not, but receive; God the Father freely giving it unto us through Jesus Christ.*[163]

This expresses the ultimate relational view of righteousness (justification and sanctification) as clinging solely to Jesus Christ, given in the context of the Holy Spirit and the Father; and so it is Trinitarian in breadth and Christ centered in focus. As readers will know, this system presents the relational Trinity, so it makes sense that salvation is relational (which Luther spelled out more clearly as time went by).

In the same way, Christ is central in the intent of the Lutheran Formula of Concord (1576–1584), which was to heal some disunity caused by different interpretations of the Augsburg Confession (1530), the first official document of the Reformation,[164] and it largely fulfilled this purpose.[165] The Formula states "sinners are justified before God and saved alone by faith in Christ, so that Christ alone is our righteousness." This is the "whole Christ," not just His divine nature or His human nature.[166] The justified Christian is "accounted" righteous, which is "imputed" by faith alone as the "means" or "instrument."[167] Merits belong to Christ alone and not to human works. After being justified by faith, faith works by love, so "good works always follow justifying faith."[168]

PHILIPP MELANCHTHON (1497–1560)

While Luther was the rugged leader who launched the Reformation, Melanchthon was the systematician who wrote down Lutheran thinking with precision. In 1521 he wrote *Loci Communes*, which was the first systematic

162. Ibid., 23.

163. Ibid., italics his.

164. See my *Systematic Theology: God as Trinity*, volume 2, chapter 18. The Augsbutg Confession presents Christ as the only intercessor of Scripture, so the invocation of saints is rejected (Pt.1. Art. 21), and says righteousness is not to be sought in counterfeit religious works, which "detract from the glory of Christ" and "obscure and deny the righteousness of faith" (Pt.2. Art. 6 and 21); Schaff, *The Evangelical Protestant Creeds*, vol. 3 in *The Creeds of Christendom*, 26 and 55 respectively.

165. Karl Von Hase, *Handbook to the Controversy with Rome* (London: The Religious Tract Society, 1906), 2:13n1.

166. Schaff, *The Evangelical Protestant Creeds*, in *The Creeds of Christendom*, 114–115.

167. Ibid., 116.

168. Ibid., 118.

statement of Luther's theology. He also wrote the Augsburg Confession (1530) and its Apology (1531). He complemented the bombastic Luther with his quieter nature and clarity of writing.[169] Like Augustine, Luther did not make a distinction between forensic justification and progressive sanctification, a difference stressed in later Protestant theology.[170] It seems that Melanchthon's use of the word *forensic* to describe justification did not materially change the alien righteousness view of Luther, as both were speaking of a declarative, or extrinsic, righteousness imputed by Christ in distinction to being made righteous in sanctification. It is true that Luther merged this into sanctification. A case can be made that Melanchthon more clearly described the distinction between justification and sanctification.

JOHN CALVIN (1509–1564)

Luther and Calvin were originally Catholics. Yet Catholic works caused Luther to feel the curse of the law, and he was relieved when he understood forgiveness by faith alone. It seems that Catholic works also led Calvin to look to God's work in election.

While Catholic theology claims that humans must work in order to be saved, Calvin's theology claims that God must work (elect) for a few to be saved. Catholic theology says Christ died for all, while Calvin's theology says Christ died for a few. Even though in Roman theology Christ died to save all humans, this is called into question by human works as necessary for salvation. Reformed theology also calls into question Christ's death by alleging that He died only for the elect. So Calvary suffers in both theologies.

Justification was finally (August 1, 1559) placed in the "benefits" segment of Calvin's system (Book 3), which focuses on the benefits of Calvary applied to Christians. Calvin is not interested in the order of salvation (*ordo salutis*),[171] which says justification precedes sanctification which precedes glorification (chronological order; note the first two are reversed in 1 Cor. 6:11). Rather, Calvin says about the first two: "Christ…justifies no man without also sanctifying him," adding "Though we distinguish between them, they are both inseparably comprehended in Christ. Would ye then obtain justification in Christ? You must previously possess Christ. But you cannot possess

169. R. V. Schnucker, "Melanchthon, Philip," in *Evangelical Dictionary of Theology*, 755–756.

170. See Geisler and MacKenzie, *Roman Catholics and Evangelicals*, 98.

171. However, in Book 3 (1559) Calvin takes up regeneration by faith (3.3) before justification (3.11). This was done to answer the Catholic claim that justification was "legal fiction" and didn't take regeneration seriously. However, "Calvin makes justification to be logically prior to—and the foundation of—that bestowal of the Spirit of adoption by which the believer is regenerated." This understands justification as forensic, a verdict of acquittal through imputation. For the problem with this logic, see McCormack, "What's at Stake in the Current Debates over Justification," in *Justification*, 103 and 100–101, respectively.

him without being made a partaker of his sanctification: for Christ cannot be divided."[172] In other words, union with Christ gives one a saving relationship with Christ, which means a reception of justification and sanctification with little interest in the order of receiving these benefits. In the opening of Book 3 Calvin speaks of the Spirit of sanctification, and that through the Spirit Christ unites Himself to humans.[173] As Berkouwer says, Calvin's thought is concentric—"salvation in Christ."[174]

In summary: the Reformation's decisive break from the medieval period is the distinction between justification and sanctification, yet Luther's justification spills over into initial sanctification and Calvin finds them to be inseparable in Christ. In other words, impartation is taken up after imputation in Calvin's *Institutes*. Thus salvation supplied in Christ (objective side) is applied as benefits through the Holy Spirit (subjective side). Nevertheless, it can be argued that relationship with Christ and all that this means is of primary interest to Calvin. Put differently, imputation and impartation are received from Christ and the Holy Spirit in Reformation soteriology. Superficially this seems the same as Roman Catholic theology, at least in the joining of justification and sanctification; but the major difference lies in Catholic infusion instead of Reformation impartation, with Catholic elevation of human nature producing works capable of merit rather than a covenant relationship with Christ and the Spirit in Reformation theology. This crucial difference needs to be clearly in mind when evaluating contemporary Catholic-Evangelical attempts to unite on this doctrine (see chapter 17).

ANDREAS OSIANDER (1498–1552)

In 1544 the third Protestant university was opened (Königsburg), and Osiander was called to the chair of theology in 1549. He stirred up a lot of controversy with theologians from Wittenberg (where Luther taught) with his views on justification. In 1551 "his mystical doctrine of an effective and progressive justification by an indwelling Christ"[175] placed him for all practical purposes on the Roman Catholic side of justification.

Whereas Catholics focused on infused righteousness, Osiander focuses on essential righteousness, which means Christ's divine nature dwells within and constitutes our righteousness. So Osiander and Catholics consider sanctification as the grounds for justification.[176] Whether Christ's divine nature dwells in a

172. John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion* (London: James Clarke, 1962), 2:99 (3.16.1).
173. Ibid., 1:462–466 (3.1.1–4).
174. Berkouwer, *Faith and Justification*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 28.
175. Schaff, *Modern Christianity: The German Reformation*, vol. 7 in *History of the Christian Church*, 570, 595.
176. See Berkouwer, *Faith and Justification*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 98–99.

Christian (Osiander) or Christ's righteousness is infused in a Christian (Catholic view), it makes little difference, for both views find Christ's righteousness within the Christian, rather than extrinsic in Christ Himself, and only declared to be imputed to the Christian (Reformation view).

However, in fairness, it needs to be said that the word *infused* was used by the Protestant Synod of Dort (November 13, 1618–May 9, 1619), a Calvinistic Synod (consisting of fifty-five formal sessions) where most of the eighty-four attendees were Infralapsarians (milder form of Calvinism) and refuted the five Arminian articles (Remonstrance, 1610) concerning salvation.[177] The fourth canon of Dort speaks of faith as "infused" into the elect so that they are irresistibly saved.[178] Some opposing Luther and Calvin didn't look to salvation objectively present in Jesus Christ, but to salvation subjectively (and mystically) accomplished in humans (Carlstadt, Franke, Schwenckfeld, Weigel), or accomplished by Christ overcoming the wrath of God and death (as real physical powers), and then He "infuses a new divine life in humankind" (Böhme).[179] The word *infused* was also used by the Reformed theologian Francis Turretin with respect to sanctification, but not in connection with justification (see chapter 16). For the most part the word *infused* was used by Roman Catholic theologians in direct contrast to the word *imputed* used by Protestant theologians when speaking of justification.

JUSTIFICATION FROM ETERNITY

Some Reformed theologians speak of justification as "eternal justification," linking it to the eternal decree. But this gave to the term *justification* a different meaning from what it had in ancient times. Yet these theologians didn't claim that this pact between Christ and His church meant "full justification," for the benefits though rooted in eternity are received in time.[180] Abraham Kuyper believed one is justified from eternity in the counsel of God.[181] This isn't possible, for there is no biblical evidence for it, and Scripture always links justification with faith.[182] I would add that it isn't logical to promote justification by faith (where faith is a response in history) when the eternal decree is the sovereign will of God which does not need any response in history.

177. See Philip Schaff, rev. ed., ed. David Schaff, *The Creeds of Christendom: With a History and Critical Notes* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1996, 1st ed. 1931), 1:509–513.
178. Ibid., 523.
179. Bavinck, *Sin and Salvation in Christ*, vol. 3 in *Reformed Dogmatics*, 346.
180. Ibid., 590–591.
181. See Berkouwer, *Faith and Justification*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 144n1.
182. Van Genderen and Velema, *Concise Reformed Dogmatics*, 621.

CREEDS

Augsburg Confession (1530)

1. Article 21: Christ, not saints, is the one mediator, High Priest, and Intercessor.[183]
2. Righteousness is not gained through "observances and services which are devised by men" for "[w]hat else is this than to detract from the glory of Christ, and to obscure and deny the righteousness of faith?"[184]
3. "And Augustine, in his *Treatise against Petilian's Epistle*, saith, 'Neither must we subscribe to Catholic Bishops, if they chance to err, or determine any thing contrary to the canonical divine Scriptures.'"[185]

Articles of Smalcald (1537)

1. These articles speak about the relationship of Lutheranism toward the papacy (not taken up in the Augsburg Confession), and gives "the strongest expression to the doctrine of justification by faith."[186]
2. Justification by faith is presented as the "chief article of faith" with the office and work of Christ as opposed to "the mass, purgatory, the invocation of saints, monasticism, and popery, which interfere and set aside the true doctrine of redemption."[187]

Formula of Concord (1577)

1. God "bestows and imputes to us the righteousness of the obedience of Christ; for the sake of that righteousness we are received by God into favor and accounted righteous," and "[f]aith alone is the means and instrument whereby we lay hold on Christ the Savior."[188]
2. Justify means "to absolve from sin." "The renewing of man…is rightly distinguished from the justification of faith."[189]
3. "But after that man is justified by faith, then that true and living faith works by love (Gal. v. 6), and good works always follow justifying faith."[190]

183. Schaff, rev. ed., ed. David Schaff, *The Creeds of Christendom*, 1:26.
184. Ibid., 3:55.
185. Ibid., 3:63.
186. Ibid., 1:257.
187. Ibid., 1:255.
188. Ibid., 3:116.
189. Ibid., 3:117.
190. Ibid., 3:118.

Roman Response: Between Diet of Augsburg (1530) and Diet of Ratisbon (1541)

Roman Catholic theologians made a dramatic change during the decade between Augsburg and Ratisbon. Their first response to the Protestant view on justification was to reject it as a novelty; then Catholic theologians made a sudden about-face, saying that the Protestant view on justification was the same as what Roman Catholic theology had taught for a very long time, but held to faith as the one point of difference, couching it in vague, ambiguous terms, with the ability to interpret the words in different ways. Ratisbon demonstrated that one point ambiguously presented is sufficient to neutralize all the concessions made.[191]

The concessions did not hold. Just four years later, the Council of Trent (1545–1563) was convened; in 1547, the subject of justification was discussed for seven months. That Council totally repudiated the Protestant views with anathemas. (This is one example that indicates that Rome never changes, though she may seem to compromise, and should give pause to those involved in the contemporary consensus seeking, which is using the same methods. See chapter 17 on the contemporary debate.)

Counter Reformation: Council of Trent (1545–1563)

The intent of Trent's sixth session was to negate the "erroneous doctrine" of justification (their perspective) and to "strictly forbid" any teaching that did not agree with the present decree.[192] Trent makes clear that humans are born with original sin, that Jesus Christ came to redeem all humans through His death, and that the merit of His passion is bestowed on all who are born again. Justification is a "translation" from the state of sin (through first Adam) to the state of grace (through the second Adam). Without any human merit, God's "quickening and helping grace" enables adults to receive the call of God and they cooperate with grace that is received through hearing, and begin to love Him (not fear Him) and are moved against sin, to repent, do penance, and be baptized.[193]

Preparation is followed by justification, which includes sanctification, for an unjust person becomes just, an enemy becomes a friend. The final cause of justification is the glory of God and Christ, and eternal life; the efficient cause is the

191. James Buchanan, *The Doctrine of Justification: An Outline of Its History in the Church and Its Exposition from Scripture* (London: The Banner of Truth Trust, 1961, 1st ed. 1867), 141–150.
192. H. J. Schroeder, *Canons and Decrees of the Council of Trent: Original Text with English Translation* (London: B. Herder Book Co., 1955), 29.
193. Ibid., 29–33 (chaps. 1–6).

merciful God who washed and sanctifies, the meritorious cause is Christ's death, and the instrumental cause is baptism. The single formal cause is "the justice of God, not that by which He Himself is just, but that by which He makes us just," not merely "reputed" as just but "receiving justice within us" through the Holy Spirit poured out in our hearts. In other words, forgiveness of sins, faith, hope, and charity are "infused at the same time." For "faith without deeds is useless" (Jas. 2:17, 20) and "faith...expressing itself through love" (Gal. 5:6). Neither faith nor works "merit the grace of justification."[194]

The above two paragraphs seem to present the gospel, and no doubt contribute to the contemporary debate that seeks to find similarities between Roman Catholic and Reformation views of justification. There are similarities, but the differences determine the extent of the similarity.

The intimate relations between Christ and humans seem to be replaced by more-mechanical means, where (1) the infusion of original sin (guilt) from Adam is overcome by (2) an infusion of grace, and (3) deliverance is attained instrumentally through baptism.

The sixth session of Trent dealt with justification as "the most important item" on its agenda.[195] Trent decreed that the Latin Vulgate version of Scripture was the official Bible, but this version does not do justice to the Greek word *dikaioō* which means "to declare righteous," for the Vulgate translates it by the Latin word *iustificare*, which means "to make righteous."[196] To be declared righteous has nothing to do with personal merit, whereas to be made righteous led to works of merit.

According to Trent, justification "is not only a remission of sins but also the sanctification and renewal of the inward man through the voluntary reception of the grace and gifts whereby an unjust man becomes just and from being an enemy becomes a friend."[197] Faith, hope, and love are infused into the Christian.[198] With the infusion of justification, there begins a process of justification in which works merit further justification.[199] This confuses the categories of justification and sanctification, and questions justification by faith *alone*, because works are included. Furthermore, Catholic-infused justification, or "physical

194. Ibid., 33–35 (chaps. 7–8).

195. Hubert Jedin, *A History of the Council of Trent* (St. Louis, MO: B. Herder Book Co., 1961, 1st ed. 1957), 2:171.

196. Michael S. Horton, "The *Sola*'s of the Reformation" in *Here We Stand: A Call from Confessing Evangelicals*, ed. James Montgomery Boice and Benjamin E. Sasse (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1996), 122; Martin Chemnitz, *Examination of the Council of Trent* (St. Louis, MO: Concordia, 1971), 1:472–473. The Paris edition of the Vulgate eliminated many of the corrupt transmissions in the thirteenth century, Alister E. McGrath, *Christianity's Dangerous Idea: The Protestant Evolution—A History from the Sixteenth Century to the Twenty-First* (New York: HarperCollins, 2007), 29.

197. Schroeder, *Canons and Decrees of the Council of Trent*, 33 (6.7).

198. Ibid., 34 (6.7).

199. Ibid., 36 (6.10); see also 45 (Canon 24).

justification,"[200] is a state in which only a partial remission of sins is experienced, for there is still guilt and debt to be met by temporal punishment—even beyond this world, in purgatory.[201] This means there is no imputation of Christ who forgives all sin in this life. Remaining sin must be atoned for in purgatory. I concur with Charles Hodge who states that Roman Catholic justification lacks imputation.[202] Evidently, infused sanctification still needs purgatory after death. So there is no full infusion, only partial infusion, in Catholic theology.

The *Roman Catechism*, issued under the direction of Trent, calls infused justification (or sanctifying grace) "'a divine quality inhering in the soul' (*divina qualitas in anima inhaerens*: II 2, 49)."[203] Those who fall from justification can regain justification through works, such as "fasts, alms, prayers and other devout exercises of the spiritual life."[204] Trent "teaches that for the justified" person "eternal life is both a gift or grace promised by God and a reward for his own good works and merits."[205] For Rome "sanctification is the ground of justification."[206] However, one is not justified on the basis of infused grace, inherent righteousness, or good works but on the basis of Christ's righteousness, which is alien or extrinsic.[207]

The sixth session ended with thirty-three canons, each with anathemas. Canon 9 states: "If any one saith, that by faith alone the impious is justified; in such wise as to mean, that nothing else is required to co-operate in order to the obtaining the grace of Justification, and that it is not in any way necessary, that he be prepared and disposed by the movement of his own will; let him be anathema."[208] Penance (Canon 29) and purgatory (Canon 30) are mentioned, the latter meaning that assurance of salvation is not attained in this life, which means Roman Catholic theology lacks the freedom and good news of the gospel. Trent declares "that Christ has only merited for us the infusion of love, that through the strength and power of this our inhering love sins are expelled, extinguished, and blotted out and that in this way God finally remits the offence." So "the teaching of the Council of Trent, interpose between his sins and the offended God not the satisfaction of Christ but his inherent love...Thus, according to this same interpretation, Christ has not, through His obedience, merited for those who believe in Him salvation and eternal life, but He has only

200. Francis Turretin, *Institutes of Elenctic Theology* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 1994), 2:660.

201. Schroeder, *Canons and Decrees of the Council of Trent*, 46 (Canon 39).

202. Charles Hodge, *Commentary on the Epistle of Romans* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1960, 1st ed. 1886), 31.

203. Ludwig Ott, *Fundamentals of Catholic Dogma* (St. Louis, MO: Herder Book Co., May 1958), 255.

204. Schroeder, *Canons and Decrees of the Council of Trent*, 39 (6.14).

205. Ott, *Fundamentals of Catholic Dogma*, 264.

206. Berkouwer, *Faith and Justification*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 98.

207. See Anderson et al., *Justification by Faith*, 24.

208. Matt Slick, "Council of Trent: Canons on Justification," http://carm.org/council-trent-canons-justification, accessed August 31, 2012.

merited this, that for His sake the inherent love is infused into us, and that it is this finally which makes man not only pleasing but 'wholly pleasing' to God."[209] So it is human virtues and not Christ's obedience that saves.[210]

On the contrary... "the only thing we could really be said to contribute to our justification is the sin God so graciously forgives."[211]

EVALUATION

No wonder Chemnitz exclaimed, "how shameful and blasphemous it [Trent] is toward the most holy merit of our Lord Jesus Christ, whose throne our own virtues are commanded to invade, after He Himself has been cast down from it, in order that they [Christ's merits] may be our propitiation for sin and the price of eternal life."[212] Trent (1545–1563) replaces Christ's substitution (life and death) and the Spirit's application of the benefits of Christ's life and death by alleged merits of human works.

The Augsburg Confession (1530) states, "For the glory of Christ's merit suffers when we seek by such observances to merit justification."[213] Further, "our works can not reconcile God, or deserve remission of sins, grace, and justification at his hands, but that these we obtain by faith only, when we believe that we are received into favor for Christ's sake, who alone is appointed the Mediator."[214] Francis Turretin declares, "this saving doctrine [justification] is of the greatest importance in religion" for when it is "adulterated or subverted, it is impossible to retain purity of doctrine in other places. Hence Satan in every way has endeavored to corrupt this doctrine in all ages, as has been done especially in the papacy."[215]

The fact that justification is by grace is shared by Roman Catholic and Protestant theology, as clearly given in the introduction to the Tridentine decrees. Likewise, both sides agree that justification is by faith. But the difference lies with Protestants' believing in justification by grace alone (*sola*) and faith alone (*sola*), compared to Roman Catholic additions that replace the word *alone*, and in so doing replace the work of Christ and the Spirit with human works.

The medieval church period, often referred to as the Dark Ages, was a time when the biblical truth of justification by faith was hidden behind the entrenched traditions of the Roman Catholic church. Arguably the Council of

209. Chemnitz, *Examination of the Council of Trent*, 1:520.
210. Ibid., 1:521; cf. 1:491.
211. Alister E. McGrath, *Justification by Faith: What It Means to Us Today* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1988), 132.
212. Chemnitz, *Examination of the Council of Trent*, 1:522.
213. Philip Schaff, *The Evangelical Protestant Creeds*, vol. 3 in *The Creeds of Christendom*, 64.
214. Ibid., 21. Article XX says Reformation theology is "falsely accused of forbidding good works," Schaff, *The Evangelical Protestant Creeds*, 20.
215. Turretin, *Institutes*, 2:633.

Trent was the first time that justification by faith was formally discussed. It was a response to Luther's challenge, and it took seven months to create the Decrees. It was done at a time when copies of the Bible were more widely available than ever before, and at a time when different Catholic orders (Dominicans, Franciscans, and Augustinians) had different ideas about sanctification and justification. Some statements in the Decrees seem close to Protestant views, but they are a mixture of "some truth mixed with much error."[216]

Conclusion

Prior to Augustine, there had been no formal study of justification as a doctrine. Augustine did not know Hebrew or Greek, and in the last years of his life he was dependent upon Jerome's Latin Vulgate, a sometimes inaccurate translation. For example, Augustine taught that justification means being made righteous, based on the Latin *justifico.* This differs from the Greek *logizetai* (Rom. 4:5; cf. Gal. 3:6), which means "being declared, accounted, or credited" as righteous. Thus Augustine focused on nature and not on status, or on an alleged reality in the Christian rather than on a relationship with Christ, fully due to His merits. Augustine misunderstood Romans 9, thinking it spoke of election to salvation of the few rather than election to mission for all humans. His thinking affected Catholic and Protestant theology.

Catholic theology focused on personal justification contributing to further justification—thus merit or human works are important. By so doing, justification was merged into sanctification. It is true that Reformation theology did not always emphasize a distinction between justification and sanctification. However, the difference between the two can be found in Catholic *infusion* contrasted with Protestant *imputation.* In other words, Christians are justified by Christ alone, through grace alone, by faith alone. There is no room for Catholic works (merit from *meritum*, a wrong Latin translation). Yet the Reformers brought with them two of the seven Catholic sacraments, and to this extent the "Christ alone" principle was compromised, even though unwittingly.

Just as imputation is the work of Christ, so is impartation. The human part is to accept these gifts and remain in a dependent relationship with Christ. The foundational focus of justification and sanctification is more than nature or status; it is an ongoing relationship with Christ in which He is the sole means of salvation. He "has become for us wisdom from God—that is, our righteousness, holiness and redemption" (1 Cor. 1:30; cf. v. 2).

216. See James Buchanan, *The Doctrine of Justification* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 1955), 141.

Study Questions

1. What occupied Christian theology in the first three-hundred-fifty years, and what was not studied during that time?
2. How does a person gain salvation in Gnostic and Pelagian systems?
3. What disadvantage did early Western theology have in trying to understand justification?
4. How did Romans 9:10–29 change Augustine's view of salvation?
5. What nonbiblical views entered theology through Augustine's *Enchiridion*?
6. What part of Christ's ministry is absent in Augustine's theology?
7. How did the medieval church understand justification and how it was mediated to persons?
8. In what ways did Aquinas contribute to the Roman Catholic view of salvation?
9. What is the Orthodox view of salvation?
10. What did Luther, Melanchthon, and Calvin contribute to the Protestant view of salvation?
11. What can we learn from the Roman Catholic response to Protestant views of justification between the Diets of Augsburg (1530) and Ratisbon (1541)?
12. How would you evaluate the Council of Trent's view of justification?

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Salvation Debate: Post-Tridentine to Contemporary

Purpose

1. Document the Protestant reaction to the Council of Trent.
2. Examine contemporary Protestant contributions.

Summary

The Council of Trent clearly rejected the Protestant view of justification by faith, taking the position that the *sola fide* (faith alone) focus of Protestant theology does great disservice to the change of life of the justified person. Catholic theology rejected the "declared just" Protestant view (forensic or imputed justification), and opted for a "made just" view (ontological), concluding that obedience is not given its due in Protestant theology. By contrast, Protestant theologians distinguish between being declared just (justification) and subsequent obedience through the work of the Holy Spirit (regeneration and sanctification). Protestants reject the idea of being made just by an alleged infused righteousness whereby the justified person's nature is elevated and made capable of doing meritorious works. Protestants claim that works are a love-response through perfect faith and dependence upon Jesus Christ. In other words, Protestant theology looks to the objective justification and sanctification in the life

and death of Jesus Christ, while Catholic theology seems to look more to an infused justification-sanctification in humans.

Outline

I. Introduction
A. Debate
II. Biblical Understanding of Justification by Faith
A. Justification and Sanctification: Need to Be Distinguished, Not Divided
III. Post-Tridentine Debate: Protestant
A. Francis Turretin (1623–1687)
B. Herman Bavinck (1854–1921)
C. Karl Barth (1886–1968)
D. Alister McGrath's Assessment
IV. Contribution of the New Perspectives on Paul Movement to Justification by Faith
V. Biblical Understanding of Sanctification by Faith
VI. Conclusion
VII. Study Questions

Introduction

The Council of Trent (1545–1563) dismissed the Lutheran view of salvation with anathemas, arguably in survival mode due to the massive impact the Reformation was having on the Catholic church. This chapter presents some of the ongoing debate since the Council of Trent, whereas the next chapter will investigate why there is a convergence between the Catholic and Protestant views. It will be seen, then, that there is a new survival mode that drives the new focus on this debate.

DEBATE

The twentieth-century ecumenical movement introduced a new focus on things held in common—instead of on differences. Whether either side changed is arguable, of course, but what was the reason for the change of focus? Both sides perceived that their common enemy (secularism) could not be defeated by a divided Christianity. Instead of seeing Catholic theology as the enemy (Protestant view) or Protestant theology as the enemy (Catholic view), Christians on both sides began to see secularism, with its culture of death (abortion) and non-Christian values (nonbiblical views of marriage), as the enemy. They believed that facing such an enemy required a united Christian front. In other words,

arguably social issues had become more important than soteriological issues, for survival drives the ecumenical mission.

In presenting highlights of the justification-by-faith debate since the Council of Trent, we see in contemporary times a narrowing of the divide between Catholic and Protestant views, as both face secularism. This is not to say they are in agreement, without differing views; but it is to say there is a developing consensus that unity based on points of common agreement must be given precedence over points of difference in order for Christians to better face their common enemy. Otherwise the fragmentation among Christians could result in a victory for secularism. The mission seems to necessitate a more unified attack on secularism.

The major problem with this approach is the assumption that *unity* is a better weapon than *truth*. After all, if the gospel is what the world needs, then the view of salvation that best concurs with the gospel is the truth needed to meet secularism. If the Protestant view of justification by faith is inextricably linked to the gospel, then it cannot be relegated to minor importance. On the other hand, if the Catholic view more closely represents the gospel, then this should end the debate, and all Christians should teach this view to better serve the gospel. So the view that is truer to the gospel must be taken to the whole world in order to defeat secularism. Soteriology must be true to the gospel if it hopes to defeat secularism.

Some believe there is really no difference between the forensic view of imputation of righteousness (Protestant) and the inherent view of infused righteousness (Catholic), and that Scripture presents both; they believe that the debate is a hindrance to the unity that is needed to defeat secularism. Another argument (made in chapter 15, and to be stressed again in chapter 17) is the need to look at all that Catholic theology teaches about salvation (by works of merit, need of purgatory, function of priests and sacraments, intercession of Mary and saints), which provides the context in which to evaluate Catholic inherent infusion compared to Protestant forensic imputation. It is necessary to factor in all that Catholic theology teaches on salvation and all that Scripture teaches on salvation to get a true assessment.

Arguably both Catholic and Reformation churches lack a perfect understanding of the gospel. For example, Catholic theology replaces the work of Christ with human works and salvation through church and sacraments, yet it teaches that Christ died for all humans. By contrast, Reformation theology (Calvinism) teaches that Christ's work, and not human works, provides salvation; but the Protestant view of predestination is that Christ died only for the elect. Neither does justice to the high priestly ministry of Christ in heaven's sanctuary during the Christian era, which is an integral part of the gospel.

The Catholic church claims to be infallible as the extension (or prolongation) of the Incarnation, essentially identifying Christ with the church. Yet in Scripture there is no automatic or mechanical handing over of Christ to the body of believers to be managed and manipulated by priests through sacraments. Christ remains in charge of salvation at the throne of heaven. The process of salvation is in divine hands (where it belongs) and never in human hands (Acts 26:18; 1 Cor. 1:2; Heb. 10:29). After declaring humans as just, God imparts His Holy Spirit as the means of sanctifying them (Rom. 15:16; 1 Cor. 6:11) for only God can create (cf. Christ: 2 Cor. 5:17; Gal. 6:15) or restore persons to reflect the image of God damaged through the Fall. Sanctification is a creative work that only God can accomplish, in a relational or covenant way, and not through a mechanical infusion, elevating human nature to earn further justification through a process of merit (Catholic views).

Issues related to salvation are central to the gospel, and are the essence of Christianity. This is not an examination of minor matters, but a review of the core beliefs that separate Christians from non-Christians, for the foundational distinction between biblical and nonbiblical religions is their understanding of how humans are saved.

Evangelicals and Catholics have produced joint statements which seem to gloss over differences, but these need to be evaluated by Scripture (see chapter 17). The biblical understanding of justification by faith is the heart of the gospel and the basis of the Reformation. It is radically distinct from all non-Christian religions that seek salvation through human works that replace (wittingly or unwittingly) the only saving work through the life and death of Jesus Christ and His post-resurrection ministry as King-Priest and Mediator in heaven's sanctuary.

Put another way, Scripture only knows of one functioning priest during the Christian era: Christ. Human traditions eclipse His priesthood, and human works hide His work.

Biblical Understanding of Justification by Faith

The biblical view of justification by faith is centered in Jesus Christ, His life and death. It is a gift that is received and can never be earned. Paul says, "they are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption which is in Christ Jesus" (Rom. 3:24, RSV), for "a man is justified by faith apart from works of the law" (Rom. 3:28 RSV), and even faith is a gift (Rom. 10:17). Humans are "justified by his [Christ's] blood" (Rom. 5:9, ESV). Calvary was the "one act of righteousness" which "leads to justification and life for all men" (Rom. 5:18b, ESV). "God made

him [Christ] who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Cor. 5:21). Justification is found in Christ, and is received by faith. This has nothing to do with Christ's faithfulness in the covenant which continues human membership in the covenant, as proposed by the New Perspectives on Paul scholarship (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 12). Justification explains how one gets in and not how one stays in the covenant, the latter being the view of the New Perspectives on Paul theology. Justification is an entry-level reality, having to do with how one is saved.

Scripture defines justification (or righteousness): "Abram believed [*'āman*] the Lord, and he credited [*ḥāšab*] it to him as righteousness [*ṣĕdāqâ*]" (Gen. 15:6). This text is the basis for the New Testament presentation on justification (Rom. 4:3, 9, 22; Gal. 3:6; Jas. 2:23). The Hebrew word *ṣādaq* in the *qal* form means "to be righteous," but in the *hip'il* form means "declare to be righteous." Justification in Scripture is consistently in the *hip'il* form (Protestant view) and not in the *qal* form (Catholic view).[1] The masculine *ṣedeq* is used one hundred and eighteen times, and the feminine *ṣedāqâ* is used one hundred and fifty and six times, with the same meaning, for most of the earliest examples (not Gen. 15:6; 18:19; 30:33) are used in the context of judging, hence declaring righteous, a legal or forensic connotation. The word *ḥāšab* has the same meaning: "to credit, to account."[2]

The words for justify in Hebrew (*hiṣdiq*) and Greek (*dikaioun*) "never refer to the infusion of righteousness, that is the transformation of someone from being ungodly to being virtuous,"[3] which is a view held by Catholic theology. Justification is the same throughout human history, in old and new covenant periods, because it is about the one eternal gospel. Hence "Abraham believed the Lord; and he reckoned [*elogisthē*] it to him as righteousness" (Rom. 4:3, RSV), or "counted to him" (ESV). The word "reckoned" or "counted" is stated nine times in the chapter. This is a forensic term. It is about the great exchange that takes place in justification: Humans become members of the covenant on the basis of Christ's substitutionary death for all humans.

The benefits of Christ's death are available from the beginning of sin, for the Lamb "was slain from the creation of the world" (Rev. 13:8b),[4] and "scripture,

1. For more on these comparisons, see Bruce A. Demarest, *The Cross and Salvation: The Doctrine of Salvation,* vol. 1 of *Foundations of Evangelical Theology* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 1997), 364–368.

2. Harold G. Stigers, "*ṣādēq*," in *Theological Workbook of the Old Testament*, 2:752–755.

3. Wilhelmus à Brakel, *The Christian's Reasonable Service* (Grand Rapids, MI: Reformation Books, 1999, 1st ed. 1993), 2:343.

4. This verse has been translated to mean that either the believers' names are entered into the Book of Life from the creation of the world, or Christ's death is from the creation of the world. The former is supported by Revelation 17:8, but the latter makes more sense because the "alternate construction separates the modifier from its antecedent by twelve words." "It is better in this case to follow the order of the Greek syntax and read, 'the Lamb that was slain from the creation of the world,'" Robert H. Mounce, *Revelation*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament*, rev. ed. (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1997), 252.

foreseeing that God would justify the Gentiles by faith, preached the gospel beforehand to Abraham, saying, 'In you shall all the nations be blessed'" (Gal. 3:8, RSV). For God chose us in Christ from before the foundation of the world (Eph. 1:4). "The Lord Our Righteous Savior" (Jer. 23:6; 33:16b) is already a focus in the old covenant. That's why David said, "God credits [*logizetai*] righteousness apart from works" (Rom. 4:6). Here is a forensic statement, God's declaring someone to be righteous. No wonder the gospel is "eternal" (Rev. 14:6). "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8).

At a deeper level, Christ was "delivered up for our trespasses and raised for our justification" (Rom. 4:25, ESV). There is a post-Calvary dimension to God's saving work that is often overlooked: Christ (Rom. 8:34) and the Holy Spirit (Rom. 8:26–27) both intercede in heaven for believers. The book of Hebrews (which is like a fifth Gospel) focuses on Christ's post-ascension ministry, which is just as important as His ministry on earth (the subject of the four Gospels). If Christians had focused on all that Christ and the Holy Spirit are doing for humans in heaven's sanctuary, believers would not have been tempted to look to Mary and saints to do intercessory work for which they have no qualifications. For there is only "one mediator between God and mankind, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a ransom for all people" (1 Tim. 2:5–6a). Christ alone is qualified to intercede on the basis of His death (Heb. 7:23–27; 8:1–3; 9:11–12, 24–26).

Just as Adam's sin is imputed to all humans, so Christ's death deals with sin, and His righteousness is imputed to all who receive justification. Christ's righteousness imputed makes unnecessary any infusion through sacraments or works to merit righteousness. Reckoned righteousness finds the recipient always dependent on the imputed and imparted righteousness of Christ. By contrast, the Catholic infusion of righteousness focuses on inherent righteousness and works that follow to merit more righteousness. Personal performance and the performance of other humans (Mary and saints) takes the place of sole dependence on Christ crucified, resurrected, and interceding before the Father at heaven's throne. For only Christ Jesus has become "our righteousness, holiness and redemption" (1 Cor. 1:30).

That is why Edinburgh theologian James Buchanan is right to say, "There is, perhaps, no more subtle or plausible error, on the subject of Justification, than that which makes it to rest on the indwelling presence, and the gracious work, of the Holy Spirit in the heart."[5] The Holy Spirit is never our righteousness, any more than He is our Savior. The Holy Spirit did not live a human life to give

5. James Buchanan, *The Doctrine of Justification: An Outline of Its History in the Church and of Its Exposition from Scripture* (London, UK: the Banner of Truth Trust, 1961, 1st ed. 1867), 401.

us His character, nor did the Holy Spirit die for our sins as our substitute. Any replacement of Christ is essentially antichrist in nature. Christ clearly made the distinction between Himself and the Holy Spirit (John 16:7–15).

Paul states, "a person is not justified by the works of the law, but by faith in Jesus Christ" (Gal. 2:16a). Abraham's experience reveals two aspects of justification: (1) Justification comes through faith. Consider what Paul says, "If, in fact, Abraham was justified by works, he had something to boast about—but not before God. What does the Scripture say? [note the repetition] 'Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness'" (Rom. 4:2–3; cf. Gen. 15:6). Paul continues, "Clearly no one who relies on the law is justified before God, because, 'the righteous will live by faith'" (Gal. 3:11). So a person is justified by faith at the beginning of his or her Christian journey, then continues to live by faith. Justification by faith alone is the gospel. No wonder the followers of God in the Old Testament were called people of faith (Heb. 11).

(2) Justification leads to the fruit of faith in the life of the justified person: James informs us that "faith without deeds is useless" (Jas. 2:20b). He continues: "Was not our ancestor Abraham considered righteous for what he did when he offered his son Isaac on the altar? You see that his faith and his actions were working together, and his faith was made complete by what he did. And the scripture was fulfilled that says, 'Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness,' and he was called God's friend. You see that a person is considered righteous by what they do and not by faith alone" (Jas. 2:21–24). With respect to subsequent works after justification, Paul is an echo of James: "For it is not those who hear the law who are righteous in God's sight, but it is those who obey the law who will be declared righteous" (Rom. 2:13). After all, justification is a declaration of forgiveness for confessed law breaking; and, in gratitude, the justified person gladly keeps the law through the abiding presence and power of Christ—which is sanctification, and not a process of justification. "Men are justified in order that they may be sanctified; not sanctified in order that they may be justified."[6]

There appears to be a contradiction here in Paul and James: (a) Abraham was justified by faith and not by works (Rom. 4:2; cf. Gen. 15:6), and (b) Abraham was justified by what he did and not by faith alone (Jas. 2:23–24). Both speak of faith as crediting Abraham as righteous. Both are forensic statements. But James adds one dimension which is not contradictory to the crediting: "his faith and his actions were working together, and his faith was made complete [*eteleiōthē*] by what he did" (Jas. 2:22b). In other words, *his faith was expressed by what he did.* James Buchanan observes that "Paul contended against Legalism,"

6. William G. T. Shedd, *Dogmatic Theology*, 3rd ed. (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 2003), 800.

and "James contends against Libertinism," for a self-righteousness through law keeping or a careless lack of law keeping are equally wrong.[7]

It is well known that Martin Luther rejected James, calling it an epistle of straw because it speaks of justification by works, and he considered the letter to James inferior to Romans and other Pauline epistles. Yet Luther believed in works. Commenting on Romans 12 onward, Luther wrote, "From there to the end he [Paul] teaches in what kind of works we should be involved, once that righteousness of Christ has been received. For in the presence of God this is not the way, that a person becomes righteous by doing works of righteousness... but he who has been made righteous, does works of righteousness."[8] Luther evidently didn't realize that this is precisely the point James is making. The debate continues, so in commenting on works in James 2:14–26, Ralph Martin wrote, "No final resolution of some exegetical matters appears in sight."[9]

Merely claiming to have faith without works cannot save a person (Jas. 2:14). Mere mental assent doesn't include a heart experience, which is what matters to God (Deut. 5:29). Knowledge by itself doesn't save a person (proven by Gnosticism). For if knowledge could save, one would not need a Savior. James is essentially saying that if someone we know needs clothes or food, it is not good enough for us to say "I hope you will be warm and fed" and do nothing to provide clothing and food for that poor person. Such faith without works is dead (Jas. 2:16–17). Commenting on these verses, James Adamson says, "Faith that produces no works is dead; and dead faith cannot produce works."[10] Donald Burdick adds that faith without "regenerative actions" is

7. Buchanan, *The Doctrine of Justification*, 263. Also, consider the fact that the gospel includes a harmony between Paul and James when both quote Genesis 15:6. Paul said: "If, in fact, Abraham was justified by works, he had something to boast about—but not before God. What does the Scripture say? 'Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness'" (Rom. 4:2–3). James said: "Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness" for "a person is justified by what he does and not by faith alone" (Jas. 2:23–24). Abraham believed God's promise of a son (Paul's point) and responded to God's command to sacrifice his son (James's point). In other words, the gospel is faith in God to fulfill a seemingly impossible promise (Paul) and faith that acts to obey God's command (James). Obedience is not a work to save a person (as a merit) but is a work of gratitude on the part of a saved person, for Christ said, "if you love me, you will obey what I command" (John 14:15). The gospel expressed in both Paul and James is a covenant heart-relationship with God, the essence of salvation. Faith is a gift (nor attempting to earn salvation), and faith launches one into a justified Christian life. The gift of faith is God's entrance into the life, and He maintains the Christian's justification which results in works of gratitude. James speaks of this as "faith and actions working together." Perhaps this is best summarized as follows: the root of justification is faith and the fruit of justification is works, and both are gifts from a loving God, so "faith without works is dead" (Jas. 2:26b). Concerning Abraham, it is said, "Faith was completed [*eteleiōthē*] by his works" (Jas. 2:22b, ESV). The fact that justifying faith results in Christian works indicates that justification overlaps a little with sanctification, and that is why it is better not to attempt to overly separate the two with human attempts at theological precision that fail to do justice to the relationship of the two in God's gift. For Christ is the source of both justification and sanctification.

8. Martin Luther, *Romans*, vol. 25 in *Luther's Works* (Saint Louis, MO: Concordia, 1972), 3.

9. Ralph P. Martin, *James*, vol. 48 in *Word Biblical Commentary* (Waco, TX: Word, 1988), 82.

10. James B. Adamson, *The Epistle of James*, in *The New International Commentary on the New Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1976), 124.

"superficial and spurious." In fact, "seeming concern for the welfare of the poor person is a worthless façade."[11]

John Calvin speaks of this "false profession of faith" as hypocrisy, saying, "They who devise for themselves faith without works, and without any duties of religion, trifle with God."[12] Such faith is empty of content (Jas. 2:20, vain, *kenos*). It is obvious that commentators such as these have caught the true meaning of what James is teaching. The epistle of James states that if someone thinks him- or herself religious, that person is deceived; his or her religion is worthless if it is devoid of works such as controlling the tongue (1:26), visiting orphans and widows (1:27), remaining unspotted from the world (1:27), and carrying out the royal law of love (2:8), or if he or she shows partiality (2:9) and fails to show mercy (2:13).[13] But, if a person has true faith, it will be evidenced by what that person does. Paul and James both speak about genuine living faith, so there is no debate between them. Luther missed the point, and so do others who believe there is a contradiction between Paul and James.

JUSTIFICATION AND SANCTIFICATION: NEED TO BE DISTINGUISHED, NOT DIVIDED

Justification needs to be understood separately from sanctification, for the distinction does better justice to justification by faith alone, which was understood by Martin Luther but rejected by the church at the Council of Trent (see chapter 15). Any overemphasis on sanctification without justification by faith is not true sanctification. For justification by faith alone is the entry level of salvation, when, on the basis of Christ's life and death, the repentant sinner is declared righteous in Christ. The Reformed theologians teach "not to merge justification in sanctification."[14] In justification believers are declared, but not made, righteous. In sanctification believers are in the process of being restored, so that the image damaged by sin is being renewed over time, allowing the person to reflect ever more the likeness of Christ. John says about Christ's second advent: "we know that when Christ appears, we shall be like him" (1 John 3:2b).

Justification is not inherent in humans, nor is righteousness infused in humans (justification is *declaring* righteousness, not *making* righteous), for Christ's righteousness is resident in Him and only in humans as Christ abides in them. Indeed, righteousness cannot be found in humans apart from a relationship with Christ and the Holy Spirit. So justification is imputed by Christ, and sanctification is

11. Donald W. Burdick, *James,* vol. 12 in *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 1981), 182–183.

12. John Calvin, *James*, vol. 22 in *Calvin's Commentaries* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1989), 309–311.

13. As given by R. C. H. Lenski, *James* (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg, 1966), 577.

14. See Abraham Kuyper, *The Work of the Holy Spirit* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1979, 1st ed. 1900), 355.

imparted through the Holy Spirit; yet both are the result of Christ's life and death, for only Christ is our righteousness (1 Cor. 1:30; John 16:10; cf. Rom. 10:3–4); the Holy Spirit is not our righteousness. Justification and sanctification, though distinguished, should not be divided (separated), for Christ is our justification (*dikaiōthōmen*, Gal 2:16, ESV) and sanctification (*hagiasmos*, 1 Cor. 1:30, ESV).

How does justification by faith relate to the topic of predestination (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapters 15–16)? There is a difference between God's declaring a person righteous in forensic justification, and God's decreeing a person's salvation. Declarative justification includes the response of a person in history (John 3:16; Rom. 4:5), while decreeing salvation does not. The first is relational, the second is robotic; the first considers human free choice to be vital, the second considers human free choice unnecessary; the first is a matter of the heart (God and humans), the second is a matter of will (God's will, irrespective of human will); the first appreciates humans as valuable in covenant relationship with God, the second is mutually exclusive to a covenant relationship. Why do Protestants believe declarative justification is so important if salvation is decreed in eternity? These seem contrary beliefs. In other words, why speak of justification by faith when human faith does not seem to play a role in election?

Faith does count. That is why biblical texts call for a human response to God's call in history (Josh. 24:15; 1 Kings 18:21; Rev. 3:20). *Once saved, always saved* is not biblical (Heb. 6:4–6). Salvation is conditional, and can be lost (e.g., King Saul: 1 Sam. 10:6–7; 16:14; 19:22; 28:1–19; 31:1–5). Salvation has a past (John 3:16–17), present (1 Cor. 1:18), and future sense (Matt. 10:22; 24:13). Note the present continuous tense of the following: "For the message of the cross is foolishness to those who are perishing, but to us who are *being saved* it is the power of God" (1 Cor. 1:18, emphasis added). Reformed theology believes justification is rooted in the eternal decree, so that before conversion, and before being born, a person is declared justified from eternity. That means that a person is justified before belief, whereas Scripture speaks only of justification that follows belief (Rom. 3:22–24). That is why one is "justified by faith" (Rom. 3:28), not by decree.

Post-Tridentine Debate: Protestant

FRANCIS TURRETIN (1623–1687)

Turretin's extensive system reminds one of the scholasticism of Thomas Aquinas, so we will only explore some insights from his writings (as the rest is not essential for our purpose of giving an overview). Turretin comments on some Catholic theologians who wanted to "lessen controversies" and who thought there

was not much difference between Roman and Protestant views on justification.[15] This is similar to the ecumenical concerns present in contemporary study of this topic (see chapter 17).

Turretin finds solid support in Scripture for forensic or imputed righteousness (Job 9:3; Ps. 143:2; Rom. 3:28; 4:1–3; Acts 13:39). He denies that justification is founded upon inherent righteousness, as declared by the Council of Trent.[16] He states that the righteousness and obedience of Christ imputed to humans is the meritorious cause and foundation of their justification with God. For "what could not be found in us" is "to be sought in another" and that is found "nowhere else than in Christ."[17] This justification includes a remission of sins, adoption, and the right to life.[18]

Turretin then takes up sanctification. He says, "As Christ was made to us of God righteousness and sanctification (1 Cor 1:30)—not dividedly, but conjointly; not confusedly, but distinctly—so the benefit of sanctification immediately follows justification as inseparably connected with it, but yet really distinct from it."[19] This echoes the thinking of Calvin (see chapter 15). In other words, although justification and sanctification are both present in Christ, one is imputed in an instant (justification), the other is imparted throughout life, and even beyond the present life (sanctification).[20] The Holy Spirit indwells believers and "excites" them to good works, which are also done because of "the qualities of infused grace mediating (which overcome the order of nature)."[21] What does this mean?

The word *infused* is used here to speak of sanctification, whereas Catholic theology uses the term to refer to justification. But why would Turretin use "infused" here? Given the predestination worldview of Reformed theology, this statement seems to describe a God who is working within believers to ensure the actualization of their eternal election through sanctification. If this is correct, then the word *infusion* (of grace) is an act of God compatible with His act in the eternal decree (since both are His decision to save). Because the word *infused* is not used in Scripture, it seems better to describe sanctification by terms found in Scripture. Of course, the eternal election as God's choice, regardless of human choice, is not in Scripture either (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapters 15–16).

15. Francis Turretin, *Institutes of Elenctic Theology* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 1994), 2:633 (16.1.6).
16. Ibid., 2:637–639 (16.2.3–5).
17. Ibid., 2:647; see also 2:646–647 (16.3.1–4).
18. Ibid., 2:656–659 (16.4.1–13).
19. Ibid., 2:689 (17.1.1).
20. For Turretin, it takes the life beyond to perfect sanctification, *Institutes*, 2:691 (17.1.10).
21. Ibid., 2:708 (17.4.10).

HERMAN BAVINCK (1854–1921)

Bavinck believes salvation is "fully trinitarian" and emphasizes the "distinct work of the Holy Spirit. What Christ gained for us must be applied to and in us in justification and sanctification." The benefits of grace are not infused into members through the church and sacraments (Catholic view) but are fruits in which "Christ first restores our relationship to God, then renews us after God's image."[22] Bavinck focuses on the heavenly ministry of Christ where He "continues his prophetic, priestly, and royal activity,"[23] which is far better than the Catholic focus on earthly priests, and Christ as present in the Church as an extension of His incarnation (almost as if the ascension had not taken place).

Christ's work on earth is completed, and nothing can be added to it. That work constitutes the benefits to be applied. The work of application is likened to the work of creation by the Father and redemption by the Son, for the Spirit's work is a "total re-creation."[24] Notice the Trinitarian emphasis, which means that humans no more contribute to applying the benefits than they contributed to creation and redemption. This Trinitarian focus is opposed to the church focus (Catholic theology) in the application of salvation. Also Christ, not the Spirit, is the meriting cause of salvation, for just as Christ brought glory to the Father, the Spirit brings glory to Christ.[25]

Infused grace in Catholic theology regenerates, justifies, and sanctifies a person through an elevation of human nature above that of angels, because it is divinized. Beyond the forgiveness of sin, the elevation of human nature is the primary purpose of infused grace, which equips persons to perform supernatural acts that deserve merit. The Reformation rejected this Neoplatonic mysticism and returned to Scripture where grace is opposed to sin, not to nature. For "the image of God is not a superadded gift" but "the essence of humanity."[26] Even when Reformed theology uses the same word as Catholic theology (e.g.,"infused," as Turretin did), it has a different meaning, for Reformed salvation restores the image of God and never something more.[27]

22. Herman Bavinck, *Sin and Salvation in Christ*, vol. 3 in *Reformed Dogmatics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2006), 489–491.
23. Ibid., 570.
24. Ibid., 571.
25. Ibid., 572.
26. Ibid., 576–577.
27. Ibid., 578. Bavinck used the word "infuses" with respect to the Holy Spirit; see *Sin and Salvation in Christ*, vol. 3 in *Reformed Dogmatics*, 580, 582.

KARL BARTH (1886–1968)

Barth mentions that there are few Catholic theologians in the Council of Trent who heard and understood the thinking of the Reformers:

> The decree itself is theologically a clever and in many respects a not unsympathetic document which has caused superficial Protestant readers to ask whether there might not be something to say for it. But if we study it more closely it is impossible to conceal the fact that not even the remotest impression seems to have been made upon its exponents by what agitated the Reformers or, for that matter, Paul himself in this whole question of faith and works. Even more depressing is the reason for this lack of understanding: that what was not only to the Reformers but to Paul the climax of justification in its character as a divine work for man was to them a completely unknown quantity. Otherwise how could they possibly have described the death of Christ as the mere *causa meritoria* of justification (c. 7), transferring justification itself into the sphere of the Church which controls sacramental grace on the one hand, and of the believer who makes use of the Church's means of grace on the other?[28]

Barth believes that justification and sanctification are found only in Jesus Christ, and not in the church and its sacraments. Barth thinks that Trent's doctrine of justification is no better than what Paul called "different gospel" (Gal. 1:6), and notes that some Protestant doctrines of justification are too Tridentine[29] (compare this with chapter 17 on the continuing influence of Trent). The later writings of Barth reveal that he considers the Catholic view as an "infusion of supernatural powers," the existential view as a "revival of ancient Pelagianism," and the Reformed view (Luther) as dictating that a person is "judged afresh and with grace, but...is in himself unaltered." Barth rejects all three, since "none of them makes it clear how there comes into being the Christian, the man who responds to God's faithfulness with faithfulness, the man who as a free subject is God's true partner in the covenant of grace."[30] I believe that human freedom and covenant partnership are more compatible with a relational Trinity than with any other view.

Catholic theologian Hans Küng's 1964 book *Justification of Karl Barth and a Catholic Reflection* argues that there is no difference between the Protestant and Catholic views on justification.[31] Whereas Barth refutes the Council of Trent's focus on the subjective aspect of justification,[32] Küng points to the objective justification mentioned at Trent (as a prelude to the doctrine of justification). This

28. Barth, *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, vol. 4, pt. 1, in *Church Dogmatics*, 624–625.
29. Ibid., vol. 4, pt. 1, 626.
30. Ibid., vol. 4, pt. 4, 5.
31. See Hans Küng, *Justification: The Doctrine of Karl Barth and a Catholic Reflection* (New York: Thomas Nelson, 1964), 194, 213, 215, 221, 232–233.
32. Barth, *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, vol. 4, pt. 1, in *Church Dogmatics*, 624–626; *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, vol. 4, pt. 2, 497–498.

does have much to commend itself as Evangelical. Küng believes that God's declaration "you are just" (Protestant view) includes "making just" (Catholic view).[33]

It is true that for Barth justification and sanctification are already objectively and fully realized in Jesus Christ. From this Christological perspective (which Barth focuses on throughout his *Church Dogmatics*),[34] there is no order of one as prior to the other (*ordo salutis*), so he says either can be first or second ("the *Prius* is also the *Posterius* and vice versa"), for there is a "unity of the two moments and aspects, the one grace of the one Jesus Christ is at work."[35] Note how this is the same as Calvin's statement: "Though we distinguish between them, they are both inseparably comprehended in Christ. Would ye then obtain justification in Christ? You must previously possess Christ. But you cannot possess him without being made a partaker of his sanctification: for Christ cannot be divided."[36]

A case can be made that there is a similarity between Trent and Barth/Calvin, in that justification and sanctification are inseparable. Küng refers to the "total history of dogma" of Catholic thinking[37] in which he finds Catholics voicing some of the same concerns on this topic as Protestants, but these do not seem to be reflected in official Catholic statements. However, as pointed out before and is necessary to repeat, there is a great distinction between (1) a *forensic declaration* focus (Protestant) and (2) a *being made righteous* focus as the basis of continuing justification with works that are meritorious (Catholic). Küng knows that "infused virtues" were inherited from Aristotle in the Middle Ages[38]—a nonbiblical addition to Catholic theology. (One should not overlook all the Catholic traditions mentioned in chapter 17, which have no biblical support but seem to be of little, if any, consequence to Küng.)

There is one exception: Barth and Catholic theology teach that salvation is objectively supplied in Jesus Christ for all humans, a biblical truth not found in Lutheran and Calvinistic predestination. Hans Küng says justification "is essentially *ecclesiological* in character" (refers to Eph. 3:9–10),[39] whereas Barth says justification is Christological, for justification and sanctification are a simultaneous reality in the double journey of the divine and human natures in Jesus

33. Küng, *Justification*, 213.

34. Within the reality of Jesus Christ, there is a simultaneous double movement of the Son of God going into the far country, and the homecoming of the Son of Man (*humanitas*, not *homo*; humanity, not one person), typified in the parable of Luke 15:11–32.

35. Barth, *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, vol. 4, pt. 2, in *Church Dogmatics*, 508–509.

36. John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion* (London: James Clarke, 1962), 2:99 (3.16.1). For Barth, theological reality (objectively) is Jesus Christ alone (Christomonism that negates the appropriate place of humans in theology), whereas for Calvin the benefit of objective salvation (subjectively) is union with Christ.

37. Küng, *Justification*, 215, 218, 221.

38. Ibid., 216.

39. Ibid., 225.

Christ.[40] One should not overlook Barth's letter to Küng in which he mentions major differences between them.[41] (See chapter 17 for more on the differences between Barth's beliefs and Catholic teaching.)

ALISTER McGRATH'S ASSESSMENT

We now briefly look at Alister McGrath's 2007 book, *Christianity's Dangerous Idea: The Protestant Revolution, A History from the Sixteenth Century to the Twenty-First*. The book's major focus is on biblical interpretation by individuals instead of by a single church authority; he considers this paradigm shift a dangerous idea that has resulted in the pluralism of Protestantism.[42] However, one should not forget the pluralism in the Catholic church with its various religious orders (Augustinians, Dominicans, Franciscans, and Jesuits, just to name a few). Nor should one forget that uniformity is a dangerous antidote to unity. McGrath traces a number of factors that led to the Protestant Reformation, for some leaders were not moved by the doctrine of justification by faith, as was Luther.

McGrath rightly asks, If justification is the reckoning of Christ's righteousness to believers, what is the point of purgatory?[43] The doctrine also renders "the cult of the saints redundant."[44] "If Luther was right about justification—and his critics insisted that he was not—then the conceptual glue binding the [Roman] church's rites, ceremonies, institutions, and ideas was fatally weakened. He [Luther] had shown that the complex edifice of salvation, largely constructed during the Middle Ages, lacked a solid foundation."[45]

At the beginning of the twentieth century, Pentecostalism was launched; today its members number a half billion members. Many modern Protestant churches don't see any reason to be defined by the past.[46] McGrath claims that more Protestants become Catholics than vice versa, because of "evangelicalism's lack of historical roots and institutional continuity with the New Testament."[47] (I wonder

40. Barth, *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, vol. 4, pt. 2, in *Church Dogmatics*, 505.

41. Küng, *Justification*, lxx.

42. According to McGrath, the dangerous new idea of Protestantism is that all believers have the right to interpret the Bible for themselves, yet this has led to multiple interpretations. The concept of the priesthood of all believers helped in this effort, questioning the right of the priestly magisterium as the sole authority to interpret. There are a number of changes to be considered: (1) Possibly soon the Protestant majority will come to an end in the United States; (2) Protestantism has changed, decisively and possibly irreversibly, in the last fifty years (e.g., Pentecostalism, seeker-sensitive churches); (3) Protestantism is growing rapidly in Asia, Africa, and Latin America.

43. McGrath, *Christianity's Dangerous Idea : The Protestant Revolution—A History from the Sixteenth Century to the Twenty-First* (New York: HarperCollins, 2007), 44.

44. Ibid., 250.

45. Ibid., 44.

46. Ibid., 403.

47. Ibid., 412.

if McGrath factored into this the number of Catholics becoming Protestants in South American countries.) In a criticism of Luther, McGrath writes:

> His [Luther's] fundamental conviction was that the church of his day had lost sight of some fundamental themes of the Christian gospel. After all, the theology he had been taught at Erfurt now seemed to him to be heretical, amounting to the idea of "'justification by works"—the notion that humanity can achieve its own salvation by its moral or religious achievements. Yet Luther is open to criticism here, in that he appears to have extrapolated from his own local situation to that of the entire Christian church throughout Europe.[48]

Earlier in his book McGrath points out that Luther responded to indulgences.[49] Indulgences were cause enough for reform, because they were a blatant repudiation of the gospel's free gift of salvation.[50] This at least seems to be far more than a local concern, and it gets to the heart of Catholic theology—the replacing of the divine with the human. This seems to me to be the fundamental issue that Luther faced, and deserves to be considered the primary reason for the Reformation. It was a fight for the true gospel. It seems reasonable that any effort to reintroduce the gospel would include justification by faith alone, to counter the Catholic emphasis on salvation by human works.

Contribution of the New Perspectives on Paul Movement[51] to Justification by Faith

The New Perspectives on Paul (NPP) was one of the movements examined in my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 12 (the reader may want to read that chapter before proceeding). Here we will focus only on highlights in order to provide the context for understanding the movement's impact on beliefs about justification by faith.

Up to this point, we have presented the biblical view on justification, and found both the Catholic and Protestant views to be less than the biblical view of Christ as the sinner's sole justification by faith, either through: (a) mixing justification and sanctification (Protestant); or (b) placing sanctification before ongoing justification with its merits (Catholic). We have noted that imputation and declarative righteousness are consistent with Christ as the sole righteousness of humans (Protestant). By contrast, infused sanctification leads to earning justification by merits (Catholic). Now we come to a new school of thinking in

48. Ibid., 58.

49. McGrath, *Christianity's Dangerous Idea*, 45–49.

50. David S. Schaff, *The Middle Ages 1294–1517*, vol. 6 in *History of the Christian Church* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1960), 761–762.

51. Because of space limitations, we will not take up New Covenant Theology, Federal Vision, and Auburn Theology, which are similar to the NPP. For these, see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 12.

New Testament studies, the New Perspectives on Paul—which has materially affected the discussion on justification by faith for those who are its adherents.

No school of thought since the sixteenth-century Reformation has had such a profound impact on Pauline studies as the New Perspectives on Paul (NPP),[52] contributed by E. P. Sanders, N. T. Wright, and James D. G. Dunn. Donald Hagner has said that NPP may be called "a Copernican revolution in Pauline studies."[53] D. A. Carson says that "the new perspective is the reigning paradigm."[54] Even though there had been other books before Sanders which shared his major thesis, his was the turning point because it was the first book about ancient Jews following the Jewish Holocaust.[55] The post-Holocaust era found Christians opposing the age-old perspective that Judaism was a very legalistic system of works-based righteousness (from Ferdinand Webster and others). W. Bousset had been influenced by this old view, and he taught and influenced Rudolph Bultmann, who became one of the most influential New Testament scholars in the twentieth century.

Just like traditional New Testament scholars, Rudolph Bultmann considered Judaism to be a legalistic religion, totally devoid of grace, and he believed that Paul was totally opposed to Judaism. In contrast to an earlier conception of Paul in corporate or cultic terms, Bultmann believed Paul focused on the individual. This was undoubtedly influenced by Bultmann's preoccupation with existentialism (personal existence). As a Lutheran, Bultmann supported forensic justification in Paul's theology, yet this was not an inner change but an "eschatological reality" experienced by the believer. The NPP was a response to Bultmann: They rejected the view that the Jews were legalistic, and had a much kinder view of them and their faith. What follows are a few ideas presented by major NPP players.

Albert Schweitzer rejected justification by faith as central to Paul, accepting rather "being in Christ." Schweitzer also presented Paul as fully Jewish, and not persuaded by Hellenism.[56] Nevertheless, many scholars didn't follow Schweitzer, instead believing that Paul gained much from Hellenism rather than from Judaism. W. P. Davis's 1948 *Paul and Rabbinic Judaism* "marks a watershed in the history of scholarship on Paul and Judaism,"[57] and paved the way for the NPP because it was the first to present Paul's positive acceptance of Judaism and the

52. See Seyoon Kim, *Paul and The New Perspective: Second Thoughts on the Origin of Paul's Gospel* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2002), xiv.

53. Donald A. Hagner, "Paul and Judaism: Testing the New Perspective," in Peter Stuhlmacher, *Revisiting Paul's Doctrine of Justification: A Challenge to the New Perspective* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2001), 75.

54. D. A. Carson, "Summaries and Conclusions" in *The Complexities of Second Temple Judaism*, vol. 1 in *Justification and Variegated Nomism* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2001), 505.

55. Hagner, "Paul and Judaism," in Stuhlmacher, *Revisiting Paul's Doctrine of Justification*, 76–77.

56. See Albert Schweitzer, *The Mysticism of Paul the Apostle* (New York: Seabury, 1968); *Paul and His Interpreters* (New York: MacMillan, 1950).

57. E. P. Sanders, *Paul and Palestinian Judaism: A Comparison of Patterns of Religion* (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1977), 7.

law, and the first to cast his conversion to Christianity as an embrace of "the full flowering of Judaism," not of "the antithesis of Judaism." For Davies, justification by faith was peripheral to the centrality of Christ in Paul's writings.[58] So Schweitzer and Davies turned away from justification by faith.

Krister Stendahl stated that justification by faith was Luther's focus, not Paul's.[59] He critiqued the introspective conscience of the West, which is not found in the East, in the Orthodox church, but is found in Augustine's *Confessions* and in Luther's struggle as an Augustinian monk. According to Stendahl, this was not Paul's struggle in his conversion, for he had a rugged relationship with the law prior to his change of mission to the Gentiles.[60] Stendahl did not consider Paul's Damascus road encounter with Christ to be a conversion experience, but a call comparable to God's calling Old Testament prophets, a call to go to the Gentiles. Stendahl also dismissed justification by faith as merely an Augustinian-Lutheran experience—not a biblical experience.

In 1971, Ernst Käsemann, student of Bultmann, posited that justification is central to Paul, and to salvation history.[61] Käsemann's view of justification was corporate (rather than individual) and participatory (which basically questioned its forensic reality). Käsemann said, "Nowhere else in Judaism is Hab 2:4 ['the just shall live by his faith,' KJV] seen in terms of attachment to a person."[62] He stated it again as "a truth which transcends the individual and is directed toward a new world." Here was a "primacy of christology over anthropology."[63] So both Stendahl and Käsemann differed on the personal experience of justification by faith taught in Scripture.

E. P. Sanders's 1977 *Paul and Palestinian Judaism* launched the NPP movement. Sanders studied a "great bulk" of the surviving Palestinian material from 200 B.C. to 200 A.D.[64] From his study he came to the conclusion that, in Palestinian Judaism of the late Second Temple period and the succeeding century, election got a

58. W. D. Davies, *Paul and Rabbinic Judaism: Some Rabbinic Elements in Pauline Theology* (London: S.P.C.K. 1965, 1st ed. 1948), 222–223.

59. See Krister Stendahl, "The Apostle Paul and the Introspective Conscience of the West" in *Paul Among Jews and Gentiles: and Other Essays* (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1976), 78–96. First published in English in the *Harvard Theological Review* 56 (1963): 199–215; cf. John G. Gager, *Reinventing Paul* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000).

60. Ir is alleged that Paul was interprered by the Reformers rather than Paul's being interpreted by Paul. For example, from Augustine's *Confessions* ro Luther's struggle, the focus was on the quest of a troubled conscience, which was read back into Paul's experience. By contrast, Paul was zealously persecuting Christians because He believed this was God's will (see 1 Cor. 15:9b; 1 Tim. 1:13–16). He was filled with self-righteousness (Phil. 3:3–7), not self-condemnation. His Damascus Road encounter with the risen Christ began a revelation of God's will for His life, a call to become God's minister to the Gentiles (Acts 9:3–18).

61. Ernst Käsemann, *Commentary on Romans* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1980), 21–32; "Justification and Salvation History in the Epistle to the Romans," in *Perspectives on Paul* (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1971), 60–78.

62. Ibid., 32.

63. Ibid., 93, both quotes.

64. Sanders, *Paul and Palestinian Judaism*, 18.

person into the covenant, and commandment keeping was a response to this prior election.[65] "The Rabbis did not have the Pauline/Lutheran problem of 'works-righteousness.'"[66] The bottom line was that the rabbis understood obedience to be a response to God's love for Israel.[67] Sanders termed this "covenantal nomism."[68] He then concluded that because covenant nomism was so pervasive during the four centuries he studied (200 B.C.–200 A.D.) that it was "the basic *type* of religion known by Jesus and presumably by Paul."[69] In other words, for four hundred years, including the first two centuries of the Christian era, the Jews kept the law of God as a loving response to their having been elected covenant members.

For N. T. Wright, righteousness is not about imputed or imparted righteousness to humans but God's own righteousness (His covenant faithfulness). "Legal fiction" is a well-known Catholic analysis of imputed righteousness (merely reckoned to be righteous, when not in reality, as in Luther's theology). So at this point, Wright seems to be close to the Catholic view.[70] Wright says Paul's gospel creates the church, whereas justification defines and sustains it.[71] So Wright dismisses the important distinction between imputed (Protestant) and imparted (Catholic) righteousness in justification by faith.

James Dunn claims that behind the Catholic-Protestant debate (make righteous and declare righteous, respectively) is the more fundamental issue of Christianity's relation to Judaism, or Paul's gospel's relation to his ancestral religion. Traditional New Testament scholarship considered that Paul opposed Judaism as Luther opposed the medieval church. [72] But the NPP claims that Palestinian Judaism was grace based, and that works were merely a response to grace to maintain their covenant membership rather than earn merit. In this new context, justification by faith is the way Gentiles can be as acceptable to God as Jews. This is "one of the most vigorous debates in current NT studies."[73]

The immediate context of justification by faith is "the righteousness of God" (Rom. 1:17). In Hebrew the word "righteousness" is a "relational concept." For Dunn, God created humans, gave a call to Abraham, and chose Israel, and in so doing was righteous, and understood as faithful. So Dunn considers that the verb *dikaioō* means both "make righteous" and "reckon righteous," which practically

65. Ibid., 85.

66. Ibid., 100.

67. Ibid., 100; see also 100–104, 106.

68. Ibid., 422.

69. Ibid., 426.

70. N. T. Wright, *What Paul Really Said: Was Paul of Tarsus the Real Founder of Christianity?* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1997), 100–103.

71. Ibid., "defines," 151; "sustains," 158.

72. James D. G. Dunn, *The Theology of Paul the Apostle* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1998), 336–338.

73. Dunn, *The Theology of Paul the Apostle*, 340, 354–355.

makes the Catholic/Protestant debates pointless.[74] The NPP, like liberal theology before it, is rooted in historical-critical methods, which are much more interested in alleged sources, than in what Paul himself says. Why should Second Temple Judaism be the hermeneutical basis for understanding Paul, when *sola Scriptura* looks to the Old Testament, and Scripture interprets Scripture?

Biblical Understanding of Sanctification by Faith

Sanctification is a work of God: "May God himself, the God of peace, sanctify you through and through. May your whole spirit, soul and body be kept blameless at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ. The one who calls you is faithful, and he will do it" (1 Thess. 5:23–24). For "when the kindness and love of God our Savior appeared, he saved us, not because of righteous things we had done, but because of his mercy. He saved us through the washing of rebirth and renewal by the Holy Spirit, whom he poured out on us generously through Jesus Christ our Savior, so that, having been justified by his grace, we might become heirs having the hope of eternal life" (Tit. 3:4–7). The Holy Spirit restores God's image within (Rom. 8:1–10), imparting the fruits of the Spirit (Gal. 5:22–23).

Sanctification is an indwelling righteousness present through the indwelling Christ, who said, "Peace I leave with you; my peace I give you. I do not give to you as the world gives. Do not let your hearts be troubled and do not be afraid" (John 14:27). The Christian worldview is contrary to the popular evolutionary worldview. The latter view has humans coming into being by chance, without any meaning or purpose, which is compounded by the postmodern worldview with its rampant relativism. And so humans find themselves in a struggle for survival, where the fittest get to the top through defeating others, where life is empty because it is filled with self-centeredness, where peace has never taken up residence.

Yet according to the Christian worldview, humans have been created by God for fellowship with Him, and relationship and God's peace within are gifts through the indwelling Christ. This is the gospel that the Reformers proclaimed. The Catholic works-based system is more in keeping with the struggle inherent in a non-Christian worldview. There is fear in the hearts of unbelievers, and lack of assurance in some Catholic believers, for both are in the process of meriting their own salvation, rather than accepting the gift of salvation that the gospel offers.

The process of sanctification is an ongoing relationship with Christ who restores the damaged image of God within (2 Cor. 3:18). There is a difference between legalism and love. In the temple the Pharisee thanked God

74. Ibid., 341–344.

that he was not like other men (and certainly not like the tax collector in front of him), and he enumerated the good he had done (and the evil he had avoided). By contrast, the tax collector didn't focus on what he had done; rather, he *focused upon God*, and pled for mercy as a sinner. The humble tax collector, not the proud Pharisee, "went home justified" (Luke 18:9–14). As Calvin commented, "Hence we may see how highly our humility is valued by the Lord: our breast cannot receive his mercy until deprived completely of all opinion of its own worth."[75]

Salvation is freedom from rebellion and the restoration of a broken relationship with God. Out of utter gratitude there flows love for God in willing obedience to do His will (which has nothing to do with merit). For the gift of God's saving love has already been received and does not have to be earned. Merit focuses on the individual's striving, whereas sanctification by faith is an ever-deepening dependence upon Christ. The difference between striving and dependence is the difference between ritual and relationship. Ritual is worthless; God has no part in it. God created humans for relationship, and salvation is a restoration of that relationship with a relational God.

Conclusion

Jesus Christ, the only Savior of humans, urges people to "seek first his kingdom and his righteousness" (Matt. 6:33a), for there is no other kingdom and no other righteousness. Christ lived, died, and intercedes as our only mediator (1 Tim. 2:5) at God's right hand in heaven's sanctuary (Heb. 1:1–3; 4:14–16). Christ opposed the traditions that religious leaders imposed upon His contemporaries (Matt. 15:6). Jewish religion, as taught by the rabbis, had become a burden with its many rules and regulations. So Christ invited the people to come to Him and find rest, for His yoke is easy and His burden is light (Matt. 11:28). Religion was a money-making racket that required the compulsory buying of sacrificial animals at the temple using temple currency purchased at a high exchange rate. Christ threw the money changers out of the temple, telling them, "You are thieves!" and reclaiming the temple as a house of prayer for all people, for salvation is a gift. Because of this, the religious leaders sought to kill Him (Matt. 21:13–14; Mark 11:12–18; Luke 19:45–48; John 2:12–16). The problem with the Jewish religion was that its multiplied human traditions buried the simplicity of salvation's plan and robbed the people of the peace offered in the gospel. Christ revolted against man-made religious activities; He cared for the humble and the poor, for whom the religious leaders had no sympathy.

75. Calvin, *Institutes*, 2:66 (3.12.7).

The gospel was later buried under man-made religious activities in the medieval Catholic system of works, until Luther and others discovered the freedom of the gospel. The selling of indulgences[76] infuriated Luther because it taxed the poor to gain revenue, much as the priests had done in the Jerusalem temple. In fact, Luther referred to the Jerusalem temple in a letter (September 6, 1520) addressed to Pope Leo X (a prelude to the "The Freedom of a Christian" document) saying that the Roman church "has become the most licentious den of thieves (Matt. 21:13)."[77]

Would Christ have thrown out the moneymakers again in the sixteenth century? There's no question that the gospel is much simpler than it was understood to be during the Second Temple and medieval periods of history. Both periods were dark ages that hid the light of the gospel from weary and worn believers, so much so that Christ the light of the world was unknown in the days of His incarnation and often forgotten in His mediation in heaven's sanctuary in medieval times (and since). Both aspects of the gospel (the life and death of Jesus, and His present priestly mediation) lay hidden beneath the rubbish of human traditions. For most weary pilgrims, the light had gone out and hope was extinguished.

But light pierced the dark night as Reformers proclaimed Christ the "light of the world" (John 8:12), and for the first time believers could say Christ Jesus is "to us wisdom from God, righteousness [*dikaiosynē*] and sanctification [*hagiasmos*] and redemption [*apolytrōsis*]" (1 Cor. 1:30, ESV). No longer were believers burdened with their own works. They responded to the invitation to fix their "eyes on Jesus, the pioneer and perfecter of faith. For the joy set before him he endured the cross, scorning its shame, and sat down at the right hand of the throne of God" (Heb. 12:2). Their look was upward, not inward, as they reveled in the light of the gospel. In all His splendor and majesty, at the eternal throne of God, resides the living Jesus Christ, with thousands of angels. The glory that surrounds the throne is indescribable, so awesome is the sight, and beyond anything this world has ever seen. Here is the source of all life, the omnipotent, omnipresent, omniscient relational Trinity working out the plan of salvation they made long before they created humans. They know what they are doing, and they alone can save, as they alone can do the creative work of salvation.

At the throne of God in heaven, Jesus has opened up a new and living way to God that rejects all human means of mediation (priestly or sacramental). Jesus Christ, second Person of the Trinity, eternal God who also became a human,

76. Indulgences financed military campaigns and the construction of cathedrals, McGrath, *Christianity's Dangerous Idea*, 47.

77. Martin Luther, *Three Treatises* (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1973, 1st ed. 1960), 268–269.

the One who lived a perfect human life, and died a once-for-all sacrificial death, rejects all other works to earn salvation. His perfect life and sufficient death cry out "It is finished!" He died once for all (Heb. 9:26). No more work is necessary, and no more is possible. It is in this context that we need to study the meaning of justification by faith.

The gospel means Christ made the ultimate sacrifice to save humans: "Christ also suffered once for sins, the righteous for the unrighteous" (1 Pet. 3:18a), slain as it were from the foundation of the world (Rev. 13:8b). The gospel is unfolded in history through the everlasting covenant, which includes the old and new covenants (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapters 9–11). The gospel is the plan of salvation from the relational Trinity, and has objective and subjective aspects. Jesus Christ in His life and death has provided a perfect life *and* a sufficient sacrifice for humans, and sinners need both. The gospel involves a great exchange, in which Christ takes the place of humans in His living and dying, gifting humans with His life and His death. This is the objective side of the gospel.

Through the Holy Spirit the benefits of Christ's life and death are imparted to humans. The gospel includes the imputation and impartation of Christ, so humans can say with Paul: "I have been crucified with Christ and I no longer live, but Christ lives in me. The life I live in the body, I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me" (Gal. 2:20). As Peter Toon suggests, the "key to understanding *ṣdq* [Heb. righteousness] is to think of relationships"[78] which involves being declared righteous (Abraham, Gen. 15:16) and being righteous (Abraham, Gen. 18:19); the first is forensic justification, the second ethical sanctification.

Study Questions

1. In the battle against secularism, why is the attempt to unify Roman Catholic and Evangelical thinking on justification the wrong decision?
2. What is Turretin's contribution to the debate on justification?
3. In what ways is Bavinck's soteriology an improvement over Catholic soteriology?
4. Why is McGrath wrong to claim that Luther's concerns were only local?
5. On what basis can we conclude that proponents of the New Perspectives on Paul are wrong about law keeping in Second Temple Judaism?
6. Is Hans Küng right when he says that Barth's views on justification are no different from Catholic views on the matter?

78. Peter Toon, *Justification and Sanctification* (Westchester, IL: Crossway, 1983), 18.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Roman-Protestant Divide: "Evangelicals and Catholics Together" Documents

Purpose

1. Document that there have been changes in the relationship between Catholics and Evangelicals.
2. Give evidence that Evangelicals and Catholics are working toward unity in mission.
3. Indicate that Evangelical theology has substantively changed but Catholic theology has not.
4. Show that there remains a significant theological division between Catholics and Evangelicals.
5. Note the global plans held by the Roman Catholic church, and show how ecumenism is compatible with these plans.

Summary

In the sixteenth century, the Reformers protested against the Roman Catholic works for salvation. In the Council of Trent (1545–1563), the Catholic church replied with anathemas against the Protestant ideas of salvation. During this era in church history, both sides saw the other as the enemy.

A new era began with the World Council of Churches (1948) and the Vatican II Council (1962–1965). It continued with the Evangelical and Catholics Together (ECT) meetings and documents (1994–2003) that identify a common ground on which to meet a new enemy: secularism Differences, though noted, are treated as irrelevant; the focus is on the common ground shared by Catholics and Evangelicals. Yet this united front against secularism ignores the fact that unity not based on truth is the worst kind of secularism, because it is in the churches.

Today Protestant scholars speak about the decline of Protestantism, for they have moved Rome-ward, making concessions, and the truth about salvation has suffered in the process. Catholic theology, meanwhile, still speaks of infused justification so justification grows within the individual, allowing him or her to earn merit. While Protestant theology has always presented Christ's imputed righteousness, Catholic theology calls this "legal fiction," because those imputed are declared righteous when they are not. It is not fiction but a fact, because believers are "in Christ" or in a saving relationship with Him—that is the reality. Moreover, impartation takes place in sanctification, which is also relational.

While Protestants have changed, evidence indicates that the Catholic church has not changed doctrinally. Even without anathemas, Trent is still influential. In fact, the Catholic church has added further distinctive doctrines since Trent, such as the infallibility of the pope when he speaks ex cathedra, and the elevation of Mary in the plan of salvation.

In spite of all the attempts to find unity between Evangelical and Catholic theology on salvation, the two systems are mutually exclusive. Catholic theology adds many human works to God's free gift of salvation, thereby calling it into question. Further, the Catholic church seeks union in order to gain global leadership (more will be said about this in my *Systematic Theology,* volume 4).

Outline

I. Introduction
- A. World Council of Churches (WCC) (1948–2006)
- B. Vatican Council II (1962–1965)

II. "Evangelicals and Catholics Together" (ECT) Documents
- A. ECT 1: The Christian Mission for the Third Millennium (1994)
- B. ECT 2: The Gift of Salvation (1997)
- C. ECT 3: Your Word in Truth (2002)
- D. ECT 4: The Communion of Saints (2003)

III. "Legal Fiction" Issue

IV. Catholics and Lutherans on Justification

V. Factors to Consider to Evaluate the Debate

VI. Pope Benedict XVI on Justification

VII. Is Trent Still Influential?

VIII. Beyond the ECT Declarations

IX. Importance of Justification by Faith: Protestant Opinions

X. Why Protestants Have Changed Their Views

XI. Conclusion

XII. Study Questions

Introduction

Before getting into the documents and evaluations, it may be appropriate to step back and briefly consider the historical context for the meetings now known as Evangelicals and Catholics Together (ECT). The ECT meetings were preceded by two important ecumenical organizations: the World Council of Churches (WCC) that began to meet in 1948, and the Second Vatican Council that ended in 1965.

WORLD COUNCIL OF CHURCHES (WCC) (1948–2006)

Ecumenism within the WCC is briefly noted here to provide context for the ECT meetings. It is important to be clear at the outset that the uniting of churches is an attempt to seek unity, not necessarily organic integration. This attempt to create unity began officially among Protestant churches in 1948. By 1961 officials from the Orthodox church were attending the third meeting of the WCC in New Delhi, India. One year before, on June 5, 1960, Pope John XXIII established the Secretariat for Promoting Christian Unity (now called the Pontifical Council for Promoting Christian Unity).[1] Pope John XXIII then called for the second Vatican Council (1962–1965) which convened between the third WCC New Delhi meeting and the fourth WCC Uppsala meeting in Sweden in 1968, when Catholics sent observers.[2]

Pope Paul VI visited the headquarters of the WCC in Geneva on June 10, 1969,[3] and Pope John Paul II visited on June 12, 1984,[4] indicating their interest in the WCC. However, the Catholic church is not a member of the WCC, nor are Evangelical churches. In fact, "It has been estimated that less than one-half of the non-Orthodox and non-Roman Catholic churches in the

1. See John Paul II, *Ut Unum Sint, The Encyclicals of John Paul II*, ed. J. Michael Miller, C.S.B. (Huntington, IN: Our Sunday Visitor, 1996), 925 (17.2, n30).
2. Ibid., 957 (2.69–2)
3. Ibid., 958 (2.71–1).
4. Ibid., 967 (3.88).

world belong to the WCC."[5] There were five more WCC meetings leading up to Porto Alegre, Brazil, in 2006. Since Vatican II, "relationships between the Roman Catholic Church and the WCC have strengthened. A joint working group between the two meets regularly to take into account past developments and to chart new areas of endeavor."[6] The nine WCC assemblies were all official meetings of leaders. By contrast, the ECT meetings were conducted by interested participants who did not officially represent their churches.

Overview of WCC Events and the Vatican Council II

Location	Date	Participants
Amsterdam, Holland	August 22–September 4, 1948	147 churches
Evanston, USA	August 15–31, 1954	161 churches
New Delhi, India	November 19–December 5, 1961 *Orthodox observers began to attend*	197 churches
	Vatican II 1962–1965	
Uppsala, Sweden	July 4–30, 1968 *Catholic observers began to attend*	235 churches
Nairobi, Kenya	November 23–December 10, 1975	285 churches
Vancouver, Canada	July 24–August 10, 1983	301 churches
Canberra, Australia	February 7–20, 1991	317 churches
Harare, Zimbabwe	December 3–14, 1998	339 churches
Porto Alegre, Brazil	February 14–23, 2006	348 churches

VATICAN COUNCIL II (1962–1965)

For the first time, the Catholic church held a Council that reached beyond its own community to Jews, the Orthodox, Protestants, and non-Christian religions. Never before had any of the previous Councils (twenty) been more than in-house events. Vatican II was the first Council to speak of its relationship with other churches and religions. In this sense it was an ecumenical Council, that took place in an ecumenical era, and followed the establishing of the new Vatican office, now the Secretariat for Promoting Christian Unity. Whereas the WCC focused on ecumenism among different churches, Vatican II had a global union in mind, desiring that "the whole human race may be

5. See William G. Rusch, "World Council of Churches," in *The Encyclopedia of Christianity*, ed. Erwin Fahlbusch (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1997), 5:763.
6. Ibid., 5:766.

brought into the unity of the family of God."[7] Thus Vatican II documents say that it is "[t]hrough the Church, we abide in Christ"[8]—and Christ's prayer for union (John 17) is allegedly fulfilled through the church. For, the church is "an instrument for the achievement of such union and unity."[9] Christ rules the church "through the Supreme Pontiff and the bishops."[10] Bishops "have therefore taken up the service of the community, presiding in place of God over the flock."[11] Hence, "the faithful must cling to their bishop."[12]

The introductory "Message to Humanity" given by the Fathers of the Vatican Council II, and endorsed by the pope, stated:

> We take great pleasure in sending to all men and nations a message concerning that well-being, love, and peace which were brought into the world by Christ Jesus, the Son of the living God, and entrusted to the Church. For this is the reason why, at the direction of the most blessed Pope John XXIII, we successors of the apostles have gathered here, joined in single-hearted prayer with Mary the Mother of Jesus, and forming one apostolic body headed by the successor of Peter.[13]

Vatican II affirmed, "After His Resurrection our Savior handed her [the church] over to Peter to be shepherded."[14] These statements claimed that Christ entrusted to the Catholic church ("Mystical Body of Christ")[15] a succession of apostles, with Peter as its head, and so apparently Vatican II believed that the church had been ordained by God to bring global unity. Thus Vatican II was an attempt to embrace the world in an ecumenical inclusiveness that gave recognition to other communities, even calling Christian groups "separated brethren,"[16] yet without yielding the belief that there is only one true church,[17] "the universal sacrament of salvation"[18]—and even stating that the legitimacy of other churches is dependent upon a relationship (however tenuous) with the Catholic church. *The Catechism of the Catholic Church*, published in 1994, declared, "Christ's Spirit uses these Churches and ecclesial

7. *The Documents of Vatican II*, ed. Walter M. Abbott (London: Geoffrey Chapman, 1967), 55 (1.2.28). This includes "the restoration of unity among all Christians" as "one of the Chief concerns," of *The Documents of Vatican II*, 341 (6.1.1).
8. *The Documents of Vatican II*, 19 (1.1.6). Cf., "In that body [the church as the mystical body of Christ], the life of Christ is poured into the believers, who, through the sacraments, are united in a hidden and real way to Christ who suffered and was glorified," *The Documents of Vatican II*, 20 (1.1.7).
9. Ibid., 15 (1.1.1).
10. Ibid., 33 (1.2.14).
11. Ibid., 40 (1.3.20).
12. Ibid., 52 (1.3.27).
13. Ibid., 3.
14. Ibid., 23 (1.1.8).
15. Ibid., 374 (7.1.2).
16. Ibid., 351 (6.2.7).
17. Ibid., 346 (6.1.4).
18. Ibid., 79 (1.7.43).

communities as means of salvation, whose power derives from the fullness of grace and truth that Christ has entrusted to the Catholic Church."[19]

The bottom line is this: from Rome's perspective, the contemporary uniting of churches is not merely a working together among some churches (WCC), but a step toward all the world (churches, religions, and the rest) uniting within the one Roman Catholic church (cf. Rev. 13:1–4). This global outreach represents an enormous change from the Inquisition, Crusades, and Council of Trent (1545–1563).

This change (*aggiornamento*) was welcomed by many, but some overlooked the unchanging nature of Catholic theology. In fact, it could be argued that the intent of all post-Vatican II ecumenical conferences has been to provide Rome an opportunity to advance Vatican II's global aspirations. This end game should be understood by Evangelical participants in the ECT dialogues.

"Evangelical and Catholics Together" (ECT) Documents

In this chapter we will examine contemporary attempts to bridge the gulf between Catholic and Protestant views, and then analyze the outcome. First we need to present highlights from Evangelicals and Catholics Together (ECT) documents. Given the extensive material involved in these documents, we will supply a representative example (not exhaustive in any sense, but rather, intended to be illustrative).

An important source book for ECT is the 1995 book *Evangelicals & Catholics Together: Toward a Common Mission* which presents the ECT 1 document, as well as commentary on it. This March 29, 1994, document ("Evangelicals and Catholics Together: The Christian Mission in the Third Millennium")[20] speaks about one Christ and one mission, and posits that "the first and chief responsibility of the church" is to proclaim the gospel,[21] without proselytizing.[22] There are many laudable aspirations laid out in the document—we cannot fault the intentions of those involved.

Of course, the unity of Christians is to be commended, if the unity is based upon truth. For Christ prayed for that kind of unity (John 17). For twenty-five years, ecumenical dialogues preceded the 1994 document, which clearly works from the premise that it is uniting Catholics and Evangelicals on the basis of truth.

19. *Catechism of the Catholic Church* (Liguori, MO: Liguori, 1994), 216 (819).
20. *Evangelicals & Catholics Together: Toward a Common Mission*, ed. Charles Colson and Richard John Neuhaus (Dallas, TX: Word, 1995).
21. Ibid., xv–xxiii (quote on xxiii).
22. Ibid., xxviii–xxx.

Many of God's children attend Catholic and Protestant churches. It is a joy to fellowship with such people, and we value their friendship. These Christians love God and are very precious to Him. The Adventist Theological Society is a regular part of the Evangelical Theological Society annual program, and has been for many years. We certainly agree that we have a common enemy in secularism—an enemy that can only be defeated by truth. God's final invitation, prior to Christ's return, will find many of us standing together, united in truth (Rev. 18:1–4).

Pope John Paul II, in his 1995 encyclical *Ut Unum Sint* (*That They May Be One*), speaks of the thirty years since Vatican II as "the first time in history that efforts on behalf of Christian unity have taken on such great proportions and have become so extensive."[23] John Paul II also calls those from the Reformation "brothers and sisters."[24] The Catholic and Evangelical study on justification, the doctrine that divided them in the sixteenth century, is a part of that ecumenism. The word *Together* in the title "Evangelicals and Catholics Together" focuses on the thrust of the documents—to find ways of working together in one mission to the world for the one Christ of Christians.

We will see that differences, though to some degree recognized, are not emphasized. Rather, common points of interest are seen as the cement that joins all Christians together as they fulfill the gospel commission to bring the good news to the world in the beginning of the third millennium. I have profound respect for Catholic and Protestant biblical values, and know that many believers are sincere in their attempts to become united, just as Christ prayed that they would. I want to be irenic but honest in attempting to evaluate what is going on in contemporary ecumenism. Ecumenism is taken up in my *Systematic Theology*, volume 4, so our major focus now is on issues that still divide Catholic and Protestant churches, including the doctrine of justification.

ECT 1:	"The Christian Mission for the Third Millennium"	March 1994
ECT 2:	"The Gift of Salvation"	December 1997
ECT 3:	"Your Word is Truth"	January 2002
ECT 4:	"The Communion of Saints"	March 2003

ECT 1: THE CHRISTIAN MISSION FOR THE THIRD MILLENNIUM (1994)

In a 1994 issue of the Catholic journal *First Things: A Monthly Journal of Religion and Public Life* is an article titled "Evangelicals and Catholics Together: The

23. John Paul II, *Ut Unum Sint, The Encyclicals of John Paul II*, 938 (2.41–1.41–2).
24. Ibid., 957 (2.68–2).

Christian Mission in the Third Millennium."[25] It states: "We together pray for the fulfillment of the prayer of Our Lord: 'May they all be one; as you, Father, are in me, and I in you, so also may they be in us, that the world may believe that you sent me.' (John 17). We together, Evangelicals and Catholics, confess our sins against the unity that Christ intends for all his disciples."[26] They concur that "the scandal of conflict between Christians obscures the scandal of the cross, thus crippling the one mission of the one Christ."[27] Within the one mission of the one Christ, they state, "We affirm together that we are justified by grace through faith because of Christ."[28] On the surface this seems to be biblical—and a welcome agreement.

In the 2005 book *Is the Reformation Over? An Evangelical Assessment of Contemporary Roman Catholicism*, Mark A. Noll and Carolyn Nystrom devote a chapter to "Evangelicals and Catholics Together."[29] There was much Evangelical criticism of ECT 1, particularly because it failed to express salvation as by grace *alone* through faith *alone*. The word *alone* was the contribution of the Reformation, dismissing all human means to salvation (as found in Catholic theology). ECT 2, in part, was a response to the criticism of ECT 1.[30] In a later *First Things* journal is a report on post-ECT study given to differences between Evangelicals and Catholics.[31] In 1996, it was "determined that further progress depended upon firm agreement on the meaning of salvation, and especially the doctrine of justification."[32]

ECT 2: THE GIFT OF SALVATION (1997)

After a full year of study, discussion, and prayer, a statement was released in New York City on October 6–7, 1997. It begins with John 3:16, which affirms that Christ is the Savior of the world, a truth that Calvinists may not be able to accept, because they believe Christ died for the elect alone. The statement admits that "serious differences" remain, but all agree that Jesus Christ is the Savior. They refer to biblical texts that Christ is the only Mediator between God and humans (1 Tim. 3:5) and that no one comes to the Father except through Christ (John 14:6; cf. 1 Pet. 3:18).[33] But how is this possible when Catholics believe that

25. Charles Colson and Richard John Neuhaus, "Evangelicals and Catholics Together: The Christian Mission in the Third Millennium," *First Things* 43 (May 1994): 15–22. This was published at the conclusion of a consultation that began in September 1992.
26. Ibid., 15.
27. Ibid., 16.
28. Ibid.
29. Mark A. Noll and Carolyn Nystrom, *Is the Reformation Over? An Evangelical Assessment of Contemporary Roman Catholicism* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2005): 151–184.
30. Noll and Nystrom, "Evangelical and Catholics Together," *Is the Reformation Over?*, 151–183. This chapter contributed to this segment.
31. "The Gift of Salvation," *First Things* 79 (January 1998): 20–23.
32. Ibid., 20.
33. Ibid., 21.

the church, Mary, and saints are also mediators between God and humans? Even though the statement says atonement was completed at the Cross, how does this agree with salvation by works and purgatory as necessary for atonement in Catholic theology? Evidently Catholics come to these texts and read into them their own traditions. In other words, the texts seem qualified by the interpretation of the church, rather than by Scripture interpreting Scripture.

What does the ECT statement say about justification? "In Justification, God, on the basis of Christ's righteousness alone, declares us to be no longer his rebellious enemies but to be his forgiven friends, and by virtue of his declaration it is so.... We understand that what we here affirm is in agreement with what the Reformation traditions have meant by justification by faith alone (*sola fide*)."[34] They admit there are differences between declarative righteousness and transformational righteousness, and mention purgatory and devotion to Mary as among further subjects to study.[35] But don't these differences call into question the supposed unity they pronounce in the document? Furthermore, when it comes to the gift of salvation through Christ alone, isn't this called into question by official Catholic theology which presents Mary and the saints as participants in human salvation? If Christ is the sole Mediator, why do believers need the church, saints, and Mary to mediate on their behalf? Also, because there are differences between declarative justification and transformational justification, how can justification be considered as a belief that unites Catholics and Evangelicals?

The end of the document declares: "As Evangelicals who thank God for the heritage of the Reformation and affirm with conviction its classic confessions, as Catholics who are conscientiously faithful to the teaching of the Catholic Church, and as disciples together of the Lord Jesus Christ who recognize our debt to our Christian forbears and our obligations to our contemporaries and those who will come after us, we affirm our unity in the Gospel that we have here professed."[36] Note that Evangelicals believe in the biblical heritage of the Reformation and Catholics believe in the traditions of the Church. This is what divided them in the sixteenth-century Reformation, so wouldn't these differences still divide them, in spite of their saying that they believe the same gospel?

ECT 2 states, "Justification is central to the scriptural account of salvation, and its meaning has been much debated between Protestants and Catholics. We agree that justification is not earned by any good works or merits of our own; it is entirely God's gift, conferred through the Father's sheer graciousness, out of the love that he bears us in his Son, who suffered on our behalf and rose from

34. Ibid.
35. Ibid., 22.
36. Ibid.

the dead for our justification."[37] Although this seems to be an improvement over ECT 1, and in agreement with Scripture, we need to be reminded that the official Catholic view of justification is an infusion (not the Protestant impartation), and the infusion enables the recipient to merit further justification.

Pope John Paul II's encyclical *Ut Unum Sint*, based on Christ's prayer for Christian unity, gives insight into how differences are to be evaluated: "The examination of such disagreements has two essential points of reference: Sacred Scripture and the great Tradition of the Church. Catholics have the help of the Church's living Magisterium."[38] The inclusion of tradition, which is considered to be equal in authority with Scripture (see Vatican II),[39] means the Catholic church uses human ideas along with divine revelation in Scripture. How can those who believe in *sola Scriptura* (Scripture alone) accept resolution of differences based merely on human ideas that are often contrary to Scripture?

ECT 3: YOUR WORD IN TRUTH (2002)

There are obvious differences between Protestants who place Scripture above the church and Catholics who place the church above Scripture. Catholics believe in a living tradition which adds to or takes away from Scripture, so that tradition is at least equal to Scripture. For Protestants to find common ground with Catholics, they must ignore the role of tradition, as well as the Catholic magisterium as the sole interpreter of Scripture. The above facts are vital because true Protestantism believes in *sola Scriptura*, where Scripture interprets Scripture.

Charles Colson (Protestant) and Richard John Neuhaus (Catholic), who organized the meetings that led to the four ECT documents, also edited the 2002 book *Your Word Is Truth*, which, among other things, agreed that the phrase "Word of God" is pre-eminently Jesus Christ.[40] Yet the title *Your Word Is Truth* cannot mean *Catholic Tradition Is Truth*, because the Catholic tradition posits the sacramental work of the church and the intercession of Mary and saints to obtain salvation, which are human additions that question the biblical truth that Christ is the only Savior (1 Tim. 2:5). In other words, the official Catholic understanding of Scripture discounts the unofficial ECT 3 document. How can papal infallibility,[41] the alleged re-presentation of Christ

37. "The Gift of Salvation," *Christianity Today* (December 8, 1997): 36, quoted in Noll and Nystrom, *Is the Reformation Over?*, 159–160.

38. John Paul II, *Ut Unum Sint*, *The Encyclicals of John Paul II*, 937.

39. "Consequently, it is not from sacred Scripture alone that the Church draws her certainty about everything which has been revealed. Therefore both sacred tradition and sacred scripture are to be accepted and venerated with the same sense of devotion and reverence," *The Documents of Vatican II*, 117 (2.2.9).

40. See Charles Colson and Richard John Neuhaus, eds., *Your Word Is Truth* (Grand Rapids, MI: 2002), 1–8.

41. Infallibility was even questioned by Catholic theologian Hans Küng in *Infallible: An Inquiry*, trans. Edward Quinn (Garden City, NY: Image Books, 1972, Ger. ed. 1970).

in the Eucharist, and the numerous changes made to God's Ten Commandments (Exod. 20:1–17)[42] be the same as *Your Word Is Truth*? For these Catholic traditions replace the truths of God's Word, and thus replace Jesus Christ, the living Word of God.

ECT 4: THE COMMUNION OF SAINTS (2003)

This document was published in another edition of *First Things*.[43] Communion concerns union of beliefs as well as union in fellowship. Are Catholics and Protestants experiencing both? There are differences between Protestants and Catholics when it comes to the saints. One big hurdle is the Catholic belief in purgatory, which encourages human intercession: Some believers go to purgatory; then on the basis of the works of others, their time there can be shortened, and they can then go to heaven. This is a second-chance kind of theology, which shares some similarity to the second chance for believers left behind after the Rapture, who during the tribulation can get ready for heaven. Beyond these similarities, major differences remain. To name a few: Protestants do not believe in purgatory, and there is a difference of opinion about the number of sacraments necessary for salvation (two for Protestants and seven for Catholics). As well, communion is impossible for Protestants in terms of sharing in the Catholic mass where the priest allegedly makes Christ present again. Protestants believe in a once-for-all sacrifice at the Cross (Heb. 7:27).

Although all true Christians are in a relationship with Christ, who is the Head of the body which is the church, does it follow that there is only one true church? What about the following statement?

> The Church itself can be understood as a sign and instrument of grace, instituted by the one mediator between God and man, Jesus Christ, and, through the gospel, mediating his grace to the world. While the ancient formula "Outside the Church no salvation" may lend itself to misunderstanding, we agree that there is no salvation apart from the Church, since to be related to Christ is necessarily to be related, in however full or tenuous a manner, to the Church which is his body.[44]

The latest edition of the *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, published in 1994, states, "the Church is catholic because Christ is present in her. 'Where there is Jesus Christ, there is the Catholic Church.' In her subsists the fullness of Christ's body united with its head; this implies that she receives from him 'the fullness of the means of salvation' which he has willed: correct and complete confession of faith, full sacramental life, and ordained ministry in

42. See *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 505–611.

43. See *First Things*, no. 131 (March 2003): 26–33.

44. Ibid., 30.

apostolic succession."[45] In other words, the Church (Roman) is "the universal sacrament of salvation."[46] "The Church has been divinely sent to all nations that she might be 'the universal sacrament of salvation.'"[47] Other churches are called "separated Churches," never sister churches, because the Catholic church calls itself the "mother Church." Communion with these separated churches is described as follows: "For the Spirit of Christ has not refrained from using them as means of salvation which derive their efficacy from the very fullness of grace and truth entrusted to the Catholic Church."[48] In other words, there is only one source for the fullness of grace, and all other churches derive grace from that source (whether they know it or not). In fact, the Catholic church reaches out to all humans to gift them salvation through the church—and to gather all humanity into her embrace.

This replaces Christ as the only source of salvation, the fullness of which is found in Him alone, not confined to any church. True communion of the saints is found in communion with Him. Carefully worded statements which seem to reflect, to some degree, the communion of saints, must always be interpreted in the context of the unchanging official belief that the Catholic church is the only church Christ established, and outside of that church there is no salvation. In other words, all the ECT documents must be understood within the end-times plan of the Catholic church. While the Catholic church claims to be the body of Christ, in which He is resident, and therefore the bearer of truth to those within and beyond its fold, it dispenses nonbiblical traditions as a means to God and salvation. By contrast, Christ said, "I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me" (John 14:6).

"Legal Fiction" Issue

Martin Luther believed that when God declares persons justified, this refers to their standing and not to their nature. It has a legal connotation, and not an ontological meaning. This means sinners can be declared righteous even before they are made righteous (*simul iustus simul peccator*). Catholic theologians responded by saying this was legal fiction, for how can people be declared righteous when they are not righteous. (As we noted in the previous chapter, in Catholic terms justification is a change of nature, and not only a change of status, because justification to them is really sanctification.)

45. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 220 (830).

46. *The Documents of Vatican II*, 247 (4.4.45). (Original quote in: Dogmatic Constitution, *Lumen Gentium*, chap. II, Art. 15 AAS 57 [1965], 20.)

47. Ibid., 584 (13. Preface).

48. Ibid., 346 (6.1.3).

Protestants argue that their view is hardly legal fiction, because it speaks of a changed relationship between God and humans, and that is authentic. It needs to be stressed again that justification and sanctification are foundationally about a relationship with the One who justifies and sanctifies, and there is no legal fiction involved in that relationship. By contrast, the Catholic idea of infused justification, which allegedly enables human works to merit justification, is contrary to a relational Trinity that teaches justification by faith alone. Hence the Catholic view is actually legal fiction. Robert Reymond discerns the difference:

> God does not treat the justified sinner *as if* he were righteous before him when actually he is not. To the contrary, the justified sinner is *in fact* righteous in God's sight because of the "in Christ" relationship in which he stands (2 Cor. 5:21), in which relationship the righteousness of Christ is actually imputed to him. It is Rome's insistence that the righteousness of justification is infused and not imputed that lies at the base of this objection. But Rome's error here is serious, for it makes the very gospel of God itself—the teaching of justification by faith alone—truly a fiction.[49]

Herman Bavinck adds, "The charge lodged by the proponents of infused righteousness against imputed righteousness—that God regards certain people as something they are not—returns upon their own heads: they have God count something as righteousness which it is not."[50]

Luther's rejection of meritorious works and his focus on alien righteousness did not mean that he rejected the need for internal regeneration in those justified. "The Catholic polemic against the Reformation made one of its greatest mistakes, therefore, when it took the Reformed doctrine of forensic justification to mean no more than the 'external' imputation of the righteousness of Christ, with no consequences for the inner man."[51] For years Luther battled against antinomians (those opposed to the law). He said,

> The Ten Commandments are still in force and do concern us Christians so far as obedience to them is concerned. For the righteousness demanded by the Law is fulfilled in the believers through the grace and the assistance of the Holy Spirit, whom they receive. Thus all the admonitions of the prophets in the Old Testament, as well as of Christ and the apostles in the New Testament, concerning a godly life, are excellent sermons on and expositions of the Ten Commandments.[52]

49. Robert L. Reymond, *A New Systematic Theology of the Christian Faith*, 2nd ed., rev. ed. (Nashville, TN: Nelson, 1998), 753.

50. Herman Bavinck, *Holy Spirit, Church, and New Creation*, vol. 4 in *Reformed Dogmatics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2008), 212.

51. G. C. Berkouwer, *Faith and Sanctification*, in *Studies in Dogmatics* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2000), 35. Even though the *Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification: The Lutheran World Federation and Roman Catholic Church* (1999) recognizes the theologies of both churches accept works as fruit of the Christian life, these are not called "meritorious" by Lutherans, but are so called by Catholics, 51. See also 24–25 (4.7.37–38).

52. Martin Luther, *Sermons on the Gospel of St. John, chapters 1–4*, in *Luther's Works*, vol. 22, ed., Jaroslav Pelikan (Saint Louis, MO: Concordia Publishing House, 1957): 39.

Philipp Melanchthon, Luther's successor said, "The Law is a teaching given by God, which directs what we are to be like, what we are to do, what we must omit. The Law requires perfect obedience toward God."[53] The 1563 *Heidelberg Catechism* presents the Ten Commandments and concludes that we should "beg from God the grace of the Holy Ghost, so as to become more and more changed into the image of God, till we attain finally to full perfection after this life."[54] So true sanctification is found in Reformation theology, in spite of Catholic counterclaims.

The greatest difference between Catholic and Protestant soteriology has to do with the place of Jesus Christ in salvation. Scripture declares God to be "The Lord Our Righteous Savior" (Jer. 23:6; 33:16b). Scripture states, "we have now been justified by his blood...we were reconciled to him through the death of his Son," and we shall "be saved through his life!" (Rom. 5:9–10). "He was delivered over to death for our sins and was raised to life for our justification" (Rom. 4:25). Our Savior is "Christ Jesus, who became to us wisdom from God, righteousness and sanctification and redemption" (1 Cor. 1:30, ESV). Two Dutch Reformed theologians declare "Christ as the heart of justification."[55]

"God made him who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Cor. 5:21). For "by the one man's obedience the many will be made righteous" (Rom. 5:19b, ESV); "he has blessed us in the Beloved" (Eph. 1:6, ESV); "You have come to fullness of life in him" (Col. 2:10, RSV). Paul says of his own experience, "I consider everything a loss because of the surpassing worth of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord, for whose sake I have lost all things. I consider them garbage, that I may gain Christ and be found in him, not having a righteousness of my own that comes from the law, but that which is through faith in Christ—the righteousness that comes from God on the basis of faith" (Phil. 3:8–9). Scripture says that "you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God" (1 Cor. 6:11; cf. 12:13).

Catholic theology replaces Christ and the Holy Spirit, and in so doing turns from the only Ones who can save, substituting human traditions that are no more relevant than the sacrificial system of the old covenant, for the Catholic priestly ministry continues the ancient priestly ministry as if Christ had not died once for all (Heb. 9:26).

Most Evangelicals are favorable to some degree of Calvinism, which means they accept God's will to elect a few and reprobate the rest. By contrast, Catholic

53. Philipp Melanchthon, *Loci Communes 1543* (St. Louis, MO: Concordia, 1992), 57 (locus 6).

54. Philip Schaff, *The Evangelical Protestant Creeds*, vol. 3, revised by David S. Schaff (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Books, 1996; 1st ed. 1931), 349; see also 338–349.

55. J. Van Genderen and W. H. Velema, *Concise Reformed Dogmatics* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 1992), 61.

justification as an internal transformation by the Spirit "offers this transformation to every person, without exception. Only a free act of the will on our part can negate God's universal salvific will."[56] Whereas justification cannot be lost for Evangelicals, because of God's alleged irresistible grace, justification can be lost for Catholics through mortal sin, so that they never have the present certainty of salvation, and may need the process of justification to be completed in purgatory. So the differences over justification are more than just imputed (Evangelicals) versus infused (Catholics). The relational view of justification and sanctification is not legal fiction, but the only reality of salvation.

Catholics and Lutherans on Justification[57]

The Lutheran World Federation convened at Helsinki, Finland, in 1963. In the final message the focus was no longer on "How do I find peace with God?" but "Where are You, God?" Reformed theologians Genderen and Velema believe that this "is no longer a matter of the justification of the ungodly, but God's acceptance of man. This constitutes a radical shift in theology" away from God to a searching and suffering humanity.[58] They conclude that "the rapprochement between Roman Catholics and Protestants as far as justification is concerned is partly a result of this radical turnabout.... The fact that a rapprochement is currently shaping up reflects in part that man has become the focal point."[59]

Catholic observers were not the reason that the Lutheran leaders moved toward Rome; rather, this was achieved through use of the historical-critical method of exegesis.[60] Ernst Käsemann argues "that the historical-critical method is inseparable from Protestantism, is indeed its very genius."[61] This exegetical method was the foundation for the work done between Catholics and Evangelicals in subsequent meetings. The same historical-critical method contributed to the new perspectives on Paul,[62] which also questioned justification by faith. Much later, in 1992, the Lutheran Church–Missouri Synod (LCMS) and the

56. Richard P. McBrien, *Catholicism* (New York: HarperCollins, 1994), 329.

57. Pope John Paul II made a considerable contribution to ecumenism. One example was at Communion time during a mass in Scandinavia. The Pope said, "Lutheran Bishops approached the celebrant. They wished, by means of an agreed gesture, to demonstrate their desire for that time when we, Catholics and Lutherans, will be able to share the same Eucharist, and they wished to receive the celebrant's blessing. With love I blessed them," *The Encyclicals of John Paul II*, 959 (2.72–2).

58. Van Genderen and Velema, *Concise Reformed Dogmatics*, 631.

59. Ibid.

60. Robert D. Preus, *Justification and Rome* (St. Louis, MO: Concordia, 1997), 21.

61. James Wm. McClendon, *Doctrine: Systematic Theology* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 1994), 465. See Ernst Käsemann, *New Testament Questions of Today*, trans. W. J. Montague (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1969), 1–65; R. C. Briggs, *Interpreting the New Testament Today* (Nashville, TN: Abingdon, 1973), 21–24.

62. Guy Prentiss Waters, *The Federal Vision and Covenant Theology: A Comparative Analysis* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 2006), 63.

Lutheran Church in America evaluated the Lutheran-Catholic Dialogue Report VII, and concluded:

> The abject capitulation to the historical-critical method...relativized the concept of pure doctrines well as the normative authority of Scripture and jeopardized the honest efforts of Lutherans and Roman Catholics to find any solid consensus on the article of justification. Also, "new modes of thinking," a kind of new logic, made doctrinal differences "not necessarily divisive."[63]

The LCMS stated: "Having reviewed carefully the 'Commitment Statement' we have come to the conclusion that beneath the 'differences in theological formulation' often noted, there remain substantive differences between the churches which go to the very heart of the Gospel itself and are therefore divisive."[64] In spite of the "Evangelicals and Catholics Together" agreement, a meeting on January 19, 1995, documents Evangelicals' continuing opposition to Catholic doctrines and church system.[65] Many mistakenly believe ECT achieved a "substantive agreement" on "crucial issues."[66] Some of these issues were not present in the sixteenth century when Reformers revolted against Catholic theology; for not until Vatican I (1870) was papal infallibility decreed, and not until the nineteenth and twentieth centuries was Mary elevated in six different ways. These comparatively contemporary views challenge Scripture and the gospel, and they are challenges which Protestants cannot accept.

Jesuit theologian Karl Rahner speaks of the Eucharist as "a real sacrifice insofar as the *one* sacrifice of Jesus continues to be efficacious *in* history."[67] Yet Protestants who participated in ECT apparently did not sense as important that the Catholic mass seems to contradict the once-for-all (*hapax*, Heb. 9:26) sacrifice of Christ, and is sufficient cause for the division between Catholics and Evangelicals, because Calvary is the heart of the gospel and central to Christ's mission for the world. Charles Colson says that Christ's "death on the cross" and "the infallibility of Scripture" are truths "affirmed" in ECT and "provide a solid foundation for all Christians. Those who can affirm these truths have something in common of monumental significance."[68] But Christ's death is considered differently by Catholics and Evangelicals (for a true understanding of Christ's life and death makes human works for salvation redundant), and the "infallibility"

63. Preus, *Justification and Rome*, 22.
64. Ibid., 23.
65. The meeting included three signers of the ECT statement: Chuck Colson, J. I. Packer, and Bill Bright. See John Ankerberg and John Weldon, *Protestants & Catholics: Do They Now Agree?* (Eugene, OR: Harvest House, 1995), 4–6.
66. See R. C. Sproul in Ankerberg and Weldon, *Protestants & Catholics: Do They Now Agree?*, 8.
67. Karl Rahner, *Foundations of Christian Faith: An Introduction to the Idea of Christianity* (New York: Crossroads, 1999), 426.
68. Charles Colson, *ECT*, in Ankerberg and Weldon, *Protestants & Catholics*, 36.

of Scripture is radically questioned in Catholic theology. The fact is, Evangelicals and Catholics do not agree on the Cross and on Scripture, and *these are the differences* which have "monumental significance."[69]

The 1983 U.S. Lutheran–Roman Catholic dialogue on justification claimed: "Our entire hope of justification and salvation rest on Christ Jesus and on the gospel whereby the good news of God's merciful action in Christ is made known; we do not place our ultimate trust in anything other than God's promise and saving work in Christ."[70] When the salvation of Catholics rests upon the church, the sacraments, works of merit (even purgatory), and the intercession of Mary and saints, their "entire hope" does not "rest on Jesus Christ and on the gospel." The two are mutually exclusive.

Many questions were in my mind as I read the "Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification" by the Lutheran World Federation and the Catholic Church (which was signed on October 31, 1999), and "The World Methodist Council Statement of Association with the Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification" signed on July 23, 2006. I wondered why there seemed such a movement toward unity—at any cost, it seemed. Then I realized: Union among the churches is sought in order to present a united front in preaching the gospel in pagan lands. On one level this seems an excellent idea, better than the competition among different denominations, which must be confusing to pagans. However, at a deeper level, how can churches unite with the Catholic church, when she adds to the gospel human ideas, such as, salvation through its church alone, through its sacraments, through Mary and the saints, placing traditions above God's holy Word? Wouldn't Paul call this another gospel that isn't the gospel (Gal. 1:6–7)? Isn't the gospel Jesus Christ alone, with nothing and no one between Him and His people?

Postmodern culture has impacted the church, questioning the necessity of Christ's substitutionary death and the doctrine of justification by faith. David Wells concludes, "In the evangelical church today, wherever the postmodern world has intruded, the affirmation of the gospel as a part of the biblical worldview is diminished."[71]

Nestor Beck has examined contemporary ecumenical documents (prior to 1987) and finds that they do not value the gospel as articulated in the Augsburg Confession (the basic Lutheran confession of faith, written by Philipp Melanchthon, 1497–1560, and presented to the Diet of Augsburg, 1530). Beck refers below to the Augsburg Confession (AC), noting that the ecumenical documents are not compatible with the Christology of AC.

69. Charles Colson, ECT Statement, in Ankerberg and Weldon, *Protestants & Catholics*, 36.
70. Ibid., 97.
71. David F. Wells, foreword to *Whatever Happened to the Reformation?*, ed. Gary L. W. Johnson and R. Fowler White (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 2001), xx.

> It is plain and clear that all the documents dissociate themselves from the Christology of the AC in some respect. They want to leave behind the representation that Jesus "made satisfaction" for sin and functions even now as Mediator and Propitiator. They try instead to develop and apply a conception of the righteousness of God which manifests itself in history, notably in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus, but which does not require substitutionary atonement. In this connection the death of Jesus undergoes a significant reinterpretation. He is said to have died "to demonstrate God's love for sinners."[72]

Instead of the Reformers' claim that Christ charged the apostles to spread the gospel, "the documents envision the apostles as developing and formulating a 'message of justification' as their *understanding* of the 'Christ event,' albeit by the power of the Holy Spirit, in connection with the process of the manifestation of God's righteousness in history."[73] This view scuttles biblical revelation, confining revelation merely to the first witnesses of it, who wrote down their witness to it—and that's all we have in Scripture (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 1, chapter 6). So Christ's death is downgraded from being redeeming of the human race, to merely revealing God; and Scripture is downgraded from being God's revelation, to merely a witness to God's revelation. On this basis, truth is thrown to the winds, and that is no foundation for the biblical union of Christians (John 17) that is only possible through the Spirit of truth who guides into all truth (John 15:12–13), the same Holy Spirit who inspired Scripture (2 Pet. 1:21).

Reformers presented a substitutionary atonement, in which Christ took our place on the cross, for He alone is our righteousness. The same Christ comes to humans in justification and declares them as righteous in Him rather than in themselves (Catholic view). Declarative righteousness, or forensic justification imputed to believers, was proclaimed by the Reformers but denied by the infused righteousness of Catholic theology. It is logical for Berkouwer to say: "It is well to remember that many objections to declarative justification are part and parcel with a rejection of the substitutionary suffering and death of Jesus Christ."[74]

Examples of the rejection of Christ's substitutionary sacrifice and of declarative justification are documented by Bruce Demarest in his 1997 book *The Cross and Salvation: The Doctrine of Salvation:* (1) Pelagians and liberals believed in justification through personal virtue.[75] (2) Socinians in the sixteenth century claimed, "That Christ by his death has *merited* salvation for us

72. Nestor Beck, *The Doctrine of Faith: A Study of the Augsburg Confession and Contemporary Ecumenical Documents* (St. Louis: Concordia, 1987), 177–178.
73. Ibid., 178.
74. Berkouwer, *Faith and Sanctification*, in *Studies in Dogmatics*, 89–90.
75. Bruce Demarest, *The Cross and Salvation: The Doctrine of Salvation* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 1997), 347.

and has *made satisfaction* freely for our sins…is fallacious and erroneous and wholly pernicious."[76] (3) Albrecht Ritschl (1822–1889) said that it was "altogether false" that justification is a judicial act by which God imputes Christ's righteousness to sinners.[77] (4) Congregationalist pastor Lyman Abbott (d. 1922) claimed, "Justification by faith no longer means to me that Christ has suffered the penalties of my sins…it means that Jesus Christ offers himself to me as my divine companion and if I accept his companionship I can be made virtuous although I have been guilty."[78] (5) Demarest said Shailer Mathews (d. 1941) rejected that justification is imputed.[79] (6) Process theologians Pittenger assimilated justification into sanctification,"[80] as did John Wesley.[81] (7) Richard Watson (d. 1833), the first Wesleyan systematic theologian, denied the imputation of Adam's sin to his posterity, and Christ's righteousness to believers.[82] (8) Charles Finney (d. 1873) believed God declares a person righteous because that person is righteous.[83] (9) Swedish Lutheran Gustaf Aulén believed Christ did not suffer the sinner's punishment, nor is Christ's righteousness imputed to others.[84]

Lutheran pietism did not emphasize forensic justification (declared righteous), because they were more interested in experience, concentrating on the process of believers being made righteous.[85] This reminds us of Orthodox theology, which also has no interest in justification by faith because it desires to experience God mystically (see chapter 15). Gordon Olson says, "Ever since Martin Luther trumpeted the watchword of the Reformation [God's declaration that sinners are righteous by repentant faith alone, apart from works], not only did Roman Catholicism vigorously oppose it, but there has been a continuing erosion of this biblical truth among Protestants, and even Evangelicals. Most outrageously, the recent Evangelicals and Catholics Together (ECT) movement has totally compromised this glorious truth by sweeping it under the rug."[86]

76. *The Racovian Catechism* (1605), chap. V.8, quoted in Demarest, *The Cross and Salvation*, 348.
77. Albrecht Ritschl, *The Christian Doctrine of Justification and Reconciliation* (Clifton, NJ: Reference Book Publishers, 1966), 70, quoted in Demarest, *The Cross and Salvation*, 348.
78. Lyman Abbott, *What Christianity Means to Me* (New York: MacMillan, 1922), 140, quoted in Demarest, *The Cross and Salvation*, 349.
79. Demarest, *The Cross and Salvation*, 349.
80. Ibid.
81. Ibid., 353.
82. Ibid., 354.
83. Ibid.
84. Ibid., 357.
85. H. George Anderson, et al., eds., *Justification by Faith: Lutherans and Catholics in Dialogue VII* (Minneapolis, MN: Augsburg, 1985), 40.
86. C. Gordon Olson, *Beyond Calvinism and Arminianism: An Inductive Mediate Theology of Salvation* (Cedar Knolls, NJ: Global Gospel Publishers, 2002), 41.

Factors to Consider to Evaluate the Debate

In assessing the present ecumenism through the study of justification, it is important to understand the following realities: (1) The Catholic church claims infallibility and the inability to err doctrinally when the pope speaks *ex cathedra.* (2) The living magisterium of the Catholic church is the final word on doctrines. (3) The authority of Catholic doctrines is indebted to tradition. (4) Catholic words spoken about justification need to be interpreted in the light of the rest of Catholic theology. (5) Protestant criticism of Scripture (historical-critical methods) is no better than the Catholic magisterium's critiquing Scripture, and this critical approach to Scripture provides common ground for decisions made on justification. (6) "The Spirit clearly says that in later times some will abandon the faith and follow deceiving spirits and things taught by demons" (1 Tim. 4:1), and hence God's final invitation is "Fallen! Fallen is Babylon the Great! She has become a dwelling for demons.... Come out of her, my people" (Rev. 18:2a, 4a). (The fall of Babylon is witnessed by rejection of the Gospel.[87]) (7) R. Albert Mohler, Jr., President of Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, has said, "By this historic and crucial measure [Justification by faith, the article on which the church stands or falls] evangelicalism in its contemporary form is largely falling—and falling fast." Mohler concludes, "The drama of the gospel has not changed, but the audience for evangelical theology *has* changed—and not for the better. The emergence of these new systems of thought [New Perspectives on Paul and Federal Vision], neither of which is as new as its proponents suggest, indicates a dangerous and potentially fatal weakening of evangelical conviction and doctrinal discernment."[88] (8) The impact of postmodernity on Evangelicals is an additional contemporary threat that questions Christ's substitutionary death and justification by faith,[89] and is compatible with Christ's end-times question: "when the Son of Man comes [Second Advent], will he find faith on the earth?" (Luke 18:8).

87. It should be noted that Ptocess theology and Openness theology are two examples of how Evangelicals question the biblical view of God (see volume 2, chapter 6). Note also Robert L. Reymond's statement on contemporary church-growth methods: "Even the evangelical church shows signs of losing confidence in the convincing and converting power of the gospel message.... In such a cultural climate, preaching on the law, sin and repentance, and the cross has all but disappeared, even in evangelical churches.... Today's 'gospel' is all too often a gospel without cost, without repentance, without commitment, without discipleship, and thus 'another gospel' and accordingly no gospel at all, all traceable to the fact that this is how too many people today have come to believe that the church must be grown," *A New Systematic Theology of the Christian Faith,* 882. Gary L. W. Johnson said, "The evangelical church used to be defined by the gospel. Nowadays in many evangelical circles this has drastically changed. The gospel is now defined by the church pragmatically in terms of whether it is relevant and acceptable to a society that, like all societies that have gone before, has no taste for the biblical gospel," introduction to *Whatever Happened to the Reformation?,* 25.

88. R. Albert Mohler, Jr., "Afterword: A Change in the Audience, Not in the Drama," in *By Faith Alone: Answering the Challenges to the Doctrine of Justification,* ed. Gary L. W. Johnson & Guy P. Waters (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2007) 207.

89. See Wells, foreword to *Whatever Happened to the Reformation?,* xix–xx.

Pope Benedict XVI on Justification

On November 19, 2008, the pope presented his teaching on justification to those gathered in St. Peter's Square. In a sense it was an official endorsement of the work done in the many consultations between Catholics and Evangelicals on this topic. He compared Saul's dependence upon the law with his new dependence on Christ after the Damascus road encounter with Christ. The pope compared two alternative paths to justice: through works of the law, or through a relationship with Christ. Paul was freed from the laws of the Torah, like circumcision, food laws, ritual purity, and rules regarding the Sabbath. The pope said, "To be just means simply to be with Christ and in Christ. And this suffices. Other observances are no longer necessary." Many Evangelicals will commend this statement, but it needs to be understood in the whole context of Catholic theology.

Pope Boniface VIII (1294–1303) even went so far as to say, "We declare that for all mankind it is necessary to obey the Roman Pontiff on pain of forfeiting their salvation."[90] In other words, "Without the Pope there is no church, no Christianity. Submission to the pope is for all people a condition for salvation (Boniface VIII, *Unam Sanctam*) [original not italicized]. The pope is the mediator of salvation, the way, the truth, and the life [words only used of Christ in Scripture, John 14:6]."[91] So it is not Christ alone after all. This illustrates the problem in assessing Catholic statements. While individual statements themselves may seem biblical, they have little meaning in the context of Catholic theology as a whole.

Compare the pope's statement on justification with the1994 *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, the publication of which he superintended as a cardinal. The *Catechism* says, "the merit of good works is to be attributed in the first place to the grace of God, then to the faithful."[92] "The grace of Christ is...infused by the Holy Spirit into our soul to heal it of sin and to sanctify it. It is the *sanctifying or deifying grace* received in Baptism."[93] "Moved by the Holy Spirit and by charity, *we can then merit* for ourselves and for others the graces needed for our sanctification, for the increase of grace and charity, and for the attainment of eternal life."[94]

After his presentation in St. Peter's Square, the pope spoke to different ethnic groups in their native languages. To the English-speaking audience, he said of justification that "we are made righteous before God," which is the view of Trent. Catholic apologist Robert Sungenis rightly pointed out the great divide

90. Karl Von Hase, *Handbook,* 1:77, quoted in Bavinck, *Holy Spirit, Church, and New Creation,* vol. 4 in *Reformed Dogmatics,* 310.

91. Bavinck, *Holy Spirit, Church, and New Creation,* vol. 4 in *Reformed Dogmatics,* 406.

92. *Catechism of the Catholic Church,* 486 (2008).

93. Ibid., 484 (1999). Emphasis in original.

94. Ibid., 487 (2010). Emphasis in original.

that remains between Roman and Protestant theology, a divide we have noted in this and previous chapters, but a divide now acknowledged by a Catholic:

> Between Catholics and Protestants lies a great divide concerning whether the Christian has imputed or infused righteousness. Indeed this difference is probably the most crucial in the ongoing debate, because it encompasses the most theological territory. In fact, the original motivation of the Reformation was to distance itself from the medieval concept of infused righteousness formulated largely by the theology of Augustine.[95]

Is Trent Still Influential?

It should be remembered that the Council of Trent was held at a time when the Catholic church wanted to distance itself from being associated with the biblical antichrist. Protestants of the day determined that the Catholic church was the antichrist through a historicist view of biblical prophecy—from the time of the apostles (2 Thess. 2; 1 John 2:18) until the end of history (Rev. 12:17; 13:1–4; cf. 13:11–17). The Council of Trent set out to debunk historicism, and eventually came up with futurism which placed the antichrist far into the future and prevented the identification of the antichrist in the present (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 4, for more on this subject). This influence of Trent still remains.

It is clear from the ECT documents that the anathemas that Trent and the Reformation hurled at each other in the sixteenth century have been dismissed as a result of the justification debates. On the one hand, it seems that the stand the Catholic church took at Trent, against the Reformation, is now obsolete. On the other hand, we must ask whether there is evidence that Catholic theology has essentially changed since the Council of Trent.

Many believe that Vatican Council II (1963–1965) marked a change in the Roman Catholic church (*aggiornamento*). It is true the Council focused on other denominations and religions in a way that had not been done before. This was for ecumenical reasons: to bring the "separated brethren" back into the church, and reach out to other religions. This could be seen as a huge change, except that in reality the Catholic church sees itself as the mother church, reaching out to other churches and religions in order to bring them home. There have been peripheral changes, as well, such as the mass being said in the native language of the faithful (instead of Latin), but the mass itself is essentially the same.

Consider that in Vatican II not only was the Catholic church revealing its global ambitions (see Rev. 13:1–4; 11–16; 17:1–18), but also reaffirming the

95. Robert A. Sungenis, *Not By Faith Alone: The Biblical Evidence for the Catholic Doctrine of Justification* (Santa Barbara, CA: Queenship Publishing Co., 1997), 299.

Council of Trent: "This sacred council accepts loyally the venerable faith of our ancestors...and it proposes again the decrees of the Second Council of Nicea, of the Council of Florence, and of the Council of Trent."[96] Such an endorsement of Trent seems to be evidenced by the subsequent elevation of Mary since the Council (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 4).[97] In other words, human participation in earning salvation (seen at Trent) is continued through Mary's intercession as the bodily assumed "Queen of heaven."

Pope John Paul II said Vatican II has been "the constant reference point of my every pastoral action,"[98] and he commissioned the writing of the latest *Catechism of the Catholic Church* with "the desire for the unity of all Christians."[99] Pope John Paul II's introduction to the *Catechism* was written on October 11, 1992, one month after the consultation on justification between Evangelicals and Catholics began. The *Catechism* was published in 1994—the same year that the Evangelical and Catholics Together (ECT) document was first issued.

These dates are important because of the teaching on justification in the *Catechism.* Justification is not an entry-level phase of salvation, according to the *Catechism;* rather, it "is not only the remission of sins, but also the sanctification and renewal of the interior man."[100] This is the same as the definition stated at Trent. Eberhard Jüngel's 1999 book *Justification: The Heart of the Christian Faith* evaluates the "Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification," saying it "promised so much," but adds, "[i]n my judgment at least, there were no sound theological foundations laid here." In fact, there are "pronouncements which almost without exception move in the area and on the level of the *Decree Concerning Justification* which the Roman Catholic Church had adopted at the Council of Trent in 1547 on the basis of, and more particularly *against*, the Reformers' doctrine of justification."[101]

The same was said even when comparing Vatican II with Trent. Paul Schrotenboer, general secretary for the Reformed Ecumenical Synod, noted in 1987 that Vatican II made no new contribution to the debate on justification by faith, concluding, "Apart from a new Roman Catholic confession on justification by faith, Trent remains a major barrier between heirs of the Reformation

96. Austin Flannery, O. P., ed., *Vatican Council II: The Conciliar and Post Conciliar Documents*, rev. ed. (Northport, NY: Costello, 1988), 1:412.

97. G. C. Berkouwer, *The Conflict with Rome*, trans. David H. Freeman (Grand Rapids: Baker Book, 1958), 174. Cf. a fresco in the Vatican where Mary is "high in the center with the Father and Son seated on her left and right as instruments of her all-powerful will," Berkouwer, *The Conflict with Rome*, 162.

98. John Paul II, "Discourse of January 25, 1985," *L'Osservatore Romano* (January 27, 1985), quoted in *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2.

99. Ibid., 5.

100. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 482 (1989).

101. Eberhard Jüngel, *Justification: The Heart of the Christian Faith*, trans. Jeffrey F. Cayzer (London: T & T Clark, 2006, Ger. ed. 1999, 1st ed. 2001), xxxiv, emphasis in original.

and Roman Catholicism."[102] So Trent is still influential, and true union between Evangelicals and Catholics can only be achieved through embracing the biblical gospel with its salvation through Scripture alone, by faith alone, through Christ alone. The word *alone* is crucial in the quest for true union.

As fellow Christians we long for the union Christ prayed for, to be united together with Him, the One who is the truth (John 14:6), to be united together with the Spirit of Truth (v. 17), as Jesus called the Author of holy Scripture. The good news is this—one day the redeemed from all denominations and beyond will be fully united together in truth, with the God of truth. May God hasten that day.

Beyond the ECT Declarations

There is a decisive difference that remains between the Catholic and the Reformation understanding of justification by faith, in spite of all the joint declarations to the contrary. Abraham Kuyper says that in Scripture "justification occupies the most conspicuous place, and is presented as of greatest importance for the sinner." It is "the very kernel of the *Reformation*, which puts this doctrine of 'justification by faith' boldly and clearly in opposition to the 'meritorious works of Rome.'" The Reformed are rightly urged "not to merge justification in sanctification."[103]

Catholic priest Richard John Neuhaus, a former Lutheran, who argues that "justification by faith" is "a theological formula devised sixteen centuries" after the church, claims "[t]hat Christian reality, comprehensively understood, is the Church. Surely it is the Church that judges the adequacy of theological formulations and not vice versa."[104] However, historically speaking, Scripture preceded the true beginning of the Roman Catholic church in the sixth century (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 4). Besides this, Paul speaks of this doctrine: "For in the gospel the righteousness of God is revealed—a righteousness that is by faith from first to last, just as it is written: 'The righteous will live by faith' [reference to Hab. 2:4]" (Rom. 1:17), and the gospel is eternal (Rev. 14:6), which is long before the origin of the Catholic church of Rome.

J. I. Packer declares that "domestic differences about salvation and the Church should not hinder us from joint action in seeking to re-Christianize the North American milieu."[105] But I would rather say, it is the true Christ, the true

102. Paul G. Schrotenboer, *Roman Catholicism: A Contemporary Evangelical Perspective* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1988, 1st ed. 1987), 66.

103. Abraham Kuyper, *The Work of the Holy Spirit* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1979, 1st ed. 1900), 354–355.

104. Richard John Neuhaus, ECT Statement, 207.

105. J. I. Packer, ECT Statement, 172.

gospel, which can re-Christianize North America, and this means *sola Scriptura, sola gratia, and sola fide* are needed. In fairness, Packer may agree with this. My concern is that anything less than truth cannot produce a truth-filled union of churches. In the end, the Joint Declaration, even though sincere, fails to allow biblical truth to guide its process.

Facing a common enemy (secularism, with its anti-family values, abortion, and moral relativism), Catholics and Evangelicals have strained at hermeneutics to bury the anathemas of Trent and those of the Reformers, as if the contemporary attack on the gospel by secularism is more important than the medieval Catholic attack on the gospel (another kind of secularism). It is recognized by some that there must be a consensus about justification, or there will be no other consensus.[106] We do not have space, nor interest, to follow the sometimes tortuous maneuvers to arrive at convergence and consensus, whether authentic or not. Luther has appropriately dubbed Catholic logic "super-subtle subtleties."[107] Yet, balance requires us to note that both sides are seeking to come together, focusing on common points of agreement, while overlooking the major and crucial differences that remain.

Edinburgh theologian James Buchanan's 1867 assessment on the subject is still relevant. He says, "The attempts which have been made to minimize the difference, on [Justification], between the Popish and Protestant Churches, on the one hand, and between the different sections of Protestants, on the other, by those who have assumed the name of 'reconcilers,' have often resulted in the sacrifice of some portion of God's revealed truth, and have seldom, if ever, been conducive to the real peace, and spiritual edification, of His Church."[108]

Consider the following commentaries by Karl Barth:

> [Trent] speaks of the good works of the regenerate man, who is only a little sinner and commits only tiny sins, and who is in the happy position of being able to increase the grace of justification in co-operation with it, and even to augment the degree of his eternal bliss. The practical consequence of all this is that the misery of man is not regarded as in any way serious or dangerous either for Christians or non-Christians. The Reformation communions could not reunite with a Church which held this doctrine, and they cannot accept the call to reunion with it to-day.[109]

Barth also declared, "But with its doctrine of justification the Roman Church closed the door to self-reformation and deprived itself of all possibility of seizing

106. Karl Lehmann and Wolfhart Pannenberg, eds., *The Condemnations of the Reformation Era: Do They Still Divide?* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1990, Ger. ed. 1988), 36.

107. Martin Luther, "The Babylonian Captivity of the Church" in *Three Treatises* (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1973, 1st ed. 1960), 124.

108. James Buchanan, *The Doctrine of Justification* (London, UK: The Banner of Truth Trust, 1961, 1st ed. 1867), 425.

109. Barth, *The Doctrine of Reconciliation*, vol. 4, pt. 2, in *Church Dogmatics*, 498.

the initiative in uniting the divided Church. It was impossible for the Evangelical Churches to return to fellowship with Rome when the decisive point of dispute was handled in this way. They could not surrender truth to unity."[110] Although Barth wrote these comments in 1955 and 1953 respectively, they are quite relevant to the contemporary ECT debate.

Barth's insights should guide the contemporary process, for arguably truth has been surrendered for the sake of unity—and that is too high a price to pay for the war against secularism, for only truth will overcome error. False theology is just as secular as any other secularism, but more insidious because it is within the church rather than outside. For historical perspective we need to be reminded of the Augsburg Conference:

> In conclusion, the Protestants returned in their Confession to their grand cardinal doctrine, salvation by grace. They especially attacked the mass, on which Rome had suspended the salvation of the world, making the priest, and not Christ, the saviour of men; the sacrifice on the altar, and not the sacrifice on the cross, the real propitiation; thus compelling men to come to her and not to God for pardon, making merchandise of heaven, changing worship into mountebankry, and the Church into a fair. "If the mass," said they, "takes away the sins of the living and dead, *ex opere operato*, then justification hangs on a mere rite," and Christ died in vain.[111]

Importance of Justification by Faith: Protestant Opinions

Below we will document quotations from Protestant scholars which indicate the importance of justification by faith. Their insights are based upon inspired Scripture. They indicate the importance of justification by faith. Their witness is placed here prior to the next segment which shows that contemporary Protestant leaders have, for the most part, forsaken the bold stand of the Reformers against the erroneous stand of the Roman Catholic Church. In other words, although the statements below are compatible with the ones stated by the Reformers, the sad fact is that most Protestant leaders have stopped protesting against the Roman substitute for the biblical Gospel.

The following Protestant scholars indicate the importance of justification by faith:

1. J. Van Genderen and W. H. Velema: Justification is "the heart of the gospel."[112]

110. Ibid., 626.
111. J. A. Wylie, *The History of Protestantism* (Rapidan, VA: Hartland Publications, 2002), 2:642.
112. Van Genderen and Velema, *Concise Reformed Dogmatics*, 607.

2. Thomas F. Torrance: "The whole question of the Reformation is at stake in the doctrine of justification."[113]
3. R. C. Sproul: "But no doctrinal dispute has ever been contested more fiercely with such long-term consequences as the one over justification. There were other ancillary issues debated in the sixteenth century, but none so central or so heated as justification."[114]
4. Bruce L. McCormack: "Lutheran and Reformed theologians disagreed on a number of things, but the one thing on which there was no disagreement was the central importance of justification by grace through faith, for it was that, above all, which defined Protestantism and gave to each of its member churches its character as Protestant. What is at stake in this doctrine is nothing less than the Reformation itself...the absence of clarity about this doctrine and the inability of its would-be defenders to offer an adequate response to the challengers which are currently being brought against it are contributing mightily to the theological confusion which reigns in the churches of the Reformation and, in all likelihood, hastening the demise of Protestantism in the West."[115]
5. Carl E. Braaten: "It is justification that distinguishes Christianity from all other religions, and which preserves its truth over against all sects, such as Anabaptists, Sacramentarians, and Papists."[116]
6. D. James Kennedy: "Truly by this [doctrine of justification] the church stands or falls and our souls stand or fall with it. If this be the case, then, indeed, most of the church is sadly fallen in our day. And how great is that fall!"[117]

Why Protestants Have Changed Their Views

It seems that based on the dialogue between Protestants and Catholics who produced the ECT documents, and in the joint statements with Lutherans and Methodists, some Protestant leaders today hold a position different from that of Protestants during the Reformation. On the doctrine of justification by faith, Protestant churches have weakened their stand through conferences with Catholics. Here are the reasons why.

113. Torrance, *Theology in Reconstruction*, 150.
114. Sproul, *Faith Alone*, 18.
115. McCormack, "What's at Stake in Current Debates over Justification?" in *Justification: What's at Stake*, 82–83.
116. Carl E. Braaten, *Justification: The Article by Which the Church Stands or Falls* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1990), 23.
117. D. James Kennedy, "A Personal Word," introduction to Ankerberg and Weldon, *Protestants & Catholics: Do They Now Agree?*, 13.

Thus Rome seems to be the same, so who is changing? David Wells noted, "The evangelical world, in fact, is now coming apart because its central truths [like justification by faith alone], what once held it all together, no longer have the binding power that they once had and, in some cases, are rejected outright with no following outcry."[118] Bruce McCormack said, "theological confusion" among Reformation churches over justification by faith is "hastening the demise of Protestantism in the West."[119] In 2005, D. A. Carson added:

> paid masses to release souls from purgatory are still notoriously common in many parts of the Catholic world. As for the fundamental doctrinal issues that divided Reformers and Catholics half a millennium ago, although the polemic is today more courteous, the current pope [John Paul II] and strong voices in the Curia such as Joseph Cardinal Ratzinger [who superintended the 1994 Catholic Catechism, and is now Pope Benedict XVI], are strictly Tridentine [representing Council of Trent]. Read the current Catholic Catechism on, say, justification.[120]

Michael Horton says, "In our day, the doctrine of justification is widely ignored, rarely central, and not infrequently denied outright by Protestant—tragically, even evangelical—theologians and pastors. If the statistics cited above are in any way indicative of reality, 87 percent of America's evangelicals are practicing medieval Roman Catholics in their view of how one relates to God" (Michael S. Horton).[121] He also adds: "Today one can easily find theological professors at leading evangelical institutions who no longer find justification by faith alone to be true, much less necessary."[122]

T. F. Torrance notes: "When we examine our own position today, it is astonishing to find how close we have come to the Roman view even in the Church of Scotland. How frequently, for example, we find that appeal is made to 'Christian instinct' or to 'the mind of the Church' over against the plain utterances of Holy Scripture, and often just at those places where the Word of God offends our will, opposes our habits, or cuts against the grain of our desire!... It is high time we asked again whether the Word of God really does have free course amongst us and whether it is not after all bound and fettered by the traditions of men."[123]

Alister McGrath adds: "[It is] clear that there exist real differences between Protestants and Roman Catholics over the matter of justification.... In recent

118. David F. Wells, foreword to *By Faith Alone*, 13.

119. Bruce L. McCormack, "What's at Stake in Current Debates over Justification? The Crisis of Protestantism in the West," in *Justification: What's at Stake in the Current Debates*, ed. Mark Husbands and Daniel J. Treier (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2004), 83.

120. D. A. Carson, *Becoming Conversant with the Emerging Church: Understanding a Movement and Its Implications* (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2005), 173–174.

121. Horton, "The *Sola's* of the Reformation" in *Here We Stand*, 123.

122. Horton, foreword to Sproul, *Faith Alone*, 13.

123. Torrance, *Theology in Reconstruction*, 164–165.

years, there appears to be increasing sympathy for the view that these differences, although of importance in the Reformation period, no longer possess the significance that they once had. This is not to say that the Christian denominations are agreed on the matter of justification, for it is obvious that their respective teachings have a very different 'feel' or 'atmosphere' to them. It seems that in the modern period the Christian denominations have preferred to concentrate on their points of agreement, rather than draw attention to their historical disagreements."[124]

Historically and foundationally Protestant theology is separated from Catholic theology by its view of Scripture. Catholic theology places human tradition above Scripture, and many of its doctrines are nonbiblical. With the rise of biblical criticism in Protestant academia, which has become widespread in Protestant seminaries, critical methods sit in judgment of Scripture. This means that the Protestant critics of Scripture are in the same position as the Catholic magisterium that sits in judgment of Scripture.

The Bible fired the Reformation, exposing Catholic doctrines as nonbiblical. Today that Protestant prophetic voice has been largely muted because of the deconstruction of Scripture—yet it is Scripture alone that can judge the authenticity of human theological conclusions. A number of Evangelical theologians now question Scripture as revelation, relegating it to a mere witness to revelation (see volume 1, chapter 6). The New Perspectives on Paul proponents have affected the discussion on justification (see my *Systematic Theology*, volume 2, chapter 12).[125]

124. McGrath, *Justification by Faith*, 71. McGrath wrote this six years before the "Evangelicals and Catholics Together" statement in March 1994.

125. See also Seyoon Kim, *Paul and the New Perspective: Second Thoughts on the Origin of Paul's Gospel* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2002). Second Temple Jews were engaged in "works of the law" to earn salvation, demonstrated by Paul before his conversion (Gal. 1:13–16; Phil. 3:3–9). The traditional doctrine of justification was by faith, contrary to any works of law to merit salvation; but the new doctrine of justification (by the New Perspectives on Paul study) was to dismiss circumcision, food laws, and the Sabbath as boundary markers to distinguish between Jews and Gentiles, Kim, *Paul and the New Perspective*, 3. Whereas the traditional doctrine of justification dismissed all law-keeping *to earn salvation*, the new doctrine of justification dismissed Jewish laws as unnecessary for Gentiles *to become covenant members*. Proponents of the New Perspectives on Paul consider law keeping, in Second Temple Judaism, to be responsive works to God's grace given in the covenant. Such works were a mark of covenant membership, and were never works to gain entrance into the covenant. Proponents allegedly substantiate this conclusion from the Qumran community. Qumran is located on the northwestern shore of the Dead Sea, several kilometers south of Jericho, and is famous for the discovery of the Dead Sea Scrolls which are Jewish parchments discovered in caves that take us back much nearer to the Old Testament writings, and they are variously numbered.

However, this conclusion is decisively called into question by J. V. Fesko, as follows: all the law is important and not just a subset of Jewish markers (1QS [The Community Rule] 5; 5:10). The law is an entry requirement for covenant membership. For example, "But when a man enters the covenant to walk according to all these precepts that he may be joined to the holy congregation, they shall examine his spirit in community with respect to his understanding and practice of the Law, under the authority of the sons of Aaron who have freely pledged themselves in the Community to restore His Covenant and to heed all the precepts commanded by Him, and the multitude of Israel," 1QS 5:20, *Justification: Understanding The Classic Reformed Doctrine* (Phillipsburg, PA: P&R, 2008), 179. Moreover, 4QMMT (Halakhic Letter) supports the traditional view because legalistic works to earn salvation were a problem at Qumran, Fesko, *Justification*, 180.

One should remember that in the eleventh century the Greek church broke away from the Roman Catholic church over doctrinal differences. In the fifteenth century the Greek and Roman leaders met at the Council of Florence (1438–1439), and drew up a formula for union, which the Greek leaders deemed necessary in order for them to successfully face the Turks (Islam). The formula contained concessions to the Roman Catholic church, and so the union never took place.[126] This event in history should be instructive to those who desire union against a common enemy called secularism. As the Greek church refused to "return" to mother church, so Protestants that broke away in the sixteenth century need to think carefully about the consequences if they "return" (in whatever form) to the Catholic church.

Carl Braaten has said, "The evangelical criterion *of justification sola fide* [faith alone] mixes with the dogma of papal infallibility like oil and water. I cannot imagine a vision of the fullness of the church in which both principles exist in relation of complementarity."[127] James Bannerman agrees: "The Pope is the centre of unity in the Romish theory of the Church" rather than Christ.[128] Braaten also maintains, "The oneness of the Church is not an ecclesiastical union, but a spiritual one."[129]

A mere church union is external, whereas union with Christ is spiritual, intimate, and relational. By contrast, sacramental theology is impersonal; it is a human addition to the biblical doctrine of salvation, and is just as alien as works to earn salvation. Sacraments which convey Christ's grace without a heart-devotion to Christ on the part of priests is contrary to God's conditional blessings in Scripture (cf. Deut. 28:1–68). Any automatic (*ex opere operato*) dispensing of grace, outside of a relationship with the Giver, is contrary to God's covenant love (Deut. 5:2, 29).

The basic question to be asked is, Why does God need sacraments? After all, if God—without any help from humans—sent Christ to become human in the greatest creative event in human history, and salvation is a creative work through Christ and the Spirit, then why are these Creators unable to administer the benefits of salvation? Sacramental theology fails to understand that salvation is a creative work that only the Creator God can do, both in supplying and applying it.

Romans 2:21–23 refers to the whole law and not merely to covenant badges. Legalism was a problem that Christ encountered (Matt. 5:17–20; 23:1–38; Luke 18:9–14), and He ministered during Second Temple Judaism. Works-righteousness was the problem Paul encountered in Rome and in Galatia, and not covenant badges (or subset of the law: circumcision, food laws, and the Sabbath), Fesko, *Justification*, 180–182. To understand justification by faith, one must return to the traditional understanding because the New Perspective is at odds with Scripture, and with historical evidence from the Qumran community. Justification is not through works of the law (Rom. 4:28), but through faith (Rom. 1:17; 3:28), which is a gift of God (Rom. 10:17).

126. Karl Von Hase, *Handbook to the Controversy with Rome*, ed. A. W. Streane (London: Religious Tract Society, 1906), 1:21–22.

127. Braaten, *Justification*, 8.

128. James Bannerman, *The Church of Christ: A Treatise on the Nature, Powers, Ordinances, Discipline, and Government of the Christian Church* (New York: Westminster, 2002), 2:249.

129. Ibid., 2:250.

The Trinity has accomplished the most difficult part of salvation through Christ's life and death, and the Spirit does not need human help to apply salvation. Why would the Spirit need sacraments to bring salvation to humans when the Spirit brought Christ to be the Savior of the world? The tragedy is that Catholic sacraments function in place of God, whether this is realized or not. I agree with Robert Duncan Culver that "one of the sad facts of Christian history is that the pure evangelical teaching of the New Testament and of the apostles was compromised in sub-apostolic and patristic ages by retreat into moralism, legalism and sacramentalism."[130] Even the sixteenth-century Reformation did not evaluate the nonbiblical view of the sacraments of baptism and the Lord's Supper.

Salvation is an intimate direct relationship with Christ. Saul's conversion on the Damascus road was not through the church. Paul said God "was pleased to reveal his Son in me," and Paul consulted with no one else for three years (Gal. 1:15–17), declaring, "I have been crucified with Christ and I no longer live, but Christ lives in me" (Gal. 2:20a). This is the Christ who said to humans "Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest" (Matt. 11:28); the Christ who promised that through the Spirit (not through the church): "I will not leave you as orphans; I will come to you" (John 14:16–18); the Christ who invited people to "[r]emain in me, as I also remain in you" (John 15:4a). This is "Christ in you, the hope of glory" (Col. 1:27b). God took the initiative in this relationship, "For he chose us in him [Christ] before the creation of the world.... In love he predestined us for adoption to sonship through Jesus Christ.... In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, in accordance with the riches of God's grace that he lavished on us" with "all wisdom and understanding" (Eph. 1:4–8).

The new covenant is different in orientation from the old covenant, for the only lawful contemporary priesthood is in heaven at the throne in God's sanctuary. The priestly system on earth in the Catholic church is not a continuation of Christ's incarnation, but a continuation of the old covenant priesthood, which is no longer relevant since Calvary. It follows that the new covenant celebrates a once-for-all sacrifice of Christ (and His resurrection and ascension to heaven), compared to an endless repetition of sacrifices which do not contribute to human salvation any more than the sacrifices of the old covenant.

Vatican Council II speaks of the priest who, "acting in the person of Christ brings about the Eucharistic Sacrifice, and offers it to God."[131] The priest "alone can complete the building up of the Body in the Eucharistic Sacrifice."[132] "For it is the function of the Church, led by the Holy Spirit who renews and purifies

130. Robert Duncan Culver, *Systematic Theology: Biblical & Historical* (Ross-Shire: Great Britain, 2006, 1st ed. 2005), 735.

131. *The Documents of Vatican II*, 27 (1.2.10).

132. Ibid., 36 (1.2.17).

her ceaselessly, to make God the Father and His Incarnate Son present and in a sense visible."[133] Bishops "channel the fullness of Christ's holiness." Through the sacraments "they sanctify the faithful."[134]

But do they? Human traditions must be evaluated by God's holy Word. The Protestant biblical principle of *sola Scriptura* means the Bible interprets the Bible, and does not need the magisterium to do so. Richard John Neuhaus, a Lutheran who became a Catholic priest, shows his true colors when he denies *sola Scriptura* is in Scripture[135] and states he "is conscientiously resolved to be utterly faithful to the magisterium of the Catholic Church."[136] This is the foundational difference between the Catholic and Protestant views on biblical interpretation. While this difference remains, there is no genuine unity between them, however much is said or written to the contrary.[137]

133. Ibid., 219 (41.21).

134. Ibid., 51 (1.3.26).

135. Neuhaus, ECT Statement, in Ankerberg and Weldon, *Protestants & Catholics*, 221.

136. Ibid., 212.

137. Neuhaus notes there is little theological criticism of ECT from Catholics compated to questions raised by Protestants; Richard John Neuhaus, "The Catholic Difference" in Ankerberg and Weldon, *Protestants & Catholics*, 179. This may be because Protestants have lost much more than Catholics through the wording of the document, and what is lost is the essence of the gospel, or the reason for the existence of Protestants, who protested against the loss of the gospel in Catholic theology in the sixteenth century. Protestant leaders must not forget their mission, or ecumenism will erase the Protestant contribution to truth, as if the Reformation had not taken place. Neuhaus claims the term "evangelical" is not owned by any church, for he believes "the gospel is embraced by all Christians, although they do not always articulate that gospel in the same way." In other words, "To say that one is an evangelical puts the accent on the message; to say that one is a Catholic puts the accent on the community that is gathered by that message. At the same time, Catholics insist that they are equally devoted to the good news of the gospel" and hence, they too "are evangelical," Neuhaus, "The Catholic Difference," 181. But Catholic emphasis on human works to gain merit is opposed to the free gift of the gospel, and is not another way of expressing the gospel. Either one is saved through Christ alone or through the church alone. The Catholic difference presented by Neuhaus is the alleged apostolic authority of the church, reaching back through a succession of office to the apostles themselves. On the basis of apostolic succession (from Peter to the present pope), there is only one true church of Christ, Neuhaus, "The Catholic Difference," 196, and hence "Protestant theories of the Church, whether advanced by liberals or conservatives, seem woefully inadequate," Neuhaus, "The Catholic Difference," 197. Neuhaus claims that Protestants have a low view of the church. Similar to a low view of Christ that fails to do justice to Him. However, paradoxically they accept the high view of Christ presented in the Councils of the fourth and fifth centuries. Neuhaus calls Protestant ecclesiologies "low ecclesiologies" (likening them to low Christologies), yet saying Protestants have a "high Christology" because they accept the Councils of the fourth and fifth centuries (Neuhaus, "The Catholic Difference," 198). What Neuhaus fails to say is those Councils (in fact the first seven Councils) took place in the East, and not in the West (where the Roman church was situated), and hence Protestants are not indebted to the Catholic church for these decisions. It should be remembered that Augustine was an African bishop, and so not in the West, and it can be argued that the later Catholic church adopted its views on justification from Augustine and not from Scripture. Alister McGrath asked why the latest *Catholic Catechism* (1994) does not speak to the issue of justification by faith (see Alister McGrath, "Do We Still Need the Reformation?" in *Christianity Today* [December 12, 1994]). Neuhaus claims that the latest Catholic Catechism does not speak of the issue of justification by faith because it does not want to be "bogged down in past disputes" (which is really a copout). See the next segment (Conclusion) for the marked difference between Catholic and Protestant understandings of justification by faith. Neuhaus also seems to gloss over the vital importance of arguments about justification by faith by calling them "theological niceties," stating that "arguments surrounding the *sola fide* formula are the preserve of a relatively small number of professional theologians, mainly Lutheran and Calvinist, in North America and Western Europe," adding that

Conclusion

It can be argued that both Luther and Calvin believed in union with Christ as defining righteousness.[138] Luther's early view of justification merged into sanctification[139] (as is true of Calvin's view throughout his theology), which is similar to the Catholic view. It can be said that Luther, Calvin, and Barth focus on righteousness in Jesus Christ without emphasizing the distinctions between justification and sanctification; still these Protestant views oppose the Catholic view of the justified person (made just) entering a continuous justification in which works are meritorious. Nor does Catholic theology have any place in this process for declarative justification. So even in examples of similarity, there are differences.

It can be argued that it is unwise to spend too much time focusing on the distinction between justification and sanctification, thus missing the fact that Christ is our "righteousness and sanctification and redemption" (1 Cor. 1:30, ESV). For He is "The Lord Our Righteous Savior" (Jer. 23:6b; 33:16b); "he has clothed me with garments of salvation and arrayed me in a robe of his righteousness" (Isa. 61:10); and "the grace of God has appeared that offers salvation" (Titus 2:11). "Beware lest anyone cheat you through philosophy and empty deceit, according to the tradition of men, according to the basic principles of the world, and not according to Christ. For in Him dwells all the fullness of the Godhead bodily; and *you are complete in Him*, who is the head of all principality and power" (Col. 2:8–10, NKJV; italics mine). The Roman-Protestant Divide as it should be is stated right here: we are complete in Christ without the Pope, church, priests, human mediators, sacraments, indulgences, purgatory, or anything else.

There are several ideas that separate the Reformers' understanding of justification from the Catholic view: (1) justification is imputed rather than infused; (2) infusion is contrary to Chalcedon, because of a confusion between divine and human natures, for divine nature is infused into human nature;[140] (3) the

arguments over *sola fide* "are not, and cannot be, at the center of the global proclamation of the gospel and the Christian mission in the third millennium," Neuhaus, "The Catholic Difference," 203–204. However, on the basis of all that has been said, it seems wiser to say that if the gospel is questioned by human traditions, then this issue is just as important in the third millennium as in any previous time.

138. See Alister McGrath, *Iustitia Dei: A History of the Christian Doctrine of Justification*, Second Edition, 224; Michael J. Gorman, *Inhabiting the Cruciform God: Kenosis, Justification and Theosis in Paul's Narrative Soteriology* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2009), 40–45.

139. Justification includes renewal according to Bernard Lohse, *Martin Luther's Theology: Its Historical and Systematic Development*, trans. and ed. Roy A. Harrisville (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1999), 262; cf., in 1519: "Everyone who believes in Christ is righteous, not yet fully in point of fact, but in hope. For he has begun to be justified and healed," Luther, *Lectures on Galatians*, vol. 27 in *Luther's Works*, 227.

140. See T. F. Torrance, *Conflict and Agreement in the Church: Order and Disorder* (London: Lutterworth, 1959), 1:64. This refers to the Christological Chalcedon Council (451).

Catholic church is not the only means of salvation, so there *is* salvation outside the church; (4) Christ is the sole Mediator, rather than additional mediators like Mary and the saints; (5) there is no need of purgatory; and (6) many Catholic traditions call into question Christ and the Holy Spirit's role in salvation. It should be kept in mind that there are many contradictory traditions,[141] but most important is the fact that (7) Scripture alone is authoritative, and must decide between authentic and counterfeit views of salvation (rather than Catholic tradition), and this includes a proper interpretation of Scripture (allowing Scripture to interpret Scripture, *sola Scriptura*, and not the Catholic magisterium as interpreter, nor the historical-critical theories held by many Protestant scholars). *Justification by faith alone is essential to the gospel.*

On the cross Christ said, "It is finished" (John 19:30)—which included the sacrificial system with its priests, for all animal sacrifices pointed to Christ's sacrifice. Their work was finished when His sacrifice was made. That is why the temple curtain was miraculously rent from top to bottom (Matt. 27:51; Mark 15:38; Luke 23:45); the sacrifices and services were no longer relevant. For Christ as priest offered Himself as the sacrifice, and now, on the basis of this sacrifice (Heb. 8:1–2; 9:24–26), He ministers in heaven's sanctuary at God's throne as our high priest. "Let us then approach God's throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need" (Heb. 4:16). Jesus Christ is the only Savior, and He does not need any church, priests, sacraments, Mary, and the saints to do the work that He alone is qualified to do.

It is through faith in Christ alone that we find the biblical meaning of justification by faith. Salvation is in Christ alone, not in or through a church. "Salvation is found in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given to mankind by which we must be saved" (Acts 4:12). David said, "Truly my soul finds rest in God; my salvation comes from him. Truly he is my rock and my salvation" (Ps. 62:1–2a). "Cast your cares on the Lord and he will sustain you" (Ps. 55:22a). No wonder Jesus beckons, "Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest" (Matt. 11:28).

The Reformation is not finished. In fact, some Protestant theology is becoming more Catholic as a result of the ecumenical battle to defeat secularism. This is the wrong battle. The right battle is over truth, biblical truth. We need to go to the One who is the Truth (John 14:6). The most fundamental truth has been enunciated by God Himself, "Before me no god was formed, nor will there be one after me. I, even I, am the Lord, and apart from me there is no savior" (Isa. 43:10b–11).

141. See Geisler and MacKenzie, *Roman Catholics and Evangelicals* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 1995), 196–198; see also 198: even at Trent there was not a unanimous decision on matters decided.

May God give us wisdom to seek the only ecumenism that counts—union based on truth, union with our only Savior, dependent on Him alone, and His Spirit, for our salvation. The Persons of the relational Trinity—with their eternal, reciprocal love for each other—long to embrace all humans in their circle of love, for outside of that embrace, there is no salvation.

Study Questions

1. Why is it important to look at all the differences between Catholic and Protestant theologies in order to determine the difference between their understandings of justification?
2. What are some of the nonbiblical traditions in Catholic theology that explain their understanding of justification?
3. What is the biblical understanding of justification?
4. What is the biblical understanding of sanctification?
5. What disqualifies the Catholic church from proclaiming the true gospel?
6. How has Protestantism changed, and why is it now more interested in union with the Catholic church than it was in the past?
7. In what ways is the Council of Trent still influential?

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